
SATIPANYA BUDDHIST RETREAT

The Teachings of Bhante Bodhidhamma

*Selected Talks on Vipassana, the Noble Eightfold Path, and the
Way to Liberation*

Bhante Bodhidhamma

SHROPSHIRE · UNITED KINGDOM

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About the Teacher

Bhante Bodhidhamma is a Theravāda Buddhist monk and the founder of Satipanya Buddhist Retreat in Shropshire, United Kingdom. Ordained in the Burmese tradition, he trained extensively in the Mahasi Sayadaw method of vipassanā meditation.

For over three decades, Bhante has taught insight meditation, offering retreats, courses, and weekly talks at Satipanya and internationally. His teaching style combines rigorous adherence to the classical Theravāda framework with warmth, humour, and a deep understanding of the challenges facing modern practitioners.

The talks collected in this volume span his entire teaching career, from foundational explanations of the Noble Eightfold Path to subtle explorations of advanced insight practice. They represent his commitment to making the Buddha's path of liberation accessible to all sincere seekers.

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PART 1

The Buddha and His Message



*Buddhaṃ saraṇaṃ gacchāmi — I go to the Buddha for
refuge*

CHAPTER 1

Why Meditate?

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 39 min

Originally given as *Why Meditate?* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma addresses the perennial question of why we meditate, drawing on the Buddha's own spiritual journey to illuminate the true purpose of meditation practice. He explores how the Buddha moved beyond jhāna (absorption) meditations and self-mortification to discover vipassanā—the direct observation of reality as it unfolds moment by moment.

Bhante explains how our conceptual mind creates a distorted view of reality through three fundamental misperceptions: continuity (seeing things as permanent when they are constantly changing), identification (believing we are our thoughts, emotions, and body), and the pursuit of happiness through manipulation of external conditions. He demonstrates how meditation develops Right Awareness (sammā sati) by establishing moment-to-moment presence, allowing us to observe phenomena without becoming entangled in wanting and not-wanting.

The talk emphasizes developing an 'observation post'—a quality of consciousness that can witness thoughts, emotions, and sensations without identification. This shift from 'I am angry' to 'there is anger' creates the space necessary for insight into the three characteristics of existence: impermanence (anicca), unsatisfactoriness (dukkha), and not-self (anattā). Practical guidance is offered on how to approach meditation without expectations, focusing simply on developing meditative skills and present-moment awareness.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato samma-sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato samma-sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato samma-sambuddhassa. Homage to the blessed, noble and fully self-enlightened one.

I thought I'd try and answer this perennial question as to why we meditate. I think one of the mistakes we make is to come to meditation with some sort of expectation. That expectation is a projection of what we want from the meditation,

whatever it might be. It might be some sort of psychological relief. We want to cure our relationships so that everybody stops hating us. It might be to become enlightened, have some sort of deep spiritual experience. But if you come with that sort of expectation, it's getting in the way of this pure intelligence that we're trying to develop.

So the best attitude when you come to meditate is just for the purpose of developing your skills of meditation. That's enough. Developing the skills of meditation. And to do that, you've got to be very clear as to what the point of it is. The point is to establish this moment-to-moment mindfulness.

If we look at the history of the Buddha himself, he starts off by practising what we now call *jhāna* meditations or absorption meditations. And the purpose of that is to develop mental states within us through the process of certain techniques such as a mantra. You keep repeating something beautiful in your mind, "may all beings be happy." And it fills the heart with a certain sensation, a certain feeling, and you keep doing that until you become absorbed in it. It's like watching a good film. You just watch a good film, you get lost in it, and then when the film's ended, that's the end of that.

So it's the same with these techniques to do with absorption or developing mental states. They're just to do with manipulating the mind so that some inner environment is created and it becomes so absorbing that you lose contact with the world. You just become that. So this was great as long as he remained in it, but when he came out of it the old sufferings would arise—depression, anxiety and stuff like that. He didn't find that satisfactory, because remember that what had awoken him to seeking were these two major insights.

First of all, the fact that all life seems to end with sickness, old age and death at some point. And that he couldn't find anything in the world as a young man which was going to give him a sense of permanent contentment—any sensual pleasure, not even relationships. A sort of weariness grew with it. These two things set him out on this task of trying to discover if there was something which was more permanent.

In that age, the real fear was continuing rebirth, continuing reincarnation, no way out of it. That was the underlying fear of that particular age—that all you could do was just keep being reborn, being reborn, and depending on what you did, you might be reborn as a dog, or you might be reborn as a king, but you just kept this. There was no way out of it. So he's looking within the concept of the age to try and find something which didn't belong to any of that, whether there was

such a thing. Already there were some inklings with other teachings that became known as the Upanishads, that there was something which didn't belong to the phenomenal world, beginning to be called *Atta*, the Self. And the whole concept of it being with some greater self, Brahma, was also being developed at the same time. So he tried all that and came up with this negative position that it wasn't much good.

The other process was to go into self-mortification. And the understanding there was that the problem lay in the body. So if you think about it, it's the body, isn't it, which gives us most suffering. The body itself, with its appetites and its sicknesses and all diseases. And even when you go into feelings, even when you go into emotions, they're felt in the body. So if you could somehow starve the body, or take the body to an excess where, in a sense, you lost contact with the body so that there was no suffering there. So the idea was to mortify the body. The most common way was to starve it. And those of you who've done a long fast, like a ten-day fast, know that after about three days when the body feels awful, it actually feels good, it feels all right. And the body feels light, and it seems to be okay. Except, of course, the body's eating itself. It won't last very long.

So he's practising these things and he takes it as usual to the limit. And he's got these companions. And something strikes him at some point where he realises it's a waste of time. He's not getting anywhere with it. And he's sitting by a roadside, feeling pretty glum, and a woman comes along with a bowl of rice that she's going to offer to perhaps a shrine or something. So she offers it to him, this bowl of rice pudding. And he tastes this rice pudding, he eats this rice pudding, he feels good for it. His body is lifted and his mind is lifted, he feels good. It's not that you need to eat rice pudding to become enlightened—that's not absolutely necessary.

Then he remembers this thing in childhood. This is really kernel stuff. He remembers a childhood event. He's watching his father doing a planting ceremony. And it's the state of that consciousness which he remembers as being radically different from all those things that he's practised with the absorption states, and from the stuff that he's been experiencing through the self-mortification. There's something different about it. And it inspires him, so much so that he thinks that this can only be the way. He can't see anything else but that particular state that he'd been in then as a child. So he meditates with that, with that state. And within about six hours, he makes his break, which is now called enlightenment.

So now, what is this state? Because then the whole of his life is about teaching people how to arrive at this state, this level of consciousness. If you go back to your childhood, or if you watch a child, you'll see that when a child, especially around pre-language, or pre-conceptual language anyway—that's like three to seven, that sort of age, even a bit beyond that—you'll see that when they see something, they lock on it, don't they? Become totally absorbed in it. And you see the jaw drop. And they're looking at it. And it's only after they've absorbed this object, a beetle, that they turn around and say, "What is that?" And when dad says, "It's a beetle," that's it. They never see a beetle again. From then on, what they see is what they imagine or conceive a beetle is. They've lost that initial interest in it, that initial pure knowing, that initial investigative intelligence.

So what is that that we have as a child which then we lose through the conceptual mind? People blame it on education, but it's not education at all. It's a natural progress into language, and then we believe that language is more real than the actual experience we're having. We actually believe that language, words, are things. If I say "car," I believe that's a thing, a car. Don't I? I do. But actually, all it is is an idea in my head—"car." It has no existence. If you said to me, "Describe a car," I can describe a car to you, but it won't exist. It'll be in my head. And it'll never measure up to a real car out there, because the description will be different. It's made up in my head.

If you take me to a car and ask me what it is, then of course I'll label it and say that's a car. But because I have a picture of a car, I might never look at that car with that open-mindedness. It'll have to fit into my idea of what a car is. And that way, I don't see the car as car. What I see of the car is what fits into my idea of a car.

So now we're constantly doing that. Whenever you look at something, you'll see that your perception is actually distorting what you're looking at. And it's only when you look twice do you see things there that you hadn't seen. So we're always looking at the world through this glass, this coloured glass of a concept. And then that glass, or that distorted glass, is coloured by our emotional relationship to the world.

So whenever I see something, I always split it into all those things I like and all the things I don't like. So I live in this world where I have everything I like and everything I don't like. And as soon as I do that, I have this response to it of wanting what I like, not wanting what I don't like. And that's what Buddhism

means by living in a dual world. And all those things I don't like, I don't look at properly. And those things I do like, I gobble up. So I'm always playing that game in the world.

And the game is being empowered by some deep misunderstanding or deep commitment that I can find happiness in the world if I can get it straight. If I get the right partner, the right job, the right house, I'll be happy. And so I'm constantly manipulating the world like that. Just watch yourself watching TV sometimes. You'll see. If you catch yourself, you're always shifting. As soon as the body feels slightly uncomfortable... We're never actually facing the world as it is. We're always trying to do something to shift it, to move it, to make it fit in to what I want.

So here's the Buddha, and he's found this level of consciousness. And he discovers a new relationship with the world. And then he goes out and he tries to teach it. So what's his approach in trying to make us correct our vision? Because that's where he starts from. He starts from a wrong understanding. That wrong understanding is deep within the way we're actually seeing things.

And what he points out is that there are three distortions that we make. The first is that we have some idea of continuity. Just think, for instance, how long is a space of time? How long does time last, normally? A couple of seconds? If you were to think of how long a space of time lasts... We stretch it, don't we? Because of memory and the ability to conceive. If you stop now, how long is time? A couple of seconds, isn't it? But actually it's not that at all, is it? It's absolutely specific. It's arising and passing away all the time at vast speeds.

Just think of the speed of your thought. Just think of the speed that the eye is moving at in terms of moving around, picking up photons, making up pictures in the mind. And then the mind has to think what it means and then put it into some sort of thought pattern. Then some emotion has to come up. We don't see any of that. What we catch is just this block of time. So the idea we have of things changing is not radical at all. We have a continuity.

So when I think of myself... I think of myself as being the same person as I was when I was born. If I show you a picture of myself when I was two years old, I say, "Look, there, that's me, that's me, that is me when I was two years old." That picture, this is me. And yet we know that physically, this body is nothing like the one we were born with. Every seven years, all atoms are completely changed. But we don't recognise that at all. As far as I'm concerned, this is me when I was two years old.

So we're constantly identifying with a process, thinking that the process is me. But the process is radical. There's no me that changes in it. Next time you stand in front of a mirror, you just point at your face and say, "I didn't have that face seven years ago. It was a completely different face that I had seven years ago." And if you can imagine looking in the mirror one day and you see somebody else's face, then that break of continuity would be shocking, wouldn't it? Because you identify with that whole process.

So what the Buddha is saying is, if in your meditation you can really come down to a present moment and see this quality of change, then you'll break through that illusion, you'll break through that delusion of thinking that anything is actually continuous. Now one of the benefits of seeing that is that when you really grasp the fact that everything is arising and passing away, what's the point of holding on to it? What's the point of attaching to something which doesn't actually exist, which is only a concept in the mind?

When you do that, you begin to undermine the idea that perhaps there's something here which I can grasp onto, which is going to actually make me happy. So you undermine that grasping nature about life where you're trying to manipulate the world in order to make you happy. Because all you're doing really is just shoring up trouble for ourselves. So these are the sorts of insights he makes. And the insights he makes come from a different level of consciousness. It can't be that awareness which is caught up in those things.

So when you come to meditate, all these techniques that you come across—doesn't matter what the technique is, or what school it belongs to—is to try and lift the meditator to this particular observation post, which is not caught up in this whole business of playing pleasure, wanting, not wanting, and seeing things as continuous.

So that's why you always begin by first of all trying to concentrate the mind. There has to be some stillness there. It doesn't matter how long it takes, but you have to wait until there's at least somewhat ability to just stay, generally speaking, in the present moment. And that takes an effort. It's not the effort of building a road, and it's not the effort of writing an essay or something. It's just a very calm effort of reconditioning ourselves to be present.

So when the mind wanders, and you acknowledge that the mind's wandering—it's worrying or something—by acknowledging it, you first of all become aware of what we obsess about. But then, you take your attention away from it. By taking your attention away from it, you're disempowering it. By not putting your atten-

tion on something, you disempower it. Why? Because every time you attend to something, you've intended it. And intention is what's actually creating the conditioning.

So by doing that, by noting where the mind has wandered, and you actually recognise where it is, and you turn away from it—you turn your face away from it, you turn your eyes away from it, you turn your attention away from it—when you come back to the breath, you make the intention to stay there. So that's empowering this new habit of being in the present.

Once you've got that, once you've got a steadiness of being in the present, you can now take a different position with everything which comes up within you. Instead of when depression comes up, you hear these words, "I am depressed." Like you pick up your phone and say to your friend, "I'm depressed." Or you tell somebody, "I'm angry." Instead of doing that, you're distancing yourself from it so that you're saying, "There, there's depression, there's anger, there's happiness, there's joy."

That little gap, that distance, makes all the world a difference. It takes you out of an identity with your emotions and your thoughts and your body to a position which disidentifies with it. So what is it that's disidentifying? What is it that's finding this new position where it's no longer experiencing itself as an emotion? No longer experiencing itself as a thought? No longer experiencing itself as the body? What is that?

And the more you practise that, the more you find that that's a much better resting place than to be stuck inside these emotions—hijacked by these emotions, confused by thoughts. And that position is an observation post that you've found. And it's from that post that you can begin to objectively observe what's happening inside you and begin to see these, specifically these two characteristics. Nothing that we experience inside us, never mind outside us, lasts for more than a second, lasts for more than a nanosecond.

And there's nothing inside us which, if we attach to, or if we say it's me, is not going to cause us problems. So that ability to stay separate from it is actually creating a very different relationship with life. You become in it—you're still in your body, you're still in your thoughts, you're still in your emotions—but you're no longer confused by them. You're no longer dragged by them.

So that's the purpose that we're meditating. We're meditating in order to establish a different level of consciousness. And it comes about by making that effort to be present, to be mindful in this present moment. And from that everything flows. Everything flows from that. Is that perfectly clear?

Well, that's the discovery, you see. That's the discovery. You can only know that by doing it. Its quality, its active quality, is intuitive intelligence. It's an intelligence which is prior to thought. It's before thought. It doesn't work with thought. And it's prior to emotion. It's not emotional. And it's definitely not physical. So everything you look at can't be it. You've objectified. If it's an object, it can't be the subject.

Remember that the question was, what are you trying to do in meditation? This is the first position, you see. You're trying to isolate an experience, a quality within, which eventually turns out to be not phenomenal. It doesn't arise and pass away. And when you get into that state, even though you might be surrounded by unpleasant feelings, you just pop a question in your mind. Am I suffering? Is there suffering here?

Well, first of all, you have to develop that state of being able to observe, you see. To observe an emotion as an object, not to get caught up in it. The example I give is, you know if you watch TV and you've got a light on, and you can see yourself watching TV. So now you have a choice. Do you watch yourself watching TV, or are you going to watch TV?

So this intelligence senses its presence within the mind, which is like a TV screen. And that's where you get this feeling of an observer. And when you have that feeling of an observer watching what's happening, that's exactly what's happening. There are two consciousnesses there, one after the other, very quick. Very quick. You can't actually see it unless you've got extremely good concentration, where there's this sense of presence, the observer, and what it's observing.

By continuing to put your attention on what you're observing, the observer will disappear. And it's at that point that you're doing pure *vipassanā*. And you won't know it until you come out of it. When you come out of it, you'll know that you've been in a state where the idea of a self has disappeared, and with it the sense of time. It actually comes quite often, believe it or not, but they're in such small little bits that the meditator doesn't actually catch it.

What we're trying to do is inform ourselves to find out who we really are, or what we really are. So we're not this body. If we were this body, then all we're looking to is annihilation at death. So you'd end up being an annihilationist. That's definitely not the Buddhist position. On the other hand, if you say, well, I am something, so I am this observer, then you fall into the error of eternalism. And he said he wasn't that either. So you're really stuck. So there's something beyond the concepts of something completely ending and something constantly existing. But the meditation has a practical result.

If you take, for instance, these two positions—the position of the person who's seeking happiness and the position of one who has moved into, for want of a better word, this level of consciousness, or the *vipassanā* state, shall we say. If you watch a film and your intention is to enjoy the film, I'm going to enjoy this film. You're saying that to yourself, I'm going, oh great, I'm going to enjoy this film. You turn the TV on and because you're interested in the film and because you want to enjoy it, you'll enter into the absorption of that film, won't you? You'll lose a sense of time, lose a sense of self, and you'll wake up at the end of the film and think that was a fantastic film.

Now the problem with that absorption is that it's conditioned us to seek happiness in films. That's the problem. Which means that we're always looking for a good film to see so that I can be happy. How can we watch a film where we appreciate it and yet we don't get that hangover of wanting, needing, a compulsive desire to see films?

So that's what we're learning. We're learning how to be with something in a completely absorbed way, but not coming off the platform of seeking happiness there. We're trying to come off the platform of simply wanting to know, simply wanting to experience something in order to understand it. So it's the same thing in meditation. The driving force in meditation is interest. It's a wanting to know.

Well, you've got to be careful here. It's a striving in order to know what is in the present moment. What is in the present moment. So therefore there's no conceptualisation, there's no launching into the future, and there's no grabbing into the past for some answer. It's right here and now. Therefore it can't be conceptual. Thought is always an afterthought. It's always a launching. If you're in the present moment, there can't be a self, there can't be an ego. Ego needs time. It needs time to reflect and needs to know what it wants. And then it needs to be able to manipulate in order to get what it wants.

Whereas what we're trying to do is to see things as they are now. That's the interest, to see things as they really are now. As a scientist might want to do that at the material level. He wants to see what is happening actually now. So there's no room to manipulate that now to fit in with what I want because it's happening. I can't think about it.

Time is a concept, absolutely. In that state, we don't make any judgements either. We're not saying then, this is good or this is bad. We're talking about meditation now. If the statement comes up, this is good, this is bad, then that is also observed as a sentence. There's no need to agree with it or disagree with it. Because what you're interested in is the mind as it expounds itself into your consciousness. You're investigating something. To start judging it would be already to manipulate it, to decide what you don't want to see and what you do want to see.

So one very good example is of a bird watcher. See, a bird watcher doesn't manipulate the birds. Just watch the bird. You watch the bird and at the end you write a book and make a million pounds. You just watch. Write your little notes. That's all you're doing. You're just trying to find a position in yourself where you're watching. Then you come to understand, ah, this is causing me suffering. This is causing me happiness. This is where real happiness lies. This is where suffering lies. If you get it right within us, then of course outwardly we get it right without any problem.

So you take, for instance, a very simple thing once you go out into the world. Say compassion. That's a very simple one. So you want to help people. It might be just helping somebody across the road. It might be doing something for a charity. You want to help somebody. So the ego says this is a very good thing to do. So you start helping.

Now there's a part of it which is coming out of a wisdom base, coming out of a desire to alleviate somebody's suffering. Because we've suffered, we see their suffering, so we want to help them. Normally speaking, you tend to help people who've suffered like you. If you've had a drink problem, you tend to be very good at helping people with a drink problem. It's very simple, there's a relationship to it.

So, you then go to help this person, and of course, you feel good. And the ego says, when you do that, you feel good. So then you start doing that, not particularly to want to help the person, but because you want to feel good. Then you become a do-gooder. See? So a do-gooder is somebody who does you the good they want to do to you. If you ask them to do something else, they get very upset. See?

So then that's ego coming in, you see, whereas somebody who is helping for the sake of the other, the self can't be there. They're at the service of the other. So if the other says, can you do this for me? Yes, I can, as long as it's skilful, moral, and all that sort of stuff.

So the feeling of goodness, the feeling of happiness would still arise, but it doesn't become your aim. If it becomes your aim, that's self-driven. It's the same with food, isn't it? Why do you eat food? Are you eating there so that you can have a good time? So that finally you can experience half an hour of delight? Or are you eating in order to nourish the body? If you eat in order to nourish the body, you still get the delight, but you don't get the hangover, you don't get the fat. Because the body will tell you enough, and then you stop, because you don't need to eat more than that.

But if you're finding happiness in food, you can't stop. You're always stocking up the fridge, there's always a snack, there's always a biscuit. Why? Because the self has found happiness there. It's just killing the body, that's all.

So that distinction between coming from the base of wisdom and coming from the base of self begins here within us as we observe what the self is doing. And the self is always caught up in that duality. Wanting, grasping what it likes, pushing away, running away from what it doesn't like. That's the game at the bottom of the triangle. Wanting, not wanting. Wanting, not wanting. And what you've done is lifted yourself to the apex of that triangle and you're looking down on that game. You're trying to liberate yourself from that.

There's no drive towards surviving. There is life. So long as there is life, one is alive. I mean, when the Buddha came enlightened, he didn't kill himself. He didn't say, well, that's it, that's finished, and jump off a cliff. He kept living. He kept living until the natural term of his life came to an end. Why?

It's a good question. Why? I mean, you could turn the question around itself. Why should he kill himself? He was happy. He was happy with the way it is. This is the way it is. I'm neither happy nor unhappy, this is just the way it is.

But I must say there was also something else, because remember that upon the enlightenment, what was the first thought that came to his mind? Once he'd actually understood what he'd actually come to experience, what was his first thought? His first thought was, who can I help? So with wisdom, compassion

arises naturally. And that set him off on his teaching career. He didn't just sit there and say, great, I've got it, to hell with everybody else, I'll just keep asking for rice pudding.

You've been going to the Tibetans, I can see. Because I never agreed with them. Well, historically it happened the other way. Historically, the Buddha suffered, like us all, and he decided to see whether there was an end of suffering for himself. Having done that, then this thought came, who can I help? So it would be silly, from his point of view, to say that he had started off in order to help others. He started off wanting to help himself. Having done that, he then goes out and can help others.

Mahāyāna tended to be a reaction against the early Buddhism which was very much about individuals becoming enlightened so they tend to... but you can see that compassion is wisdom in action. It just flows. And then the Buddha put it in the Eightfold Path as soon as you have right understanding your attitude changes. Once your attitude changes your speech, your action, your livelihood changes just a natural outflow.

CHAPTER 2

Bodhisatta's Birth to Renunciation

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 46 min

Originally given as *Bodhisatta's Birth to Renunciation* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this exploration of the Buddha's early life, Bhante Bodhidhamma guides us from the Bodhisatta's miraculous birth at Lumbini through his privileged youth to the profound existential crisis that led to the Great Renunciation. Beginning with the practice of spiritual reading (lectio divina), Bhante emphasizes approaching these accounts not as historical facts but as archetypal teachings that speak to our hearts.

The talk examines key themes: the prophecy of Asita revealing the two paths of world-conquering monarch or fully Awakened being (representing our eternal choice between worldly and spiritual pursuits), the significance of birth under the sal trees (highlighting the Buddha's connection to nature), and the early loss of his mother Queen Māyā. Bhante particularly focuses on the Buddha's encounter with the four signs—sickness, old age, death, and the peaceful ascetic—as catalysts for spiritual awakening.

Central to this teaching is the concept of nibbidā, often translated as 'disgust' but better understood as 'world-weariness'—that natural arising of 'enough' when we fully experience pleasure without grasping. Drawing parallels with Camus' Sisyphus, Bhante explores how confronting life's apparent absurdity can awaken genuine spiritual seeking. He offers practical guidance on mindful eating as a way to understand the difference between satisfaction (which increases attachment) and contentment (a quality of the liberated mind).

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā Sambuddhassa. Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā Sambuddhassa. Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā Sambuddhassa — Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-enlightened one.

I want to carry on with the Buddha's life, but first something I should have mentioned in the last talk — better late than never: the idea of spiritual reading, as opposed to the way we normally read. Ordinarily we read to accumulate knowledge, to gather information. But reading for spiritual purposes was developed, I think, best by the Benedictines. They had three methods called *Lectio*, *Meditatio* and *Contemplatio*. You read an inspiring book — say a book by Ajahn Chah, something written from the heart — rather than an academic book, although even academic books can inspire.

You read it as if you're reading poetry or listening to music. You're reading along and, of course, it's going in. Every so often there'll be a paragraph, a sentence, or a phrase that seems to hit, to catch you. What you do is keep repeating that until you've absorbed it — like you might listen to a piece of music over and over again, or read a poem over and over. You're not thinking about it. You're allowing the heart to grasp it, you might say — an intuitive feel. When you've had enough of that, you stop still. Maybe some thoughts come around it, some ideas. You can follow them for a little while, develop them. Then you drop them and fall into silence. And then you go to the next passage.

What you may find is that it has an inspiring effect. It makes you want to go and sit, as it were. And it's interesting because these passages pop out when you're talking, every so often. You haven't tried to remember them, but they're there — more deeply absorbed.

In a sense, that's the purpose of all art, isn't it: to allow us to re-experience in our own way what somebody else has experienced. T.S. Eliot called it the objective correlative. Need I explain? What he meant, as I understand it anyway, was this: I have an experience and I want to pass it on to you. I have to find some symbolic way in which your heart and mind can communicate with mine. Say I have an idea — music — and it comes out as a feeling, joy for a start. Joy comes up in the heart and I'm a musician and I want to express that joy through a certain medium. It's specific culturally, isn't it? Unless you've listened to Chinese or Japanese music, or even Indian music, you've got to get into that symbolism, that way of expressing particular emotions and understandings. Through art, two people can communicate at a deeper level than just an intellectual one. If I say I'm depressed, that's one thing. But if I write a piece of music that makes you depressed, then we have some deeper communication.

When I'm going through the life of the Buddha here, I'm really just allowing thoughts to arise in that way, seeing what comes up. Often when I go through the same material, different thoughts emerge because other information from somewhere else has come in, other feelings arise. Every time I reread the life of the Buddha, there's always something new that comes up for me. This isn't an academic approach. Whether it's history or myth is in a sense immaterial, because it lies there within the Buddhist tradition as an archetype, an exemplar whom we're following. And anyway, I'm not an academic — I'm a would-be academic. So you have to take everything I say with a pinch of salt.

The first thing is that we got to the point where he was about to be born. He was born somewhere around 2,300 to 2,500 years ago. When you consider that length of time, and you consider how many religious leaders have probably appeared, started something, and then their teaching has disappeared — one example would be the Jains. If you look at the ancient maps, the Jains were, I think, just about as numerous at some point, maybe even more numerous than Buddhists in India. But somehow they fizzled out and are now down to around 3 million, which in the population of India is very small. This doesn't mean the teachings of the Niganthas were wrong, but there's obviously some feeling there of fading out. It may grow again. But there are lots of little religions, and especially these days with gurus popping up here and there — that sudden rush of interest, it builds up and then slowly dies away. When you think that Buddhism is a 2,500-year-old tradition, that inspires faith and a certain trust.

Remember that faith in our understanding is not a belief. A belief is putting faith in a statement. If you were to say, 'I believe the Buddha was enlightened,' you're in great danger of being deluded. There's a difference between believing that statement and trusting it. In a sense, we don't know, do we? We don't know what the hell he was talking about until we get there. And when we get there, we don't know whether it's the end — there may be something more. Who knows? So it's a case of trusting, and the trust grows as we practice because we get the benefits of it. That leads us towards the goal, and hopefully we get a peek of it, a little touch of it. At that point, faith becomes immovable because now we've had a taste of that end we're moving towards.

When we consider that for 2,500 years millions of people have been practicing in this way, have been contemplating the life of the Buddha, and it's affected them, and cultures have grown around it — this is part of the basis of our faith: the fact that it's been such a long and deep tradition, and that it's spread across cultures. Similar to Christianity and Islam, which have been able to go far beyond

their cultural bounds and move into different cultures, being developed by them in their own way. There is, I think, a trust that comes with something that has such an ancient history.

That's something that, in the sense of this *meditatio*, thinking of it raises that feeling of faith, that feeling of trust. You stay with it. You delight in it. Remember that part of our practice is going through all this hell stuff, but the other part is developing what is beautiful in us. When something joyful comes up, don't kick it out. Don't say, 'Oh, where's all my depressions and anxieties?' When you're reading in the library or listening to a tape and suddenly you get this lovely *pīti* come up, this joy around the teaching, this interest — stop the tape, stop the book, and just stay with it. Let the heart absorb it. Don't rush through it.

That age, just as an aside, was quite an age for human beings. At the same time there was Moses, there was Lao Tzu in China, Socrates. It's known in the history books as the Axial Age. Something happened in human consciousness. Something moved, something turned. From that point you can say history begins. Written history, the history that we know, actually begins around about that time. History in India begins with the life of the Buddha, frankly. That's when it begins — history in the sense of facts.

Anyway, he's born. Being a very advanced being, he's chosen his mother and father, and seems to have chosen rather well. His father is a local potentate, and his mother also belongs to a family that is rich and powerful. He's got the good *kamma* there. As you know, she wants to go home to have her child, and he's born under the Sala trees on the way. She gives birth in the park at Lumbini.

This is the theme, isn't it? The Buddha and nature. He's born under a tree, he's enlightened under a tree, and he finally dies under a tree. That connection with nature is something our society can easily lose, especially living in a city. I remember once being at a meditation centre when a little chick had fallen out of its nest onto the ground. Being a townie, I just looked at it, wondering what to do. So I bent down to pick it up and put it on the wall, just in case the cat got it. As I reached for it, the thing bit at me and I leapt out of my skin. This tiny bird scaring me to hell. Eventually I did get it onto the wall — I don't know what happened to the little thing. Afterwards I was saying, if I'd found that in town, I'd probably have stamped on it and put it in the bin. That's how detached you can become from living beings and nature.

Again, it's a case of recollecting on these things and what nature means to us. Walking in nature, being close to it, hugging a tree occasionally. How close are we to the ground, to the actual earth we live on? Do we ever sit and consider how utterly dependent we are on what the earth gives us — the produce of the ground, the air we breathe, the water we drink? And that understanding of the body being in constant change — it's like a double-edged fountain with stuff coming in through one aperture and escaping through all the rest. You get the feeling of the body not being static at all, but this flow. It's actually in a state of flow: digesting and giving away, receiving and digesting and giving away. You get this feeling of being part of that process we see in nature.

Then, of course, there's a consideration about the importance of our parents. He's chosen these two people. Well, I doubt we chose the people we ended up being born to. Just to recollect what we owe our parents — usually we hold on to the more sticky bad memories we have of them, but when you consider what they actually did for us, you come to the conclusion of the Buddha: that even if you were to carry your mother and father on your shoulders all your life, you would not have repaid them their gift, even if they kicked you around a lot. You're still here. You made it. And parents are so much part of our makeup — even the little habits we have, just the way we do things, we pick up from our mother and father. That intimacy we have, especially with our mothers.

And then, of course, his mother dies within a week. One wonders what effect that might have had on a wee baby. We know that the intimacy is already there in the womb. The child actually knows the mother's voice, the feel of the mother. Having tasted her milk and got close to her, and then suddenly there's a change — a change of environment. Although it's her sister who takes over, one wonders how that early child would have been affected. Knowing later on what identity crisis he goes through, his existential crisis around sickness, old age and death — there's a suggestion from our own depth psychology that this was the beginning of his suffering, that awakening to loss. Never mind the birth process.

Now he's born, and the next thing is that he's recognised by the seer, the ascetic. The ascetic says he's either going to be a world-conquering monarch, or he's going to be fully enlightened — a fully self-enlightened being. This business of the world-conquering monarch is like an alter ego that runs through the scriptures. There's always a picture of this monarch who rules the world out of the Dharma, by way of the precepts. It runs almost concurrent with the idea of the Buddha being the fully self-enlightened being. In other words, if he hadn't chosen that path, this is what he would have done: he would have set his horse loose — this is the

way it was done — and followed his horse, and wherever the horse went, he'd have conquered, and eventually the whole world would have been brought under his Dharma rule.

The story about the *Chakravartins* is that finally one of them doesn't keep the precepts and the whole thing begins to collapse. There's one discourse which is rather interesting from a modern point of view — well, from any point of view, but specifically these days — and that is that poverty is the root of social evil. That's what the discourse says. And that's something we can think about.

But this idea of the split within us between the worldly life and the spiritual life — that stays with us all the way, doesn't it? Not to say we're going to become world-conquering monarchs, but there's always that pull towards the world. And what is the world? It's riches, isn't it? Riches, power, fame, and sensual pleasures — the pleasures of life. Even here, when you're doing your meditation and you get that feeling, which is not sustainable from the body's point of view, that you might have a cup of tea when there's no need for it — then you might say, oh, there's the world-conquering monarch. I have to let go of that. And you get back onto your seat. So consider that there's always that split within us: one part renouncing the world, one part being dragged away into it. It's good to see it in these terms.

So here the Buddha has been prophesied to take one path or the other. Now he's brought up in a very worldly way. Once his father knows he could shoot off and become an ascetic, he definitely doesn't want that. He wants him to follow in the family and build up the empire. So he surrounds him with pleasures. That's the tale.

But I would have thought that his particular group, the warrior caste, the *Kshatriya* caste, were the dominant caste in that part of India. As you move towards what is now Bengal, it would have been the Brahmins. But in his part of India, it was definitely the warrior caste at the top. That's why you'll see him always taking the mickey out of the Brahmins in the scriptures. He always says, well, a true Brahmin does this and does that — he doesn't do this. He never talks about the warrior caste. The true warrior caste is always the Brahmin. So he's knifing occasionally — in, of course, a very compassionate way, I'm suggesting. It's usually Brahmins who are approaching him when he's talking about Brahmins.

So he's there in his palaces, and we go through this whole business of an identity crisis. It's very interesting from the point of view of the general growth of our psychology. He's married around the age of sixteen — this is the myth, which would have been normal in those days. We know in India you get married pretty

soon. And somewhere in his mid-twenties, I would have thought, this happens. It happens, I think, to a lot of people. It's the first crisis in life about letting go — youth is passing. There's something within the person saying, actually, let's get serious. So it's usually around twenty-five onwards that people get married, get a job, and stop being fools. They think more about what they can get out of society.

And this carries on, doesn't it, until the midlife crisis when you're looking for a bridge to throw yourself off. At that time around twenty-five, I'm not at all surprised that he suddenly begins to wake up to the reality of life itself, having had such a good time for twenty-five years — sex, drugs and rock and roll.

This crisis has two parts, which is rather interesting. The first part is they've had a good old party and a disgust comes up. This is the story of Gautama Buddha from the Jataka, one of the tales, and it's creative — it's got some lovely passages. Here it's describing how he woke up after this night, and this is what he saw.

"As the Bodhisattva woke up and sat cross-legged upon the couch, he saw those women" — these are the women who had been enticing him and dancing — "who had lain aside their musical instruments and were sleeping, some of them with saliva pouring out of their mouths, some with their bodies wet with saliva, some grinding their teeth, some talking in their sleep, some groaning, some with gaping mouths, and some others with their clothes in disorder, revealing plainly those parts of the body which should be kept concealed for fear of shame. He saw the disorder in which they were and became all the more detached from sensual pleasure. The large terrace of his mansion, magnificently decorated and resembling the abode of Sakka, king of the gods, appeared to him as an existence, seemed to him a house in flames. He made the inspired utterance, 'Alas, this is beset with obstacles, alas, it is constricted,' and his mind was greatly drawn towards renunciation."

Now, unfortunately, this passage stresses the business of disgust. And to me, that's always been not a very good word. They often translate this word *nibbidā* — which you'll also see comes up in one of the sermons, as *vipassanā* knowledge is *nibbidā* — for some reason they always describe it as disgust. To me, the word disgust always carries an aversion with it. But if one were to enter the spiritual life with aversion, then obviously there's some feeling of pushing away, of not wanting. And that will come back upon you, because you have to face that disgust. You have to go beyond it.

Sometimes it's translated as boredom. But I think the real word in English is weariness. When you've done something often enough which has brought you pleasure, you get weary. You might listen to the same piece of music and get a lot from it, and then you become weary of it. It's like you've had enough.

One of the things you might have experienced is, for instance, playing tiddlywinks with a child. I don't know what you call it in the States — it's just flicking little things into a pot. A three-year-old might come to you and say, "Come and play tiddlywinks." Because you want to communicate and you enjoy being with the three-year-old — they're delightful little beings — you play tiddlywinks. And after a good ten or fifteen minutes, when all the little things are in the pot, you think it's been a good little game in your way. But the kid's jumping up and down saying, "More, more, more!" And suddenly you're saying, "Well, you know, I've got to get on, I've got to do this" — because another game would definitely make you feel weary.

A friend of mine told me he was a bit of a jazz follower. He went along to this jazz concert, and just partway through, there came this sense of weariness. It wasn't disgust. It was just like, enough — and that was it. He didn't need it again.

So there's something about staying with a pleasure. Be careful that you don't push pleasure away out of fear, but actually experience it fully. If you've got an obsession with something — like food, say you're a chocoholic — take a piece of chocolate and really nibble at it. Make every nibble worth its salt. Actually taste it completely, let it drip around your tongue, slap it around the mouth. Do everything you can to get the fullness out of that. And you may find that after one piece, you've actually had enough. Because normally speaking, when we're obsessed with something, when we're addicted to something, we're feeding into something else. We're trying to feed something else. And when you see how horrible chocolate can be, you become weary of chocolate. I shall be in another country, so you won't be able to sue me.

I always remember — slightly to the side, but you know during student days one tends to drink a bit. I remember going through this period of getting absolutely paralytic. I don't think you have this syndrome in the United States so much, but in Britain we have what's called binge drinking. You just drink, drink, drink until you drop. I know people on the continent seem to be getting into it now, so it's not a very good thing. But I remember waking up — literally, I woke

up in the gutter. I woke up in the early morning and my head was in the gutter. My body was lying on the pavement and my head was in the gutter. I turned over and thought, "Oh my God, this is terrible."

I got up with this throbbing head and feeling sick. The closest place to me was a graveyard, so I entered the graveyard and lay — because I was feeling so bad — on top of this grave. And it slowly dawned upon me that the suffering I was getting from the pleasure wasn't worth it. It wasn't worth getting that drunk. So I set myself this task: the next time I'd get tipsy, but I wouldn't go over the top. And to my surprise, I really enjoyed myself. I came off all that binge drinking and still have a decent liver.

There's a lovely little poem from Blake which I was trying to find, but I just can't get it. He says it so beautifully — that the road to salvation is often through the road of excess. In other words, you get to this point where you've just saturated yourself so much with this stuff that you don't want it anymore. You're over-weary with it.

So when it comes to pleasure, especially here, make it a real exercise in food to really get in contact with what pleasure is. Get in contact with the tongue. When you approach the food, get in contact with the body. There's hunger there. This hunger is mixed — it's both a natural appetite coming from the body, but there's greed there too. There's a seeking of happiness in food, a seeking of relief. I mean, after that sit, you really want to have some happiness. So there's this seeking of happiness in the food, and that's greed.

As you approach the table and put the food on your plate, just be aware of how much you're putting. Be aware of the feelings and the contact you're making with the food, the way the mouth is salivating. And remind yourself you can always go for seconds. Then when you're sitting in front of the plate, just wait. Get in contact with the body and feel that magnet. You want to become — what is it? — ghetto, ghetto we had today. We want to become that food.

And then, mindfully making that intention, lifting, scooping, lifting. As that food touches the tongue, you get this amazing explosion of delight. Now stay with that, stay with that at the physical level, and make it very clear to yourself: this is taste, this is the physicality, the basic ground upon which all my happiness rests. There's two inches of skin on top of the tongue. At this moment, my happiness is dependent on that.

As I'm chewing, I'm feeling the texture, actually feeling the sensations of pleasure. What is pleasure? That's the question. Not a matter of trying to describe it, but of direct experience — the tongue in delight. And when that's really clear in your mind, when you've penetrated it, you might take a few more bites. Sometimes you do this from the beginning; it depends how you want to tackle it.

You can come away a little bit and see that the taste is surrounded with this joy. That's the mind. That's the heart — delighted in this food. And if you stay off it like that, especially if you just leave the fork on the table and sit there looking at the food, you can see that there is this desire for sensual pleasure, this desire to eat more. What was being satisfied when we were eating now becomes like a magnet, like a drawer, like something sucking you into the plate.

If you can just stay with that — and all we're doing is investigating. Because remember, part of it is natural. Part of it is appetite. You've got to eat. Just stay with it. And then as you keep eating, investigate these three qualities: the basic sensual stimuli coming into the brain, which the mind is working with to produce an idea — spaghetti, lettuce. What are the sensations it comes up with when it says spaghetti, lettuce?

And you're aware of the delight that's to be had. Delight in food — there's nothing unskillful about that. The heart should respond with delight to things. But there is something twisting it, putting a kink in it: that consciousness wanting to seek delight, to somehow identify with it, to grasp it, to attach to it. You might feel it as a sort of magnet, a draw, being sucked in. And if we keep eating like that, at some point we begin to get these really clear signals from the body: enough. Enough. Now you can't always trust that, because if you have some emotion in the body — if you feel a bit anxious or something — then it's tight and it doesn't take all that much food.

But let's say, generally speaking, you are relaxed, you're in a decent mood. The body begins to give you these signals: "Enough, enough." Normally we override that and just go for the cream cake. But here, because we're strictly doing our meditation, we hang on in there and feel the override more deeply. More. And you hang on in there. You wait, you wait, you wait, you wait — right to the very end of that. Right to the very end.

Now, what we want to distinguish is the satisfaction — to use that word — the satisfaction of eating something fulfilling desire. That satisfaction, remember, increases our attachment, increases our desire, and after a little while we want more, more, more. So that's satisfaction. And then there's what we might call con-

tentment, which is when the mind is not in a state of desire. The task is to taste those two as quite separate experiences, and to know that contentment is a figure of the nibbānic mind.

One of the qualities of the unconditioned mind is that there is no desire. We can experience that by watching right to the end point when the desire just goes out. Like a light on a wick, it just goes and it's out. And then — just catch that peace in the mind, that contentment.

When somebody complains to the Buddha — a deva complains and says, "Look, this training is very hard" — he says, "Well, it is. But people do it and they attain liberation. And Nibbāna." And the deva says, "Nibbāna, yeah, but so what?" And the Buddha says, "Well, when you get liberated, you are contented and with it happy. *Tuṭṭhi sukha vahati*. You are contented and with it happy." So he's describing to this person his state of mind: contented and with it happy. That's the state of his heart — at peace, contented, happy.

The next thing that moves him, of course, are what's known as the four signs, sometimes the three signs. You remember the story: he's out hunting three times, and he comes across a very sick person, a very old, bent-over person, and a corpse. In some versions, there's also an ascetic sitting under a tree — in which case there's that hope. Maybe there's a way out of this suffering.

Here he's entering into what we would call these days an identity crisis, some sort of existential crisis, a feeling of the absurd. If you say to yourself, "At the end of this life there is complete disappearance, complete annihilation, that's it," you're stuck with this terrible fact that we're conscious and we're suffering. The idea of suffering becomes absurd. It becomes ridiculous. Unreasonable, absurd, beyond reason.

I thought to bring along this: the myth of Sisyphus, whom some of you might know. Going back to ancient Greek mythology — Sisyphus promoted navigation and commerce but was avaricious and deceitful. He killed travellers and wayfarers, and from Homer onwards he was famed as the craftiest of men. When Thanatos — Māra, the king of death — came to fetch him, Sisyphus put him in fetters so that no one died, till Ares came and freed Thanatos and delivered Sisyphus to his custody.

But Sisyphus was not yet at the end of his resources. Before he died, he told his wife that when he was gone she was not to offer the usual sacrifice to the dead. So in the underworld he complained that his wife was neglecting her duty, and he

persuaded Hades to allow him to go back to the upper world and expostulate with her. But when he got back to Corinth, he positively refused to return — until forcibly carried off by Hermes. It's a lovely story. And of course, finally, he has to go to hell. He's in hell because he's been a bad boy.

His punishment is to roll a boulder up a hill. When it reaches the top, it rolls back down. And so he must roll it up again. That's his job for eternity. For eternity. Albert Camus, who was one of my favourite writers — a French existentialist — actually wrote a book called *The Myth of Sisyphus*, in which this became a motif for the absurdity of life.

If you really, really believe that all there is, is annihilation, why get up in the morning to roll that boulder up the hill, go to sleep, let it roll down again, and the next morning roll it back up? Camus was absolutely at one with this idea of the absurdity of suffering — which I think the existentialists understood very well; they definitely understood the first noble truth. And he said that the only dignified way to approach this problem was to commit suicide. That was his answer. Luckily, he did not have to follow his own thought too far, because he sadly died in a car crash.

Last week, when I was answering a question about afterlife and rebirth and all that sort of stuff, I said something I like to say: in terms of the Buddhist teaching, the people who don't believe anything's going to happen when they die are, in my estimation, much closer to becoming liberated than the people who do. For the simple reason that when we believe something is going to go on, it comforts us. The self feels comfort in the fact that, oh, when I die, I shall be born. I'll be happy if I'm born a rat, as long as I'm born, as long as I keep going, this I. And so there's never any facing of the collapse of the self, which happens at death. That's supposed to happen.

Even Muhammad, I think, said, "You have to die before you die." You have to die before you die. And I think even Christ put it in some way — he put it more positively: "Unless you are born again, you will not enter into the kingdom of heaven." You will not be born again. So there's something about facing the horror of that point of complete loss of self, which is death, that is part of the process of our liberation.

The prince was so shaken by what he had seen that, of course, he decided to leave home.

So in your meditation, when these fears come up — fears of sickness, old age, and death — go into them. They've come as messengers from the gods. They're there to awaken us. And remember that it's all delusion. It's all symbolic in the mind. You have to, as it were, always go beneath the thought, beneath the image, to the viscera, to the actual mental state that's driving it. You have to go into that fear, feel it, get accustomed to it, get comfortable with fear, and really allow it to express itself.

Because this fear, remember, is always generated out of that delusion of self. And as we become accustomed to fear — that's Māra, the expression of our fear, the expression of our delusion — the sense of self is disappearing. The sense of self manifests through these negative states. But as we become accustomed to them, we see them. If you remember, when Māra attacked the Buddha every so often, Māra had to slink away because the Buddha saw him.

Seeing those emotions, feeling them, burying ourselves in them, seeing them even going beyond the idea of an emotion, beyond the idea of a feeling, to the constituents themselves — the feeling of sickness, the feeling of tightness, the nausea, getting right down to the physical level — in so doing, it's a process of depersonalising. You are depersonalising the process. And that, of course, eventually relieves us, and hopefully we can stay steady in fear. Once we've lost our fear of fear, what is there to frighten us?

And I shall quote your own very great president, Roosevelt, who said, "What have we to fear but fear itself?" I think I've got that correctly...

So I'd like to bring our little talk to an end there. At one of the sessions, I want to do an exercise rather than give a talk — an exercise on looking at the body, looking at our relationship to the body, our feelings of disgust with the body and all that. These are exercises that come out of the *Satipaṭṭhāna* discourse. And then towards the end, I want to move towards a little new age input of healing. I'll tell you when I'm doing it, so if you're not particularly attracted to that, you needn't come.

Because somehow we have to find a way of making this deeply meaningful to us in ourselves, rather than it just being stories. So I can only hope that my words have been of some assistance to you, and I can only hope that even by the end of this course you will be fully liberated.

CHAPTER 3

Buddha Day Address: What Was the Mindset of the Bodhisatta When He Left His Family and What Made Him Carry On?

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 37 min

Originally given as *Buddha Day Address: What Was the Mindset of the Bodhisatta When He Left His Family and What Made Him Carry On?* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this Buddha Day reflection, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the psychological state that compelled the 29-year-old Bodhisatta to abandon his comfortable life as a Khattiya (warrior caste) prince and newly born son Rāhula to seek an end to suffering. Drawing parallels with modern existential despair—"what's the point when you just end up a photograph on someone's computer?"—he explores how the fear of endless rebirth, rather than annihilation, drove the Buddha's spiritual quest.

The talk traces the Bodhisatta's journey through various teachers and practices, from jhāna states to extreme asceticism, before his revolutionary insight: instead of seeking happiness externally, he turned inward to understand how we create our own suffering. Bhante explains the Four Noble Truths as the Buddha's foundational discovery about dukkha, taṇhā (craving), and the possibility of complete liberation.

Through practical examples of meditation and daily life awareness, he demonstrates how we constantly recreate ourselves moment-to-moment through identification with body, emotions, and thoughts. The teaching culminates with insights on 'not-self' (anattā) as a practical method rather than philosophical doctrine, and the liberation that comes from recognizing the unchanging awareness that witnesses all experience. A powerful discourse on the Buddha's relevance for contemporary seekers facing life's fundamental questions.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa (three times) — Homage to the Buddha, the Blessed Noble, and fully Self-Enlightened One.

I want to start with a quote from somebody who sent me an email: "I thought I had a pretty good grasp on death, but I can't get a handle on it right now. It all just seems so futile and pointless, all the striving. Whether it's striving to earn enough money, striving to maintain ethics, striving to make good memories, what's the point when you just end up a photograph on someone's computer?"

Now, you might be thinking to yourself, today we're celebrating the Buddha and his life, why is this monk making me depressed? The reason this caught me was not only because of its poignancy, but also because there's a truthfulness about it, and it gives us a feeling for why the Buddha should leave his family.

You've got a 29-year-old — this is the story told around the Buddha — and he leaves his wife, his family (that would have been a long extended family in those days, very close) and a newly born child whom he calls Rahula, meaning chains. We have these pictures of him having a peek and then obviously getting on his horse and shooting off into the homeless life.

Men and women, of course, have left their families for various reasons. War, for instance, is a regular one. But he was living in a place which had peace. It was a small clan living in the south of present-day Nepal, part of the greater kingdom of Kosala. His father was the head man, head honcho. He would have had a bit of influence, a good future to look forward to. He was a Kshatriya, which meant the warrior caste.

The caste system was fairly well established. The Brahmins were still considered second class in his area. More to the east, towards present-day Bangladesh, it seems they'd become first, the top of the caste system. They were the mouths of Brahma, and the Kshatriyas were the shoulders, and all the rest were the body and the legs. That image of a caste system, quite rigid.

His life would have been fairly pleasant. He wouldn't have been toiling as such, messing about most of the time, I would have thought — practising maybe a couple of arts, a couple of the martial arts, generally talking about government and all the stuff that was going on, but generally not a stressful life. Something in him drove him. Even around that time there's nothing to suggest that there was a close death or anything like that, although remember his mother had died at childbirth, so I'm sure that hangs somewhere in a person's memory.

It's the way this person puts it, you see: "I thought I had a pretty good grasp on death." I think most of us would say that. We've got a pretty good grasp on it. And then somebody close dies, or it's our time, and then you suddenly realise that this grasp hasn't got such a good hold. You can't get a handle on it — death shocks you. The reason is that death is so final. That's it, isn't it? Everything is lost at death.

I remember there was a little joke about an elderly lady who died, who was very rich, and they asked the solicitor, "How much did she leave? What did she leave?" And he said, "Everything." That's it — everything. When it touches upon you then you get that feeling of ungroundedness, that floatiness, that fear, that anxiety, and that sense of uselessness, desperation, meaninglessness.

That takes us to the existentialists of the middle of the last century — people like Albert Camus, who said that consciousness was absurd. That was the general existential position, that consciousness itself is absurd. In other words, there was no reason for it, and it was completely absurd to suffer. Camus' idea was, enjoy life while you can, and if you can't, jump. Get rid of it. What's the point? Here he has got into this worthlessness, this meaninglessness of life.

That gives us some idea, maybe, of the Buddha's mental state when he left. Because in those times, the horror wasn't this finishing, wasn't this annihilation. It was this continuous onward going — that you'd be reborn again as a human being over and over again. There didn't seem to be an escape from it at all. Although there were teachers who said there was an escape, it was usually into some higher realm, and it was all predicated on a particular person's experience — mainly, from the Buddha's point of view, as he came to find out, based on your meditative experiences.

We have these absorption states which are very refined states of mind. If you were to die in that state, or you were an adept at getting into that state, then you would be reborn into this higher realm. That actually still exists in the cosmology of Buddhism, Theravāda Buddhism.

We have to capture him at that moment — in a sense, a moment of desperation born from meaninglessness, from the sheer pointlessness of having to come back again and again. It's with that feeling that he goes on his search, setting out with the hope of discovering, as he would later put it, the end of suffering. But actually, I think, in his own mind it would have been the escape from rebirthing, from constant reincarnation.

When he practises with the first two teachers, remember, he gets these very deep mental states. And again it's this idea that if you die in that state, you'll be reborn there, and you'll be there forever in this beautiful realm. But as he was a human being, he kept falling out of it. There must have been a suggestion in him that even if he were born in this heavenly place, the *kamma*, the energy that would keep him there, would eventually run out, and he'd fall back into being a human being. That's basically also some of the teaching we have from the Buddha — that in this rebirthing process, depending upon the energy or the amount of power in that state, you can fall from it when it's been exhausted. You would fall down, or perhaps move up with it, who knows.

When he practises self-mortification, that's a completely different philosophy. That's the understanding that the soul is trapped in the body, and the body itself is a manifestation of your bad *kamma*. The idea is to try and get rid of your body, especially its appetites. You deny yourself in order to reduce your appetites for the body, reduce your attachment to this life form. By doing so, the soul would untrap itself and rise to heaven and stay there. This would have been an understanding of the Jains, for instance.

So you can see there's a lot going on. There were also materialists who believed that once you die, that was it. And there were people who didn't believe in good works or bad works having any effect. They would say that if you went to one side of the Ganges full of compassion and love and joy, and came down the other side with hatred, greed and aversion, it didn't actually matter — because it was all fate, all driven by circumstance.

You can see he's in this area of tremendous fermentation, a bit like today really. If you look at the human race — all over the place. You get this feeling that there was a lot of investigation going on about the purpose of life.

He goes out with this sort of despairing state, this feeling about the meaninglessness of life. When, of course, he becomes fully liberated, what he discerns is how we create this suffering. The whole accent then turns upon who is actually — or what is actually — causing this rebirth.

Now, whether we believe in rebirth as something that happens after death doesn't really matter, because all we have is this present moment, and we must be rebirthing now. We must be in a process of recreating ourselves all the time. It's not a case of launching it into an after-death process. That really remains within your own personal belief, your own perspective on life. If you've had a past life

experience, then you probably have some proof within yourself that you go on. But if you haven't, then you take it on, as we say, confidence for the while and hope for the best.

The fact that there might be annihilation upon death is in itself not that tremendously horrible, because once you're annihilated, at least there's no suffering. That's it, it's gone. But the thing is to catch the teaching as a moment-to-moment teaching — that actually here and now we are rebirthing — and to understand what's empowering that.

When we talk about rebirth, if we just go through what it is to be a human being from moment to moment — first of all, there's this body. Now, we know this body is made up of something like ten trillion cells, and it's got a hundred trillion guest cells. These cells are constantly dying, reproducing themselves. So this body is not the body we were born with. They tell you it's not the body you had seven years ago.

That's something really — when you look into a mirror, you can say to your face, "You weren't here seven years ago and you won't be here in seven years." It's like reminding ourselves that this feeling of being me, this hardness, this constancy, this substantiality we have around this body, this me, actually doesn't have a basis.

When you look at the body like that, you can then ask yourself things like, "What do I know about my body?" You might know things theoretically — you might know, for instance, what your liver does — but do you know what it's doing now? It better be doing a good job, because it's supposed to be doing a good job now.

If you ask yourself, "What would I have known about the brain before modern science?" — all I know actually about the brain is that I'm up here somewhere, aren't I? Most times I'm talking to you, I'm talking to you from up here somewhere, about half an inch or so behind this bone. I feel myself to be up here, and I'm talking to you, and I haven't a clue what's inside there at all. I've no direct experience of it.

If you look at me now, what do you know of your own face? It's a big hole, isn't it? A big hole you're looking through. Weird when you think about it. I can see your face, but you can't see yours. Very strange situation we're in.

Then there's your heart life, your emotional life — it's all over the place, isn't it? You get up feeling great and then suddenly you're not. There's no control over it, no absolute control. You can push things away, suppress stuff, put your mind on something that lifts your spirits. But apart from that, you're still going to have to deal with it all, because we know it's there underneath.

So the heart itself is in this constant process of changing, of moving. In meditation, if we look closely, what happens is that we put words to it. We say, 'Oh, I'm angry,' or 'I'm depressed,' or 'I'm happy, I'm joyful now.' But when you actually go into it, when you feel what's there, it's just a feeling — like a sensation, like an itch you want to scratch and then it disappears. There's nothing substantial about it at all, except that we give it substantiality by saying it's me.

Something happens with the body and the heart whenever we turn it into something that I am. It's impossible to escape. As soon as I say to myself, 'Oh, I'm depressed,' that's it, isn't it? I'm depressed — where do we go from there? It's like Prozac. There's no escape from 'I am depressed.' Worse still is 'I am happy.' Because in the midst of 'I am happy,' I am happy. And then the happiness goes. Then what am I? See?

Even more fleeting are these thoughts. When we watch them come and go, most of the time we're caught up in them — and rightly so, often enough. We're having a conversation, we're on the telephone, whatever. But what we notice when we come to meditate is that it goes completely haywire. We've no control over it at all. Then you realise that maybe that's the way it is in daily life too, and I'm just fooling myself.

You realise that no thought ever repeats itself. There's no repetition. Everything is absolutely creative. And therefore there's no ability to hold on to something. You can't hold on to this body — it's changing. You can't hold on to the heart states either, although they feel very similar. One state of depression generally feels very much like the next. But they're all completely different in terms of what's actually happening in this moment.

The idea of trying to hold on to something — which is what we do — becomes ridiculous. See? That's one of the drives of our meditation. And when I say meditation, I'm not just talking about sitting posture. Even in ordinary daily life, just to be aware at the end of a day that the day is gone. That's it. Finished. Complete. At the end of a meal, it's gone. Finished. You can't do anything about it. You never come back. That's it — and feel the grief.

It's just catching that impermanence of things, that absolute annihilation. That's where we get the feeling of annihilation — in the present moment. Every moment actually annihilates. Phenomenally speaking, the consciousness that we have, what we experience, even though the stimulus comes from the outside world — everything we have completely comes to an end. It annihilates. That's it. It's gone.

Concentrating on that, concentrating on the end of things, brings us right face to face with this problem of death. That's where I think the Buddha must have been when he started on his journey.

Something changed in him, as we know, when all these things failed. There was this change in his way of looking at things. We can only imagine that, having been to all these teachers, he was in a bit of a state of despair, really, because there was no answer. Nobody had shown him. He'd been through all the exercises. He knew all the arguments — because later on, after his liberation, he could argue his point with all the other teachers around, all the other philosophers and people like that. Yet he'd come to this point of desperation.

So there was a flip, a turnaround. Basically, instead of chasing for happiness, instead of trying to find it, he now turns inward to see how he creates suffering. What his discovery is, you might say, is that the world we're living in is the one we are creating. Even in this room now, we have as many rooms as there are people. And when you grasp that — if you grasp that actually...

Everything you're experiencing now is being manufactured within here, within this body — the heart process as well, and the feeling of the room. It's all being manufactured through the sense bases of the body and what the brain does with it, what the mind does with it. And we have this consciousness which is only limited by phenomena. I'm only limited to what I can see by these walls. If these walls weren't here, my consciousness would be able to contain the whole area. If I was stuck in the middle of the universe, I'd be able to contain the whole universe, because my consciousness is as wide as what comes in through my sense bases. But it's all here, it's all me, it's all projections. None of it actually exists outside me as something I can experience. That's why I can't experience the world you experience.

So there's a kind of disconnection between us. We can only reach each other through language, through a certain empathy, a certain feel. But you can't actually be in another person's world. We're trapped in this consciousness, trapped within our own world — which is a terrifying idea if you think about it.

When you begin to realise that, the problem becomes: how do I make this world I'm manufacturing somewhere I want to continue living, somewhere I actually enjoy life rather than being always in a state of conflict? And that's when we come back to this process and realise the whole thing about desire and attachment, and aversion, and having a relationship with what we're experiencing — always to do with either wanting, grasping, or pushing away, or running away.

And then, as you come behind that, you find there's somebody that wants to do this. So the original problem lies deep, deep, deep within our psyche, all around this idea of: who am I? This sense of identity. In our meditation, when we distance something from us — as those of you in the room this morning, and those who've been meditating anyway — what we're doing is finding a kernel of identity within ourselves which is separating out from the psychophysical organism with its sensations and feelings, emotions, moods, thoughts and images.

Now, that's a very strange place. Think about it. Because now you are the observer. You're actually saying to yourself, in so many words, I am the observer of... The perceiver can't be the perceived. You can't have the two. And my feeling is that I am this observer, this feeler within everything that's going on in my mind. So I'm an alien. I shouldn't be here. I've lost my identity at a certain level with the body, heart and mind. It's a very strange place to be.

The thing is, when you get into that place, when you're very quiet and you're there, just have a glance back into it and find out what's not there. And that's where you get the Buddha's teaching about not me, not mine. This 'not me, not mine' is not a statement that there isn't a self, that there isn't a soul, that there isn't something transcendent. Nowhere in the scriptures does he say there is no self. It's a teaching tool. What he's saying is: everything that becomes an object to your awareness, you should be saying to yourself, the perceiver can't be the perceived — it can't be me. So that's not me and it's not mine.

I can't possess something if I don't have a relationship with it. And most of our possession, remember, is either some sort of emotional clinging or a legal fiction. If somebody steals your mobile, you might go around saying, 'Somebody stole my mobile' — but it's not yours anymore. It's just possession. You have to watch the way the mind works in terms of identifying and possessing something.

Now, as we go down through the layers: here we are, we've looked at the body and it's just a pile of cells constantly changing, completely out of my control. I can't get into a cell and tell it to divide. I can't do anything with the cellular makeup of my body. When it comes to my heart level, I can allow the heart to

manifest and it will slowly heal itself of its problems, and I can build up the heart through the same process of imagination so that I actually have a beautiful heart, a beautiful mind. And I can do something about thinking, so there's some way of controlling it — if you consider a driver in a car, for those of you who have cars, those who can drive.

When you're driving and you're actually in the driving, you're in the zone, you and the car are one, and there's this feeling of total control. It's only when the wheel drops off that you realise you're not actually in control — you freak out. So there's that sense of identifying which gives you a sense of control. This is the problem with identity. Here we are, constantly disidentifying with things, and in so doing, undermining the relationship that identity creates — which is wanting to control.

That wanting to control manifests in terms of desire and attachment. As soon as something is pleasant, you want to control it, maintain it, increase it. As soon as something is unpleasant, you want to get rid of it. So we're in constant conflict with the way things are. Now I'm talking within ourselves — a psychology which is the negative part of us. Don't confuse this with compassion and love, which come from a wisdom centre, where you're trying to do something but from a very different angle. It's coming out of trying to find an honest and skilful relationship. That's what we're moving towards when we develop this goodwill, this compassion and joy. And that, of course, brings a happiness which is not clinging. Love doesn't cling. Love allows.

So this was his discovery. And it's interesting that, as it's put in the mythology of his teaching, the first teaching was around these Four Noble Truths, just laying the platform that there is suffering. This is it: there is death. It's really laying the platform about life as unsatisfactory — that we shouldn't be seeking permanent happiness in life. The joys in life come and go. Simple as that.

The second noble truth points to the very kernel which is the problem: desire, which is to do with our relationship to things. This English word 'desire' is not quite right, because you can have a good desire, an honest desire. I'm translating the word *taṇhā*, which is often translated as thirst or craving. But all it is, is desire based on wrong understanding, desire based on delusive understanding.

And then the third noble truth: a really clear declaration that there is an end to suffering. You can't get clearer than that. No Western psychotherapist has said that. They all say you can get to an accommodation with life, but nobody has ever stated in the West that you can come to the end of suffering in this very life. Not that I know of anyway. Is there one? No, I don't think there is.

And of course the fourth noble truth is how to get there: the Eightfold Path. At the top of this path is right understanding — or right view, which is probably a better way of expressing it. This means beginning to turn around the way we see things. It's a constant reminder about how things arise and pass away. A constant reminder that every time suffering arises, there must be something wrong within my relationship to what's happening. There's something in me that's got it wrong. And so I look into it and take responsibility for it. Part of this is learning not to substantiate things, not to make this sense of 'I' so strong.

You do that, of course, by connecting with other people. There's a lovely example where the Buddha visits three monks who are completely liberated — he calls them the Anuruddhas. He asks one of them, 'How is it that you live so peacefully together?' And the kernel statement within the discourse is this: 'Well, when I get up in the morning, I say to myself, what if I put aside what I want to do and do what the others want to do?'

Now, how many of you get up in the morning and say that to yourselves? What if I put aside what I want to do and do what the others want to do? Frankly, in a community, that only works if everybody says it. Otherwise you'd end up being slightly abused, because everybody would make you do what they want to do. So there has to be that reciprocity.

We can see now, as we go through this, just the amazing insight that the Buddha had. I couldn't have got there myself without him. I couldn't have got there without my teachers who told me to look this way. I'd still be a raving lunatic. I would never have been able to grasp this were it not for the direction from my teachers, and they going right back to the Buddha who made that kernel insight.

So that's where he stands within our particular tradition. He's the founder, the fountain of all the insight that we have. And he's the exemplar, because he himself went through this whole process. It wasn't something he thought up — it was something he personally experienced about himself. In that sense he's an archetype, because all of us have to go through this process of renunciation.

If you look at any spiritual tradition, it doesn't matter what religion it is, you'll find it's always a process of renunciation. And remember, renunciation isn't the denial of the world. It's not a world-negative thing. It's a denial of seeing the world as the place to become perfectly happy in. What we're aiming towards is this: when we are in a state of joyfulness, we can actually fully enjoy it without wanting it to be repeated, without holding on to it. And when we're in a state of misery and pain, we're able to be patient with it and just bear with it. That's where we're going.

When the Buddha died, he was praised afterwards for his patience, for his bearing of his illness. He had food poisoning. And even there, just finally, even there before he died, he was able to encourage people: all compounded things arise and pass away — strive diligently for your liberation. Always ask yourself, what will be our last words? Why me? There was a lovely cartoon with all these ladies around an elderly lady who was dying, and she's looking at them and saying, 'Why me? Why not one of you?'

In fact, just to bring the talk to an end — could you bring me that thing, Marion? That picture frame. It's not a picture, just a picture frame. I didn't think I'd need this, but I said I had it. It's just that when you start talking, you never know where you'll end up. Thanks a lot, mate.

This is an amazing woman. She died in 1991, at ninety years old. And here she's telling us what it's like to be fully liberated. This is a very clear, straightforward statement. She says: body, mind and essence are all distinct and separate realities. The body, the mind, and then she's talked about essence. So just keep that word in mind.

And absolutely everything is known. It's not as though she doesn't experience things as they come up. When she talks about earth, water, fire and wind, she's talking about her sensual experience — weight, temperature, movement, feeling, memory, thought and consciousness. They all come up: sound, sight, smells, taste, touches, emotions, anger, greed and delusion. All known.

Now note that: anger, greed and delusion. The enlightened person hasn't got rid of all the habitual little tendencies within the mind. They're known when they come up. She says, 'I know them all as they exist in their own natural states. But no matter how much I'm exposed to them, I'm unable to detect even an instant when they have any power over my heart.' Notice that word: over my heart. No power over my heart.

She continues: 'They arise and cease, they're forever changing, but the presence that knows them never changes for an instant. It is forever unborn and undying, and this is the end of suffering.' Presence.

She uses three words to point to something indescribable: essence, heart, and presence. Our job in practice is to begin recognising what that is. And we recognise it more easily by constantly making everything we experience an object of our experience — by pointing to it.

I can only hope my words have been of some assistance and haven't caused even greater confusion — and that you will, by your own deliberate and devoted practice, soon liberate yourself from all suffering. Sooner rather than later.

Sādhū, sādhu, sādhu.

CHAPTER 4

Buddha Day Address: His Training — The Fetters

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 30 min

Originally given as *Buddha Day Address: His Training — The Fetters* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this Buddha Day address, Bhante Bodhidhamma draws from the Mahāsaccaka Sutta (MN 36) to recount the Buddha's intense ascetic practices before his Awakening under the Bodhi tree. He vividly describes the future Buddha's extreme fasting and breathless meditation attempts, which nearly killed him, before his breakthrough realization that the jhānas could be used as objects of investigation rather than mere absorption states.

The talk then explores the ten fetters (saññojana) — the mental shackles that bind beings to saṃsāra. Bhante explains how the first three fetters are broken at stream-entry (sotāpanna): self-identity view (sakkāya-diṭṭhi), doubt (vicikicchā), and attachment to rites and rituals (sīlabbata-parāmāsa). He traces the progressive weakening and elimination of sensual desire, ill-will, and the subtler fetters through the four stages of Awakening, culminating in the arahat's complete freedom from conceit (māna) and ignorance (avijjā).

This teaching offers profound insight into both the historical Buddha's journey and the systematic path of purification that leads to liberation, making it essential listening for understanding the graduated training in Theravāda Buddhism.

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā Sambuddhassa Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā Sambuddhassa Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā Sambuddhassa — Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

Since it's been a while since we've done a proper Buddha Day here, I thought just to go over his journey. I was going to quote this Mahāsaccakasutta, the long discourse around this fellow called Saccaka, whom the Buddha also refers to as Aggivessana, which is his family name. So this is the Buddha expressing what he went through, his mortifications.

"Then it occurred to me, why don't I practice the breathless absorption? So I cut off my breathing through my mouth and nose and ears, and then there was an intense burning in my body like two strong men grabbing a weaker man by the arms to burn and scorch him on a pit of glowing coals. My energy was roused and unflagging, and my mindfulness was established and lucid, but my body was disturbed, not tranquil, because I had pushed too hard with this painful striving. But even such painful feelings did not overcome my awareness."

"Then some deities saw me and said, the ascetic Gotama is dead. And others said, he's not dead, he's dying. And others said, he's not dead or dying. He's the ascetic Gotama as a perfected one. For that is how the perfected ones live."

Well, he isn't the perfected one yet. They've misunderstood his efforts. So that failed.

"Then it occurred to me, why don't I practice completely cutting off food? But the deities came to me and said, good sir, don't practice totally cutting off food. If you do, we'll infuse divine nectar into your pores and you'll live on that. Then I thought, if I claim to be completely fasting while these deities are infusing divine nectar in my pores, that would be a lie on my part. So I dismissed these deities and said there's no need. Then it occurred to me, why don't I take a little bit of food each time, a cup of broth made of mung beans, horse gram, chickpeas or green gram?"

So that's what I did until my body became extremely emaciated. Due to eating so little, my limbs became like the joints of dried bamboo or withered creepers. My bottom became like a camel's hoof. My vertebrae stuck out like beads on a string and my ribs were as gaunt as the broken down rafters on an old barn. Due to eating so little, the gleam in my eyes sank deep in their sockets like the gleam of water sunk deep down in a well. Due to eating so little, my scalp shriveled and withered like a green bitter gourd in the wind and sun. Due to eating so little, the skin of my belly stuck to the backbone, so that when I tried to rub the skin of my belly, I grabbed my backbone. And when I tried to rub my backbone, I rubbed the

skin of my belly. Due to eating so little, when I tried to urinate or defecate, I fell face down right there. Due to eating so little, when I tried to relieve my body by rubbing my limbs with my hands, the hair rotted at its roots and fell out.

"Then some people said, the ascetic Gotama is black. Some said, he's not black, he's brown. And some said, no, he's neither black nor brown. The ascetic Gotama has tawny skin. That's how far the pure and bright complexion of my skin had been ruined by taking so little food. Then I thought, whatever ascetics and Brahmins have experienced painful, sharp, severe, acute feelings due to overexertion, whether in the past, future or present, this is as far as it goes. No one has done more than this. But I have not achieved any superhuman distinction in knowledge and vision worthy of the noble ones by this severe, grueling work. Could there be another path to awakening?"

So he's telling us that he took these ascetic practices to their limit. Now, that one about not eating seems to have been because he had some relationship with the Jains. The Jain teacher was an elder contemporary. In that teaching, your physical body is an expression of your personal *kamma*. So by letting go of the body completely, your soul would then rise naturally into heaven. Jains to this day, when they're very old, they'll just stop eating. It's the way they choose to die. Often, not always.

"Then it occurred to me, I recall sitting in a cool shade of the rose apple tree while my father, the Sakyan, was off working. Quite secluded from sensual pleasures, secluded from unskillful qualities, I entered and remained in the first absorption, which has the rapture and bliss born of seclusion, while placing awareness and keeping it connected. Could that be the path to awakening?"

Now, he had practiced these *jhānas*, remember, right at the beginning, according to the usual way that we see the way his life spanned out. He went, first of all, to two teachers who taught him how to practice these absorption states, which are very delightful. You do it inside yourself. You don't need anything outside. So if you practice loving-kindness and you get beautiful feelings, and they're such beautiful feelings that's all you want to do all day, sit on a tree and practice loving-kindness, you don't need anything at all apart from a bit of food. So he had dismissed that. The distinction here, I think, when he says "while placing awareness and keeping it connected," there's a suggestion there that he's caught on to the idea that although he's practicing these *jhānas*, they become themselves the object of investigation.

"Then it occurred to me, why am I afraid of that pleasure? For it's nothing to do with sensual pleasures or unskillful qualities. Then I thought, I'm not afraid of that pleasure, for it has nothing to do with sensual pleasure or unskillful qualities. Then I thought, I can't achieve that pleasure with the body so excessively emaciated. Why don't I eat some solid food, some rice and porridge?"

"So I ate some solid food. Now at that time, the five mendicants who were my companions were thinking, 'The ascetic Gotama will tell us of any truth that he realises.' But when I ate some solid food, they felt disappointed in me, saying, 'The ascetic Gotama has become indulgent. He has strayed from the struggle and returned to indulgence.' After eating solid food and gathering my strength, quite secluded from sensual pleasures, secluded from unskillful qualities — so the greed wasn't there, remember — I entered and remained in the first absorption, which has rapture and bliss born of seclusion, while placing awareness and keeping it connected. But even such pleasant feeling did not occupy my mind."

This tells us something crucial: here he's understood that the *jhānas* themselves become a way of investigation, whereas before, when he'd started the path, he would absorb into them and just enjoy them. In other words, as it's put here, they "did not occupy my mind." A better translation would be, "and even such feeling did not occupy my awareness." If you read that statement on the window ledge out there from the Arhat Meiji Kyodo, you'll see that's exactly what she says. Everything comes in front of the awareness and never enters into what she calls her heart.

"When my mind was immersed in *samādhi* like this — purified, bright, flawless, rid of corruption, pliable, workable, steady and unperturbable — I extended it towards recollection of past lives, and I recollected my many kinds of past lives with features and details. This was the first knowledge that I achieved in the first watch of the night. Ignorance was destroyed and knowledge arose. Darkness was destroyed and light arose, as happens for a meditator who is diligent, keen and resolute. But even such pleasant feelings did not occupy my awareness."

This is where he understands that all his past lives were driven by his actions, his *kamma*.

"In the next watch, when my mind was immersed in *samādhi* like this — purified, bright, flawless, rid of corruptions, pliable, workable, steady and imperturbable — I extended it towards the knowledge of the death and rebirth of sentient beings. With clairvoyance that is purified and superhuman, I saw sentient beings

passing away and being reborn, inferior or superior, beautiful or ugly, in a good place or a bad place. And I understood how sentient beings are reborn according to their deeds."

Here he's understood that the law of *kamma* is not just his personal law but a universal one. It's interesting — later on we'll mention these four levels of attainment: the stream entrant, once-returner, non-returner, and fully liberated one. In the commentaries, it says anybody who understands the law of *kamma* is a *cūḷa sotāpanna*, a lesser stream entrant. By which is meant: anybody who truly understands the law of *kamma* is already on the path. It's inevitable that they will become liberated in the goodness of time.

"Then when my mind was immersed in *samādhi* like this — purified, bright, flawless, rid of corruptions, pliable, workable, steady and imperturbable — I extended it towards the knowledge of the ending of defilements. I truly understood: this is suffering; this is the origin of suffering; this is the cessation of suffering; this is the practice that leads to the cessation of suffering. I truly understood: these are defilements; this is the origin of defilements; this is the cessation of defilements; this is the practice that leads to the cessation of defilements. Knowing and seeing this, my mind was freed from defilements of sensuality, desire to be reborn, and ignorance. And when it was freed, I knew it was freed."

When he attained liberation, he knew it. He knew he was completely free of these defilements. Now, this word "defilements" is usually understood to mean those things that come because of our immoral, unwholesome actions. But it's more than that. It's also the defilements that come from this fundamental misunderstanding about self. One of the things that arises because of that misunderstanding is fear — fear of death, fear of illness, fear of others. That fear is also a defilement. Later, they made a list of ten defilements. But actually, the way he uses "defilements" in the scriptures is just anything which arises out of this ignorance. And the basic ignorance, the basic delusion, is to believe we are human beings in a complete, total way.

"I understood: rebirth is ended. The spiritual journey has been completed. What had to be done has been done. There is no return to any state of becoming."

That's a lovely little phrase there: "What had to be done has been done." You can feel the release, the relief of having finally arrived at the place of liberation.

"This was the third knowledge that I achieved in the last watch of the night. Ignorance was destroyed, knowledge arose. Darkness was destroyed and light arose, as happens for a meditator who is diligent, keen and resolute. But even such pleasant feeling did not occupy my awareness."

We've talked about these defilements, and one of the discourses is the Bhayabherava, where he's in the jungle training and this great fear comes upon him — wild animals and so on — and he has to overcome that. Now, that fear isn't caused by some unwholesome action. It's just part of the structure that comes when you have a sense of self, of this body being a self. When the body's in danger, you get that fear. That would be included in defilements. Also, these days when we talk about trauma from childhood and things like that, that's also part of the defilements — not caused by personal wrongdoing or anything, just something that arises because of our fundamental delusion.

So these four attainments — the Buddha describes the stream-entrant's insight as like a flash of lightning. A person who has that experience sees everything, but it's not deep; it's just a flash. Often when someone does have that experience, they can't really say what happened. Sometimes they don't even believe they've had it. It's that subtle, that underlying. But it's not big enough to be held, to be contemplated.

The next one, the once-returner, he said is like a starry night. There's enough insight for it to be held and understood. But the *anāgāmi*, the one who is not going to return — and we'll explain that in a minute — is like a full moon. Very clear, but there's still this darkness around it. Finally, the *arahat*, the one who's fully liberated, is like the full noonday sun.

One way of looking at this process is through the fetters, the *saṃyojana*. The word *saṃyojana* has *yoga* in it — that fundamental word is one of those that comes right through the Indo-European languages. Our word 'yoke' comes from the same place.

There are ten of these fetters. The first three are what goes when somebody has this first insight. The first is *sakkāyadiṭṭhi*, translated as self-identity view. It's basically the view, the notion, the belief that I am this human being, this person.

Even at an intellectual level, when you think about the body, we know it changes every seven years. They tell you all the cells have been replaced every seven years. I've almost had eleven bodies by now. Time I got rid of it.

When you think about your thoughts — what you used to think when you were three years old and what you think now, your feelings, your emotions — you can see it's a flow of events, isn't it? Just a flow of events moving one into the other.

The example I use is when you bite your tongue. You're eating away, enjoying your food, and you bite your tongue. For that one wonderful singular moment, you and the pain are completely one. That's identity. Then you jump out of it and find yourself a little angry with yourself. Now you've become anger, you see. Identity is when you lose that sense of objectivity — what you're experiencing is what you are at that moment.

So you trap your finger in a door. Pain's wonderful at doing that for us. But sometimes great pleasure, great joy does it too. You absorb into it and become it. You lose that sense of somebody enjoying something, somebody feeling something. You are that feeling, that pleasure, that mental state. That's what we mean by identity. And that's the first fetter that goes.

The second fetter is doubt — a particular type of doubt. It's the doubt that stops you doing anything, the doubt that stops you from committing. Often in life you come across a situation like a job and you apply for it, but then you go through this doubt business. Can I do it? Should I do it? Sometimes that self-doubt is so strong you don't take the job. You lose it. You don't give yourself a chance.

It's the same in meditation. You sit and think, well, everybody else is amazing, I'm absolutely useless. You keep convincing yourself you're no good at it, so you may as well stop. It's the same with the Buddha Dhamma. There may come a time when you think, I don't know whether the Buddha is right, whether this is the path for me.

But that goes completely with somebody who has this level of insight. There's no more of that prevarication, that oscillating doubt. Now, that's not the same as honest doubt. The Buddha actually wants us to investigate what he says, because the process of investigation itself is the process of liberation.

The third fetter is attachment to rites and rituals. This goes back to those times when, for instance in Hinduism, just bathing in the Ganges would get rid of your *kamma*. That reminds me of something I encountered years ago when I went out there as a sort of pseudo-hippie. I met this young woman — I was young myself, of course, in those wonderful days. I went to this yoga centre and she was there, and she had all these spots and things all over her face. I said, what happened? She said, well, I went down to the Ganges and joined them in this washing, this

getting rid of *kamma*. And I drank some of it. I said, what? Not only does everybody's toilet go into the Ganges, but dead bodies of all sorts, even humans. This poor woman was just getting over what looked like almost blood poisoning. And she's getting over it.

We do little rituals like lighting candles, repeating the refuges and precepts. But if we believed that these acts themselves would help us become liberated, that would be a severe delusion. It goes back to those days when people thought that undergoing certain rituals was cleansing.

This insight undermines all of that. It tells the person who has it that the path is one of purification. Remember, the Buddha only taught two things: the path of purification, which is getting rid of all these defilements within us, and the path of insight, which is seeing things as they really are.

What do we mean by seeing things as they really are? We mean understanding how we cause suffering. There's the process of desire and how it leads us into certain ways of attachment. That attachment then creates people, situations, things that we don't like — because as soon as you're attached to something, you're cutting off the other bit that you're not attached to. You immediately create a conflict. And then there's impermanence. Those are the three things: *dukkha*, *anicca*, *anattā*.

Impermanence really drives home that everything comes to an end. We're very good at noticing beginnings — the beginning of a film, the beginning of... You see these pop stars come and then they disappear. You don't know what happened to them. There are all things like that. It's really beginning to recognise that everything comes to an end. After you finish a meal, recognise: this is one less lunch in this lifetime. After you finish the day: this is one day less of my living. Slowly driving it home, coming to terms with what impermanence really means for us.

The final one is *anattā*, not-self. The easiest way to investigate this, as the Buddha states in the discourse on not-self, is to ask: when you talk about this body or this mind or my mental state, how much control have you actually got? Then you realise your control isn't absolute. And if your control over something isn't absolute, it can't be you. That's the definition of me — that I'm in control. That's how he begins the discourse. He said, if this body were mine, I'd make it grow taller, I'd make my hair grow more, and so on. But you can't. There are certain

things you simply can't do. We find that this sense of control over this organism is quite surface. I can move my arms around, I can do things with my body, but once my back goes, that's the end of it. I've learned that the hard way.

All three chains, all three shackles, disappear. That fundamental idea of identity — even though the notion is snapped — still stays with us to the very end as conceit. It's not as though you get rid of that sense of self just because you've had this insight. The doubt goes, though it may reappear in different forms, but faith in the Dhamma itself is usually rock solid. And a distinction arises between why you do little rituals and how they're not actually going to create salvation or purification. That word salvation, although it's a Christian word, actually does mean healing.

Now, it's only when we come to the second level, the once-returner, that two major things are undermined: our sensual desires and all our aversions. But they're only attenuated, not actually destroyed. That only happens at the third level, the non-returner. That's why a person at the third level doesn't come back — because they're not interested in sensual pleasure anymore. It's as simple as that. Their happiness comes from these absorptions and these beautiful mental states that they can achieve.

Finally, when we get to Arahant, these *jhānas*, these absorptions, are no longer places to indulge. It doesn't mean they can't achieve them — the Buddha was often going through the *jhānas*. But they weren't something he would be attached to as a source of personal pleasure. The awareness would always be there.

And finally, this conceit goes — that sense of I am. Conceit always draws us into comparison. I'm better than somebody — that's obvious pride. I'm worse than somebody — that often masquerades as humility. "I'm not as good as so-and-so." Then there's a more subtle one about we. If I say, "I'm right," and I can get a few other people to agree with me, this sense of I, of conceit, grows because now it becomes we. It's not just I believe this, it's we believe this. That's a more subtle form of conceit. Normally we might think, "Oh, that's not conceit, that's not pride," but it's just an extension of our conceit.

Restlessness goes too. This restlessness is all the remaining defilements that are there. But now they're so fine, so disempowered, that they finally just disappear. It's understood that even after liberation, there are still traces of those habits in the mind. If you read what Meichi Kyao says, that's exactly what she describes.

She says she still gets these little traces of greed, aversion, and delusive ideas, but none of them ever enter into her heart. In other words, this sense of awareness is always something distinct. And that's where she is.

Then finally, that ignorance — really, that's just a blanket statement that all ignorance has gone, along with the delusion that arises from it. That fundamental ignorance, of course, is the definition of who I am.

These are your ten fetters, and they are shackles. If they're shackles, something must be unshackling. Something is being shackled by these shackles. What we discover is that the very thing being unshackled is awareness. Every time you sit in meditation and you see an object, that object can't be you. No matter what you're seeing inside yourself — whether it's a feeling or a thought or some sort of physical sensation — as soon as you turn it into an object, this awareness is separating out from it. That process of separation is the process of unshackling. That's where the sense of release comes from, the sense of relief. That's why the Buddha says the taste of *Nibbāna* is freedom. The taste of *Nibbāna* is freedom.

That's it. I can only hope my words have been of some assistance — that they haven't driven you into deep sleep and somnolence, and that by your diligence you will be liberated from all suffering sooner rather than later.

The Awakening

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 1h00

Originally given as *The Awakening* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this dharma talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines what the Buddha discovered during his awakening beneath the Bodhi tree and how this revelation formed the foundation of Buddhist practice. Drawing from the traditional account, he explores the Buddha's three insights: knowledge of past lives, understanding of kamma and re-birth, and the destruction of the āsavas (mental influxes). The talk delves deeply into the Four Noble Truths as the Buddha's fundamental diagnosis of human suffering, explaining how dukkha arises through our wrong relationship with the phenomenal world.

Bhante Bodhidhamma presents the three characteristics of existence - anicca (impermanence), dukkha (suffering/unsatisfactoriness), and anattā (not-self) - as practical tools for investigation rather than mere philosophical concepts. Using vivid analogies and practical examples, he explains how meditation practice involves taking the position of objective observer to see through the delusion of selfhood. The discussion includes detailed exploration of paṭicca samuppāda (dependent origination) as the psychology of suffering, showing how ignorance leads to the cycle of craving, grasping, and becoming.

The talk emphasizes that liberation comes not through force of will but through the gradual undermining of wrong view through Right Awareness (sammā sati) and wisdom (paññā). Bhante concludes by pointing to that transcendent sphere beyond the six sense doors - the goal toward which all Buddhist practice aims.

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble, and fully self-enlightened one.

I want to turn now to the question: what was his awakening? What did he discover, and how did that translate into practice? I'm not going to say anything that will surprise you, but at least this is an occasion to reflect on what his awakening was all about.

If we go back to that point where he's sitting by the roadside and the rice pudding turns up—and this enlivens him and fills him with great glee, as rice pudding does—he went off to make the great determination to sit beneath the tree, saying he would not rise from this posture even if he were to die. And so he sat there. Remember, he went to sit with that memory of the child—the child who was watching his father doing the ploughing ceremony.

A child has this ability just to receive, especially from about the age of one to about six—that ability to let the jaw drop and the eyes go wide open. Entire receptivity with no mentation at all. There's nothing guarding against anything coming in because there's not enough history, not enough experience to block or to play around with. So seeing his father doing the ploughing ceremony was a surprise, a joy for him.

With that—with what we now understand to be *sati*, that awareness, *sati paññā*, intuitive intelligence, just that receptiveness which is the definition of equanimity, remember: the ability to receive without reaction—he went and sat. And luckily for him, and for us of course, he finally cracked the puzzle. His koan: Is there an end to suffering?

The context of his awakening is the one that's, shall we say, normally accepted: his insight into his own past lives; his ability to see how people were reborn according to their moral or immoral actions; and his knowledge that the *āsavas* were completely destroyed. The floods—we'll come back to them.

There are three things he understood. The first: when he was able to review his past lives and understand how he got to where he was then, it became a personal understanding—you might say a personal law. But when that ability extended beyond himself, to see other beings arising and passing away according to what became the law of karma, what had been a personal law then became a cosmic law. And that's what he taught: the law of karma and the law of rebirth.

The *āsavas*, these floods as they're called—there are three of them. Normally there are three, then somebody added a fourth one in the later scriptures. The first is, of course, the flood of desire for sensual pleasure. Here 'sensual' you have to stretch out a bit to include emotional pleasure. It's the pleasure of the senses, which includes the mind and heart—so it's the whole pleasure syndrome, seeking pleasure in the phenomenal world, in the transient world.

The second is the desire to become, to continue, to keep reappearing as myself. And the third is ignorance. This was later reinforced by the idea of a flood of wrong view. In a sense, wrong view is an expression of ignorance; as to why they added it on, I don't know. But those three were the basic āsavas that he had destroyed.

These āsavas, these floods—the image I have is of a watercolour painting where the artist first puts a wash across the back. Sometimes you get watercolours on a black background, don't you? Or at least I've seen them like that. They might use oil, I can't remember. But anyway, they put a wash on the back, and this wash gives the whole picture a certain tone.

If we look at our mind-heart complex, the psyche, it has these three basic tones: the tone of seeking happiness in sensual pleasure, the tone of wanting to become, to become, to become, and the tone of that ignorance—that wrong relationship we have with the world we're in.

Now, when he talks about the world we're in, he talks about the Four Noble Truths. The truth that there is suffering—just a straightforward statement. The cause of suffering, which is that desire for sensual pleasure in the phenomenal world. And that there is an end—so there's your prognosis, not bad, is it?—an end to this constant misery. And that there's a path which leads to that place.

In the Four Noble Truths, you'll find one formulation where he says *loke*—in this world there is suffering. And when he defines *loke*, he says: in this fathom-length body. So this suffering, this karma, this onward going, this saṃsāra, is happening within us, within the mind itself. What he discovered was that there is a position which lies beyond that.

I've got a couple of quotes here, if I can find them. One of them is: 'There is a sphere.' Now, a sphere, an *āyatana*, is a level of experience that doesn't overlap with others. Through our eyes, for instance, we see form and colour. Through our nose we have smell or aroma. You can't see through your nose and you can't smell through your eyes—you can try, but it doesn't happen. That's what he means by a sphere.

There are six spheres, the sixth being the mind itself. Now he's saying there is another sphere—a sphere to be experienced directly—where the eye stops and the perception of form fades away, disappears. And that perception is the mental noting.

There's a sphere where form and perception disappear, to do with the eye. The same with ear and sound—they disappear. The perception of sound disappears: 'that's a bird' or 'that's pleasant.' The nose and smells, aroma. The tongue and its tastes. Body with its sensation. And the intellect with its mental objects, the images and thoughts. All that disappears. He says this sphere should be realised.

Here he is pointing to something which goes beyond this body, this mind, this heart—the five *khandhas*, the five aggregates—and, as he uses them here, the six spheres or six avenues of consciousness. We can only know the world through these six consciousnesses. We can only see it, smell it, hear it, and so on, and we can only know it as an internal image. What he's saying is that there's a place beyond that.

Having stated that, he points out that this can't be got by a simple act of will. You can't get there by saying, 'Well, okay, let's take a rocket or something and get up to that sphere.' It just doesn't happen like that. It's beyond the will. It's beyond the self.

If you remember, his next talk—having laid out, at least in the mythology, the way the scriptures were later collected—was about the self. Now, this sphere that is to be known, which is beyond all else, is beyond the dualistic world. It's beyond objects, and therefore it can't be known as an object. It is something totally subjective, and it cannot be known as an object. So somehow we have to approach it by some little trick.

All the Buddha is saying is this: look at whatever is arising and passing away and simply know that it's not me, not mine. Here, the knowledge comes into direct practice. That's what he means by this *satipaṇṇā*, this awareness and intelligence.

He's saying that if we can take this position within ourselves of the observer—if we can find that observation post and begin to see things within ourselves as objects—then very slowly, at least, we'll become clear as to what we are not. And it's presumed that if we're very clear as to what we're not, then hopefully, eventually, we'll be very clear as to what we actually are. That's the idea of the practice, anyway.

How do we do that? What process do we use to access that vantage point? We begin to investigate things in a way that liberates. And what's it liberating? It's liberating that which is this special sphere. What is the content of that, or what is it made up of? It's the *sati*, it's the *pañṇā*—the awareness and the wisdom, the looking, the seeing.

He always says: first of all you look, and then you see. If you take that into ordinary day-to-day life, you can see that first you've got to look. If something goes wrong with the car, you've got to open the bonnet and have a look. And then when you look, you see. It's the same with anything—that process of looking. But we're looking, remember, with that attitude of wanting to know. That has to be there. There has to be that desire of wanting to know.

What is it that we want to know? We cannot know Nibbāna directly. We cannot know the end of suffering by turning round upon it and saying, 'Gotcha.' It doesn't work like that.

Think of an archer—this is an image that works for me, anyway. When they're firing at a distant target, they never point the arrow directly at it; they're always pointing it up in the air somewhere. They know that if it travels at a certain speed and passes through that point, it's going to hit the target.

The Buddha shifts our investigation away from Nibbāna. He says, don't worry about that—it will arise in its own good time. Just shift your attention towards the way you are looking.

This element that we have in us, in Theravāda, is dryly referred to as the Nibbāna Dhātu, the element of Nibbāna. I think it takes on a certain fleshy quality when you call it Bodhicitta—the heart seeking enlightenment. When that arises, when we actually bring it forward by lifting this awareness to look at what is happening within the body and mind, the Buddha says don't worry about Nibbāna; just see how you're looking.

And then he gives us these three vantage points: anicca, dukkha, anattā. The sense of impermanence. Where is the suffering? Where is it in this complex of body, mind, heart? Where is it arising from? What's actually the cause of that suffering? And then the more subtle teaching of not-self.

When we're looking and we take the vantage point of anicca—of transience and impermanence—we're becoming aware of that quality that everything is in a process of change. Now, if we centre simply on that, you'll find that the mind is very much aware of the beginning of things, but not the end of things. Because beginning, new for us, symbolises something exciting. Even if it's something horrible, there's still a sense of awareness that it is beginning.

Then as it begins to end, our attention really goes to what is the next beginning. We always know who the new film star is, or pop star, but we never actually know what happens to them. They've disappeared. They just fade away from consciousness, from cultural consciousness.

By putting the attention on the ending of things—on the ending of things—we begin to see that actually this process of change is not a continuum. There is an actual stopping.

The image here is of a row of billiard balls. They're all joined up together, but they're actually all separate. Usually that's explained as showing the difference between the Buddhist position and the Hindu position, which says that there's something which continues through the arising and passing away of things—like a row of beads with a string through it. But the Buddhist position is radical change. Something completely finishes before something else can begin.

And that radical change, as we get into it—there's a seeing of it from the point of view of the intellect, from actually understanding that things arise and pass away. But it's at the emotional level, at the heart level, that it begins to strike home.

Even though in our school we go for the minuscule—the actual seeing of things in the minute, watching the rising and falling of the breath and eventually the rising and falling of a sequence of sensations—at the heart level, it doesn't have to be that particular find at all. Somebody close to us who dies can hit you just as hard as watching the arising and falling of the breath.

It's hitting at a point of attitude. When that attitude is broken—this sense that things have some continuity—when that attitude is broken, it reverberates back onto our understanding. There are always different ways in which the quality of transience can strike us, and it's by constantly putting our attention there that we slowly begin to understand what's happening.

Now, what is it that's arising and passing away? Remember that the Buddha's teaching is that everything is mind. Our knowledge of the outside world is totally dependent upon the senses that we have. Even though we're in this room together and nobody would dispute that this meditation hall actually exists when we go away—in other words, our mind is not actually creating this hall—the fact of the matter is all of us have walked into it, and we all have a different view of it, a slightly different feel of it.

So in a sense our experience of this hall is varied, individual—and that's true for everything we experience. It's only through language and general communication that we can get across to people that we generally see the world as they do. And of course sometimes we don't, which is where you get this image of parallel universes. We're all running parallel to each other in some way, sometimes we crash a bit, but the idea is that everything I know is within my mind.

All these stimuli—the light, the smells, the touch—they're all being brought into this central box we call the brain. But there's also, in Buddhist understanding, a mind matter there, a more subtle form, which produces for us a picture. We know this from our own knowledge of how the brain works. This picture that we get is, shall we say, that act of cognition. And there's something that knows it—something that has a double take on it. It knows it knows.

That picture, as it were, is arising and passing away, holding an image for us so that we can grasp it, and then it disappears and the next image comes up—dependent on stimuli coming in from the outside through the senses, or from the inside through our memories.

When we see that the world is arising and passing away, I think personally it would be truer to say that what we're watching is our minds arising and passing away—the actual act of cognition. To see that, of course, undermines the idea that I can be that.

So *anicca*, the quality of transience, does refer back to the self. This is what the Buddha said, if you remember, in the discourse that I read: is something which arises and passes away to be understood as me, mine, and so on?

That quality of radical impermanence reflects back to the not-self. And in so doing, of course, it ruptures a type of relationship that we have—a holding on. Remember that the self is constantly trying to build a world of comfort around itself, a sort of castle, so that it doesn't shake, doesn't fear anything, doesn't fear death.

But to see that *anicca* quality, that real radical arising and passing away, reverberates back onto the self in its relationship to the world it's in. Now, there I said the relationship of the self. That was wrong. It's a relationship of this *satipaṇṇā*, of this *bodhicitta* or this *nibbāna-dhātu*—it depends what school you're in and what expression you feel happy with.

So now we're getting this idea that there is something within us—this awareness, this very basic intuitive intelligence at the root of our being—and it moves into every moment with some sort of wrong view, that not-knowing. Coming from the position of not-knowing is the basis, the beginning, of the wheel of dependent origination, which is how the Buddha explains how we come to suffer.

I think I said before in an earlier talk, when I was answering a question: if we go back to our little origins in this particular life, remember that we became alive as just a bundle of cells. In that bundle, what did we know? It's only through the growth of the senses that we come to collect, as it were, enough information. And then finally we find ourselves out in the open world, gasping for a bit of breath. And then we grow up.

All the time there's this presumption, gained right back there in the womb, that this must be me, because this is what I experience. That delusion stays with us all the time, and it's only through meditation, by taking this objective position in ourselves, that we begin to break through it.

The process of *anicca*, of transience, of impermanence, comes from a slightly different angle. It's saying that even if you hold on to it, it's going to disappear. Nothing stays the same. Everything is in a state of radical change. So even the effort to try and hold on to something, to maintain a comfort, is a non-starter. It's not going to get you anywhere.

Watching *anicca*, even at the breath, is a constant undermining of that wrong view. A wrong view, remember, that has not come from a position of stupidity. That's the unfortunate thing about this English word ignorance. There is another word, *nescience*, but nobody knows it, so there's no point in it. Only the dictionary knows that word. It means a simple don't-know. Don't-know, you see.

And that don't-know is a frightening place to be. So one throws oneself into something, defines oneself as something. This has happened to you all, I'm sure—a time when you've been in a strange hotel or in somebody's house and you've just woken up and you don't know where you are. There's that sudden rush of panic as to who you are. It's only when you remember, oh, you're in this hotel, that you can breathe again.

That panic, you see, is the self. At that moment, the self can't define itself, so it's rushing around like a mad fool, trying to work out what the hell it is. And when it grasps it—fantastic—then it's happy. Oh, it's me again.

That sense of transience, really seeing transience, isn't only coming back to the idea that nothing in this world is worth holding on to—that's a direct quote from the Buddha. It's also the fact that if something is transient, it can't be me, because it's arising and passing away. We're watching this at all levels, remember—whether it's right there in the minuscule arising and passing away of a sensation, or whether we're just watching these leaves fall, watching the change of leaves, and catching our feeling towards it.

Sometimes if you stand by a river, just watch the river coming at you and catch the feelings that come up with that coming, the newness. Then turn around and watch it flowing away, and catch how your feelings are at letting something go. If there's a puddle around or a pond, look into that and see how you feel when there is no flow.

It's not as though we have to do this meditation in order to break through these things. All this meditation is doing for us is making more and more clear what this satipaṇṇā is.

If we sit with the idea that right now I'm going to crack it, I'm going to really break through this sitting like the Buddha did—you can try it, but it usually ends up with severe frustration. If we see our sitting simply as training, all we're doing is training ourselves to constantly lift ourselves into this position of at least the objective observer.

Now, from this position of not-self, we've created these delusions. The fundamental delusion is that I am this person—that's the fundamental delusion. I am this personality and I am this body. These we call our saṅkhāras. A saṅkhāra is all those things we've been able to create through an act of will.

Once you've got a body and you've got an eye, the eye will see—that's not a saṅkhāra. Whatever's coming into the eye is a given. What we do with that which comes into the eye, with the image that comes—that's our saṅkhāras, because there comes that intention into what we're doing. And that intention is building up a mood, building up an attitude, building up a whole series of thoughts, building up a history.

These intentions, remember, at all levels in all areas of our lives turn into action. You have an intention, it turns into an action. When you've got similar actions going on, you've produced a habit. And once you've got a collection of these

habits, that's your personality. And once you've got a personality, it just drives you towards your destiny—until, of course, you come to meditate. Then you can reverse some of it, and hopefully end up with a decent destiny.

Here we are, with this satipaṇṇā, this awareness, this buddho within ourselves—and then we're born. That's the next stage, nāma-rūpa. With that being born, there arise these acts of cognition. This body-mind complex and the act of cognition rebound off each other; the one can't arise without the other. You can't cognize something if there's nothing there. There can't be a cognition unless there's something coming in through the perceptual faculties—the eye and so on.

Once that's started, once you've got the consciousness and the basic body which has these six senses—that's your next step, the saḷāyatana, the six sense bases—then finally you can have some contact. That's your next stage.

At the point of contact, there have to be three things. You have to have a sense base, you have to have something that stimulates that sense base, and you've got to have that consciousness. Once that arises, then the mind, the perceptual faculty, comes in and knows what it is. But then there's that quality of judgment—now this isn't a judgment to do with good and bad and all that—it just experiences what comes in as pleasant or unpleasant. It's as simple as that.

Sometimes we get a sensation that's pleasant, like when we're eating. Sometimes we get something unpleasant, like when it's getting cold. Whatever sensation comes in after the contact, there's this relationship built up with it. The relationship is simple: like it, don't like it.

Now, once the self grabs hold of that as a position—pleasant, unpleasant—it has to take a stand. And that position comes from the fundamental misunderstanding that this is what it is. It knows there's suffering. It's not happy. But what is it that's not happy? What is it that's not happy?

We started off way back there in the womb, being this, shall we say, this satipaṇṇā, this Buddha nature. And it's formed a relationship. When we talk about the self, we're not talking about something, not talking about an object—we're talking about a relationship.

When we're suffering, what is it that's suffering? It's this very nature, our essential nature of the Buddha. That's what's suffering. And it's suffering because it's formed this wrong relationship.

When this perception comes—that this is pleasant and that is unpleasant—the knowing, which is ignorant, which is creating the delusion, says to itself: I've got to make myself happy. This is where happiness is. I've got to make it now or else I've had it.

Whatever it sees that creates a happy mental state, it'll want to grab, hold, and develop. And once it's into that relationship, that's when we get greed in all its forms. It doesn't matter what it is—power, sex, drugs, rock and roll. The fact is that the more I can have of it, the happier I will be. It's as simple as that.

Having built that little castle, that little place of joy, now of course it has to protect it. Anything it sees as not pleasant, it'll want to destroy, annihilate, get it out, push it away. And whenever that's too much, when it's overwhelming, then it runs. It picks up its bags and goes for it.

There we have the fundamental psychology arising out of that wrong perception of the self. This is me. This is mine. On one side you've got the attachment, the holding, the developing. On the other side, the protection and the pushing away. And the running away—that's all included in that word aversion.

Having got to that stage, we can move very quickly into immoral action, which is basically doing harm—doing harm to others and doing harm to myself. And once I've started doing harm, I'm into the second level of emotions: shame, guilt, horror, all that sort of stuff—remorse, regret. All those flow in once I start doing something unwholesome.

And of course, there's that side of the development which we take pleasure in but which is horrible. We like getting angry at people. It's a relief. We like banging the door. We like being cruel. We like stepping on people's toes, saying that little sentence which really digs them. Cruelty, not being generous, being selfish—all these things can be very pleasant. There's a whole area of unpleasant behaviour which we enjoy, and that of course creates further psychological problems for us.

All of that is included in those three little steps after *vedanā*: the *taṇhā*, the *upādāna*, and the *bhava*. *Taṇhā* is that movement of the self moving towards something because it likes it, it wants it. Having perceived something as likeable, it now moves towards it as wantable. I want that.

Once that want has come—and this is the sequence of psychological events according to the Buddha—the I comes in. The I doesn't come in first. In our language we say, "I want that." But it's not—it's "want I." First the desire arises, and then there's the association with the desire, the identification with desire. And that's the upādāna, that's the grasping.

Once that's happened, it's very difficult to stop the cetanā—the will—from coming in. And the reason is this: that delusion of 'I want' is coming directly from the Buddha within, which is deluded, and with it comes the power of the will. That too is coming from that centre.

So the moment we say 'I,' it's very difficult to stop the grasping, the actual going for the object. And that's the bhava, the becoming. At that point we've created an act. And that act, repeated, becomes a habit.

Now, what we're trying to do in our meditation—in terms of seeing the path through understanding dukkha, understanding how we create this unsatisfactory situation for ourselves—is to put our attention right in between that which we perceive as likeable, unlikeable, or neutral, and to catch that relationship of wanting, not wanting, and ignoring. Not wanting, just simply ignoring it, not even knowing it.

If we put our attention there, it can't go anywhere else—it can't move into 'I.' Why is that? Because the awareness, this intelligence we have, this Buddha nature within us, has taken a completely different position. It's now become transcendent to the whole psychological process. It's above it, beyond it, watching from above.

So if we stay in that position, it can't go into that identity. It just can't do it. In that position, we're actually snapping the idea of me or mine. As soon as you see a desire and let it go, you're constantly destroying the idea that desire is me, that I am the desire. And it's through that process of seeing that we can find this realisation—through simply understanding how we create suffering for ourselves.

When I was in Thailand, I did a tour of all the different techniques. The Thais are very creative. I went down to a place called Boon Kanchan, on the bay around Bangkok. When I got there, the teacher—I'd heard about her—had died. She was obviously a very good teacher. But the instructions are very simple: you don't stop doing what you're doing until it hurts. Really hurts. Really, really, really hurts.

So you sit, and it starts to hurt, and you're not supposed to do anything until it really, really, really hurts. Then, when it really, really, really hurts and you can't handle it anymore, you change your posture—but very, very slowly. All you're looking at is how, as the pain arises, as the discomfort arises, you're just watching your reactions to it. And as it gets to the point where you can't take it anymore and you're shaking with it, you just watch your reactions to that.

When it comes to a point where you really can't take it anymore, you say, 'intending to change.' And as you change, you watch very carefully how the physical sensations are changing and how the mind is changing. Then you come back to a state of comfort. From walking you might go to sitting, to lying down—whatever you're doing, you keep doing it until you get to that point where you're able to see that change.

In seeing that change, you're seeing the distinction between pain—which is both physical and mental—and how you can take a position towards it whereby you're not actually suffering. By observing that process, you're actually undoing the idea of a self. Because the self is always identifying with that process. It says, 'Oh, it's pain, I'd better go and get an aspirin.' It's always moving off it, unable to stay with it.

So even by going through this process of understanding dukkha, of understanding how we create suffering for ourselves, we again undermine that wrong relationship which lies at the base: the idea that this is me, this is mine.

When that is finished, of course, you're also cutting the end of that process of the wheel of dependent origination: birth, ageing, death—or arising, decay, death, arising and passing away.

The traditional teaching is three lives, but the other teaching—which is right there in the scriptures and right there in the commentaries—is of course moment to moment. As we see something we like and indulge in it, we become the indulger, and that arises and passes away. With every sequence of actions in which we've indulged, or pushed away, or run from, we've become somebody. There was a beginning, there was a middle, there was a decaying, and there was an end.

Not everything we do is part of the wheel of dependent origination. Not everything we do is continuing with the self. A simple action like opening a door—there's no moral problem there. It's only where a moral and ethical situation arises, involving greed, hatred, or aversion, that the wheel can actually turn.

So when we do something out of a correct intention—when we eat in order to nourish the body, when we eat to live rather than live to eat—then we're not turning the wheel. In fact, we're going backwards on it.

Now, why is it that the wheel doesn't simply come back on itself? You might think you'd start with not becoming, then go down to not grasping, no I, and then come back to desire. But no—the Buddha starts the negative side of the wheel, the wheel that draws us towards enlightenment, back at ignorance again, back at the point of wrong view.

The reason he does that is because when we're meditating, we're always correcting that view. And whenever you correct a view, whenever you correct the way you're looking at something, the whole castle of cards we've built on that wrong view simply collapses. You don't have to take everything apart. As soon as you see transience, the whole thing you've built on permanence completely collapses.

That's why these insights are immediate. Not all of them have a colossal effect on us, of course. We don't jump up and down. But they're little. They're slowly cutting away at the delusion.

There was a friend of mine who was going to pick me up so we could go for a walk, and his car broke down. It was parked by the road, so I, being an expert mechanic, said, 'Well, open the bonnet.' He opened the bonnet and told me what had happened—the engine had just cut. My immediate diagnosis was that it must be the electrics. I pointed at this part of the machine and said, 'It'll be the dynamo.'

Anyway, the AA came—I don't know what you call it in America—and the mechanic opened the bonnet and immediately saw that the fan belt had broken. What he pointed to as the dynamo seemed to be different from my own description of a dynamo. Now, if my friend had taken my advice, the car would have ended up in a scrap heap. But luckily, somebody who knew came along and saved the day. So you can see how wrong view can end you up in a hole.

As soon as that mechanic came along with the right view, the whole problem disappeared. I felt a real idiot, but there we are. That's why the wheel starts again with ignorance, and that's why the whole force of the Buddha's teaching is right view.

To see things as they really are. To understand, to know and see things as they have—if you want the direct translation—as they have come to be. To see the process. It's often translated as 'to see things as they really are,' but it's actually 'to see things as they have come to be.' So it's always catching that process in which we create the world we live in.

Then there's the final characteristic: anattā, not-self. We've talked about that from the point of view of anicca—if something arises and passes away, it can't be me, it can't be mine. And we talked about it through seeing dukkha, through seeing that if I can take this transcendent position towards the mental process of greed and such, then unwittingly I've snapped the self, I've broken the self, as soon as I'm in that position.

Anattā, the doctrine of not-self, is just getting that position where, instead of being within yourself when you're watching something, you turn it into an object you're looking at. It's catching that little distance. Although I talk in terms of space, it just feels like you're looking at something.

Remember, we're told that a child up to about the age of four months doesn't have that distance. Everything is me. It doesn't matter what it is—it's all me. Only slowly, after four months, does an object arise out of this bath which is me—and his mother, isn't it? That object now becomes something in the mind of the child, something that's not me. Just the beginnings of a perception.

By the age of three, the child is very clear: this is my body, and I'm not that. They know exactly where their boundary is. All we're doing in meditation is continuing that same process inward. We're slowly realising that all these things within us—things I thought were part of me—are actually objects.

One of the things the Buddha talks about when he discusses not-self is this idea of control. If the self can't control something, how can it possibly be the self? The whole idea of being a self is that you're in control. This is me. This is mine. I do what I want, in my own way, in my own time. And of course you can't.

So here you see, as we go into the body—even the body itself—we cut ourselves. What do we do? You keep it antiseptic, but who mends it? You're not in there telling the cells to do this and do that. The body just gets on with it.

When you breathe, what do you know of your body? Even when you go into yourself, what do you actually know? Do you know the marrow of your bones? We're told we've got it, but can you perceive it? Can you know it's there? The brain—we can't even feel the brain, for heaven's sake. At least I can't. Perhaps I need a CAT scan.

And then there's the whole system, how it's working. We're breathing, and I have no control over it at all. If I stop breathing, I panic. The digestive system—I haven't a clue what goes on there. I'm told about enzymes and all that, but I don't feel anything. I just feel good. I haven't a clue what's happening.

Even now, if you look at me and your whole vision is filled with my face—this isn't an ego trip—if you fill your whole vision with my face, where's yours? Where's your face? It's just there in your imagination, isn't it? You haven't a clue, have you?

When you look in the mirror, you think that's how people see you. At least I do. But it's only when you take another mirror and look at what's reflected that you realise you didn't know your ears were that big. You catch your face from the proper way that people see it. Normally that's not our vision of ourselves at all. So we walk around with this enormous delusion of either being ugly or beautiful, and it's completely our own idea.

Emotions. What control do we have over our emotions? You don't go to bed thinking, well, tomorrow I'll wake up depressed. You just wake up depressed. Tomorrow you say, I'll wake up happy, and you do, and you think, oh, I've got some control. But you haven't a clue how you're going to wake up. You might not wake up. Heavens.

Take that, you see. We go to sleep with a sheer presumption—a sheer presumption that tomorrow we're going to wake up. You go to bed, you feel absolutely comfortable, you're all curled up and it's nice and warm, and there's just this underlying presumption that I'm going to wake up.

Now, if the doctor said to you, you fall asleep, it looks like curtains to me—you'd be there with pins in your eyes and pulling your nails out. Anything to keep awake. But we're quite happy to lose the self for eight, ten hours. Some people sixteen. As long as we're absolutely certain within ourselves it will reappear.

There's a lovely poem here from my favourite author. Some of you might know Samuel Beckett. He's known for getting to grips with death. One of his plays was just a mouth speaking, and every so often it would wake up: still here. That was one of the refrains. It would just stop. Still here. He's right at the edge of death, asking what happens when you die.

And he's got this very simple but lovely poem. He says: just think if all this, one day, just one fine day, just think, if one fine day, all this stopped. I like that.

Let's go back now to the Buddha's original understandings. He's had this experience, and he comes back on himself, spending his time reflecting on how he got there. What he comes up with is this wheel of dependent origination—which is simply the psychology of suffering. That's all it's about: the psychology of delusion. He sees these three vantage points, and that's what he begins to teach. That's all he's teaching: how to get into this position, the vipassanā, to see things as they really are and to observe these three points of view.

When we finally make it—when we have at least a glimpse of Nibbāna—he also talks about it in this way. There is a sphere, he says—so we go back to the idea of a sphere—where there is neither earth nor water, nor fire nor wind.

Now, you've got to be careful here, because this comes from a question about where the physical earth ends. And he doesn't say the physical earth ends. He says there's a place where it finds no footing—which is very different. The Buddha's enlightenment did not destroy his body. He simply found a different relationship with it. And for the rest of his life, forty-odd years, he lived in what he called Nibbāna. Nibbāna in this life.

Where there's no infinite space, consciousness, nothingness, perception or non-perception—these refer to the four arūpajhānas. He says: no this world, no next world, no sun, no moon. There is, I say, no coming, no going, and no standing still.

We can understand in our meditation the no coming and no going, because we can stand above things arising and passing away. But there's also no standing still. In other words, that's not a position in relation to what's happening. It's transcendent—completely transcendent.

There's no passing away and there's no arising. It is without ground—without ground. There's nothing underneath it, nothing holding it. It's without foundation and without support. And he says, just this is the end of suffering. Just this is the end of it.

Now, I'm going to suggest to you that in your meditation, when you get at least to the position of very clearly being the observer—an observer of pain, an observer of physical pleasure, an observer of emotions, an observer of thought—even though we can't say that's a pure Nibbāna because there's still the self there, at least we've got some idea. We begin to sense that there is no coming, no going, and no standing still within that process.

And it's recognising that which will draw your interest into really beginning to see that everything we experience is not me, not mine.

Then in those quiet moments, when you're very still, when there's just the breath, you get that very strong sense of being the observer. Now, that's the subtlest of things we produce. That's the subtlest of things the delusion has produced—this idea of 'I'm the observer. This is me.' And that is a reflection in the mind.

The image I use is watching TV. Sometimes when you watch TV, you can see your image in the screen. Now you've got a choice: you're going to watch yourself watching TV, or you're going to watch TV. If you watch TV, you lose that sense of self which is in the screen.

That's what happens when in your meditation you feel yourself to be the observer, looking with interest at an object such as a feeling or a sensation, and suddenly there's that collapse into it. That collapse is the loss of self. It's a direct perception by this satipaṇṇā, this Buddha within, this intelligent awareness, of exactly what's going on.

When we come away from that sort of experience, whether we like it or not, whether we're even aware of it or not, there's been some undermining of delusion. Those are the little power points.

Often, when we're in that experience, there doesn't seem to be any comeback. We don't seem to come away with some sort of understanding. But remember, in time there's this subtle change going on in the way we're looking at things. It's changing the level of consciousness we're at. It's a very slow process—that's how it feels—this slow changing.

And every so often, an insight may come in terms of words, a sudden understanding. You suddenly find yourself behaving in a different manner, reacting to a situation in a different way than you did before. All these are telltales.

Here we enter into the Eightfold Path. From right understanding, moving into right attitude, it expresses itself through right speech, right action, right livelihood.

Now, this Noble Eightfold Path, remember, starts at any of those points. When you make the effort to speak well, to speak truthfully; when you make the effort to do something wholesome; when your livelihood has a wholesome effect on you—it reverberates back on your attitudes. It reverberates back on your understanding. The whole thing turns upon itself. Turns upon itself. And in this way, over a period of time, we do feel a certain change within ourselves—hopefully for the better.

I think that brings me to a sore throat, so I'd better stop before I die. I hope my words have been of some assistance, and I can only hope that in the very shortest length of time you will be fully liberated. Thank you.

CHAPTER 6

The Years of Teaching and Parinibbāna

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 55 min

Originally given as *The Years of Teaching and Parinibbāna* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this concluding talk of his series on the Buddha's life, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the 45 years of teaching that followed the Buddha's Awakening and his final passing into Parinibbāna. Drawing from various suttas in the Pāli Canon, he explores how the Buddha's initial hesitation to teach was overcome by compassion (anukampā), leading to the establishment of the Saṅgha and a lifetime of skilful teaching adapted to individual needs.

Through vivid stories including Aṅgulimāla's transformation, Kisāgotamī's lesson on impermanence, and Bahiya's instant liberation, we see the Buddha's extraordinary ability to perceive what each person needed for breakthrough. The talk also reveals his engagement with social and political issues, his humanity in caring for sick monks, and his clear but compassionate leadership style.

Bhante Bodhidhamma concludes with the Buddha's final words - "All conditioned things are impermanent. Work diligently for your liberation" - and his ultimate instruction to make ourselves and the Dhamma our refuge through the practice of satipaṭṭhāna. This deeply moving portrait shows the Buddha not as a remote figure but as an accessible exemplar whose path we can follow.

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā Sambuddhassa
Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā Sambuddhassa
Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā Sambuddhassa

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble, and fully self-enlightened one.

For those who have just joined us, over these past few weeks I've been going through the Buddha's life and using it as a basis to consider his teachings. We come now, finally, to the years of teaching and his final days. If we recall that

wonderful night: he became enlightened with the dawn—that's how they put it—in the full moon of May. He became fully awakened and understood exactly why he had been in a state of dissatisfaction or suffering.

He spent the following night contemplating the Dharma, going through especially the Wheel of Dependent Origination—his psychological paradigm for why we get ourselves into such a dreadful state. After that, his first thought was: who can I teach? Who can I pass this on to? Then came the doubt. He couldn't think of anybody who would really be open to this.

Consider that at the time, all the philosophies, all the understandings were about the self—about whether the self annihilated. Some people presumed that when you died you simply annihilated, which would be equal to our materialists. Others believed in some sort of future life, rebirth, but that eventually you would annihilate. Still others thought that all you did was keep being reborn and there wasn't much you could do about it; it was just the way it was. Some were so convinced of this that one teacher said if you went down to one side of the Ganges doing all sorts of compassionate and wonderful deeds, then came up the other side burning, murdering, and thieving, it wouldn't make a jot of difference. Your karmic line was already set; it was fated and there was nothing you could do.

All the philosophies of that time concerned the self and what happens to the self. So when the Buddha suddenly realised that this self they were talking about was a phantasm—didn't actually exist, was just a concept in the mind—he hit a block. Who could he possibly get this message across to? This is my own interpretation, you understand. The scriptures say that the great Brahmā Sahampati came and said, "No, Lord, do teach, for some people have only a little dust in their eyes."

These days we'd be rather cynical about Brahmā Sahampati turning up. It's more in the sense that the Buddha had a second thought about it. But you must remember there's always a little bit of propaganda in the Buddhist texts. Brahmā, of course, is the highest of all gods in the Hindu pantheon. That he should come down and ask the Buddha to teach was simply a way of saying that the Buddha had gone beyond the teachings of his day.

Leaving that aside, he then decides to teach. Some writers you'll come across say he hesitated, that he could have just sat there in bliss until the body gave up. But this goes completely contrary to his own teachings. The Eightfold Path is one path. We can think of it as a highway with eight lanes, but I think we're closer to the mark if we imagine a tightrope made of eight strands—because it's so easy to fall off. That's why we find it difficult to walk the path.

These eight strands move together. In the Buddha's teaching it's not possible to separate right understanding from its expression in action, in what we do. Wisdom will naturally express itself as compassion. That's the whole point: there's a flow downward and outward, inward, into the very heart of our existence, our being, for want of a better word. Once we've understood such things, there's a change of attitude in the heart. That's why in the Eightfold Path we go from right understanding to right attitude.

Right understanding is always about the three characteristics. It's always about understanding the role of desire. It's always about undercutting the idea of self. When that translates into the heart, it manifests as an outward going. When the Buddha talks about himself as a teacher, the word he uses is *anukampan*. He says, "I as a teacher have done everything that a teacher could do for you out of compassion." But the word isn't the usual *karuṇā*, which we've come across, but *anukampan*—moving towards the other, an empathy, a sympathy. That's what drives him to teach.

When the self goes—or as the self goes—we begin to understand interdependency, interconnection, all that. When that understanding goes into the heart, it expresses itself in love, compassion, sympathetic joy. If it doesn't, it can remain as an idea, a notion, but it won't affect our behaviour until it moves into the heart.

In the Zen tradition they'll tell you that compassion arises naturally with wisdom, and I think we can take that as fairly true. But even so, we should budge it along a bit, because sometimes we can stay up in the head too long. When understanding moves into the heart and we're in communication with people, it naturally expresses itself in the way we speak—kindly, appropriately—and how we behave in a gentle manner. Not getting angry and killing people. In our livelihood. You can see there's an outward flow.

Consider the Buddha: he's had this amazing insight, he's suddenly understood something to which there is no further profundity. He's thinking about it, working it through, and as it drops into the heart, there's that movement outward—who can I bring to this liberation? The doubt isn't whether he should teach or not. The doubt is whether people are ready for it. Once he's overcome that, he moves forward.

The first two who come to mind are his old teachers, because they trained him and he knew their religious and spiritual depth. But they had died. When I was in Burma last, I saw a statue with a *mudrā* I'd never encountered before—the Buddha sitting with his hand pointing towards the heart centre. I asked what it

was, and I was rather touched when they said it represented the sadness he felt when he realised his two teachers were dead and he couldn't pass on the message of his teachings. I thought it was rather touching.

The next people he thought about, of course, were his five former companions. He walks a hundred-odd miles from where he was up to Isipatana Park, perhaps a little more, finds them there, and that's where he begins his teaching.

Even we ourselves have to accept that once you're on the path, whether you like it or not, you become a teacher. It might not be an official post, and you might not get paid for it, but you're immediately there as an exemplar. I think I've mentioned before: if you tell somebody that you meditate and that it's done you a powerful lot of good, and then they find you completely drunk in the gutter, they have second thoughts about whether they want to do any of this meditation.

When we look at the other tradition—the Pacceka Buddha, the private Buddha, someone who simply becomes enlightened—it's not that they don't want to teach. The idea is that they can't; they don't have that ability, and it's something that has to be learned. This comes out in the Buddha himself.

He's now got up from his seat and he's off searching for disciples. He comes across a *samaṇa*, another ascetic. The ascetic looks at him and says, "You look very bright, very clear. Who's your teacher?" The Buddha announces, "I have no teacher; I'm the fully enlightened being; I know the cosmos in and out." The ascetic simply says, "Oh no," shakes his head, and moves on.

He obviously learned very quickly that's not quite the way you teach somebody.

You'll see this in the scriptures. If you read the early parts, like the Sutta Nipāta, the teaching isn't so formalised—four of these, ten of those, twelve of them. It's very personal. You can see that these are memories of actual conversations he had with people. It's only as he's teaching and as people come to him wanting to remember what he's taught that these mnemonics get worked out. It's easy to remember if there are five of these and four of those and thirty-seven factors of enlightenment. By the end of his life it was beginning to turn into almost an academic exercise, which later became the Abhidhamma.

Teaching was just part and parcel of his nature. When you go through his life there are all sorts of incidents that happen—I've only covered a few—but just to give a sense of his teaching: there was one very dull monk, so dull that it's said as he remembered one phrase it pushed the other phrase out. He never got beyond

this one phrase. His brother said to him that he really wasn't fit to be in the order, because part of it was trying to remember the Buddha's teaching. If he couldn't remember the Buddha's teaching, what the heck would he do?

When the Buddha heard about this, he went to visit and immediately gave him an exercise: just take a piece of clean cloth, wipe your face, the sweat on your face, rub the cloth, and simply say, "*Anicca*, impermanence, impermanence." Lo and behold, in no shorter time, as the scriptures say, he became fully liberated.

The gloss on that phrase "in no length of time," according to the commentaries, is around twenty-five to thirty years. It's not as though he just wiped his face a few times and bingo. I don't know whether you ever want to try that. It didn't work for me.

It's a case of understanding that the teacher has a marvellous ability to get into the person and catch exactly what they need.

Another famous story is that of Aṅgulimāla, the murderer. According to the tale, he was actually fulfilling a demand made by his teacher, who was jealous of him and fearful of being supplanted. As a guru reward—in those days you gave a present to your guru—this teacher demanded that Aṅgulimāla collect a thousand little fingers.

Off he goes and does exactly that. At some point the Buddha either meets him by chance, or hears about him, or through his powers understands that Aṅgulimāla is not a murderer in his heart—he's just been driven to this. I wouldn't be surprised if the Buddha already knew of him, since Aṅgulimāla was supposed to be of Brahmin caste.

The tale goes that when Aṅgulimāla spies the Buddha and starts to hunt him down, the Buddha produces this magical trick: he's walking, yet always stays ahead of Aṅgulimāla, who's racing and racing trying to catch up. When Aṅgulimāla shouts out, "Stop, monk!" or "Stop, ascetic!" the Buddha turns around and says, "Well, I have stopped. It's you that haven't stopped."

Somehow that just cuts into Aṅgulimāla and makes him consider what he's actually doing. Presumably in the conversations that follow, he recognizes that he's fallen foul of his own heart by following a tradition of giving a present to the guru—even though that present was unwholesome. He then takes on the Buddha's teaching and becomes a member of the order, which saves him from execution by the king, by the way, who comes looking for him. And in no length of time he becomes fully liberated.

The other story I'm sure you all know is Bāhiya of the Bark-cloth. Bāhiya is a very old man who wears only bark-cloth. He's been an ascetic for a long time and he's not getting anywhere—he's stuck. Then he hears about this great *samana*, the great ascetic, and off he goes to find the Buddha.

When he finds the Buddha, he says, "Can you give me some teaching?" He wants to sit down and talk about all his issues, but the Buddha says, "Well, this isn't the time, because I'm off on alms round." Bāhiya, being very elderly, says, "Listen, I could die any minute. It's very important for me to hear any teachings you've got." The Buddha simply says to him, "In the seeing there's only the seeing, in the hearing there's only the hearing, in the cognizing there's only the cognizing." Right there and then Bāhiya breaks through the delusion and becomes fully enlightened.

As the story goes, not long after leaving the Buddha, while walking along the street, an angry cow butted him to death. So he was extremely lucky that the Buddha actually answered his question there and then. I love these stories.

There's also a little story about Nanda, the Buddha's half-brother. He joins the order and he's struggling and struggling to practice, falling into the error of over-effort. Realizing that he's not getting anywhere, he immediately thinks—which is understandable—that he's wasting his time. He may as well leave the holy life, go back, live the good lay life, bring up some children, and hope for a better rebirth.

When the Buddha hears this—and what's actually drawing Nanda away is lust—he takes him up into the highest heaven to see the most beautiful nymphs. He sets this as a goal that Nanda could actually attain, rather than going off to be with human women. Nanda then carries on with his practice, and lucky for him, he also, in no length of time, becomes fully liberated.

There are all these lovely little stories about how the Buddha was able to really see what was necessary in a person as they approached him—to see right into their heart and give them just the technique they needed to make a break.

You'll see that although in the scriptures there is this idea of a basic technique around the breath and so on, these stories show that actually anything that works will do. Anything that brings us to some sort of realization of the three characteristics—the transience, how we create suffering for ourselves, and the not-self—will do.

Just one last story to finish this off, because the Buddha's sense of humour comes through. Humour doesn't carry very well across time, but you've got to presume this must have been a rather humorous scene. In those days, if you remember, there was this great idea of ascetic practice. Somebody leaves the sensual world, recognizing that it's not going to be a place where they'll be happy. They go off and practice *jhāna*, following the same path as the Buddha. Up until he sat under that tree, the Buddha wasn't doing anything that lots of people weren't doing at that time.

They get into the *jhāna* and the happy states, and then they realize, well, that doesn't do it. The next thing is to blame the body.

So there are these two ascetics who are called the dog ascetic and the cow ascetic. And the understanding is that they're going to preempt any future rebirth as a cow or as a dog by living as a cow or as a dog right here in this very life. So the dog ascetic approaches the Buddha with his friend the cow ascetic and says, "Lord, my friend here is practicing the cow ascetic practice. What will be his future? What will be his born? What happens to him when he dies?"

And the Buddha says, "Don't ask me." And his second time, the dog ascetic said, "Lord, please." "Please don't ask me." And for the third time they insisted that the Lord give them some answer. So the Blessed One said, "This cow ascetic – he is developing cow perceptions. He is developing cow feelings. He is developing cow consciousness. Therefore upon death he will be reborn as a cow." And the cow ascetic wept heavily and finally came to his senses. And then having come to his senses, he approaches the Lord and says, "Blessed one, my friend is practicing the dog ascetic practice." And I'll leave you to finish the story.

So you get these lovely little instances in the scripture where obviously the Buddha is having a bit of a pulling somebody's leg. There was – I heard somebody say, I can't remember where – that the Buddha was only, there's only one or two incidences in the scriptures where he's actually engaged in a compassionate act. And in a sense that undermines the whole point of teaching. The teacher is, or a teacher is compassionate. When somebody is actually teaching anybody, that is a compassionate act. Whether it's a parent teaching a child or a teacher in a school or a Dharma teacher, anybody. Once you teach, you're offering something. What you're offering is your own wisdom and skills and understandings.

So when we talk about compassionate acts, it needn't be something quite so, shall we say, so obvious as, say, serving in a leper colony or something. Compassionate acts can be very small and very simple and they might not need at all any sense of bravery or anything of that nature.

So when it comes to what you might look at, what you might see as actual acts of compassion, as these days people might see it, there are just one or two. So remember the lovely story of Kisagotami. So she had lost her child and the dead child was looking around for somebody to bring it back to life or to do something for the dead child. And bringing it to the Buddha, he simply set her this task of finding a mustard seed, of which of course there are over plenty in India, from a house, but with the proviso that nobody had died in that house.

So Kisagotami is in a state of desperate bereavement, leaves the child with the Buddha and goes off searching for the seed. And going from house to house, the message is the same. "Sure, I've got plenty of mustard seeds, but my Lord, this house has known death. It's known death from who knows when, right up to this present day – so-and-so died, grandfather died, this child died," and so on. And very slowly it dawns on her that death is just part of life and this brings her to her senses. And coming back to the Buddha she takes refuge in him and again later on joins the order and in no length of time becomes fully liberated.

There's also a lovely scene where there's a monk who's sick and the Buddha hears about this and goes to visit him. And the poor man's got dysentery and he's in a dreadful state. It's all over him. And he says, "Well, why aren't the monks helping you?" And the monk replies, "Well, I don't do anything for the monks, so they're not going to do anything for me."

So the Buddha goes to the monks and says, "Look, this man is sick, he's dying, why aren't you doing anything for him?" And they say, "Well, he doesn't do anything for us, so we won't do anything for him." So seeing the callousness of the monks, the Buddha with Ananda go and tend to this fellow. And then he gave the talk to the monks saying, "You know, you have no mother and no father, and if you don't look after each other, who will?" And there he is, he's being a nurse to this monk. It's one of these little incidences which as it were brings out his humanity.

Even there on his deathbed, I mean, he's actually – he himself, of course, dies of dysentery. And he's on his deathbed and presumably getting weaker and weaker, when somebody turns up, a *subhadda*, and asks for ordination, a direct ordination from the Buddha. And he keeps asking, knowing that the Buddha's dying, and

Ananda keeps saying, "Go away, this isn't the time, the Buddha's dying, come back afterwards and I'll ordain you." But the Buddha, on hearing this, insists that he be ordained right there and then.

So one of the, I suppose, blessings, you might say, of the Theravada scriptures is that you really do get a feel of just an ordinary human being walking around the place and being in contact. There's a little tale in there where somebody walks into a room with, and he's there amongst these monks. And they have to ask him, "Which one is the blessed one?" So they get that sense of ordinariness, and just a real sense of humanity about him. Something which gets lost when you move into the Mahayana scriptures, where, of course, he only appears in his *sambhogakāya*, the body of bliss, teaching to hundreds of thousands of bodhisattvas. So this brings us back to his simple, simple humanity.

Apart from that, there's a whole business where he's actually engaged in society, in the politics of the time. One of the disputes that he helped to disarm was around the water rights between his own people, the Sakyas, and the Koliyas. And he went up there to help them overcome this argument. They were going to enter into some sort of war or something. And he simply asked them what was more precious to them, the water in the river or the blood in their veins.

There's a lovely little tale that goes with it where he asks the people who are the leaders, the warrior caste, what is the fight about? And they're not very clear. And then as he comes down to stratifying society, they don't quite know why they're fighting. They're just very angry. And they hate the Koliyas. And the Koliyas hate the others. And it's only when it gets down to the farmers that the farmers actually make it clear. "Oh, we're fighting over water rights." And I think that has a certain resonance for these days, exactly why we're fighting. There's only a few people actually know why we go to war.

There's another incident where, right towards the end of his life, where so much is happening. The king Ajatasattu wants to attack the Vajjian confederacy and sends an ambassador along to ask the Buddha whether in fact this was the right time to do it. It's a rather strange thing to do. And the Buddha actually gives him some directions as to what maintains a good society. And I thought I might just read out his things, which some of them, I think, make sense to us.

So he turns to Ananda and he says, "Ananda, have you heard whether the Vajjians hold frequent and well-attended meetings?" "They do, Lord." "As long as they do so, Ananda, they can expect to prosper and not decline. Have you heard whether they assemble in concord, rise in concord, and do their duty as Vajjians in con-

cord? Whether they avoid enacting the unenacted or abolishing existing enactments and proceed in accordance with the ancient Vajjian laws as enacted? Whether they honour, respect, revere and venerate the Vajjian elders and think they should be heeded? Whether they honour and respect and venerate the Vajjian shrines both in the towns and country without allowing the lawful oblations hitherto given and made to lapse? Where the lawful protection, defense, and guarding is provided among the Vajjians for the religious?" Here you see Arahats.

So he's got these various ways in which he says that a community will remain strong. And when the ambassador hears this, he goes back and tells Ajatasattu that it's not quite the right time to attack them. So in that way he was able to undermine that. Later on of course through devious means Ajatasattu did actually attack and take over the Vajjian territory.

There's also this quite astonishing story when you think about it. Virudhaka became the next king after Pasenadi of Kosala, and he was the overlord of the Sakyan. And when Virudhaka wanted to marry into the Sakyan clan, the Sakyan thought that his caste was too low for them so they tricked him into marrying a lower caste. When Virudhaka found out about this of course he was utterly mortified and determined to attack the Sakyan and destroy them.

So the Buddha having heard this and knowing that he was out on his elephant went out and stood before him and was able to turn him back. And he did that a second time and a third time. And the fourth time – and this is something to record – when he was told the fourth time he'd gone out, the Buddha said he could do nothing. And it seems those people were attacked and the city was destroyed and they moved Kapilavatthu.

Now this has, I think, a teaching for us these days because of our understanding of being engaged in society and how much you can do, and being aware of the circle of power we have and the circle of influence. And that once we touch the edge of those circles, there's nothing more you can do. So any frustration, any disappointment, any despair about the situation, which you can't do anything about, is actually unnecessary and is coming from some other centre, which is not being, shall we say, humble about oneself. Like, what can I do? So anything else after that, one has to simply accept. It's part of what you might call our social *kamma*, for want of a better phrase. So the Buddha's, he's done his best. He's been out there three times. And when the fourth time comes, he says he can't do anything. And that's the end of it.

Now, towards the end of his life, there's all sorts of things happen. Ajatasattu, this king, kills his father, starves his father to death so that he can take over the kingdom. And he's supporting Devadatta, whom I'm sure some of you know. Devadatta was the monk who decided that he should lead the order. And there's a lovely passage here where he approaches the Buddha: "Lord, the Blessed One is now old, aged, burdened with years, advanced in life and come to the last stage. Let the Blessed One now rest, let him dwell in bliss in the present life. I will govern the *Saṅgha* of *bhikkhus*."

And the Buddha's reply: "Enough, Devadatta, do not aspire to govern the *Saṅgha* of *bhikkhus*." And so he rebukes him. Devadatta then of course, as I'm sure you know, tries to kill him. He sets the elephant, Nalagiri, to rage upon him. And there's a lovely story where the Buddha, as the elephant's coming towards him, just actually offers his loving kindness towards the elephant, and the elephant actually stops before him, sucks dust from his feet, and blows it over his body, his own body, not over the Buddha's.

And the other story is of course he rolled a boulder down a hill which caught the Buddha's big toe and made it bleed. So Devadatta has really bad press. But actually if you think about what he was trying to do, then in a sense one can understand what was happening. The Buddha, remember, his early life as an ascetic had been quite basic, living under tree roots, living off rag robes, only taking what was in the bowl to eat. Very, very basic life of a beggar.

And as the order grew, and there were invitations to come into the families, to food, to be served food by his supporters, he was given monasteries with rooms and carpets and things like that. And you can understand that Devadatta, and it would seem quite a few monks at the time, just thought the whole thing was getting very soft. And so he comes with these 60 men, you see, that they live only in the forest and not live in villages. That they eat only from arms round and not go to houses. That they only wear robes that are made from the rags from dead bodies. That's what they used to get them from. That they lived at the root of a tree and that they were vegetarian and not meat-eaters.

And what this brings us to is, you know, the Buddha's feel for not being fundamentalist, not being rigid, recognizing that within any society there has to be some sort of latitude, there has to be some sort of give and take.

When he starts the order, he doesn't seem to come from any ideal. He's not sat down and thought, "Now, you know, what sort of order do I want to create?" There were the basic rules of those times of how you should live if you had left

the lay life and undertaken what became of the *brahmacharya*, the holy life. So he was simply following the customs of the day. As people said to him, "Well, you know, we'd like to join you, we'd like you to be our teacher, our guru," as they would say. He said, "Well, do likewise."

So for 20 years, such were the quality of people who joined him that there wasn't any need to create a rule. And then as people with less integrity, you might say, joined, then things began to get done which were against the customs of the day and he would make a rule about it. So the institution of the *Saṅgha* as it grew up wasn't something which came from an ideal, it just gathered this law as people did wrong, as people made mistakes and then he would make a rule. So eventually there came this body of law by the end of his life which constitutes the institution. And if you think about an institution, an institution has an aim and it has a body of law, the body of rules and regulations which hopefully make that aim possible.

So when he's instituting or when he's developing the *Saṅgha*, the only duties that he says that order members have is to study the Dharma and to practice *vipassanā*. That's the actual duties that a monk or nun have. There's actually no duty there to teach. And there came this complaint where the lay people had gathered on a full moon day where the Buddhist monks and nuns were gathered in a park. And that was the custom of the day, the full moon, very bright, very easy to see. And they would spend the moonlit hours discussing Dharma. That was what seems to have been the great custom of the day.

So they complained to the Buddha that when they approached his monks and nuns, they just sat there like dumb pigs. So then there came this rule that if you were asked a question of Dharma, you had to answer it. But it's interesting to know that that's, shall we say, something that the monastic does because of a response. So it's not within the tradition to go out and proselytize. One has to wait. One has to wait to be asked.

I wanted to, we have the idea of the Buddha being a very warm, compassionate, huggy-wuggy, touchy-feely sort of person. But I thought I'd read out to you what happened when somebody actually goes against the rule. Unless you've read the Vinaya, the books on the Vinaya, you probably won't have come across this. Now, the only one in this book, unfortunately, is to do with the first *Parājika*.

Now Suddina had left his wife because of his urge to seek liberation. But when he went back home, they cajoled and insisted that he cohabit with his wife to produce a child so that the family would continue. And falling for the argument, Sud-

dina does cohabit with his wife and she gives birth to a son. However, when the monks heard about this, they of course rushed to the Buddha and said, do you know what he did?

And so the Buddha brings him to him and I'll just give you a bit of the language so you can get a feel for him as, shall we say, well, the leader, you know, the tough leader. "Misguided man, it is unfitting, unseemly, improper and unworthy of a monk. It is unrighteous and must not be done. How can you not live out the holy life in complete perfection and purity after going forth into homelessness in the Dharma and discipline as well as proclaimed as this? Misguided man, have I not taught the Dharma in various ways for the sake of dispassion, not for the sake of passion? Have I not taught the *dhamma* for the sake of unfettering, not for the sake of fettering? Have I not taught the *dhamma* for the sake of relinquishing, not for the sake of clinging? The *dhamma* thus taught by me for dispassion, unfettering and relinquishment, you would conceive to be for passion, fettering and clinging. Has the *dhamma* not been taught by me in various ways for dispassion, for disintoxication, for curing thirst, for abolishing attachment? For severing the round of being, for exhausting craving, for dispassion, for cessation, for *Nibbāna*. Have I not described in many ways the abandoning of sensual desires, the full understanding of perceptions of sensual desires, the curing of thirst for sensual desires, the eradication of thoughts of sensual desires, the allaying of the fever of sensual desires?"

"Misguided man, it would be better for you as one gone forth that your member should have entered the mouth of a hideous venomous viper or a cobra than it should have entered a woman. It were better for you that your member should enter into a pit of coals burning, blazing and glowing that it should have entered a woman. Why is that? For the former reason, you would risk death and deadly suffering, but you would not, on the dissolution of the body after death, reappear in a state of privation, in an unhappy destination in perdition, even in hell. But for the latter reason, you would do so. Therefore, misguided man, by this act, you would pursue the Dharma's opposite. You would pursue the low, vulgar ideal that is impure and ends in ablution."

And he carries on like that, so you can see he holds no punches, doesn't mince his words. He's very clear about if you undertake the rule then that's what you do, you don't fall for arguments of this and arguments of that.

So, we also have to balance our idea of the Buddha as somebody who's very clear, very precise about the way he wants people to behave. Now, this *sila*, this conduct, which we've just chanted before, so the five basic ones, of course, are to do with our moral behavior. And what we have to really grasp is that our unethical behavior is a measure of our delusion. Delusion expresses itself in the way we speak, act and what we do. And therefore, whenever we do something wrong, it mirrors back to us the level of our delusion. And that's another reason why if you put your accent on making sure that what we do and what we think and what we say is wholesome and skillful, it comes back on the path and comes back to our understanding and our compassion.

So I think I've just got time for the last little bit here. I just want to, there's a lovely sweet little thing here which gives us a feel for those last days. So as he's approaching old age, you see, Ananda says to him, "It is wonderful, Lord, it is marvellous. Now the colour of the blessed one's skin is no more clear and bright. All his limbs are flaccid and wrinkled, his body is bent forward and there seems a change in the sense faculties of his eyes, ears, nose, tongue and bodily sensations."

And the Buddha replies, "Well so it is, Ananda, so it is. Youth has to age, health has to sicken and life has to die. Now the colour of my skin is no more clear and bright, all my limbs are flaccid and wrinkled, my body is bent forward and there seems a change in the sense faculties of my eyes, ears, nose, tongue, body and bodily sensation." So you get these little hints throughout the scriptures that he's also very much aware of his own dying.

There's a lovely little bit here I'd like to read to you. By this point, Ananda has been accompanying the Buddha for twenty years, tending to all his needs, protecting him from people, taking over when necessary. For instance, the Buddha had a bad back. In one talk he says, 'Listen, my back's really bad, can you take over my talk?' And since my back is bad, I have a direct feel for that aspect of the Buddha's life. I think that's probably where the similarity ends, but there we are.

So here we have poor Venerable Ananda, seeing the Buddha now coming to the end of his days. "The Venerable Ananda went inside a dwelling and stood leaning against the door bar and wept. "I am still only a learner whose task is not yet completed. My teacher is about to attain final *Nibbāna*. My teacher has compassion on me."

Then the Blessed One asked the *bhikkhus*, 'Monks, where is Ananda?' 'Lord, he has just gone inside the dwelling and is standing, leaning against the door bar weeping. "I am still only a learner whose task is yet to be completed. My teacher is about to attain final *Nibbāna*. My teacher has compassion on me."'

The Blessed One told the *bhikkhus*, 'Come, *bhikkhus*, go to Ananda and say to him in my name: the teacher calls you, friend Ananda.' 'Even so, Lord,' the *bhikkhus* replied, and they went to the Venerable Ananda and said, 'The teacher calls you, friend Ananda.' 'Even so,' the Venerable Ananda replied, and he went to the Blessed One. Paying homage to him, he stood at one side. The Blessed One said to him, 'Enough, Ananda, do not sorrow, do not lament. Have I not already repeatedly told you that there is separation and parting and division from all that is dear and beloved? How could it be that what is born, come into being, formed and bound to fall, should not fall? That is not possible, Ananda. You have long and constantly attended on the perfect one, on the *Tathāgata*, with bodily acts of loving kindness, helpfully, gladly, sincerely and without reserve. And so too with verbal acts and mental acts. You have made merit. Indeed, keep on endeavouring and you will soon be free from the taints.'

So now we come towards his death. As he's dying, he asks whether there are any more questions. All these monks have gathered around him, and no more questions are coming. Then, very sensitively, he says, 'Listen, if you have a question but you feel a bit ashamed about asking it, or you don't have the courage, ask somebody else to ask it for you.'

More silence follows, and at that point he decides to die — not before he's spoken his last words. Before he goes he says, 'Whatever is formed and compounded will dissolve. Work diligently for your own liberation.'

Whenever I read that I always ask myself, well, I wonder what my last words will be. 'Why me?' Something like that. I always remember in *Unforgiven* by Clint Eastwood, he shoots all these enemies and I can't remember the name of the actor, but his last words are, 'This shouldn't have happened.' I thought it was marvelous. And then there's the story of dear Oscar Wilde, who as you know became derelict at the end of his life and was dying in a room in Paris as a destitute. He hated the wallpaper. And it seems he turned to the wallpaper and his last words were, 'One of us will have to go.'

Going back to the earlier talk I gave: after the Buddha's death, a certain Brahmin called Moggallana asks Ananda, 'Is there any single monk who possesses in all ways and in every way those qualities that Master Gautama possessed?'

Ananda refuses to reply. But right at the end of this particular discourse, this is what Ananda said: 'The Blessed One was the arouser of the unarisen path, the producer of the unproduced path, the declarer of the undeclared path, the path-knower, the path-seer, skilled in the path. When disciples dwelling in conformity with the path become possessed of it, they do so after him.'

And that's really the position of the Buddha. I entitled these talks 'The Buddha as Archetype and Exemplar.' It can be heartwarming to begin reading the scriptures and to flesh out the Dharma — rather than four of these and four of those and all that — and to recognise that there was an actual human being who lived through this and came to this wonderful conclusion. With that recognition, there arises that lovely feeling of gratitude. And here you see this wonderful centre. It simply wouldn't have happened if 2,500 years ago this particular person had not made this breakthrough.

Finally, when Ananda says to him, 'Who are you going to leave to govern the order when you go?' the Buddha replies — and I may as well read the actual text — 'Each of you should make himself an island, himself and no other his refuge. Each of you should take the Dharma as an island, the Dharma and no other refuge.'

And how do we do that? 'Here, you abide contemplating the body as a body, ardent, fully mindful and aware, having put away covetousness and grief for the world. He abides contemplating feelings as feelings, contemplating consciousness as consciousness, contemplating mental objects as mental objects, ardent, fully aware, mindful, having put away covetousness and grief for the world. Either now or when I am gone, it is those, whoever they may be, who make themselves their island, themselves unto themselves and no other island, who make the Dharma their island and the Dharma no other refuge to themselves, who will be foremost amongst my disciples — of those, that is, who want to train.'

So his final instructions to us were that eventually we have to find that strength within ourselves. What we're doing here is finding a way — taking his teachings as a refuge, taking that Dharma as a refuge — to find for ourselves our own liberation. And that old teaching remains: the Buddhas only point the way, and that's all they can do. It's left to us to do the work.

So that brings me to the end of my sojourning through the Buddha's life. There's much I haven't touched upon — I had the whole incident around women joining the order written in my notes but skipped over it. I'm sure you've heard about all that before. The purpose, really, is to be inspired by his life and his teachings, and to make them our own.

I can only hope that my words have been of some assistance to you. May you be fully liberated even before you leave this centre.

CHAPTER 7

The Buddha as a Teacher

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 23 min

Originally given as *The Buddha as a Teacher* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this illuminating talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the Buddha's exceptional abilities as a teacher, focusing on his skillful methods of instruction and guidance. Drawing from the Cūḷamāluṅkyasutta (MN 63), he explores how the Buddha masterfully handled the monk Māluṅkyāputta's demand for answers to metaphysical questions about the eternality of the world, the nature of the soul, and what happens to a Tathāgata after death.

Bhante demonstrates the Buddha's characteristic teaching approach: first listening fully, then restating to ensure understanding, followed by Socratic questioning, and finally using powerful analogies—in this case, the famous parable of the poisoned arrow. This discourse reveals how the Buddha consistently redirected students away from speculative philosophy toward practical spiritual development.

The talk highlights how the Buddha refused to engage with questions that don't lead to disenchantment, cessation, peace, and awakening. Instead, he focused on the Four Noble Truths: the reality of dukkha (suffering and unsatisfactoriness), its origin, its cessation, and the path leading to that cessation. This episode offers valuable insights into both the Buddha's pedagogical genius and the practical focus that characterizes authentic Dhamma teaching.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā-sambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the Blessed One, the Noble and Fully Self-Awakened One.

I'm going to talk about the Buddha's extraordinary ability to teach. He was certainly a very charismatic person, but charisma alone doesn't make someone a good teacher. What made him a particularly skilled teacher was something more.

His usual way of discussing subjects was to first listen fully to what the other person was saying, then repeat it back to make sure they both understood. He would correct the person through a Socratic method of questions and answers. Once he had expressed his position, he would restate it clearly, and usually add a metaphor or analogy—because, as he would say, some people understand better that way.

Over the next few Buddha celebration days, I hope to take one technique after another and use a discourse to illustrate it.

This is the shorter discourse with Malunkyaputta. Malunkyaputta was the son of Malunkhya, who was married to a relative of the king of Kosala. He became a *samaṇa*, a wandering ascetic, and when he heard the Buddha speak, he took ordination under him. He didn't attain liberation, though, until he was very old.

Now, while Malunkyaputta was alone meditating near Savatthi in Jeta's Grove at Anathapindika's monastery, he found himself considering the subjects the Buddha would not answer. These were the metaphysical questions of the day. After much thought, he came to a decision: if the Buddha didn't give him satisfactory answers, he would lose confidence and leave the Sangha.

So in the late afternoon, Malunkyaputta came out of retreat and went to the Buddha. He bowed, sat down to one side, and told the Buddha of his thoughts:

"Venerable Sir, while I was alone in meditation, the following thought arose in my mind. These speculative views have been left undeclared by the Blessed One, set aside and rejected by him—namely: the world is eternal, or the world is not eternal; the world is infinite, or the world is finite; the soul is the same as the body, or the soul is one thing and the body another. And after the death of the *Tathāgata*—that's the Buddha—does he exist, or does he not exist? Or does the *Tathāgata* both exist and not exist after death? Or does he neither exist nor not exist?"

"Now, if the Blessed One knows the answers, then let him declare them to me, and I will lead the holy life under him. But if the Blessed One does not know, then it is simple for one who does not know, does not see, to say, 'I do not know, I do not see.' In that case, I will abandon the training and return to the lay life."

"Well now, Malunkyaputta, did I ever say to you, 'Come, Malunkyaputta, lead the holy life under me, and I will declare to you whether I have answers to these questions or not?'"

"No, Venerable Sir."

"And did you ever say to me, 'Venerable Sir, I will lead the spiritual life under the Buddha only if the Buddha will declare these things to me?'"

"No, Venerable Sir."

So now the Buddha makes sure they both agree as to what has been said. "So it seems to me that I did not say to you, 'Come Malunkyaputta, lead the spiritual life under me and I will declare these things to you.' And you never said to me, sir, 'I will lead the spiritual life under the Buddha only if the Buddha will declare these things to me.' In which case, you foolish man, who are you and what are you rejecting?"

"Now, if anyone should say, 'I will not lead the holy life under the Blessed One until the Blessed One declares answers to these questions,' they will still remain undeclared by the *Tathāgata* and meanwhile the person would die."

"Suppose, Malunkyaputta, a man were wounded by an arrow thickly smeared with poison, and his friends and companions, his kinsmen and relatives, brought a surgeon to treat him. And the man would say, 'I will not let the surgeon pull the arrow out until I know whether the man who wounded me was a noble, a brahmin, a merchant, or a worker; whether he was tall or short or middle height, whether the bow was long or a crossbow, what kind of feathers the shaft that wounded me was fitted with—whether those of a vulture, a heron, a hawk, a peacock, or a stork—and what kind of arrowhead it was that wounded me, whether it spiked, or razor-tipped, or curved, or barbed, or carved-toothed, or lancet-toothed.' All this would still be unknown to that man, and meanwhile he would die."

"So too, Malunkyaputta, if anyone should say, 'I will not lead the holy life under the Blessed One until the Blessed One declares on these questions,' they would still remain undeclared by the *Tathāgata*, and meanwhile that person would die."

"Whether such views are answered or not, there is still birth, there is still ageing, there is still death, there is still sorrow, lamentation, pain, grief and despair. And it is the destruction of these, right here and now, that I prescribe for."

"Therefore, Malunkyaputta, remember what I have left undeclared as undeclared, and remember what I have declared as declared. And why have I left them undeclared? Because they are not beneficial. They do not belong to the fun-

damentals of the spiritual life. They do not lead to disenchantment, to dispassion, to cessation, to peace, to direct knowledge, to awakening, to *Nibbāna*. That is why I have left them undeclared."

"And what have I declared? There is suffering and unsatisfactoriness. There is the origin of suffering and unsatisfactoriness. There is a cessation of suffering and unsatisfactoriness and there is a way leading to the cessation of suffering and unsatisfactoriness."

That is what the Blessed One said, and the Venerable Malunkya-putta was satisfied and delighted in the Blessed One's words.

So this discourse shows us how the Buddha generally taught by first listening and then probing and then finally stating his teachings and his use of metaphor. He would not be drawn into hypothetical, metaphysical or speculative discussions. They were simply not conducive to the spiritual aim of liberating oneself from *dukkha*, suffering and unsatisfactoriness. The Buddha tells us there is a limit beyond which reason and logic simply cannot go, and which can only be transcended and realised by direct experience.

Finally, the reason he refused to answer questions about himself—what happened to him after he died—was that these questions invariably arose from some idea of a self that would either exist or not exist, exist and not exist, and neither exist nor not exist.

I hope this little talk has been of some assistance, that it has not caused confusion. That by your careful practice and reading you will be liberated from all suffering sooner rather than later.

CHAPTER 8

Faith

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 48 min

Originally given as *Faith* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines faith (saddhā) as one of the five spiritual faculties in Buddhism, drawing on the Abhidhamma's analysis of consciousness to explore faith's three essential components: understanding, emotional involvement, and will. He carefully distinguishes between faith as trust and confidence versus belief in mere statements, using practical examples from climbing mountains to medical treatment to illustrate how genuine faith operates in daily life.

The talk explores how spiritual faith develops through hearing the Dhamma, personal reflection, and direct experience through meditation practice. Bhante discusses the famous Kālāma Sutta's teaching against blind belief, emphasizing the Buddha's instruction to test teachings through personal experience. He addresses common obstacles to faith including intellectual pride, spiritual despair, and unrealistic expectations, while explaining how faith becomes unshakeable wisdom (bala) upon reaching stream-entry (sotāpanna).

Drawing from classical commentaries, Bhante illustrates faith's purifying effect on consciousness and its essential balance with wisdom (paññā) in meditation practice. The talk concludes with practical guidance on nurturing faith through spiritual friendship (kalyāṇamittā), ethical conduct (sīla), and understanding impermanence (anicca), making this teaching valuable for both newcomers and experienced practitioners seeking to deepen their commitment to the path.

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble, and fully self-enlightened one.

I thought I'd give a little talk around faith, which in the Buddha's understanding is fundamental. Nothing happens without faith.

I read a rather nice little essay on it by Nyanaponika, whom some of you might know — a very famous German monk who started the Buddhist Publication Society in Kandy. He didn't write all that much himself, but what he wrote was influential. His main book, *The Heart of Buddhist Meditation*, still remains a classic on meditation.

The way I'd like to tackle this is through three constituents of an act of consciousness. I'm drawing from the *Abhidhamma* here, but actually it should be pretty obvious to us. Not being too specific about one act of consciousness, but in a series, shall we say, of consciousnesses: you always have the intellectual part, the cognitive part, the understanding. There's always some affective part, your emotional involvement. And for an action, there has to be an act of will.

It's interesting — just a little aside — that if you look at the way Buddhism grew, it was very much a cognitive effort. The Buddha's teaching is very much about understanding first of all, and from there everything flows. But that became too rigid, too dry perhaps, so the next wave through Mahayana raised up *karuṇā*, raised up the heart to the level of *paññā*, wisdom. *Karuṇā* and *paññā* became equal. And if you go over to the Far East, to Japan, their centre is very much in the *hara*, the will. A samurai. Just a little aside. Nothing to do with faith.

So these three things I want to look at from the point of view of faith. But before we do that, I have to make one big distinction between faith and belief. A belief is faith in a statement. If you say there is no God, or there is a God, that's a statement which, in effect, you can't prove either way. If you believe it, then it comes under belief rather than faith. When we're talking about faith this evening, we're concerned with an attitude: trust, confidence. That's what we're talking about.

To give us some idea of what we mean by that, we can take a few ordinary things that demand faith. Suppose you decided to climb Everest. There would have to be these three things, wouldn't there? You'd have to understand what the actual path up Everest means and what it might take. There has to be that understanding. There has to be the desire to get up there, doesn't there? You might read about it and think that's very interesting, but have no desire to go up Everest. And you might have a good understanding of what it's going to take, you might have an incredible desire, but somehow you just can't get your boots on — and that's the lack of will. Lots of times like that in our lives, isn't there?

Somebody came to see me, and she was in quite an upset state because she was convinced she had throat cancer. She had no trust in her doctors, so she wouldn't even go for a biopsy on the grounds that she didn't trust them. As we discussed it and looked at what other options were open, it finally began to show that what was really undermining her faith wasn't to do with the doctors or the profession at all — it was the fear that she might actually have throat cancer. That underlying fear was, as it were, translated into a lack of faith. I think in this case she actually did eventually go.

If you think of anything you have to do with doctors, you have to have a primary faith that their diagnosis is correct and that the medicine they prescribe is correct. In the old days you would have just had blind faith in the doctor. My parents wouldn't have ever argued with a doctor. If the doctor said this pimple on your nose is a dreadful cancer, they would have believed it. It wouldn't have occurred to them to question the diagnosis. These days we're a bit more argumentative. We want to know why and what happens. Recently I went to the doctor with a tinnitus which had just arrived out of nowhere. She said, I'll send you for a blood test. I said, a blood test? I had to squeeze out of her why she was sending me for a blood test. I won't tell you.

This whole business of taking medicine, of going for an operation — you've got to have that trust in the surgeon. Take another thing we do in our lives: a job. If you're taking on a job, especially one you know will stretch you, then there have to be these three elements. First, you've understood what the job is asking you to do. Then there has to be that attraction to the job, a desire to do it. And finally, you've got to sign on the dotted line, or else it just doesn't happen. That's the commitment, the act of will. Sometimes what stops us is that doubt — can I do it, can I do it? So you can see that the opposite of faith is doubt. There's something that stops you from that commitment.

And if we take another example: forming a relationship or getting married. This takes us into the realm of a more intimate human relationship where your trust is in this other person. They're not going to abuse you or take advantage of you. Take all your money. There's got to be that trust. And again, there is that knowledge that comes from knowing the other person long enough, the confidence that arises with that. Then, of course, that special love one has in that sort of relationship. And eventually, there's got to be that movement towards yes, yes.

These are just little examples which we now translate into the spiritual life. When it comes to the spiritual life, and specifically to Buddhism, faith is what the Buddha calls the spiritual faculty. Interestingly enough, he doesn't put it in with the factors of enlightenment. The presumption is — at least I presume — that by the time you're actually meditating, the faith must be there, at least some level of faith. The factors of enlightenment are put into the Satipaṭṭhāna discourse, the discourse on how to establish mindfulness or this awareness which leads us to awakening. But the five faculties are not there; they're talked about in other places. What's in that particular scripture are the seven factors of enlightenment. So when it comes to the faculty, it seems to me, faith is presumed.

All of you here now, whatever your level of commitment to the Buddha's teaching — the fact is you wouldn't be here if there weren't some faith already present.

If we go back to what faith entails, the cognitive part — the actual understanding — can be pointed out as three different stages. First, you hear the teaching, and that immediately arouses interest. There's also something stirring in the heart, a sense that this is the truth, an attraction. There must be some sort of attraction. Then, after you've heard it and read about it, there are reflections. The knowledge that was given — hearsay, read — now becomes your own personal understanding through your own reflections. And the more that happens, the more confidence arises, the more faith arises in us about the doctrine, because now in a sense it's becoming our way of thinking, our way of understanding. It's my way, not the Buddha's way. I'm slowly turning towards that.

But there's still that missing link between an understanding which is intellectual and the actual experience. It's all right saying that everything arises and passes away — there are very few people in the world who wouldn't grasp that. And when we turn inward and look around a little bit, we can see that thoughts arise and pass away, emotions arise and pass away, feelings arise. It's not a brain twister to go into that. But actually coming to the point where this I, this me, which feels so solid, is also arising and passing away — turning inward and really coming to terms with what transience actually means at a deeper level through our meditation — that now becomes, shall we say, a knowledge which carries into experience. But we would never have got there, really, without that initial confidence. That initial confidence.

When it comes to the heart itself, there's that feeling of trust — to trust somebody, to have confidence in, faith in somebody. And then there's a desire to devote oneself, a loyal service to the Dhamma, for as much as it feeds you personally. If

you're devoted to somebody, then you're there to actually help, please, make them happy. Think of a mother and father devoted to their children. That act of devotion is not just a lovey-dovey thing. It's part of that movement of the heart to give of oneself. A votary offering. It's an offering. And running along with that, there's love, which translates as a lightness, a joy in faith.

Once those two are there, there comes this point of commitment. And the commitment is at all different levels. It might be just the commitment to practise a bit of meditation. Eventually it's a commitment to actually follow the Buddha's path as your centre line — a total life's devotion to it.

For instance, when people take refuges and precepts — that's the normal way in all forms of Buddhism. The refuges are the Buddha, the Dhamma, and the Saṅgha. Then you take the five precepts, which is just your basic morality: not to kill anybody, steal, and so on. But the first part, the taking of refuge in the Buddha, Dhamma, Saṅgha, is an act of commitment dependent on the person. It might be that they are committed on a rather superficial level — that the Buddha's teaching is good, and it's part of my spiritual smorgasbord. I've got all this other stuff, and here's the Buddha's teaching over here, and I do a bit of that. That's fine.

As the teaching takes a more central position in your life, the commitment grows, to give oneself more to that teaching. But there still might be a holding back. It takes a long time to actually commit yourself to something, especially if you are converted to it. If you're born into a religion, born into a spiritual way of life, then it's just natural to you because ever since you woke up, you've been cajoled to make that sort of devotion. But for those who have come from other forms and come into Buddhism, it takes quite a long time before you ever get to that point — if ever, of course — that you actually commit yourself in terms of this life.

Now, you only get back what you give. If you give a bit of commitment, then you get a little bit back. If you give a bit more, you get a bit more back. And if you give the whole thing, then eventually you get the whole thing. It's like in a relationship: if you say, "Well, I love you a bit," and the other person says, "Well, I love you a bit" — and it slowly builds up until finally there's some sort of connection, which one can call a marriage in one form or another. That's the same with our relationship to the spiritual path.

And that commitment can't be forced. You can't say, "Oh well, I'm fed up with messing around now, I'm going to devote myself to the Buddha, Dhamma, Saṅgha." Not at all, because it's a movement within the heart. There just comes a time in a person's life when they make these little commitments, and so it grows, it grows, it grows.

As that happens, one gets the satisfaction of acts of commitment based on faith. Here's one way of putting it. This is taken from the commentary, but it also turns up in what's known as the Questions of King Milinda, which was written quite a while after the Buddha. It says: as a water-purifying gem of the universal monarch — he has seven of these, by the way — as a water-purifying gem of the universal monarch thrown into water causes solids, alluvia, water weeds and mud to subside and makes the water clear, transparent and undisturbed, so faith arising discards the hindrances, causes the corruptions to subside, purifies the mind and makes it undisturbed. The mind being purified, the aspirant of the noble family gives gifts, observes the precepts, performs the duties of the Uposatha and commences bhāvanā. Thus, faith should be known to have purifying as its characteristic.

So here we have the purifying of water, transparency. All you've got to think about is those times when your life has been full of doubt. Should you move house? Should you go for this job or that job? Should you go into this relationship or that relationship? In those times of doubt, as soon as there's a commitment, as soon as there's a decision and a commitment, all the stuff around that disappears, doesn't it? All that disturbance, all the doubt, all the fear — it just clarifies, it just disappears. That's what this is pointing to: an act of faith, or an act of taking refuge in Buddhist language, is that point where all doubts about how one should lead one's spiritual life begin to fade away. And one is clear. That's its effect on us.

Just a little bit more about the intellect and the affective, the emotional thing. If something is only intellective, if it's only an understanding coming from the mind and it doesn't have the force of the heart behind it, then it remains brittle, quite brittle, and it can easily be cracked by another argument. For instance, later on there's a question on rebirth. If a person thinks, "Well, you have to believe in rebirth to be a Buddhist and I can't really believe that," then the whole thing shatters. If faith is only at that sort of intellectual understanding — "This is okay, I understand it" and all that — but without the heart behind it, it's not going to really penetrate. It's not really going to have the effect of true devotion.

On the other hand, if it's only the heart, we have a different problem. Some people are drawn to the path simply by seeing a statue of the Buddha. I know people who, the moment they saw a Buddha image, fell in love with it. Something in their memory clicked and there was this heart connection, this leap of faith. But if that's not balanced with some intellectual understanding about what they're doing, then we would call that blind faith.

What happens then is an easy falling into belief systems. "I believe the Buddha is right; whatever the Buddha says, it's got to be right." And what that does to the practitioner is undermine their commitment to practice. If you believe the Buddha is right, then why prove it? The whole point of the practice we do — the *bhāvanā*, the *vipassanā* — is that question: Is the Buddha correct? Has he got it right? You're not saying that to yourself when you sit, I hope. But that's the underlying basis of the great doubt. This is not doubt as a sceptical thing. It's not coming from fear. It's coming from a desire to really know personally, as a personal experience, whether the Buddha's liberation is true. And whether once one gets to this point of *nibbāna*, there isn't in fact more. We might get there and think, "No, this isn't it. I've got to keep going." You don't know, do you? It's that sort of doubt — better translated as a wonder, a philosopher's wonder — which drives our meditation.

In your meditation, if you're just sitting there watching, looking — that won't do. That's called being lazy. There has to be a sense of curiosity. If that curiosity isn't there, just that simple question mark in the mind, a way of looking, then insight can't arise. The Buddha is quite clear about this: awareness is essential. Without placing attention on something, insight can't arise. You can't have insight without awareness. But on the other hand, insight won't arise unless there is that curiosity in the mind, that wanting to know.

So you have to have these two in balance. And of course when we say balance, there's no objective measure. You can't step on a weighing scale and say, "Well, I've got a bit of this and a bit of that." It's to do with the individual. Every person has to find that balance within themselves — an intellectual understanding alongside a commitment in terms of devotion, in terms of what their heart wants to do.

And it's just like we were saying about not getting your boots on. There can always be this lovely intellectual understanding. Some people read so much and can splurge it all out and quote *ad infinitum*. Sometimes they've got a good feeling behind it, but they don't practise. No practice at all. Don't do any meditation. Now

what stops them making that little effort to actually climb the mountain? It's the lack of will, the lack of commitment. Unless there's that too, there can't be progress on the path.

It's interesting that the Buddha places faith opposite insight in the five faculties — he balances them against each other. If there's no faith, if there's not that act of devotion to the practice, then insight can't come up. These two things are intimately linked.

Eventually, when we have an insight into the final goal — what's known as entering the stream, the *sotāpanna* — at that point faith becomes unshakeable. It's then known not so much as an *indriya*, which we translate as faculty; it becomes a *bala*, a strength. Now that faith is unshakeable because that person has actually seen the top of the mountain. They know where it is. It's no longer clouded. It's not that they can't see it — they've actually touched it. And now that faith, which is a strength, must necessarily draw them to the end of the path through the next few stages.

Until we have intuited this *nibbānic* moment, faith will always have a little shake in it.

This brings us to what undermines our faith, what undermines your commitment to the practice. The first we've already talked about: the confusion between faith and belief. You can very easily slip into that lazy place where you say, "Well, I believe the Buddha — what's the point?" And it undermines the practice. You've got to keep up that sense of curiosity, that wanting to know.

The Buddha laid this out very clearly when he visited the *Kālāmas*. It's a very famous discourse — everybody quotes it, so I may as well quote it myself. He ended up at the village of the *Kālāmas*, and they said to him, "We're in a state of calamity. Everybody who comes here tells us that this is what it's all about, this is the truth, and everybody else is wrong. Who are we to believe? Where are we to go?"

And he says: do not believe anything simply because you've heard it; simply because it is tradition handed down for many generations; simply because it is spoken and rumoured by the many; simply because it is found written in your religious books; simply on the authority of your teachers and elders. In other words, don't believe anything. Then he says, only when it works for you, only when

you've tried it out, only when it's something of benefit to you — only then would you commit yourself to it. So belief is something contrary to the Buddha's path as such.

The other thing we talked about was this balance between devotion — the heart — and understanding. This is from the commentaries: "For one strong in faith and weak in understanding has confidence uncritically and groundlessly." That's your blind faith. That's your gullibility. That's believing something. "For one strong in understanding and weak in faith errs on the side of cunning and is as hard to cure as one sick of a disease caused by medicine." Interesting, isn't it? We know about the side effects of drugs. One strong in understanding and weak in faith.

What he's saying here is that you can have such a good intellectual grasp of Buddhism that you actually believe you've experienced it. There's a total confusion between something clearly understood and something directly experienced. I knew of a monk who believed this of himself. He had an enormous, wonderful, deep grasp of the Dharma, and he was convinced that he must be a reborn stream entrant. In other words, somewhere in a past life — he had to believe this — he had intuited Nibbāna. How else could he have this amazing understanding of the Buddha's teaching? It's such an easy confusion for those with a very strong intellect.

The commentary then goes on to say that with the balancing of the two, a person has confidence where there are grounds for it. In other words, it's the balance we're looking for.

The other thing that undermines faith has more to do with self-expectation — the big one about self-doubt. Everybody can do it but not me. That sort of thing. And that can be a real barrier to progress.

There's a particular monk in the scriptures who becomes despairing of his practice and commits suicide. Fortunately, when the Buddha comes along and is asked, "What happened to this monk? Where's he gone?" he says, "Oh, he became enlightened in the process of committing suicide." Now, I'm not suggesting that, of course. In this case, it was a happy outcome. But I don't think there's a deeper despair than spiritual despair. To despair of somebody, to despair of your ability to have a relationship, to despair of your ability to earn money and live a good life — all these things throw people into suicide and jumping off bridges. I'm thinking

particularly of a young man in Australia who made — and remember this is a piece of news — an enormous amount of wealth on property. When that crashed in the mid-90s, he committed suicide.

But spiritual despair digs at the deepest level of our being, doesn't it? Because that's what the spiritual life is about. It's about being. It's about who we are at fundament. To have entered the spiritual path, to have seen the possibility of spiritual advancement and attainment and that end of suffering, and then to despair that one could ever achieve it — I don't think you can get worse than that when it comes to despair. It's existential despair at its most profound. So don't despair.

When self-doubt comes up like that, it can often be caused by over-expectation. You thought you'd be further along the path than you are now. There's pride involved in that, and a loss of self-esteem.

I met a man who told me that when he first came to meditation, he went to a course — this was back in the 70s — and he went to it as you would go to any old course of calligraphy or basket making or French. The idea was you got a jhāna, you got a certificate, and then you left. A week on how to attain Nibbāna. He entered thinking he'd have a go, and at the end he'd know Nibbāna and that was it. That's what he'd come for. Well, of course, as the course began to end, despair entered his heart. It took him a while to realise it wasn't that sort of course. And that's why you don't get certificates after meditation courses. Nobody hands you a certificate.

So, this expectation. Here's the Buddha: "I do not say that the attainment of profound knowledge comes straight away. Nevertheless, the attainment of profound knowledge comes by a gradual training, a gradual doing, a gradual course. How does the attainment of profound knowledge come? By means of gradual training, gradual doing and gradual course. As it is, one who has faith draws near. Drawing close, they sit down nearby. Sitting nearby, they lend an ear. Lending an ear, they hear the Dharma. Having heard the Dharma, they remember it. They test the meaning of things they have borne in mind. Whilst testing the meaning, things are approved of. There being approved of things, desire is born. When desire is born, they make an effort. Having made the effort, they weigh it up. Having weighed it up, they strive. Being self-resolute, they realise for themselves the highest truth itself, penetrating by means of wisdom." See? Stages.

Remember that all spiritual traditions warn us the spiritual path is full of deserts, dry places, empty places. It's surprising how many people, when they enter into that place, just begin to flag off and disappear, then reappear about

twenty years later. But those periods when you think you're not advancing are more important than those periods when you think you are. That's the slog, that's the dryness, that's the desert. You've just got to keep one foot in front of the other.

I use the image of the mountain. Mountains appear often in spiritual literature because they're so close to the experience of the spiritual life. The actual practice is extremely simple. To climb a mountain, all you've got to remember is you put one foot in front of the other and, generally speaking, go up. That's it, isn't it? You don't need any more instructions than that. Then, of course, there come all sorts of techniques and ways of handling certain situations. Stamina, commitment, yeah?

The worst thing you can do on a mountain, especially the higher you get, is to sit down and have a break that's just a wee bit too long. You start getting cold. You drink your last cup of tea. And that's it — you're on the way down then. So it's a case of that commitment, especially during those periods where you feel nothing is happening. It doesn't matter how long nothing is happening. You just keep going.

It's a testing time. You're looking at the loss of self-esteem, the feeling that you're not going anywhere — as if there was anywhere to go — a lack of success. All of it comes up, and it's the ego. So the dryness, the aridity of practice, is one of the most potent parts for getting rid of the ego. Usually it's the time when we give up, which is a sorrow, because it takes a bit to get up there. So don't worry about lack of success. Just keep doing the job.

Then of course there are the more obvious obstacles: doubt in the Buddha. Doubt in the Buddha has always felt to me, in a sense, slightly unnecessary. Because as you go along, there are signposts. You don't have to believe in Nibbāna. You don't have to believe in any of that stuff. The whole point about the Dharma is that it's immediate. You either benefit from it now or you don't. That's the point.

Now, when we're practising we might not see an immediate benefit right here and now in this present moment. Yet when we look back on our practice over a period of years, we can see that it's helped us to progress — it might even be the fundamental reason for our progression. So the doubt we have in the practice is undermined by not looking too far ahead. It's right here and now. If we can look back and think, 'Oh, this has been a benefit,' then we don't lose that sense of faith in what we're doing.

When it comes to the Sangha, that's really an extension of faith in the Buddha, because the Sangha is simply other people who've said they've actually attained the same thing. And the more people who say that, the more it gives others confidence.

Now, at least two of these three refuges have to be internal. Even at the end, when the Buddha actually becomes enlightened, as that doubt appears — is this it, or is there more? — that's when Māra attacks him with all the armies. That's how it's put in the mythology. And the Buddha touches the earth. You've seen the posture, the Bhūmisparśa posture where he's touching the earth. That was the point where he touched the earth as a witness, as it were, that he had attained the end of suffering. And the earth quaked and the earth goddess rose, wringing from her hair the water poured as libation to her by the Buddha in previous lives. That's nice, isn't it?

But when we actually take the refuge, it's not simply in that historical Buddha. It's the presumption that there's a Buddha within us, that there's something within us which is to be liberated. And that's what you're taking your faith in.

So when the Buddha is dying, Ānanda wants to know who's going to take his place, because Ānanda has this overflowing faith in the Buddha. And the Buddha's answer is that he mustn't take faith in him as a person, but take faith in the Dharma — the teaching itself, the practice itself.

'Ānanda, be an island unto yourself. Be a refuge unto yourself. Seek no external refuge. Live with the Dhamma — the truth, the law — as your island, the Dhamma as your refuge. Take no other external refuge.'

So eventually this is our journey. That's all the Buddha is saying. The usual quote is that the Buddha can only point the way. When we take these refuges, when we make that commitment, it's always a commitment to ourselves.

There was only one period in Buddhist history that I know of where there was a doubt that some human beings couldn't make it. It's a heresy, of course. These people who couldn't make it were labelled the Icchantikas. Icchantika means forever going on in the world of samsara — there was no ending to their rebirth because they were so stupid. But luckily that didn't take on. It remains as one of these little side schools. Some beings were really thick. They couldn't make it, even if they tried.

I must tell you, in Sri Lanka — and it's very strange to us — they can tell by the shape of somebody's head whether they're going to make it or not. Some monks can tell, and nuns I presume. The teacher at my own monastery, who was an excellent teacher, a direct disciple of the Maharshi, very strict, very demanding — he often wouldn't take on students, but he especially wouldn't take on certain students whose head wasn't quite right. I say no more. Maybe there are ways of telling things that we're not privy to. That's all there is to it.

So first of all, there's spiritual friendship. That's very important — to be with the right people. To be with people of like mind who are supporting you is obviously crucial. Ānanda says to the Buddha, 'I believe that good relationship is only half of the spiritual life.' And the Buddha says, 'Oh no, it's the whole of spiritual life.' When a meditator has a good friend, a good companion, a good comrade, it is to be expected that they will develop and cultivate the Noble Eightfold Path.

It's also important to be clear about one's training. If you're sloppy with your virtue, then it slips. It undermines your commitment to the path, because you can't separate insight from virtue. You can't have a Buddha who goes around robbing. Wisdom, when it expresses itself in action, is virtuous.

You have to be careful of your speech especially, it says. You must be energetic in abandoning what is unprofitable. Remember that every time you attend to something, there's an act of intention — and therefore conditioning. You have to be careful what programs you watch on the telly.

And finally, the understanding of impermanence. The more we understand impermanence, the more we develop what's known as *samvega* — that enthusiasm, that urgency. I mean, we haven't got that long, have we? So visits to the teacher, or to a centre where you can receive teaching, become all the more important.

Just as an aside: the group, the evening group, your local group — that's always a nice fillip. I always remember that making the effort every week to go across town and join a group had the effect of raising my energy for the whole practice during the week. And if I missed it, I could feel the lack of energy. So remember that the effort you put into practice is an attitude, and the attitude stays with you.

So I think that brings me to the end of my little homily. I'll leave you with a final refrain taken from the Sutta Nipāta. Faith, in the way that we've been describing it, is the best wealth to a person of this world. Well-practised Dhamma brings the most happiness. Truth is the sweetest of all tastes, and living with wisdom is said to be of the noblest kind.

CHAPTER 9

How to Critique the Dhamma and Buddha

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 42 min

Originally given as *How to Critique the Dhamma and Buddha* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this dharma talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the Buddha's radical approach to spiritual inquiry through the Kālāma Sutta (AN 3.65), where the Buddha explicitly tells followers not to accept teachings based on oral tradition, scriptural authority, logic, or even respect for the teacher. The talk begins with a fascinating categorization of five religious ideologies—from fundamentalism to universalism—before diving into the scriptural foundations of the Buddha's non-dogmatic approach.

Bhante explores how the Buddha encouraged the Kālāma people to test teachings against their own direct experience of what leads to wholesome versus unwholesome states. Rather than promoting skepticism for its own sake, the Buddha provides practical criteria: observe whether teachings lead to greed, hatred, and delusion (and thus to harm) or to their opposites (leading to welfare). The discourse reveals how the Buddha even submitted himself to investigation, outlining specific ways disciples should evaluate a teacher's conduct, consistency, and freedom from defilements.

The talk illuminates the Buddha's emphasis on mettā (loving-kindness) practice as the path recommended to the Kālāmas, and discusses the four assurances that come from ethical conduct—benefits that manifest both in this life and beyond, regardless of one's beliefs about rebirth. This teaching demonstrates the Buddha's confidence in the Dhamma's ability to prove itself through direct application rather than requiring blind acceptance.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa, Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa, Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-enlightened one.

I'm using this book by Bhikkhu Bodhi, *In the Buddha's Words*. It's a nice collection, and his translations are very clear and he's got good notes on it. The chapter I'm looking at is "Approaching the Dhamma", about stuff that I'm sure you've heard about: no dogma, no belief. But I thought we'd have a look at the scriptures on it.

Before we start, there's a little categorisation here which may be of small interest. There are five types of ideologies, for want of a better word.

A fundamentalist – we all know what a fundamentalist is. Basically they think theirs is the only true mountain, so you think you're actually climbing a mountain but really you're descending into a pit. That's their point of view. It's a case of "I'm right, everybody else is wrong." Obviously, there's going to be contradiction and conflict.

Then you get the relative fundamentalist who has respect for the traditions. They're all mountains, but my mountain is bigger and better. Whereas yours will stop short, mine will actually reach the ultimate goal. At some point, you've got to come across and join my mountain. That even happened to me in India with a Tibetan monk. He told me that the Theravāda path is all right, but if I wanted really to make it, I'd have to become a Mahāyānist.

Then there's a relativist. The relativist is in a sense acknowledging their ignorance of other religions. They usually say all mountains are equal but they're all different. And it's up to you. It's all relative, and there's no way of telling which is more true than the other. The only way realistically a person can decide whether your path is better or less good than their path is by actually doing it, actually reaching the end by some teacher in a path saying, "Yes, this is the end." And they said, "Well, hold on, I went one step further."

This is what happened to the Buddha, remember? He went along to these teachers and they all said, "Yeah, you've got it. We want you to teach, we want you to be part of our faculty." And he felt they hadn't quite made it and he left them. That was two teachers, wasn't it? And then there was the mortification stuff. That was also another path at the time, probably best exemplified by the Nigaṇṭha, the person who founded the Jains. Even that he found wanting – he just said it was more suffering.

Then there's the relativist universalist. This person says, well, if you look below the surface of culture and words, you find that actually all religions are on the same mountain, because eventually they're all saying the same thing. Although

each path is distinct and separate going up the mountain, you're always actually on the same mountain. You find that especially in this conjunction between Christianity and Buddhism. There's a lot of work done by a lot of people trying to connect them, trying to find a way, and there's books on it of course. Even Thích Nhất Hạnh threw his lot in, didn't he? What was it called? *Buddha*... But anyway, there's lots of these efforts, both at a very high theological level – when I say high, I mean academic – and at an actual practice level where a lot of Christians practise meditation. A lot of Christians practise *vipassanā*.

But I don't see it going the other way. I don't see much going the other way. In fact, I read an article about this, where the person was saying there was so much connection between Christianity and Buddhism, and that a lot of Christians were – I'm not putting a percentage on it, just a lot of Christians practised Buddhist things, but he hadn't seen Buddhists move over to things like belief in God and all that, and a practice of praying to God. If you don't believe in God, there's no point in praying to him. Anyway.

Finally, there's the universalist – not the relative universalist, like yours is equal. There's actually, I would say, the universalist who sees clearly that beneath all these rites and rituals, customs, cultures and all that, there are in fact just three ways. And that's the way of insight, the way of knowledge, the way of love, and the way of action. Usually they're all together.

If you look at the Eightfold Path, they're there. You start off with right understanding. You have right attitude, which is always described as selfishness to generosity, hatred to love, cruelty to compassion. Those are the three examples that come with it. And then you have, of course, right speech, right action, right livelihood. So you have those three ways in the Eightfold Path, but you can see that each religion does put an accent on one of the ways.

Buddhism obviously tends to be right understanding. A lot of its practices are about understanding things. There is the heart development, but if you were to categorise Buddhism, you'd put it in the path of understanding, I think, first of all. Because that was the Buddha's own path. You don't hear of the Buddha practising *mettā* before his liberation. I'm sure he did, but I don't know anywhere in scriptures where that's pointed to. It was more the jhānic thing based on the breath and these mortification things. Yet in his teachings, he obviously pushes *mettā*, he sees the importance of it. And there seems to be some hint somewhere – I'm working on it – where the Buddha says that *mettā* alone is a path of liberation. But I haven't got proper proof, scriptural proof of that yet.

The path of love — I think most of us would agree — is very much Christianity. It's a guru path, a relationship with Jesus Christ, and becoming like Jesus. As you know, I've been doing this walk with St Francis, the Camino St Francis. He's a very great example of that path. And then there's the fact that he received the stigmata. In Christian terms, of course, he was given that by Jesus or by God as a gift, even though it hurts and bleeds. But I think we would probably see it more as such a deep identification — such a deep identification through concentration — that the actual manifestation of Christ's body began to manifest in his own. We know the power of mind. That would make more sense to me anyway. So definitely the path of love.

But Christianity has also got the path of good works. And if you were thinking about good works, in a sense you'd have to look at Islam. Because Islam is very much about the will of God — the will of action, doing things. And of course it's exemplified mainly in their jihād. Muhammad said that the inner jihād was much more important than the outer one. But there's still the jihād — force, will, and all that.

So all these three paths you find in religions, but you get an accent one way or the other. And probably the most balanced — or at least seemingly so; I'm not sure about the good works side — is Hinduism. Hinduism has many saints on both sides: the bhakti, the devotional, and the insight path. I can't remember some of the devotional ones. Ramakrishna. But the insight ones — like Ramana Maharshi, who's very modern, and also somebody I really like, Nisargadatta Maharaj, Sri Nisargadatta Maharaj. His book, *I Am That*, I think is quite remarkable.

So that's a run through of the types as I see them. You can comment on that over the weekend. But what we're interested in now is how the Buddha explains this whole business about belief and no dogmas. And the main teaching I'm sure you've all heard of is the Kālāma Sutta. We'll just read it through, mainly to get the flavour of the discourse and the way things come across in the scriptures. It's formalised because it had to be formalised for the oral tradition. But you do get a feel for the sorts of conversations that would have gone on, and the Socratic thing where you're asking the person a question and they have to give you an answer. That's very much all the way through the scriptures.

Although the Buddha gives talks, he's very much in conversation, starting off with some problem that's been brought to him. He always steers the conversation to a point, to really find out what the person's opinion is, where they are. And then he tends to show the error of that. When they see the error of it, they're open

to his own understanding. Then he darts in with his own understanding, and lo and behold, for the most part, they all take him as their teacher. Not always. Some go away clicking their tongues.

So here's the Blessed One, and he's arrived at Kesaputta amongst the people called the Kālāmas. Now the Kālāmas of Kesaputta heard: 'It is said that the ascetic Gotama, the Sakyan son who went forth from the Sakyan family, has arrived in Kesaputta. Now a good report about the Master Gotama has been circulating. The Blessed One is an Arahant, perfectly enlightened, accomplished in true knowledge and conduct, fortunate, knower of the world, unsurpassed leader of persons to be tamed, teacher of devas and humans, the Enlightened One, the Blessed One.' So that's what we chant every morning. That's a basic formula.

'And having realised with his own direct knowledge this world, with its devas, Māra and Brahmā, this population with its ascetics and brahmins, with its devas and humans, he makes it known to others. He teaches a *dhamma* that is good in the beginning, good in the middle, and good in the end. With the right meaning and expression he reveals a spiritual life that is perfectly complete and purified.' So he's obviously got a very good reputation by the time he gets to the Kālāmas. That's quite a paean, isn't it?

Well, it says: 'Some exchanged greetings with him, and after greetings and cordial talk, they sat down to one side. Some saluted him reverentially and sat down to one side. Some remained silent and sat down to one side.' Then they said to him: 'Venerable sir, some ascetics and brahmins who come to Kesaputta explain and elucidate their own doctrines, but disparage, debunk, revile, and vilify the doctrines of others. But then some other ascetics and brahmins come to Kesaputta, and they too explain and elucidate their doctrines but disparage, debunk, revile and vilify the doctrines of others. For us, Venerable Sir, there is perplexity and doubt as to which of these good ascetics speaks the truth and which speaks false.'

Now here's the famous passage, you see. 'So it is fitting for you to be perplexed, O Kālāmas. It is fitting for you to be in doubt. Doubt has arisen in you about a perplexing matter.' So he agrees with them that they are in fact confused.

And then comes this very famous statement: 'Come, Kālāmas. Do not go by oral tradition, by lineage of teaching, by hearsay, by a collection of texts, by logic, by inferential reasoning, by reasoned cogitation, by the acceptance of a view after pondering it, by the seeming competence of the speaker, or because you think "the ascetic is our teacher." But when you know for yourselves: these things are un-

wholesome, these things are blameable, these things are censured by the wise, these things, if undertaken and practised, lead to harm and suffering — then you should abandon them.'

These categories really cover everything. We're talking about spiritual authority, scriptural authority — oral tradition, lineage of teaching, hearsay, collection of texts. That's where the fundamentalists place themselves, isn't it? They place themselves directly into their texts, into what the text says.

And then you get the four rational grounds: logic, inferential reasoning, reasoned cogitation, and acceptance of a view after pondering it. This is more the modern thing, isn't it? So you've got fundamentalists who will only look at the texts, and that's it. Even though they have a reason to it, they'll only accept what has been reasoned in the past. Fundamentalists are very much based in the past. Whereas the modernists — by that I mean people brought up in the European Enlightenment — really rely on their own rationality, their own logic. But even that you can't depend upon. You can't depend upon your own logical thinking, because remember, all logical thinking has to be based on a premise. If the premise is wrong, that's the end of it.

I think this touches on one of the doubts of present-day people: you can't believe anything, because beliefs in the past have caused such huge problems. Once you believe in a racist understanding, you end up with some form of Nazism. If you believe in the proletariat and all that, you end up with a form of communism. When the premise is wrong, the whole thing becomes quite nasty and evil. These days, of course, we're stuck with capitalist consumerism, materialistic capitalism — which is a world religion, really. And most thinking people know that its basis is greed. It shouldn't be there.

Then there are authoritative persons: impressive speakers and respected teachers. And that gives us our breakdown, really — it depends on your relationship to somebody. There's a later passage I'll quote concerning how the Buddha says people should actually find a critique about him. How do they know that he's fully liberated? He doesn't even let himself off the hook.

So then comes the conversation. Once he's cleared the boards and said, 'Look, don't believe anything,' he puts to them what is really a Socratic dialogue, asking questions and letting them answer. He's very basic, you see.

'What do you think, Kālāmas? When greed, hatred, and delusion arise in a person, is it for their welfare or harm?' 'For their harm, sir.' 'Kālāmas, a person who is greedy, hating, and deluded, overpowered by greed, hatred, and delusion, his thoughts controlled by them — will he not destroy life, take what is not given, engage in sexual misconduct, and tell lies? And will he not also prompt others to do likewise? Will that conduce to his harm and suffering for a long time?' 'Yes, Venerable Sir.'

So there you've got your basic precepts, your basic conduct — things you ought not to do. Sometimes we overstress that, because the whole point of being clear about what we don't do should make us clear about what we should do.

Then he really wants to drive it home. 'What do you think, Kālāmas, are these things wholesome or unwholesome?' 'Unwholesome, Venerable Sir.' 'Blameable or blameless?' 'Blameable, Venerable Sir.' 'Censured or praised by the wise?' 'Censured, Venerable Sir.' 'Undertaken and practised, do they lead to harm and suffering or not? How is it in this case?' 'Undertaken and practised, these things lead to harm and suffering — so it appears to us in this case.' 'It is for this reason, Kālāmas, that we said do not go by oral tradition.' And then he repeats himself.

Then, of course, he gives them the opposite. 'What do you think, Kālāmas? When non-greed, non-hatred, and non-delusion arise in a person, is it for their welfare or harm?' By actually negating it — by saying non-greed — he opens up all the virtues to do with non-greed: generosity, kindness, and so on.

By saying non-hatred rather than specifying something, he implies that where there's no hatred, there has to be the opposite. You don't live in a vacuum. And remember, with these qualities there's no middle ground. Sometimes people translate this as though there's some neutral state where you're neither generous nor greedy. But all he's saying is there's a state in which there's no greed. And because you're always in relationship, you must manifest some relationship — and that relationship depends upon the condition, the situation.

So when I walk into the dining room and sit down to eat with non-greed, there's also a right attitude to the food: to nourish the body, and so on. It's not as though he's saying there's a state of neutrality. Same with non-hatred — we're always in some position of love, some sort of connection. And non-delusion means that we understand. We're in a state of wisdom.

'Now, is that for his welfare or harm?' 'For his welfare, Venerable Sir.' 'Kālāmas, a person who is without greed, without hatred, without delusion' — here he translates it as 'without', you see, which makes it a bit more clear — 'not overpowered by greed, hatred, and delusion, his thoughts not controlled by them, will abstain from the destruction of life, from taking what is not given, from sexual misconduct, and from false speech. He will also prompt others to do likewise.'

That's an interesting one, you know. Normally the precepts are a very personal thing — taking precepts and keeping precepts are things that I don't want to do. But remember that we are exemplars. Wherever we go, we exemplify what we actually believe in. Maybe not in a pure, beautiful way, but we're there. So if you say to somebody, 'I practise Buddhist meditation and I'm a follower of the Buddha,' and next morning they find you in the gutter completely stupefied — well, it makes you wonder. They say, 'Oh, that's the Buddha's teaching, is it?'

'Undertaken and practised, will this lead to their welfare and happiness or not? How is it in this case?' 'Undertaken and practised, these things lead to welfare and happiness — so it appears to us in this case.' Then he repeats the points. And then he reinforces that by telling them how they should develop.

So he says: the noble disciple, devoid of covetousness, devoid of ill will, unconfused, clearly comprehending, ever mindful — see, that happens occasionally, doesn't it? — dwells pervading one quarter with a mind imbued with loving-kindness, likewise the second, the third, and the fourth. Thus above, below, across, and everywhere, to all as to himself, he dwells pervading the entire world with a mind imbued with loving-kindness: vast, exalted, measureless, without hostility, without ill will. And he dwells pervading one quarter with a mind imbued with compassion, and so on — with altruistic joy, with equanimity. He dwells pervading the entire world with a mind imbued with love, compassion, altruistic joy, and equanimity: vast, exalted, measureless, without hostility, without ill will.

Notice that he doesn't say, 'Practise vipassanā.' His advice to the Kālāmas here is to practise mettā. The word mettā has a specific meaning of love — we translate it as non-attached or universal love — but it's often used as a figure of speech, a metaphor. It's normally used to refer to the four illimitables.

Now he connects this with daily life, with the effect of practice both short-term and long-term. When this noble disciple has thus made his mind free of enmity, free of ill will, uncorrupted and pure, he's won four assurances in this life. The

first assurance is this: if there is another world, and if good and bad deeds bear fruit and yield results, it is possible that with the breakup of the body after death I shall arise in a good destination, in a heavenly world.

So it's kamma — kamma in the sense of your comeuppance. This was one of the Buddha's three knowledges at the point of his awakening, wasn't it? He saw that the driving force behind all his rebirths was his ethical decisions, his ethical life. He saw beings moving from one realm to another driven by the same force: ethical decisions. What had been a very personal law became universal through that understanding upon awakening. That's one of the things he understood: this connection between delusion, the ethical or non-ethical life, and how wisdom always draws you towards an ethical life. And the other way around — the more ethically you live, the more wise you must become, because the mind and heart are connected.

The second assurance is this: if there is no other world, and if good and bad deeds do not bear fruit and yield results, still, right here in this very life, I live happily, free of enmity and ill will. He often points to the fact that living according to the Dhamma has immediate results. It is just to be seen immediately.

The third assurance is this: suppose evil befalls the evildoer. Then, as I do not intend evil for anyone, how can suffering afflict me, one who does no evil deed? Now that's always a big problem, because evil, horrible things do happen to good people. I think you always have to read this from the point of view of kamma. And kamma, in terms of liberation from suffering, is always internal — it's always to do with dependent origination.

Just because you're the most peaceful, loving, compassionate, charismatic, booming personality in the world doesn't mean somebody's not going to hate you. In fact, you create a lot of jealousy in somebody, and they'll shoot you. Look at the examples — Martin Luther King, Gandhi, all these people going right back to Socrates himself. You always find that when the Buddha's talking about evil deeds or things happening to a person, you have to see it from the point of view of this inner kamma, the wheel of dependent origination. In other words, the atmosphere we live in.

Now, it doesn't mean the world doesn't mirror back to us our problem. If I'm angry and I happen to meet somebody who's angry and bigger than me, I might end up in hospital. But it's not so much that. When it comes to suffering, when it comes to liberation, it's always this internal thing. And I don't think we really grasp that until we realise that actually the world we're living in is being com-

pletely manufactured within me. Of course I'm getting information — photons and sounds coming in as air pressure and all that — but what I actually make of it is totally dependent on my perceptual faculties. And then what I make of that, the internal atmosphere I create — my emotional life and my thoughts — is again entirely dependent on something in me.

In meditation, when we open up to ourselves a little bit, we find there's all this stuff — leftover stuff. Smelly stuff, like a kitchen smells after lunch: leftovers of yesteryear and who knows, yesterlife. But it's understanding that which makes us understand this better. Because it's quite obvious that good people suffer from evil coming from outside them.

The fourth assurance is this: suppose evil does not befall the evildoer. Then right here I myself am purified both ways in this respect. In other words, just because the evildoer gets away with it — well, that's their good luck.

This does put a question mark on what I've just said, because here the Buddha seems to be suggesting that some of the evil that befalls us is a reaction from somebody else towards us. But obviously you can't talk about, say, an earthquake — if you get squashed by an earthquake, that's not your personal kamma. What is your personal kamma is how you've experienced the process of being squashed.

Before I move on, a word about reading the scriptures. You see this constant repetition of things. If you understand it as a way in which we absorb stuff, where stuff can be digested in the heart — remember that spiritual reading is different from reading for knowledge or reading for facts so you can present a good argument. It's really about being affected by something deeply. Just as you might read a poem or listen to some music and it really draws something out of you — you really feel it, great joy or sadness or whatever — so it is with these little phrases. You can take some of these phrases, and if one strikes you, you just keep repeating it, repeating it, until you get that sense of digestion.

So even this whole idea of tradition — do not go by oral tradition, lineage of teaching — and yet after you've understood something, just keep repeating it. It has an effect. Simply repeating something in the heart towards yourself produces this feeling of digestion, as though it's been absorbed. And then it becomes part of you — you don't get anything more from it. When you go back to the text later, you might find it has an inspirational effect on you again, and then finally it doesn't do anything at all because the effect has been complete. There's no need to keep going over it.

On a slightly different note, one of the things that had an enormous effect on me when I look back at it was Beckett's play, *Waiting for Godot*. It really did something. And for a while, every time I saw it, I would still get this feeling from it — this peculiar mixture of the complete senselessness of life and yet somehow the inherent humour of it. He has that quality in that particular play. But then, many years afterwards, I happened to see another production. I just saw it as a play. Beautifully acted and all that, but it had lost that zappiness. Whatever that play gave me at that spiritual level — spiritual meaning emotional, the whole thing — had been absorbed. I sometimes find that with poems, although some poems I read over and over again.

So here's the Buddha telling us how to approach the Dhamma, basically. Don't do anything until you've proved it to be true for yourself. Then there's a whole section here — I won't go over most of it, but I'll give you a hint — in which you have to investigate the teacher himself. He's putting himself up for investigation. And he addresses the monks, you see. By the way, the word 'monk' in all the scriptures refers to all listeners. It would be better to translate it as 'listener.' Anyway.

A monk who is an inquirer, not knowing how to gauge another mind, should make an investigation of the Tathagata in order to find out whether or not he's perfectly enlightened. So they should investigate me — that's what he's saying to them. And they of course say, 'We're rooted in the Blessed One, guided by the Blessed One, we have the Blessed One as our resort. It would be good if you could explain these things to us.' Then he says they should investigate the Tathagata with respect to two kinds of states: those cognizable by the eye and those cognizable through the ear. In other words, what you see of a person and what you hear. Although he's talking about himself, this is in a sense what we do with anybody, isn't it? You first of all see what they're doing and you hear what they're saying. He's asking people to watch him, to see how he behaves, and to listen to what he's saying.

In this way, they have to ask: is there any defilement there? Any defilement that's cognizable? In other words, is the Buddha doing something immoral, unethical? Or is there not? Is there no such state? Or is it more subtle — is it mixed? Like sometimes he's the Buddha and sometimes he's not. He's doing naughty things without telling us, you see.

Then he talks about whether cleansed states are found in the Buddha or not — through the eye or through the ear. These cleansed states cognizable through the eye are beautiful states, beautiful states of mind. Then he wants to know: has he

attained this wholesome state over a long time, or did he attain it recently? When the inquirer comes to know that the venerable one has attained this wholesome state over a long time, then he has a deeper faith in that person.

And then he investigates further: has this venerable one acquired renown and attained fame so that the dangers connected with renown and fame are not found in him? That's a common error, isn't it — people who become famous take on that sort of conceit or arrogance that comes with it? I'm not that famous yet, so... How does a person bear their reputation, really? Is the one restrained without fear, or restrained by fear? Does he avoid indulging in sensual pleasures because he is without lust through the destruction of lust, or is he just doing it out of fear? You've got to watch that as well. Is he putting it on, in other words?

Then he asks whether the venerable one dwells in the saṅgha or alone. While some there are well behaved and some are ill behaved, and some teach a group while others are seen concerned with material things and some are unsullied by material things — still the venerable one does not despise anyone because of that. In other words, although he's living with people of different virtues, he's impartial. He doesn't side with one or the other. That sort of impartiality.

And so: 'I am restrained without fear, not restrained by fear. And I avoid indulging in sensual pleasures because I am without lust through the destruction of lust.' These are signs of the Tathagata.

Then this is basically repeated, because he simply reinforces those positions we talked about. A disciple should approach the teacher who speaks in order to hear the Dhamma. The teacher teaches him the Dhamma with its successively higher levels, its successively more sublime levels, with its dark and bright counterparts. As the teacher teaches the Dhamma to a monk in this way, through direct knowledge of a certain teaching here in that Dhamma, the disciple comes to understand.

Finally, just to sum up the actual situation — and of course the proof is always in one's personal experience: when anyone's faith has been planted, rooted, and established in the Tathagata through these reasons, terms, and phrases, his faith is said to be supported by reasons, rooted in vision, firm.

It is invincible by any ascetic or brahmin or deva or Mara or Brahma or by anyone in the world. That is how, monks, there is an investigation of the Tathagata in accordance with the Dhamma, and that is how the Tathagata is well investigated in accordance with the Dhamma.

What he's saying here is that once we have that confidence in the teacher and follow the teachings, the description that follows is of one who has attained first path and fruit — a noble person.

The Buddha is very much in line with our modern way of approaching things: not having blind faith, really questioning, and always coming back to our own personal experience. But even there, there's danger — just because we've had an experience doesn't mean we've understood it correctly. It is of value to have it commented upon by somebody you feel has the authority to do so. I don't mean someone in authority — I mean someone who's an authority.

Very good. I can only hope that these scriptural readings and my commentary, shall we call it, have been of some use. May you, by your practice and personal experience, finally arrive at the gates of Nibbāna — sooner rather than later.

CHAPTER 10

Discourse to the Kālāmas

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 16 min

Originally given as *Discourse to the Kālāmas* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the renowned Kālāma Sutta (AN 3.65), often cited as exemplifying the Buddha's non-dogmatic approach to teaching. The discourse addresses the timeless question: how do we know what is true? The Kālāmas faced competing religious teachers, each claiming their doctrine was correct while disparaging others—a situation remarkably similar to our modern spiritual marketplace.

The Buddha's response was revolutionary: don't accept teachings based solely on tradition, scriptural authority, logic, or respected teachers. Instead, examine through direct experience whether teachings lead to harm or benefit. Using the concrete examples of greed, hatred, and delusion versus their opposites, the Buddha shows how we can evaluate teachings by their fruits in our lives.

Bhante Bodhidhamma explores the Buddha's emphasis on personal investigation over blind faith, connecting this ancient wisdom to contemporary challenges of discerning truth in our information-saturated world. The talk concludes with the Buddha's famous deathbed instruction to Ānanda: 'Take the Dhamma as your lamp, take yourself as your lamp.' This foundational teaching establishes the principle that ultimately, each practitioner must verify spiritual truths through their own careful investigation and experience.

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Samma Sambuddhassa
Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Samma Sambuddhassa
Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Samma Sambuddhassa

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble, and fully self-enlightened one.

There's a very famous discourse that people always quote to express the non-dogmatic way the Buddha taught. It's known as the *Kalama Sutta*, the discourse to the Kalamas. The question at its heart is: how do we know something is true?

Picture the scene. It's a time when all sorts of gurus and ideas are coming forward—quite an exciting little period, really. You're living in a small town with only a few thousand inhabitants, and these gurus keep turning up and telling you what for. They're all saying slightly different things and, of course, insisting that everybody else is absolutely useless. So you're stuck. Who's right and who's wrong?

Think of someone today who's been brought up in a non-religious family and suddenly becomes interested in the religious field. They go out in search—and I mean, it's colossal, isn't it? Where would you even start? This is, in a slightly lesser degree, the situation of the Kalamas. It's very modern in a way.

"Thus have I heard." Remember, all these scriptures were related by Ananda, the Buddha's assistant, and remembered by him. He had to repeat them all at the great meeting after the Buddha's passing.

On one occasion the Blessed One was wandering on tour with a large sangha of monks when he arrived at the town of the Kalamas called Kesaputta. Now the Kalamas of Kesaputta had heard: "It is said that the ascetic Gautama, the Sakyan son who went forth from the Sakyan family, has arrived at Kesaputta. A good report about that master Gautama has been circulating thus: that the Blessed One is an Arahant, perfectly enlightened, accomplished in true knowledge and conduct, fortunate, knower of the world, unsurpassed leader of persons to be tamed, teacher of devas and humans, the enlightened one, the blessed one. Having realized with his own direct knowledge this world—with its devas, Mara, and Brahma, this population with its ascetics and brahmins, its devas and humans—he makes it known to others. He teaches a Dhamma that is good in the beginning, good in the middle, and good in the end, with the right meaning and expressions. He reveals a spiritual life that is perfectly complete and purified. Now it is good to see such a worthy one."

Then the Kalamas of Kesaputta approached the Blessed One. Some paid homage to him and sat down to one side. Some exchanged greetings with him, and after cordial talk sat down to one side. Some saluted him reverentially and sat down to one side. And some simply remained silent and sat down to one side.

The Kalamas said to the Blessed One: "Venerable Sir, some ascetics and brahmins who come to Kesaputta explain and elucidate their own doctrines, but disparage, debunk, revile, and vilify the doctrines of others. Then other ascetics and brahmins come to Kesaputta, and they too explain and elucidate their doctrines while disparaging, debunking, reviling, and vilifying the doctrines of others. For us, Venerable Sir, there is perplexity and doubt as to which of these good ascetics speaks truth and which speaks falsehood."

"It is fitting for you to be perplexed, O Kalamas. It is fitting for you to be in doubt. Doubt has arisen in you about a perplexing matter." Now here comes the bit that's always quoted: "Come, Kalamas, do not go by oral tradition, by lineage of teaching, by hearsay, by a collection of texts, by logic, by inferential reasoning, by reasoned cogitation, by the acceptance of a view after pondering it, by the seeming competence of a speaker, or because you think 'the ascetic is our teacher.' But when you know for yourselves: these things are unwholesome, these things are blameable, these things are censured by the wise, these things if undertaken in practice lead to harm and suffering—then you should abandon them."

"Now what do you think, Kalamas? When greed, hatred, and delusion arise in a person, is it for his welfare or for his harm?"

"For his harm, Venerable Sir."

"Kalamas, a person who is greedy, hating, and deluded—overpowered by greed, hatred, and delusion, his thoughts controlled by them—will destroy life, take what's not given, engage in sexual misconduct, and tell lies. He will also prompt others to do likewise. Will that conduct lead to his harm and suffering for a long time?"

"Yes, Venerable Sir."

"Now what do you think, Kalamas? Are these things wholesome or unwholesome?"

"Unwholesome, Venerable Sir."

"Blameable or blameless?"

"Blameable, Venerable Sir."

"Censured or praised by the wise?"

"Censured, Venerable Sir."

"Undertaken and practised, do they lead to harm and suffering, or not? How does it appear to you?"

"Undertaken and practised, these things lead to harm and suffering. So it appears to us in this case."

Now he goes on to the opposite. "So what do you think, Kalamas? When non-greed, non-hatred, and non-delusion arise in a person, is it for his welfare or his harm?"

"For his welfare, Venerable Sir."

"Kalamas, a person who is without greed, without hatred, without delusion, not overpowered by greed and hatred and delusion, his thoughts not controlled by them, will abstain from the destruction of life, from taking what is not given, from sexual misconduct and from false speech. He will also prompt others to do likewise. Will that conduce to his welfare and happiness for a long time?"

"Yes, Venerable Sir."

"What do you think, Kalamas? Are these things wholesome or unwholesome?"

"Wholesome, Venerable Sir."

"Blameable or blameless?"

"Blameless, Venerable Sir."

"Censured or praised by the wise?"

"Praised, venerable sir."

"Undertaken and practiced, do they lead to welfare and happiness or not? Or how is it in this case?"

"Undertaken and practiced, these things lead to welfare and happiness. So it appears to us in this case."

"It is for this reason, Kalamas, that I said, do not go by oral tradition, and so forth."

And then he gives them this practice: "Then Kalamas, that noble disciple, devoid of covetousness, devoid of ill will, unconfused, clearly comprehending and ever mindful, dwells pervading one quarter with a mind imbued with loving kindness. Likewise the second, the third and the fourth. Thus above, below and

across and everywhere and to all as to himself, he dwells pervading the entire world with a mind imbued with loving kindness, vast, exalted, measureless, without hostility and without ill will."

And this he says also of compassion, altruistic joy and equanimity.

"When Kalamas, this noble disciple has thus made his mind free of enmity, free of ill will, uncorrupted and pure, he has won four assurances in this very life.

The first assurance he has won is this: if there is another world and if good and bad deeds bear fruit and yield results, it is possible that on the breakup of the body after death I shall arise in a good destination in a heavenly world.

The second assurance he has won is this: if there is no other world and if good and bad deeds do not bear fruit and yield results, still right here in this very life, I live happily, free of enmity and ill will.

The third assurance he has won is this: suppose evil befalls the evildoer. Then, as I do not intend evil for anyone, how can suffering affect me, one who does no evil deed?

The fourth assurance he has won is this: suppose evil does not befall an evildoer, then right here I see myself purified in both respects.

When Kalamas, this noble disciple has thus made his mind free of enmity, free of ill will, uncorrupted and pure, he has won these four assurances in this very life."

And then the usual ending: "Magnificent Venerable Sir, Magnificent Venerable Sir, the Blessed One has made the Dharma clear in many ways, as though he were turning upright what had been overthrown, revealing what had been hidden, showing the way to one who was lost, or holding up a lamp in the darkness so those with good eyesight can see forms. So now we go for refuge to the Blessed One, to the Dharma and to the Sangha of Monks. Let the Blessed One accept us as lay followers who have gone to refuge from today until life's end."

Very successful, eh? So let's just look at this, the main thing that he says. The first one he says is don't believe anything. Don't believe anything just because it comes from these things that are established by scriptural authorities or something coming from the past - so oral tradition, lineage of the teacher, hearsay, col-

lection of texts. So fundamentalists might be described as people who believe that the texts are infallible, that they are true records and that they have to be entirely and fully believed.

My brother-in-law believes that the whole of the Bible is the word of God, full stop. And you'll find people in the East who believe that all the scriptures are actually the word of the Buddha, I mean the direct word of the Buddha. Sometimes you can get the flavour of the Buddha's teaching coming through, but to say, you know, to make a statement that it's the actual words he spoke... but it gives them assurance that, you know, it must be right. Of course they don't recognise that the way they read it is their own interpretation. Putting that aside, they just take it for real.

Then there are the four rational grounds: logic, inferential reasoning and reasoned cogitation and the acceptance of views after pondering upon it. Now most people would think that if they'd thought something through it must necessarily be true. But we know from the history of our own rationality that it can lead you in a very strange place.

I mean, our 18th century enlightenment, which was about rationality, and probably its greatest product was the Declaration of Human Rights, also produced communism and Nazism, which were very rational doctrines. Remember, all rationality has to be based on a premise. And if the premise is wrong, then you're going to end up somewhere else. A lot of people would believe that just because they've thought something through, it must be therefore right. It's a dangerous one, eh?

So now you've got this real problem: how do you find out whether something is true or not? And on top of that, there's the post-modern understanding that all our truths are completely relative to the individual. Whatever's true for you might be true for you, but it's not true for me.

So you have these three ways of trying to decide what's true: what's given to us from traditions, what we can think about and rationalise and come to some understanding, and what's true for me. The Buddha simply says, well, go back to your experience. That's why he talks about something as concrete as greed, hatred, and delusion, and asks you: does this create harm or not? He's always going back to direct experience, using that as the basis for our understanding of what truth is.

Remember that when the Buddha was dying, Ananda asked him, 'Are you going to leave somebody to lead us?' And he said no. He said, take the Dhamma, the teaching, as your light, as your lamp. Take yourself as the lamp. The Dhamma, of course, is the tradition and all that, and the logic and all that. But eventually, I'm afraid, it's us. And if we get it wrong, it's only us that suffer.

I can only hope my words have been of some assistance. May you, by your investigation of this, arrive at that place of utter happiness sooner rather than later.

Premodern, Modern, Postmodernism and Buddhism

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 1h22

Originally given as *Premodern, Modern, Postmodernism and Buddhism* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines three historical approaches to truth and spiritual development: premodern society's reliance on revelation and faith, modernism's emphasis on reason and investigation, and postmodernism's focus on individual interpretation. Drawing from the Visuddhimagga's three character types - the person of faith (saddhā), the intelligent type, and the speculative type - he explores how each corresponds to different societal approaches to awakening.

The talk investigates whether enlightenment is possible within each worldview, examining figures like Cūḷapanthaka (the faithful practitioner) and Tucca Poṭṭhila (the intellectually gifted but inexperienced teacher). Bhante discusses the challenges Western practitioners face, often caught between rational inquiry and the need for trust in the Buddha's teaching. He explores the tension between the Buddha's encouragement to investigate everything personally (as in the Kālāma Sutta) while also emphasizing refuge in the Dhamma.

The discussion concludes by suggesting that balanced spiritual practice requires integrating all three approaches: confidence in the Buddha's revelation, rational investigation of the teachings, and personal experiential verification through meditation practice. This reflects the Buddha's own teaching method, which combined faith-based trust, Socratic questioning, and direct insight through vipassanā meditation.

This is one of the few times I'm going to give a talk about which I know very little. So I'm hoping for lots of comments, and that you'll reserve your tomatoes and eggs for the end.

I read a very interesting essay by a man called James Kurth, written for the Foreign Policy Research Institute in New York. He called it 'Religion and Globalization.' It suddenly pointed out to me the distinctions between a pre-modern, modern, and post-modern society—or should we say ethos. I began trying to think of it from a Buddhist perspective, to link it with spiritual practice.

I don't mean to confuse this with a comparison between different societies, as though one is better than another. I'm not talking about history or art or anything of that nature. All I'm doing is looking at certain ways in which these three societies see the process of enlightenment, and asking whether a Buddhist—somebody following the Buddha Dhamma, the Buddha's teaching—could actually become enlightened in any of them. That's the task.

Starting at the beginning with pre-modern society: that refers to what we know as the medieval ages. A pre-modern society depends upon revelation for its spiritual founts. It's a given. In both Islam and Christianity you have a given revelation which is then believed in, and because of the structure of dogma, you can only have very few people interpreting it. If you have too many interpretations, you start getting what later happens—a sort of reformation.

You have to control the power, and this fitted in well with the whole idea of Christianity at that time: establishing on earth a static society which would be ready for the second coming. It was actually during the twelfth century, thereabouts, that the idea began to arise that the second coming wasn't going to happen—or was going to happen in a different way.

What the medievalists tried to do was set up a society in which people knew exactly where they were. You had both the temporal and the spiritual, and it was very hierarchical. The serfs rising up through the lords, king, and finally the emperor. And in the spiritual realm, the ordinary punters down below, then the priests, bishops, and finally the pope.

It was never really a question of questioning the revelation itself. It was always the idea of supporting it, even when it didn't make complete sense. Tertullian, the great theologian, said that we believe because it is absurd. What he meant wasn't our sense of being ridiculous, but that it was beyond rationality—something you had to believe, full stop.

The spiritual path was totally dependent upon a practice which took that for granted. It demanded what we would call a certain faith, a certain blind faith—which gives it a wrong intonation really—an unquestioning faith. With that as your basis, you then either practised good works or prayer, and you would make sanctity.

I think the archetypal saint may be somebody like Saint Francis. A total belief, no questioning of the actual revelation as such, but a total giving of oneself to the practice. Even today you might say that somebody like Mother Teresa of Calcutta fits into that mould. When you hear her talk, there's no question that the revelation might not be true or anything of that nature.

What does that produce in terms of a teacher–student relationship? It's one of hierarchy, isn't it? The teacher is in authority as well as being an authority. He has authority over, and the student is one who listens and follows. There's no question about it. You don't question the teacher; the teacher knows. It's that sort of relationship.

There are character types in Buddhism based upon the three basic roots of greed, hatred, and delusion—greedy types, hateful types, and deluded types. The opposite of that, according to later commentary rather than the original scriptures, is the person of faith, the person of intelligence, and the speculative type.

Now, the one who is of faith shares with the person who craves the idea of wanting. But of course the wanting here is more skilful, more wholesome—they really want the Dhamma. Here is the description of one, taken from the *Visuddhimagga*, which is later medieval commentary.

"In one of faithful temperament, there is frequent occurrence of such states as free generosity, desire to see noble ones, desire to hear good Dhamma, great gladness, ingenuousness, honesty, and trust in things that inspire trust."

This describes the sort of person who is ready to submit, to give themselves to the teaching without question, based on that faith. And my experience with Eastern teachers is that that's really your relationship to them. If I were to ask one of my teachers a question as to why we are watching the breath at the nose, he'd be miffed. What do you want an explanation for? Just do it.

One of the great criticisms Eastern teachers had of Westerners was that they didn't have faith. What they meant was this unquestioning reliance upon a teacher. Now, you can imagine: if you're born into a culture, imbued with that culture,

and there you have a teacher in front of you—a monk or layperson, whoever—when they speak, they're part of that tradition. There's no idea of actually questioning them.

The danger, of course, is gullibility. You get led. So many Westerners who fall into the trap of the guru find themselves being led all over the place. Of course, they tell you in Buddhism, in the actual guru tradition of Tibet, that people take years to decide whether this person is going to be their guru or not. How true that is, I don't know.

But there is a type of Westerner who really wants that sort of relationship. Even though we've been through our wonderful Enlightenment and arrived at this amazing rationality, there's still a surprising number—surprising to me, that is—who actually just want somebody to tell them what to do. Just do this, do that, and I'll be happy.

To illustrate this utter faith in the Buddha's time, there was a man called Cūḷapanthaka. He had a brother called Mahāpanthaka, which means Big Panthaka. He was Cūḷa—lesser, a lesser Panthaka. His brother had joined the order and then asked his younger brother to join him. So his younger brother joined, and after four months he hadn't learnt a single verse of the Buddha's teachings. His brother said, you'd better get out. You've wasted time.

When the Buddha heard this, he went to see him and urged him not to leave. Then he gave him this exercise—some of you will know it. He gave him a piece of cloth and told him to wipe his face with it, keep saying "getting dirty," being aware of the change in the cloth as he's wiping it and looking at it. Remember, it's a hot country like we are now. He's wiping his face and he suddenly sees the quality of transience, of change, and he sees it to such a depth that he becomes enlightened.

He must have been ready. We can presume he did lots of training in his past life. But there he was, you see—a person not particularly bright, just open. Just open to the Buddha's suggestion without any question. And there comes that insight.

So what I'm saying is this: in a society where the truth is being expounded, to somebody brought up in a more rational way, you may be on a winner just having faith. I mean, if it is the truth, and you have faith and you do the practice, it saves a lot of bother, doesn't it? You don't have to read books, you don't have to argue, you don't have to ask questions—you just do it. So that's pre-modern.

Now, the rejection of that was modernism. The core of the modernist movement was the Enlightenment. And I suppose the glory of the modernist movement was the ending of slavery, the demand for equality amongst people, and the turning towards people, towards society as a measure of truth rather than revelation.

Reason—being able to reason with people and come to a reasonable outcome—was the mark of a modernist approach. Perhaps one of its glories is the United Nations Declaration of Human Rights, in which I'm pretty sure God is not mentioned. Revelation is not mentioned. It's a document which human beings have agreed upon totally through their rational understanding.

The downside, of course, was that rationality then became its own servant. It couldn't, shall we say, look beyond the rational. And as we know, anything which is rational is always based on a premise. So if the premise is wrong—no matter how wonderful the rationality, no matter how good the argument—then in a sense you're moving towards a peculiar situation. Communism, you know. Nazism, although Nazism had a romantic streak about it. So you can see how eventually people became disillusioned.

The other great gift of modernism, of course, was investigation—that opening of the universe to inquiry, our science, and eventually our technology. All these were products of the modern mind. I don't think the pre-modern mind could have done it because they weren't interested. What they were interested in was simply stabilising society.

Then there's the idea of progress. As far as I've read, I picked up this little bit of information about a monk called Joachim de Fiore, a Calabrian, who came up with the idea—and this is how the notion of progress crept into the West, the idea that we were going somewhere, that we weren't actually static. He talked about three ages: the age of the Father, which was the Old Testament; the age of the Son, which is the present age; and the age of the Spirit, towards which we're moving. Everybody will be saved. Here on Earth.

Now, in that sort of society—in terms of your spiritual development, that sort of ethos—the teacher takes a different role and the student has a different role. Here we have much more of a Socratic approach, where everything given to the student is understood to be questioned. It must become their knowledge.

I've tried to find somebody in the West who achieved some sort of enlightenment and who might have been brought up with that modernist outlook. Because with modernism, the whole of human effort came off the spiritual. The entire me-

dieval age was moving up towards the spiritual all the time—all the music, all the art, all the philosophy and theology was centred on Christianity, all facing up that way. With modernism, our whole effort sort of flattened out. It wasn't so much interested in the spiritual.

This relates to the second character type, which is translated as 'intelligent', though you'll see from the actual quote that it's not quite the intelligence we might expect.

"In one of intelligent temperament, there is frequent occurrence of such states as readiness to be spoken to, possession of good friends, knowledge of the right amount of eating, mindfulness and full awareness in task, in what we're doing, devotion to wakefulness, a sense of urgency about things that should inspire a sense of urgency, and wisely directed endeavour."

So here you get the impression that this person is constantly reflecting wisely upon their life. They're actually engaged. They're not there with a teacher who says, do this, do that. They're turning upon themselves as, in a sense, the source of their own wisdom. Not without the help of the teacher, because they go and visit people—'possession of good friends', 'readiness to be spoken to'.

Such a person has that inner reasoning to understand their own position and has confidence in it. In the scriptures, the Buddha is often in that sort of position where he takes on a Socratic role, asking: what do you think? He says, does everything arise and pass away? Yes, Bhante. If it arises and passes away, is that satisfactory? No, Bhante. It's all pretty simple stuff from our point of view, but it's there as a dialogue. He's not simply declaring that everything passes away.

There's an example of somebody the Buddha called Tuccha Potila. Tuccha means 'empty'. Now Potila was a teacher, somebody who was recognised and understood the Buddha's teaching. He could really talk about it. But he hadn't experienced anything. So the Buddha called him Empty—Empty Potila.

He got rather worried that the people he taught were all becoming enlightened while he wasn't. So, swallowing the bitter pill of humility, he went off to his students. They saw him coming and immediately saw this intellectual conceit. They thought, well, there's no way I can get through this. So they passed him on down the line, each saying, I'm not really the right one. And he ended up with a young seminarian boy, a little monk.

Again swallowing his pride, he followed this little fellow, who took him to an anthill. The boy said to him: if there are six holes in this anthill, and there's a lizard or a snake in there—if an anthill's vacated, in the East, lizards, sometimes snakes, live in anthills—how would you get the snake out? He said, well, you stop up five holes. And the little boy said, that's what you must do. You must stop up the five senses and observe the mind, observe the heart. Well, as the story always goes, in no length of time Tuccha Potila became one of the Arahats.

One of the actual straight contradictions you'll find people get into in Buddhism is this—especially on the monastic side—because what makes the monastic order is the rule. It's an institution, so it's the rules of the institution that make you a monastic.

I've come across this quite a few times in the East, mainly among Westerners. Easterners don't seem to have a problem with it. The logic runs like this: in order to be enlightened, you have to be pure of heart. But you can't be totally pure of heart unless you're fully enlightened. So people get themselves into this corner, and if they've been meditating for some time without breakthrough, they conclude it must be because they're not keeping the rule strictly enough. In other words, they're not pure in the rule. So they get tighter and tighter and tighter around it.

We had one case in Sri Lanka. An Australian fellow. He went back to the original texts and realised that the robes we're wearing now were not the robes the Buddha had started with all those many years ago. The top robe was just like a shawl you put over your shoulders when you went into a city—a modesty thing. Generally speaking, you just used the lower robe.

So he went to see a very famous teacher—some of you will know him—Ananda Maitreya of Balangoda. He died at 150. And he was a Bodhisattva. During one of his meditations at the monastery I was at in Kanduboda, as you progress there comes a point where some deep memory may arise, and he remembered being in the Buddha's time and making the vow to become a Buddha. So he was known as the Bodhisattva. He said he could remember the faces of Sariputta and Moggallana, the two main disciples of the Buddha, but he couldn't remember the Buddha's face.

Unfortunately, when you make that sort of determination in Theravada Buddhism—I don't know about Mahayana—it means you can't progress. You've got to keep building up your virtues until you're right on the point of enlightenment. And then, when you take your next rebirth, you have to do it all in that one go, in that one lifetime.

So this particular monk went to see him, and Ananda Maitreya agreed that, in fact, the original lower robe was just that. And the bowl was wrong too. If you've seen monks' bowls, they're pretty big. But in fact they're supposed to be quite small.

I had a little embarrassing moment over that. I was in India at Goenkaji's Centre in Dhamma Giri, near Bombay. We were lining up for food and with me there was a Jain monk. He had a bowl—very small, like that. And I made a rather foolish comment: 'Bhante, that's a very small bowl.' He looked at me and said, 'This is the size of my stomach.' And there I was. So I made this limp excuse about my bowl also being the place I put my robes in because it's my luggage case. He didn't look all that convinced.

And this particular monk turned up at the Kathina ceremony—the ceremony at the end of the rains retreat where monks have to stay in one monastery, and at the end all the lay people come offering gifts for what the monastery and the monks might need. He turned up with this twee little cape tied around his neck—looked like a bullfighter—and a biscuit-tin-sized bowl. The general opinion was that he'd gone mad. And he eventually drove himself out of the order.

So, rationality. But it would seem from the story of Tuccha Potthila that if a person is completely locked into a way of being in the world which is so totally rational, so totally conceptual, the problem isn't that they lack the intelligence to become enlightened. The problem is to evacuate that situation of intelligence.

One of the things that, for instance, Dzogchen does—we had Sogyal Rinpoche come down to Gaia House to give a retreat—one of the things he was trying to do was just so relax people, make them feel so happy, that with a couple of exercises this original mind would just pop out from that embeddedness in rationality. And the person might just realise their true self. We do it the hard way in Theravada. Sweat.

In the methodology that I personally teach, which is the Mahasi—my own particular practice too—we try to trick the mind by refusing to allow it to think about something, save in the simplest of concepts. We engage that intellect through a

noting technique—rising, falling—so when there's only one word there, at least there can't be a thinking about the object. At least there's only one, shall we say, concept between that intelligence and the direct perception of what it's trying to experience.

Then as the concentration grows, and the ability of that mind to stay absolutely within the present moment, there isn't time for thought—because thought's always an afterthought, always a comment. And by force of that practice and concentration, suddenly that intellect will just stop. Then you have that brightness of pure awareness. And hopefully, in no length of time, we join the Arahats.

So now we come to postmodernism. I haven't a clue. I've read little bits about it. As far as I understand it, postmodernism is a rejection of modernism. Actually, historically speaking, the first rejection of modernism was Romanticism. It was people like Rousseau and Wordsworth and all our poets who went back to feeling and sensual experience, took that as the basis of truth, not thought. 'I think therefore I am' became 'I feel, I sense, therefore I am.'

The problem with Romanticism, of course, is that it couldn't accept the present. It looked back into the past for its inspiration—the noble savage, the Garden of Eden. And in the present day, certain feminists look back to a matriarchal age as having been better than a patriarchal one. There's a reaching into the past, a nostalgia.

I read somewhere about 'deep ecology' going back to hunters and gatherers. But the idea of running around with a dog pelt around your privates chasing rabbits didn't particularly appeal.

What happened with Romanticism was that there was no particular practice to go back to. It expressed itself more in terms of art. I don't know whether it produced anybody you might look to as a spiritual figure as such, although it was spiritually directed.

As Romanticism faded, the reaction to it—but also in a sense a reaction to pure reason—was Idealism: people like Hegel and Fichte. The bits I've read of these philosophers, they definitely had a very highly tuned idea of the growth of consciousness. It seems to relate in many ways to Buddhism.

But I think the downfall for those people was that they didn't have a practice. The philosopher Fichte told his students to face a wall, become aware of the observer, and then become aware of that. That doesn't sound so bad actually. But it was all very heady—wonderful ideas, very inspirational—yet there was no practice to it. So it seems people got fed up with that.

Then, of course, modernism really took hold. And that's where we ended up with the Second World War and all that. So after the war, after communism and all that, we have this other modern strain of rejection of modernism, which we call postmodern.

I don't know whether you'd agree with me, but the crucial position for a post-modernist is interpretation. Before, it was revelation—truth was out there, it was given. Then it was we, as rational beings, conversing to come to understand the truth together. Since both of those have failed, I'm now reverting to me.

So I am now the fount of my own truth. And you are for you. And if we don't agree, that's fine—what's true for you is true for you; it doesn't have to be true for me. We move towards a sort of absolute relativism. There's no objective truth at all, just what's true for you. So Noddy is as important as Shakespeare, because it depends where you are.

There's no objective reality. I read an article which said that the 9/11 collapse of the Twin Towers put an end to postmodernism, because from a societal point of view there was no doubt that something objective had happened. It was through this postmodernist thinking that people could undermine the idea that there was ever a Holocaust—because it's your take on reality, your narrative. That's the word, isn't it? Your narrative. A society builds up its own narrative for its own purposes, and once you catch that in fact there's no objective truth to it, then of course it collapses as science, as truth.

In society, it's very strange. When I went to Gaia House, it was a very strange place for me because I'd always been brought up in modernist societies, and the Order is almost pre-modern really in many aspects—in terms of its authority structure. But when I got to Gaia, I found there were these centres of authority making decisions without others knowing. It was all very strange. Things happened.

Just recently, for instance, a huge armchair arrived in the lounge and the executive manager didn't know about it. This big thing just appeared and she looked round—I was in the room with her. What happens is that since I am now the

centre of authority, we're all centres of authority, and when a society has no centre, you can do what you do because it's right for you and I can do what I do because it's right for me, and you've no right to stop me at all. It's a sort of movement towards anarchism in its absolute true sense.

A friend of mine told me about a lovely postmodern situation they found themselves in. They'd been invited to a meal with two friends and went to this couple's house—he and his partner. After the meal, they were sitting in the lounge enjoying the postprandial discussions and all that, when the lodger, a woman, came down and started doing yoga right there in the nude. They said to her, 'Is this appropriate?' 'Well, you do what you do and I'll do what I like.'

It's that 'me generation' mentality. I've noticed at Gaia that anybody in their thirties is very different from somebody in their fifties. In their fifties, you'll still get people talking about responsibility. In their thirties, they're talking about rights. My rights. It's weird.

So living in that sort of community, you tend to get people who are very fierce about their position, trying to come to a consensus. And the problem with consensus is that if everybody has a right, then everybody has a right to veto. Even though seven people say they'll do it, if one person says no, you've had it. You can't move. So they come to an agreement that nobody has an actual veto—they can have a majority rule, I think.

We went out for a walk, a few of us, heading to a riverside that somebody said was absolutely beautiful—we'd have a picnic there. On the way, over a dell, down in the bottom we came across a very delightful little stream, and one of the party said, 'I want to stay here.' See? Everybody else said, 'Well, we were going over there.' 'No,' she said, 'this is where the group begins to control the individual.' That's what she felt—controlled. So we said, 'Well, fine. You stay here.' Then we had to share the food, and she ended up with the orange juice. We had to do without it because we'd brought it all in one bottle. Wonderful.

I've got a lovely description of postmodern art that gives you an idea: 'A rejection of a consistent, coherent aesthetic in favour of a playful, eclectic style which draws on many sources.' In other words, the artist feels free to use whatever they want, however they want. And often, as I'm sure some of you have experienced—especially with very modern art—the artist is really looking to symbols which make sense to them but don't have that objective aspect, that position where other people can relate to it.

It's Eliot who said art was 'objective correlative.' I have an experience, I want to relate it to you, and I choose an object through which we can make that communication. Now if I choose an object which is meaningless to you but full of meaning to me, the communication stops. Although the artist could argue, 'Well, you should make the effort to come towards me, to try and understand this symbology.'

So now we have the problem of the role of the teacher. You can see that in this framework there can't really be a teacher. Because if a teacher says to you, 'Listen, I think you ought to...'—like they're saying, 'Your meditation's not so good, and it's because you're not working on this particular...'—the student will reply, 'Well, that's true for you. But that's not the way I see things.' How do you get anywhere with that sort of relationship?

And the student, of course, feels an authority unto themselves, only taking little bits from what they want from different traditions, building up their own eclectic style. You've all come across those, eh? A bit of yoga, a bit of tai chi, a bit of vipassanā, a bit of Dzogchen. Get it all in. And you decide what you're going to do. Unless you're very, very spiritually inclined, unless there's a clarity in your mind, you end up with quite a lot of confusion in your spiritual practice.

Now in these character types, there's what's called the confused or speculative type. Here's the description:

'In one of speculative temperament, there is a frequent occurrence of such states as talkativeness, sociability, boredom with devotion to the profitable, failure to finish undertakings, smoking by night and flaming by day, and mental running hither and thither.'

The 'smoking by night' is planning and scheming. 'Flaming by day' is running around doing. That's the speculative type—and perhaps also open to scepticism because of that. It's an inability to commit yourself entirely to a particular way or path because you've only got your own reason, your own particular experience to go on. You're not prepared to put faith either in a person or in a tradition, either in revelation or in somebody else's guidance. So there's a huge danger there.

And yet, we have in Buddhism this idea of a Paccekabuddha—a 'private Buddha.' What it's saying is that some people become enlightened but can't teach. There's a hint that people become enlightened in other forms, in other traditions. But this is the kernel: they can't teach. That's very postmodern, isn't it? This

person has made their way through their own paths. And in a sense, because it's not part of a tradition, because they've ended up in their own private way—how far they can't teach, I don't know, but it says they can't teach.

One of the amazing things about the spiritual scene these days is the arrival of these independently enlightened beings: Rajneesh, Krishnamurti, and more recently the flavour of the month—Eckhart Tolle, Andrew Cohen, Ken Wilber, Adi Da. Interesting, isn't it?

These people, of course, do have a teaching. And if you read their stuff, they've obviously had some experience—but not within a particular tradition. They might have touched upon a tradition, but they've had something peculiar to them. And then somehow they do have a following. But I dare say there are some people who are enlightened but simply can't get it across, or maybe don't even want to. Just happy being enlightened. I'd be that.

There are two occasions where the Buddha is talking to Ananda that are relevant here. The first is when he's dying, during his last few days. Ananda's getting a bit worried as to who will lead the order, so he asks the Buddha whom he will appoint. Now, his two main disciples had already died. Sariputta died shortly before the Buddha's own death, and Moggallana was murdered by thieves on some path or other. So the two to whom he might have handed on his leadership were gone.

But the Buddha's response is: I'm not going to leave anybody. You should live as islands unto yourselves, being your own refuge with no one else as your refuge. That's very postmodern, isn't it? But then in the same breath he says: you should live with the Dhamma as an island, with the Dhamma as your refuge, with no other refuge. Now that's revelation—his revelation to the world. That's very pre-modern, isn't it?

Then there's another occasion where Ananda is walking with him. He seems to be doing this all the time. Ananda always says to him, I think I've understood this, and the Buddha says, no, he doesn't. It's humorous really. On this particular occasion Ananda says, in my opinion, half the spiritual life is good friendship, good community. And the Buddha says, oh no, the whole of the spiritual life is good companionship, good community. In other words, to be with people who can, as it were, balance your own views. Which suggests a very modern approach.

And when you couple that with the way he would teach—this Socratic way—you can see he's also got the modernist perspective in there.

There's also the Kalama Sutta, which is almost a declaration of free thought—which is a declaration of free thought. The Buddha turns up at a village, at the Kalamas, and they complain. They say, look, this guru comes along and he says this, and then the next guru comes and says, well, he's a load of rubbish, this is what the truth is. What are we supposed to believe?

And the Buddha goes through a whole list of things: don't believe something just because it's tradition, because it makes sense rationally, because somebody with great authority has said so, and so on. Only believe it when you've experienced it as being true for yourself.

Now the last thought I had was this: whenever society or we ourselves make one of these three things the be-all and end-all of our spiritual practice—whether it be the written statement or revelation, whether it be reason, or whether it be my own personal experience—it always subordinates the other two.

If you're going to believe in what the Buddha said, then reason is subdued, it goes out the window almost, and your own self goes out. If you say you've got to be reasonable, then there comes an undermining of faith in the revelation. And if you put yourself first, you've almost undermined everything, because you yourself become the centre of authority. So if a person is deluding themselves into a belief, it's very difficult for them to get out of that little box they've put themselves into.

It's only when we have something which, shall we say, reaches beyond the revelation, the rationality, and self, that we might be able to get this balance of the three. So there's the Buddha's word, which is a touchstone. There's our reasoning. And there's our own personal experience. And that personal experience can only come through actual practice, not through thought—through a basic personal practice.

This is the way the Buddha actually puts the growth of wisdom. First of all you gain wisdom by what you've heard. Then as you take that wisdom in and think about it, it becomes your understanding, your own thought-understanding. But it's still at the thought level. It's only when you turn to the practice and directly experience wisdom—the truth that the Buddha is talking about—that it becomes vipassanā, which is, in my opinion, the insight knowledge.

So I suppose it's a case of not leaning too heavily on any of these three things: the Buddha's word, rationality, or oneself as a central authority.

Buddhist View of Christ's Teaching

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 29 min

Originally given as *Buddhist View of Christ's Teaching* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this reflection, Bhante Bodhidhamma shares his spiritual journey from Roman Catholic seminary student to Buddhist monk, offering a unique Buddhist perspective on Christ's teachings. Drawing from his intimate knowledge of both traditions, he explores how Jesus's seemingly paradoxical instructions—to 'sell everything' and 'hate father and mother' while commanding us to 'love one another'—align with the Buddha's core teaching on detachment.

Bhante examines the Buddhist understanding of non-attachment not as callous indifference, but as the foundation for genuine compassion. He illuminates how detaching from our identification with body, emotions, and thoughts liberates the awareness within us—what he calls the 'Buddha nature'—allowing for unconditional love that isn't dependent on the object. The talk culminates in a mystical interpretation of Christ's words 'I am in you and you are in me,' suggesting these point to the same transcendent awareness that Buddhist meditation reveals.

This accessible yet profound exploration offers valuable insights for practitioners of any tradition interested in the universal principles underlying spiritual awakening, demonstrating how the deepest teachings often transcend religious boundaries.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa — Homage to the blessed, noble, and fully self-enlightened one.

Just so you're sure I'm not coming in from a completely blank space: I was brought up as a Roman Catholic. My mother was Italian and my father was English. They met when he came up from Africa in the RAF and was billeted in her home. He fell immediately in love, though I think she took a bit more time. On his

side, going back to his maternal grandfather, that man came from Milan and his wife was Irish. So here I am, an Italian Irish Catholic. You can't get more Catholic than that.

My experience of Catholicism is very different from some experiences I've heard from people of my generation, mainly because of my mother. The whole centre of my Christian practice was the love of Jesus. I knew full well that if I missed church on Sunday and unfortunately died before I could get to confession, I would definitely spend an eternity in hell. But that was never particularly stressed. It was always the love of Jesus. So I was very devotional as a young boy, and I must have been a rare young boy in that I actually enjoyed going to Mass.

This manifested later, around the age of eleven or twelve, as suddenly having a vocation to become a missionary priest. I joined a junior seminary run by the Society of the Divine Word, near Birmingham, and spent four years there. When I think of the regime and the training I had, I can't imagine any modern kid even coming near it. We were up at six o'clock in the morning, out in the cold doing exercises, back in for Mass, then breakfast, then an hour of clean-up, and only then did school start. After school there was another religious gathering, followed by one hour off for games. That was it. The rest of the day was spent in silence.

Interestingly enough, I look back upon the first two years as the halcyon days of my life. I was extraordinarily happy — in a continuous state of ecstasy. Then unfortunately, puberty entered. If I could have stayed as a thirteen-year-old, I'd have been happy for the rest of my life. After that, something shifted. The practice — and this is why I wanted to start with Vipassanā meditation — was really much to do with what we would call *samatha*, the development of the beautiful mind. It's done through imagery, through repetitive prayer, where you can lift the heart into a lovely ecstasy.

Think of very empowered business people, how they lift themselves up to tremendous energy. From the moment they wake up to the moment they fall asleep, they're right there on that plane of existence. They never drop; they just keep going, going, going — always up, up, up, and get, get, get. That's what happens when you can train yourself to lift your heart into a beautiful ecstasy. It will remain with you all day. Even if people say something rude to you, it doesn't affect you; it just comes off like water off a duck's back. Nothing can touch you because the heart itself is lifted into this lovely state.

Once that period had passed, I left and went to sixth form, then on to college. Then something happened that, as always, slightly amazed me — something quite peculiar. I was lying in bed on a Sunday morning, and I said to myself, "I wonder what will happen if I don't go to church." Remember, this is hellfire we're talking about. Nothing happened by the end of Sunday, nothing at all, and I never went again. Just like that. Having been consistent with all my practice, I lay in bed and asked, "What will happen if I don't go to church?" Nothing happened, so I never went again. People talk about guilt, especially in Catholicism — Holy Mother Church and how could you leave. But there was no guilt, no sorrow, no nothing. It just cut like that.

I spent the next ten years looking like a hippie, but actually I was an existentialist. I didn't know what it meant, but it felt good to be an existentialist. I thought, well, I wasn't a nothing — I was an existentialist. It just felt so much better than being a socialist. It launched me into hours of discussion and talk.

As life has it, it comes with its tribulations, and having hit a very low point, I sought some help. At the time, Zen Buddhism was in the air — this was back in the mid to late seventies. I wrote to the Buddhist Society, and eventually, through this and that, I ended up going to a Zen Buddhist meeting held not very far from where I was living, in Birmingham.

I remember Vajra, whom I look upon as my spiritual mother, inviting me in. Her instructions were very simple. In Zen you sit facing the wall — because of Bodhidharma, which is what I'm called. I'm named after this particular figure; I'll come to that in a bit. You sit facing the wall, and she said, "Just sit here and watch whatever arises, whatever comes up." That was it. Those were the instructions. None of this watching the breath, none of what I've done for you now. Just sit here and watch whatever comes up.

By the end of that forty minutes, I just knew this was going to get me out of my problems. I had that intuitive feeling that this was the path that would get me out of my emotional state. And over a period of time, that's exactly what happened.

I stayed with Zen Buddhism — there's a monastery up in Northumberland — for three years, and then became involved with the Theravāda type of Buddhism, which you find in Southeast Asia: Thailand, Burma, Sri Lanka, those sorts of places. It was in that tradition that I met my teacher of this particular practice I've taught you, who was a disciple of the Mahāsi Sayādaw, a very famous teacher

from Burma. Shortly after that, after a bit of a struggle, I decided to spend three years in the order to develop meditation. It's been twenty years; I've just not been able to get out. I only joined up for three, and here I am.

The reason for telling you these little things is that one of my struggles was to accommodate what I had learned in Christianity into my Buddhism. It wasn't a case of saying the past was all rubbish and I didn't want anything to do with it. Within my heart there's always been this very intimate connection with Jesus Christ — I developed it for the first fifteen years of my life, for heaven's sake — so trying to deny that would have been ridiculous. I had to come to terms with it, to find an explanation for the teachings of Christ through this new prism I'd found in Buddhism, which had worked for me.

Of course, I reminded myself that in the early days, Christianity had worked for me too. The form I'd been given actually provided the basis for all the spirituality that came afterwards. First, a clear moral understanding of life. Second, an understanding that there was an interior life. These days, so many people have no idea what religious emotions are. No idea whatsoever. They confuse it with rock music and stuff like that.

On that basis, when I came to Buddhism and found it was investigating this whole phenomenon I call myself — this psychophysical organism — I had to meld the two together. I had to move them from what felt like contradiction to what felt like complementarity.

So the first teaching I'd like to point to is the story of the rich young man who comes to Jesus and says, "I've followed the law perfectly. What must I do now to enter the kingdom of heaven?" And Jesus' reply is, "Go sell everything you have and give to the poor, and you will have treasure in heaven. Then come and follow me." Go sell everything — in other words, give everything up.

He then goes on to say something else, in a different gospel — the first is in Mark, the second in Luke — something very hard for us to take: "If anyone comes to me and does not hate their father and mother, their wife and children, their brothers and sisters, yet even their own life, they cannot be my disciple." That's pretty heavy, isn't it?

If you remember, there's one point where — I can't remember the details, I'm sure you'll remind me — Jesus says to his mother, "I have no mother." Now the fact of the matter is that he had a mother. So what was he saying? What did he mean by "I have no mother"? What does he mean by saying those who hate their father and mother? What does he mean by giving up everything?

One of the core teachings of the Buddha is around detachment and what detachment actually means. In the meditation here, I asked you to catch how you were relating to what was arising — how everything you perceived as pleasant, you were moving towards and trying to develop. Even if you didn't catch it in your meditation, just consider how you gravitate towards a cup of tea. And what it feels like when there is no tea. Can you imagine waking up in the morning and finding there's no tea in the house? That's pure misery. So that attachment, that gravitation, that holding on to things — what are we actually doing? What are we doing when we say, "I have to have my tea"? Clinging on to relationships — my wife, my children, my family. What are we doing?

In Buddhist understanding, we're seeking happiness right there. That's what we're doing. We're investing in something phenomenal, something arising and passing away, and demanding that it make us happy. The problem is that when you attach like that, when you demand something like that, anything in this phenomenal world is going to let you down. Because the first thing I asked you to notice was that everything is arising and passing away.

So the Buddha's statement on "go sell everything you have" would be this: there is nothing in this world worth holding on to. That's what the Buddha's commentary on Jesus' words would be.

Now, in his lifetime, if you know the story, the Buddha comes to what I would call an existential crisis. He gets to the age of twenty-five, mid-twenties, when most people recognise that youth is over and they'd better start taking life more seriously — get married, get a job, and the pension comes a bit later. In that seriousness, the Buddha's own experience is put in mythological form. He's been guarded from certain realities of life, and he's out hunting on three occasions. On each occasion, respectively, he sees somebody who's very sick, like a leper; somebody who is very, very old and crotchety and hardly able to move; and a corpse. Each time his question is, "What is this?" And he's told, "This is a human being. This is what happens to people." Then he asks the crucial question: "Does this happen to me?"

So here we have the existential crisis. And it was with this that he left his wife — his child was just born. Some people think that's very, very selfish, but then a man's got to do what a man's got to do. He leaves his child, cuts his hair off, goes to the river with his assistant Channa and his horse, his lovely horse that he loves — Kanthaka — who loves him back. Remember the Rubicon? It's all mythological. He crosses the river, cuts his hair off, throws all his robes and finery away, puts on rag robes. And his horse is so upset he dies of grief. Then the Buddha spends his years training.

So here you see: "One who comes to me and does not hate their mother, hate their father, wife." If you define the word hate as some sort of negativity towards these people, then I think you've misunderstood the teachings of Christ. I've read somewhere that this is a very strong Jewish way of saying to be detached. To be detached — in other words, not to find your happiness in that other person.

This whole process of letting go — if you get into Buddhist circles, you come across these little pat phrases: letting go, let it pass, don't own it. When you were in yourself in the way I instructed a minute ago, you were detached. That's what the Buddhist understanding is.

Most times, when you feel depressed, what do you say to yourself? You say, "I am depressed." So how are you going to get out of that? "I am depressed." That's it. All you can do now is get depressed about being depressed. Then you get angry about being depressed, and you get afraid of being depressed, and it spirals down, and you end up on Prozac.

But if you were to sit inside yourself as I instructed, and you notice that there is depression — not "I am depressed," but there — then of course you don't have the reaction of being depressed about being depressed. You've discovered a place within yourself that cannot be touched by depression.

The same applies to pain. In the sitting posture, you might have got some discomfort, or perhaps you've got a headache. Instead of saying, "I have a headache" — owning the headache — you immediately form a relationship of attachment. But if you sit there quietly and feel the sensations of your headache — there's the headache, there — that which is actually experiencing the headache comes to understand that it itself does not have a headache.

These are very deep insights. There is something in us that experiences directly everything we call ourselves as a human being — our sensations, our actions, our feelings and emotions, our thoughts and our images — and yet which isn't that. So what is it?

If that within us is not the body, if it's not the heart with its emotional states, if it's not thought, then it is detached from the very psychophysical phenomena we call a human being. This detachment is often confused with being some sort of callous, unregarding, unlovable way of being. Yet when you discover that position of being with your body, heart and mind, you begin to realise you can now use it, as it were — you can have a relationship with it that is kind, generous, compassionate. And yet, because you're detached, you're no longer upset by what it's actually doing.

So if this body is something that this within us inhabits — we might call it something like the Buddha nature — when the body gets sick, there's a compassionate movement towards it. Why fear it? Why should you fear the sickness of the body when it's not you?

And when an emotion comes, why should you be so concerned about it when it's not you? Somehow this detaching is a process of liberating ourselves. That's exactly what the Buddha means by detaching, and that's exactly what we mean by Nibbāna.

Nibbāna translates as unshackling. What is it that's being unshackled? What is it that's being liberated? It's that within us which knows, which experiences. And once we develop this attitude towards ourselves, we develop the same attitude towards others.

So at the end of this period, I'll do a loving-kindness meditation. The loving-kindness meditation, or the meditation of goodwill, is taking what we feel about somebody we like. It's easy to love somebody you like. So you take somebody you have a warm relationship with anyway, and then you keep displacing that image — first with people you hardly know, then with all beings — so that this love we're developing is not dependent on the object standing before us.

Whoever is before me, if I was doing this practice properly — whether it be somebody I know intimately, somebody belonging to my own family, somebody I've never met in my life, somebody who stinks, or somebody who hates me — I

still have that attitude towards them. That attitude of love, compassion, sympathetic joy is what we mean by detached joy. It's not attached to the object. It's an attitude developed within our own hearts, not dependent on the object.

Now, to get to that level, you've got to go and sell everything and hate your mother and father. So do you have to do that? If you take these words literally, then you're really going to have to sell everything. And if you take the word hate literally, then you're really going to have to hate.

But it's not that at all. What Jesus, from the Buddhist point of view, is pointing to here is forming a completely different relationship to the things you own, and a completely different relationship to the people you relate to. The underlying movement in the philosophy behind it all is this: whatever happiness is, you're not going to find it in the sensual world. And you're not going to find it in somebody else.

Other people can't make you happy. When you grasp that, you'll stop demanding that they do so. And it feels very liberating on those people around you, I can tell you.

Now I want to get a little bit more mystical. The third quote was, "My commandment is this: to love each other as I have loved you." That stands in stark contrast to "hate your mother, hate your father." You're not going to understand this love business unless you understand clearly that other statement about hating your mother and father. That's what I was pointing to.

Those two statements go together. "If anyone comes to me and does not hate their father, their mother, their wife, their children, their brothers and sisters, yet even their own life, they cannot be my disciple." But "my commandment to you is this: to love one another as I love you." If you can get beyond that paradox, you've understood the true message of the spiritual life. And you'll find that in every religion through its mystics.

Let me go a bit deeper. There's this commandment. Jesus says, "I and the Father are one. I am in my Father and you are in me and I am in you." Now, this was the real struggle I had. Remember that in Catholicism, the host at Mass is changed into the veritable body of Jesus Christ. The bread is the body, even though it's under the species of bread. It tastes like bread and everything, but actually it is the body. And the wine is actually the blood — even though it tastes like wine, it is actually the blood. This, of course, is the separation of substance from attributes.

That really just didn't make sense to me. If I wanted to give you a critique of that from one of the greatest philosophers of the human race, it would be Nagarjuna, who in a sense brought metaphysical philosophy to an end. He simply states: if the substance of a thing is different from the attributes, how do you know it exists? Because the only way you know something exists is from its attributes — whether it's hard or soft, whether you can see it's yellow or blue. And then he says: if the substance and the attributes are the same, why make a difference? This problem around substance and attributes is a philosophical problem.

Jesus says, "Unless you eat my body and drink my blood, you cannot enter the kingdom of heaven" — something like that. "Eat my body" — and of course people were disgusted and they all walked away. Then just before his passion, he instigates this ritual, which is, to my mind, the loveliest of rituals you'll come across in any religion: the sharing of the bread and the wine. He says of the bread, "This is my body, take of this," and of the wine, "This is the blood I shed for the new covenant."

He's equated flesh and blood with bread and wine. And he's always referring to himself. I struggled with this for a long time, and it was only because I visited a friend of mine, an elderly Sri Lankan man — and I must tell you, in truth, I went there for toast. While I was eating my toast, I was able to have long conversations with him about this business.

For him it wasn't a problem, because he was brought up a Catholic and then became a Hindu. He accepted all the stuff that Catholicism had taught him in that mystical way, in the way of metaphor. It was funny how long it took for the penny to drop. The key was this: every time Jesus Christ talked about himself, he was actually talking about the phenomena that we call Jesus — meaning the body, heart and mind that you've just been looking at. That was where my confusion lay. And that confusion was coming to me through, I have to say, a little bit of my Catholic upbringing.

It was only when I realised that when he talked about flesh and blood, when he talked about bread and wine, he wasn't talking about that at all. What he was talking about was the Christ within him. "I and the Father are one, and I am in the Father, you are in me, I am in you." You can't get deeper than saying "I am in you and you are in me."

So now, what is it that is the bread and what is it that is the wine within that nature he's pointing to — which is that which is in me, in you, me and the Father one? When you meditate, when you begin to do this form of meditation I've taught you, you will begin to abstract, to disembody from the mass that you call yourself, this peculiar quality of intuitive intelligence.

It begins with awareness. It begins now. It's not as though awareness is not always with you. It's not as though consciousness is not always with you. It's always there — even when you're asleep. Somebody turns you over. Somebody pulls a blanket over you when you feel cold. And somebody wakes up. Somebody hears the alarm clock, and then there you are. Normally we associate awareness with just, here I am. You go to sleep, and where are you?

Aṅgulimāla: A Monologue

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 54 min

Originally given as *Aṅgulimāla: A Monologue* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



This powerful dramatic monologue presents the complete story of Aṅgulimāla from his own perspective - from his privileged Brahmin childhood as Ahiṃsaka ('the Harmless One') through his transformation into a notorious serial killer collecting human fingers, to his ultimate awakening as a Buddhist monk. The narrative follows his encounter with the Buddha on the Kosala roads, his ordination, and his gradual purification of mind through meditation practice. Drawing from the Aṅgulimāla Sutta (MN 86), this dramatisation explores profound themes of karma and its consequences, the possibility of redemption even for the most heinous crimes, and the Buddhist understanding that suffering arises from ignorance rather than inherent evil. The story culminates in Aṅgulimāla's realisation of his fundamental innocence despite his terrible actions, illustrating the Buddhist teaching that liberation is possible for all beings regardless of their past. This compelling retelling offers insights into the transformative power of Right Awareness practice and the Buddha's boundless compassion.

I am amused when I look back on my life. To say I lived it wouldn't be the truth. To say I did not live it would be a lie. In the clarity and distance of old age, it seems a tale of another age, another person. Yet I remember it all as clear as day.

I was born at the beginning of the cold season, the Himalayan wind chilling the dying embers of a warm sun. My mother rejoiced, of course, as did the household of relatives and friends. But my father was more concerned with my horoscope, and he slipped away with colleagues to study the charts.

The next morning, it was an anxious father who hurried to the palace to fulfil the morning rituals of a royal chaplain. There he found the king troubled and agitated.

"Ah, Gagaji, I was dozing after my evening meal when I woke into a living nightmare. All my armour was shaking, clattering, flashing."

"Oh, that would have been the time Mantani gave birth to our son, Your Majesty, and... I'm afraid, into an inauspicious constellation."

"Inauspicious?" A worried king has no time for sympathetic joy.

"There are signs that show great promise indeed, and yet others that indicate something quite terrible."

"Something terrible, such as?" The king wanted precision.

"I can't say, Your Majesty." And at the king's growing frustration, he quickly added, "Perhaps it may be prudent to be rid of him."

My life hung on a thread. Thankfully, this king was not so easily frightened. Indeed, he was surprised my father should put such little value on my life.

"But he's born a Brahmin. Surely, properly educated and carefully nurtured, he'll overcome any evil tendencies, and that promise will shine through."

This was not the first time I was to owe my life to the compassion of this young, arrogant king, Pasenadi of Kosala.

My parents expressed their uneasy hope in naming me Ahimsaka, the Harmless One.

My childhood was happy and untroubled. I was my mother's favourite. I do remember being offered all manner of bribes to be good. Not that it had much effect. It seems I had an insatiable desire to chase mosquitoes, cockroaches, frogs, anything that moved, and squash them.

However, there was one extraordinary incident that shook my usual happy composure. Suddenly, a gang of boys, all friends, playmates, stood around me. One of them, a big boy, Vajiro, began jeering at me.

"Creep, think you're better than all of us."

They all joined in. At first, I thought they were joking. Then they began to push me around. All of a sudden, everything went blank.

When I came to my senses, the children were staring at me. Before me lay Vajiro. One by one, they sidled away. When the big boy got up, his blood-stained lips flamed with implacable revenge.

"I'll get you for this!"

I laughed at his threat. I felt only the power and grandeur of a conqueror. But, more ominous, I was savouring the exquisite pleasure of drawing blood.

By young manhood, I was well practised in the arts of war, and it shone such potential in my studies that my father sent me to Takasila, the foremost seat of learning. Such was my reputation that the most learned teacher wanted to see me.

Agamaha Pandita Abinyana, a small, rotund, elderly man, was revered for his incisive intellect. That, coupled with a stentorian voice, made him a formidable debater. He fired all manner of questions at me, jabbing them at me with his little finger that seemed to turn them into sharp needles. It was a trait that was to take on a sinister meaning for me.

"You'll outshine them all, even me," he announced with great delight.

I felt a great devotion to my guru. I began to treat him with a special veneration due to a natural father. I felt sure he saw me equally as a natural son. It was my devotion to learning and a desire to please my guru that caused me to excel.

Then, one day—I remember it too well—he glanced at me in a way that greatly disturbed me. There was suspicion in his eyes, a tightness to his face suggesting fear, or was it hatred? As the days passed, he grew more and more distant. During those final days, there were awkward silences and false smiles. I felt hurt by our loss of intimacy, too confused to ask what the matter was.

I decided to put it all to one side, especially since my final exams were starting: the recitations, the public debates, the competitive games. I performed very well. In fact, I was acclaimed foremost student of my year.

On the very day the results were given, my deepest anxieties were confirmed. My guru called me to see him. I expected praise. I wanted to express my irreparable gratitude, and indeed that's what I did.

But then he said, "You know, it is the duty of every student to offer a gift of homage to their guru."

"Oh, indeed," I exclaimed. "Name it, Guruji."

What he asked for came as an utter shock.

"For your homage," he said with absolute authority, "bring me a little finger from one hundred people."

His eyes demanded obedience.

"I can't do that," I remember stuttering.

He was silent, his glare insisting on submission.

"My family are all Brahmins. We live as harmlessly as possible, to the highest standards of one who is born of the mouth of Brahma."

"Those who refuse to pay the ceremonial gift of homage, a sacred duty to their guru, are to be detested. Such a person tramples on our time-honoured tradition. All their learning will produce but sterile fruit. Is this the behaviour of a son born of the mouth of Brahma?"

There was an inexplicable hardness to his tone, a sneer in his question. I had no response. I bowed, mumbling that I would follow his wishes. When I looked up, he'd turned away and was calling for his servant. I backed away, cowed and confused.

The guru had a right to name his gift of homage, but why was mine so terrible? Why had he not asked similar of others? All he asked of them was fruit, clothing, medicine.

That night I fell into a heavy, disturbed sleep, then woke into a terrible night terror. Pointed fingers like darts burst upon me from every angle. I fought furiously with sword and shield, writhing in agony. When I came to my senses, I was lying on the floor, soaked in cold sweat and shaking, awake to the full horror of my duty.

In a daze, I gathered my belongings and began to make my way homeward—a journey of two weeks or more, time to clear my head and cool my heart. I stayed in villages along the route, hardly talking to anyone. And all the time I was convincing myself of my duty.

I must get one hundred fingers. How else could I possibly do so without killing? People aren't just going to let me walk off with their little finger. I have to kill. There's no other way. Such killing isn't murder—I have to fulfil my sacred duty. Who am I to renounce a time-honoured tradition? I have to do it. I have to.

In this way, by the time I arrived at the dark and dense Jalini forest on the border of my country, Kosala, I was steeled for my first killing. I found a cave on a hill that looked down on a stretch of road travelled by hunters, gatherers, and merchants. Water and forest food—banana, mango, rich papaya, various nuts—were all in abundance. There I spent my first day.

That evening, in the pearl-white silence of a full moon, soft with the scuffing of cicadas, I dug a fire pit to Kali Durga, Divine Mother, womb of all creation. Into this cremation ground I would offer the flesh of my victims to gain them her protection and so sanctify my deeds. I cut my little finger and offered my blood as libation into the sacrificial fire.

Staring at the flames, I began to develop a fierce concentration. It was going to take all the courage and strength I could muster. For all my battle skills, I'd never yet killed an animal, never mind a human being.

In the dark dawn of early morning, I rubbed the sacred ash into my body. Filled with religious confidence, I made my way down to the path. There I hid, waiting.

And sure enough, in that early hour, came the shuffle of a wood-gatherer with his hacks and bundles of rope. I'd imagined a swift dagger attack from behind, but instead I pulled an arrow into the bow—a more easy prey there couldn't be. Yet I couldn't let that arrow fly. I continued to stalk him, all the time urging myself to fulfil my duty.

And anyway, what had life left for this old, feeble man but a miserable diseased end? It was a mercy to kill him.

I took a deep breath. Quick as lightning, I thrust my sword. It seemed to penetrate like a knife through butter. His body startled, tensed, then suddenly slumped, dragging me downwards so I tumbled onto him. There I looked into his face. His eyes glazed, empty and deaf. His mouth wide open, locked in shock.

Horried, I leapt up, hardly able to catch my breath. Suddenly there were great cries. A small crowd of men came racing towards me, axes shaking in the air. All went blank.

I remember nothing but standing there with these same men strewn around me, twisted and bleeding. As I realised what had happened, there came upon me a strange feeling of omnipotence. I stood towering above the slain bodies—the skill, the power, the glory of it. Like some all-conquering hero, I sliced off each little finger with a flourish.

I hid the bodies. The more I could keep the killings secret, the easier it would be to capture my victims. Back at my cave, I cut what flesh I could from the fingers and fed it to the sacrificial pyre. Then I threaded the bones with vine and tied them onto a branch. Once they were picked clean by birds or ants, I'd hang them around my neck as a divine amulet.

Late that same afternoon, I heard a calling in the distance. Names being called by many voices, over and over again. Intrigued, I went down. Of course—family and friends had come to look for the wood-gatherers.

Again I stalked and pounced like a tiger. My attacks were swift and smooth, the blows of death precise, clean. Having taken the fingers of two men, I moved around a bamboo coppice—and there in front of me stood three women.

Yes, I stopped. For a moment there was doubt. I felt something tight against my heart. But by now I was too committed. Two were dead before the other could turn. She stared at me, paralysed with fear. And that was the face that fell into the embrace of soft grasses and wild flowers.

Did I feel pity? None. I was drunk with conquest.

I could have easily killed the rest, but for a scream of horror some distance away. I'd been moving so fast I hadn't bothered to hide the bodies. The game was up. Now it was a matter of stopping the news from travelling beyond the village.

I ran at maddening speed until I arrived at a large clearing. Many buildings nestled there among the palm trees, the place littered with busy chickens and scrawny dogs. I was sure that once the villagers returned, they'd send a party off to the king at Savatthi. It was on that road I lay waiting.

Sure enough, a handful of men came bearing the usual crude weapons. I followed them till they had gone quite some way from the village, well out of earshot. Then, full of the courage of invincibility, I pounced. None of this low caste would have had my training. It was all becoming too easy.

I decided to take full advantage of the situation. I made my way back to the village, and in the early hours of the following morning—just when colour begins to seep into the shades—I crept into the first one-room hut. The air was hot and stale with the exhausted slumber of grief.

Husband and wife lay together; the children—seven, maybe eight of them—snuggled in the opposite corner. Their pitiful defencelessness couldn't soften my cruel resolve. I bathed myself in the blood of carnage. First the man, then the woman, then the children. Quietly and speedily, I slit their throats and stabbed their hearts. And so I savaged hut after hut, until I could see streamlets of blood picking their way down the slope towards the well.

Suddenly, as I left a large wooden house, a scream. I lurched back inside and grabbed that child by the throat. A rage took me. I lifted the little body until it dangled in the air, its little arms flailing, mouth agape, eyes bulging in terror, its tiny fingers wrenched into my hand, its little feet booting the air. My grip tightened till the tiny body seized and fell limp.

I stared at that beautiful little face as in a trance. I couldn't bear to acknowledge what I'd done. As I dropped the body to continue the slaughter, it was the one finger I left behind.

But that little child's cry had stirred the village. It was only because of the poor light that I was able to disappear unseen into the forest.

I arrived back at my hideout, exhausted. As I lay down, the child's face returned. I turned on my side and slept through the heat of midday.

Late that afternoon, I woke refreshed and of a sudden decided to hunt animals. Each kill reaffirmed my command over life and death. In the cool of that evening, for the first time in my life, I sank my teeth into roasted boar. It was delicious.

Again, I rejoiced. Soon I'll have my hundred fingers. The debt will be paid. I'll return home in secret triumph and through my father's good offices enter into the service of the king. I'll marry a beautiful girl, inherit the farm, have many children, and my life will be a rolling countryside of nothing but contentment and joy. I danced in joy. I danced in gratitude. I danced for Kali, my divine protectress.

The following morning I woke in more sombre mood. I realised that even now a platoon of soldiers would be searching for me. There was only one thing for it, to keep on the move without coherent plan and to range as far as possible. In this way I could attack unwary travellers along any road, enter any unsuspecting vil-

lage in the dark. The kill was easy so long as it remained unexpected. Even the soldiers were useless defence. Such was their clatter, I could always hear them coming.

On one such outing, I overheard a conversation that first made me laugh, and then showed me to what depravity I had descended. I heard a small crowd talking about this madman who murdered for little fingers.

"A demon, Angulimala."

Me? I was Angulimala, Garland of Fingers.

Returning that evening, I caught my face in a pool of water... and what I saw truly shocked me. My black hair was tortured, spikes around my head... my face hidden beneath a matted, grubby beard. My eyes seemed to bulge. My lips and tongue, blood red from betel leaf... which I chewed to calm my nerves. My clothes, torn, filthy and bespattered with human blood...

And there, around my neck, the garland of fingers.

Yes, a demon. A yucca.

Over this period of but a few weeks, as I gathered my tally of fingers, my bloodlust consumed me. My dreams were full of it. Daydreams addicted to it. To see the horror in their eyes, to hear their screams, was my joy.

I had now but one finger to go, and I thought to come full circle and return to the very spot on that road where I'd stabbed that poor old wood-gatherer. Then at last I would present this blood homage to my guru, against whom I'd built up a healthy hatred and often plotted how to avenge my humiliation.

As I hid in waiting, I began to hear a calling.

Oh, my heart jumped into my throat.

"Amy! Amy!"

My mother! My mother calling me as she'd always done. How could she have known it was me? Her mother's intuition...

Mother or no, there raged inside me a desire to kill. A loud, clear no arose, yet against my will my legs began to move nearer and nearer until I saw her. I couldn't stop. I just kept advancing, my hand now taking the sword from the scabbard. I was all but ready to pounce when a tall, bald-headed monk suddenly appeared.

My mother bowed to him. He must have said something to her, for my mother turned and walked back the way she came. He then continued along the road.

I was intrigued. I began to stalk this monk, moving faster and faster, yet the faster I moved, he seemed to be the same distance away. Finally, frustrated, I burst out of my hiding into the road and ran towards him. Faster and faster I ran, yet never getting any closer. He kept on walking at the very same easy pace.

Finally exhausted, I shouted out, "Stop!"

And he did. While I panted, he turned round, quite unhurriedly, and replied, "I have stopped, Angulimala. It's you who haven't stopped."

I was full of rage and yet taken aback. He was smiling at me. We stood facing each other for what seemed a long time.

Finally, my curiosity, at his supernatural ability to walk faster than I could run, his obvious fearlessness, and this strange reply brought the student out of me.

"You've stopped, but I haven't!" I shouted angrily.

"This vicious craving and enjoyment in making others suffer, do you think it will end with your hundred fingers? With the murder of your own mother?"

I was dumb.

"And the consequences, the karma. Don't you believe the torturer reaps in kind?"

Of course I did. Do harm, and surely harm will follow as a cart follows the ox.

"I'm fulfilling an ancient obligation to my guru," I offered in defense.

"Ha! Put yourself in the place of your victims. How would you like to be murdered, just so that some bright young Brahmin can offer your little finger as a present to his guru?"

The absurdity of my position hit me like a bolt of lightning. Why had it never occurred to me to take the victim's point of view?

"So come then," he said. "You may as well finish the job." He offered his hand. "You needn't kill me for it."

I stared at him in disbelief. He was a big man beyond his prime, but still strong enough to defend himself, offering me his little finger. His fearless act of generosity made my own courage seem puny.

"You've been amazingly stupid," he continued. "What happened to your common sense? It just goes to show how brilliance can service the most ludicrous delusions. That, not to despair, that very dedication to your studies, and indeed to your murderings, is a virtue that will help perfect contentment even in this very life."

His compassion had utterly exposed my callous logic. The full horror of what I had done was upon me. I could hardly bear to look into his kindly yet penetrating eyes. He indeed was a guru of another kind.

He asked me to take him to my hideout. We talked of how we'd both been brought up in the lap of luxury. He, the son of Suddhodana, king of the Saka, north of my own country. How even as a young man he'd become weary of courtly life. How he had an insatiable hunger to know the true destiny of a human being. Were we to wander around aimlessly from life to life, suffering this, enjoying that, or was it simply death, annihilation? Or was there something else?

On the way I came across some jungle fowl. I grabbed an arrow, only to feel acute embarrassment. Such was his immediate effect upon me. I returned to gathering fruits and nuts.

That midday, we ate together in silence. It was late afternoon when I woke from a heavy sleep. Suddenly, seeing the monk again, I jumped and grabbed my dagger. He chuckled at my ferocious posturing.

"Angulimala, when will you again be Ahimsaka, the harmless one?"

He asked me to sit in meditation with him, just observe and feel anything that comes into your attention. I couldn't sit for long, I was so restless.

"Walk up and down, slowly," he said, "but again, just to be aware of any thoughts and feelings."

"Patience," he said, "this is going to take some time. Don't worry, I'll stay with you till your future is clear."

I immediately relaxed with this assurance.

It took a few days to calm down enough to sit still and watch. Again and again, I re-enacted my killings. Endlessly working over the same old themes, the chase, the battle, the kill, and always the excitement, the enjoyment. I couldn't stop them dominating me.

"Don't indulge these fantasies," he warned. "Take away their nourishment and they'll simply die away. Or else they'll drive you to further atrocity. And where will it all end? The king's prison? To be publicly tortured?"

That sent a cold shiver up my spine.

"And," he added, "undermine these overpowering cravings by considering how much your victims suffered."

That was hard. I still wanted to justify myself, to make light of their suffering.

Disheartened and weary, I stretched and looked into the dark emptiness of a starlit night. There I caught the first delicate arc of the new moon. I decided to meditate just once more, and as if by magic, the focus of my fantasies began to change. Instead of relishing the chase and the kill, I began to see the pain and panic of my victims. It was with these images that I fell asleep.

It was still dark when I felt a hand rock my shoulder. I woke with a start.

"Continue," he said. He must have felt the change in my heart. "Get up. Shake off the sloth of sleep."

The voice was sharp, but his smile completely disarmed my angry indignation. By now I had unwittingly become a disciple. Like any good student, I obeyed. I splashed water on my face and sat down to meditate.

And there they came — the faces tortured in pain, weeping and pleading, vivid and alive as if risen from the dead. I began to feel their agonies. And there arose a remorse that began to shake my body. Till it started to release, first in little spurts, then in cries, then in loud moaning and weeping. I cried and cried and cried. I felt my very insides were gouged out. Who knows how long I filled that jungle with my wailing.

"Excellent," said the monk, smiling. "Only when true remorse arises can the heart begin to heal."

The images of my cruelty continued to haunt my every meditation, my every action, my every dream. Every moment was shame, guilt, and remorse. And I was so angry with myself. Why had I not seen the sheer idiocy of my guru's request? The gall I felt when I realised I could have said no. What had stopped me but vile servitude to custom, enslavement to tradition? And how was I ever going to compensate for such monstrous crimes?

My remorse turned to despair when I saw they were too terrible to be forgiven.

"How can we compensate for murder, of all things?" this gentle monk asked. "What could replace the loss of grandparents, husband, wife, children? In such a case, we must simply bear the consequences. Isn't that enough? Do we have to punish ourselves as well?"

I began to realize that in the end, I would have to give myself up to the authorities. They would mete out a terrible, tortuous death. My identity would be revealed, my family shamed and ruined, my mother...

Oh, better for me to live wild, or go to another country far away, take my chances with uncivilised tribes, or better still, to commit suicide, secretly, somewhere the body would be eaten by wild animals, so that I remained anonymous.

"Do you want to be a fugitive or live like an animal all your life? And having murdered so many people, you now want to murder yourself? Is there no end to your stupidity? Past deeds cannot be altered, and they will produce present and future consequence. The true question is, do you have the courage to face it, to suffer it? For this is the only way you can drain the past of its effect."

His eyes looked steadily into mine.

I jumped up. I had to walk. The arguments went round and round, but the truth stood out. It was better to face the consequences.

Surely the king would have sympathy for me. He'd known me since I was a baby. We'd even wrestled each other. He would understand my dilemma. What else could a disciple do but obey his guru? There was my father's influence, the standing of my family. Indeed, I could defend myself before the king as I defended my actions to my own self. And if I was shown no mercy, well, then I would have to suffer the consequences. At least, as this teacher says, I'd wipe the slate clean.

I returned and told him of my decision to give myself up to the authorities. He nodded, as if in approval. There was a long silence in which we gazed into each other's eyes.

Then he said, "Would you not rather put an end to this whole weary round of births and deaths?"

"Is there an escape?" I asked.

His face shone with a smile, and he spoke with that absolute assurance of one who knows.

"There is, Ahimsaka. That which is not born does not die. It is not created, nor can it be found where there's earth, fire, water or air. It cannot be seen or heard or in any way perceived. It is the deathless, the unconditioned. If this were not so, there would be no escape from birth, sickness, ageing and death and the endless, endless rounds of rebirth."

Suddenly I heard myself asking, "You would accept me, Angulimala, a criminal, a murderer, as your disciple?"

"You can stop, Ahimsaka, as I have stopped," he replied.

A huge burden seemed to lift from me, and an enormous joy, born of hope, settled in its place.

"First," he said, "you must bury the tools of your abhorrent profession. You must no longer harm any living being—not even a cockroach."

For the last time, I caressed those beautifully wrought weapons, especially the slender blade with its snake-embraced handle. I stabbed out a trench and placed these precious jewels there, gleaming and glistening in the noontday sun. How difficult it is to give up an addiction, an obsession. I forced my hands to cover them with soil and placed heavy boulders over them until I felt sure I had truly buried them, and for good.

Then he asked me to go in search of suitable robe cloth. That meant cemeteries—oh, disturbing places, those charnel grounds. Corpses steaming the air with their sickly, sweet, pungent stench. Dismembered limbs half eaten by tigers, rodents, vultures, strewn among the white shrouds that mourners had wrapped their dead in.

I was about to wash the cloth when my teacher told me I hadn't yet fully buried the past. I looked at him, puzzled. He pointed to a tree. There, hanging forgotten around my makeshift shrine to Kali, was the garland of finger bones, gently swaying in the sighing breeze, their chimes hollow and choked.

I laid them down in a circle, each finger pointing inward to the now empty pit. On the burial mound over these sacred bodies, I planted a frangipani tree, whose white, sweet, perfumed flowers would ever shower their sad grave. I watched over this cemetery, recalling their murders, begging forgiveness, till sleep overpowered me.

The next day I washed the white cloth and, with my teacher's needle and thread, made robes. He then shaved my head and beard. Finally, all was ready for me to make my request.

"Bhagava, may you be my guide. I shall live dependent on the Bhagava."

"Come," he replied, "and conduct yourself diligently according to the customs of ascetics."

That evening, for the first time, bliss was the object of my meditation.

The following day, he wanted to return to his monastery in Savatthi. He sensed my fear.

"I will not recognise you," he assured me, knowing how different I looked.

When we arrived at the first village, there were shouts of recognition.

"Bhagavā Gautama!"

A great thrill passed through my body. I'd only heard of this great teacher—I couldn't believe my good fortune.

The villagers told their tales of Angulimala and how they thirsted for revenge.

"Ah," said the Bhagavā, "your revenge makes you no better than he. Let the king deal with him. Oh, the law of karma. Better to live good lives and offer your merit to your departed loved ones. That is what they need."

None recognised me. As a young, clean-shaven disciple, it was proper for me to keep my eyes lowered and remain silent. He asked them to help me dye my robes. That evening I approached the Bhagavā in ochre robes, knelt before him, and asked him for a name.

"You shall be known by the name of your innocent childhood," he said.

I was to be known as Bhikkhu Ahimsaka—the Harmless One.

That day all the villagers took a day away from their labours. He talked both to the group and to the individual, calming and consoling them. And so we continued, staying at village after village, until we saw ahead of us the walls of the capital city, Savatthi.

The monastery stood on the outskirts of the city—a set of buildings with a large meditation hall, neat footpaths, bushes, flowers and trees bordering well-kept lawns. Everyone stood waiting, hands joined before them in añjali. They greeted him with silence and smiles.

I was shown to a hut hidden in the tamed forest grove close by—a sturdy little bamboo affair covered in layers of banana leaves, no more than two good strides in length and one in breadth. I had that strange feeling of coming home.

I lay there that night on the soft-platted palm-leaf mat, listening to the crickets and the conversation of owls, musing how my life had so quickly turned around. Truly miraculous.

During the first few days I would constantly visit the bhagava, but his attendant, the elder Ananda, would always tell me to go back to my hut and practice. I felt annoyed and frustrated.

Then one day the bhagava asked to see me.

"Dear friend," he said, "it's not proper to develop an affection for the teacher. I can't bring about your deliverance from suffering. You must take refuge in the teachings and the practice, but above all in yourself. I can only point the way. So please don't come unless called."

That day I felt utterly dejected, abandoned. So much so, I even began to dream of being Angulimala, and all the pleasures of hunting assailed me. I was guided skillfully, and I came to realize that it was this craving to be teacher's best boy that had so angered my fellow students. I was a creep.

Then, early one morning, there were drums, and the occasional salute of trumpets. The king and his army are en route somewhere. To my horror, I suddenly realized they were coming to the monastery.

You can imagine my alarm. I'd all but decided to run away when a young monk came and told me to come at once. As I entered the Bhagavad's room, he saw the look of anxiety on my face and smiled. With an insistent gesture, he motioned me to sit by him.

We sat and waited as the marching footsteps approached us. And suddenly at the door stood the king, a short, stocky, heavily bearded man, the warrior in his eyes. The king and his officers paid homage to the bhagava. I knew all of them, though none recognized me. In mind, I did keep my head low.

After the usual pleasantries were exchanged, the king explained.

"We've come for your blessing, Bhagavan. It's this Angulimala. I've sent out dozens of platoons, but to no avail. He's murdered hundreds, wiped out whole villages. Extraordinary. But how to deal with a deranged madman? Why is he collecting fingers?"

There came a burst of suggestions. He's possessed. A demon. A lunatic.

When the excitement had calmed, the Bhagavan said, "What would you say, your majesty, if such a dark-hearted murderer were to become a monk?"

I could feel the panic rising in me.

"What?" shouted the king, his mouth agape with incredulity. A chorus of scoffing supported his scorn.

"Don't be so dismissive," urged the Bhagavan. "Even this Angulimala can transform himself."

"Transform himself?" The king continued to shout. "When I catch him, I'll transform him. I'll have him roasted alive."

There were great guffaws and equally delicious torments suggested. But one especially made my hair stand on end.

"I'd have him slowly cut to pieces so that he could watch his body being eaten by dogs."

It wasn't the horror of it, but the voice. It was that childhood enemy, Vajiro, now an officer in the king's guard.

"Do you really think that revenge can ever be satisfied?" the Bhagavan asked. "Whatever you do, the bereaved will complain it wasn't harsh enough. Violence breeds violence. It can only be attained by compassion. This is an ancient law."

There was an uneasy silence.

"You did come for my advice."

Again that smile. The king looked around at his company. Everyone was baffled.

"So you want us to catch him and bring him to you, Bhagavad?" suggested the king.

"No need for that." And turning to me, the Bhagavad cheerfully announced, "Here he is, Angulimala, now Bhikkhu Ahimsaka."

The whole company, to a man including the king, instinctively grabbed their swords. There was a stunned silence.

"Perhaps you know him?" asked the Bhagavad.

I looked up in surprise. The king glared at me.

"Ahimsaka," he said at first in shock, and then in growing surprise. "Ahimsaka, son of Gaga and Montani."

"But why," he asked, "why the fingers?"

I then told him about the gift demanded by my guru. Realizing my predicament, a sympathy grew towards me among the king and his company. Indeed, I could see sadness shadow the king's face.

After a long pause in which the king kept looking at me and then to the bhagava, he said, "You're a lucky man, Bhikkhu Ahimsaka, a very lucky man."

With that they began to leave. But the king, as he reached the door, turned and warned me not to leave the Bhagavata's order.

We listened to the marching steps. The Bhagavata turned to me and smiled. I took a very deep breath.

The very next morning, as I was preparing to go on alms round, there was a knock at my door. I opened it to find what I most dreaded standing before me. My mother.

Was a basket of food enough for an elephant? Here and then I began to sob, to sob uncontrollably. No doubt she thought it was remorse for the shame that I'd brought upon the family, not the sobbing. Not so many days ago, I was stalking this very woman, intent on stabbing her through the heart, slicing off her finger. This woman, my mother, who bore me, suckled me, tended to my every care.

My heart cramped into a solid spasm of agony. If ever I were to describe hell, it would be the heart-wrenching compunction I felt that day. Happily, even hell passes. But this was the bloodiest of daggers I'd pierced into my own heart.

I told her my tale, and of the king's stipulation that I not leave the Order, and that I needed time to cure the festering in my heart. I sensed her disappointment. She'd wanted grandchildren and all that.

As for my father, he wasn't surprised, of course. Hadn't he foretold it? What he found offensive was that I had become a disciple of someone who wasn't a Brahmin. Eventually, though, he offered me his blessing.

Not everyone came to accept me, of course. On alms round, children poked fun at me, making up silly songs about Angulimala. More serious were the stones people threw, some bouncing off my head. I'd just walk on. They would eventually tire.

But once I was attacked viciously. A few of the aggrieved families whipped up a crowd to such a righteous frenzy that they beat me with sticks and were dragging me out of the city to kill me, when the guards at the gates stopped them. Ironically, it was Vajiro in command of the post. With a great look of disdain, he ordered a platoon of soldiers to escort me back to the monastery. It took days for the bruises to heal, but luckily there were no broken bones.

It was on one of these alms rounds that something quite remarkable happened. I'd stopped in front of a house in case someone should want to offer food, when I heard great cries from within. A man came out looking desperate, saw me, and shouted, "This is no time to come begging. Can't you hear my wife?"

Her cries resurrected the screams of my victims. I was so depressed by this that I went to see the Bhagavata.

"Go back and offer this blessing," he said. "Say, 'By the power of a harmless life, let that mother's pain cease and the child be born safe.'"

"Harmless life?" I said incredulously.

"Since your spiritual life began," the Bhagavata replied. "From the day of your ordination."

Yes, I thought, at least I could make an offering of my harmless life, albeit a short one. How wonderful if I could actually assist a birth—I who had assisted so many deaths.

She was still crying out and praying to the gods when I returned. Quite a crowd had gathered outside the house. I stood at the gates and offered my blessing.

"Sister, since I was born into the noble life, I do not recall having ever intentionally killed a living being. By this truth may you be well and may your child be safe."

Everyone began to scoff and jeer. I could feel the anger rising. I left at once.

That evening the clamour of a crowd approached my hut and called for me. I began to panic again. I took a deep breath and opened the door.

And there before me stood a man holding a baby. There were shouts of "Saru, Saru, Saru," well done. Presents were laid before me and a garland of the most beautiful white frangipani was placed around my neck. They told me that almost immediately after my blessing, the baby was born and both mother and child were well. I was to be honoured guest at the feast. It was all I could do to blubber my thanks.

Oh, to my surprise, my chant has become a magical mantra for mothers to be. And from that day on, the children stopped poking fun. Coarse words became kindly greetings, and the stones turned into flowers, incense, and sweets. My heart ached with relief and joy at their forgiveness.

After many years, once I felt sure enough in my practice, I decided to go to the neighbouring kingdom of Magadha, where no one would recognise me, in order to live a more solitary life. I found a secluded forest, not far from the prosperous capital of Rajagaha. It was the dry, hot season, so I made my home beneath a great shady fig tree. In time, the villagers generously built me a hut.

There I continued to work, work hard, through all the mental anguish. There were the burning hurts and scorching revenge towards my enemies, especially my guru. It stung to know, to find out, that he had believed the malicious slander that I had been scheming to have him removed so that I could take his prestigious post, and that he had given me such a heinous obligation out of hateful spite.

Then there was the nauseous guilt and agonising remorse towards my victims, as well as all the usual unquenchable lusts, paralysing fears and so on. Oh, I thought they'd never end.

And yet, over the years, everything began to subside. And in the clearings it became so obvious. No one had actually ever made me suffer. No one. Not the plots of my enemies, not the punches of Vajiro, not even the vicious malevolence of my guru. All the ensuing hurt and hate was of my own making.

Was it not my own befuddled thinking that led me to murder? The demonic delight I took in killing, was that not mine to develop? And all the self-pity, self-hatred, guilt, remorse, and so on, and so on, and so on. Was that not all direct consequence? All the time I was blaming it, unwittingly, I was creating my own hell.

And so it was that since none had actually caused me to suffer, I lost all reason, all need to forgive anyone.

And it was then I saw as clear as day. But for mistaken understanding, deluded reasoning, I had never actually meant any harm, never meant to cause anyone any suffering whatsoever.

And so it was that I lost all reason, all need to be forgiven.

I was like a man wandering through a forest who kicks a crooked stick, only to disturb a viper. Just because he's mistaken doesn't mean he and others won't be bitten.

Is this not a great paradox of human life? That we are at once responsible for our moral behaviour, yet because we are fundamentally not immoral, not bad, not evil — but ignorant, mistaken, deluded — we're therefore intrinsically innocent.

Indeed, if this were not so, how could we ever attain purity? And without purity, there can be no liberation from suffering.

These insights came early one morning. From my hut, perched on the side of a wooded valley, I watched the sun rising through golden air full of sweet early monsoon blossom, and heard the trill of songbirds.

There arose in me such relief, such release. And I remembered how the Bhagavad had answered me on the killing road.

"I have stopped, Angulimala."

Now I've stopped too. I've done what had to be done. My heart is purified of all defilements, and I live in utter contentment and peace.

PART 2

The Nature of Existence



Sabbe saṅkhārā aniccā — All conditioned things are impermanent

Dukkha — The Buddha Grounds His Teaching on This Word

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 14 min

Originally given as *Dukkha — The Buddha Grounds His Teaching on This Word* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this teaching, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines dukkha — the cornerstone upon which the Buddha built his entire teaching. Beginning with the ancient etymology of the word (relating to a faulty axle hole), he explores how Buddhism differs from theistic religions by grounding itself in an undeniable human experience rather than supernatural beliefs.

The talk centers on the Dhammacakkappavattana Sutta (SN 56.11), the Buddha's first discourse to his five companions, which established the Four Noble Truths. Bhante explains the three aspects of dukkha: ordinary suffering (dukkha-dukkha), suffering due to change (vipariṇāma-dukkha), and suffering due to conditionality (saṅkhāra-dukkha). He shows how dukkha functions as one of the three characteristics of existence alongside anicca (impermanence) and anattā (not-self).

The teaching concludes with the Buddha's comprehensive definition of dukkha — from birth and death to the five clinging aggregates (khandhas) — demonstrating how our attachment and reactivity create suffering. This exploration provides essential context for vipassanā practice, showing how understanding dukkha leads to liberation through direct perception of our conditioning processes.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā-sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā-sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā-sambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the Blessed Noble and Fully Self-Awakened One.

This evening I thought we'd get back to basics and look at this word *dukkha*. Let's begin with a little etymology. According to Winthrop Sargeant, the ancient Aryans who brought Sanskrit to India were a nomadic horse and cattle breeding

people who travelled in horse and ox drawn vehicles. *Su* and *du* are prefixes indicating good and bad. The word *kha* in later Sanskrit comes to mean sky, ether or space, but originally it meant simply a hole — particularly an axle hole. Thus *sukha* meant having a good axle hole, and *dukkha* meant having a poor one. That gives you some indication of its roots.

Before we go into *dukkha* and its crucial place in the Buddhist teachings, a word about religions in general. All the Abrahamic religions have a God — a supernatural being who punishes you if you do something wrong and gives you lots of ice cream if you do something right. This God, as you know, has created enormous problems for Western civilisation, depending on which side God was on. The East is different. There's no such personal God in Hinduism; all that around good and bad moral behaviour is taken care of by the law of *kamma*, as it is in Buddhism and Jainism. Hinduism came to teach more of Brahman, who was an impersonal God. But the other main religions — Taoism, Jainism and Buddhism — have simply no God. They are non-theistic.

For the Buddha, as for Jainism and Taoism, it all depends on the individual human being. We create our own worlds. We have to get out of the mess. And once we're out of the mess, we are in a state of purity and happiness.

The word *dukkha* has such a wide meaning that no single English word can capture it. It was originally translated as suffering, but that's far too heavy, you might say. Then came unsatisfactoriness, and then even stress, for those of you who know the work of Ajahn Thanissaro.

Once a premise is proven untrue or leading to disaster, the whole fabric, the whole architecture of that belief disappears. The Buddha grounds himself on something that simply cannot be denied: *dukkha*. And his first discourse is built around this very word.

This is what he says at the beginning: "There are two extremes that should not be followed by one who has gone forth into homelessness" — and we can take homelessness to mean anybody on the spiritual path. "What two? The pursuit of sensual happiness in sensual pleasures, which is low, vulgar, the way of worldlings, ignoble, unbeneficial. And the pursuit of self-mortification, which is painful, ignoble, unbeneficial. Without veering towards either of these two extremes, the *Tathāgata*" — that's what he called himself; it translates badly as "such gone"; it's basically the transcendent one — "has awakened to the middle way, which gives rise to vision, gives rise to knowledge, which leads to peace, to direct knowledge, to enlightenment, to *nibbāna*."

The first extreme is about indulgence — desire and attachment. The second is really about blaming the body for all the desires we have. If I didn't have a tongue, if I didn't have the sense of taste, I'd have no problem with food. This was perhaps the mistake made by the Jains, who felt that the body itself, the material of the body, was the karmic result of bad actions.

In that discourse, the Buddha delineates the truth. He first states clearly that there is the truth of *dukkha* — we'll come to exactly how he defines that later. Then he points to the second truth: the cause of *dukkha*, which lies in craving. The third is the cessation of *dukkha* — *dukkha* is completely overcome by letting go of craving and attachment. And then there's the path leading to the cessation of *dukkha*, the Eightfold Path.

He then goes on to say what we should do about this *dukkha*. The noble truth of *dukkha* is to be fully understood. The noble truth of *dukkha* has been fully understood — he's talking about himself now. Then he speaks of the origin of *dukkha*. The noble truth of the origin of *dukkha* is to be abandoned. That cause of *dukkha* is eventually to be abandoned. And he states of himself: the origin of *dukkha* has been abandoned. In the third, he says there is a noble truth of the cessation, the complete eradication of *dukkha*. The noble truth of the cessation of *dukkha* is to be realised — personally experienced. That's the liberation from suffering. And the noble truth of the cessation of *dukkha* has been realised by himself.

This discourse was given to his five companions. Remember, he'd left them, gone on his own, and finally found enlightenment — or became, shall we say, awakened. When he came back, this is the talk he gave them. It's a formalised version, of course, but it gives us some idea of what that original conversation was about. This is what the Blessed One said. And being pleased, the group of five delighted in the Blessed One's statement. While this discourse was being spoken, there arose in the Venerable Koṇḍañña the dust-free, stainless vision of the Dhamma: "Whatever is subject to arising is all subject to ceasing." Then the Buddha expressed this heartfelt sentiment: "Koṇḍañña has really understood. Koṇḍañña has really understood." And that's how Venerable Koṇḍañña became known as Añña-Koṇḍañña — Koṇḍañña who understands.

That's the first definition of *dukkha*. Later on, *dukkha* becomes slightly more refined in the sense of being one of the three characteristics of existence — the very things we're investigating in our *vipassanā*. First is *anicca*, the quality of impermanence. Knowing impermanence, seeing impermanence, begins to explain why

holding on to anything pleasant leads to suffering, because everything, of course, disappears. Impermanence also leads us to understand *anattā*, not-self, because the self is supposed to be eternal, immortal.

Now we come to the core aspects of *dukkha*, and this is the most general explanation that he gives. First of all, there's ordinary suffering, *dukkha-dukkha*. That first *dukkha* refers to all the natural suffering and displeasure that we get in life. And the *dukkha* that he's referring to, which we get rid of, is of course the relationship we have of wanting and not wanting. Reactivity. All our reactions based upon the idea of a self seeking to make this world a pleasant place for itself, always manipulating the world to make a pleasant place for itself, wanting, not wanting. That's the first form of *dukkha*.

The next form is caused by, as we just mentioned, *vipariṇāma-dukkha*, change. Even pleasant experiences are to be looked upon as impermanent, and it is very foolish to hang on to them. When we have a party, we always want another one just like it. And of course, it never turns out the way we want it.

Finally, there's the suffering due to conditionality, *saṅkhāra-dukkha*. *Saṅkhāra* is conditionality, but it's also to do with compoundedness. Everything is made up of bits and pieces that constitute an object — or rather, that the human being sees as an object. We ourselves experience ourselves as whole, complete, entire. Yet when we actually investigate ourselves, we're just a mass of cells, or bodily speaking, just chemicals or just subatomic energy. And the mind is just this constant flow of thinking, imagining, emotionals. This means that this body, this self doesn't have a permanent essence. That's the important thing. Not seeing that leads us into this delusion, which is the fundamental cause of our suffering.

Finally, he sums it all up in a sense. This is his definition of *dukkha*: "Birth is *dukkha*, ageing is *dukkha*, illness is *dukkha* and death is *dukkha*. Sorrow, lamentation, pain, grief and despair are *dukkha*. Association with the unloved is *dukkha*. Separation from the loved is *dukkha*. Not getting what one wants is *dukkha*. In conclusion, the five clinging aggregates, the *khandhas*, are *dukkha*."

That final sentence: the clinging aggregates. Remember that those are the body itself, all our feelings — physical and emotional in the body — all our perceptions. And then the *saṅkhāras*. This is where we come in, because through an act of will, we've created these volitional conditionings, habits, which are conditioned and conditioning. Our job as meditators is to perceive this whole process of how we create suffering, and it is perceiving the process that is the process of liberation. The final *khandha* was consciousness, by the way.

I can only hope that this little talk on *dukkha* will be of some benefit and that you will, by your personal and complete devotion to the practice, liberate yourself from all suffering sooner rather than later.

The First Discourse: Dhammacakkappavattana Sutta - Turning the Wheel of the Dhamma

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 51 min

Originally given as *The First Discourse: Dhammacakkappavattana Sutta - Turning the Wheel of the Dhamma* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this teaching, Bhante Bodhidhamma takes us through the Buddha's first discourse, the Dhammacakkappavattana Sutta (SN 56.11) - the 'Turning of the Wheel of the Dhamma' delivered at the deer park in Sarnath. He begins by contextualizing the Buddha's journey from his training under Ālāra Kālāma and Uddaka Rāmaputta through the jhānas, his period of extreme asceticism, and finally his Middle Way approach that led to Awakening under the Bodhi tree.

Bhante vividly describes the Buddha's encounter with his five former companions who initially dismissed him as having 'gone back to luxury.' He then explores the discourse's core teachings: the two extremes of sensual indulgence and self-mortification, and the Middle Way that transcends both. The Four Noble Truths are examined in detail - dukkha as the five clinging aggregates (pañcupādānakkhandha), taṇhā (craving) in its three forms, the cessation of suffering in nibbāna, and the Noble Eightfold Path structured through sīla, samādhi, and paññā.

The talk concludes with the beautiful imagery of the Dhamma spreading through all realms and Venerable Koṇḍañña becoming the first disciple to achieve realization, earning the name Aññāta Koṇḍañña. Throughout, Bhante emphasizes the practical relevance of working with our ethical conduct and negativity as the foundation for wisdom to arise.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā-sambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

What I want to do is take the first discourse, the Dhammacakkappavattana Sutta—the Turning of the Wheel of the Law—and lead up to it.

Remember, he'd left his family and trained under two particular teachers. First was Alara Kalama, who took him up through the jhanas and the higher jhanas, then invited him to become a teacher himself. He was quite an adept very quickly, I think—together the training took about six years, remember. Then he goes to another teacher called Udaka Ramaputta, who takes him through the eight jhanas, the eight steps. But this doesn't satisfy him, remember.

He then goes into these austerity exercises, mainly around eating—or rather, not eating. He talks about eating less and less until he was down to a grain of rice, until he could hold his spine through his stomach. If you try that, you'll see how thin he was. He gets himself to a point of disappointment, really, because he doesn't feel he's going anywhere. He just thinks it's more suffering.

Then he's out on the road. He's left his companions. And this woman comes along—Sujata. We know her name means 'auspicious birth.' She's carrying some sweetmeats for the local shrine, the local god. Seeing this poor wretch, she offers them to him. Of course, the scripture says he was glowing like a god by the side of the road, so you have to set aside all the hagiography—the stories of saints.

This revives him. He has a memory of childhood, watching his father perform the ploughing ceremony. And this is the point where his whole process turns around upon itself—the way he's looking at his practice. Instead of trying to achieve something, these wonderful mental states that people had talked about, that he'd heard about in the parks where people would gather to listen to the ascetics.

By the way, that seems to have been one of the big entertainments of the day. On the full moon, people would go to these parks where there were shrines, and all the ascetics would turn up and give talks, saying how they'd got it and this other person had completely got it wrong. There were big debates. He's coming from that sort of background where there was a lot of fermentation going on, spiritually speaking.

His whole practice now turns around upon itself. Instead of seeking happiness, he turns inward to find out how he's creating suffering. With that sort of inspiration, he sits under the tree. Within six hours, he cracks it.

One thing to remember: there's a point called the Great Doubt, where Mara approaches him and basically says, 'Look, who are you to try and achieve this?' Mara puts a great doubt in his mind about what he's trying to do. Then comes this moment where the Earth Goddess rises and says he has every right to do this be-

cause he has the perfection of generosity—he's perfected the virtue of generosity. In other words, he's not doing it just for himself; he's doing it for all beings. That gives him that little bit of courage. He carries on. And breaks through all the delusion.

He said he spent seven weeks just sitting there, amazed by what he'd discovered, going through his mind as to the meaning of it. Then comes that point where he asks himself whether he wants to teach or not. At first he thinks, no, this is just too subtle—I'm never going to be able to get this across. Then he thinks of his two teachers and finds out they've died. Then he thinks of his old companions, and he goes in search of them.

He's around Bodh Gaya—presumably still where he was liberated—and he makes his way to the deer park at Sarnath, near modern-day Varanasi, which was an old capital of that kingdom around the Ganges plain. It's about 250 kilometres, about 155 miles he's got to walk—and that's by modern roadways. Presumably in those days it was little pathways, wishways, from village to village. And he finally finds them.

The text talks about the Gracious One, the Bhagavā, while walking gradually on walking tour, approaching Varanasi and the group of five at the deer park in Isipatana. The group of five saw the Bhagavā coming from afar, and after seeing him they resolved among themselves: 'This ascetic Gotama who is coming, friends, is given to luxury. Having forsaken the striving, he has gone back to luxury. He should certainly not be worshipped or stood up for, nor should his bowl and robe be taken. However, we can prepare a seat, and if he wishes to sit down, then he can do so.'

But as the Bhagavā approached, the group of five found themselves unable to keep their agreement. They went out to greet him. One took his bowl and robe, another prepared his seat, another placed water for washing his feet along with the footstool and footstand. The Bhagavā sat down on the prepared seat and washed his feet.

So you've got this lovely scene where they've determined he's a waster now—he's lost it, really. But something made them drop this rather cold greeting they'd planned. Perhaps it was old friendship, that connection. Perhaps he'd been, in a way, an unrecognised leader of the group. But something, anyway, softened them.

Still, they're not letting him off the hook. They approach him and call him by name—presumably Siddhattha, though it doesn't actually say. The word here is āvuso—they address him as a friend. In the order, if somebody is younger than you in years—that's in how many years they've been ordained—you address them as āvuso. If they're older than you, you address them as bhante. That's scriptural. Every culture has its own way of distinguishing between younger monks and older monks.

Then the Buddha addresses them. He now calls this Nibbana 'the deathless.' He's pumping it for them, you might say.

And they reply: 'But you, friend Gotama, by that ascetic lifestyle, that practice, that difficult way of living, did not arrive at the state beyond ordinary human beings, a distinction of what is truly noble knowledge and insight. So how can you now, given to luxury, forsaking the striving, gone back to luxury, attain a state beyond human beings, a distinction of what is truly noble knowledge and insight?' Ha!

He then repeats his claim. He calls himself the Realised One, the Tathāgata. Tathāgata literally means 'someone who's gone there,' and it's translated in lots of ways. Professor Harvey, whom some of you might know—he's written a couple of good books and used to run the online course—translates it as 'one who is attuned to reality.' That's really taking it a little bit far.

'The Tathāgata is not given to luxury, is not forsaking the striving, and has not gone back to luxury. The Tathāgata is a worthy one, a perfectly awakened one, a sambuddha. Lend an ear, monks, I'll instruct you about the attainment of the deathless'—and so on and so forth—'to be experienced and attained by yourselves in this very life.'

In those times, presumably, everything was said three times, and if you didn't get what you wanted after three times, you had to shut up. So they approach him again with the same accusation—that he's gone back to luxury. How could he possibly have attained any enlightenment if, while he was doing the real practice of self-mortification, he'd attained nothing at all?

He goes through the round a second time, and the third time they approach him. But this time he answers: 'Are you aware of my having spoken to you like this before?' And they say, well, certainly not. Then he goes through it again. And finally, they're ready to open to the teachings. It's a lovely little scene, if you can imagine it for yourselves.

This came up when I did a Skype with the Brighton group. What happens to a lot of people, especially if they've come from a devotional religion like Catholicism, is that they come into Buddhism with that fervour for the meditation and all that. And then there comes this dryness, this lack of heart connection with the teachings. I know people who, because of that, will continue their practice but then will go to church. I know of one person, for instance, who really doesn't go to the monastery, Amaravati, anymore, but actually just goes to join the Christian group—mainly because of that heart connection.

The way you would develop that, if you feel it, is by contemplating the life of the Buddha—making that connection to a past personage. A person might do it for many various things. If somebody now was into civil rights, for instance, they might bring to mind people like Nelson Mandela. Reading their history, reading their biography, you get that connection, and from that connection you get the energy that comes of wanting to be like that person. So that's the devotional thing that some people are drawn to. That's why I've got all these statues around. There you go—you can make a visual heart connection with the Buddha. So you see my Catholic upbringing.

Anyway, then he begins the teachings. He starts off by saying: there are these two extremes amongst those who have gone forth, not to associate with. The first is devotion and clinging to the pleasures of the senses, which is low, vulgar, worldly, ignoble, and not connected with the goal. It's not leading anywhere, in other words.

Now, that would resonate with us as a materialist goal. If you think this is the only life you have, you may as well enjoy it, for heaven's sake. What's the point of not enjoying it? So your whole effort goes into trying to make this life deliver at least some level of happiness, and as regularly as possible. That's why you get people moving—whether they're entirely conscious of it or not—towards fame, power, riches, or just sensual pleasure. Or all of them if they can.

For a materialist, the goal has to be happiness now. But that happiness has to be based on what this psychophysical organism can give them—some mental or emotional state generated by accumulating something outside themselves. They might be adept; they might get into spiritual practice and attain these beautiful mental states. And there would have been people, even in the Buddha's time, who practised those without any real understanding, or without any real faith—shall we say, belief in some future life—because there were materialists in the Buddha's time too.

Some even said it didn't really matter whether you went down one side of the Ganges murdering and pillaging, and up the other side performing great acts of compassion—your fate was set. When you died, that was the end of it. So there were all sorts of understandings in those days, as we have these days. All sorts.

In fact, this materialism has in a sense entered Buddhist mainstream as secular Buddhism. Not all secular Buddhists are materialists in that complete way, but it definitely opens up the Buddhist teachings to people who are grounded in science—scientism, really. The belief that everything comes out of matter, and that's about it. At least it gives them some way of creating happiness in this life that's a bit more lasting, by seeing this whole process of attachment and desire. So that's where it centres—on desire and attachment. And that, of course, takes them back to the whole business of identity.

So you never know. They might become fully liberated and find themselves in a state of shock for eternity. Anyway, that's the business of self-indulgence. And of course the Buddha had left all that.

What had awakened him, remember, was seeing these four great signs—these four messengers from the gods, as they said. He's in his late twenties, maybe middle twenties, which is a time when normally you leave youth and suddenly realise that what you're looking at is sickness, ageing, and death—and that there might be an escape. Those were the four images given in the scriptures in a metaphorical way: the sick person, the elderly person, the corpse, and somebody sitting under a tree suggesting there might be a way out of this problem.

So he left that life. Then, in a sense, he followed a similar trajectory when he did the jhānas. He was trying to attain happiness through this psychophysical organism. And he finds that this also has a problem, because when he comes out of those jhānic states, he just gets neurotic again—depressed and anxious.

That's one reason, I think, why he then goes into this mortification stuff. Remember that mortification is not the same as renunciation. The mortification he was practising came from a general understanding that the soul was trapped in the body. The body was an expression of your karma—your bad karma—else you wouldn't be born here. So the idea was that through self-mortification, through letting go of the body, the soul would be released into a heavenly place.

The Jains definitely have that idea. That's why they're so careful about not doing anything that harms, even when they don't mean to. Because even when you don't mean to, something suffers. You stand by accident on an ant and it suffers,

and you've got consequences you might never have meant—that's the point. So that's why you see Jain monks being very careful, sweeping the ground before them. Even when they're sleeping, when they want to turn over, they wake up to brush away any insects that might be underneath them. They really are spot on.

So that was the idea anyway—at least one of the main ideas. The Buddha would have had that in the back of his mind: that he was going to attain this eternal bliss by drawing the body down almost to the point of death. In the Jain religion, by the way, it's considered a saintly thing to let go of the body through starving yourself.

I actually looked that up for myself, about starvation. There's no suffering, it seems. This idea we have—that if you stop eating you become ravenous, and you'd eat an animal alive if you caught one—is based on images of people in famine situations where they eat a little. You're feeding the body and the body wakes up with its hunger. But actually, if you just stop eating, the body goes into this starvation mode.

The passage I read says that the vast majority of animals die simply because they can't eat anymore. The bird gets too old, it can't feed itself, it just dies. And you get these ketones—I haven't a clue what they are—but what happens is the body seems not to suffer at all. It knows how to draw itself down, and then one or two of the organs just stop, and that's the end of it.

That's the underlying philosophy, shall we say, that was driving him to practise these mortifications. But renunciation is something different—it's letting go of attachment to something. It's not as though you stop eating; you just try to distinguish between the desire that comes from ordinary appetite and the desire that's seeking happiness in food. A completely different idea.

What the Buddha says of self-mortification is that it's painful—*dukkha*—he says it's painful, he says it's ignoble, and it's not connected with the goal. He's trying to get this balanced.

Now, we talk about the middle way, which he then goes on to explain. Just to read it to you: 'Not having approached either of these two extremes, monks, the middle practice, the middle way, was awakened to by the realised one, by the Tathāgata, which produces vision, produces knowledge, which leads to peace, deep knowledge, complete awakening and emancipation.' *Abhiññāna* means knowledge; *abhi* means very great or very deep—you could probably translate it as transcendent knowledge.

And what is this middle way, monks? The one awakened to by the realised one, and so on—that's the Eightfold Path.

When we say 'the middle way,' you might think it's just a bit of moderation. You do a bit of this and a bit of that, and you end up somewhere in the middle. And although it's called the middle way because you're still enjoying life rather than going into these self-mortification practices, it's actually a completely different psychology, a completely different understanding. The word 'middle' doesn't quite get to the root of it.

It's more, I would have thought, transcendent of those two paths and yet feeding into both of them. On the one side you're still enjoying life, but you're trying not to be attached to it. On the other side, you're not self-mortifying, you're not trying to blame the body for anything—but you are renouncing things that you see are not good for you. It's coming from a different understanding about how we've got into this situation, which goes back to this business of identity and the self. Anyway, that's just a little side point.

Then there's the Eightfold Path, which we'll come to in a bit. After that, he goes through the actual Four Noble Truths.

This discourse isn't verbatim, obviously. He wouldn't have come out with such a formulated talk. You might think, well, he's been there under a tree for seven weeks, so he's got his talk in his head. But remember, he's illiterate. It's very difficult for us to grasp that, isn't it? He's illiterate. People didn't read, didn't write. It was all memory.

Obviously he would have continued in a conversational mode, and then later on the teaching became formalised. This is a formalised teaching laying the basis upon which all the rest is built—and that's why, in a sense, it can be called the turning of the wheel of the Dhamma.

There are parts of the scriptures which are very, very old, but of course they developed as they went through. What happened was that monks would hear a talk, and it would be systematised into ways of memory—that's why we've got so many lists. Then groups of monks would take responsibility for remembering certain groups of scriptures. They were called the *bhāṇakas*, the reciters. It would be very rare for one monk or nun to know all the scriptures. It depended on which group of monks you were with, the flavour of the teachings that you got. Because it's quite a collection when you think about it.

Scholars and academics can see that there are different levels in the Pali, in the way the Pali is structured. Bhikkhu Bodhi has just translated the Sutta Nipāta, which is one of the earliest strata. It's a great big book—not such a big collection of discourses, but he's added all the commentarial material to it. Included in that are the two chants we do in the evening: the loving-kindness one and the Maṅgala Sutta, the blessings. That comes from that strata too. They would also create verse, which made it easier to remember.

He starts off now by saying: 'This, monks, is the noble truth of suffering. Birth is suffering, old age is suffering, sickness is suffering. Death is also suffering. Getting what you don't want is suffering, and being separated from what is dear to you is suffering. Not obtaining what one longs for is suffering. In short, the five grasping khandhas is suffering.'

Here in the discourse we have the first way he looks at the human being—through these five aggregates. And there's a purpose to it, of course.

The first aggregate is the body and how the mind experiences it—the primary sensations you feel: heat, cold, and so on. Then there's feeling, where we distinguish between what's pleasant and unpleasant. That's a natural process within us; you can't stop it. As soon as you feel something, we judge it to be either pleasant or unpleasant. This isn't a bad judging—it's just the way we are in the world.

Then there's perception, which moves into memory. Remember too that feelings include those caused in the body by mental states. After that we have the volitional conditionings. And finally consciousness, which is the screen upon which everything happens—a multidimensional screen. Everything you experience is flashing on that screen.

What he's pointing to with the volitional conditionings is what we're actually developing, producing. Our habits—that's the best word I've come across for it—just our habits, the way we reinforce certain patterns of behaviour, patterns of thinking. Some of them are wholesome, some of them aren't, you see.

But he says it's the clinging nature of these aggregates that matters. It's the way we cling to this psychophysical organism—that's what it amounts to. The clinging is what is suffering. That's really important.

If I give another talk on dependent origination, remember this: there's the feeling, there's the reaction to it of not wanting it or trying to overcome it, and then there's the identity—I don't want. What we've got to really grasp is that the suffering doesn't start until the point of identity.

This is often a difficult point to really grasp. When you're in yourself and something horrible is coming up and you can feel the negativity, it's difficult to realise that actually you've separated out of it. Only when that separation becomes more and more obvious do you realise that there is this gunk going on, but there is no suffering as such. That's a different quality from when you suddenly say, 'I can't handle this,' and then you drop into it, as it were. That's the point of suffering.

That's why he doesn't say the five desiring khandhas. He says the five grasping khandhas—the ones that we grasp with a sense of self.

At the same time, in other discourses there's a different description of dukkha. This word dukkha—the root word upon which he builds everything—just means hard to bear.

First of all, there is dukkha-dukkhata: just the pain, the suffering we engender because of the unsatisfactoriness of body and mind. Then there's the suffering that arises because everything we experience is a compendium—a conjunction of things, an imminence where all these little bits and pieces come together to create something. Nothing has any reality. Nothing has any substance to itself. Everything is dependent on something else. Just contemplating the body and that it's made up of billions of cells which can all go their own way if they want—and that's the end of it—you begin to recognise that everything doesn't have the substantiality we think it has, or experience it as.

And then of course there's the suffering that comes from change. You can't just stop. You can't say, 'Well, this is it, this is what I've always been looking for—stop the world.' It doesn't happen.

So that's how he describes the noble truth of suffering.

Then comes the second noble truth: samudaya, the arising of suffering. And here the Buddha points to this word taṇhā.

Remember, there's another word in Pali, chanda, which means desire—and that can be good or bad depending on your motivation, your intention. But taṇhā is a specific word referring to desires that lead to suffering one way or another. That's why you get other translations for it like thirst, or lack.

Desire comes out of a state of unsatisfactoriness at some level and is itself a state of suffering. To be in a state of desire is not pleasant. It only becomes pleasant when we see the end of it—that it's going to be satisfied or gratified. If it's not, then it's suffering. So desire comes out of suffering and is itself a state of suffering.

Suffering here is used in the widest sense: unsatisfactoriness. That's worth noting too—*dukkha* used to be translated simply as suffering. But then people would say, well, I don't suffer, meaning they were having a good life at that time. So translators had to find another word and came up with unsatisfactoriness.

And that's the other side, remember, that I always keep pumping: this business of how indulgence in pleasure has its comeuppance.

The Buddha says desire is the cause of suffering—the craving for sense pleasure. And he divides this *taṇhā* into three types: *kāma taṇhā*, *bhava taṇhā*, *vibhava taṇhā*. Craving for sense pleasure. Craving for continuation. And craving for discontinuation.

Kāma taṇhā, the desire for sense pleasures—well, we know that, that's sincere enough. *Bhava taṇhā* is the desire to make it continue, but it's also the desire to keep becoming. So it refers both to trying to maintain a certain pleasure as best you can, and to the self wanting pleasure—the self wanting to continue, wanting to keep living.

And the same with *vibhava taṇhā*. This refers to wanting to get rid of what you don't want—a sort of aversion. But it also refers to wanting to get rid of yourself. Either you're just fed up and bored and depressed and you dive under the duvet. Or you actually want to make your way to a bridge.

Whenever I say that, I always remember this lovely clip from a comedian—I can't remember his name now, but he's extremely funny, from around the fifties or so. He's about to jump off Westminster Bridge in London. A copper comes along and says, excuse me, sir, you mustn't do that. They have this sort of argument about life and all that. And the sketch ends when they both jump off the bridge. It was really funny.

So yes, that's *taṇhā*. Sense pleasures, always wanting to maintain, wanting to continue, wanting to live—and *vibhava taṇhā*, wanting to get rid of. These categories are pointing us to actually investigate in our practice, to name what's happening and say, oh, that's an aversion, or that's me being averse to myself, wanting to get rid of myself at this present time. It's just being aware of these mental habits.

And then, of course, the Buddha makes this great statement. He says there is a noble truth of the cessation of suffering. It's the complete fading away, the cessation without remainder of that craving. It's the liberation, the letting go, the release and non-adherence.

That's a really very direct statement. There's no pulling back on it. It's not as though, say, modern psychotherapies might say, well, you can get to a decent accommodation with life, you can be generally content and whatnot. I don't know of any psychotherapist who says there's a complete end to suffering here and now. A lot of religions point to the afterlife: you're working at it now and then you get to the gates and you're away. But this statement is right here and now. And of course you find the same in Hinduism—that liberation is right here and now if we work hard enough for it, or if we want it enough.

So that brings us to the path itself: the Noble Eightfold Path.

The usual way it's written down is right view, right attitude, right speech, right action, right livelihood, right effort, right mindfulness, right concentration. But it's normally taught in the order of *sīla*, *saṃādhi*, *paññā*—moral and ethical life, the development of meditation, and then the wisdom that comes from it.

Looking at it that way brings us, I think, to a correct view of how to approach our lives. Coming back from the way the Buddha put it: there is this great misunderstanding that lies within us, this delusion about who we are, or what it is, or however you want to phrase it.

Because of that delusion, we make a sort of bargain with life. We say, well look, this is it, this is the way it is, so I'm going to try and make the best I can of this life, seeking happiness there. Remember, that's our platform. We're not working off—nobody works off, even the most horrible characters in history—they're not working off the platform "I hate." They're working off the platform "I want to be happy." If that "I want to be happy" moves towards, well, for me to be happy I've got to hate you—that's the way it moves. But our basic human nature, right down at the base, is that we're actually seeking happiness. Everybody's trying to seek happiness one way or another.

And because of this wrong understanding, we form a wrong relationship with the world, thinking that if I accumulate things, that's going to make me happy. So there's your greed. Then you've got to defend it because somebody else wants your accumulation. And if whoever wants your accumulation is bigger than you, we've got to run for it.

So those three things—acquisitiveness, aversion, and fear—are right at the base, manifesting from this wrong understanding.

The way we behave from this wrong understanding—we're not always behaving from wrong understanding, but when we are—that's actually the way back to undermining it. By living ethically, looking at our moral lives, being careful about what we allow the mind to get caught up in or what we indulge the mind with—that's the way back, as it were, to the original problem.

As you come back, you can feel the energies that are based on this delusion. Renouncing something gives you an inkling of how much you're attached to what you want to give up. When you're with somebody for whom there's a natural aversion, you're with that part of you that doesn't want to be with anything upsetting. And when you're in a frightening situation, a situation that causes anxiety, you're coming back from it.

So by working with our ethical life, our moral lives—which manifest in these attitudes, mental states, emotional states—we're actually coming back to the original problem, which is the identity. And at base, the last guard against undoing that delusion is fear.

The loss of identity. Who are you? And all that sort of stuff. We come close to that whenever we're struck by a serious illness, or eventually our death. That's when we hit that point. And the fear and aversion that arise are the measure of this delusion.

So I always think, rather than our meditation always trying to attain something—some sort of insight, some great explosive experience that's going to change my life—you're far better off working with the negativity within us. Because there you can eventually begin to see some results.

As the heart begins to purify itself, this intelligence, this *sati-paññā*, this intuitive awareness becomes clearer. Because remember, the delusion lies in the looking. It doesn't lie in the body; the body's not deluded, the body's just the body. It doesn't lie within the heart; the heart's just feeling, that's all it is. It's only because we personalise it, only because I say "I am angry" or "I am afraid," that it becomes a sense of me. The heart is just feeling—that's all it is. And the head is just thinking, imagining.

So the delusion isn't in the body, the heart, or the head—those are manifestations of delusion. The delusion lies in *sati-paññā* itself. In other words, it's the Buddha within us that is deluded. And this is where we can begin to have little insights into how we create suffering, how we imagine things are going to last when

nothing lasts at all, how we give things concrete form, stabilise them, conceptualise them into some sort of reality we presume will continue. All of that begins to be undermined when we actually start looking at our ethical lives.

This brings us to right speech, right attitude—it's translated as 'right thought' here, but I think 'right attitude' is closer—right action, and right livelihood. Don't forget that our livelihood, what we do for most of the day, has a conditioning effect on us. Then there's the meditation itself, the vipassanā, which is what we're doing here. And from that come the insights, the sammā diṭṭhi.

If you look at your practice as sīla, samādhi, paññā, I think it moves much more easily. We don't feel so frustrated about not attaining something. Just allow that to happen as the purity grows.

Anyway, once the Buddha had laid this out, there's a lovely paean. But first he goes into the three modes of each of these noble truths.

The first mode is simply that there is suffering—a bold statement: there is the noble truth of suffering. Then he says this ought to be known. It ought to be understood what he means by suffering. And finally he tells us that he has fully understood it.

Then he talks about the arising of suffering, the cause of suffering, and says that this ought to be given up. This is where academics become, I think, a little silly, because it says the noble truth of desire has to be given up. How can you give up a noble truth? But it's shorthand, isn't it? Shorthand for: it is true to say that we ought to give up desire. Never mind. And then he says that he has given it up. It has been given up.

Then there is the cessation of suffering, which ought to be realised—and he has realised it. And finally the path leading to it, which ought to be developed—and he has developed it fully.

So we ought to be moving towards those final statements ourselves: that we have overcome desire, we have attained Nibbāna, and we have practised the path to its end.

Then he says: 'When to me, monks, in regard to these four noble truths turned like this in three ways...'—and this gives us the idea of a wheel. Wheels within wheels. Especially in the Abhidhamma you'll find this word vaṭṭa coming up all

the time. There are little wheels within wheels. In Dependent Origination, for instance, there's an internal wheel: the feeling, the desire, the *taṇhā*, and then the grasping—they revolve around each other.

'Knowledge and insight, as it really is, was quite clear. Then, monks, I did declare to the world with its gods, *Māra* and *Brahmā*, to this generation with its ascetics and brahmanas, princes and men, that I was the fully and perfectly *Sammasambuddha* with unsurpassed complete awakening. To me, knowledge and insight arose. Sure is my liberation of mind. This is my last birth. Now there is no more continuation.'

That's a lovely statement. You can imagine him saying that. If you said that here in this room, we'd all go, 'Oh yeah.'

And then comes this lovely paean: hearing these words, the earth deities, all the gods in the universe, the Heaven of the Four Kings—they proclaimed that the matchless wheel of the truth, which cannot be set in motion by a recluse, a brahmana, a deva, a god, a *Māra*, a *Brahmā*, or anyone in this world, has been set in motion by the Blessed One at the Deer Park at Isipatana near Varanasi.

Thus, at that very moment, at that instant, the cry that the wheel of truth had been set in motion spread as far as the *Brahmā* realm. The system of ten thousand worlds trembled and quaked and shook, and a boundless, sublime radiance—surpassing the effulgence of the gods—appeared in the world.

And then the Blessed One uttered this paean of joy: 'Verily *Koṇḍañña* has realised! Verily *Koṇḍañña* has realised!' From that moment the Venerable *Koṇḍañña* received the name *Añña Koṇḍañña*—'*Koṇḍañña* who knows'. So there was one of his companions who got it.

That's how this lovely discourse ends: with the wonderful image of the wheel of the teaching rising up through all the heavens to the very top, and with the Buddha finally acknowledging that this old companion of his has now become fully liberated.

I can only hope this hasn't confused you but has inspired you to devote yourself entirely to the practice, for liberation awaits us. May you be fully liberated from all suffering—sooner rather than later.

Setting the Wheel of the Dhamma in Motion

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 24 min

Originally given as *Setting the Wheel of the Dhamma in Motion* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this foundational talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma delves into the Dhammacakkappavattana Sutta (SN 56.11), the Buddha's first formal teaching delivered to his five companions at the deer park of Isipatana near Varanasi. This discourse established the "wheel of Dhamma" that continues to turn today, offering liberation from suffering to all who follow the path.

Bhante carefully examines the Buddha's rejection of two extremes: the pursuit of sensual pleasure (which leads to addiction and dependency) and self-mortification (blaming the body for spiritual obstacles). The Middle Way transcends both approaches, neither indulging nor suppressing, but understanding the true nature of dukkha (suffering/unsatisfactoriness) and its cessation.

The talk provides clear explanations of the Four Noble Truths in their complete framework: dukkha must be fully understood, taṇhā (craving) must be abandoned, nirodha (cessation) must be realized, and the Noble Eightfold Path must be developed. Through exploring how Venerable Koṇḍañña became the first to gain the "dust-free, stainless vision of the Dhamma," practitioners gain insight into what genuine spiritual understanding looks like and how the Buddha's teaching continues to offer a path to awakening for all beings.

Greetings, peace and joy. I trust you had a fruitful day. I do not say happy, though I also wish you did have a happy day.

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammasambuddhassa. Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammasambuddhassa. Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammasambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the Blessed Noble, and fully self-awakened one.

Okay, so we were still answering this question about the Four Noble Truths and slowly making our way to the Eightfold Path. And yesterday we talked about the Buddha's first efforts to teach there, meeting the Ajivaka, meeting that wanderer and not really impressing him, and then finding his five companions not really wanting to speak to him, being rude, thinking he'd gone soft and very slowly opening up with his question of, "Have you ever heard me speak like this before?"

And now I want to follow that through with the discourse called the *Dhammacakkappavattana Sutta*, which is translated as "Setting in Motion the Wheel of the Dhamma." So here the teaching is more formalised. It was put together obviously later, but it's still understood traditionally to be his first talk given to the five companions.

But before I go on that, I just want to tell you a story which illustrates hagiography – how people build up in their imagination somebody whom they think is saintly through passing messages from one to another, what is called Chinese whispers. I'm not so sure that's PC anymore, but that's what we call it. I think in the States they call it telephone or something. And, of course, the same happens with anybody. If you talk about somebody, they pass it on to somebody else. Before you know it, they're either a criminal or a saint.

So it so happened I was up in Kandy and went to visit Bhikkhu Bodhi up there. Occasionally, very occasionally I would go up and visit him. And there was a Danish monk with him whom I hadn't known, whose name of course I'd forgotten. And what had happened was that he was living in the forests in Sri Lanka in a three-sided hut – I mean he was living there with a three-sided hut, that means that one side was completely open to tarantulas, snakes, et cetera. And he's very well known for that, and I do believe there are other monks now living in a similar way.

When he was coming back from alms round, which would have been in the morning, early morning I suppose, from the local villages, an elephant suddenly shot out and ran over him. Now, if an elephant, I'm told, if an elephant wants to kill you, they will definitely kill you. But in this case, it seems they just wanted to shock him or something. But unfortunately, one of its feet landed on this monk's hip and shattered it, of course. And when I saw him, his leg was still up in the air. He'd been to hospital. They tried to do their best. Hopefully he's had it better seen to. Who knows?

Anyway, I had visited Colombo just before this. It was on my way up, you see. So I used to stay at the International Buddhist Center there, which was established by the Bandaranaiques, who were both presidents of the – well, prime ministers at that time of Sri Lanka – especially built for the Mahasi Sayadaw when he visited in about 1956 or something, maybe a bit later, who knows.

And there was a Swedish monk whom I knew there, a friend. And again, I've forgotten his name. And he told me a story about this Danish monk, you see. He said, "Have you heard about it?" I said, "No." He said, "Well, he said he was sitting in lotus under a tree meditating, and a she-elephant passed with a baby elephant, a baby elephant. And the baby elephant was drawn to this figure under a tree and approached it and tried to sit in lotus, fell over and broke his hip."

So you can see what happens when stories are passed along the lines. As the story goes, he actually laid there all night. It was only in the next morning that the villagers recognised he hadn't turned up for alms round and went looking for him. So quite a telling story there about the way we build stories around things.

So putting that aside, let me start this particular discourse. And as I go through, I'll try and make some sort of comments.

"Thus have I heard." Remember, these were all remembered by his attendant, Ananda, who became an Arahant just before the meeting, the big meeting that happened after he died. And it says that "On one occasion, the Blessed One was dwelling at Varanasi in the deer park of Isipatana." So this is the place near present-day Varanasi on the Ganges there. And the deer park at Isipatana, I think it's now known as Sarnath.

"There, the Blessed One addressed the *bhikkhus* of the group of five thus." So he's now with his companions, his old companions. He says, "Bhikkhus, these two extremes should not be followed by one who has gone forth into homelessness. What two? The pursuit of sensual pleasure, of sensual happiness in sensual pleasures, which is low, vulgar, the way of worldlings, ignoble, unbeneficial. And the pursuit of self-mortification, which is painful, ignoble and unbeneficial. Without veering towards either of these extremes, the Tathagata has awakened to the middle way, which gives rise to vision, which gives rise to knowledge, which leads to peace, to direct understanding, to enlightenment and to *Nibbāna*."

Now, these two extremes – so by one who's gone forth into homelessness, so he's obviously talking to people who are wandering mendicants. But here we can translate this as anybody who's on a spiritual path, right? This isn't just for monks and nuns. This is for anybody who is on a spiritual path wanting to be released from all suffering.

So he says the pursuit of sensual pleasure, sensual happiness in sensual pleasure. So remember, it's not the object itself that we want. It's not the good food, the sex, drugs and rock and roll. It's how we personally feel happy, excited when we have those things. He says this is low, you see, vulgar, the way of worldlings, ignoble and unbeneficial. So we have to stop it. That's the message there. In fact, it's more than unbeneficial. It produces addiction, doesn't it? That's the problem with depending on sensual pleasures in order to make ourselves happy. They become a dependency.

And the next one is the pursuit of self-mortification, which is painful, ignoble and unbeneficial. Now, this self-mortification is really about blaming the body. It refers, I think, specifically to the practice of those days. The Jain leader was one of the – what was well known for this practice, and he was an elder contemporary of the Buddha, and there's some suggestion that the Buddha might have spent some time or at least visited him or whatever. But he was definitely practising self-mortifications for four years it said, and the main thing of course was to draw the body down, not indulge in any of the senses. He said he got so thin he could hold his spine through his stomach. So if you try that, you can see he's very, very, very thin.

And the understanding was that it's the body that's at fault. You wouldn't have lusty thoughts if you didn't have eyes. You start blaming the body for your problems. You wouldn't be greedy if the body didn't have appetite. So you start working with the body to draw down its sensual pleasures. And that way you stop these reactions which lead you to more suffering. But he, of course, found this to be painful. Well, it's painful, of course, yes. Ignoble, so it wasn't leading on the spiritual path. Whenever the word *ariya* is used, it's always about the spiritual path. And it was unbeneficial. He didn't get anything from it. In fact, he said it was just more suffering.

There was, of course, a philosophy that underpinned this idea. And that was that the body itself was your *kamma*. And that if you could just let go of the body, just let it go, the soul would rise naturally to an eternal heavenly place. And this

definitely is true. The philosophy that underpinned Jainism – and a saint in Jainism is one who stops eating, basically, and often very elderly people will do so with that understanding. So the Buddha didn't think that was beneficial, right?

Now when he says the middle path, you see, it's not in between sensual pleasure and self-mortification. It's not you can have a bit of sensual pleasure and a bit of self-mortification and you'll find the way out. No, it's above, it's transcendent of it, right? The middle path has nothing to do with either the path of self-indulgence or the path of self-aversion. So this word "middle" has to be understood as a path which is transcendent of these other two unbeneficial paths.

And then he says, "Well, what is the middle way awakened to by the Tathagata?" Remember that the word *Tathāgata* means, translates as "thus gone," which isn't particularly helpful. He's transcendent. He's gone, in his own words, he's gone beyond. Gone beyond. And he says, "What is that middle way awakened to by the Tathagata which leads to Nibbāna? It is this Noble Eightfold Path: right view, right intention, right speech, right action, right livelihood, right effort, right mindfulness and right concentration. This is the middle way awakened to by the Tathagata, which gives rise to vision" – so a direct seeing – "which gives rise to knowledge, a direct understanding, leads to peace, to direct understanding, to enlightenment or awakening and to Nibbāna."

So the first one is, "This is the noble truth of suffering." So remember that word *dukkha* has a whole meaning going from the smallest dissatisfaction, irritation, to the highest, the most terrible sufferings that we're capable of, and it's also an existential suffering which comes to us when death approaches. So "birth is suffering, aging is suffering, illness is suffering, death is suffering." So there we have it, you see. "The union with what is displeasing is suffering, and separation from what is pleasing is suffering." So getting, having to deal with something that we don't like, and having not to be able to get what we do like. I mean, these are sufferings for people, for us who are committed to trying to find some sort of permanent happiness in this life form. And then finally "not to get what one wants," of course. So we've done that. "And the five aggregates subject to clinging are suffering." Now we haven't got time to go into the five aggregates this evening, but some other time. So these five aggregates really refer to what we would call the psychophysical organism, and this is what we identify with, and that identity is of course the root cause of our suffering.

"Now this is the noble truth of the origin of suffering," or the cause of suffering. "It is this craving that leads to renewed existence, accompanied by delight and lust, seeking delight here and there. It is the craving for sensual pleasures, craving for becoming, craving for annihilation." So our general motivation is to keep living. Like, we want to wake up tomorrow morning for instance. And what we're chasing, this business of pleasure and trying to get rid of what is unpleasant, and that's what this whole desire is concerned with.

So the word *taṇhā* translates as desire or sometimes craving, which is a bit strong. It can be a craving, of course. But there's no English word which gets across the idea of a desire which is constantly unwholesome. And that's what *taṇhā* refers to. There is another word for desire, *chanda*, which can be either good or bad. But *taṇhā* is a specific word which refers to those desires that are unwholesome for us, whether we're wanting or not wanting.

And so the more fundamental desire, of course, is to keep living, to keep becoming, to keep being me. And the desire to exterminate or to commit suicide, basically, is the opposite of that. In a more gentle way, the desire to become is always to put myself first, to make sure that I'm okay, that's how it manifests. And the desire to annihilate can be as simple as not being able to handle something and just falling asleep. And that's some of the problems of dullness and lethargy we get in our meditation – it's based upon that attitude, not wanting to be with anything that's painful or upsetting. So you fall asleep. So sleep becomes a way of suppressing it, keeping it out of consciousness.

So that's the second noble truth. The third noble truth is the cessation of suffering. "It is the remainderless fading away and cessation of that same craving, the giving up and relinquishing of it, freedom from it, non-reliance on it." So that craving, that *taṇhā*, that unwholesome wanting, that unskillful wanting, not wanting – that's what has to go. And a word for it would be reactivity, just reacting to things, not responding from wisdom, not responding from a position where we understand, but always reacting from this deluded place.

Now, we don't do that always, obviously, but often we do. And what we're doing is reinforcing an old habit of ours. It's so easy to fall into old habits. Old habits die hard. But in a sense, that sounds so simple, just get rid of this wrong desire. But of course, what we discover is that that is quite a challenge. It's more than a lifetime's work if you believe in rebirth.

And finally, "the noble truth of the path leading to the cessation of this suffering is the Eightfold Path." And just quickly before we begin, because I want to do the Eightfold Path finally tomorrow. I'm absolutely determined.

The noble truth of suffering, having stated what it is, he says, "This is what has to be fully understood." You have to understand it. And it's not just basic intellectual understanding, of course, but a direct understanding through personal experience. And part of that is the process of meditation, *vipassanā*. And then he says, as far as I'm concerned, "This has been fully understood."

The noble truth of suffering, the origin of it, he says, has to be abandoned. This is what we have to abandon completely. And then he goes on to say that he has, in fact, abandoned it.

The noble truth of end of suffering has to be realised, a direct personal experience of a *nibbānic* moment. And he says that, of course, he has actually experienced that too.

And then, of course, the path itself is something that is to be developed. And, of course, he goes on to say that this has been developed. So that's the process of becoming fully liberated from suffering.

"So long, *bhikkhus*, as my knowledge and vision of these four noble truths as they really are in their three phases and twelve aspects" – that's what we've just been through – "was not thoroughly purified in this way, I did not claim to have awakened to the unsurpassed perfection, to the unsurpassed perfect enlightenment in this world, with its *devas*, gods, Mara and Brahma" – those are the higher gods – "and in this generation of ascetics and brahmins, its *devas* and humans." *Devas* are the beings around us. "But when my knowledge and vision of the Four Noble Truths, as they really are in their three phases and twelve aspects, was thoroughly purified in this way, then I claimed to have awakened to the unsurpassed perfect enlightenment in this world. Unshakable is the liberation of my mind. This is my last birth. Now there is no more renewed existence." This is the knowledge and vision that arose in me.

"This is what the Blessed One said and elated, the *bhikkhus* of the group of five delighted in the Blessed One's statement."

And while this discourse was being spoken, there arose in the Venerable Kondañña the dust-free, stainless vision of the Dhamma. Whatever is subject to a beginning is subject to an end. Everything arises and passes away.

And when the wheel of the Dhamma had been set in motion by the Blessed One, the earth-dwelling devas raised a cry: "At Bārāṇasī in the deer park of Isipatana, the unsurpassed wheel of the Dhamma has been set in motion by the Blessed One, which cannot be stopped by any ascetic or Brahmin or deva or Māra or Brahmā or anyone in the world."

And having heard the cry of the earth-dwelling devas, the devas of the realms of the four kings raised the same cry. And from there to the Tāvatiṃsa devas and the Yāma devas, the Tusita devas, the Nimmānaratī devas, and the devas of the Brahmā's company raise the cry: "At Bārāṇasī in the deer park at Isipatana, this unsurpassed wheel of Dhamma has been set in motion by the Blessed One, which cannot be stopped by any ascetic or Brahmin or deva or Māra or Brahmā or anyone in that world."

Thus, at that moment, at that instant, at that second, the cry spread as far as the Brahmā world, and this ten-thousand-fold world system shook, quaked and trembled, and an immeasurable, glorious radiance appeared in the world, surpassing the divine majesty of the devas.

Then the Blessed One uttered this inspired utterance: "Kondañña has indeed understood. Kondañña has indeed understood." And in this way, the Venerable Kondañña acquired the name of Añña Kondañña—Kondañña, the one who knows.

So that's a lovely poetic remembrance of the effect of turning the wheel of the Dhamma for us poor human beings.

The Gratification, the Danger and the Escape

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 43 min

Originally given as *The Gratification, the Danger and the Escape* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this dharma talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma presents the Buddha's own teaching framework that he claimed was essential to his awakening: understanding gratification (assāda), danger (ādīnava), and escape (nissaraṇa) in relation to the world. Drawing from key suttas, Bhante explains how we naturally seek gratification through sensual pleasures and emotional fulfillment, yet this very seeking creates psychological suffering through attachment, fear of loss, and the inevitable disappointment when pleasures fade.

The talk traces how our identity formation from childhood creates a pattern of seeking comfort and avoiding discomfort, leading to the complex web of greed, hatred, and delusion. Bhante emphasizes that the Buddha didn't deny the reality of worldly pleasures, but recognized their impermanent nature and the suffering that arises from our attachment to them. The 'danger' lies not in the experiences themselves, but in our relationship to them.

Most importantly, the discourse illuminates the 'escape' (nissaraṇa) - not as annihilation or withdrawal from the world, but as a fundamental shift in consciousness that transcends attachment while remaining fully engaged with life. Through mindfulness practice, we learn to observe our intentions and reactions, finding moments of choice that lead to genuine freedom. This teaching offers both theoretical understanding and practical guidance for developing the factors of awakening in daily meditation practice.

Namo tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā-sambuddhassa Namō tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā-sambuddhassa Namō tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā-sambuddhassa — Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-enlightened one.

I want to bring all the teachings together using a schema that the Buddha himself seems to have liked very much. In fact, he said that until he'd understood the world this way, he hadn't attained the unsurpassed perfect enlightenment. So these three moments are important. They're translated as gratification, danger and escape.

Let me read the discourse. It's only a short one. "O monks, I set out seeking the gratification in the world. Whatever gratification there is in the world, that I have found. I have clearly seen with wisdom just how far the gratification in the world extends. I set out seeking the danger in the world. Whatever danger there is in the world, that I found. I have clearly seen with wisdom just how far the danger in the world extends. I set out seeking an escape from the world. Whatever escape there is from the world, that I have found. I have clearly seen with wisdom how far the escape from the world extends."

And to complement that, in another discourse he says: "If, monks, there were no gratification in the world, beings would not become enamoured with the world. But it is because there is gratification in the world that beings become enamoured with it. If there were no danger in the world, beings would not become disenchanted with the world. But because there is danger in the world, beings become disenchanted with it. And if there were no escape from the world, beings could not escape from it. But as there is an escape from the world, beings can escape from it."

So this little schema — gratification, danger and escape. None of this will come as a surprise; it's what you've been listening to all the time you've been here. The word "gratification" — I looked it up because I think it's a good translation. I tended to use "satisfaction," but Bhikkhu Bodhi uses "gratification," and I think it's actually a better word in some ways. The dictionary gave two examples: "She was gratified to see the shock in Jim's face" and one that shouldn't surprise us — "a thirst for sexual gratification." So this word has a slightly stronger meaning than satisfaction. It suggests compulsive behaviour, a demanding nature about the desire we have. For that reason, I think it's probably a slightly better word for us.

If we go back to the Buddha's own life story, there's a little incident which comes up when he's having a good time — sex, drugs and rock and roll, shall we say — and he's just had a party. He wakes up in the middle of the night and sees all these men and women, dishevelled, saliva dripping from their mouths. He goes into great detail about how disgusting it was. It's that moment when he wakes up

from the gratification he'd had from the party before. There's something about the search for gratification in the sensual world. Why is it that we seek happiness there?

There's no denial on the Buddha's part that there is gratification in the world. There is gratification in ice cream and Costa coffee and all those things we enjoy. It's not that he denies that — it would be foolish of him to do so. So what is it that draws us to that? Why is it that we seek it there?

If we go back a little into the sequence of our psychology, remember that we're born into this frame, this body. Right from the beginning, we're seeking milk because it's nice to taste and it comforts us. We seek the touch of our mothers. There's an immediate connection right there — even in the womb, they say, with the voice of your mother — where the unborn and the born child finds pleasure. And this pleasure isn't just physical, is it? It's actually an emotional well-being, a sense of being protected and close to some other being.

So it's right there at the beginning of our experience. It shouldn't be strange for us to realise that even though it's not an intellectual thing, there's an immediate, total identity with that experience. Obviously the child's not saying, "This is me." It's just the way they experience life — a total identity with what they're experiencing. And I think that goes on. An ordinary person, I would say, would say that they are what they experience, in that total identity way.

What we tend to do is try to develop comfort around us. We want to be comfortable. Even in our sitting posture, if it gets a bit uncomfortable, there's that urge to move. If you watch yourself watching TV sometimes, there's a shuffle here and there — as soon as it becomes slightly uncomfortable, we move the body. Even at that very basic physical level, we're always trying to be comfortable.

When it comes to the more delightful things — what we eat, our friendships and all that — then of course there's an added factor of real delight. There's loveliness in life, there's beauty in life, there's all the things we enjoy. None of this the Buddha would have denied — there is gratification, there is gratification. So if you go through the whole gamut of your experiences where you've been happy — from ordinary basic things like eating, to lovely times in relationships, being out in the country, listening to beautiful music, and in meditation sometimes these beautiful states of mind arise — all that is given. They're going to come, hopefully, till we die. It's not that we're going to disappear because we meditate — I hope not. So there's always that part of life which gives us comfort, pleasure, joy — all those things.

Even in our meditation, we're trying to develop these factors of enlightenment to the point where they are just the way we are. So there is that calmness, that equanimity and openness. And what that means, of course, is there's no fear — it's fear that stops us being open, isn't it? There's just a quiet attention to things. And then there are the four great *Brahmavihāras* — the dwelling place of the Brahmas, the great gods, perhaps better understood as the illimitables: love, compassion, joy and peace. That's the Buddha mind or the Buddha heart, shall we say — always in that state.

Sometimes I think we get the impression through the coolness of *vipassanā* meditation that you end up being soulless or emotionless — a little bit like a dried prune, I suppose, but very wise. It isn't like that, is it? The Buddha says he feels joyful, he feels happy, he feels compassionate. His experience of life at the emotional level is always in these lovely, beautiful states. But somehow he's not fooled by it. In this sense he's not gratified.

So what is it that makes the joys and pleasures of life ultimately unsatisfactory, not in the end gratifying? Basically it's very simple, isn't it? The fact that they arise and pass away. Just when you think you've got everything sorted, life chucks a spanner and that's the end of it. You try to build up a life which is meaningful and fulfilling — good job, good relationship, all that — and then your partner dies or they leave, or the job suddenly disappears. There's nowhere you can rest.

I love the sayings of Jesus on that: "The birds have their nests and the foxes their holes, but the son of man has nowhere to put his head." That's it, isn't it? There's nowhere in this world that a human being is going to be comfortable in that total way.

And when we come to investigate the psychology around pleasure, we see all these downsides. There's the frustration that comes from the attachment you've built, the dependency on what's giving you happiness — frustration when you can't get it. There's the fear of losing it, all the insurance we have to buy just in case we do lose it and can buy another one. And then there's the grief, of course, when you do lose it. There's a whole messy psychology in the aftermath of having indulged in something pleasurable or joyful.

That connection, that identity, is the root cause, isn't it? It's because I'm saying "I am" — I am, or I have. There's that peculiar connection with things, very subtle, but it manifests mainly in these negative emotions and that indulgence. So it's catching that, understanding that, where we begin to see the danger. There's the danger of it. In fact, these things hurt.

Having seen that danger, one seeks for the escape. That's the Buddha. He saw the danger of the emptiness, the vacuity of sensual pleasure. It wasn't going anywhere. That's when he leaves, prepared even to leave his wife and his child that was just born. Those sorts of decisions wouldn't have been taken lightly, would they? People are called away from their families for various reasons — for war — and in this case the Buddha felt, or the Bodhisattva as he would have been then, just compelled to go and try to work out what was at the core of his deep-seated unhappiness.

When you get to that level, you're really at an existential level of suffering. What I mean by that is questions of why am I alive, why am I conscious? And in the Buddha's more immediate experiential question: why am I suffering? He couldn't work it out. In the evening when we go through these recollections on sickness, old age and death — which refer back to the mythical way they explain how the Buddha slowly came to awaken to these factors of life, seeing somebody who was sick, old and dying while he was out in his chariot, remember — he also sees an ascetic sitting under a tree. And that awakens in him: is there an escape? Is there a possibility of an escape?

Now, going back a little on the psychology of this, remember that because of this deep identity we have with this life form, with being a human being, there isn't just that side of greed. There isn't just lust and seeking happiness in the sensual world — you can put it all as indulgence or acquisitiveness. As soon as we hold on to something, we put a fence around it, a barrier, and that defines what our pleasures are. Anything beyond that boundary becomes unpleasant, something we don't want or don't need. Our attitude to something unpleasant but neither here nor there is to ignore it. That's what we mean by neutral feelings. We don't get particularly angry about it; we just don't notice it.

But as soon as these things outside this fence, outside this boundary, begin to look dangerous to us, begin to look as though they're undermining what we own and identify with, then you start getting these negative things — aversion, the pushing away, the anger and hatred and spite. All of that comes under this: there's been some aversion. In our meditation, it's boredom. That's an aversive state — boredom. And included in that, remember, is that when these things seem to be undermining us, seem to be overpowering us, we start getting this other side of anxiety and fear. It all comes down to this basic position of seeking gratification in the world.

Once we've established in childhood this way of behaving, you can see how it moves into another layer of psychology when we hit the whole problem of good and evil. When we do good and attach to it, then of course you get into the downside of really using compassion, using love, using sympathetic joy in order to make yourself happy. When the other person doesn't appreciate what you've done, you feel hurt, you feel broken, you feel angry. "What I've done for you" — all that.

On the other side you've got the evil — evil in the sense of doing what is harmful. It can be something rather unskillful, which is neither here nor there. But we're capable of doing great evil, really doing something tremendously harmful both to ourselves and to other beings. Then you get into all that other psychology of guilt and shame and remorse. You can see how all this builds up and up until you get this massive human suffering stuck in this fathom-long body, as the Buddha would call it.

When you're meditating, of course, all this starts to come up, doesn't it? It's like — I think I say on one of the tapes — like lifting a lid off a dustbin. Suddenly it all comes up. Suddenly the depression comes up, and you've got to see it as a consequence of past conditioning. You've got to see that actually, we've manufactured this. It hasn't come because your mother hit you around the ear with a banana when you were three years old, as she might have done. It's how you reacted to this banana which is causing all this problem.

Now that doesn't mean childhood is fraught with both ecstatic joy and disaster. It needn't be that any parent has actually, physically or purposefully done you harm. You can just fall off a bed and it becomes a catastrophe that remains as a trauma inside you. But even so, that's how the child has reacted, and there's that continuation of all those things we learn in childhood throughout life — until we get really bad and then we look and we try to find an answer. We come to meditation.

When we're meditating, we're opening the gates. We're opening ourselves up to all the stuff that's been suppressed. But also, from this understanding, we're beginning to see the danger of this wrong relationship we have to the world.

It's seeing that danger which is painful. It's hard to sit with it. It's hard to bear with some of the stuff that comes up. But there's no other way. There doesn't seem to be any other way of curing our psychology except in this conscious way. Drugs don't help — they just suppress the physical frame, don't they? And then you feel

good, but when the drug passes, oh, it's even worse. I don't know of any spiritual practice whereby you don't have to go through this purging, this purgatory, this process of purification. It's just a matter of fact.

But if you understand it as a growth in consciousness, as a growth in wisdom, then you see there's no other way. Because how else would you know that the gratification is wrong? How else would you know that there is danger? How else would you seek the end of suffering?

If you see that what you're doing through your meditation is discovering a wiser way of being with the world, then in a sense you're prepared to go through the purgatory. And I think when you actually go through it, when you actually see that it is a process of healing, you're more and more open to it. That's important.

It's important that you actually see there is gratification and that somehow something goes wrong with it. This is what we mean by indulgence — whether it's indulgence in something pleasant or indulgence in something outwardly unpleasant, like anger. But it is pleasing to let go of your anger and bang the door and bump somebody on the nose. That's gratification — to finally get your own back. But it's not particularly skillful, it's not really wise.

It's actually beginning to see that, that we begin to see the path out. And that's the next business of it: the *nissaraṇa*, the escape. If there were no escape in the world, then, boy, we'd be miserable, wouldn't we? And people who get themselves into these dead ends — the meaninglessness of life, or a religious person who thinks they're damned. I've met a few people like that. What do you do? They're damned. In Buddhist terms, that's to really believe there's no escape from *saṃsāra*.

That whether you like it or not, you'll be reborn and reborn and reborn — first as a shrew in a meditation room, and then you get chucked out with a bit of cheese into a paddock, and then you're reborn as a human being picking up a shrew and chucking it out. There's this constant *saṃsāra*, this onward going. In the Buddha's day, that was the horror. It wasn't ecological disaster; it was this thing about having to be reborn and reborn and reborn again.

There's a lovely conversation in one of the scriptures — I can't remember the details now — where two of the Buddha's cousins, if I remember rightly, discuss whether to follow Gautama and take up the robe and bowl. The argument goes something like, "Look, what is life? You've got to go out there, you've got to plow the ground, you've got to harvest the seed, you've got to eat it, and then you do it

again next year. It's really boring." One of them gets really into this and says, "Yeah, you're right," and he goes off with the other fellow. The second one says, "No, it's for you. I'm still enjoying this." So he doesn't leave — he's still getting something out of the life form. But it was this fellow who pointed out to the man who finally leaves how terrible life is in this boring, repetitious way. I think that would have been perhaps more obvious to people in those days, in some ways anyway, because there wasn't this huge entertainment industry.

It reminds me of an old pre-war comedian. He's on London Bridge and he's going to jump, and the policeman sees him and calls him over. They start having this big discussion about life — why suicide? The policeman's arguing that life's worth it, and the comedian is arguing how useless it is. The conversation goes on and on, and finally they both jump off the bridge. That's brilliant. "Yeah, you're right!"

This finding of the escape — that's the Buddha's great thing, isn't it? He says what he's discovered, he hasn't invented. He says this is an ancient path; he's just rediscovered it. It's not as though he's the first human being that's ever done it. He doesn't claim to be that. In fact, in the mythology of Buddhism, there are Buddhas previous to him — going back I don't know how many times — twenty-eight previous Buddhas named in previous huge eons of world systems. It was just the way you begin to think when you think of time being cyclic. I think I mentioned this morning that the years just roll over, just keep going, and the whole universe is expanding and then it'll collapse, and then it expands again and collapses. There's that idea that this has been going on ever since. He says he doesn't see the beginning of kamma. He doesn't see that there is a beginning — it's always been like this. Presumably in that sense he doesn't see the end of that process, but as an individual he found an escape.

Now this escape — be careful here — because this escape, as hopefully you've all come to realise in your meditation, is not the destruction of the world. There's a very interesting discourse in which somebody asks him, "Where do the four mahābhūtas come to an end?" The four mahābhūtas, the four great elements, are earth, fire, water, and air, and they constitute the physical universe. What the person is asking is: where does all this come to an end? And the Buddha says, "It's the wrong question." He says, "Where do they not find a footing?" It's very interesting. Where do they not find a footing? In other words, is there an experience, something experiential, where you will not find these — but it doesn't deny their existence or destroy them or annihilate them?

He goes on to say there is a consciousness not touched by the five or six senses — a consciousness not coloured by them. There's no hearing, no seeing, no thought, nothing. And yet it is without boundary. The reason it's without boundary is because there are no phenomena. You've got to have something to create a boundary. If there's nothing in this universe, then it's empty space — no boundary in it. It's the things we have that create boundaries for us. And he says there is this consciousness which is without boundary, and in all directions full of light.

He's pointing there to an experience which is a total escape from the world. Now remember, when we say an escape, he's still there. It's not as though he's disappeared in a puff of smoke and there's just this mystical voice arising from nowhere. This escape is not the destruction of anything.

Again, when they ask him whether he believes in any form of annihilation, he says no. Everything arises depending on something else, and there's no annihilation. The only things that are annihilated, he says, are greed, hatred, and delusion. And greed, hatred, and delusion are this way of expressing the wrong relationship we have to the world — which in a psychological sense is this seeking gratification. That's what he means by desire. When we chant *taṇhā* in the morning, that's what he's referring to.

But remember there's a completely different psychology — the psychology of the Buddha, the psychology of the enlightened beings. It doesn't have that downer, doesn't have that gratification, doesn't have all the downers of gratification: the grief, the fear, the anger, the frustration. It doesn't have any anger, doesn't have any fear. The fearless one — that's one of the epithets of the Buddha. He's fearless. What's he afraid of? There's no connection to the world whereby suffering could arise.

That escape is suggestive of all the Buddha's teachings concerning the practice which leads us to this point of liberation. It's an escape — like escaping from prison, like you're finally released.

This is where our practice comes in, because it's a fundamental practice. What we're learning is not only to see that gratification is wrong because it has these dangers, but to see this escape. That's all we're doing — we're just seeing where the escape is. And the more the escape becomes clearer to us, the more we'll practise, because it's like when you see the finishing line you really want to go for it.

Even in our practice, when we're confused or don't think we're getting anywhere or don't think we're progressing — that's a regular one for meditators — because you still keep doing these pratfalls and you think, well, I'm still as I was before. If you have those sorts of feelings, those sorts of ideas about yourself, remember that all those come from this gratification. You're now seeking gratification, as it were, in the spiritual life — seeking a certain type of comfort there. And that comfort usually comes from the sense of achieving.

But if you abandon those ideas of trying to achieve anything and draw that word simply into moment-to-moment mindfulness, then you're always achieving, as long as you're mindful. You're always here. And that mindfulness, that sharp mindfulness, is a guard — because as we begin to realise, the problem starts with these intentions. When we see these intentions and we're awake, bright with it, not caught up in it, not suddenly dashing off and doing something, then that gives us that moment of choice. And we begin to see: oh, here's the escape, here's the escape.

When we access that point within us which is the observer — that's not the fullest escape because there's still a sense of me there — but we can see that it's an escape from all the pain the body might offer us. From there we can feel the pain, see the reaction to pain, allow the reaction of fear and aversion to die away, and find this equanimity, this peacefulness with pain — just this patient forbearance. That's an escape. It's an escape from all the fear and anxiety we have around the body.

It's the same with emotions. When you distance them, when you can feel them there rather than being them, it's an escape, isn't it? You've transcended them. You're in a different position. You're not identifying with them, not possessing them. You're saying, "Oh, look — there's anger. See, there's grief. There's depression." And it's seeing that clearly that we begin to say, "Oh, here's the escape. Here's the escape."

That doesn't mean to say it's easy — it's very difficult, in fact, to stay with these mental states as they arise. But the more we see that this is the escape, the more we'd be happy to stay there. The more we see it actually as a place where there's healing going on.

And then finally — this all takes a long time — there's always going to be that little bit of self left right to the bitter end. It's not going to let go. There's always going to be these pratfalls on the way, always going to be moments when we feel we've slipped back and we're not moving forward. But we have to keep remind-

ing ourselves that this is an onward going. This is a long-term commitment. In the Buddhist sense we're talking lifetimes, not just this life. It's a whole process that we're going through.

So there we have it — these three ways of looking at our practice: to be aware of where we're seeking comfort, where we're seeking gratification; to see that greed, that lust, the avarice. We've got lovely big words for all of it, all centring around the four great lusts: power, riches, fame, and sensual pleasure. Everybody wants to be famous, powerful, and rich. That's pretty simple. And those are your four main areas, aren't they?

It's just to see how the mind is constantly moving that way, always trying to achieve that particular state. Renunciation is the point where we allow that desire to fade away, to begin to release itself. As I pointed out this morning, we let any desire fade away and then stay with it long enough to see what the mind is, what the heart is, when there's no desire there — to see that lovely contentment. And then with it comes the peace. Hopefully you're beginning to experience this even during these times of quiet abiding, where we're trying to develop the more passive factors of enlightenment: calmness of the body, just being still; calmness of the heart, stillness; the silence of the mind. All of that comes under calmness, in a way.

Every so often, just be like that — resting within the present moment, relaxing into it, wide awake. And then, when it passes, ask yourself: what was that like? Was that a pleasant place to be? Now fair enough, we can get attached to that too, and then our practice becomes a sort of quietism — just seeking this lovely quiet place. Leave me alone. Get out of my way.

But of course that's balanced, because we then bring in the more active factors of the process: the interest, the wanting to see; the effort to begin to see things; the effort to remain at that point of interest; and the investigation of the Dhamma.

During your day, try to balance these things. Go through your day and say, "Well, this is when I'm practising samatha-type meditation, peaceful abiding, and this is when I'm doing vipassanā." Get to know yourself. Know where your weak points are during the day. Say, "Here I mustn't fall asleep again," or "Here I just let my mind go — I give up effort at this particular point." Catch your rhythm. These patterns are probably connected to the natural rhythms of our bodies, the circadian rhythms as they call them. There's all those rhythms going on too. Once we've got to this point of observation, we can see all this happening.

Let me encourage you to keep putting in that little bit of effort. Nick and Sarah have been here now for two weeks. It's coming to the end, so you have to be careful that your energy level doesn't drop. Be more like the long-distance runner — when you see that wire, you've got to put on that little extra spurt to get there. That's important. And this is about your fourth day, isn't it, Haji? Hopefully you'll be more at ease now with the schedule, with the regime. But with that comes a danger: "Well, this is easier now." And there's a drop of commitment, a drop of energy.

So you've got to keep lifting it. You've got to keep seeing where the effort begins to drop, and then very gently push yourself. That's what one of my teachers says: push gently. And then you'll see the energy comes. So keep going. That's all there is to it.

May you be liberated sooner rather than later.

CHAPTER 18

Desire the Root of Suffering

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 12 min

Originally given as *Desire the Root of Suffering* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines a powerful sutta dialogue where the Buddha demonstrates his masterful teaching method. Rather than discussing abstract concepts about past or future suffering, the Awakened One brings the teaching directly into the present moment, asking a village headman about his relationships with people in his town.

Through careful questioning about the headman's attachments to his son and wife, the Buddha reveals how taṇhā (craving or desire based on wrong understanding) creates psychological dependency and becomes the source of all suffering. Bhante Bodhidhamma clarifies that not all desires cause suffering—only those rooted in misunderstanding and seeking happiness in things that cannot truly deliver it.

The talk explores the Second Noble Truth and demonstrates how the Buddha's oral teaching tradition used repetition to allow profound truths to be absorbed rather than merely intellectually understood. Bhante Bodhidhamma guides listeners in understanding how spiritual phrases can transform our thinking through contemplative repetition, drawing parallels with the Benedictine practice of lectio divina. This teaching offers both newcomers and experienced practitioners insight into the Buddha's pedagogical brilliance and practical wisdom for recognizing the roots of suffering in daily life.

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā Sambuddhassa Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā Sambuddhassa Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā Sambuddhassa Homage to the Buddha, the Blessed, Noble and fully self-enlightened.

This particular passage is called the visible origins and passing away of suffering. The reason I want to use it in this little section about approaching the Dharma is that it gives us an even clearer view of how the Buddha taught. It's just nice to see how he very carefully guides people to understanding and reinforces it.

I'll read through and then we'll stop for little comments. On one occasion, the Blessed One was dwelling at the town of the Melians named Uruvelacapa. Then Bhadraka, the headman, approached the Blessed One, paid homage to him, sat down to one side and said, "It would be good, Venerable Sir, if the Blessed One would teach me about the origin and passing away of suffering."

"If, headman, I were to teach you about the origin and passing away of suffering with reference to the past, saying 'so it was in the past,' perplexity and uncertainty about that might arise in you. And if I were to teach you about the origin and passing away of suffering with reference to the future, saying 'so it will be in the future,' perplexity and uncertainty about what might happen might arise in you. Instead, headman, while I'm sitting right here and you're sitting right there, I'll teach you about the origin and passing away of suffering. Now listen and attend closely and I will speak."

The Blessed One said, "Now what do you think, headman? Are there any people in Uruvelacapa on whose account sorrow, lamentation, pain, dejection and despair would arise in you if they were to be executed, imprisoned, fined or censured?" "There are such people, Venerable Sir." "But are there any people in Uruvelacapa on whose account sorrow, lamentation, pain, dejection and despair would not arise in you in such event?" "There are such people." "So why is it, headman, that in relation to some people in Uruvelacapa, sorrow, lamentation, pain, dejection and despair would arise in you if they were to be executed, imprisoned, fined or censured, while in regard to others they would not arise in you?"

"Those people in Uruvelacapa, Venerable Sir, in relation to whom sorrow, lamentation, pain, dejection and despair would arise in me if they were executed, imprisoned, fined or censured—these are the ones for whom I have desire and attachment. And those in relation to whom they would not arise in me—these are the ones I have no desire and attachment for. Probably the opposite."

"Headman, by means of this principle that is seen, understood, immediately attained, fathomed, apply the method to the past and the future thus: Whatever suffering arose in the past, all that arose rooted in desire, with desire as its source,

for desire is the root of suffering. Whatever suffering will arise in the future, all that will arise rooted in desire, with desire as its source, for desire is the root of suffering."

And you get this and the usual great praise. "It's wonderful, Venerable Sir, it's amazing, Venerable Sir, how well that was stated by the Blessed One." And then he tells the Buddha what he just heard: "Whatever suffering arises, all that is rooted in desire, has desire as its source, for desire is the root of suffering." That's what therapists do, isn't it? They listen to you and then they tell you what they've just heard. He's pretty good to tell the Buddha that in fact he's just heard what he said.

Now you'll notice here that the Buddha always starts with what a person can experience right here and now. He doesn't start talking about suffering and pain in the past—like why did it happen in the past, now I've got this pain, if I do this, what will happen? He brings it right down to the very present, to the very present now, and he's just asking a very simple question: If anybody whom you have a love for, an attachment for, were to suffer some sort of misfortune, would you suffer for them? Yeah, I would. But of course, other people whom you don't know, or those people whom you dislike—as a result, you might rejoice.

Very quickly he brings the person to understand this role of desire. Now remember that whenever we're talking about desire we're always talking about a specific type of desire, because translating words from one language into another is always very difficult to get the exact translation. This desire is translating the word *taṇhā*, and *taṇhā* is the desires that we have based on wrong understanding, and that wrong understanding is seeking happiness in something which is not going to deliver basically that. What happens is we form a psychological dependency on something, and that's where the problem lies.

Desires to do with wanting to become liberated, desires coming out of a pure act of love or a pure act of generosity or an act of compassion or joy—like giving somebody a present for their birthday but doing it just for the joyfulness of it, to increase the other person's joy—all those desires are to our benefit. They make the heart grow. But as soon as something creeps in there which is to do with "I give a present so somebody will like me," then I'm into a relationship which eventually can cause me suffering.

Now he wants to reinforce that, so he gets more personal. This man repeats to the Buddha, "This is the root of desire." And then he tells him, "Look, Venerable Sir, I have a son called Chiravasi who stays at an outside residence. And I rise

early and send a man, saying, 'Go, man, and find out how Chiravasi is.' And until that man returns, Venerable Sir, I'm upset, thinking, 'I hope Chiravasi has not met with any affliction.'" So there's a parent's worry.

"And what do you think, headman," replies the Buddha, "if Chiravasi were to be executed, imprisoned, fined or censured, would sorrow, lamentation, pain, dejection and despair arise in you?" "Venerable Sir, if Chiravasi were to be executed, imprisoned, fined or censured, even my life would seem futile. So how could sorrow, lamentation, pain, dejection and despair not arise in me?" "In this way too, headman, it's to be understood: Whatever suffering arises, all that arises rooted in desire, with desire as its source, for desire is the root of suffering."

Now, you have to make these statements, you have to repeat them and let them sink in. They have to be digested. What the Buddha is saying is: whatever suffering arises, all that arises rooted in desire. You have to keep repeating that. Remember, suffering is not the same as pain, physical pain. That's a given. But whatever suffering arises, all that arises rooted in desire. With desire as its source, for desire is the root of suffering.

These phrases have a real power when you just gently repeat them to yourself in the quietness, in some way in which you can feel the digestion. You don't have to think about it, because it's going in—it's like osmosis, you're absorbing it, and it's actually beginning to change your attitude by doing that. That's the way spiritual reading works. You don't have to think about it.

And then he wants to really drive it home. This is the final nail. "What do you think, headman? Before you saw your wife or heard about her, did you have any desire, attachment or affection for her?" "No, Venerable Sir." "Then was it, headman, only when you saw her or heard about her that this desire, attachment and affection arose in you?" "Yes, Venerable Sir."

"Now what do you think, headman? If your wife were to be executed, imprisoned, fined or censured, would sorrow, lamentation, pain and despair arise in you?" "Venerable Sir, if my wife were to be executed, imprisoned, fined or censured, even my life would seem futile. So how could sorrow, lamentation, pain, dejection and despair not arise in me?" He drives home the point: "In this way too, headman, it's to be understood. Whatever suffering arises, all that is rooted in desire, with desire as its source, for desire is the root of suffering."

There's something about the oral tradition where you repeat it and repeat it and repeat it. These phrases—when you read the scriptures, when you come across a phrase which catches you, and it doesn't have to be the scriptures, it could be any spiritual work, and a phrase catches you, or a sentence catches you, or even a small paragraph, and you think, "That's interesting"—don't think about it, just keep repeating it, keep repeating it.

There we are. Suffering is rooted in desire. The Second Noble Truth. I can only hope that these words have finally driven home the truth: suffering is in fact rooted in desire. And hopefully you'll work towards your liberation and find *Nibbāna* sooner rather than later.

Sādhu, sādhu, sādhu.

The Three Characteristics of Existence

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 50 min

Originally given as *The Three Characteristics of Existence* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this dharma talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma introduces the three characteristics of existence (tilakkhana) that form the foundation of Buddhist understanding. Beginning with the Four Noble Truths and the meaning of dukkha as 'hard to bear' or 'unsatisfactoriness,' he explains how these characteristics reveal our fundamental delusions about reality.

The talk explores why anicca (impermanence) comes first in practice, examining both momentary and long-term impermanence through death contemplation. Bhante discusses how recognizing impermanence naturally leads to understanding dukkha through paṭicca samuppāda (dependent origination), showing how our wrong view of self creates taṇhā (craving) and psychological suffering.

The final characteristic, anattā (not-self), is explored through the practice of disidentification - learning to observe rather than become our experiences. Using noting techniques with 'there is...' rather than 'I am...', practitioners gradually separate awareness from the psychophysical process. Bhante emphasizes that as delusions are undermined through seeing these three characteristics, wisdom and the brahmavihāra (loving-kindness, compassion, appreciative joy, equanimity) arise naturally. This profound teaching offers both theoretical understanding and practical guidance for insight meditation.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa.

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble, and fully self-enlightened one.

This evening will be, for some of you, just a recap—perhaps an introduction to what are called the three characteristics of existence.

The place to start is really with the Four Noble Truths, because that's where the Buddha begins to express his understanding. And the operative word is *dukkha*. We have to get a hold of that word. Translated directly, it just means hard to bear.

It used to be translated as suffering. When people were told that the Buddha's teaching was "there is suffering and this is the cause of suffering," everybody thought it was very pessimistic. In fact, the first book I read on Buddhism that I remember was one by Dr. Schweitzer, who was a humanist—well, he was a Christian, but very late in life he trained as a doctor and went to work in Africa, and he was known for his humanitarian work. He wrote this book contrasting Christianity to Buddhism, and he declared without a shadow of a doubt that Christianity was life-affirmative and Buddhism was life-negative. I don't know how I overcame that prejudice, but somehow I did.

A lot of it goes back to these early translations. These days, the most common translation is unsatisfactoriness.

In that first noble truth, the Buddha tells us why life is unsatisfactory. He talks about *dukkha-dukkha*, *viparināma-dukkha*, and *saṅkhāra-dukkha*: the unsatisfactoriness of pain and suffering; the unsatisfactoriness caused through impermanence; and the unsatisfactoriness caused by things being compounded, having no substance.

Remember, there's not only the basic suffering, the *dukkha*; there's *dukkha-dukkhatā*, which means the suffering of sufferings. The Buddha is always making a distinction between the facts of life—the sickness, old age, and death which are painful—and the suffering, which is our relationship to it. Always remember that he's not denying there is pain in life. He himself never overcame physical pain. He died in pain from some sort of gastroenteritis.

When he then goes into the second noble truth—that the cause of this is *taṇhā*, this attachment—you see, it's not just our attachment to pleasure. It's our attachment to wrong views: that things do have a certain permanency, that things are truly real and have some substance.

I was with a friend of mine and we were talking about something, and I happened to say, "But the body's unreal." His father, who was standing next to him, blurted out, "Yes it is!" And that was it. He died within a few weeks of that. It was such a punch in the air that the conversation came to an end. You couldn't go anywhere with that sort of statement. Of course, it depends what he meant by real, but definitely the body has no ultimate reality.

These three characteristics are telling us where our delusions lie. Remember, the definition of delusion is that you don't know where you're deluded. If you knew you were deluded, if you knew where you were deluded, you wouldn't be deluded. You might still suffer from the consequences of delusion, but you wouldn't actually be deluded—because that's the whole definition of being deluded.

These three characteristics are trying to define delusion, or rather to counter-define what in those days people were arguing about: what is substantial, what is ultimate reality. The Brahmins opted—generally speaking—for the self, the attā. This attā became more and more refined as time went on. Eventually, both the Brahmins—Brahmanism, which we now call Hinduism—came to the same understanding as Buddhism, but that's another story as to how it was filched. We won't go into that.

What was understood by a self at that time? The self was the centre of its own power. The whole idea was that you were in complete control—that's the first thing. The second was that it was permanent; it wasn't changing, always the same. And the third was that it was happy, always happy. Now if you think about it, if you have complete power over your being, then you could simply say to yourself, "From now on I'm going to be happy," and that'd be it. You would be happy all the time. And that would presume a state of absolute continuity. This was the idea of a soul, an attā, as understood at that time.

What the Buddha is saying is: if there is something substantial, if there is this self—and we would say in our language a spirit or a soul, something eternal—if there is that, how can we discover it? How can we find out what it is? Through the process of negation, which is again the same as in Brahmanism: not this, not that. That process of looking at things and saying "not this, not that" is part of waking up to the way things really are, what we might call reality.

These three avenues of investigation are really trying to clarify for us what can't be ultimate truth, what can't be a real soul or spirit or self.

When it comes to practice, though, it's always anicca which comes first: anicca, dukkha, anattā. We chant this in the morning: sabbe saṅkhārā aniccā ti, sabbe saṅkhārā dukkhā ti, sabbe dhammā anattā ti. All compounded things are impermanent, all compounded things are unsatisfactory, all things don't constitute anything substantial or a self.

Why is it that in our practice we actually start with anicca, with impermanence? If you were to say to anybody in the street, "Everything changes, nothing is permanent in the universe, and this is the deep teaching of the Buddha," they'd look at you and say, "Yeah." It's not as though people aren't aware of change. But it doesn't change their behaviour. It doesn't motivate them to look more deeply into their lives. They just accept it—things change, sometimes for the better, sometimes for the worse. They don't go deeply into the problems that arise when we fail to actually change our lives through the insight into impermanence.

When we see something is impermanent, the natural thing is not to get attached to it. Every time you have something you treasure—it might be a ring, a precious vase, or something of deeper value like a relationship or your work—it's good practice to say, "This too will come to an end." This too will come to an end.

Now, you might think that would send you into a depression. Well, it might. But the point is to be ready for what is inevitably going to happen, because all things come to an end. Seeing anicca, seeing something as impermanent, is about forming a different relationship to the world. It's about really recognising that whatever we have or possess is going to change, going to disappear at some point. It's not going to be there for us.

So that's the first thing. And because we see that when we attach to something without seeing impermanence, we also see that this is the cause of suffering. Anicca, this impermanence, guides us into seeing suffering from the angle of impermanence. That's one way of looking at things.

The way we undermine attachment is by constantly reminding ourselves that things arise and pass away. And the biggest arising and passing away, of course, is being born and then having to die.

So the actual contemplation of death is really a very strong contemplation, which at first might seem a bit lugubrious. It might drive you into jumping off a bridge. But actually what it does is put your life into a certain balance. Because we recognise that life comes to an end, and because of our aim to become liberated, this present moment becomes that much more precious.

If you think that death's going to happen sometime in the vast future, then of course there's no sense of immediacy, no sense of *saṃvega*, that urgency in our practice. So by reminding ourselves that we are one breath away from death, one heartbeat away from death—it's not very far, is it? One heartbeat. Boom, boom. That's it. Finished. Gone. See?

By reminding ourselves that we're on this knife edge, that life can end at any time, we begin to experience life as much more bright, much more alert. We're actually making it more meaningful for ourselves. And that's, of course, where the spiritual practice comes in.

So we really look at impermanence in all its different facets. In the minutest moments—how long does a moment last? How long can you hold one? It's gone, isn't it? And yet the mind creates this sense of continuity for us.

Think about music. You only hear one note at a time, but somehow we hear the whole tune. We capture it as it goes along and think we're actually hearing the whole piece. But it's only one note at a time. The mind has this ability to contain some idea of continuity—without which you couldn't live in the world, for heaven's sake. You'd be waking up everywhere you were. So there has to be that quality of continuity in our ordinary lives. But we're fooled by it into thinking that's the way things are. That's the problem.

Even in the minuscule layer of each moment arising and passing away, we can begin to catch the insecurity of our lives. And it's living with that insecurity which sharpens the present moment.

In the long term, that contemplation every so often—that the end of life is this full stop—puts a pressure on us to make sense of this present moment, not to waste it, not to get lazy. Don't be lazy now and be remorseful afterwards, says the Buddha.

Remember that I mentioned earlier in the week Sunlun, this fierce Arahant, who when asked why people don't become liberated as quickly as him, said: because they're lazy. And we're lazy because we think our lives are just going to carry on. What's the problem?

In the East, where the idea of rebirth comes easily to people—it's just part and parcel of their culture—you do get this sort of laziness. When you ask them, are you working to become liberated? No, I'm building up my bank account of good deeds and virtue. I'll be there when the next Buddha comes. Like, when's that? And of course, when the next Buddha comes, they'll still be there getting in their virtue and building up their good deeds. So sometimes believing that life goes on in this rebirthing process really makes a person lazy.

To bring about this sense of urgency that the Buddha talks about, the recollection of death is a very strong practice. It's right there in the discourse on how to establish right awareness. There he describes, I think, thirteen states of a corpse

rotting on the charnel ground. In those days they would leave the corpse out to be eaten by vultures and wild animals. Monks were instructed—it was the general practice of the day, part of the self-mortification—to go out and watch corpses slowly corrupt and disappear into dust. The commentaries are very helpful. They tell you not to sit windward.

Unfortunately we can't do that these days, but interestingly enough, if you're a monastic and you go to the East—Thailand, Sri Lanka, Burma—the hospitals will let you in to see an autopsy, and that's always quite an interesting thing to see. Most people haven't seen a dead body, most people haven't felt one, and it's quite an experience to actually see one and catch its lifelessness—and how the mind wants to give it life. You look at the face of a corpse, and it's as though the mind wants to give it some sort of expression, some sort of movement, but it just won't. It's dead.

There was a lovely story, while I'm on about it, about a Westerner who went to Sri Lanka and became a monastic. He wanted to do this death meditation as the Buddha described it. Somehow he got permission to take the body of a convict, somebody who had died in prison. He carried this corpse on his back to the cave where he was living. There he built a glass cage with a funnel, put the body in it, and observed the rotting.

When the newspapers heard about this, they declaimed: finally, a real monk. Finally, we've got somebody who can really look at this. Anyway, as the story ends, he eventually left the order and went off to help Mother Teresa in Calcutta, I think. So it must have done something for him.

That's a bit extreme, of course. We needn't do that. Just contemplating our own death is often enough. And every so often when you wake up with a pain you haven't had before, or during the day with a pain, just watch that fear that comes—the fear of death.

It's just something you can bring in as a small daily practice. These practices—the vipassanā, the mettā, the contemplations we do in the evening about sickness, ageing and death—it's just this constant little reminder every day that works. It doesn't take a second, doesn't take any time, just that little reminder every day. And it very slowly changes our attitude to the way we're living.

Now for the other side of anicca. One aspect guides us into dukkha, the suffering. The other, of course, is that because everything is impermanent, nothing has any real substantiality—and this takes us into the anattā teaching about not-self. So starting with anicca gives us a perspective into the other two: into the suffering or unsatisfactoriness, and into the not-self.

But each of these has its own particular viewpoint. When it comes to dukkha, the Buddha expresses it through dependent origination. And in dependent origination, he points very clearly at two places where this whole problem of dukkha, of unsatisfactoriness, rests.

He starts with avijjā, that not knowing. It's through not knowing that we make a mistake and form a wrong relationship with this psychophysical organism, this human being. If you think about it, it's understandable. When we're born, what do we know? You just find yourself in this body. You are this body. It's quite natural that we should think this is what we are. And we end up living with that delusion.

Because of that delusion, we try to seek happiness in this form. That's the driving force of our life, is it not? To seek happiness—however you wish to define it. Some people might define it as a wonderful relationship, others as riches, others as fame, others as lots of money, others as all of that. It depends on how you define your happiness. That's what you're chasing.

And seeking some sort of permanent happy state in the human form always lets us down. It lets us down, firstly, because it's impermanent. But the attachment itself has its own consequence of suffering, which we've been through, especially around pleasure.

Remember what happens: we form our happinesses around things that we collect. These things can be money, fame, power, people—it doesn't matter what it is, we collect them. And the more we collect of these happinesses, the more we feel safe, the more we feel secure, the more we feel happy. A person feels much happier if they have a billion pounds in the bank than if they have one million. Your happiness grows with the amount of money you've got.

So these happinesses are an accumulation of things. And this accumulation now has to be guarded. Other people want what you have—your billion pounds, for a start. Anybody that undermines this happiness must be annihilated as

quickly as possible. There's your aversion, pushing away anything that threatens you. And if what's undermining you is too big to handle, then you've got to run for it.

So there you have your three basic attitudes arising out of this wrong relationship: acquisitiveness, aversion, and fear. Once we've got those attitudes, we start acting upon them. That produces unwholesome actions, which themselves have unwholesome consequences—because it all demands that the world be moved and shifted in order to satisfy my happiness.

From a delusive point of view, I'm constantly manipulating the world so that I can feel comfortable, so that I can feel happy. I'm in constant conflict with the world, except in those small moments when I've finally got it. And then it lasts—what, a couple of seconds, a few days at most—and it's gone. Then I'm back on the trail again, trying to get this happiness.

This manifests as *taṇhā*, this special word the Buddha uses, which we translate as craving. But 'craving' is far too strong because it doesn't include the small attachments, the small little selfishnesses—I'm just taking that big piece of cake while everybody else takes the little one. It's that whole area of grasping, wanting, needing in the psychological sense. That's the attachment. And wherever there's attachment, there's a psychological dependency on it for happiness.

When we describe that happiness, when we say, well, what do I mean when I say I am happy?—I think you'll agree with me that we're talking about a mental state. If I put pleasant food in my mouth but it doesn't make me happy, I just spit it out and try another dish. I'm looking to food to make me happy. I'm looking to a relationship to make me happy. And this happiness always defines a mental state, mainly the emotional content of that mental state. It's never the object itself which is happiness. The object may be the proximate cause of the happiness—something I'm dependent on—but what I'm really trying to do is create a happy state within myself.

Now, that's when the seeing of *anicca* comes in. When you realise that these happiness states are not under your control—that you can bring them up under certain circumstances, but they just change whether you want them to or not, and sometimes the same circumstance that made you happy then doesn't make you happy now—we're constantly, as drug addicts say, chasing the dragon. And that's the point of *taṇhā*.

So what the Buddha's pointing to is, firstly, a profound misunderstanding underneath our lives—one that manifests as greed, aversion, and fear. The consequence of that is guilt, shame, remorse, and so on. And if you don't have guilt, shame, or remorse, then you end up being callous, hard, unfeeling, unforgiving.

In our meditation, what we're trying to do is constantly separate out the given from the reaction. That's the process of seeing how we create suffering for ourselves. The given might be a pleasant mental state, some sort of memory arising here and now. It could be something from a walk in nature that gives us a certain pleasurable feeling. What we're catching is how we relate to that—and how, when it doesn't satisfy us, there's a feeling of disappointment or boredom.

There's a whole psychology around the relationship we have with the world we experience. The practice is catching that, and then not joining in—not identifying with it. Being able to name it, to know it, without identifying with it. Very slowly, this relationship changes: away from wanting to manipulate the world, moving towards 'this is the way it is'—that sort of radical, straightforward acceptance of each and every moment as it arises.

When I was at Kanduboda monastery, I was in the back end of the grounds in my own kuṭi, my own hut. Not far from me—maybe thirty metres through the trees—was a block of rooms built for foreigners, not Sinhalese. There'd be this constant change of people coming in and going out. Some of them were very serious meditators, utterly committed. But some of them were absolute—well, prats, for want of a better word.

They used to complain to the abbot: 'He's doing this, he's doing that.' This was the male section—the female section I didn't know anything about because there was a wall around it. They would go to the abbot with their complaints, and the abbot would never do anything.

At one point we had this self-professed schizophrenic. He would sit out there in the nude, and sometimes he'd jump up and dance around. It was an absolute riot. Eventually, I felt this was just a bit beyond the pale. A little disturbance, fine—you accept that. But this seemed different.

So I went to see the abbot, thinking I would have this great authority as a monk rather than a layperson. I explained that this was very injurious to the whole practice, that it was messing people up. But he did nothing. Nothing at all. I went back and thought, hmm, very interesting.

And then I realised what we're constantly doing. Whenever something disturbing comes—especially when something is, shall we say, evil (perhaps that's too strong a word), when we see something as dangerous or find somebody who threatens us—our attitude is to move away. And that, of course, allows the person to have full reign of the situation.

The teaching for me was this: yes, there is this disturbance, and at some point it will go—and you stay with it. That's what happened. He disappeared. He went one day and never came back.

If you take that to a political level, you see how important it is. When something happens in a country—some manifestation of real wrong thinking, some evil—the good people tend to shy away, tend to leave, instead of staying there and working with it and eventually undermining it.

This whole idea of delusion manifests in many, many subtle ways in our lives. Always remember: we're trying to manipulate the present moment, doing something about it to make ourselves feel comfortable, or at best happy. The practice is catching that, and then allowing the wisdom to arise: given this situation, what ought to be done from a truly ethical point of view? That wisdom undermines the wrong understanding. It drops downwards, as it were, through the whole process to the very idea of 'me.'

In those happy hippie days, people used to go around saying, 'I do my own thing in my own way, in my own time.' That was the greatest expression of Western individualism you could get. To hell with the world. I will do my own thing in my own way, in my own time. Forget the rest of you. I'm the one who's important here.

This process of constantly letting go of attachment, of constantly working with the unpleasant, of constantly not trying to manipulate the present—it undermines this sense of an isolated self. And that's when you begin to make connections with the world around you. That's when you begin to establish a different relationship, one not based on this very solid idea of a self or an ego.

Consider when the Buddha visits three monks who happen to be fully liberated—he calls them the Anuruddhas, I think. He says to the chief monk, 'How is it you live peacefully together?' And the monk replies, 'Well, every morning we say to ourselves: what if I put aside what I want to do and do what the others want to do?' That's not quite 'I do my own thing in my own way in my own time.' Of course, in any group everyone has to adopt this attitude, or else it doesn't work—

you just get abused. But if this were our approach, you can see how we'd begin to feel much more at ease with life: asking the people around us what they want to do, rather than walking into a situation and saying, 'This is the way I want it to be.'

So this whole area of dukkha, of unsatisfactoriness, has two sides. There's the acquisitiveness—which we've been looking at through the eating process, through trying to enjoy life with that override of indulgence, which simply means attachment, trying to create a beautiful mental state by stuffing ourselves. And then there's the other side: the actual suffering, the bit where we become averse, where we become fearful, anxious, where it gets on top of us and we get depressed. All of that belongs to this deep, profound, wrong relationship we have with this psychophysical organism.

When we begin to understand this, we move to that slightly deeper level of not-self, not-me, not-mine. What we're doing here is beginning to disidentify with this psychophysical organism.

So when we're sitting in meditation using these little noting words—especially if you preface them with 'there's,' so 'there's pain,' 'there's unhappiness,' 'there's sadness,' 'there's joy,' whatever it is—what we're doing is pushing it away from ourselves. We're disidentifying.

Let me go back very quickly to when we were born. There's a woman called Margaret Mahler, a student of Freud, who studied babies up to about the age of three. What she discovered was that for the first three or four months all there is is this blanket of sensation, an undifferentiated sensation, except that some sensations are painful and some pleasant. Then slowly, around four months, there looms your first object—usually your carer, your mother. Very slowly the baby pushes the world out, creates a three-dimensional world. That seems to be what's happening when they're reaching out for rattles and such. They're actually creating that world.

So it's not as though we're born with that. We're born with the potential of creating that phenomenal world, but it has to be developed. And it's not until the age of two and a half or three that the child says, 'I am a boy,' 'I am a girl,' and everything else isn't me. It's taken three years.

Now, what we're doing is taking that process inwardly. We're separating out of this person that we've made, examining what constitutes the person. The person is made up of the body, the image of the body, of the pleasures and the pain that

the body gives us. The person is made of emotions and habits and thought patterns and all our conditioning. All of that is then put into this concept of a person. This is me.

By sitting and finding this observation post within ourselves—this place where we can observe and feel things—we're actually doing exactly what the baby did with that two-dimensional world: creating a three-dimensional world, creating it-self away from there. We are beginning to isolate this awareness from everything that it's aware of. And that is the process of liberation.

The process of liberation is both this liberating ourselves from the wrong desire of things, the wrong attachment to things—but at this deep level it's disidentification. We relocate ourselves backwards until we reach this self-awareness, this observer, the feeler, the witness, the one who knows.

Every time we fall into the old habit of becoming this other self, that's the point where we have to jump out and recognise the mistake we've made. When you have a pain, a headache, and you say, 'Oh, I've got a headache,' you stop and say, 'Hold on, no, no—there is a headache.' Every time you have an emotion and say, 'Oh, I feel so depressed, I feel so anxious,' you catch yourself: 'Ah, no—there's depression, there's anxiety.' This is a constant practice we have to take into our daily lives, constantly separating out.

But remember that this too is a false position, because here we have a new self—another self who is disidentifying with everything—and there's a danger that you become so disidentified you're no longer engaged. That itself is not a pleasant place to be. So you still have to go into the psychophysical organism, but you go in with right intention.

It's this ability to go in with right intention that reinforces the wisdom gained from disidentifying. Through disidentifying, you're undermining all those consequences of delusion—the greed, the fear, the aversion. And by going in with right intention, by becoming your actions, your wholesome thoughts, your wholesome speech, your skilful deeds, you're reinforcing and manifesting your right understanding of the way things are. That understanding always manifests as some shade of the four illimitables: love, which is that basic connection; compassion; joy; and peacefulness or equanimity.

Now remember, that position of the self as observer is also a false position. Because there are two things there: the observing, and the observing of the self—self-awareness. So you can't be that either. You can't be the object you're aware of.

Unfortunately, you can't get beyond that state by an act of will. You can get beyond the body—as soon as I look at something or feel something as an object, I've disidentified with it. You can do it with an emotion too, rather than just becoming it. Rather than just being angry, you can say, 'There is anger.' We can do it with images. Thoughts are more difficult because they're so fast. But when we've got a decent, steady concentration, you can catch thoughts coming. Sometimes they're like neon lights in front of you.

This is the constant pulling away, re-establishing an inner sense of self, this self-observer. But you can't get rid of that image. You can't get rid of the self. Because that's an image of the knowing in the mirror of the mind. It's like when you look in a mirror—you can't get rid of that face. Every time you look, it's there.

The unfortunate thing is, I think most people assume that when they look in the mirror and see their face, that's how other people see them. But it's a great horror and shock when they actually use a second mirror to see this mirror image. Remember, it's turned round. That's why if you put writing up to the mirror, you can't read it—it's the other way round. And it comes as a great shock to know how big your nose really is. It's the same when you hear your voice first recorded. 'God, I don't sound like that.' Or worse, when you're videoed: 'I didn't think I was behaving like that.'

Anyway, we're beginning to recognise that the self is an image. Now, when everything is absolutely quiet, when everything is really, really still—and I've been saying this to a few of you—turn that gaze inward towards the knowing. Turn the gaze inwards and ask yourself afterwards: What is the knowing made of? What constitutes it?

For instance, when we go into pain and investigate what constitutes it, we might find tightness or heat and all those sorts of things. So now we know that's the reality of the situation, in inverted commas—that there is sensation. Pain is a mental construct.

This sense of self, you see, is telling us something about our true nature. It's this sort of investigation that begins to undermine the really, really deep and basic mistake we've made about identity.

In that vein, the Buddha states quite clearly that mind is foremost. Mind is there right at the beginning and it's there right at the end. It's the most important thing.

Just consider for a minute. Photons are coming into our eyes. Pressure waves are hitting the ear. But these are actually quite minimal information. When you see diagrams of what happens to a person's eye when they look at a picture, it's going all over the place. But the actual viewer still sees the picture as a whole. The eye is moving at tremendous speed, picking up little pixels here and there.

So we have these sense bases which are sensitive to certain data, certain information, but the information is quite minimal. What the mind does is take it into what's known in Buddhism as the inner sense door, the mind door, and there it's filled out. I read somewhere that what happens in the eye is that this filling out is then put back onto the retina, so it gives us a real picture, in inverted commas.

There's a whole thing going on inside this complex of the brain and mind. What we end up with is the world we've actually created. That is the phenomenal world. And we're beginning to recognise that it isn't an objective thing—it's something we are actually creating all the time.

So even though we'd all agree that this room exists—in the sense that it doesn't disappear when we leave—the fact is there are as many rooms here as there are people, in terms of experience.

Once we grasp that the world we're living in is being manufactured by us, something shifts. Part of it is given—both the pleasant and the unpleasant—and that we have to accept with radical acceptance. But what I do with it afterwards, the misery and horror I create afterwards, is totally my own doing. Nobody can make me angry; nobody can make me sad. If people could make me angry, could make me sad, could make me depressed, could make me happy, then to become fully liberated I'd have to get rid of you all. Because full liberation is perfect happiness.

It's precisely because we create our own happiness and our own sadness that we can become—each of us—individually liberated before other people.

So that's what our practice is doing. It's guiding us to see impermanence in a much more direct way, a much more experiential way—to see that things actually do come to an end. And those exercises we've mentioned around death, especially that one about saying goodbye. Constantly saying goodbye. Thank you, goodbye. Thank you, goodbye.

You have a pleasant meal with somebody, and when it's finished you say, "Thank you, goodbye." You don't say it to them—you're saying it internally. And every time you see a good DVD, any time you've had some degree of happiness,

actually be grateful for it. Really accept that there was a time when I was happy—and then goodbye. This allows us to keep finishing, to keep bringing things to an end, because we don't like to see endings.

Here's something you could do tomorrow: put more accent on seeing the ending of things. We're habituated to seeing beginnings, because beginning means new, and new usually means good. But end usually means bad. And although we see the rising star, the great pop star, nobody ever knows what happens to them. They just disappear.

This seeing of anicca—the dukkha is much more psychological, much more felt. You can grasp it more quickly because you can see, you can feel, the unsatisfactoriness and the way we're attaching to things.

Anatta is slightly more difficult to see, but it's there to be seen by constantly pointing to our experiences. There is, there. And that business of no control. The whole idea of a self is that it's in control. If it's not in control of something, the control centre must be somewhere else.

If I am my body, I should be able to say, "Right, from now on you're never going to get ill and you're not going to grow old. Full stop." But the control centre of the body is within the body, not in that which wants the body not to grow old—and this shows me that it can't be me.

Remember that although this talk has been mainly about undermining what is delusive, as we do that, the opposite arises quite naturally. As soon as we cut through a delusion, wisdom arises. Whereas delusion manifests in self-centredness, selfishness, aversion, and cruelty, the opposites just happen naturally. They arise of their own accord: generosity, love, and compassion.

It's not as though you can't help them on a bit through exercise and practice, but there's no intermediate state where there's nothing. Either you're cruel or you're compassionate. Either you're hateful or you're loving. There's no middle ground between those two.

The gift of practising like this is a movement of our characters and personalities towards the beautiful. It just happens naturally.

So there's hope.

I can only hope my words have been of some assistance and haven't created further confusion and despair. And that through your devotion to practice and careful investigation of these three characteristics of existence, you'll become liberated sooner rather than later.

Impermanence and Not-self

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 42 min

Originally given as *Impermanence and Not-self* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this dharma talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma delves into two of the three characteristics of existence: anicca (impermanence) and anattā (not-self). He begins by addressing practical meditation questions about emotional purification and the differences between masculine and feminine approaches to working with emotions. The talk then explores the Buddha's teaching on the five khandhas (aggregates) and how deconstructing our experience reveals no fixed, permanent self.

Bhante examines the illusion of control and free will, showing how all our choices are conditioned while pointing toward the unconditioned consciousness achieved through Awakening. He addresses the fear that arises when we truly see impermanence, particularly regarding sickness, old age, and death - the very sights that motivated the Buddha's spiritual quest. The teaching emphasizes that recognizing not-self and impermanence leads not to nihilism but to freedom from compulsive attachments to health, youth, and life itself.

The talk concludes with contemplation on mortality, drawing from Samuel Beckett's meditation on consciousness and last moments. This is essential listening for understanding how vipassanā practice reveals the deepest truths of existence.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa.

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble, and fully self-enlightened one.

The first point concerns what I mean by the process of purification—emotional purification and mental purification. The purity of the heart is the transformation of all that negative side of our experience: depression, anxiety, you name it, the

whole gamut of human misery. We transform it into its opposites. Where there's depression, there's joy; where there's boredom, there's interest; and so on. It's going from darkness to light.

Emotional purification is done by bearing it—first, by bearing the product of what we've created, and then by making sure we don't unwittingly develop more of it through fantasy, through our actions, through speech and body. That's all it means. In other words, it associates very closely with what we would normally mean by psychotherapy. The added dimension, of course, is that the spiritual practice goes down to the core root of why we're suffering. We're not really concerned as such with emotions. We're not concerned as such with wandering thoughts. We're trying to get underneath it.

Just while I'm on emotions, there's the divide between the feminine and the masculine. A feminine person—you note I don't say female—tends to be much closer to their emotions. They're the sort of person who says, "I feel, I feel." On the other end, the masculine tends to be in the head, and they normally start sentences with, "I think."

When a person is very close to their emotions, feeling them constantly, and they come to meditation, it's very difficult for them to create that distance I keep talking about. Because they know their emotions, because they've always identified with them, because they've always had this relationship of possessing them, the habit is to go into them and feel, to experience those emotions rather than observe them.

For those sorts of people, if you go underneath the idea of an emotion, if you go to the body and feel it as sensation—heat, nausea, heaviness—instead of seeing it as an emotion, you see it just as physical feelings. This way, they regain their objectivity. It's not a suppressive measure; it's just a different view of what it is. In the Buddha's understanding, it's all feeling—it all comes under one word: *vedanā*, physical and mental feelings.

Just by being there with those feelings at the level of physical sensation, we're still allowing that energy to dissipate. And that's the curing. That's the healing of the process.

On the masculine side—and this is a big generalisation—often people who have lived in their heads have thought their emotions rather than actually felt them. When they come to meditation and feel their emotions, it's a big shock. And the shock means they maintain that distance, because they've never felt this stuff before. For them, it's easier to remain with emotions as emotions.

Put yourself somewhere on that line. There are some emotions we allow ourselves to feel and justify—anger, for instance—and there are others we don't: jealousy and stuff like that we don't like to look at, guilt, remorse. Sometimes all that is hidden away. Even though I've talked very generally, everyone has a bit of masculine and feminine in them, obviously.

Remember that we're not trying to destroy the reasoning mind. We're not trying to destroy thought. We're trying to be able to stop it. The enlightened person, if they don't want to think, they don't think; the thoughts don't arise. I remember Krishnamurti saying that when he went for a walk in a forest, the thought never arose. He was just there, walking through the forest. It's not a destruction of thought.

Again, remember that thought is always driven by some mental state, some emotion, some motivation—I'm talking about ordinary thinking. Now, as we purify the mind, this intelligence, this *satipaññā*, this knowing, understands something. But it cannot come to know what it knows until it tells itself through thought. That's the paradox.

When the Buddha was enlightened, it's not as though he emerged and laid out a big book—four noble truths, eightfold path, off I go. It wasn't like that at all. He came out knowing he'd experienced something, and he went along and began to teach individuals, and the teaching came out. If you look at the early parts of the scriptures, they're very spontaneous; they're not particularly rigidified or made into lists. Then in the middle section you suddenly start getting these lists appearing—for memory, of course—and suddenly this whole framework emerges.

The whole teaching then becomes much more of a logical framework. Just for one very simple thing: he talks about the 37 factors of enlightenment. We talked about the 7 factors of enlightenment, that's one thing, but the whole teaching is the 37 factors. The whole of the Buddhist teaching is enclosed in them.

Now, there were 37 musical chords at the time. It's a number which everybody, shall we say, has in the back of their minds as an important number, a mystical number. And it so happens that his teaching comes out to be 37. He fiddles a bit,

because the five spiritual faculties, he also says, are five strengths—unshakable strengths when one has actually intuited *nibbāna*. So there's a bit of a double take to get his 37, which is all right.

Talking about that—when I mention Enlightenment, these are big words. If they don't grab you, forget it. Our work is groundwork, our work is dogwork. We're at the coalface here. Enlightenment is just a word pointing to some sort of end game; there's some sort of process where we're moving towards it.

When we say we're moving towards it, we're not creating it. If you take a train from Newton Abbot to London, it's not as though London is being created by the time you get there. It's already there. This enlightenment—the Mahayana are very good on this—we're already enlightened, that's not a problem; we just don't know it. That's the problem. And to get to know it we have to go through this whole process of purifying the heart, because the impurities in the heart, the distortions in the mind, are the measure of our delusions. We're coming back to delusions, to misunderstandings, to mistakes we've made.

These days we expect things to be very quick. If I wake up with an earache, by nine o'clock I'm at the doctor's, he puts something in it, I take a tablet, and the thing's gone. The car breaks down, I phone up a service and it'll be mended within half a day. When we come to this sort of work, we think, well, I've been here for a few days now. I've done this for weeks. I've done this for years. And not much seems to have happened. Then you start getting a bit depressed about it.

But what I would say to you is this: when you look back over a period of time, especially something like five, six, seven years, you can definitely see a change within yourself. There is a change going on, but it's very subtle. And why does it take so much time? Because of the strength of these conditionings. Those of you who drink tea, just stop drinking tea. It's hell. When I stop drinking tea, you'll know I'm enlightened.

The teachers that you come across—we're practically as unenlightened as you all. What we've done is a bit more training. We've had maybe some good insights, some reading, spent a bit more time than most people, and that's it. We're on the same path.

When an idea comes up in your head in meditation which seems absolutely sublime—like suddenly you think, "I'm going to create a charity to help the lepers in India"—you think, "That's very, very good. Now, I'll think about that." That's not meditation. Even beautiful, wonderful, sublime desires and ideas are, as far as

we're concerned, in this retreat, for this period of time, just a mental aberration to be noted and let go of. If you really, really are interested in setting something up for lepers in India, write a little note and come back to it at the end of the week. There's nothing wrong with that lovely idea. There are lots of lepers in India, aren't there?

Sometimes the body shakes or jerks in meditation. That's just energy caught up in the body trying to release itself. It can be quite something—I remember somebody shaking his head like this; I kept saying, "yes, yes, yes"—but sometimes it's a swaying and it feels good. Of course it feels good, because it's letting off this energy.

What you do is you stop. You stop it. And you mentally bring the energy up the spine, down to the stomach, up the spine. That's where the energy is supposed to move, isn't it? Tai Chi and all that. You lift yourself up like that. As soon as you stop, you may begin to feel the actual underlying disturbance which is causing this swaying. That's what you have to deal with. When it passes, no more swaying.

Now, the breath. Sometimes around about this time, people do start becoming much more calm, especially over the next two days, but even today. There are moments during the meditation when this peacefulness comes, this great calm descends, the body's very still, the mind is not thinking, it's pretty empty, and the heart seems to be just calm. And when you look, there's only the breath to watch. There's only the breath.

At this point, a meditator might say, "Now what?" — expecting some explosion, something dramatic to happen. But the thing is, now there's this lovely moment to really plunge into the breath, to move towards its very centre. What we're doing is beginning to focus on a specific area. The smaller the area, the sharper the attention — it's like when somebody studies for a higher degree, they always go to some really abstruse little bit, like why flies land on mushrooms. There's a whole thesis on that.

As we go into the middle of the breath, we're really sharpening the focus, really sharpening the concentration. The intelligence is still there. There's still that question mark in the mind, that sense of curiosity, of wanting to know. But it's a relaxation. If your forehead starts furrowing because you're doing this business, then that's wrong. Remember, this is a relaxation. It's driven by interest — not a desire to concentrate. Driven by interest.

As you get closer and closer, because of that focus, time begins to collapse. How long is time? What does it feel like? A couple of seconds, or something? About so long? But in reality, it's not like that at all. It's moment to moment. It's minute — the way things are arising and passing away.

As we go deeper in, the whole of time is collapsing. And it's right here that we begin to see these things I'll be talking about — this sense of transiency — much more clearly. When we come out, when something does come up, we have that sharpness of concentration as a quality of our looking, and of course we can see it more clearly. So don't waste those times, no matter how brief. They may only last a minute or so. Don't waste them.

The other two marks are *anicca* and *anattā* — transience, impermanence, and this idea of not-self. Whereas *dukkha* — suffering, dissatisfaction, unsatisfactoriness — belongs to the realm of sentient beings, belongs specifically to our realm (it's us who suffer, it's us), transience and not-self reach out to the whole phenomenal world. Everything is in a state of arising and passing away. It's one eternal law that everything changes — one steady law in the universe. Everything is changing. And everything is not-self.

The first thing about not-self is that it's not a philosophical statement. The Buddha's not saying there is no self. It's a teaching tool — a way of looking at what we're experiencing and beginning to see that there's no ghost within the machine. There's nothing metaphysical about what we experience. Everything arises because it's in relationship with everything. Everything arises dependent on something. So nothing has its own essential nature. Nothing has its own being.

Now when I walk around, I feel very individual. I think it's me. Me, I'm walking around. I have this feeling of being me. But when I look at this me — if I look at the body — I don't know where the me begins and the me ends. When does air become me? Does it become me when it's in the mouth, or when it's in the blood? When does food I'm eating become me? There's a sort of boundary, isn't there?

When I say these are my thoughts, how many of them are coming in from radio, from people I talk to, from all that? What do I mean by "my thoughts" across this membrane? When I talk about emotions — sure, they're developed by me, but they're also to do with my relationship to people. They evoke things. There's this passage of communication between us, between nature, wherever I go. So this idea of me, a sharp wall around me, begins to undo.

This process of undoing, this process of deconstruction — which I've been pointing you to especially when you're doing the eating — is the main technique the Buddha uses to get across his idea of not-self.

Just to look at one example: he talks about the five *khandhas*, the five aggregates. He says, when you take a human being apart, what do you find? You find the body, and that's made up of all sorts of stuff — chemicals and all that — and it's not one thing. So where this body is me, this is my body, I also have a possessive idea: is my body me?

Do I lose me if I lose a foot? Suppose I lose a leg — I've now moved from being a biped to a monopod. Is it still me? Have I lost a bit of me when I do that? At what point do I lose me? Do I lose my arms? Lose my legs? Chop my head off? Do I lose me? Is that me gone? This definition of me is strange, yeah?

Then he says there's this whole process of perceiving, where the mind actually creates pictures — basic pictures that we work on, basic ideas and concepts. They can be very grounded things, like just the colour, for instance, or they can be quite florid, beautiful pictures and all that sort of stuff I create in my mind, ideas. And it's all bits and pieces. Where do they exist? Have I got them in little drawers around my head?

It's the same with a computer, isn't it? Where's the program? You press a button and this thing comes up — Word, Outlook Express. Where was it? This idea that things exist somewhere in their totality, in some sort of subconscious, some sub-realm, and they just appear when they want to — it's not like that, is it?

Then the Buddha says we've got all these feelings. Which feeling are you? Today I felt happy — is that me? Now I'm feeling depressed — no, that's me. Which emotion are you going to draw on and say, this is me? And as soon as it's you, you've got to hold on to it: I am depressed. I'm really depressed. Even when I'm happy, I'm depressed. You get blocked into this, because you've defined yourself as miserable.

Actually, I've confused things there. Feelings should really mean just the feelings in the body — likeable, unlikeable sensations. The feelings I've just talked about, depression and all that, really belong to the next section: the *saṅkhāras*, those things we've developed by an act of will. Remember, the body is conditioned. I can do certain things with it, but there's a blueprint there; it just follows the genome. I can't do much about that. Perceptions are dependent on my brain and mind. I can't do much about that either. Feelings are dependent too — if

somebody kicks me in the shin, it hurts, and that's it. I can't do anything about that; it's just something that arises. But this whole business of emotions is something I create through my will. That's what we're all beginning to understand by watching this process within us — these emotions arising and passing away, and how we want to indulge them. So which feelings are we?

Are yesterday's feelings the same as today's feelings? Who am I now? Yesterday I had these feelings, but now I've got different ones. So who am I? Because the idea of a me is something static, isn't it? Something solid, something I can really point to and say, this is me. And the goalposts keep changing.

And then finally there's consciousness. Consciousness is always dependent on the object. If there's no object to be conscious of, who are you? Who are you in sleep? Where do you go? In the middle of your sleep, do you say, I'm still here? It's gone, isn't it? There's no me. It's not that there's no awareness there, but there's definitely not a sense of me.

Suppose the doctor said to you, listen, you've got this very strange and terrible disease — if you fall asleep, you will die. Are you going to fall asleep? See? The reason we fall asleep is because we presume I'm going to appear again in the morning. I wake up and there I am. Me again.

So we have to really look at this and begin to experience things, to realise that this concept of me being this body, me being this personality, me being this character — I can't sustain that, at least not at an intellectual level. I can't sustain it.

What the meditation does is take us in. And by creating this distancing — that's why we distance, that's the first position — we're looking at an object. If it's an object, it can't be the subject. I can't be what I'm looking at, because there's a distance there, isn't there? So when we make that distance very obvious to ourselves, in ourselves, we're creating that objectivity, that not-self.

And that's what the Buddha says. When you look in and you feel something, just say: not me, not mine, not a self. The body's not a self — it's not me and it's not mine. Emotions — they're not me, they're not mine, and they're not a self. Feelings in the body are not me, they're not mine, and they're not a self. The consciousness that arises knowing things is not me, not mine, not a self.

These little reflections burst through the bubble; they burst through the hard idea of me. And of course it's frightening, isn't it? Because the point of me, where me really comes to an end — the point of death — is very frightening for us. Who am I when I die?

The other thing the Buddha points to is control. This whole idea of free will has badgered Western philosophy ever since — free will. So I walk into a supermarket, and there's something like a hundred biscuits there. Fantastic. I have free will to choose any biscuit I want. I go along the shelf and come across Crunch It. I pick it up and it says, Crunch It really puts you in a good mood. Crunch It? I've never heard of that. I'll put it back. Then I walk along and see McVitie's chocolate biscuits. Oh, that's what I want. Chocolate biscuits. I have exercised my free will. Totally conditioned, isn't it?

I have free speech. I will say exactly what I want, anytime. But it's conditioned, isn't it? I only say something if somebody asks me, if somebody gives me an opinion on something. Everything I say is dependent on my history, my ideas, my connections.

I have free will. Perfectly free will. I can vote for whomever I want. Liberals? I never vote for them. Conservatives? No, I'm fed up with that lot. I'm not going to vote at all. I have exercised my free will — driven by prejudice, driven by hatred and greed. But I've exercised my free will. See?

So first of all, we have to get rid of that pathetic idea that the will is some sort of floating entity that can choose whatever it wants — to do my own thing in my own time and in my own way. We can get rid of that completely.

And then when we come down from that, we realise that obviously we do have choices — but what we choose is conditioned. So now, if we want to get to some freedom — not freedom to do, but freedom from, freedom from conditioning — we need to know what the conditionings are that make me make certain choices. Do these choices lead to my personal comfort, my happiness, my well-being? Do they lead to the well-being, comfort, and happiness of others?

Now, if I can see the conditioning, and if I can see the choice, and if I can see the result of the choice — and I can then step back and reflect, is this skilful or not? — then I have some sort of choice to say no. But that no is coming from another conditioning, one arising out of the wisdom factor. Now I'm not going to do anything which leads me to unhappiness. I'm not going to do anything which leads others to unhappiness.

So everything is conditioned, and yet through wisdom — through wisdom — there's this slow movement, this transformation of all our habits over to the other place, from wicked to wonderful, just by exercising this reflection driven by the idea of goodness, beauty, love, and all that. Even when we do that and we've come

to know it, there's no free will about it. There's nothing free about it. You're compelled. As soon as you realise that something's doing you harm, you don't do it anymore. As soon as you realise something's doing you good, you start doing that.

So there's something within us which is driven. It is driven. It's not within the bounds of our ego. It's not within the bounds of our choice. It is being driven towards Enlightenment. The whole world is so manufactured to drive us, to herd us, towards Enlightenment. We don't have a choice. Even when you're in hell, it doesn't last that long. And when you come out, you realise, God, I've been in hell — I don't want to go there again. I'm not going down that road again. See?

The whole process is one of learning, because of this intelligence. It's this intelligence that wants to get out of suffering. It's this intelligence that wants to get out of dissatisfaction.

And yet there is something which is unconditioned. We chant in the morning this little chant from the Buddha, *aneka jāti saṃsāraṃ*. He says, I've been through loads of rebirths, loads and loads, and I've constantly been pulled by the nose by this self, by this ego. But now, he says, I've seen you. I've broken your ridge pole, I've pulled down your house, and you're definitely not going to build another ego and self for me. He says, I have destroyed all my impurities, everything is gone. And I have achieved the unconditioned consciousness.

That unconditioned consciousness of the Buddha still, while he's here, has to live in the world. His body tells him he's hungry, so he goes out and gets some food and eats. When somebody comes to him and says, now what's all this stuff about? — he has to respond. He's using the language of the time, which is totally conditioned.

That's why he says the feeling of moving towards enlightenment is a freedom from — not a freedom to do something, but a freedom from compulsion. When we talk about control, that's coming from ego, from ego trying to control things, power and all that.

When we understand rightly, we understand that we're in relationship, and that it's always a contract. We're always moving around. You decide you're going to go for a picnic and the weather's pouring. That's okay. You take an umbrella. You work with it.

Now I want to get onto *anicca*, which is in a sense a more easy concept, because we can all see everything's arising and passing away. But how much do we really see it? We see it out there, and we want it, we love it. Who wouldn't want winter

and summer? They're a lovely balance — you don't get that in the East, for instance; it's always the same. But it's when change hits us — old age, death — that's when we don't want to look at it. That's when we avert our eyes and don't really recognise that this change is something happening within us, internal.

Because we don't recognise this, because we stay with moments and string them together, we create an idea of continuity — and that feeds into the idea of self. It's always me. But just look at the body you were born with. That little screaming hulk. How much of it is left now? It doesn't exist anymore, does it? That baby is dead. That body is dead. According to our science, it died within seven years. Every cell, every atom in that body was replaced. The whole thing has very slowly, unwittingly, just dissipated. Just disappeared.

Next time you look in the mirror, you can say to that face: you weren't here seven years ago. That's what transiency is. Things are changing. And yet, because we have this idea of continuity — because I can show you through photographs that it was me, that little screaming hulk that doesn't look anything like me now — was me. Was me. Crazy, eh? How can you be a was-me? You've got to be me now. You can't be me then. But I also launch myself into the future. I'm going to appear without any doubt tomorrow. I know exactly what I'm doing tomorrow. I'm coming here to meditate in the morning. That's me.

This idea of transiency also has to be undone. And it's undone by seeing — just seeing that process, just being aware of it. When we see it inwardly and it brings up fear, that's what we've got to look at, because this fear is coming from the ego. Fear is the last barrier of the self. That's how it protects itself. There's no worse emotion than fear. You may think there is, but fear is the last thing the self has to protect itself.

When fear comes up, that's really something to move towards. And what you find, of course, is that where there's fear, there's also the fear of fear. You bounce off it. When you're afraid of fear, you get into panic — that's what panic is — and you lose it. You just run away. So when fear of fear comes up, you look at the fear, you stay with it, you try to stay steady between the two, as it were. Very difficult, but you stay steady. Slowly you keep bringing your attention back to the original fear. And as you get close to it, you begin to lose your fear of it. It's just another state, just another mental state, another emotion, another feeling. That's all it is. Not me, not mine, not self.

And when we finally lose fear of fear, what the hell's going to frighten us? See, the problem isn't the object. The problem isn't the wild beast attacking you. The problem is the fear. As soon as you let go of fear, as soon as you can feel fear and not become afraid by it, then nothing will frighten you. And that's a sign to the person that they've undone this idea of ego, of self.

The Buddha's often referred to as the fearless one. There is no fear. What is an enlightened person going to be afraid of? Who can hurt you anyway? What can people do to you? What can the world do to you? They can only do things to your body. They can't hurt you emotionally. Nobody can cause you psychological pain.

Even when somebody comes to me and says, you're a very stupid, bald-headed monk — see? It's words, isn't it? It stopped here. That's all. It stopped here. But it's me, isn't it? I take it in. Of course I forgive you. But it's me, isn't it? I've created this hatred, this aversion, because I've heard these words. And then I create a relationship with this person. Tell them what I think of them.

Nobody can cause us psychological pain. The worst the world can do to us is cause us physical pain. But if we're not the body, if it's not me, not mine — you've sat there in meditation and you've been able to get some distance from that physical pain. You can see that there's an equanimity with it; you can stay with it. If there's total detachment, if there's no connection whatsoever with pain, how can it hurt?

I want now to draw us to a conclusion, and to an exercise I'll be doing at the beginning of every last session. It's simply to bring to mind sickness, old age, and death. These are the three things that drew the Buddha to his enlightenment — when he saw a sick person, a very old person, and a corpse. Each time he said, what is this? He'd been sheltered from this sort of stuff. Each time they said, well, he's a human being. And then the big question: does this happen to me? That shook him. That sent him into a tizzy. He had a nervous breakdown and ran off. I'm going to be a monk. Now you know why people become monks.

These meditations are to undo. The Buddha says when we meditate on the fact that this body can become sick, we undermine this intoxication we have with health — this worry. These household gyms and stuff like that, worry about vitamins and diets and all that. It's all this obsession with health. He undoes the obsession. It doesn't mean you don't care for yourself. It's just undoing the obsession.

He says when we contemplate old age, it gets rid of our obsession with youth — with wanting to be young, to be forever flowering. Can't decay. Ugly. Terrible.

And when we contemplate death, we undermine this very intoxication, this enchantment, this utter dependency we have on life itself. We're undermining that, and what does it bring? It brings a freedom. A freedom from obsession with health. A freedom from having to look beautiful and young. A freedom from having to live, having to exist.

Just to put us in the mood, I'd like to read this little poem from my favourite author, Samuel Beckett, whose work is a total meditation on last moments. Consciousness. It's up to you. Sometimes I close my eyes when I listen to poetry.

"Just think if all this, one day, all this, one fine day, just think if one day, one fine day, all this stopped. Just think."

I hope my words have been of some use to you. May you be enlightened even within these seven days.

CHAPTER 21

The Discourse on Not-self (SN 22.59)

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 23 min

Originally given as *The Discourse on Not-self (SN 22.59)* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this exploration of the Anattalakkhaṇa Sutta (SN 22.59), Bhante Bodhidhamma guides us through the Buddha's second discourse to his five companions at the deer park in Benares. This teaching systematically examines each of the five aggregates (khandhas) - form (rūpa), feelings (vedanā), perceptions (saññā), volitional formations (saṅkhāra), and consciousness (viññāṇa) - demonstrating how none can be considered as 'self'.

Bhante clarifies common misunderstandings about the not-self teaching, emphasizing that the Buddha doesn't deny the conventional existence of a self, but rather reveals its lack of ultimate control and permanence. Through practical examples, he shows how we have limited control over our bodies, emotions, perceptions, habits, and consciousness. The discourse reveals the fundamental questions: Is it permanent or impermanent? If impermanent, is it satisfactory? If unsatisfactory and changing, can it be 'mine, I am this, this is myself'?

This teaching addresses the core issue of identity (attavāda) that underlies all suffering (dukkha), offering profound insights for both meditation practice and daily life understanding of the nature of selfhood.

Good evening. I hope you've had a fruitful day. I do not say happy, though I hope it has been happy.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa.

Homage to the blessed one. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

So, I am going to labour the point. It's just to carry on with this not-self, because I remember my own personal confusion when I came across this teaching for the first time. It seemed to be saying that there was a not-self, which seemed very confusing, and the denial of a self. So the Buddha doesn't deny that there's a self, he just says it's unreal. And the not-self is a teaching tool. It's a way of saying, well, this is not me, it's not mine, and it's not myself.

The discourse I want to look at tonight is traditionally the second one he gave to his disciples, to his five friends who had been his five friends during that time when he was self-mortifying mainly through not eating. If you remember, he approaches them and of course they don't respect him anymore - he's gone soft. But as he does approach, they see that something's changed. And when he begins to speak, he keeps asking them, have you ever heard me speak like this before? And just very slowly they open up to his teaching, and one of them actually becomes what we call a stream-enterer, just the first step of four steps that take us to liberation.

So now, during the day, of course, they go off. Well, I would have thought it was some time, days maybe, because he does say that three of them went for alms round and came back, and they all left. Sometimes it was two of them went on alms round. But it's been formalized into what's known as the *Anattalakkhana Sutta*, the discourse on not-self. So this, in a sense, encapsulates this whole teaching. So we'll just go through it and you'll see how it works.

So again, he's at Benares in that deer park where he's met his five mendicants and he's talking to them and he says, "Is form..." Now this word *rūpa* is often translated as form, but obviously for us as human beings, it's basically the body. Everything has form, everything has some sort of spatial reality - a cupboard, a table. But as far as we're concerned, human beings, the *rūpa* refers to this body.

So he asks, "Is this body..." This body is not self, he says to them. So the identity to the body is an illusion, is a delusion. And he says, well, if this body were you, you'd be able to have control over it. You'd be able to say, do not fall sick. Do not suffer from any affliction. You'd be able to tell it to grow a bit more, or I would anyway, and to have more hair on the head. It doesn't matter to me at this present time, but there was a time when I could have done with more hair on my head. But unfortunately, the centre of control is elsewhere.

So this is the important point. Where is the centre of control? Where is the power? Who controls the body to stop it aging, to stop it dying, falling ill? Of course, we can move our arms around and shake our heads, but it's very superfi-

cial. It's a bit like driving a car, isn't it? I mean, when you're in a car driving, you feel you're in control, but actually the car's propelling itself. It's got all sorts of stuff going on and anything can go wrong any time. And then when of course it breaks down or a tire bursts, then you realize you're not in control of the car. The control is quite superficial. So it's the same with the body.

And when you realize that, you begin to realize that, how does he put it now? This body is not mine. You use it, but you don't actually own it. That's the distinction. Like with all objects, the ownership of an object is a legal fiction. I mean, we all agree to it. Like, for instance, this is my laptop. But that's just an agreement that we have between us as human beings. The fact is I don't actually own it. And of course, this ownership gets very big because then people own their houses. States own their country. And that causes all sorts of problems, this idea of possessing something.

And then the body is not me. See, there's a disjunction. There's some sort of separation between me and the body because the body won't do what I tell it to do. And I am not the body. So this sense of self that I have is not the body. So again, we're going always back to identity. This was the big breakthrough of the Buddha, this problem of identity. If identity manifested as delusive action, it caused *dukkha*. So that's why the Four Noble Truths are phrased in what we can actually experience, unsatisfactoriness, suffering. But the root cause is this problem of identity.

So then he goes on to talk about feeling. Now, feelings are both physical and emotional, heart feelings. So again, if you hurt your body, you bump your knee or something, or you bite your tongue, then at that moment, you're not in charge of the body. The body actually goes into a spasm of pain. And you can't say, well, you know, I don't want this pain. The pain remains. If you've got a headache, you have a headache. And you realize that when it comes to actually feelings in the body, again, very little control. You can take tablets these days, of course, but that's just covering over the pain.

When it comes to emotions, if you feel sad, you feel sad. You can distract yourself — listen to some music, jump up and down, dance. But you can't get rid of the sadness that way. It's just buried underneath this attempt to escape it. We have very little power over our emotions. They arise and pass away. This becomes obvious when you're sitting. You might sit with every intention to get deeply concen-

trated, to have these wonderful insights, and all you get is emotions coming up. One minute there's anxiety, then excitement, then you're depressed, then you're angry. It's just a waterfall of uncontrollable emotions.

Then we have perception. Perception belongs to the mind, that part which thinks — not only in an abstract sense of thoughts and words, but also in imagery, in imagination. If I said the word 'cat', you not only understand what that means intellectually — four legs, a little tail, and all that — but you also have an image in your mind of what a cat is. You know it's not a dog. We can normally tell clearly: this is a cat, not a dog.

These perceptions aren't controlled by us. They arise because we see things, hear things, touch things, smell things, taste things — and then we make a photocopy of it. The more we experience something we see every day, a car for instance, the more it builds up a concept about it, an image which runs with the concept, a concrete concept. So you know this is a car — it's not a truck, not a train, not a plane. And then of course it gets very subtle, because then it becomes very big: freedom, democracy. But all these things are given to us. They develop through our experience, through our cultures. And you can't get rid of them. You can't get rid of your sense of what personal freedom means to you. You can change it, but you can't get rid of it. It's just there within you.

It's the next part, the *saṅkhāra*, where we have some sort of choice, where we do have some sort of power. All the time the Buddha is saying: these feelings, these perceptions, this body — it's not right to say this is mine. You don't possess it. It changes of its own power. I was going to say free will, but there's no free will. It changes because of its own power. The eyes have a power to see. There's a process of vision which comes when the retina receives an object, and you have this mentation going on, the whole process happening within the mind, within the brain-mind. The brain would be the sensitive base for the mind.

When it comes to *saṅkhāra*, the volitional conditionings, our habits — I much prefer just the word habits — you can't get rid of a habit. You can change it. You can draw it down so that it doesn't have any effect on you. But even in an arahat, old habits will arise, even those that belong to delusiveness. They arise, but they have no power. They're called *vāsanā* — leftovers, traces of past habits. The Buddha is said to have got rid of all of those, but that's just hagiography, turning the Buddha into some magical being, some hyper-human, a beyond-human being. As a human being, he would have had habits. That's what a human being is: the body and a process of habituation.

When you see these habits come, when you find yourself acting out of a habit, you can become an observer of it. You can be aware of it and realise: I don't have to possess this. If I have an attitude of possessing it, it's going to be difficult for me to change it. If I identify with it — 'if I did that, it wouldn't be me' — I remember an old aunt saying that. A very stuck idea of who I am. And that just produces staleness, stagnancy. Whereas we want to be able to flow, to flow with events and change with events. That's how our lives grow, hopefully towards what is beneficial.

By the way, I did see a little cartoon about going with the flow. It just said: 'Only dead fish go with the flow.' I don't think that's the meaning here.

Finally we have consciousness, the fifth of the *khandhas*. So remember, we've just been through them: the body, feelings, perceptions, habits, and consciousness. Consciousness only arises when it is impinged upon, when something touches it. It's like a screen, like this monitor I'm looking at. There has to be an object that impinges upon a sense base. Light must impinge upon the eye. Sound must impinge upon the ear. Something must come out of — for want of a better word — the subconscious: some sort of image, some sort of emotion, which arises and touches upon this screen of consciousness.

That screen of consciousness isn't always the same, because it's being touched constantly by different impulses, different stimuli. And you can't stop being conscious. You can put yourself to sleep — obviously when we sleep, we lose consciousness. You can hit yourself on the head and lose consciousness. But while we're awake, you cannot be not conscious. Consciousness just arises because it's constantly being awoken by stimulus.

So we don't have that control over consciousness — whenever I put my eye on something, I become aware of it; it becomes part of my consciousness. This idea of control again. If the centre of control is elsewhere, then it can't be me. That's one of the definitions of I, me. I know I'm not you because I can't control you. I know I'm not something outside me because I have limited control. I can move objects, I can control them, but they're still objects, still outside me, so I know they're not me.

When you're meditating, you're taking a position within yourself of identifying with the observer, the feeler. Once you're in that position, everything's an object, and it's not under your control. The body offers feelings, sensations; the heart

offers its moods and emotions; the mind offers its thoughts and images. Whether you want it to or not, it isn't under your direct control when you're in the position of the observer, the feeler, the experiencer, the one who knows in *vipassanā*.

Having explored the idea of control, the Buddha then goes on to impermanence. Ever-changing. 'What do you think, mendicants?' — that's another word for *bhikkhu*. 'Is form permanent or impermanent?' Is the body permanent or impermanent? The answer: 'It's impermanent, Venerable Sir.' 'And if it's impermanent, is that suffering or happiness?'

Now, those two words, *dukkha* and *sukha*, you can translate as suffering or happiness, but I think it makes more sense to say, is that satisfying? Is it unsatisfying? Because one of the translations of *dukkha* is unsatisfactoriness. And of course they say no sir it is unsatisfactory. "And if it's impermanent, unsatisfactory and perishable, is it fit to be regarded as 'this is mine, I am this, this is myself'?" Well the answer of course is no, venerable. So there's your basic questions.

And then he goes through the rest of it. Feeling - so feelings, are they permanent, impermanent? Now this permanent-impermanent is not it's not the same thing changing all the time, they are completely new moments. Every consciousness is arising and passing away, so it's at that fundamental level the impermanence is immediate and. Even now consciousnesses are arising and passing away in me and in you at a speed such as that we're not aware of, so it gives some idea of continuity. But in Buddhist psychology these consciousnesses are flashing, they're flashing moment after moment.

So then of course with perception, so perceptions arise and pass away just as quickly. And is that desirable? Is that undesirable? Sometimes it is, sometimes it isn't. Then we have what he calls choices in this particular translation, Sujato Bhikkhu. But habits, I much prefer the word habits. Are they permanent, impermanent? They're constantly changing. They're either getting worse or getting better and so on. Consciousness is the very seat of impermanence because that's, as I say, flashing and arising and passing away.

So none of this can be satisfactory to a sense of self because the sense of self wants to be in control. The identity, me, I want to be in control and I find myself not so.

So then he goes on to say, so you should truly see any kind of form, so it's any kind of form, but here especially the body, past, future, present, internal, external, coarse or fine, inferior or superior, far or near, all form, the whole material world is empty. Now, that's the word *śūnya*, and I do believe he actually uses the word *śūnya* here. Oh, sorry, *anattā*. And the other word he uses in other scriptures is *śūnya*, which means empty. It doesn't have any substance.

And this, of course, was taken into a more metaphysical understanding by the Mahāyāna that everything is empty. But in the Theravāda's discourses, the Buddha is very much centred on the person, on me, me and you, trying to really imprint upon us this idea that nothing is permanent and nothing has any substance.

So this is what happens - when you begin to investigate this then this word *nibbidā* and it's translated variously but the one I particularly like is disillusioned. Disillusionment grows and then because of that disillusion your desire fades away.

And then finally, with that desire fades away, when all desire, the wrong desire fades away, then of course you are left with the experience of *nibbāna*, not self, which is that experience of something that is beyond the five aggregates, and we'll come to that at another time.

And then finally, when a person is fully liberated, there's this lovely way of talking about it: that rebirth is ended, this constant production of a self of a false self is ended, the spiritual journey has been completed, what had to be done has been done. That's a lovely feeling about that — what has to be done has been done — and there's no return to this constant becoming of a false self, of a false being becoming.

And so satisfied, the group of five mendicants were happy. And while the discourse was being spoken, the minds of the group of the five mendicants were freed from defilements by non-grasping, by losing that sense of desire. In other words, they all became fully liberated. So let's hope that bit is true.

So I think that virtually concludes my effort to try and get across this teaching about not-self, which some of you may have found quite confusing. So remember, it's all about identity. It's about me. Who am I? I mean, that's a question you can always ask. Who am I or what am I? That would be Korean Zen. What am I?

CHAPTER 22

The Discourse on Not-self — Anattalakkhana Sutta (SN 22.59)

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 23 min

Originally given as *The Discourse on Not-self — Anattalakkhana Sutta (SN 22.59)* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this profound teaching, Bhante Bodhidhamma guides us through the Anattalakkhana Sutta (SN 22.59), traditionally considered the Buddha's second discourse given to his five mendicant companions in the deer park at Benares. This pivotal sutta reveals how each of the five khandhas — rūpa (form/body), vedanā (feeling), saññā (perception), saṅkhāra (volitional formations), and viññāṇa (consciousness) — demonstrates our fundamental lack of control and ownership.

Bhante carefully explains how the Buddha used systematic questioning to show that none of these aggregates can be considered 'mine,' 'I am this,' or 'this is myself.' Through examining our limited control over bodily functions, emotions, perceptions, habits, and consciousness itself, we discover that the center of control lies elsewhere. The teaching progresses through the three characteristics: impermanence (anicca), unsatisfactoriness (dukkha), and not-self (anattā).

This talk is particularly valuable for practitioners struggling with the concept of anattā, offering clear explanations of why identity and the grasping for control create suffering. Bhante emphasizes that this isn't a denial of conventional selfhood, but rather a teaching tool for liberation from delusive identification. The discourse concludes with the beautiful description of liberation: 'What had to be done has been done' — the ending of false becoming and the realization of nibbāna through non-grasping.

Good evening. I hope you've had a fruitful day. I do not say happy, though I hope it has been happy.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa.

Homage to the blessed one. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

I am going to labour the point. It's just to carry on with this not-self, because I remember my own personal confusion when I came across this teaching for the first time. It seemed to be saying that there was a not-self, which seemed very confusing, and a denial of a self. The Buddha doesn't deny that there's a self. He just says it's unreal. And the not-self is a teaching tool. It's a way of saying, this is not me, it's not mine, and it's not myself.

The discourse I want to look at tonight is traditionally the second one he gave to his five friends — or who had been his five friends during that time when he was self-mortifying, mainly through not eating. If you remember, he approaches them and of course they don't respect him anymore — he's gone soft. But as he does approach, they see that something's changed. And when he begins to speak he keeps asking them, have you ever heard me speak like this before? Just very slowly they open up to his teaching, and one of them actually becomes what we call a stream-enterer, just the first step of four steps that take us to liberation.

Now, during the day, of course, they go off. I would have thought it was some time, days maybe, because he does say that three of them went for alms round and came back, and they all shared. Sometimes it was two of them who went on alms round. But it's been formalised into what's known as the *Anattalakkhaṇa Sutta*, the discourse on not-self. This, in a sense, encapsulates this whole teaching. We'll just go through it and you'll see how it works.

Again, he's at Benares in that deer park where he's met his five mendicants and he's talking to them. He says, is form — now this word *rūpa* is often translated as form, but obviously for us as human beings it's basically the body. Everything has form, everything has some sort of spatial reality — a cupboard, a table — but as far as we're concerned as human beings, the *rūpa* refers to this body. He asks, is this body — this body is not self, he says to them.

The identity to the body is an illusion, is a delusion. And he says, if this body were you, you'd be able to have control over it. You'd be able to say, do not fall sick. Do not suffer from any affliction. You'd be able to tell it to grow a bit more, or

I would anyway, and to have more hair on the head. It doesn't matter to me at this present time, but there was a time when I could have done with more hair on my head. But unfortunately, the centre of control is elsewhere.

This is the important point. Where is the centre of control? Where is the power? Who controls the body to stop it ageing, to stop it dying, falling ill? Of course, we can move our arms around and shake our heads and all that, but it's very superficial. It's a bit like driving a car, isn't it? When you're in a car driving, you feel you're in control, but actually the car's propelling itself. It's got all sorts of stuff going on and anything can go wrong any time. And then when it breaks down or a tyre bursts, you realise you're not in control of the car. The control is quite superficial. It's the same with the body.

And when you realise that, you begin to realise that — how does he put it now? This body is not mine. You use it, but you don't actually own it. That's the distinction. Like with all objects, the ownership of an object is a legal fiction. We all agree to it. For instance, this is my laptop. But that's just an agreement that we have between us as human beings. The fact is, I don't actually own it. Of course this ownership gets very big because then people own their houses, states own their country, and that causes all sorts of problems, this idea of possessing something. And the body is not me — there's a disjunction, there's some sort of separation between me and the body because the body won't do what I tell it to. And I am not the body.

This sense of self that I have is not the body. Again, we're going always back to identity. This was the big breakthrough of the Buddha, this problem of identity. If identity manifested as delusive action, it caused *dukkha*. That's why the Four Noble Truths are phrased in what we can actually experience — unsatisfactoriness, suffering. But the root cause is this problem of identity.

Then he goes on to talk about feeling. Feelings are both physical and emotional, heart feelings. Again, if you hurt your body, you bump your knee or something, or you bite your tongue, then at that moment, you're not in charge of the body. The body actually goes into a spasm of pain. And you can't say, I don't want this pain. The pain remains. If you've got a headache, you have a headache. And you realise that when it comes to feelings in the body, again, very little control. You can take tablets these days, of course, but that's just covering over the pain.

When it comes to emotions, if you feel sad, you feel sad. You can distract yourself — listen to some music, jump up and down, dance — but you can't get rid of the sadness that way. It's just buried underneath this attempt to escape it. We

have very little power over our emotions. They arise and pass away. This becomes obvious when you're sitting. You might sit with every intention to get deeply concentrated, to have these wonderful insights, and all you get is emotions coming up. One minute there's anxiety, then excitement, then you're depressed, then you're angry. It's just a waterfall of uncontrollable emotions.

Then we have perception. Perception belongs to the mind, that part which thinks — not only in an abstract sense of thoughts and words, but also in imagery, in imagination. If I said the word 'cat', you not only understand what that means intellectually — you know it's got four legs and a little tail and all that — but you also have an image in your mind of what a cat is. You know it's not a dog. We can normally tell clearly: this is a cat, not a dog.

These perceptions are not controlled by us. They arise because we see things, hear things, touch things, smell things, taste things, and then we make a photocopy of it. The more we experience something we see every day — a car, for instance — the more it builds up a concept, an image which runs with the concept, a concrete concept. You know this is a car, not a truck, not a train, not a plane. And then of course it gets subtle, because then it gets very big — like freedom, democracy. But all these things are given to us. They develop through our experience, through our cultures. And you can't get rid of them. You can't get rid of your sense of what personal freedom means to you. You can change it, but you can't get rid of it. It's just there within you.

It's the next part, the *saṅkhāra*, where we have some sort of choice, where we do have some sort of power. All the time the Buddha is saying: these feelings, these perceptions, this body — it's not right to say this is mine. You don't possess it. It changes of its own power. I was going to say free will, but there's no free will. It changes because of its own power. The eyes have a power to see. There's a process of vision which comes when the retina receives an object and you have this mentation going on, the whole process happening within the mind, within the brain-mind. The brain would be the sensitive base for the mind.

When it comes to *saṅkhāra*, the volitional conditionings — our habits, I much prefer just the word habits — you can't get rid of a habit. You can change it. You can draw it down so that it doesn't have any effect on you, but even in an *arahat*, old habits will arise, even those that belong to delusiveness. They'll arise but they have no power. They're called *vāsanā* — leftovers, traces of past habits. The Buddha is said to have got rid of all of those, but that's just hagiography, turning

the Buddha into some magical being, some hyper-human, beyond-human being. As a human being he would have had habits. That's what a human being is: the body and a process of habituation.

When you see these habits come, when you find yourself acting out of a habit, you can become an observer of it. You can be aware of it and realise: I don't have to possess this. If I have an attitude of possessing it, it's going to be difficult for me to change it. If I identify with it — I remember an old aunt saying, 'If she behaved like that it wouldn't be me.' A very stuck idea of who I am, and that just produces staleness, stagnancy. Whereas we want to be able to flow, to flow with events and change with events. That's how our lives grow, hopefully towards what is beneficial.

By the way, I did see a little cartoon about going with the flow. It just said: only dead fish go with the flow. I don't think that's the meaning here.

Finally we have consciousness, the fifth of the *khandhas*. So remember the *khandhas* — we've just been through them: the body, feelings, perceptions, habits, and consciousness. Consciousness only arises when it is impinged upon, when something touches it. It's like a screen, like this monitor I'm looking at. There has to be an object that impinges upon a sense base. A light must impinge upon the eye, a sound must impinge upon the ear, something must come out of — for want of a better word — the subconscious: some sort of image, some sort of emotion which arises and then touches upon this screen of consciousness.

That screen of consciousness is not always there because it's being touched constantly by different impulses, different stimuli. And you can't stop being conscious. You can put yourself asleep — obviously when we go to sleep, we lose consciousness. You can hit yourself on the head and lose consciousness. But while we're awake, you cannot be not conscious. Consciousness just arises because it's constantly being awoken by stimulus. So we don't have control over consciousness either. Whenever I put my eye on something, I become aware of it. It becomes part of my consciousness. Again, this idea of control.

If the centre of control is elsewhere, then it can't be me. That's one of the definitions of I, me. I know I'm not you because I can't control you. I know I'm not something outside me because I have limited control. I can move objects, I can control them, but they're still objects, still outside me, so I know it's not me.

When you're meditating, you're taking a position within yourself of identifying with the observer, the feeler. Once you're in that position, everything's an object, and it's not under your control. The body offers feelings, sensations; the heart offers its moods and emotions; the mind offers its thoughts and images — whether you want it to or not. It isn't under your direct control when you're in the position of the observer, the feeler, the experiencer, the one who knows in *vipassanā*.

Having explored the idea of control, the Buddha then goes on to impermanence. 'Ever-changing! What do you think, mendicants?' — that's another word for *bhikkhu* — 'Is form permanent or impermanent?' Is the body permanent or impermanent? The answer: 'Impermanent, venerable sir.'

'And if it's impermanent, is that suffering or happiness?' Now, those two words — *dukkha*, *sukha* — you can translate as suffering or happiness, but I think it makes more sense to ask: is that satisfying or unsatisfying? Because one of the translations of *dukkha* is unsatisfactoriness. And of course they say, 'No sir, it is unsatisfactory.' 'And if it's impermanent, unsatisfactory and perishable, is it fit to be regarded as "this is mine, I am this, this is myself"?' The answer, of course, is 'No, venerable sir.' So there's your basic question: is it permanent or impermanent?

If something is impermanent, is that satisfying for you? If you arrive at a beautiful state of mind and then it disappears, that's not very satisfactory. You want to maintain it, you want to develop it. Then the Buddha goes through the rest. Feelings — are they permanent or impermanent? Now, this permanent/impermanent isn't just about changing all the time; these are completely new moments. Every consciousness is arising and passing away. So at that fundamental level, impermanence is immediate. Even now, consciousnesses are arising and passing away in me and in you at a speed such that we're not aware of it. It gives some idea of continuity, but in Buddhist psychology these consciousnesses are flashing, moment after moment.

Then of course there's perception. Perceptions arise and pass away just as quickly. Is that desirable? Is that undesirable? Sometimes it is, sometimes it isn't.

Consciousness is the very seat of impermanence because, as I say, it's flashing, arising and passing away. None of this can be satisfactory to a sense of self, because the sense of self wants to be in control. The identity, me — I want to be in control, and I find myself not so.

So then the Buddha says, 'You should truly see any kind of form' — any kind of form, but here especially the body — 'past, future, present, internal, external, coarse or fine, inferior or superior, far or near, all form' — the whole material world is empty. That's the word *śūnya*, and I do believe he actually uses that word here. In other scriptures he uses *suñña*, which means empty — it doesn't have any substance. This was taken into a more metaphysical understanding by the Mahāyāna, that everything is empty. But in the Theravāda discourses, the Buddha is very much centred on the person, on me and you, trying to really imprint upon us this idea that nothing is permanent and nothing has any substance.

When you begin to investigate this, then this word *nibbidā* arises — it's translated variously, but the one I particularly like is 'disillusionment.' Disillusion grows. And because of that disillusion, your desire fades away — *virāga santīti*. It's interesting.

Finally, when desire fades away — when all the wrong desire fades away — you are left with the experience of *nibbāna*, not-self, which is that experience of something beyond the five aggregates. We'll come to that at another time.

When a person is fully liberated, there's this lovely way of talking about it: rebirth is ended. This constant production of a self, of a false self, is ended. The spiritual journey has been completed. What had to be done has been done. That's a lovely feeling about that — what had to be done has been done. And there's no return to this constant becoming of a false self, of a false being.

And so, satisfied, the group of five mendicants were happy. While the discourse was being spoken, their minds were freed from defilements by non-grasping, by losing that sense of desire. In other words, they all became fully liberated. So let's hope that bit is true.

I think that virtually concludes my effort to get across this teaching about not-self, which some of you may have found quite confusing. So remember, it's all about identity. It's about me. Who am I? That's a question you can always ask. Who am I — or what am I? That would be Korean Zen. What am I?

Wheel of Dependent Origination

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 38 min

Originally given as *Wheel of Dependent Origination* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this exploration, Bhante Bodhidhamma presents the wheel of dependent origination (paṭicca samuppāda) not as metaphysical speculation, but as a practical psychological paradigm essential for meditation practitioners. Drawing from the Buddha's core teaching of 'suffering and the end of suffering,' he maps out the twelve-link chain from ignorance (avijjā) through to birth, aging, and death, emphasizing how this process operates moment by moment in our present experience.

The teaching illuminates the crucial junction between feeling (vedanā) and craving (taṇhā) as the pivotal point where liberation becomes possible. Through careful observation in meditation, practitioners can witness how pleasant and unpleasant feelings naturally arise from contact, and learn to maintain awareness without automatically moving into wanting or not-wanting. This understanding transforms our relationship with both pleasure and pain, allowing us to 'take the suffering out of pain and the indulgence out of pleasure.'

Bhante Bodhidhamma concludes by exploring how an awakened being operates through kriyā (functional action) rather than karmic conditioning, acting purely for others' benefit without identification or attachment. This practical teaching offers clear guidance for applying the profound wisdom of paṭicca samuppāda directly in daily meditation practice and life.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa
 Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa
 Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa

Homage to the blessed, noble, and fully self-enlightened one.

First of all, just to put it into the perspective of the Buddha's life. Remember that he left home, and we can presume it wasn't for frivolous reasons. He wasn't doing a hippie trip or something. He was motivated by what we would call these days an existential angst. It's put mythologically as him coming across these devadūtas, these messengers from the gods, as it's put: a sick person, an elderly person, and a corpse. What it signifies is that in his middle or early twenties, he woke up to the fact that life comes to an end—there's sickness, old age, and death. This threw him.

Eventually he leaves, goes and practises with various teachers, and then finally, as it were, goes on his own to achieve enlightenment. He can reduce the whole of his teaching to suffering and the end of suffering. That's what he says he teaches. He reduces it to those three words: suffering and the end of suffering. It's three words in the Pāli. And what he discovers, of course, is the way out. Luckily for us, he has this ability to get it across.

What he gives us is a psychological paradigm. I think it's very important for meditators to know this, because if we don't, we come to the meditation with our own psychological paradigm, got from our own tradition of psychology and psychotherapy. Not that that's all wrong—it isn't at all. But when the Buddha's talking about psychology, he's talking about suffering and the end of suffering. It's specific. It's nothing to do with how we learn, how we develop. It's not developmental psychology. It's nothing to do with psychotherapy as such. It's to do with finding out how suffering arises and how it passes away.

If we have a clear idea of the paṭicca-samuppāda, the dependent origination, then that intelligence which is going to liberate us can see more clearly. This is the paradox: that intelligence which liberates us needs to be instructed on how to do it. It doesn't come naturally, it seems.

Now, just to put what I say in perspective: his regular companion, Ānanda, who was with him for twenty-odd years eventually, was obviously present for all his talks that he gave, or at least most of them, and he would obviously take the opportunity to discuss this with the Buddha when he's with him. He's there in the room, he's attending to the man. So he comes one day to this conclusion, and he says to the Buddha, "I think I've understood this business now. I think I understand this wheel of dependent origination that you're teaching." And the Buddha says, "Oh no, don't say that, Ānanda. This stuff is deep. This stuff is profound. It's subtle." So whatever I say must be taken in the context of that announcement of the Buddha towards Ānanda.

The first thing to understand about the Buddha's teaching is that he's not into metaphysics. He's not into where does the universe begin and where does it end. Is it eternal or not eternal? Is the soul lasting or not lasting? Is there a God or is there not a God? He's not talking about origins in that sense.

When he points to the first link of the wheel of dependent origination, when he's pointing to the base of it, when he talks about ignorance, not knowing, he's not talking about some distant time where consciousness arose out of some primordial mass into this state of not knowing. He's simply saying that at this present moment, right now, consciousness is in a state of don't know. It doesn't know.

That not knowing is not culpable. It's not as though we deserve to be not knowing. It's not as though we should feel guilty because we don't know. It's simply a state of not knowing. Just as when a car breaks down, we don't know. If you're not mechanically minded and you open the bonnet, you still don't know. Just don't know. You don't say to yourself—well, some people do, of course—"I'm a fool, I should know about this," etc. You just don't know.

And of course it's a position that we as human beings find very difficult. We do want to know. We feel secure when we know. So you wake up and you've got a pain at the end of your nose and you're sure it's cancer. And you go to the doctor because you want to know. "What is it?" "It's just a pimple." "Oh... Fantastic relief." If he said it's the most dangerous cancer, it'll blow your brains apart in two weeks, of course you'd fall apart. But at least we know. It's better for us to know we're going to be blown apart than not to know. It's an easier state to be in. We can handle that. We know that. But not to know is very difficult.

Bringing ourselves, as it were, into this lifetime, not worrying about past lives and future lives and getting into what might seem to others to be metaphysics: what does the foetus know? What does it wake up to? As its sensual basis begins to develop, it begins to hear heartbeats of the mother, begins to feel the place it's in. And there's no doubt a time when it's absolutely gloriously in this lovely bath of warmth, being fed, growing. And then, slowly, it becomes uncomfortable. Then the dreadful passage, a smack on the arse, and they're there. The eyes open, and suddenly we're here. From a state of not knowing, we're suddenly somewhere. From a state of some sort of cloudy feelings, which are nice, we go through this terrible pain. And suddenly we're here. We've got no language. We can't reflect on it. We just hear. Very present. But we're present in a total state of ignorance as to what's happening to us.

So it's no wonder that very slowly we come to see, to accept, to understand that this is what we are. I am my body. I am my eyes and my ears. I am my feelings and my thoughts. It's got to be a natural mistake, because that's all consciousness knows. But it is a mistake. And because of that essential mistake, a load of suffering comes our way—in fact, all our suffering comes our way. The mistake is the belief, the conception, the understanding that we are what we appear to be: human beings, psychophysical organisms. Rather like that phrase—a psychophysical organism. A breathing, feeling, sensing, emoting, thinking, psychophysical organism. And so that's what we think we are.

That's our first disposition, *saṅkhāra*. From *avijjā*—*vijjā* means knowing, *avijjā* means not knowing—we produce our first *saṅkhāra*, our first disposition, which is me, self. Embodied. An incarnate entity.

With that fundamental disposition we find ourselves in the next link: the body and the mind. In Buddhist understanding, these are two different forms of energy. Both suffer from transience, both are not-self, and both, if we attach to them wrongly, will create suffering, will create dissatisfaction, won't bring permanent happiness. But body and mind in the Buddha's understanding are two different things, though intimately entwined as milk in water. Through good meditation, even in this lifetime, they can be separated as a sword can be taken from its scabbard. It's one of the powers we can get if we want it. And then you don't have to pay anything at all to go to Mallorca and all these beautiful places. You just wander off.

Having entered into this conglomerate of body and mind, it obviously has ways of communicating to the world and for the world to communicate to it—and that's your five senses, six senses. The five ordinary senses that we know, and the sixth is that part of us—the brain, and the mind which is in the brain—which is there to receive and process stimulus. This has a special word for it in Pāli: *mano*.

Having established these qualities, having established a fundamental disposition—all these things are arising at once—we make contact with the world. Contact comes to us also from the world. We hear a sound. The sound, as we know, is just pressure on the eardrum. It comes into the brain. And that first contact is known as *phassa*. At that point of contact, there is only what is stimulating the sensual base—here the eardrum—the eardrum itself, and this consciousness. Nothing else is there.

At the primary level there is just that percept of the fundamental stimulus coming in at the eardrum. It's just a pounding. It's just the earth element. It has no sound about it at all. Once that is there, it is brought into the mind, which is the sense base, and there it's processed and we begin to hear something. That's really all part of this contact.

But when that happens, there arises in us a response. The response is to perceive it, to experience it as either pleasurable or non-pleasurable. This is when we move on to the next stage: *vedanā*, feeling. From contact, which is felt as a neutral experience, we move into experiencing it as something pleasant or unpleasant.

Now, this consciousness which has come into life is experiencing things as pleasant and unpleasant. Is it any wonder that it just wants to centre on what is pleasant? And when it centres on what is pleasant, it finds happiness. There you have your next link, *taṇhā*, which is translated, unfortunately, as craving. But *taṇhā* means this reaction, this reaction of wanting, not wanting.

From the stimulus, from the actual given percept of *phassa*, contact, we have a judgmental mind coming in at a feeling level—a feeling level saying likable, unlikable. There's an immediate reaction by that consciousness: this is it. If it's likable, it's wantable. If it's unlikable, it is definitely not wantable. There's a whole area in between of neutral feelings, but if in your meditation you really go into the neutral feeling, you'll see that there's always a shade of liking and not liking.

These feelings are divided by the Buddha, at their simplest, into five. The physical pleasant and unpleasant feelings—such as when you're sitting there and you get pain in the knees, that's a physical unpleasant feeling. If you're sitting there feeling very comfortable in the body, that's a pleasant physical feeling. Then there are pleasant and unpleasant mental feelings, which is basically our emotional life. If you're sitting here and you feel joyful, you're experiencing pleasant *vedanā*, pleasant feelings. If you're depressed or angry or whatever, you're feeling unpleasant stuff. And there's that whole business of the neutral feelings—for instance around the breath, which are very neutral.

Having established that *vedanā*, that feeling base, we have this reaction of wanting and not wanting. And when that wanting and not wanting comes up, only then—only then—does the I appear. I want. I don't want. The I, the idea of a self, of me wanting something, in terms of the psychological process, comes in quite late at the end.

Our sequence is "I want a biscuit," but the actual psychological sequence is biscuit, want, I. If it were "I want a biscuit" there'd be no escape. You wouldn't be able to escape because the identity would be immediate. It's the very fact that identity comes last that allows you to cut into that process and let these desires pass away.

At that point, consciousness has identified with what it's now wanting—it has become it. Up until then, that identity isn't there. You know this from your meditation. When you've sat there and, shall we say, a depression or an angry feeling has arisen, or a joyful or wonderful feeling, and you're observing it as an object, then that I—meaning 'I am depressed,' 'I am joyful'—can't arise. It only arises when you become it. It only arises, for instance, when the sun comes out and you throw yourself on the lawn and suddenly you become sunshine. You're there with the sun. From the point of view of indulgence: I am this pleasant feeling.

Because we're not enlightened, we're constantly moving in and out of that identification. Because we're meditators, we can find that position of not being caught. And when we fall out of that grace, we fall into the self, and we establish this relationship with the world whereby we're seeking happiness out there. That's what we're doing all the time—trying to seek comfort, trying to seek security, trying to seek happiness in the sensual world. There's your upādāna.

When the Buddha describes the five khandhas, the five heaps that some of you will know—another division of human experience, meaning the body, all our perceptions, all our feelings, all our emotional and mental productions, and our discriminative consciousness—he calls them the upādāna-khandha, the grasping khandhas. In other words, this is only a problem when we say 'this is what I am,' when we identify with it.

So there's your upādāna. Now at this point, not only has the I come in to identify—the next step is bhava. Bhava means becoming. The wanting, 'I want,' becomes 'get it.' There's an impulsion of will into that want, and it becomes an action: an action of thought, an action of speech, or an action of the body. At which point, kamma is created. That's an action. That's becoming.

From liking and not liking; to wanting and not wanting; to 'I want' and 'I don't want'; to 'I do' and 'I don't do.' Remember that even not doing something is also an action—it's a decision not to do something.

Now we've taken a whole series of progressive acts that has produced a bhava, a becoming, an act of kamma—which is basically just an action. The importance of an action is this: because the mind is something we can condition, as soon as we put an action into the mind, an empowerment, we have conditioned it. The more actions of a similar nature we put in, the more it becomes a habit. The more habits we engender, the more we define our personality. And once we have that personality, which is no more than a compendium of habits, our destiny is assured.

Having made this bhava, this act, we now go into the process of being born, decay, and death. Keeping the wheel of dependent origination right in the present moment, this simply means that the action is begun, the action is gone through, and the action is completed. That's the end of the process. In terms of the mind, there's been a conditioning—a conditioning set into the mind.

A child, for instance, hears the little dingy bell of the ice cream man. What comes to the ear is just this little knocking sound. It's taken in, and suddenly there's a perception of bell, a perception of understanding what the bell means, a perception of ice cream, a memory of ice cream—and joy arises. This is *vedanā*. We've had the contact; this is *vedanā*. As soon as the joy arises, wanting arises—I want, jumping up and down, I want an ice cream! And nothing will satisfy that child now unless he gets that ice cream, goes through the motions of eating it, swallowing it, completing it, and feeling for a moment that lovely satisfaction which only ice cream can give us.

But foolishly, he has now established a habit—a habit of seeking happiness in ice cream. Hence, whenever that ice cream van comes, out he'll go demanding his ice cream. Later on, of course, ice cream becomes beef stroganoff, spaghetti à la Bolognese, beautiful wines. And the more we indulge in food, the more we must seek our happiness there. If one day there's no food in the larder, no tea in the morning, no toast—misery, frustration, horror. That's the other side of the wheel. That's another conditioning coming up.

Anyway, that in summary is how the wheel works—in terms of this process. Parts of it are given. A state of ignorance is with us all the time until we're fully enlightened. We have a set of dispositions; they're your *saṅkhāra*. With that disposition you enter into every moment, and a disposition will manifest according to the stimulus. In this case, ice cream. A certain disposition arises entirely due to the sound of that ice cream bell, that ice cream tune.

And remember, we're not always turning the wheel. When we're asleep, there's no paṭicca-samuppāda. It's not as though it's always there. But every time there's an act of volition based on greed, hatred, or this essential delusion, the wheel turns.

Now, once we've understood that process, we can also see that there is one specific link that will undermine the whole thing. And it's right there between vedanā and taṇhā.

Right up until we reach vedanā—feeling—everything is utterly and totally conditioned by the past, by dispositions we've already developed. There's nothing you can do about that. Whenever the ice cream van goes by, we will reach vedanā just like that: the pleasant, lovely feelings that arise when we hear it. That is set by past conditioning.

The next process—wanting it, the desire for it, the craving—is also set by past conditioning. But by putting our mind right there at that juncture, we stop the next process, which is to identify with that craving: 'I want.' We stop the empowerment of that craving, and we undermine the conditioning of seeking happiness in ice cream.

This moment of desire is actually the only moment of—for want of a better word—free will. That's the point where we can actually say no or yes. Otherwise we'd just be automatons, living fatefully, without any ability to guide ourselves.

Now, in order to do that, we have to be able to distinguish that moment. And that is the core of our meditation if we want to approach enlightenment through the understanding of dukkha, through the understanding of suffering—which is one of the three characteristics.

When we're in a position to see that moment clearly, we can see that one is a reaction of the other, one is dependent on the other. Dependent—paṭicca, paṭicca-samuppāda. That which arises dependent on. We can see that the feelings arising from the sound of the ice cream van depend on that sound; and dependent on those feelings, there arises the craving.

By keeping that aloofness—and this is what solitude means in its spiritual sense—maintaining that inner aloofness to see the connection between these two things, sometimes we're aware of the pleasant feeling, sometimes we're aware of the craving. Sitting there before your morning porridge, not moving, just watching that movement in the mind: the pleasant feeling that has arisen at the very sight of porridge, and the craving for it which arises with that pleasantness. Just

to sit there and wait till this craving passes away. And there's just the pleasantness. And then to eat for the purpose of feeding the body, not to feed the greed. Feeding the need, not the greed.

In doing that, we're undermining all that process of seeking happiness in porridge. Which is ridiculous, isn't it? To seek happiness in porridge. And in so doing, we undermine that disposition of seeking happiness in the sensual world. This consciousness begins finding a new relationship to the world—not based on seeking happiness in it, not based on craving.

To be able to experience pleasure without indulgence is an important experience in the meditator's life. Then they know it's possible to live life without expecting anything from it, without wanting anything from it. It's a liberation. The taste of Nibbāna is freedom.

In the same way, when it comes to pain and suffering: whenever that pain arises, there arises that not-wanting—'I don't want.' Get the Prozac. Swallow the Prozac, finish your pain, fine. But the pain is still there somewhere.

In the same way, we see the original pain, whatever it is—emotional or physical—and we see our reaction of wanting to push it away or, if it's too great, wanting to run away. Just trying to hold that connection, just trying to see it. Being aware of one and the other, sometimes being aware of both, seeing the connection. Allowing that pain, allowing that reaction to slowly die away, and just staying with pain.

To stay with pain as pain is to discover that there's no suffering in it. The suffering only comes because of our reaction to it.

So we can say that the whole process of our meditation is to take the suffering out of pain and the indulgence out of pleasure. Just to do this will make us arrive at Nibbāna, the end of suffering. It is the process of seeing how suffering arises and how it passes away.

When we're calm, we can also see the other two characteristics. It's easier to see them when we drop down to the point of contact, where there isn't even the idea of pleasant and unpleasant yet. There we can see this transiency, this constant transformation, this flow of events—each single and discrete. No sensation is ever the same as the last one, even though it may feel the same. It isn't, because a sensation arises and passes away every single moment.

To be aware of sensations, whether they come from the body or the mind, is to always be in the present moment. That's why we always centre on the breath. That's why we always centre on the body. When we're there with a sensation or a feeling, we know we're in the present moment.

That sense of anattā, not-self—remember, this is not a philosophical proposition by the Buddha. It's not a metaphysical proposition. He never said, 'There is a not-self' or 'There is a no-self.' What he said was, 'There is not self.' Everything in this world is anicca, dukkha, anattā. It's transient. It will cause some sort of dissatisfaction if we associate with it or identify with it. And it is not self. Not me. Not mine.

So as soon as we get into that meditative posture and we can see, feel, experience a sensation—painful or not painful—an emotion—painful or pleasant—and we can see it as an object, we are experiencing not-self. To stay at that point where we see vedanā and taṇhā, the given feeling and our response to it of craving, is the position of not-self.

Understanding this makes our meditation very clear. As soon as we sit, we must make the effort to come to a point of concentration, at least some stillness in the mind. Sometimes that takes a little while and sometimes it takes a long while. It doesn't matter. Just bring a stillness.

Then we access this level of consciousness which is just observing, just observation. And here we need a kind of essential faith—an essential faith in our own Buddha nature. They say the Buddhas can only point; we ourselves have to become enlightened. So it's an act of faith in what is within us: a higher faculty which will work this stuff out, which will make the insight and liberate itself. And it will do it the quicker we get out of the way.

How then—just to finish off the talk—would the Buddha mind work? This has to be a little conjecture on my part, because it's never said explicitly. But in the later works of the Abhidhamma, there has to be an explanation as to how an enlightened being works. How do they actually experience life?

First of all, the avidyā, the ignorance, is now vidyā. There's no confusion in the enlightened person's mind as to the way things really are. We can say that the enlightened person is now not coming out of a state of ignorance, but coming out of a state of knowing.

This knowing, remember, is not a matter of facts and knowledges; it's a disposition. It's a way of being in the world which is not going to cause that being any more suffering. That's what we mean when we talk about somebody being enlightened. The Arahant, somebody who's enlightened, need not know how many hairs there are on his head, or her head. It's not necessary. What is the paññā? What is the enlightenment? What is the wisdom? It is a relationship with life which is different from being deluded.

So now that person is coming from a state of wisdom. They still have the body—a body which can be painful, not painful, pleasant. No problem. But when that body is giving sensations—we're coming all the way up now, straight up to contact—there is no delusion coming from that particular disposition. Reality, as it were, is not distorted into a delusive idea of the way I want it to be. And the way I want it to be is to get the world to make me feel happy. That's your essential position as an unenlightened person.

Coming into the world without any demands upon it, you can see that an enlightened person is very sensual—because there's no filtering. Pleasant and unpleasant feelings arise. There's still some sort of reaction to it. But that reaction is no longer suffering. There's no reaction to those pleasant and unpleasant feelings in terms of all those things we associate with suffering: depression, anger, anxiety, and all that.

All that, from taṇhā onwards—which are the saṅkhāras, the dispositions, the same thing as what we start off with—have now been totally transformed from the vicious to the virtuous. The enlightened person lives always in some mode of the four illimitables: either friendliness, love, compassion, joy, or peace. The Buddha himself says it. When you get to Nibbāna, you are contented and with it happy.

Being in that state, how then does the Buddha act? They had to coin a new word to express an enlightened person's action: *kiriya*. In the Buddha's understanding there are two types of actions, *kusala* and *akusala*—skillful and unskillful. What he means by that is those actions taking us towards enlightenment and those taking us the other way. When the Buddha is already enlightened, this business of *kusala* and *akusala* no longer applies because he's already there. His actions now become what's translated as 'functional'—which is rather dry.

But basically, his heart is now motivated to help other people become enlightened. All those actions arising out of a base of wisdom are for the benefit of others. Yet there's no attachment to them. There's no 'I am doing this.' The grasping is gone, and yet the action is still there. The doer has disappeared; there's only the doing.

That's why when a very old man corners him and says, 'Look, give me your teaching now,' and the Buddha says, 'Sorry, I'm on my alms round, can you come back later?'—the old man replies, 'I'm an old fellow, I could die any moment.' So the Buddha says, 'Well, okay, I'll give you the teaching in short. In the hearing, there's only the hearing. In the seeing, there's only the seeing. In the cognising, there's only the cognising.' And this old man became enlightened in the click of an eye. It didn't work for me.

So that's how an enlightened person works in the world. She no longer identifies with what she's doing. It's just an act coming out of a pure relationship with the world and with the people she finds herself among.

I would suggest that there are times when even we act like that. Even though we might not have cleared the base of ignorance, there are times when—through our constant effort to do what is skillful, constant excitation of that motivation of loving-kindness, of compassion—just occasionally, we do something out of an absolute purity of heart. For the benefit of the other, not for oneself.

I think that's it.

Transcendent Dependent Arising: The Spiral Path from Dukkha to Liberation

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 18 min

Originally given as *Transcendent Dependent Arising: The Spiral Path from Dukkha to Liberation* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this teaching, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the Upanisā Sutta's presentation of Transcendent Dependent Arising, a teaching that traces the complete journey from dukkha (suffering/unsatisfactoriness) to full liberation. Unlike the traditional twelve links showing how we create suffering, this teaching reveals twelve progressive steps leading from dukkha to awakening.

Bhante presents seven practical "entry points" to the spiral path: faith (saddhā), wise investigation, virtue (sīla), restraint, dedication, right awareness (sammā sati), and inspiration. Using climate change anxiety as a contemporary example, he demonstrates how each entry point can transform our relationship with suffering. The teaching progresses through gladness (pāmojja), rapture (pīti), tranquillity (pas-saddhi), happiness (sukha), and concentration (samādhi), ultimately leading to wisdom and liberation.

This approach offers a refreshing complement to traditional Vipassanā practice, allowing practitioners to actively cultivate wholesome states rather than merely observing. Bhante emphasizes keeping expectations modest—recognizing that even small shifts from suffering toward gladness constitute genuine progress on the spiral path. The teaching provides practical tools for meeting life's challenges while maintaining spiritual integrity and moving toward freedom.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa
 Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa
 Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa

Homage to the Blessed, Noble and Fully Self-Enlightened One.

During the summer I got interested in a teaching commonly known as Transcendent Dependent Arising, the Upanissaya Sutta. I was drawn to this via the six maxims, ethical practices designed to help us face climate change in a way that preserves our integrity. One of these maxims is to see our good fortune in being alive right now at a time of such crisis for mankind. Instead of seeing floods, droughts, wildfires, and soil erosion as horrors, we are to welcome each one as an opportunity to develop courage, resilience, and other gifts that come of meeting suffering with open arms.

The Upanissaya Sutta provides Dhamma support for this, as it traces out the list of causes and conditions leading to enlightenment. The first twelve steps might be familiar, showing how we create *dukkha*—meaning suffering in all its variations from minor irritation to heartbreak, excruciating pain, or abject fear—by believing we can make ourselves happy in a world which is unstable, uncontrollable, and inherently unsatisfying.

What is special about this teaching is that it doesn't stop at *dukkha*, but traces an equal number of steps leading from *dukkha* to liberation. It gives us a list of skills and qualities we can and should develop to bring about our own liberation. I recently attended a Tricycle online course entitled The Spiral to Freedom, in which the teachers, John Peacock and Akincano Weber, look at this particular teaching, as well as a number of related teachings which explore the same area. They refer to these as the spiral teachings, and call the path leading from *dukkha* to liberation a spiral path. They also stress that all the links in the spiral path can be seen in ordinary daily life.

It all starts with *dukkha*, which I think is really good news. If you know you're unhappy, irritated, or out of sorts, then you're already at the launching pad for the spiral path. Taking *dukkha* as a given, the teachings suggest a number of responses, which John and Akincano refer to as entry points to the spiral.

Let's take *dukkha* over climate change as an example. Suppose we are in a stew of misery at news of another wildfire. How can we meet this with open arms? For some, faith is the easiest way to counter the pull into negative thinking. This could be the bright faith of the beginner, or the mature trust that grows with long practice. Every time another dark thought takes us back into the pit, we place our trust in the Dhamma to draw ourselves out. It could help to look at a Buddha *rupa* or whatever symbolises the Dhamma for you. The Buddha touched the earth when

he needed all his faith, and this is worth trying out sometime. Place your hands on the ground, feel its stability, its solidity; trust the vastness of the earth as a grounding in truth.

For some of us, faith might not come so easily. News of an environmental catastrophe—and knowing that this has been wrought by human greed—stimulates doubt rather than faith. We are flooded by questions like, what is life all about? But the only answer is, I don't know. If we're willing to explore the experience of I don't know, this is wise investigation, a second entry point to the spiral. Although we don't have the answers, we have access to teachings that can point us in the right direction. Thus, the feeling of bewilderment is the catalyst that motivates us to learn about suffering and how it can be transcended.

At other times, investigation may seem irrelevant. We want to do something, anything, to relieve the suffering. In this case, virtue becomes the link from dukkha to the spiral. We respond to the news of the wildfire with ethical action. We might donate to a charity supporting those affected, sign a petition, or write to our local council. We find some positive action aiming to minimise the harm and pain. As well as being beneficial for the world, this counters the pull into depression owing to the perilous state of the world and restores our confidence in the power of goodness.

But sometimes we just can't find the energy, the goodwill needed to sign yet another petition or make that donation. Everything in us wants to turn away from the world, forget all its horrors. This impulse contains the wisdom of restraint, which is another entry point to the spiral. We let ourselves turn away from activity, withdraw to some quiet place, let go of all the thoughts about climate change or other news. We give ourselves the silence and rest we need to let our hearts heal. This could mean an hour's meditation; it could mean a long retreat; or perhaps all we can do is a few mindful breaths. Whatever works is fine. We're honouring a wholesome response to dukkha.

The opposite can happen too. The news of the wildfire leads to restlessness. We can't keep still and we certainly don't want to turn inwards. Instead, we need something to occupy us. In this case, we can use the entry point of dedication. We could wash the dishes as if this were a sacred ceremony, the most important task in the world, taking care of all the little details. Although we can't fix the wildfire, we can take care of what is at hand. And this is a very worthy response to dukkha.

At other times, the thought of taking care of anyone or anything seems an impossible burden. Perhaps thoughts of who is to blame and how it should be fixed crash into one another, making our heads spin. In this case, mindfulness provides a good entry point to the spiral. We don't have to follow each sensation of the breath. We can use phrases like "walking to the shops," "making the dinner," "driving to work" to keep us present, alert, mindful. Although news of the wildfire might still be tempting us to fret and worry, we are choosing present reality as an antidote to those dead ends. And this is a valid way to lift ourselves out of dukkha and into the spiral path.

Sometimes we can't even muster the energy to be mindful. Everything seems hopeless. In this case, we need to look outside ourselves and let inspiration become our stepping stone from dukkha to the spiral. Who or what will draw our attention away from misery? What might persuade us that life is worth living? For some, it's a weekend camping. Others might sign up for a study course. It could be as simple as meeting a friend, listening to a dharma talk, leafing through photos of happier times. I keep some well-worn biographies at hand when I need a lift, or go out for a long walk. Sometimes gazing at the sunset is enough to inspire me, to remind me of life's promise.

Thus we have seven options for digging ourselves out of dukkha and into the spiral: faith, investigation, virtue, restraint, dedication, mindfulness, and inspiration. Each of us will have our own strengths, our preferred entry points, and these will vary from one situation to another depending on what mood we're in. Working with these entry points is a powerful practice. As we try them in practical situations, we get to know our strengths and learn to play to them.

This provides a contrast with the standard *vipassanā* approach, where we simply observe, don't interfere, don't try to make things better. To launch ourselves out of dukkha and into the spiral path, we're allowed to be biased, to seek out and amplify feelings and mind states that lift us up. Mindfulness is not only an entry point in itself but also works in the background for all the others, noticing what works, what doesn't, when we've gone too far, when we need to step back, take it easy, and try another approach when we're ready.

Once we've found an entry point, the next link in the spiral is gladness. A moment ago we were stuck in the pits of dukkha; now we've found a way forward. The heart quite naturally gladdens when this happens. Surprisingly, the feeling of gladness is easily overlooked. We can be so intent on doing our virtuous action, so immersed in the beauty of the sunset, that we don't notice the change of heart.

Unless we pay attention to this, we could inadvertently start another round of dukkha—stressing ourselves out in the effort to do our good deeds, so inspired by the sunset that the rest of life pales by comparison. We need to be on the lookout for gladness. It deepens our faith that there really is a path leading from suffering to liberation—and that it is possible for me to follow it.

Gladness sets up the necessary conditions for rapture, the next link in the spiral. The word suggests an over-the-top joy, but if we're on the lookout for it, we find rapture to be quite a simple, down-to-earth experience. The background mood of gladness helps us engage, be interested in whatever we experience. This engaged interest in present experience is what we mean by rapture. It can be experienced quite simply as interest or curiosity. Look out for this at the start of any activity—as you step into the shower, take the first bite of dinner, say hello to a friend, listen to a podcast. Sometimes it can feel a bit giddy or overexcited, expecting too much. Sometimes very mild, like a gentle uplift or refreshment.

Rapture sets up the conditions for the next link, tranquillity. This was one I struggled with until Akincano described tranquillity as that cooling phase in every activity, when the initial fizz goes out of it. This put a completely different light on tranquillity for me. And true enough, once I investigated that slight deflation when a new activity lost its sparkle, I detected an inner relaxation underlying the more obvious surface layer of disappointment. I needed to bring attention to the body for this. The mood of deflation still predominated in the mind, but within the tissues of the body, particularly the limbs, I sensed peace and ease. I realised I had become more grounded, more settled within myself.

So keep an eye out for any slight deflation when a new activity starts to feel humdrum. Ask whether deep down peace has descended. I never knew disappointment could hold such treasure. But don't go straight for tranquillity, skipping over the rapture stage, thinking it's silly to be getting excited by things. For tranquillity to have any depth, we need to put our heart into the activity while it still strikes us as novel and interesting. The energy of enthusiasm lifts us up, and that same energy transforms into tranquillity when the novelty wears off.

Tranquillity sets up the conditions needed for the next link, happiness. Once I had detected and assured myself that tranquillity was really present, the mood of disappointment evaporated and the heart softened. I realised I was content, happy. While tranquillity for me could be described as a bodily form of happiness, the recognition of tranquillity allowed that happiness to spread from body to mind. Unless I had looked for tranquillity within that deflationary phase when the

fizz went out of an activity, the mood of disappointment would have remained. Nothing had changed in my circumstances to make me happy—only that I'd noticed and paid attention to the physical relaxation that happened as an activity turned from novel and exciting to humdrum.

I hope any of you who often feel depressed will take this point to heart. Trust that it is possible to be happy, even if you can't change the circumstances of your life. But beware the temptation to skip over the early stages and go straight for tranquillity or happiness. Each step needs the support of the previous ones. We need to investigate each one, be prepared to come back to *dukkha* again and again, getting more familiar with the entry points, detecting the change of heart to gladness, and so on.

A happy mind quite naturally rests attention on whatever it chooses to attend to, and thus happiness sets up the conditions needed for *samādhi*. *Samādhi* is the ability of the mind to rest, be still, gather its energies around a particular focus. If we're happily washing the dishes, it won't take any effort to feel the rubbing movements, see the dishes, hear the gurgling of water. It's only when we're unhappy that we get distracted, planning or worrying so intently that we never notice our hands in contact with dishes. The unhappy mind has its energies going in multiple directions as one thought careers after another. The happy mind is unified. While washing dishes, we know we are washing dishes. The only thoughts that come up relate to washing dishes.

There are many advantages to *samādhi*. We sense the gathering of our usually scattered thoughts as restful healing. From the Buddha's point of view, the greatest value is that the gathered mind can see more deeply into whatever it focuses on. If we want to see the cause of suffering and the path to freedom, *samādhi* lets us see this more clearly.

This brings us to the many fruits of the spiral path, which start with understanding the Dhamma and lead onwards to full liberation from all suffering. To stick with our climate change example, I might start with a confusing mix of anxiety, anger, and despair at the news of the wildfire. If I can follow the spiral until the mind gathers in *samādhi*, I might then see how I'm torturing myself with imagined fears. The horror has been grasped so tightly I feel guilty unless I'm suffering too. It comes as humbling relief to admit that I am not suffering physically—and this liberates a much more genuine compassion for those who are.

I hope you'll try out these teachings—get to know your easiest entry points to the spiral and learn to recognise the transition from misery to gladness. A word of warning, though: words like gladness, rapture, tranquillity, and happiness can set us up for disappointment. Set your expectations very low. A momentary uplift from dukkha counts as gladness. The slight buzz that comes from a new activity counts as rapture. The slight relaxation in the body when that buzz dies away counts as tranquillity—and so on. Remember, small is beautiful.

In small steps, may we all be liberated from suffering. Thank you so much.

Paṭicca Samuppāda Revisited

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 44 min

Originally given as *Paṭicca Samuppāda Revisited* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this teaching, Bhante Bodhidhamma guides practitioners through paṭicca samuppāda (dependent origination), describing it as the central pillar from which all Buddha's teachings emerge. He explores how avijjā (not-knowing) creates the delusive self-relationship that perpetuates suffering, examining each of the twelve links: from initial ignorance through saṅkhāra (mental formations), viññāṇa (consciousness), nāmarūpa (mind-body), the six sense bases, contact, vedanā (feeling), taṇhā (desire), upādāna (grasping), bhava (becoming), jāti (birth), and jarāmaraṇa (aging and death).

Drawing on the Buddha's victory verse, Bhante explains how the 'house builder' represents our false sense of self—not a thing but a relationship between knowing and experience. He illuminates two key escape points in the cycle: between vedanā and taṇhā (the primary focus of meditation practice), and at the root level of avijjā itself. The teaching emphasizes how renunciation—even small acts of non-indulgence—undercuts the delusive self that drives our suffering.

Practical insights include understanding identity as complete absorption (losing sense of self), recognizing that all experience happens through the six sense doors, and seeing how consumer culture exploits our desire for excitement over genuine happiness. Bhante concludes by exploring the nature of awareness itself—empty like the tongue that can taste all flavors precisely because it has no inherent taste.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble, and fully self-awakened one.

I thought we'd go through dependent origination together. I'm presuming most of you haven't explored it in any detail, so if you like, you can use this little booklet and we'll work through it step by step. From dependent origination, all the other teachings of the Buddha fork off—each of these little sections branches away into other teachings. It's a central pillar of the Buddha's dispensation.

We'll come back to the victory verse, but I just want to point you to the last line: *visamkhāragataṃ cittaṃ*. *Saṅkhāra* means something compounded. *Citta* here refers to mind, consciousness—and what the Buddha is saying is that there is an unconditioned consciousness. Yet there's nothing in our experience of the world which is not conditioned.

We start with this word *avijjā*. *Vijjā* simply means knowing, so *avijjā* is something's not knowing. It's not ignorance in the pejorative sense—just don't know. And it's a place where we don't like to be. It creates a little confusion for us, a certain sense of anxiety, because we like to know.

I just had an email from Wey, who's coming to teach with me at Gaia House. She says it's been yonks since she's been there—where do I park and what do I do? So I wrote back and said, as soon as you come in through the gate, you'll see where to park because it's on your left. Then make your way to the office. Now I'm waiting for her to reply and say, where's the office?

I think we'll all find that whenever we don't know something, there's always that little tremor. Don't know what's going to happen. This place of don't know is a place for us to explore.

What's happened is that we didn't know and we made a mistake—we presumed. What was the presumption? Well, if we go back to the Buddha's victory verse, he says, I've travelled through rounds of countless births, seeking but not finding the house builder. Who's doing this? Who the hell keeps making me go through life after life?

And then he says, painful is birth over and over and over again. Oh, house builder, I've found you. You've been caught, I've got you. You won't build another house for me. Your rafters have been broken, your ridge pole demolished. What he's referring to, of course, is this self.

This self is a relationship—it's not a thing, it's a relationship. Selfing. It's about something in us identifying with something else, and through that identity, possessing things.

What do we mean by identity? If you catch your finger in the door or bite your tongue, just for that one moment you, the tongue, and the pain are completely one. That is identity. Then you jump out and punch yourself on the nose—which means you're stupid—because you're angry, or upset, or whatever. Now you're identifying with emotions. You've separated from the tongue; you can feel the pain, but now you're the one who's angry with it.

Identity is when you actually lose the sense of self—you become what it is that you identify with. It happens, for instance, when you're watching a video. You turn it on, two hours pass. Where have you been? Where's the sense of self gone? You've been completely absorbed in the story. Then you come out of it, suddenly wake up, and there you are. You say, that was a good video, wasn't it?

Identity is that point where you actually lose a sense of self, but it's also a complete identity with the self. And when you come out of that identity, you have a different relationship—you own it or you want to disown it. Obviously the pain from biting your tongue you want to disown. But if you have a mobile, you definitely want to own it.

And of course, what we've discovered is that this self is a false identity. There's something happening there—we'll come back to it. The sense of possessing something is also a delusion. When a thief steals your mobile and you go around saying, 'Somebody's stolen my mobile,' the thief keeps saying, 'It's my mobile.' It's not yours, is it? It belongs to the thief now. But you insist it's your mobile.

What you begin to realise is that with objects, you can only use them. To possess them is just going to cause problems. Sometimes it's helpful to imagine what would happen if you lost your mobile or it was stolen. Then you have at least a strategy to work with, and the situation doesn't take you by so much surprise.

The amount of suffering that comes when you lose something is the measure of your attachment. The amount of fear you have towards losing something—your life, say—is the measure of your identity with this psychophysical organism.

All these emotional states are actually telling us something about our relationships. And as human beings, that's what we are, isn't it? We are our relationships. Inwardly, it's my relationship to my body, my emotions, and so on. Outwardly, it's my relationship to nature, to people. Everything is in this process of relating—one to the other, the one affecting the other.

We get a sense of self, which gives us the feeling that I'm in charge, I'm the one who does this, I'm the one who does that. But when we investigate, it's always some recognition of something affecting me—something I'm actually in relationship with, some sort of dance with. If it's happy, it's a dance with people, with objects.

This is what the Buddha found. He found there was a core mistake being made, and it was causing him to be reborn over and over again.

So now, this *avijjā*. What it suggests is that something must not know. You can't have not-knowing without something that doesn't know, that doesn't actually have the not-knowing. Something that knows, knows.

It is depending upon that *avijjā*, that not-knowing, that we create this wrong relationship we call a self. A self is a relationship happening between the knowing and what it's actually experiencing—the relationship between the knowing and what it's experiencing.

When you look into a mirror and see yourself there, there's a relationship with what you're looking at. This knowing has come into this life form, awakens into it at birth, and presumes that this is it—this is what I am.

Because of that presumption, it begins to create a delusion and acts through that delusion. What is the essence of it? What is this knowing searching for?

We go back to the Buddha's verse: I've travelled through rounds of countless births, how painful it is to be born over and over again. This not-knowing, this delusion, is seeking happiness. And it's seeking happiness in the world it finds itself in, which is the world of the mind. There's another little split here—the mind-body split. We'll come to that in a minute.

What has been done in the past has created a whole set of habits based upon this delusion. All our habits have running underneath them this delusive understanding.

It's because of this movement in the mind that consciousness arises. Consciousness is dependent on an object—and here the English words make it very difficult not to think of consciousness as something that thinks or does something. But consciousness here is just a mirror. It's just a screen upon which information arises.

The information is the *saṅkhāra*—your habits. What's a habit? It has a physical component, like eating. It has an emotional component—there's always a feel to something. And it has an understanding component. If you look at any habit, you can see there are always those three factors: the body, the heart, and the mind. That's the information coming upon this screen, and that's the meaning here of *viññāṇa*.

It's because of *viññāṇa*, because of that consciousness, that there comes a realisation: there's the body and there's the mind. We know this split just from popular culture. A lot of people do yoga for the body and meditation for the mind—the separation is already there. We can see it in sports too: some are physically based—football, tennis—and others are mentally based—chess and the like.

So you've got this *nāmarūpa* split. Now, the Buddha says that mind is foremost, mind is at the base of everything. What have we got here? We've got a sense base—the retina. And it's sensitive enough to actually feel subatomic particles. That's incredible, isn't it? A tiny, tiny, tiniest of all things—a photon. And the eye actually feels it. There's a felt sense to it.

At that point of touch with the physical base, the mind is already there. Otherwise, we wouldn't know it. You know this from sleep—your eyes aren't open, so you don't see anything. There has to be a consciousness there. There has to be that screen.

As that photon hits the eye, it's not just hitting the physical base, which is a medium for that photon. It's hitting the actual mental process, the process of mind. And it's the mind that creates out of that photon the colour you're actually seeing.

This is more obvious with hearing. At the sense base of hearing, all there is, is a touch. There's no sound. There's no sound in the universe—just a touch. You can actually experience this. And then, not suddenly, what you get next is the mind translating that touch into a sound. Then it gives it a name—bell. Then it gives it a meaning—wake up bell. And only then does the idea of 'me' arise—I've got to get up. That's the process. And you can actually experience it in meditation.

There's a very good book on the process of seeing by a woman called Cynthia Thatcher. She died very young, unfortunately. But her book—*Seeing*—I can't remember the full title, but I can give you the name of it. It's a really excellent book on the Mahāsi process. Her big insight was on seeing. What she says is that there's

a point where you're so down at that base level, before the mind can work on it, that the world splits into little dots—like the pointillist paintings. That's what you see, just little dots. And then it's all put together.

Here we have that first separation. Actually, we've got a couple of separations. There's the not-knowing separating from the habits that the delusive self has manufactured. Then there's the split between the habits and how they manifest on the screen of consciousness. And because of that screen of consciousness, we can begin to separate out the body from the mind.

But of course, what we discover is that it's all mind. It's just that mind has a way of contacting matter—but it only contacts matter by way of that gate. It's called a door in Pali. And therefore, our experience of the world is entirely dependent upon the sense base.

Obviously, if you're colourblind, you live in a different colour world than somebody who has ordinary sight.

It's dependent upon this body-mind split that you have these six sense bases. Again, in the Buddhist teachings, for something to be known there has to be an object, there has to be a sense base, and there has to be that consciousness—that screen upon which it appears.

One way of looking at the human being is that we're made up of these six consciousnesses. There are the five ordinary ones—eye, ear, nose, tongue, body—and then the mind. The mind here is really the interpreting mind. It's not the higher mind of thought or energetic work. It's just that part of the mind which interprets what's coming in.

Now, once the six sense bases are there, dependent on all of that is the point of contact we've been talking about—this point of touch. And it's at the point of touch that those three things need to be present: the object, the sense base, and consciousness, the screen.

Once that point is created, the mind begins to separate out what is pleasant and unpleasant. There's your next split—pleasant and unpleasant. There's a whole bit in the middle, which is neutral. But when you get really close to a neutral feeling, I think you'll see it either shades off into unpleasant or shades off into pleasant. That's the dual world we live in. We can't go beyond that. Whatever we experience in this world will either be pleasing to us or displeasing. That's a given fact.

Now the self comes in. At this point there's a movement towards or away from what we're actually experiencing. This is the process of desiring. When something is pleasant, when it's something we think we're going to enjoy, there's a movement towards grasping it. And when it's something we don't like, we want to push it away, get rid of it.

Here's the beginning of suffering—but it's not actually suffering yet. This is what we discover through this practice: we can be aware of that process, but that which is aware of the process is not actually suffering. It's standing above it, standing apart from it, just watching.

Now, between those two—the recognition of something as pleasant or unpleasant, and this reaction, a learnt reaction coming from the *saṅkhāra*, the habitual nature—that's one point of escape. By putting our attention there and allowing this wrong relationship, which manifests as a form of desire, to slowly dissipate, we're undermining that bad habit.

Remember, underneath this process we've got two things running all the time. One is the essential delusion. And all the habits are there constantly, just like programs on a computer. The mind isn't like a computer, by the way, but I'm just... It's running underneath every moment of our lives—the habits and the delusion that's creating the habits. And it's dependent upon what's happening at the sense base, which awakens some form of habit.

If your eye hits the ice cream button, then this desire for ice cream comes up, based upon seeking happiness in food.

Once that desire has come up, we have this word *upādāna*. Desire here—I've translated it as desire. They usually translate it as craving. But I've always thought craving was just over the top, really. At times we do crave, but even the smallest attraction is also part of *taṇhā*. It can be the smallest little movement in the mind, or it can be an addiction.

And then, because of that, we have this next reaction. These are all reactions, not responses. They're not coming from wisdom. They're just something that happens habitually.

This is *upādāna*. *Upādāna* is a grasping, and what's actually happening there is a process of identity. Now that this self manifests, at that point it's extremely difficult to stop the next step.

The next step is, of course, to empower the desire. But once you've identified with the desire, you've got to be right on the ball to stop it moving into action. I've only ever done it once. I was just aware enough to see the desire, to see the grasping, and then to pull myself out. What I experienced was a sort of sucking into the object.

That's why the whole attention of the practice is on the bit we can grasp quite clearly: the gap between feeling—pleasant or unpleasant—and our reaction of desire or aversion. But here a question arises: what is it that's doing the grasping? Remember, although we say the grasping is where the 'me' comes in, the 'I', what is it that's actually doing that? Just keep that in the back of your mind.

Let me repeat that: the self isn't a thing. It's a relationship. It's an identity, a relationship that the knowing—some knowing—has with what it's actually experiencing. It feels solid, but it isn't.

The next link is dependent upon that: you get this bhava, this becoming. The reason the Buddha used the word bhava here is because he's referring to the self. The process isn't just one self doing things. The process is a continuous selfing. Every time you go through this cycle, another self is created. And according to the psychology, this can happen quite quickly—even within a minute. You can just be constantly reaffirming your connection to what you want or what you don't want.

But bhava also includes an action. Whatever that desire was, whatever it attached to, now begins to manifest—either as a train of thought, a train of speech, or a physical action. The becoming refers back to the self acting out its desires. That's the bhava.

Now, looking at this more as an immediate process rather than the traditional way—it's not even traditional now because both ways are taught, but traditionally it was about past lives, this present life, and future life. That's why the next link is jāti, which means birth. But this jāti can also be understood as beginning. As soon as you empower something, there must be a beginning to the action.

And dependent upon that power, you've now got ageing and death—of an action. You've got the beginning of an action, the process of an action, and the completion of the action. That's seeing dependent origination as something happening now, immediately.

And then, of course, there's this wonderful cascade of horror: death, sorrow, lamentation, pain, grief, and despair. This gets across the message that we're not having a great time sometimes. The process is not going to lead us to the happiness we seek.

So what is it that doesn't know? What is it that's made the mistake of not knowing? Is it not so that when we're meditating, we're pulling out of what we're experiencing and finding this little observation post within ourselves? And in that observation post, we can sense ourselves to be the observer, the feeler, the watcher, the one who knows. Everything is just passing in front of us, like a show. Where does that sense of self come from? Because it's even there with the knowing.

It must be coming because it's a reflection. You're aware of yourself being the observer. You're aware of yourself being the knower. So that must be a reflection. And the only place where you can have a reflection is on that screen of consciousness. So something has pulled itself out of the psychophysical organism, found a place to observe it, and sees itself doing so.

Now, in Buddhist understanding, that can't be happening at the same time. That screen can only flash one sense base—it can only do one at a time. But it's happening so quickly that we get the feeling of continuity and simultaneity. For instance, when you're watching a film and chewing your popcorn and hearing the soundtrack, many senses are involved. To us, it seems like it's all happening at the same time. But in Buddhist psychology, it's a waterfall of sense bases being awoken one after the other at such speed that it feels simultaneous.

Think about the old reel films, which I think ran at 26 frames per minute or something like that—as you slowed them down, the individual frames became obvious. It's the same with us. That's one of the blessings, one of the benefits, shall we say, of the Mahāsi system: as you slow the whole psychophysical process down, these processes become more and more obvious.

So what is the nature of that awareness? What is the nature of the knowing? That's what we're chasing. Recognising that the body and mind are two different things is, shall we say, an important understanding, because then you might open up the possibility of rebirth. That allows there to be some sort of karmic justice in the universe. Otherwise it's a bit awful when you think that Stalin died in bed from a heart attack, I think—but he died in bed, nice and warm.

You can understand, then, that in terms of moral justice—some sort of justice in the universe—there has to be movement from one birth to the next where our past behaviours are sorted out. But you have to be careful here, because it's not at all mechanical. Not at all. It's all about relationship, all about how a habit will respond to a particular situation.

It might be, for instance, that somebody dies with a great feeling of generosity in their heart. That's the main force carried into the next rebirth—you might say that's the habit which is uppermost. But they enter into a situation which undermines that quality of generosity: living amongst selfish people, cruel people, and so on. And so that begins to erode their generosity. On the other hand, they could be born into a situation where they're supported in that generosity, and they grow more and more generous. So it's not a simple case of direct connection. It's all to do with relationship. And it's all to do with the being, whatever they are, recognising where the suffering is and slowly purifying their own heart.

Eventually, it's just us purifying ourselves of all this negative stuff. And as we were saying this morning, the transition, the movement towards what is beautiful, happens naturally. When we put our concentration upon what is unwholesome, the wholesomeness arises of its own accord. That's what they say in Zen: with wisdom, compassion arises naturally. It's just a natural process.

Our spiritual aim is to find out what the nature of that awareness is. What is the nature of that awareness? And we're in a double bind here, because the awareness can't see itself. Just like the eye can't see itself. The tongue can't taste itself—it doesn't have a taste. If your tongue had a basic taste of curry, how could you ever enjoy ice cream? It's because the tongue is empty of taste that it can have all these different tastes. It's because the eye doesn't have any sense of light within it that it can receive the light.

This awareness has nothing in it, and that's the meaning of emptiness. That's the meaning of *śūnyatā* that you'll come across, which is pushed a great deal in the Mahāyāna tradition because they extend it to everything—everything is empty. But it's there in the Theravāda scriptures too. The Buddha uses both the word *anattā*—not-self, referring to the idea of a soul which is permanent and has personality—but he also uses the word *śūnya*, which means empty.

Here we have a rather unfortunate situation where we find ourselves in this position of an observer. We're slowly pulling away from everything we thought was me, because you're pointing at it. You're pointing at your body with its pains and pleasures. You're pointing at the emotions and moods which you thought was

really you, which you felt was you. And you're looking at thoughts and images—especially images that come across the mind—beginning to realise that this awareness which is pulling itself out isn't actually them. It's of another order. But in so doing, it creates this sense of self. Now there's your double bind. How are you going to get out of that sense of self in order to experience the true nature of awareness?

And of course, this true nature of awareness is exactly what the Buddha found. Buddha means the one who knows—that's all it means, the one who knows. In his victory verse, the Buddha is talking about something which is being manufactured. He's found it, he's destroyed it, he's destroyed the process of manufacturing through the delusive self. But he himself, of course, continues.

Once he was liberated, he didn't sit there like a blob and hope the world would come to an end very quickly. He got up and began to teach. Everything that was already there—all his understanding, his intellect, his imagination—remained. He loves to explain something intellectually and then give a metaphor; there are hundreds of metaphors in the discourses. And he likes to walk. He walks all over the place. He must have travelled thousands of miles right across that North Indian plain.

It's not as though he was somebody different. And he had the same personality—it's not as though his personality changed. It just became purer. He didn't have the nastiness of anger and resentment. He didn't have the nastiness of indulgence and greed. But it was still him. When he appeared to his disciples, they didn't say, 'Have you had a psychotic breakdown or something? Because you're completely different.' They immediately recognised him.

And as he's talking to them—this isn't in the scriptures, it's in the Vinaya, in the discourses about the monastic order—he approaches them and starts talking about the Four Noble Truths. And he interrupts himself by saying, 'Have you ever heard me talk like this before? Have you ever heard me say anything like this before?' Very slowly, these five disciples, who had rejected him because he'd gone soft—he'd given up on the mortifications, for heaven's sake—began to open up to him. And one of them actually made it. One of them had the eye of the Dhamma, the Dhammacakkhu, opened. And the Buddha rejoices. And he actually calls him—oh dear, what's the word? It'll come to me, it'll come to me, it's gone. Aiyo... So annoying. You get to an age when words disappear. Very annoying. Koṇḍañña. Koṇḍañña knows. He's the one who knows. Koṇḍañña, Koṇḍañña. That's what he called him—Koṇḍañña the one who knows—and that was the name he gave him.

He used to give titles to people. Sāriputta, who knew the Dhamma perhaps as well as the Buddha, he used to call the general of the Dhamma, the Dhamma Senāpati. And then when they come back—they've gone on alms round, I don't know how long that took—the next talk he gives is about not-self. And they all become fully liberated. That's how powerful it is.

Now you might think, what? He gives about a half-hour talk on not-self and they all become liberated? But then you have to understand that we have to accept these people had been practising like mad for so many years with the Buddha. They were on the edge of enlightenment. All they needed was some sort of guidance. And it was this guidance that liberated them.

So we're coming to the end, and I want to look quickly at the order of ceasing. What we note here is that undermining that delusive self cuts the whole thing. The entire structure collapses like a pack of cards. All this ignorance and all the unwholesome stuff we've created simply falls away. That's how important it is. And we're undermining the self every time we renounce that desire to indulge. Because that's how the self manifests, remember. It manifests in indulging—indulging in what we like and indulging in rejecting what we don't like.

Greed and aversion are manifestations of this delusion. Every time we undercut them, we're cutting deep down at the root of all our problems. That's where it begins. With the entire cessation of this ignorance, all those unwholesome habits disappear. It's as simple as that. It's going to happen this evening.

And then, of course, because of that, everything else starts to disappear. This consciousness disappears. Now, it's not that consciousness disappears; it's the consciousness of unwholesomeness that disappears. If consciousness itself disappeared, the Buddha would have ended up being a blob, sat on a stone, waiting for the world to come to an end. So you have to read this carefully, or else you think, oh my goodness, Nirvāṇa is some sort of blackout, some sort of complete, total annihilation.

And really, that's what happened when the Christian missionaries went out in all their forms to places like Burma and Sri Lanka. They just couldn't get it. They thought this was annihilation, and they dismissed Buddhism as world-negative.

There's a book by Dr. Schweitzer, who was a great philanthropist of the last century. He trained himself to be a doctor and worked out in Africa. He wrote this book, *Buddhism and Christianity*—it was the first book I read comparing the two traditions. And it was quite clear: Buddhism was life-negative and Christianity

was life-positive. That was the book. I don't know why it didn't convince me to become a Christian, but it failed. Isn't he the same one who was the musician, the organist? No? I think he was a philosopher too. Dr. Schweitzer.

So everything else begins to collapse—but only in the sense of supporting the delusion, of supporting those habits which are unwholesome. And as we pointed out, the other escape is between the *vedanā*, the feeling, and the reaction of *taṇhā*. That's when we are renouncing. So the whole of the spiritual life is a process of renunciation. Let go, let go.

Now, at first, when you begin to renounce something, you might feel you've lost something. Have you noticed that? If you don't react to the greed while you're eating—you can try this when you prepare yourself something you really like. You maintain a distance and just taste pleasant sensations. Because you're not indulging, a level of excitement disappears. You're not enjoying the food as much as you did before. And you think, oh, there's something wrong with this. I've got to get back to stuffing myself.

But I'm hoping the talk you heard this morning has convinced you that there's a penalty to pay for that excitement—which is, of course, the frustration, the anger, the anxiety, and so on. You have to let go of something in order to begin experiencing pure enjoyment without the suffering. And that's what's so difficult, because we just love to indulge. It gives us that little buzz.

The whole consumer society is based upon that. It's not based upon you being pleasantly happy. It's based upon you being excited. That's why products change. Even if they only change the look of a mobile phone, they'll change it to make you excited. So that, oh yeah, I've got to get that one. The whole consumer process is driven by that desire for excitement, not happiness. Because when happiness comes, there also comes contentment. You are contented. You're not chasing things at all. And that happiness is coming from within you, not because of an object.

That's a hard thing for us to move towards, because it does feel like you're losing something in not allowing yourself to indulge. And yes, just the final thing: every time you renounce that indulgence, even if it's only a little bit—even if it's just, you normally have three or four biscuits and you say, well, I'm only going to have two—even a little renunciation is undercutting that sense of self.

I can only hope my words have been of some assistance, that I have not caused even greater confusion, and that by your devotion to the practice you will be liberated from all suffering sooner rather than later.

Kamma

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 37 min

Originally given as *Kamma* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this exploration of kamma, Bhante Bodhidhamma begins with the fundamental Buddhist principle of idappaccayatā (dependent origination) - 'because this, that' - explaining how the present arises from both past conditions and current circumstances. He distinguishes the popular understanding of karma from the Buddha's precise teaching, clarifying that kamma refers specifically to intentional action, while vipāka denotes its results.

The talk examines the five universal laws governing existence: utu (physics/chemistry), bīja (genetics), citta (mind/psychology), kamma (intentional action), and dhamma (spiritual laws). Through this framework, Bhante explains why not everything that happens to us constitutes personal kamma - natural disasters, genetic conditions, and cultural circumstances arise from other causes.

Drawing from the wheel of paṭicca samuppāda, he traces how contact (phassa) leads to feeling (vedanā), then to craving (taṇhā) and grasping (upādāna), ultimately creating bhava (becoming) through our empowered intentions. The teaching emphasizes that while we cannot control external consequences of our actions, we have complete responsibility for our inner responses and the mental conditioning we create. This understanding offers profound hope: that individual liberation from dukkha remains possible regardless of external circumstances.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble, and fully self-enlightened one.

To start at the beginning: to understand the Buddha's way of looking at what happens in the universe, we need to look at the fundamental law known as *idappaccayatā* — the law of this and that. You can't get simpler than that.

The law states: because this happened in the past, this is happening now. Because this hasn't happened in the past, this doesn't happen now. Because this is happening in the present, that is also happening in the present. And because this isn't happening in the present, that doesn't happen either. Need I explain?

The first part concerns kamma in terms of cause and effect — temporal cause and effect, passing through time. You made a decision to visit a dentist, and there you are. Cause and effect, passing through time.

However, if it were just that — if the present moment were conditioned only by the past — then you're into predestination, aren't you? You're into a set pattern. It would be hard to see how you could get creativity. Perhaps the universe would just keep repeating itself. On the other hand, if things only happen because they arise in the now, unconnected with the past, then you're looking at chaos, aren't you?

If we put those two concepts together, we have the Buddha's understanding of what's happening in the universe. In a sense, it approximates — as far as I understand — the modern theory of chaos. Having read that book, and therefore presenting myself as an expert, I can tell you it gives one example where the flap of a butterfly's wing in Australia ends up as a hurricane bursting its way through the United States. In the past we can see the butterfly wing, but conditions around it produce turbulence, conditions around that produce further turbulence, and before you know it, you have a hurricane or a tornado.

The law states that something is coming into the present and meeting other things coming from different pasts, and hence you have a new creative situation. The opposite is also true: if something doesn't arise, something else happens. The sun comes up, it's a lovely summer, and the harvest is great. The workers are out there, the money's earned, and everybody's happy. The sunshine fails to come, the harvest doesn't happen, people don't eat, and there's famine.

All of us are here in this room having made decisions in the past, completely separate from each other. And here we are — oh, happy gathering. That's the law of *idappaccayatā*. That's what the Buddha saw as basically happening at that level.

When it comes to human beings — that's a physical law, you see, the law of physics, you might say — it's fairly easy to accept the law of kamma so long as we can see some justice. You work hard, you get the money, and you own a nice house. That's good kamma. You have a good life, but then unfortunately you get a bad illness. That's bad kamma. But that's the way it is.

When something outlandish happens, though, it's difficult. The murder of two innocent little girls, Holly Wells and Jessica Chapman. An earthquake in Turkey, or the one in Japan — thousands of people just crushed. Or indeed, the people in the Twin Towers. When we come across a real disaster that doesn't make sense, this idea of human justice comes in. Something has to be just.

Now, justice belongs to a system of punishment and reward. In the eighteenth century it was perfectly just to hang somebody for stealing a sheep. Now you can commit mass murder and you go to jail. I'm not suggesting that's not what should happen — it's just that, obviously, when we come to justice, reward, and punishment, it's entirely dependent on what human beings think is justice. Remember the old Gilbert and Sullivan? *The Mikado*, isn't it? Let the punishment fit the crime. For his innocent merriment — that was the emperor, wasn't it?

That isn't the law of kamma. The law of kamma is really stating that all this business about reward and punishment is something we produce for ourselves — it's our personal kamma. If we decide to punish somebody, we're laying extra suffering on that person. And whatever we do, there's got to be some consequence. That's actually the better word for kamma: consequence. You do something and there's a consequence, an effect.

The problem is, we're not in charge of the process that happens to an action once we've performed it. That butterfly never meant to do any harm, but it was put in jail for years for causing that hurricane. There was a case here in Totnes, I was told, of a charity group that collected clothes — clothes for the poor in Africa. A very compassionate, loving idea. They collected all these clothes and sent them to Africa. And they put all the tailors out of work. That wonderful compassionate act ended up causing massive suffering for a lot of people. Just because you do something out of the goodness of your heart doesn't mean everybody's going to be happy with it. The world is a very complicated place.

Now, if we say that kamma is much more to do with action and its product — and I'm using kamma here as we use it in the vernacular, in the ordinary sense of something that's resulted; that's not its actual proper use. Its proper use is just

action. The proper word for the result is *vipāka*. But using it as we normally do — bad kamma, good kamma — we can see that everything that happens to us is not our personal responsibility.

The law of kamma is only one of five laws that the Buddha taught. Now, strictly speaking, I'm not absolutely sure whether this was something he taught directly — I can't remember — or whether it's something extrapolated from the text by later commentaries. But these five laws are, shall we say, a compendium of laws which hopefully explain why things happen to us as individuals, to us as we experience ourselves as individual human beings.

The first is known as the law of heat, *utu*, and it actually refers to what these days we would call physics, chemistry. There are things that happen in that world which have nothing to do with us. An earthquake, for instance. You can't say you were crushed in an earthquake because in a past life you stood on a thousand ants. The connection between all those ants you very cruelly stood on and the movement of the earth with its tectonic plates is difficult to see. Did all those ants go down there and push those plates? It gets ridiculous. You can't measure what happens to you from the outside world as being your personal kamma. In fact, it seems a little arrogant.

The second law is *bīja*, which translates as seed, and it equates to our genetics. Now we know the physical structure we have is the product of history. If you're born with a congenital disease, what can you do? It's come up to you from past generations. In the 1960s, I think it was, we had that awful disaster when thalidomide was produced as a help for women in pregnancy, and children were born without limbs — that's not personal kamma. When it comes to anything to do with genetics, this body has to be accepted as a product of past generations.

Now, there's a little side comment to make here. The Buddha says the mind and the body are intimately connected — milk in water, he says. And we can see that when we produce unwholesome states in ourselves, it has an effect on the body. Very simply, we know that anger hurts the heart, we know that anxiety gives you bad indigestion. On that level, it's pretty obvious. But there are also suggestions that it can change the very genetic structure, so that the gene patterns change, or fault, so that you come up with a fault line in a genetic pattern. And this carries on as a history.

But it could also be other things. It could be all the radioactive pollution we've got. All these poor animals up in the Arctic — polar bears being born with all sorts of peculiarities because of this distortion in the genetic code through pollution.

We can't say they deserve that. So that's *bija*, the business about genetics. The body we end up in — well, that's just it, you've got to do your best. It's not part of our personal kamma.

The third is *citta*, which means mind. Strictly speaking, in the commentaries it refers to the way the mind works — what we would call psychology. But I don't think you can abstract that from the effects of society on the mind. So through mind, you have to include culture. You have to include the language you speak, which orders your thoughts, gives you certain patterns of thinking, connects you with your civilisation, and on a very personal level connects you with the culture of your own family.

So your mind is that whole business of what we've constructed within ourselves — our emotional and thought life — but obviously in communion, in communication with the situation we've found ourselves in. And we're not in charge of that situation, are we? If you happen to be born destitute in a family in the middle of Africa or India, it's a very different life from somebody born in the West, generally speaking. Not to say there aren't poor people here. But you've no control over that. That's what we're working with, the stuff we've got to work with. So that's the mind, *citta*, in its general form.

The last is *dhamma*, and that's all the laws, the spiritual laws — the Four Noble Truths, the Eightfold Path, all that. They belong to another section in Buddhist understanding: laws which, if you follow them, have certain effects.

Now kamma is specifically to do with our intentions. As the Buddha says, quite clearly: *Cetanāhaṃ bhikkhave kammaṃ vadāmi* — I call your will kamma. The Buddha here is using kamma to mean action, and the will is what empowers something to produce an action. There are three kinds of action: actions of thought, actions of speech, and actions of body. What you're doing is empowering an intention.

This kamma, in terms of why we suffer, is contained in the wheel of dependent origination. In that wheel, you have contact with the world — *phassa*, for those of you who know the term. From that contact, we have an internal response, which we call feeling: pleasant, unpleasant, or neutral. This is our reaction to the world as it comes to us. Whether it's a television set, somebody speaking to us, or a meditation room, it doesn't matter. There arises in the heart a certain response, a certain feeling.

And we react to that feeling from a self that either indulges what is pleasant or pushes away what is unpleasant. We're always caught up in that game. The self really doesn't have an option apart from simply ignoring something — it's always caught up in the game. You've only got to watch yourself. The mind is always moving: oh, that's nice; oh no, I don't want that. Always shifting.

As soon as you've decided you like something or dislike something, you have that reaction of wanting or not wanting. That's your *taṇhā* — your desire. And as soon as that desire has arisen, there's an identification with it. *I* want. In our language, the 'I' comes first: I want. But in Buddhist psychology, it's the other way around: want, then I. There's a grasping onto it — that's why it's called *upādāna*.

As soon as you've done that, the desire is empowered. *Bhava*. And *bhava* translates as becoming. So becoming and kamma and will are all the same thing.

Now, when you do that, two things are happening. First, there's an action which goes out into the world, over which we can see we have very little control. Whether I set up a good action of sending old clothes to Africa or a bad action of mugging some sweet old person on the street, after that it's like the butterfly wing — I don't know where it's going to go. I might get away with the mugging, and it so happens the person has one million pounds in their pocket. Pretty good. On the other hand, I might be taken to court by all these tailors in Africa and sued for ruining their jobs. Next time you send clothes, send us a wage. See?

You don't know. How much responsibility can we take for that? Because you've put it into the pot, and other people are going to grasp it, the environment is going to grasp it. Surely the only responsibility we can take is for our initial intention. As soon as other people join in, as soon as the environment takes hold of it, that's it. We can't blame ourselves or feel guilty for things over which we've no control. But we can take responsibility for our particular intention — the initial intention we had.

Having made this decision, there's an action which goes out into the world over which we've got very little control, and which will come back to us in some way. It may be, for instance, that I'm here preparing this wonderful charity and all these people are really getting cheesed off about it. I go out there thinking what a wonderful thing I've done, and I land and somebody shoots me in the head. Somebody doesn't like me. Am I responsible for that?

But while something is happening on the outside, something else is happening on the inside. That action, that act of will, is now producing a circumstance within my own mind.

As soon as I intend something, I'm setting up a specific conditioning within my mind, within my heart. If I intend something compassionate, I'm producing a conditioning in myself toward a compassionate heart. If I empower a cruel thought — even just in my thought, remember, it doesn't have to be speech or action — I set up a conditioning for cruelty.

So you can see we have two things happening here. We have the outside world, over which I have little control, and the inside world, over which I have total control. There's a real split. It's myself who's produced all these emotions — all this restlessness and depression and guilt. But I've also produced joy, compassion, peace. My inner environment is my own little domain.

I didn't know this as a kid, else I wouldn't have done a lot of things I did. But unfortunately, I'm stuck with what I've got. That's my ignorance, that's myself — me looking at the world as a place where I can be perfectly happy, trying to manipulate it so that I can be happy in it. But all the while, I'm also constantly creating this environment within myself.

We can see that when something happens to us from the outside, we may be connected to it only by way of being there. All those people in the towers — they were just there. Some of them were just there. But somehow they were connected because of what they did, because of their job and all that. They were connected with all this business going on at the political level. But some of them were there just as tourists.

So what is their kamma? In the sense of what have they suffered as a consequence of something in the past? Or what are they suffering as personal kamma? If we say it was the crushing towers, then we've got a lot of explaining to do. But if we say it was their fear or their lack of fear — well, that's them, isn't it?

In that situation, as in all situations of great stress — be it a war, an earthquake, or something as terrible as that — there's always this individual who is in that situation, in their own little world.

We see it as an objective thing. We see the wall, we see the towers collapse. But what the person there is experiencing is only what they're experiencing. That's their suffering or non-suffering. And that's their *kamma*.

There will have been somebody in that tower who didn't feel afraid, who felt a need for compassion, who wanted to help people in dire straits. There will have been those killed outright — perhaps without any feeling at all. And there will have been those who died in abject fear, in terror. But that's them, that's their particular mental state produced by their own internal kamma.

What we're trying to do in our meditation is to purify the heart completely and to take away that initial mistake we've made — the mistake of believing that this is what we are: this body, mind and heart, this psychophysical organism. I like that phrase: psychophysical organism. We're trying to break through the delusion that that's what we are. And if that's not what we are, how can it ever cause us suffering?

If we look at something like innocence, like these two little girls... We know that many children these days are in dire straits. And I'm just bringing back to memory now the Moors murders, where they even taped the screams of the children they were torturing. They were on tape, for heaven's sake. For us, of course, this is very difficult to bear because of the innocence of it. Even if it's somebody who isn't so innocent, it's difficult to bear. But when it's a child, it's extra specially difficult.

What then would be the understanding of kamma for those children? For some reason, conditions outside them — this man, who knows how he came to be in that state of mind — suddenly chooses them. Lots of children. Why choose them? Was it opportunism? Was it just that they happened to be there and he was suddenly taken by this obsession? Who knows. Was it planned? Had he had some sort of special relationship with them? Who knows. It may come out in court.

But for those children, that whole time has now produced in them — one can only presume — this huge conditioning of absolute terror. Real hell, a real hell state. One can only presume that, at worst.

Now what happens, in Buddhist understanding, is that this is something they will have to sort out in future lifetimes. This fear — remember, and this is what you really have to grasp — has not been caused by that man. Nobody can cause us psychological pain. That fear has been produced by their fundamental delusion, the same delusion that we have: that I am this body, I am what I appear to be.

What happens in Buddhist understanding is that through the process of rebirth there is a working out of that, and everything that was unwholesome in that mind is eventually turned into its opposite. The amount of fear that we have in us will

produce an equal amount of courage once it's turned. The cruelty that we have in us will produce an equal amount of compassion. Because all it is, is an energy force. All the hate we have will turn into love.

But more than that — as this transformation takes place, we can continue to develop those qualities of joy, peace, love and compassion infinitely. Well, better word: indefinitely. Infinitely takes us into metaphysics. Indefinitely in two ways: horizontally, in the sense that since there are an illimitable number of beings we can extend those qualities indefinitely that way; and vertically, in the sense that there is no end to the depth of love, compassion, joy and peace we can feel.

Even though these two children have had to suffer, have had to go through an experience which has produced in them — because of their delusion — an awful and dreadful state of mind, in the fullness of time they will work it out and gain the benefit of that working out. Nothing is wasted. Nothing we suffer is for nothingness. It always will produce something beautiful in the end.

The universe, as far as our consciousnesses are concerned, is so constructed that we don't have a choice but to become enlightened. You simply don't have a choice. Only once in Buddhist history was there ever the dastardly theory that some people would always remain in *saṃsāra* — onward going. They were called the Icchantikas, those who would go on forever, because it was understood that some people were just too thick. This awful doctrine remained only in a very small sect in Mahāyāna for a very short time, and was banished.

The reason is that the self is continuously trying to find happiness in this world, and it only has two ways of doing so: either it must try to build up a pleasurable situation, or it must run away from what is unpleasurable. The image is the base of a triangle. The self is always running towards pleasure, or always running away from hatred, away from painfulness — always running up and down this base.

And that's what you're observing when you meditate. You're observing: this is *dukkha*. This is what the Buddha is talking about when he says suffering, unsatisfactoriness. Every time we hit the wall of pleasure — when the pleasure doesn't arise, when the pleasure we depended upon disappears — suffering arises. Every time aversion arises, every time something horrible arises, we run away from it, but it chases us. You can't get away from your internal pain. You might think you're doing it. You can take drugs if you want, but the pain is still there.

At some point, the Buddha says, this suffering awakens a person. It awakens them to find the end of suffering. This is his own life. There he is, having a good time, and he comes across a very sick person, a very old person, and a corpse. You know the story. Each time he says, what is this? Because he's never seen anything like this before. And when they tell him this is a human being, his next question is crucial: Does it happen to me?

When that broke into his consciousness — that he could grow old, sick, and die — he had what we would call a nervous breakdown, an existential identity crisis. It shot him out in search of the end of suffering. And he found it.

This allows an enormous creativity, especially when the human will comes into it. And remember, human will creates. Look what we've done to this planet — this is human will doing this. On top of that, you've got all the laws of the universe around us, the laws of culture and civilisation. All these things we're in the middle of.

In the middle of all that there's this little puddle with its own little internal dynamic. And that's us — our little minds and our understandings. Although we have contact with everything around us, there's a separation. We all live in a little personal bubble. My world — although none of us would disagree that this room is here, we've all had a different experience of it. Even if it's very similar, it's different. So we live in this little bubble, and this little bubble is what we're creating. If it's awful stuff, then we've got to do something about it, and we can. If it's good stuff, then we increase it.

Remember that this individual, because of that wrong relationship to the world, will produce pleasant and unpleasant feelings whenever something happens out there. These pleasant and unpleasant feelings will produce a reaction. And the reaction is what causes all our fear, depression, anxiety, and so on. It's not caused by the outside world — and that's the essential hope of the Buddha's message.

An individual can completely cure themselves of all dissatisfaction and suffering in the midst of a horrible world or a beautiful world. And you can do it in a single lifetime. In fact, you can do it in seven days if you come and join my course. That's what the Buddha says: seven days if you really work at it.

So, that's it really. Are there any immediate questions that arise out of that?

Rebirth

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 38 min

Originally given as *Rebirth* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this exploration, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the complex topic of rebirth in Buddhist understanding, addressing the fundamental questions that arise for Western practitioners. He begins by explaining the death process (chutti) and how one's state of mind at death influences the next birth, drawing parallels with Elizabeth Kübler-Ross's five stages of terminal illness - shock, bargaining, anger, depression, and acceptance.

The talk provides a detailed examination of the six realms of existence (hell beings, animals, hungry ghosts, humans, asuras, and devas) and their psychological correspondences in our present experience. Bhante distinguishes between Hindu reincarnation (continuity of an eternal soul) and Buddhist rebirth (dependent arising without a permanent self), using the metaphor of billiard balls touching versus beads on a string.

Addressing scientific perspectives, he discusses research by Ian Stevenson on past-life memories, cryptomnesia, and genetic memory, while acknowledging both evidence for and skepticism about rebirth phenomena. The talk concludes with the essential point from the Kālāma Sutta: whether rebirth exists or not, the Dhamma works here and now (sandittihiko), and liberation depends on present-moment understanding of dependent origination rather than beliefs about future lives.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa.

Homage to the blessed, noble, and fully self-enlightened one.

I want to try and collect my thoughts around all the problems surrounding rebirth. What I've done is put them in question form—the normal questions that people ask. After each question, I'll make sure everybody's got the idea.

The first interesting question is: what happens at death in Buddhist understanding? What actually produces your next rebirth? I'm presuming now that there is such a thing. So what's going to affect your next rebirth?

It's said that when you die, some image of where you're going to go appears in the mind—a product of your actions during your life. Sometimes they say it can be a strong image, an actual memory, which takes you into your next life. If, for instance, just as you died there came this image of you squashing a fly against the window, this may take you into the deepest hells. On the other hand, catching a fly gently with your hands and showing it the window may produce a very happy realm.

We'll come to the different sorts of realms you can end up in shortly. But one thing that's interesting for us as Westerners is what has been studied about the process of terminal illness. There are five states that people go through, it seems, and it's been well documented. The first book written on it was *Death and Dying* by Elizabeth Kübler-Ross.

Some of these stages you'll recognise. When you're told, for instance, that you only have so long to live, the first thing—it's a bit of a shock, isn't it? That's your first reaction: the shock, the horror of it. And the measure of that shock is the measure of ourselves, the measure of our ego, the measure of how much we're attached to life.

Once the shock is over, we tend to get happier—we go into a sort of magical stage: "If I do the right thing, it'll pass away." They call it bargaining. If I eat a thousand carrots, the cancer will definitely disappear. If I pray very, very hard, God will take this disease away from me.

Then, of course, you visit the doctor and he says, "No, it's getting worse. You are going to die." The next thing is you rage. Why me? I saw this lovely cartoon once—there's a woman in bed with a few friends around her, and she's saying, "Why me? Why not one of you?" Why are you saying that on your deathbed? "Why me? Why not one of you?"

After the anger passes, there's this coming up against the reality of it. There's no way around it now. It's very depressing—life's going to come to an end. But if the person gets through that, they come to a state of equanimity, acceptance.

Fear, elation—what would you call that? Excitement, anger, depression, peace. Now, if there is a rebirth, you can see that if you die in any of those states, that's the one that's going to carry you. That's why in every religion they make this big effort when somebody's dying to get around them the images of their religion—images that will make them peaceful, joyful. People give them permission to go so the sadness disappears; they sing hymns, all that sort of stuff, being with them in the last moments just to give them that aura of equanimity, of peace, so that they themselves can die gently, can let go.

I think all the Buddhist literature would say is that the image which comes to mind as you leave the body will be determined by the state you're in, that's all. And it determines where you go. If you want a full explanation of that, you can always look up the *Comprehensive Manual of Abhidhamma* on page 124, and that will give you the details.

That's the process—it's called the death *cuti*, the death moment when you leave the body. It's going to be determined by the state of mind you're in. In Buddhist understanding, it may not particularly be connected to the illness itself. It could just be some big past regret that comes up, things like that.

The next question, of course, is what happens when you die? Here, unfortunately, the Buddhist tradition gives us an option—it depends what tradition you're in as to what's going to happen to you, it seems. The Theravāda understanding, and so I'm told Zen and those Chinese forms of Buddhism, simply say that you're reborn immediately into another space, another realm, another place.

But the Tibetans have this idea of a *bardo*, where you stay for up to forty-nine days. In that state, you seem to be bombarded by, or come into contact with, forms of light—figures who emanate light, all representing the six realms. We'll come to those in a minute. The big one is the light of enlightenment, of the *dharmakāya*, the body of the true law. Normally speaking, the person can't handle it, and they go for these softer lights leading to a different rebirth. Eventually they take rebirth wherever this soft light is. The human realm, as I remember, was yellow—I'm not absolutely sure; you have to look it up. Then one goes towards that light and manifests, as it were, through it.

A more interesting explanation of *bardo*, in terms of our life here and now, is the in-between point between one thought and the next. Just catching that moment is meant to be symbolic of *bardo*. It's that moment of emptiness, when the mind stops, you might say. That's what happens at death in these two major traditions.

Next, of course, is the question of what the realms of existence are and how they match what humans can experience—in other words, how they relate to us. The six realms are hell, the animal realm, the hungry ghosts, the human realm, the angry gods, and the devas, the gods.

The hell realm, the worst of the hell realms, is reserved especially for those who've been cruel and horrible. But in terms of our experience, it really refers to those states of mind that we ourselves would consider pretty hellish: really delusional states, schizophrenia, deep profound depression. The big thing about a hell state—and all of us have experienced it in some way or other—is when we're in a bad state and just for a moment, or maybe even more than a moment, we don't think there's a way out. That's hell. If you're so depressed, if you're caught in a job and you just don't see a way out—that's really, I think, the quality of hell.

The animal realm is the realm of the dull mind—you get drunk or something like that. The problem with these two realms is that they're not very good places for enlightenment because they're too heavy. The hell realm is obviously too painful, too deluded. And the animal realm—you don't have the intelligence. It's just not possible.

The hungry ghost realm really refers to obsession, addiction—and these days we know all about them. That's what it refers to: an addictive nature. So next time you serve yourself soup, especially when a huge desire to devour it arises, you have to warn yourself, "Oops, if I die now, I'll be a hungry ghost. I won't be able to leave this pot forever." No, no, nothing's forever.

The human realm is characterised by what we know as—in Buddhist terms, remember, everything we say is always about the liberation, always about the enlightenment—joy and woe, joy and woe, suffering and joy. We have this intelligence. We can make our way out of it. That's the process, of course. *Vipassanā* is a technique we use, or in other traditions Dzogchen, Zen, to access that intelligence which is going to lead us out of this suffering. That's specific to the human realm, you might say.

The angry gods are always fighting, always at each other—so it's obviously a place where we're angry, frustrated, whatever. Finally, the devas is for the rich, the powerful, and the famous. You're just too happy; you just can't be bothered with practice. Why bother when you're lying on the beach in Acapulco?

These realms don't particularly relate directly to the five points of a terminal illness, but there's some relationship between them. This isn't the fullness of it. If you look at a book called *The Psychological Attitude of Early Buddhist Philosophy*—a hell of a title—by Anagārika Govinda, there the later scholastics went and divided all these realms into myriad realms depending on the particular state you were in, especially the particular absorption, the particular *jhānic* state. All these different stages, these different paths, have a particular place to go to.

I don't know whether these things exist or not. Who knows? I've got this awful feeling that they're all here, all here around us. Just like the human realm is a jumble of hellish people, ghostly people—these hungry ghosts, they're all around us here now. I can feel them, you might say.

So there we have this whole thing about the way you die, the way you're re-born. Everything we talk about regarding the afterlife is actually a mirror, in Buddhist understanding, of what you can experience in human life. You can say it's just creative imagination. You can take the position of believing it—we'll come to that in a minute. Or you can take it that this is in fact a holographic universe, where everything is virtually the same, everything contains everything else. This goes back to the idea of Indra's net, where each jewel at the joining of each little rope mirrors the whole universe. So why should any other realm be really outside what we can experience here in this realm?

The next question is: what's the difference between rebirth and reincarnation? This whole thing is worked out in Indian culture. You don't get much of it at all, as far as I know, in Chinese culture. Of course, they believe in ancestors and rebirth and stuff like that. But in the old Confucian culture, the ancient Chinese culture, there was obviously some idea of onward going, like Christians have, but it was never worked out in any great detail, I don't think.

The main difference between reincarnation and rebirth—between the Hindu system, shall we say, and the Buddhist system—there's a nice image. The Hindu system would suggest a string of beads. All the beads are different, but there's this string that goes through them, a continuity, a sort of self that continues steady throughout all these little apparitions. Whereas the Buddhist idea would be more like a line of billiard balls that touch each other. They're all quite distinct, all arising dependent on conditions. Not entirely the same, not entirely different. But always arising, one after the other. It's a radical transience.

The Hindu idea might give you the impression of a lump of clay which you mould into a saucer, screw it up again, mould it into a cup—the same substance moving around. Whereas the Buddhist idea is that there's nothing that actually moves. It's more like—well, the great example of course is the body. According to modern science, the body completely changes every atom. Every atom is supposed to be changed within seven years. So next time you look in a mirror, just remind yourself: this face wasn't here seven years ago. Get back to reality. That's the difference.

The next thing is: what are the proofs for rebirth, for reincarnation? There's a man called Stevenson who spent his whole life going around interviewing people, finding out about their recalls and rebirths and all that sort of stuff. Some of it is, in a sense, pretty convincing. Usually the sharpest cases come from children. Children around the age of three to five suddenly remember things. There are stark examples where they've actually demanded to go and see their mother who lives in the next village. When they take them there, they describe everybody, even tell how they died. It's pretty heady stuff.

Then there are adult past life experiences, where a person remembers something that happened in a past life and they can sometimes prove it actually happened. Another small thing is birthmarks caused by death. Often how you died is mirrored in the next body you get. You get moles—and the next time you look at your moles, just say, 'These must have been stab wounds in my previous life.' Birthmarks too. There are things like that which are supposed to relate. Again, proven by people with past life recall who said they were shot, and there's a mole, a sort of ugly birthmark, where the bullet went in.

The mark of a true past life experience, according to Stevenson and according to my understanding, is that the person remembers this past experience, re-experiences it as that person. They're not this person. They're not actually this personality. It's as though for a moment you've become somebody else. That can happen in a rebirth situation in this life, where a childhood memory comes up as a trauma and you remember it as that child. That's the difference. So if somebody says, 'I suddenly remember being Napoleon at the Battle of Waterloo,' you can ask them, 'Were you really Napoleon? Or is it just a memory?'

There are, of course, other reasons why somebody might have past life recall. The first one, and this relates to Napoleon, is called cryptomnesia. I don't know how they make these words up. Cryptomnesia. The biggest example that most books use concerns a woman called Virginia Tighe. She certainly had these very

vivid, clear memories of being Bridie Murphy in the south of Ireland in her past life. Described it absolutely perfectly. From everybody's understanding—this was under hypnosis, so it wasn't something conscious, you might say—it seemed to be real proof that past life exists. Because they went there and it was there. Everything was as she said it was.

Then through an intrepid investigator they came across a certain Bridie Murphy who actually lived opposite Virginia Tighe and had told her all these stories. They'd obviously sunk into the subconscious, taken on emotional meanings, and come up as a whole story of vivid images. So that unfortunately was the end of this amazing proof of past life. Now that's given the whole thing a bad name, because now, well, it's just cryptomnesia. I don't know what crypto means. What does it mean? I forgot to look it up. Hidden. So it's a hidden amnesia, a hidden forgetfulness, an unknown forgetfulness. Thank you.

The other explanation, of course, from a materialist point of view—something like Dawkins or whatever—is genetic memory. Our genes not only carry the physical nature of our bodies, but also bring with them what Dawkins calls memes. Genes and memes. The idea is that just as you get pieces of information in your genes which make up your body, you get pieces of information which are cultural. He doesn't refer to that in the genetic structure as far as I know. It's more in the sense that that's what we do to each other. We keep giving each other these little blocks of information which we then pass on, and it builds up into a culture.

Another explanation is simply the power of retrocognition. The opposite of retrocognition is clairvoyance, where you can see what's going to happen. Sometimes clairvoyant people really do see what's going to happen. Sometimes they don't, but sometimes they really do. So this retrocognition may be real—maybe it did happen—but it's more like a mystical ability to see into the past.

The bad thing about the whole rebirth, reincarnation theory—we can call it theory—is that for the self it becomes a comforting thought. I won't die after all. I'll keep going. Even though I might have to go through this little gate and it's painful, I will arise. And to actually turn around and face for a moment that in fact there is no re-arising of this person, which is true—this person will not re-arise—it's a bit of a, whoa!

To actually turn around and face the annihilation of this personality is a bit of a challenge. It's sometimes easier to believe that yes, the personality changes, but when I die the changing will go on and I'll recognise me as I am, as I've always done.

The other awful thing about the whole rebirth understanding is that people delay the process of their liberation. They think, well, I'll just collect a bit of good kamma now, build up a good bank account, die in this lovely place, and off I go. So they keep delaying it, delaying it. And the whole idea of building up a bank account is based, of course, on a big ego. The very fact that you're doing good things for that ego reason undermines the whole process. In other words, you're not facing the process of liberation.

For born Buddhists, for traditional Buddhists, I would say the vast majority of lay people delay it. It's the way the vast majority of monks and nuns think too. They're all building up good kamma for the next life. So these are drawbacks of the belief in rebirth.

The other thing that comes up when you talk about rebirth is: how do you square it with evolutionary theory? If you look at the Buddhist scriptures, they live in this ancient time of cyclic time. This goes back to earlier times when, if you think about it, every year was virtually the same. You did the same thing. Society was static. For as long as you could remember and for as far as you could see, people would be doing the same thing over and over again. There was no idea of progress at all.

Progress as such didn't really come into the Western mind until fairly recently, although it was started off by a cleric somewhere around the twelfth century, if I remember rightly. Having now been twelve centuries since the birth of Christ and he hadn't returned, this cleric began to say that the time before Christ's birth was the time of the Father, the time we're going through now is the time of Christ, and we're leading up to the time of the Spirit, when all will be resurrected. So this idea of actually going somewhere, of an aim, of an end to life, suddenly appears before us as an evolutionary process. This was of course reinforced by Darwin and all that we know these days. Although they say you can pick holes in the theory, I don't know enough about it to give you that. The fact is it's pretty convincing stuff that there's a process of evolution going on.

Whereas if you read the scriptures, what you get is the names of the past twenty-eight Buddhas. Every Buddha has a Pali name, they have two main disciples, and it's this repetition, repetition. If you lived in those times—say you were a farmer, working with your ox in a field day after day, no TV, no holidays except in winter when it's dry season—you go through this, and then you have to go through these horrible old days because there's no medicine. There may be some

palliatives for pain, but people have died, their teeth are falling out. And leprosy, oh God. The whole thing is there. When you're going to die, you think: I don't want to come back here.

So this idea of being reborn was really quite the big thing in the Buddha's time. Everybody wanted the end of rebirth. They wanted not to be brought back as a human being, to be born into a god realm, not to fall down from the gods to be a human being again. It was pretty obsessive. And it actually ends up in the three great insights of the Buddha's enlightenment. That's where it's put. It's called the *te vijjā*, the three knowledges.

The first knowledge is that he sees the process of his rebirth has been very much according to his moral life. Before the Buddha, the idea was more chaotic—you just got reborn. The only way you could get out of this rebirth was through ritual, through appeasing the gods. There wasn't a close relationship between rebirth and your moral life, your ethical life. So this was an insight into the fact that it's our morality. Morality here means what is skilful. It's not just to do with killing and whatnot. It's to do with all that stuff around you, what we might call these days little neurotic patterns and stuff like that. It's the purification of the heart.

Then through his vision, he saw that this was true of all beings. So what was a personal law became a cosmic law. And the third understanding was that he'd actually completely purified his heart. Now, to be an *arahant*, to be a fully enlightened being, it's the third one you have to do. You don't have to have these other insights. So there's a small suggestion that these crept in, you might say, as part of the whole teaching around *kamma*—part of the whole teaching around how we create kamma, the process of kamma, how it's guided by what is skilful and unskilful.

In terms of these days, does rebirth make sense? I suppose if you think of it as an evolutionary process—that you're actually moving towards a liberated consciousness, a liberated *citta*, you might say—then it is some sort of evolutionary process. It still seems to work. It's the evolution of consciousness, you might say.

The other thing that comes up is the question about seeming inequality. People who've been absolute villains seem to die in bed, fairly happy. Others who've been wonderful and good end up on the gibbet and get themselves hanged. How does that work? There are all sorts of ways of trying to explain that. But one thing you have to understand about *kamma* is that our moral life is only to do with our internal, our interior life.

Of course it affects others. If I'm into stealing, that's going to affect people. If I'm into good works, it's going to affect people. But morality, my ethical life, has a direct effect upon my inner life and eventually should clear it up, should move it towards purification. Things that happen to me on the outside, of course, are coming from other sources. It might be that I steal something and I get caught and put in jail—a fairly straightforward sequence of events that I can understand. It may be that I do some little good for somebody and they turn out to be a billionaire and they give me a million pounds. So I can see how wonderful that is—if you find anybody like that, by the way.

But then, suddenly, you win the lottery. Or suddenly you find yourself caught up in a terrorist ordeal—think of all those people getting kidnapped in Iraq. We live in a fairly chaotic universe, in the sense that we don't know what's going to happen to us. There are various forces at play: the force of nature, the force of other people's decision-making and actions towards us. You have to take all that into account when you ask, why did that happen to that person? Why did they die this way and not that way? Because we're not in control of the situation we're in.

One little example I like to give: in one of the great earthquakes—I think it was in Mexico—they found a mother and her child after something like ten days, trapped between two blocks of concrete. Over that period, the mother had constantly cut her fingers to feed the child her blood. So presumably they were fairly comfortable down there, for the time being. But that's quite something, isn't it? She didn't freak out.

Finally, I suppose, a big question: is the concept of rebirth necessary to become enlightened, or to get the best out of the Buddha Dhamma? I think you'll find amongst Western scholars and Western Buddhists—and if you look up the Journal of Buddhist Ethics on the web, you'll find some very good essays about this—the general opinion is that you don't need to believe it at all.

The Dhamma itself either works now or it doesn't work at all. One sees the benefit here and now—*sandittiko*, here and now—or what's the point of it? Worries about whether there is a future life don't really pertain to the direct practice. The wheel of dependent origination, this whole process of mentation that brings about purification—or rather, the seeing of it, seeing how we cause ourselves suffering—is the process of liberation, happening right here and now. The escape is here and now. So rebirth isn't actually necessary for the Dhamma to work.

Let me leave you with one little understanding the Buddha gives in the *Kālāma Sutta*, a discourse where he really talks about freedom of thought. He says: if you live with the idea that there will be a rebirth, and that your good actions here and now will produce a better life—well, if there is rebirth, all well and good. If there isn't rebirth, all well and good. In other words, the reason for our practice has nothing to do with whether there's rebirth or not.

So in terms of your practice now, here, at Satipanya, this whole talk has been a waste of time. Because it's irrelevant. But it's been a pleasant three-quarters of an hour.

Kamma, Rebirth and Transcendence: A Top-Down View of the Buddhadhamma

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 52 min

Originally given as *Kamma, Rebirth and Transcendence: A Top-Down View of the Buddhadhamma* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this dharma talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma offers a 'top-down' perspective on the Buddha's teaching, examining transcendence, kamma, and rebirth from the viewpoint of the unconditioned rather than through scientific materialism. He explores the Buddha's descriptions of nibbāna as the 'unborn, unmade, unconditioned' realm where the four great elements find no footing, and examines what the Buddha deliberately left unanswered - the avyākata questions about the world's eternity and the Tathāgata's existence after death.

The talk delves into the Aggañña Sutta's creation narrative as satirical commentary on caste systems, while emphasizing that the Buddha's teaching centers fundamentally on ethics (sīla) - our relationships with ourselves, others, and the world. Bhante discusses the descent of Buddha-nature into psychophysical existence, the process of delusion and awakening, and addresses the challenging topic of rebirth within the six-realm cosmology.

Drawing on contemporary research including Ian Stevenson's reincarnation studies, he presents rebirth not as provable fact but as rational framework for understanding karmic equilibrium and the path to liberation. The discourse concludes with the Buddha's teaching that the world, its arising, ceasing, and the path to its cessation are all found within this 'fathom-long body' - emphasizing the immediacy and accessibility of liberation through ethical conduct and wisdom.

In the last talk I discussed how our cultural ways of looking at things—through science or scientism, through our romantic understanding of life, and through psychotherapy—tend to distort the Buddha's teaching. I boiled this teaching down to two essentials: ethics and transcendence.

From a scientific point of view, you're looking upwards through matter. Matter creates chemicals, chemicals create some sort of bio-life, and consciousness appears as part of that upward process of evolution. It's quite understandable that this would make sense to somebody brought up in that scientific tradition.

If you've been brought up in a religious tradition—one of the Christian traditions, or Islam, Judaism, or Hinduism—then of course you're looking at it from a different angle. You're looking down from above, seeing how everything slowly descends to the material base. This evening I want to offer you a different perspective altogether.

The first thing is to be clear about what the Buddha means by transcendence, what he's pointing to. In the last talk I mentioned some of these quotes, and the one where people feel he's been most clear is this: there is a sphere or dimension where there's no earth, no water, no fire, no air. Those, of course, are your four great elements by which the mind contacts matter. When you're looking at the pain in your knees, it will either be fiery or it will be heavy and thick.

Remember that when the Buddha talks about the world, the all, he's not talking about the objective world of science. He's talking about the way we experience it—the world we're actually manufacturing. He's always talking from that angle. It's not that he denies the world out there exists, but he's saying that from the point of view of liberation, it's the world we're creating that we've got to be liberated from.

He goes on to say there's no base consisting of space, consciousness, nothingness, perception, or non-perception. This refers to the higher jhānic states, the most refined place the mind can reach. It's when the mind actually stops producing, and there's just the awareness of that space, and so on.

Then he says it's neither this world nor another world, nor both; neither sun nor moon. He's saying there isn't a physical world where this transcendent place is. He says there's no coming and going and no staying—no sense of space and no sense of time. There's no ceasing, no uprising. It's without change. This place is without change.

Remember those three characteristics: dukkha, anicca, and anattā. There's no suffering there—it's adukkha. There's no impermanence there—it's nicca. And of course there's no self there, no sense of a self. It's a non-dual state.

It's not fixed, it's not movable. From our position, everything has a place and you can move most things. Everything changes. But there, there's nothing—you can't talk about something being fixed or movable. And it has no support.

Everything in this world is dependent on something else. Nothing arises of itself; there's no existent. But this is a place where it doesn't need anything at all. He's obviously pointing to something quite other than what we're experiencing—that's what we mean by transcendence. And he says, just this is the end of suffering.

Then there's the other famous passage people quote. There exists—the word *atthi*—there is the not-born, the not-compounded, the not-created, the not-conditioned. But he goes on to a second verse: if there were not this not-born, not-compounded, not-created, not-conditioned, no escape could be discerned from the born, the compounded, the created, and the conditioned. And the final verse says: but because there is this not-born, there is obviously an escape. Again, he's talking about something of another nature, you might say—another dimension.

The final one I brought up last time was this question of where earth, water, fire, and air find no footing. Remember, somebody asks him where the world comes to an end—this world we're creating. And he says that's the wrong question. You should ask where it finds no footing. Nothing is destroyed in the process. He himself says the only thing destroyed in the process of liberation is greed, hatred, and delusion. Everything else remains.

Where are long and short, small and great, fair and foul? Where are subject and object wholly destroyed? Remember this non-dual place. If you say there's one, there's a presumption that there may be a two—that's why the word non-dual is coined. But of course each system has a different understanding of non-dual. For the Hindus, the non-dual state is to be at one with Brahman. In the Buddhist tradition, it's to be in this state of *nibbāna*.

The Buddha says there is a consciousness which is non-manifestive. A consciousness that's manifestive is manifesting through the six senses: the five basic physical senses and the mind—mind, heart, emotions, and thoughts. He said it's non-manifestive, without boundary. Boundaries are created by phenomena, by objects, by things. There's nothing there—that's what he's saying. And it is all directions full of light. Consciousness. You can take that as either a state of light or brightness, as if you were inside the bulb, or you can take it as a state of pure awareness.

Now, if we keep the idea of something that's transcendent, what doesn't the Buddha talk about? What won't he actually discuss?

There were ten questions that were, I suppose, the obsessions of the age. The first: Is the world eternal? Is the world not eternal? Is the world infinite? Is the world finite? Then: Is the soul the same as the body? If it is, you would be an annihilationist, because when the body dies, you go as well. Soul here would mean your mind, rather. And is the soul different from the body? In which case, the soul would separate from the body and you'd be an eternalist.

These were the two opposites at the time of the Buddha. You've got the Brahmins and the Jains who said the soul was released, the *jīva* was released into a heavenly state or at one with Brahman. And there were the materialists who said that was it—when you're dead, you're dead.

The last four questions concerned somebody who was fully liberated. Does the Tathāgata exist after death, or does he not exist? Does he both exist and not exist? And finally, does he neither exist nor not exist? He's cornered any sort of effort at rational response. And of course, he's silent. He's silent because the questions are always coming from the point of view of a self.

This is what he says to Vacchagotta. And then he says his usual thing: they regard feeling as self, perception as self, volitional formations as self, consciousness as self—or self as possessing consciousness, or consciousness as in self, or self as in consciousness. Therefore when the wanderers of other sects ask such questions, they give such answers: the world is eternal. They can be very certain about it. But the thing is, the Buddha never actually says anything about it. He doesn't make any indication as to whether it is or not.

The next thing you might ask—we might ask—but it doesn't seem to occur in the scriptures, is: why does this occur in the first place? Where does this *sati-paṇṇā* come from, or as the *Abhidhamma* would put it, this nibbanic element in us, or as the *Mahāyāna* would point to it, Buddha nature—where does it come from? Why has it come here? Where did it all begin? Those sorts of questions about the relationship of this *Nibbānadhātu* and how it's come here are never broached. I don't know of a question that comes up in the scriptures to do with that.

It's the same with the relationship that our individual—inverted commas—*Nibbānadhātus* have with each other. Presumably there are lots of Arahants whose *Nibbānadhātus*, this element, this Buddha nature, is somewhere. Do they commu-

nicate? Do they know whether the last perfectly enlightened person is next door or upstairs? All that area just doesn't come up for discussion. It just doesn't arise, you see.

Other traditions, like the Hindus, tried to work something out for that. As you become liberated in the Hindu tradition, where you get moksha, freedom, your atta—your self, inverted commas, big self—goes back into Brahman. You become Brahman, you see. So you've got this idea that Brahman, who's neuter by the way, neither male nor female, bursts into all these different attas, and then they've got to find their way back to him. In other words, they're trying to answer this question, but it never comes up in the Buddhist scriptures. The Buddha never approaches it. So that's the end of that. It's just knowing that Buddhism doesn't have a monopoly on all truth, that's all.

Now, some would say these are known as avyākata questions. Avyākata just means not determined—he's simply not spoken about it. But maybe there's something that is forever unknowable. Just to be able to accept that these sorts of questions are actually unknowable. That may be one reason why the Buddha kept himself strictly to this particular teaching of liberation.

He does say in one place, pointing to the monks he's with: you see all the leaves in this forest? Well, I know all this, but I've only given you a clump of leaves—which is what you need in order to be liberated.

The trouble is, you don't know where that was put in later. In the Visuddhimagga, the medieval work of Buddhaghosa, they describe the qualities of a Buddha—and by that time, of course, he's grown into this superhuman figure, just amazing, beyond human. They say he's omniscient. What they mean by that is if he bends his mind towards anything, he'll know the answer. And one thing he knows is that the world is flat. That's a killer, isn't it? So you have to recognise there's been some, shall we say, messing about here.

So that's something he doesn't talk about. And just to go back a step—to the origins of the universe—again, there's no effort to address that either. There is this peculiar discourse, the Aggañña Sutta, in which he lays out a certain creation myth, but it's obviously a satire. Most people see it now as a satire.

It starts off with him having a talk with a man called Vasettha. Once the Lord was staying at Sāvattthī at the mansion of Migāra's mother in the East Park. At that time, Vasettha and Bhāradvāja were living among monks, hoping to become monks themselves. In the evening, the Lord rose from his secluded meditation

and came out of the mansion, and started walking up and down in the shade. Vasettha noticed this and said to Bhāradvāja, 'Friend Bhāradvāja, the Lord has come out and is walking up and down. Let's go and approach him. We might be fortunate enough to hear a talk on Dhamma from the Lord himself.' 'Yes, indeed,' said Bhāradvāja. And they went up to the Lord, saluted him, and fell into step with him.

Then the Lord said to Vasettha, 'Vasettha, you two are Brahmins born and bred, and you have gone forth from the household life to the homeless life from Brahmin families. Do not the Brahmins revile and abuse you?' 'Indeed, Lord, the Brahmins do revile and abuse us. They don't hold back with their usual flood of reproaches.' 'What kind of reproaches do they fling at you?'

'Lord, what the Brahmins say is this: the Brahmin caste is the highest caste. Other castes are base. The Brahmin caste is fair. Other castes are dark. Brahmins are purified. Non-Brahmins are not. The Brahmins are the true children of Brahma, born of the mouth of Brahma, created by Brahma, heirs of Brahma. And you—you've deserted the highest caste and gone over to the base caste, these shaveling, petty ascetics, servant, dark fellows, born of Brahma's foot. It's not right, it's not proper that you should mix with such people.' So this is the way the Brahmins abuse us, Lord.

'Then, Vasettha, the Brahmins have forgotten their ancient tradition when they say that. Because we can see Brahmin women, the wives of Brahmins, who menstruate and become pregnant, have babies and give suck—and yet these womb-born Brahmins talk about being born of Brahma's mouth! These Brahmins misrepresent Brahma. They tell lies. They earn much demerit.'

Then he goes into exactly what happens at the end of the world. You can't have all beings destroyed, because that would be the end of kamma. And it would suggest that some beings are just not going to make it. So at the end of a world cycle, everybody gets shunted into this highest realm, the Ābhassara Brahma realm.

Of course, questions were asked about this by later commentators. How could this be? To get up there you've got to be in the highest of jhānas and be pretty pure. The explanation was that everybody's been around this saṃsāra so many times that they must have hit one of these jhānic states at some point, and the good kamma would come just at that moment and they'd be up in the Ābhassara realm. This saved the whole idea of realms from bringing an end to kamma. But it also suggests that everybody, all beings, will eventually be liberated, no matter how many world cycles they have to go through.

Anyway, they're all up there now, and they lived there for a very long time. Here they dwell, and having passed away, they were mostly born into this world. They dwell mind-made, feeding on delight, self-luminous, moving through the air, and glorious. Now at that time there was just one mass of water, and all was darkness.

This is often how a creation myth works. Out of the chaos—the Greek chaos, which was this darkness. Out of nothingness—the Christian idea of everything coming out of nothingness. Even science, with the big bang: where does it come from? So just out of this mass of water and all darkness, blinding darkness—neither moon nor sun appeared, no constellations or stars, no night and day, no male or female, and so on.

Sooner or later, after a very long period of time, savoury earth spread itself over the waters where those beings were. It looked just like the skin that forms over hot milk as it cools. It was endowed with colour, smell, and taste. It was the colour of fine ghee or butter, and it was very sweet, like pure wild honey.

Then some being with a greedy nature said, 'What can this be?' And he tasted the savoury earth—and of course he gets a craving for it. Everybody else says, 'Well, what about that?' And they get into it too. The result was that their self-luminosity disappeared. The greed destroyed their self-luminosity.

As they grew more and more greedy, this beautiful skin of earth began to disappear. In its place, fungus grew up—similar in nature, but coarser. Then something like a mushroom appeared. Then creepers, shooting up like bamboo. And all the while, their luminosity faded and their bodies grew heavier. They were moving towards becoming more and more material.

Finally, rice appeared in open places—free from powder, free from husk, fragrant and clean-grained. But as they collected this rice, their bodies became coarser still, and the differences in their looks became greater. Females developed female sex organs, and males developed male organs. The women became excessively preoccupied with men, and the men with women. Owing to this excessive preoccupation with each other, passion was aroused, and their bodies burnt with lust.

Later, because of this burning, they indulged in sexual activity. Those who saw them threw dust, ashes, and cow dung at them, crying, 'Die, you filthy beasts! How can you be doing such things to one another?' And just as today, in some districts when a daughter-in-law is led out, some people throw dirt at her, some ashes,

some cow dung—without realising they're repeating an ancient observance. I don't know where that custom comes from. Must have been one of those things you did at the marriage.

So it gets worse and worse. Finally, because of all the immorality, they decided to appoint somebody who would show anger when needed, who would censure people, who would banish those who deserved to be banished. This was the first king, the people's choice: Mahāsammata. And so the idea of kingship came in. Because of that, a whole level of society was created—the warrior caste, the Khattiya. He was also called Rāja, which means 'he who gladdens others with Dhamma.'

Evil things appeared—taking what is not given, and all that—and so the king carried out banishments. Then there were people who said, 'Enough of this,' and they became very pure and went to live out in the forest. These were the Brahmins. Others, of course, who couldn't handle the meditation and the seclusion, began to adopt various trades. And finally there were those called the Sudda—'base' because they lived by the chase. So slowly but surely, the four castes appeared.

But the whole discourse ends with a verse: 'Was rightly sung,' he said, 'and this too is true: the warrior caste, the Khattiyas, are best among those who value the clan.' So it becomes a sort of explanation of how we've got to this place—the four castes and so on—but by way of ethics. We're always coming back to ethics.

As to the question of creation—where we came from and all that—that also is not answered. So again, we have to accept that there are things that may simply be unknowable. But one thing we do know is that we are here. We actually are existing, or becoming, in this very present moment.

If we consider this Nibbāna Dhātu descending—now, this idea was later taken up by the Mahāyāna in the Yogācāra school of the Tathāgatagarbha, which means 'the embryo of the Buddha.' The embryo of the Buddha: that within us which is deluded comes down to find its own true nature, enters into this psychophysical organism, and then through the practice becomes the Tathāgata. Tathāgata means 'come there' or 'gone there.' This 'there,' of course, is that place of transcendence. Probably the best translation is 'the one who has transcended' or 'the transcendent one.' This is how the Buddha referred to himself—the Tathāgata.

Now, this Nibbāna Dhātu finds itself... I'll keep referring to it from now on as simply Buddha nature—it's simpler. This Buddha nature finds itself in this psychophysical organism. And in the Buddha's teachings, there are three bodies. Again, this was developed out of the basic scriptures, the Pāli scriptures, the early scriptures. These different strands of understanding were developed from those bases.

My teacher, Dr. Rewata Dhamma in Birmingham, said to me that everything the Mahāyāna says about their teachings, you'll find the kernel of it—you'll find something of it within the basic scriptures of Pāli, the early scriptures.

These three bodies are: the Dharmakāya—that's the Buddha, the Buddha nature; the Sambhogakāya, the body of bliss, which is your mental body; and the Nirmāṇakāya, the body of apparition or the body that's made—this physical body that we find ourselves in. So: psychophysical.

In Buddhist understanding, these two things—mind and body—are quite separate. Although they're melded together at this level of being, they separate at death. And then you have rebirth into different realms, which we'll come to towards the end of the talk.

Let's recall the process: the Tathāgatagarbha—the embryo of the Buddha, the Buddha nature—comes down in a state of not knowing. Remember, this isn't a culpable state. Ignorance here simply means not knowing. And the mistake that gets made is believing itself to be this psychophysical organism it finds itself in.

From there, it seeks happiness. It's as simple as that. And in seeking happiness, it begins to manipulate the world. The more it has, the happier it feels, the more secure—more money, more friends, all that sort of stuff. Of course, then you have to protect what you've got, so that's where aversion comes in, your hatred towards anybody who undermines what you have. And if the person's bigger than you, well, you run for it.

Remember, these are your three basic attitudes arising from delusion: acquisitiveness, aversion, and fear. And because of those attitudes, we act in the world and create habits. These habits are unwholesome, and they have unwholesome results—both inwardly, where they create agitation and all the rest of it, and outwardly, where they create situations that aren't good for us. War, for a start.

Coupled with that, of course, there's the wisdom factor, which grows as you begin to see how we create suffering for ourselves. Then the other side of our nature begins to manifest—the love, the compassion, the sympathetic joy, courage, gratitude, and all the rest of it.

You could say that the process we're undergoing is a movement away from the effects of delusion towards the effects of wisdom. We're coming back, shall we say, to that original mistake. And that original mistake we call the self—an identity we manufacture with the psychophysical organism we find ourselves in.

This is our practice: to begin discriminating, to discern those things that bring us suffering and those that don't, those that bring us real happiness. As you come back into yourself, you arrive at this business of the observer—and of course that's where the initial problem lies, because it's through the observer that you enter into the world we're creating.

I was going to reinforce the idea that the Buddha only teaches ethics. Ethics, you can translate as relationship—how you're relating. Morality tends to mean wrongdoing for us, so it has a more restricted meaning in our minds—the Ten Commandments and all that. But ethics is simply about relationship.

Now, we're in relationship all the time. We're in relationship with our food, with the door when we open it, with people. Our whole lives are an act of relationship—and of course there's the relationship with ourselves too. So ethics is really about how we relate: how, if we get it wrong, it creates suffering, and how, if we get it right, it creates happiness.

If you remember, when the Buddha was born, a holy man—a sage—saw him and determined that he would become either a world-conquering monarch or a fully self-enlightened being. The sage began to cry, and when they asked why, he said, "Well, I won't be around to see which one he'll go for." But the accent was that he would actually become fully self-liberated.

Running through the scriptures, you get this alter ego of the world-conquering monarch. In one scripture, the old monarch is dying. The wheel treasure—you have to imagine this wheel in the sky—when it begins to disappear, it's time for the king to move on and leave the throne to his son.

Just before the son takes rule, he asks, "Sire, what is the duty of the Aryan wheel-turning monarch?" And the king says, "It is this, my son. Yourself depending on the Dhamma, honouring it, revering it, cherishing it, doing homage to it and venerating it. Having the Dhamma as your badge and banner, acknowledging the Dhamma as your master, you should establish, guard, ward, and protect according to the Dhamma your own household, your troops, your nobles and vassals, Brahmins and householders, town and country folk, ascetics and Brahmins, beasts and birds.

"Let no crime prevail in your kingdom, and to those who are in need, give property. And whatever ascetics and Brahmins in your kingdom have renounced the life of sensual infatuation and are devoted to forbearance and gentleness, each one taming himself, each one calming himself, each one striving for the end of craving—from time to time you should go to them and consult them as to what is wholesome and what is unwholesome, what is blameworthy and what is blameless, what is to be followed and what is not to be followed, and what action will in the long run lead to harm and sorrow, and what to welfare and happiness.

"Having listened to them, you should avoid evil and do what is good. That is the duty of an Aryan wheel-turning monarch." The son says, "Yes, Sire. Yes, Sire, thank you very much." And of course he becomes the king.

But then, of course, he doesn't do that. Things go wrong, and the wheel slips from its position. A man comes to the king and says, "Sire, you should know that the sacred wheel treasure has disappeared." That's bad news.

At this the king was grieved and felt sad, but he did not go to the royal sage or ask about the duties of a wheel-turning monarch. Instead, he ruled the people according to his own ideas, and being so ruled, the people did not prosper as well as they had under previous kings who performed the duties of a wheel-turning monarch.

Then the ministers, counsellors, treasury officials, guards and doorkeepers, and the chanters came to the king and said, "Sire, as long as you rule the people according to your own ideas, and differently from the way they were ruled under previous wheel-turning monarchs, the people do not prosper so well." And they say to him, "Sire, there are ministers in the realm, including ourselves, who have preserved this knowledge of how a wheel-turning monarch should rule. Ask us, Your Majesty, and we will tell you."

So he asks them and consults them, and having listened, the king established a guard and protection—but he did not give property to the needy. As a result poverty became rife, and with the spread of poverty a man took what was not given, thus committing what was called theft. They arrested him and brought him to the king saying, "Your Majesty, this man took what was not given, which we call theft."

The king said to him, "Is it true you took what is not given, which is called theft?" "It is, it is, Majesty." "Why?" "Your Majesty, I have nothing to live on." Then the king gave him some property, saying, "Look, with this, my good man, you can

keep yourself, support your mother and father, keep a wife and children, carry on a business and make gifts to ascetics and Brahmins, which will promote your spiritual welfare and lead to a happy rebirth with pleasant results in the heavenly sphere." "Very good, Your Majesty," replied the man.

And the exact same thing happens to another man. The people heard the king was giving away property to those who took what was not freely given. "Supposing we were to do likewise," they thought. Another man took what was not given, they brought him to the king, and the king asked him why he'd done it. He replied, "Man, I've nothing to live on."

The king thought, "If I give property to everybody who takes what is not given, this theft will increase more and more. I'd better make an end of him, finish him off once and for all, and cut his head off." So he commanded his men, "Bind this man's arms tightly behind him with a strong rope, shave his head closely, lead him to the rough sound of a drum through the streets and squares and out through the southern gate, and there finish by inflicting the capital penalty and cut off his head." And they did so.

Hearing about this, the people thought, "Now let us get sharp swords made for us, and then we can take from anybody what is not given. We will make an end of them, finish them off, cut their heads off." Having procured sharp swords they launched murderous assaults on villages, towns and cities, and went in for highway robbery, killing their victims by cutting off their heads. You can see once the rot sets in, you're just not going to get out of it.

And so it goes on. Finally, after many generations—five thousand years—a Dhamma monarch is re-established. But actually it gets worse before that, because as people become more and more unethical they lose their lifespan. A time will come when children of these people have a lifespan of ten years. Girls will be marriageable at five years old. And with them, these flavours will disappear: ghee, butter, sesame oil, molasses and salt. So it gets worse and worse and worse.

But again, it's just this idea that morality—ethics really—is what it's all about. And actually, that was the teaching of that axial age. If you look across to Lao Tzu and the Dao, and Moses with the Ten Commandments, and Socrates—all the same age. Socrates also said desire was the problem. There's an awakening of mankind to this idea that you do unto others as you would have them do unto you. That was the big message of what's known as the Axial Age. So anyway, that's the Buddha's teaching. It's about ethics.

So now we come to this knotty problem about rebirth. That's another question the Buddha doesn't answer. He doesn't tell us how the process takes place.

Now, we hear of people with near-death experiences, especially on operating tables where they come out and they can actually tell what's actually happened during the operation. We also know that people have out-of-body experiences and see this whirling tunnel through which they go, sometimes into another realm. But none of that is in the Pali scriptures. The question of, you know, nobody said to the Buddha, yeah, but how does it happen? You know, like, what? So it's just that there's a teaching about there are different realms.

And the basic one is, of course, the six realms. So the purgatorial realm, which is sometimes called hell realm. But hell, you know, according to Dante, I mean, that's, you know, abandon all hope, ye who enter here. So there's nothing eternal in the world, according to Buddhism, so it's much better to think of it as purgatory, where you purge your sins and get rid of all your bad karma. And there are various levels of that, the worst one being the Avici hell, of course, where those who've been extremely cruel go, which is the opposite of the Buddhist teaching about compassion, of course.

Then there's the animal realm. You see, born an animal. There's the human realm, which is ours. The hungry ghosts, they're the ones who are driven by greed. There's the angry devas, they're the clever people who are driven by anger, jealousy, all that sort of stuff. And then finally there's the deva realm, which is where people are happy. Beings are happy. So you've got these six realms.

And of course, what tends to happen is the relationship between what we experience as human beings extended into other realms of existence. So if you're in a deep depression and you don't see a way out of it, you're despairing, you're obviously in a hell realm. If you get drunk and do all sorts of daft things, then you're obviously in an animal realm. There's the human realm, of course. When we're craving for stuff and we can't just stop going for those biscuits, then you're a hungry ghost. And when we're getting angry and trying to get the best of somebody, we're in the angry deva realm. And then finally when we're happy and peaceful and wandering about the meadows here, then we're in the deva realm.

So there's always that connection between what we as human beings can experience and the cosmology that Buddhism talks about. So those are your basic things. But in the Abhidhamma it gets much more refined because then they talk

about all these various realms to do with also with the jhanas. So the whole cosmology is built up into this huge sort of idea of vast different realms, many realms all over the place. Whether they exist or not is a moot point of course.

So when it comes to rebirth, which is very difficult for us, because if you've been brought up a Christian or a Muslim or something like that, then it's easier. But for people who've been brought up in a more secular way, it's very difficult to actually, you know, just open up to the idea.

There's been lots of studies on it. I mean, there's Ian Stevenson who wrote *Twenty Cases Suggestive of Reincarnation*. And there's also stuff on the website. I've actually put a clip on our website.

So there's no way it's ever going to be proven scientifically. There's not going to be an fMRI scan of somebody being reborn. In the medieval ages, they would weigh a body before it died and then weigh it again after it died to see how much the soul weighed. And they were always upset because it didn't have any weight. There was no change. We're trying to prove that something which is transcendent actually exists. So we can forget about trying to prove whether there's rebirth or not.

But one thing is for sure, that when you start reading the discourses, it comes across all the time. You can't read the discourses without including rebirth. They begin to... they don't make sense in terms of the whole law of karma.

So even in the Buddha's awakening we talk about the three knowledges that came to him where he remembered his past lives which showed him how he came to be fully liberated and what was the driving force of that was his ethics. And then he saw other beings moving from realm to realm, driven again by their ethics. So what had been just a personal law, he saw as a universal law. And then, of course, the third knowledge was that he himself was purified of all his defilements. So he goes right back to the, in the tradition, it's right back there to the awakening of the whole thing about rebirth.

And there's... Bhikkhu Bodhi has written a sort of monograph on it. And I've taken his ideas from there. And the question he asks is, well, does it make sense? Is it intelligible? Does it make any sense in terms of the Dhamma?

Well, you can see that without the idea of rebirth, how do you ever resolve the actions that you've made? And this also moves into the idea that the universe has some sort of moral equilibrium, has some sort of moral resolution to it.

You might say this is more of an intuitive thing—that eventually whatever harm somebody has done has to be mended in some way, has to be ameliorated, has to be compensated for. So you have to forget the idea of punishment. It's to do with results. You do something wrong and there will be a result within your psychophysical organism. And that result will reverberate back to this Buddha nature when it wakens up and realises, oh, I've done something wrong. I'm now in a world—my world, the world I'm creating—which is full of guilt, full of remorse, full of shame.

And of course the world then mirrors back to you. If you're very sarcastic, you find yourself being a bit lonely sometimes. The way you behave affects other people, and they mirror your behaviour back to you by the way they behave towards you.

There's a feeling that there must be some working out, because as we know, in the ordinary world as we see it, people get away with murder, and people who do wonderful things are never acknowledged. They might end up in a bad way too. Remember that poor man who went out to help with charity work in the Middle East, and they caught him and shot him out in the desert somewhere? Jihadi John, one of the ISIS people—do you remember that awful thing? He'd gone out to help a Muslim charity and got out to the East, and they showed him on YouTube just before he was to be shot. That makes you think, well, how does that work out?

Some people think that just because you're born or you go through something terrible in this life, it's because you did something terrible in a past life. I think you've heard me talk about this tale from the Dhammapada, where there's a ship going across the ocean and it suddenly stops. It doesn't move. The captain goes and consults some monks who are on board. They sit down in deep contemplation, then go to him and say, well, it's your wife. In a past life she killed all these dogs—I can't remember exactly what it was now, dogs or something. So the only way the ship is going to move is to get rid of your wife. So he throws her overboard. And of course the ship moves on. There's one way to get rid of your wife.

In terms of the whole process that we're in—which is about liberation—there's what you might call a sort of categorical imperative in the Buddha's teaching: that all beings are heading towards liberation, and they will make it. There is in us this Buddha nature which is indestructible. That's the point. It's immortal. It doesn't die. It's not born. And so it will keep being reborn until it finds that it doesn't have to be reborn anymore and finds itself in a blissful place which we call Nibbana.

There are two descriptions of what that is. In Theravada, the Self-Enlightened One just goes into Nibbana, full stop. Nothing more is said. But in the Mahayana, you're drawn out to help other beings, and therefore you reappear in your bliss body in different realms. So the whole idea of kamma fits in with that basic idea that all beings are destined to be liberated one way or the other.

With this sort of rational argument—not scientific, but rational—one might open up to the idea of rebirth. But having said all that, of course, it doesn't matter, does it? Because the Dhamma works for us whether we believe it or not. It's a case of really not coming to a conclusion.

I quote here Bhikkhu Bodhi: the kammic process functions autonomously, without a supervisor or director, entirely through its own intrinsic power of volitional action. It's just the law of kamma; there's no need for a god, there's no need for punishment. It just works itself out.

There's a quote from the Buddha which I'll end with: 'The end of the world is to be seen, known and reached by travelling, that I do not say. And yet I do not say that one makes an end of suffering without reaching the end of the world. Rather, in this fathom-long body, with its consciousness and mind, I declare the world, the arising of the world, the ceasing of the world, and the way leading to the ceasing of the world.' Just this is the end of suffering.

I can only hope my words have been of some assistance, that they have not confused, and that through your practice you may be liberated from all suffering—sooner rather than later.

PART 3

The Path of Ethics



Sīlaṃ samādhī paññā ca — Virtue, concentration, and wisdom

Ethical Behaviour and the Awakening are One

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 43 min

Originally given as *Ethical Behaviour and the Awakening are One* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this dharma talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma addresses a common confusion in Buddhist practice: the false separation between paññā (insight/understanding) and sīla (ethical conduct). Drawing from the Buddha's own description as vijjācaraṇasampanno (accomplished in both understanding and conduct), he explains how wisdom and virtue are like two rivers flowing into the same sea.

The talk examines the distinction between 'Nibbānic Buddhism' and 'Karmic Buddhism,' exploring how insight naturally gives rise to compassionate action, as seen in the Buddha's spontaneous desire to teach after his Awakening. Through the Noble Eightfold Path's structure of sīla, samādhi, and paññā, Bhante demonstrates how right understanding transforms into right speech, action, and livelihood, while ethical behavior supports deeper insight.

Key concepts include kusala (skillful/virtuous action), puñña (merit), and their relationship to spiritual progress. The dramatic story of Aṅgulimāla illustrates how even the most terrible past actions cannot prevent liberation when genuine transformation occurs. This teaching offers practical guidance for reflecting on our daily choices through the lens of virtue and wisdom, showing how every moment presents an opportunity for spiritual growth through mindful ethical action.

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble, and fully self-enlightened one.

I want to talk about a confusion that people sometimes have between paññā—insight, awakening—and sīla, which is conduct.

I think it's still the case in some circles that when you say morality, it gets people very angry. They don't want to know about morality as such, or the ethical life.

In the morning chant, we say of the Buddha that he's vijjā-caraṇa-sampanno—accomplished both in his understanding and in his conduct. And he himself says that understanding and conduct are like the Ganges and the Yamuna rivers that join and flow into the sea. He doesn't make a distinction between understanding and how it expresses itself.

Some of you will know that the Eightfold Path is normally split into three sections: sīla, samādhi, paññā—right conduct, right meditation, and right understanding. Samādhi normally refers to the absorptions.

But in the Buddha's teachings the absorptions are not actually necessary, so the whole teaching can be reduced—in terms of the process of purification and awakening—to those two words: paññā and sīla. Paññā is this business of trying to understand how things really are, and sīla is right conduct, ethical behaviour.

Yet you'll come across writers who split them. And when you go to the East and see how people behave, you can understand how they might come to these conclusions from their fieldwork, their anthropological fieldwork. One writer talks about Nibbanic Buddhism and Karmic Buddhism.

Often when you speak to Eastern Buddhists—or born Buddhists, anyway—they won't have a doubt that the end point is to become liberated, Nibbāna, and that's the point. But their whole life is really centred around sīla, right conduct.

When you follow that train of thought through, they're not so concerned with getting rid of this self, but more with making it a good self, a happy self—insofar as the self can be happy. Their whole lives are about doing right things, and this is where the word kusala comes in, in order to gain merit, which is puñña.

These two words, kusala and puñña, are also key words in the Buddha's teachings. The general idea is that you stop doing harm, you do as much good as you can, and you get reborn in the heavenly realm. And in the heavenly realm, it's a little easier to seek Nibbāna.

Even amongst monks and nuns, you'll find that this is the prevalent attitude. In Sri Lanka—I'm not so sure about Burma and Thailand and other places—being influenced by Hinduism, the hierarchy will tell you that this is the Kali Yuga. It's impossible for anybody to become enlightened during this particular time, so forget it. The best thing you can do is to do good and get reborn into a better place.

It's a bit disheartening, really. But they're happy with that. In a sense, it's a let-out. If you say to yourself, "I can't become enlightened"—phew—you may as well enjoy yourself. That's the case. So you've got to be careful with that sort of mentality.

But when you look at the Buddha's actual behaviour, at his general teachings, and even at the psychology—what we chant in the morning about dependent origination—you begin to see that you can't split the one from the other. The one arises out of the other.

There's this point in the Buddha's life: once he's become enlightened, once he's become liberated and has this deep understanding into the way things are, he spends some time recollecting over it. Mythically it's said he goes through this wheel of dependent origination for three nights—forward, backward, both forward and backward. But obviously he sat there, and that insight had to permeate his understanding.

And then he came up with this, and at that point an idea arose in his mind: who can he teach? It arose spontaneously. Now when he looks around, he sees through his powers that his old teachers have died. And doubt arises—doubt whether anybody can receive this teaching. It's too subtle. He doesn't believe for a moment that people are ready for this.

You'll find some writers call this the great hesitation, and they argue that the Buddha's accomplishment is therefore twofold: his enlightenment, his liberation, and secondly his teaching. They suggest he need not necessarily have taught. He could have said, no, I won't—I'll sit here in this bliss until I pop off.

That's where you get some idea that perhaps there's a choice—that you can become liberated and yet not do anything. That it doesn't manifest outwardly into the world.

Supporting that is the myth of the Paccekabuddha, the private Buddha. The person who's become fully liberated, but what it really says is that they can't teach—that's the normal understanding. Not that they don't want to; they just can't. They don't have the skills or the capacity. If you think of ordinary life, sometimes you get people who are very clever in their subject but just can't get it across.

So teaching is another skill. The Buddha had a special skill whereby he could actually get this stuff across to people. But the hesitation—this is just my own understanding—was only around whether people were actually ready to receive it. The hesitation wasn't about whether to teach or not.

Which is a distinction, isn't it? The desire to teach, the desire to actually share what he had with others, arose spontaneously after he had understood what it was that he had gained.

In the Zen tradition, you'll hear it said that with wisdom, compassion arises naturally.

So it's not possible to continue on the path and for our behaviour not to change. To take it at a ridiculous level, you couldn't have a neurotic Buddha. That would be awful, wouldn't it? Worrying about his fingernails while he's teaching. Worrying whether he'll be liked. Worrying whether he'll get any food today. It doesn't sit, does it?

And it would be awful if he were immoral—teaching all this stuff and going around robbing banks. There's something that jars when you consider what the behaviour of somebody spiritually advanced might be if it doesn't connect with understanding.

There's got to be that immediate connection between a person's understanding and purity. The whole point is that there's a purification of the heart going on.

So here we are, meditating, doing this vipassanā, and we can see that two things are happening. First, there's insight—this understanding about ourselves and how we create suffering. But there's also purification. We are getting less depressed, less angry, or at least not for such long periods. There's a certain progression.

If you're not progressing, then you have to look at your practice and find out why. Because that's the point—to progress, both in understanding and in our happiness, our contentedness.

This slow gaining of understanding into the way we are, manifesting as good action, is right there in the Noble Eightfold Path. It flows right down.

Right understanding changes your attitude to life. For the Buddha, once the understanding had come, the compassion arose. And he himself constantly says, *anukampā*—out of empathy, out of sympathy, I teach you. Whatever a teacher can do for his students, I've done for you.

Now, we also know it can go the other way. Depending on your livelihood, you yourself can be changed, can't you? Just imagine if we all joined the SAS, the Special Air Service. It would be different, wouldn't it? You'd be out there with your machine gun, waiting to kill somebody, or at least protecting yourself. Your whole mentality would change.

Or take a policeman—a policeman's always suspicious. A policeman walks in here, he'd be suspicious. I have my brother-in-law in special service. He protects politicians. He's always suspicious. He's got to be. He's trained to be suspicious. He wanted to be suspicious.

A teacher never asks a question they don't know the answer to. They always make sure they know the answer.

What we do affects us directly, doesn't it? Our personality, the way we speak, our friendships, our acquaintances, what politics we follow, what religion we follow—all of that has an effect on us. It produces a certain way of behaving, but it also comes with an understanding. And that understanding is either going to take us into further happiness or further unhappiness.

So it runs both ways. Through our understanding—which operates at three levels: actually hearing something new that affects us, our own reflection and mental processes, and then direct insight through experience—our understanding changes. But it can also change by what we do.

When you understand that, you can see quite clearly how this applies to lay life. Because most of the time you have to be doing something—your job, whatever it is. This is the path, the path of action. What we're actually doing at any present moment is a path leading us either towards or away from liberation.

And therefore, anytime we do something, there is the importance of that moment of reflection about whether it's kusala or akusala.

Now this word kusala has two meanings in English. One is that it's skilful. Unfortunately, if you say, well, I'm only doing this because it's skilful—I'm only being good, only being generous and compassionate because it's skilful—then the action is taken off the action itself for some future purpose. I'm being skilful now so I can be liberated later.

Immediately you cut between these two processes, *paññā* and *sīla*. It becomes a sort of utilitarian thing: I'm only being good so that I can become enlightened. I'm only helping you so that I can become... See what I mean? There's a split there.

You'll often see in the books that kusala is translated as 'skilful.' But that's the danger. It means that sīla itself is not an end in itself.

But in fact, the end in this life is perfect conduct—vijjā-caraṇa-sampanno—perfected, accomplished in understanding and behaviour.

So although we might say 'skilful' in the sense that it's wholesome and right and all that, we also have to use the word 'virtuous.' It is virtuous as opposed to being non-virtuous or vicious.

And the question is: is virtue an end in itself? Is it? Is the virtuous life an end in itself?

Now, if you look at it the other way, you wouldn't be virtuous unless you knew why you're being virtuous. There has to be an insight into it. It needn't be an intellectual insight—it needn't be something you can scribble on a piece of paper.

When we feel a certain compassion towards somebody, when we want to help them, when that feeling comes out—the underlying understanding there is our interrelatedness.

We can talk about interrelatedness from a high intellectual level: how things all fit together, how everything is conditioned by everything else, and all that. But the actual experience of it—in terms of our relationship to other beings, to plants and the earth—is this heart relationship of compassion, love, sympathetic joy.

That's a heart understanding. If you split the two, you move towards a dry intellectual understanding and miss out on the heart level.

On the other hand, if you stick with the heart level without some sort of understanding, it can so easily slip into mawkish behaviour. That's where we were saying last time about the slippage of compassion into pity or grief.

Now when we have this word kusala—this word virtuous or skilful—there's always this follow-on of puñña, which translates as 'merit.' And it begins to sound a bit like some Christian doctrines, like grace.

You'll often hear in Buddhist circles—born Buddhists, cultural Buddhists, I don't know what you call them—that it's like a bank account. You've got all this merit, and you can draw on it at any time, and you can share it with people. And that's meritorious, so you get more merit because you've shared your merit. It's a sort of bank account that manufactures itself—which is wonderful, isn't it?

But when you actually read the Buddha's psychology, this puñña has nothing to do with the outside.

Of course, the outside might change. If I decide to move away from a certain job or a certain set of friendships that I can see aren't virtuous—they're not quite supporting the life I want to lead—that movement away may be painful because I have certain attachments. But in doing so, I'm moving into another area. The decision takes me into a different realm of experience, one that does support me.

So we could say that the friendships I meet here and the job I'm doing now is my puñña—my merit for shifting across. But in a sense, that misses the point. That's all well and good, but the real puñña, the real merit, is within the heart itself.

That's why, when we become fully liberated—in a couple of days, you'll see—there's no more puñña. There is no more merit to be had, because the liberated person is completely full. They're completely contented and completely happy, so they cannot increase their puñña.

This is what it says in the scriptures: you can't increase that. That's it—they've made it. Yet they still behave out of this compassionate action.

And that's when it becomes selfless. Because whether we like it or not, when we do good, we are increasing our own goodness within ourselves. So while we're not liberated, we do get the benefit of this puñña. But once a person becomes liberated, there's no more puñña.

I'm reminded of Saint Teresa of Lisieux. She was asked: if everybody goes to heaven, some people have obviously been better than others. Everybody's in heaven, so how can they all be happy? Some will have more happiness than others. Probably a bit of jealousy.

Her answer was: everybody gets a glass and it's completely full, but each glass is of a different size. Everybody's glass is completely full, but the size depends on their craftsmanship.

If you look at the different arahats from the Buddha's time—people like Sāriputta and Moggallāna—you can see this quite clearly. They have different areas which produce for them a different type of contentment.

Sāriputta is known as the general of the Dhamma, so his whole interest was in understanding. It's said that he's second only to the Buddha—perhaps even equal in his understanding. The Buddha definitely praises him as quite exceptional in his insight. And because of this whole interest in understanding, he doesn't develop the powers.

Moggallāna, the other chief disciple, isn't so interested in that angle of things but does develop the powers. When Moggallāna asks Sāriputta, "Why don't you develop the powers?" Sāriputta's answer is simply, "I'm not interested."

There's something about Sāriputta's state where he is totally content with the way he is. He doesn't see any point in levitation, or moving from here to there, or doing amazing things. But from Moggallāna's point of view, that was part of his puñña—that was part of his happiness.

Paññā and sīla—our understanding and our conduct—are completely interrelated. If we constantly reflect upon our conduct as virtuous, then our understanding will grow naturally. And if we understand that our understanding must be translated into right conduct, then we should progress.

This whole teaching around karma—which means action, though it also means the consequence of action—has to be guided by our principles, our virtuous principles.

This is where kusala comes in: the idea of reflecting on why we're doing something, even the most mundane things. You might decide you want to watch a bit of TV. When you turn it on, you have to ask yourself: do I want to watch this programme or not? What am I putting into my heart when I watch this? What am I doing to my head? And as soon as you see that it's not quite doing you good, you have to have the strength of will to turn it off.

One exercise I've set people is this: sit in front of your favourite programme—EastEnders—with a cup of tea, make yourself comfortable. And when the time comes, you don't turn the TV on. You just sit there watching that blank screen. Feel that compulsiveness to actually know what's going on. Your mind's making up little stories, trying to work out the plot, just in case you might have missed something.

You keep doing that until you don't want to watch it anymore. You do it every day, or whatever it takes. And then, when you're totally equanimous sitting in front of that screen knowing that EastEnders is on now, you can turn it back on. When you turn it back on, then you can ask yourself: should I be watching this or not?

What about listening to the radio? All of it. TV, radio, whatever entertainment. Friendships. Even going for a walk. Everything has to be questioned. Is this the right thing to be doing now? Is this the virtuous thing to be doing now?

How could you explain that to a friend? Like, "I feel maybe it's not a virtuous relationship and I don't want to see you." You can be stark. You can say that if you want: "I find my relationship with you utterly unskilful and unvirtuous, and I have no wish to see you again." That's it. You can be assured that would be the end of that relationship. That's what you call a sword of wisdom.

But I'm sure there are more kindly ways of getting the message across that you don't particularly want to see them again. Just showing a lack of interest. Making little white lies. It depends. It's up to you. But at some point, if you decide that a friendship is not virtuous, then you have to get rid of it. Full stop.

"I didn't understand the thing about Aṅgulimāla. He'd done dreadful things, and when he was found dead he'd raised a child. But the Buddha said because he decided to be good, because he'd changed, it was all forgiven. Isn't there any karma?"

Aṅgulimāla is one of these stories like the good thief on the cross. What the story shows is that no matter how awful you've been, you can still become totally liberated.

Now, again, you have to make a distinction between this puñña, this merit, and... The merit that Aṅgulimāla had when he met the Buddha was—I'm just guessing—an angry, hateful, fearful, vengeful, grudgeful, you name it, full mind. That's what was in his mind.

When he meets the Buddha, something happens there, some magic happens where he suddenly sees how badly he's behaved and the consequences of it. Remember, in those days the whole idea of karma would have been fully accepted—rebirth and all that, and going to the hells. And suddenly, when he realises what he's done, he has to come back on that.

The first thing he does is join the order. Immediately, as it were, he cuts away from one type of behaviour into another, like a knife. He just moves out of all that business of murder into the brahmacharya life. That's a direct cut.

Now, it's said that when he was unarmed, going on his alms rounds, people threw stones at him, bricks, all sorts. Because he was in robes—because of people's respect for the robes—it seems nobody actually tried to lynch him. But he still had that outside effect: children running away from him, people throwing things, spitting at him. That's his karma.

But that's only the outside, shall we say—the reflection back to him, other people's reaction to him. The process of liberation is now him within himself, dealing with all that horror of remorse and guilt which will be with him because of his past actions.

If you take the Moors murderer, Ian Brady, and his biographer—I've not read the book; I don't even know if it's out, actually; I just read a little bit in the newspaper about it—his biographer asked him whether he ever thinks about the children he tortured.

For those of you who don't know, it's a dreadful thing. He and a woman called Myra Hindley tortured little children, actually put it on cassette, so the recordings were heard in court. This was in the 60s. And he was asked by this biographer: does he ever think about the suffering he caused those children? His answer was, if I did that, it would drive me mad.

So even in the most dastardly of human beings, the most awful of human beings, there's always that seed of compassion, that seed of recognition of our total humanity. There he is. Now, is he going to be able to turn on that? Is he going to be able to turn around and see it?

Some of you might have read that book, *The Man Who Mistook His Wife for a Hat*. Have you come across that? It's a great old book by Oliver Sacks—definitely worth a read. It's about people with mental illnesses caused by parts of the brain going wrong.

There's one story in there which is very apt for somebody who is into the Buddha Dharma. A man murders his daughter atrociously—so much so that the facts are never actually publicised, even in court. It's horrific, absolutely horrific. But the man can't remember. He has no memory whatsoever, so they can't convict him. What they can do is put him in a mental home.

In the mental home he acts perfectly normally, and within a certain amount of time the staff have enough confidence to let him go out for bike rides. On one of these rides a car hits him and he lands on his head. This little bump awakens that memory. According to the book, it took over six months for the staff to stop this man wanting to commit suicide. They had to actually tie him down. You'd have to read it for the details.

So when Aṅgulimāla—no matter how horrific his murders had been—there is that being able to turn upon oneself, to sit within himself with his sense of misery, his sense of remorse.

What we have to understand is that once we've acted, once we've done an act, you can't go back on it. If you steal something, that's it—it is done. You can do something to assuage or undermine the consequences by slipping the money back. But the action is done, and therefore the consequence will be there.

That consequence outwardly—the effect of that consequence outwardly—will be totally dependent on circumstances completely beyond your control. It might never be known, and you die very rich. On the other hand, it might be known, and you end up in jail. All that is completely out of your ability to control.

But this inner guilt, these inner feelings of remorse—they will be there to be handled. And you'll never escape from that, because that's the world you're actually living in. The world we inhabit is this mental world that I'm creating. There's no escape from that.

The texts don't say how long it took for Aṅgulimāla to become liberated, but it was years. Once he was given the same instructions we've been given, he would have had to sit with the horror inside him about all he'd created. Just as we sit with our depressions and our guilts and our remorse, so he would have had to do that. And at some point, all of it would have passed away, all of it would have gone.

For us, this is one of those stories that allows us to have tremendous hope. Because if somebody who has been truly evil can become liberated within a lifetime, then there's a good chance for us, isn't there? Before next new year, perhaps?

In Buddhist history, there was only one time when a heresy arose—a particular school began to teach that some people were so thick they just wouldn't be able to make it. They were called the Icchantikas, the ones who go on forever. For these people, there was no escape from saṃsāra. That's the only time such a view appeared. And of course, it's definitely not mainstream Buddhism.

That's the underlying hope within the Buddha's teaching. Aṅgulimāla stands as an example of it: no matter how extreme and horrible we've been, the liberation from all suffering is ours to achieve.

Just to sum up: there are things to reflect upon every so often—that relationship between our understanding and our conduct, and the other way around, our conduct and our understanding.

At an ethical level—which is where we're actually creating the mental states that will cause us happiness or unhappiness—we ask: is it virtuous? And remember, this isn't just tied to the basic precepts about not killing and stealing and all that. Those are fundamental. But it becomes much more subtle when we consider the relationship we ought to have to our own emotions.

We were talking yesterday about attachment. You can't say attachment is evil. But it's not skilful, it's not virtuous—and it's not skilful for the person who is the object of your attachment either. Because remember, attachment always comes from the self, and it necessarily turns the other person into an object, an object to service your needs.

So you dehumanise somebody, actually, as soon as you attach to them—whether you like it or not. That may not be your intention, but that's what happens.

So there's this business of kusala to understand, and alongside it there's always this puñña, this merit to be gained. The spiritual life is constantly rewarding us for what we're doing. There's always this consequence for correct understanding and ethical behaviour.

It doesn't always seem like that, does it? The world doesn't seem to get any better. But the practice seems to, the insight seems to get better.

Then you go through the barrier, if you like. When I first began to meditate—I was doing Zen meditation in Birmingham—I had this dream. In the dream, I was running like mad. Running, running, running, running. And there was a shower of javelins coming after me. Then I stopped, and every javelin just went into my back.

When we start practising, that's exactly how it feels—because we're always running ahead of our suffering, always trying to escape immediate discomfort. A bit of unease, so you shift your seat. A bit bored, so you phone up a friend. You're always moving off the discomfort.

As soon as you begin practising, you can't do that anymore. And all that conditioning, all that horrible stuff, just hits you—from behind, of all places. So it definitely feels like things are getting worse.

It's the same when you join the Order, or anything really—even a new group or a new workplace. There's that lovely honeymoon period which lasts a few months. And then comes the struggle, because you have to enculturate yourself. You have to change into what the institution wants you to change into, behave in a certain way.

So the first three years—for some, forever—is a miserable process. That torturing: you have to behave in this way. And sometimes people decide it's not what they want. They don't want to be manoeuvred like that.

The understanding is, in those wonderful terms, that it has to get much worse before it gets better. And that's where your faith has to be. You have to hang on in there just to see.

Right Speech, Action and Livelihood

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 22 min

Originally given as *Right Speech, Action and Livelihood* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this teaching on the Noble Eightfold Path, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines three interconnected aspects of ethical conduct that arise from right understanding and intention. He explores sammā vācā (Right Speech), emphasizing truthfulness, kindness, and beneficial communication while avoiding lies, slander, harsh words, and idle chatter. The discussion includes practical guidance on listening with an open heart and choosing appropriate timing for difficult conversations.

The talk continues with sammā kammanta (Right Action), covering the five precepts as a foundation for moral refinement: moving from non-killing toward active protection, from not stealing toward generosity, and from sexual misconduct toward respectful relationships. Bhante addresses the challenge of alcohol abstinence in our society and the importance of sense restraint in daily practice.

Finally, sammā ājīva (Right Livelihood) is presented as an expression of our deepest values, showing how our work shapes our character. The Buddha's guidance to avoid trades in weapons, slavery, meat, alcohol, and poison reflects the principle of non-harm. Throughout, Bhante emphasizes the feedback loop between understanding, intention, and ethical action, demonstrating how virtuous conduct both arises from and reinforces wisdom and compassion.

Greetings and good evening. I trust you've had a fruitful day. I don't say happy, though I hope it has been.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and self-awakened one.

I want to read an email that came through. They write: "I have been meditating with you daily and have set up my evenings around this time. You won't be surprised by this, but it's changed my life. I'm sleeping better, feel less burdened in the day. During meditation, I'm able to stay with painful surface and deeper emotions whilst holding them with *mettā*. Seeing you meditate and knowing lots of others are doing the same at the same time offers a sense of connection and commitment to my practice. Thank you." There we are. Thank you so much for that feedback. I'm presuming the same is true for many of you.

Now, I want to go back and try to complete this Eightfold Noble Path. Remember, my aim over these two months has been to introduce you to the various discourses in the Middle Length Sayings. I'll try to get through most of this material this evening.

We started with *sammādiṭṭhi*, right understanding. The Eightfold Path is transcendental — not in between indulgence and aversion, but rising above them. In that sense it's the middle; it's transcendent. And this *sammādiṭṭhi* has to do with the conceptual: the way we conceive, the way we look at things and experience them through our concepts.

The big mistake, according to the Buddha, is to seek any sort of lasting happiness in anything to do with this world — things are impermanent, radically so. They're arising and passing away momentarily. And this whole concept of me, the self, is causing a great deal of problems. That manifests through our attachments. Attachments are psychological dependencies: we use things, we use people in order to make ourselves feel happy. That's not the same as *mettā*, compassion and generosity. Those come from a different place — from wisdom, from not me, me, me.

This right concept draws us into the social virtues. The main ones are generosity, love, goodwill, and compassion — the desire to help people. Once these pass into our attitudes, into our intentions, they begin to manifest in the way we think, which is an internal speech, an internal speaking. I speak to myself. Sometimes I'm speaking to myself, but I also find myself speaking to lots of other people inside this little head of mine. And it includes, of course, speech in ordinary daily life.

The type of speech we don't want to get into is, of course, untruths. We don't want to slander people. Blake says, "A truth told with bad intent beats all the lies you can invent." That's a beautiful little verse. It depends on your intention, which makes it either slander or having to say something that might undermine some-

body's reputation — but for good reason. Then there's abusive speech, using speech to upset people. And finally just chit-chat, talking for talking's sake — a waste of time, really.

We hate silence when we're walking with a friend or with somebody close to us — our partner or a child. There's always this compulsion to communicate, to speak. And it's a sign of maturity in a relationship that you can be silent with each other. That's my understanding anyway.

When it comes to free speech, there was a period a couple of years back where this came up around the whole business of Islam and not insulting the prophets. Out of that came this phrase "the right to insult." That's a very aggressive way of saying everybody has a right to express their opinion, even though they know it'll upset somebody. It became a sort of aggressive thing, the right to insult. I don't think you have a right to insult. You have a right to express yourself, your own truths, even though you might upset somebody.

When that happens, we normally introduce it, don't we? We say, "I know this is going to upset you, I hope you don't mind," and so on. It's a case of being kind, being gentle. That's one of the qualities of right speech: being gentle and being truthful — truthful to ourselves, truthful to the situation. And there's the sense of being beneficial: you're speaking for either your own benefit, somebody else's benefit, or both. And with a heart of loving-kindness, the Buddha says — coming from a heart of loving-kindness.

Sometimes that's difficult, of course, when you're talking to somebody who's being aggressive. In which case, at least you can come from the heart of no harm. There's no point in upsetting ourselves and getting angry. That's just a waste of energy. And there's a distinction between being aggressive and being assertive — a very clear way of putting it. You can state your truth coming from a position of strength, a position of goodwill, a position of compassion. You don't have to come from anger.

In fact, anger often manifests a certain weakness, because sitting underneath it there's always fear. You don't get angry unless you're afraid. Fear underpins anger.

One of the interesting things the Buddha says is to speak at the right time — to choose your moment. There's a right time and a wrong time, and I'm sure we've all experienced dropping a clanger. It's a case of recognising the situation and being careful about what we say. And the key to that, when we're with people, is the ability to listen.

Listening is difficult, especially when somebody is expressing ideas or positions that aren't the same as ours, or even opposed to ours. There's a sort of fear, I think, that we're going to be converted — that if we allow ourselves to listen, open-hearted and open-minded, there's this terrible danger that they might change us. But if we come from that sense of inner stability, just that calmness, with a willingness to understand the world they're living in... We're all creating our own little worlds, and the intention is to understand: where are they coming from? It doesn't have to convert us.

On the other hand, we may find that our views and opinions are nuanced by what other people say. And that's coming from the heart of humility — none of this business of "I'm right and everybody else is wrong." I'm special that way.

There's a whole area of right speech we can contact on a daily basis, and that would be the purpose of an evening reflection — looking back at a conversation that didn't go right, or one that really did, where you felt you were skilful and wise. On both counts, you can reinforce and encourage yourself. You can congratulate yourself; there's nothing wrong with that. "Well done. Well done, Bodhidhamma." Absolutely.

So that's the position of right speech. And again, it comes from these attitudes we've developed because of our different view about life. It all goes back to view. This is what I meant about all the factors being important — and we'll see why when I come to the end. But some precede others.

When it comes to sammākammanta, right action, that's usually expressed as basic morality: not to kill, steal, or engage in offensive sexual behaviour. Included in this is being untruthful and, of course, the use of drugs and alcohol, which isn't very good for us.

The move here is towards refinement. Obviously we've given up killing, at least for a while, and we're moving towards protecting — protecting each other, protecting animals, protecting wildlife, protecting flowers. It's a change of attitude towards protection. Stealing moves us towards generosity. Offensive sexual conduct moves us towards right relationship, treating the other as a person rather than an object to satisfy our personal erotic desires. And right speech — well, we've done that.

This idea of non-alcohol is difficult for our society because we are alcohol-based. It's a case of recognising that under the influence, especially if we've drunk a little too much, we can do things that aren't particularly good. And when you

consider that our purpose is to maintain a bright awareness at all times — from the moment you wake up to the point you fall asleep, we're supposed to be bright, we're supposed to be mindful — putting alcohol in the system really doesn't help.

I had a very good experience with that myself. I'd given up alcohol and had just come out of a Zen session — so this was right back at the beginning of my practice. On the way home, I slipped into a pub and had half a beer, half a mild or something. I did it to see what effect it would have. And to my surprise, after I'd drunk it, I felt this curtain — it's difficult to describe — a net coming down, an actual physical feeling in my brain. That convinced me I had to give it up, which I did.

So those are the things we're moving towards: refinement. The other aspect here is restraint of the senses. That's one of the big teachings of the Buddha: to restrain, to guard the senses, to be on the lookout for when they get involved in stuff, and to be aware of our reactions to what we see and hear.

That sounds like suppressing something, but it's not. It's holding and saying, no, we don't want to keep developing that particular mental state. For instance, when you see something that draws a certain anger out of you, or a certain neurotic feeling, you catch it at the beginning and say, no, I don't want to go there. That way you're undermining an old habit. Not saying, by the way, that there aren't times when erotic feelings are to the point — within a proper relationship, okay.

Right livelihood. The importance of livelihood is that it's an expression of our desire, of the way we see ourselves. If you happen to have the job you wanted, the area of work that suits your own personal interest, your own personal bent, your own special qualities — that matters. Some people want to move towards helping others, so they end up as nurses or doctors or involved in some sort of medical work. But even wanting to work in a hospital as a cleaner — that might come from that same desire to be part of a place where people are helped.

Other people want to devote their lives to art or to nature — they want to be involved in gardens and things like that. Others want to be involved in artificial intelligence and information technology. What you do is actually developing your particular characteristic, your particular character. So it's a case of recognising that the work you're doing is affecting your personality and your character. And that's why it's so important.

Of course, there are particular types of trades we don't want to get involved with: trading in arms, in living beings, slavery and prostitution, meat, alcohol and poison. Those are the five you try to avoid. So you can see there's a flow down from right understanding, right attitude manifesting in the way we speak, in the way we behave, and in our work.

The last three factors we'll come to at another time. They're basically to do with our meditation, both in sitting practice and in daily life. This mindfulness, affectionate mindfulness. When we read or chant the loving-kindness discourse, the Buddha talks about how we should always live with this mindfulness — he's talking about a mindfulness imbued with a sense of kindness, a sense of goodwill. So the heart's always involved.

It's the same with your work — I should have mentioned this earlier. There are these two qualities: being attentive, attending to what you're doing, but you also have to give the heart a good reason. So there's attention and care. You can always bring care into anything, a sense of care.

The important thing is that all of these feed back into themselves. Although we began with the importance of getting our concepts right, of understanding how we create suffering, of getting our attitudes right — and from there there's a flow — there's also a feedback. Because as we behave coming from that position of wisdom, it feeds back into the wisdom. It supports the wisdom, and there's a desire to deepen it. There's a desire to grow in those attitudes: love, compassion, joy, peace, and all that.

So there's a feedback loop in this. And the interesting one is between attitude and understanding. Because if we're drawn to compassionate action — compassion driven by goodwill, action driven by generosity, by giving — remember that this is constantly undermining the sense of this isolated me. It's constantly reinforcing the fact of we, that we're all in this together, that I am my relationships. And that undermines this very isolated sense of self.

Every time we give or do something that hurts a little — like what you give through generosity or what is demanded of you from your compassion — all that is undermining the sense of me. It's all about me, me, me. That doesn't, of course, undermine self-care. It just takes away this barrier of me. And we see ourselves more as interrelated. We know all these words: interrelated, interdependent, interbeing. That's *taṇhā* being loosened, and it manifests through the way we actually speak, the way we act, and so on.

So that reinforces again, that changes our concepts. If, for instance, you've been the sort of person who's not been very generous and then suddenly you begin to be generous, you realise the joy you're giving to people. When you give joy to people you find your own heart rejoicing. That's your feedback. Then you realise, 'Well, this is where I can find some real happiness — happiness based on community, based on communication.'

Okay, so time has moved on and it's time to do our little meditation here.

Skillful Discussion: The Buddha's Guide to Noble Conversation

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 19 min

Originally given as *Skillful Discussion: The Buddha's Guide to Noble Conversation* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this teaching, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines a discourse from the Aṅguttara Nikāya that addresses how to engage in meaningful dialogue, particularly relevant in our age of polarization. The Buddha outlines three types of discussion—about past, present, and future—and provides practical guidance on determining whether someone is competent for genuine conversation.

The talk explores four key skills: asking appropriate questions (categorical, analytical, counter-questions, and those to be set aside), understanding conversational conventions, handling confrontation skillfully, and maintaining the right disposition for learning. Bhante discusses the Buddha's famous avyāgata—the ten undeclared questions about the world's eternity, finitude, and the post-death existence of a Tathāgata—explaining why speculative metaphysical questions were set aside in favor of practical liberation.

The discourse emphasizes that noble ones consult "for the sake of knowledge and clarity," avoiding hostility, arrogance, and the desire merely to win arguments. Instead, they listen actively, acknowledge well-spoken points, and engage without intimidation or mockery. This teaching offers valuable guidance for practitioners seeking to embody Right Speech in daily interactions and contribute to more compassionate discourse in society, supporting the ultimate goal of liberation through non-clinging.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa.

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed noble and fully self-awakened one.

I've just picked up a discourse concerned with how we discuss things with each other, how we talk to each other. In this age of great polarisation, I thought, let's see what the Buddha has to say. It comes from the *Āṅguttaranikāya*, the collection of shorter discourses.

It starts off like this: There are, mendicants, these three topics of discussion. What three? You might discuss the past: this is how it was in the past. You might discuss the future: this is how it will be in the future. And you might discuss the present: this is how it is at present.

At first, that seems a bit obvious. But of course, these are three very different conversations. The first is all about memory—opinions about memory and what we thought had happened. The second is driven by some future idea, some idealism, and there could be arguments about that. And the present is an attempt to see things as they are—but everybody sees things differently, so there's all sorts of argumentation there too.

The discourse then takes up the process of discussion itself. The first element is skill in questions—through which you can see whether it's worth talking to somebody. The text says a person is 'competent to hold a discussion', but what it really means is whether it's worth you talking to them. Remember that when these discourses were composed, they didn't have recording machines. The way you got people to be clear was to ask the question three times and make sure: is that what you mean? This was done either between two individuals or in a group, so that the position taken was clear, what was said was clear, and silly arguments were undermined from the start.

At that time, people had what's called reproductive imagination—not like ours. If you see a car crash today, you'll see it one way and then you won't be sure you've seen it correctly because you didn't record it fully, and questions will be asked. In those times, with reproductive imagination, they were very good at remembering things.

Even today this capacity survives. At the 1956 Sixth Great Council held in Burma, there were six monks who knew all the scriptures—all the Abhidhamma and all the Vinaya, the rule of the monks. That's a massive amount of literature, and they knew it off by heart. When questions came up about certain passages that were perhaps not quite right, it was these monks who became the experts, quoting directly from the scriptures.

Here are the sorts of questions someone might ask. When a person is asked a question that needs to be answered categorically and they don't answer it categorically, that shows they're not worth talking to. For example, you might ask: is the Buddha impermanent? If they prevaricate—yes, no, maybe and all that—then what we want is a clear statement. Yes, yes, it is.

Another example: is the UK a European country? I should say yes. Lots of UK people don't think they are, I suspect. But that's what should be said, at least geographically.

The next sort of question might need analysis. A regular one is: is Buddhism a religion? Then you have to ask, what do you mean by religion? Another example is when the Buddha describes this whole idea of not-self; he starts off with control. How much of the body can you control? Is it under your control? Can you make it grow taller? You'd have to say that when he means control, he obviously means the body as an organism. But obviously I can move it around—I do have some ability to control it. And of course, what he's really pointing to is sickness, ageing, and death.

Sometimes you ask a question and it needs a counter-question. A Dhamma example would be: are the ear and nose the same? You say, in what way? They say, in their function. Then yes, they are the same—they both perceive.

These days, of course, we have this whole thing about immigration. A question might be: should immigrants be allowed to stay? Then you say, what type? What are the types of immigrants coming to the country? And can we make distinctions?

As a Vipassanā teacher, I might ask you: how's your practice going? And you say, oh, it's good. If I'm a bad teacher, I'll say, very good, I'll take your word for it. But if I'm a good teacher, I'll say, in what way? And you say, my mind is quieter, I'm able to see process more clearly. Then I say *sādhū, sādhū*. But if you say to me, I'm feeling a lot happier—no, it's not about happiness. That's the end product.

And then there are questions that should simply be set aside. In conversation, somebody might ask you a personal question. You don't have to answer that, even if it seems relevant.

In the Buddhist teachings, there were ten questions the Buddha wouldn't answer. They're known as the *avyākata*—the undeclared ten statements or questions. They run like this: Is the world eternal? Is the world not eternal? Is the world finite? Is the world infinite? These he wouldn't answer. I don't think he'd

know, frankly. Although I have to say, the commentary on the Visuddhimagga does unfortunately claim that the Buddha knew the world was flat. But he didn't say anything about the world as something objective out there. His main interest was the world we're creating moment after moment.

The next set of questions: Is the soul the same as the body? Is the soul one thing and the body another? He doesn't answer these either. It's something worth investigating in another little talk, so I won't go into it here.

And then finally, there were four questions around a Tathāgata. Remember, that's how he referred to himself—the one who had arrived, who had gone, who had completed the path. It refers to any Arahant, really. Does a Tathāgata exist after death? Does he not exist after death? This is known as the quadrilemma. Does a Tathāgata both exist and not exist after death? And here's a headbanger: does a Tathāgata neither exist nor not exist after death? Not surprisingly, he didn't answer that. The real reason, of course, was that people were thinking of the Tathāgata—a liberated one—as a person, as a self. He just didn't like those sorts of questions. He didn't like any questions that were speculative, basically.

Now we move on to a different section: the skill in the conventions of conversation. When a person is asked a question, if they're not consistent about their position—what it is and what it isn't, what they're actually proposing—and then they change the subject, or speak from some fake position rather than from what they know, and it's not appropriate to the procedure... This is really about having a proper discussion with somebody, not speaking over each other. Politicians are very good at that.

I was watching a BBC interview with Varoufakis, I think that's his name—the Greek economist. Some of you may know him. There was an economics lecturer there too, from Oxford or somewhere, and of course the interviewer. At first, he was asking the questions, they were answering, it all looked very civilised. And then right at the end, all three of them spoke at once, trying to crush each other. It's just weird. And of course, I didn't get a word of it.

How do people engage when being attacked? You can know whether or not a person is competent to hold a discussion by seeing how they take part in one. When a person is asked a question, if they dodge the issue, distract the discussion with irrelevant points, display annoyance, hate and bitterness—then that person is not competent to hold a discussion. That's politicians, isn't it? Dodging the issue, distracting with something irrelevant, and occasionally getting a little bit uppity about things.

The next question is how people engage with confrontation—so afraid of being bettered. Again, you can know whether a person is competent to hold a discussion by seeing how they take part in one. When a person is asked a question, if they intimidate, crush, mock, and seize on trivial mistakes, then they're not competent to hold a discussion. In other words, don't talk to them. But when a person is asked a question and they don't intimidate you, crush you, mock you, or seize upon trivial mistakes—then it's worth talking to them.

So often in conversation, it's about winning—not about finding some truth, not about finding some way of compromise, not even coming to a position of agreeing to differ. It's about who wins. I saw a really quite horrible discussion on YouTube between a university professor and Jordan Peterson. And somebody else whom you'll know—I just can't bring his name to mind—but it was vicious. It was about woke. The professor especially was very insulting. But what can you do? Jordan Peterson is a right-wing guru, and the other fellow was on the left. If I was any of them, I'd have just walked out. He was just insulting.

Now we have a general disposition. You can know whether or not a person has what's required by seeing how they take part in a discussion. If they actively listen, they have what's required. The next section is actually about the Four Noble Truths, but here the Buddha is stressing the ability to listen—not to be afraid of what the person might say. Be open to the fact that your own position may be changed, may be nuanced.

The next one is much more to do with the scriptures. It says that for someone who has what's required, they directly know one thing, completely understand one thing, give up one thing, and realise one thing. That one thing, of course, is *Nibbāna* and the path to *Nibbāna*. Here the Buddha points out that the purpose of all discussion, as far as he's concerned—all consultation, sitting close and listening well—is the liberation of the mind by not clinging, by not grasping.

Finally, there's a coda. Those who converse with hostility—too sure of themselves, arrogant, ignoble, attacking virtues—they look for flaws in each other. They rejoice together when their opponent speaks poorly, makes a mistake, becomes confused, and is defeated. But the noble ones don't discuss like this.

If an astute person wants to hold a discussion connected with the teaching and its meaning—the kind of discussion that the noble ones hold—then that wise one should start knowing when the time is right. Neither hostile nor arrogant, not overexcited, contemptuous, aggressive, or with a mind full of jealousy, they speak from what they rightly know. They agree with what is well spoken, praising the

other person who has a contradictory idea—or at least accepting when they've made a decent argument—without criticising what has been poorly said. They don't persist in finding faults, nor seize on trivial mistakes, nor intimidate, nor crush the other. Nor would they speak suggestively or snidely.

Good people consult for the sake of knowledge and clarity. That's a really good statement, worth repeating: good people consult for the sake of knowledge and clarity. That's how the noble ones consult. This is noble consultation. Knowing this, a wise person should consult without arrogance.

That's the final section of the discourse. And remember, we shouldn't take these discourses as final statements. Even subjects like dependent origination crop up in various discourses from various angles. It's not as though we take a discourse and say, well, that's everything to be said about discussion. Far from it. They're just pointers. Our task is to translate what we've understood back into our own lives and, of course, into society—especially these days, when there's so much polarisation. The Buddha himself, when somebody reported to him what one of his monks or nuns had said, would say, 'Well, if you'd asked me that question, I would have said the same thing.'

Now, just before we finish, I want to point to three books—I'll put them on the website. The first is *Nonviolent Communication* by Rosenberg. It's a really famous book and definitely worth reading about how to talk to people. The second, which I've not read entirely but have dipped into, is called *Difficult Conversations*. Finally—I don't think you'll be able to get this book, but you might—it's called *Bad Arguments*. It tells you all the ways that people don't answer your question, don't converse with you in a proper manner, and just cause confusion and anger. Very good.

I hope this little discourse is of some use to you in your life and in society, and is just part and parcel of your path to complete and full liberation from suffering—sooner rather than later.

Dhammapada 256-257: Judgmental vs Judicious

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 17 min

Originally given as *Dhammapada 256-257: Judgmental vs Judicious* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



Drawing from Dhammapada verses 256-257, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the crucial difference between being judgmental and being judicious. The teaching begins with the story of bhikkhus who witnessed corrupt judges in King Pasenadi's court, prompting the Buddha's discourse on righteous judgment.

Bhante explores the Pali terms dhammato (standing in the Dharma) and sahasa (hasty, violent action), explaining how true righteousness requires thorough investigation from all perspectives before making judgments. He discusses the qualities of a good judge—patience, open-mindedness, compassion, and freedom from bias—and how these apply to our daily interactions.

The talk addresses the reality of cultural conditioning and inevitable prejudices we all carry, offering practical guidance on acknowledging these mental formations without suppressing or indulging them. Through Right Awareness, we can recognize prejudicial thoughts as conditioning while choosing not to act upon them, eventually transforming judgment into wisdom and compassion. A valuable teaching for developing discernment while cultivating love and understanding in our relationships.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa.

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

Na tena hoti dhammiko, yen' atthaṃ sahasā naye. Yo ca atthaṃ anattaṃ ca, ubho niccheyya paṇḍito. Asāhasena dhammena, samena nayatī pare. Dhammassa gutto medhāvī, dhammiko ti pavuccati.

That translates as: One is not called righteous because one hastily judges what is good. A wise person has thoroughly investigated both the right and the wrong. Judging others without haste, justly and impartially, such a wise person, guardian of law, is called righteous.

So it's about judging. And Gil Fronsdal's translation: One is not a judge who judges a case hastily. A wise person considers both what is and isn't right. Guiding others without force, impartially and in accord with the dharma, one is called a guardian of the dharma, intelligent and just.

Before we go into the actual verses, here's the little story that surrounds it. It seems that some bhikkhus were returning from alms round, caught in a storm. They sheltered in the hall of justice at Sāvattī, which is the capital of Kosala. King Pasenadi was a great supporter of the Buddha. They saw judges making arbitrary decisions and taking bribes and reported this to the Buddha. The Buddha said, "If one is influenced by monetary considerations in deciding cases, he cannot be called a just judge who abides by the law. If one weighs the evidence intelligently and decides a case impartially, then he is called a just judge who abides by the law."

Now, the commentary says something that perhaps is more attuned to us: it is very easy to judge others, to point out others' mistakes and bad qualities. Therefore, we have to be very thorough when we have to judge others. We have to listen to every possible point of view. We have to look at the problem from all sides. Only then can we be able to judge according to truth and call ourselves righteous.

Just one or two words that we've come across there: *dhammato*, translated as righteous. It actually means to stand in the Dharma. The Dharma here means, of course, the law, the truth—not only the spiritual laws, but just the general laws, truthfulness. Well, *dhammato* is given in the dictionary as fitness, propriety, a general rule, higher law, cosmic law, general practice, regular phenomenon, usual habit. So it's got a wide range of meaning.

In terms of justice or in terms of our sense of judging, it means to be as truthful as we can. And that means you need to collect as many facts and views and opinions as you can before you can come to a decision about somebody.

The other one is a rather interesting word: *sāhasa*. It has an odd meaning. It has violence, violent, hasty, arbitrary action, acts of violence, a sense of force. So one translator translates it as hasty—get on with it without really listening to both sides. And the other one is with a bit of force, a bit of push. Get on with it. So that's what these two words are.

And of course, one is called a guardian, a *gutto*, a guardian of the Dharma, if one is judging properly.

Of course, I looked up what makes a good judge—I mean a judge in court. My research came to some qualities that perhaps we should all have: patience, open-mindedness, courtesy, tact, firmness, understanding, compassion and humility. But of course, these are general characteristics of somebody who is a judge.

But when you're in court, there are four qualities that we would expect of a judge. The first one is that he's not averse to the accused, no matter how terrible the actions of the accused have been. Not to be glowering there saying, "I hate this guy, I hate this woman. I'm going to make sure that they go down." He's going to be aware of that aversion and not indulge it.

And of course, he's not going to be partial to the prosecutor. Could be the other way around, of course, that he has a liking or he feels that there's been some injustice done to the defendant and he's biased against the prosecutor. Either way, it obviously isn't going to come to a good judgment, or the way that he talks to the jury is going to be tainted.

He also doesn't want to be swayed by the baying of the crowd, the newspapers saying "hang him." You've got to be careful not to get caught up in that general feel of things. And the way things are really riled up by newspapers and politicians, as we've seen all over this business of the government and Brexit and all that.

And finally, of course, he's got to be free of fear—fear of reprisals, especially when he or she, the judge, sends somebody to prison, or in the old days, to hanging. In some parts of the world that still is possible. To be killed as a judge—in fact, in 1992, Giovanni Falcone, who was the judge in Sicily who brought many of the mafiosi to trial, was shot dead. So it happens.

This is the judge sentencing somebody to death. This would be before 1965, so it's not that long ago:

"You will be taken from this place to a lawful prison and then to a place of execution where you will suffer death by hanging, and your body buried in the precinct of the prison in which you shall be last confined before execution. And may the Lord have mercy upon your soul."

You can imagine listening to that. Just to rub that in, I thought I'd give you what they used to say in the 18th century: "The Lord is that thou shalt return to the place whence thou camest, and from thence to the place of execution where thou shalt hang by the neck till the body be dead, dead, dead, and the Lord have mercy on your soul."

It's pretty gruesome. These days, of course, at least in many of the Western countries, we've abandoned hanging. But just to finish this little bit off about judges, there was, of course, a standing joke when they brought hanging to an end in Britain. The judge sentenced somebody: "You will be taken from this place to the place of execution and be hanged until dead." And the clerk of the court jumped up and said, "Your Honour, hanging has been abolished." So the judge cleared his throat and said, "You will be taken to the place of execution and hanged by the neck until it really, really hurts."

What this takes us to, of course, is the whole thing about judging. And this takes us to the fact that when we're judging people, when we see people, when we hear people, we've always got this background judging going on. We're always fitting them into a box in some way. And of course, what we're doing is being prejudicial—prejudging, prejudicial.

Now, the Dalai Lama actually says that love is the absence of prejudice. Well, it's definitely one of the big cornerstones of it—not being judgmental. But that doesn't stop us from being judicious, which means, of course, to come to a right understanding about somebody or some action. So it's not as though we have to stop judging. We just have to make sure that it's fair and that it is based on facts and truth.

Just thinking about judging or prejudice, speaking for myself, but I'm sure it's true for everybody in any society: you are given the prejudices of your society from the moment you're born. They're inculcated. You can't—it's part of the whole cultural education that you get. So you're bound to have, in my opinion, you're bound to have racist, sexist, prejudice against religions, et cetera, et cetera. It's got to be there.

And what's important really is to understand that when, because we are more aware, more mindful of what we're doing and what we're thinking—when you see a prejudicial thought come up, to know that that's all conditioning. And even though some shame and guilt might come up around it, those are to be seen as guardians. So this is where the Buddha says that shame and guilt about doing something harmful are guardians. Otherwise, you know, we would just indulge it. So there's a proper sense of shame and a bit of guilt that comes up which stops you from indulging that particular prejudice.

But if the guilt goes on and on—dreading consequences because of old conditioning—then it's gone on too long. It's not proper to the situation; there's no need for it. It's only when we indulge those thoughts—either letting the mind escape into fantasy, or actually speaking or doing something prejudicial—that we should feel a greater sense of shame and guilt.

And that leads us to apology. Shame and guilt are the beginnings of compassion—of understanding, of opening up to the pain we've caused somebody else.

Of course, we're full of these prejudices. I've even forgotten classism, which is a big one in our society. Xenophobia brought up through immigration. All these prejudices that come up have to be acknowledged. If they're not, we suppress them—out of fear, out of aversion towards them. But remember, Freud was perfectly right: these things slip out in little Freudian slips, and they can be very embarrassing.

So it's best to be aware of any prejudicial thought that comes up and to accept that it's part of our conditioning—but we're not indulging it, not giving it headway. In doing so, we've not done anything wrong whatsoever. There's no consequence, no *kamma* to suffer. And eventually these things become very light in the mind—little traces that really don't bother us anymore.

Now, one little trick you can try, which opens us up to these background voices, these little devils within us: just walk down the street, turn your head, look at somebody, and listen to the judgments coming up, the opinions, the biases arising in the mind. As I say, that's not something to be excessively guilty about. It's just to know that these conditionings exist within us, and that by not indulging them, in time they atrophy, they die away. And of course, they are replaced by love, compassion, sympathetic joy, and so on.

So these two verses are really asking us to look at this whole process of judging and to make a distinction: between being judgmental—being prejudicial, coming to opinions and decisions and actions based on not enough knowledge or on our own biased views—and being judicious. Being judicious means coming from the point of view of what he calls intelligence: to do something rationally, but with a sense of wisdom about it too. Then we can make proper judgment. We can be righteous. We can be standing in the Dharma. Standing in the Dharma—that's where we want to be.

I can only hope my words have been of some assistance, that I haven't caused any confusion, and that you will, by your own devoted practice, liberate yourself from all suffering—sooner rather than later.

Sacca: Honesty

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 10 min

Originally given as *Sacca: Honesty* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this DhammaBytes episode on the pāramīs (perfections), Bhante Bodhidhamma explores sacca - the perfection of honesty and truthfulness. Moving beyond obvious dishonesty, he examines the subtle ways we deviate from truth: exaggeration to impress others (rooted in the three conceits of superiority, inferiority, and equality), 'being economical with the truth,' and pretending knowledge we don't possess.

The teaching addresses the challenge of honest reporting in meditation practice, drawing from his experience with Eastern teachers who emphasized authenticity in describing spiritual experiences. He explores the complex territory of 'white lies' - examining intentions behind withholding or modifying truth, illustrated through stories from Sri Lanka about cultural differences in saying 'no' and keeping commitments.

Bhante emphasizes that the most difficult aspect of sacca is radical self-honesty - seeing ourselves as we truly are, which he defines as genuine humility. He presents the Buddhist teaching that when two people meet, six people are present: how each sees themselves, how each is seen by the other, and who each truly is. This perfection of honesty cuts through self-deception and supports clear communication, making it essential for both meditation practice and daily life interactions.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa.

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-enlightened one.

To carry on with these *pāramī*, the next one is *sacca*. The 'c' in Pali is always 'ch' and it translates as honesty, truthfulness.

I think we can pass over telling the great whoppers. I think we've gone beyond that. But Churchill talked about it. Churchill put it as being economical with the truth. The other dishonesty is to do with exaggeration. We tend to exaggerate in order to impress people. It's to do with the three conceits. We're either trying to impress somebody that we're better than we are, or worse than we are, or we're equal to them, even though we know we're not.

There's that exaggeration we put about ourselves, but there's also exaggeration about the weather, the climate change, the financial crisis—just the way we talk about it, exaggerating to create some impression. I think it's a case of just being aware of what we're saying and what we're doing. It's always to do with right speech.

But there's a point where exaggeration leaves the humorous and moves into that little area of slight untruth. You just have to be careful. I've occasionally found myself, when somebody's come up with a Pali word, pretending that I know it. It embarrasses me. Then I've got to go and look it up. It's just because I've got in my head that I know Pali words, and I don't. I've got to get over the fact that I'm not a Pali scholar. It's happened to me—once I remember distinctly being corrected, and so I'm humbled and made some excuse about it.

In terms of meditation, it can be a real problem. It was funny—when I used to work with my Eastern teachers, they were often all about honesty. This was because Westerners would talk about their experience. I never really found out whether it was that Westerners were exaggerating or whether it was the teachers who didn't believe that Westerners could attain these experiences. I remember once saying to Ajahn Sumedho, "They think we're spiritual nerds, like we would think of Easterners at one time as being technological twits." There was that confusion, but they were always on about honesty, being honest in your reporting.

The next one that is of interest is white lies. These are all to do with intentions. What's your intention in not saying something that you ought to say, or in saying something that is not right, but for some good reason? I think in former times it was very difficult to tell somebody they were dying. You always had to pretend that they weren't actually dying, even though the person probably felt that they were dying. These days people are a bit more open about that, but it's a case of having a good reason for not saying the truth and being clear about it.

I remember once there was an old teacher of mine from primary school whom I met, and he had become headmaster of a local place. The catering service decided to serve TVP, textured vegetable protein, instead of meat. He didn't tell the

staff. Then he asked the staff what it was like, and of course they said it was all right, good mince, very nice meat, and all that. Then he told them. They were very upset, because they felt they'd been used as guinea pigs. It was all right doing it to the kids.

It was funny, because he told me with this sense of astonishment as to why they were so upset about it. What he didn't realise was that in not telling them, he presumed that they would be prejudiced. If he'd told them that it was TVP, they'd have eaten it with that critical mind and said, "This isn't like meat, it doesn't have the same crunch, it doesn't have this, it doesn't have that." He was tricking them in a way. So he got a bit of flack for that. But it just shows you—it was a good intention in a sense. Yet from his point of view, there was this lack of trust in the teachers that they wouldn't accept this TVP business.

The one that's usually talked about in the commentaries is keeping your word, actually. That's the one they usually go on about, keeping your word. I think we often find when somebody asks us to do something, we can be a bit too quick with the "yes, I'll do it." Instead of just holding a minute and saying, "I'll have to think about it, I'll have to look at my diary or something." You find yourself saying yes and then kicking yourself for doing it.

Then when it comes to the time to actually help them out—moving house or painting and decorating or something—suddenly you're feeling ill. You phone up and say, "Can't come, there's an elephant just entered the house and I've got to deal with it," things like that, to get out of this hole you've got yourself in. Then you do it and you're feeling rotten all the time for doing it. All it took was this moment of just saying, "I'm not sure I can help," or what have you.

There's a lovely incident of that in Sri Lanka. Easterners, because of loss of face, find it very difficult to say no. I came across this when I was in the *kutī*. I was trying to keep the rule very strictly. It was very difficult to do that. I would ask the office to buy me something. I can't remember what the object was now, but let's say it was apples. I would say to them, "Can you get me so many apples?" They were in trust with my money that I had. They were my *kappiya*, the ones who make it allowable.

If they couldn't get apples, they came with a whole load of oranges. They couldn't come to me and say, "There aren't any apples." They had to come with something else. Eventually I got fed up because I was wasting all my money, so I had to give up on asking them to do something.

There was this Australian monk—now this is really going to make you laugh. He had turned up in Sri Lanka and he had invited this senior monk to come to Thailand with him. The senior monk couldn't say no. He can't say no. So he does this shake of the head business. And the Australian bought a ticket, bought a ticket. It was all arranged to meet at the airport, and the senior monk never turned up. It was just too much for this Australian guy. This was the absolute pits, a senior monk. I found that constantly in the East, the inability to say no and giving you the impression they're coming. Then they don't. Or they say they'll do something and then they don't. I think it's to do with that Eastern thing about losing face and not being shamed—a shame culture rather than ours, which is more guilt-ridden.

That gives you some ideas about this quality of *sacca*, of truthfulness, being absolutely honest. I think the most difficult thing is to be honest with oneself, frankly, to be brutally honest with oneself, to see oneself as one really is. In a sense, that's the definition of humility in its proper sense: to see oneself as one really is.

You come across this way of talking about it in Buddhism. I don't know where this has come from, but when two people meet, there are six people there. There's me as I think I am, there's me as you think I am, and there's me as I really am. The same applies to you. How we communicate is a problem, and it just shows how we have these self-images which don't live up to the way other people see us. They see us from their vantage point; they put a twist on us. Seeing ourselves as we really are would cut through a lot of this stuff that comes up—through honesty.

I can only hope my words have been of some assistance. May you be liberated from all suffering sooner rather than later.

26 More Reflections

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 32 min

Originally given as *26 More Reflections* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this concluding talk of his reflections series, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines profound community insights on truth, interdependence, and sympathetic joy. He begins by addressing the critical importance of truthfulness in our 'post-truth' world, discussing how dishonesty affects personal relationships, corporate ethics, and political life. Drawing from monastic discipline, he explains how lying about spiritual attainments constitutes a pārājika offense—grounds for expulsion from the Saṅgha.

The discussion moves to our fundamental interdependence with all beings, from humans to insects, emphasizing how harming others ultimately harms ourselves. Bhante explores the challenging practice of sympathetic joy (muditā)—one of the four brahmavihāras—noting how rejoicing in others' success can be more difficult than feeling compassion for those who suffer. He addresses the three forms of conceit (māna) and how gratitude supports the development of joy.

The talk concludes with a beautiful reflection on how all the pāramīs interconnect, allowing each perfection to become an entry point for developing others. Using the classic simile of blind men describing an elephant, Bhante illustrates how our limited perspectives can come together to reveal fuller understanding. He emphasizes that developing the perfections and reducing the āsavas (taints) can happen simultaneously, with unwholesome energies being sublimated into wholesome states.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble, and fully self-awakened one.

I find it difficult to choose one topic above others. Ideally, I would go for one that involves keeping the precepts. If that's too wide, I'll allow myself to be influenced by our post-truth world and identify the value of Truth—Truth with a capit-

al T. Truth in personal relationships and interpersonal transactions, truth in the corporate world and the world of work, truth in politics (don't laugh), and the spiritual truths we seek, the truths of the Dharma.

Yes, not to lie. It's in right speech, of course. Not telling the truth also includes things like calumny—talking badly about people. It includes abusive language and, of course, just talking for talking's sake. But the main thing is truthfulness.

We live in a post-truth world. It's been shocking, really, when you think about it, how politicians like Trump and our own blessed Boris get away with the most astounding lies. Nobody pulls them up. You can't take them to court. Politicians seem to be above the law. You can actually go on a website called Boris Johnson Lies, where a journalist has listed all the lies, all supported by research. It's extraordinary. It's not that we ever thought politicians told the truth—well, we never thought they told the whole truth. As Winston Churchill said, a lie is to be economical with the truth, so you only tell half of it. But some of the stuff we hear from Boris and Trump and others is just completely untrue, and nobody pulls them up about it. It's just extraordinary.

On a personal level, being truthful in our relationships and interpersonal dealings matters deeply. You could say that our relationships are based on that honesty—on being open, not hiding things from each other, not exaggerating. Exaggeration is another way you can be dishonest. In the corporate world, of course, we have astounding examples: the cigarette companies, the tobacco companies, and all that false research, and the same with the oil companies and their research on climate change. It's awful, really, absolutely awful. And we talk about transparency, yet governments are anything but transparent. So that's just the way it is.

Somehow we have to keep working to ask for the truth. We're very fortunate in this country that we have a free press. As you know, what happened in China when somebody was being truthful about coronavirus—they were definitely pulled up by the police for being subversive. So it's an awful state we're in.

Lying in the monastic rule is a very serious offence. If it's about your attainments—if you say that you're an Arahant or something, or you've been through all the jhānas, and it's a lie and you know it's a lie, and perhaps you've done it to get supporters—that's a *pārājika*. *Pārājika* means end of life; that's how a defeat is often termed, a defeat by which you have to leave the order. Interestingly enough, much in the same way as with our politicians, you can't make a monk leave the order. In certain organisations in certain countries, the force of the order can

make you leave, but they can't disrobe you. All they can do is not accept you in their monastery. So if somebody declares themselves to be an Arahant and has enough lay people who believe them, they can continue. There's not much can be done about it. It's an interesting little point about the order.

There were people who made that mistake in the Buddha's time. On one occasion—and I'm not absolutely clear whether it was a *pārājika*, one of these defeats—the Buddha wouldn't start the recitation of the *Pātimokkha*, the rule. You have to forgive me these little lapses; I've got the main story right. They sit all night, and finally the Buddha is asked why he isn't starting. He said there's somebody impure. Moggallāna, with his special abilities, could see who it was, got hold of him, and threw him out of the meeting. It's about the only bit of violence that seems to occur in the scriptures.

So truth is of course an absolute necessity. I've got here that wonderful moment when Trump's people came out with this brilliant phrase: alternative facts. I thought that was absolutely brilliant—alternative facts. And perhaps the hardest thing is to be truthful to ourselves. Sometimes we're not truthful to ourselves, not really open to our own defilements. I always remember being slightly shocked when I realised that I was jealous. I was jealous of somebody. It took me by surprise because I would have gone around saying, well, I'm not jealous of anybody. But in fact, on this particular occasion, I was. That pulled me up. So I keep a lookout for that sort of unwholesome mental state.

Jealousy is one of those things we don't obviously like to accept about ourselves because it diminishes us. As soon as you're jealous of somebody, you're saying that they're better than you. So yes, truth is something we could all ponder more on and demand—demand of our politicians especially. Very good.

We've had similar expressions of interdependence, of course. Thich Nhat Hanh's poem about "I am this, I am that"—some of you might know it—"I am the flower on the..." It's a bit romantic, but really it's a poetic way of saying that I am my relationships; that's what I am phenomenally. And as soon as I meet somebody, I become somebody else. As soon as I'm in nature, I become somebody else. We're always recreating ourselves within a given situation, within a given environment. If there's no environment there, it becomes a really unpleasant place.

I remember in earlier talks we discussed solitary confinement of prisoners and how it can really mess them up psychologically, because you need that feed. You need the feed from other people or else your mind just goes a bit bonkers. That is, unless you haven't got so many defilements. In the monk's life, you're not sup-

posed to go out on your own until you've reached the first path and fruit—meaning going into the jungles and the forest in those days—because of the danger of losing your mind.

I'm especially aware of the lack of insects. I remember driving from London to Manchester—my home, home of the brave—in the sixties and seventies, and you'd have to get out and wash your windscreen. The insects would be splattered all over it. These days you drive anywhere and there's hardly anything that hits the glass. I must say this year I've noticed more bees and such, but last year I hardly saw any. So what to do?

This is where interdependence becomes real: when we harm anything out there, we're actually harming ourselves. That's the thing, isn't it? That's the interconnectedness, the interdependency. And it's really beginning to understand that, getting to a position where you try to do as little harm as possible—definitely as little harm intentionally as possible.

I laid out these questions as they came in rather than grouping them by topic, but these two arrived one after the other, so clearly they share the same sentiment. There's an awareness I think we've all developed these days: our dependence upon other species, upon other beings—especially, as I say, these insects upon which we so depend for our food.

Here's another response to my request for thoughts: 'What I found most rewarding and liberating is rejoicing in other people's happiness and success. I find it trickier than feeling compassion for those struggling. It's so much easier to be a bigger person, to find love for someone in need. But the joy that comes from truly feeling happy for someone who is already in a good place, and finding the generosity to wish them even more happiness—this has been a lovely, uplifting revelation for me from our evening sittings. Not an easy one, though.'

It's not an easy one. Rejoicing in other people's success isn't something we particularly practise, is it? We do it on birthdays, of course, and special days like marriages and births. But we don't go around rejoicing in people so much. And it's another level of connection. You have love and care; you have compassion when people are not in a good place. And then there's this sense of rejoicing in people's success, in people's abilities.

Recognising people's abilities and rejoicing in them lifts the heart tremendously. And you have to do it to yourself too—rejoice in your own qualities, in your own success. This lifts us. If we don't, the tendency is always to think negatively, to

think how it could have been. The glass is always half empty; it's not half full. Joy balances out those more negative feelings we have towards ourselves, because most of us never feel good enough. We're always lacking something. It could have been better. It's to do with comparison, and comparison is a form of conceit.

There are three conceits, you know. First: I'm better than you—that makes me feel good. Second: I'm worse than you—that doesn't make me feel very good, but there's an inverted pride in it. I can take comfort there; I can excuse my failures because I'm not as good as you. And then there's a more subtle one: we are equal. At first you might think, oh well, that's egalitarian, that's perfectly all right. But when you look into it, when you say we're equal, what you're really saying is that you and I are part of this group who are equal—but actually we're superior or inferior to others. So it's a communal conceit.

Rejoicing undermines that near enemy of envy and jealousy, so yes, it's a lovely thing to practise. And what actually supports it is gratitude, thankfulness. When we develop a certain level of gratitude, we're much more open to the qualities people have and to the things they've achieved. Sympathetic joy—it is one of the four Brahmaviharas, one of the four dwelling places of Brahma.

What the Buddha is saying is that this is one of the greatest mental states we can develop. And I have to say, it's not often taught. I don't remember doing any specific training in all my years of practice. I mean, it was there, of course—one is happy. But there was no specific training at any time in my spiritual practice, in Buddhism, to do with joy. I have put you on to that book, by the way—I mentioned it before—*Awakening Joy* by James Baraz. Very good.

Today I had an email which nicely sums up everything for me, so I've not had to think about how to draw these questions to a conclusion. The writer says: 'I've been enjoying the exploration of values over the last few days. It is fascinating to see how the different perfections all link up, so that each one of them can become an entry point to developing all of them. That works nicely with the diversity of humanity.'

The email continues: 'My initial response to your question—which value would be most fundamental—was humility. It's not one of the pāramis, the ten perfections. On reflection, I see it as related to generosity. Both imply that my own needs and opinions are not of more value than those of others around me or far away, and allow for the possibility that my own views may be limited—that another person may be as blind as I am, their view as limited as mine, holding a different part of the same elephant and describing the whole beast from their own perspective.'

'If enough of us could come together to share our limited perspectives openly and without clinging, then between us a fuller picture of reality might emerge—and hopefully lead to better collective and individual actions in the world. I can now see that it also links up with renunciation, in particular of ego-driven views. The *pāramis* are an area I have so far not greatly looked at, partly believing it was necessary to get rid of the taints before they can develop. If I understood you rightly last night, both processes can actually happen in parallel. That's great and encouraging to hear. Of course, thinking about it, the two are like positive and negative images. By developing the perfections, I can start reducing the taints—and vice versa.'

Humility isn't one of the *pāramī*, the perfections. On reflection, I see it as related to generosity. Both imply that my own needs and opinions are not of more value than those of others around me or far away. Both allow for the possibility that my own views may be limited—that another person may be as blind as I am, their view as limited as mine, holding a different part of the same elephant and describing the whole beast from their own perspective.

If enough of us can come together to share our limited perspectives openly and without clinging, then between us a fuller picture of reality will emerge—and hopefully lead to better collective and individual actions in the world. I can see now that it all links up with renunciation, in particular of ego-driven views. The *pāramī* is an area I've so far not greatly looked at, partly believing it was necessary to get rid of the taints before they can develop. But as I understood you last night, both processes can actually happen in parallel. That's great and encouraging to hear. Of course, thinking about it, the two are like positive and negative images. By developing the perfections, I can start reducing the taints—and vice versa.

That's a lovely conclusion for us—a really good point that manifests our diversity, all these different views, but also our fundamental unity, which he later points out. This image of the elephant is an old Indian simile about blind men feeling an elephant and then saying it's a brush (the tail) or a stump of a tree (the leg), completely misunderstanding the elephant as a whole. That's what happens when we cling to a view or an opinion and think we've got it all. It's a case of seeing our views and opinions, as he said, as a perspective.

This business of working with the taints when they come up, but also developing the *pāramī*—yes, indeed, that's what we're instructed to do. And remember that the energy, the malevolent energy, the turbulence that comes with

the defilements—that energy is not lost. It is transformed. In fact, the word I prefer is sublimated. It moves directly from the unwholesome state into the wholesome, and sometimes you might actually experience that.

I remember having a hard time with my teacher once. I was doing a personal retreat, working with this really deep disappointment I had in him, and it came up with a lot of aversion. Being a very good meditator at that time, I just stayed with the feeling, stayed with the feeling. And to my honest surprise, it turned right in front of me into this really warm, compassionate feeling for him. That manifested for me that these energies just turn—they evaporate and become something else. So you can work on both.

On that last line about hopefully leading to better collective and individual actions in the world—I was told a story by Nori. She was in Bulgaria, and somebody told her that he was in Sofia, the capital, and just noticed that lots of people were walking towards the centre. So he joined in. A whole crowd began to develop in the central square.

Then one man got up and began to talk about all the people—relatives, friends—who'd gone missing in the communist era. More and more people got up to talk about their grievances. The government building behind them was full of lights, it seems. And eventually, when everything had been spoken, everybody turned and looked into the building, and all the lights started to go out. There's a presumption that they were all escaping. From that moment onwards, it seems the communist government began to give in.

Of course, that was all around '89 when the wall collapsed. Looking back at that time, what a peaceful revolution that was, generally speaking, compared to the earlier times when there were uprisings in Hungary—'56, I think—which were brutally suppressed.

So the whole purpose of us really considering these different qualities is to begin to see how they can manifest through our economics and our social life, even personally and individually. It might make us much more aware of what we're buying, what we're eating, how we talk to others, how we actually begin to persuade others—especially those we meet who have opposite views and opinions—perhaps to get them to open up to our views and for us to understand theirs.

We've been through this whole Brexit thing where it was very difficult for some people who were for staying to understand that anybody could want to leave. There was all this thing about them being a bit thick—they didn't understand. And of course, one of the fundamental reasons people wanted to leave was that they just weren't benefiting. They saw nothing but their own poverty, and the immigration had made them feel a loss—this is the white English people and the Welsh—had made them feel their sense of community was being undermined.

Anyway, that's what we have to do. We have to keep these values, these virtues in our minds, and whenever the opportunity comes to say what's necessary, to be open about it, not to be afraid. And hopefully we shall move towards a very wonderful and enlightened society in no length of time. We can hope.

So with those wonderful words, let us now begin our practice.

Right Livelihood

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 1h00

Originally given as *Right Livelihood* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this Dharma talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines sammā ājīva (Right Livelihood) within the context of the Noble Eightfold Path and the Four Noble Truths. He begins by outlining what constitutes unwholesome livelihood - trades that cause harm to others, including dealing in weapons, living beings, intoxicants, and poison. Moving beyond these obvious prohibitions, he explores the more subtle aspects of motivation in our work lives, examining how the pursuit of wealth, power, and fame can distort our professional activities.

The talk emphasizes that Right Livelihood isn't simply about avoiding harmful occupations, but about transforming any honest work into a spiritual practice. Drawing on examples like the wealthy merchant Anāthapiṇḍika, who generously supported the Buddha's community, Bhante shows how entrepreneurship and business can be expressions of service when approached with the right attitude. He discusses practical strategies for bringing mindfulness and compassion into the workplace, whether dealing with difficult colleagues or performing repetitive tasks.

A central theme is viewing our work as a training ground for developing the brahmavihāras (divine abidings) - loving-kindness, compassion, sympathetic joy, and equanimity. Bhante offers concrete guidance on starting each workday with meditation and loving-kindness, maintaining awareness throughout daily tasks, and using evening reflection to learn from our experiences. This approach transforms ordinary work life into a path toward awakening, making the workplace as spiritually valuable as formal meditation retreat.

When the Buddha formulated his teaching, it didn't come immediately. It was something that grew as he taught. He ended up with the Eightfold Path, which forms part of the Four Noble Truths.

The First Noble Truth simply states that there is dukkha. Dukkha translates as 'a hard place' — we're in a hard place, that's what it means. The Buddha defined this in three ways: there's the constant state of change, the ordinary suffering we get through unfulfilled desires and so on, and then there's that more subtle suffering of knowing that the self is not real.

There's an underlying feeling about life, I think, because of death — because it's not steady, because it's always there in the background. The sense of self doesn't have a ground, and that causes a deep anxiety within us. Indeed, you can say that all anxiety and all fear is the fear of death, the fear of disappearance.

The Buddha then goes on to be more specific, saying that the cause of suffering is this desire. He simply points to it as a kernel psychological position that we have: seeking happiness in things that are simply not going to deliver, that's all. You wouldn't invest in a stock that everybody told you would fail. Life will fail us — we're going to die. And yet there we are, investing everything in it.

That desire is a psychological point, and from there he goes on to give us the wheel of dependent origination — a template of all sentient beings, that's what he says, not just human beings — which is definitely common to all of us. It shows how we cause suffering for ourselves. That's the basic psychology he's into. It's not developmental psychology. There's a little bit about the psychology of perception, but he's very clear, one-pointed, always centring on this problem of dukkha. The whole psychology is centred on that. And in the Second Noble Truth, he pinpoints where the problem lies, psychologically.

The Third Noble Truth, of course, states quite categorically that there is an end to dukkha. He doesn't use the word nibbāna, you see — nibbāna appears in other texts. But in terms of the formulation of the Four Noble Truths, the Third Noble Truth is simply this: there is an end to dukkha, dukkha nirodha. And then finally he states the path leading out of it.

The formulation of the Four Noble Truths follows the way that doctors wrote their prescriptions, or at least worked with an illness. First the illness was diagnosed — like dukkha — and then the cause was discovered. Next came the prognosis, which in this case is perfect health and happiness. Not health — perfect happiness. And the fourth was the actual medicine to be used.

The medicine we're using is the Eightfold Noble Path. We begin, through this practice of meditation, with trying to correct *sammā diṭṭhi*, right understanding — to see the world in a correct way. When we do that, it has a systemic change. That doesn't mean we can't work on the other parts of the path as well.

The second part is getting the attitude right, getting the right attitude to things. Today, for instance, we've been trying to develop a much clearer attitude around food. Why are we eating? You sit there and say, no, the pleasure is secondary. It comes up, but I'm not eating for that purpose. I'm eating specifically for nourishment of the body.

Having got the intelligence right and the heart right — the mind and the heart — there is that natural flow into action. So it's through speech, through action, right action, and then right livelihood. Interestingly enough, there's really no need logically to put right livelihood in there, because it's included in right action. Livelihood is an action. But the Buddha obviously felt it to be so important as to have its own particular category.

There's an interesting passage which relates to this. Ānanda, who was the Buddha's companion for the last twenty-odd years of his life, comes to one of these conclusions where he seems to always get it wrong. One of these conclusions was that good companionship was half the spiritual life. And the Buddha says, oh no, Ānanda, it's the whole of the spiritual life.

That's how important our companions are — the people we mix with — because of course they affect us. We're in constant conversation with them. We relate to people who are close to us, who work with us. So the Buddha states right livelihood as a section on its own. It's worth thinking about it a little bit, reflecting on it, and seeing what pointers we can get.

The fact is that livelihood takes up so much of our life that it obviously has to become a vehicle through which we can practise and, hopefully, liberate ourselves.

We can quickly dismiss all those things that are not right livelihood — anything that brings harm to other people. Trading in arms, in living beings, intoxicating drinks, poison; slaughtering, fishing, soldiering, deceit, treachery, soothsaying, trickery, usury, and so on. There's a whole load of things that would not be considered skilful because they are inherently doing other people harm.

Remember that all ethics, the whole of the ethical life in the Buddhist teaching, simply comes down to harm. To do harm to somebody else in any way is considered unwholesome. Any job that you can see is actually doing harm to another person — or we can extend it these days to the planet — may give you cause for concern.

Just on that note, if one finds oneself in a job that raises ethical problems, you have to be kind to yourself. You can't just drop it there and then. But simply by deciding that you don't want to do this job anymore and inclining towards another, you'll slowly find your way out of it. There are other conditions to be taken into consideration, generally speaking.

For instance, I know somebody who was in the beer trade, selling beer for a company. Once he came into the Dharma, he had this problem about selling beer. I never quite got a straight answer from him as to how he finally rationalised himself into keeping the job. But the fact was that he wanted to know what I felt. I said, well, if I really felt strongly about that, I would move towards another job of some sort — but I'd have to take into consideration the effects on my family. I don't want to take a hard position on something and then find myself redundant and putting huge pressure on them.

I know somebody else who was in the police and had similar problems. He really didn't like the way the police worked — he had a lot of ethical problems about how the force operates. He wanted to move, and he was interested in some sort of therapy, I remember. But he took the road of trying to get funding for it, and eventually he couldn't. So he simply found a corner within the police force where he felt at least he wasn't joining in those parts he considered unethical. He ended up in special branch, looking after politicians. Yeah, that's an ethical problem. Don't be too cynical, you understand.

Leaving all that aside, we can also delineate those motivations which aren't as bad as selling human beings and that sort of stuff, but are still unwholesome, still unskilful. And here we come to this whole area of — we've got this word now, haven't we — the celebs. So who are these, what is a celebrity? It's somebody who's made it either with riches, power, or fame, isn't it? They've done something that makes them well-known in their own field.

Now, you can understand that if getting rich, getting power, or simply becoming famous is the aim of your life, then it puts a twist on the job you're doing. It puts a twist on the job.

I know we have downers on people who've made a lot of money out of their business — poor old Bill Gates comes in for a hammering. But the interview I saw, his interest wasn't so much in making money; it began with a real interest in the whole idea of computers and what computers could do. Then, of course, it's very successful and you build an empire. And then you're into defence and you're up against Sony and people like that. And the whole thing becomes slightly twisted.

So again, it's to do with attitude. It's not about not getting money. The Buddha, again, is quite clear: it's not how much you earn that's important, it's how you earn it. The amount you get is neither here nor there. And then, of course, what you do with the amount — what do you do with the money you have? If it's done for the benefit of others, then obviously it's a very wholesome thing.

So the Buddha is definitely into entrepreneurship, and I'm sure he'd be a supporter of some form of capitalism if he was here. I hope nobody's going to shoot me.

If you look at somebody like Anāthapiṇḍika, he was one of the Buddha's great supporters. Anāthapiṇḍika was a merchant who made a lot of money and bought grounds for a monastery. In fact, so the tale goes, he wanted to buy this park from Prince Jeta, and the prince didn't want to sell it at all. So the prince said he would only sell if it was completely covered with gold coins. Anāthapiṇḍika, wanting to make this gift to the Buddha, completely covered it with gold coins and got it from Prince Jeta. It's known as the Jetavana Monastery. And obviously the Buddha liked being there. It was a nice place.

Anāthapiṇḍika then, it seems, loses all his money. Yet even in abject poverty, he never comes to the monastery without something. At one point he arrives with just soil in his hands — good soil he's picked up from his own garden — and spreads it onto the monastery grounds. Later, it seems, he does become rich again, and the story goes he dies as a sotāpanna, one of the noble ones, one who has intuited nibbāna. So there's hope for us all, I think — even hope for the rich.

From the Buddha's point of view, there's nothing actually wrong with being rich. And of course the same goes for power. People who use power for purely selfish reasons — well, we've got plenty of examples of those these days. It's one of the big problems in Africa, isn't it? Really bad governance where people just screw their own people for all sorts of things.

But when you get somebody who holds power for the benefit of the society they're in, that's obviously not something to be seen as unskillful or unwholesome. Somebody has to make decisions. Even in a small workplace, somebody has to make decisions, and whoever makes decisions has the power. So again, power is not in itself unskillful or unwholesome — it's how we use it.

Just as an aside: in our lives, especially at work, we all have what you might call a ring of power — things we can actually do, things we can affect. Then there's another ring, which is about influence — we can influence people to do things. And then, of course, it stops. A lot of our problems arise because we don't recognise where the end of that ring is.

When we try to exercise more power than we have, we tend to become frustrated. And if we find ourselves not using our power but being overridden by others who are less powerful than us, then we feel we've let people down, that we've not lived up to our responsibility — because with power comes that responsibility.

It's the same with influence. Whatever influence we have, we should use for the benefit of others. But when we see that our influence isn't working, we have to be very careful to accept that boundary. If we don't, we start feeling frustrated and all sorts of stuff.

People who are caught up in work with a lot of emotional value attached — ecological issues, political issues — if they don't accept where their boundary of power and influence lies, they just get burnout. And that doesn't help anybody at all.

And then fame. Fame is probably the shallowest of them all, really. But as you know, famous people — film stars, football stars, and whatnot — can use it for the benefit of others. A very good example is Bob Geldof, isn't it? After all, he's only a musician. And yet he's able to motivate people.

Anything we have, even within our small area of influence, which is done for the benefit of others, is thereby wholesome. But if one becomes famous and gets a very big head, it just becomes a headache in the end, doesn't it?

All these things, of course, when they're taken from you, cause misery — a lot of misery. I always remember the case of a very young immigrant to Australia, an East European — I can't remember his name now — who in a very short time built up this huge property empire. When property dropped, I think it was in the eighties or nineties, he committed suicide.

You can see how we make this mistake of actually identifying with the power we have, no matter how little, and with the riches, and the fame. That's one of the big problems with being made redundant, isn't it? Sure, it's a catastrophe in the sense that your wage can go, your sense of work can go, all that sort of stuff.

But what makes it despairing is the relationship the person had with the job. You lose your sense of identity because unwittingly you define yourself by the work you do, don't you? Whether you like it or not. If anybody asks, what are you? What do you do? You don't say, well, I clean the toilet at home. You say, I teach. You don't say, I cook a meal every so often. Even our most basic questions point to what we do in society.

From what we do in society, we tend to build up our self-esteem, our self-importance — all those sorts of areas. And of course our basic wealth. So when these are taken from us in an act of redundancy, that's when you hit despair, because you have to redefine yourself. And the definition of being unemployed isn't a particularly happy one in our society.

So it's really just being aware of that. If things happen to us which take away our wealth and power and good name — fame doesn't here just mean famous in the sense of pop stars, it just means your good name, which somebody can take away — then you have to watch that, watch your reaction to it, and recognise that the suffering you're getting from it is the measure of your attachment to the wealth you had, the power you had, the good name you had.

And in that way, you don't justify it. This is the problem with negative emotions: we actually justify them. We say we ought to be angry, we ought to be depressed, we ought to be fearful. As soon as you do that, you empower these states.

When we look at various jobs, most people can find some sort of compassionate angle to what they do. It's easy in areas of service — health workers, the teaching profession, doctors, and even the police, for heaven's sake. All that sort of area is, I would have thought, fairly easy to develop a right attitude, to see the job as something being done for others, a sense of service.

When it comes to other jobs such as entrepreneurship and business work, you often get a bit of a downer on that — making money, setting up a business. But actually, it's another service, isn't it? Depending on your attitude, depending on the purpose of what you're doing, it can be tremendously worthwhile, tremendously wholesome.

Now when it comes to those jobs where at one point we used to use the word 'workers' — now it's more politically correct to talk about 'operatives' — when you're a machine operative doing something very repetitive, very monotonous, you can still engender that sense of service. Somebody has to do the job; that's a bit of a negative way of looking at it, but in the sense that whatever the product is, so long as it's a wholesome product, a good product, then this is what society has offered you at this particular point, and one does what one can within that situation.

There are some jobs which, shall we say, are more directly effective upon the heart. To work with the sick, with the dying — especially working with people — has an immediate effect, with right attitude, of extending the heart, of making it grow in those areas we call the illimitables, because they can be developed indefinitely. Love, compassion, sympathetic joy, care — all those lovely attitudes can be developed.

But when you get into a job where you're working with a machine, say in an office or in a factory, it's difficult to have the same value of compassion towards a machine. There is, however, an opportunity to see it as a meditative exercise.

I often think about people these days, but even more so in earlier times in our society, where so many people had very repetitive jobs doing the same thing. And of course that's all we're doing in meditation, isn't it? Rising, falling. You couldn't get more repetitive than watching the breath. If you were to take that same attitude to a repetitive job, no matter what you're doing — using it to establish this constant mindfulness — then you can see it would definitely have a strong spiritual impact.

I remember when I was a kid, sixteen or seventeen, I used to get a job after school. One job I had was in this bakery, this cake factory. There was a line of women who followed the process from when the dough arrived or whatever, when they baked. The cakes swung round this little machine and things were added on as they came round. I was given the job of adding the cherry on top — the last point. As each cake swung round, I had to get this cherry and stick it on.

Well, occasionally I'd miss, or it wasn't centred, and I'd go after it and try and put it right... Eventually they shifted me. I was absolutely useless. Even though I protested that I was school captain, dexterous of my feet, and if they'd just give me time, I could actually do this job! I remember these lovely, kindly, simpering looks from the women — oh, he's only a boy, and all that sort of stuff.

But the thing is, just being able to accept one's position there and use it as a concentration exercise — you can see that even something so repetitive can be turned to spiritual advantage.

So you might think, well, how would you profile a good day? A good day at work? How would you set your mind to take as much spiritual advantage out of your work as you can?

The first thing, of course, is to get up and do your two-hour meditation. After that, develop a bit of loving-kindness. In that loving-kindness, actually bring to mind the people you work with, bring the place to mind, bring everybody associated with it to mind. What you're doing is establishing a right relationship. Right attitude is right relationship.

And if there's somebody you're having problems with, at least offer an attitude of no harm, and occasionally just think of their brighter side. In a sense, you're setting yourself right with the people you have to work with.

Now, if you get out of bed in the morning and there's just this huge desire to take a day off, stay with that. Don't be hijacked by it, no matter how much you can justify it for all sorts of reasons. Let that feeling, that down feeling, just evaporate a little bit, and then make the commitment to give your best to the job in hand.

By doing that, the heart will lift. The heart won't lift unless you make a decision. Once you make a decision to do something, the heart will follow.

For instance, if you've got a job at work and you want to do it, but there's a negativity towards it—now it's the same in meditation. If you suppress it, it remains there as a rumbling within the psyche. But if you accept that there's a negativity towards the job, and you're just there with it, and you can distance from it with this wonderful noting technique—it's there, you know it's there—and then you override it with right attitude, that lifts the heart.

A slightly parallel situation is when you might feel angry towards a colleague or a workmate. These days, especially through certain therapies—not all of them—you get these things about owning your emotion. Now that's all right; it's just that people confuse owning with actually being.

It's all right to say there is anger arising with this person. But as soon as you say, "I am angry with this person," then of course you have to be "authentic," and you have to tell the person that you're angry with them. Now, how do you feel when somebody comes up and says, "I'm angry with you"? What's your response to that?

While I was at Gaia House, I had a manager who was forever coming to see me and would sit there and say, "I've got problems with you." What am I supposed to say? I'd say, "Oh, what can I do about that?" And she was being authentic. She was being truthful. And of course, the presumption is that I am the cause of her dissatisfaction. When you go to work and say, "Look, I'm very angry with you," what you're really saying is, "You are the cause of my anger. What are you going to do about it?"

So it's recognising that all those negative states are arising out of me because of some wrong attitude. Now we know from our meditation that we can't sink them, we can't push them away or try to bury them, but we can, as it were, shift them to the side. This is being skilful.

It's not me, it's not "I am angry"—there is anger, and I'll deal with you when the opportunity occurs. It's not a case of pushing it away and suppressing it; it's simply putting it to the side, dealing with it at an appropriate time. And then one raises the attitude of kindness—kindly words, a smile. You find your heart lifts towards that attitude and supports you.

But again, it would be a mistake to think that therefore I am kind. It's just that there is now kindness, and this is the relationship I'm engendering towards this particular person.

So getting the attitude right every morning is important. When it comes to the work itself, re-establish why you're doing it, and give it an attitude that's worthwhile and meaningful spiritually. You can do that. Apart from those dreadful jobs that some people do, most of the time you can find a worthwhile reason for the work.

Then you go into the workplace, sit at your place or take up your position, and just stop for a minute. Re-establish—constantly re-establish—that sense of mindfulness and right attitude. Then give yourself to the work.

Now, it's a case of being loose in that situation and recognising that you're in relationship with other people—if you're working with other people, that is. It's much the same as our meditation. When you're sitting here meditating, you've got

this desire to investigate what's going on inside, but if somebody comes in and starts talking and draws your attention, and you see that as a disturbance, you're immediately in conflict. You're immediately raising all those dreadful states that here we're supposed to be letting go of.

It's the same at work. You're doing your work and a colleague comes over, all flustered or whatever. You can say little things like, "Just one minute, just one minute," so you know where you are—and then you respond.

Remember that when somebody comes to you with fluster, with anger and whatnot, put your concentration on what they're saying, not how they're saying it. If you focus on how they're saying it, it's very difficult to stop that immediate reaction of anger towards anger, anger towards their dumping their anxiety on us. But so long as your attention is on what they're saying, you can guard yourself from that sort of immediate reaction.

Just on that point too: when you're with somebody coming at you in that sort of way, one thing you can do—if you're quick enough—is image the Buddha hand. Remember this? There's a statue called the Abhaya posture, the fearlessness.

This goes back to when the dastardly Devadatta tried to kill the Buddha—three times, I can say. The third time was with this dreadful elephant, Nalagiri, the raging bull elephant, whom he set loose. Nalagiri paced down upon the Buddha. And the Buddha stood there, held up his hand in a sort of fearless posture, and blasted the elephant with compassion. The elephant, of course, immediately stopped and adored the Buddha.

Now, whether we believe the fullness of that story, the fact of the matter is that it tells us how to deal with situations where negativity is coming towards us. It's a case of protecting ourselves. You don't have to receive somebody's anger. You don't have to accept it. You don't have to take it in. You don't have to empower it by actually reacting to it. This is what we do, isn't it? You empower anger when you react to it.

So by doing that, you protect your own heart. But from behind the hand, at least you're offering an attitude of no harm. And I personally find that much easier if I'm actually listening to what they're saying rather than how they're saying it.

In my job, of course, I occasionally get very strange people. I was running—nobody here, nobody here at all—a Christmas retreat at Sharpham House, which is a very beautiful place, by the way. Lovely place to have a Christmas retreat.

Because of some mistake on the calendar, one advert said Wednesday and another said Tuesday. So this elderly lady came who had seen it was Wednesday. When she arrived and realised she was late and it was all... she got very, very, very angry and flustered about it.

I was working with a very good manager who'd been at Gaia House. She went out of her way—gave the lady back a day's money, tried to make her feel at home, showed her around, and so on. But when we met, she was still very, very angry about it all. So a huge heart of compassion embraced this elderly lady, to make her feel at home. And we explained everything.

The next day—she had arrived in the evening—I spent some time with her and showed her around the house. She was still very angry. And once she realised this wasn't the retreat she wanted—she wanted something hard, like Zen—and the one I was leading was more reflective, more contemplative, just spending time in quiet reflection, she was angry about that too.

So I was still keeping my hand up, beaming out an amazing amount of compassion and all that sort of stuff. Then, of course, on Christmas Day we broke the silence and had cake. Everybody got fairly loud in conversation without putting off other people. And she was sitting there by the side.

Earlier I'd seen her chatting quite well and openly with these other people. So I just went over and said, 'Oh, how is everything?' And off she went, moaning and groaning. Well, I said, 'Oh, for heaven's sake. You've been giving them nothing but...' And there I'd lost my guard. I'd chewed into it.

Well, of course, she didn't moan again—not in front of me, anyway. Unfortunately, we were leaving about the next day, so we didn't have the opportunity to really make it up. But I doubt I'll be seeing her again.

So now, what did I do? Well, frankly, I found it rather funny. But the last thing I tend to do is get into this big self-judgement of, 'For God's sake, you're supposed to be a monk, you're not supposed to lose your temper.' I just accept that there was a failure there. One records it. One says, 'Ah, right.' You've got to be on your toes, because you never know where somebody's at.

This whole business of working with people who, remember, like ourselves, are going through various ranges of emotion within one day. Just think: if you were to log the mental states that arise from the time you get up to the time you fall asleep—it's madness, isn't it? You're happy, you're sad, you're depressed, you're angry,

you're fed up, you're bored. It's constant. And every so often there's a little blip of peace. 'Oh, God, relaxation. I'm happy. I'm happy.' You tell the world and suddenly—oh, angry again.

Our emotions sort of hold us hostage, the skeleton of our emotional life. And when you actually catch that that's how I am—and I expect other people to be compassionate and kind towards me, not to get angry, to understand me and give me a hug every so often—it asks us to behave in the same way towards other people.

So that whole business of interrelationship at work, especially where there's difficulty with colleagues—these for us are real points of growth. 'Another bloody opportunity for growth,' as somebody said. To look upon things positively. To see these other people who are absolutely awful as our teachers—that's the attitude we ought to have.

Then of course there's that constant effort to bring us back into the present moment. Some of you might know Thich Nhat Hanh and Plum Village. One of the little techniques they use there is to have somebody randomly ring a bell every so often. When the bell goes, you have to stop. Whatever you're doing, you just stop. Then you wait for the third bell, and you can carry on. They even do that with telephones.

Now, most of us work around telephones or have a telephone at home. Normally, when a telephone goes, we launch ourselves towards it. But ask yourself: most people will hang on for three or four rings. It's a case of acknowledging it.

If you're doing a piece of work, it's very confusing—at least for males—to have to do two or three things at once. It's a case of seeing where you are, acknowledging the phone call, and then just that moment of clarification, of clearing the mind, stopping—so that when you answer the phone you've actually given yourself to the whole call. Half the mind isn't still doing your work, half the mind isn't still over there; you're actually dedicating this time to the phone call.

And then of course when you put the phone down, the same thing: that moment of reflection as to what has passed, anything that needs to be done from that call, whatever. Then a return back to the work you're doing, a moment of stopping, a recognition. Because you've left it mindfully, it's so much easier to remember where you were at, and off you go.

By doing this, you stop the rollercoaster—the way emotions gather during the day like a storm. Even simple occasions where someone said something that upset you a little bit. You've all been through this: there's been that little irritation, but you've palmed it aside. 'It's just the way they are.' But it's not being dealt with. It's a little suppression.

Then just when the mind relaxes and you're having a cup of tea—'How dare you!'—all that sort of stuff, and you get into telling them exactly what you feel. It builds up, and by evening you're hanging them and ripping them apart, and then you have to take an aspirin.

So it's a case of watching that, being very clear as to when it happens, and actually stopping. That's where this meditation we're doing has an immediate role to play in everyday life. Because that's what we're learning: as soon as I feel any sense of irritation, immediately that alarm bell goes and I'm with it. I don't join it, I don't get into it. There is irritation, or there's anxiety. As soon as it's there, the alarm bell should go and I should be awake to it. It only takes a second.

So if we take the workplace as a place to train spiritually, you can see it's got massive potential.

When you finish work and come home, that evening meditation really is very important—that's the point where you allow the day to come up. At the end of each sitting I ask people to reflect. So what are we reflecting on? We're reflecting upon how skilful we've been through the past three-quarters of an hour, an hour. By bringing that reflection up and thinking about it, we can see where we've gone wrong. Then we talk to ourselves in a way that's going to guide us in the proper direction in our meditation.

It's exactly the same in daily life and at work. You come back in the evening and look back and think, 'Oh, I did this and I did that and I shouldn't have done this and I shouldn't have done that.' Then you reflect upon it, make a little determination—a very firm determination—that when a similar occasion arises, you'll be right there on the ball.

Now, on the other side, remember, you have to balance that with congratulating yourself. If you're always concerned about the negative, you never get the joy of having succeeded, of having been successful in some spiritual training. So when you look back on the day and you've had a difficult situation and you know you've handled it fairly well, then you ought to say, well, that was good. A little pat on the head, things like that. A cake. Give yourself a cake.

These are the times we ought to give ourselves little fillips. You shouldn't eat cake just because you want to eat a cake. You should eat cake to celebrate. Now, if you think about only eating cake to celebrate, by the end of the day you've always found something to celebrate. There's no problem with that at all.

It's a case of getting our attitude right and trying to balance the books. Over a period of time, a real balance comes to your life, a sense of purpose, meaningfulness. And that's really what we want, isn't it? Meaningfulness. Something that's meaningful.

Paradoxically, we get most meaning when we do things for others. Compassion, love, sympathetic joy. When you actually do things for others, there's a natural comeback in the heart of feeling joyful. You're joyful for somebody else's joy. You're joyful that you've been able to help somebody in distress. And you're joyful with friendship. That's a natural thing.

That doesn't mean you can't do it for yourself, but you do it for yourself for the right reasons. When we have those beautiful states through doing things for others, that's what Buddhism means by puñña. Puñña means merit.

It becomes vulgarised when you think of merit as some sort of piggy bank—and when you die, you go to heaven because you've been so good. That may very well be true. There are karmic consequences through time which have their original cause in the past.

But when we do something wholesome and good, the feeling of joy we get, the contentment, the sense of well-being — that is our puñña. That's the merit we have.

You can see now the connection between the process of awakening and the process of good conduct. You can't have one without the other. They come in tandem.

Now, it's true we can devote our lives to pure meditation. We can become a hermit and sit in a cave — and surely that's one way. That's the Buddha's way, yeah?

There's a lovely bit in the scriptures where some monks go to various senior monks and ask them: what's the path? What's the path to awakening? And they split into two main types. There's one led by the great Venerable Kassapa, a big forest monk, hard on the rules and the Vinaya. He says, look, you've got to keep the rules absolutely perfectly, and you've got to sit — meditate, meditate.

Then they go to the other side, which is more Sāriputta, and he says, no, you've got to understand the Dhamma, you've got to learn the Dhamma, and you've got to meditate. For that side, the rules don't take primacy.

After that they went to the Buddha and said, well, we asked these people and they said this. And the Buddha says, no, that's all well and good — everybody teaches you the way by which they themselves came. They said, well, what would you ask us to do? He says, oh, meditate, meditate, meditate. So it's pretty direct.

Sure, there are some human beings drawn to that path — the path of pure meditation. But for most of us, there is this path of action. That's the way most of us go, I would have thought.

So we've got to make that the path. We've got to make what we do the path to our own awakening. If we don't, we miss out on a chance. If we think we're only working spiritually when we come on a weekend retreat or when we're meditating morning and evening, then a whole chunk of our lives is wasted.

But when you actually turn to your work and see it as the vehicle — your major vehicle, because heavens, it's the best eight hours of your day going into work — then of course that's where your whole effort goes. You make sure that vehicle's working for you.

And that's the importance of Right Livelihood. It's right there on the path. Number five. Right Livelihood.

Once we understand that importance, we need to reflect upon it. Keeping a diary — a spiritual diary — can be very helpful, at least to set us off. At the end of the day you write up what you've done, what you've learned, and then your little *adhiṭṭhāna*, your little determination. In the morning, you repeat that determination.

When we come to see this, the split that a lot of people make between the monastic life and the lay life — it doesn't appertain. It doesn't appertain.

The only plus of monastic life, shall we say, is that your companions tend to be of the same ilk, the same interest — and they're actually supportive of your effort as you are of theirs. Generally speaking, anyway. It's not always true.

The problem with living in our society, which is all over the place spiritually, is that you often work with people whose intentions are quite the opposite of yours. In a more homogeneous society — say a Christian society in the Middle Ages, or

even right up to the eighteenth century before our own Enlightenment, or in present-day Muslim societies, which are probably the best examples — you have a whole society centred upon a particular vision, a particular understanding.

Given that good companionship is the whole of our livelihood, yes, there can be that draw of having to work with people who aren't specifically supporting the way you want to work. But if we look at this in a more positive way, rather than see it as a negative thing, we can make that work for us too — even working with people who are negative towards what we're trying to do.

I hope I've convinced you, without any shadow of a doubt, that the path to full awakening lies in the very work you're doing.

Right Livelihood

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 16 min

Originally given as *Right Livelihood* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this talk on sammā ājīva (Right Livelihood), Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the Buddha's traditional warnings about five types of harmful businesses while exploring a broader understanding of right livelihood as 'right lifestyle.' Drawing from the Upa-sakāsutta and teachings on spiritual friendship, he discusses how the Buddha advised against dealing in weapons, human trafficking, meat, intoxicants, and poisons, while acknowledging the complexities these guidelines present in modern contexts.

The talk expands beyond mere occupation to encompass how all our activities—work, leisure, relationships—can either support or hinder spiritual development. Bhante emphasizes the importance of centering our lives around the Dharma, creating balance in our activities, and cultivating the wholesome qualities that naturally emerge in ethical professions. He shares personal reflections on how meditation practice naturally transforms our interests and social connections, leading to a more integrated spiritual life.

This teaching offers practical guidance for practitioners seeking to align their daily activities with the Noble Eightfold Path, showing how right livelihood becomes a comprehensive approach to living that supports awakening in all aspects of life.

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammāsbuddhassa Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammāsbuddhassa Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammāsbuddhassa

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble, and fully self-awakened one.

We're celebrating the full moon of November, which falls in the middle of next week, but it's convenient for us to come together on a Sunday. The topic for this month is livelihood—right livelihood.

Let me go through the usual warnings the Buddha gives. First, he says we shouldn't engage in five types of business. They're pretty straightforward, actually. The business of weapons—selling them, making them. This does, of course, raise questions about the role of the soldier. In the Buddha's time, warfare was really about conquest. Kings were trying to expand their kingdoms at the expense of tribal democracies, and the Buddha was definitely for the democracies, I think. He didn't like the way kings were warring, often against each other. These days there's a call for defence, so it's a slightly different era. Perhaps we can't make these rules absolute, because it depends upon your take on violence and whether there is such a thing as justifiable armed intervention. But that's for somebody to write a book on.

Then he says nobody should be involved in the business of people. That means prostitution and modern-day slavery, which is absolutely awful—indentured workers, workers who've fallen into debt and are working for a pittance. We know this goes on anyway.

Then there's the whole business of meat. Monks aren't supposed to eat any meat if they've seen, heard, or suspected the animal has been killed for them specifically. I've always thought the Buddha was a crypto-vegan. But being a practical person, he wasn't going to make this a hard and fast rule—which, of course, the Jains did. You can't enter a Jain temple if you're wearing, say, a leather belt or leather shoes. They just won't let you in. They're absolutely severe. But the Buddha never really did that, especially for lay people. For them it was always rules of training. It was never "thou shalt." Rather: "I undertake the rule of training not to kill," et cetera.

Then there's the business of intoxicants. The West has this very refined intoxicating industry of wine and beer. I don't think there's another culture with quite the range of tastes, so it's a bit difficult for us to keep that one. But these days you see more and more of these non-alcoholic alternatives. I often wonder how a person feels who's taken this seriously and works, shall we say, in Tesco's or a supermarket that sells alcohol. I think you have to be careful not to take on other people's responsibilities.

And then there's the business of poison. We all know about Putin and his clever use of sarin to get rid of enemies. But poison was quite widespread in Renaissance Italy too. The Borgias were especially good at it. At the time, it's said, nobody believed that popes, cardinals, or royalty died natural deaths. It was that prevalent.

So those are your five businesses that people shouldn't be engaged in. There's actually something for monastics too. It says they shouldn't procure their requisites—whatever they need—through flattery, hinting, bribery, coercion, or hypocrisy. There's a whole load of mistakes that even in the monastic life you can make.

All this gives us a grounding in how the Buddha sets these limitations. But there's another discourse worth considering: the Upaddha Sutta, the discourse on the Holy Life. Ānanda, who's a very endearing character, agreed to be the Buddha's personal attendant for the last twenty years of his life, on condition that he heard everything the Buddha said. If he wasn't there to hear it, the Buddha had to relate what he had said. Ānanda thus became this enormous audio memory. It's difficult for us to grasp that these days because we've become so visual and we've sold our memory to microchips. But he had this seemingly phenomenal memory, and that's where the Pali discourses come from.

Ānanda had the habit of thinking he'd really understood something. There's a lovely moment where he says to the Buddha, "I think I've really got this *paṭiccasamuppāda* business." And the Buddha says, "Oh no, *paṭiccasamuppāda* is deep, profound." He does the same with good companionship. He tells the Buddha he thinks good companionship is half of the holy life—having admirable people as friends, companions, and colleagues. And the Buddha says, "Oh, don't say that, Ānanda. Don't say that. Having admirable people as friends, companions, and colleagues is actually the whole of the spiritual life. When a monk or a monastic has admirable people as friends, companions, and colleagues, they can be expected to develop and pursue the Noble Eightfold Path."

This definition of right livelihood as the spiritual life—our spiritual lives within the life of our ordinary lives at work—seems to give us a little latitude. I'm tending to think of it more as right lifestyle.

For instance, I Googled the important qualities of a police officer. The list included physical fitness, critical thinking, problem-solving skills, communication skills, interpersonal skills, strong moral character, devotion to the community. Then I looked up what makes a successful nurse practitioner. Empathy comes at the top there. Enthusiasm—an intense and eager enjoyment accompanied by a big grin and a list of questions. Tenacity, creativity, integrity. And when I searched for 'common traits of a good employee,' fifty-four million responses came up. There's

a whole list: dedication, confidence, reliability, teamwork, independence—that's interesting, teamwork and independence—leadership, interpersonal communication skills, and self-awareness.

Now, whatever job you're doing—and of course, if you're retired, you'll still be doing something with your life—all these activities reinforce certain parts of our characters and personalities. It might be worth thinking about what you're doing and how it's affecting you personally: your character, your personality. And then doing something which does the opposite, so that you get a balance.

I remember at work, I was teaching, and I really got fed up with all the head stuff. It's always head stuff—you're always talking about things. I got to a point where I felt that if I was going to progress, I really needed to do something physical. I got the idea in my head that I'd be a great cook, so I went for a week's introduction to vegetarian cooking. By the end of the week, by the way, I knew I didn't want to be a cook—there's too much vegetable shopping. But it did give me confidence, and it gave me a physical base, because I hadn't been brought up to take care of gardens or anything like that. I just found ways of bringing something physical into my life. I started doing things like Tai Chi.

You can imagine that if somebody runs a business, their mind is always caught up in running costs and profit—I know that just running this little centre, you're always worried about running costs—and it would be nice to balance that with some charitable work where those sorts of thoughts just don't come in. It's a case, I think, of translating right livelihood in a wider sense and looking at our lives, trying to get that balance right.

I don't know whether they have them anymore, but in the old fairs—I'm sure they do, really—they used to have these roundabouts with different animals. You could ride a horse or a bear or a pig, and you go round and round with this silly music as a kid. If our lives are unconnected, we tend to go from one thing to another, really just to keep busy, keep occupied. There's no connection. Yet if you were centred on the Dharma, on what you understand to be your personal spiritual path, then everything you do has to make sense to that particular position.

One thing that happens to a lot of people when they start practising—it definitely happened to me—is that interests you had begin to disappear. I remember once listening to jazz. I used to go to jazz in pubs, and this was a special night. They had this American trumpeter—I can't remember the name, but he was phenomenal. The backing group were finding it really difficult to keep up with him. You could see them sweating, trying to keep up with the speed of his playing.

Somehow, halfway through the performance, I just got this feeling that I was wasting time. It just didn't make any sense to me anymore. Just after that particular performance, I made my excuses and left.

You find that your life begins to collect around those things that make sense to the heart of your Dharma. I like to quote Lewis Carroll: if you don't know where you're going, any road will take you there. But the thing is, some wit also said, how do you know when you've arrived? At least the Buddhist path is fairly clear for us, gives us parameters, and allows us to be very creative within that too.

Often when people think of the monastic life, they think it's just one type of livelihood. Maybe they know the forest tradition and think all you do is meditate all the time. But there's quite a variety of things you can do and become involved in as a monastic. I'm thinking of things like the study part—many take degrees and such. Other people are involved in the community. I know in Colombo, for instance, there was a monk who was a constant visitor to the hospital. So there's a whole load of variety in life, but we have to think of it in terms of where I'm standing in the Dharma and how it makes sense to it.

You might find, again as I did, that certain friends drop away. It's not as though you end up telling them to go away. You just stop seeing them. A different social scene begins to appear.

I can only hope my words have been of some assistance, that they haven't caused confusion, and that by your devotion to right livelihood, you will be liberated from all suffering sooner rather than later.

Use of Wealth for Happiness

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 17 min

Originally given as *Use of Wealth for Happiness* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the Buddha's practical advice on wealth and happiness given to the wealthy merchant Anāthapiṇḍika. Drawing from discourses in the Pāli Canon, he reveals how the Buddha encouraged laypeople to first make themselves happy with righteously earned wealth, then extend that happiness to family, friends, and the community.

The teaching outlines four worthy uses of wealth: creating happiness for oneself and others, securing against future losses, making offerings to relatives and spiritual beings, and supporting renunciants dedicated to Awakening. Bhante explores the four types of happiness available to laypeople: possession, enjoyment, freedom from debt, and blamelessness, showing how the Buddha valued both spiritual development and worldly wellbeing.

This practical Dhamma addresses common misconceptions about Buddhism being overly austere, demonstrating instead how the Buddha supported a balanced approach to material life. The talk includes valuable guidance on distinguishing between healthy enjoyment and harmful indulgence, offering wisdom for navigating wealth and pleasure in accordance with the Dhamma while maintaining ethical conduct and supporting spiritual growth.

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā Sambuddhassa. Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā Sambuddhassa. Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā Sambuddhassa.

Homage to the Buddha, the Blessed, Noble and Fully Self-Enlightened.

The advice the Buddha gives to lay people is interesting, particularly how he phrases it. Much of it resembles what we covered last week, but with a slightly different nuance. First, I want to read out his advice on the proper use of wealth. Here he's talking to a householder called Anathapindika.

Anathapindika was one of the new class of people, the merchants, and he was very rich. When he heard about the Buddha at one of his relation's houses, he felt this sudden desire to see him. And when he did see him, he really took him as a teacher and immediately offered to buy him his first monastery. As the story goes, he wanted to buy a park owned by a particular prince, and the prince obviously didn't want to let go of it. He said something like, 'Even if you covered it with gold...' So Anathapindika offered to cover it with gold—and he did cover it with gold—and it became the Buddha's first monastery. That's how committed Anathapindika was.

The Buddha says, 'With the wealth acquired by energetic striving, amassed by the strength of his arms, earned by the sweat of his brow, righteous wealth righteously gained, the noble disciple undertakes four worthy deeds.' So this is what you do with your wealth.

'With the wealth thus gained, he makes himself happy and pleased and properly maintains himself in happiness.' Often when you read the Buddha's teachings, it's all about suffering and misery—it goes on and on about suffering and misery. But he's quite clear here that if you're earning good money, your first duty is to make yourself happy, pleased, and maintain yourself in happiness.

But then he says you also make your parents happy and pleased and properly maintain them in happiness. 'He makes his wife and children, his slaves, workers and servants happy and pleased and properly maintains them in happiness. He makes friends and colleagues happy and pleased and properly maintains them in happiness.' This is the first case of wealth gone to good use, fruitfully applied and used for a worthy cause.

In our society, money has a certain dirtiness about it—filthy lucre and all that. But the Buddha's quite clear: there's nothing wrong with money if it's righteously gained. And the first duty, according to him anyway, is to make yourself happy. In making yourself happy, you then have the opportunity to make others happy. Your happiness becomes infectious; it spreads outwards.

Then he says, 'Further, a householder with wealth thus gained, the noble disciple makes provision against the losses that might arise on account of fire and floods, kings and bandits and unloved heirs.' Remember that one from last time—unloved heirs. 'And he makes himself secure against them. This is the second case of wealth gone to good use.'

This is something we in our recent history have failed to understand. So many people have landed themselves in huge debt and have been happy to do so, living on the old never-never. But the Buddha's quite clear that you have to hold something back, just in case of fire and floods, kings—government always robbing us—and bandits and thieves.

Just on that point, a person who comes to meditate here had left her window open. She lived in a first-floor flat, and some neighbour was able to sneak in and steal her laptop, her Mac. Being an honest person, following the teachings of the Buddha, she was quite truthful and said the window was open—so she never got compensation, never got her insurance. Luckily she had some money put back and was able to get another one.

'Further, the householder with wealth thus gained, the noble disciple makes the five kinds of offerings: to relatives, guests, ancestors, the king, and the devas.' So on top of making people happy, you actually offer them things. You give to relatives and guests, and to ancestors—remember, in those days you made sacrifice for the benefit of others. Often it was animal sacrifice. The great king's sacrifice was, I believe, hundreds of horses and cows, all slaughtered to create good karma for the person who died. I'm not so sure he'd actually want that.

Later, in another discourse, when the Buddha is asked directly whether one should kill animals for the benefit of other beings, he's obviously against it. He suggests instead that people do good deeds for their ancestors, the king, and the devas. Now, this idea of protecting deities is a bit difficult for us these days. Well, that's really up to your personal beliefs—whether you believe there are other beings, powerful beings around who protect your property.

In ancient times, every house had its own little deity to which you offered your prayers. If you go to Thailand, they've all got their little places in the garden—small houses for the devas. So that's completely up to you whether you want to do that or not. I mean, I do it. Every time I leave this place empty, I always ask the devas to protect it. You never know.

'Further, the householder with the wealth thus gained, the noble disciple establishes a lofty offering of alms for those ascetics and Brahmins who refrain from vanity and negligence, who are settled in patience and gentleness, who are devoted to taming themselves, to calming themselves, and to attaining *Nibbāna*—an offering that is heavenly, resulting in happiness, conducive to heaven.' So it's about making offerings to ascetics. This is a bit strange for our society—a sort of northern European Protestant culture that got rid of all the priestly caste and especially monks, absolutely. It would be difficult for people in these particular countries to explain why such people should be supported.

As you know, if you've received my latest little e-reminder, I'm off on a pilgrimage following some of the places that St Francis followed. St Francis took to its absolute degree this idea of poverty—letting go of everything and living off the alms that people would offer him. So why would he do that? Why would people offer to feed him and look after him? Not that he needed very much; his clothes were just sackcloth stitched together. Obviously it was because they thought it would be a benefit to them to support somebody who was developing themselves spiritually.

In the Buddhist tradition, the idea is that somebody who joins a monastery, who becomes an ascetic in that sense, really is trying to overcome that deeper sense of suffering—seeking *Nibbāna*. Properly speaking, a good monastery is really a spiritual hospital, and lay people offer gifts so that people can become healthy.

In return, of course, the monastic is supposed to be advanced enough in their meditation and understanding of the Dhamma that they can guide lay people. That's the benefit for both sides. But the lay person is supposed to be driven by compassion—making offerings for this person who's trying to get out of suffering.

Not that it's always like that. It always becomes slightly corrupted because the person ends up making offerings for their own benefit. I heard of a case where someone came up from Bangkok with delicious food to offer to Ajahn Chah and his monastery. If you offer to somebody who is highly attained, you obviously get far more grace than from somebody with very little attainment. When he got to Ajahn Chah's monastery, he found that Ajahn Chah wasn't there—so he put all the food back in the van and went somewhere else. That's not quite the way it's supposed to work.

'The householder, these are the four worthy deeds that a noble disciple undertakes with the wealth acquired by energetic striving, amassed by the strength of his arms, earned by the sweat of his brow—righteous wealth righteously earned. And for anyone whose wealth is expended on other things apart from these four worthy deeds, that wealth is said to have gone to waste, to have been squandered and used frivolously. But for anyone whose wealth is expended on these four worthy deeds, that wealth is said to have gone to good use, to have been fruitfully employed and used for a worthy cause.'

For me, what stands out is this idea that one has to make oneself happy first, and then others. Whenever we begin the *mettā* practice, I usually put ourselves further along the line, but traditionally you start off with yourself—because when you're happy, you can make others happy. We sometimes get confused about this, thinking it's being selfish. But it's not; it's self-care. You don't have to assume that just because you've treated yourself, you're being selfish. No, you might need to lift your heart a bit, so you buy an ice cream or something.

Just to reinforce that, I'll read this small discourse. Here the Buddha is actually talking about what happiness is. The Blessed One said to the householder Anāthapiṇḍika—the same person—"There are, householder, these four kinds of happiness which may be achieved by a layperson who enjoys sensual pleasures, depending on time and occasion. What four? The happiness of possession, the happiness of enjoyment, the happiness of freedom from debt, and the happiness of blamelessness.' These are the happinesses. But notice that the first one has to do with sensual pleasure.

'What is the happiness of possession? Here a family man possesses wealth acquired by energetic striving,' and so on. 'And when he thinks, "I possess wealth acquired in this way, righteously gained," he experiences happiness and joy. This is the happiness of possession.'

'And then what is the happiness of enjoyment? With the wealth acquired by energetic striving,' and so on, 'a family man enjoys his wealth and does meritorious deeds.' These two always come together: to enjoy your wealth and to do meritorious deeds. 'And he thinks, "With the wealth acquired in this way, I enjoy my wealth and do meritorious deeds," and he experiences happiness and joy. This is called the happiness of enjoyment.'

"And what, householder, is the happiness of freedom from debt? Here a family man is not indebted to anyone to any degree, whether small or great. And when he thinks, 'I'm not indebted to anyone to any degree, whether small or great,' he experiences happiness and joy. This is called the happiness of freedom from debt."

"And what, householder, is the happiness of blamelessness? Here, householder, a noble disciple is endowed with blameless conduct of body, speech, and mind. And when he thinks, 'I am endowed with blameless conduct of body, speech, and mind,' he experiences happiness and joy. This is the happiness of blamelessness."

"These, householder, are the four kinds of happiness that a lay person who enjoys sensual pleasures may enjoy, depending on time and on occasions." I can only hope these words have been of some assistance and that you will continue to enjoy your life and do meritorious deeds, and in such a way arrive at that lovely place sooner rather than later.

When we say this grace before meals—perhaps you can look at it when you go to the kitchen—it's distinguishing between indulgence and enjoyment, appreciative joy and indulgence. These two are so close together, it's very difficult. You only know that you've slipped into indulgence after the event, when you find craving arriving for biscuits again. Then you know—ah, you didn't just enjoy them, you were becoming psychologically dependent on them for happiness. That's a very fine distinction, a very fine distinction.

How would you get over that? If you find yourself raiding the biscuit tin every ten minutes, how do you get over that? You get over that through renunciation. That's when you place the biscuit tin in front of you and refuse to take one until all desires for biscuits have disappeared. When all desires for biscuits have disappeared, then you can start again and enjoy them. And you have to be very careful not to just go over that edge so you're indulging again. Difficult, isn't it?

Dignity and the Qualities of a Ruler

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 48 min

Originally given as *Dignity and the Qualities of a Ruler* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this exploration, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines dignity not as aristocratic bearing, but as inner strength arising from spiritual cultivation. Drawing from the ten qualities of a ruler found in the Jātaka tales, he demonstrates how these virtues—generosity (dāna), morality (sīla), altruism, honesty, kindness (mettā), self-discipline, non-anger, non-violence (ahiṃsā), patience (khanti), and uprightness—develop our character and create genuine self-worth.

The talk beautifully connects these classical virtues to daily practice, showing how generosity undermines self-clinging, how restraint of the senses protects the mind from unwholesome conditioning, and how patience becomes "the greatest form of ascetic practice." Bhante emphasizes that dignity comes not from external status but from treading a worthwhile spiritual path, creating an unshakeable sense of self-worth that external circumstances cannot disturb.

With characteristic warmth and practical wisdom, he addresses challenging topics like righteous anger, the distinction between force and violence, and the cultivation of forbearance in meditation and relationships. This teaching offers profound guidance for developing the inner strength and noble bearing that naturally arise from committed spiritual practice.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa three times. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble, and fully self-enlightened one.

I thought we'd talk a little bit tonight about qualities we can develop in daily life. In some reading I've done over the past couple of weeks, I came across the word dignity. I hadn't really thought about dignity before. It's not a common or

garden word, is it? We associate it with emperors, royalty, aristocracy—people who act in a dignified way. In the past they did. Well, I think they did. Unfortunately, that moves towards snobbery, so it's not the best of examples, really.

But we do talk about dignified behaviour, don't we? You'll hear it said of people at funerals—somebody who's been heavily grieved, yet they behave in a dignified way. People under duress, or in court, falsely accused or even properly accused, act in a dignified manner. It's a certain bearing, isn't it? And that bearing arises out of certain qualities within us.

I don't know how many of you saw the YouTube video of Saddam Hussein's execution. Anybody see that? No? I did. Later on I'm going to talk about what we shouldn't be putting in our minds. You have to say he was surrounded by jackals—just the cruelty of it. One or two were trying to give him instructions on what was going to happen, but the rest were taunting him. Within all that, he seemed to maintain—well, you could call it a dignified bearing. That cool stillness that comes when you know you're going to die. I don't know, but I was quite amazed by it. His daughter then wrote or spoke saying she was proud of her father in the way he faced his death. Charles I got his head chopped off. He had a certain dignity, and then he lost his head.

Inner strength comes up when we're under duress, doesn't it? We find something that maintains a dignified posture. In a more scriptural incident, Bimbisāra, the king of Magadha—that was the kingdom really growing in those days around Varanasi on the Ganges—when he saw the Buddha doing alms round, it seems he was taken by his bearing, by the dignified way he was doing it. It struck him to such an extent that he actually wanted to know who that monk was. And that's how the friendship was first formed.

Dignity is self-worth, isn't it? To feel worthy of yourself, to have a dignified bearing. That can slip into pride, but there must be some self-worthiness in the word because you feel good about yourself. I think it's a deeper goodness we feel about ourselves when we see our lives in terms of spiritual growth. That puts it into a much greater context, doesn't it?

If one has a bearing because of status that society puts upon you—certain kudos from having a job and all that—then that dignity is dependent on the job. But if our sense of worthiness comes from living a spiritual life, then really nothing that happens on the outside can upset that feeling of self-worthiness. That's a theory.

This life, in terms of all these religions, is seen as a training ground, isn't it? It's not a matter of being perfect in order to have dignity. It's not a matter of having arrived. It's the sense of worthiness you get from treading a worthwhile path.

I came across these ten factors, ten qualities of a king in the scriptures. I think they're commentarial—they come in the *Jātaka*, the tales of the Buddha's past lives. But they give us something to work around. And the one that always seems to head the list is generosity, charity.

It's interesting that when the Buddha was attacked by the great doubt just before he became awakened—put mythologically as Māra attacking him—the doubt was: Who was he? Who was he amongst all human beings to think there would be an end to suffering? Who was he to have that presumption that he could find it? It was a real deep self-doubt. He touches the earth, you see, and the goddess arises to say that the quality he's perfected which allows him to have this presumption, inverted commas, is the perfection of generosity. Which means he's not doing it just for himself. He sees himself already connected to the whole of humanity, the whole mass of suffering. That's what gives him his sense of self-worth back, to go back into the meditation. And after that, he makes the break. Very interesting.

Generosity is a quality of not getting flustered, not getting angry when we lose something or when somebody takes something. There's the Zen story of the monk sitting there when a thief came and took all his possessions, even his clothes, left him naked in the moonlight. He looked up at the moon and said, if only I could have given him this beautiful moon. That's generosity, isn't it? It's that spirit of not just giving when you're asked, but letting go—actually giving when you don't feel you want to. And to do that, there has to be that connection to the other.

The more generous we are, the more it mirrors back to us our lack of possessiveness. When we're generous, we let go of something we could have used for ourselves—our wealth or our time. Just to do that is to let go of the self. That's the practice of undermining self-view in action. This business of undermining self isn't just an act of insight, like when we observe things as separate and all that. It manifests in our virtues. The Buddha puts generosity always at the head of the list because the more generous we are, the more we have to renounce. And that process of renunciation is the spiritual path. It doesn't mean you have to actually let go of everything, but you have to have that attitude with everything—being able to let go of it should occasion demand. Develop that attitude.

Sometimes you can play little mental games with this. Take the most treasured thing you have and imagine it being stolen, being lost. Would it really be that important? Can you let go of something treasured? Just do a mental game with it. Because often our fears are unfounded—we think that if we lose this or lose our jobs or lose that, the world crashes around us. But if you turn it into a little story within the mind, using the creativity of the mind to set up a thought experiment, you see there's nothing. You can even try this with losing your life. That one's a bit heavy.

Last year I went to Auschwitz, and there are just heroic stories from all those years of that camp. Heroic tales of people who acted out of kindness and got severely punished or killed for it. When you go to the place, it grounds all the stories you've read. It has quite an effect on you—on me, anyway. So even to the point of being able to let go of our lives—that's the ultimate generous act, isn't it? Our greatest gift. Generosity digs deep. It's a profound virtue.

The next quality is morality. Here we can take it more in the sense of not doing what is wrong—keeping the basic precepts, resisting the old temptations. Most of us have given up killing and thieving; we're not talking about gross behaviour. But there are those little things, little greeds, little aversions. Just to work with them, to see them as ways of developing that strength of resisting temptations.

Even at these more subtle levels where we can't talk about good and evil, we're talking about unwholesomeness, unskilful behaviour. Just attachments to a certain routine in our lives—the morning cup of tea that's difficult to give up. You can play little games with yourself: what happens if I don't have my Lapsang Souchong this morning? Go through the hell of letting go. What that does is build up your will, your will to resist what is unwholesome for us.

Then you try going back into the routine, see how it is. It's a case of breaking routine. The practice is really getting rid of habits and getting other habits. But as soon as we get a habit, we tend to hold on to it. Even meditation can become an obsessive thing—you think your day will collapse if you don't do your forty minutes. It's a case of tempting oneself to let go of things we've become attached to. And it strengthens our character, strengthens the will—the ability to resist temptations.

It's not necessarily anything negative. You were talking about the morning cup of tea—there's actually nothing wrong with the morning cup of tea. It's a question of breaking the habit because you've become attached to that particular behaviour. The self comforts itself in little ways. In Christian literature they're called

imperfections. But the purpose is again to renounce, and in so doing, you create a certain inner strength. This is the point. I think that's one of these things about when you see somebody who has dignity, to use that word—an inner strength. It comes from being able to resist what is harmful.

On the positive side, the next quality is altruism. If you remember that verse from the *Dhammapada*: "Cease from evil, do good, purify the heart. This is the path, this is the ancient path." This is the path before the Buddha—an ancient path. Altruism means putting somebody else before yourself, or at least equal to yourself, when the situation calls for it. You're not saying there isn't a situation where you're caring for yourself. The Buddha is clear about that—we do things for ourselves, for others, for both ourselves and others. But altruism is really an expression of that interconnectedness, isn't it? That interdependency. So when we offer our service, we offer our wealth, we put ourselves out for somebody.

There's a lovely passage—the scripture is called the *Anuruddhas*, I think—about three *arahats*, three fully enlightened monks living together, and they live, hopefully not surprisingly, peacefully. The Buddha asks Anuruddha, how is it you live peacefully? And he says, well, when I get up in the morning, I say to myself, what if I put aside what I want to do and do what the others want to do? I think that only works if the others are saying the same thing. If they're not, you'll be messed about. But at least that attitude—just putting aside what I want to do and let's see what the others want to do. You're not getting rid of what you want. You're just putting it aside for a moment so you can hear what other people want to do, which is not our normal position. We prefer that other people know what we want to do. Then we bargain, then we negotiate. This is coming around it from the other way, and hopefully people respond. That's altruism.

Then there's honesty. I think honesty is a great part of this dignified bearing. Truthfulness with ourselves, truthfulness with others—not to trick people, not to exaggerate. It comes close to humility, really, in its proper sense of knowing who we are. Honesty comes in all sorts of ways: to do one's due at work, to give of one's best in business.

On a retreat there was somebody who was into buying and selling. He said he could go to a house and someone would show him something—someone who hadn't seen the Antiques Roadshow. He'd work out that they didn't really know what it was worth. So he could say, well look, I'll give you twenty quid for that, I'll take it off your hands. And he'd always sell it for a couple of thousand. I could see he was confused because this was business—this is what you did in business. But

there was some doubt in his mind, because he asked. What about that, you see? Before I could say something, I just let it rest in the air, see what the others would say. There was another businessman there, and of course he went on about integrity. They blew that one out of the water, really. But it's funny how you can confuse yourself by having different aims. This person's aim was to make money. It's not his fault the other person didn't know what it was worth—they should have known better. It's not his problem, is it? So that sense of integrity, I think, is part of the quality of dignity.

The next quality is kindness. Gentleness. We often translate *mettā* as loving-kindness, don't we? The quality of being kind, being gentle. It's a lovely word, isn't it? Kind. In a sense, the word itself tells us what it is. I was always amused by "gentleman." In old literature they say "gentle woman," but it's very rarely used. It's the man who's about to be gentle. A gentleman. Interesting, eh?

Kindness. Often it's to see the fragility in others, isn't it? To see their weaker part and not take advantage of that or hammer them for it. Often you can ask people to do things they wouldn't do if it weren't asked with kindness. There's a gentleness about the way we speak to people. It even extends to objects.

How do you close the fridge door? It's treating everything with that sort of care. When I used to visit the Zen monastery at Throstle Nest, just here in Hexham—North England anyway—they insisted we treat even cracked bits of pottery as if they were Ming vases. Everything had to be handled with that gracious kindness. And you bow to everything out of gratitude. Bow to the room, bow to the door, the doorknob. At first it all feels like a game, and then you realise, no, no—this is what it's about really. Kindness. Remember, these are the qualities that are supposed to be of a king.

Self-control, self-discipline. It's not a word we particularly like, discipline. It reminds us of Victoriana and the old ways. But the interesting thing is that the word actually comes from 'to learn'—a disciple, following the advice of a teacher. On this course, for instance, the schedule was your discipline. It set out the rota of the day. So one tries to follow that particular rota as best as you can, no matter how you feel or don't feel.

This discipline comes from some other centre. It's not coming from feelings. It's not coming from whether you want to do it or not in that feeling way, whether you're bored or not. One has the discipline, the inner strength, the control to actually do what you've set yourself—like resolution.

There was a robbery in Bishop's Castle just down the road—it's a close town to us. I was in the builder's merchant's yard, and they mentioned there'd been a robbery. I said, oh. Then I said, why?

I don't know why I said 'why.' It's not a silly question, really. It's like the bank robber who was asked why he robbed banks. He said, because that's where the money is. And this fellow answered me—he said, just lack of discipline, and walked off. Lack of discipline. That's the way he saw it. All this bad behaviour is all lack of discipline.

I think you have to be careful that discipline doesn't become disciplinarian. That's what we associate it with. It's more cajoling. It's more returning to that kindness, that self-cajoling, to actually do what we'd set ourselves to do.

When it comes to self-control of the senses, the Buddha's hot on that. Because everything that comes into the senses is conditioning you. An act of attention is an act of intention. Intention is an act of will.

I always like to refer to an example of those billboards on roads. In the 80s, I was living in Birmingham, and there was obviously some doubt about the efficacy of these billboards—whether they had any worth in terms of advertising. So the owners of the billboards advertised this really funny perfume from Australia. It had a funny name, which I've forgotten. Did you ever see it? It had a hat on top of the bottle with corks dangling down. Really funny. And the amount of enquiries about this proved without a shadow of a doubt that these billboards worked. I can't remember the name, but I definitely remember the shape of the product. Anyway, the perfume didn't exist. So there you are on the bus, lazily looking out, and you're catching these images. And it's coming in, it's coming in.

The Buddha always talks about restraint of the sense bases. Restraint of the sense bases. So we have to be careful about what we put into our heads—what we see on TV, the stuff we read. It's not a matter of guarding ourselves against, shall we say, bad news, but just recognising that what we put into the mind has a conditioning effect, that's all. Now remember, these conditionings are not everlasting. It's not as though, oh my God, I'm about to go to the Avīci Hell or something. It's a case of recognising that if there is a negative conditioning in the mind, then we're going to have to suffer, stay with, be patient with that conditioning coming out and exhausting itself. That's all.

But once we put a conditioning in the mind to which we're attracted, every time we put it in, we're reinforcing that conditioning. That's the problem. It becomes more and more difficult to resist the actual temptation. So this self-control is absolutely necessary for the spiritual life.

You see, the Buddha—all these rules that we have, it's 227 at the last count—so many of them were to restrain the monastics from doing things. One of them concerned food. In the early times, the monks and nuns could go out any time with their bowl, collect a bit of food, go back, have a munch. There was no rule as such. Then the lay people started to complain. They said, look, your monks are turning up any time of the day, and they're all rushing off with all this food. So then he made this rule: from now on, you have to go out in the morning, you can only go out once, and you have to eat it by midday.

The monks didn't like that. They rebelled. They said, no, we're not having that. But eventually they came to their senses and agreed to it. There were proper arguments, like: well, everybody cooks the best food in the evening—you go in the morning, are you going to get his rice? But he wouldn't have it. I can't forgive him.

You get things like that throughout the Vinaya. Once the Buddha saw monks coming away from a village with loads and loads of cloth. By that time, obviously, the Sangha had become well-established in society and was receiving lots of presents, lots of gifts from lay people. So he thought, well, that's not right. He himself went out and experimented to see what was actually needed. At night, he just had his two robes. Then as the night got a bit cool, he put another robe on top. And in the early morning, the coldest hour, he needed another. So he made a rule: you can only have three robes. The under robe, the over robe, and the last two he combined into one—you have to stitch them together. And that's it.

All these little institutional rules we have are really there to restrain the senses. That's the idea. So it's up to you, this self-restraint—like retail therapy. That's a bad one. Nipping in, getting a pair of shoes you don't really need. If you gave one blouse away or one skirt away or one pair of trousers away and then bought another one, there might be something to it. But the wardrobes just get bigger and bigger.

Then there's non-anger. Oh, this is a very strange area for us. The question of righteous anger comes up often. It's there within Christianity, depending on how you interpret the actions of Christ when he overturns the tables. I don't see why he should necessarily have done it with anger. He could have done it in a dignified

way, couldn't he? Just get out of here and tip the table over. But they always think he's all rage, like berserk. Which doesn't—I don't know. Anyway, this idea of righteous anger.

Anger itself always has an underbelly of cowardice. You'll only manifest anger to somebody you can beat. If the person's bigger than you, you're not going to get angry. If they're more powerful than you, you're going to keep it cool because you don't want to lose your job or get flung into jail or something. Anger always rests on the presumption that you'll win the battle. It's not a very strong position to come from, I think.

We have this little distinction between being aggressive and being assertive. Being assertive, as far as I can see, is far more wise than being aggressive. And to be assertive, you don't have to be angry. I think that's part of this dignity—it means you're coming from a place of truthfulness. And there's strength in that.

Today we have this problem of wars. Just last week actually—was it last week? Or the week before? Anyway, I gave a talk to Her Majesty's Armed Forces on this business of non-violence. I think the problem lies around the words force and violence. Force, I think, can be assertive. Violence is always aggressive. Violence is force with something added—force with anger, with revenge, with all that.

Of course, it's difficult if you're a soldier and your mate's just got shot, not to have a sense of redress against the enemy. But I don't think it has to be like that. Think of people sent out by the UN as peacekeepers. Even the Irish army does that, doesn't it? They were out in Israel, weren't they? On the border? Their job isn't to kill, but to protect. It's a very different attitude. So I think that distinction between force and violence is important. In a sense, you've got to have a righteous cause. That's your other problem.

But leaving aside armed conflict, I think when we feel angry, it's this business of sublimation. That's another word they very rarely come across these days, but it's there within a lot of Christian literature from the old days. I just don't hear it anymore, to sublimate. Now, I believe I'm right in saying—do correct me if I'm wrong—that in chemistry, to sublimate means something moves from a solid directly into a gas. What's the word I'm looking for?

Gas. Thank you. It doesn't pass through the fluid state. So, somehow—anger is energy, that's all it is, it's energy. And to somehow turn that energy around and use it for benefit, it can really give you a lot of force. But you've got to take the

turbulence out of it. Somehow you've got to drop down to the righteousness of your cause and work from a base of equanimity. Then it becomes very powerful, I think.

A person's ability to stand their ground without anger has a lot more force than somebody jumping up and down. It's that inner strength—people feel it. All these people we praise these days, like Gandhi, Martin Luther King, Nelson Mandela—they all have that. That's one thing they've really developed, isn't it? Not to get angry when they're being attacked, but to maintain that dignified presence and the strength that comes from it. It's very difficult.

And then you always get this in the list: forbearance, patience. The Buddha talks about patience as being the greatest form of ascetic practice. You don't have to lie on a bed of nails to get the best form of ascetic practice. Just be patient with what you're doing. Enormously annoying. Remember old Frank Sinatra, "I did it my way. I took the blows." Frank took the blows.

The idea is that you can't win all battles. You're not going to win all your battles, whether at work or in the family or anywhere. Somehow there has to be a point where you say, well, I'll give in to that. Even—there's only myself and a manager at Satipaṭṭhāna, and sometimes I think, no, it's not worth it. Let that one go. And it's good practice, because then you give up trying to win battles. You've got to stop always trying to be the one who gets their way. Just lose a few—it gets easier then. We're not talking about immoral things. Just doing it my way.

When I was a kid, I remember a raging argument between my mother and father over polishing shoes. My father, having been in the armed forces—you put the polish on with the cloth and then you brush it up with the brush. Bloody obvious. And my mother, who wasn't trained in these fine arts, just used the brush all the way through. The thing was, the shoe came up just as bright anyway. But that wasn't the point.

So it's a case of being able to give in sometimes. I think that's a quality of patience, of forbearance. And in meditation, of course, we're learning exactly that. You want the heart to be other than it is, but you can't force it; you have to let it go. If it feels a bit depressed or a bit anxious or whatever, as soon as you try to get the better of it, you're in conflict. Somehow we have to let the heart do its thing while putting our energy into how we ought to be behaving at the present time—and deal with the heart later. You don't put yourself in conflict with your own heart, with your own mind, or with your body, for heaven's sake.

Pushing the body to do things when it's not capable is another form of this conflict. When somebody comes to meditation for the first time, you have to judge from the body, but generally speaking, once you've reached thirty, forget the cross-leg business. It's just not worth the pain. I did it, but looking back at that guy, it could have been easier. Sat there with a raging bull in my knees.

And these little things are so annoying. It's amazing how they can make us so angry about the smallest of things. That's because, remember, these emotions aren't caused by the object. These emotions are like a big bag full of stinky air, and all you've got to do is put a pinprick in it and everything wants to get out through there, like a balloon. We've got this vast reservoir of anger and self-righteousness and all that sort of stuff. Somebody's only got to, just at the right time in the right place, put a little punch in there and you go boom! Completely inappropriate.

It's funny how we gauge when that's possible. If somebody comes into the house who's a stranger or a visitor and they knock something over—oh, no problem. But if the kid does it, you go for a second. If the dog does it, you hang him. That sort of inappropriate behaviour we have—just to have patience with things, just develop that patience.

And then finally there's this business of uprightness. I presume that's the word for dignity really—just the courage to stand up for what one thinks is right. What's that lovely phrase? I always forget it. Something about how if people of right mind stood up for something, then these bad things wouldn't happen. If they only spoke their mind and stood up for what was right. Have I touched upon anybody's memory? One of these beautiful quotes. Can you remember it? It's to that meaning, isn't it? No, no, that's about—no, it's a different matter. It's a lovely thing, actually.

"For evil to flourish, it is only necessary that good men stay silent." That's the one. Yes, I want to write that down afterwards. Could you say that again, Ruthie? "For evil to flourish, it is only necessary for good men to stay silent." Yes, see? There may be one or two words out of place, but that is definitely what it is.

So these qualities—we haven't discussed other qualities that I'll go into a little bit tomorrow: the mettā, karuṇā, the loving-kindness, the compassion, the joy. These are just things that were listed as qualities of a king.

But is it what the Buddha himself said? Not in so many words, I think, as far as I can see. I don't have my books here, so I can't say for absolutely sure.

Is it presented as being from the Buddha or from his advice? Well, usually the Jātakas are, but they're not canonical. They're not put into the canon as such. But they'll do, won't they? As a list, as a starter.

It occurs to me, actually—very interesting—that list is absolutely vital, given the nature of kings in those days, and in fact even today. Because without a list like that, you've got mayhem; the king is all-powerful. So it's a way of tempering the king's power, to assign him all these qualities.

That's right. In the scriptures you have this figure of the world-conquering monarch, who seems to me to be like the alter ego of the Buddha. Remember, when he was born, the wise man said he would either be a world-conquering monarch or a fully self-enlightened being. So you have this figure coming up through the scriptures—this very good, very gracious king who does everything right according to the model law, and everything's very peaceful.

Think about it: suppose everyone on this earth simply took the first precept—not to kill another human being. Just that, never mind the rest of it. The idea that a king shouldn't kill another human being is totally revolutionary. It would essentially forbid warfare, wouldn't it?

Yes, that's right. But by this time, he's conquered everything anyway. He's rolled his wheel. He doesn't have any opposition, really.

There's a nice little scripture where there's lots of robbery and the kingdom falls into disarray because the king hasn't kept these rules. The advice given by the Buddha in a previous life is that he ought to stop inequality of payment—there shouldn't be anybody who's poor.

It says that when you get rid of poverty, the stealing stops, the hatred stops, and the killing will stop. That's an interesting ancient idea.

So anyway, that's it. This gives us some ideas about how we can walk around in a dignified fashion from now on. I can only hope my words have been of some assistance.

May you be liberated from all suffering sooner rather than later.

Patient Forbearance

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 19 min

Originally given as *Patient Forbearance* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this exploration of khanti pāramī (the perfection of patient forbearance), Bhante Bodhidhamma examines one of the Buddha's most emphasized virtues. Drawing from the Akkosa Sutta, he shares the famous teaching where the Buddha responds to verbal abuse by comparing it to food that, when not accepted, remains with the giver. The talk covers five key areas of forbearance: dealing with insults and slander without retaliation, enduring life's inevitable hardships and adversities, cultivating patience with difficult people, working skillfully with inner reactivity and mental states, and maintaining patience with one's spiritual progress.

Bhante illustrates these teachings with practical examples, including his own experience with illness and stories from his time at meditation centers. He references the challenging Parable of the Saw, where the Buddha instructs maintaining loving-kindness even under extreme duress. The discourse emphasizes that patient forbearance builds inner strength and resilience, allowing practitioners to maintain equanimity when 'everything falls apart.' This teaching is particularly valuable for understanding how acceptance ('this is the way it is') can transform our relationship with difficulty and support gradual spiritual development on the path to liberation.

Namo tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā-Sambuddhassa.

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed and noble, self-enlightened one.

So last month we did courage, which doesn't actually come up as a separate item in the ten perfections, the ten virtues to be perfected. But I suppose you could fit it into *adhiṭṭhāna*, which means resolute resolution. We'll do that another time anyway. But what we talked about was courage is doing something, achieving something, even though it's very difficult one way or the other. But there's a passive side to courage, which is, of course, patient forbearance.

Now, the Buddha is very big on that. He encourages us to develop it. So this is what he says: "Patient endurance is the supreme austerity. Whoever endures abuse, assault and imprisonment without animosity, and who has forbearance as one's strength, as one's mighty army, I call a Brahmin." So a Brahmin in the Buddha's understanding is someone who's achieved something. He was always poking fun at the Brahmins who were pretending to be the spiritual leaders of society. Many of them were a bit corrupt, I think. I'm sure there were some good ones there.

"He who holds back rising anger like a rolling chariot, him I call a real driver. Other people are but holding the reins." And there's a verse here from the *Theragāthā*, which is the collected verses of the elders – this is the senior monks, not the nuns: "Forbearance is the highest virtue, forbearance is the highest self-control, forbearance is the highest happiness."

So there's a lot going on for this virtue of forbearance. And we'll look at one or two areas: all those areas where we feel insulted, slandered and all that sort of stuff. Then there's the hardships and adversities that come to us through life. Then we're cultivating patience with others. Then there's this inner bearing with reactivity, letting go of our inner reactions to things. And finally, patience with the spiritual path. And in so doing, we build up this inner strength and resilience. When everything falls apart, there's that ability to bounce back.

So the first one: dealing with insults, criticism, slander. It's important for us to face these things when they come up instead of retaliating, becoming upset. You have to develop this patience and maintain equanimity, which is difficult, of course. I mean, often the best thing is to approach the person who's done this to you and have a little discussion with them. That's before you hit them.

Now, there's an occasion here where the Buddha is actually abused by somebody. So I shall read out this little bit. At one time, the Buddha was staying near Rajagaha in the bamboo grove, the squirrel's feeding ground, and the Brahmin Bharadvaja the Rude heard a rumour that a Brahmin of the Bharadvaja clan had gone forth from the lay life to homelessness in the presence of the ascetic Gautama. So remember, that's his family name, Gautama. Angry and displeased, he went to the Buddha and abused and insulted him with rude and harsh words.

And when he'd spoken, the Buddha said to him, "What do you think, Brahmin? Do friends and colleagues, relatives and family members and guests still come to visit you?"

"Well, sometimes they do, Master Gautama."

"And do you then serve them fresh and cooked foods and savouries?"

"Sometimes I do."

"And if they don't accept it, Brahmin, who does it belong to?"

"Well, in that case, it still belongs to me."

"In the same way, Brahmin, when you abuse, harass and attack us, who do not abuse, harass and attack, we don't accept it. It belongs to you, Brahmin, it still belongs to you. Someone who, when abused, harassed and attacked, abuses, harasses and attacks in return, is said to eat the food and have a reaction to it. But we neither eat your food nor do we have a reaction to it. It still belongs to you, Brahmin. It still belongs to you."

Now, the Brahmin mistakes the Buddha's assertive forthrightness for aggressive bluntness. And he says, "The king and the retinue believe that Master Gautama is a perfected one, and yet he still gets angry." So one of the signs of somebody who's perfected, of course, is that they don't get angry – or at least when they do show anger, they're only putting it on.

Anyway, the Buddha replies, "For one free of anger, tamed, living in balance, freed by right understanding, one who is composed and at peace, where would anger come from? When you get angry at an angry person, you just make things worse for yourself. And when you don't get angry at an angry person, you win a battle hard to win. When you know that the other is angry, you act for the good of both yourself and the other if you're mindful and stay calm. People unfamiliar with this teaching consider one who heals both oneself and the other to be a fool."

Anyway, this seems to have convinced Bharadvaja – he's practically bowled over because he then says, "Oh, excellent Master Gautama." And before you know it, he's taken refuge in the Buddha, his teaching, and the order. And he wants to become a monk. So then he receives the going forth, the ordination in the Buddha's presence. And not long after the ordination, the Venerable Bharadvaja the Rude, living alone, withdrawn, diligent, keen and resolute, soon realized the supreme end of the spiritual path in this very life. He lived having achieved it with his own insight, the goal for which people rightly go forth from lay life into homelessness. And he understood: "Rebirth is ended. The spiritual journey has

been completed. What had to be done has been done. There is no return to any state of becoming." And the Venerable Bharadvaja became one of the perfected ones.

I don't know how you handle feeling angry about what somebody has done or said about you. But if somebody has been angry with me, I've learned to listen to what they say rather than—even though there's a reaction here, I put my whole attention on actually what they're saying. In so doing, I then reply to what they're saying and maintain at least an outward sign of non-anger, non-reactivity. That normally allows them to cool down a bit. And then hopefully there's some discussion before anything gets worse.

This leads us, of course, to having patience with others. We also meet people who just get up our noses. Somehow we have to cultivate this acceptance, this patience with them—responding with a certain understanding and compassion.

There was a case at Kanduboda, where I stayed for quite some time. A schizophrenic came—at least he told us he'd been diagnosed as a schizophrenic. He'd obviously stopped taking the pills. And he was doing some very funny things, like meditating in the nude, which in the East is a bit off, and sometimes showering—public showering where you go to the open well and pour water over yourself. He was doing some other silly things that were disturbing people.

The people there—I didn't know this was going on because the place was a little bit far away from my own hut—went to the abbot and complained about him. But the abbot did nothing. Eventually, in a bit of desperation, they came to see me. I said, "Well, I'll go up and see the Venerable Upalian and see what he'll do." So I went up and expressed their annoyance—the fact that they felt their practice was being heavily disturbed. And he didn't do anything.

I never knew whether it was because he didn't want to confront this man or whether it was a teaching of just bearing up with what is unpleasant. Usually it's the unpleasant which disappears. Usually it's the opposite—somebody disturbs you and we tend to move away. But actually, if you just hang on in there, they usually give up and disappear. This was a big teaching for me.

The second one, of course, is endurance in adversity—when things fall apart. When you have an illness or something like that, or you lose a close friend or a family member, or somebody at work leaves whom you had a good relationship

with. All those things, just the ordinary adversities of life that come our way. Just being able to accept them. This is the way it is. That's the big phrase, isn't it? Just to accept it.

Sometimes I've found it helpful to write out the situation so that I'm clear about what's actually happening. That allows whatever has arisen—anger, disappointment, grief, despair, all that sort of stuff—to eventually burn itself out.

As you know, I recently had some really bad trouble with a slipped disc—the sciatica actually stopped me from walking. Funnily enough, having accepted the situation, this year is the first time I've actually walked around the meadows twice a day and really enjoyed the way nature's come alive over the spring. So it's not been that heavy.

It all comes down to this basic acceptance: this is the way it is. If you keep saying that to yourself, just banging it into your head—"this is the way it is"—and then letting the heart relax around that. The possibilities usually turn up. We went through that very strange period of lockdown; that was really weird. For many people, it was just an opportunity to do stuff they'd always wanted to do. Now they couldn't do what they usually did, so they took up new hobbies—writing and music and stuff like that. It's very much a case of bearing with it. It begins with acceptance. And then, of course, we find that it's not so bad.

However, there can be situations which are very painful. There's a discourse called the Parable of the Saw. I'm sure many of you have heard it. The Buddha says: "Monks, even if bandits were to sever you savagely, limb by limb with a two-handed saw, he who gave rise to a mind of hate towards them would not be carrying out my teachings. Monks, even in such a situation, you should train yourselves thus: Neither shall our minds be affected by this, nor for this matter shall we give vent to evil words, but we shall remain in full concern and pity with a mind of love, and we shall not give in to hatred. On the contrary, we shall live projecting thoughts of universal love to those very persons, making them, as well as the whole world, the object of our thoughts of universal love—thoughts that have grown great, exalted, and measureless. We shall dwell radiating these thoughts, which are void of hostility and ill-will. In this way, you should train yourselves."

That's a bit of a demand, isn't it? In fact, when I once said this in a talk, somebody said, "Well, the Buddha had a great sense of humour."

When it comes to our inner practice, this is also to do with how we react to what's happening on the outside. But of course, it also affects how we react to ourselves within ourselves. All this comes under that quality of reactivity. Here again, there's an importance to being able to bear with ourselves—to bear with our own thoughts and emotions, sensations and stuff like that—just so that we can develop a clarity of mind.

I was reminded here of Brian Keenan. Some of you will remember this. He was captured by Shiite militiamen—1990, that's when he wrote the book. Luckily, he had another person, John McCarthy, who shared the cell with him. For four years, they lived in this really horrible state of imprisonment. If you read the book, *An Evil Cradling*, it really is a shocker. He came out of it, from all intents and purposes, really strengthened. I remember when I read it, there's a point where he has an insight into thought, which I thought was a spiritual insight, actually. But unfortunately, there was another man there, an American, who really was broken by it. It's a sad story. Some people just—now we've got this business in Ukraine and Russia. There are people having to go through this sort of stuff.

The final thing is patience with our spiritual progress. You have to be careful here because lots of people say to me, "Well, I don't feel I'm progressing." That normally means we've got some idea as to where we ought to be, what we ought to have achieved by now—some idea of what the insight practices are, some idea about *nibbāna*.

This can be very debilitating. I always think it's best just to put that to the side, because the spiritual practice—so long as you're making that effort, that gentle effort to just keep mindful, keep working with it—is bound to move. The Buddha talks of it like the growth of a tree from a tiny seed and how long it takes for that tree to finally fruit. It is a case of really having patience with that, but also not getting into it at all, really. It just happens naturally.

I think it's much wiser just to work with our negative mental states, because as they begin to lose their power over us, there's a greater clarity anyway. It's just part of the practice.

In fact, somebody complains to the Buddha about how hard the practice is. The Buddha says, "Well, in the end, you achieve *nibbāna*." The questioner says, "Yeah, *nibbāna*, so what?" And the Buddha says, "Well, when you get there, you are happy and with it contented." That's the idea.

Very good. I can only hope my words have been of some assistance, and that by your development of patient forbearance, you will achieve the final liberation from all suffering sooner rather than later.

Non-Violence vs. Pacifism

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 15 min

Originally given as *Non-Violence vs. Pacifism* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this dharma talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma clarifies the important distinction between non-violence (ahiṃsā) and pacifism from a Theravāda Buddhist perspective. Rather than being a philosophical "ism," the Buddha's teaching on non-violence emerges from practical wisdom and direct experience of what causes and alleviates suffering.

Bhante explains how the Buddha, teaching in a preliterate society, grounded his ethical guidance in experiential reality rather than systematic philosophy. Drawing from the Dhammapada verses "All tremble at violence, all fear death," he explores how true non-violence arises naturally when the mind is free from hatred and delusion. The talk examines canonical accounts of the Buddha's interactions with kings and warriors, illustrating how non-violence operates as an internal state rather than absolute external prohibition.

A crucial distinction is made between force and violence—the same physical action can be performed with or without hatred in the heart. Bhante discusses the monastic rule (pārājika) regarding taking life, and references the ideal of the Cakkavattin (wheel-turning monarch) who establishes the five precepts. This teaching offers practical wisdom for navigating ethical complexity in our contemporary world, emphasizing the cultivation of compassion and wisdom over rigid ideological positions.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhasa.

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

I thought I'd clarify—or at least give you my opinion on—this business of non-violence as opposed to pacifism.

Pacifism is really an ideal. It comes from some great concept about violence, making it a global, total position. At its most radical, an absolute pacifist would never take part in any war. It's normally centred on war, but of course it spreads out to killing as well. The basic position is that the value of human life is such that deliberately killing a person is simply not on.

Unfortunately, with isms, they do tend not to be in touch with reality as it is. You do get types of pacifism that are a bit closer to reality. You get militant pacifists who will oppose all violence and war, but then you get conditional pacifism—accepting circumstances where war might actually lead to less suffering. The Second World War would be one example, I think, to overcome Nazism. Then there are selective pacifisms that really only concern weapons of mass destruction. But normally speaking, when people talk about pacifism, it tends to be in that absolute category.

Non-violence is of a different nature. One thing I think we find hard to understand is that the Buddha was teaching in a society that was preliterate—there was no writing. If you don't have any writing, you really can't think about things in that systematic philosophical way. So there are no isms during the Buddha's time. The Buddha is always grounding himself on actual experience—his personal experience as to what actually causes suffering and how to get rid of it.

What he's actually teaching is how to be in a world that is largely driven, at the moment, by greed, aversion, fear, and delusion. So it's a very practical approach to the world, coming from a wisdom base—a practical wisdom base—and from his own personal experience and, of course, the good heart. What we're getting to is an ethical stand, a way of relating to people and, in fact, all sentient beings. These days, you can also add nature.

When there's no violence in the mind—and the mind is never empty in the sense that there's nothing there, apart from maybe sleep—when the mind is in a state of non-violence, empathy and compassion arise quite naturally. Those two can't exist together. That's the point.

Interestingly enough, in the discourses, when the kings are talking to him and one or two of them go to war, he never advises them to get rid of their armies. He never tells them to stop executing people. Also, certain punishments were vicious. There was one I remember which involved rubbing the convict's head with a conch shell until the bone glistened. It's amazing how we can think up these

things. But the point is that he never actually advises kings to get rid of their armies. There's some basic understanding that this is the way it is. He does, of course, invite them to develop this sense of non-violence.

Basically, it's about principle rather than going into the details of how you ought to do something. He always leaves that to us. It's up to us to decide what we feel to be ethically good or bad.

This translated in later Buddhism, in later Buddhist cultures—for instance, the samurai. The samurai was taught, or developed himself, to kill without any hatred. There's one story where a samurai has beaten his opponent and the sword is high, about to crash down on his head—and he walks away. When they ask him why, he says his opponent was angry. You'll also know the martial art of Aikido, which is really based upon the idea that you use the other person's energy to deflect their violence towards you.

There's another interesting thing about the scriptures. Remember that when the Buddha was born, the Brahmins—one in particular, a sage—came to see him and decided, or saw, that he was either going to be a world-conquering monarch or a fully self-awakened being. This alter ego of the world-conquering monarch appears in the scriptures as the *Chakravartin*. He has this wheel which appears and begins to roll. He follows it with his fourfold army: his foot soldiers, his cavalry, his chariots, and his elephants. Wherever it goes, of course, he defeats the enemy. At times he's actually invited.

As soon as he takes over, what does he do? He establishes the five precepts. In so doing, everywhere he goes becomes a very peaceful and loving place. That's a motif that occasionally comes up in the discourses. Then it gets to a point where one of these *Chakravartins* doesn't follow the five precepts. Immediately the society begins to corrupt and all sorts of things happen.

There was one rather interesting occasion where stealing began. The minister told him, "The person's stealing because they're poor." So he decided to give this person some wealth, some land, so that he had no reason to steal. Then others thought, "If I want more wealth and land, what I've got to do is steal." So stealing became common. That's when he had to start chopping heads off. That's the way it goes.

There's also an occasion which brings about a rule for the *bhikkhus*, for the monastic life, *bhikkhus* and *bhikkhunis*. The Buddha had obviously given a very enthusiastic talk about the repulsiveness of the body. Of course, the purpose of

seeing the repulsiveness of the body is to become non-attached to it. However, the *bhikkhus*, the monks, seem to have misunderstood this. They went off into the forests and began to do this contemplation on the disgusting nature of the body. They became so disgusted that they started killing themselves and asked other monks to kill them.

There's this wonderful story of a monk who's actually just stabbed a monk to death to release him from this disgusting body, and he's wiping the blood off the knife. When the Buddha hears about this, of course, he must have been in a bit of a shock, really, because his words had been completely misunderstood.

So he makes up this rule: "Should any *bhikkhu* intentionally deprive a human being of life, or search for an assassin for him, or praise the advantages of death, or incite him to die in this way: 'Dear friend, what use is this wretched, miserable life to you? Death would be better for you than life.' And with such an idea in mind, such a purpose in mind, should in various ways praise the advantages of death and incite them to die, he is also defeated and no longer in communion."

This is what we know as a *pārājika*. In other words, he's defeated in the sense that he can no longer be a monk in this lifetime, and he leaves the order. The people who actually murdered the other *bhikkhus*—this rule, of course, doesn't apply to them because it's not backdated. It starts from that point onwards.

The other interesting thing about this rule is that the person has to actually be killed or die for it to be a proper *pārājika*, a proper defeat. If the person whom he's trying to kill, or intentionally trying to kill, fails to die, then it's a serious offence, of course, but he's not actually asked to leave the order.

As we've said, it's not a philosophy as such. It's really just practical moral reasoning. These two verses come from the *Dhammapada*:

"All tremble at violence, all fear death. Seeing others as being like yourself, do not kill or cause others to kill."

"All tremble at violence. Life is dear to all. Seeing others as being like yourself, do not kill or cause others to kill."

A distinction here has to be made really between force and violence. I think this is the crucial bit. For instance, if you drop your mobile phone, you might just go and pick it up and see if you've broken the screen and then just put it in your

pocket. But on the other hand, you might be quite angry with yourself and fed up with yourself. So you go down and there's that extra pressure in the hand of grabbing this mobile phone and stuffing it in your pocket.

One is non-violence and the other one is violence. One is the use of just simple force to put what has gone wrong right, whereas violence is the same with some form of anger, hatred, revenge, etc.

There are arguments to justify armed intervention which would prevent further worse bloodshed. In this terrible thing that's happening in Ukraine, if the soldiers are following their duty—this is the Buddha saying, well, you've been given a command, this is what you've determined to do with your life—if they kill soldiers and people of the other side, but there isn't any violent hatred in their hearts doing it, then obviously that would come under non-violence. But it still isn't something that they should be doing.

Now, the *Abhidhamma*, this later teaching, says that you can't kill any sentient being without some negativity in the heart. But as you can see, if somebody kills with hatred, revenge, or anger, that's a far worse place to come from than somebody who kills in order to defend themselves.

Very good. I can only hope my words have been of some assistance, and that by your devotion to non-violence, you will eventually liberate yourself from all suffering—sooner rather than later.

Gratitude, Generosity and Renunciation

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 12 min

Originally given as *Gratitude, Generosity and Renunciation* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this timely talk given during the season of giving, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines one of the ten perfections (pāramī) — generosity (dāna) — and its profound role in Buddhist spiritual development. Drawing from the Buddha's own story, he explains how perfect generosity gave the Awakened One the final push toward liberation, allowing him to 'open the gates of the Dhamma' for all beings.

Bhante distinguishes between ordinary generosity with expectations of return and true spiritual generosity — giving without any expectation of payback. The key practice involves suffusing one's mind with pure intention before making donations or offering help, while remaining vigilant against Māra's whispers of pride or stinginess that may arise afterward.

The foundation for developing genuine generosity lies in cultivating gratitude. Through reflecting on all we have received freely — from parents, teachers, society, healthcare, education, and countless daily kindnesses — we recognize the impossibility of repaying what has been given. This overwhelming sense of gratitude naturally inspires us toward greater generosity.

The talk reveals how generosity connects to renunciation (nekkhamma), as each act of giving involves letting go of our acquisitiveness and greed. This creates a 'virtuous circle' where gratitude leads to generosity, which cultivates renunciation, gradually undermining delusion and spiraling us toward nibbāna. A practical and inspiring teaching for integrating the pāramī into daily life.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa.

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble, and fully self-awakened one.

The topic for this evening was the ten perfections. Let me read through them: generosity, morality, and renunciation; wisdom, effort, and patience; honesty, determination, goodwill, and equanimity. This is one list I never bothered to learn—so you can see that's a bit too much for one evening.

What I've chosen is generosity, since we're at that time of year when we give presents. Generosity rates highly in the Buddhist teachings. If you remember the Buddha's own story, he went through that great doubt just before he became liberated—a doubt that really centred on who was he, of all people, to try and find the end of suffering. As the myth goes, the earth goddess rose and said he had every right to do this because he had fully perfected the virtue of generosity.

Basically, what gave him that last bit of extra energy, as far as I'm concerned, is that he knew he was doing it for other people. Think about Mount Everest: when Sherpa Tenzing and Edmund Hillary got up there, they opened the gates, and now everybody and his dog can climb it. It's the same with the Buddha. Once he discovered this path, as he said, the gates of the *dhamma* were opened—and that business of generosity was what gave him the last little push to go for it.

Whenever the Buddha is talking to lay people, he always starts with generosity. He points out that even thieves can be generous—after they've stolen a thousand pounds from you, they can always share it with their mates. What we have to distinguish is between ordinary generosity and spiritual generosity.

At this time of year, you're giving presents. If you spend a lot of money on an amazing pair of socks for a family member, and they send you a scrappy pair of gloves, you know what they're going to get next Christmas. It's a sort of generosity, but obviously there's a bit of payback. The same applies when you help people. If somebody asks you to help with their garden or do some decorating, you're very happy to—but you presume that when your garden needs doing, somebody will come back and do it for you. You're very upset if they don't. That's what you might call friendly generosity.

But I think we get to spiritual generosity when we make donations to charities that have nothing to do with us personally. Giving to organisations like Oxfam or Médecins Sans Frontières—we're obviously giving something, and there's not going to be any personal return for us at all.

That's a different sort of generosity, and we can call it spiritual generosity: giving something without any expectation. How do you do it? This is the point, you see, because normally speaking, even if we're not aware of it, there's always a

bit of greed in there. We're always doing it for some payback. Whenever you make a donation—whether you're putting money in a box or pressing a button on a screen—you have to suffuse the heart and mind with that intention: this is for such and such, and I don't expect and I don't want any return. That has to suffuse your mind, and then you press the button, or you drop the coin into the box.

That's what's conditioning you. And then of course the evil Mara will turn up and whisper in your ear, "You truly are a very generous person." As soon as you hear that, you say, "Ah, I saw you, Mara"—just like the Buddha did—"I see you, Mara, you didn't fool me this time." Or he might say something like, "That's too much, get some back." That's the old stingy Mara. As soon as that comes into your mind, you note it. You see it's there, but that wasn't the intention—that was not conditioning. This is really important: the actual conscious intention with which you do something is the main conditioning factor.

Keep this in mind: whenever you're going to give something, even to a friend, even if you're helping them with decorating, you can still do it as a pure gift. And that has the effect of developing in us a natural generosity.

The question is, how do you develop this generosity? Obviously there's compassion—if you feel bad about some situation, you're prepared to give. There's also joy: birthdays, Christmas, marriages. You give naturally because you want the other person to have even greater enjoyment, greater joy.

But these are dependent, you might say, on particular relationships—on compassion or joy. If we want to develop a general attitude of generosity, the real thing to cultivate is gratitude.

I don't know whether you've ever done this, but if you make a list of everything you've received in life for which you've not paid—things that were simply given to you—it can be a bit overwhelming. You realise it's impossible to pay back what you've been given.

Just start with your parents: even if they were the most awful, terrible people in the world who messed up your life completely, the fact is they fed you enough to keep you alive. And in this particular lifetime you happen to meet the *dhamma*, which is going to liberate you from suffering. So even for that you can be grateful. Then there's society: the health care you get, the social care, the education. Your parents could not have afforded all that. It was given because of the general commitment of the community towards individuals.

Then you've got teachers—your ordinary teachers through school, your spiritual teachers—all these people have given. And especially during school, I bet you never gave anything to your teachers. I don't remember doing so. As a teacher myself, the only thing I ever received was a bottle of wine from one of my students. Eight years for one bottle of wine. That was their expression of—well, I can't have been a very good teacher, that's all. That's what I put it down to.

Then your employers. You have to thank your employers whether you like them or not. They give you work, and it's through your work you earn money. What about the government? They never do what you want them to do, but somebody's got to do the dirty work, so you have to thank them for that.

And then there's all the little things—the gifts of the day. For instance, I was trying to get on the computer at the centre this morning, and Kristin and then Dita went out of their way to help me. Failed completely, of course, but the fact is they were there, just giving that bit of assistance. Even during the day, these small things—opening doors, saying "keep well," "I hope you're happy"—all those are little offerings to us that we don't recognise as generosity.

If you make a list of all the things you've received in this life, there arises this unrequited desire to repay. Of course you can't repay, and I doubt most of these people would want you to. But it invites you to really develop your own generosity.

Now, finally, the reason for all this is because it's part of the spiritual path. One of the perfections is generosity, supported by gratitude—which isn't listed but, shall we say, is presumed. But the other factor that comes in now is renunciation, just natural renunciation. And what we mean by renunciation is not feeding our desire to indulge our desires.

Every time we give something away—some of our wealth or some of our time—we're actually renouncing something. That process of renunciation is letting go of all the greed and everything that comes from acquisitiveness, which is the manifestation of delusion. So the more generous we are, the more we're undermining that sense of delusion.

And that will eventually—according to the commentaries, unfortunately it doesn't actually say this in the scriptures, but you can see the logic of it—just by exercising generosity, that in itself is a path to liberation.

So you can see there's a lovely little virtuous circle here: gratitude, generosity, and renunciation, which as it were just spirals us, twirls us up towards nibbāna.

I can only hope my words have been of some assistance, that I have not caused confusion, and that by your devotions of generosity, you will be liberated from all suffering sooner rather than later.

New Year Reflections

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 31 min

Originally given as *New Year Reflections* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this New Year's Day reflection, Bhante Bodhidhamma presents four spiritual undertakings that can guide our contemplation of the past year and intentions for the year ahead. Drawing from both monastic wisdom and practical lay life experience, he explores sufficiency (recognizing what is truly enough), surrender (yielding to the spiritual path rather than ego demands), celibacy (understanding relationship and attachment), and service (putting others' welfare first).

*Bhante examines how the Buddha himself refined monastic life, moving from extreme asceticism to a middle way that included beauty and orderliness alongside simplicity. He discusses the concept of *saṃvega* - spiritual urgency arising from contemplating life's brevity - and how this motivates us to examine our activities, friendships, and consumption patterns. The talk addresses the challenging question of how lay practitioners can engage in relationships without falling into dependency and attachment that causes suffering.*

Using vivid examples from daily life - from having too many garden forks to dealing with train delays - Bhante shows how these four principles can transform ordinary situations into opportunities for spiritual growth. The discussion culminates in exploring how true service involves genuine attention to others' needs rather than our own ideas of what help should look like, illustrated through stories of arahants living in perfect harmony through mutual care.

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā Sambuddhassa Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā Sambuddhassa Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā Sambuddhassa

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-enlightened one.

First, I want to make sure everybody understands that after this talk, the rest of the day until five o'clock is really for you. It's meant to be a time for reflection about your life, about the past year, and for making some of those resolutions for the next year—the ones we never keep. But they're there; they're part of our good intentions. I wanted to say a few things and then perhaps contemplate the life of Saddam Hussein as a point of reflection.

I want to talk about what are actually monastic vows, coming more clearly from the Christian tradition, though I think it might be better to call them spiritual undertakings or communal undertakings. I've called them S to the power of four.

The first is sufficiency, sometimes called simplicity—what in the old days they used to call poverty. The second is surrender, what they used to call obedience, but nobody likes that word these days. It's too hard for the ego. Don't want to be obedient. The third is celibacy. Say no more. And the fourth is service. These are four things we can contemplate about our lives.

This sufficiency thing—that's a nice word. What is sufficient? It brings us into this ecological business and the way the world is at this present time. Just go through your wardrobe and ask yourself, what's actually sufficient? That doesn't mean you have to be rigorous to the point of self-denial or self-mortification, ending up with one pair of shoes or something. It's more a sense of recognising that at certain times of our lives we need different shoes.

Even I have a pair of pumps, proper walking shoes. I've got a pair of ordinary shoes. I've got slippers. Now I would say that's sufficient for me. It's not a case of having some absolute standard, but just looking at what one has. Go around the house, go around your flat, and keep asking yourself: is this sufficient? Is this enough?

I remember when I sold my house just before I joined the order—I had four garden forks. I don't know how I ended up with four garden forks. I must have just gone into a shop and thought, that's a nice garden fork, bought it, come back, and gradually built up this stock. I had lots of knives, a massive amount of plates; don't know where they came from. Of course, I heaved them all off onto poor friends. I don't know what they've done with them.

If you look at the monastic order going back to the Buddha's time, taking into consideration the climate, housing was under a tree during the dry season and in a hut during the wet season—built just out of local grass. That's how simple you can get. In this climate I suppose you need a shed with some cladding.

When you look at your house—most of us have nice houses, nice flats—and you realise you've got more than sufficiency, then we should relax into that. We should say, oh yeah, I'm lucky, I've got more than I actually need. If you feel guilty about it, sell your house. But I don't think you should. What I'm saying is that sometimes we get into this consumerism where we're always going for the next thing, the next big house, the next fashion. But if you keep asking yourself what's sufficient, then contentment arises easily. You're just content with that. And then you're thankful that you've got more than you feel is sufficient. It's just a nice little reflection on the simplicity of life, sufficiency.

In the early days, the monks and nuns were happy with just rag robes taken off corpses left on the charnel grounds. That's what they did—the animals would come and eat the corpses, or they'd just corrupt, and the monks sewed the remaining cloth together. But the Buddha wasn't happy with that. He didn't like it when he saw groups of monks in rag robes tied higgledy-piggledy, washed but obviously dirtied. He didn't like that at all. So he ended up asking them to sew the robes in a way that reminded them of paddy fields—these strips, you see—and then to dye them with a particular nut, giving them a brownish colour so there was a sense of beauty and orderliness about it.

In Plato's understanding, if I get it right—please correct me otherwise—three things come together: wisdom, goodness and beauty. Beauty. It's interesting that in the Abhidhamma, all those mental states that are unwholesome they call unskillful, but the ones that are wholesome they use the word beautiful, *sobhana*. You have to be careful not to grow yourself into a rigorous prune-like existence, a dried prune existence. There has to be a certain levity about the spiritual life. There has to be a certain seasoning to it.

We can look at this idea of sufficiency and simplicity in our own lives, just check it out. Go back and see what you've got. But it's not only about what you have—it's how you live. Spiritually speaking, we have this core aim, this objective we call *nibbāna*. Now whether we have a clear idea of *nibbāna* or not, the fact is that it's a matter of purifying the heart—a purification that has to go on.

You look at your activities and ask yourself: why am I doing that? Right down to the simplest things, like why am I watching this program? Remember that anything I attend to is an act of intention, and therefore it's conditioning me. If I attend to a program that's just silly, just nothing—it comes under wrong speech in the sense of *samphappalāpa*. How do you translate that? Gossip, useless speech. You're watching a program that's basically useless.

And that's time. We talk about this word *saṃvega*, which means a sense of urgency about the spiritual life. When we consider the brevity of our life—sickness, old age, and death—we pull ourselves up short and ask: why am I watching that program? Why am I going to that show? Why am I going to that film? Why am I with these friends? They might not be the right friends anymore.

A lot of people who begin to move spiritually find they leave old friendships. It's not that they blame them or criticise them or anything like that. It's just that those friends don't draw them anymore, and there's a shift over to another type of friend. That can be a conscious thing, but often it's quite unconscious in the spiritual life. You do things not fully aware that you're actually moving. And then you realise your friends aren't calling you up because they got fed up with you and all your Buddhist stuff.

The second quality is surrender, which in the old days was called obedience. Surrender in the spiritual life means abandoning one's own ideas and lending oneself to the teachings. Every time you feel that resistance to what the spiritual life is calling you to, you see it as something negative, drawing you away. You have to make that act of surrender, yield. I think they have that in the States, don't they? When you go to a crossroad, yield. What a lovely word. You have to surrender to what the spiritual life is asking you to do.

We've got these basic rules, these basic precepts—like not to kill people. But they always have their opposites. When the first rule is not to harm any living being, that moves quickly towards taking care of all living beings. Not to take what is not freely given moves very easily into giving—not just when asked, but when you see a need. If you take all those negative sides, the way that you don't do things, you've only got to see that actually not doing those things—because we're in time, because we're in time and space and events have to happen—they're always beckoning you to do the opposite.

At all times—Sunday morning when you wake up and there's that desire just to turn over, roast the other side, and then the call comes: get up and meditate. Resistance. And then just to do as the old sailors did on the hammocks, you show a leg. You shake it out and get a feel of the air out there, then shake it off and say to yourself: God, I've got to surrender to the path. I've got to be obedient to it.

We find ourselves in situations that demand we follow a certain rule—even coming here, just following the rota, going into a workplace with their rules and regulations, going to see a friend and washing the pots like they wash the pots. It can be enormously annoying, can't it, when somebody comes in and washes the pots in a different way than you do? It's just using those little situations where you're going against your own conditioning to loosen you up a bit.

That's one of the benefits of coming on a retreat, especially a strong retreat—it snaps some of the old habits. And then it gives you strength. You know that you don't have to behave like that. Even not eating after lunch. Then you realise, oh yeah, nothing happens when I don't eat after lunch. Nothing happens. And then to take a day's fast and realise that nothing happens either. That allows us just to be more easy with life, able to move and shift with things. Not to get upset—you get on a train and it's late. That's the way it is.

People get very upset about that. I must say, the British aren't so bad. Usually a joke runs around the place. You're used to it, especially when they very truthfully announce that the train's been delayed because there's a cow on the line. Great announcements are made—leaves on the line, things like that. I must say, it's all got much better now. But you're driving along and you're in a traffic jam. What are you going to do? That's when you surrender to the situation. The situation is asking you to let go of what you want and to see things as they are. And of course with that surrendering, that yielding to the way it is, all that stress just evaporates. This is it. This is the way it is.

There's also that sense of surrendering to ourselves, just giving up on our own little dictates, those little dictates we give to ourselves. There's a whole area of looking at your life from the point of view of surrendering, yielding to situations. Of course we draw a line—we draw a line at the point of unskillfulness, at the point where we're doing harm. Sometimes that's not such an easy line to see, but as long as we don't mean to do harm, remember there's that stress in the Buddha's teaching: the harm that leads away from awakening, away from the path, is the harm we intend, not the harm we end up doing without knowing.

In fact, the story that goes with the Dhammapada verse I read out last night—the opening about everything being mind-made—is a story about how if you do evil, it follows you like the wheel of a cart follows the hoof of an ox. The story is of this arahant doing walking meditation, and he's crunching all these ants, so there's blood all over the place. The monks say to the Buddha, "Look what he's done. He's done this terrible harm to all these ants." The Buddha says, "He's blind. He doesn't know what he's doing. He doesn't see where he's going." And then there's always these little add-ons, these bolt-ons they put about the past life—he killed so many ants or something, and it's all coming back to him.

But that aside, the point is this: when we come across those shady areas where we don't quite know if something's right or wrong because of circumstance, we shouldn't be afraid to make decisions we're not entirely clear about. What matters is the intention—to do what's for the benefit of others, for the benefit of oneself. The Buddha always puts it this way: for the benefit of oneself, for the benefit of the other, for the benefit of both oneself and the other. There are times when you do things for your own benefit. That's not being selfish—that's self-caring. And that's another area where we sometimes become confused.

The third one is celibacy. I always like to coin a phrase from Churchill: some are born celibate, some become celibate, and others have celibacy thrust upon them. There are always times in our lives when we find ourselves not in a relationship. Those are times to see what role sexuality and romance and friendship—certain types of friendship—play in our lives. And to recognise that relationship is an option, not a necessity. Ever since Freud, sex has taken the role of food. But it's not. You can live without it.

When we find ourselves in situations where that sort of relationship isn't about, that's the time to really open up to the situation and relax into it. If one wants to go there, one makes the intention to move that way. But if it becomes an obsession, it creates a lot of suffering, doesn't it?

Now the question is, why is celibacy always seen as part of the direct path in the spiritual life, especially in Buddhism? Was it because the Buddha himself was celibate and he was just bitter about it? He didn't want anybody else to have a good time—hell, if I'm not going to do it, nobody else is going to do it. No. It's because of the attachment, of course. It's always this business of seeking happiness in the wrong place. We can see that seeking happiness in just the physicality of a relationship, just the sexual act by itself, is empty—it doesn't go anywhere.

I usually quote Woody Allen when he says sex is an empty experience, but as empty experiences go... That aside, romance involves a very strong connection with a person, which comes and goes of course, and can lead to a deeper friendship. The mistake is making one's own happiness dependent on that person. That's where the suffering is. When that person leaves or dies, there's this huge hole in one's heart—grief and all that.

The fact that the Buddha, having attained enlightenment, did not go back to the married life is a bit of a downer. It might have suggested that even after attaining enlightenment, there was still that sort of re-engagement in life. But there's a suggestion in the Buddha's life and within the tradition that this isn't possible.

Now in later Buddhism, of course, there was a movement against that, wasn't there? The lay life as a way one could also attain full liberation. And I think that in the lay life, one has to look at that and see the possibility. I don't see it as something which necessarily has to be against the spiritual life at all.

I much prefer the Hindus on this one—their way of approaching the whole spiritual life through total engagement in communal life. The Brahminical way is a bit patriarchal about the man, but equally so for the woman. The first twenty-five years you're a student, around that. Then you're supposed to marry, have children, go through all that. Then round about sixty, when all the children have grown up and all that's done, you remove yourself from society with your wife and try to live more separately, letting go of life—a renunciation, a post-renunciation. And then when you're seventy-five, you kick your wife out. It happens to your wife. But presumably she's kicked the bloke out as well. The point is that separation at the end of life—meeting, trying to go beyond that attachment to the world.

And of course, the next bit I'll talk about is service. That's where this slips into—all these things come out in that outward flow. The sufficiency, the surrender, the celibacy: these are internal. Of course they affect our relationships. But then somehow there has to be an outward flowing of that, and that's the sense of service.

It's just one of these paradoxes that we're most happy when we're giving. But as soon as that giving becomes self-conscious—as soon as we're doing it in order to feel happy, in order to feel worthy, for fame and all that stuff—then it becomes cancerous. Demands are put on that service. We only do certain things that make us happy. And you end up being a do-gooder, don't you?

A working definition of a do-gooder is the person who does you the good they want to do you, whether you want it or not. The usual example I give: you know somebody's sick and you go along with your chicken soup. They say, "I'm just too sick. I can't have that. I'm terribly sorry." Of course you understand that. You're a bit disappointed, but you understand. And then they say, "But listen, you could do something for me." You say, "Sure, what's that?" "Could you clean my toilet?" You had all these highfalutin ideas about how to help somebody. All you do is clean the toilet.

That sense of service is giving up one's own desires for the benefit of others—looking at the world from the other's point of view.

Now, there's a scripture in which the Buddha visits these three Arahants. Now, fair enough, they're fully enlightened and haven't got any selfishness left, and they're living together perfectly peacefully. The Buddha's with them, and he asks them, he says, "How do you do it? How do you live peacefully like this?" And of course, living out in the forest, in your hut, I mean, it's very simple. But Anuruddha says, "Well, we get up in the morning, go on Pindapat—we go on our alms round—and whoever's last out prepares the stuff for people coming back. And then we all come back with our food and we share it out, and whoever's last eating clears up." That's it. There's no—once your attention is on the other, what the other wants, life becomes very easy, isn't it? Because people are always looking out for you and you're always looking out for them.

So it becomes a sort of society based on this idea of generosity, on *dana*. As soon as you're playing your part and you're putting the other first, and then you see the other ones actually putting themselves first, then you get that shaking, don't you? So it needs a communal effort for everybody to live on behalf of the other. And because everybody's looking out for the other, then you have this harmony. At least that's the theory.

But as soon as somebody holds a position, you've had it. In the Buddhist order, there are these rules of how to work with disputes. So there are those disputes that have to be put under the mat and just leave it alone because you just get so caught up in what's right, what's wrong.

But keeping that in mind, I suppose the danger of putting the other first, especially with others who aren't doing that, is that they can abuse you. But generosity doesn't demand that you find yourself being abused, being used. You yourself have to be sensitive to that.

So these are four ways that you can look back on the years—on what you have and what you do with your life. The idea of sufficiency, the idea of surrendering to the path, doing what the path asks, that whole area of relationship—what sort of relationships do you want to cultivate—and the idea of service. It's just four points of recollection.

Good Friendship

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 22 min

Originally given as *Good Friendship* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



Drawing from the Aṅguttara Nikāya and the Sīgālaka Sutta (DN 31), Bhante Bodhidhamma presents the Buddha's detailed teachings on good friendship, both in worldly relationships and on the spiritual path. The talk explores seven essential qualities of good friends: giving what is hard to give, enduring difficulties, keeping confidences, remaining loyal during troubles, and maintaining respect.

The discourse examines four types of kind-hearted friends described in the Sīgālaka Sutta: the helpful friend, one who shares happiness and suffering, one who points out what is good, and the sympathetic friend. Each category includes practical examples, such as protecting friends from heedless actions, safeguarding their property, providing refuge during fear, and even the ultimate sacrifice of one's life for another.

The talk concludes with the famous exchange between Ānanda and the Buddha about spiritual friendship, where the Buddha corrects Ānanda's view that good friendship is 'half the spiritual life,' declaring instead that it is the entire spiritual life. Through good spiritual companionship, beings develop the Noble Eightfold Path and find liberation from birth, aging, death, and suffering. This teaching offers both self-reflection opportunities and practical guidance for cultivating meaningful relationships that support spiritual growth.

Good evening, everyone. I trust you've had a fruitful day. I don't say happy, though I hope it has been happy.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa.

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

Today we ran a little day retreat, and I think one or two people from that retreat will be here this evening. One thing that has come out of this lockdown is how people have become neighbourly—helping each other get food and such. It has brought out a friendship that was hidden before.

So I thought today might be a good time to look at one or two things the Buddha says about good friendship. These aren't from the Middle Length Sayings; they're taken from the Aṅguttara Nikāya, the collection of discourses arranged by numbers—one of these, two of those, right up to eleven. There's also a quotation from the Dīgha Nikāya, the Long Discourses, from a discourse to Sīgālaka—one devoted to lay people. And there's one from the Connected Sayings about friendship, about good friendship in the spiritual life.

My idea is that I'll read out what the Buddha says about good friendship. There are two sides to the question. First, we have to bring somebody to mind—or some people—whom we consider good, close friends. Of course, your closest friend, if you're married or in partnership, would be your partner, or your parents, or whatever. But just bring certain people to mind, and we're going to ask ourselves: would they? And then afterwards: would I?

The first teaching is this: one should associate with a friend who possesses seven factors.

They give what is hard to give.

So the first time round, think of somebody you know—somebody who's a friend. Would they give something that is hard to give? Would they do something for you that was hard to do? In other words, would they make a little sacrifice?

Would they patiently endure what is hard to endure? In other words, when you're being nasty.

Would they reveal their secrets to you? Would they give you that kind of confidence?

And would you have confidence in them not to tell your secrets to others?

They would not forsake you when you're in trouble.

They would not look down upon you. The word in the text is 'despise', but I think that's a bit strong.

Now let's turn to ourselves. Would we show these qualities towards certain people in our lives?

Would we give what is hard to give? Think of an example. It doesn't have to be just one person—but have you actually given what was hard to give?

Have you done what was hard to do?

Have you endured what was unpleasant about them?

Have you revealed secrets to them that you wouldn't want other people to know? And have you kept confidentiality—have you preserved their secrets?

Have you ever forsaken somebody who was in trouble? Just not helped them when you could have done?

Have you looked down upon friends on occasion? Or have you indulged that? Occasionally it might happen, but have you actually indulged in looking down upon them, thinking badly of them?

Now there follows a verse: 'A friend gives what is hard to give and does what is hard to do. They forgive you your harsh words and endure what is hard to endure. They tell you their secrets and they preserve your secrets. They do not forsake you in difficulties and they do not look down upon you. The person in whom these qualities are found is a friend. One desiring a friend should resort to such a person.'

That's the first description of a friend. The next one is similar, of course, but it does have a little twist.

One should associate with a friend who possesses—again—seven qualities.

First, they are pleasing and agreeable. That's an easy one, isn't it?

Second, they are respected—someone who is generally held in esteem. If you look around at your friendships, you'll have to choose.

Third, they are a speaker. I tried to find out what exactly that means. I couldn't really discover the intended meaning, and there are no notes on it, so you'll just have to imagine what it refers to.

Fourth, do they patiently endure being spoken to? That's when you have to say something they don't like but which is, from your point of view, for their good.

Fifth, do they engage in deep conversation?

And sixth, do they not encourage you to do something wrong?

Now what about us? How have we acted in the past?

Have we been pleasing and agreeable?

Can we be respected?

Do we patiently endure being spoken to, being corrected?

Do we talk deeply about things—or at least go into them a little more than just surface talk?

And do we not lead people into wrongdoing?

This is followed by a verse: 'They are dear, respected and esteemed, a speaker and one who endures speech, one who gives deep talks and does not enjoin one to do what is wrong. The person in whom these qualities are found is a friend, benevolent and compassionate. Even if one is dismissed by him, one desiring a friend should resort to such a person.'

So even if you meet somebody like that but they don't particularly want to know you, you should still try to find someone similar.

Now there's another way of describing good friends—four kinds. This is the advice the Buddha was giving to Sīgāḷaka.

He says there are four kinds of kind-hearted friends. Again, see if you can think of somebody:

The friend who is helpful.

A friend who shares one's happiness and suffering.

A friend who points out what is good.

And a friend who is sympathetic.

Now what about ourselves? How do we see ourselves?

Are we helpful?

Do we share our happinesses and sufferings, our disappointments?

Do we point to what is good?

Are we sympathetic?

The Buddha describes four cases of a helpful friend.

They protect you when you're heedless. Think of someone who's helped you in a moment of heedlessness.

They look after your property when you're heedless—not necessarily your house, but whatever you've asked them to look after.

Are they a refuge when you're frightened?

And when a need has arisen, have they given twice the wealth required? That's a big ask. In other words, have they given more than you asked for?

What about us?

Have we protected someone who was about to be heedless—about to do something that wouldn't have looked good?

Have we protected their property when they've been heedless?

Have they been able to take refuge in us when they're frightened or anxious about something?

And when someone's asked for financial help, have we given them a little bit more?

Then there are four cases of a friend who shares one's happiness and sufferings. We've come across some of these already.

They reveal their secrets to you.

They guard your secrets.

They don't abandon you when you're in trouble.

And this is the big one: they would sacrifice their life for your sake.

Think of anybody who might sacrifice their life for you. It's a tall order, isn't it?

What about us?

Have we shared somebody's happiness and suffering?

Have we not abandoned them when in trouble?

And this final one: is there anyone for whom we would sacrifice our life?

Jesus of course said there is no greater gift than to give one's life for another. And there have been cases in history. The one that came to mind was actually a novel: *A Tale of Two Cities*. Out of love—Sydney Carton, is it?—he finally goes to the guillotine in place of the man his true love actually loved. She didn't love him. But he was happy to offer his life for her happiness. "It's a far, far better thing I do now than I've ever done before."

Finally, there are four cases of a friend who points out what is good.

They restrain you from evil. We've had something like that before.

They enjoin you to do what is good—they encourage you towards it.

They inform you of what you have not heard. I presume this means that if somebody says something about you, they will let you know—especially if it's something that might harm you.

And they point you to the path of heaven—which is, of course, the ethical path.

There are four cases of a sympathetic friend.

They do not rejoice in your misfortune. Can you think of somebody who doesn't rejoice in your misfortune?

And they rejoice in your good fortune.

They stop those who dispraise you.

They commend those who speak praise of you.

But what about us?

When a friend of ours falls into misfortune, do we rejoice or not? Can you think of an occasion?

Do we rejoice in a friend's good fortune? Or are we caught up in jealousy or envy?

Do we stop somebody who's speaking badly about our friend?

And do we commend those who speak well of them?

This final quality also points us toward spiritual friendship.

Here's Ānanda. Ānanda always claims to know something, and then the Buddha always has to correct him.

So Ānanda says, "Bhante, this is half the spiritual life—that is, good friendship, good companionship, and good comradeship."

And the Buddha replies, "No, not so, Ānanda, not so. This is the entire spiritual life, Ānanda—that is, good friendship, good companionship, good comradeship. When a person has a good friend, a good companion, a good comrade, it is expected that they will develop and cultivate the Noble Eightfold Path."

Having a good friend on the spiritual path is obviously a great support. I've known cases where one person within a marriage became a Buddhist and the other just couldn't stand it—found it very threatening. It was a difficult time. Eventually it sorted itself out, but if you happen to be in a relationship where both of you are committed to the path, you can see what a great support that would be.

The sutta ends by explaining how the entire spiritual life is good friendship, good companionship, good comradeship. The Buddha speaks of himself here—you see, that confidence we should have in him—saying: "By relying upon me as a good friend, beings subject to birth are freed from birth; beings subject to old age are freed from aging; beings subject to death are freed from death; beings subject to sorrow, lamentation, pain, dejection, and despair are freed from sorrow, lamentation, pain, dejection, and despair. By this method, Ānanda, it may be understood how the entire spiritual life is good friendship, good companionship, and good comradeship."

In other words, when we take refuge in the Buddha and his teaching, they become our very good spiritual companions.

These are just reflections—a way we can use the discourses to consider ourselves and to move along the path. I can only hope that you are moving along the path and that you will be liberated from all suffering sooner rather than later.

We can begin our practice.

At Sāmagāma Discourse (MN 104)

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 20 min

Originally given as *At Sāmagāma Discourse (MN 104)* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this discourse on the Sāmagāma Sutta (MN 104), Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the Buddha's wisdom regarding disputes and their resolution, sparked by the division among Jain followers after their leader's death. The talk explores the Buddha's identification of six roots of dispute: anger and vengefulness, contemptuous domineering, envy and avarice, deceit and fraud, evil wishes with wrong view, and rigid adherence to one's views. The Buddha outlines seven methods of settlement for four types of litigation, including removal by confrontation, majority opinion, and the beautiful practice of 'covering over with grass' - allowing heated disputes to cool before resolution. Bhante emphasizes how these ancient teachings apply directly to modern workplace conflicts, political disagreements, and community disputes. The discourse reveals the Buddha's preparation for his passing, ensuring the Saṅgha would have clear guidelines for maintaining harmony. The talk concludes with the six memorable qualities that create love, respect, and unity - teachings that remain profoundly relevant for creating peaceful relationships in contemporary life.

This evening we're looking at the Samagama Sutta. This discourse concerns the Jains again—what happened, according to Buddhist propaganda you might say, when the Nigantha, the leader of the Jains, died. I don't know whether events unfolded exactly as described, but definitely something happened.

Here's what is said: on his death, the Niganthas split into two factions. They had taken to quarrelling and brawling and were deep in dispute, stabbing each other with verbal daggers.

"You don't understand this Dharma and discipline. I understand this Dharma and discipline. How could you understand it? Your way is wrong. My way is right. I am consistent. You are inconsistent. What should have been said first, you said

last. What should have been said last, you said first. What you had so carefully thought up has been turned inside out. Your assertion has been shown up. You are refuted. Go and learn better, or disentangle yourself if you can."

Daggers, definitely. So it seems there was nothing but slaughter amongst the Nigantha's pupils—I think that's a bit of an older expression; I don't think it means physical slaughter. And the white-clothed lay disciples were disgusted, dismayed, and disappointed with the Nigantha's pupils, as they were with "so badly proclaimed and badly expounded dharma and discipline, which was un-emancipating, unconducive to peace, expounded by one not fully enlightened, and was now with its shrine broken, left without a refuge." That's a bit of Buddhist propaganda, I think.

Anyway, the novice Chunda—seemingly a younger brother of Sariputta—was spending the rains in Pava, where the Nigantha supposedly died. He met Ananda and told him about all these goings on. Ananda said, "We'd better go and have a chat with the Blessed One." So they tell the Buddha everything that's been happening.

The Buddha replies, "What do you think, Ananda? These things that I have taught you directly—my teachings, the thirty-seven factors that lead to liberation, the Bodhipakkhiya Dhamma: the four foundations of mindfulness, the four right kinds of striving, the four bases of spiritual power, the five faculties, the five powers, the seven factors of enlightenment, the Noble Eightfold Path. I'm sure you understand all those. Do you see even two bhikkhus who make differing assertions about these things? Do you see any disputes arising?"

"No, Venerable Sir, I don't even see two monks differing about this. But Venerable Sir, there are people who live deferential towards the Blessed One who might, when he's gone, create a dispute in the Sangha about livelihood and about the Patimokkha, the rule. Such a dispute would be for the harm and unhappiness of many, for the loss, harm, and suffering of gods and humans."

The Buddha replies. A dispute about livelihood or about the Patimokkha—livelihood meaning how they live. Remember, "bhikkhus" stands for all four assemblies: monks, nuns, laywomen, laymen. The Patimokkha here is the specific institutional rules that govern the order, but as lay people you can take it as the moral law.

He said a dispute about that would be trifling. But should a dispute arise in the Sangha about the path and the way, such a dispute would be for the harm and unhappiness of many, the loss, harm, and suffering of gods and men. So he was much more concerned about the Dharma.

Now he says there are six roots to disputes, and I think most of these we'll recognise. You can bring this into your daily life—where you've seen it in the workplace, amongst your friends, and of course in politics.

The first: someone is angry and revengeful and dwells disrespectful and undeferential towards the teacher, towards the Dharma, towards the Sangha, and doesn't fulfill the training. If we see any such root of dispute, either in ourselves or externally, we should strive to abandon that same evil root and make sure it doesn't arise in the future. That's the great effort—one of the great efforts, isn't it? To let go of something unwholesome and to stop the unwholesomeness arising. So the first root is this business of anger and revenge.

Then there's contempt. Anger and revenge could be, for instance, of an employee towards the employer. Contemptuous and domineering could be the employer towards the employee.

Then, of course, there's always envy and avarice—wanting what other people have.

There's deceit and fraud, fiddling the books.

There's evil wishes and wrong view—basically wishing somebody would drop dead or something.

And there are those who adhere to their own views tenaciously and relinquish them with difficulty, even when they're wrong. They won't negotiate, they won't compromise.

The Buddha then describes four kinds of litigation—situations where things have to be sorted out formally. There's litigation because of a dispute, litigation because of an accusation, litigation concerning an offence, and litigation about proceedings. So there are four reasons why you take things to court in the order: first, to work out a disagreement; second, to sort out an accusation made against somebody; third, to address a specific offence; and fourth, to settle questions about proceedings.

To resolve these, there are seven kinds of settlement. Once we look at these, it becomes clear what the four types of litigation actually involve. And again, this has a direct connection with ordinary daily life.

The first is removal by confrontation. So there's a dispute, much like the one among the Jains: 'It is the Dharma. It is not the Dharma. This is the discipline. This is not the discipline,' and so on. What the Buddha says is that everybody should meet in concord—in other words, come together with a heart of goodwill. Having met, the guideline of the Dharma should be drawn out; they should actually discuss the way, the teaching. Remember, he's preparing the order for when he's not there. And once the guideline has been drawn out, the litigation should be settled in a way that accords with it.

Supposing that doesn't work, there is the opinion of the majority. If those bhikkhus can't settle the litigation in that dwelling place, they should go to a dwelling place where there's a greater number of bhikkhus. In other words, you go to a different court, a higher court, for guidance and a decision. So the opinion of the majority settles the dispute.

The next three settlements deal with individual offences—more like people who commit crimes.

The first is litigation on account of memory. Here a monk reproves another monk—this is more to do with monks, but as I say, you can easily transfer it into ordinary daily life. So somebody reproves somebody else of a grave offence, in this case one involving defeat or bordering on defeat. Remember, the rules of defeat cover killing, stealing, any sexual intercourse, and creating a split in the Sangha, the order of monks. Transferred to society, that last one would be something like creating hate speech.

So the question is put: 'Does the Venerable One remember having committed such a grave offence involving defeat?'

'I do not, friends. I do not remember having committed such a grave offence.'

In this case, the removal of litigation on account of memory should be pronounced. In other words, it looks as though the witnesses were unreliable, or perhaps there were no witnesses at all—it may have been hearsay. We have to give the benefit of the doubt to the bhikkhu who says he doesn't remember any such thing and that somebody is defaming him.

The next settlement is litigation on account of past insanity. Here again, a bhikkhu reproves another bhikkhu of a grave offence involving defeat.

'Does the Venerable One remember having committed such a grave offence involving defeat?'

'I do not remember having done so.'

Despite the denial, the former presses the latter further: 'Surely the Venerable One must know quite well if he remembers having committed such and such an offence.'

And he says, 'Oh, I had gone mad, friend. I was out of my mind. When I was mad, I said and did many things improper for a recluse, but I don't remember. I was mad when I did it.'

In this case, because he was mad, the litigation is removed. It's not taken any further.

He might of course be lying. But some of you might have read a book called *The Man Who Mistook His Wife for a Hat*, which was quite a bestseller—oh, I don't know, sometime in the eighties. It was written by Oliver Sacks, a great psychiatrist and writer about mental diseases. There was a case in there of a man who murdered his daughter—did terrible damage to her. If I remember rightly, it was an adopted daughter. He couldn't remember what he'd done, and he was believed. They put him in a mental home.

While he was there, the nurses and people around him became more and more confident about him, and they would allow him out on a bicycle ride. One day while he's riding, he hits something and bumps his head—and he remembers what he did. According to Oliver Sacks, it took them six months to stop him from trying to commit suicide. So things can happen where you just basically forget. That's called madness, and as we've seen, it probably is.

Now there's another settlement: effecting acknowledgement of an offence. In this case, a monk has done something wrong. He accepts it and goes to apologise. He reveals it and discloses it. He goes to a senior bhikkhu and, after arranging his robe, paying homage at his feet, and sitting to the side with palms together, he says, 'Venerable sir, I've committed such and such an offence, and I confess it.'

The response is, 'Do you see what you've done?'

'Yes, I do.'

'Will you practise restraint in the future?'

'I will practise restraint in the future.'

Now, this applies only to the lesser rules. Every half moon, the monks gather to make this confession. This is the actual dialogue: you say you've committed so many offences—you don't have to name them specifically, although in some orders you do. The response is, 'Do you see what you've done?' You say, 'I have. I've seen what I've done.' 'Will you restrain in the future?' 'I will restrain.' Every two weeks, as it were, the slate is wiped clean. But remember, this is only for the lesser offences.

Then there's the pronouncement of bad character against someone. Here, somebody is reproved for a grave offence—one involving defeat, and so on. He says, 'I do not remember having committed the grave offence.' Despite the denial, the accuser presses. Again he denies it. And again, despite the denial, the accuser presses. Finally, he does actually admit it.

This reminds you of libel cases, really, where somebody is trying to defend themselves against libel. Eventually, of course, it turns out the libel wasn't libel at all—it was true. And such a person has a pronouncement of bad character made against them.

If the order does that—I'm not exactly sure what it means in practice—but probably he says, 'I remember having committed such a grave offence, one involving defeat or bordering on defeat. I was hurried. I was confused when I said that I did not remember having committed such a grave offence.' And so there comes a settlement on this.

I think once somebody has bad character pronounced against him, he has to leave that monastery. And once he's done that, he's got to find support from somewhere else. If the lay people begin to recognise that he's not behaving properly as a monastic, they can refuse to offer him food and so on. Eventually, he could be driven simply to disrobe.

The final one, I think, is a lovely way to deal with something. It's called covering over with grass. It's not the same as sweeping under the carpet—not trying to forget it.

Here there's quarrelling and brawling, deep disputes, and the parties may have said and done many improper things. They should all meet together and try to come to some agreement. But the disputes and the brawling are far too heated.

For the good of everyone involved, for benevolence towards themselves, they confess—but there's an inability to reach agreement. And so the thing is to put grass over it and let it simmer for a while. Let it just rest. When the heat's gone out of the argument, then it's possible to bring it back.

Finally, the Buddha says these six memorable qualities create love and respect, and conduce to helpfulness, to non-dispute, to concord, and to unity. This is repeated in another discourse that we'll be looking at tomorrow. And we'll see the actual dispute that arises, which gives us some idea of what monks can get up to.

I hope that at least this has been informative and has increased your confidence in the Buddha and his teachings—and that this will drive you on to liberate yourself from all suffering sooner rather than later.

PART 4

The Path of Meditation



Bhāvanāmayā paññā — Wisdom born of meditation

Right Awareness: Introduction to Vipassanā

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 28 min

Originally given as *Right Awareness: Introduction to Vipassanā* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this teaching, Bhante Bodhidhamma traces the Buddha's spiritual journey to illuminate what sammā sati (Right Awareness) truly means in vipassanā meditation. Beginning with Prince Siddhattha's existential crisis upon encountering sickness, old age, and death, the talk follows his exploration of jhāna states with spiritual teachers and extreme ascetic practices, neither of which resolved his fundamental question about the meaninglessness of conditioned existence.

The pivotal moment comes when the Buddha-to-be remembers his childhood experience of natural absorption while watching his father's ploughing ceremony—a state combining deep concentration with open curiosity, free from conceptual overlay. This "original mind" of direct perception becomes the foundation for investigating the three characteristics (tilakkhana) of existence: impermanence (anicca), unsatisfactoriness (dukkha), and not-self (anattā).

Bhante explains how vipassanā practice requires drawing our intuitive intelligence away from intellectual confusion back to direct bodily experience and sense-base awareness. He distinguishes between formal sitting meditation—where we observe with childlike openness—and clear comprehension (sampajañña) in daily activities, where awareness accompanies intentional action. Practical guidance includes observing flowers without mental commentary, listening to sounds without identification, and eating with direct tongue-contact awareness. This gradual training in present-moment awareness, grounded in the Buddha's own discovery, forms the essential foundation for insight meditation leading to liberation.

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā Sambuddhassa. Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā Sambuddhassa. Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā Sambuddhassa — Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-enlightened one.

Remember, the Buddha was brought up in an aristocratic family. Later tradition builds him up into this great kingship and all that, but basically his father was a vassal to the local king. His people were just part of that empire at the top of India, bordering Nepal. Being of the Kshatriya caste — the warrior caste — his education would have been mainly about flashy swords and shields, maybe a bit of astrology, things like that. It wouldn't include any cooking or domestic stuff, so we can presume he lived a fairly happy life, sensually anyway, just getting what he wanted. Somewhere in his twenties he got married, and round about twenty-nine he left his wife and newborn child.

For us, of course, that sounds terrible — desertion. But you have to remember it was an extended family; it wasn't as though his wife was out on the street. Still, if somebody leaves a home and the people they love, one presumes there's something very urgent in that need. We can only presume he had what we would call an existential crisis.

Remember, it's put in that mythological sense: as he's taken out to do some hunting, he comes across a very sick person, a very old person, a corpse, and an ascetic sitting under a tree. They're called messengers from the gods. What the myth is trying to tell us is that somewhere in his mid-twenties he came out of youth and realised that what he was heading for was sickness, old age and death. That can come as a shock — this realisation that all the effort we put into life, everything we do personally, just ends up as a load of ashes scattered here and there. The basic meaninglessness of life.

In his day, of course, this would have also included the idea of rebirth or reincarnation. That meant having done all that which was completely meaningless, ending up as a pile of ashes, he'd have to do it all over again — and again and again. It seemed a ceaseless process, life after life going through the same routine. That was partly the despair of the age, mirrored in the many people moving out of lay life into some sort of ascetic practice. There were many other religious teachers; perhaps the other famous one was the person who founded the Jain tradition, a contemporary of the Buddha.

When he left, I find it a bit like the hippies in the sixties — you left everything, though for a different purpose. We have to imagine he's in a pretty turbulent mental state when he leaves home. It's put mythologically, of course: in the dark night he leaves on his horse, Kanthaka, with his servant. He goes to the river, crosses the river — the Rubicon — and there's a change of life. He cuts his hair off, all that. Even his horse dies of grief. Can you imagine? It's a terrible time.

Now he's left what we would call the sensual life, the life of pleasure, the consumerist life. What drives him there is the essential sense of uselessness about it — the vapid uselessness of sensual pleasure if you're seeking true happiness, everlasting happiness.

The first thing he does is join teachers who show him how to establish very beautiful states of mind, blissful states. You'll find this in all religions — the ecstasies. The great thing about *jhāna*, the absorptions as we call them, is that you don't need anything at all once you can access them. Last night we did a little bit of *mettā* practice. Just by repeating that gently over and over, there's a draw inward, and the heart begins to respond. A lovely beauty comes to it, and the body feels good. As you draw inward to that, you leave the body into a beautiful state of the inner mind. You can stay there.

All you need is a loincloth and a bit of food. You need a little bowl, hang about, go and get your porridge, come back, sit under a tree, and get blissed out all day. The problem, he found, was that when he came out of it, he was still the depressed, anxious Siddhartha Gotama.

Even though he'd now found a joy far superior to the ordinary transient pleasures of life — something you could really maintain within yourself, and when you become an adept you could just click into it, settle down and in you went into this inner ecstasy — there was this sense of uselessness again. Eventually you came out of it. It wasn't eternal, and although it wasn't based on anything outside yourself, it was based on some technique, some ability within yourself.

He had two teachers, and both took him to a point where they actually invited him to come and teach with them. But he hadn't really solved this gnawing problem in his heart concerning the meaninglessness of life — that true existential angst.

The next thing he tries are mortification exercises. For this he was obviously influenced by the Nigantha, the Jain founder. The Jains have an idea that the *jīva*, the soul, is weighed down by these clumps of chewing gum — karmic clumps. When you do something wrong, it's like a splodge on your soul that keeps it weighted down. The way to get rid of it was through heavy mortification exercises; all these splodges fell off and the soul rose to the highest heaven. It's very material, a very concrete idea of what happened.

Of course there's a truth in it — once our defilements disappear, we do enter into a very beautiful state. But the understanding was that the body itself was the problem. You wouldn't have greed if you didn't feed your hunger. If you denied yourself all sex, you wouldn't have any lust. The idea of the ascetic life was to deny the body, to draw it down to essentially just bones and a bit of muscle, and keep yourself away from the world. Eventually everything would just drop off. The Jain saint is one who starves themselves to death, by which time of course they're not attached to anything.

Siddhartha tried these exercises, and he talks of being able to hold his spine through his stomach. Have you tried that? He got thin, really thin. But unfortunately, he still ended up miserable. There came a point where he realised this wasn't taking him anywhere either. He almost killed himself, you could say.

At that point, he leaves his five companions. We can only presume he's in a state of despair. He'd gone out with this real hope of finding an end to his inner suffering — this inner meaninglessness of life — and he'd tried all these famous teachers, almost killed himself with mortification exercises, and he's still stuck. He still hasn't answered this deep inner problem. One can only presume he's feeling pretty wretched standing there on the roadside.

Some of you will know that Sujata comes with an offering of rice pudding for the local god. It's actually rice cakes, but I much prefer rice pudding. Seeing this poor wretch, she offers it to him. In the literature you'll see that he's shining like a god, and she mistakes him for one — but basically he's pretty miserable. Eating this stuff revives him.

Shortly after that — and this is why we call him self-enlightened — he has a memory. As a child, he'd watched his father doing a ploughing ceremony to open the ploughing season. He remembers the state he was in while watching. It was an absorption state, but also full of inquiry, full of curiosity. It was the first time he'd really become aware of this ceremony. He was just a child.

At this point, his whole practice turns around on itself. He's no longer trying to escape suffering by finding some other heavenly state. He now turns upon suffering and asks the question: how does suffering arise in the first place? With that new inspiration, he goes to sit under a tree. He sees no other way apart from this particular attack, and he determines to sit there either to crack this problem or die. Lucky for him, lucky for us, he cracks it in a mere six hours. From that point on, something has deeply changed within him — his relationship to the world has been completely turned around.

Now let's go back a step and consider this state he remembers from childhood. Take anybody under six or seven, that age. When you see a child looking at something they've not seen before — like a beetle — their eyes become fixed on it, they even stop blinking. The jaw drops and they look gormless. They're completely fixated. There's no thought in the mind because they can't describe it; there's no concept to attach to it. Then when it's completely absorbed, they turn around and say, 'What is it?' And the beautiful parent says, 'That's a beetle.'

From that point on, that child never sees a beetle again. Because every time we see a beetle, we put the experience of all past beetles onto it. The life we lead is constantly being distorted by concepts, by our history.

In order to find this path to the end of suffering, we have to go back to that mental state — what Zen calls the original mind, the original mind of the child. That is our difficulty: to draw this intelligence, the Buddha within, out of its confusion with the intellect. All meditation techniques are trying to make us do that. That's the prime object. All this stuff about mindfulness and constant attention, concentration — all of it is subservient to the point of trying to purify this intelligence we have, this intuitive intelligence.

For instance, in this technique — and I'll go into it in more detail this evening — the idea of using a single word is to draw the intellect down to a singular concrete concept: rising, falling. There's no thinking around it. At that level, it's possible to draw this intelligence directly into the experience that's happening, which is at the level of sensation, of feeling.

Whatever techniques you've practised, you'll see that they always draw you back to your body, back to your sense base. It's there that you begin to rediscover this way of looking at things. The practice of quiet abiding that we do is to clarify that awareness — an awareness which is not engaging, which is completely open. Just like the child's mouth dropped, just like its eyes fixed: just receiving, just receiving.

It's only when that has been established that we bring in this quality of curiosity. It's an open curiosity, the curiosity of a cat. It mustn't come from any expectation or any ideas — just a complete state of curiosity, best coming from a position of don't know, don't know. That's what we mean by right awareness in terms of its quality.

But this curiosity, remember, has already been educated to look at certain things — and that's where the three characteristics come in. If you go to anybody who's into science, anybody who's into nature, an artist, they all have to develop that open-mindedness again, or else they just repeat. The whole point about an original artist is that they see the world differently, and to do that they have to drop all the art they've learnt before. A philosopher has to drop all past philosophy in order to see in a new way. A scientist has to investigate not from the point of view of what has already been discovered, but from what has not been discovered. It's the new question, the new way of looking at things, that brings discovery.

Even so, there is that scientific knowledge, that philosophical knowledge, all the artistry sitting as it were behind, supporting the looking. So with us it's the Buddha dhamma — especially the teaching around impermanence, the role of desire as the cause of psychological suffering, and the fact that nothing has any substance. Nothing's real that you can point to and say, 'This is real, this is me.' Because every time you hold on to something that's me, it's constantly disappearing.

When we sit, we put all that to the side. At the end of last night's instructions I said: putting all instruction aside. You use your instructions, you use your techniques to get yourself primed to a point where you're just observing, just feeling, just experiencing what's drawing your attention within the field of awareness. It's simply that — and it's the simplicity which foxes us. We're looking for something a little bit cleverer than that, something a bit more demanding.

As long as we understand that in our practice we keep bringing ourselves back to that simplicity, then slowly but surely that original mind begins to manifest much more obviously to us. We know when we're in it, and we know when we're not.

The other thing, of course, is to bring that same sense of mindfulness into daily life. This morning we were talking about work — about actually bringing it into everything we do: when we're conversing with each other, when we're thinking about something like planning our holiday, when we're doing something.

There, obviously, it's a different type of awareness. The awareness now is into action, into doing. Before, it was abstracted — it had found this observation post within ourselves — but now it has to re-enter. It has to re-enter the psychophysical organism: body, mind and heart, and through these into the world.

Once that happens, the idea is not so much to be observing ourselves, but to have still that wide open awareness — so that we're aware not only of what we're doing, but of what we're feeling. We know, for instance, when we meet somebody and feel a high degree of irritation and hatred. On the surface of things, I may be presenting a very kind, lovable, huggable person, but inside I just want to strangle them. Here I am, not getting caught up in either, but putting my attention more in the process of observing.

When I'm at work, outwardly doing my job very well — all very diligent and all that — inwardly I'm utterly and completely bored, and I'm aware of that. Somehow I can stand above it. I can be with the boredom and yet pay attention to what I'm doing and come from a different place — a place of wisdom, a place of compassion — whereby I can actually put my energy into the right intention.

I can only do that if I can dissociate from, disidentify from, this boredom, this irritation, this depression, this anxiety. As soon as I drop into an identity — I am bored — then who's going to get me out of that? As soon as I say, 'I am depressed,' that's it, I'm stuck. I'm depressed.

The whole point of this meditation is to continue that sense of objectivity within us — not suppressing it, not pushing it aside, not turning away from it, but allowing it to express itself at that level of awareness somewhere within the field. Meanwhile, my attention is on what I'm supposed to be doing, and with that attention comes an intention. Whenever I place my attention, it must be an act of intention. And that's what's conditioning me.

Every time I start a job, every time I meet somebody, every time I go to work, every time I come to sit — there has to be just that moment of inward gazing. There has to be a sort of global awareness of both what's outside and what's inside. And then, having recognised it, I can make a skilful decision as to what I'm going to do.

That's the distinction between vipassanā — which is about investigating the three characteristics — and mindfulness in daily life. What this draws us to, as the Buddha says, is clear comprehension. That's his phrase for mindfulness in daily life: clear comprehension. When you're stretching your arm, you know you're stretching your arm. When you're opening the fridge, you know you're opening the fridge. When you're closing the fridge, you know you're closing the fridge. In other words, you're not walking out of the kitchen and slamming the fridge be-

hind you. When the bell goes for lunch, your mind is not already in the dining room with your body catching up ten minutes afterwards. Your mind knows it's going to the dining room, but your attention is right on your footsteps.

This is the practice: knowing where you're going, yet constantly bringing yourself back to what's actually happening now. That distinction has to be made. Otherwise, you might make the mistake of trying to observe yourself at all times of the day — and that just drives you potty, frankly. On the other hand, you might think, 'Well, when I'm meditating, I'm trying to create something. I'm trying to see these three characteristics.' That's wrong effort.

You have to have a certain faith that there is within us this quality — this Buddha nature, call it what you wish — which is constantly seeking its own liberation. That's what's suffering. It's constantly seeking liberation, constantly seeking understanding. And it's crying out all the time: get that meditator out of the way!

So as soon as you see yourself trying to do something — trying to see, trying to attain — turn on it and say, 'You're the meditator, get out of the way.' And then start again. Start again.

During the day, you can practise this open awareness as you walk around the grounds. Put your attention on a flower, for instance. See how the mind immediately tries to position it — what type of flower it is, describing it, how wonderful it is. Let all that pass. Just keep the eye on the flower and be aware of the process of perception. How is the eye seeing the flower? Not what you think about it, whether you've seen one before and all that rubbish — just how is the eye seeing the flower?

When you're out there walking — or sitting, actually, since we might walk into something — close your eyes and start listening. See how the mind wants to know what bird it is and where it is. Let that go and put your attention entirely on the process of hearing. What is it you're actually hearing?

When you go for a meal — and I'll remind you of this when we go for lunch — as soon as you put food on the tongue, there's always that comparison: 'This isn't curry. This isn't pizza.' There's always that. 'Oh, this is wonderful.' See it? Let all that pass. Put your attention directly on the tongue, and you're back to being a child. You're back to being a person who can directly experience what's coming from the body.

This is the beginning of our practice — all the time, to come back to the body. The body offers us its sensations, its feelings. It offers us moods and emotions as felt sense. By drawing ourselves into that, leaving thought alone, we begin to have these deeper insights into our nature. And before long, we will surely be liberated.

The scriptures talk about so-and-so having listened to the word of the Buddha, going away into the jungle and forest to practise, and in no length of time becoming fully liberated. The commentarial gloss is 'after twenty-five years' — so it's a gradual process, a gradual process.

Very good. I can only hope my words have been of some assistance. May you, by your fierce practice, liberate yourself sooner rather than later.

Samatha-Vipassanā

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 51 min

Originally given as *Samatha-Vipassanā* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the Buddha's personal quest for liberation and how it led to the development of two complementary meditation approaches: samatha (concentration/peacefulness) and vipassanā (insight). Drawing from the Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta (MN 10), he traces the Buddha's journey from his existential crisis as a young prince through his training with jhāna masters and ascetic practices, to his breakthrough understanding under the Bodhi tree.

Bhante explains how the Buddha's early training in absorption states (jhānas) with his first two teachers, while producing blissful concentrated states, failed to address the fundamental question of suffering's end. Similarly, extreme asceticism with the Jains proved fruitless. The breakthrough came when the Buddha recalled a childhood memory of natural concentration while watching his father - a state of pure, open awareness without striving.

The talk illuminates the crucial distinction between the 'two-way path' (combining samatha and vipassanā) and the 'one-way path' (ekāyāna magga) taught to householders in Kāmaṭṭhadhamma. This direct approach, emphasizing the four foundations of Right Awareness with natural concentration, became the foundation of the Mahāsi Sayādaw method. Bhante emphasizes that true liberation requires investigating the three characteristics of existence through calm, steady, equanimous awareness - not mere concentration or charismatic states, but the purification of heart through wisdom.

Let me try to make a distinction between the two types of meditation we find in all forms of Buddhism: Samatha and Vipassana. Samatha means peacefulness, quietening. Vipassana means insight. To get an angle on this, it's always good to go back to the Buddha's own personal experience and how it comes across to us through the scriptures.

So here we have a young man in his mid-twenties, slowly becoming disillusioned with life. He's living the good life, he belongs to a ruling family—though in later commentaries he's put up as this huge eastern potentate, he's really just a local boss. A local head of a tribe who actually has to pay tribute to the king of Kosala. Upper middle class, how about that?

He has a wife and an ordinary family life—extended family life, lots of cousins, many of whom of course join him when he starts the order. And the women join him eventually, just about the time his son is born.

From a psycho-dynamic point of view, from our Western psychology viewpoint, it's rather interesting that his own mother died when he was only a week old. That must have had some psychological effects on him, even though it was his mother's sister who became his stepmother. And somehow he leaves just as his child is born. That's a rather interesting coincidence of facts, I'm sure. Freudians or Jungians might say something about that.

One could perhaps say that this trauma, even at that young age—the loss of your mother—creates some imbalance in the psyche which begins to manifest in his early twenties as what we would call an existential crisis, leading perhaps to an identity crisis, who knows. What brings it about is a sudden growing realisation: once youth has passed, once you've come out of the fantasy of youth where things like sickness, old age and death are very far away, where one isn't concerned with these things anyway, only with good living—something shifts.

Around about twenty-five there is a change of view. Something happens within us, most of us anyway, where we realise that youth is passing as we know it and we're looking ahead to a glorious hopeful middle age. We start taking things seriously—we tend to take out our pensions, get married, take a career. A shift from the easiness of youth. Within that context he comes to realise that actually, in the end, there's just sickness, old age and death. It's a crisis which builds up in him to such a degree that it makes him leave.

But there's another side to it, which reinforces that search: he's experienced, shall we say, what Blake would call the road of excess. I think that's how he puts it—the road of excess leads to the palace of wisdom. At some point when he's had all his parties and he's had a good time, he sees the vanity of it, the emptiness of it. It's expressed in a visual sense: he wakes up at the end of a big carousing and just sees these dishevelled bodies, maybe the smell of sickness and who knows what. That gives him the other side of pleasure, the downside of pleasure.

Psychologically, remember, this indulgence brings about frustration when you can't get what you want, grief when you lose what you've got, and anxiety when you've got what you've got and you're afraid to lose it. All that psychology is in there. We can say that he was waking up to the fact that the life he was leading had this deeper emptiness to it. He hadn't found any real purpose in the family life he was leading, in the career that was being offered to him as a kshatriya, a warrior caste, a ruler.

And so there comes this crisis point. We know about crisis—we know about financial crisis. He's having a psychological crisis, and so he leaves. Now he wouldn't have left if he didn't have somewhere to go. Just as in the seventies there was a great movement of hippies searching for love, in those days there was quite a movement of people searching for the answer to life in what we call Hinduism, the Vedas. There was this slow growing new literature, the Upanishads, which manifests this questioning of the age.

It was also an age of cultural change—a movement away from pastoral societies dotted here and there with local rulers to a city-based civilisation in which there grew a merchant class that had not been there before, a rich merchant class that began to have power and kingship. The Buddha didn't particularly like this; he preferred the more democratic meetings of the pastoral societies. So there's ferment, there's change happening in society—not perhaps as vicious as we've experienced, but definitely some dislocation going on.

And there were these groups of men—very rare for women to do it because of the dangers involved, and of course the sexism involved too—who went out into the forests and tried to find the meaning of life. That was their job. One of the strains of understanding which empowered them was the belief in rebirth, the belief in reincarnation. There were many answers to it, but at the heart was the horror of having to be reborn again into this life.

The idea that one had to be reborn again and again and go through this horror—because in those days, of course, sickness, old age and death wasn't something that happened in hospitals or was shut away somewhere. The dead were taken to charnel grounds. You could see the bodies rotting. When the wind changed, you knew where it was coming from. It was there, it was in the open, as you might still see in India. When you go there, that's one of the great things about India—it doesn't disguise these things. So this whole idea of having to come back to this, again. One was looking for an escape—where was the escape? And that was the atmosphere in which the Buddha left home.

I dare say that when he left, he didn't announce he was off for good. More likely he said something like, 'I'm just nipping off for a little while to check this thing out, see if I can find an answer to my deep disturbance.'

I remember when I told my mother I was going to become a monk. She collapsed into such deep weeping—it came from the deepest part of her heart. Even I started crying. So I gave her a hug and said, 'Mum, it's only for three years.' And she stopped, just like that. You have to put it in the context of Catholicism, of course, because priests are around—you can see a priest there. But if you become a monk, that's it. You cut your ties. You enter the monastery and nobody ever sees you again. I think they've softened up on that now; I think they can see people once a month or something. But in the old days, that was it. You left. She collapsed.

So I dare say there was a lot of gnashing of teeth when the Buddha left. Later tales describe how his parents wept at his leaving. His wife wept, everybody wept. And I'm sure he said, 'Well, I'm only going—I'll be back in a bit.' He was going to see what it was like.

So he goes off and joins these ascetics living in the forest. The first two teachers he finds teach him what we now call the *jhānas*—the absorption meditations.

When you practise this *samatha* type of meditation, you're creating a state of mind. The beauty of it is that although you begin with an outside object—a candle flame, you all know that, or a circle—or an inner object like a mantra or your breath, it's still an object. You're only using it to bring about a certain laser quality to the mind. And I think you'll know that when the mind begins to concentrate, bliss arises naturally. It's just the quality of the mind as it concentrates, an energy in it, and we experience it as a certain type of inner happiness.

The first teacher really took him right through what we now recognise as the *jhānas*—the *rūpa jhānas* and the *arūpa jhānas*. The *rūpa jhānas* are those states you reach by deepening your concentration until, as it were, the mental state leaves the body, goes inward, and finds its own joy—and then even leaves that to find a perfect peace.

Beyond that, one enters a stranger place where there's no object at all. Right up until that point, there's always an object—a light, a feeling, a sense, something there. But when that disappears, this consciousness, as it were, if I want a better word, flips into a different state and there's nothing there.

Those places are called infinite space, infinite consciousness, infinite nothingness. These relate—I'm talking now to people who know the Dharma a bit deeper—to the four khandhas. When you're in that area of nothingness, it's out of that nothingness that the saṅkhāra arises, the manifestations of mind. When you're in that space of consciousness, you're at the beginning of the vijñāna process which manifests eventually as one of the aggregates. When you're in the space where everywhere there's just space, you're at the subtle level of vedanā, feeling. And when you're at neither perception nor non-perception, that's the beginning level of perception as consciousness descends into the mind and finally coagulates into what we call the physical body.

The Buddha took all this with his teacher and became an adept. The teacher said, 'Please, join me.' But he said no—although he'd done all this and they were very blissful states and all that, it hadn't really answered his question as to whether there is an end to suffering.

Now that's the core thing I should have mentioned earlier. The quest was: is there an end to suffering? And that eventually puts his whole teaching in just three words in the texts: dukkha, dukkha nirodha—suffering and the end of suffering. This dukkha, of course, has a very wide meaning. Here I've translated it as suffering, dissatisfaction, sense of lack, meaninglessness. It's the whole gamut of human suffering, from the smallest little disturbance to the deepest despair and horror.

So he leaves that teacher and finds another who takes him just one step further than these arūpa jhānas. Again he becomes an adept, again he's asked to teach, and again he says no and leaves. Although he's practised these concentration meditations, although he's taken them to the fullest development recognised by his own teachers, there's just something lacking. Something has not been undermined, something still causing him suffering, some feeling of dissatisfaction.

So now he tries a different tack, which seemingly he gets from an elder teacher, a contemporary called the Nigaṇṭha, the leader of the Jains. His understanding was that bad karma was accrued even when one didn't mean it. You know that Jain monks go around with a whisk and make sure there are no bugs they're going to tread on accidentally. Their understanding is that even accidentally, you still cause suffering, and therefore there's going to be a karmic comeback.

The real problem, according to this view—and it runs right through Indian literature—lay in desire, tṛṣṇā. One had to live the absolute ascetic life, denying the body any pleasure, because pleasure itself was dangerous. The Nigaṇṭha seem-

ingly made no distinction between pleasurable sensations and the attachment or desire you have to them. So one had to undermine that whole process. And if you think about it, pleasures come through the body, don't they? So you begin to blame the body for your problems. You fast, you sit in front of very hot fires, you do all sorts of ascetic practices meant to steel you against the pleasure of the body.

The Bodhisattva took this on too, and seemingly took it to his own personal limit—he couldn't go any further with it. Basically he just got thin. He said he could hold his spine through his stomach, that's how thin he was. And again he wasn't achieving anything. This fundamental question about suffering, about meaningfulness, had not been answered.

He's with five companions at this time, remember. They're going for it, helter-skelter, really whipping themselves and getting into it big time. And so he leaves.

Now, in the opening stanzas of his very first talk, the Buddha says that the life devoted to sensual pleasure is base, ignoble, a waste of time, leading nowhere. And the life devoted to self-mortification—which is not renunciation; renunciation is not doing something to see your attachment—self-mortification is based on self-punishment, self-negation in that bad way, rejection of life as it is. That too was just painful, he said, and led nowhere. At least the first path was pleasant and led nowhere, but this was just painful and led nowhere.

But he doesn't say that the *jhānas*, that the other things he learnt about developing the qualities of mind, were a waste of time. Those become part of his system.

We can—at least I can—get a sense of his despair when he leaves his companions. What's he going to do? He can't go home because it would just go back into that emptiness, that bad emptiness. He's been to all these teachers, he's talked to a lot of people, and you can see from his teaching that he knows all the local philosophies and psychologies of the time. They learned that. He's tried everything and he's got nowhere to go.

So I imagine that when he sat on that road along which Sujātā came, he was in a state of real existential despair, and thin. When Sujātā comes along with her rice pudding—or well, rice cakes—she takes pity on this man. In the scriptures they soup it up: she's going to offer this to a god and sees the Bodhisattva who is resplendent and believes that this is the god. But actually, he must be looking miserable. She thought, well, maybe he needs it more than this god. And we all know the salvific effect of rice pudding. It's enormous in its power.

Having tasted it he feels better. Around that time he has a memory of his father doing a ploughing ceremony. He's a child, and there's something about the way he remembers, something about the way he's looking at his father doing the ploughing ceremony, which offers him another way of seeking the end, seeking the answer to his predicament.

Here's this child watching his father do a ploughing ceremony, and there is a tremendous interest in what his father is doing. That interest draws him into an absorbed state. He's just looking. And you see it in children, don't you? You see it when their jaw drops and their eyes become fixated. You can't shake them out of it unless you give them a clip on the back of the head.

That's it—that's the pure openness of intuitive intelligence just receiving. That's why I try to stress this quiet abiding, because there you drop your preconceptions, you drop your ideas, you drop your concepts, you drop your history, and you lay yourself open just observing, feeling, experiencing what's happening right now.

There was something in that looking which raised again, that encouraged him to have another go. And he was so certain this would actually be the answer that he makes a determination. He sits under the tree and either dies or finds the answer to his existential problem of suffering.

Looking. For him, looking; for us. He does six hours, it seems. There's an interesting moment worth pondering. The great doubt arises. I'm sure you've seen that posture of the Buddha where he's putting his hand touching the earth to ground himself. Māra the evil one attacks him. Although it's put in pictures of all sorts of things attacking him, what it is is the great doubt. It's known as the moment of great doubt.

The doubt is this: Who are you? Who are you to try and work this out? There's no single human being you know of who's ever worked this out. Who are you? How come you've even started on this quest? And with that doubt comes the temptation of going back into ordinary life. That's what Māra is. Later on in Buddhism, Māra is put across as an evil figure, a bit like the Christian devil trying to kill you and do all sorts of bad things. But he's much more the tempter. The god Māra is actually the chief of a most delightful heaven, so what he symbolises is the attraction of the sensual life.

It's interesting that when the Buddha touches the earth and the earth goddess appears, it's his perfection of generosity that makes him continue to sit. Now what is generosity? Generosity is doing something for somebody else. And I presume

what came to him at that moment was that this wasn't just for him—this was for humanity. It wasn't a selfish thing, that he wanted to get out of suffering, trying to save himself. It was in the greater context that this was the question, and it was for the benefit of others. That, I think, gave him the strength to sit there and continue his investigation.

So when he began to teach, he taught these two things in tandem. The absorption states were something he really pushed. The thing about the mind is that if it's very concentrated, very open, very still, obviously it sees something. Obviously it's more capable of seeing something than a mind that's scattered, unable to be gathered onto a single point.

One can develop that sort of single-pointed mind through various exercises, and you can do it, as it were, just by repetition, just by repetition. But remember that when you do that there's a tendency to block, to stop the purification process. That's what the Buddha found. When he was in these beautiful states, fine. But when he came out again, he was still the same old depressed Gotama. It hadn't done anything to purify the heart. It had built another mindset which as an adept he could enter any time. So he could always go to this place when he felt a bit depressed, push it away, do his mantra, in he goes, blissed out. But it never actually dealt with the problem. That's what he came back to. And it can't, because these jhānic states are about developing the mind.

Now we see this in the distinction between a charismatic who is not wise, somebody who is wise, and somebody who is both charismatic and wise. Somebody who's charismatic builds up this huge love, and it can become a radiance—you can be attracted to it. And then one day you stand on their foot and they go berserk.

That's why the Buddha says you can't tell how wise somebody is until you live with them for quite some time. Then you suddenly see these little defilements, these little odd bits of behaviour come out, and you know that something has not been purified. But that doesn't mean to say that in their charismatic form the person might not be doing a huge amount of good. Even that person may be confusing their charisma with wisdom.

The great enemy of the leader, the Buddha points out, are the followers—because they keep telling you how wonderful you are. The person who is fully liberated might not be charismatic at all. They might be quite an ordinary person.

Even though the Buddha definitely had some charisma, there's a lovely moment in the scriptures where somebody—a monk, or it might have been a lay person, I can't remember—comes into a group of monks and has to ask which one is the Bhagavan. So it's not as though he displayed this huge charisma, or it doesn't seem to have done. But then again, you can have somebody who is charismatic and who is fully liberated.

What the jhānas do, all these jhānas, is produce charisma, depending on what you practise. So if you practise love, that's the charisma you'll get.

In my travels in Thailand, I met about four or five people really—five monks, because you only get to see monks as a monk—who were all highly developed, and all of them were generally considered to be liberated. They all had very different atmospheres around them.

The two I remember most vividly: one was Ajahn Sim, who lived just up beyond Chiang Mai. There were three of us travelling together, a couple of Americans and myself. When you sat in his presence, you were immediately drawn into his sense of peace. It was a tangible feeling, and it immediately affected you. You sat in peace. Just like that.

When I went to see Ajahn Tate, who had this beautiful monastery up on the borders of Laos, on the Mekong, I was just on my own at the time, I think. You were simply enveloped with this very, very lovely loving-kindness. He might just have been feeling that at the time, I don't know. But it was tangible—a real tangible feeling. Immediately softening. Immediately you felt this open friendship. When he died, something like a couple of million people turned up to the funeral, they said. He was pretty famous, Ajahn Tate.

He's the one I quote, by the way. When I do a day of resolution on the retreats, I offer three simple instructions: make it simple, take it easy, stay with the one who knows. That's Ajahn Tate. Make it simple. Take it easy. Stay with the one who knows.

Now, when people began to join the Buddha, all the members—bhikkhus and bhikkhunīs—were people who'd left the worldly life. So what were you going to do? What do you do all day? You haven't got to go to work. You can't grow anything—you're not allowed to grow. You can't cook. You don't have any money. You can't buy anything. You can't get into retail therapy. What are you going to do? You've got to do something.

So these jhānic exercises are specifically for people who have time. If you find yourself with time, this is something you might want to practise. And it's beneficial—it's creating beautiful states of mind.

But the Buddha was travelling once, later on in his teaching, out towards Kammāsadhamma, amongst the Kurus. It was a village of the Kurus, and the Kurus lived in what we would now recognise as modern Delhi, that sort of area. He'd been there before. These are ordinary village people, people who look after cows and sheep. The fields—there's nothing technological. This is drawing water from the well, cutting wood, all that sort of stuff.

He'd been there before and given them the teachings. When he turns up again, he's quite taken by how they're actually practising the Dhamma. He says for a start there's no well talk—no gossip around the well. Everybody was doing things mindfully and they were all practising meditation.

He was so moved by this that he gave the talk known as the Discourse on the Establishment or Foundation of Mindfulness, which is recognised as the jewel of the whole collection. Because here he actually tells you how to become liberated. This is it—he puts it all together in one discourse.

And he says it to these ordinary people in Kammāsadhamma. He doesn't give this talk to his monks or anybody else. For me this is highly significant, because normally speaking he's going on about jhāna and vipassanā—the one leads to the other, and so on. And there are teachers who teach that now. But this, you see, is directed to lay people who haven't got the time to sit there and get into these blissful states. They've got a family and all that.

It starts off by telling them clearly—and the word he uses is ekāyāna-magga, which means the one-way proceeding path, or the path that proceeds in this single way. The commentary normally puts that as opposed to the dvāyāna, the two-way path, which is the combination of samatha practice with vipassanā. That's his first word: ekāyāna-magga.

It's translated variously by authors, depending on their particular viewpoint. You'll see in Nyanaponika, in his really still the core book on meditation, *The Heart of Buddhist Meditation*—he says it's the only path. That's a bit fundamentalist. Then there are these people who are friends down in Devon who translate Pali as a hobby, and they call it the sure path. But Bhikkhu Bodhi, who is the doyen—

the American monk who's the doyen of Buddhist studies—makes it quite clear that ekāyāna means the one-way path as opposed to the two-way path. To me that makes a lot of sense.

So this is the one-way path for the purification of beings, for the overcoming of sorrow and lamentation, for reaching the end of suffering and discontent, for finding the true way, for the realisation of emancipation—namely the four applications of mindfulness.

When we practise vipassanā, there has to be included in it a certain concentration content. What the Buddha does is pull out for us seven factors which, developed, lead to this natural insight process. The first one is just this awareness.

But it's right awareness, and right awareness always means the observation of the three characteristics, because that's where the delusion lies. It's seeing the impermanence; it's seeing how we indulge or resist what is happening, whether pleasant or unpleasant.

And then there's the quality of not-self. This not-self is not a philosophical statement. The Buddha doesn't say there is no self. It's a teaching tool in which everything you experience you make clear to yourself is an object you're aware of. So if you're aware of something, it cannot be that which is aware.

Think of how as children we began to distinguish, out of that mass of sensation, the world out there—object relationship, I think they call it. Out of this mass of sensations, mother starts to loom, your first object, something separate from you that separates out of the mass, until eventually you're quite clear that this is me and everything else is not me.

All we're doing is taking that process inward and making the inner part of our experience as objective as this room is. This room has a body—walls, ceilings—and it has atmosphere; it's a mind. So it is the same within us. As we begin to push out, push away, objectify the inner world as we've done the outer world, that process is the process of detaching from it, undermining that relationship of it being me or mine. And that's why we feel this process of liberation. That's why the Buddha says the taste of Nibbāna is freedom. It's the liberation from that wrong connection with what we're experiencing.

But this awareness has to be supported. And here the split is between those qualities which are passive and those which are active.

When we practise this quiet abiding, we are practising those passive qualities, which for us are not highly developed in our society. It's the active qualities which are developed.

Those passive qualities include calmness. Just be calm, not excited all the time. Not seeking a high level of energy but just bringing ourselves to a real deep calm.

Interestingly, that calmness is linked with interest, because interest can get excited. If you're interested in something you can feel yourself getting all excited. But that excitement then becomes—that interest then becomes—tainted with trying to achieve something, trying to see something. Once there's a trying to see something, the self is taking over the process.

So to see something at this level, one has to let go of the idea that I'm achieving it. There has to be this business of just having faith, a real confidence that there is within us that which will make insight without us trying. And that's the abstraction, the taking away of this self which manifests as a sort of over-effort, a trying to see something. You won't relax and just let the eye look.

So tomorrow when you're wandering around the paddock or the garden or you go for a walk, just rest your eye on something and watch the way the eye perceives. You don't have to try and perceive. Put a leaf in your hand, or just look at a tree and watch how the eye itself is perceiving. Stand back from that process and then you gain confidence. Oh, the eye perceives. I don't have to try and perceive.

It's the same with intelligence. If we get out of the way, the intelligence works naturally because that's the quality of intelligence. It understands. It perceives. It has insight. It doesn't think. This is the thing. Thought is another process. The insight is immediate. You either see it or you don't see it.

Then there is this passive quality of a steadiness of attention. Just steadiness, concentration, focus—keeping the attention steady. And that has to be coupled with right effort. The effort is just to maintain the focus. Put too much effort in and you start getting restless, you start getting a shaking. Too little effort and the concentrated mind very quickly falls into sweet oblivion. Sleep. Because that's what happens when the mind's nicely concentrated. It's calm. And off you go.

Finally, there's the passive quality of equanimity. That's so difficult for us. In this sense it's coming from a position of don't know, which means you're looking at something, investigating something without any preconceived ideas, preconceived notions—that this has to be this way. Very difficult, because on one side

we're being fed these three characteristics and then we're told just look, forget about that, just look and see for yourself. And there's no prejudice in the sense that the heart isn't involved in any over-desire. It's a calm heart, you see.

All these factors we've talked about are natural to daily life. Everybody has them. What turns them into factors that lead to liberation is the investigation of the Dhamma. These same qualities would be present in anybody involved in science or active research—they're all the same sort of qualities you need. But once you turn them to investigating the Dhamma, which here means these three characteristics, then this leads to a change in the way we relate to the world we live in.

Just as a little aside about the Mahasi, whose picture you see here: after the Second World War, when Burma gained independence from us—oh, pity—a group of people who knew the elected prime minister, the only one unfortunately, because in 1963 there was the military coup which they're still suffering from, were looking for a meditation teacher. The Mahasi was a well-known teacher up in middle Burma, and they brought him down and set him up in a meditation centre.

By all accounts he had virtually immediate success. He was teaching this. He wasn't teaching jhāna absorption, for which you need time. He was teaching a direct path—it's ekāyano. And he created the parameters whereby people could move quickly. It was great effort, as you know: sitting, walking, sitting, walking, eighteen hours a day. But it was never to try and attain something. He was always trying to relax and to watch and to see, to explore.

His effect on local society in Rangoon was immediate. Eventually it expanded so much that by 1956, not many years later, he was doing his first world tour around the East. He didn't come West, I don't think, for a while. That's the specific place the Mahasi holds in the Vipassanā scene, you might say: he teaches this ekāyana magga, this direct path.

So there we have it. What makes the Buddha an especially great person in spiritual history wasn't simply the amazing insight that he had, but also his amazing ability to get it across—to actually produce a systematic way and a systematic teaching which people can understand. And not just the intellectuals—that's the point—ordinary people, people of Kuru Siddhāma.

I can only hope my words have been of some assistance. May you be liberated from all your suffering, sooner rather than later.

Samatha and Vipassanā

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 51 min

Originally given as *Samatha and Vipassanā* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



Bhante Bodhidhamma takes us through the Buddha's own spiritual journey to illustrate the relationship between samatha (concentration meditation) and vipassanā (insight meditation). Beginning with Prince Siddhattha's existential crisis and his quest to find an end to suffering, the talk traces his experiences with two jhāna teachers who taught absorption states, followed by his extreme ascetic practices with the Jains.

The Buddha's breakthrough came through remembering a childhood moment of natural concentration while watching his father plow - a state of open, interested awareness without effort. This led to his teaching of the "one-way path" (ekāyāna magga) described in the Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta (MN 10), specifically given to ordinary householders in Kammāsaddhamma village.

Bhante explains how vipassanā practice includes natural concentration through the seven factors of awakening, emphasizing passive qualities like calmness, interest, and equanimity alongside active investigation of the three characteristics (impermanence, unsatisfactoriness, not-self). He concludes with the Mahasi Sayadaw's contribution to making this direct path accessible to modern practitioners, teaching the systematic observation that leads to liberation without requiring years of jhāna practice.

This talk offers both historical context and practical guidance for understanding how concentration and insight work together in Buddhist meditation.

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammāsambuddhassa, Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammāsambuddhassa, Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammāsambuddhassa — homage to the Buddha, the Blessed, Noble and fully Self-Enlightened One.

I want to make a distinction between the two types of meditation we find in all forms of Buddhism: *samatha* and *vipassanā*. *Samatha* means peacefulness, quietening. *Vipassanā* means insight. To get an angle on this, it's always good to go back to the Buddha's own personal experience and how it comes across to us through the scriptures.

Here we have a young man, probably in his mid-twenties, slowly becoming disillusioned with life. He's living the good life; he belongs to a ruling family — although later commentaries elevate him to some huge eastern potentate. Really, he's just a local boss, the head of a tribe who actually has to pay tribute to the king of Kosala. What you might call upper middle class. He has a wife and an ordinary family life, an extended family life with lots of cousins, many of whom join him when he starts the order. The women join him eventually too, just about the time his son is born.

From a psychodynamic point of view, from our Western psychology viewpoint, it's rather interesting that his own mother died when he was only a week old. That must have had some psychological effects on him, even though his mother's sister became his stepmother. And somehow he leaves just as his own child is born. That's a rather interesting coincidence of facts. Freudians or Jungians might say something about that.

One could say that this trauma, even at that young age — the loss of your mother — creates some imbalance in the psyche which begins to manifest in his early twenties: what we would call an existential crisis, leading probably to an identity crisis. What brings it about is a sudden growing realisation that once youth has passed, once you've come out of the fantasy of youth where sickness, old age and death are very far away and one isn't concerned with these things anyway but only with good living — around about twenty-five, there's a change of view. Something happens within us, most of us anyway, where we realise that youth is passing as we know it, and we're looking ahead to a glorious, hopeful middle age. We start taking things seriously. We tend to take out a pension, get married, take a career.

Within that context, he comes to realise that actually, in the end, there's just sickness, old age and death. It's a crisis that builds up in him to such a degree that it makes him leave. But there's another side to it, which reinforces that search: he's experienced what Blake would call the road of excess — the road of excess leads to the palace of wisdom. At some point, when he's had all his parties and he's had a good time, he sees the vanity of it. He sees the other side, the emptiness

of it. It's expressed in a visual sense: he wakes up at the end of a big carousing and just sees these dishevelled bodies, maybe smells the sickness. That gives him the other side of pleasure — the downside of pleasure.

Psychologically, remember, this indulgence brings about frustration when you can't get what you want, grief when you lose what you've got, and anxiety when you've got what you've got and you're afraid to lose it. All that psychology is in there. We can say he was waking up to the fact that the life he was leading had this deeper emptiness to it. He hadn't found any real purpose in the family life he was leading, in the career being offered to him as a *kshatriya*, a warrior caste, a ruler. And so there comes this crisis point. We know about crisis, don't we? A financial crisis. He's having a psychological crisis. And so he leaves.

Now, he wouldn't have left if he didn't have somewhere to go. Just as in the seventies there was a great movement of hippies searching for love, in those days there was quite a movement of people searching for the answer to life. In Hinduism, in what we call Hinduism, the Vedas, there was this slow-growing new literature, the Upanishads, which manifests this questioning of the age. It was also an age of change in the culture — movement away from pastoral societies dotted here and there with local rulers toward a city-based civilisation. A merchant class grew up that had not been there before, a rich merchant class that began to have power. And kingship, which the Buddha didn't particularly like. He preferred the more democratic meetings of pastoral societies.

There's ferment, there's change happening in society — not perhaps as vicious as we've experienced, but definitely some dislocation going on. And there were these groups of men — very rare for women to do it because of the dangers involved and the sexism too — who went out into the forests and tried to find the meaning of life. That was their job. One of the strains of understanding which empowered them was the belief in rebirth, the belief in reincarnation. There were many answers to it, but what drove them was the horror of having to be reborn again into this life.

Remember, these times are a bit harder. There's no videos, there's no DVDs, there's no cars — it's dog work. You're out in the field digging, and when you come back, what do you do? The only entertainments were the occasional big events, the occasional military parades. And, believe it or not, the holy men, who would turn up in their parks, in their shrines. Everybody would go out on a full moon night and ask questions, and they'd do some chanting. That was, in a sense, the fullness of their entertainment, apart from the usual things, playing games.

The idea that one had to be reborn again and again and go through this horror — because in those days, sickness, old age and death wasn't something that happened in hospitals or shut away somewhere. The dead were taken to charnel grounds. You could see the bodies rotting. When the wind changed, you knew where it was coming from. It was there, it was in the open, as you might still see in India — that's one of the great things about India, it doesn't disguise these things. This whole idea of having to come back to this again — one was looking for an escape. Where was the escape? That was the atmosphere in which the Buddha left home.

I dare say that when he left, he didn't say, "I'm off for good." He said, "I'm just nipping off for a little while and checking this thing out, see if I can find an answer to my deep disturbance." I remember when I told my mother that I was going to become a monk. She collapsed into such deep weeping, it came from the deepest part of her heart. Even I started crying. So I gave her a hug and said, "Mum, it's only for three years." And she stopped like that.

You have to put it in the context of Catholicism, because priests are around — you can see a priest there. But if you become a monk, that's it. You cut your tie, enter the monastery, and nobody ever sees you again. I think they've softened up on that now — I think they can see people once a month or something. But in the old days, that was it. Left. Collapsed. I dare say there was a lot of gnashing of teeth when the Buddha left home. His parents wept. In later tales they describe how his parents wept at his leaving. His wife wept. Everybody wept. And I'm sure he said, 'I'm only going. I'll be back in a bit. We're going to see what it's like.'

He goes off and joins these ascetics living in the forest. The first two teachers he finds teach him what we now call the *jhānas*, the absorption meditations. When you practise this *samatha* type of meditation, you're creating a state of mind. But the beauty of it is that although you begin with an outside object — a candle flame, you all know that, or a circle — or an inner object like a mantra or your breath, it's still an object. You're only using it to bring about a certain laser quality to the mind.

I think you'll know that when the mind begins to concentrate, bliss arises naturally. It's just the quality of the mind as it concentrates — a certain energy in it — and we experience it as a certain type of inner happiness. The first teacher really took him right through what we now recognise as the *jhānas*: the *rūpa-jhānas* and

the *arūpa-jhānas*. The *rūpa-jhānas* are those states you get by deepening your concentration until, as it were, the mental state leaves the body, goes inward, and finds its own joy — and then even leaves that to find a perfect peace.

This is not the equanimity of the seven factors of enlightenment. They use the same word — these words are used variously — but they have slightly different meanings. Then, leaving that peace, as it were, one enters into a stranger place where there's no object at all. Right up until that point, there's always an object — a light, the feeling, a sense, something there. But when that disappears, consciousness, as it were, flips into a different state and there's nothing there. Those places are called infinite space, infinite consciousness, infinite nothingness.

These relate — I'm talking now to people who know the Dharma a bit deeper — to the four *khandhas*. When you're into that area of space, of nothingness, it's out of that nothingness that the *saṅkhāras* arise, the manifestations of mind. When you're into that space of consciousness, you're at the beginning of the *viññāna* process of consciousness, which manifests eventually as one of the aggregates. When you're in the space where everywhere there's just space, you're at the subtle level of *vedanā*, feeling. And when you're at neither perception nor not perception, that's the beginning level of perception as that consciousness descends into the mind and finally coagulates into what we call physical body.

That process a person might go through has its own insightfulness as you pass through it. The Buddha took this with his teacher and became an adept, and the teacher said, 'Please join me.' He said no. 'Although I've done all this and they're very blissful states and all that, it's not really answered my question as to whether there is an end to suffering.'

Now that's the core thing which I should have mentioned earlier. The quest was: is there an end to suffering? That eventually puts his whole teaching in just three words in the texts: *dukkha*, *dukkha nirodha* — suffering and the end of suffering. This *dukkha*, of course, has a very wide meaning. Here I've translated it as suffering, dissatisfaction, sense of lack, meaninglessness. It's the whole gamut of human suffering, from the smallest little disturbance to the deepest despair and horror.

So he leaves that teacher and finds another one who takes him just one step further than these *arūpa jhānas*, and there he becomes an adept. Again he's asked to teach, but he says no and leaves. So although he's practised these concentration meditations, although he's taken them to the fullest development recognised by

his own teachers, there's just something lacking — something which has not been undermined, which is still causing him suffering, causing him some feeling of dissatisfaction.

Now he tries a different tack, which seemingly he gets from an elder teacher, a contemporary teacher: the Nigaṇṭha, the leader of the Jains. His understanding was that bad *kamma* was accrued even when one didn't mean it. You know that Jain monks go around with a whisk and make sure there are no bugs they're going to tread on accidentally. Their understanding is that even accidentally, you still cause suffering, and therefore there's going to be a karmic comeback.

And the real problem lay — and this runs right the way through Indian literature — in desire, *tṛṣṇā*. So one had to live the absolute ascetic life, deny the body any pleasure because there was a danger. He didn't seemingly make a distinction between pleasurable sensations and the attachment or desire you have to them. So one had to, as it were, undermine that whole process. And if you think about it, pleasures come through the body, don't they? So you begin to blame the body for your problems. You fast, you sit in front of very hot fires, you do all sorts of ascetic practices meant to steel you against the pleasures of the body.

So he took this — again, he seemingly took it to his own personal end, like he couldn't go any further with it — and basically he just got thin. He said he could hold his spine through his stomach. That's how thin he was. And again he wasn't achieving anything. This fundamental question about suffering, about meaningfulness, had not been answered. He's with five companions, remember, at this time. They're going for it, helter-skelter, really whipping themselves and getting into it big time. And so he leaves.

In the opening stanzas of his very first talk, he says that the life devoted to sensual pleasure is base, ignoble, a waste of time, leading nowhere. And the life devoted to self-mortification — which is not renunciation; renunciation is not doing something to see your attachment; self-mortification is based on self-punishment, self-negation in that bad way, rejection of life as it is — that self-mortification was also just painful, he said, and led nowhere. At least the first one was pleasant and led nowhere, but this was painful and led nowhere. Yet he doesn't say that the *jhānas*, that the other stuff he learnt about developing the qualities of mind, was a waste of time. And that becomes part of his system.

I can at least get a sense of his despair when he leaves his companions. Where was he going to go? He couldn't go home — that would just mean falling back into that emptiness, that bad emptiness. He'd been to all these teachers. He'd talked to

so many people, and you can see from his teaching that he knew all the local philosophies and psychologies of the time. He'd learnt it all. He'd tried everything. And now he had nowhere left to go.

So I imagine that when he sat on that road along which Sujata came, he was in a state of real existential despair. When she comes along with her rice pudding, or rice cakes, she takes pity on this man. In the scriptures they soup it up: she's going to offer this to a god and sees the Bodhisattva who is resplendent and believes that this is the god. But actually, he must have been looking miserable. She probably thought, 'Well, maybe he needs it more than this god.' And we all know the salvific effect of rice pudding — enormous in its power. So having tasted it, he feels better.

Around that time he has this memory of his father doing a ploughing ceremony. He's a child, and there's something about the way he remembers — something about the way he's looking at his father doing the ploughing ceremony — which offers him another way of seeking the answer to his predicament. That's why I've got these pictures. The little baby at the back there on the board was on a poster, an advert in Birmingham Station. I came out of the train, saw this, went home, then came all the way back to Birmingham Station to take that picture. I've probably broken some sort of publication rights, but I thought it was a fantastic image.

Make sure you have a look at that, because what it expresses is that way of looking and the moment of seeing. The little girl in the other picture was given to me by a friend in Dublin, Dennis. This is a picture that was brought into the Irish Times. There was an opening of a nature reserve where they'd put trees and little animals. You can see she's reaching out to a plant to see what's there, but the look on her face, if you look at it, has both an intense interest and also a sense of trepidation — a sense of fear of the unknown. Like, if I see this, what will happen? So that comes first, and the baby face comes second.

So here's this child watching his father doing a ploughing ceremony, and there is a tremendous interest in what his father is doing. That interest draws him into an absorbed state. He's just looking. You see it in children, don't you? You see it when their jaw drops and their eyes become fixated. You can't shake them out of it unless you give them a clip on the back of the head. And that's it — that's the pure openness of that intuitive intelligence just receiving. That's why I try to stress this quiet abiding: there you drop your preconceptions, you drop your

ideas, you drop your concepts, you drop your history — dropping your history — and you lay yourself open, just observing, feeling, experiencing what's happening right now.

There was something in that looking which encouraged him to have another go. And he was so certain this would actually be the answer that he makes a determination to sit under the tree and either die or find the answer to this existential problem of suffering. Looking for him, looking for us, he does six hours. There's an interesting moment worth pondering: the great doubt arises. I'm sure you've seen that posture of the Buddha where he's putting his hand touching the earth to ground himself, and *Māra* the evil one attacks him. Although it's depicted in pictures as all sorts of things attacking him, what it actually is is the great doubt. It's known as the moment of great doubt, and the doubt is: who are you? Who are you to try and work this out? There's no single human being you know of — nobody's ever worked this out — who are you? How come you've even started on this quest?

And with it comes the temptation of going back into the ordinary life. That's what *Māra* is. Later on in Buddhism, *Māra* is put across as an evil one, a bit like the Christian devil, trying to kill you and do all sorts of bad things to you. But he's much more the tempter. The god *Māra* is actually the chief of a most delightful heaven. So what he symbolises is the attraction of the sensual life.

It's interesting that when he touches the earth and the earth goddess appears, it's his perfection of generosity which gives him the strength to continue sitting. Now what is generosity? Generosity is doing something for somebody else, and I presume that what came to him at that moment was that this wasn't just for him — this was for humanity. There wasn't a selfish thing that he wanted to get out of suffering; he was trying to save himself. It was in the greater context that this was the question, and it was for the benefit of others that, I think, gave him the strength to sit there and continue that investigation. This is my own interpretation, by the way. The commentaries just say it was the perfection of generosity that gave him the strength.

So when he began to teach, he taught these two things in tandem, and the absorption states were something he really pushed. The thing about the mind is that if it's very concentrated, very open, very still, obviously it's more capable of seeing something — rather than a mind that's scattered, unable to be gathered onto a single point. One can develop that single-pointed mind through various exercises, and you can do it just by repetition.

But remember that when you do that, there's a tendency to be able to block, to stop the purification process — and that's what the Buddha found. When he was in these beautiful states, fine, but when he came out again he was still the same old depressed Gautama. It hadn't done anything to purify the heart. It had built another mindset which, as an adept, he could enter any time, so he could always go to this place when he felt a bit depressed — push it away, do your mantra, in you go, blissed out. But it never actually dealt with the problem. That's what he came back to. And it can't, because these *jhānic* states are about developing the mind.

Now we see this, and this is the distinction between a charismatic who is not wise, somebody who is wise, and somebody who is charismatic and wise. Somebody who's charismatic builds up this huge love and it can become a radiance — you can be attracted to it — and then one day you stand on their foot and they go berserk. That's why the Buddha says you can't tell how wise somebody is until you live with them for quite some time. Then you suddenly see these little defilements, these little odd bits of behaviour come out, and you know that something has not been purified. That doesn't mean to say that in that charismatic form the person might not be doing a huge amount of good — yet even that person may be confusing their charisma with wisdom. And the great enemy the Buddha points out of the leader are the followers, because they keep telling you how wonderful you are.

The person who is fully liberated might not be charismatic at all. Might be quite an ordinary person. Even though the Buddha definitely had some charisma, there's a lovely moment in the scriptures where somebody — a monk comes in, or it might have been a lay person, I can't remember — comes into a group of monks and has to ask which one is the Bhagavān. So it's not as though he displayed this huge charisma, or doesn't seem to have done. But then again, you can have somebody who is charismatic and who is fully liberated.

What the *jhānas* do — all of them — is produce charisma, depending on what you practise. If you practise love, that's the charisma you'll get. In my travels in Thailand, I met about four or five monks who were highly developed — you only get to see monks as a monk — and all of them were generally considered to be liberated. Each had a very different atmosphere around them.

The two I remember most vividly: one is Ajahn Sim, who lived just beyond Chiang Mai. There were three of us travelling together, a couple of Americans and myself. When you sat in his presence, you were immediately drawn into his sense of peace. It was tangible, and it affected you at once. You simply sat in peace, just like that.

Then there was Ajahn Tate, who had this beautiful monastery up on the borders of Laos, on the Mekong. I went to see him — just me at the time, I think — and you were simply enveloped in this very lovely loving-kindness. He might just have been feeling that way at the time, I don't know, but it was tangible. A real tangible feeling — immediately softening. You felt this open friendship at once. When he died, something like a couple of million people turned up for the funeral. He was pretty famous, Ajahn Tate. He's the one I quote, by the way, when I do a day of resolution on retreats: make it simple, take it easy, stay with the one who knows. That's Ajahn Tate. Make it simple. Take it easy. Stay with the one who knows.

Now, when people began to join the Buddha — all the *bhikkhus* and *bhikkhunīs* — they were people who'd left the worldly life. What were you going to do? What do you do all day? You haven't got to go to work. You can't grow anything — you're not allowed to grow. You can't cook. You don't have any money. You can't buy anything. You can't get into retail therapy. You've got to do something. So these *jhānic* exercises are specifically for those who have time. And if you find yourself with time, it's something you might want to practise. It's beneficial; it creates beautiful states of mind.

The Buddha had been there before and had given them their teachings. When he turns up again, he's quite taken by how they're actually practising the Dhamma. For a start, he says, there's no idle talk, no gossip around the well. Everybody was doing things mindfully; they were all practising meditation. He was so moved by this that he gave the talk known as the Discourse on the Establishment or Foundation of Mindfulness — recognised as the jewel of the whole collection, because here he actually tells you how to become liberated. This is it: he puts it all together in one discourse.

But this discourse, you see, is directed to lay people who haven't got the time to sit there and get into these blissful states. They've got a family and all that sort of stuff. It starts off by telling them clearly — and the word he uses is *ekāyāna-*

magga, which means the one-way proceeding path, or the path that proceeds in this single way. The commentary normally puts that as opposed to the *dveyyāna*, the two-way path, which is the combination of *samatha* practice with *vipassanā*.

That's his first words: *ekāyāna-magga*. It's translated variously by authors depending on their particular viewpoint. Nyanaponika, in what's still the core book on meditation — *The Heart of Buddhist Meditation* — says it's 'the only path.' That's a bit fundamentalist. Then there are these people who are friends down in Devon who translate Pali as a hobby, and they call it 'the shore path.' But Bhikkhu Bodhi, the American monk who's the doyen of Buddhist studies, makes it quite clear that *ekāyāna* means the one-way path as opposed to the two-way path. To me that makes a lot of sense.

So this is the one-way path for the purification of beings, for the overcoming of sorrow and lamentation, for reaching the end of suffering and discontent, for finding the true way, for the realisation of emancipation — namely the four applications of mindfulness. Not a bad translation, really.

When we practise *vipassanā*, there has to be a certain concentration content included in it. What the Buddha does is pull out for us seven factors which, when developed, lead to this natural insight process. The first is simply awareness — but it's right awareness, and right awareness always means the observation of the three characteristics, because that's where the delusion lies. It's seeing the impermanence, seeing how we indulge or resist what is happening whether it's pleasant or unpleasant, and seeing the quality of not-self.

This not-self is not a philosophical statement. The Buddha doesn't say there is no self. It's a teaching tool in which everything you experience you make clear to yourself is an object you're aware of. If you're aware of something, it cannot be that which is aware. Think of how as children we began to distinguish, out of that mass of sensation, the world out there — object relationship, I think they call it. Out of this mass of sensations, mother starts to loom. Your first object, something separate from you, separates out of the mass, until eventually you're quite clear: this is me and everything else is not me. All we're doing is taking that process inward, making the inner part of our experience as objective as this room is.

This room has a body — a wall, ceiling — and it has atmosphere; it has a mind. So it is the same within us. As we begin to push out, push away, objectify the inner world as we've done the outer world, that process is the process of detaching from

it, undermining that relationship of it being me or mine. That's why we feel this process of liberation. That's why the Buddha says the taste of *Nibbāna* is freedom. It's the liberation from that wrong connection with what we're experiencing.

But this awareness has to be supported, and the split is between those qualities which are passive and those which are active. When we practise this quiet abiding, we are practising the passive qualities — which for us are not highly developed in our society. It's the active qualities which are developed. The passive qualities are calmness: be calm, not excited all the time, not seeking a high level of energy, but bringing ourselves to a real deep calm. And interestingly, that's linked with this interest.

Interest can get excited. When you're interested in something, you can feel yourself getting all worked up — and that excitement taints the interest with trying to achieve something, trying to see something. Once there's a trying to see, the self takes over the process. To see something at this level, you have to let go of the idea that you're achieving it. There has to be real confidence, a faith that there is within us that which will produce insight without our trying. That's the abstraction — the taking away of this self which manifests as over-effort, as trying to see something. You won't relax and just let the eye look.

Tomorrow, when you're wandering around the paddock or the garden or you go for a walk, just rest your eye on something and watch the way the eye perceives. You don't have to try to perceive. Put a leaf in your hand, or just look at a tree, and watch how the eye itself is perceiving. Stand back from that process and you gain confidence. Oh, the eye perceives. I don't have to try.

It's the same with intelligence. If we get out of the way, intelligence works naturally — that's its quality. It understands. It perceives. It has insight. It doesn't think; thought is another process. Insight is immediate. You either see it or you don't.

Then there's the passive quality of steadiness of attention — just steadiness, concentration, focus. Keeping the attention steady. This has to be coupled with right effort, and the effort is simply to maintain the focus. Put in too much effort and you start getting restless, you get a shaking. Too little effort and the concentrated mind very quickly falls into sweet oblivion — sleep. Because that's what happens when the mind is nicely concentrated: it's calm, and off you go.

The passive quality of equanimity is so difficult for us in this sense: it comes from a position of don't know. You're looking at something, investigating something, without any preconceived ideas or notions that it has to be this way. Very difficult, because on one side we're being fed these three characteristics, and then we're told: just look. Forget about that. Just look and see for yourself. And there's no prejudice in the sense that the heart isn't involved in any over-desire. It's a calm heart.

All these factors we've talked about are natural to daily life. Everybody has them. What turns them into factors that lead to liberation is the investigation of the Dhamma. These same qualities would be found in anybody involved in science or active research — they're all the same sort of qualities you need. But once you turn all that to investigating the Dhamma, which here means these three characteristics, it leads to a change in the way we relate to the world we live in.

All that is within this discourse. This is what the Buddha taught lay people. And just as a little aside about the Mahāsi, whose picture you see here: after the Second World War, when Burma gained independence from us — oh pity — they elected a prime minister, the only one unfortunately, because in 1963 there was the military coup which they're still suffering from. A group of people were looking for a meditation teacher. The Mahāsi was a well-known teacher up in middle Burma, and they brought him down and set him up in a meditation centre.

By all tales, it was a virtual immediate success. He was teaching this. He wasn't teaching jhāna and absorption, for which you need time. He was teaching a direct path — it's ekāyana. And he created the parameters whereby people could move quickly. So it was great effort, as you know — sitting, walking, sitting, walking, eighteen hours a day — but it was never to try and attain something. It was always trying to relax and to watch and to see, to explore.

That's the specific place the Mahāsi holds in the vipassanā scene, you might say — he teaches this ekāyana magga, this direct path. So there we have it. What makes the Buddha an especially great person in spiritual history wasn't simply the amazing insight he had, but also his amazing ability to get it across — to actually produce a systematic way and a systematic teaching which people could understand. And not just the intellectuals, that's the point. Ordinary people, people of kuru saddham.

So I can only hope my words have been of some assistance. May you be liberated from all your suffering — sooner rather than later.

Vīriya: Effort

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 15 min

Originally given as *Vīriya: Effort* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this talk on vīriya (effort), one of the ten pāramī or perfections, Bhante Bodhidhamma explores the Buddha's teaching on right effort as found in the Noble Eightfold Path and the Satipaṭṭhāna discourse. Drawing on the Pali terms vīriya, vāyāma, and ātāpī, he explains the paradox of 'effortless effort' - establishing a position of objective observation rather than straining to achieve specific results.

The talk illuminates how genuine effort in meditation involves finding the balanced attention described in the Buddha's teaching to the monk Soṇa about tuning a vīṇā - neither too tight nor too slack. Bhante emphasizes that our effort should focus on becoming the 'objective observer' who watches body, heart, and mind with curiosity, allowing wisdom to naturally arise through sustained awareness.

For daily life application, he discusses how right effort manifests through proper intention (cetanā) and mindful engagement with work and relationships. Drawing connections to right livelihood within the Eightfold Path, he shows how intention determines whether our actions create stress or serve as spiritual practice. The talk concludes with practical advice on overcoming laziness through contemplation of urgency and the benefits of mindfulness, making this teaching accessible for both meditation practitioners and those seeking to integrate Dhamma into everyday activities.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-enlightened one.

For fear of boring one or two of you, I gave this talk at Chrissie's but forgot how to operate my little recorder, so I wanted to repeat it here. The topic is effort—one of what we call the perfections. You could translate *pāramī* as the seven virtues, but the word simply means those things that take you to the other shore. That's the Buddha's image for Nibbāna: to be over on the other side.

The Pali word is *virīya*, and you'll also find *vāyāma* in the Eightfold Noble Path. In the *Satipaṭṭhāna* discourse on establishing the mindfulness we've just been practising, the Buddha uses *ātāpī*. The first two words simply refer to effort, but *ātāpī* points to something more—a real, consistent effort in the practice.

This effort in practice is what Zen calls the effortless effort. What's meant by that is you're not trying to achieve anything—and that's really important. What you're trying to do is establish a way of looking at something, and then you have to trust that this intelligence we have will actually see. It might not work immediately, so you've got to have a certain confidence. That's the effort.

The Buddha is quite clear about this. Three things come together: effort, mindfulness, and intuitive intelligence. This intuitive intelligence manifests as curiosity—the curiosity of a child. It comes from a place where you don't know. If you're curious about something but already have ideas, you tend to see what you're looking for. Yet whatever we're looking for is something not directly obvious to us, or else we'd have seen it already.

Take our meditation just now, where we were trying to look at impermanence. If you said to anybody in the street, "Everything changes," they'd say, "So what? Quite obviously everything changes." But in the Buddha's understanding, this change is radical. Everything actually disappears and reappears. It moves into potential and then into actual. There's death with every moment; every single moment drops away and then arises. This can obviously be experienced, but what it shows us is discontinuity. That's the point—the discontinuity.

When you see yourself in the mirror, you recognise the same person you've always known. You presume it's the same body. But we know the body completely changes every seven years; all the atoms are transferred, yet we don't see that at all. So we live in the comfortable delusion that this is the body I've always had, that there's some stability to it. It's only when we get down to understanding these things that we come up against the real nature of life—how it rises and passes away.

The point about right effort in meditation is that we have to be clear: our effort is not to see this. Our effort is to get into a position where this is seen. In other words, we're trying to reach that place of the objective observer—an observation post within us—and we're just watching.

One example I tend to use is the twitcher. They hide in a hide and look out through a little window with their binoculars, just watching the bird. They don't do anything to the bird—that's the point. They don't do anything; they just watch. Then they go away and write their bestseller. That's what we're doing. We're trying to find this little hide within ourselves and just watch. And what are we watching? We're watching our physicality, the body, and how it manifests. We're watching the heart and how it manifests. We're watching the mind and thoughts. It's just in the watching that we come to know ourselves. You don't have to try. It's just the watching.

If you try too hard, if something comes in that makes you strain, then something else has entered the equation. You're either trying to achieve something or trying to concentrate—and that's a bad one. Concentration comes with relaxation.

There's a story of Sona, one of the monks during the Buddha's time. He'd given up and decided to leave the monastic life and return to ordinary lay life. When the Buddha heard this, he went to see him. The problem was clear: Sona was straining and straining. So the Buddha talked about tuning a string on a *vīṇā*—a bit like a guitar. It mustn't be too tight, or you miss the note, and it can't be too slack. It's about finding the right effort so that your attention is steady. If you find yourself getting tense, you immediately pull back and relax. If you find you're falling asleep, you wake up and make an effort. That moment of being relaxed yet firm is very difficult for us, because we're always on one side or the other.

When it comes to right effort in daily life, there's obviously some form of achieving involved. If you're at work, you've got to do a job. If you're at home, you've got to do this and that. The achieving isn't the problem. The problem, if there is one, is your intention. What is your intention? This is where we begin to develop our personalities and our characters.

It's interesting that right there within the Buddha's Eightfold Path you have right livelihood. He's saying that what you do in society is of central importance to your spiritual life. If you're doing a job simply to get on—simply for status, simply for money—then those intentions are going to drive you in a way that creates what we know these days as stress. But if your intention is service, if you take your attention to service, then there's a very different feel to what you do. That

doesn't mean you can't ask for proper wages, or that you can't go for a job with high status that you feel you can do. But it's the intention that's going to create either an internal state of stress or not.

There's a story of a Zen master having breakfast, eating and reading a newspaper. One of his students said to him, "Roshi, I just noticed that you're eating your breakfast and reading a newspaper." He replied, "When I'm eating breakfast, I'm eating breakfast. When I'm reading the newspaper, I'm reading the newspaper." It depends where you put your attention.

When you're at work or doing something, make sure you have the right intention for this particular piece of work. And you have to keep stopping to reaffirm it, because the old intentions keep creeping in. Then you put your attention into what you're doing.

In our meditation, we've found this place of an objective observer—this feeling of a self looking at things, an observer watching. That's actually a false place; it's not the final end we want to get to. But then we think that's what we've got to do in daily life. You watch yourself doing something and you think that's mindfulness. You can get away with that if you're doing something physical, but you can't have a conversation and observe yourself speaking—you lose the train of thought. You definitely can't add up your bills either.

When that self-awareness comes, it's there, but you keep putting your attention on what you're doing. As you do that, the self disappears because you're absorbed into the task. That's your meditation in action. And you know you've been there because when you come out of it, into that self-awareness, a certain time has passed where there's been no time and no sense of self. What makes that an enlightening experience is the purpose with which you went into it—the intention. This is all included in this idea of right effort.

Right effort begins with what the Buddha called *cetanā*, which translates as will. In the standing meditation we came to that point where we could see intentions arise. Just before we sat, we noted intending to rise, intending to sit. We could have stayed there; we could have kept standing. You don't have to obey an intention. But as soon as you moved, you empowered that intention. And as soon as you do that, you create a conditioning—you've created what in the language is called a *kamma*. You hear this word *kamma*, which normally means your comeuppance, but actually in the original literature it's what you do, your action. There's another word for your comeuppance.

As soon as you've put your will into something, that's it. You can't stop it. It will have an effect internally, and it will have an effect externally. And you don't know what's going to happen either way, because it moves into conditions over which you don't have control. So it's good to know what your intention is, because even if it turns out wrong, at least you feel good in yourself. You might do something for the benefit of somebody else and they hate you for it—occasionally happens. But you feel good within yourself because you did it with the right intention. There's that feeling of goodness in you. You can't stop people reacting from their position. So that's the important thing about effort.

And finally, there's this whole business of getting lazy, which is the opposite of effort. When we do things lazily and feel guilty, that's good. You should feel guilty. You should feel guilty and ashamed that you've been lazy. And then you should give yourself a little exercise or something to increase your effort. One of the things the Buddha advises to create this sense of urgency—a sense of urgency that's not stress, but a sense of getting on with the job—is to contemplate the negative side: sickness, old age, and death. If you haven't got that long to live, it doesn't matter where you are. You don't know when you're going to go, so better make the best of the circumstance you're within.

The other is to contemplate the benefit of mindfulness and how it can radically change your life, radically change your relationships. It doesn't mean that life gets that much easier, but at least we're here, at least we're aware.

Right effort is really central to the Buddhist teachings. It's right there, within virtually everything the Buddha says—right effort. I can only hope my words have been of some assistance. May you be liberated because of your unending efforts towards your liberation, sooner rather than later.

Sādhū, sādhū, sādhū.

Dhammapada 21-23: The Path of Diligence (Appamāda)

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 18 min

Originally given as *Dhammapada 21-23: The Path of Diligence (Appamāda)* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this teaching on Dhammapada verses 21-23, Bhante Bodhidhamma explores the crucial quality of appamāda—diligence, heedfulness, or vigilance—which the Buddha identified as the path to the deathless (amata), a term often used for Nibbāna. Drawing from the traditional commentary story of Queen Samāvatī and the vengeful Magandiyā, Bhante examines how these verses emphasize the fundamental importance of sustained spiritual effort.

The talk breaks down appamāda into three essential components: mindfulness and attentiveness, careful and conscientious action, and sustained effort with perseverance. Bhante explains how the vigilant 'do not die' spiritually, while the negligent remain bound by the yoga (fetters) of existence. He offers practical daily reflections for cultivating diligence: examining our mindfulness throughout the day, assessing whether we've acted with care and put our heart into our activities, and evaluating our effort in completing tasks.

Significantly, Bhante reminds us that appamāda were among the Buddha's final words: 'All compounded things are impermanent. Strive diligently (appamādena) for your liberation.' This teaching provides both philosophical understanding and practical guidance for developing the sustained spiritual effort essential for progress on the path to Awakening.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa (three times)

*Appamādo amatapadaṃ, pamādo maccuno padaṃ
Appamattā na mīyanti, ye pamattā yathā matā*

*Etaṃ visesato ñatvā, appamāde panditā
Appamāde pamodanti, ariyānaṃ gocare ratā*

*Te jhāyino sātaccakārī, niccam daḥhaparakkamā
Phusanti dhīrā nibbānaṃ, yogakkhemaṃ anuttaraṃ*

Translation: "Vigilance is the path to the deathless, negligence the path to death. The vigilant do not die, the negligent are as if already dead. Knowing this distinction, vigilant sages rejoice in vigilance, delighting in the company of the noble ones. Absorbed in meditation, persevering always, steadfast, the wise touch Nibbāna." A better translation would be "attain Nibbāna, the ultimate rest from bondage, the ultimate escape from bondage."

Now, the story is a bit strange and it was very long, so I've narrowed it down to specifics. The King Udena of Kosambī had a few consorts, I dare say, but one of them was Sāmāvatī. Now, Sāmāvatī had maids, and a Khujjuttarā used to fetch flowers from the forest for her every day. And one day when she got there, the Buddha was giving a sermon. On hearing it, she became a stream-entrant because of her past very good *kamma*.

When she went back, she told Sāmāvatī about this and related the whole talk to her and the other maids. They all took on a devotion to the Buddha, so much so that they put holes in the walls of their apartment, of their palace, so that when the Buddha came on alms round, they could bow to him. The reason they put holes in the wall was because they didn't want to tell the king, because they thought he might be a bit upset.

Now his other consort was a very beautiful woman called Māgandiyā. Her father, the brahmin, had actually offered her as a wife to the Buddha, and the Buddha of course said that he was way beyond all sensual, romantic pleasure—none of that. But then he went on to say, why would he be attracted to a body full of filth? And then he gave a discourse on impermanence. The brahmin and his wife became *anāgāmis*, which means non-returners, but her daughter was offended and she vowed revenge.

So the first thing she did, when she heard that the other wife, Sāmāvatī, had been bowing to the Buddha and looking at him through these holes in the wall, she told the king, Udena, thinking that he would be extremely angry. But when they explained to him what they were doing, he was quite all right with it. So now she began to gaslight, putting little ideas that, in fact, Sāmāvatī was out to kill him or do him great harm.

One time when the king determined to see his wife, taking a lute along—a vina—this Māgandiyā hid a snake in it and put flowers in the hole. When the king got to the queen and her maids, the flowers were taken out, the snake jumped out at him, and he realised then that in fact they had meant to kill him. So he lined them up in a row and took out his bow and arrow and began to shoot them. But the arrow kept missing the target, even though he was an excellent archer, which meant that they were innocent. So he gave up, he let them off.

That wasn't the end of it. Māgandiyā now was really in a very bad mood and she asked her uncle with some relatives to come and burn the palace down. That's what they did—they burned the palace down. When the king heard this he rushed over, and I shall read the last paragraph:

"As soon as he heard the news that all had been burnt, the king rushed to the scene, but it was too late. He suspected that it was done at the instigation of Māgandiyā, but did not show that he was suspicious. Instead, he said, 'While Sāmāvatī was alive, I had been fearful and alert, thinking I might be harmed by her. Only now is my mind at peace. Who would have done this? It must only have been someone who loves me very dearly.'

Hearing this, the foolish Māgandiyā promptly admitted that it was she who had instructed her uncle to commit this terrible deed. The king pretended to be very pleased with her and said he would grant her a great favour and honour all her relatives. So the relatives were sent for, and they came gladly. On arrival at the palace, however, all of them—including Māgandiyā—were seized and put to death in the palace courtyard. Thus the evil Māgandiyā was punished for plotting the death of the holy queen and her attendants.

When the Buddha heard of these incidents—he says 'incidents' here, these little things—he spoke the verses concerning diligence. Frankly, I don't quite know how that fits into the story, but we shall let that be.

A little vocabulary from the Pali: the word *amata*, the deathless, is often how the Buddha speaks of Nibbāna—a state of deathlessness. *Pada* means footsteps, so we have the path to the deathless. The quality of diligence is really important here. The commentary doesn't say much more; it simply notes that negligence, on the other hand, is the way to the repeated cycle of birth and death. Remember that rebirth is presumed throughout the Buddhist scriptures—*saṃsāra*, the on-ward going. That's what happens to those who aren't diligent.

In the second verse, knowing this distinction, vigilant sages rejoice in vigilance, delighting in the field, sphere, or dimension of the noble ones. There's an interesting word here: *gocara* is where the cows go. *Go* is cow and *cara* means to go, so it's basically a pasture—you might say it's their club. The wise ones have distinctly understood the importance of vigilance, and we'll come to that a little later. They rejoice in it; they're happy when they're in that state. The same is true for us, I hope.

The third verse speaks of being absorbed in meditation, persevering always, steadfast—the wise obtain Nibbāna, the ultimate rest from bondage. The translation here has 'toil,' but *yoga* is actually a bond or yoke. In the Dhammapada it might be referring to the ten fetters—I won't go into them in detail, but the ten fetters are what you have to get rid of to become fully liberated. Later on, *yoga* became a technical term for three qualities: acquisitiveness, always trying to hold on and get hold of things and people; wrong view that this would bring happiness; and delusion, which is always basically to do with the sense of self. So long as we believe in some smallest way that we are this psychophysical organism, we'll be seeking happiness through this form, and it will always be disappointing in the end—because we die.

In the commentary, there's one little line: one has to persevere constantly and with right effort. If you go into resources and then tips, you'll find one on *ap-pamāda*. There's a verse I quoted there where the Buddha says, 'I do not see even a single thing that so causes latent unwholesome qualities to arise and arisen wholesome qualities to decline than negligence. For one who is heedless or negligent, latent unwholesome qualities arise and arisen wholesome qualities decline.' Of course, the opposite is true when one is actually diligent.

I looked up synonyms for diligence in the thesaurus and came up with a whole load of words, which happily could be divided into three qualities. First, there was mindfulness: attentiveness, vigilance, being heedful. Then there was a sense of care: careful, conscientious, meticulous, thorough, painstaking. And finally the quality of effort: hard-working, industrious, assiduous, zealous, dogged, perseverance.

So these three qualities are included in the word diligence. Mindfulness—right attention. Care—where you put your mind you always put your heart into what you're doing; there has to be a sense of care, even just doing something carefully. And of course effort—the right effort to complete what one is doing as best one can.

I've suggested some reflections one can make. At the end of the day you might ask, 'How mindful have I been all day?' You don't want to ask it if you're going to be very disappointed. Well no—if you ask it and you are very disappointed, then of course we should encourage ourselves. That's where you make the determination in the evening: 'Tomorrow I shall try to be more attentive.'

The next reflection would be, 'Have I been careful with everything I've done? Have I been gentle? Have I put my heart into what I'm doing? Have I done it for good reasons?' And then finally, 'Did I put the right effort in? Did I actually complete the task, whatever I was doing?'

Of course, this *appamāda* is expressed not only in our doing but in the way we speak and the way we think. Remember, everything starts with something in the head and then manifests through our speech and action.

Just as a little aside, diligence is one of the seven heavenly virtues, as opposed to the seven deadly sins. The first virtue is chastity—purity, abstinence—and the opposite, of course, is lust. The next is temperance, put as humanity and equanimity, with gluttony as its opposite. Then charity: goodwill, benevolence, generosity, sacrifice—the opposite being greed. And then comes diligence. The Latin word is *industria*, hence industry, persistence, effortfulness, and ethics. Its opposite is sloth.

When I looked up synonyms for diligence, the dictionary also gave me the antonyms—and that's something we can remind ourselves of too: lazy, sluggish, slothful, can't be bothered, do it tomorrow, slapdash. So we've got plenty of ways to consider our actions during the day, even after every single action.

This quality of heedfulness—that's Bhikkhu Bodhi's preferred translation, though others render it as diligence—remember that it appears in the Buddha's last words. All compounded things are impermanent. *Appamādena sampādetthāti*—strive diligently for your liberation. That was his second to last utterance before he completed his journey. Something to consider.

I can only hope my words have been of some assistance, that they haven't caused even greater confusion, and that by your diligence you will be liberated from all suffering—sooner rather than later.

Overcoming the Taints by Endurance

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 21 min

Originally given as *Overcoming the Taints by Endurance* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this dharma talk from the 2020 lockdown series, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the fourth method for overcoming the mental taints (āsava) - through patient endurance (adhivāsanā). Drawing from the Buddha's teachings, he explores how we can transform our relationship with life's inevitable irritations, from minor daily frustrations to major challenges like illness, loss, and even the current COVID-19 pandemic.

The talk covers the Buddha's teaching on enduring physical discomforts, harsh words, and painful experiences without allowing taints of aversion and craving to arise. Bhante discusses the four worldly conditions (gain/loss, fame/obscurity, pleasure/pain, praise/blame) and shares practical examples of how impatience and rejection create unnecessary suffering.

A highlight is the humorous story of Vedahikā and her maid Kālī, illustrating the difference between genuine patience and suppressed anger. The talk culminates with the profound 'Simile of the Saw' teaching, where the Buddha instructs that even if bandits were sawing off one's limbs, one should maintain loving-kindness without hatred. This radical teaching on forgiveness and endurance offers a transformative approach to dealing with life's difficulties through acceptance rather than resistance.

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā Sambuddhassa
 Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa
 Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

We're still on the taints — can't seem to leave them behind. Let me remind you that we have seven taints here, and it's good to revise them. There's the taint overcome by seeing, which is through insight, remember — the insight that overcomes the taint, especially regarding not-self, the false sense of 'I', through *vipassanā*.

Then we had the taint overcome by restraint, by restraining ourselves. Next, we abandoned taints by using things wisely. And now we come to abandoning things by enduring. The quality here, of course, is patience.

The Buddha is big on patience. He calls it the highest form of ascetic practice — by which he means renunciation. It's the highest form of renunciation because you are renouncing reaction to what is unpleasant.

So let's read what he says. 'What taints, bhikkhus, should be abandoned by enduring? Here, reflecting wisely, he bears cold and heat, hunger and thirst, contact with gadflies, mosquitoes, wind, the sun, creeping things' — and COVID-19. 'He endures ill-spoken, unwelcome words and arisen bodily feelings that are painful, wracking, sharp, piercing, disagreeable, distressing and menacing to life. While taints, vexation and fever might arise in one who does not endure such things, there are no taints, vexation or fever in one who endures them. These are called overcoming the taints by enduring.' Vexation here is the aversion; fever is the desire.

Let's look at one or two areas where we find ourselves getting very irritated — those little niggly irritations. Leaving the freezer door open and finding it's all iced up. And then you kick it too. The toaster when you set it wrongly and it burns the toast. All these little irritations, an impatience with things. It's surprising how everything has to be now. Everything has to be now. I read somewhere that Amazon spent millions developing immediate delivery — what do they call it? Prime? — so that as soon as you've clicked on your box of chocolates, you can hear it drop through your letterbox. That's how we're demanding that everything has to be now.

In fact, I have to confess to a certain impatience myself here. This little gadget I'm looking at — I did actually order it through Amazon, and after about two weeks gave up on them and went to eBay. That doesn't mean I prefer eBay to Amazon; it's just that I finally got it on eBay. But I remember my concern bordering on a certain annoyance that it hadn't been delivered.

Then there are neighbours. Oh my goodness, neighbours. If you have a noisy neighbour, it can drive you potty. I know it. I used to live in these two-up, two-downs, and my next-door neighbour had a real love of Elvis Presley. Now, I myself like Elvis Presley, but not all the time and not at the volume she would play it. I had to go down once and ask her to turn it low. 'Do you mind just turning it low?'

And her reply was, 'I pay my rates.' I thought, well, OK. Anyway, she did — she was very kind. But yes, neighbours. Those little noises from the TV or music coming through the walls.

This reminds me of when I used to go to Sri Lanka. When I first got there, I had this beautiful little hut, this *kuṭi*. The squirrels were around, and what they used to do was climb along the beams of my walking path — there was a channel for walking, a *caṅkama*. They were gnawing at the wood to get the grubs out, and I found this tremendously disturbing. Then there was this, what you might call, cartoon moment when I jumped off the cushion I was sitting on and ran down the corridor waving a flag and beating these beams. These days, if that had been caught on camera, it would definitely have gone viral.

Of course I went back to my seat. The squirrels disappeared, and I thought, that's that. But as soon as I sat down again, they were at it, scratching away. So one has to accept these things. Noises in the East — I only remember real quietness descending around about one o'clock at night. I used to wake up in real quietness at two o'clock, and then it would all start again at about three. But even in the absolute quietness, there would be crickets or cicadas. There was always noise.

I remember coming back once — I had to return to England when my mother and father died during that time. And the noise was just overwhelming. The birds, the squirrels — there were these birds that squeaked to each other all the time. They're called the seven sisters, and they don't stop talking. Then I noticed that as soon as I stopped getting irritated, within a day or two, I didn't hear them. This is the point, isn't it? As soon as you're angry, as soon as you're irritated, your ear sticks on it. And as soon as you stop being averse, trying to reject it, trying to get rid of it, the attention moves away and it just becomes background noise — within reason, of course.

We also get angry at people's opinions if they're not the same as ours. This whole Brexit thing — boy, do we see some awful stuff there. And of course there's a fear that you're going to be somehow converted to their point of view. That's where the pride sits. So when you hear something and feel yourself getting irritated with the person for expressing that view, we have to remind ourselves: everybody has their perspective. If I open up to this person's point of view, I might not agree, but at least I'll understand where they're coming from.

Then there's illness. Obviously we're suffering this COVID thing now, but any illness — we simply don't want to be ill. That's the end of it. You can be quite angry with yourself for catching a cold, or angry with somebody else for giving you the flu, or worse, COVID. And of course there's loss of work. A lot of people are facing that right now, and it brings about a sense of depression, a sense of not wanting to bear with it.

Patience, remember, is not resignation. We're not resigned to it. We're not rolled over by it. Patience is accepting things as they are and recognising that any aversion, any rejection, any trying to manipulate the situation for my own personal good is just causing more trouble — and makes us even more angry.

The Buddha talks about the four worldly conditions. First, there's gain and loss. Every time we gain something, we're happy. When we lose it, we're unhappy. We don't like it. We get angry, we get depressed. But recognising that this is just not necessary — it's simply not necessary. Loss comes and that's the end of it. One receives it. One accepts it fully. And if one accepts it with a good heart, one always sees potential. When that situation ends, you're open and ready to see where the potential lies.

Then there's fame and being ignored. You walk into a crowd and they all know you, they all greet you, and you get some high idea about yourself. Then you walk into another crowd and they completely ignore you — or worse, they want to ignore you, which is even harder to bear. This whole idea of having lots of friends — in the Sangha, you often find that monks gather together because they feel comfortable in each other's company. But when they mix across different nationalities, you find them not so open to each other. It's not so very nice sometimes, but it occasionally happens.

And then there's happiness and unhappiness. One minute we're happy, the next minute we're unhappy. You have to bear with that. There's no point in trying to fight it. Whatever is causing the unhappiness — it could be a relationship, it could be the weather, it could be your financial situation, your own personal circumstances — to get angry with it, to get irritated with it, to try and get rid of it, it's all wasted energy.

Finally, he talks about praise and blame. We all like to be praised — that's wonderful. But blame? We're always trying to defend ourselves. Even when we've obviously done something wrong, we'll find some way of defending ourselves. Of course it's worse if you're blamed and you know you shouldn't be. That is hard to bear, hard to bear. But the Buddha is asking us to bear with it.

Now I want to break off here for this delightful story of Kālī. This is about somebody who is pretending to be patient. Formerly, in Sāvattthī — remember, that's where the Buddha's main monastery was, or definitely one of his main monasteries, which Anāthapiṇḍika, the rich merchant, had bought for him — there was a housewife named Vedehikā. A good report about Mistress Vedehikā had spread: Mistress Vedehikā is kind, is gentle, is peaceful.

Now Mistress Vedehikā had a maid called Kālī, who was clever, nimble, and neat in her work. The maid Kālī thought: a good report about my lady has spread — Mistress Vedehikā is kind, is gentle, is peaceful. But how is it now? While she does not show anger, is it nevertheless actually present in her? Or is it just because my work is neat that my lady shows no anger, though it is actually present? Supposing I test my lady.

So the maid Kālī got up late. Mistress Vedehikā said, 'Hey, Kālī!' 'What is it, madam?' 'What's the matter with you, getting up so late?' 'Nothing is the matter, madam.' 'Nothing is the matter, you wicked girl? Yet you get up so late!' And she was angry and displeased and she scowled. Then the maid thought: the fact is that while my lady does not show anger, it is actually present in her — not absent. It's just because my work is neat that she shows no anger, though it is actually present, not absent. Supposing I test my lady a little more. She's a bit cheeky, really, isn't she?

So the maid Kālī got up later in the day. Mistress Vedehikā said, 'Hey, Kālī!' 'What is it, madam?' 'What is the matter with you? You get up later today.' 'Nothing is the matter, madam.' 'Nothing is the matter, you wicked girl, yet you get up later in the day!' Now she was angry and displeased, and she spoke words of displeasure. Then the maid Kālī thought: the fact is that while my lady does not show anger, it is actually present in her, not absent. Suppose I test my lady a little more.

So the maid Kālī got up still later in the day. Mistress Vedehikā said, 'Hey, Kālī!' 'What is it, madam?' 'What is the matter with you? You got up later still today.' 'Nothing is the matter, madam.' 'Nothing the matter, you wicked girl? And you get up still later in the day!' She was angry and displeased. She took a rolling pin and gave her a blow on the head and cut her head. Then the maid Kālī, with blood running from her cut head, denounced her mistress to the neighbours: 'See, ladies, the kind lady's work! See, ladies, the gentle lady's work! See, ladies, the peaceful lady's work! How can she become angry and displeased with her only maid for getting up late? How can she take a rolling pin, give her a blow on the head, and cut her head?'

And later on, a bad report about Mistress Vedehikā spread: Mistress Vedehikā is rough. Mistress Vedehikā is violent. Mistress Vedehikā is merciless.

So often you meet somebody who doesn't show anger, but actually it's all hidden inside them. I remember one person who declared that he never felt anger. But of course, it was all over him. You could tell a mile off that he was very angry.

This is a case of bearing up — bearing up what we have to suffer now. It's that sense of endurance. And of course, in our practice, there's a lot of that. When we sit, all this turbulence comes up: the fears and the worries and the angers and the depressions and all the stuff we suffer from. Remember that we open up to it, and we open up to it with loving kindness. We embrace it. If we can take that attitude to anything in the world that disturbs us, it just undermines this wrong relationship we have — getting angry, not wanting to endure things.

Of course, it gets worse because there are severe situations. Victims of violence, and of course torture. That's the worst. Torture really is quite awful. And we know that even our own soldiers were playing at torture. That's very hard to forgive, especially when you've been really brutalised like that. There was a lovely book — although he wasn't particularly brutalised in a way — by Brian Keenan, I think it was, called 'An Evil Cradling.' It goes back to the 80s, where he was a hostage. Some of you might remember. That is definitely worth reading — his ability to forgive them is remarkable. And you'll find people who've been terribly damaged and are able just to forgive. Forgiveness is the way out of this resentment towards them and resentment towards yourself. You have to be able to forgive yourself.

It's often a case of pride — an inverted pride. 'I'm horrible. I'm useless. I'm terrible. I ought to live in hell.' So again, the Buddha gives us a wonderful simile, which many of you will know. It's called the simile of the saw: 'If bandits were to sever you savagely, limb from limb, with a two-handed saw, he who gave rise to a mind of hate towards them would not be carrying out my teaching.'

When I said this at one place, somebody said the Buddha had a great sense of humour. But I think he actually means it. 'Hearing this, bhikkhus, you should train yourselves thus: Our minds will remain unaffected. We shall utter no evil words. We shall abide compassionate for their welfare, with a mind of loving kindness, without inner hatred. We shall abide pervading them with a mind imbued with loving kindness, and starting with them we shall abide pervading the all-encompassing world with a mind imbued with loving kindness — abundant, exalted, immeasurable, without hostility and without ill will. That is how you should train yourselves.'

'If you keep this advice on the simile of the saw constantly in mind, do you see any coarse speech, trivial or gross, that you could not endure?' 'No, venerable sir.' 'Therefore, you should keep this advice on the simile of the saw constantly in mind. That will lead to your welfare and happiness for a long time.'

That was what the Blessed One said, and the bhikkhus were satisfied and delighted in the Blessed One's words. So this is our overcoming certain taints. Remember, taints are oozings, floods, these washes of negativity and unwholesomeness that are within us. They manifest in specific situations, specific incidences. Therefore, we have to have that real awakenedness to catch the first movement of irritation, of anger, of rejection, of trying to change something just to make us feel more comfortable.

But more than that — there's this sense of opening up to the unpleasant. And then you see there's no suffering in it. There's no suffering in it.

When those moments of resistance come up, when you feel that contraction, that wanting to push away the unpleasant or grasp onto the pleasant, remember this teaching about endurance. Remember that you have the capacity to remain equanimous, to stay present with whatever is arising without being overwhelmed by it.

May you all find this helpful in your practice, and may it lead to your welfare and happiness for a long time.

Dhammapada Chapter 3 - Verses 33 & 34: The Unruly Mind

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 17 min

Originally given as *Dhammapada Chapter 3 - Verses 33 & 34: The Unruly Mind* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this exploration of Dhammapada Chapter 3, verses 33-34, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the Buddha's teaching on the naturally unsteady and difficult-to-control mind. Using the story of Thera Meghiya, who struggled with wandering thoughts during meditation, these verses illustrate how the wise train the mind like a fletcher straightens an arrow, and how the mind quivers like a fish out of water when withdrawn from sensual pleasures.

The talk provides detailed commentary on the Buddha's practical instructions from the Vitakkasaṇṭhāna Sutta (MN 20) for dealing with unwholesome thoughts: focusing on opposite wholesome objects, examining the drawbacks of negative thinking, ignoring and forgetting distracting thoughts, investigating the causes of mental formations (saṅkhāra), and using strong concentration practices like loving-kindness meditation to overwhelm unwholesome states.

Bhante Bodhidhamma explains how these ancient techniques remain relevant for modern meditators struggling with mental restlessness, offering both immediate practical solutions and deeper insight into the workings of consciousness. The teaching emphasizes the importance of persistent effort in mental training while maintaining balance and avoiding self-hatred in the process of spiritual development.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā-sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā-sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā-sambuddhassa.

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

In this chapter, I want to turn to chapter three of the *Dhammapada*, which concerns the mind. I've chosen the first two verses, and I shall chant them in my own inimitable way.

The wavering, unsteady mind, hard to control, difficult to restrain — the wise one straightens it like an arrow maker straightens an arrow. That was the first verse. And the second: As a fish quivers when taken out of its watery hole and thrown onto dry ground, so does the mind quiver when it is taken out of the sensual world to escape the realm of Mara.

How did these verses come about? For that, we turn to the story of Thera Meghiya. While residing at Cālika Mountain, the Buddha uttered these verses in reference to this monk. Now *thera* means elder — you have to be a monk or nun for ten years to become a *thera* or *therī*. After twenty years, you're called a *mahāthera* or *mahātherī*, which is a big *thera*, a big elder. These days, you don't normally use the word *mahāthera* except for people who've become quite elderly.

At that time, Thera Meghiya was attending upon the Buddha. One day, returning from alms round, the *thera* noticed a pleasant and beautiful mango grove, which he thought would be an ideal spot for meditation. He asked the Buddha's permission to go there, but since the Buddha was alone at the time, he was told to wait until some other *bhikkhus* arrived. The *thera*, however, was in a hurry. He repeated his request again and again until finally the Buddha told him to do as he wished.

So Thera Meghiya set out for the mango grove, sat at the foot of a tree, and practised meditation. He stayed there the whole day, but his mind kept wandering and he made no progress. In the evening he returned and reported to the Buddha how all day he'd been assailed by thoughts associated with the senses, with ill will, and with cruelty. The Buddha told him that because the mind is easily excitable and fickle, one must learn to control it.

In the first verse, there's nothing particularly important about the Pali as such. It's simply a case of the mind being excitable, unsteady, wavering — difficult to control, difficult to restrain — yet one has to work at it, as a fletcher straightens an arrow. I did go onto YouTube to find out how to straighten an arrow. Where the arrow is bent, you place it on a surface so the bow is sticking upwards, then rub it up and down with a piece of wood. The friction creates heat, making it easily bendable, and when it cools it stays straight. There were other methods, but I think this is the one the Buddha was referring to — because of course in training the mind, you've got to keep bringing it back, bringing it back.

The second verse, about the fish, has a slightly interesting word: *vārija*. *Vāri* means water and *ja* means born — so born in the water, hence a fish. As a fish quivers when taken out of its watery home, so the mind quivers when taken away from the realm of Mara.

We are, of course, entranced by our senses: what we see, what we hear, what we taste. When we suddenly find ourselves in this inner quiet place, no longer feeding the senses, those old habits go berserk. They want to be back out in the world, engaging with Mara, the enticer. Just like a fish taken out of water, almost gasping for oxygen and quivering, so the mind gasps for sensual delights. That's a very good image. The Buddha is very good at these little metaphors to get his meaning across. Some people think like that — they have imaginative, poetic minds — while others have very intellectual minds. Most of us, of course, are somewhere in between.

Having said all that, does the Buddha somewhere give ideas on how to train the mind? For this, we have to go to the scriptures themselves. But just before I do, let me read the commentary. There's a commentary on all these *Dhammapada* verses and on the scriptures generally. The story behind this verse is the same as the previous one, so they're both much the same. Our mind is indeed wavering, writhing, and difficult to restrain — and the commentators want to give us an image like a snake or a young branch. An arrow maker making an arrow has to straighten it, otherwise it would be worthless. In the same way, we have to straighten the mind, otherwise it won't hit the goal. The goal, of course, is *nibbāna*.

Now, how to stop thinking. This is found in the middle discourses, the *Majjhima Nikāya*, number 20. You can look it up yourself. I shall only mention the various ways in which it can be done.

The first method is to focus on some other foundation of meditation connected with what is skilful. For instance, if erotic images appear in the mind, one thinks of the foulness of the body — and that definitely undoes the eroticism. With food, when you're eating and feeling greedy, overeating, just imagine what happens to the food until its final elimination. That would definitely put you off eating much more.

The principle here is that when desire arises, you try to create the opposite. Now, you're not trying to develop disgust and self-hatred, or hatred towards the body. You're just trying to balance things. When something pleasant comes up as an obsessive thing, you bring up the opposite and they cancel each other out. It's simply a way of undermining these unwholesome habits.

If the desire is directed towards an inanimate object, then of course it's impermanence. You might be wandering around the shops, escaping from lockdown and seeing all these wonderful clothes, and then you recognise that the body's impermanent, clothes are impermanent, everything's impermanent. You undermine that greed. That's what we're concerned with — not with not buying clothes; we need to dress ourselves.

When thoughts of hate arise towards another person, the opposite is loving-kindness. If it's towards an inanimate object and there was a greedy desire to have something, see it in its characteristics, the four great elements: that it is actually just something that comes together with pressure, with heat, with something elastic and moving — movement. In other words, just deconstruct it. See it for what it actually is. Thoughts with delusion are slightly different — that would be something like doubt. For these, the text says to put yourself under the guidance of a teacher, study the Dharma, inquire into its meaning, listen to the Dharma and inquire into its causes.

The second method is to examine the drawbacks of these thoughts. Just remembering the unworthiness of evil thoughts causes us to feel shame. Now, shame doesn't have very good support in modern psychotherapy, but that would be neurotic shame — shame to do with self-worth, with self-esteem, statements that we have about ourselves. Sometimes we feel a wholesome shame thinking about these things or getting ourselves into those sorts of mental places. This is only about thoughts, remember. And of course, we need to understand that there are dangers, because when you develop unwholesome states, they do grow within us, and every so often they'll escape through what we say and even through what we do. There has to be a little bit of dread of consequences.

The next method is a little bit difficult for us: to try to ignore the thoughts and forget about them. When the mind is just restless, moving all over the place, sometimes the best thing to do is push it aside and bring the attention back into the body. Sometimes that works; sometimes you do forget them. Of course, here we're talking about training the attention to be still. This is obviously a little bit of suppression, but we can deal with these things much better when we've attained some level of steadiness of the mind.

Then the text says you should stop the formation of thoughts. That's interesting because the Pali uses the word *saṅkhāra*. *Saṅkhāra* are our habits, our volitional formations — what we have created in ourselves through acts of will. All our negative speaking, all our anger, all our anxiety — all that is self-created, just as much

as our love, our happiness and joy. Here it actually translates as stopping the causing of thought. We can ask the question: what is the cause? Why is this happening in me? That's getting us close to a more *vipassanā* position where we would go into the body to examine the actual mental state that's causing the thoughts to arise. And of course, that's where we would stay — investigating, feeling, allowing this mental state to express itself.

Finally, if all that doesn't work, the Buddha says: with teeth clenched and tongue pressed against the roof of the mouth, they should squeeze, squash and torture the mind with mind. That sounds pretty heavy, but what the Buddha is saying is that we should really replace an unwholesome thought with a wholesome thought.

This is especially useful if you're trying to develop a particular mental state, such as loving-kindness. If you find that you're very involved in some sort of hateful thing, angry place, anxious place — doesn't matter what it is — you really just keep going with beads: "May all beings be happy, may all beings be safe, may all beings be healthy, may all beings..." and you just pound, pound, pound. What you're doing is creating a mental state which will eventually sit on top and keep these unfortunate states underneath. You are developing that mental state. When we practise this, we are developing loving-kindness, but we're not looking at what's underneath. Again, the purpose is to still the mind, to stop this energy going up into the head and creating this vortex of energy.

So what we've done is read these two little verses. The mind is excitable and unsteady. It is difficult to control and to restrain. The wise one trains his mind to be upright as a fletcher straightens an arrow. As a fish quivers when taken out of its watery home and thrown onto dry ground, so does the mind quiver when it is taken out of the sensual world to escape from the realm of Mara.

I can only hope my words have been of some assistance, that they have not caused even greater confusion, and that you will, by your devotion to practice, liberate yourselves from all suffering sooner rather than later.

The Importance of Tranquillity — Passaddhi

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 16 min

Originally given as *The Importance of Tranquillity — Passaddhi* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines passaddhi — tranquillity or calmness — as one of the seven bojjhaṅgas (factors of Awakening). He explains how this essential quality affects both body and mind, from activating the parasympathetic nervous system to releasing beneficial neurotransmitters like serotonin and reducing cortisol.

Bhante explores how tranquillity functions in meditation practice, particularly in samatha (calming) exercises and jhāna (absorption states), and its connection to the fourth brahmavihāra of upekkhā (equanimity). He demonstrates how cultivating calmness improves decision-making, relationships, creativity, and overall mental health, while serving as the foundation for deeper concentration and insight.

Drawing on both Buddhist psychology and modern neuroscience, this talk offers practical guidance for developing passaddhi as a daily habit — from mindful transitions between activities to creating peaceful conditions for sleep. Bhante emphasizes that tranquillity is not merely relaxation but a crucial spiritual quality that supports all aspects of the path to Awakening, ultimately pointing toward the sublime serenity of Nibbāna itself.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

This evening I thought we'd tackle another factor of enlightenment. The word is *passaddhi*, and it translates as calmness, tranquillity, serenity. You can see how important this quality is — the Buddha included it among the seven factors of enlightenment.

Just to remind you, the seven factors are awareness, effort and concentration, this calmness and curiosity, and then equanimity and the investigation of the Dharma. The first six are general virtues that everybody can develop. What turns them into factors of enlightenment is the investigation of the characteristics of existence: impermanence, how we create suffering for ourselves through wrong attachments and wrong desires — wanting, not wanting — and of course, identity, not-self.

The Buddha always splits everything into body and mind, so let's look at what happens in the body. I did a bit of research, though most of you probably know this better than I do. Remember, we have autonomic systems: the sympathetic and the parasympathetic. The sympathetic is fight and flight. You're walking across the road and a car suddenly makes for you — before you know it, you've got to the other side. That's the sympathetic nervous system. The parasympathetic is the opposite: calmness, rest and digest. I've picked that phrase up somewhere. It affects your heart rate, and so on.

The big thing about being calm, about relaxing into the present moment, is that physically it releases all these wonderful neurotransmitters: serotonin, which makes you feel happy and gives a sense of well-being, and the endorphins, those feel-good factors. Now, in Buddhist understanding, these hormones within the body affect the mind. There are two different systems within us: a more gross energy that we call subatomic particles or subatomic energy, and a mental energy which is separate from that. This you can actually experience in your meditation.

It's not as though these hormones directly make you happy; they have an effect on the heart, on your emotional life, which makes it happy. And of course, it works the other way too. When you're angry, the body gets hot. Similarly, relaxation reduces cortisol — that's what floods us when we've got all this stress-related stuff, which isn't very good for us.

Because you're relaxed, because the body is feeling okay, it's obviously much better for our immune system. We're able to fight diseases. As you know, there's a syndrome where people who are stressed at work go on holiday and then fall ill. It's as though they have to have a real rest before the body can let go.

Relaxation also lowers muscle tension — that's the whole point of relaxing, isn't it? To relax the muscles. And this can alleviate even chronic pain. Going back to my first episode with my back, the first time the disc prolapsed, I went along to an acupuncturist. I was surprised that as the needles went in, this anxiety came

up. And as the anxiety dissipated, the pain wasn't anywhere near as bad as when I had this anxiety holding the body, as it were. It was trying to protect me. These systems are trying to protect us.

And of course, relaxation helps digestion. Stress can lead to digestive issues such as indigestion and irritable bowel syndrome, so it's especially important to feel relaxed around eating. If you're at work being pressured and you're just chucking the sandwich down your throat, that can't be doing you good, can it? In Eastern understanding — I was thinking of the Chinese — eleven o'clock to one o'clock is eating time. Your body is primed to eat then. And from one o'clock to three o'clock is liver time. If you're rushing around while your liver's trying to handle all these nutrients, you can see it's not going to do you much good. So between eleven and three, make an effort to be a bit more relaxed. That's if you're stressed.

There's also a change in brain activity: you get these lovely alpha brain waves, the ones you have when you're feeling relaxed. It's a very creative place to be. And we're there when we meditate. When you're actually in that state of just *vipassanā*, normally the mind will go down to these alpha waves.

Obviously, relaxation improves your sleep too, because if you're not calm when you're trying to sleep, it's difficult. That's why it's really important to close everything down about half an hour before we intend to sleep. Get off the social media, turn off Netflix, the BBC. Do something that's going to calm you. I personally sometimes listen to the chanting from Throssel Hole Abbey, which was my first Buddhist encounter — I just love their chanting. But there's other types of music, or you could read poetry. There are many things you can do that are just relaxing, preparing you to go into sleep.

What we want is for that substrate under sleep to be calm and peaceful. And of course, when we're in bed, we can put the attention on the breath and just feel it, just feel the body breathing. It wafts you into sleep, very calm. You can do *mettā*, of course. But the big thing is this sense of being relaxed, of being at ease.

When it comes to *cittānupassanā*, the calmness and tranquillity of the heart, the stress works the other way round. It comes as a reaction to a given situation or person, and that stress in the heart moves back into the body. As soon as we can relax around something that's upsetting us or making us anxious, all the better. And if we have a habit of being calm in ordinary situations, it should extend

itself into stressful ones — which means we become slightly more emotionally resilient. We can move our emotions a bit. We're not stuck in one groove of being angry or anxious or getting depressed about something.

And of course, when you're calm, it just improves your decision-making. I have a rule for myself, and whenever I break it, it's always disastrous: I try never to make any decision when I'm miffed or angry, when I'm anxious or when I'm in doubt. If I make a decision in those states of mind, something bad turns up. You have to wait sometimes. You have to wait until there's calmness, and then there's greater clarity.

It's obviously better for our relationships too, isn't it? If you're with somebody who's neurotic, it affects you. And if you're neurotic, it affects them. If we can get into the habit of just being calm — not rushing in conversation, not trying to get the answer ready before the person has stopped talking — we can actually get into that mode of listening. And to listen, you've got to be calm. You've got to be open.

Calmness is obviously a good place for creativity. We're not talking about winners of the Booker Prize or ecstatic artists — it's just daily being creative about what we do. Even washing the pots can be a creative action. You can find different ways of doing it. Every moment, every day is different, and without us knowing it, we've got to be creative. Even if you're driving a car, you've got to be creative. You've got to see where you're going, drive in a safe and easy way, and feel relaxed.

You know what happens when you drive and you're tense, anxious to get somewhere, or late. That's how accidents happen. Being calm has an effect on our mental health. And developing that calmness as a base within our lives, from which we move into action — it's got to make us happy, hasn't it? Remember, these things are just habits. They're habits we can develop.

Calmness affects the body and it affects the heart. And so it becomes a *bojjhaṅga*, a factor of enlightenment. It looms quite large in the Buddha's teachings, normally connected to calm concentration. *Samatha* is the word for calming exercises — *mettā* practice would be a *samatha* practice — and it leads into an easy concentration. If you want to be concentrated, the worst thing you can do is try to be concentrated. Concentration comes when you're relaxed and at ease, just placing the attention on the object and allowing the concentration to manifest. As soon as you try to push the process, you're getting in the way, and what you get is restlessness.

You find it in the Eightfold Path. The last three factors are to do with mindfulness: right effort, right mindfulness, right concentration. And we can include in that concentration this sense of calmness.

It's also one of the four divine abidings — also called the illimitables. These are social virtues: love, compassion, joy. And there the word is *upekkhā*. This is where you get that touching of calmness and equanimity. Equanimity has to rest upon calmness; you can't be equanimous if you're all agitated. Equanimity, in my understanding, refers to a certain attitude, a certain way of looking at things. Calmness is your mental state, and it's supporting it.

It's there in meditation too. The concentration of *samatha* practice leads to an even deeper sense of relaxation through the practice of *jhāna*, through the practice of absorptions. It's right there within the practice — not something we add on, but a necessary part of it. And when we're calm and not restless, whenever something arises that obstructs our meditation or messes us about in ordinary daily life — from minor silly things to heavy mental states — if we've got that substrate of calmness, we can deal with it. That's the point.

And then finally, of course, there is the great calmness itself. In the *Metta Sutta*, remember, it talks about what must be done for those who wish to reach the state of peace. They use a different word there, *santa*. But of course, it is this calmness, this state of sublime serenity. That's one of the adjectives the Buddha uses for *Nibbāna*.

Getting into this habit is something I've been working on all my life since I became a Buddhist. When you finish something — when you've done a task, even just the washing of the pots, or a piece of work, or a bit of gardening — don't rush on. Just relax for a moment and reflect on what you've done. See how you feel about it.

Then just stop for a moment and relax into the present. Quite naturally, the next thing to be done will arise. You're moving into it from that base of calmness. And that allows us to be more wise, more loving.

I hope I've convinced you to really practise this quality of calmness — and that through your devotion to it, you'll be liberated from all suffering sooner rather than later.

CHAPTER 53

The Buddha and the Hindrances

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 47 min

Originally given as *The Buddha and the Hindrances* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



Bhante Bodhidhamma provides a comprehensive overview of meditation practice, beginning with the Buddha's own spiritual journey from worldly pleasure through ascetic extremes to the Middle Way of awakening. He explores how the Buddha's childhood experience of natural awareness (satipaṭṭhāna) became the foundation for his enlightenment under the Bodhi tree.

The talk examines paṭicca samuppāda (dependent origination) as the Buddha's fundamental insight into how suffering arises from ignorance (avijjā) and the mistaken identification of consciousness with body and mind. This creates the illusion of a solid, permanent self that seeks security through attachment and aversion.

The core teaching focuses on practical guidance for working with the five hindrances (nīvaraṇa): sensual desire, ill-will, sloth and torpor, restlessness and worry, and doubt. Rather than suppressing these mental states, Bhante emphasizes acknowledging them and investigating the underlying emotions in the body. He explains how each hindrance tells us to act in ways that reinforce conditioning, while wise practice involves doing the opposite - staying present with the uncomfortable feelings until they naturally subside.

The talk concludes with guidance on using periods of calm concentration to develop penetrating insight (vipassanā) into the three characteristics of impermanence, unsatisfactoriness, and not-self through careful observation of the breath.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa.

Tonight I thought I'd give a wide sweep to our meditation practice, to put it in some context. We'll begin with the Buddha's own experience, then look at this crucial teaching of the wheel of dependent origination—his understanding of where our peculiar delusion lies. And finally, at the end, hopefully a little bit about these problems we come across when we're sitting: the hindrances.

The Buddha himself is the basic paradigm; he's the archetype of this particular path—that's what he stands for. His early life is meant to be full of pleasure: easy-going, loving family, all that stuff, everything people dream about these days. Then around his early to middle twenties, something happened and he got fed up with it. What we can say is that he went through what we'd now call an existential crisis. He wondered why he was alive. In his terms, why he suffered.

In the mythology surrounding that psychological event, we have this business of him being out hunting or wandering the countryside when he comes across three different types of people: one very sick, one very old, and one dead. Each time it comes as a surprise to him because his family had shielded him from such things. We can take this as a metaphor for the fact that not until our early twenties do we really have an inkling of what death might be. It's the stirrings, shall we say, of a future middle-aged crisis, and the following old-age crisis.

He's now asking about these three things: sickness, old age, and death. Does every human being suffer from this? Do I suffer from this? And it was this recognition—that the end of life normally comes with some sickness, some of what my father called the decrepitude of old age, and then death—that changed everything. Of course it makes nonsense of trying to live a life around pleasure, riches, fame, or anything else that's going to come to an end. Because fundamentally what we want is something that's going to last, some everlasting state.

During his time there was a movement—it had begun before—this business of leaving home and becoming an ascetic. It tended to be anti-establishment. The establishment was the Brahminical tradition, which eventually developed into what we now know as Hinduism. They did have their ascetics, but new teachers came along who said quite radically different things. One of them was what we'd now call an absolute materialist: you just have the body and the brain, and when you died, that was the end of it.

There were some people with strange ideas about karma—some predestination that you had to run the gauntlet of karma. From being born a bug, you had to go right through to a rat, to a cow, to a human being, and onwards until the process just naturally came to an end. And there was nothing you could do about it. This

person said that if you went up one side of the Ganges slaughtering and pillaging and doing all sorts of rubbish, it wouldn't have any effect at all on this predestined path. And if you came down the other side doing great acts of compassion and wonderful acts of love, it would make no difference whatsoever. It was completely predestined.

Within that atmosphere the Buddha began his training, starting with what you might call the conservative orthodox line of Brahmanism. He went to two teachers who basically taught him very ancient techniques of meditation aimed at gaining highly ecstatic states of mind. Whenever he achieved this to the satisfaction of the teacher, the teacher would acclaim him as their equal and invite him to teach. But both times he refused the appointment, saying it hadn't completely satisfied him. He hadn't really got to the end of suffering, because whenever he came out of these states, he was as bad as before. There wasn't any particular improvement.

He then went on to a second type of training that was very common in those days: what we now term self-mortification. The worldly life, the materialist life, presumes you can get happiness through the ordinary gifts of living—TVs and stuff like that—and perhaps there's a stoicism there that, well, you can't be perfectly happy. The meditative school he'd attended said that real happiness wasn't to do with the material world; it was mental. You could create these beautiful mental states. Even here, in our *vipassanā* meditation, sometimes beautiful states do arise, correct? Definitely. And we can presume that this is nirvana, this is actually where we're really aiming for, if we could just maintain it.

The next school said that, in a sense, what was wrong was the body itself. Somehow you had to free yourself from the body. Self-mortification exercises were about subduing it. The most common was simply to starve it, to eat very little. Now those of you who've done something like a ten-day water fast will know that the first three days, just like a retreat, are horrible. Then somehow the body has cleared a lot of its toxins and you can feel quite lovely within it. Except, of course, that the body is now eating itself. You can't go on like that for too long.

They reduced their intake to a minimum. He says of himself that he came to a point where he could hold his spine through his stomach—that gives you an idea of how thin he got. But this led him nowhere either.

In desperation, he was sitting by himself on a road, probably looking fairly disconsolate, when a woman passed by with what seems to have been a bowl of rice pudding to offer to a deity at a shrine. Seeing him in such a miserable state, she

offered it to him. Actually, the commentaries bump it up a bit—they say she thought he was a deity and therefore offered it to him. I can't really imagine him looking like a deity. Anyway, this rice pudding gave him a certain energy, which he'd been lacking through the self-mortification exercise, and it brought up a certain hope in him. He must have been recollecting his own spiritual journey.

He remembered a moment from childhood, probably around the age of eight or nine, when he was watching his father perform the ceremonial first ploughing of the season. The state he recalled seemed somehow different from all the mental states he'd achieved through those meditations. It was deeply concentrated—the commentaries describe it as a kind of *jhāna*—but something else had been present too, something he recognised as having an investigative quality, a certain curiosity.

When I want to describe to people what this *satipaṇṇā*, this awareness with intuitive wisdom, is like, the closest image I can find is of a little child at the beginning of language. There's no great conceptual thinking yet. They see something like a little bug they've never encountered before, and they become entranced. Totally bewitched. They just look at it. You can see them—locked onto the object, watching so intently that the mouth drops open, the jaw goes slack.

One thing about posture—especially in Zen, which is very good at describing these things—is that the lips are together but the teeth are apart. When your teeth are apart, your jaw is relaxed. In your meditation, if you watch carefully, whenever you're thinking you may feel very small movements on your tongue. Thoughts are naturally connected to the tongue because of speech. And any tension around thinking immediately brings in the jaw. Sometimes, even by concentrating on your tongue and on relaxing the jaw, you can find that your thoughts stop—or at least calm down.

That moment when a child just looks at something with open curiosity—they're not coming to the experience with a concept. And while they're there with it, they haven't got conceptual thinking to think about it. All they can do is purely absorb what's going on directly. It's only afterwards, after a certain time, that they turn around and ask: What is that?

Trying to get back to that pure inquisitiveness—without a verbal question—that's what we're aiming for. That's the aim of the practice. We're trying to lift consciousness out of its confusion. In that confused state, it's blending with everything we experience: in the body as feelings, in the heart, and in thoughts.

The Buddha went to sit, and in a sense he was at the end of his tether. So he made this rather remarkable determination: he wouldn't move, wouldn't shift from his seat until he was fully enlightened—or he'd die. I don't know whether you've tried that. It doesn't last very long for me, anyway. One too many. But that was his determination, and he just sat there. Luckily for him and for us, he made the breakthrough and came to this understanding.

It's said that he spent the first night going through the psychological understanding of what he'd experienced, seeing how suffering arises. Then he went through the next night the other way, seeing how it comes to an end. And in the third night, he recapitulated and did them both. This is really a way of saying that when the Enlightenment came, when he actually realised the way things really are, it took a while for this whole thing to work out in terms of how to teach it—looking at the human being from the point of view of the enlightened person.

This has come up quite sharply since I've been down at Gaia House, where that area around Totnes and Dartington is a hotbed of alternative stuff. I've got myself a really bad name as being anti-psychotherapy and all that. But I didn't actually mean to do that. What I was trying to do was make very clear to people that if you want to become enlightened, if you want to actually be liberated from suffering from the Buddha's point of view, then you've really got to understand the psychology as the Buddha understood it.

This takes us into the wheel of dependent origination, which we touched on earlier. The fundamental stance of the Buddha, what he came to understand, was that the fundamental problem is ignorance. Now, this ignorance is not culpable. We're not blameworthy. It's a simple existential state. We don't know.

Not worrying about whether we have a past life or a future life, but just taking this life: in Buddhist understanding, mind and consciousness arise with conception. That's what consciousness is actually experiencing—just being in a cellular life, in a very material base. It's only later, as the fetus grows, that it begins to get some messages about feeling, touch, hearing. When it's born, we open our eyes, light comes in, we begin to hear things, we begin to understand things. And all this is coming into a consciousness which has begun from a position of not knowing.

That not knowing now makes a mistake which is quite understandable. It presumes itself to be what it finds itself in. I am the body, I am these feelings, I am what I think. I think therefore I am. It comes all the way up to the highest of philosophers, so you can understand that it's a very natural error—I mean, what else could consciousness do? It doesn't have another choice.

Having made this step, this mistake of thinking that we are this body, we are this mind, and so on—which is your basic delusion—on the wheel of dependent origination that's *saṅkhāra*. That's your dispositions; that's what it's created: a certain mode of dispositions around this essential mistake of thinking we are, for want of a better word, human beings. From that, of course, we form a relationship to the world whereby 'me' is here and everything and everyone else is out there.

Now this 'me' and 'other' become a separation. This is what Buddhism means by duality—living in a dual world. There's me here and everybody else out there. And me, I have things, so these are mine. As soon as I've created mine, I've created yours. Having created mine and yours, I live now in a very dualistic world. And the tighter I hold to me, the more afraid I am about maintaining me, what might have been a simple boundary becomes more and more a barrier.

Consider the difference between a barrier and a boundary. A river, for instance, might flow through a certain countryside, and on one side it might be green, on the other side desert. The river creates a boundary, you might say—a watershed on one side and none on the other. But things can still move across it. Yet when these two places become two countries, that river suddenly becomes a barrier, and nobody can move from one place to the other.

What the 'me' does, this ego—I don't particularly like using the word ego; it is used, but the better word is the self, this sense of self that we have. What the self does is demarcate very sharply. This is me, and that's not me. This is mine, and that's not mine.

Once the self has got itself into that position, it presumes itself to be more secure. Remember, fear is always the root emotion of self. Fear is right there at the base, prior to any other emotion. Why? Because the one thing that self is afraid of is its own death. That's why it's always trying to aggrandise itself, always trying to sustain itself, trying to make everything secure, to batten things down.

This self now has a relationship to the world whereby it's going to feel more secure the bigger it is. The bigger house I've got, the bigger the pension, the bigger the car—I feel better. And the more things I've got, the more things I own. You can see how this aggrandisement slips into immorality, because at some point I'm up against other people. So now I'm into thieving and not doing my tax returns—things like that, I try to fiddle.

And now you're into this area of aversion, of hatred, of pushing things away that you find impinging upon your little bit of security. And when it's too much, there's fear. This goes right through, not only material well-being but even our relationships. My partner, my children. Do you see what I mean? Then you get this barrier turning up. Then you get working for your own family, for your own ethnic group, for your own nationality, for your own civilisation. It grows out like that.

And of course, wherever it meets the other—that is your conflict. That is your war.

What the Buddha discovered was this root cause, this root cause of self. That's the point. Having discovered it, this idea of a self, this feeling of a self, he discovered that there are three characteristics which symbolise the state of that self. Three fundamental delusions, you might say. The first is that although things change, actually I'm always the same.

The self always seems to be the same self. I go to sleep and wake up in the morning feeling the same as when I fell asleep. There's a feeling running through life that, okay, everything else changes a little bit, but I, me, inside me—I never change. I'm always the one person I always thought I was.

Now that, of course, is manifestly untrue. When we actually look at what we mean by 'me', it turns out to be the personality, the character, my thinking—because these are all the things that the self says it is. But we know we're not the same person we were at the age of two, when we looked at bugs and discovered this wonderful *satipaṇṇā*, this awareness wisdom, which we've since forgotten.

When that is taken a step further into our daily living, we get this business of a relationship to what we experience. That's when we get this wanting what makes me happy, what gives me pleasure, and not wanting what doesn't. So I'm now caught in a duality.

If you just watch yourself in ordinary daily life, you'll see there's this constant judging going on. Liking, disliking, wanting, not wanting. If I like it, I want it. If I don't like it, I don't want it. The whole of life is partitioned into these things. If I like the person, we can meet for coffee. If I don't like them, I don't want to see them. This constant shifting of life according to two different colours—the dark and the bright.

These are the three characteristics. You could call them existential characteristics, because they're fundamental to this whole question of what our existence means. And what is the purpose of our meditation? In a sense, we're trying to see these three things. Because in seeing them clearly—and seeing that they are false—that brings about the liberation of the very consciousness which had identified with everything it thought was permanent and substantial.

Our viewpoint of whatever comes up is always coming from these three angles. For instance, when I'm sitting here, all these hindrances arise. The first one might be something like this: I've been planning a holiday somewhere. I've come on this weekend retreat, and all I can think about is this holiday I'm planning. Because that's what's uppermost in my mind, that's what I'm really going to enjoy, and I've got all these ideas of what I want to do and where I want to go. I'm sitting here, and it's quite natural—because I want to do this, the mind will now be incredibly inventive and give me all sorts of wonderful ideas.

What we want to do is discover what's empowering this. Why can't I just stop it? Why can't I just say, 'This weekend I'll put it aside and won't think about it anymore'? Why can't we do it? Coming to terms with the fact that we're not actually in control of the mind is a bit of an eye-opener. We thought it was me thinking, but actually it's just thinking—and I'm swamped by it.

There are occasions when I can use this kind of thinking. If I go on holiday, I have to use it for planning—I've got to phone people up, set up hotels, and so forth. This is a correct use. But overlaying that are all these dreams about what we're going to do, how it's going to be. That's where the wishing comes from, that's where the wanting comes from. And once we've begun to build an atmosphere, a conditioning in the mind of seeking pleasure in a holiday, seeking happiness in a holiday, then of course it'll carry on.

So we come to a meditation retreat and suddenly we can't stop thinking about it. It's completely flooded us. What we've come to realise is that by empowering a certain conditioning, we give it its own life. And the only thing we can do once we've set something in motion is wait for that momentum to die out.

It's exactly the same as driving a car. You can stomp on the brakes as hard as you want, but it's still going to move forward. In our meditation, if we try to stomp on this stuff, what is it we're stomping on? What is it we're trying to put the brakes on? You can see that's a suppressive measure. It's no good if we're full of this desire, the mind just full of thinking, thinking, thinking, to get hard with it and smack it down and get rigid and start watching the breath come what may. Because that's just putting the brakes on. All we're going to do is create even more turbulence, more bad energy within the system.

All we can do is recognise that here is the conditioning I've set up. Only I can govern the mind. Only I can put ideas into the mind and empower those ideas. Here I am in this enormous desire—what can I do? Every time I wake up to it, I just have to recognise: ah, desire, holiday, desiring, desiring. Then I come back.

Now I have two choices. I can either come back to the breath, or I can, as it were, search for the excitement in the body—that sense of wanting to enjoy myself. If I go back to the breath, even though I do it gently, in a way that's also a very gentle suppression. I've acknowledged it as it is, but I'm still not looking at the root cause.

Many a time the mind is just restless, and often you'll find that simply guiding it back to the breath brings a sense of peace. But when the desire is very strong, you've really got to go underneath it to find out what emotion is empowering it. Dropping into the body, one feels that excitement. Staying with that excitement at the feeling level means, first, it isn't going to slip up into these higher faculties and create further dreams. And second, just by watching it here—because it can't do this—it'll slowly begin to die out.

The time it takes to die out is a measure of how much we've empowered it. If it's going to take a couple of hours, it takes a couple of hours. If it's going to take a couple of weeks, it takes a couple of weeks. There's not much you can do about it.

Whenever the mind wanders off like that, even though it hasn't been a conscious decision on our part, there has been a moment of empowerment. This is known in Buddhist psychology as a habitual act of will. There are many things in life we just do as a habitual act of will—you catch yourself doing something. Often, even before you know it, an idea for tea has come into your head, and before you know it, you're drinking it. It's just been empowered naturally as a habit. That's what a habit is.

Recognising that there has been an act of will in there, we're even sharper, as it were, to wake up out of that fantasy and recognise what's happened. The thing about a habitual act of will is that it will just keep the wheel rolling—it won't actually make things that much worse. It's only if you were to stop here and say, 'I've come on this retreat, but really what I want to do is think about Machu Picchu and Antigua'—you sit here and that's what you do. Of course, you're off then. You've written a book.

Every time you wake up out of that and notice—ah, dreaming, dreaming—and come back, whether to the breath or to the emotion, that is an act of will. A conscious act of will. An empowering act of will. You're beginning to develop a new attitude, a new habit of being in the present.

That's your practice with desire—with anything that attracts us. When it comes to the second hindrance, aversion—all the little grudges and hatreds and irritations that do very much the same thing—the technique is exactly the same. You have to observe what it is, recognise it, acknowledge it: that's irritation. And then again, if it's something small, something silly, perhaps you can come back to the breath and it will simply die out because it's not being empowered.

But if it's very strong, you may have to go into the body and search out the feeling of anger—feel the irritation, the grudge, the unforgiveness, whatever's there causing it. And you have to stay there. You have to wait for it to burn out, which isn't always very pleasant.

When you get there, you've got to recognise the feeling of not wanting to actually experience these things. There's your aversion. This aversion is what's not allowing that bad feeling, that anger, to die out—because we like expressing anger. We enjoy it. Correct? It's a relief, isn't it? But with the relief of anger, with the relief of kicking the dog or something, there's a development of that particular way of thinking, that particular way of feeling. We're actually saying, it's right for me to get angry. We have to come back on that and notice this relationship we have with anger, with cruelty.

Cruelty is a delicious thing. The torturer enjoys his job. Correct? Definitely—because he wouldn't do it otherwise. That's this whole business of aversion.

Within aversion, of course, there's boredom. Boredom can be a real bane for meditators. And what you've really got to ask yourself is: where's it coming from? What's the root of boredom? It's expectancy, isn't it? We expect something excit-

ing. We expect something to happen, some great wonderful thing—and nothing's happening. We get bored. I'm just watching the breath. I mean, what the hell? Really boring.

Again, you have to be very careful, because what boredom will tell us to do is seek distraction. You're watching the breath here and you think, I'll watch it there. Then you watch it there—boredom. I'll do a mantra. Then you're fed up with that. I'm going to do some walking. Before you know it, you're just being swung around by this boredom.

The last thing you do with boredom is seek distraction. You just keep going back and you feel the boredom. It's an aversion. It's a dislike. Hatred. And again, you always notice your relationship to boredom—how you don't want to feel it. Don't want to feel it.

Even when we live a very fast, pacey life, it's actually mixed in with things like anxiety and stress—and that's not a good energy. When you come here, when you come to a retreat like this, of course there's nothing to do. So what happens to all that energy? It doesn't know where to go. It just collapses into itself. You feel this exhaustion, this restless boredom, this restless exhaustion.

The first three days of any course of this nature are always brutal. Sloth and torpor refer to two different states of feeling down. One is physical tiredness; the other is the mental cloud you can get into. Sometimes they both come together—in fact, they mostly come together. But sometimes you can feel one and not the other. You can be fairly clear in the head, but you just feel down.

Again, you don't do what the hindrance tells you. The hindrance says, have a kip—ten minutes, you'll feel great. But in fact you go to sleep and that's the end of it, because what you're doing is piling more energy pushing down, using sleep as a suppressive. Remember, we were taught that early on as kids: if we get a bit naughty it's because we're tired. Put them to bed and they wake up all right. And you think, oh yeah, if I feel bad I go to bed.

And of course depressives—people who are depressed, especially those who have depression as an illness—so much of their time is just going to sleep, falling asleep because of this awful heaviness. They haven't got the will, they haven't got perhaps a reason, to lift themselves up against it.

The thing to do when you feel slothful or tired is to do the opposite. Put energy into the posture, open your eyes. If that's not enough, stand up. Just refuse to be annihilated. And that's why it's important during the day to get every walking period in—a good ten or twenty minutes of fast walking—because there is a connection between the body and these sorts of feelings.

The next hindrance is the opposite of that: restlessness. For me, the way I experience it, the one is the other—one's going in, and one's coming out. Restlessness, of course, tells you to get up and do things. Don't hang about. Don't just sit there—do something. Again, you do the opposite. You sit very still, you don't move, and you just try to get in touch with that feeling of wanting to move, wanting to go.

Often it begins to express itself in fantasies, in which case you've got to work with those desires. But sometimes it can be almost a pure restlessness, just a feeling of fidgetiness. The more you relax around that, the more you relax the body. Remember, in the posture the energy is just coming up the spine—that's all the energy you need to become enlightened. If you could sit like that and maintain your mindfulness for seven days, the Buddha says, you'd probably make it. Either that or what we call the non-returner.

Whenever there's frazzledness, whenever the body feels restless, just lift the spine up. Draw the energy with the in-breath up the spine, with the out-breath down the body, and relax around it. You'll feel that restlessness, but because it's got nowhere to hold on to, eventually it'll just collapse. It'll just turn.

This is true if you feel restless before you sleep. One of the good tricks for falling asleep when you're very restless is to take a position where you're comfortable, then refuse to move. You don't move at all. It'll be a battle for a little while—the body wants to move around and do this and that.

Then suddenly it'll just flip, and that's it. Because it's got nowhere to go, it just burns itself out. But as soon as you turn over, as soon as you get up from the posture, you've empowered it. The uncomfortable feeling of restlessness disappears when you move, but the restlessness itself—the way turbulent energy is expressing itself—is simply being re-empowered. The more we can suffer this stuff, the more we can burn, the more we can allow ourselves to sit in the midst of these flames, the quicker all these hindrances begin to die out for us.

The other hindrance linked with restlessness is guilt and remorse—all that to do with what happens when we do something harmful. You can see the connection, because guilt makes you fidgety, doesn't it? It makes you jump a bit. Again, it's very much the same approach. When guilt feelings come up, remorse feelings come up, one acknowledges them, stops the dreaming, and goes into the feeling. One suffers the consequences of one's unwholesome actions.

There's no need for punishment in Buddhism. You just have to suffer the consequences of your actions. There's no need to judge ourselves as evil or bad. There's no need to give ourselves extra punishment. You don't have to give yourself up to the police. Isn't that a relief? You can just sit there, and the very pain of coming to terms with these things is the consequence and the healing.

It's very interesting—I read a little article about this. If you remember, in England we had that terrible Moors murder case with Brady and Myra Hindley. He's written a book, it seems, about serial killers, and it's meant to be very insightful. The person who helped him write it says in the article that he asked Brady whether he ever thought about the suffering of his victims. His answer is very telling. He said, if I thought about the suffering of my victims, I'd go mad. So it's in him. You can't hurt anybody out there without hurting yourself. Very interesting, I thought.

The final hindrance is doubt. The Buddha asks us not to believe anything he says. It's not a faith religion in that sense, because it's about knowledge, about understanding. Faith grows. Faith is an intellectual assent, a confidence we put into the teaching of the Buddha by way of listening, which makes sense to us. We hear the teaching, it makes sense, and then we go away and think about it ourselves, do a bit of practice, and the confidence comes to give the practice a go.

When the practice begins to yield results, of course you tend to get more confidence, and so it rolls on—until, it is said, a person glimpses nibbāna. The sotāpanna, the stream entrant, as they're called. Once that happens, they know now that there is an end to suffering. Even if it's only a glimpse—the Buddha says it's like a flash of lightning, as quick as that—at least within that person there is this real knowledge of the end of suffering. At which point faith becomes rock hard. It can't be disturbed.

But until that happens to us, there will always be some doubts floating around. And doubt stops you committing yourself, so you don't do the practice. There are usually three areas of doubt. First, doubt in the teaching itself—that it's not going to deliver. Then there's doubt in the teacher, of course. Don't look at me like that!

But the big one is usually doubting oneself. Everybody else can do it, but I can't. That's often a big one for a lot of meditators. They have a certain ground faith in the teaching and they see how it works. They usually have a certain faith in whatever teachers they meet. But about themselves they're saying, I can't do it.

So doubt is pernicious. You have to be very careful with it—it can really destroy your spiritual life. Whenever doubt comes up, you have to turn on it, feel it fully, and refuse to do what it says. Be very careful about that self-judgment; it's deeply undermining. And that's not only in the spiritual life, is it? It's anything. If you start a job doubting you can do it, you won't be able to do it. You just undermine yourself. So whenever doubt arises, you always have to make that leap of faith—yes I can. To hell with it, yes I can. Beware of doubt if you suffer from it a lot. Some people do, some people don't. These hindrances vary from person to person. Everybody has their own little constellation of horror to work out. That's our *kamma*.

So I hope that's given you some pointers when it comes to the hindrances. The last thing to say, of course, is what happens when we feel peaceful and wonderful, when everything seems to be going perfectly well? Don't rest on your laurels. That's the big thing. You don't say, ah, finally a bit of peace, and then sink into it, just indulging peace now. Because when it goes, you get really frustrated. Why can't I be peaceful like I was yesterday?

So when a calmness comes, when a certain clarity comes, when the meditation is, as we would say, good—remember, in terms of the process of enlightenment, even if we spend a whole hour just coming off these thoughts, that's good meditation. That's the practice. But even so, there are times when a certain concentration comes, a clarity, a quietness, a stillness. Well then, really use that to begin to penetrate the breath. Because that's what you're left with. There's not much else when you're completely quiet. The only thing going on tends to be the very subtle movement of breath.

So you go into that, looking at it very closely, very intently, trying to see the exact beginning of the in-breath, the exact ending of it, the exact beginning of the out-breath, the exact ending of it. Where you're driving that consciousness is to the point where mind contacts matter. And it's right there that we can see especially these qualities of transience, impermanence, rising and falling, and the insubstantiality, this not-self. That's when it becomes very apparent.

Now, such is our state of delusion, such is our ignorance, that it just isn't good enough to see it once. You've got to keep seeing it and seeing it and seeing it, and very slowly the penny drops. Only occasionally does a person have one of these blowout kenshōs or satoris. The normal spiritual progress is just this wearing away—this Chinese drip. Slowly we begin to perceive, slowly the way we see things begins to turn. And in turning the way we see things, the personality begins to change, the relationships begin to change. For most of us, it's a very slow process.

The Hindrances: The Psychotherapy of Vipassanā

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 53 min

Originally given as *The Hindrances: The Psychotherapy of Vipassanā* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this teaching, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the Buddha's categorization of all suffering into five hindrances (nīvaraṇa): sensual desire, ill-will, sloth and torpor, restlessness and remorse, and skeptical doubt. Drawing from the Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta (MN 10), he explains how these mental defilements (kilesa) and latent tendencies (anusaya) arise from our unresolved psychological material and block both concentration and insight.

The teaching emphasizes the power of the thinking and imaginative mind in creating these mental states, and provides detailed instructions for working with each hindrance through the practice of objective observation. Bhante explains how to disengage from dream-like fantasies by noting the hindrance, returning to the breath, and investigating the underlying emotions in the body. He particularly focuses on the process of disidentification - learning to observe mental states as objects rather than identifying with them as 'self.'

Special attention is given to practical challenges like working with boredom (a form of aversion), distinguishing between genuine tiredness and the hindrance of sloth-torpor, and understanding skeptical doubt as fear-based resistance to commitment. The teaching concludes with encouragement about the gradual nature of purification and the ultimate liberation from these mental obstacles.

This evening we need to revise our hindrances—that's the normal thing. For some of you this will be revision; for others it might be an introduction.

The Buddha categorizes all our suffering into five types. First, everything to do with pleasure, desire, attachment, indulgence. Second, all those problems we have with hate, aversion, fear. Third, what my teacher used to call our two very good

friends: dullness and lethargy. Fourth, restlessness—which is a bit of a catch-all really, but it also includes remorse, guilt, shame, that sort of area. And fifth, skeptical doubt. Those are your five areas.

We have to know how to deal with these hindrances when they come up. In the discourse on how to establish the awareness that leads to liberation, we must understand how they arise, how to undermine them, and how to stop them ever arising again. This is the hard work. This is the work of our meditation. If we had no hindrances, well, you'd be there really—just a couple of weeks' meditation and you'd made it.

The hindrances prevent us from making insights. They're also hindrances to concentration because, as you know, they take us away from the object, take us away from meditation. They set us up in a dream place or a sleepy place. So we have to know what to do.

This is part of the skills of meditation. The other part we do tomorrow: developing the seven factors of enlightenment—that's the beautiful side. Best to leave the best wine till last. Those factors also demand a certain skillfulness. But for most of us it's this hard grind of dealing with our defilements.

Defilements is another word the Buddha uses—*kilesa*, defilements of the mind. He also has another word, *anusaya*, which means latent tendencies. This comes close to our understanding of having things buried in our psyche, things we don't know the extent of until somebody presses the right button. Then we realize just how angry we are.

So we have this underlying base of unresolved problems, and they arise every so often depending on circumstance—whatever makes them come out in ordinary life. But in meditation we're just letting the heart speak for itself. We're sitting back, and whatever comes up, that's what we've got to deal with. We don't choose to deal with any of these hindrances. They just come up by themselves—the *nivarana*, the hindrances.

As I'm sure many of you know, one retreat you're falling asleep all over the place, and the next week you're a jumping bean—you can't sit still. One retreat the mind is like that; the next retreat the mind is that. One sitting you fall asleep, the next sitting you can't stop moving. There's no logic, no rationality of that sort in the heart. It has its own internal logic, which is completely illogical from the rational point of view.

You're sitting here thinking: why am I feeling depressed? Why does this anxiety come up now, when I'm trying to be peaceful and fully liberated? Once we step out of the system, once we put ourselves in a position where we just want to let the heart manifest its turbulences, of course it does all sorts. And we've got to be ready. We've got to know what to do.

Now, what I've been saying all weekend is about the power of the mind—the thinking mind, the imaginative mind—because it's through the imaginative mind that these mental states develop in meditation. They do it also in daily life. Everything human beings have created, from jet planes to vaccines, began in the mind. All the horrors we've committed as humanity against humanity and dumb beasts—that's all begun in the mind too.

So it's really about beginning to realize the importance of understanding what the mind does. By mind here I mean this imagination, this thinking capacity, this rationality. Through our Enlightenment—the 18th century Enlightenment—we put a lot of faith in rationality, in reason, in being able to sit and reason things out. Unfortunately, what was misunderstood was that reason always depends on a premise. If the premise is wrong, your reasoning will lead you into trouble. That's why we ended up with Nazism, Communism, and all the rest of it. It's undermined a lot of our faith in rationalism, which is what it should have done. That's why we have a postmodern idea of: my reality is my own and to hell with yours.

Once we understand the power of the thinking mind, the imaginative mind, to create a world for us—how it develops and produces these mental states—then we're very wary of it. One of the things we have to do in meditation is keep coming off the thinking mind and plunge into, as U Pandita puts it, really feel what's motivating it, which is coming from the heart.

In our sitting practice, it normally begins from the heart, then moves into these higher faculties of imagination and thought, and then it starts to churn itself. In daily life, of course, it can come the other way. You're watching television—some usual stuff about murder and divorce and argument. It's all going in, and of course you're responding to it. You're resonating with what's happening on the screen. Every time you listen to the news and its usual horror stuff, you resonate with that. So in effect, that's coming the other way: from the mind into the heart.

But our problem in meditation, in the sitting, usually comes from inside—from memories, from unresolved turbulences in the mind. I much prefer the word turbulence. We have this word about blocks. A block gives you the impression that that's it—it's blocked. There's no way you can get out of this. It's stuck, like some-

thing in your throat. But if you look at the mind as an energy system, just as we experience the weather—sometimes it blows hot, it blows cold, it storms, sometimes it's beautiful and peaceful—then you see it differently.

So the first thing is all this stuff with desire. Remember that deep down, our aim is just to be happy, let me say. That's all we want—just to be peaceful and happy. And whenever we see something that's making us happy, we hold on to it. We try to aggrandize it.

We might come to a deeper understanding of this later on in the week. Of course, we associate happiness—real happiness—with a mental state, an emotional state. When you say, 'I'm happy,' what you're saying is: emotionally, I feel happy. My heart feels happy. I'm filled inside with a happy feeling.

Now, that's the first thing we have to begin to disconnect from. When happiness arises, it's trying to look for an object to increase itself. There you are, happiness arises, and suddenly you're with the person you've been looking for all your life on a dreamy island beneath coconut trees. Love abounds, yeah? And you're walking down the aisle, oh my goodness. Or it's just raw sex, wonderful. And you wake up—oh my god.

These feelings, coming from old desires of wanting this lovely relationship and so on—that's just arising. And now what's happening is that the imagination is latching on to it and you're dreaming it. Within the dream, it's real. When you're dreaming, it's real. This is the problem. When you wake up out of it, suddenly you realize you've been fooled. It's only a dream. God, it's only a dream. And then you get this depression and this feeling of: I'll never find the person I can really love.

So it's being able to recognize that we have to stop that. You go back into just the feeling of excitement or that desire, and you're pulling out of it, pulling out of it to make it an object.

Just to go back to childhood—when we're born, so they tell us, we experience the world without any depth. It's just a blank screen, or a screen full of colour and shape and movement. That's why they say babies are always reaching out for those rattles and stuff in their pram. What they're doing is creating distance. They're creating a third dimension. You've got to believe these people. Slowly, for that young child, the world begins to separate out. Before, they were in that bath of sensations. And this slowly pushing out to the world, so that sometime—I don't know when it happens, maybe two or three years old—they're quite clear the world is out there and this is me. And they're pretty clear that I'm a boy or a girl.

Now all we're doing is taking that process inward. The world inside has to be externalized. You're pushing it away from yourself and looking at it. Whereas before: I am happy. I am in a state of excitement. I love this and I love that. Come off the mind. Come off the mind. You're pulling away from this emotion. That's your first state: making it an object.

It's just like this room. The room is outside us. It's now outside this consciousness. You've made it an object. You feel it's there. That distance allows us to create the knowledge that this is not me, not mine. Not me, not mine. And when that's steadied, when I know that, then I can re-enter into it and begin to investigate it more closely.

But I have to first establish that position of objectivity within myself. What I'm doing is breaking a connection with it. I'm breaking an identity with it. This identity is telling me that this happiness is me. That's the problem. So long as I think this emotional happiness is me, I'm going to be seeking what makes me happy in this emotional way.

At first you think you're losing something. How the hell am I going to be ever happy in life now that I know this happiness is not me? You pull yourself out. This is an awful place to be because it's an identity crisis. How am I ever going to be happy if I can't be this happiness that I feel?

If some fear comes up, some anxiety around that, you go to it, you feel it. Don't let the anxiety throw you back into the happiness and back onto the beach. Maintain your position of objectivity. Then, as you become clear about that, you re-enter the happiness to investigate it. Slowly you become convinced that in fact this is just a form of energy—just like a light, just like a nice feeling, just as you might have an itch. It's just a feeling. That's all there is. That's all there is in the body: a feeling.

The Buddha's word for this is *vedanā*. *Vedanā* covers virtually everything we mean by feeling—both sensation, as when I say I'm not feeling well or I'm feeling really good physically, and also mental states, as when you say I'm feeling unhappy or I'm feeling sad. The English word 'feeling' comes very close to the Buddha's understanding. What it tells us is that everything we associate with in the body is just feeling, whether it's a raw sensation or some great form of delight.

When it comes to this area of happiness, we begin to realise something important. Having identified with happiness as the purpose of my life, having sought that happiness in the sensual world—and remember, when the Buddha says 'sen-

sual world' he means everything you're experiencing—of course all my energy goes to make it real. If I know I'm going to be really happy when I find the right person, off I go clubbing, doing all sorts, looking for this right person. And especially in my dream world.

I come back and I recognise the power of this desire, whatever it might be—a good job, money, fame, whatever's driving me. By doing that, I'm disidentifying with it. I'm able to see it for what it is: just a mental state. Then slowly it loses its energy. And as it loses its energy, that conditioning of seeking happiness in the sensual world is slowly being undermined.

That's our process. When we see ourselves lost in a dream or a fantasy around the whole idea of happiness and pleasure, we stop the thinking and move back down to the breath. We connect with whatever is in the body—the heart area usually—and we stay with it and wait for it to pass away. Then, if nothing else comes up, you go back to the breath. If it pops up again, do the same thing over and over and over again. That's the practice.

Now, of course, when I talk like this, people say, 'Well, you mean there's not going to be any romance? There's no happiness in the world? Can't I—?' No. Quite the opposite.

It's not that the Buddha fell in love once he was liberated. At that level of liberation, when you're totally liberated, you're no longer attracted to the sensual world. But that doesn't mean these things don't have their place and their time. What we don't want them to be is cloying. What we don't want them to be is overpowering, completely rushing our lives towards some obsessive destiny—whether it's to be rich or to be famous or whatever it might be.

When it comes to romance, to relationship—if one wants a relationship, one has to trust oneself. One has to trust that as we put that act of desire into the world, as you will it, then it will manifest or it won't. But if it becomes obsessive, then it just becomes an area of disappointment, of addiction.

It's the same if you say to yourself, 'I want this sort of work in the world.' You push out that act of will, and of course you're open to it, you look around for it—but you're always open to the fact that it may not manifest. And therefore there's no huge disappointment or grief. It just becomes something you put out there.

You might ask, how does that work? I'm sure you can all look back into your life and see that once you will something, there's something quite magical about the interconnectedness of the world. The cosmos even seems to make an effort to

help you manifest what you want. Correct? There's something about the interconnection of things. I'm sure most of you have had the experience of wanting to know something and the very book turns up. It's magical.

I'll give you one example from my own life. When I began this teaching, I really, really, really didn't want to do it. What I wanted was just to find a hut somewhere and continue. But once I decided to live in Britain, it seemed impossible because there wasn't the infrastructure. So I began teaching, and it evolved to what it is now.

Over the crisis of it—it was actually the millennium, 2000—I went to meditate at U Pandita's place in Rangoon, Yangon. This question was in the back of my mind. I wasn't thinking about it; I just put it to the side. The question was open. I laid it out there in front of the Buddha. I just said, 'Look, if this is what I have to do, then I'll do it. I don't particularly want to, but there's a call. People are asking me.' So I just laid it out, as it were.

And there it was: a small book someone had extracted from *A Course in Miracles*, containing just the passages about teaching. This thin little volume was tucked away in a huge library, and I happened to find it. By the time I finished reading it, I knew I had to teach. There was no doubt at all in my mind. It was the strangest thing.

So in a sense there also has to be trust: once you put out a real act of will, a real decision that this is the way you want your life to go, more often than not it will go that way. You can't entirely depend on that, because you don't know what forces are against you. It's no good me wanting to become prime minister. There's got to be a realism about the desire. You have to test it. You have to be tested.

But in terms of the obsessiveness we have around desires, we overcome them by coming off the dream world and sitting in the midst of that turbulence—that strong desire, the addiction. The thing is, our habits of clinging, of attachment, of having to have, must have—once you tackle the real tough nut, it all fades away, because it's all one attitude. You don't have to go from this obsession to that obsession and then all the way down the line. If you hit the big one, they all begin to fade. That's a bit of a blessing, because otherwise we'd be here for lifetimes trying to get rid of it all. Go for the big one, and everything begins to be undermined.

This is why the eating exercise we're doing here is so important. What we're trying to discover is: How can I be with pleasure, with the joys of life, with a loving relationship, without this attachment? Without this obsessiveness, without this need?

What we're doing is not just breaking away from the things we're dependent on. By finding this position within ourselves—the objective observer—we're actually discovering a new identity. We're taking identity out of the body with its sensations, out of the heart with its emotions, out of the mind with its thoughts. Very slowly, we're beginning to identify with something much deeper within us: our Buddha nature.

The more you identify with that which knows, the less you become needy for the world to give you happiness. You're finding your resting place in the one who knows, the Buddha within. And part of that process is letting go of the world as a place where we can find true happiness—not confusing these passing happinesses and joys and pleasures with real, sustainable, unchangeable, unalloyed, non-suffering happiness, as the Buddha would have it. That's his way of putting it. He prefers to tell you what it isn't. Because as soon as you say Nirvana is happiness, everybody thinks it's some sort of blissed-out state. But it's not.

Now, you know what it is, because when you're meditating in that state of the pure observer, you're actually it. But you may not have recognised it. You may not have recognised the absolute peace and stillness that exists within the observer.

The next business, of course, is this area of aversion. And this is much the same. You find yourself in a dream world—you're hating people, chopping their heads off, all that sort of stuff. Then you just note: anger, hatred. Or you're full of anxiety, worrying about this, worrying about that. These days people might be worried about financial problems, losing their jobs. It's not a pleasant place to be at the moment. So you get these anxieties. You note it, you come back. As you go down to the breath, you feel, you get into those feelings.

So this again is the other side of attachment, the other side of wrong identity. And just by tackling the big one—where you feel most aversion, where you feel most fear—you're undermining that whole attitude of being averse to the world, to people, of being afraid of it. It's the same technique: just coming off the dream, feeling the fear. You know that book, *Feel the Fear and Do It Anyway*? That's it—just feel the fear.

Now, of course, in both these cases—as is true for all the other hindrances—you're also being aware of your relationship. When something good comes up, we see the relationship of indulgence: wanting it, grabbing it. When it comes to things like hatred and cruelty, we want to indulge too. We don't like to accept that, but being hateful can be very satisfying. Being angry, hurting somebody, can bring quite a bit of internal joy.

Fear is different. You panic with fear. So remember, when fear comes up, you want to be aware of the fear of fear. There's your panic. So long as you can keep the two in mind, both there within your observation, and just keep breathing in and out, wait for that fear of fear to go—the panic stops, and you're with fear.

The more we get used to the texture of fear—and that's why it's so important to come into the body, off the mind—the more we get into the texture of fear, the feel of it, the nausea, the trembling of it, the more we lose our fear of it. And then, of course, it's not fearful anymore. What's going to frighten us? When we've lost our fear of fear, what can frighten us? But it's getting beyond that barrier. And you do it always by sinking into, feeling the fear.

This is the Buddha's language: to feel feelings in feelings, to know the body in the body, to know mental states in mental states.

With all these dream factors, when you come off the dream and back into the body, there has to be a very clear decision that you're not going to go back there. If it's only a semi-decision—especially with those things we like to indulge, whether averse or pleasurable—then there's a leakage of desire.

Say you've come off something—let's go back to romance. You come back, noting, noting, but actually there's a part of you that still wants to go there. You've not actually said no to this leakage. So there you are feeling, and whoop—off you go again. It takes only a moment of mindlessness. One millisecond of mindlessness coming off the subject and you're away.

So there has to be a clear recognition and acknowledgement. As you turn away, there must be a decision: you don't want to go back there. That stops the leakage of desire. It's important. If you find yourself in a sitting constantly returning to this dream thing, it may be just restlessness, or it may be the power of that desire. But check whether you've made a real decision not to go back into that dream space.

I'll pass over the third hindrance—dullness and lethargy—and move to the next one: restlessness. Restlessness is a sort of catch-all, and you've got to be very patient with it. If the mind is constantly in a state of agitation, you just have to be patient. It's just this energy in the mind.

Sometimes you think you're going mad. And you are mad when you are mad. So you just have to note: restlessness, madness—and then keep coming back to the breath. If that's all you do the whole sitting, the whole day, the whole week, that's the practice.

Don't think to yourself, "Well, I've sat here for forty minutes just saying madness, madness, and trying to get back to my breath. It's absolutely useless." No, it's not. That's the practice. Now, if you note madness and think, "Well, why not? Let's go mad," and off you go—that's bad. You should feel terrible. You should really feel guilty and horrible. But the practice is this: keep coming off the mind, keep coming off the mind, until that energy has exhausted itself. That's where the energy has gone—into the head. What can you do?

The same applies to the body. If you feel tremendously restless and you really want to move, one thing you can do is feel sensations from the top of the head going down to the feet, and just keep going from the top downwards. That tends to calm the body a bit. But don't do it entirely for the purpose of calming the body. Do it to see where restlessness is.

Did you ever feel restless at the end of your nose? Very difficult. It doesn't happen. So you have to come down the body, find where you feel the restlessness, hang on a little bit, keep moving. That also stops the mind wandering.

And with restlessness there's this other business of guilt, shame, remorse. These things have to be felt too. Often it's because we've left things undone. We might have hurt somebody and not apologised. It might be that somebody's hurt us and we've not told them, we've not forgiven them.

These are processes you can work with in your sitting. If you find a lot of guilt coming up over something you've done, stay with the guilt—but then write yourself a note saying, "When I leave, this is what I'll do." That puts it to rest, at least for a while, until you've put right what you did wrong.

If there's a lot of hate and vengefulness over somebody who's hurt you, then feel it, feel it, feel it—and then write yourself a note that you'll approach the person when you leave.

If the person is unapproachable—either because they can't be found or they've died—then you have to do a little ritual for yourself. Write a letter, do something to externalise the problem. It helps, that's all. But eventually, it's about coming into those feelings and resting with them. There's a whole load of stuff around that area which I tend not to tackle until the end of the week. So if this comes up and you find it difficult to handle, just come and see me.

Then there's sceptical doubt. This is really pernicious in any part of our lives. Sceptical doubt is the doubt that stops you doing something. That's what it does—it stops you doing something.

If you're applying for a job and there's this constant, well, I don't know whether I can, maybe I shouldn't, I don't know whether I could—before you've decided, the job's gone. If you get into a relationship and you think, well, maybe I can't, maybe I'm not, I don't know whether I should—it's gone. It's gone away, isn't it? You can't commit yourself. That's what sceptical doubt does.

Now, the fact that you've all come here and you're all meditating means there can't be much sceptical doubt about meditation. But it has its little ways. The main one that people suffer from—I think we all suffer from it to some degree—is doubt about ourselves, doubt as to whether we can make progress in this practice. You look around, everybody's sitting very, very still, and you think, well, I can't sit still. Even though everybody's looking at you saying, my God, you're sitting still. But we have all this doubt going on about ourselves.

When that sort of doubt comes up, just remind yourself of the Buddhist teaching. It's a psychological, a spiritual imperative that all beings will become liberated. All beings. It's a spiritual imperative because that's the way consciousness is moving. Just because it's not moving fast enough doesn't mean it's not moving.

Often in our practice we go through times when it's very dreary, like a desert. Nothing seems to be happening. We seem to be putting a lot of effort in and not getting any real results. Those are testing times. You just have to keep going until you move through it. And often it's caused by false expectation.

Once when I was in Birmingham, a man turned up to do some meditation at the centre. He said that when he first came on a retreat—this is going back to the late 70s—he thought he was going on a course in which one achieved Nibbāna. So he went thinking, Saturday, Sunday, that's it, I'll have made it. As the time rolled on and came to the end, there was this, God— We didn't turn him off; he came back and did some more.

But that's what we think. We think, oh, I'll keep doing this for a while and things will get so much better—I'll be liberated and all this sort of stuff. But of course these expectations eventually undermine our practice because they're not real. So be careful about expecting something from the practice.

We have to have a certain faith that purification is going on, that wisdom is slowly being formed. As soon as you enter into that position of the observer, it has to happen. It can't not be happening. As soon as you're there taking that position of observing, of feeling things, of allowing things to manifest, there must be some small change within our looking.

It's like Chinese torture—the drip, the drip torture. Slowly there are little aha moments, when finally the penny drops a bit. It's very rare for somebody to have a cosmic opening where everything bursts into light and one suddenly rises up in the air. Most times it's just this plodding, plodding, plodding. And then when you look back over time—five, six, ten years—you say things have changed. It's a slow process.

The Buddha warned us: it's gradual. I know you hear in certain traditions about sudden enlightenment—sudden and gradual enlightenment. But these are misunderstandings, because when an insight comes, of course it's sudden. An insight doesn't take time. You either see it or you don't. But to get there can be one hell of a journey.

So it depends where you're standing. If you're standing in the insight, yes, it's sudden enlightenment. But if you're standing outside the insight, it's blooming gradual. Right? So all those arguments about sudden and gradual insight seem to me to be a bit silly, really.

Then there's doubt in the teaching, doubt in the Buddha and all that. This too is undermined through practice, through reading, through thinking about it and reflecting on what the Buddha's actually talking about. Through our practice, the teaching becomes realistic.

Of course, that has to be tested, because the teacher in Buddhism is only there to guide. It's not faith in the teacher in that guru sense—that would really undermine the process. The Buddha himself couldn't handle that. Just before he died, there was a young monk who looked upon him mooningly. He sent him off to the forest. The Buddha's on his deathbed, and he saw that this monk had got the wrong relationship with him. Sent him off. Get out.

So it's not that sort of—whatever we mean by a guru relationship. It's not meant to be that at all. The teacher is meant to be someone who just gives instructions, pointing to the moon, as they say. The Buddha points to the moon. You shouldn't be looking at the end of his finger.

So, sceptical doubt—that's something just to be aware of. And again, when you go into it, you may find it's just fear. Fear of failure. Fear of criticism. Usually it's some sort of fear down there, which stops us making that commitment.

This often comes up when I offer people the opportunity to take refuges and precepts. It's the same as the distinction between, shall we say, a partnership and marriage. Somebody explained it to me once as the difference between bacon and eggs. Have you heard that? When it comes to eggs, the chicken gives of its egg, but the pig gives of its life.

There's something about marriage which is like a further giving of oneself. It doesn't surprise me to find that people who've been in a partnership for quite some time finally decide to get married, to go through an actual ceremony. I've done that for a few people. It just points out that so long as it's just a partnership, there's always this clause underneath that gets you out. But the point of a marriage is complete commitment to the other.

Like we had this lovely wedding. Sickness and health, poor or rich—it doesn't matter. You're committed to the person entirely. And that, of course, is an act of compassion. It's an act of complete giving of oneself to the other. Of course, it works as long as the other is giving their complete self to you. Once that begins to separate, then you're stuck.

One thing I haven't looked at is boredom. Remember, boredom comes under the heading of aversion, and it's important for us because boredom comes up in the practice. If you told people in the ordinary world that you just spent a whole week trying to observe the breath, they would probably think, well, I can't think of anything more boring than watching my breath and feeling it arising and passing away.

So when boredom comes, remember: this is the product of indulgence. There are five negatives that come up as an aftermath from indulgence. Once you connect these two, you tend to come off at least gross indulgence, gross dependency.

There's addiction, there's compulsive behaviour, there's frustration when you don't get it, there's grief when you lose it, you're always afraid of losing so you take out an insurance policy—and boredom.

Remember, when the Buddha was fully liberated, for seven years Māra chased him with his three daughters: sensual desire, sexual desire, and boredom. Interesting, eh? What that story is telling us is that there were still remnants in his mind for seven years—old habits of seeking happiness. But Māra goes away, slinking away, saying, the Buddha sees me.

So even though there were still these—what's known as *vāsanā*—in the Buddha's mind, even after he was liberated, it took seven years for them to completely die out. And boredom is there among them. Boredom is a state of aversion, right? Not wanting, seeking excitement. And that's what it tells you to do. It tells you to seek *divertissement*. It tells you to seek excitement.

But what you do with boredom is repetition. You feel the boredom and you keep doing what you're doing. This is true for anything in life—whether you're learning an instrument, or doing work where boredom arises because it's the same thing day in and day out. You recognise the boredom and you just keep going. You don't indulge it. You don't seek distraction.

All these things we're talking about pertain to ordinary daily life. You can't just do them when you come on retreat. It's constant. It's terrible, but there we are.

And then finally, there are our two very good friends: dullness and lethargy. Or if you want to put a moral twist on them, sloth and torpor.

Now, we have to make a distinction between tiredness—where the body needs rest, the mind needs rest—and this dullness and lethargy. Tomorrow, for instance, we get up a little earlier, and there may still be some remnants of tiredness from when you first arrived. Virtually everybody comes to a retreat with some sleep imbalance. Either they're oversleeping or undersleeping. They're not sleeping well. And it normally takes three or four days for that to slowly iron itself out.

So tomorrow, getting up a little earlier just pushes the system a bit. But we shall struggle. And then by the fourth day, of course, there's massive energy, and one wonders where it was all before.

How is it we have this conditioning of dullness and lethargy? Just consider how many times you've indulged in that subliminal state of sleep. Just hanging around at the weekend in bed on that lovely level where you're neither asleep nor awake. Where you've taken a newspaper to bed or you're listening to the radio and you just keep wafting in and out of these pleasant states. How many times, when you feel a bit depressed, a bit low, a bit down, you've just flung yourself onto the couch and fallen asleep for a while?

In other words, it's a way we get rid of ourselves. A way we can annihilate ourselves. Of course, we wouldn't do it if we didn't think we were going to wake up. But it's a way we keep pushing ourselves into this state of oblivion. And the reason we do it is because there's no suffering there. There's no suffering in oblivion. Unfortunately, we'll wake up. What we hope is that on waking, all the troubles will have gone.

It's actually a small way in which we commit suicide. That's what we're doing—getting rid of the self. Every time we use sleep to annihilate ourselves, we're actually desiring non-becoming. The Buddha points to three desires: sensual desire, the desire to become, and the desire not to become. There is in us always, when it gets too heavy, a desire to escape. And one way we escape is to fall asleep.

What we're suffering from when we have this dullness in the mind like porridge, when the body feels as heavy as lead—all that is the consequence of these indulgences. What do we do? We refuse to be annihilated. Absolutely, completely, and utterly refuse.

We use noting to keep ourselves awake. You can come up the body, from your toes to the top of the head, just keep the attention moving so there's energy being displaced into that looking, that process. And you're looking to see where you feel this heaviness. You feel it in your toes? You feel it in your knees? See where it is. If you keep coming upwards like that, it just keeps the energy coming up, and you're able to stay awake within that state.

When the body feels fine but the mind is full of this heavy dullness like big fog or smog, then just roam around it. Roam around it, feeling it, seeing it. And you might be surprised to find that you wake up like a bulb right in the middle of that fog. I'm sure you've all experienced that.

You wake up completely bright and alert in the middle of this dullness, in the middle of this awesome smog. That just shows you what's actually making us become the dullness: association with it. It's an identity with the feelings of lethargy. And the more you move around in it, the more you're pulling out of it. The more you try to investigate the taste of it, the feel of it, the texture of it, the more this knowing awakens—until eventually it wakes up completely and you're there in the middle of this smoke, this heaviness, fully alert.

And it's a mental state—as valid a mental state as depression or anxiety. We have a no-no on those, and this is also a no-no. It's an awesome state to be in.

When you reach that point, you're allowing this energy to dissipate. It's an energy like a whirlpool, drawing you down into a black hole—not those other energies that swish you out into galaxies. This is mirrored in nature. It's quite remarkable, really.

As soon as you feel yourself being washed down into this black hole, make sure you lift yourself up. Keep awake. You can open your eyes, let the light in. You can stand up. If it gets too much, gently leave the meditation hall and do some walking.

I've walked for hours up and down with this stuff. At one point it used to last for ten days—just up and down, up and down. At one point I was doing the times tables; I got as far as seventeen, going forwards and backwards. Can you imagine that? I knew the seventeen times table backwards. Not bad. And that was just to keep myself awake.

When I told my teacher Janica about this, he said, "It's very good—but better to think of the Dhamma." I'd spent all my time learning these times tables! It was just the effort of staying above it, that's all. I'm not so sure that was all that skilful. It would have been perhaps more skilful to do this investigation more. But it was just the effort to stay awake, to stay awake.

That really covers all our negativity. If I've missed something, I think you'll be able to slot it into one of those five.

All those things to do around indulgence and pleasure; all those things to do around aversion, hatred, and fear; all those feelings around dullness and lethargy; all the restlessness, the guilt, shame, and remorse; and finally, sceptical doubt. That covers the whole range of stuff we have to deal with.

Just to repeat: our job is to recognise these hindrances, to point to them, to know what they are, to know what to do about them—so that we undermine them, and eventually they stop altogether. The Buddha is liberated from all that, liberated from that suffering. Somebody who is fully liberated doesn't have these kilesas; they're gone. He doesn't suffer from them anymore. So the future looks bright.

I can only hope my words have been of some assistance. May you be liberated from all suffering by your acute and unrelenting practice, undermining these dreadful hindrances sooner rather than later.

Dullness, Lethargy, Restlessness and Pain

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 58 min

Originally given as *Dullness, Lethargy, Restlessness and Pain* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this practical dharma talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma draws on the Buddha's encounter with Māra to explore how meditation hindrances serve as our spiritual trainers. He offers detailed guidance on working with sloth and torpor (thīna-middha), examining its roots in our conditioning toward seeking happiness in oblivion and avoidance of unpleasant experiences. Drawing from the story of Moggallāna's nine remedies, he provides practical techniques including posture adjustment, walking meditation, and investigative awareness.

The talk addresses restlessness (uddhacca) as refined energy that persists until the final stages of awakening, offering methods to work with both bodily agitation and obsessive thinking. Bhante emphasizes the importance of non-resistance while maintaining firm resolve not to indulge these states. He concludes with guidance on working with physical and emotional pain, distinguishing between necessary bodily signals and suppressed emotions held in the body. Throughout, he emphasizes seeing hindrances through the three characteristics (tilakkhana) and allowing their energy to transform rather than be suppressed, supporting the natural purification of the heart on the path to liberation.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa.

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-enlightened one.

Last time I spoke about the moment when the Buddha becomes enlightened—how he's attacked by Mara and eventually overcomes that attack to become liberated. I want to go back a little now and really discuss this fellow Mara.

There were nine storms: the wind, the rain, the rocks, the missiles, the embers, the ashes, the sand, the mud and the darkness. When they approached the Bodhisattva, he was either untouched or they turned into garlands, flowers, sandalwood powder, banners and light. These, of course, refer to what are called hindrances.

The Buddha's own image for these hindrances is a pool of water. The mind is like a pool of water, and if it's discoloured with all sorts of different colours, kaleidoscopic, you can't see into it—you're too enchanted by the colours. If the water's boiling, that's an image of hatred and anger. If it's covered over with mosses, that's the effect of dullness and lethargy. If the wind blows across the pool and makes waves, that's restlessness. And if it's turbid and muddy, that's the insidious pervasiveness of doubt. The Buddha being a little poetic.

For us, the defilements when they arise are to be acknowledged as our trainers. They must be embraced as friends—they've come to help us develop our perfections. We can say that the greater the defilement, the greater the potential for perfection. The more horrible you are, the more wonderful you'll become. So there's hope even for people like Hitler and Stalin. Heavens, they might become Buddhists.

One of the things about hitting these hindrances is that we don't know our virtues until they're tested. I'm reminded of a book I read many years ago by a man called Brian Keenan, an Irish fellow who was one of the many kidnapped in Lebanon during that time. His book *An Evil Cradling* is well worth reading because he really went through some horrible stuff. I heard an interview with him, and the usual question came: "You must be very strong to undergo these things; you must have had tremendous power inside you." He insisted it wasn't so, that other people found similar strengths. There were one or two who broke, but generally speaking, we have this inner virtue which we don't know until we're tested.

The first big hindrance we usually hit when we come to retreat is the old dullness and lethargy. The old sloth and torpor. We have to understand why we have so much of it. The first reason, of course, is that we like sleeping. We indulge in it. Sunday morning—roll over, cup of tea, newspaper, roll back over, the beach, say no more. All these times we've longed to sleep, to rest, for no reason at all apart from it being a sweet thing to do—this builds up the conditioning of seeking happiness in oblivion. That's what we're doing.

And the fact of the matter is that in oblivion there is no suffering. Correct? In oblivion there's no suffering. It's only when you wake up that you realise it hasn't worked.

The other reason we tend to fall asleep is that we're turning away from something, pushing something away. We feel depressed, we feel down, we feel a bit anxious—and we just lay out on the couch and off we go. Here are the two great *taṇhās*, the two great cravings: *bhava-taṇhā*, the craving of becoming, so we want to become oblivious to the world; and *vibhava-taṇhā*, the craving to annihilate ourselves, which takes us towards suicide. When we understand that these are at the root of our problem, we have some basis on which to really argue with ourselves, to really confront these feelings when they come up, no matter how heavy they are.

There's a story of Moggallāna. He had just met the Buddha and, not surprisingly, the big thing he suffered from was sloth and torpor. He went to the Buddha, and the Buddha gave him nine things to do. First, when the first sign comes, take no notice—just lift the spine, put more energy into the practice. If it's still coming, then consider the Dhamma. Recognise the danger of the hindrance. Build up some wholesome fear, you might say—a dread of consequences. That should lift a bit of energy.

If that doesn't work, recite the Dhamma. Now, if you don't know any Dhamma, you can recite anything, just to keep yourself awake. This is an effort just to keep awake, remember. Then, if that doesn't work, rub your ears—he must have known about acupuncture points. If that doesn't work, rub your legs. If that doesn't work, get up and wash your face in cold water. If that fails, open your eyes. You must have opened your eyes before, but somewhere along the line you can open your eyes. Then, if that doesn't work, create a light source in your mind—only people who have practised *jhāna*, I should think, can do that. And finally, walk up and down.

The point here is: don't give up easily. The Buddha gave nine different ways to work against that desire to fall asleep. In terms of our practice, we can simplify this. Yes, when those first feelings come, you have to recognise them fairly quickly and just lift up the body. Sometimes that's enough—it's just a bit of low energy moving us towards sleep, and it goes.

If that doesn't work, open your eyes and let a bit of light in. Another thing I've tried is putting your hands on your head—not on top, that hurts your neck, but something like this. Have you ever tried that? It works. Of course, if it fails, you tend to move forward pretty quickly, which could be dangerous. But generally speaking, you catch yourself.

If that doesn't work, stand up. And if you feel you're going to fall over, then you have to walk. When you walk, don't do the slow walking meditation—just gently walk up and down. What we're trying to do is refuse to fall into that temptation. Whatever the hindrance is telling us to do, we must do exactly the opposite. If it's saying, "Look, fall asleep, have a little kip, a power nap, that's what you need," you say, "No way, I know you, Mara." That's the mud he threw at the Buddha. You stand up against it, you won't do it. You have to resist, no matter what.

But you don't fight it. If you find yourself fighting it, you're pushing a lot of turbulence back into the system. Then it becomes a struggle and you just get a headache. It's a case of being with it, allowing it to be there. When you walk up and down with it, for instance, just imagine you're taking a big fat dog for a walk. He's dragging along with you, that's all. Come on, come on.

Now, you can go to extreme levels to overcome sloth and torpor. There's a story—I can't remember where I picked it up—of a monk who was rather desperate about it all. He sat against a pole and tied his head to it. Unfortunately, he fell asleep anyway. When they came in, they thought he'd hanged himself. He'd actually just fallen asleep.

Another thing you can try is sitting near a wall. When you go forward, you definitely wake up with that last little crack on the head. Unfortunately, as I found, it doesn't seem to help very much when you've got very strong torpor. You do wake up, as it were, but then eventually, if it's really bad, your body tends to collapse and you really knock the wall. After a week of this, I got the feeling there was a bit of brain damage going on. I gave up on it.

But when I got to my *kuti*, my hut, I found that I used to sit under a mosquito net. Just that little touch on the head from the net was enough to keep me up. These are only suggestions, you understand.

I was at a retreat years ago and a big tall man was standing next to me. We were meditating and there was this almighty crash—he had actually keeled over. So you have to use a bit of common sense somewhere. When we went over to help him, he refused to be helped.

That was when I was a lay person. On another occasion, when I was a monk, I was in Penang—they've got a beautiful centre there. A young German monk, very tall, big fellow, would get up with us at two o'clock, would you believe, to do the meditation. He'd do walking meditation at the back of the hall. And there was this, again, enormous crash. He'd walked into a painting. It was lucky it wasn't a window. Very embarrassed. None of us got up, by the way. We all just noted here and here.

So obviously you have to use a bit of common sense with these things. But what do you actually do when sloth and torpor comes? What's the practice? It's to investigate it, isn't it? First of all, there's usually that reaction—the aversion, the not wanting it, the urge to shake yourself out of it, go for a brisk walk. Now if you do that, you're suppressing it. If you think you can kick this out of the way by walking up and down fast, then there's a possibility that all you're doing is pushing it away. And that pushing it away re-enters the system, and then you get more sloth, more torpor.

So when we're sitting there and this stuff comes, there may be that desire to go there—that's the pleasure—and there may be that resistance to it, not wanting to deal with it. But frankly, of all the painful mental states we have—depression, anxiety and all that—this isn't so bad, is it? I'm alright with it. Gentle, fuzzy feelings in the head. Sometimes it gets a bit like porridge, but you just...

The idea is that you wander about. If you keep your attention moving, it'll keep you awake. You just wander about, feeling this, feeling that, around the middle of your head. Then maybe you can come out of your head and see if there's any dullness, any lethargy anywhere else. If the mind is bright but the body feels very lethargic, you move around, just feeling here, feeling there. Just wondering if your big toe feels lethargic. Have you ever investigated that? See?

It's this keeping the attention moving that gives it just enough energy not to be drawn in. And what we're investigating, as always, is the quality of those sensations, those feelings. We can see them from the three characteristics point of view—the fact that they're constantly in a course of change. When you're looking at it, the observer can't be the observed; there must be some distance, so it's not me, not I. And again there's that reaction of wanting, not wanting, which is the *dukkha*, the suffering.

But you can also look at it more in terms of the four great elements. Try to feel its—sometimes we haven't got words for these things—its featheriness, its lightness, its dustiness. Just get into it. If you're using the noting technique and words don't come, don't bother with them. Just feel what's actually happening there, actually get into it. That's what we're doing, that's all we're doing.

In doing this, remember, we're always allowing this turbulence—because it is a turbulence, an energy—to expend itself, to just blow itself out. Now every time we fall into it, even when we don't want to, even if we do it totally unwittingly, there's always that little moment of impulsion. Remember that. Whenever we fall into some dream, fantasy or whatever, there's always that little moment of impulsion. That's the *cetanā*, the will. And it's recreating, continuing to create and reinforce that conditioning. It's not a powerful thing, but it's there, constantly pushing that wheel round.

When we know that, we get a feeling of putting a little bit of special effort into the practice. These things can last a long time—they can last for days—so you just have to bear with it. It's not as though it's like that all the time, but it can be hanging around. And it feels as though you can't investigate anything because it's all so dull. But that's because you're not making the dullness itself something to investigate. If boredom comes, you note that too, because boredom comes out of a desire for pleasure, a desire for some happiness or distraction. You just keep going back to it, keep going back to it.

Remind yourself that when these things come up as physical feelings, they're actually exhausting themselves. That's how the conditioning exhausts itself. Often when we do this, as the feelings begin to disappear, whatever has been suppressed begins to arise. It might be fear, it might be anything down there.

So the resolution is to refuse to be annihilated. And with all these hindrances, remember, that's the purification of the heart. This is an energy, and when it's released, it's transformed—it doesn't stop. The energy isn't dissipated or lost. Remember that in right attitude of the Eightfold Path, hatred turns to love, cruelty to compassion. There's a transformation going on. This energy, now purified of that tightness, is there to be used. It'll come back into the awareness, it'll come back into all the factors of enlightenment. So it's really worth struggling with it.

It's up to you how much you want to find out where the point of tiredness is and where this dullness and lethargy starts. On a retreat, if after three days you've settled in and you're sleeping something like seven hours, push it back a bit—go back to five and a half. Remember, we sleep in these one-and-three-

quarter-hour patterns. When you do that, of course you have to go through three days of misery to get that energy up, but in doing so something may be released, because we don't know how much of our so-called sleep is actually needed. Then when that's settled and you're actually flying along on five and a half hours and you feel generally okay with it—not that these feelings won't come up—push it back a bit more. You can get back to four hours, three and a half, and give it another three days.

If you can do that, lift it up three days, then really it's very difficult to go back beyond that. Even the Buddha needed two hours. And on a hot day, in the hot season, you have to have a kip in the afternoon too. So it's not as though we want to do without sleep—we just want to find out how much sleep we actually need.

Now, if you knock it back to three and a half or four hours, and after four to five days you're still falling all over the place and crashing through doors, then you come back forward again and try five and a half hours. Then you know where the line is as far as this retreat is concerned. That's not an all-time rule—it's just this moment, this retreat, this is what I can handle. In doing this, you're actually gently pushing the system. You're gently, shall we say, squeezing the pimple. You've got to give it a little squeeze and it'll pop. So you've got to work with it a little bit.

Now opposite to that is all these feelings of restlessness. When we look at the root cause, restlessness is all part of our indulgence, isn't it? Rushing here, rushing there, getting this done, getting that done, wanting this, wanting that. The whole society is in a constant rush. We're in that flow of getting things done in order to achieve something. There's that pleasure that comes with doing something fast and achieving something.

One very good exercise you might try—because this is also a lot to do with our relationship to time and time passing, and everybody has slightly different relationships to psychological time—is to get a clock with hands and just sit there watching it for two hours. Just watching the clock go round. Listen to what comes up. All this stuff about wasting time. What are you doing here? You should be out there doing something. And you just sit there watching it go round. Minute after minute. The passage of time. The fact that we can't control it. All sorts of stuff comes up. The office can buy you a clock.

The other reason we rush, of course, is that we're pushing things away. We don't want to look at certain things, so we're running in the opposite direction. Often, for instance, when we feel depressed we'll force ourselves—the old kick in

the you-know-what and get going. Unfortunately we do that only by way of not looking at something unpleasant. We're running away from it, so it's a form of aversion. And when we do that, we're suppressing. So when we slow down—and that's one of the great things about slowing down—you can feel that impulse to rush, rush, rush, move, move, move. If you just stop and stay with that, then often when it begins to dissipate, an underlying feeling, an underlying mental state which it's been suppressing, begins to arise.

Interestingly, restlessness is the last hindrance to go, along with conceit. Now, if we think of restlessness as simply a form of energy being restless, I don't think that's quite right. Restlessness is anything that's actually shifting the mind—so it could be any of the hindrances making the mind shake. If we look at our practice as a refinement of the heart, a refinement of the mind, then all these hindrances just get more and more refined until they peter out, until they go out. They go out when the self disappears. So restlessness is going to be with us right to the bitter end. We've got to get used to it, we've got to stop fighting it, we've got to know how to be with it.

When you're sitting there and the body feels tremendously restless, again you have to make a resolution. You do exactly the opposite. Even though there are these little *nāgas* coming in saying, move, get up, get out, do something, shift, go take a walk, you'll feel better—all that sort of stuff—you don't move. Absolute rock still, refuse to move. And as it were, relax around it. Relax the frame of the body around these feelings as best you can. That sort of puts a damper on it, you might say. It just stops the energy beginning to shake everything.

If you can keep the mind moving around until you feel that you can hold it, as it were, then it'll keep that attention right on those feelings. And if you investigate the body, parts of it don't feel restless at all. The end of your nose, for instance—it's very rare at the end of your nose to feel restless. Then just keep going around and see it from one of the three characteristics, the quality of transience and all that. Go into it and see what the building blocks are.

Remember that every time we go towards that point of contact where we're actually just experiencing the elements—the four great elements: heat, fire, water and earth, pressure and all that—at that point the intellect has to stop because you've got to be right with it there. We're seeing things very clearly. And at that point, because we've gone beyond the idea of restlessness—same with all the others, the idea of fear, the idea of sloth and torpor—the energy, the suppression, goes.

Suppression only goes when you recognise something as pleasant and unpleasant. The suppressive forces, *taṇhā*, desire, wanting, not wanting, only come into force after we've defined something as pleasant and unpleasant. If we go beyond that into the actual feelings and lose that definition, then there's no suppression. That means whatever turbulence is there, that restlessness, it's completely free to exhaust itself. And remember, when I'm using words like exhaust and expend, the energy is not lost. It refines itself and is thereby to be used. Normally it comes back into the factors of enlightenment—the calm, the spaciousness, the equanimity, the concentration, the effort. All that begins to get ironed out and reinforced.

So when we're working with restlessness in the body, the big resolution is not to move. Now if you do walking meditation and the restlessness is severe, there's no point in doing a slow walking meditation because it's like you're trying to force a concentration on the step when the rest of the body is shaking like mad. So just walk up and down. It's like taking a frisky dog out for a walk. Just walk up and down and stay with those feelings. Keep the attention moving and feeling it and just being with it. Take it for a walk. But do it gently. Don't start walking up and down like a mad person, because that's just empowering it. It's a case of moving the body gently up and down and letting these feelings express themselves. Again, remember that they've got a grudge against us. They need to get the grudge off their chest. Mara. Embrace them. Friends. I don't want to sound too new-agey now. Huggy-wuggy normal.

If the restlessness is in the mind—obsessive thinking—what's happening there? The old habit whereby an emotional state is seeking some sort of metaphor to work with. So the restlessness will grab anything it can be restless with. Doesn't matter what it is. And if you find that the mind is doing that, then that's an avenue which has been conditioned to slip out into these higher faculties of thought and imagination. If you try and kill that, if you try and destroy it, then of course you're feeding aggression back into the system. So we just have to be patient, don't we? Very patient with it. You just note it, acknowledge it.

I'm always for really acknowledging it. Sometimes we note something and it's more like a flip away—restless—a little flick. And it's an aversion, and we're not catching it. But if you actually note something, even if you don't use a word, just note it—restless, restless mind, obsessive thinking—and then the second one is like an acknowledgement, like driving it home to ourselves that this is the restless

mind. That stops that reaction of pushing it away, and then you're just noting what it is. Come back, come back into the body. And again just feel, if you can, the restlessness which is empowering these thoughts.

At first you might not be able to feel it because the energy of that restlessness has that way out of exhausting itself. But if you keep doing it, slowly I think you'll find that you get in touch with that restlessness. And that means you're stopping that avenue of indulgence. The more these feelings come out through the body, the more they're exhausting themselves.

So you can take this as an absolute rule until you prove me wrong: whenever these emotions slip into the higher faculties, whether we meant them to or not, they are indulging themselves and they are growing. One obvious example is during the day at work or at home somebody says something a little upsetting and you just put it aside, you don't worry about it. Then when it comes to morning break it slips up in the mind and while you're drinking your tea you're thinking, "How could they say anything like that to me?" By lunchtime you're eating and thinking, "I'm pretty well told I'm not going to do that." By evening you're ripping them apart, throwing them out of windows. And you have to take Prozac.

All that's been done, not because you meant it to, but because every time there's a slippage into the fantasy world, it's developing the emotion. That's what the emotion wants to do. That's how it finds relief. If you're angry and you bang the door, there's a relief there. But unfortunately, we've reinforced the habit of being angry with doors. So with obsessive thinking, it's just real, constant persistence, just working with it. Every time the anger comes up, the fed-upness comes up, all that, that's also to be noted. And just, as you know, after time, it fades out.

I like these two hindrances; they often move from one to the other, don't they? You can be restless one minute and then just fall asleep the next. Then you fall asleep and suddenly you can't stop moving. So there we see that actually all we're working with are forms of energy. The image I have is of an internal weather system. The storms come, the whirlwinds, all that. And it's all the same thing—it just takes on a different hue, a different form.

The next thing that comes up, apart from those two, is simply pain—physical and mental. When it comes to physical pain, that's just the nature of the body, isn't it? We can't stop that. Even the Buddha had pain. So what we're concerned with is taking the suffering out of pain, and we find that the suffering is simply our rela-

tionship to it. When pain comes, at least one good thing about it is that it does concentrate us. I'm sure there are often times in our meditative lives when we're feeling very restless that we're crying out for pain. Just stick us on a pin or something.

Of course, you have to be careful with physical pain—you need to be clear that it's coming from the body and that the body is actually saying something. When we begin a retreat, for instance, you can start getting these sore knees, screaming knees. So you have to give them a bit of a stretch, a bit of a rest, have a bit of kindness towards your knees. But even so, it's an interesting thing for us because we're investigating that relationship we have with pain, which is aversion and fear. The idea is not, of course, to overcome pain. We're not supposed to get macho with it, try to kill it, destroy it. But as soon as we lose that sense of the ability to investigate and to see our relationship to it, it becomes too much. Then you change posture.

Now don't forget, when we change posture, there's a whole thing to be learned there. Here we are moving from a situation where the body is in pain and the mind is in pain, the emotions are in pain—aversion and all that. As we move slowly—the more slowly you go, the more you can see the connection between body and mind—you can see the sensations of pain fading out to neutral, and you can see the heart moving from being very agitated to being calm, comfortable. It's just watching that, watching how the mind-body, like the Buddha said, milk and water, are constantly reacting off each other. So we're learning a few things there by just working with physical pain.

And don't forget the usual rule about physical pain: if it carries on after a sitting or after walking, then go and see a doctor, because you never know. Generally speaking, as you know, these things disappear when you get up.

But the other sort of pain, which is more interesting in a way, is the pain that comes from something suppressed in the body—some emotion that's, for want of a better word, blocked or held in a certain part of the body. When those feelings come up, we're employing the same quality of seeing our relationship to it always, and as that dies out, to go into the pain to see what pain is made up of. Tightness, burning, whatever it is—just to get down to that level which makes it very clear that the idea of pain is a concept. It's something the mind works with. The mind conceives it, and of course there's a good reason for it. We want to know when the body is in pain.

Sometimes I think we can become—especially with physical pain—a little insensitive to what the body is saying to us because we become so equanimous with it. You have to be slightly careful about that. I remember one occasion, because you can slightly overdo it, when actually as soon as I started meditating, I started getting this discomfort in my neck, the back of my neck here. And it grew and grew and grew. At that time I was working with Goenkaji, with that system, a few years ago now. I went off by myself to his beautiful centre in Jaipur. They've built a castle there. As you go in, it's a rotunda, with all these little rooms on the outside and the inside. They're all nice little rooms; when you get in there you do feel supported by the walls. And this pain was...

It was really bad, and I got into the habit of thinking that I was just going to squeeze it out of the system because I could feel it was in the musculature. So I began moving my head about and stretching the muscles, and eventually it got fairly wild. Over a period of ten days, it was really what I would call the lower depths of hell. Often I walked out and watched the little mice running here and running there.

Anyway, when I got back to the UK, whenever I sat, my head would flop forward. I'd begin like this, but it would end up like this. It was only when somebody complained—there had been a group of monks at the bihāra I was staying at, maybe six or seven, and there were two Westerners amongst them. A friend came up and said to me that they were a little bit ashamed that the only monks who fell asleep were the two Westerners, because I wasn't saying anything. I was like this, you see. So that propelled me to go and see the chiropractor.

When he was fiddling about with my head, he told me that my skull had come off the top of my spine. I said, "What?" He said, "It has." And then, as they do, they got hold of my head, and there was this ten-thousand-world almighty crack. It was alright, back on top of my spine. So you see, you can take things too far. I dare say that if I'd carried on in that meditation centre, I might have beheaded myself.

So you have to be slightly careful. It's up to you really to gauge your own personality—if you're the timid type then you can push a bit, but if you're the foolhardy type then just watch your neck.

When it comes to emotional pain, remember to be very clear in your mind that the external cause—some fright that was given to you as a child or whatever it might be—is not the root cause of that emotional state. The root cause is the conditioning which goes back to the self. Therefore, any memory which comes up is irrelevant.

This emotion of fear now will be chasing something to get hold of. If the fear is there on the surface of your mind and you happen to be walking along and a spider jumps on you, then you end up with this arachnophobia for the rest of your life. So it's always searching for something by way of expressing itself. Well, actually it's an indulging of itself.

By sitting with fear, by sitting with that pain in the body, even though we don't know what it is—it's only when these mental states hit the heart centre that we can begin to recognise them as emotions. Tightness in the belly—I mean you can call it anxiety but you don't know, it's just tightness in the belly. So long as you get those feelings and the tightness in your body and the burning and all those peculiar things that come up, just stay with them and treat them as physical pain. You go into it, you get into the feelings of it and just get the feeling of allowing it to blow its energy out. In the meantime, we're investigating these three characteristics. And in so doing, we are very slowly beginning to realise all the time that we are not that. We are not that.

There's one last little story which goes with this from the Mahāsi Centre. It's written in a book where all the healings that went on there over a period of so many years are listed, and there was one particular man who turned up with terminal cancer in the stomach. As he describes it, he didn't take any medicine—he was just going to work with it and sit there and die. As it goes, as I remember it, because I've not been able to get hold of this book since, he was sitting there just watching the pain in the stomach, and there was an explosion—that's how he describes it, an explosion—and the cancer disappeared.

Now, not all cancers are caused by emotional states, but in this case, lucky for him, it was. It disappeared. So that's a very graphic example of what's actually happening when we allow these emotional states, which are in the body, to express themselves.

Very good. So this evening we've covered just these three major ones: dullness and lethargy, restlessness and pain. Next time I'll try and cover the rest. I just wanted to spend a bit of time on these questions. If I can't answer them all tonight, we can do so tomorrow.

"Please discuss concrete practical means of balancing concentration, energy and mindfulness. How to gauge what is needed without manipulation, that is, without desire."

When it comes to the spiritual faculties—which, of course, these are your three main ones, aren't they? Energy, awareness, concentration—the Buddha makes it very simple for us. All he says is, if you pay attention to something, the other faculties will rise up to support it. So we don't have to worry about things like concentration and effort. As soon as you make the effort to be attentive, that's enough effort you need. As soon as you're attentive, that's enough concentration you need. You don't have to worry about these things.

If you make concentration an obsessive thing, then you're missing out on the awareness because your attention is always on "Am I concentrated enough?" If you're constantly worried about your energy and "Have I got enough energy for this?" then again your attention is moving off being attentive to being worried about whether you've got enough energy or not. But the fact of the matter is, as soon as you are paying attention, you have enough energy and concentration. And the more you keep placing the mind into that attentive mode, the sharper it becomes.

So abandon concentration and energy. Just let the awareness do the trick. Remember that awareness is always coupled with intelligence. It has to be an awareness with a question mark. You can't be just aware. It has to be that wanting to know. And that's what empowers the system.

"What is the relationship of the *Brahmavihāras* to the Four Noble Truths, the Factors of Enlightenment and the Five Spiritual Faculties?"

What is the relationship of the *Brahmavihāras* to the Four Noble Truths? Well, it comes into Right Attitude, and it comes into Right Livelihood, because your attitudes begin to express themselves in what you do. To practise the *brahmavihāras* as *jhānic* states is all well and good in terms of developing our own mind, but unless you can take those attitudes out into the world...

Remember that the Buddha is constantly saying, "Whatever a teacher can do out of compassion for his students, I have done for you." So his developments of the *Brahmavihāras* were presumably enormous, but they had to be expressed into action. And the word he uses is *anukampā*—which means to move towards the other. So compassion, love and all these move you towards the other. That's the relationship.

Now, of course, you don't need them to become enlightened—this is the point. These are the merits, this is your *puñña*, this is what you get as we move along the path of liberation. For liberation we're talking about a level of consciousness.

We're talking about a way of looking. So this way of looking is directed through these three characteristics of existence. When we've looked in the right way, one of the obvious insights we get is our interconnectedness. And when that interconnectedness is translated into a heart expression, when it moves into the heart as an expression, then it has to be love, compassion, sympathetic joy. If it just stays up here, well, it's not much cop.

I'm reminded of an incident with a cat. I was at a monastery and there was a cat, and this cat was playing around with a mouse. It didn't want to eat it—it had been fed. It was just playing around with it. When I walked in, there was a cat with a mouse and the mouse was dead, and I said to the monk, "What happened here?" He said, "Oh, he was just playing around with it." And I remember saying to him, "Well, didn't you stop it?" He said, "No, it calmed me."

I was at another monastery when this cat sort of shot out and got a bird, and this monk went up and gave it one hell of a wallop, took the bird out of its mouth, looked at it, realised that its lungs had been punctured and it died. He held it up very beautifully with its wings and chanted, "*Aniccā vata saṅkhārā*"—all compounded things arise and pass away.

Now you see what this first monk didn't realise or didn't understand was that his seeing the cat is part of the cat's *kamma*. The fact that he didn't react to the cat's cruelty is part of the cat's *kamma*. And that's what I mean about it being alright talking about the interconnectedness of the universe and all that, but if it doesn't express itself through a compassionate action then it's dead as a dodo.

"What does one do after leaving the anchor?"

I'm not so sure what that—I think that came up in an interview. It's not that you leave the anchor. The breath is your anchor, it's a primary object. So the whole idea about the breath is that it's always there. I mean if it's not there, worry! So when everything calms down, the mind becomes absolutely silent, the body is absolutely still, and the heart is completely in peace—it's happened once or twice, hasn't it?—then there is only the breath. So now the breath is where you centre your whole attention, and it's through the breath that these characteristics are seen. And that's why it opens up in the *Satipaṭṭhāna* discourse, the discourse on how to establish awareness, because that's where you hone your skills, that's what you can always come back to, and eventually there is only the breath.

"Can you say something about the little thoughtlets which circumambulate, as it were, the primary object?"

Well, if they're only little thoughtlets, you see, just keep turning away. And as you're turning away, remember, you're drawing energy out of the system into the observing. You're actually drawing it out and putting it where it ought to be. So this is just a sort of mild restlessness, isn't it?

Remember there are those two stages: *vitakka* and *vicāra*. So the *vitakka* is when you are constantly bringing that focus back, constantly bringing it back. You know the image of the bee flying towards the flower. And then the *vicāra* is when finally the bee settles on the flower. So when you get that feeling of being settled on the breath—those are signs of that concentration coming, you see. Not that you are worrying about it. You're just worried about being attentive. And then there's that settling.

So now that's a dangerous point because you tend to think, "Oh, I'm finally there, brilliant." And you pull back a bit and off you go—the mind just bursts out because it's not really settled. You've got to keep working on that until there's a real sense of being absorbed into it, real steadiness, you know.

"How does one contemplate the three characteristics of existence without getting lost in concepts?"

So in the discourse on how to establish this mindfulness, there are these three steps that the Buddha points out. He uses the word *sikkhati*, which means to train. He says, "Train on the breath." Once you're settled, he says, "See its quality of *anicca*, the quality of transience." And then he says there comes a point when there is just enough *sati*, just enough awareness and just enough intelligence for insight to arise. At that point one isn't thinking anymore.

You don't have to think because the intelligence, this intuitive intelligence, has already been pointed that way. All we have to do by bringing up the idea in the mind of *anicca*, of transience, is you're directing your attention to a certain quality. Once it's directed to that quality and you begin to look at it, the thinking stops as you become absorbed in just looking. Remember the picture—for those of you who were here—that wonderful little baby with its eyes completely wide open and its jaw dropped. If you can get that feeling of just looking. And that's the point where thinking and all that about the hindrances disappears because you're actually directly experiencing them.

"Would it not be equally valid to follow the flow of breath sensations at the nose tip while doing walking meditation?"

You can do actually. It's more of a *samatha* practice just to keep your mind on the breath. Make sure that you're walking in a very open space. You tend to walk into things when you do things like that. Just be aware of where you generally are.

"It says that walking meditation balances the faculties. Which faculties in particular does walking meditation balance?"

Well, as far as I remember, the normal thing is that what walking meditation is very good for is concentration. If you're worried about concentration, do the walking meditation, because the walking meditation is gross. I mean, you can feel it. You're there with it. And you can use it to just keep your mind actually on the footstep.

Now the balancing of the faculties—presumably means the factors of enlightenment or the five spiritual faculties. Again, what balances those things is awareness, attention. That's what balances them. So walking meditation is very good for that if you can actually do it in a way that you determine to stop whenever the mind wanders. So you stop, collect yourself, intending to walk, and off you go. You don't have to turn around or anything, but you stop every time the mind wanders.

I'll just do one last one. "Can you say more about *sati* combined with *paññā* and where it's discussed in the suttas?"

The main place is the discourse on how to establish awareness: *Satipaṭṭhāna*.

Very good. I think that's enough for this evening. I hope that my words have been of some assistance. May you be fully liberated from all your suffering sooner rather than later.

Subliminal Inclinations, Defilements and Hindrances

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 55 min

Originally given as *Subliminal Inclinations, Defilements and Hindrances* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this teaching from a 2011 Gaia House retreat, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines how Vipassanā meditation serves as therapy for the heart by addressing three categories of unwholesome conditioning taught by the Buddha. He explores the anusaya (subliminal inclinations or proclivities) - the seven hidden tendencies including sensual greed, grudge-holding, wrong views, skeptical doubt, conceit, craving for existence, and ignorance. These manifest as the kilesa (defilements) - ten mental impurities including greed, hatred, delusion, mental torpor, restlessness, shamelessness, and lack of moral dread, which the Buddha called "guardians of society."

The teaching culminates in practical guidance for working with the five hindrances encountered in meditation: sensual desire, ill-will, sloth and torpor, restlessness and worry, and skeptical doubt. Bhante emphasizes that all mental states arise from our own attitudes and conditioning, liberating us from blame while empowering personal transformation. He provides specific techniques for each hindrance and explains how mindful acknowledgment without suppression allows these mental formations to naturally dissolve, leading to genuine purification of the heart. This comprehensive exploration demonstrates how Vipassanā meditation addresses psychological healing within the framework of Buddhist liberation.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-enlightened one.

This evening I thought to try and answer one of the things that we touched upon yesterday: how does *vipassanā* work, or what is it that *vipassanā* does to help us get rid of our unwholesome conditioning? In other words, what's its therapy at a mental level?

There are three ways in which the Buddha categorises these unfortunate conditionings. The first he calls the *anusaya*, which is translated as proclivities. They're basically inclinations or tendencies. The next one is the *kilesa*, which is translated as defilements. And the third one is the five hindrances that we deal with when we're meditating. These are just ways of looking at the same problem, although they have different accents.

When he's talking about *anusaya*, these tendencies, I think it gets very close to our idea of things being repressed or suppressed. Just as in our understanding we ignore, we don't want to see certain parts of ourselves—painful parts, fears, griefs, all that sort of stuff. And we push it out of consciousness, turn away from it, just ignore it. Sometimes we keep it down with fear, not wanting to go there, and aversion—we just don't like being in that state. Those things that are suppressed like that, I think, equate to the word *anusaya*, these inclinations or tendencies.

They're there within the system, and there's no way of knowing what's in the system until it manifests, until something triggers, until the button's pressed and then you realise, "Oh, I've got that, have I?" This word *anusaya*, as I understand it, was later categorised into seven types. But in the actual discourses, the Buddha uses it quite loosely as meaning the tendencies, hidden tendencies, things that we're not aware of at all. And sometimes we're not aware of characteristics, but other people are. And you wonder why everybody's crossing the street when you're coming down.

The first one is sensuous greed—greed for the pleasures that the sense bases give us. That's pretty straightforward: indulgence, greed. It's always there as a potential. That's the point—it's always there as a potential.

The next one is grudge, which you could put down to aversion really, but holding on to something, a grudge. That's what it's translated as.

The other three are more to do with mental states, the way we think about things rather than feel about things. Speculative opinions—holding on to views and opinions. "I'm right, everybody else is wrong." It's that sort of thing.

The other one is sceptical doubt, and we'll come to that in more detail when we do the hindrances. Just very quickly, that's not the same as questioning something, wondering whether something's right or wrong. That's the sort of mind the Buddha would have us develop, actually. That makes us investigate. What sceptical doubt does is it stops you from investigating, stops you from even going near it, because, well, you don't believe it. It's a lot of rubbish.

I was once leading a retreat, and somebody was a biology student, and he'd come to the very firm view that there was only the body—that emotions, thoughts, consciousness and all that were simply effects of the brain, neurons and stuff like that. And as I began teaching, and one of the teachings, of course, is to separate the body and mind, with the suggestion that there's even another quality that we refer to as *Nibbāna*, he couldn't hack it. He'd come to meditate, which I think what he meant was to cool out, chill out, calm. And so that was it. I saw him again. He left after a day or two. I thought, well, that's the way it is. Wrong speculative opinions, sceptical doubt.

And this conceit. The conceit is normally split into three types. "I am better than you." That's what normally people think of as conceit. But the obverse is true—"I'm worse than you." Even that's a conceit. It might feel good about that. "I am worthless." It's a sort of downing oneself, isn't it? But it's to do with comparing, constantly comparing who we are.

And the other one is more subtle: "I'm equal to you." Now, we're only equal to people who think like us. It's a sort of subtle conceit. Because I have you as an equal to me, it means that all the people who aren't equal to us must be either better than us or worse. It's just a group identity. And that happens all the time, doesn't it? That's why people join groups, religious groups, political groups, and they say, "We've got it right, everybody else got it wrong." That's the conceit business.

The next one is this craving for continued existence. In other words, we want to keep living. We don't want to die. It's as simple as that. We want to just keep going and going. And that's, of course, a very deep desire within us. That's a real obsessive thing. When illness, any serious illness approaches, or a hint of death, even somebody we know can put the fear of God in us. Somebody who died and you think, "All right," especially when they're your age group, or your age—that's even worse. And so you get that craving, the desire for continued existence.

And the final one is the usual basis upon which all this is built. It's ignorance. This word *avijjā* is a bit strange because it literally means not knowing. Not knowing. It's not really ignorance in the sense of "you should have known" or "you're stupid." It's a very neutral state. I did find a word actually which translates it rather well: nescience. But nobody knows it. And I didn't know it until I found it in the Oxford English Dictionary. There was no point in going around calling it nescience. Everybody else said, "What's that?" And I said, "Well, it's a sort of ignorance." So what's the point?

Anyway, these are listed, the seven. You see there, there's something to do with attitude—the greed and the hatred. It's the usual split, greed and aversion. It's just put slightly differently. There are three to do with the way we think, which rebounds back onto this final one, ignorance: the wrong views, the sceptical doubt, and the conceit. The sceptical doubt is also based on a fear. Most of these will be based on some sort of attitude, but you can see that they're more mental attitudes than anything else. And the craving for continued existence is a projection of craving really, just another form of craving. The Buddha in the Four Noble Truths talks of three cravings: the sensual desire, the craving for existence, continued existence, and the craving for non-existence.

That sometimes puzzles people, but suicide is craving for non-existence. And in our own little way, every time we use sleep to get rid of a certain down feeling or go for a sleep or something, that is also a form of getting rid of yourself. And again, we'll come to that when we come to the five hindrances.

The reason I mention this is to let you know that in the Buddhist teaching there's also these potentials that lie within the mind, which to me is akin to something which is suppressed or repressed or something like that. But the Buddhist teaching always has an ethical bias, whereas our modern way of thinking of it is more like diseases, mental dis-eases, mental health. In a sense it's more neutral.

But the Buddha would really bring us back down to the fact that a lot of our problems are created by unwholesome decisions. But you can't say all of them are. Fear, you know, if somebody frightens you a great deal when you're a child, you can't really call that an ethical thing. But later on, when you become aware of your fear, when you become more self-reflexive from about the age of 16 or 18 onwards, then in a sense you have to take responsibility for it and do something about it. And in that sense it becomes an ethical problem - ethical in the widest sense of that term, not to be confused with evil. So for instance, an attachment

that a mother has for the child, a child has for the mother, you can't call that evil, but the attachment is actually causing problems, especially when it's confused with love.

So when these begin to rise into consciousness, then there is this other category which is called the *kilesa*. And when you read Eastern writers, I'm thinking especially somebody like Mahāboowa, he'll use things like "kill the *kilesa*." Really sort of heavy. But I'm not so sure that's a skilful way for us anyway, urging people to kill the *kilesa*. And these are defilements.

So there are ten of these. And again, you won't be surprised by any of them. And some of them, of course, mirror these underlying tendencies. The first one is greed and the second one hatred. So you've always got that split. And the third one is delusion.

Now, this not knowing - and we're talking about consciousness here, we're talking about that which knows. Unfortunately, the word consciousness these days is getting really confused because they've decided to study it. Before it was just meant "to know," but now they... To me, when I read some of the writers, they seem to confuse it with the mind in terms of content. But in the Buddha's teaching, it's just a knowing, just an act of cognition, which really is a discriminative consciousness. It's being able to tell this from that. That's that.

When we talk about the five aggregates, which some of you may know, the body, perceptions, feelings, all our emotions and thought patterns, and consciousness. This consciousness at the end of the line is that part of us which is able to discriminate, to know the difference, to discern, and it's part of the intellect.

So that's deluded, you see. There's a delusion at a deeper level which we call this not knowing, and that's referring to this real deeper intelligence, this intuitive intelligence which we are contacting when we do vipassanā, when you become the observer and thought has stopped. So that there's something about that intelligence which sees clearly, sees directly, doesn't have to go through thought or anything like that. So there's something about the way it's looking which isn't quite right, and what it forms is a fundamental delusion.

And that fundamental delusion is to believe we are this body and mind — in other words, that we are human beings. It's a big delusion. Conventionally speaking, of course we are human. But when we look deeper and try to define what a human being actually is, we don't come up with much. We come up with little bits and pieces tacked on to each other, and these always split into a relationship.

We're seeking happiness, so where we see happiness we greed for it, and where we see unhappiness we try to get rid of it, annihilate it. There's always this basic split that we're working with.

When people approached the Buddha and asked him questions such as, "What's your understanding of *kamma*?" he was clever enough to throw the question back at them: "Well, what do you understand by it?" And of course, they'd be very happy to tell him what they thought. Then, as they explained their view, he would point out some wrong thinking, some wrong understanding. It was only when they were able to drop their view that their minds became malleable and easy to receive — and that's when he would offer them his teaching.

If you'd gone to the Buddha and said, "What do you think of *kamma*?" and he'd simply replied, "Well, this is what I think," he'd just be tapping you on the nose with all his thoughts. So he was very clever to first ask the person and, shall we say, play on their conceit — "I'm right, you're wrong" — and then undermine their position by showing its illogicality, or the fact that it doesn't work. And then, when they were just ripe, he'd hit them with the Four Noble Truths.

It didn't work all the time. Some went away clicking their tongues. There's a fellow called Dantapāda — the name means "stick in hand." He says, "What do you teach?" and the Buddha gives him a cryptic reply, I can't remember what. And he goes away clicking his tongue. So he obviously didn't particularly like that.

Then there are two defilements which are rather interesting because we tend not to think quite this way: shamelessness and lack of moral dread, or unconscientiousness. In other words, a big defilement would be not to have shame or dread of consequences — which we could loosely call guilt, although guilt has other meanings.

Generally speaking, we talk about shame and guilt as being unwholesome things people shouldn't have. A lot of therapy books seem to say that all our problems come from the shame that was poured upon us when we were children and stuff like that. Now I'm not saying there isn't neurotic guilt and shame — shame that really is just inbred from childhood and what not. But in the Buddha's teaching, shame and dread are actually guardians. Because when we do something unwholesome, we're letting the side down, we're letting ourselves down.

That letting ourselves down, that loss of self-esteem — especially in other people's eyes — is what we call shame. It's not a very pleasant feeling. And a less intense feeling, although it need not be, is embarrassment.

I always like to tell the story about Sir Walter Raleigh. He was at the court of Queen Elizabeth, and presumably as he was bowing, he unfortunately let off a rather loud fart. Do you know this? He was so embarrassed — can you imagine, in front of the queen — that he didn't return to court for a year. And when he did, Queen Elizabeth greeted him: "We welcome you to our court. We're glad to see you, Sir Walter. We have forgot the fart." I think that's brilliant.

These sorts of embarrassments can be almost as mortifying as being caught shoplifting or doing something actually unwholesome — a social gaffe can feel that way. So I'm not sure the Buddha is referring to that sort of thing, but he's definitely referring to things which are unwholesome.

The lack of moral dread, which we can loosely call guilt, is this: if you don't see that there are going to be consequences to unwholesome actions, then why would you not do them?

Once I was at the Goenka retreat in India, his big place there, Dhamma Giri. After the retreat, I was sitting on the grass and this man joined me. I asked him, "What work do you do?" He said, "Well, I'm a theologian." I hadn't met a theologian before — a Catholic theologian, no less. Amazing, isn't it? So I asked him, "In terms of Buddhist teaching, what do you think about God and evil and being sent to eternal hell and things like that?" He was of the opinion that no matter what harm you did, once you saw the beatific vision, once you were actually in the presence of God, God's compassion would forgive everything. Which is a beautiful idea.

But it occurred to me afterwards — I didn't say this at the time — why would anybody stop doing evil if you believe that?

You mess everybody up, make your million, kick everybody in the teeth, and then God says, all right, come in and stay forever. So I think he was probably a little confused about it. But that sort of person who doesn't have any dread of consequences, or any shame, moves towards criminality — and at worst it can be a sign of mental illness.

These two qualities — shame and moral dread — the Buddha actually calls guardians of society. When we feel ashamed of what we've done, or dread the consequences, then the next time that temptation comes up, these guardians arise and we say, well, I don't want to go down that road again.

One of the exercises I suggest to people is this: when you're eating and you've taken too much food, you've got a moral dilemma. Are you going to throw it away and waste food, or are you going to eat it and do your body harm? My normal advice is to eat it and to know you're doing your body harm. Then when you come to the next load of food — I don't want to harm myself. It sometimes works.

If I just read through those again, you can compare them and see how we deal with these things in meditation. You've got these proclivities, these inclinations — greed and grudge, hatred, delusion, speculative opinions, sceptical doubt, conceit. Here it's turned around — conceit, speculative views, and sceptical doubt. Then you have this craving for continued existence, which in a sense produces everything else, and there's the ignorance and conceit. On this side you have much the same, but added to that is mental torpor, restlessness, shamelessness, and lack of moral dread. The ignorance in the anusaya as a potential manifests in the kilesa, the defilement, as delusion.

So that gives you a sense of the basic conditionings we have within us — on the dark side. We'll do the light side another time.

Now, what we come across in meditation is a different way of categorising all this: the five hindrances. They're very straightforward. There's everything to do with greed and wanting and craving; everything to do with hatred and aversion; dullness and lethargy; restlessness and remorse, where I think you can count in things like guilt and shame; and finally, sceptical doubt.

As each of these comes up, it will always manifest as a thought pattern — either a thought pattern or something you're doing. When you're eating, these things manifest. When you're sitting in meditation in the quietness, there's nowhere for them to go except up into the head. You can't express them outwardly anymore because you're keeping the silence and the stillness, and so they create these dreams. That's the first thing to recognise — that these mental defilements develop themselves through the mind, not only in meditation but also in daily life.

That's why we might be thinking about getting into an argument with somebody before we actually get into an argument with them. There'll be some mentation before we do it. Everything in the Buddha's understanding begins at the mind level, and from the mind you get that expression out into words and actions.

This is why, when we come out of a fantasy, come out of a dream sequence, that noting of it is so important — because that's a recognition. As I say, it's nice to do two notes; it's like you're reinforcing it with an acknowledgement: this is what the mind is doing. And by turning away from that — and this is what's so important — we're no longer developing that state, because the mental state can only develop itself through thought and imagination. When you turn away from something the mind is producing, that's not a suppression, that's not a repression. You see?

But it's only not a suppression, not a repression, if you then contact the actual feeling which is empowering it. Getting in contact with that feeling and allowing it as an emotion to express itself — that's where the therapy lies.

The next thing to understand is that the history lying behind a particular mental state is not the actual cause of that mental state. Therefore, dealing with it doesn't mean we have to seek history.

The Buddha puts it as an image of a person who gets shot with an arrow. People come to heal him, to take the arrow out and do something with the wound, and he says to leave it alone until he knows who shot it, why they shot it, who made the arrow — and of course he's dead before they can help. So here we are, we're angry and we're thinking, why am I angry? Was it because my mother hit me with a banana when I was three? And we keep going back and back, and of course it's all wanting to know things that are absolutely irrelevant to the actual mental state.

The reason history isn't connected to the present state is that all these mental states are reactions to a given situation, shaped by an attitude. They come from the heart itself. That's why some people fly into a rage at a small insult while others can simply palm it off. Our differences lie within the heart.

When an emotion comes up, a mental state comes up — it doesn't matter what it is, anywhere on the whole gamut of human misery — we have to remind ourselves that this has been created by me. It's not that the other person, or whatever 'caused' it, didn't have a role to play. Of course they did. But the actual way we reacted, the way we responded, is dependent on us.

If somebody is cruel to us, that cruelty can't get through, can't get beyond the body or what's actually being heard at the eardrum or felt at the surface of the skin. If somebody is shouting at us, we can hear it — we can hear the voice. It's like me with that chicken today. The chicken heard the voice — 'get out of this

room' — and the feeling behind it. I gave it a real 'get out', and the chicken knew it was not wanted, so off it went. You've got this hearing, and the hearing is telling you this is anger, and you get the feeling of the person — they're angry.

You can call that the catalyst — it's pressing certain buttons within us. If those buttons didn't exist, then the anger and the feel of the anger would stay just at the doors of perception, stay where we actually receive it. But because we have a conditioning to react to anger, anger arises in us, out of us, out of an attitude towards that person's anger. So the anger we're left with when they're gone is completely self-made. It is rooted within our own hearts.

This means we cannot blame others for our mental states — and it releases us from wanting to blame them. That doesn't mean they get away scot-free. Remember, in their anger they're developing a state of mind, developing a conditioning which burns within them. It's not as though they get away with it. They've got their own mental state, and of course they'll come across somebody who really can't handle their anger and they get punched on the nose or something.

When we come off any type of dream, any type of fantasy, and we come back into the heart to actually feel the emotional content, what we're experiencing is a product of an attitude within a given situation. It's all ours. All ours. And it is disappointing at first to recognise that you can't blame somebody else — it's always nice to find somebody to blame. But on the other hand, suddenly we're liberated.

Because if other people actually cause my suffering, I'm going to have to get rid of them. If another person really does cause my suffering, then I've no option — I've got to annihilate them. It's the only way I'm going to attain my own personal happiness. And of course, that's unfortunately the way most human beings think, isn't it?

So this understanding liberates us from that, and it also liberates us completely to do something about it. When I recognise that it's me who's developed these mental states, then it's me who can undo them. The whole process of mental purification — specifically through vipassanā, but also just through not indulging these things in daily life and acting from goodwill — undermines them anyway. We can change our personality, change our characters. That's not a problem. And we'll do it the quicker, the more we take responsibility for what we've engendered in our own hearts.

So when it comes to these first two hindrances — greed and hatred — whenever you see a fantasy in the mind, a story in the mind, you should be quick enough to say, 'Well, that's greed.' Even though it's very enticing, even though you want to get into it, even though you want to develop it, just really cut into it and say no. And know you're not doing yourself any harm. Then you come into the body and feel that state.

Sometimes these feelings are very loud, very painful, really. But the longer you can stay with them, the more the heart is actually healing. You can think of it as a sore in the heart, a pustulating sore, and it needs to get rid of the poison before it can heal itself. So that has to be borne; you have to be able to bear with it, to sit amidst the flames. That's one of the reasons the Buddha calls patient endurance the highest form of ascetic practice. It's more difficult to sit with our own burning than to sit on a bed of nails. That's external. You can do all the ascetic practices you want, but the hardest one is to sit in the bonfire within us.

So these two — everything to do with anything we crave for or wish for in that wrong way, and anything we hate or dislike (even depression is a form of aversion, and boredom too) — have to be felt. Have to be felt. Sometimes it's difficult because they're so loud and so constant that you think, 'This is never going to end.' You get that feeling that this is forever.

But if you hang on in there and begin to see it release, begin to see it die away a bit, that gives you the confidence that yes, this is the path of healing. And occasionally, with a bit of luck, you might see that energy turn and present its opposite.

Take something like loneliness. Loneliness comes with all these little stories — nobody loves me, I'm hateful, why should anybody love me? All that sort of rubbish. And it's painful to be lonely; it's not a pleasant place to be at all. But instead of rushing out and calling a friend to say, 'Look, I'm really lonely tonight,' instead of seeking that sort of escape, you just stay with the feelings of unlovability, unwantedness, being orphaned. If you stay with that feeling in the heart and don't let the mind wander, it might just be that as it passes away, as it dissolves, there comes this lovely moment of simply being happy on your own.

And that's solitude. Then you see that loneliness is actually a lie, because you're never less alone, never less lonely, than when you're happy being by yourself. It just doesn't occur. One of the pieces of advice the Buddha gives is to fare lonely as a rhinoceros.

Now I don't know much about rhinoceros — or rhinoceri, I'm not sure which to use — but I was once on safari. It was the only time I happened to be in the right place, and we did see a rhinoceros, I remember, and it was actually alone. There was nobody around. It's a huge beast; you don't want to get near one. And I remember the driver, because somebody said, 'Come on, let's go and have a look at it.' Big clothes. 'Whoa,' he said. 'Once that thing moves, it's like a tank.' Anyway, that's the Buddha's advice — to fare lonely as a rhinoceros.

The next hindrance is all this dullness and lethargy that everybody has a huge dollop of. Now, this isn't to be confused with real tiredness — we need sleep, everybody knows that. But this dullness, this stupor in the mind, feels like porridge, a soupy mix in the head, along with heaviness in the body. One aspect is to do with the brain and the mind, the way you can't think anymore, and the other is to do with the body, which is lethargy. You can have one or the other, but most times you have both. It's all a general state.

This is, of course, a consequence of seeking happiness in oblivion. As we said at the beginning of the talk, it's a form of annihilation. When you're a bit fed up, when you're tired, off you go to sleep. But it's not only that. Being asleep is, in a paradoxical way, rather pleasant. We seek sleep.

Now, we wouldn't do that if we thought we wouldn't wake up. There's a presumption that I'm going to bed tonight and tomorrow I'll wake up. If the doctor said, 'You fall asleep and you're never going to wake up,' that would be a real pain. You'd put pins in your eyes. So there's something about sleep which is delightful, especially that falling asleep. The way we actually say it — falling asleep, like falling in love, like falling, just letting go. It's lovely.

So there's something very pleasant about it; one feels refreshed. But if you also use sleep to escape some unpleasant state, then it becomes a suppression. And this stuff always comes up later as a heaviness in the body, as a feeling of depression itself.

So with dullness and lethargy, after two or three days on a retreat — definitely by the fourth day — if you're feeling tired during the day and you've had a good sleep, then really name it for what it is. The way we counter it is by always doing the opposite. If you get heavy, lift the spine, open the eyes, look straight into the light of the window. If it gets too heavy, stand up, and even then you might be so heavy that you just go for a walk. Now, whatever you're doing, you're accompanying it. You're not trying to get rid of it.

As soon as you try to get rid of something, you're putting aggression back into the system. So you're walking with it, and it's a real mental state — as important as anxiety, depression, and everything else. You just take the big fat dog for a walk. You keep going. Come on, come on. One step after the other. Just keep going up and down, up and down, up and down. And of course, just like all these things, it begins to evaporate, begins to loosen up.

These things can hit you hard. All these kilesas, all these hindrances and defilements, can hit you very hard at various times in your life. And everybody has their own particular constellation of them. Some people suffer horribly from sceptical doubt — especially the 'me' variety. Everybody else can do it, but not me. I'm not good enough or something. But from my experience with meditators and myself, dullness and lethargy are definitely there. They go back a long way.

The next hindrance is the opposite: restlessness. Sometimes the mind can be so restless you think you're going berserk. Absolutely berserk. It's terrible. But you have to be patient with it because that's the energy of thinking. Sometimes the dullness and lethargy just flip and you find yourself running around like a chicken. And sometimes the restlessness is in the body — you're sitting there, the mind's all right, but you get this tremendous feeling of wanting to move.

When that happens, it's good to move your attention up and down the body. Just move around the body, feeling where the restlessness is. That draws a bit of energy back into the observing. You can do the same with dullness and lethargy — move around the brain, around the head part here, move around the body. It keeps you awake.

Moving around the body works differently depending on which hindrance you're facing. With dullness and lethargy, move your attention up the body — from the toes to the top of the head. Wherever attention goes, energy follows, so moving upward actually lifts a bit of energy. With restlessness, do the opposite: go down from the top of the head to the toes. Attention has a way of bringing energy with it.

And with restlessness, don't move. That's basically it. With dullness and lethargy you move, and with restlessness you don't. Very simple instruction. Just hang on in there. Wait for it to give. And if it doesn't, fine, okay. It's going to come back — you'll have plenty of opportunity to work with this stuff. It's not as though you failed. Don't say, 'Oh my god, I failed.'

Running alongside restlessness is remorse, guilt, shame — you can put all that in — and these make you very fidgety. When they come up, you have to sit with them. Just sit with them. And if something arises that you feel you can put right — perhaps you remember saying something sharp to somebody and upsetting them — you make a decision to close off that karmic line by simply apologising. As simple as that. Whether they accept the apology or not doesn't matter. You've cleared it within your own heart. That's what's important.

Then finally there's sceptical doubt. Sceptical doubt is the inability to believe anything. It's a stopper, a killer. You just won't do anything if you don't have some sort of confidence in it. And it can be fear or aversion — fear, I think, mainly. If you're of a very scientific frame of mind, everything has to be measurable. Even with something like homeopathy, they can't understand it. There's nothing in the medicine, so it's all hocus-pocus to them.

You might say, 'Well, if it's true medicine — if it really is true medicine — it'll work whether you believe it or not. It's like an aspirin. Whether you believe it or not, it'll work.' So I say, have a go. But they say, 'No, no, don't go near it.' There's a block. Just don't go near it.

There are three things you can obviously be sceptical of. First is the actual teaching of the Buddha. When we feel sceptical about that, always remember that the Buddha never put it to us as some sort of belief statement. It was always something for us to investigate, to make our own knowledge. That's why we have these three levels of understanding: the understanding we get when we hear something, the understanding when we think about what we've heard and it becomes our own intellectual knowledge, and the third is understanding through insight meditation — through direct experience.

In the Buddha's understanding, that is the process of liberation. Belief is a stopper. You just don't investigate; you just bow to the Buddha-rūpa, and that's the end of that. But he'll still end up with you. He's not going to do much for your hindrances or your insight.

Then there's doubt in the teacher — heaven forbid. I can't imagine it, but there can be. Actually, it's a healthy thing to always question what the teacher is saying. Again, it's not to be taken as gospel, but one tries it. One tries it.

I remember one of my teachers, the main teacher, said to me, 'What meditation did you do before?' I said, 'Zen.' He said, 'Well, they don't meditate.' I said, 'They don't meditate, Sayadaw? Why is that?' He said, 'Because they keep their eyes

open.' And I said, 'Hmm. Well, we keep our ears open.' Dead silence. It's prejudice. You don't have to believe what a teacher says to you. But it's good to try things out. And if it doesn't work, well, yeah. If you find there isn't that connection, well, yeah.

But the one I think is most pernicious is doubt in oneself. One begins to lose confidence in oneself. Often, when a person's been meditating for a long time and they don't see much progress, this comes up. But usually they've taken a very short-term view, and when you actually ask them to look back over the years to where they were when they first started, they can normally see the progress. Everybody I've talked to who's experienced this sees progress. It's just never progressive enough, that's all. We're not expected to be fully liberated by now. Just see what our presumptions are, really.

Remember that the path isn't one direct upward slope. It's up and down, up and down. But every so often you get to a hill, you can look back and see that the hills you've climbed are lower than where you are now. You haven't gone down. When you feel that lack of confidence — getting nowhere, what's the point, all that sort of stuff — again, just name it. Give it its true name: sceptical doubt.

That's our task anyway. That's what we're working with on the negative side. Everything we've been talking about, of course, is what therapy tries to deal with. In a sense, the way we're dealing with this not only brings us spiritual understanding, which is the true liberation; it's also helping the heart to purify itself.

Sometimes when you listen to certain teachers, you get the impression that Vipassanā isn't enough — that you've got to have therapy. In fact, I know certain teachers who say exactly that. And I dare say there are people for whom walking straight into meditation would be just too much. But I think the main reason for that is lack of faith. It's not our culture to be Buddhist. It's not our culture to have that absolute faith in the teacher. And if you don't have that faith, of course, it undermines everything you do. I think that's one reason anyway.

I dare say there are certain things Buddhism doesn't tackle particularly well — like madness. There's not much in Buddhism, at least in Theravāda Buddhism, about how to deal with madness. Frankly, that's done by local shamans, by the local culture. The ancient cultures are usually better at dealing with that than Buddhist monks anyway.

But for the ordinary person with our usual little neuroses and stuff, it's not that therapy won't help — it does, and I think some therapies are very skilful — but it's not necessary. In my own personal practice, I never had any therapy. Childhood traumas came up. Two childhood traumas cleared out of the heart. This is exactly what Freud talks about: these traumas, deeply hidden within the psyche, causing all these whirlpools on the surface, which you're dealing with, not recognising that there's some deeper disease underneath.

But it wasn't easy, that's all. It's not easy to really squeeze a boil — get your thumbs into the side and give it a real squeeze till it pops. What I'm saying is that no, you don't actually need therapy. A lot of these modern therapies are very skilful, very helpful. And complementary. Most of them are complementary.

So that's it. That's what you're tackling, and it's up to us to develop our skills. This is one side of the skills of meditation that we're developing. I can only hope my words have been of some assistance.

May you, in your wise tackling of the hindrances, overcome them, allow them to dissipate, and achieve a full purification of the heart and liberation — sooner rather than later.

Overcoming Thīna-middha: Understanding Dullness and Lethargy

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 20 min

Originally given as *Overcoming Thīna-middha: Understanding Dullness and Lethargy* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this practical dharma talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines thīna-middha, traditionally translated as sloth and torpor but understood phenomenologically as dullness in the head and lethargy in the body. Drawing from the Buddha's advice to his chief disciple Moggallāna, he explores the pernicious nature of this often-overlooked hindrance and its impact on both meditation practice and daily life energy.

Bhante distinguishes between temporary dullness (a state) and clinical depression (a trait), offering specific techniques for working with drowsiness: changing focus, physical adjustments like opening the eyes or pulling earlobes, walking meditation, and mindful investigation of the dull sensations themselves. He emphasizes the connection between restlessness and lethargy as expressions of the same dysregulated energy, sharing practical methods for lifting awareness from the feet upward through the body.

The talk addresses common causes including overeating, oversleeping, and boredom, while stressing the importance of recognizing life's urgency as an antidote to spiritual complacency. Through personal anecdotes and traditional teachings, this session provides essential guidance for maintaining the energetic awareness necessary for vipassanā practice.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

This month, I thought I'd have a go at dullness and lethargy. It used to be called sloth and torpor, which are, of course, moral views of these states. Sloth is also listed among the seven deadly sins of the Christian tradition. You'll know them all: pride, avarice, lust, envy, gluttony, anger and sloth. These days, we tend to use

gentler phenomenological titles and call them how we feel them. We feel them as dullness in the head and lethargy in the body. And of course, cognitive science always comes up with its own little definitions: arousal dysregulation. When you feel very dull and lazy and all that, you can say, oh, this is just arousal dysregulation.

The Pali term is *thīna-middha*. *Thīna* refers to this dullness in the head, and *middha* refers to heaviness or physical torpor.

I don't think we put enough accent on this hindrance. The others, everybody knows about—sensual desire and ill will, anger and all that. We know about restlessness, and we know about remorse and guilt and shame. Doubt often comes up for us. But I don't think we realise how pernicious dullness and lethargy is.

How does it come about, this dullness and lethargy? Consider certain situations. Sunday morning. You wake up nice and warm in bed and it's absolutely wonderful. You think, I'll just roll over and roast the other side for a moment. You don't need it, but it's just a lovely thing to disappear into this sweet oblivion—especially when it's subliminal, when you're not quite asleep but not quite awake. It just feels very lovely. Well, of course, that's really bad energy. Everything we do creates physical or mental energy, and this energy is one that pulls us down.

Then there are occasions when we feel a bit bored, or a bit upset, or a bit depressed. We think, oh, and we get on the sofa and disappear, or throw ourselves under the duvet. One way or another we just get rid of ourselves. It's a sort of soft suicide. But it takes an effort. You have to do it. There has to be this intention to disappear, and there's an energy that makes you do that. When it comes up in meditation or in ordinary daily life, you just get this dullness in your head and this heaviness in the body. It's just a bad habit, that's all.

There was an arahant in Burma called Sun Lun, and he attained full liberation at record Olympic speed. It seems he was a clerk in an office, and he met someone who taught him breathing meditation. But what they taught him was this very heavy, fast breathing—you can find it on YouTube, S-U-N-L-U-N. He just did this practice, and within something like six months, he'd made it. Then he began to teach the system. He was asked, why is it that people—I mean, you did it at this express speed. How is it people don't? And he said, it's because they're lazy. There we are. That's coming from an arahant.

The problem with dullness and lethargy is that it expresses itself as a sort of apathy, an unwillingness to do something. I can't be bothered. Boredom sinks in. It really has a long effect on us in terms of our attitude in daily life.

You have to be careful not to confuse dullness with depression. In meditation, or in ordinary daily life when you feel dull or heavy in the body, it's normally just a state—it comes and goes. But depression is a trait. It's with you a lot of the time. In posture, dullness improves with lifting the energy. If you feel drowsy, there are a few things you can do: open your eyes, let the light in, lift your body up, put more energy in it, and it will normally dissipate. The other thing, of course, is to sink into the feeling and just be with it and investigate its qualities—the softness of it, the tingliness of it. You'd be surprised how it feels when you drop into the body. Sometimes if you're dull in the head and you just wake up, as it were, and investigate this porridge in the head, you'd be surprised. You wake up like a light bulb. It's quite remarkable. But if it's depression, it's a mood. It just doesn't move. You have to be careful not to confuse those two. And if you do think that you are depressed, then obviously you might need some help.

The Buddha himself addressed this with his early disciples. Moggallāna and Sāriputta were brahmins who became his two chief disciples. Moggallāna went to him for advice about dullness and lethargy, and the Buddha gave these sorts of suggestions. Change the focus, he says—put your attention on something that's going to raise your energy. In his terms, it could be reflecting on the dhamma. You can even do some chanting, just something to lift the energy. He also suggests that you pull your earlobes. You can always try that. If you really press your fingers in, it really hurts. In the old days, that's what your parents used to get hold of, just to wake you up. Then there's light, of course—I've mentioned opening the eyes and letting the light in. And then he says, oh, and walking meditation, of course. You can always do that.

In ordinary daily life, remember that after you've eaten, even if it's the right amount, if it's carbohydrates, the body produces a chemical that makes you feel drowsy, wanting you to spend some time resting in order to digest. But you have to be careful that you don't give in to the sleepiness of it, that's all. If you are overcome by sleepiness after you've eaten, you might be eating too much. And then the Buddha says, when all that fails, he talks about mindful rest—to actually rest and try something like the yoga nidra, just to relax without actually losing consciousness.

One thing you can do if you feel sleepy is to remind yourself of the urgency of the situation. Every morning we wake up and I'm sure we are absolutely sure that we will live the whole day. But there's nothing certain about that at all. We can drop dead any time, or we could be caught up in an accident, or fall off a cliff. Who knows? It's getting that feel that we're living on this knife edge, and that brings a sense of urgency of wanting to really bring the practice into daily life. Sometimes you can bring inspiring teachers to mind, or teachings to mind.

Dullness and lethargy is one of the hindrances, and I think we have to take it quite seriously. In my own practice, I've spent hours dealing with it. At one point, it used to last for ten days—I'd just walk around in this fog.

There was a lovely occasion in a meditation room in Malaysia, when I was working with Sayadaw U Pandita. Everybody was getting up at half past three, of course. The diligent ones, if they were falling asleep during meditation, were doing walking meditation at the back of the hall. The lights were quite low. We're all sitting there. And then there's this hell-raising crash, glass breaking—it sounded terrible. This poor meditator, a monk or a nun, had walked straight into a glass picture. That's how dull you can get. He wasn't hurt, but it was a funny occasion.

I think we've covered all those areas. But I'd like to leave you with something I haven't said for a very long time. Recognise that we were most probably conceived on a bed and probably born on a bed. We spend a third of our lives in bed. When we're sick, we go to bed, and we'll probably die in a bed. It's good to remember that the bed is probably the most dangerous place on earth. Just stay with that. Every time you look at the bed, think of it as the pit—so that you actually regulate how much you're falling asleep. Because any oversleep creates this bad energy, this downer.

On a final note, there's a connection between restlessness and dullness. Often in your meditation, you'll be quite restless and then suddenly find yourself dozing. And sometimes you're feeling very dull and unenergetic and suddenly you become restless. As I experience it, it's the same energy—one's coming up and the other's going down. One trick when you're feeling dull is to start from the feet and just bring your attention up the body, feeling things, exploring. But don't go down; start again at the feet and keep coming up. That, for me anyway, has an effect of lifting the energy.

Very good. I can only hope my words have been of some assistance, and that by your diligent practice—never falling into the error of dullness and lethargy—you will be liberated from all suffering sooner rather than later.

The Seven Factors of Awakening

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 38 min

Originally given as *The Seven Factors of Awakening* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this teaching from a 2011 Gaia House retreat, Bhante Bodhidhamma presents the seven factors of awakening (bojjhaṅga) as the natural qualities that support insight meditation. He explains how these seven factors - sati (awareness), dhammavicaya (investigation of dharma), vīriya (effort), pīti (joy/interest), passaddhi (tranquility), samādhi (concentration), and upekkhā (equanimity) - work together in perfect balance to enable spiritual realization.

The talk emphasizes the crucial distinction between mere belief and the confidence (saddhā) needed for genuine investigation. Bhante explores the three stages of wisdom - received knowledge, intellectual understanding, and direct realization - showing how vipassanā practice moves us from conceptual learning to experiential knowing. He offers practical guidance on balancing effort and concentration, using the Buddha's simile of tuning a stringed instrument - neither too tight nor too slack.

Drawing from the Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta, Bhante shows how establishing Right Awareness naturally manifests all seven factors. He addresses common meditation difficulties like restlessness from excessive effort and dullness from insufficient energy, offering the Middle Way approach that allows genuine insight to arise. The teaching concludes with inspiring stories demonstrating that awakening depends not on intellectual brilliance but on patient, balanced investigation of the three characteristics of existence.

We began by revising—or for some, being introduced to—the actual technique we're practising. Then we looked at the hindrances, which is the Buddha's way of categorising all those things that take us away from meditation.

These five hindrances are simply a way of looking at what arises in meditation and pulls us away. The idea is that we can see what it is, note it, be clear about it, and know what to do to stop it taking over. We don't want to stop hindrances

arising—that's the purification process—but we definitely don't want to get taken over by them. We want to remain awake within them and actually use them to investigate the three characteristics, especially the characteristic of suffering, dukkha.

Remember, the Buddha points to three types of dukkha. The first is dukkha dukkhata—the suffering of suffering. It's our relationship with suffering that constitutes the suffering, not the original stuff that comes up. I'm sure you're all very clear on that by now: the pain in the knee is not suffering, but our aversion towards it is the actual suffering.

We can prove this to ourselves by finding equanimity with a painful knee. The same applies to our emotional life. We can find a position with our depressions and anxieties and overexcitements—a way of being where it's all carrying on and we're just with it. There's a separation. For most of us, I think, this tends to be 99% of the practice. It's 99% perspiration and 1% inspiration.

Running concurrent with all this, however, are the seven factors of enlightenment, and conjoined with them are the five spiritual faculties. The five and the seven meld into each other.

The spiritual faculties are confidence, effort, awareness, concentration, and wisdom. The seven factors of enlightenment are awareness, effort, concentration, calmness, interest, equanimity, and investigation of the Dharma.

First, let's talk about this faith business. Remember that in Buddhism, faith or confidence is not to be confused with belief. Belief is putting our confidence in a statement to the point where we hold it to be true—and what that obviously does is stop investigation. The whole of the Buddha's path is about self-realisation: in other words, me realising the truth.

If I just repeat the Four Noble Truths—suffering and the origin of suffering, which is desire—then bow to the Buddha statue and think that's it, well, it's an absolute waste of time. Just believing in that sense, the way we believe so many things we don't actually know. We believe, for instance, that the Earth goes round the Sun. It doesn't happen perceptively, does it? Not for me, anyway—the Sun still comes overhead. But I have this absolute belief that we're going round the Sun.

There's a whole load of science I believe, but I don't know if it's true for me or not. I haven't tested any of this stuff. A lot of it we just believe because in a sense it's neither here nor there. Whether the Sun goes round us or we go round the Sun, as long as it's shining that's the important thing. But when it comes to the

Dharma, when it comes to the Buddha's teaching, it is about us realising what he realised. That means we have to go through the very same process he went through.

In that sense he's not just an exemplar—he's the archetype. There's a Buddha within us following that same path. So this faith is more of a confidence, and the confidence is in the teaching.

Wisdom unfolds in three stages. All of us came to this practice by hearing about it first, so it begins as received knowledge. If that interests us, if we're drawn to it, we tend to read a bit more and eventually we think about it. At that point it becomes our own intellectual knowledge. Even if you quote everybody, it doesn't matter—it's your quote from now on. What was received now becomes your knowledge.

I don't know about you, but at one point I was trying to understand relativity theory. I would read it and say to myself, oh yeah—and then I tried to explain it, and it was impossible. I couldn't explain it. There's that gap between thinking you've understood something and actually trying to explain what it is you've understood, when you get all tongue-tied.

Take dependent origination, the Four Noble Truths—could you explain the Four Noble Truths to somebody else? If you can, that means you must have thought about it and you're able to pass on that information. If you can't, it's still at the level of received knowledge. The same applies to all the important teachings around dependent origination, around vipassana—could you introduce somebody to it?

And then of course that isn't enough; it has to be realised. That's where vipassana comes in—the next stage of *paññā*, of wisdom, when you actually perceive it for yourself, actually realise it for yourself. This confidence and this whole process of investigation and realisation are linked.

Obviously if you didn't have confidence you wouldn't go into it, full stop; you'd go into some other form of spiritual practice. That confidence underlies really everything we do—putting faith in the teaching, faith in the tradition, faith in the Buddha. These are called spiritual faculties. They're what enable us to enter the path.

Remember that concentration is a word that tends to make us tight—mainly because of our school days or whatever. Think of it much more as a steadiness of attention. How long can you hold your attention on something? That's what it's referring to. A real steady gaze. How long can you hold it?

These days, because of the enormous amount of information we have to process—computers and iPods and all the rest of it—our concentration tends to be a little bit short, especially, they say, of children. A couple of seconds and that's it, they're off somewhere else. A lot of our practice is to bring us into a state of steadiness of attention.

And the effort we need is just to keep that. That's the only effort required—to keep that attention steady.

Now if the effort is too much, what you get is restlessness. We're presuming here that the meditation is such that the hindrances aren't there for the moment. We're presuming there's clarity in the mind, there's stillness, and there's concentration—this steadiness of attention, a focus.

If something extra comes in apart from just maintaining that steadiness—such as the idea of trying to see, trying to attain, trying to make the focus more focused—then you get this little bit of extra energy which starts shaking it. Before you know it, you find yourself getting quite restless. At worst, if the energy is really over the top, there tends to be a collapse in the meditation.

Some of you might have experienced that, where it just stops. And that's it, really—it's difficult to describe if you haven't experienced it. You basically have to take an afternoon off and start again. It just drops like that, and you can't do it. It's like when you force yourself to run and run and run and eventually the body just stops. That's a telltale to the meditator—they're putting too much effort into it.

On the other hand, if you don't put enough effort, this steadiness of attention drops you into a state of unconsciousness. You'll know it's not sleep because when you fall asleep your body rocks and shakes and you start banging your head on the floor. But with this you're still sitting bolt upright, and anybody walking in the room would say, now there's a meditator—but actually you're just not there. You've gone completely asleep. And depending on the force of that concentration, you can be there for quite some time.

In the Hindu tradition there's a tale of a guru who asks for some water and then enters into this state. Many years afterwards—ten years afterwards—he wakes up and his first words are, where's my water? Nothing's happened for ten years. It's just one of these little tales you get about states of unconsciousness.

There's a place in Chiang Mai, Wat Long Pern, where they teach this Mahasi system. The teacher is a very old man; he doesn't teach himself, but the system's there. You really go at it—this is soft stuff compared to what they'll put you through. Then right towards the end of your three weeks—it's a three-week bash—you're not allowed to sleep. And during those three days, if you have a blackout, they suggest to you that it was Nibbana.

I've always thought that was a bit fishy. In fact, somebody turned up at the meditation centre in Sri Lanka claiming exactly this, and the chief monk asked him, do you think it was Nibbana? The man said, no, I fell asleep. So it's a dodgy one; you have to be careful.

This also tells us something about good sleep. When a person has difficulty sleeping, often the underlying mental state beneath that unconsciousness is restless—it keeps bursting through and waking us up.

That's why the Buddha says if you practise loving-kindness before you sleep, it creates this lovely underlying state. You sleep well. You can do it on the breath if you find that easier. But people often tend to rush around all day, come back, eat, watch TV, and then just launch themselves into bed when it's time. That's no preparation at all. You have to prepare yourself before sleep, wind down at the end of the day—play some sleepy music or something like that. What you're creating is this subliminal level of beautiful mind.

There's the case of a monk—whose name escapes me—who is trying very, very hard, getting nowhere, and decides he's had enough. He's going to return to the lay life, get married, and have a decent time for a change. When the Buddha hears about this, he goes and has a chat with him. He says it's like tuning a string—not too tight and not too slack. You've got to be able to tune the string on an instrument. It would have been a string instrument, the vina. And that's how he describes it: just getting to that point where the effort is just right.

This is all part of our skills of meditation—experimenting within ourselves to get the right level of concentration. Nobody can tell you that. All the Buddha could do was give this monk an example: sometimes it's too much, sometimes it's too

little, you've just got to get it right. We ourselves have to discover our own level of effort, our own level of concentration. And that's part of the practice, part of becoming skilful.

When I started teaching—this is going back to the late 90s really, and even before that I was doing a little bit—I used to teach in the method of my old teacher, Ujanaka. So even on a weekend retreat I had them up at half past three. Get in there, beat them up, sit there, don't move. The room would be filled with this plasma—like they're having in these fusion reactors—everybody sitting there going through this dreadful pain. I used to do these really heavy retreats even for a weekend, because that's what I was brought up to do.

And nobody came back. Only the real hard nuts came back, the bruisers. So I thought, well, something's wrong. I even did it on my first long retreat, when I came to Gaia—I've a lot to thank Gaia for because my four years spent here was really my teacher training college. It was here, just seeing what the other teachers were doing, that I recognised maybe this was a bit of the wrong tack.

Because frankly, of all the people I remember from those days—and you hardly remember people—when the Mahasis came in the late 70s, a retreat would have 100, 150 people. In those days the men and women were all separated, the Eastern way. The men's side was chock-a-block, knee against knee, and the women were just up here, a few. We'd be looking over thinking, why can't we... And I don't remember them. I don't think any of them actually ever came back. Very few that I remember.

I got to Burma once and there were five or six of us, and I often wonder what happened to them, whether they're even still practising. I know one person gave up and came to see me. I'd just ordained in Birmingham, and it was this push—push, push, trying to get the passing, that insight. He came to see me and I hadn't seen him for about four or five years. That year he'd spent ten thousand pounds on crack, as he told me. This was an ardent meditator.

Too much effort, and then that sense of failure. Within that, you give up, really. Mind you, in those days there tended to be the erroneous idea that you went at it for six months, and then it was sex, drugs, and rock and roll for the next six. Then you went to Burma to do a bit more headbanging. It never did get people very far, really.

So I began to reflect on this—on the way Westerners put tremendous effort into things compared to certain Eastern cultures. And I began to stress the other two factors: interest and calmness. People returned. This was a great breakthrough for me.

Interest here is that fundamental curiosity that arises with intelligence. You see it with birds, you see it with all creatures that have some form of consciousness we can conceive for ourselves.

Here's a little story to show you just how intelligent other creatures can be. We think we're the only species that plays with other species—we play with dogs and cats. But I was at Kanduboda once, waiting in line for a meal, and the place was always full of dogs and crows. They used to just put the food out on the ground. It's all gone now, a bit cleaner these days.

There was a little pup chewing away at some rice. A crow jumped towards it and bit its tail. The dog turned around, and the crow bounced back. The dog went back to eating. The crow jumped forward, bit its tail again. The dog turned around. And I thought, well, that's very clever—the crow wants the rice.

So the crow went a third time, the dog turned, and then just walked away, fed up with it. And the crow—I swear—looked longingly after the little pup and then flew away. When you see things like that, you think, well, a crow could become fully liberated.

So this curiosity is just a fundamental quality of intelligence. And the word interest, I think, gets across the idea that it's joyful. In the list of seven factors of enlightenment, you'll see the Pali word *pīti*. This *pīti* is also associated with the absorptions we've been talking about—it means a pure mental state of happiness. But here, it's the joy that arises when you're interested in something.

Think about it—the times when you've really been interested in doing something, it's been full of joy. Now, even that interest can become too interested. It can take on this business of wanting to know too much. And that's why it's balanced with calmness.

The final factor is equanimity, paired with *dhammavicaya*. In the standing meditation I did at the beginning, I was trying to point out this quality. Equanimity means coming from a place of don't know, a place of not sure, as if this is the first time we've ever done it. The beginner's mind, as Zen would say.

It's also not an emotional involvement. It's not coming from a prejudicial place. These two aspects describe this even-mindedness—that's another way of putting equanimity. Unfortunately, both the word equanimity and even-mindedness put the accent too much upon thought, but it's also an emotional state. A calm, even emotional state.

In a sense, it's the qualities you would expect of a judge. You don't want the judge to get caught up in the clever arguments of lawyers, and you don't want them to get caught up in the baying of the crowd—hang them! You want them to keep equanimous, above it all. And this allows us to investigate the Dhamma.

Investigating the Dhamma simply means examining the three characteristics, the five defilements, the five hindrances we've been talking about, the four noble truths. It can be anything that leads to understanding, and understanding to liberation.

Now if there's not that equanimity there, what we tend to do is look for something we've already conceived. And the mind is very clever, remember. Even though we've heard about these words *nibbāna* and all that sort of stuff, unwittingly we can be searching for this sort of experience. We can have some idea of what it means to be a stream-enterer. And things like that. What that does is distort the looking.

With expectation of that sort, even if it's quite unconscious, there arises a certain disappointment—disappointment that it's not happening. There arises a feeling that you can't get it because you've got this ideal in your head about what a spiritual insight is or where you should be. Again, that leads to discouragement, to giving up the path.

And if unfortunately you do see what you've conceived, then surely you're deluded. You've simply manifested what you wanted. I had one lovely experience with a man at the centre. He came back and said he'd had this amazing experience—believe it or not, while he sat on the toilet. Now if you remember, Luther also had his great insight while evacuating. Those are moments of relief and release, remember. So one can expect to have amazing insight on the pot.

Anyway, he came back and described it to me. It was obviously a lovely mental state, but from his description it was equally obvious that it wasn't what he thought it was. There was no way he was going to believe it wasn't *nibbāna*, though. He was utterly convinced he'd had this experience, and that was that.

What happens to such a person? Well, they might stop investigating. They might think, 'That's it—why should I carry on practising?' There's always this problem: when we have an experience, we overestimate it. And the overestimation often comes from some preconceived idea of what a spiritual insight should be.

Generally speaking, if we have an insight, we might go to a teacher and describe it, and they might explain it and put it into context. But the real spiritual progress is that as you go along, your next insight throws light on the one you had before. Eventually a balance comes about what you feel you've experienced and what you haven't.

It's best not to decide. If you have an experience, you can certainly say what it was—that's not a problem. But rating it can be the problem. It's best simply not to rate it, but to accept it and say to yourself: this is what I experienced, and this is what I've come to understand.

What we've come to understand ought to affect us systemically. It's no good going around saying you had this amazing experience of interconnectedness and then going around shooting everybody. Interconnectedness, when it falls systemically into the heart, expresses itself as love. And that's what love is, isn't it? It's the heart's connectedness with all beings. If it doesn't do that, then it's just been a head thing—not a real spiritual experience. That's the difference.

Now, you'll notice that everybody has all these factors. The only thing that turns them into factors of enlightenment is dhammavicaya—investigating the Dhamma. Everybody's got concentration and calmness and interest and effort and confidence in one way or another. But it's actually getting all those qualities and placing them into this sort of investigation that brings about spiritual insights.

When we begin meditating, when we sit like this, we're trying to manifest these factors both mentally and physically. Physically, you're calming and stilling the body. Mentally, you're calming the heart and silencing the mind. And you're finding a position within yourself as the objective observer.

Nyanaponika, in his very good book *The Heart of Buddhist Meditation*, calls it the observation post. It's like a crow's nest on a ship—you find a particular place. As you move to that place, as you withdraw into it, all the factors of enlightenment are there in the looking.

That's why awareness is the governing factor. Everything I've said this evening is virtually a complete waste of time, because if you centred the whole of your effort just on this awareness, all the faculties would come up to support it. It's a natural movement of these faculties to support that awareness. That's why we always start with the breath and establishing mindfulness on the breath.

Remember, what we're talking about is this *sati-paññā*, this awareness-intuitive faculty within us. Some traditions call it Buddha nature. What it's trying to do is abstract itself, to bring itself out of this morass of the psychophysical organism. As it does so and finds this place where it can observe body, heart, and mind, it is pure awareness at that point.

And it's when the light goes on—when the intelligence awakens—that all these factors are already there in the looking. That's why we can have all these factors present even when there's enormous restlessness, enormous dullness, the mind expressing itself, the heart emoting. Yet you can maintain this poise.

We get there through the practice of, first of all, quieting the body and slowly raising ourselves up to the level of the objective observer. Perfectly clear. Our practice is to get always into that position of the observation post. Once we're there, all the factors must be there. That's basically our practice—that's what we're constantly trying to do. And once it's there, this intelligence, this curiosity, is able to investigate.

In investigating what it sees—what it's experiencing out there in the mind, in the heart—this awareness slowly begins to realise its own nature. That's why the noting word is so powerful: it pushes things away from us, makes us look at them as objects. And through this process, awareness comes to know itself.

Among these seven factors, you'll see some are passive and some are active—that quality of the feminine and the masculine. Eventually we ourselves begin to develop both qualities within us, and their balance. What holds that balance is awareness.

On the more passive side, you have concentration, calmness, and equanimity. On the active side, you have effort, interest, and investigation. These must be absolutely balanced for insight to come.

One of our dangers, now that we know all this, is to start worrying about whether our interest is high enough. That's why I say: abandon all that completely. Forget you've heard a word. Just put your whole effort into this moment-to-moment awareness. It's enough.

That's what the Buddha says in the Discourse on How to Establish Mindfulness. He says, start by observing the breath, contacting the body in the breath, knowing it's long or short, coarse or fine. As you keep watching, you train yourself on that until the body becomes a bit calmer, the heart's calm, the mind is still.

Then you begin to observe. By now you've found this observation post. You begin to observe the quality of impermanence—the beginning and end of each breath. And the Buddha says, just keep doing this until there is enough awareness and enough intelligence, this intuitive intelligence, for insight to arise.

Essentially, the practice is very simple. Very simple indeed. It doesn't take a great big intellect. Remember the story of the monk who was so dull that when he learned a phrase of the Buddha's teachings—because in those days nothing was written, it was all learned by rote—when he learned a new phrase, it knocked the previous one out of his head.

His brother said he was just too dull to be a monk and had better go back to lay life. When the Buddha heard this, he went to see him and gave him a very simple exercise: a clean cloth. He said, just rub it and wipe the sweat from your face, and keep saying, 'impermanent, impermanent.' Before long, the monk was fully liberated. It didn't work for me.

The Buddha has a special insight into where you are. This story is told to show that you don't need intellect. As opposed to that, there's a story in the commentary about a monk who's extremely clever—a real scholar and expert. All his students become liberated. Then he starts thinking to himself, how is it that I'm the teacher and all these students of mine are liberated, but I'm not?

He goes to see them. One after another, they see this fellow is just too intellectually conceited. Each one says, 'Well, I'm not really the one to help you. Why don't you go and see so-and-so?' He went all the way down the line until finally they gave him to a child. That was very humiliating, but he thought, well, we'll have a go.

The child took him to an anthill. When ants move out of their anthills, snakes live in them—it becomes a snake's home. The child said, 'Supposing this anthill had six holes and you wanted to get the snake out, what would you do?' The teacher said, 'Well, you'd just stop up five holes and it would have to come out from the sixth.'

The child said, 'That's what you've got to do. Stop the five senses and everything comes out through the mind. And observe.' They went away, and in no length of time—fully liberated.

May you, through wise reflection and excellent development of the seven factors of awakening, arrive at that wonderful place—nibbāna—sooner rather than later.

Developing the Factors of Enlightenment

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 46 min

Originally given as *Developing the Factors of Enlightenment* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this dharma talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma provides detailed guidance on cultivating the seven bojjhaṅgas (factors of awakening) through vipassanā meditation practice. He leads practitioners through a step-by-step meditation exercise, demonstrating how each factor—sati (awareness), dhammavicaya (investigation of dharma), vīriya (energy), pīti (joy), passaddhi (tranquillity), samādhi (concentration), and upekkhā (equanimity)—naturally supports the others when properly established.

The talk emphasizes that these factors are not special qualities reserved for advanced practitioners, but natural human capacities that can be developed through gentle, sustained effort. Bhante explains how negative mental patterns like depression are cultivated through repetition, and similarly, positive spiritual faculties can be strengthened through mindful practice. He distinguishes between mental states (citta) and levels of consciousness, showing how vipassanā creates an observational stance that prevents identification with passing phenomena.

Drawing from the Buddha's core insight that delusion lies within our way of seeing rather than in thoughts or emotions themselves, Bhante guides practitioners to investigate the three characteristics of existence directly. The teaching concludes with practical advice on maintaining these factors during daily life, emphasizing that true achievement in meditation is simply being aware in the present moment.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble, and fully self-enlightened one.

Make sure you're comfortable. Always begin your meditation by creating at least that physical comfort. Start by checking that your basic posture is comfortable, then lift up the spine without any tension. From there, just begin to physically relax around it.

Pass your attention over your forehead, your jaw, your shoulders, and feel that relaxation coming. If there are any spots that are tense, like the shoulders, give them a squeeze. If you feel a lot of tension in the face, screw it up and let it go. Sometimes a deep breath helps—just hold it for a little while, then let it go.

Now, as you scan your body and feel the whole of it, you may notice a calmness there. That calmness is *passaddhi*—one of the factors of enlightenment. It can become quite delicious, that sense of calm.

Having established that at a basic physical level, we can now bring the attention to the breath, becoming aware of its sensations. You can do this at the nostrils, but with this sort of exercise, you can also contact the abdomen—just the rising and falling, just the sensations there. Get in touch with them, feel them, experience them as if you were feeling cloth.

What you're bringing to that is awareness, which is the leading factor of enlightenment. As you begin to become aware of those sensations—those gentle feelings, calm *passaddhi* feelings, the rising and falling of the abdomen—use a little noting word just to keep the mind steady: rising, falling. And if there's a gap after that out-breath, feel a touch point like your hands. Rising, falling, touching.

As you contact these sensations, these feelings, go closer to them, as it were. Get the feeling of focusing in. It's a gentle thing. If you're knitting your brow and forcing it, that's putting pressure. You're just looking and focusing. It's like you're looking at a countryside and in the distance you see something—suddenly your eyes stop and focus in on that object. Get that feeling of focusing down into the breath.

That's the concentration. And all the effort you need is just to keep that focus in and hold it there. In the old cameras you had to turn the lens to focus it; now it's done by electric motor. The effort, the gentle effort, just focusing in on the object—these are two factors of enlightenment.

As you focus in on the object, other things begin to fade into the distance, as it were. You become less aware of sounds, of other feelings in the body. All this is a sign that you're beginning to concentrate on the object. You can see it's very much a relaxation—just drawing your attention more and more particularly into the sensations and feelings caused by the breath.

Now we have a general calmness and awareness. We know what's going on. We can see, feel, and experience the breath. There's a general focusing down and an energy to support it. Now we bring in the factor of investigating the dhamma,

which means we don't just focus on the feelings and sensations, but on the quality of impermanence, transience, change, process. Become aware of that now. This is the quality of investigating the dhamma.

This is supported by the quality of equanimity, which means we're not coming from a fixed position, some expectation, some idea. We actually want to experience the arising and passing away—first of all, of the gross long breath: the beginning and the end of the in-breath, the beginning and the end of the out-breath. And we can say, yes, the in-breath begins and ends. The out-breath begins and ends. Very simple.

As we draw our attention to that, you might feel a sort of joy, a delicate energy in the body—and that's the interest. Now we've raised that wanting to know, a childlike curiosity. Am I really seeing things as they really are? Or am I just seeing a concept in the mind, an image in the mind? Hopefully now you're actually moving towards pure vipassanā.

As you observe the breath, you might notice there's an image in the mind of the abdomen rising and falling—even an idea that something is rising and falling. These are mental concepts, mental constructs. Focus more deeply into just the sensations themselves.

As we go through these qualities, remember that all of this rests upon trust, upon faith—*saddhā*—which is a spiritual faculty. We wouldn't be here if we didn't have that initial confidence. When that confidence goes—and the usual loss of confidence is in oneself: everybody else can do it but not me—when you get that wavering, that doubt about your own capacity, that's when you have to remind yourself that these qualities are natural to all human beings, just there within us. It's not as though they're special qualities belonging to someone who's a Buddha or already spiritually advanced. Once a child's over the age of seven, you can talk them into this sort of state. It's easy, any time before puberty. After that it gets very complicated.

These qualities are simply to be developed, just like any other mental quality we have. We're very good at developing the negative qualities—we've learned how to do that very well. You feel something, you start whinging. You know how to do that. You whinge. You know that sound with the whinge. And you just develop it. And at the end you become a whinger.

If you look at all these negative qualities we've developed, all the irritations—it's the same with depression. You feel a bit depressed, so you say to yourself, I'm depressed. Then you go around saying, it's really depressing. Everything's depressing. And then you start saying, subtly underneath it all: I am a depressive. May I be depressed. And then you want to spread that out. May all beings be depressed. Then you feel you're in communion. You look for other depressives.

I once went to a Depressives Anonymous meeting. A bit sad, really. They're all sat around in this circle, and the leader said, like, everybody who'd like to, just speak out. It's like one of these counselling sessions. How do you feel? So everybody told everybody else how depressed they were. Everybody said, yeah, really depressing. And I was getting depressed.

Then there was one fellow who said he'd had a fantastic week. You could see he was on a high, he was manic, lifting himself up. So everybody was looking at him.

And then there was this lovely, lovely moment where the leader of the group said, well, I've had a very good week. I was doing very well, keeping high. It's all the experience of talking yourself into this high. And then I tripped over a pavement. So I wrote to the council and said, I've just tripped over your pavement and I've hurt myself, and I asked for compensation. Well, they wrote back and said there was no compensation for that. So I felt really angry about that. And now I'm depressed.

It's amazing. I was sat there thinking, hmm. So at the end of it, I gave this talk on how we make ourselves depressed. It was funny. I said, well, I teach over in North London—I think I was teaching at the Vihara at the time. There's only a tube ride, so about seven or eight of the twenty-odd people in the room came over to see me, and they all determined they'd learn this meditation so they wouldn't get so depressed.

Well, they never turned up. I just presumed they got so depressed they couldn't come and see me. I left that meeting feeling very sad, because they were obviously trying to help themselves. There was nothing immoral or wrong about it. It just hadn't clicked. They hadn't understood how they were continuously recreating the same old scenes and driving themselves deeper and deeper into depression. Anyway, after a while I heard that the money ran out and they had to stop the meetings. They must have gotten really depressed. Very unfortunate. Very depressing.

So here you can see that through practices like mettā, you can develop quite the opposite. Now, if you develop mettā—loving-kindness, compassion, all those sorts of things—but you don't develop the vipassanā, then you're laying over the top of your mind like a manic. You're laying over it this sort of icing, like icing on top of dung. And when it cracks, all this stuff comes pouring out. Very depressing.

So here, in the vipassanā, we're actually trying to create a level of consciousness. Don't confuse that with a mental state. I'm using mental state to mean a general state: the physical feelings that go with depression, for instance, the heart state, the depression in the heart, and the thoughts that go with that depression—all that I'm calling a mental state. This is, in the Pāli for those of you who know, citta.

Now, to associate with that, to identify with that, to go around saying I am depressed—that is a level of consciousness. Because there, you believe yourself to be that state. There's no separation between me and that. I am depressed. It's there in the sentence. The I and the depression are one and the same thing.

Now, what we're doing in meditation is this: we have the same feelings as anybody who's depressed. You've got the sensations, you've got the heart feelings, and you've got the mental thinking that goes with it. But now you're observing it. You become an observer of your own inner state. So you must have pulled yourself out. You're no longer identifying with it, no longer saying 'I am depressed'—you're saying 'there's depression.' That's it. Can you see that's a very different way of relating to ourselves? It's a different level of consciousness. Remember the image I gave you this morning: a cone on top of the cone, looking down on this vicious circle.

So now what we discover is that we can develop beautiful mental states. We do that with pleasurable things like ice cream and such. But here, when we develop these states, they're dependent on something within ourselves—not on something outside. The weather can be awful. There can be no ice cream. There can be no tea. And yet you can develop these beautiful mental states just by this inner exercise. Yeah?

All you have to do is keep gently, gently pushing yourself. Just gently. When I say push, it's against the grain. The grain wants you to fall asleep, get tired, go to bed, take a walk, jump up and down, beans on toast. So when you go against that, it feels like you don't want to do it. But as you keep doing it and these beautiful

feelings start arising—the calmness, the sense of joy, the wanting to know—then all your energy begins to move that way. And very slowly, these factors of enlightenment are becoming developed.

The Buddha says they have to be developed to perfection. And the perfection is when you start having insights. So when it comes to all the negative stuff—these five hindrances we've mentioned, the greed, the hatred, all that sort of stuff—you have to see how they arise and how they pass away, and how they are not maintained. You've got to see that process. That's the vipassanā: insight on these negative states as they arise.

On the other side, you've got to see: now this is a spiritual faculty, this is a factor of enlightenment, this has to be developed. The acuteness of awareness, the sense of one-pointedness in the mind that we call concentration—that word is unfortunate for us because it goes back to school, people giving us cuffs on the back of the head and telling us to concentrate. But actually, when you're interested in something, when you're really interested, have you ever had any problems with concentration? So it's raising that interest, that wanting to know, and immediately you get that focus. Immediately the mind comes into ekaggatā. Ekaggatā means going one way. It's not coming here and there. One-pointed is probably a much better word for us than concentration. A one-pointed attention.

It all begins with this factor of sati, this awareness, which is essentially the Buddha mind. It's essentially that Buddha nature within us. Sati. It knows. There is this knowing. Its quality is knowing. In English we have this facility of making a verb into a noun, so we can say 'the knowing.' If you say 'consciousness,' it blocks it into an object. Whereas if you think of 'knowing' or 'the awakening,' it gives you the sense of process. It's not something—it's a faculty, an ability.

As you place your awareness on the breath—you always begin with that to create these faculties—there is that raising of interest. I've done it slightly differently, but you can do it another way. You can raise the interest by saying, 'Oh, let's see this. What is this? What is this?' You can drop a question in there. 'What is this? Who am I?' It doesn't matter, but you don't think about it. You just stay in that emptiness after the question. 'What is this?' And then you look.

As you focus down, all the peripheral stuff begins to fade away. You can become so centred on the breath that you don't hear anything. And then suddenly somebody coughs, and you can be shocked out of your meditation. Now, you might want to kill the person, but that's a good sign to you that you were fairly

concentrated. There'll even come a point where you're so concentrated that somebody coughs, fires a gun, and you won't hear it. Because you've brought yourself down into this singularity.

Now, that's an effort. That's all the effort you need to become awakened. Just that. Just that of looking. Just like in the body, all the effort you need is to keep the spine erect. You can get away with just breakfast. If you just have breakfast and meditate all day, within seven years—see, the effort needed is a very gentle effort. If any force comes in, if you feel that forcing, something's getting in there. You're trying to see.

As soon as the trying to see comes in, there's the I. It's looking for something. As soon as you know that, as soon as you get the tightness—you stay with the body, you can feel the tightness coming—then you know: stop. Wanting to see something. That's not like just looking at something. What we should be doing is just looking at. And have faith. Have faith that if you look at something, there will be a seeing.

This is the Buddha. He says, first of all, just look at something. And the insight arises naturally. For instance, if your car breaks down and you open the bonnet, first you look, don't you? If you go to the bonnet with preconceived ideas as to what's happened, you can be looking for a long time. But a trained mechanic—they know what they're looking for. They open the bonnet and they see. Same with the doctor. So it's a case of training ourselves to see these three characteristics.

With something neutral like the breath, it's always the sense of transience. Always the sense of something arising and passing away. It can also be the sense of that distance—not me, not mine—that you can get. But remember that's only a first position. Once you've created that objective stance, you go towards the object, investigate it. Concentration is better developed when you draw up the interest of wanting to know. You'll see there's a natural focusing in on the object. And just that effort of wanting to know—that's enough. You don't have to go beyond that.

Now, as you do that, the calmness in the body supports you. That calmness balances the joy that comes from interest. Sometimes, if the calmness goes a bit too far, that's when you begin to get feelings of heaviness, sloth, torpor—there's too much of it. When you feel that, you just lift the spine, correct your view, and raise

the interest. The interest will raise the energy of wanting to know. But if you start looking for something, if the interest overreaches itself, then you find yourself getting restless. All these are little pointers to what's happening within us.

It's that sense of general awareness, being aware of anything that's happening, and then slowly moving towards the object. Now, we've been primed, and this is where the faith comes in. What we've understood from the Buddha's teaching is that the delusion lies within the looking. It doesn't lie within thought—thought is only an expression of our delusion. It doesn't lie within the emotional life—that's only an expression of our delusion. The delusion lies deep within that which is looking. It can't see properly. There's a kink in the way it sees things. And what the Buddha points out is that this kink manifests in these three characteristics.

Where there is real radical impermanence, we have a sense of continuous time. But actually there's no such thing as time in any continuous sense. Time is just the way the mind relates events or experiences a sequence of moments. How long is a moment in time? Is it as long as the word 'time'? It's a bit longer than 'time'. How long do you actually experience a piece of time for? Interesting, isn't it? At some point we lose the present. It suddenly becomes the past. Yet this present is long enough for us to believe that it's the same person moving through time.

We've got this idea that time is like a tunnel or something, and we're moving through it. So the past somehow exists in a way, and the future exists because we're going towards it. But actually, nothing in any essence exists. When you get down to the actual moment as it arises and passes away, it's just a sudden coagulation of energy—and it dissipates, it's gone.

That's why when you keep watching the breath, eventually you'll get down to a point where there's no breath. All there is is a sequence of arising and falling away of sensations. Which is frightening. Because before, you thought you existed. And this existence was based on your experience of your body, your emotions, your thoughts. So it's beginning to perceive that.

The process is undoing, undermining all our concepts about who we are and what we are. We believe we're human beings. This is a big mistake. If the word 'being' means anything beyond the present moment, it's a big mistake. Because at some point, the body of the human being will be as lifeless as a useless log, it says in the scripture. It'll just lie there, totally lifeless. Somebody will pick it up and chuck it in a hole.

Whatever we mean when I say, 'I am a human being'—if you go into that as an investigation, there's not much there, is there? Investigating that is to begin to realise that this self we've constructed is a delusion. It doesn't exist.

By observing the quality of transience, by observing that quality of not me, not mine, we're undoing these essential misunderstandings we have. Now, if this were to lead us just to annihilation—just to the fact that there was nothing there anyway, and that's the end of that, and when you die you disappear—then that would be depressing. But what the Buddha's saying is that as you begin to perceive what you are not, what you truly are becomes more and more obvious to you. So the process is one of negation. It's one of not me, not mine.

To do that, these spiritual faculties have to be clearly honed. They've got to be nicely developed, and you've got to be able to hold that steady gaze within the calmness. Keep the interest going and keep looking at these three qualities.

Even when the negative stuff comes up—even when the body begins to shake with restlessness or feels heavy with tiredness, sloth and torpor—even then you can maintain that same quality of watchfulness. Even then there can be that quality of calmness behind what's happening on the surface of the body and mind. Even then you can maintain an interest.

Even in dullness, where all it is is just porridge in your head, you can wander about that and be completely awake as if you'd woken up brightly in the morning. Because it's within that awareness to be awake like that. It's only by way of association and habit that it keeps falling into that state of drowsiness, sloth and torpor. By way of habit. By way of, in the past, seeking refuge there. Seeking refuge in the bed—the final haven. When everything goes wrong, go to bed. Just when everything goes bad, you get this little neon sign come up: head for the bed. That's it. You dive in and you wake up and you feel better, usually. And all you've done is use sleep to suppress, to push down whatever it was that made you head for the bed.

Now you begin to see all these things. You begin to see how we're moving away from what is unpleasant, moving towards what is pleasant. And that's the psychological vicious circle we get caught up in. Again, having established this watchfulness, having got these seven faculties developed, we begin to see that.

Just the seeing and the understanding is the moment of liberation. A moment in the sense of: ah, now I understand. But then, of course, come the trainings. If it were just that, I should think we'd all be fully awakened in a very short while. If it

were simply a matter of seeing these things, we'd be out of this state very quickly. But the problem is that the conditioning is so heavy and so deep that you have to keep working against it all the time.

Here on this retreat, you're moving forward a bit. Then you leave, and you say, to hell with it, and you go back a bit. This spiritual life is up and down, up and down. That's why it takes so long before you can look back and think, oh, something might be happening. So that effort has to be kept up even in daily life. Remember, this is not whipping yourself or kicking yourself or forcing yourself. It's a gentle self-cajoling, encouraging yourself.

Just to revise these seven factors that we've tried to distinguish in our meditation: in every sitting, that's how you should begin. You should begin by trying to establish that state. If you lose it, go back, start again. Bring yourself back to the breath. When I say lose it, I mean when there's too much thought around. But remember that sometimes the mind is just like that—it goes mad—and you just have to have patience and keep bringing it back and bringing it back.

Remember too that you can have these seven factors even though there's a negative mental state present. You can still see the quality of transience. As we've mentioned with depression, you can still see how you relate to that depression, which is understanding how we create suffering. You can still see that there is depression—not me, not mine. So these factors of enlightenment, as it were, are sitting behind or beneath the presenting quality that's arising in the mind.

The essential quality is this sati, this awareness, the knowingness. And what empowers the meditation is that sense of interest, the wanting to know. It's wanting to know something quite specific—wanting to know these three characteristics, wanting to experience them, to see them very clearly.

To support that, the body has to support it. There has to be that stillness. Even though you might feel depressed in the chest, the body can still be quite energised and relaxed. Even though you feel restless, very restless, you can still relax the body around that restlessness. That quality of what's known as *pīti*—often translated as bliss, I think, which is way over the top—it's just that sense of joy in the body and the calmness of the body balancing each other. And what's driving that is the interest.

And then you're investigating the Dharma. You're investigating these three characteristics. To investigate them you have to come at it as somebody who doesn't know. You've heard this from the Buddha, but you don't know. So you've

got to keep looking. You come from a point of no position. You're not saying to yourself, the Buddha said everything's transient, so it must be right. If the Buddha says everything's transient, I'm not so sure about that. Let's have a look. It's a case of that investigation. That equanimity.

You have to be careful with the sense of achievement. It's a difficult word for us in English because achievement is always something in the future. You're doing something now to achieve something in the next moment, in the next year, by the end of your life, when I'm retired I will. Achievement is always ahead of time. But if you define your achievement—if you want to use that word—as being aware in this present moment, then that's the achievement. To be aware is to be there. There's nowhere else to go.

Awareness. We can actually make things very simple for ourselves. Sometimes, especially for those of you who are more established in your meditation, you can see these faculties and do things to balance them. That's the skills of meditation. But for those of you who are new, and all this sounds very complicated—what, seven of these, ten of those, and five—you can actually put all that aside. The one factor which draws everything into balance is that awareness. And that's the key discovery of the Buddha.

Once you place your awareness on something with right intention—to observe the characteristics or to be stilled—then all these faculties just come up to support that awareness. Now that awareness, you might say, is our intuitive intelligence, but in its passive mode. In a passive mode, it's receiving, being aware of. And as that information comes in, there's a sudden seeing. So awareness has an active mode of intuitive understanding, which is known as *paññā*. You will notice that our trust is called *Satipaññā*. *Satipaññā* is the Buddha mind. It's that which is to be liberated, to be awakened, to be enlightened.

Having said all that, having gone on like this for too long, there is a very simple approach: just keep placing the awareness on the object. Just that activity of wanting to feel, to experience exactly what's going on now—whether it's the subtle feelings of the breath or the feelings associated with a heavy state or a beautiful state—that's enough. Just doing that, and the insights will arise.

Remember, these insights are not cataclysmic. They're just little incremental points which over a period of time, for most people, build up to a change in the way we see things. It's a change within consciousness. And when that change begins to take place, it has a systemic effect. It affects your attitude to things.

If you see transience, then of course you don't hold on so much. When you're watching TV and somebody phones you, you can turn it off right in the middle of a soap. It doesn't matter—just as he's about to score the goal, you can turn it off and go answer the phone. Before, you couldn't do that. Now you've understood. This change becomes a change of attitude, and that immediately expresses itself in the way we speak, in what we do and how we do things. And in our livelihood.

People sometimes change their livelihood if they meditate. They find themselves in work that doesn't fit with the Dharma, so they make the effort to move over. To change. Even if it means a loss of wealth. A dislocation.

Now, just as that happens outwardly—from understanding into livelihood—remember, it's also coming back the other way. Your livelihood has a great effect on your attitude, on your general understanding. As you know, if you're trained as a policeman, you're always suspicious. You have to be. You're trained to be suspicious. Anybody you see, you think, hmm. If you're a soldier, you're trained to kill. So your profession—those, of course, are heavy examples. But if you're a nurse or a doctor or in a more helping profession, then you're developing that compassion, usually.

Remember that the whole of the teaching is one composite. It's a mandala. As soon as you affect one part, the whole mandala changes. Something happens.

I hope this little exercise, this explanation, has clarified for you these factors of enlightenment—how to establish them and use them in order to gain, slowly, just little insights that change our view of things. I hope that's been a benefit, and I can only hope that your liberation is sooner rather than later.

PART 5

Vipassanā in Practice



Yathābhūtaṃ pajānāti — Knowing things as they really are

The Mahāsi Method

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 22 min

Originally given as *The Mahāsi Method* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma provides a comprehensive introduction to the Mahāsi method of vipassanā meditation, explaining both the historical context and practical theory behind this influential approach to Buddhist insight practice. He traces the lineage from the Burmese master Mahāsi Sayādaw through to contemporary teachers like Joseph Goldstein, highlighting how this system revolutionized lay meditation practice.

The talk focuses extensively on the noting technique (mental labeling) used in sitting meditation—rising, falling, feeling—explaining how simple verbal labels help contain the thinking mind and establish moment-to-moment awareness (sati). Bhante describes the progressive stages of concentration development, from initial mind-wandering through to sustained attention on meditation objects. He emphasizes how this method trains practitioners to experience sensations and emotions directly in the present moment, rather than getting caught in mental commentary.

The second half addresses walking meditation and continuous practice throughout daily activities, explaining the importance of slowing down to maintain investigative awareness. This approach supports the fundamental Buddhist inquiry into the nature of suffering (dukkha) and its cessation, making every moment an opportunity for insight into the psychophysical process we usually identify as 'self.'

Now what I want to do this evening is just explain the theory behind the practice you're doing so that you feel a bit more confident about it.

The Mahāsi Sayadaw was a monk living in the north of Burma who must have got himself a good name for teaching meditation because it was people in Rangoon, which is in the south, well, in the middle of Burma, who went looking for a

teacher after the war. Generals, actually. A couple of them were. And they asked him to come down and begin teaching. And I think to everybody's surprise, it took off.

Up until he began teaching, although there'd been a small resurgence of *vipassanā* meditation in the early century, by the time he began, it really wasn't something that lay people did. I don't think it was what monks did either. Monks tended to practice a form of meditation known as *samatha*, which is basically just being peaceful, being calm, using the breath just to be calm but not for purposes of trying to understand or trying to have insight.

So it was really quite a new venture and as I say it really took off. So much so that by the mid-fifties he was actually traveling and he went to Sri Lanka, set up centers there and it was at one of those centers that I spent so many years. And then he eventually came to Britain, did a tour of Britain, used to be a centre over in Oxford. And that's where I first contacted this particular form through one of his protégés, Sayadaw Ujanaka, who's still living and has a centre in Rangoon, and later his other protégé, Upandita. And some of you may know, for instance, people like Joseph Goldstein, he's pretty famous. So he teaches this particular system.

So what he did was present a system of investigation supported by techniques so that there wasn't a moment in the day when you were let off, when you could relax into a dozy, peaceful state. You had to make a real effort to develop this quality of just watching with a sharp or an attentive curiosity, a wanting to know. Remember, it's this wanting to know which is specific to the Gnostic path. Gnostic here meaning the path that leads to a spiritual awakening by way of investigation, rather than, shall we say, a path that might lead there through developing love, a more devotional path, a bhakti path.

So all these techniques that we're doing are really there just to awaken this pure intelligence within us, this intuitive intelligence that can directly experience things before words and concepts interfere, before emotions distort what we're actually looking at, prejudice.

So, first of all, in the sitting posture, there's this noting technique. So one thing this intelligence has to do is go beyond the word. So the question is, why do we use a word anyway? So obviously the technique, what it does when you present one word, is at least it stops the mind from wandering. At least it stops the mind thinking about something. So we're going right back to that slightly pre-verbal stage when, for instance, a child might see something and just shout, "Car, car." But the word car has very little meaning. It doesn't have a desire to have a car. It

doesn't have all the experiences that we get going around in a car. It's just a car. It's just an object. And it's that clarity of just noting that we want to get down to. And the clarity comes because the noting word is restricting the thinking mind. So, okay, there's a concept there, but at least it's a simple concept. Just a word. Rising. Falling.

Now I say in this particular tape, I mean to change it for my next edition, that you go rising, falling, and in the break between the out-breath and the in-breath, you see the whole feeling body. And I give this image of a bird in a tree, and then you see the whole tree because the bird's not moving. You don't have to specifically look at the bird. But as soon as the bird moves, your eye catches it.

So some people find this a little bit difficult. So the other thing you can do is simply go to a touch point. So rising, falling, and then if you feel, for instance, your ankles on the floor or your knees or your hands, so you just go to that point. The reason for that is just to keep the thinking mind occupied. If you don't occupy it, it'll occupy itself and off it'll go somewhere. Acapulco. Who wants to go to Acapulco in the middle of London?

So by maintaining that word, you're actually containing the thinking mind and constantly aiming it at the object. Now some people in their meditation don't get this break after the out-breath. In which case, forget it. Just go rising, falling, rising, falling. Don't create a break if there's not one there. Usually it's because of tension. A person who doesn't have that break actually is slightly hyperventilating. This is the truth. So, it'll come as you relax. Because the breath just stops and then there's the relaxation. Then the in-breath comes. So, that's the noting as it comes to the breath.

When it comes to sensations in the body, keep it very simple. Heat, itching, pain. Don't start looking for the word like a poet might. You've lost the plot. All we're doing is just if the word doesn't come up then just use the word feeling because the attention should be riveted on just the sensation, just sensation. Why just sensation? Because sensation happens only now. You can't have a sensation yesterday. You can't have it last minute. You can't have it tomorrow. You're going to have a sensation right here and now.

So the more that we're aware of sensation as a basic premise for our meditation, the more we're driving that intelligence into this present moment. And the more it locks into the present moment, the less it can think. Because thought is always an afterthought. You see something, you feel it, and then you say some-

thing. So to get that purity of intelligence, we need more and more to just bring that attention into the present moment, relaxing into the present moment but yet remaining alert.

This noting word is part of training ourselves to stop living in thought, living in the mind. Now, some people find this very difficult because when they start noting, all they can be aware of is the word itself — rising, falling. They can't contact the breath at all. Just *rising*, and it dominates the whole mind. When that happens, what it's showing that person is that they're living up here, above the chin. They don't contact the body at all. People will say things like, 'Yeah, I suffer anger, but I don't feel it. It's just in my head as an angry thought, an angry dream.'

We lift ourselves up into this space, this fantasy world, this virtual reality, and we've actually left the physical feelings — the actual feelings in the body that are motivating all this stuff. So we have to reverse that process; we have to stop living in a fantasy world. Even though the word is, for some people, flooding the whole of consciousness — that's all you can be aware of, this word, rising, falling — keep guiding your attention to the sensation, and eventually it'll drop. As it drops and the word recedes, that's a sign to the meditator that they're coming off this never-never land. It's a very powerful technique.

At first, probably the whole weekend, there is just this effort to come back into the present moment. The mind wanders, you know where it is, you come back. The mind wanders, you know where it is, you come back. That's the practice. That's part of the course, and you can't speed it up. All it shows us is how restless we are. The Buddha compares it to a monkey — the monkey mind, jumping from branch to branch.

So the first part of the practice is to use the noting technique to bring us slowly to the object, more and more into the present moment, just being aware of sensation, feeling sensation. There comes a point — hopefully by tomorrow noon — where the mind begins to settle on the object. It's not wandering off. It's actually staying still, at least for a second or so, actually staying still on the sensation.

Now, at this point, the meditator can say to themselves, 'Ah, I've got it, this is it, concentration, I'm *samādhī*, I'm stuck right now, wonderful, I've collapsed into the present moment, it's marvellous' — and they stop noting. And of course, in their desperation, they find the mind immediately shoots off and goes all over the place.

So although we've matured the noting to a point where the mind is beginning to feel more still on the object, you have to keep going with it until it matures further. There's a real feeling that it's as though you can't take the mind off the object — it's really stuck there. That's the second stage of the noting. One continues with that, and for those of you who are mature in your meditation, you can find a point where you can drop it. But the normal thing is to keep noting, because at some point the concentration and the effort will so support that sense of knowing, that sense of intelligence, that *sati*, that awareness, that the noting will simply stop. And you'll just be there with the object.

That's the growth of *samādhi*, the growth of concentration supporting moment-to-moment awareness. And that's the purpose of using a noting word — just to bring us to that.

Once we've got this moment-to-moment concentration on the breath — mainly we do it on the breath, but of course, whenever something draws the attention, whether a sensation in the body, a feeling of discomfort, a pain in the knee, or something coming from the emotional base, some heaviness, some depression, burning from anger — then that same consciousness, now more like a laser beam, can move on to these objects. It doesn't get caught up in them, doesn't allow them to slip up into this higher mentation and create fantasy. In so doing, we directly experience an emotion as a physical mental feeling, not as a dream, not as a fantasy. We become very intimate with it.

And we're observing its qualities — the fact that it's just a process, that it isn't an object or something substantial. It's like a blowing cloud just passing through the mind. In so doing, we're not engaging it. When an emotion comes up, pleasant or unpleasant, we immediately form a relationship with it. Either we want to indulge it, and thereby we create a greater state of that emotion — if you want to get into revenge, before you know it, you've blown it up into a war; if you want to get into thinking about how you're going to get rich, before you know it, it blows up into a book.

Or if you don't want to have something — if you don't want to feel the boredom, the depression, these things — then you push it down, push it away, turn your attention elsewhere, don't want to see it. But all these actions of pushing away are simply more energy into that bad system, into that bad turbulence.

In our meditation we take a very radical stance, one which doesn't occur to the self or the ego. The ego can only engage in the world — it can either indulge or suppress, push away. But here we find a consciousness which does neither and yet experiences things directly. That's a paradox.

By finding that position of the objective observer, we're just allowing these turbulences to arise and expend themselves. We're not pushing them away and therefore creating more bad energy, and we're not developing them. So what can they do? They need our will, they need our empowerment to grow. Finding that position of the objective observer just allows the psychotherapy to continue. But like I say on the tape, if you make that the object of your meditation then you're missing the point. What we really want to see is how we relate to these things.

So that's the sitting practice.

Now, to carry that moment-to-moment awareness throughout the day, what Mahāsi Sayadaw asked people to do was to go very slow. The slower you go, the more you see. If you watch one of those nature films — a frog's tongue catching a fly, slowed down to thousands of frames per second — you can actually see the whole thing happen.

What we want to do is really see what this psychophysical organism is doing. This is what I've been calling 'me' all these years. And of course, the underlying reason is to find out why we're suffering. When the Bodhisattva, as he was then, set off on his spiritual journey, the question wasn't 'How can I get rich?' or 'How can I be famous?' or 'How can I get blissful?' It was 'What is the end of suffering? Is this it? Is human life about suffering, full stop? Just carrying on until you get sick, get old, and die? Or is there something else?'

That was his search, and it must be our search — or else we're not actually doing his practice. We're doing something else. Our purpose is to really find out why suffering arises. What maintains it? That investigation has to carry on all day, as a background theme to everything we're trying to do. Trying to understand why we're suffering, why we're not in a state of satisfaction, why we can't find lasting satisfaction in a sensual world — even though we may occasionally be happy with it. Why we can't make it a constant thing.

So we go slow, as in this walking meditation. That pace is extremely slow. We don't have to go that slow all the time, but we do need to go slow. Just take your time. When we break from here, don't leap up the stairs. Stop. Find yourself, take a breath, relax. Then start to climb. Lifting, placing — use the noting word just to stay with it.

When you brush your teeth, don't go mad. Take your time, stop. Note: intending to brush the teeth. Do it mindfully. You don't have to get dead slow — you'll never finish. But slow enough to actually be with what you're doing.

When you open the door to your room, just stop. Intending to open the door. Reaching. When you hold the handle, feel it. Feel what steel, what metal feels like. Get in contact with those feelings. Pressing. Turning. You communicate with the spring. Don't attack it — wow, bang, open the door, crack. Can you feel that? Open the door gently. Close the door in the same way.

There's a constant effort just to be with what's actually happening at its base. Don't try to get beyond it. Don't try to find out what lies beyond consciousness. You're just trying to be with what's happening right here, right then. And you're trying to see your relationship to it.

You might close the door gently, and somebody up the corridor, somebody next door, might bang theirs. Then you notice irritation. Anger, anger. It dies away.

Take this slowness with you wherever you go. Every time you find yourself rushing — which you will do — stop. And this is something I shall urge you to take into your daily life. It's a very powerful technique for stopping all that agitation, all that accumulation throughout the day of emotional stuff. You just stop, intend, and then do it. When you come to the end of that action, be aware of it. That's been done, that's finished. Stop. Bring yourself into the moment. Intention.

Those are basically your two techniques: going slow, taking your time, relaxing into the present moment, staying awake of course — and keeping the noting going. All the time.

There's not supposed to be a time of day when you stop noting. That's the effort — to keep the thinking mind steady on the object, not to let it move off. Now this isn't a strenuous physical thing. This won't exhaust you. It actually contains our energy, so that by the end of the day you feel you've really not wasted it. There's a lot of energy around because it's not frazzled.

The beautiful thing about this method is that it's so complete. Every moment of experience is included — nothing is excluded. Whatever arises in consciousness becomes the object of meditation. If you're walking and you hear a sound, you note "hearing." If you're sitting and you feel an itch, you note "itching." If you're lying down thinking about tomorrow, you note "thinking." Everything is included. Nothing is rejected. Nothing is suppressed.

Because of this, it becomes a very natural way of living. You're not trying to create artificial states or manufacture special experiences. You're simply becoming more and more aware of what's actually happening, moment by moment. And this leads to tremendous insights into the nature of reality, into the nature of mind, into the nature of suffering and the end of suffering.

The Mahāṣī Method

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 48 min

Originally given as *The Mahāṣī Method* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this overview of the Mahāṣī method, Bhante Bodhidhamma explains how meditation techniques serve as preparation for insight rather than guaranteeing awakening. He explores the three core practices developed by Mahāṣī Sayādaw: noting (to contain the thinking mind and develop objectivity), deliberate slow movement (to observe the minutiae of body-mind processes), and catching intentions before they manifest as conditioned actions.

The talk emphasizes understanding these techniques as tools for developing moment-to-moment awareness rather than goals in themselves. Bhante discusses how noting helps create distance from experiences, allowing investigation without identification, while slow movement reveals the multiple processes underlying what appears as continuous experience. Special attention is given to observing intentions - those crucial moments of choice before desire becomes conditioned action.

Drawing from his own intensive retreat experience in Burma, Bhante illustrates how repetitive routine creates ideal conditions for observing the subtle workings of consciousness. The ultimate aim is developing the relaxed alertness that characterizes awakened awareness - being completely present without struggle or resistance to whatever arises.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsbuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsbuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsbuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble, and fully self-enlightened one.

This evening I want to revise much of what we've said about the skills of meditation, and see if any questions arise.

The first important thing is to recognise what these techniques actually are. We might make the mistake of thinking that the technique itself creates the insight—that if you get the technique perfectly right, insight is bound to arise. But consider other areas: sports, tennis, instrument playing. Musicians and athletes spend hours practising the backhand over and over, or going up and down the scales. Yet when it comes to actually playing the game or playing the instrument, it's a different situation, isn't it? If they're thinking about their skills, it's going to sound pretty turgid. They're definitely going to miss being in the moment. When the shot comes over, they're too worried about what their backhand is like.

I had a friend in Bangkok, a Chinese man who was Australian champion for table tennis. He once beat the world champion in a single game, which he thought was very good for himself. To reach that level, he'd gone to Japan, and he said the Japanese know how to train you. They have a really rigorous programme that lifts your game. But the Japanese don't win. The reason, he said, is that they can't stop practising. They can't let the practice go and just play the game. They're still too bothered about getting the shot right.

These meditation techniques work the same way. All they're doing is laying the ground, preparing a basis for insight to arise. But the insight itself arises because of the power of your attentiveness. All these exercises, all these techniques, are simply helping you attain the right sort of attentiveness, the right sort of focus, and pointing you in the right direction.

And of course, this intuition we talk about—this *satipaṇṇā*, this intuitive awareness—is beyond the control of 'me'. I can't sit here and say, 'Well, I'm going to meditate now for an hour and I'm going to have an insight into *Nibbāna*.' It doesn't work like that. Very frustrating.

I'm reminded of somebody I met way back when *vipassanā* was just coming in as a practice, in the 70s or so. He'd heard about this course: meditation, *Nibbāna*. So he joined a week's course. And it's like anything else—if you do a course in cookery or whatever, they tell you what you'll achieve by the end and you get a certificate. He'd presumed that after one week he'd get *Nibbāna* and get his certificate. It gave him a huge disappointment when he realised it wasn't quite like that.

These techniques are to be seen for what they are: simple methods preparing the ground for the real, actual moment-to-moment mindfulness that the Buddha talks about. You can tell when you're getting caught up in them, when you're getting too worried about whether you're doing the technique right, whether you've

got it perfect. There's something wrong if somebody is really getting anxious about 'Am I doing it right? Have I got it perfect?' So be careful of that idea of perfection.

The other thing to say about techniques is that it's not so good to mix them. These various *vipassanā* techniques have their own pros and cons, their own drawbacks and advantages. If you mix them, it's sometimes confusing for the teacher, especially if you don't tell them what you're doing. It's good to keep on one line, because the teacher can generally spot when something goes wrong from the report the meditator gives. But if they're mixing stuff, it doesn't work. It's like these alternative medicines, isn't it? You're not supposed to do acupuncture and homeopathy together. It confuses both the acupuncturists and the homeopaths because you're getting effects from both. This is much the same.

All these techniques have arisen out of some teacher, and this is the Mahāsi method. You can find all of these techniques in the commentaries—it's not that he made them up—but somehow he put them together in a particular way, and he himself was such an inspiration that a new school began. That's basically what happened. It usually occurs when there isn't much meditation about, when practice has faded, and then you get this revival.

The Mahāsi and a man called U Ba Khin, who began another system—known mainly in the West through Goenka and his centres—these two really did affect the whole Theravādin world with their methodology.

Mahāsi himself was interesting because he was actually a scholar, a renowned scholar, which meant he was the sort of person who was very much up in his head. So the technique he uses of noting is specifically good for those people who are head-bound—it keeps the thoughts from wandering away. I've always presumed that's why he developed it. I've never been able to determine whether that's right, but it definitely works in keeping the mind still on the object.

The other thing to be careful of when you come on retreat is this business of gaining something. If you have a goal in mind, all your efforts move towards that goal, and in doing so you miss everything. It's like people who go for walks in the country and their idea is just to get to where they're going—they get there, but they've missed out on the country. So be careful that you don't have any goal. It's best just to be completely open and let the practice itself manifest what it has to offer you.

It's like going to a strange country for the first time with no particular idea of what you want to see. You're very open, and you tend to see much more. But if you go there with just the idea of seeing ancient sites or tasting the food and what-not, that's all you get. So have that sort of attitude—open exploration—and you'll find it offers you quite a lot.

It offers you an understanding of your physicality, of your body. It offers you an understanding of your psyche—and by psyche I'm referring to the heart and mind together. We've lost the word that combines those two. We can blame Descartes, blame somebody. He split off the mind, didn't he? And everybody got head-bound. But in the old way of explaining the human being, there was a word that conjoined both heart and mind in one. We had the word soul, psyche. We've lost that a bit. So now we have to keep saying the heart and the mind, or emotions and thoughts, but in a sense they're both one and the same process—just two sides of it.

So the practice gives you an ability to recognise how the psyche works, how these two things work, and how we create the world. And of course there are spiritual insights. In Buddhism, a spiritual insight isn't some sort of transcendental communication with another being. A spiritual insight, in Buddhist understanding, is the final level of consciousness. That's what it is.

If you look at the evolution of consciousness—not just in terms of beings like animals and all that, but in ourselves, from the point where we're born to where we are now—we don't think like a newborn baby. I don't think it's possible; we've all lost that. We don't think like a three-year-old anymore. We don't have the magic anymore. Up to about the age of seven, we live in a world where we believe what we imagine. That's why Father Christmas can come down the chimney. No problem.

All these stages manifest a different relationship to the world. And what we're trying to do is take that process of consciousness, that process of relationship, to the very end. What manifests at the very end? A complete accommodation with the way it is. There's no struggle, no wanting for other than is given, no attempt to destroy or annihilate what we don't want. It's a contentment with the way things are, whether pleasant or unpleasant. And that's the state of non-suffering.

It doesn't mean you don't have physical pain—that's just natural to the body. But in terms of the heart-mind, the psyche, it manifests a very different relationship. And for that to happen, there has to be this pulling out, as it were, of our

intelligence—this intuitive intelligence—from its confusion with the body and the psyche, this psycho-physical organism. All these techniques are to do with that. That's all.

When I talk about distancing, I mean objectifying. I mean being able to turn the inside as objective as we now see the outside. You don't come into this room and say, 'This is me.' You'd be put away. But inside, that's all we're doing. We're turning all this inner furniture, this inner environment, these inner walls that we see, the body and all that—we're turning it very slowly into an objective world. And in so doing, we're no longer reacting with it. That's what produces this inner peace. Even when you're disturbed, even when you're angry or stressed, you can still find a still small point within that storm.

That's what these techniques are hoping to do. And of course, not just here on retreat, but to actually take them into daily life. It's something contiguous. You can't stop spiritual practice like climbing a mountain—if you stop, you can stop so long and then you get cold and want to come down. You've got to keep going. It's the same with spiritual practice. Once you're in it, you can't stop it. You've got to keep going.

In other words, now that you know—or for some of you, are beginning to intuit—this level of consciousness, you can't go back on it. It's a piece of knowledge; you know it. And this awareness that we have, this intuitive awareness, will always be in some way or other wanting to seek its own liberation. This is beyond the idea of some sort of me or mine. It's something deep within us that seeks liberation, and that's what we really mean by the Buddha.

So let's consider some of the techniques now—this noting. The noting is primarily, as far as I'm concerned, to contain the thinking mind. But it also has the effect of pointing you to actually look at something. Mahāsi talked about it like throwing a stone at a wall. As you say 'rising, rising, rising,' it's like pushing your attention to where you want to see. It's a push towards it.

Now, one of the problems that might come up is that the word seems to get in the way of what you're looking at. It seems very loud in the mind, and in a sense it obscures what you're looking at. When that happens, what does it tell us? It tells us that our intelligence, this *satipaṇṇā*, is locked into the intellect. In other words, it's always seeing things through the intellect.

In daily life, this is sometimes quite obvious. Take a flower—this one here, an orchid. When you look at an orchid, if you've seen lots of orchids, you don't really see that orchid. What you're seeing fits into your conception of an orchid, drawn from all the others you've seen. It flips into a category. And we trick ourselves into thinking we're actually seeing that orchid. But it's only when you place your eye on it and really see it—the delicacy of it, the different little bits and pieces—that the word 'orchid' begins to disappear. Because what you're seeing is something quite unique.

This is something you can practise while you're here. The flowers are coming out, and you can just place your eye on them. By saying the word 'looking' rather than naming the flower, very slowly you become quite concentrated upon what the flower is offering you. The flower doesn't want to be categorised. And that's clarifying this ability to see things as they really are—one of the phrases you find throughout the scriptures: to see and understand things as they really are. Not as I would wish them to be, not as I think they are. Thinking that we know something is one of our big delusions, isn't it? We confuse the thought with the actual experience.

So a word actually helps us to stay present, so long as it reflects the process we're engaged in—looking, seeing, touching, feeling. That's not to say we can't sometimes use a noting word to describe what we're experiencing, such as pain.

The noting word also helps us keep a distance, because it's pushing the object away so we can actually note it. It's all part of that process of pushing something away to look at it more clearly. When we get involved in a pain or an emotion, falling into identity with it, we can't see it—in a sense we're suffering it. We're more concerned with how I feel about it rather than seeing it objectively. So when pain comes from the posture of your back or your knee, that's an opportunity to just say 'pain, pain.' The more you say it, the more it pushes away. You can see it objectively. The word does have an effect on the way you're looking.

If the word does seem to get between you and the object, just keep the noting going while putting your attention on the object. Very slowly the word, as it were, disappears. It moves into the background, becoming like a background note that pushes you forward. This tells a meditator that their intelligence is slowly emerging out of its confusion with thought. If you find that happening, just keep gently working at it.

Now, the other thing about noting is that it has to be deliberate—it's actually an act of noting. That's why some of you have already noticed that you can be happily sat here saying 'rising, falling' while your mind is miles away. When you come back, you're still saying 'rising, falling.' This tells us how mechanical it can become, and how easy it is to create a habit in the body.

Going back to sports and musical instruments—just running up and down the scales of a piano, the fingers do it without thinking. Even when we walk across the road, we don't have to think about our legs. Imagine having to think about your legs—terrible, isn't it? But you just go, and the legs follow, moving up and down, flapping away underneath you, and you don't notice. So many things we do are automated, and thank heavens for it. Here, however, we're trying to be mindful even of the minutest movements, because we want to really catch intention. We'll come to the importance of catching intentions towards the end.

It's really boring. Seven days of doing exactly the same thing. You walk from here to the dining room, you eat, then you go to your bedroom, you go back, then you come back here. Always the same thing. And this makes it very easy to really make clear to ourselves the process of thought, of intentions, of actions.

When I did this long retreat with my teacher in Burma, all day long I was stuck in a room like this. We didn't go out—the windows are open, so there's no point. And it's too hot anyway. So all day long I'm in this room, sitting and walking, never going out. Then there were two or three times we went out: once for breakfast, once for lunch, and once for a drink. It was just down the stairs, across the yard, and you sat at a table. Breakfast was always the same. Lunch was slightly different. The drink was always the same—this dreadful chemical orange juice. Then you went back up the same stairs, across the same way.

What that does is make it very, very simple to watch the most minute movement of body and mind. Because you're not thinking. There's no choice left. You don't say to yourself, 'Shall I go down this way or that way?' No, you go down this way. There's only one way to get there. By sweeping away any idea of choice—and confusing choice with freedom—you're simply doing what you have to do. The more you restrict yourself, the less the mind has to think about what you have to do. And this means you can really settle down to observing the minutiae of how body and mind work.

The reason for that, of course, is that when you see how it works—and we're specifically interested in how we create suffering for ourselves—then you see the way out. Unless we can see how we create problems for ourselves, we're not going

to see a solution. But when you see how we create the problem, the solution manifests at the same time. That's all the Buddha did. Remember, we're following the same path as this ancient personage 2,500 years ago. He just sat under a tree and walked about a bit, sat under a tree and walked about a bit, and he began to see where the suffering was arising from.

So habitual practice and noting allow us to go deeper and deeper into the process of mentation, the process of the body. I think that just about covers noting. Does anybody have any questions about noting as such? Have I missed something? I suppose one thing is not to worry about the word too much. Sometimes there are many experiences for which there just isn't a word. Use a general word—feeling, thinking—always remembering what the word is trying to do. If we find ourselves getting caught up in 'Is this the right word or the wrong word?' and we're searching for a dictionary, then we've definitely lost the plot.

"Can I ask a question? Is there sort of tension between the benefit of noting in objectifying whatever it is, but at the same time the desire to actually experience it? But at the same time you're trying to also be fully conscious of the experience."

No, that's a really crucial point to understand. The word helps us to push away so that we get some objectivity, some sort of witnessing, some sort of ability to be objective with what it is that we are trying to experience. Then, once you've got that position of being objective, once you've got that position where you know that you're not being caught up in the feeling or the emotion, one then goes towards it. And hopefully, through the power of that curiosity and the power of that focus, there's a collapse into the object, the word disappears, and there's just the pure experience.

Now that's really your true *vipassanā* moment. But that you can't make happen. This is the point, because then at that point the self also disappears. It's like when you fall asleep. Where are you? Where have you gone? And who wakes up? So it's like you're moving towards that just by this noting, but it's the interest and the curiosity which will draw you towards the object you're trying to understand and feel.

"Presumably the moment that you do achieve that kind of being in that experience, the moment you notice that, you've lost it."

Exactly that. Yes, that's right. It's one of these paradoxes that you're most happy when you don't know it. As soon as you know you're happy, you've lost it. It's like when you watch a film. You're perfectly happy, completely enthralled by the film. And then it ends. That's it, you've lost it.

But our aim is really to become very intimate with the body, heart and mind, and not to be too concerned about that business of losing, becoming, collapsing into that process, because that happens naturally when the conditions are right. Even at the level of objectivity, you can still be having insights, spiritual insights, because you are observing impermanence, you're observing your reaction to things, and you're also, by creating that distance, recognizing that what you're looking at can't be what's looking, because you're looking at it. So these themselves are true spiritual insights. And again, remember, what we mean by spiritual insights is a change in the way we relate to the world. These are radical changes in the way that we see the world.

"So if you notice a pattern of thinking, say judging for example, so if you notice that the thoughts that come into your mind are judgmental of either yourself or of other people on a repetitive basis, on a frequent basis, you notice a sort of habit of that. Then what's the process for reflecting on that which doesn't involve... Is there a process for reflecting on it?"

Well, if, for instance, something like that is coming up, as a constant judging, judging, the first thing to recognize is that you can't change that. It's a conditioning. It has to run its course. And it'll run its course and empty itself of its energy so long as we don't identify. And by noting it as judging, you're not identifying. Otherwise, you'd be judging. But you can hear these little judgments going on. I'm no good. She's no good. They're no good. They're better than me. I'm worse than them. And you just hear that going on. But by just observing it and noting it, it no longer has power over you. That's the point. But we'll deal with those things more clearly tomorrow when we talk more about the hindrances.

So sitting. Remember that your sitting posture is the very physical representation of the enlightened mind because there is that alertness in the posture, the energy, but there's also to be the relaxation. And those two are the qualities of your observation, a relaxed but alert looking. And of course that's difficult for us because one way we either fall asleep or the other way we get tense. And it's just being aware of that and just bringing, it's always starting with that calmness. Starting with the calmness and then raising the curiosity. That's the way to do it.

And don't struggle with pain. The tell-tale is, as soon as pain, whether it's physical or emotional, has actually made it difficult to investigate, then that's it, you cut, you go for a walk, you take a break. There's no point, because this is a process of investigation. If you can't do it, what's the point of suffering it? And then, of course, one builds up a resistance. You can take a bit more pain and all that sort of stuff. You can hang around with very difficult emotions more. And I think you have to be slightly careful not to push that because you can frighten yourself. That's one of the problems. And just go easy with things.

In the long-term view, in the Buddha's understanding, so long as there's a self there's going to be an existence. So we have an eternity of time to sort this one out. There's no need to get into a panicky rush about it. And even if we are more inclined to believe in one life, then the meditation works in that it's at least sorting out this present moment, and hopefully we'll make our future life a bit more easy to live with. That's the important thing about the sitting posture. Don't struggle with pain to the point where you can't do the investigation.

Now, the walking is really important. People tend not to see its importance, but it's extremely good for developing this calm attentiveness. It's very calming, and you don't have to go so slow. When you're going so slow like that, like we do in the evening, that's really also to investigate. Because the feeling of the foot rising is different from the feeling of the foot moving forward is different from the feeling of the foot falling and it's different from the feeling of the foot pressing. And it's these discriminations that are making, that are sort of tuning this intelligence, making it more sharp to see things that previously would have just seen as just one feeling, the foot moving through the air. But you can also use walking gently up and down just to develop this calm abiding. So it's a very powerful exercise. So don't try and do as much of it as you can.

I know there's a tendency to rush off for a cup of tea, and there's nothing wrong with having a cup of tea, you understand. But often it stretches out to forty minutes, and then you do a ten-minute walk and come back to sit. If you do want a beverage, make it short and sweet, and really just keep walking up and down.

Going slow — that's the other big technique, the Mahāśī's technique. If you find yourself rushing anywhere, just stop. Stop in your tracks and let the energy fall away. Then take your time. I don't think you ought to be going faster than left, right, left, right. That's about it. If you're going faster than that, you're rushing.

Try to find little things during the day when you can really take your time. This door, for instance — you can actually open and close it completely silently. You don't have to bang it or push it; you can make the opening of that door a specific exercise. I always know where people are by how they go out through that door. Pushing the door open to your bedroom — just do it very slowly and sort of communicate with the spring.

Certain things you can't go so slow. You can't brush your teeth at that speed; you'd never finish. But there are many things you can do where you're not holding anybody up. That's the other thing about the bathroom — there may be people waiting. But there are many things you can do really slowly. Just observe it. And the main place, of course, is when you're eating. If you finish before me, you're definitely going too fast, because I'm eating at what I would consider to be an ordinary pace. An ordinary pace.

The more you go slow, the more you see. We've all seen those nature films on TV — a butterfly, or hummingbirds, how their wings flap and you can actually see it. It's just slowing the film down frame by frame. That's all we're doing. The slower you go, the more you'll actually see. You'll see the connection.

We chant this dependent origination in the morning. The Buddha there is showing us that although we experience life as one continuous thought process, one emotional process, actually there are myriads of little processes going on. What we catch are the end products. These processes continue throughout the day. Even to see something, there has to be a process whereby what hits the retina is sensed in the mind, categorised, put into some sort of picture. What we see is the final product, the picture. Same with hearing. There's a whole process going on from the point where all there is is pressure on the eardrum. By the time we get to 'alarm bell' or 'bell to sit', that's gone through a whole load of mental processes. But what we're always aware of is the end product.

What we're specifically interested in is not just the way we produce a certain concreteness about our existence, a certain substantiality — whereas in fact it's all these myriad processes going on — but also seeing it as something transient. And we're interested in this relationship we have: wanting, not wanting, wanting, not wanting, wanting, not wanting. That's another level of this mental process, which for the most part we're not really aware of.

Just watch people around supermarkets. They don't distinguish the product they're looking at from the wanting of it. It's already my product. As soon as they see it, it's my product — they've already bought it. For us this is very important: to

see the distinction between liking something and wanting it, between disliking something and not wanting it. Pleasant, unpleasant. Wanting, not wanting. That will become more and more obvious the more we slow the process down. So make an effort over the next few days to just take your time. Take your time.

Finally, there's this intention. What we mean by an intention here is a desire that hasn't been empowered — a desire which is arising. This is a very important moment in Buddhist psychology, because as a desire it's not having a conditioning effect. It's not an action; it just lies as a potential in the mind. But if we act on it — or as they put it in this awful committee-speak, if you 'action' it — then it immediately becomes an act. Once that happens, it will have a conditioning effect within us. And of course it will produce something. If it's wholesome, it will produce something wholesome within us. If it's unskillful, it will produce something unwholesome.

That's why the accent is always on this: when you're sitting and you hear the bell go, or you've done the reflections and it's time to get up — intending to rise. Now you're empowered. You're not acting like an automaton. You're watching the intention arise. Intending to rise. That's the moment you can reflect and say, is this a good thing to do or a bad thing? Skillful or unskillful? Virtuous or unvirtuous? That's the only moment you've got in terms of choice. Once you rise, you've lost it. You've already created an act.

That's why in the standing meditation you can stand there and say, intending to walk. Nothing happens. You can stand there all day, intending to walk. These intentions, remember, aren't huge, strong desires. We're not talking about cravings. We're just talking about a simple intention, a wanting to walk. You can stay there with intending, and nothing happens. Then suddenly there's a decision and your foot moves.

This is a magical moment, isn't it? How does something move out of potential into actual? That moment of actuality the Buddha calls will, and at that point an act is created. Then you can't stop its problem — it's already gone into the system. And if it's something out there, it's gone into the world, and you'll get your response.

That's why when we're eating, rather than getting caught up in our natural appetite and turning it into something greedy, just by noting the intention 'wanting to eat' — having already set the intention that you're eating only to nourish the body — you reaffirm that larger intention every time you eat. These are conditioning acts. The more we condition ourselves to eat for nourishment, the less

likely we are to develop eating problems. And of course, this is one way to work through an eating problem if we find we have one: simply not reinforcing the intention to eat for comfort or happiness.

Intention is a really important thing to note. If you can at least begin by noting the main intentions — the intention to rise, the intention to walk somewhere, the intention to start your sitting, the intention to eat — these create a natural break. You're actually stopping for a moment. And in that moment of stopping, there's this ability to reflect.

What this shows us is that if we were to take this practice full time, we'd become in charge of our lives. We'd begin to be in charge rather than behaving according to old conditionings or coming under other people's influence. We gain our autonomy, you might say.

You'll hear me constantly encouraging you to note your intention. There's a little passage in the *Visuddhimagga*, a later commentarial work, in which a teacher is teaching his students and at one point raises his hand — then stops, stops talking. He puts his hand very gently back down. His students ask, 'What happened there?' He says, 'I didn't note the intention.' It was just an old automatic thing he did. But if you're quite wide awake, if you're really awake, you'll see it come across the mind: 'move your hand', intention to move your hand, intention to scratch.

It's the same when you get an itch. You note your intention. You try to handle the itch as much as you can, and you see this enormous desire to scratch. When you can't take it anymore, say 'intending to scratch', and then just watch how the mind reacts — how it becomes relieved of its tension once you've given yourself a good scratch.

These are the basic components of your practice: this continuous noting as best you can, going slow and slower, and choosing certain actions during the day where you really do things very slowly, so that you've got a standard. That's why we walk together in the evening — there I hope to create a standard for you of going slow. Then try to do that as much as you can during the day, noting intentions throughout.

Just as when you're intending to eat there's a back story — your bigger intention is to eat only for healthy purposes — so too with many other intentions. In order to decide rather than simply noting that you're intending to do something and then doing it, if there's a possibility of saying 'I'm not going to do it', you need

a kind of back story: what's the bigger intention behind this intention? It helps to have a large intention. The intention behind this whole retreat is to develop moment-to-moment mindfulness. That's the purpose of all these techniques: to actually be completely awake to the presenting moment.

And of course our nature is not to stay there. We like to live in the future or live in the past. We don't like to be completely in the present moment — unless it's really happy. Unless we're really, really enjoying it.

Now your response is *sādhū, sādhū* — which means 'well done'. You can imagine how I feel if I don't get *sādhū, sādhū*. It's desperate, isn't it? Very good.

So we have some walking, and then at quarter past come in again and I'll join you to do the walking meditation together. We'll sit the last period together and finish with me.

A Detailed Guided Meditation

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 45 min

Originally given as *A Detailed Guided Meditation* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



This guided meditation offers detailed instruction in the Mahāṣī Sayadaw tradition of vipassanā bhāvanā (insight meditation). Bhante Bodhidhamma begins with establishing proper posture and relaxation techniques, then guides practitioners through breath awareness using the abdomen as the primary meditation object with noting practice (rising, falling, touching).

The teaching progresses from developing samādhi (concentration) through mindful observation of the breath to establishing satipaṇṇā (mindful awareness) of all arising phenomena—sounds, sensations, emotions, and thoughts. Practitioners learn to maintain the observer's position, noting whatever arises without attachment or aversion.

The instruction culminates in understanding vipassanā's ultimate purpose: recognizing the three characteristics of existence—anicca (impermanence), anattā (not-self), and dukkha (unsatisfactoriness). Through this bare attention and choiceless awareness, practitioners develop the intuitive intelligence that leads toward nibbāna realization.

Perfect for establishing a solid foundation in Mahāṣī method vipassanā practice, suitable for both beginners learning the technique and experienced meditators deepening their understanding.

First, we must settle the body into a meditative posture. Some sit on chairs, others use kneeling stools, but the usual position is to sit on the floor with a cushion, cross-legged. Your hands should rest on your lap, preferably one on top of the other. Whatever posture you adopt, it should feel comfortable at first. Then make sure the spine is straight while keeping its natural curvature. It's best not to lean against anything, for this will induce sleep.

Now imagine a puppet string running from the base of the spine to the top of the head, being gently pulled upward so that all the vertebrae separate. There should be a feeling of growing tall and light—a sense of energy running up the spine without any tension or tightness. The head should feel balanced on top. Now just let everything relax off that central column.

Here we can help ourselves relax with some simple exercises. First, let's see how relaxed we can become by simply telling muscles to relax. Start from the top of the head and work down the rest of the body. Come down over the brow, the eyes, the cheeks, the jaw—especially the jaw—the neck, shoulders, arms, and hands. Just feel everything getting heavier as tension stops supporting them. Now go back to the chest and relax it. Move down to the stomach, to the abdomen, relaxing as best you can. Finally, feel your legs heavy on the floor.

Superficial surface tension should now be released, if only a little. But we may feel a deeper level of tension, more habitual and therefore not easy to relax by mental volition alone. We can use a second technique here: muscular tension. Where you feel tension, tense the muscles in that area as hard as you can, then release them slowly. This is especially good for tension in the face. Just screw up the face as much as you can now. Hold it. And relax. Let's try that again. Hold it. Hold it. And relax.

This technique is also good for the neck and shoulders. Tighten up that whole area now. Hold it. And relax slowly. Let's try that again. Tighten up the whole area—neck and shoulders. Hold it. And just relax slowly.

A third technique is best for tensions felt in the chest, though it affects the whole body: controlled breathing. Take a slow, deep in-breath, fill the lungs to capacity, hold for as long as comfortable, and just let the whole ribcage fall quickly, expelling all the air. Then wait for the next breath to arise naturally; this prevents hyperventilation. So now let's take in a deep breath, hold it, and just let it go. Let's try that again. Take a deep breath. Hold it. And just let it go.

Hopefully you will now have developed a deep relaxation. We should find ourselves in a posture highly conducive to meditation. The spine should be energised but not tense. The rest of the body should feel relaxed, hanging, as it were, off this central column. And the head should be gently poised on top, symbolising the balance between physical alertness and relaxation. For a few moments now, let's feel this posture as a whole and recognise its qualities of alert energy and calm relaxation.

Now we need to develop the same sense of energetic alertness and relaxed calmness in the mind, and to achieve this we use the breath. Place your attention on the abdomen and feel its rising and falling motion as you breathe naturally. Please note this is not a breathing technique—the breath should not be interfered with. It may be that the breath is not obvious to you at the abdomen, in which case see if you can feel it at the chest, rising and falling. The breath at the nostrils may also be used, but for the Mahāsi technique it's preferable to use the abdomen. See now which one is most obvious to you.

Whichever place you've chosen, this is your primary object of meditation. You will use this place to establish an alert and calm awareness. If you move from one place to another—say from the nose to the abdomen—this will undermine your ability to become concentrated. That is, the ability to watch with an alert but calm attention without flitting away.

If you're watching the breath process at the abdomen or chest, observe the movement, the rising and falling, and use a noting word to still the thinking process. With the in-breath, note "rising, rising," and with the out-breath, note "falling, falling." After the out-breath there's a rest, and there's danger that the mind will run away on fantasies. To stop this happening, we choose a touch point—it may be the feeling of your hands on your lap, or the feeling of your legs on the floor. Choose what is most obvious.

As you feel the abdomen or chest rising with the in-breath, feel those sensations, watch them closely, and point your attention directly at them, noting "rising, rising." In the same way, as you feel the abdomen or chest falling with the out-breath, feel the sensations of the movement, watch them intently, and note "falling, falling." If there's a pause before the in-breath, note a touching point: "touching, touching, touching." Be sure, as soon as the in-breath starts, to return immediately to the abdomen or the chest.

If you're concentrating at the nostrils, the process is the same, except it's more appropriate to use the noting words "in, in," "out, out"—while remembering to concentrate on the sensations at the nostrils or the upper lip, wherever the passage of air is felt most acutely.

Please note, it doesn't matter how many times you say the noting word. Once may be enough. What's important is to be attentive to the feelings or sensations as they arise. The word itself is of little importance—it's just a simple and very effective way to stop the mind from wandering. What you must pay attention to are all the sensations caused by the process of breathing.

You may find that your mind wanders off on thoughts and fantasies. When you wake up out of them, just note "thinking, thinking" or "dreaming, dreaming" once or twice, then quickly and firmly go back to watching the sensations of breathing. But you mustn't be rough or forceful. Training the mind is a bit like training a puppy dog to sit. When it gets up, you have to pat it down kindly but firmly. If you get angry and hit it, it will just want to run away.

Now let's practise this breathing meditation for a while, observing and noting all the sensations. "Rising... falling, touching." If your mind is wandering, note what it's doing—dreaming, thinking, worrying, and so on—and bring it back gently but firmly to the breath. If you feel sleepy, put more energy into the spine. Sit tall, but not tense.

This part of the meditation is mainly concerned with establishing concentration. It's normal to spend a good ten minutes doing this until the mind becomes fairly still—at least until gross restlessness has gone and you can watch the object, in this case the breath, fairly constantly. We use the breath because it's a neutral feeling; it doesn't excite or depress us. So the mind becomes still and moves to a point of concentration by way of calm and peacefulness.

This is different from the sort of concentration we get when doing something engrossing, such as watching a film or having to do a job carefully. That depends upon stimulation, but the concentration we need for insight must arise out of a quiet and still mind. When this sort of concentrated, quiet mind is established, we find another faculty becomes prominent: our intuitive intelligence, *paññā*.

Sometimes, when you're trying to listen to shortwave radio, there's so much interference it's hard to hear exactly what's being said. Once the fuzz goes, everything becomes clear. So it is with *paññā*, our intuitive intelligence. Once the heart is calm and concentrated, and thinking and imagining have stopped, the intuitive intelligence is able to see and understand clearly what's going on.

So now what we have to do is establish this concentrated attentiveness, alive with intelligence—*satipaññā*—not just on the breath, but on anything that comes into our field of awareness. The example I like is that of a bird watcher. They sit in a so-called hide, hidden from the birds they're watching. In this way the birds are not disturbed, and their natural habits can be observed. All the knowledge—of feeding, nesting, mating, and so on—comes by just observing, merely watching. This ability to be simply observers, interested to discover the true nature of our body, mind, and heart, is the key to spiritual insight.

But this watching, please understand clearly, is not a searching for something. We're not looking for something. We're just non-interfering observers, looking at whatever comes into our field of awareness, watching whatever arises right here and now, while it's happening, without any thoughts about it or questions.

So we begin by establishing attentiveness on the breath. Should a sound be heard, we avert to it immediately, noting "hearing, hearing." Try to catch the quality of the sound at the very eardrum. In this way we'll stop the mind flying out, as it were, to the object—a chirping bird or passing car—and setting up a whole train of imaginative thoughts.

The same with smell: note it as "smelling, smelling," right there in the nostrils. And again with any sensations on the body, such as itching and prickling—just note "itching, itching," "prickling, prickling," right there where the sensations are felt, and plunge your attention into them.

Then there are feelings that arise in the body, such as heat and cold, heaviness and lightness, all sorts of discomforts and pleasures. A particular word like "heat" or "cold" can be used where appropriate; otherwise a general word, "feeling," will do. It's important we don't react to these feelings unless they're too severe to tolerate, for to react to them will lead us into restlessness. And do remember: the noting word is a technique we use to keep the attention steady on the object. In other words, it controls the thinking faculty, but the attention itself should bury itself into the actual sensations.

Again, there are feelings in the body arising from moods and emotions: dislikeable ones such as fear and depression, and likeable ones such as joy and love. We can use specific words here—"love," "guilt," and so on—but all the time feeling fully the mood or emotion, the actual feelings wherever they occur, such as in the chest or stomach.

Finally, there are thoughts and images. Note these as "thinking" or "imagining," and they will stop. Otherwise, they will carry you off onto a daydream, sometimes for the whole of the meditation period. And be especially aware of the judging mind: "That's terrible," "That's good," "That's bad," "That's nice," and so on. Don't correct or interfere with such thoughts. Just acknowledge them and note "judging, judging."

We're not trying to become spectators, getting involved in all the mental play, supporting this against that. We must take the position of an observer, an objective observer, just allowing all the play to unfold right there before our very gaze.

All the time we're trying to maintain that separation, that distance, that detachment from what's going on in the body, mind and heart. We observe all these psychophysical events as something other, as if belonging to someone else. In this way we can investigate objectively.

So whatever is offered – a sensation, a feeling, a thought – just watch it carefully. So now, let's sit tall, and with keen interest, let's watch the flow of physical and mental phenomena. Begin always with the breath: "rising, falling, touching."

Sometimes there's a lot of pain, aching and tension comes up in the body. This won't be due to posture so long as the posture is correct. They'll probably be caused by unresolved emotions and mental states that have until now been suppressed out of consciousness. It's important to relax around them and develop an attitude of interest. Such discomfort, sometimes severe, may continue throughout a whole sitting or for many sittings until it resolves itself, and it may be that the underlying reason, such as an emotion, will not manifest itself. Just the passing of the discomfort will mean that the curing has taken place.

We need to develop patience to bear this sort of thing and use the opportunity to see pain as pain – just sensations – and to separate out the suffering which is the aversion or fear we feel towards them. We make both sides, the painful sensations and the mental attitudes, objects to be noted, observed, and understood.

Here we are sitting within ourselves, as it were, watching the inner films. The body, mind and heart display themselves just as they want. We don't interfere. It's a natural process of revelation. In time, many things may arise out of the subconscious which have long been suppressed. They'll reveal themselves when the time is right and the time is right when we'll be ready to accept them. In this way, insight meditation brings about a psychotherapy. Even painful traumatic memories from childhood will be eventually cleared out of the system, and with them all the neuroses and tensions they've caused. All we have to do to attain this purification of the heart is to remain steadfast at our observation post.

Now, although the cleansing of our psychology will happen naturally, it's not the aim of our meditation. The aim of our practice is to go to the deepest levels to see why suffering arises in the first place. One way is to note the relationship we have to whatever is being observed. The mind constantly jumps from liking to disliking, wanting what it likes, not wanting what it dislikes. This sort of involvement is simply a way in which we try to find happiness in pleasurable states and escape unhappiness by running away from unpleasurable states.

This constant oscillation, this ricocheting from greed to aversion and back to greed, this is what the Buddha taught as the cause of our suffering in the Second Noble Truth. So, as pleasurable or unpleasurable objects arise, we must keenly note this secondary reaction of grabbing at them or pushing them away, sometimes turning away in fear, the twin of aversion. In this way, this reaction will cool down and even stop, and we shall experience a deeply satisfying equanimous mind. And this in turn will allow us to investigate deeper into the causes of suffering.

So let all that pain and pleasure surface and express itself. Watch the reaction, the grabbing, the aversion, the fear. Begin again with the breath: "rising, falling, touching."

As we begin to deepen our awareness of all the phenomena arising in our body, mind and heart, we'll become increasingly aware of what the Buddha called the three characteristics of existence. The first is the fact of transience. Everything is arising only to pass away.

The second is the difficult teaching of non-self. As we watch all these mental and physical phenomena, we'll notice they arise of themselves. There's no one controlling them. They have their own life, their own energy. At times the body, mind and heart may seem distant, something other. Before we talked of "my sensations," "my thoughts," "my emotions," but now we find ourselves pointing at them, as it were, through the noting technique. "There's a sensation," "there's a thought," "there's a feeling." We're slowly moving away from a relationship of identity and possession: "I am my seeing," "I am what I think," "I am what I feel," "I have a body," "I have a mind," "I have a heart." Instead, we're moving towards a position of detachment. This is the beginning of the experience of non-self. We discover that the psychophysical organism we call "me" doesn't constitute anything substantial. It's just made up of many parts that work in unison, just like a car. But there's no core to it, no substance.

Thirdly, as we've noticed, whenever we do fall into a relationship of attachment, desire or aversion to the body, mind and heart, of identifying and possessing, suffering follows.

This is the third characteristic: unsatisfactoriness. We should develop an attitude towards the body, mind and heart like one who rents a house, not one who owns it.

It's the observation of these three characteristics—transience, insubstantiality and unsatisfactoriness—that brings about the spiritual insights releasing consciousness from its delusions and leading to liberation from all suffering. And *vipassanā* is the tool we use. This bare attentiveness, simply observing all that arises and passes away; this choiceless awareness that doesn't control or manipulate; this impartial watchfulness that doesn't question or judge; this intuitive introspection, fully experiencing each mental and bodily phenomenon as it really is—this is the faculty of intuitive awareness, *satipaṇṇā*, the very faculty that will eventually bring the realisation of Nibbāna: the unborn, the unbecome, the unmade, the unconditioned.

All we have to do is watch. Just observe whatever arises as it arises and passes away. So let's begin again with the breath. Rising, falling, touching.

During daily life, to sit like this even for a few moments—long enough to re-establish a calm and alert attentiveness—will stop our emotions from snowballing. It will undermine the causes of stress. Just fifteen seconds may be enough to re-establish our centre. With practice, this can become a regular state of mind, instead of something that comes only under special conditions.

This calm heart and alert mind is the state we ought to be in all the time, even under stress. It's within this inner environment that intuitive awareness, *satipaṇṇā*, can operate. Otherwise it becomes lost, drowned and controlled by runaway thoughts and emotions. Constantly make the effort to regain and maintain this inner posture. This is to live fully consciously.

In this way, the practice of *vipassanā*—insight meditation—will seep into every moment of our lives, and we'll be rewarded with great benefits.

Now, when we come to the end of a meditation period, it's best not to just jump out of it but to come out slowly. First, open the eyes and take in the light, gently swaying from side to side. Then rise slowly and mindfully. In this way our intuitive mindfulness, *satipaṇṇā*, will be maintained.

May you be well. May you be happy. May you soon be liberated from all your suffering. May you experience the peace and bliss of Nibbāna.

Why Noting Without Stop

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 7 min

Originally given as *Why Noting Without Stop* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this teaching on Mahasi vipassanā technique, Bhante Bodhidhamma addresses a common question: why should practitioners continue noting without stopping? Drawing from the classical Mahasi tradition, he explains that noting engages the vijñāna—the discerning mind that distinguishes and categorizes experience through concepts and words.

Using the traditional metaphor of a bee approaching a flower, Bhante describes the two stages of vitakka-vicāra (initial and sustained application): first the mind circles around an object, then settles upon it. Many meditators mistakenly stop noting when concentration seems stable, but this premature cessation leads to wandering. The noting mind, when properly conditioned through consistent practice, becomes automatic and continues to support steadiness even as satipaṇṇā (intuitive awareness) develops its capacity for direct experience.

Bhante explains how advanced practitioners may shift from noting specific sensations to noting the process of experiencing itself, deepening attention through phrases like "feeling, feeling." He describes the eventual natural separation between the knowing awareness and the noting mind, culminating in moments when satipaṇṇā completely merges with its object—a non-self experience beyond personal control. This practical guidance illuminates why continuous noting remains crucial throughout all stages of concentration development.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa — homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble, and fully self-enlightened one.

A quick note about the technique. In the strict Mahāsi tradition, one doesn't stop noting. The reason is that the noting mind is the discerning mind. For those of you who know your *khandhas*, that's the *viññāṇa* — the mind that can distinguish between black and white, that knows what something is for. It's the higher faculty of the mind.

This discerning mind works on basic perceptions, basic cognitions. It uses words, concepts, images — but mainly words, thinking. At first, when beginners start the Mahāsi method, it's up front in your face. It's like you're watching yourself; all you're aware of are these words coming out of your head. But as you keep displacing your attention onto feeling, onto sensation, the words recede and become like a quiet note in the background.

As you begin to settle on an object, to fix on it — we were talking yesterday about the two stages of *vitakka-vicāra*, the bee flying around the flower and the bee landing. While you're noting, the bee is flying around the flower, and then suddenly you find yourself landing on it. The noting might seem to get in the way, so the meditator stops — and before long they're wandering again, because the landing on the flower has not matured.

If a thought arises like, "My attention is steady — I'm really steady on the rising and falling of some object" — and you keep noting, that noting now becomes automatic. Sometimes you might find it more skillful not to note so much what you're experiencing, but the process of experiencing. Instead of saying "pain, pain" — or it might be a subtle sensation for which there's no word — you might use the word "feeling." You're using the word "feeling" to describe what you're actually feeling.

But at that point, it's often more skillful to describe what you're actually doing, which is feeling the object. When you say "feeling, feeling," you're driving your attention closer and closer, more steady on the object in the act of feeling. You're actually feeling. Because this *satipaṇṇā*, this intuitive awareness, has the ability not only to observe at that level, but also to directly feel, to directly experience.

When that bee really sticks to the flower, you may be surprised to find that this very noting mind distances itself. There's quite a clear separation between the knowing and the noting. The noting carries on because it's been conditioned to carry on discerning — just like when you've learnt to walk, and now when you cross the road you don't have to be aware of your legs; the legs just do it. This dis-

cerning mind keeps discerning, and you're aware of both the object and this discerning mind. But the discerning mind is still helping you, still keeping you on the object. See, still keeping you there.

In the classic Mahāsi teaching you don't stop, because at some point that bee begins to so suck the nectar that it loses itself in the nectar — and there's, it sounds a bit dramatic, a collapse. There's a complete joining of this *satipaṇṇā* with what it's actually experiencing, at which point the thinking mind shuts down. At that point, *satipaṇṇā* is at its purest. Not that insights can't come before that, but here it is extremely pure — and it's not something you can manufacture.

You can get yourself to that point by diligently noting and diligently guiding your attention to the object. But you can't make it collapse, because that collapse is a non-self experience. It's beyond your power. As soon as you say, "Let it collapse," there's somebody there saying it. You can't do it. That has to happen naturally.

The Body - Kāyagatāsati Sutta (MN 119)

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 47 min

Originally given as *The Body - Kāyagatāsati Sutta (MN 119)* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this detailed exploration of the Kāyagatāsati Sutta (MN 119), Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the Buddha's comprehensive teaching on body contemplation. Beginning with the remarkable complexity of our physical form—12 billion neurons, millions of cells dying and regenerating each second—he highlights how little the mind truly knows about the body it inhabits.

The talk covers the four main aspects of body meditation: breath awareness (ānāpānasati) as the foundation for both samatha and vipassanā practice; full awareness (sampajañña) in all postures and daily activities; contemplation of the body's repulsive aspects to develop equanimity rather than disgust; and the powerful practice of death reflection (maraṇasati). Bhante emphasizes that these contemplations should be practiced regularly in small doses to gradually transform our relationship with embodied existence.

Drawing from both ancient wisdom and modern science, this teaching offers practical guidance for developing a balanced understanding of our physical nature—neither clinging to the body as self nor rejecting it with aversion, but cultivating gratitude and equanimity toward this temporary vessel that supports our spiritual development.

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble, and fully self-awakened one.

Last time, we explored how the mind experiences the body, looking especially at those four great elements. But of course there's also the body as an organism, and the first thing that always strikes me about this little book called *Human Body*—whenever I pick it up and read a bit—is that I'm absolutely gobsmacked.

For instance, the brain contains twelve billion neurons and fifty billion supportive glial cells. Twelve billion neurons. The mind boggles. You can fit all that inside your skull. It's an amazing figure.

And then it goes on about the spinal cord. Here's another one, even slightly more interesting in a way: every second, two million oxygen-bearing red blood cells die. Every second. I'm not aware of that, are you?

But they're replaced at the same rate by new ones generated in the process of erythropoiesis—something like that anyway. This begins in the kidney cells, which are stimulated by low oxygen levels to release a hormone. The hormone travels to the body's red bone marrow, which stimulates increased production, raising the blood oxygen levels. And these cells have to make their way through the bone into the blood. That's remarkable, isn't it?

When you read books like this and realise all this stuff's going on without your having a clue—absolutely not a clue—you do feel a bit like a body snatcher. Like you're in this body and somehow you're not really connected.

That's our first contemplation, really: that the mind simply doesn't know this stuff. There's nothing in the Buddha's teaching about it. If he'd known, for instance, that malaria was carried by mosquitoes, I think he'd have told us. But he didn't. You probably know that the word malaria comes from the Italian *mal'aria*, meaning 'bad air', because the Romans thought it was the bad air off the swamp that was giving them the illness. It's only in very recent times—over the past hundred or so, hundred and fifty years—that we've got these facts.

What comes across to me is that every one of these little cells produces its own energy and a bit more for us. And it's got its own little intelligence. It knows what it's supposed to do: go and pick up oxygen, deposit it, and then die. It's just remarkable.

We're contemplating the fact that we have this connection with the body, which is absolutely intimate. Our identity lies with the body. How do you know that? You know it when serious illness comes along, when death looms you in the face—the fear, the anxiety that comes. And yet all this science is telling you that you can't be the body. The body is made up of billions and billions of cells, and they're all dying. They're all dying all the time.

The cornea in your eye is changed every week. Every week, you've got a new cornea, a new eye. Amazing. And supposedly, the body changes all its cells within a period of seven years. I've had ten bodies. Ten completely renovated bodies. Ten completely re-gearred bodies. I shall leave you with that.

The Buddha knows this, of course. He knows that the body is not him. And there's a whole discourse devoted to the body called the *Kāyagatāsati Sutta*. *Kāya* means body. *Gatā* means 'towards the body' or 'going' or 'about the body'. *Sati* means awareness of it. And *Sutta* means discourse.

I must put you onto this website—it's absolutely wonderful. It's run by a monk called *Ānandajoti*, an English fellow who was with me in the monastery I was at in Burma. He's ended up being a very good scholar and lives now in Thailand. What he's done with a number of discourses is put the translation underneath the Pali so you can actually see how the words all connect. It's really quite interesting for those of you who want to know a bit of Pali.

The discourse begins with monks gathered in a hall, saying to one another: 'Wonderful friends, marvellous friends, how it is said that the Gracious One who knows, who sees, the Worthy One, the Perfect Sambuddha—mindfulness related to the body, when it has been developed and made much of, yields great fruit and brings great advantages.'

Just then, the Buddha gets up from his seat and interrupts them. 'What were you talking about before I came in?' They tell him they've been discussing this contemplation of the body. So he takes the opportunity to go into it in greater detail.

The first thing he goes into, of course, is the breath. When you read this, it translates as: he sits cross-legged, setting his body up straight. He goes to the wilderness, to the root of a tree, to an empty place. That normally means the wilderness is for the cold season, the root of a tree for the hot season, and the hut for the rainy season. This was the life of those ascetics at the time.

He sits cross-legged, establishes his mind in front of him, breathes in, breathes out. And while breathing in a long breath, he knows: 'I am breathing in a long breath.'

Now, the Pali is *dīghaṃ assasāmi*. The verb in Pali is like Italian—it includes the pronoun. So *mi* means 'I', *ti* means 'you', and so on. You can't really separate them. It's the same in Italian: *amo*, *ami*, *ama*—'I love', 'you love', and so forth. The way you get around it in Italian is by adding the pronoun separately.

You've got to be careful about this 'I' business. In our noting we just say 'rising' and 'falling', but you can't actually say that in Pali unless you use the infinitive. Be a little careful when you read this stuff, because it seems as though he's noting, but it could also just be a reflection. And then you observe the breath.

The word he uses here is *pajānāti*. That *ñ*—'to know'—comes right through to our language as *gn*, as in 'knowledge', or *kn*. The *pa* means to really know, and we translate it as insight—to actually feel, to realise, to experience it. He uses *pajānāti* for knowing there's a short breath or a long breath, and so on.

Then he says 'trains himself'. He uses a different word here, *sikkhati*—to train himself experiencing the whole body. 'I will breathe in the whole body. I will breathe out, making the bodily process calm. I will breathe in. Making the bodily process calm, I will breathe out.' So there's your *samatha* quality. That's the beginning of any of our meditation—just trying to settle the mind on the breath a little bit. And then when you're settled, you open up.

'He trains himself.' What he doesn't say here—which it does say in the *Satipaṭṭhāna* discourse, the discourse on how to establish awareness—is that you train until you reach such a point where the *sati* and the *paññā*, the awareness and the intuitive intelligence, are at such a pitch that insight arises. For some reason, that's not included here.

So that's the breath. And then there's always this little verse at the end. 'For one who is living heedful'—he's translated it as 'heedful' here; this is *appamādo*, one of the Buddha's last words, which we normally translate as 'diligent'. Then *ātāpino*, meaning *ātāpi*—very devoted effort. And *pahitatta*, which is 'resolute'.

These are the three qualities he expects us to have: to be diligent with the noting, with the feeling, with the seeing; to put real ardent energy into it. Remember, this is not the energy of trying to gain something. It's just the energy of trying to be aware of what is. Just enough energy to keep the attention steady on the object—and resolute.

I think I've told one or two of you about a meditator I asked how he could stay on the breath for so long. He said, 'Well, I do what they do when they're pumping iron. Rising, falling—just one more. Rising, falling—just one more.' And that way he keeps himself resolute on observing the breath.

Then he speaks of 'whatever rushing thoughts are dependent on the household life.' This is normally translated as regrets and planning and all that sort of stuff. But I think I agree with those who translate it as 'rushing thoughts'—even

Bhikkhu Bodhi renders it as memories and intentions and other things like that. It depends how you look at the word. And it seems to me that 'rushing thoughts' makes much more sense, because that's what we actually experience, isn't it? Thoughts constantly coming.

When it says 'dependent on the household life,' it means dependent on sense pleasures. That's what 'household life' means here. It doesn't mean that a householder—or in our terms, a lay person—can't also have spiritual aims. It's just that when you see 'household life' in the scriptures, the Buddha is referring to those who are entirely devoted to sense pleasures.

'And are given up when they're given up.' With the giving up of these rushing thoughts, the mind becomes internally stable, settles down, becomes well-pointed and concentrated. And like this does a monk develop mindfulness related to the body.

When you're reading the scriptures and you see 'monk'—the commentary always says it means whoever's meditating. It's just a figure of speech. I can't remember the term for it: using a part to mean the whole. 'All hands on deck'—that sort of thing.

So then he goes on to postures. You've got your four postures. And again he says, 'The monk while going knows I am going.' Going and coming—so there's your walking meditation. He knows when he's standing and when he's sitting. He knows when he's lying down, and whatever way his body is disposed, he knows it just that way. So again it's just this business of being with what you're doing. Being what you're doing, actually.

Then there's the verse again, which we've just read. And then there's 'full awareness.' He translates this as sampajānakārī. Kārī means doing. Pajāna means to really experience it. And sam means with. So basically, it's doing something really mindfully. Doing really mindfully what we're doing. Sampajānakārī.

Here he's got a whole list of things. Of course it's related to the monastic life, but it's easy to translate to ordinary daily life. 'When looking ahead or looking around, he is one who practises full awareness.' Now in the dining hall, I often see people picking up their plate mindfully, looking around, and then keeping their eye on the food in the distance while their legs slowly take them to the counter. And of course when you get there you have to watch yourself, you see. When you see what they take—one, you're going to watch these thoughts, and let them go.

'When he's looking around. When he's bending and stretching, he practises full awareness. When he's bearing his robe and bowl'—so when we're dressing, and so on—'he practises full awareness' of what he's actually doing. 'Eating, drinking, chewing and tasting.' See, it's there—the accent on the whole process of eating. And then 'passing stool and urine,' which is nicely put, 'he practises full awareness.'

Now, often, generally speaking, when it comes to that sort of activity in the lavatory, we try to keep the mind somewhere else—Timbuktu or something. But it's a good practice to actually be with the whole process of evacuation. There's a nice word. We'll keep it Latin. Evacuation—although I do like Anglo-Saxon words for it.

Just as a little aside, you do know where the word 'crap' comes from? Well, the nineteenth century was full of wonderful inventions. One was the U-pipe, which filled up with water and stopped the smell of the sewer coming up into the room. And the person who invented that was called Mr Crapper. He's not only left us with this lovely invention, but with a noun, a verb, an adverb, and an adjective. Quite a legacy. Poor old Mr Crapper. Anyway, that's by the by.

So this urine business—for a very long time, maybe about five years actually, I started in that. Every morning, diligently, I drank a third of my urine, according to the yoga practice. You let a third go, you keep the middle third, you let the rest go, and then you drink it. And the great teaching is that it's okay—it's actually fine. It has vitamins, it has antibiotics, you've got all sorts of things in there, you see. And I never felt better.

Unfortunately there was this other monk, an American, and you can read this book called *The Waters of Life*—it's all about retaining your urine. He was drinking all of it, all day. And he was coming out with great big boils out of his skin. We said to him, 'Your skin is the biggest excretory organ we've got, actually. It's all coming out through the skin, you see.' And he said, 'No, no. I've read this book.' I don't know what happened to him. He probably disappeared in a great big sore. Poor man. Well, let's hope somebody told him.

So again, the text says: when standing, sitting, sleeping, walking, talking, and maintaining silence. Sleeping is a bit difficult. I think you can understand it to mean from the moment you lie in bed until you fall asleep. But some of you may find that as your concentration grows, you actually wake up within sleep—you know you're asleep and you're just awake in it.

I often talk about a student I had—I haven't seen her for a very long time now—but she did lots of practice visualising Chinese deities or Buddhas, I can't remember which. Such was her concentration that she told me she'd go to bed and wake up in sleep, and she'd be awake all night. But the body would be completely asleep, the brain would be asleep, everything asleep. She woke up perfectly refreshed. That tells you something. It's not an aim in order to become fully liberated—I'm just saying it's a consequence.

Let's have a look now. The next section is—actually, I should have talked about my healthy drink in this particular session, because this is about the repulsiveness of the body. So let me give you the background story.

It seems the Buddha gave a very detailed talk about this. He talked to the bhikkhus in many ways on the subject of impurity. He spoke in praise of what is impure. He spoke in praise of the contemplation of what is impure. And he spoke again and again in praise of the stage of meditation on what is impure—because you can get to access jhāna, I think, with this practice.

And the monks dwelt upon the practice of contemplating what is impure in different ways. They were troubled by their own bodies, ashamed of them, loathing them. It's as if a young woman or man, delicate and fond of dressing up, having washed their hair, would be troubled, ashamed, and full of loathing because they had the corpse of a snake or a dog or a man hung around their neck.

So these bhikkhus, being troubled by their own bodies, ashamed of them and loathing them, deprived themselves of life and deprived each other of life.

When the Buddha hears this, he states: Bhikkhus, this is not suitable for these bhikkhus. It is not fit. It is not proper. It is not worthy of a disciple. It is not good. It should not be done.

So they'd obviously got very enthused—he'd given this great talk about the repulsiveness of the body, and they just got into the repulsiveness of it and drove themselves to suicide. It's a bit odd, isn't it?

So then, of course, he makes a rule. This comes out of the Vinaya. It ends up with a rule concerning one of the four Pārājikas—if you break any of these, you're actually no longer a monk or nun. There's no ceremony for disrobing a monastic. Basically, if a monastic grouping decides that somebody has committed this offence, they can ask him to leave the monastery. But so long as he can get lay people to feed him and give him a place, there's very little to force him out. He has to do it from his own conscience, really.

So then the Buddha made up this rule: Should any bhikkhu purposefully deprive a human being of life or provide him with a life-taking knife or recommend advantages in death or encourage him to kill himself—who should in fact recommend advantages in death or encourage him to kill himself in various ways, with such thoughts in mind and such intentions in mind as: 'Good man, what good is this miserable life to you? Death is better for you than life'—that bhikkhu is defeated and no more in communion.

So he didn't like that at all—that they'd encouraged each other to kill each other or in fact kill themselves. This business of the repulsion of the body: you have to be careful. I don't want to hear somebody's committed suicide having drunk their morning pee. So let's take it easier.

Anyway, he goes through the parts of the body, and the idea is that as you go through them, you're not purposefully building up disgust. You're actually trying to find out what your relationship is to these parts. As the images come to mind—hairs on the head—well, that rarely brings up any sense of disgust for people. It's the same with body hairs, or it might do with certain body hairs. Nails, teeth.

For some people, just picturing a tooth in the mind might bring up a certain reaction—I don't know. Skin rarely does, unless it's old and wrinkled and horrible. Flesh, sinews, bones, bone marrow, kidneys. As you go through the list for yourself, you're simply trying to catch your relationship to each part.

Heart, liver, spleen, lungs. I don't even know what my spleen looks like. Intestines, undigested food, excrement, bile. Now this is more like it. Bile, phlegm, pus, blood, sweat, and fat.

When you get in contact with your image of these—or when you encounter them in ordinary daily life, as we were talking about with going to the toilet—just catch your relationship to it. Ask yourself: is this reaction necessary?

Disgust is a natural response of the body to something it perceives as unhealthy. If you put rotting food in your mouth, you ought to feel disgusted. But the emotion of disgust—like when we say we are morally disgusted—you've got to ask yourself, is that necessary? Even though it might be a spontaneous reaction.

So it is with all these parts of the body. We've learnt this, we've been taught that this stuff is to be disgusted at. But when you actually question whether you should feel disgusted or not, as the disgust disappears, well, it's just parts of the body.

People who work in surgery, nurses, those in mortuaries—they get over that. In the East, if you are a monastic or you go with a monastic as a layperson, you can get easy entrance into the mortuary to see bodies being cut open and have a look.

For somebody going into such a place for the first time, there's just a dead body on this table, and the doctor—in this case it was a woman—was cutting it. The thing that strikes you about a dead body is that it is actually dead. Completely lifeless. It really is quite something to stay with.

In fact, my companion, another monk who'd come with me, had to leave. I think mainly because of the smell of substances they use to keep it antiseptic. When the body's cut and they're investigating what actually caused the death, you see it's all bits and pieces. It's quite remarkable, really, how it all fits together.

Then you're supposed to say, "Like this body is, so is mine." If you're going to do this exercise, it's best done just a little bit every day, as a reminder. You don't have to go through the whole list—just a little bit every day before your morning meditation or afterwards. Run through the body and remind yourself that this is the body, this is how it is. And the disgust is not necessary.

The one thing the list misses out, though it was added later, is the brain, the mataluṅga. I've asked a few people about that. Nobody knows why it was left out in the first place. It became the thirty-second part, I think— isn't it thirty-one? I can only think that they didn't know what it was.

To go back to what we were saying before about the senses—the five senses and the basis of the senses—happily, both in the discourses and in the later work of the Abhidhamma, the mind itself, the mind door, manodvāra, is not given a sense base. It's not actually given a sense base.

But the commentaries then began to think about this and decided it should have one. So they settled on a phial of blood—did I mention this? Yes—a phial of blood in the heart, which was the base for the mental door, the hadaya vatthu, the base of the heart. And they put it actually in the heart.

I've often wondered whether this was misplaced—whether what they were really connecting to was the heart chakra, which is in the middle of your chest here, and which, you might say, is the exchange box for your emotions. You might feel a certain tension in your abdomen, which you intuit as anxiety or something. But it's only when it rises into consciousness that you really feel it—you feel it in the chest, don't you? You don't feel anxious so much in your abdomen. It comes here and becomes an emotion you can recognise—anger, fear—it's all at this level.

I'm wondering whether they mistook it, or whether they were thinking about it because at the same time, of course, yoga was being developed. Anyway, this phial of blood—there was one teacher who was asked, "Well, if you have a heart transplant and the blood goes into the machine, your heart's stopped, and the blood's being pumped by a machine, where's this phial of blood?" He said it was in the machine. So any excuse.

I was very relieved to read that in fact the Buddha doesn't say this either in the discourses, and the people who put the Abhidhamma together don't say it either. I think the reason is that the base of the mind is the whole body. Any information that comes in from the five senses—this secondary door must be all over the body, as it were, sensitive to any of the five sense bases. That's the only way I can personally understand it.

So yes, those are the impurities. In the monastic life, where of course you take a vow of celibacy, this can be quite helpful. When a beautiful image comes to you which is erotic, you simply imagine it doing something not very pleasant. And immediately that desire does fade away.

Now, what you don't want to do is make the mistake of growing in disgust completely, so that as soon as a beautiful image arises, you get disgust. The two should cancel each other out, leaving you with a state of equanimity. But if you keep on with this business of disgust, you end up, instead of having erotic desires, with just a load of disgusting desires. You see what I mean? It's a sort of balance really. That's a skilful way of using the asubha, the unlovely parts of the body.

Now, I think we've done this. The sutta then goes into the elements. We went through all the elements and how you can visualise them inside yourself—the four elements. I think there was also the fifth, wasn't there? The space element. Did we do that? Maybe another time.

Then we finally come to, on the body side, the charnel grounds. Remember, in those days the bodies were just laid out and the animals ate them. They were wrapped in white cloth and simply left out there.

It was this white cloth that the mendicants—not just the ones of the Buddha—would take to make robes out of. One day, when he saw a group of his monks with these ragged robes just joined together as they came, bits and pieces, he thought that didn't look so nice. So he asked them to cut the pieces of cloth in a way that when laid out, it looked like a paddy field. If you ever see monastic robes, they've got squares with passageways around them. Then he asked them to boil the cloth

with the areca nut, which gives it a light brown colour. On top of that, he asked them to shave their heads. With this, they became quite distinguished from the long-hairs and the other robes. The Jains, of course, dress in white. If you see a Jain monk, they're dressed in white.

We don't have to hang around here too much. The Buddha simply goes through the various stages through which a body completely decomposes—dead after one or two days. Then the next stage, after being eaten by vultures, eaten by hawks, eaten by crows. It's all in bits and pieces.

Then comes a skeleton with flesh and blood still bound together by tendons. The next stage is a skeleton without flesh, smeared with blood, bound together by tendons. And the next, a skeleton no longer having flesh or blood, bound together with tendons. The tendons and the bones are the last to go.

Then the bones are scattered in all directions. A hand bone here, a foot bone there, a knee bone there—no longer connected, as in the great song. Then the white bones, bleached by the sun like a conch shell. I think there's one more—the eighth, maybe some more. Then just a heap of bones, a year old. So they're still hanging about, aren't they? And then they become like powder. Rotten bones have become like powder.

Those are your sets. And of course, let me go back a bit. With all of them, with all of those stages, the meditator compares it to their own very body, thinking: this body is also of such a nature, such a constitution, has not gone beyond this.

Remember our evening contemplations? That's the idea—you always connect with the rotting body. This is very difficult for us. We could do it with pictures, but unfortunately these days they just burn you up and give you a casket.

I was very fortunate when my first teacher died. She was cremated, and the ceremony was led by a Zen Buddhist nun from Throssel Hole. We had permission to go down to the hall of the coffins. There's a man there who handles all the coffins. He's got two ovens, and he opens the one that's empty, takes half an hour, and shovels the coffin in. But unfortunately, you never get to see the body burning. You have to go to India for that, to the burning ghats.

And that's always something to watch while saying to yourself: just as this body is, mine will also be. That's if you intend to be cremated. The idea, of course, is to really begin to sense the connection we have with the body—a connection that goes deep, real deep. I am the body.

Just on that point—I've got time. There's a whole chapter in the Visuddhimagga on how to contemplate death and the body. It starts off by saying there are types of death; there's timely death. And the development can be very simple. You can just sit very quietly and keep repeating to yourself: Death will take place. The life faculty will be interrupted. Or you can just keep saying the word death, because the word itself will lead you into your feeling about death. Maybe images come up. Fear comes up, and so on.

The first contemplation is the appearance of a murderer. Just as a murderer appears with a sword, thinking, "I shall cut this man's head off"—so it is as soon as you're born. At some point, it'll be cut off. Death is lurking behind us. There's that medieval tale—I was trying to find it, but I couldn't—where somebody meets death and then runs from it, saying, "I won't meet you." And he runs off to the market. And when he gets there, death's waiting for him. You can't escape it.

The next one is death as the ruin of success. This is the old thing about whatever you've achieved, you've just got to leave behind. All your money, all your great attainments, all your gold medals—they've all got to be left behind. I remember somebody asked a solicitor, what did the very rich elderly lady leave behind? And he said, "Everything."

Then there's the contemplation of comparing oneself to others. All these people who died—David Bowie, that's a shock, isn't it? You've got all these people who were perhaps icons in our lives, people we know. And they're all dead. Recently—you probably won't know this—there was a very good footballer who was taking a plane across the channel, and unfortunately the plane dropped in the water. I can't remember his name. He drowned. He was only about twenty-six or so. A great tragedy.

Then there's sharing the body with many. I thought this was rather good because they must have known this. The body is shared by many—shared by the eighty families of worms. Creatures live in dependence on the outer skin, feeding on the outer skin. Creatures live in dependence on the inner skin, feeding on the inner skin. Dependence on flesh, feeding on the flesh. It goes right the way through. Born, grown, die, evacuate and make water.

Even these little creatures that we know live in our bowels, helping us to digest things—they also are born, grow old, die, evacuate and make water. There's also this contemplation of the fact that our body is home to a lot of other little creatures. Not ours, is it?

Then there's the signlessness of death—as Jesus said, we know not the hour nor the day. We just don't know our destiny. We just don't know. That's worth contemplating.

And then the limitedness of extent: the extent of human life is short. One who lives long lives a hundred, more or less—that's all. The life of humankind is short. A wise man holds it in contempt and acts as one whose head is burning. Death will never fail to come. A bit gloomy though, isn't it?

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And then there's contemplating the shortness of the moment—bringing that momentariness to mind. In fact, I'm one breath away from death. One half breath away. I breathe in, and that's the end of it.

I always like to tell this rather sad tale. I can't help but find it humorous, though for the people involved it was obviously very tragic. There was a woman I knew who came back and met an old love from her early life. They fell in love—they were quite elderly—and determined to marry and live together. They moved into a beautiful cottage. And one morning, he was just on his way to get the toast, had a heart attack, and died.

I always think: if I had a piece of toast with marmalade on it, holding it right here in front of my very nose, and then—is that not suffering?

Just to bring this talk to an end: the contemplation of death is very powerful. The Buddha says that of all the contemplations, this is the most powerful—the contemplation of death.

There's a lot to recall when you call the body to mind. We don't actually experience the body directly—we don't experience these cells, we don't experience what the liver is doing right now. I think you'd have to have some sort of extraordinary ability to know that.

And then there's that whole business of our relationship to the body. We've talked about repulsiveness, but as you know, I suggest that in the morning, with the very first beverage you have, you take the opportunity to thank the body. That

thankfulness forms a relationship. See how wonderful it is—it makes you want to care for it, not put it in danger, not put it where it's going to fall ill, where you're going to fall over and all that. A sense of gratitude.

And then finally, this very strong, powerful contemplation of death. It really is powerful if you just bring it up. As I say, these exercises, like mettā, are done best every day, just for a little while—little reminders. Then it gets through to you. It begins to change your attitude, to actually have an effect on you. It's no good doing it once every year, you see. It's the constant effort. Just a little reminder, that's all.

It does change you. Just the matter of reflecting changes you over a period of time. It has to—because every time you reflect on something, you're developing a certain attitude. And old attitudes, which may be contrary to this, are not being developed. So they atrophy. If you don't use your muscles, they just die away. It's the same with these attitudes we see as unwholesome. If you just let them come up, feel the desire to act that way, and let it go, they're slowly dying. Burning out. But you have to replace them with something positive.

I can only hope my words have been of some assistance, that they haven't caused even greater confusion. May you, by your contemplation of the body, arrive at that place of perfect peace and happiness—sooner rather than later.

Discourse on the Establishment of Awareness: Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta (MN 10) - Elements and Charnel Ground Contemplations

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 19 min

Originally given as *Discourse on the Establishment of Awareness: Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta (MN 10) - Elements and Charnel Ground Contemplations* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this profound exploration of the Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta (MN 10), Bhante Bodhidhamma examines two crucial contemplations within the body section: the four elements (mahābhūta) and the nine charnel ground reflections. He explains how the classical elements of earth, water, fire, and air correspond to pressure, cohesiveness, temperature, and motion, demonstrating their practical application in vipassanā meditation. Through vivid examples, Bhante shows how to deconstruct painful sensations by investigating their elemental components, moving beyond conceptual suffering to direct perception at the sense base level.

The teaching then turns to the traditional charnel ground contemplations, where practitioners reflect on corpses in various stages of decay. Bhante shares personal experiences with death and explains how death contemplation paradoxically brings us into the present moment, fostering appreciation for life's preciousness. He emphasizes the Buddha's direct experiential knowledge of these practices and their role in developing Right Awareness and insight into impermanence (anicca). This teaching offers both theoretical understanding and practical guidance for incorporating these profound contemplations into daily meditation practice and spiritual development.

Good evening. I trust you had a fruitful day. I don't say happy, although I do hope it has been.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

We're continuing our passage through the discourse on the foundations—or the establishment—of mindfulness. We're looking at the body. The first section is the body, and we've been through the breath: using the breath for mindfulness and seeing mainly impermanence. Then the four postures, and then full awareness, which is basically daily life practice. After that we have the body parts, to overcome any sense of disgust with the body. Remember, it's about being disenchanted.

Two more sections remain: one is called the elements and one is called the nine charnel grounds. These elements—I think this runs across the ancient world actually—were said to determine four different characteristics, from which the mind built up some image, some feeling. They were earth, which has to do with pressure and lightness; fire, which has to do with heat, cold, and warmth; water, which is elasticity and cohesiveness, so it also includes stiffness; and air or wind, which is motion or, again, stillness.

These were meant to be investigated when we actually meditate. Now, it's pretty clear to see when we're doing touch—the feeling of touch. We'll come to it in a minute. With eyesight, it's the subatomic particles, which is quite amazing really when you think about it—to be sensitive to subatomic particles. Photons, light, maybe heat, but it's not really discussed. The ears: definitely pressure, definitely the pressure of sound waves. And that's actually all you get at the ear drum—that's the sense base. Everything else is done by what's known as the mind door, the whole process within the mind itself, turning it into a sound, giving it a meaning. When it comes to taste and smell, that's even more subtle in a way. I don't think they pertain so clearly to these four elements, although things like pressure and heat—that's obvious when you're eating—but the more subtle sensations I think really aren't explained by these four. That's just a personal understanding.

If you want the traditional understanding, it's in the *Visuddhimagga*, The Path of Purification by Buddhaghosa. There's a whole section there if you want it. It's a big tome—probably one of the great spiritual works of the world, of any spiritual tradition. It holds not only the understanding of the Buddha but also all the practices. It's quite a compendium. You wouldn't want to read it from the first page to the end; there are about a thousand pages. But as an encyclopedia of spiritual practice and understanding, it really is quite extraordinary. It was compiled, I think, in our Middle Ages, about the 500s or so.

What it says is that the meditator reviews the same body, however it is placed, however disposed, as consisting of elements. In this body there's the earth element, the water element, fire element and the air element—just as though a skilled butcher and his apprentice had killed a cow and were seated at a crossroads with it cut up in pieces. So a *bhikkhu*, a meditator, reviews this same body as consisting of the elements. Just as a butcher sees the leg or the head or whatever—you understand that.

This comes into play when we're practising *vipassanā*. For instance, if you have a pain in the knee when you're meditating—or discomfort, whatever—as it draws your attention you go to it and your first word will be, say, pain. You're saying pain, this is pain, this is what pain feels like. Then when you're established there, you make sure that the aversion to the pain has disappeared completely, so you're entirely equanimous with it. You then, as it were, absorb into the pain. You go into the pain to deconstruct it—to find out what sensations constitute this concept of pain. And of course, when you go in there, you'll find things like pressure or heat or a combination of little sensations. At that level there's no concept of pain, so there's no suffering. You've deconstructed it.

That's the level of direct perception at the sense base. This is where the Buddha talks about the point of contact. For those of you who know dependent origination—the psychology of the Buddha—at the point of contact there has to be an object, there has to be a sense base: the five senses, including the mind, the sixth sense, because that's the one upon which emotions and thoughts appear. And this basic information from all the other senses also appears upon the mind door, as it's called.

The object, the sense base, and consciousness. Consciousness is obviously there like a screen upon which this arises. If it doesn't arise on the screen of consciousness, then you don't know it. I'm sure you've all had the experience of wondering where you got that bruise from, or how you cut yourself, because your mind was so involved in something you didn't actually notice how you got caught in a door—a slight bruise, not a big one. That means the sensation didn't impact on the mind door.

These four elements become really apparent to us when we go deeply into a sensation or feeling. It's the same with an emotion—deconstructing an emotion. What is an emotion before you give it a name? You might find, for instance, anxiety or fear, and it's in you, you can feel it in your heart, and you draw your attention to it. Then of course you've got to make sure the fear's gone, all the reaction's

gone, the aversion's gone. So you're left with the fear. Then you go into the fear. Now what is it you're actually feeling at that sense sensation base? It's not very much—some watery business, some fluidy stuff, some pressure. And of course by doing that you begin to undermine this fear of the fear, when you realise actually it's just a compendium of these sensations. So it does have a real purpose for insight.

The second thing is that when you're at that level of perception, impermanence becomes more obvious. These sensations are just arising and passing away all the time. This is an important teaching about elements in the foundations of mindfulness.

The next section concerns the charnel ground — always an interesting topic. In those days, bodies were simply laid out in an open ground, and as you'll see from the text, local animals would eat them. The corpses were shrouded in white cloth, and it was these cloths that mendicants — not just the followers of the Buddha, but all mendicants — would take and sew into robes. The Buddha simply followed that practice. Later on, when he had a group of monks and nuns around him, he wanted them to look a bit more tidy. So he asked them to cut the cloth in such a way that it recreated a paddy field. You can probably see the lines on my robe here at the back. The sections represent the paddy fields, and the narrow bits are the raised paths that follow the paddy field round so you can walk around it. Then they would boil the cloth with a root, which gave it a sort of brownie colour.

The text reads: 'As though he were seeing a corpse thrown aside in the charnel ground one, two, three days dead, bloated, livid and oozing matter. A bhikkhu compares this same body with it thus: this body too is of the same nature. It will be like that. It is not exempt from that fate.' It's that connection — to sit with this rotting corpse and remind oneself that one day this body is going to be like that.

By the way, the commentaries advise people not to sit windward — obviously a bit of good advice. The refrain continues: 'In this way, he abides contemplating the body both internally and externally,' and so on.

And again: 'As though he were to see a corpse thrown aside in the charnel ground devoured by crows, hawks, vultures, dogs, jackals, various kinds of worms.' And again: 'This body too is of the same nature. It will be like that. It is not exempt from that fate.'

And further: 'As though he were to see a corpse thrown aside in the charnel ground: a skeleton with flesh and blood held together with sinews. A fleshless skeleton smeared with blood held together with sinews. A skeleton without flesh and blood held together with sinews. Disconnected bones scattered in all directions. Here a hand bone, there a foot bone, here a shin bone, there a thigh bone, here a hip bone, there a back bone, here a rib bone, there a breast bone, here an arm bone, there a shoulder bone, here a neck bone, there a jaw bone, here a tooth, there a skull.' And the bhikkhu compares this same body with it thus: 'This body too is of the same nature. It will be like that. It is not exempt from that fate.'

The final stage describes a corpse thrown aside in the charnel ground: 'Bones bleached white, the colour of shells. Bones heaped up more than a year old. Bones rotted and crumbled to dust.' The bhikkhu compares the same body: 'This body too is of the same nature. It will be like that. It is not exempt from that fate.'

So the Buddha is very big on death. For those of you who are new to these sessions, I covered death contemplations and the Buddha's teachings about death in earlier videos. But here he's really grinding our nose in the dirt, you might say. And you can see from his explanation that he's done it — he's been there, he's sat with this lot and made those observations. This comes from his own personal experience, without any doubt.

I don't know if you've actually seen a dead body, but it is definitely lifeless. When you go to the East as a bhikkhu, as a monk or nun, you can visit the mortuary or the pathology department and watch them cutting the body open to find out why the person died. That's quite an experience.

My first experience with a dead body actually goes back to when I was about ten years old. My great aunt Florence — which is a lovely First World War name, isn't it, Florence? — she died, and my father asked if I wanted to come and see the body. I was ten; of course, that sounded like an adventure. When we got there, she was laid out, and I remember touching her forehead here. It was very cold, or cool, and it moved — I'd thought it would be stiff, but it moved. I don't remember being particularly upset by it. It was just a dead body.

The next time I had an occasion with a dead body was when I was at the Buddhist Vihara. I was already ordained — it was my first year — and I was staying at the Vihara in Birmingham. We had a visit from some Christian monks from St. Bernard's Abbey, which is near Birmingham. They were picking up Tibetan monks who were staying with us, part of this communication between monks of different traditions — Buddhist and Christian. One of them was an elderly man,

and he got hold of this huge case and carried it out to his car. As I came out from the gate, he was falling to the ground, calling for assistance. I put the bags down and ran over to him, holding him as he lay on the ground. He lost consciousness. Then he made this huge effort to come back — his eyes opened and he was trying to come back. And then he just let go. The weight of the body was quite obvious to me. I remember thinking it was rather ironic that this wonderful Christian monk died with a Buddhist head as his last vision. The ambulance came ten minutes later, but he was gone.

When we have an occasion to be with somebody who's dying, this is a real teaching for us. That sounds a bit callous, almost — you're there for the person who's dying, of course — but it does bring it home. To observe anything that's died, your pet that's died, can be quite a teaching too. Or anything you see on the road that's been run over by a car. That also teaches this finality, this disappearance of the person. And what you're left with is just a bag of bones, really.

So this is something good to contemplate. I do it every day, every evening — the reflections on sickness, aging, and death. It only takes a moment, but it puts that reality back in life: everything is coming to an end. Quite paradoxically, you'd think you'd get depressed bringing that to mind. But of course, it brings you into the present moment and the sheer miracle of being here, the sheer miracle of being awake, of being aware. The effort then is to make the most of it. So the contemplation of death, however you do it, has great benefits. And in the final hour, we remind ourselves: my mother died, my father died. Everybody's been there. The Buddha died, for heaven's sake. And that gives you the courage to go through the gate.

Now let's begin with the Refuges and Precepts.

Dhammapada 46: How to View the Body

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 18 min

Originally given as *Dhammapada 46: How to View the Body* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this teaching on Dhammapada verse 46, Bhante Bodhidhamma explores the Buddha's instruction to see the body as foam and mirage - impermanent and insubstantial. Through the traditional story of a bhikkhu who attained Arahatsip by contemplating these similes, Bhante examines three key characteristics: the body's impermanence (like froth breaking up on water), its insubstantial nature (like a mirage created by water vapor), and how attachment to bodily beauty becomes a source of suffering through Māra's 'flower-tipped arrows' of sensual pleasure.

Drawing from the Girimananda Sutta's contemplation of bodily parts and afflictions, Bhante discusses the traditional 31-part meditation and the Buddha's comprehensive list of bodily ailments - practices designed to undermine attachment rather than create disgust. He emphasizes that the goal isn't rejecting sensual pleasures entirely, but understanding our dependency on them for happiness. The teaching connects body contemplation to the broader path of liberation, showing how awareness of impermanence and not-self leads beyond the 'king of death' to awakening.

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā Sambuddhassa
 Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā Sambuddhassa
 Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā Sambuddhassa

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble, and fully self-awakened one.

So this evening, to carry on our little Dhamma exploration, *Dhammapada* exploration, I thought I'd choose verse number 46. I shall chant it in the Pali first:

*Phenūpamang kāyam imang veditvā
 Marīcidhamang abhisambudhāno
 Chetvāna Mārassa papupphakāni
 Addassan gacche maccurājassa*

And the translation. This is Gil Fronsda:

"Knowing this body is like foam, fully awake to its mirage-like image, cutting off Mara's flowers, one goes unseen by the king of death."

"Knowing this body is like foam, realizing its nature a mirage, cutting out the blossoms of Mara, you go where the king of death can't see."

So let me read a little story that comes with it:

On one occasion, the Buddha was residing at Jetavana Monastery in Savatthi, and a certain *bhikkhu*, after obtaining a subject of meditation from the Buddha, went to the forest for the purpose of practicing meditation. Although he strove diligently, he made little progress and was not happy with himself, and so he thought, "I'll return to Jetavana Monastery and request the Enlightened One to give me another subject of meditation better suited to my temperament." And with this thought he set out to return to Savatthi.

Now on the way he saw a mirage. Reflecting mindfully within himself, he realized that a mirage after all is only an illusion caused by a sheet of water vapour. So also was his body an illusion and insubstantial by reason of birth and decay. And fixing his mind on the mirage, he continued with this meditation practice.

Later, he went for a bath near the bank of the river Aciravati. While resting under a tree close to the river and seeing the froth breaking up, he realized further the impermanent nature of the body. Now from Jetavana Monastery, the Buddha saw the *bhikkhu* and sent forth his radiance and exhorted him: "*Bhikkhu*, you are on the right track. Keep it up. It is good that you've realized the body is impermanent like froth and insubstantial like a mirage."

At the conclusion of the exhortation, the *bhikkhu* attained *Arahatship*.

Well, that's not bad, is it? See what we're missing out on, not being born at the time of the Buddha!

A couple of vocabulary items here. *Marīci* means to shimmer or glitter, and so it becomes a word for mirage — a metaphor for illusion. If you see it as a mirage, recognise that it is a mirage, then it's an illusion. But if you think it's real, then it's a delusion.

Now here it says "having cut off Mara's flower-tipped arrows" — that's a more direct translation of the Pali.

This is interesting, because the only time I'm certain that the arrows of Mara approached the Buddha was just before he was fully liberated. Mara attacked him with thoughts like "What about the sensual life? It's great out there! What are you doing just sitting under this tree?" And then there was fear — fear of failure — and who was he anyway to try and become fully liberated?

As these arrows came to the Buddha, because of his determination, his commitment to the path, and that sense of hope, they turned into flowers. So here, I think "Mara's flower-tipped arrows" extends the metaphor a bit, because flowers stand for sensual pleasure. He cut off sensual pleasure.

There are three things in this discourse: insubstantiality, impermanence, and of course the cause of suffering — attachment. The last thing mentioned is the king of death. If he's gone beyond the king of death, then of course he must be liberated. That's just another way of saying the person is free.

When we're contemplating the body as body, there are these three characteristics to look at. The impermanence of the body is pretty easy for us to see the older we get — things change downwardly. That's not so difficult to notice. But we don't really see the power of seeing impermanence unless somebody dies.

Even today I was talking to a student who is having problems with seeing impermanence everywhere. It's coming up as a lot of fear. They've had two close deaths in the family, one after the other, very sudden. When that happens, the impermanence of the body becomes quite real — its insubstantiality, its fragility. We're all living on a knife edge.

The image in the discourse is of froth on water. It just breaks up. You've seen it gathering on streams, and then it breaks away, breaks up. It's the whole deconstruction of the body. If you were to imagine the body laid out before you, all the bits and pieces, you would see that it's just something constructed, something put together.

Of course, the body is real in the sense that we feel it. You bite your tongue and you can't deny that you have a body — it definitely feels real. But that is the perception we're trying to cut through. Pain is pain — that's fine. But when it's *my* pain, when *I'm* suffering from it, then we give it a sense of reality which it doesn't have.

It's interesting that the discourse uses the idea of vapour creating the mirage, the froth on the water, because the body, it seems, is sixty percent water. If you were to separate all the elements of the body rather than the parts, you'd end up with a lot of bottles of water.

When it comes to attachment to the body, the main thing is our attachment to the body as something which is — well, we can't say beautiful for most of us, because we have this awful image of Hollywood, Bollywood, and CGI. Nobody lives up to that standard! But there is always that, shall we say, slight concern that people see us as pleasant, as something to look at which is agreeable.

There is this concern about how we look. And if a person uses their looks to gain advantage, they very quickly catch somebody who is attracted to them — and with that comes power. But there's also a real bite back. It's not feedback; it's a bite back. Because now your sense of power is dependent on their admiration.

And of course, when their admiration fades, you discover it's not love. When their admiration turns to somebody else, you're fired up with rage and jealousy. There's a whole mixture of suffering that comes with being too concerned about how we look.

There's a distinction between cleanliness, tidiness, and beauty. So how do we overcome this connection to the body — the body as something that has to be beautiful in other people's eyes?

In the discourse on Girimananda, a monk who is very ill, the Buddha knows about his condition and tells Ananda to go and see him. He gives Ananda ten perceptions to share: perception of impermanence, of not-self. Then there's one translated here as ugliness — sometimes it's translated as repulsiveness. Then the drawbacks, giving up, fading away, cessation, dissatisfaction with the whole world, impermanence of all conditions, and mindfulness of breathing.

Interestingly enough, there are thirty-one parts of the body enumerated by the Buddha. In this body: head hair, body hair, nails, teeth, skin, flesh, sinews, bones, bone marrow, kidneys, heart, liver, diaphragm, spleen, lungs, intestines, bowels, undigested food, feces, bile, phlegm, pus, blood, sweat, fat, tears, grease, saliva, snot, synovial fluid, and urine.

That's quite a wonderful list! Interestingly — and I've always wondered why — the brain isn't included. But it is when you do the Mahayana list; they've added it, and the list changes a little bit. You've got feces and then brain, presumably saying you might be a fathead or something! But it seems as though the ancients didn't

know what this lump of fat in the head was. They thought it was part of the skull, part of cartilage or something. They had no idea that's where your thinking and imagining is manufactured.

Now, although we might be surprised by that because we take it for granted, when you're thinking and imagining, it's out there somewhere, isn't it? Although it's inside you, you wouldn't imagine it to come out of this lump of fat inside your head. And I think in those days, prior to our severe split between body and mind, people thought more from the heart — more about what I feel, what I understand, rather than what I think and understand.

Anyway, what we're supposed to do is bring the image of these parts to mind and just feel what our relationship is to them. Normally speaking, it's some form or level of disgust. And we're meant to recognise that disgust isn't necessary. That's, again, something to do with not really accepting our body as animal. We're here as animals as well, and part of that is unpleasant. It doesn't smell nice, for a start. But it's just recognising it's a smell — the disgust isn't actually necessary at all. Which is a measure of our delusion about how the body should be, or how we imagine the body to be.

Now, of course, the Buddha says what we do is contemplate the drawbacks. "This body has much suffering and many drawbacks, for this body is beset with many kinds of affliction, such as the following: diseases of the eye, inner ear, nose, tongue, body, head, outer ear, mouth, teeth and lips; cough, asthma, catarrh, inflammation, fever, stomachache, fainting, dysentery, gastric pain, cholera, leprosy, boils, eczema, tuberculosis, epilepsy, herpes, itch, scabs, smallpox, scabies, hemorrhage, diabetes, piles, pimples and ulcers. Afflictions stemming from disorders of bile, phlegm, wind or their conjunction. Afflictions caused by change in the weather, by not taking care of ourselves, by over-exertion, or as a result of past deeds. Cold, heat, hunger, thirst, defecation and urination."

And so they meditate, observing the drawbacks of the body. Great old list, isn't it? He's not shy of listing these things at all. Hits it on the nose, you might say.

These exercises are given us to undermine this relationship of attachment to the body. Now, we have to ask ourselves: why do we form this attachment in the first place? And for that, you have to go back a couple of steps to this idea of identity, which we're trying to constantly undermine.

This identity, this "me," is seeking happiness, remember. It's just seeking it in the wrong place. And what it does in seeking happiness is form a relationship with what makes it happy. How do we define our happiness? I would say, for the most part, it's how we feel. I feel happy, I feel comforted, I feel warm, I feel beautiful, I'm in love, and so on. This happiness has an anchor in the way we feel, and that's what we're always chasing — something that's going to make me feel good.

And that's where the problem lies. Everything that makes us feel good becomes something we depend upon. When it's not there, that's when you get your grief. Behind it sits your fear of loss, and so on. All the miseries come out of trying to seek some sort of permanent happiness through the body.

The mistake we can make, of course, is then to try and get away from all sensual pleasures. That just takes you into a very miserable place, like a dry prune. That's no good at all! So it's not a case of getting rid of sensual pleasures as such, but of getting rid of that relationship — being aware of it, being aware of it.

This was the old reason for fasting, and why Muslims also fast for one month every year — to try and cut through this dependency we have on the sensual world for pleasure. That's what we used to do as Christians, or I as a Catholic. During Lent you had to give something up — your sweets. There's a pain in that, really, but the idea was to realise that you don't need sweets in order to be happy.

So this verse — I've built up a lot around it, but the basic message is the impermanence, the insubstantiality, and how not to be attracted by Mara's flowers.

I can only hope my words have been of some assistance, that they have not caused confusion, and that by your devotion to practice you will be liberated from all suffering sooner rather than later.

Rūpa: Corporeality

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 13 min

Originally given as *Rūpa: Corporeality* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this talk on the first of the five khandhas (aggregates), Bhante Bodhidhamma examines rūpa - corporeality or the body - from the Buddha's profound perspective. Rather than discussing the physical body as solid matter, he reveals how the Buddha understood rūpa as our direct experience of embodiment through the four great elements (mahābhūta): earth (pressure, heaviness), fire (temperature), water (cohesion, elasticity), and air (movement).

Using practical examples from toenails to wine tasting, Bhante demonstrates how our 'solid' sense of body dissolves when examined closely into component sensations. He guides us through exercises to deconstruct pain, touch, and even the subtle processes of seeing and hearing down to their elemental basis. This analysis serves the Buddha's strategy of undermining the delusion 'I am the body' by showing what we are not.

The talk also touches on rūpa's broader meanings - the subtle mental images (nimitta) used in concentration practice, the formless (arūpa) absorptions, and even Buddha statues (Buddha-rūpa). Essential listening for understanding how vipassanā practice reveals the constructed nature of our embodied experience.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā-sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā-sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā-sambuddhassa.

Homage to the Buddha, the Blessed, Noble and Fully Self-Enlightened One.

We've been going through the *khandhas*—these five heaps, five aggregates, in which the Buddha deconstructs the psychophysical organism. Today we'll take up the word *rūpa*.

Rūpa translates as corporeality—basically, your body. And the first question you have to ask yourself is: what do we actually know? What do we know, in terms of direct experience, of the body itself, save through the senses?

Take a simple example: your toenails. Every so often you cut them off. What do you know about your toenails? You know how they look, you know how they feel—hard and all that. But you don't know what it is to *be* a toenail. If there were nerves within your toenail, can you imagine the agony of having to cut them off every so often? The same with your hair.

Our direct experience of the body is still dependent on these outer senses. If there are no nerves there, we don't know what it is. And we don't even know the inside of things. We don't know what makes a nail or what makes your hair. We know scientifically, but we don't know by direct experience.

Science tells us, for instance, that every time we breathe there's this exchange of carbon dioxide for oxygen—but you don't *know* it. At least I don't—I should speak for myself. I've never known oxygen. I'm told it's there and I'd die without it, but I haven't a clue. I've never experienced it directly.

When it comes to understanding what the Buddha means by the body, he's not talking about the physicality of the body. This is the point—he's talking about how we *experience* the body, the direct experience of it. And what it comes down to is the four basic elements, the *mahābhūta*. They're described in a metaphorical way: earth, fire, water and air.

Earth refers to those feelings we experience as pressure, heaviness, lightness—that sort of sensation. Fire is heat, though it also includes cold, the whole gamut of temperature. Water is cohesion, elasticity, what joins things. And air is movement.

What the Buddha is saying—and this would have been fairly straightforward in the ancient world, it seems—is that if you go into a sensation deep enough, you'll be able to describe it in those sorts of ways. Now, don't confuse this with the four great forces in science: electromagnetism, gravity, strong and weak force. Those are completely different. What science is describing is matter, as it were—the laws of matter in itself. We experience gravity in terms of weight, but the others don't seem to fit.

From there—I'll just mention them quickly because there's no real time to go into it—arise the derivatives. From the basic elements you get seeing, hearing, smelling, tasting, touching. Then there are further ones: femininity or virility, the

physical base of mind (which is the brain)—actually, I won't go into that just yet. Then there's bodily and verbal expression. All of these are secondary to that original contact the mind has with the body.

Physical life itself—we know that the body has its own energy, its own force. Each cell has its own little life, you might say. There's a space element too, that's part of it—there are holes in the body. And then there's physical agility, elasticity, adaptability, growth, continuity. There's decay, there's impermanence, and finally there are those things that are nutrients to the body. All of that is secondary.

What we're interested in, for the process of awakening, is this: although we experience the body as a whole, as an entirety, when you go into it, it's made up of all these little bits and pieces—and therefore it loses that substantiality. It feels substantial enough if you fall over on a mountain and bang your head on the floor. But in fact, it's just feeling, different types of feelings that arise. At a physical level, it's just a bunch of subatomic particles touching another bunch of stuff. But in terms of our normal reality, it's a person who's hit his head on the floor and is hurt.

This is part of the Buddhist strategy of undermining the mistake, the delusion, the belief that I am the body—by knowing what you're not. It's by realising what you're not that you begin to realise what you are. That's the Buddha's methodology. He's not turning us around to look at something which is the unconditioned or *nibbāna*. He says that will arise naturally when you realise what you're not.

Let me leave you with one or two exercises you can try. We did the standing meditation earlier. Even there, just that very simple thing—normally speaking, there's just the feeling of standing. But when we go into those feelings in the feet, we find we can actually distinguish heat from pressure. At one level it's just the feeling of standing; at a different level we see it's made up of all these bits and pieces.

When you get pain—you might have a sharp pain from the sitting, or a headache—when you go into it, when you stop using the word 'headache' or 'pain' and you go in to describe the sensations that are actually there, you find yourself using different words. You might use heat or pressure, tightness or something else. The word 'pain' disappears.

Here's another exercise: how do we know the difference between the touch of metal and the touch of wood? If you go into that touch, you'll be able to discern what's actually different at that feeling level. Wine tasters and tea tasters do this, don't they? They get very into the distinctly different little bits that go into making this fullness of taste.

At a more subtle level, there are the eyes. The eyes are the heat element, fire. And in a moment of sharp meditation, you might actually experience what's happening in the mind when it takes in the stuff from the eyes—and it's actually imaging it as little flames.

It's the same with hearing. When you actually put your attention on the ear drum, on the actual process of hearing, you can get right down to the basis of that first impact. All that is, is the touch of the air wave on the ear drum, which is then taken inward, as it were, to the next perception. You see it drawn into the mind until it actually takes on the sound of a bell. But that's not what's actually at that base. It's just contact. It's just pressure.

That's what the Buddha means when he's talking about *rūpa*, about corporeality. You may also, just as an aside, come across another meaning when you're reading: the subtle material within the mind itself that creates images. Through concentration meditation, these become very bright, very obvious images in the mind, like a light. These *nimitta*, as they're called, are then used for absorption meditations to create an inner sense of bliss. Those also are known as *rūpa*.

Taking that as a basis for those types of mental states we call the absorptions, there's a further stage when even that image disappears. These are known as the *arūpa*, the no-image states. So there's the fullness, really, of this word *rūpa*. Often you'll hear of a Buddha *rūpa*, meaning the Buddha statue—it's used in that sense too. With Easterners, that's a normal way of referring to a statue, a *rūpa*.

I can only hope my words are clarified, not modified. May you be liberated sooner rather than later.

The Greater Discourse to Rāhula

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 1h21

Originally given as *The Greater Discourse to Rāhula* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this profound discourse, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the Mahārāhulovāda Sutta, where the Buddha provides sophisticated guidance to his teenage son Rāhula who was struggling with sensual desires. The teaching demonstrates remarkable pedagogical skill: first deconstructing attachment to the body through contemplation of the four elements (earth, water, fire, air), then using these same elements as metaphors for developing unshakeable awareness that remains unmoved by agreeable and disagreeable contacts.

The Buddha's approach is methodical and compassionate - after establishing dispassion toward the body, he guides Rāhula through the four brahmavihāras (loving-kindness, compassion, appreciative joy, equanimity) to develop a wholesome heart. Only then does he introduce contemplation of bodily repulsiveness to abandon lust, followed by impermanence practice to uproot the conceit 'I am.' The discourse concludes with ānāpānasati (mindfulness of breathing), presented as preparation for death itself.

This teaching showcases the Buddha's understanding that spiritual development requires careful sequencing - balancing analytical deconstruction with heart cultivation, ensuring practitioners don't fall into extremes of either sensual indulgence or harsh aversion to the body.

I wanted to carry on with Rāhula. There are three discourses to him. The last one was given when he was twenty-one or older—you can't become a fully ordained monastic until you're twenty-one; until then you're a samanera, a lower ordination. In that final discourse, the Buddha essentially repeats the teaching on anatta, not-self. And it's said that after that, or shortly after, Rāhula becomes fully liberated.

The Buddha had the misfortune of having his son die before him—as, in fact, both his main disciples, Sāriputta and Moggallāna, also died before him. So a bit of sadness there.

But at around the age of eighteen, the Buddha gives Rāhula a second discourse, called the Greater Discourse to Rāhula. They're at Sāvattthī again, at Jeta's Grove, Anāthapiṇḍika's Park—the one he bought off Prince Jeta with a field of gold, it seems.

When it was morning, the Blessed One dressed and, having taken his robe and bowl, set out for Sāvattthī. Rāhula also dressed and, taking his robe, followed close behind. Then the Blessed One looked back and addressed Venerable Rāhula: "Rāhula, any kind of material form whatever, whether past, future, or present, internal or external, gross or subtle, inferior or superior, far or near—all material form should be seen as it is with proper wisdom. This is not mine. This I am not. This is not myself."

Rāhula then asks, "Only material form, Blessed One?" And the Buddha says, "No, no, there's also feeling, perception, habits of mental formation or volitional formations, and consciousness." Those are your five aggregates, if you remember. But he didn't mention all that—he only mentioned the body. So although he's put "material form," he's obviously talking to Rāhula about the body: the body past, future, present, gross, my body, other people's body—the whole thing should be seen as it is. This is not mine, doesn't belong to a me. It's not me and it's not myself.

Now Rāhula says to himself, "Who would go to town for alms today when personally admonished by the Blessed One?" Thus he turned back and sat down at the root of a tree, folding his legs crosswise, setting his body erect and establishing mindfulness.

It's obvious that at the age of eighteen, that dreadful devil and drugger testosterone has got into him. The Buddha's noticed that his son has an eye out for likable objects, shall we say, and he's afraid Rāhula might return to the household life. So he's now giving him instructions on how to overcome such desires.

Anyway, while Rāhula's sat there, Sāriputta sees him and says, "Rāhula, develop mindfulness of breathing. When mindfulness of breathing is developed and cultivated, it is of great fruit and great benefit."

Then when it was evening, Venerable Rāhula rose from meditation, went to see the Blessed One, paid homage, and sat to one side. "Venerable sir, how is mindfulness of breathing developed and cultivated so that it is of great fruit and great benefit?"

The Buddha replies, "Whatever internally belongs to oneself is solid, solidified and clung to." In other words, he doesn't answer the question. What seems to have happened, according to the commentaries, is that Sāriputta, seeing Rāhula sat under a tree, gave him a little push and suggested mindfulness of breathing—not realising the Buddha had already given him an object, which was, of course, the body.

So now the Buddha goes through the four elements, starting with the earth element. "Whatever internally belonging to oneself is solid, clung to." Whatever is clung to—remember that phrase; it's the upādāna khandha, the five aggregates that are clung to. It's the clinging that's wrong, right? The blame can't be put on the five aggregates; that's just the psychophysical organism. It's seeing it as a self, and so on, which is the problem.

"There is head hair, body hair, nails, teeth, skin, flesh, sinews, bone, bone marrow, kidneys, heart, liver, diaphragm, spleen, lungs, large intestine, small intestines, contents of the stomach, feces, and whatever else internally belonging to oneself is solid, solidified and clung to. That is the internal earth element."

Then he says this solidity should be seen simply as earth element—solidity seen just as solidity. When one sees it with proper wisdom, one becomes disenchanted. It loses its witchy craft over you. Disenchanted with the body, the mind becomes dispassionate towards it—in other words, it doesn't get caught up in the body. So that's his first bit of advice.

Then he looks at the water element, whatever is internal water. Whatever is watery and clung to: bile, phlegm, pus, blood, sweat, fat, tears, grease, spittle, snot, oil of the joints, urine, and whatever else there is. He doesn't let you off, does he? He gets down to the nitty gritty. And again, he says you have to see it with proper wisdom: it's not mine, this is not what I am, this is not myself. When you see this as it really is, you become disenchanted, and your mind is dispassionate about the water element. Dispassionate means non-attachment.

Then, of course, the fire element. Whatever internally belonging to oneself is fire, fiery and clung to: what is warmed and ages—the fact of aging is considered part of the heat element—and what is consumed. That by which what is eaten,

drunk, consumed and tasted gets completely digested, and whatever else internally belonging to oneself is fire, fiery and clung to. This again should be seen in the same way: it's not me, not mine, and so on. Then we become dispassionate towards these things of the body, and the mind cools.

Then there's the air element. Whatever internally belongs to air or airiness: up-going winds and down-going winds, winds in the belly, winds in the bowel, winds that course through the limbs, in-breath and out-breath, and whatever else belongs to the air or airy. Lots of wind there, both internal and external. Wind should be seen as it is—it's just movement, right? Just movement. When one sees it as it actually is, one becomes disenchanted, and we arrive at dispassion, non-attachment.

Then the space element, which in Theravāda Buddhism isn't actually an element as such, though it does become so, I think, in the Mahāyāna tradition. But it's obviously there—space. The space element is either internal or external. Whatever internally belongs to oneself is space or spatial or clung to: holes in the ears, the nostrils, door of the mouth, the aperture whereby what is eaten, drunk, consumed and tasted gets swallowed, where it collects, and whereby it is excreted from below. Whatever else internally belonging to oneself is space, spatial, and so on. And again: it's not mine, I am not that, it doesn't constitute a self. In this way, we become disenchanted and dispassionate.

Now, having gone through a way of looking at the body by dividing it into its various elements—and therefore, by that deconstruction, losing that sense of attachment to our identity with it—the Buddha goes through them again, only this time to show how they can be used. This is an instruction to us as well.

"Develop meditation that is like the earth. When you develop meditation like the earth, arisen agreeable and disagreeable contacts will not invade the mind and remain." There's your phrase with all these elements: if you develop meditation with that element as a simile or metaphor, you'll find that both what is agreeable, what is attractive, and what is disagreeable, what is not attractive, will not invade the mind. The mind here is sati—will not invade the mind and remain. Actually, the mind here is what you're aware of. In other words, this is one way of keeping at bay those particular thoughts.

"Just as people throw clean things and dirty things, excrement, urine, spittle, pus and blood on the earth, and the earth is not horrified, humiliated and disgusted because of that, so too, Rāhula, develop meditation like the earth. When you develop meditation like the earth, arisen agreeable and disagreeable contacts will

not invade your mind and remain." Sati has to keep, as it were, like the earth—solid, clean of all these things entering into it. Or better: not allowing the awareness to become engaged in them, but to remain objective.

"Develop meditation like the water. For when you develop meditation like water, arisen agreeable and disagreeable contacts will not invade your mind and remain. Just as people wash clean things and dirty things, excrement, urine, spittle, pus and blood in water, and the water is not horrified, humiliated and disgusted because of that, so too, Rāhula, develop this meditation like water." Again, he's talking about the awareness—being aware of something but not attaching itself to it.

"Rāhula, develop meditation like fire. Just as people burn clean things and dirty things, excrement, urine, spittle, pus, blood in fire, and the fire is not horrified, humiliated and disgusted by that, develop your meditation like a fire." By doing this, of course, you stop these things invading your mind and remaining there.

"Develop meditation like the air. Just as the air blows on clean things and dirty things, on excrement, urine, spittle, pus and blood, and the air is not horrified, humiliated and disgusted because of that, so develop your meditation like air." These are similes, metaphors that give Rāhula some idea of how to meditate, how to be objective within oneself, to investigate things, not to allow this awareness to get caught up in what is agreeable and disagreeable.

In the same way with space. "Just as space is not established anywhere"—so it's everywhere—"so too, Rāhula, meditation is like space. For when you develop meditation like space, arisen agreeable and disagreeable contacts will not invade your mind and remain." There you have an image of space, or the awareness, the field of awareness—that space we're aware of all around us. Sometimes it's very tiny, what we're aware of, and sometimes it's everything all around us. To be spacious like that—that space does not cling onto anything. Things move through space, just as things move through our awareness.

So the Buddha has got Rāhula to look at the body dispassionately, seeing it as just elements. It's a bit like when your mobile phone breaks and you're really upset about it—but then you separate it into all those little pieces and you see, what's the point of getting upset over a mobile? Having done that with the body, he then uses those same elements to give us an image of how we ought to meditate.

And then, having done that, he invites Rāhula to contemplate the four Brahma Vihāras, the four illimitables: loving-kindness or love, goodwill—I prefer goodwill—compassion, appreciative joy, and equanimity.

Having established dispassion for the body—and remember, Rāhula may be eighteen at this point—he now develops the heart into these wonderful states. And when that is done, he can return to the body to look at its foulness. When you develop meditation on foulness, any lust will be abandoned.

If you remember, we went through this a while back: the Buddha had given a discourse about the foulness of the body to some monks, but somehow he hadn't softened it. He hadn't shown them how to balance it. They'd gone off and got so upset about the foulness of the body that they'd committed suicide. Some of them had even helped others to commit suicide. The Buddha was really upset by that.

Here he's actually undermining that possibility by first having developed the good heart. The body is to be let go of as a place of sensual delight, as something to indulge in. The delight the body gives is quite natural, but to attach to it as 'this is mine, me'—that's going to cause problems, especially at this age. Any lust will be abandoned when you consider the foulness of the body, especially of that body you're attracted to.

Then he says, after that, develop meditation on the perception of impermanence, because when you do that, the conceit of 'I am' is abandoned. That's one good thing about observing impermanence, especially of oneself—the body getting older and older, the fact that one is constantly changing. Every self that you create must be somebody else. So you start letting go. To see impermanence is to take away that sense of continuity which the self demands.

And then finally, when Rāhula has done all that, he can go back to Sāriputta's suggestion. A bhikkhu gone to the forest, to the root of a tree, sits down, folds his legs, body erect, establishes mindfulness before him, and begins to practise meditation on the breath. The Buddha then goes through—very quickly—how to contemplate the breath, which we have touched on slightly with the discourse on how to establish mindfulness.

And then he finally says, 'Even the final in-breath and out-breath, known as this, is not unknown.' This is how mindfulness of breathing is developed and cultivated—this is a great fruit and great benefit. When mindfulness of breathing is developed and cultivated in this way, even the final in-breaths and out-breaths are known as they cease, not unknown.

In other words, our meditation is always about preparing for death. Every out-breath, every end of an in-breath, every point at the end of an out-breath—these are moments, these are endings. What the Buddha is saying is that this is also a preparation for our final breaths.

So that is the Greater Discourse on the Advice to Rāhula. What we can try to remember is these images of using the elements—but also how skilful the teaching is. The Buddha has a young man who's being tempted. First he tells him to deconstruct the body. Then he tells him how to use those very same elements to form an image of what meditation is about. Then to develop the heart with love, with goodwill, compassion. And when that's done, to return to the body to see its foulness, so that lust is abandoned. Then finally, in the coolness of this new situation, Rāhula can develop mindfulness of breathing.

I hope the discourse has been of some benefit. And I can only hope that we, all of us, through our devotion to practice, will become liberated sooner rather than later.

Feeling (Vedanā)

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 46 min

Originally given as *Feeling (Vedanā)* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this exploration of vedanā (feeling), Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the second of the five aggregates, tracing how feelings arise from the initial point of contact (phassa) at the sense bases. Drawing extensively from the Pañcakaṅga Sutta, he unfolds the Buddha's detailed classification of feelings—from the basic two-fold division of pleasant and unpleasant, through the traditional three-fold classification, up to 108 different types of feelings when categorized by sense base, time, and spiritual quality.

The talk addresses a fundamental insight: what we truly seek in life is not external objects but the inner feeling of happiness itself. Bhante explores how this understanding transforms our relationship to experience, distinguishing between worldly feelings based on sensual pleasure and renunciation feelings based on seeing impermanence. He clarifies common misconceptions about karma, explaining that not all feelings arise from past actions—many result from present conditions like weather, diet, or current mental states.

The discussion extends to the refined feelings experienced in jhāna states and the ultimate cessation of feeling and perception. Throughout, Bhante emphasizes the practical importance of developing awareness of vedanā in meditation, as feelings form the bridge between sensory contact and the mental proliferation that leads to suffering. This detailed examination provides essential groundwork for understanding how feelings condition our entire experience of existence.

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā Sambuddhassa — Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble, and fully self-awakened one.

In the last couple of talks, we covered *rūpa*. The first was really about the sense bases — how the mind receives information and how it's then processed. The second, which I probably should have done first, was about the body as body as a contemplation object: movement, bringing mindfulness to movement, the cemetery contemplations, contemplating death, and things like that.

Now we come to *vedanā*. Since we're working through the five aggregates, we need to go back to the point of contact, *phassa*. At *phassa*, information comes in at the sense bases. There has to be a sense base, and there has to be consciousness — it must arise on some sort of field, a screen upon which it can be known. Those are your three absolutes.

Whatever comes in at that base is very minimal sensation, but it still comes under just about the idea of feeling. The distinction is that when it comes to *vedanā* proper, feeling is defined as pleasant or unpleasant — and the definitions get even more complicated. But at the point of *phassa*, there's definitely a feeling. Some are very difficult to catch, like the feeling of photons on the retina. I'm not so sure that can be felt. But the fact that we can perceive light, that it's actually touching something, is a sign that contact must be occurring.

With the ear, it's a little better because at the eardrum you can actually experience sound waves as pressure. That's possible. And then you really know there's a point where, at the sense base, you're just getting raw data. The next thing is it moves into the mind, the mind door. And it's at the mind door that we begin to perceive it differently.

This *vedanā* feeling and perception arise together. I'll try to do a bit about perception, but there's a lot to cover here, so we'll see. This point of contact is present even in transcendental experiences — there must be some sort of contact that's known. And then after the experience, one reflects upon it.

There are three such contacts. First is the contact of being empty of self — *suññatā*, empty of anything there at all. Then there's what's known as the signless contact, which is basically that there's no impermanence. That's what they call it, signless. And then there's freedom from desire — that's the one to do with *dukkha*, suffering. Each of these experiences that release us from delusion has this point of knowing, this point of contact, and then the rest is reflection.

How important is that point of contact in ordinary daily life? Well, I think I've mentioned this before, for those of you who've listened to all my talks. When I used to go to work, there were all these billboards, and suddenly there appeared

advertises for an Australian perfume. The image showed a cork hat — an Australian hat with corks hanging around it. What had happened was that people in modern advertising had lost faith in billboards, didn't think they were having much effect.

But the number of inquiries about this Australian perfume was such that they began to realise billboards have an enormous effect. Consider: you're sitting on a bus in a half dream, thinking about this, thinking about that. But of course your eye catches this thing and it goes in. That's it — it just goes in. And once it's in, you're conditioned. The next minute, you're craving this Australian perfume.

That point of contact is where conditioning begins. That's why the Buddha speaks of restraint, restraint of the senses — not looking at things that build up old bad habits, but looking at those things that build up good habits. That's one of the reasons for statuary and pictures. Now, as you know, Buddha statues have become a sort of garden gnome — you can buy them anywhere and stick them in your garden. "Oh, there's a Buddha." But you can see it has an effect on people, even those who know nothing about Buddhism. They see in the statue some expression of peacefulness, I presume. That's how important that point of contact is.

Interestingly, the word *vedanā* is rooted in *vid*, which is similar to our idea of feel — when somebody says, "Oh, I feel it's wrong." There's a feeling content, a sort of knowledge content that arises with feeling. You could put this down to knowing whether the feeling was wholesome or unwholesome. You'll see later on all sorts of other categories.

Just as an aside, one writer suggests that this split between body and mind is a sort of Cartesian duality — the mind is one thing and the body something else. But they reckon it's actually a spectrum of energy that moves from physical energy into mental energy. I dare say there's truth in that. But there's also the mental body, which has its own existence, as it were. In traditional Buddhist understanding, when you die, that's what comes out — your mental body. It's the mental body that then seeks rebirth. And if it hangs around where you actually died, that's your hungry ghost.

I have no problem with that sort of understanding because even when I set up this place in London — a little meditation centre we were trying to set up there — there was definitely somebody in the house and I could hear them moving about, I could hear them rattling around. At that time there was a friend of, actually, she was on the trust, Ramini, and she brought a friend along who was a medium. We were just talking about this and that. And then I said, "I think there's somebody

here who's hanging about," because I got a feel for it and I could hear it. I could hear him. I didn't know whether it was a him or her. I just said him. I remember saying that.

She went into a silence, closed her eyes and went into a silence. It was about maybe three, four, five minutes. And when she came out, she said, "It's all right. I've helped him find somewhere else to live." And from that time onwards, I didn't hear anything. And there were no mice. There was nobody. There were no dogs, no cats. Anyway.

The one thing that I think we need to ask ourselves is, when I seek happiness, what am I actually seeking? For instance, when I eat lovely food or see a film or have a romance and all that, there's obviously a base of things that I want — the food, the romance, et cetera. But what is it that, for want of a better word, I really want from those experiences? What do I really want?

Can I suggest that what we really want is a beautiful inner environment. We want to feel happy. We want actually an emotional state, a mental state in which we are happy. In other words, the food is secondary, the romance is secondary, everything's secondary. What I want to do is feel happy, not think happy. That doesn't get me anywhere, does it? I can think the word "happy" — it doesn't do much for me. But I want to feel happy. Am I getting regular nods at the back there? The four judges, sitting on a high plane. Yes.

If we just take that for a moment — that actually all I want is to feel happy — then, of course, I'm taught by society, culture and nurture and all that. I'm brought up to believe that this type of food makes me happy, this type of music, this type of person, et cetera. I then begin to manipulate the world to try and really feel happy. And in meditation, of course, that's what we're all yearning for, isn't it? The end of this continuous suffering and to just get blissed out for a moment or two and hopefully get into *jhānas* and stay there forever.

It's OK. Once we realise that, then what it does is it turns your attention towards the feeling content of your experience. And then the question arises: is it worth it? What I'm doing, the energy that I'm putting out there in order to get this inner feeling — is that worth it? Now I'm being a bit cynical here because obviously there's a whole business of ethics involved, but we won't get into that just now.

So it's the feeling tone of our existence, isn't it, as living beings, sentient beings. And the Buddha splits them all into different types. And so I just want to go through this particular discourse, which does that for us. It's called the Pañcakaṅga Sutta. And Pañcakaṅga was a carpenter and he went to Venerable Udāyin and on arrival, having bowed down to him, sat to one side. He was sitting there.

As he was sitting there, he said to Venerable Udāyin, "Venerable Sir, how many feelings has the Blessed One spoken of?"

"Householder, the Blessed One, has spoken of three feelings, the feeling of pleasure, the feeling of pain, and the feeling of neither pleasure or pain. These are the three feelings that the Blessed One has spoken of."

Now when this was said, Pañcakaṅga, the carpenter, said to Venerable Udāyin, "The Blessed One has not spoken of three feelings, he's spoken of two feelings, a feeling of pleasure and a feeling of pain. And as for the feeling of neither pleasure nor pain, the Blessed One has spoken of it as a refined pleasure."

The second time, Venerable Udāyin said to Pañcakaṅga the carpenter, "The Blessed One has spoken of three feelings." And the second time, Pañcakaṅga the Carpenter said to Udāyin, "No, the Buddha has not spoken of three feelings, but of two feelings."

Now the Venerable Ānanda overheard this discussion between Venerable Udāyin and Pañcakaṅga. So he went to the Blessed One and on arrival, having bowed to him, sat to one side. And as he was sitting there, he told the Blessed One the entire discussion between... heck of a discussion. I'm not so sure it was a discussion, but it's often the way we sort of talk to each other. Yes, I am. No, I'm not. Yes, yes.

The Buddha's response to Ānanda was striking: both were right. True was the exposition that Pañcakaṅga the carpenter would not accept from Venerable Udāyin, and true was the exposition that Venerable Udāyin would not accept from Pañcakaṅga the carpenter. "There is the exposition by which I've spoken of two feelings," the Buddha said.

And then he goes on. By the time he's finished, we actually get to 108 types of feeling, believe it or not. This whole business of deconstruction is about categorising different types of feelings so that we're clear as to what we want to develop in our own hearts.

The first two, of course, are a very simple split between pain and pleasure — what is unpleasant and what is pleasant. In a sense, that's the dual world we live in at its base. You can't escape it. It's just part of our existence that we either feel happy or unhappy.

But then the Buddha goes a little further into categorising. He gives us three feelings: *dukkha*, *sukha*, and that which is neither. *Kha* means to bear; *dukkha* is hard, *sukha* is easy. So: hard to bear, easy to bear, and that which is neither easy to bear nor hard to bear. The reason for this third category, of course, is to make us in our meditation become much more aware of these subtler feelings that we tend to ignore.

We're usually aware of what's painful and what's pleasurable. But there's a whole set of neutral feelings that we're not particularly interested in, and it's just a matter of becoming aware of them. When there are no strong physical feelings around — painful or pleasant — then that's what you have: that sort of neither pleasant nor unpleasant. The obvious example is the breath. As long as there's no tension around the area, it's usually very, very neutral — neither pleasant nor unpleasant.

Then the Buddha takes us just a little further and talks about *dukkha*, *sukha*, *domanassa*, *somanassa*, and *adukkhamasukham*. He's trying to distinguish again, always trying to deconstruct what we have. This separates pleasures and pains that come from the body from those that have to do with the mind. So: mental pleasures, mental happiness — happiness and unhappiness. I suppose we would translate it as pain and pleasure, happiness and unhappiness, and neither. That "neither" covers both types. So those are your five feelings.

Again, it's a case of just being aware in our meditation that some feelings, some sensations, are body-based and some are heart-based. That split matters, and it does affect what we do in our meditation. If something is physical, we have to discern whether it's truly just physical pain in the knee or something like that, or whether the physicality — the pain in the chest, say — also has some mental feeling involved in it, some sort of tension.

By investigating that, you might actually discover this separation where the physical feeling separates from the mental feeling. If you have that sort of experience, then the teaching becomes very clear to you: this mental feeling is causing this physical upset. The physical pain or pleasure is like a sounding board — it makes everything louder. Mental feelings are not so loud, but when they affect the

body and the body comes back, as it were... So anger is anger, but when the body gets heated up and comes back with tension and a ferocious sort of tightness, then of course it makes it just that much more obvious to us.

Then there are the six feelings, based on your senses. Some are pretty straightforward, like hearing and smelling. Some are more subtle, like the eye. What comes in through the sense bases may have a physical base, but of course it's taken into the mind base, and that's when we determine it as being pleasant or unpleasant. So those are your six feelings.

Then there are eighteen feelings, depending on the sense base. Each of these sense bases has an unpleasant, a pleasant, and a neither pleasant nor unpleasant feeling — so you end up with eighteen different types. And don't forget the sixth sense base, which is the mind. Our experience of that is what we call emotions or moods. Even "feeling" covers that in our language. In the Buddha's language, there was seemingly just this one word, *vedanā*, which covered it all and had to be defined.

So that leaves you with eighteen. Then you can split them all again and get thirty-six different types of feelings, depending on whether these feelings — physical, mental, and so on — are worldly or non-worldly. Now that's an important distinction, because if you remember, in one discourse the Buddha says that one of the things he realised was that these thoughts were wholesome and these thoughts were unwholesome. If he followed the unwholesome thoughts, things got worse. If he followed the wholesome thoughts, things got better.

Seeing a form via the eye, one explores a form that can act as a basis for happiness. One explores a form that can act as a basis for distress. One explores a form that can act as a basis for equanimity. And he goes through the different sense bases — the ear and so on. Then finally, cognising an idea via the intellect: one explores an idea that can act as a basis for happiness, one explores an idea that can act as a basis for distress, and one explores an idea that can act as a basis for equanimity.

That's one of the reasons he split these into eighteen different categories. It's what we do with the feeling that makes it either wholesome or unwholesome. That gives us the eighteen.

We can split these eighteen again into what is wholesome and unwholesome — or as he would say, worldly and non-worldly. Now, if I can just read this. What are the six kinds of happiness? First, there's householder happiness. Here it's using

the word householder, *agarika*, but the other word it uses would mean based on the flesh, based on sensual pleasure. Happiness that arises when one regards as an acquisition the acquisition of form cognisable by the eye — agreeable, pleasing, charming, endearing, connected with worldly baits. And when one recalls the previous acquisition of such forms after they have passed, ceased and changed, this is called householder happiness.

You've only got to think of times when you decide to go to a restaurant and you go through all the things you might like. Is it going to be a curry? Is it Chinese? Are you going for a pizza? You're reliving past experiences — and that's based upon our physicality, upon being a householder.

However, we're renunciates. What are the six kinds of renunciation happiness? The happiness that arises when, experiencing the inconstancy of those forms, their change, fading and cessation, one sees with right discernment as it actually is that all forms, past and present, are inconstant, stressful and subject to change. This is called renunciation happiness.

It's not that he's saying we shouldn't go to restaurants and have pizzas and all that. It's just recognising that attachment to that is going to cause distress. But when we see that even pizzas come to an end, we liberate ourselves from the possibility of terrible depression. And of course, that's the same for all the other senses — for sensations and ideas. That's to do with happiness.

Now the similar formula for distress. What are the six kinds of householder distress? The distress or unhappiness that arises when one regards as a non-acquisition the non-acquisition of forms cognisable by the eye — the language gets a bit tortuous — agreeable, pleasing, charming, endearing, connected with worldly baits. And when one recalls the previous non-acquisition of such forms, after they've passed, ceased and changed, this is called householder distress.

In other words, you wanted the pizza, but the restaurant wasn't open. Now you've got distress. Now you're going to have to have a Chinese, whether you like it or not. That's what he's saying: if you don't get what you want, you have this distress.

Then he asks, what are the six kinds of renunciation distress? The distress coming from the longing that arises in one who is filled with longing for the unexcelled. When experiencing the inconstancy of those very forms, their change, fading and cessation, he sees with right discernment, as it actually is, that all forms,

past and present, are inconstant, stressful, subject to change — and he is filled with this longing: Oh, when will I enter and remain in the sphere of the noble ones?

Now, "enter and remain in" — that's a strange sentence. When will I enter and remain in the sphere that the noble ones enter, are now in, and remain in? In other words, when we actually discern the distress that comes from not getting what we want, there's this longing to become liberated, to be with the Buddha. And that longing, if it really takes us, is known as *saṃvega* — which translates as an urgency, a having to do it.

Then of course the next one: what are the six kinds of householder equanimity? The equanimity that arises when a foolish, deluded person — a run-of-the-mill, untaught person who's not conquered his limitations, all the results of actions, and who is blind to danger — sees a form with the eye. Such equanimity does not go beyond the form, which is why it's called householder equanimity.

He's using the word equanimity, but it's a bit of a downer really, isn't it? It's the sort of feeling you get when you don't know the distress or the happiness you're in. You can't see where happiness is because you're too dull-minded. And even though you're in distress, you don't see yourself as being distressed. People who say, "I'm not angry, I'm not depressed" — when you get that deluded attitude driven by some wrong understanding, it's a sort of equanimity, but obviously a poor equanimity. I suppose our word would be indifference.

What are the six kinds of renunciation equanimity? The equanimity that arises when, experiencing the inconstancy of those very forms, their change, fading and cessation, one sees with right discernment as it actually is that all forms, past and present, are inconstant, stressful, subject to change. This equanimity goes beyond form, which is why it's called renunciation equanimity — spiritual renunciation equanimity.

That's the equanimity that comes when we accept the way things are — that things change, things pass, things die away. This equanimity is to be discerned from the equanimity that comes simply because we can't see: dull-minded equanimity.

Having explained these thirty-six feelings, the Buddha then considers what happens when, through memory, we recall past instances of those six types — and when we dream or think about future things. Most of you right now, I'm sure, are dreaming of the amazingly wonderful things that will happen when you leave

this place, and the sense of freedom and liberation that comes with it. That launching into the future — all of this brings us to 108 different feelings, which can be pleasant, unpleasant, or neutral, and can be either worldly or non-worldly, spiritual renunciation and all that.

That's how he split up all these feelings. He does say somewhere that people see feelings differently, categorise them in different ways. But all the categorisations the Buddha offers are always designed to make us see more clearly where the point of delusion lies. They're all about making us discern feelings — first from this simple separation of pleasant and unpleasant, then through to pleasant and neutral, and so on. And how to discern what is good for us and what is not so good for us. To know what to do with it.

Just another discourse, to read it out: "Thus have I taught the Dhamma by means of exposition. When I've taught the Dhamma by means of exposition, it can be expected that when there are those who do not consent to, assent to, or accept what is well spoken and well stated by another, there will be arguing, quarrelling and disputing, and they will dwell wounding one another with the sword of the tongue."

"Thus have I taught the Dhamma by means of exposition. When I've taught the Dhamma by means of exposition, it is expected that when those who do consent, assent to, and accept what is well said and well stated by another, they will live in harmony, with courtesy, without quarrelling, like milk mixed with water, regarding one another with friendly eyes."

Obviously, that's a little reference to Udāyī and Pañcakaṅga, seemingly at each other's throats.

There's a whole section then about the different types of refined feeling that come with concentration meditation and the eventual cessation of feeling and perception. In the process of *jhāna*, these states are all beautiful — there are no negative mental states or anything like that. But the first one, as you might know in our tradition, involves what we call the soft *jhānas*, for which there is seemingly scriptural support. And there are other types of *jhāna*, which are deeper, known as the *Visuddhimagga jhānas*, written by Buddhaghosa. That's a late text, about 700 years after the Buddha, I suppose.

But there are these two types of beautiful mental states that we can achieve, and they do have an agreement between them as to what the contents are. The first one is that there's still some sort of mentation — even like the noting, it can

be as simple as the noting — but the general feel is one of physical joy, mental joy, and then equanimity. Is that right? Yes, before I've missed one out — there's physical joy and there's mental joy. Oh dear.

In the first *jhāna*, there's this mentation going on, but there's also a physical feeling of pleasure, a mental feeling of happiness, and behind it all is equanimity. Then as you go deeper and deeper, as it were, you move away from the mind, then from the body, and then from the happiness in the mind until you reach that state of equanimity. From there, you can even go into what's known as the *arūpa-jhānas*, where it's just pure equanimity.

We're talking now about the feeling content of these mental states. There's a point where even the last of the *arūpajhānas* — the ones not based on any material base — goes beyond. Remember that when you start the *jhāna*, you start on the breath and that becomes your base. But with the *arūpajhāna*, there's no base. There's nothing there as such.

The text says, "another pleasure, more extreme and refined." What, Ānanda, is another pleasure more extreme and refined than that? What is the happiness which is even more refined than even these very refined *jhāna* states?

"There is the case where a monk, with the complete transcending of the dimension of neither perception nor non-perception" — that's the last of these *jhāna* states — "enters and remains in the cessation of perception and feeling. This is another pleasure more extreme and refined than that one."

"Now it's possible, Ānanda, that some wanderers of other persuasions might say, 'Gotama the contemplative speaks of the cessation of perception and feeling and yet describes it as a pleasure. What is this? How can this be?' When they say that, they are to be told, 'It is not the case, friends, that the Blessed One describes only pleasant feeling as included under pleasure. Wherever pleasure is found, in whatever terms, the Blessed One describes it as pleasure.'"

It's the English here. He describes it as *sukha*. In other words, he describes it as happiness. It's not physically based. That's a state supposedly that can only be achieved by people who attain the third path and fruit, *anāgāmi*—the cessation of feeling and perception. And there is some dispute as to whether that is *nibbāna* or not. But we won't worry about that just for the moment.

One of the misunderstandings of *kamma* is of course that everything that happens to us is *kamma*. Any bad feelings we have, physical anyway, is because in a past life we did something terrible, or even in this life we did something terrible. And the Buddha is quite clear about that. That doesn't hold.

In the sutta to the purse-maker called Sīvaka: "Some feelings arise on account of irregularities in the bile. Some on account of irregularities in the phlegm. Some on account of wind. Some on account of the confluence of numerous factors. Some on account of changes in the weather. Some on account of irregular exercise. Some on account of external dangers. Some on account of *kamma* results."

After all these, there are results from *kamma*. "That feelings arise dependent on these different causes is something you can see for yourself and that people everywhere acknowledge. On this account, any recluse or holy man who claims all feelings that arise, be they pleasant or unpleasant, are entirely the result of previous *kamma*, can be rightly said to have spoken in excess of what is obvious to people everywhere. And I say that such views are wrong."

That confusion is not just in present-day Buddhists, but also in that time where everything was seen as fate. There were teachers who taught that everything that happened to you is caused because of past *kamma*. And his argument would be: what about what you do now? What is the effect? If you do something now, it has an effect on you. It's not just the past coming at you; it's your decisions that you make now which have effect.

"Monks, when there is an intentional, fixed and steady deliberation on any theme, that theme becomes an object for sustained consciousness. Where there is an object, consciousness has an abiding object. When consciousness is so firmly established and developed, birth in the new sphere ensues." That's the *bhava*. "And when there arises into a new sphere of existence, birth, old age, death, sorrow, lamentation and pain. This is where the arising of this whole mass of suffering arises." This is where all that suffering arises.

But in terms of our inner life, you see, where there is an intentional, fixed, steady deliberation on a theme—where we're thinking about something, especially obsessively—that thing becomes the object of sustained consciousness. And where there is an object, consciousness has an abiding. The consciousness has an abiding in what you're actually thinking about.

Now there is somewhere else where he actually says that the mind has its abiding in the body. If you remember in the earlier talk, we were wondering where was the sense base of the mind. We know that with eyes, it's the retina and so on. So where's the mental sense base? It becomes pretty clear that it's the whole body.

When consciousness is so firmly established and developed, then you get that rebirth. That's your dependent origination; that's *bhava*. Now *bhava* here means not only intention, but an empowered intention—an act of will. It is an action and the self recreates itself. You're constantly recreating that sense of me through time. And it's because of this that all the rest of it happens: a new sphere of existence, birth, old age, death, sorrow, lamentation, pain, grief and despair. That's quite a list, isn't it? This is the whole mass of suffering.

Just to recap there, *vedanā* has its base in the initial contact. And then from then on, it's all mentation. It's all the mind working with feelings. And our lives are a jumble of these feelings. And the question is: what sort of mental state do I want to develop? What sort of mental state do I want to be in all the time?

If we look at the Buddha, we can presume that all that negativity had gone. When he's in contact with somebody, the social virtues—love, compassion, joy, gratitude—they would all arise naturally as beautiful mental states. And when nobody's there, or when other people are there but they're sitting quietly or whatever, the heart would just slowly come down to that equanimity. And that equanimity is the basis for all the other mental states, because it stops the other mental states falling into their

—their subtle enemies, or 'near enemies' as they're sometimes called. Love slips towards mere affection, compassion towards grief, joy towards excitement.

That's where we want to get to, isn't it? That underlying steady line of contentment and equanimity. And then these little pleasant blips arrive—a bit of love, a bit of compassion, a bit of joy. And then just the silence of equanimity.

That's where we're heading over the next couple of days, of course. Or we can live in hope. Why not?

I can only hope my words have been of some assistance—that they haven't caused even greater confusion. May you, by your constant effort to establish the right type of mental state, be fully liberated sooner rather than later.

Discourse on the Establishment of Awareness — Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta (MN 10)

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 21 min

Originally given as *Discourse on the Establishment of Awareness — Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta (MN 10)* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this continuation of his series on the Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta (MN 10), Bhante Bodhidhamma explores the second and third foundations of Right Awareness: contemplation of feelings (vedanā) and mind (citta). After completing the body section in previous talks, he examines how to observe pleasant, unpleasant, and neutral feelings, distinguishing between worldly feelings arising from sensual experience and unworldly feelings connected to spiritual practice.

The talk covers the contemplation of mental states, including minds affected by desire, hatred, and delusion versus those free from these hindrances. Bhante discusses concentrated and unconcentrated states, exalted jhānic absorption, and the liberated mind. Throughout, he emphasizes the importance of maintaining the observer position — watching feelings and mental states arise and pass without identification or personalization.

Key practical guidance includes recognizing when desires or aversions end naturally, experiencing the peace of an untroubled heart-mind, and using investigation to deconstruct the apparent solidity of mental phenomena. This approach cultivates dispassion and insight into the three characteristics of existence while establishing the independence necessary for vipassanā practice.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa.

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble, and fully self-awakened one.

Let's continue with the foundations of mindfulness—discourse number 10, the jewel of the collection, as Bhikkhu Bodhi calls it. We've finished the body section, which contained the breathing instructions, the four postures of standing, walking, sitting, and lying down, and the practice of full awareness throughout the day. It also covered the foulness of the body—which, remember, is really about becoming disenchanted with the body, disinterested in it. Then the elements, the four basic elements that point to where our physicality and mentality meet at the sense doors: the retina, the eardrum, and so forth. And of course, the good old charnel grounds—the nine bodies slowly corrupting into pure dust. To dust thou shalt return.

The next foundation is feeling. I've actually covered quite a bit of this already in talk number 28, if you want to look it up. But we'll read through it here—it's pretty straightforward.

"And how does one abide contemplating feelings as feelings?" Bhikkhu Bodhi translates it as "feelings as feelings," but to me the grammar suggests feeling feelings *in* feelings. In a sense, both mean the same thing. But there's something in that phrase about being right in there—like in a room, in the bath, like you're sunk in. Whatever feeling arises, the idea is to get into it and really feel it. Open up to it completely, absorb into it, you might say.

"Here, when feeling a pleasant feeling, the meditator understands, 'I feel a pleasant feeling.'" Now remember, you're not supposed to be saying to yourself, "I am feeling a pleasant feeling." It's simply a recognition that you're feeling a pleasant feeling—a consciousness of it, an awareness. "When feeling a painful feeling, he understands, 'I feel a painful feeling.' When feeling a neither painful nor pleasant feeling, he understands, 'I feel a neither painful nor pleasant feeling.'"

So there's the neutral bit. Actually, if you look closely enough, feelings will always shade ever so slightly towards pleasant or ever so slightly towards unpleasant—that's the dual world we live in. I think we sense this even in the womb: pleasant feelings and unpleasant feelings, with this whole area we call neutral in between. And it's upon neutral feelings that we can establish calmness and peace. That's why the breath and walking meditation have their purpose in our practice.

The text then distinguishes worldly and unworldly feelings. The meditator knows when there's a worldly pleasant feeling, a worldly unpleasant feeling, or a worldly neither-pleasant-nor-unpleasant feeling. And he knows when an unworldly feeling is present. We covered this distinction earlier.

Worldly feelings are simply to do with being in the world—the sensual world of work, eating, whatever we're experiencing. Unworldly feelings are all to do with the spiritual side: renunciation, letting go, compassion, love, the peacefulness that comes through practice, the factors of enlightenment, equanimity, and things like that. Anything to do with the spiritual life is unworldly; anything to do with the world is worldly. That doesn't necessarily mean it's unwholesome. The work you're doing, for instance, has a worldly purpose—you've got to earn money and so forth—but that doesn't make it unwholesome. It just doesn't lead to liberation. What leads to liberation is the investigation of the three characteristics: how we cause suffering through wrong desire, impermanence, and not-self.

Then comes the usual refrain: the meditator abides contemplating feelings internally, but also notices such feelings in other people. You can tell it on their face. And if you're sensitive enough, sometimes you can actually feel how they feel—if they're joyous, you can feel the joy mirrored on the surface of your own heart, and equally so with anger. He abides feeling feelings both internally and externally. He also contemplates feelings in their arising factors, in their vanishing factors, and in both their arising and falling. This is basically being aware that everything is always in process, always consistently changing. That's the one thing that never changes.

"Or else mindfulness that 'there is feeling' is simply established in him to the extent necessary for bare knowledge and mindfulness. And he abides independent." This last phrase really describes the position of *vipassanā*, where finally you're just resting on the object, observing it very carefully. There's a background view that looks at any reaction we have from the perspective of impermanence and not-self. It's just a way of looking.

And just enough, the text says—just enough knowledge. Actually, the word is just enough intuitive awareness. Bare knowledge and mindfulness. It's that ability to observe with open curiosity, with the intelligence awakened—that intuitive intelligence awake. And that's part of the whole of awareness. Remember, there's the active and the passive: the passive is when we're receiving, and the active is when we actually grasp what's happening. First you look, and then you see. "And he abides independent, not clinging to anything in the world"—let go of the world as such. That's the whole section on feeling.

This is an important section. If you look into your body, you'll notice feelings that are caused by the mind. The text doesn't actually say this, but there are two different types of feelings. There are feelings coming from the body—pain, discomfort, a sense of pleasure, itching, all those sorts of things. And then there are pleasant feelings coming from the heart, from mental states.

When you say you're happy, just ask yourself: what do you mean by that? Do you mean you have happy thoughts? Is it a sensation? Or is it more a feeling of happiness in us? Do we rate our happiness by how we feel rather than what we're thinking, or by our physical state? If I put something sweet in my mouth, do I say that this is happiness? No, that's just sweetness. But if the sweetness makes me happy, I say, "Oh, I'm happy. I'm happy because of the sweetness." We often judge our lives according to whether we're happy or not. If I'm not happy, I find that I'm wasting my life, or that my life isn't worth living anymore.

So it's important to find that distance from feeling and not to be governed by them, not to personalise them. There it is. There is now a happy feeling. There is now a sad feeling. Now get on with what you have to do. As soon as you identify with it—"I am happy, I am depressed"—in a sense you've locked yourself in. It's like an imprisonment. So that's the section on feeling.

The next section is also pretty straightforward: the section on mind or mental states. These include both your thinking and imagining, and also general mental states as such—of which feeling is part, and of which the body, of course, comes in somewhere.

So how does one abide contemplating the mind as the mind? He understands a mind affected by lust. The text has "lust" here, but that's pretty heavy—it tends to be around erotic desires, but it could be any sort of desire, the mind affected by wrong desire. He understands the mind affected by wrong desire as a mind affected by wrong desire, and the mind unaffected by wrong desire as a mind unaffected by wrong desire.

It's also about recognising when there's no desire in us. How does that feel? How does it feel when there's no desire? So it's not only the negative bit—you know, I'm overcome by this desire and whatnot—but how does it feel when it finishes? When it ends? The same with hatred: a mind affected by hatred, a mind unaffected by aversion or hatred. If we are in an adverse state, when it comes to an end and the aversion passes and the mind is just empty of those sorts of feelings, how does that feel?

When we begin to experience the heart-mind—I should say heart really—as a pleasant place to be, when we begin to experience directly a heart-mind which is not caught up in wrong desires or some form of aversion, then of course we tend to go there. Remember that we're always caught up with being excited, always trying to exercise a certain emotional mental state. What's it like when there isn't any there? When it's just a sense of peacefulness, calmness? And delusion as well—that's the mind which is perhaps in a sense of doubt, confused.

The next one is a contracted mind. This is much the same—contracted by wrong desires, aversions, things like that. Sloth and torpor, the wrong sort of tiredness, dullness in the head, lethargy in the body. That's caused by acts of laziness. That is a contracted mind. Whereas a distracted mind is one governed by restlessness—mind going all over the place, obsessive thinking, that sort of thing. It's a case of just knowing what the mind is actually doing, what the heart-mind is actually doing.

He understands an exalted mind and an unexalted mind. That's to do with the *jhānas*, really, these absorption states. Mostly we're not in an absorption state. He understands a surpassed mind as a surpassed mind and an unsurpassed mind. Again, this is just about these absorption states—exalted, unsurpassed. These are all very high, very refined states of mind. The unexalted ones and the surpassed ones are really to do with just the worldly states of mind.

Then there's the concentrated mind and the unconcentrated mind. You can see they all shade into each other—just slightly different ways of looking at it. And finally, the liberated mind and the unliberated. That's not to do with final liberation. It's just that when we're in an insightful mode, the heart-mind is liberated. And when we're in a *jhāna*, in more of an absorbed, concentrated state, the mind is liberated from hindrances.

And he abides contemplating the mind as mind internally and externally. You can see these moods and emotions, mental states in other people, can't you? Even in their body language. He abides contemplating the mind again with the arising factors and the vanishing factors—always this impermanence, always this impermanence. And then finally, just this—this is the mental state—and he abides independent, not clinging to anything in the world. That covers the sections on feeling and the mind itself. The next one is mind objects. We'll tackle that tomorrow because that's a whole new section.

Really, it's just ways of looking at what we're experiencing. Remember that when we open up to something—say an emotional state, say we're full of joy—there's always that tendency to want to develop it. We're always looking at that reaction. We're not getting caught up either in the joy or the reaction to it. We're just watching that process, that's all. Just watching the process and watching that desire to indulge begin to fade away. Then we come back to the joy, and there's that mental joy, that mental state.

From there you can go deeper, asking: what is this joy made of at the most basic level? How is it affecting the body? What does the body feel like when we're in a state of joy? You can move between these different levels of perception—the perception of the four elements, some form of lightness or warmth, and then at the next level, this warm joy that you recognise simply as joy. There are different ways you can play around within yourself, slowly deconstructing things. And this takes away that sense of solidity.

In doing all this, unwittingly of course, we're establishing the position of the observer—and that's where we want to stay as best we can during meditation. But remember, as you begin to absorb, as you become very concentrated in what you're seeing, that reflexive moment of awareness being aware of itself as the observer, as the feeler, can disappear—and with it, time. When you come out of that, you can always say to yourself, 'Well, that was a moment of pure vipassanā.' That doesn't make the other type of vipassanā, with the observer present, impure—not at all. Insights are just insights. They come at any time.

Just work with whatever comes up and see it as something to investigate, constantly awakening that sense of curiosity.

If you're still in firm lockdown—just you in a room or in a house—I hope you'll take advantage of that. Very good. I can only hope my words have been of some assistance. May you, by your fierce determination, be liberated sooner rather than later. So—we can begin our practice.

Vedanā — Feeling

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 7 min

Originally given as *Vedanā — Feeling* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this exploration of the five khandhas (aggregates), Bhante Bodhidhamma examines vedanā — the aggregate of feeling or sensation. Drawing from the Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta (MN 10), he explains how the Buddha distinguished five types of vedanā: pleasant, unpleasant, and neutral sensations, each divided into physical and mental categories.

Bhante clarifies the important distinction between bodily sensations and mental feelings, explaining how these represent two different energy systems that influence each other. He explores how vedanā extends to all six sense doors — including sight and hearing as physical sensations — creating approximately thirty different types of feelings and sensations.

A key teaching is that vedanā is present in every conscious moment, making it essential for vipassanā practice. The talk addresses the Satipaṭṭhāna method of vedanānupassanā — observing feelings within feelings — as a way to deconstruct our ordinary experience and see through the illusion of a solid, permanent self. This analytical approach helps practitioners understand how the psycho-physical organism operates without constituting a permanent entity or soul.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble, and fully self-enlightened one.

We're still investigating the *khandhā*, the five aggregates into which the Buddha dissected our experience. There is the body with its sensations; *saññā*, the perceptual faculties that grow into concepts and intellect. Today I want to talk

about *vedanā*, which is feeling. The fourth aggregate is *saṅkhāra*, which we can loosely translate as volitional conditioning — where the will comes in. And finally there's our act of cognition or consciousness.

Looking at *vedanā*, there are five types, and it's a slightly different way of approaching things. Two of them are physical — that's pretty straightforward for us. We have pleasant and unpleasant sensations; easy enough to distinguish. But there are also pleasant and unpleasant *mental* sensations, and that's where the confusion comes in. Normally we talk about feelings and emotions, and I think they shade into each other. Emotions are very complex things, but when you go into the body they manifest as some sort of feeling. Depression is heavy, anger is hot, and so on. That's what we're looking at when we feel a sensation in the body that we recognise is caused by a mental state rather than the body itself — distinguishing those two. The fifth type, of course, is the neutral state, which applies to both bodily and mental sensations.

The reason we distinguish these two is that the Buddha taught the physical and mental parts of our nature to be two actually distinct forms of energy. Both suffer from impermanence; neither constitutes a self or a soul or a person. But they are two different energy systems, each affecting the other. When you're sitting and you get a sore knee, the mind becomes agitated. If you feel depressed, the body becomes heavy. If you feel tired, the body becomes heavy too.

This distinguishing, this deconstructing of our experience, is part and parcel of understanding that the psycho-physical organism we experience ourselves to be doesn't actually constitute an entity as such — something whole, entire, self-subsistent, that can exist outside this universe. It just isn't that.

The Buddha also splits it up again, dissecting it into the various feelings that arise from the six senses. Sight — what we see is also a sensation and comes under physical feelings. Hearing — what we hear comes under physical feelings, bodily feelings. By dividing it this way, we can see that there are something like thirty different types of sensations and feelings. These are only types, as you know. Within each type there are myriad feelings and sensations. I dare say it's never the case that one is exactly the same as another, like leaves on a tree — they're not the same.

The other thing to say about *vedanā* is that it's always present at any level of consciousness. Whenever you're conscious, there has to be the factor of *vedanā*. If you're seeing, there's the feeling or sensation of light. If you're hearing, there's the sensation of sound, and so on. It's not possible for there to be a conscious moment without some sort of feeling.

Now the importance of separating out feeling in this way comes up in the discourse on how to establish right mindfulness — the *Satipaṭṭhāna* discourse, which is about seeking liberation. There's a second section there; after physical feelings, bodily feelings, comes *vedanānupassanā*, which means to see feelings in feelings. It's a funny construction — what's known as a locative case, where you're *in* something. To feel, to see, to experience feelings in feelings. It seems like a double take.

But all he's saying is: try to separate out feelings completely from perceptual things, from emotional fantasies and such, and centre completely on feeling itself. What is a feeling? Ask yourself the question: what is a feeling? What is a sensation? Normally we don't experience life this way. We just experience it in the fullness of our personality and physical contact with the world. But by doing so — by isolating feeling — it's all part and parcel of seeing how this life works for us.

That, short and sweet, is the description of *vedanā*. I hope my words have been of some assistance. May you be fully liberated from all your painful *vedanā*, sooner rather than later.

Saññā Perception & Vedanā Feeling

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 12 min

Originally given as *Saññā Perception & Vedanā Feeling* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this teaching on the five khandhas (aggregates), Bhante Bodhidhamma examines saññā (perception) and vedanā (feeling) as fundamental components of our experience. He explains how saññā functions as our basic perceptual memory, recording characteristics like shape and color, eventually developing into conceptual thinking and intellectual understanding. The talk explores how perception and feeling always arise together in every moment of attention, along with five other mental factors.

The discussion of vedanā reveals the Buddha's precise analysis of feeling into five types: pleasant and unpleasant physical sensations, pleasant and unpleasant mental sensations, and neutral states. Bhante emphasizes the importance of distinguishing between physical and mental feelings, showing how this discrimination helps us understand that our psycho-physical organism doesn't constitute a permanent self or entity.

Drawing from the Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta, he explains vedanānupassanā—observing feelings within feelings—as a practice of isolating pure sensation from perceptual interpretations and emotional elaborations. This teaching offers practical guidance for meditators learning to deconstruct their experience and understand the workings of consciousness according to Buddhist psychology.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble, and fully self-enlightened one.

We're carrying on with the *khandhas*, these five heaps. When you look into the body during meditation, you can see it's made up first of all of sensations coming from the body. We covered that last time—the *rūpa*, the body—and we can break down most of these sensations into four categories: pressure or weight, temperature, movement, and some form of cohesiveness or elasticity.

Then there are all these other things we can feel in the body: feelings that come from the mind that we describe as emotions, and thoughts, images. That's the Buddha's first three: *rūpa*, the body; *saññā*, perception; and *vedanā*, feelings. Tonight we'll look at *saññā*.

In Buddhist psychology, when you attend to something, it will always have a feeling content and a perceptive content. They arise together—you can't have one without the other. They're said to be present in every moment of attention. What *saññā* does is record the basic characteristics of something.

Take the zabutons, these mats you're sitting on. The basic thing *saññā* would record is the shape—rectangular—and the colour. These things slowly become your memory. By seeing many colours and many shapes, the mind begins to discriminate between all the different colours and shapes you experience. That's perceptual memory. As it grows to a higher level, it puts labels on things. There's the growth of the intellect coming from this perceptual level, these basic percepts. And so *saññā* has the job of recognising things. It's your basic memory.

You might be interested to know the other factors present in a moment of attention. There are these two I've mentioned: feeling and perception. There's also the moment of contact, which I'll come to another time—it's part of the dependent origination, where you must have an object, you must have a sense organ, and you must have awareness of it: consciousness. Remember that there are six sense organs in the Buddha's teaching, the sixth being the mind itself. The base of that is presumably the brain.

Then there is will—some power within that moment keeping things together and pointing them. There's also one-pointedness of attention, which is a quality. And there's that quality of attending, best expressed in the phrase "to pay attention." It's actually a quality called the mental life faculty—the basic mental energy. All seven of these mental factors are said to be present within any given moment of attention.

What happens is that the quality of these perceptions joins with the emotional base, and then through the act of will, through attending, you get creativity. At worst this is known as *papañca*—a lovely word meaning proliferation—where your mind goes all over the place. But at its more important level, it's the growth of the conceptual mind, the growth of thinking, and eventually of philosophy and the arts. All that begins from this particular perceptual base of *saññā*.

Looking at *vedanā*, there are five types, and it's a slightly different way of looking at things. Two of them are physical—that's pretty straightforward for us. We have pleasant and unpleasant sensations, which are easy to distinguish. But there are also pleasant and unpleasant mental sensations, and that's where the confusion comes in, because normally we talk about feelings and emotions as if they're the same thing. I think they shade into each other. Emotions are very complex, but when you go into the body they manifest as some sort of feeling. Depression is heavy, anger is hot, and so on. That's what we're looking at when we feel a sensation in the body that we recognise is caused by a mental state rather than the body itself—distinguishing those two. The fifth type is of course the neutral states, both bodily and mental.

The reason we distinguish these two is because the Buddha taught that the physical part of our nature and the mental part are actually two distinct forms of energy. They both suffer from impermanence, they don't constitute a self or a soul or a person, but they are two different energy systems, each affecting the other. When you're sitting and you get a sore knee, the mind becomes agitated. If you feel depressed, the body becomes heavy. If you feel tired, the body becomes heavy. This distinguishing, this deconstructing of our experience, is part and parcel of understanding that this psycho-physical organism we experience ourselves to be doesn't actually constitute an entity as such—something whole, entire, self-subsistent, that can exist outside this universe, all that sort of stuff. It just isn't that.

The Buddha also splits it up again, dissects it again into the various feelings that arise from the six—well, seven—senses. Sight: what we see is also a sensation, and it comes under physical feelings. Hearing: what we hear comes under physical feelings, bodily feelings. By dividing it this way, we can see there are something like thirty different types of sensations and feelings. These are only types, as you know. Within each type there are myriad feelings and sensations. And I dare say it's never the case that one is exactly the same as another—like leaves on a tree, they're not the same.

The other thing to say about *vedanā* is that it's always present at any level of consciousness. Whenever you're conscious, there has to be the factor of *vedanā*. If you're seeing, there's the feeling or sensation of light. If you're hearing, there's the sensation of sound, and so on. It's not possible for there to be a conscious moment without some sort of feeling.

The importance of *vedanā*—the way the Buddha separates out feeling as its own category—becomes clear in the *Satipaṭṭhāna* discourse, the teaching on how to establish right mindfulness for the sake of liberation. After the section on bodily feelings comes *vedanānupassanā*, which means to see feelings in feelings. It's a funny construction. It uses what's known as the locative case—you're *in* something—so it's to feel, to see, to experience feelings *in* feelings. That seems like a double take.

But all he's saying is: try to separate out feelings completely from perceptual things, from emotional fantasies and such, and centre completely on feeling itself. What is a feeling? What is a sensation? Ask yourself the question. Normally speaking we don't experience life this way. We experience it in the fullness of our personality and physical contact with the world. But by isolating feeling like this, it's all part and parcel of seeing how this life works for us.

That, short and sweet, is the description of *vedanā*. I hope my words have been of some assistance. May you be fully liberated from all your painful *vedanā*, sooner rather than later.

Q&A: Emotions, Awareness/Delusion, Insight, Masculine/Feminine, Sense-of-Self, Porridge-itself-has-no-taste

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 48 min

Originally given as Q&A: *Emotions, Awareness/Delusion, Insight, Masculine/Feminine, Sense-of-Self, Porridge-itself-has-no-taste* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this comprehensive Q&A session, Bhante Bodhidhamma explores fundamental questions about vipassanā practice and Buddhist psychology. He begins by explaining how emotions arise during meditation despite being conditioned phenomena, clarifying that in vipassanā we take the position of objective observer, allowing the heart to manifest its turbulences naturally. The discussion delves into the complex question of how awareness can be deluded if it's unconditioned, with Bhante noting that the Buddha avoided metaphysical speculation about origins, focusing instead on practical liberation from the three characteristics of existence (anicca, dukkha, anattā).

The talk explores masculine and feminine approaches to meditation practice, drawing distinctions between deductive and inductive thinking patterns, different emotional experiences, and varied relationships to willpower. Bhante discusses the persistent sense of self that remains even after mental chatter quiets, explaining how this observer-self is also an object of awareness, pointing toward the emptiness of awareness itself.

The session concludes with an examination of Buddhist sense perception theory, using the metaphor that "porridge itself has no taste" to illustrate how sense objects, sense bases, and sense consciousness must come together for perception to arise. This practical teaching helps meditators understand the constructed nature of experience and the mind's role in creating meaning from raw sensory data.

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammāsambuddhassa Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammāsambuddhassa Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammāsambuddhassa

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

The first question concerns emotions. Since they're conditioned, how can they arise when we're meditating in the present moment? Is it because we're not fully present?

In *vipassanā*, remember, we're standing off from the whole organism. We've found a place — this observation post, this place within ourselves — from which we look into ourselves. When we actually experience emotions in the body, they're just some form of feeling, aren't they? We give them a name — we might say anxiety, for instance. But as soon as we name it, we slot it into a particular category: it becomes unpleasant, and so on. You can't stop that happening. That's just part and parcel of recognizing the emotion that's arisen.

Because we're standing off the whole process — everything that's going on psychologically and physically — the heart expresses whatever turbulence is at the surface. These turbulences that we call emotions or moods, along with the thought patterns that accompany them, belong to that category of the aggregates, the *khandhas*, known as the *saṅkhāras*. The *saṅkhāras* are something we manufacture. All the rest is a given.

The sense base sees something and it moves back into memory, which is part of our perceptual process. That memory — the image, together with the concept or perception we have of it — brings up the feeling tone of what we're experiencing. Altogether, we just call that a mental state. An emotion points to that feeling value, the affective value of our experience. And there's no telling what the heart's going to offer.

This is one of the understandings we come to: that we don't actually know ourselves in that way. You're sitting there and just out of the blue some memory surfaces from childhood — someone hitting you on the head with a bat. That's what happened to me, you see. I've never been the same. And suddenly you remember it. I even remember his name: Ken. And suddenly I think, I'll kill him. Where's that come from? It's all mixed up inside yourself. Then suddenly, for apparently no reason — like just now, I haven't thought of this for years — it just came up out of the blue. And it latches on to an emotion.

That's the important thing to realize about an emotion: the emotional state is not attached to the object. Your emotions — all these things to do with desire, hatred, aversion, fear — I imagine them like balloons. You've got a balloon of anger and a balloon of excitement and joy. What happens is something comes up

that puts a little pinprick in one, and all that emotion wants to get out through there. That's where we get these inappropriate reactions — road rage and stuff like that. The emotion itself is a conditioning we've developed towards an object. It's not caused by the object.

Very simply: if somebody hits me on the nose, the pain stops there. It doesn't travel anywhere else — it's on the nose and there. The feeling of anger that I get from them hits me, I can feel it, and it stops there. But what I do is react to it with anger or fear. That's what I'm generating: the anger and fear I have towards what's coming at me. And that anger and fear isn't specific to the object. It's just something I've developed whenever I see something that's dangerous to me.

So you're sitting there in meditation and there's Ken again with his bat — he bonked me on the head because I beat him, you see. He's a bad loser. I think what's happened in my own mind is that the turbulence of anger has begun to rise to the surface of consciousness, where it touches the mind. And it's seeking an object, seeking something to grab hold of. So it grabs hold of this memory. And off you go — you start thinking about it, developing this anger through a storyline around Ken, whom I'm still hunting for. I've sent out a search warrant.

None of this has anything to do with the observer, the feeler, the one who knows. Normally speaking, you're engaged in the organism and therefore you seem to be, as it were, in charge of your emotions. You might say to yourself, I'll go to the cinema and watch this horror film. I know it's going to frighten me, and that's great because I like being frightened. So you sit there and watch it. That's your decision. You've made that. You seem to be in control.

But at other times — for instance, you wake up. You never say, tomorrow I'm going to wake up depressed. But you wake up and you're depressed, and it's just come up of its own accord. That's what we're discovering: when you take this position of the observer within yourself, the feeler — remember, awareness is multiple in its sensitivities; it can feel, it can see, it can understand.

What you're saying to the heart is: manifest yourself. What have you got hidden from me? This, remember, is the process of therapy. We're not doing the practice in order to have psychotherapy or for the mind to heal itself — it's simply a natural process that the heart does when you come off it. The turbulence begins to manifest, and so long as we don't get lost in the thinking and all that, the energy begins to evaporate. But it doesn't disappear, remember. It always moves towards its opposite.

Whatever was a hateful, angry mood will move towards love. In Zen they say that with wisdom, compassion arises naturally. We practise *mettā* just to give it a little bit of a push. But in the process of purifying the heart — in the process whereby the heart purifies itself — it's always moving towards purity naturally. Towards the virtues. See? I always say it's very cheap.

This has to do specifically with being present in the moment in that particular way. The heart then manifests its turbulences. It can throw up even traumas — real traumas from early life — that can be liberated through this process. Are there any questions arising out of that?

In answer to the question: yes, emotions are conditioned, so how can they arise when we meditate? They arise of themselves — this is what you realise. The knee hurts of itself. It doesn't ask you for permission, does it? Do you mind if I scream? No. It just starts screaming.

And is it because we're not fully in the present? No, we are fully in the present, but in a particular way. We've taken this objective position within ourselves. That's not the same as being fully present when you're doing something, because then you're engaging the organism and it will come up with a certain mental state to support your engagement. If you say to yourself, right, I'm going to wash the pots or do this piece of work on the computer, you're ordering the organism to do this particular task. It might be that during that, some little bit of irritation comes up because of your reaction to what you're doing, or you might just suddenly have boredom arise.

The point is that we can use this organism to do stuff. And that's different from being in this position of the objective observer, where we're just leaving the organism alone, just watching the process. Remember, that's the Buddha's approach to things. He's not interested in why something's happened, but how something's happened. Because in seeing how we create suffering for ourselves, we should be able to undo the knot. We should be able to undo the process.

This is a tricky question: how can awareness be deluded if it's unconditioned? I'm no great scholar, and I can't say I've read all the scriptures — I've read the main ones. I don't think this question ever actually comes up in the scriptures. I must ask a scholar sometime.

The question of being unconditioned is not relevant to whether awareness is wise or deluded. It's simply unconditioned. The unconditioned refers mainly to the fact that it's not dependent on anything — it has its own existence, its own

being. I'm using words very loosely here, because the Buddha doesn't like to talk about the qualities of the unconditioned. He just points to them. He points to them with metaphor too, like the island, the refuge, and so on.

As to how awareness appears in a deluded state and then moves towards a wise state — as to why that happens — I don't think that's ever discussed. The only thing ever discussed is how to do that, but not why. There's never any — to use a big word — ontological question in Buddhism. There's no question about why something has come to be in that ultimate sense. No questions about why it was created in the first place, anything like that. He shies off all those sorts of questions. Anything to do with metaphysics, he doesn't answer. He says it's a waste of time.

This is put in the famous quadrilemma — not the dilemma, quadrilemma. The four main questions, as I'm sure you know: On his death, does the Buddha exist? Does he not exist? Does he both exist and not exist? Does he neither exist nor not exist? It just goes on and on, these negatives. Does he continue? Does he not exist? Does he both somehow exist and not exist? Does he neither exist nor not exist? The Buddha, of course, is silent. He says it's not a question that leads anywhere. It's just the intellect thinking, thinking.

But what we do know is that we are deluded, in his terms. And the delusion lies at its base in identity. We identify with this form and it leads us into all sorts of mess. Every time we move back into that position of the observer — unwittingly, even if we're not fully aware of it — we're disidentifying. As soon as something's an object, you can't be it, see. That's one of the things we can say to ourselves; we can reflect upon it in the meditation. We can look at something — an image in the mind, an emotion — and say, well, I'm looking at it. It can't be me. And then, of course, you abandon thinking and just watch. Because even that thought is stopping us from having a direct experience of not me, not mine.

Can I ask, what does it mean for awareness to be deluded? I can't quite... Is there an example where one says, oh, my awareness is deluded?

Well, awareness here is short for intuitive awareness. And the delusion, in Buddhist terms, is that it doesn't see the three characteristics clearly. Because it's so committed to this life form, it doesn't really catch impermanence. Although we in our practice get down to this business of arising and passing away — a breath, a sensation — remember that the real point of impermanence is death. That's

what truly manifests our impermanence. And it's one place we don't like to go. Death is something that's going to happen to everybody else, and maybe to me at some point in the future.

So that's impermanence. And we do what we can to ignore it, to entertain ourselves away from it. There's a fantastic book called *The Denial of Death* — the author's name has just flitted through my mind. It's a classic, written I think in the 70s or 80s. And the effect of the denial of death is unbelievable. It makes us run. It makes us accumulate.

So this intuitive awareness, because of its identity with this form, doesn't see impermanence directly. It sees it superficially — day and night and all that — but it doesn't really see the cause of suffering. And if it does see it, that's a break, but it finds it very difficult to let go.

One example I often use is smoking. In the 50s, it was still understood that smoking was okay, didn't do much harm. Then as the science came through and people realised they were killing themselves, they didn't stop smoking. They just couldn't stop the process. It's like with us: we can see the process of craving and we can see it's doing us harm, but it's very difficult to stop going for that tenth biscuit. That's the power of our cravings — which is the psychological cause of our suffering.

Sometimes I talk about it as desire, because I always think craving is far too strong a word. It covers the whole range from simple wrong desires to great big wrong desires. But remember that desire in English also covers all those beautiful things we ought to desire, arising out of our social virtues: love, compassion, joy, and so on.

And when it comes to not-self, that's what awareness doesn't know. Because of that wrong identity, it's lost its own identity — its own sense of what it is. Now, whether it ever had that, it's difficult to say. I can't see it ever having had that in some other rebirth, in some other place, and having lost it. I can't see that happening.

So we're back to that question of time, of the origin of awareness, of how it arose in the first place. It's just unanswerable. All we know is that we aren't happy in that absolute fundamental way. There is an alienation with life. We don't feel we fit completely in with life. And what tells us that is, of course, the body falls ill and you die — because you don't want to do that, really. Usually.

Jesus says it in that lovely poetic way, doesn't he? The birds have their nests, the fox has its holes, but man has nowhere to rest his head. We're always out of sync with nature. We're not like animals that are very in the moment in that totally immersive, deluded way. But they are at home. This is where it makes — for want of a better word — sense to them. They don't think about death. You never see sheep or cows having philosophical arguments as to whether they could do something about this problem.

So there's no answer to the origins of awareness. All we know is that it's within us. We experience it. And through our practice, we're slowly isolating its qualities — individuating it out of the mass of those five aggregates, those psychophysical organisms. People who have had an out-of-body experience know this. It's a very clear experience.

Do you not see animals grieving death? They do, don't they? The higher animals — elephants and the higher apes.

Yes, it's true. Would that not suggest they have an understanding of death? I don't know whether they have an understanding of death. It's probably the sense of... well, understanding in the sense that they know that's a corpse now. It's becoming more and more obvious as they study the higher animals that they're far more intelligent than we would presume. Elephants grieve, don't they? So it's a spectrum, isn't it — and then something happened to a particular ape and we went into a different category.

Is the insight into the true nature of ourselves? Can't that change? Or is it an insight into the world and others?

These insights are accumulative. As soon as you hear the Buddha's message about *anicca*, *dukkha*, and *anattā*, there's a click — our awareness, our relationship to the world, just clicks. And it clicks every time you have a new understanding of things. Even at an intellectual level, you can have a different view of something, and this feeds into your attitude and how you speak. That's the Eightfold Path, you see.

So all our insights are slowly changing our relationship to the world, moving us towards this position: the world is not me, it's not mine, but I have to be engaged in it. And the reason you want to be engaged is because you've made a connection with other beings. You're drawn by compassion.

The Buddha talks about compassion as a little trembling in the heart when you see other people suffering. It draws you. That would be a certain sorrow, and if you don't react to it, it remains unrequited. It stays within you and you might feel guilty, or you might feel sad that you didn't respond at the right time. That's just a natural thing that happens. I don't think you have to work at it — it just comes with insight into ourselves. These are universal insights all human beings are capable of.

The insight itself doesn't change; you just get further insights. It accumulates. In the four stages of liberation, the Buddha says stream-entry is like a flash of lightning. The person sees everything, but that was it — not really a full grasp of the situation. The second stage, I think he says, is like a full starry night. Again, there's a deeper seeing, but it's not complete. The third is like a full moon night — in the East, you can see colour; it's very bright. And then you don't get to see the world like the sun until you've finally cracked it.

So it's a slow progression, but the insights are always the same. They're always around impermanence, the creation of suffering through wrong relationship — desire or craving — and not-self. Always the same thing. Once you've understood that, there's nothing more to be known. There's only the practice.

That's why people can be fully liberated who in society are considered dull-minded. You don't need the intellect. What you need is the liberation of intuitive awareness, intuitive intelligence, from its confusion with the intellect. In fact, people who are intellectual, or even those lost in art, are less well disposed.

There's a story that runs with the Dhammapada about a monk who had disciples — something like ten of them — and all his disciples became liberated while he wasn't. He was a teacher and he knew everything. So he bit the bullet and went to see one of them and said, 'Could you teach me how to become fully liberated?' But the fellow knew this man was too intellectually conceited; he couldn't help him. So he told him, 'Well, actually, the person you want to see is this other past student of yours.' And so he was passed on down the line.

Eventually he got to a monk who said to him, 'Well, you need to work with this boy. He'll show you.' So there's this little child, you see, and the child took him to an anthill. Do you know this story? No. He took him to an anthill and said, 'In an anthill, when the ants leave, a snake often lives in it. Supposing this anthill has six holes — how would you get the snake out?' The teacher said, 'Well, you'd stop up five holes.' And the boy said, 'Yeah, very good. So you stop the five senses and watch the mind.'

And of course, in no length of time, he became fully liberated. His problem had been conceit — thinking that because he'd understood something so well, he must be liberated from delusion. That's what the intellect can do. It can fool you.

So to return to the question: is the insight into the nature of ourselves, and can it change? Yes, the insights grow. Look at it that way — they expand, they accumulate, they develop one on top of the other. As for insight into the world and others, remember that in the Buddha's teaching, whenever he talks about the world, he's talking about the world we're creating. He's not talking about the scientific world, the objective world. It's not that the world out there doesn't come up, but when he's speaking spiritually, it's always the world we're creating through this organism. In this world, in this fathom-length body, is suffering and the end of suffering. Is that right?

Is there a fundamental difference between men and women? In your experience? There's definitely — I think you've got to be careful, because some women shade into the masculine and some men move towards the feminine. So there's always that. But if we talk about the two extremes...

When I used to stay in Dublin — I still teach there — there was a time when I'd stay with a very elderly lady called Beatrice. She was blind from diabetes. She'd lost her husband, her two sons. An extraordinary person with a lovely feel about her. We got into a conversation, and she said to me, 'You know why we're taking different positions.' I said, 'No.' She said, 'Well, men think deductively and women think inductively.'

'That's interesting, Beatrice,' I said. 'What does that mean?' Because I couldn't remember what deductive and inductive thinking was. She explained — and I'm paraphrasing — that the feminine takes the particular and from the particular produces a concept. Whereas the masculine starts from the concept and draws it down to the particular.

Later on, we were talking about the war in Afghanistan. And I suddenly went, 'We're doing it, aren't we, Beatrice?' She said, 'Yes, you do it naturally. You don't know you're doing it. It's just the way you think.'

From a feminine point of view, when you look at a war, you see people being blown to bits, dead. So the obvious conclusion is: we mustn't fight a war. From the deductive masculine point of view, there's the bigger picture — we've got to get rid of these terrorists. So those people become collateral. They become part and parcel of this greater view.

In a patriarchal society, women are seen as stupid because they can't see the bigger picture. But what happens is that the patriarchal society loses contact with the suffering, with what's actually going on. So that's quite a distinction, at least at the ends of the spectrum.

The other distinction is will. The masculine will is the will of the storm. The feminine will is the will of the mountain. My parents were like that. My father was a get-things-done sort of person. And when my mother didn't want to do what he wanted, she simply said, 'No.' And that was it. He couldn't move her. No. The mountain does not move.

Emotionally, there's also quite a distinction at the far ends. The masculine experiences emotions in the head. I often see this with meditators — when they're angry, it's up here. The fear's up here. It's all up here. Whereas the feminine will feel it in the body as an emotion.

In my own case, I remember having an insight that changed my life. And I remember thinking, 'My next task is: what is an emotion?' I was twenty-five years old, asking myself, 'What is an emotion?' Because up until then, it was always up here. There was no distinction between the thought and the emotion. I had no contact with the body as such.

So in meditation, in terms of the practice, the masculine has to come into the body to feel emotions — sometimes for the first time — as real feelings in the body. For the feminine, because they're so locked into emotion, they have to lose their connection with emotion as emotion. The process is to go down to the sensations, the four *mahābhūta*, to see that an emotion isn't real. It's just feeling, just sensation. That's one sort of distinction. These are all generalisations, you understand. But yes, I think the masculine and feminine views of life are different — a different experience.

After all the chatter of the mind has quietened down, a sense of self remains. Talk a bit about this perception that I am in my head looking out at the world.

Yes, just to remind you — because I think most of you know my imagery around this. The most obvious example, I suppose, is looking into a shop window. You're looking at the things there that you might want to buy, and suddenly you become aware that there's a mirror image. You catch yourself looking into the window.

That window pane is a sort of screen. All the light from the shop is moving out onto that screen, and that's what you're looking at. But the screen is also catching your image looking into it. That's consciousness. When you're in the position of the observer, the knower, and you become aware of it, the object you're seeing — the sense of self, the observer — is also an object.

Everything we experience from that position of the observer is an object. Pain in my knee, emotions, an image in my mind — they all become objects because I can point to them, give them names. And when I become aware of being the observer, of being the one who knows, then somehow that sense of self, that sense of the feeler, is also an object. So I can't be that either.

At that point, you can stay there and simply sense that presence as an object — a sense of presence. But it's telling you something about this quality of intuitive awareness. What are you actually experiencing when you're in that very clear state of the observer?

In Mahāyāna, they sometimes tell you to glance back, as it were, into the observing state. And then when you've done that, you can reflect: Was there a body there? Were there any feelings, sensations, emotions — what was in it? These little insights, little seeings, begin to change our relationship.

Of course, you can pull yourself out of all these different selves — an emotional self, a thought self, a job self, a relationship self. You can pull yourself out to this position of the observer. But you can't get rid of that self. Can't get rid of that self.

Now, consciousness is arising and passing away. It's not steady. It's not something that's always there — it disappears in sleep, for instance. In the Abhidhamma they say these consciousnesses are flashing at an enormous rate, picking up information from the various senses so fast that it gives us a sense of continuity and also a certain combination. So you're hearing and seeing at the same time — but not in Buddhist psychology. There's one consciousness seeing and one consciousness hearing, and it's happening so fast that it creates this illusion.

Being aware of that self, the consciousness in which that sense of self is arising is also still arising and passing away. And if you keep your eye there long enough, you might catch that.

So in terms of the question, that perception of self-awareness is telling us something about the nature of awareness. It's emptiness — that's where you get this word. The awareness is empty of all phenomena. It's empty of whatever the psychophysical organism manifests. That's what it's empty of.

But of course, what you're beginning to experience when we're in the position of self-awareness — that is the real. Everything else is an object of awareness arising and passing away, but this awareness seems to be there all the time. Maybe. Any questions around that?

The last question is: 'You commented that porridge itself has no taste. Were you referring to the conditions of sense object, sense base, and sense consciousness needing to be present in order for sense contact and perception to arise?'

Yes. The sense base has this sensitivity to — in this case — chemicals. In the eyes, to amazingly subatomic particles, for heaven's sake: photons. The ear sense base is sensitive to pressure. So they're all sensitive. But then as that information is taken into the mind, the mind plays with it and creates something.

If you make a determination before you fall asleep that you will see the process of hearing when you wake up, you'll notice that the first sign of the bell is just pressure — like your hands touching together. Then as it's taken in, you get the sound. Then the sound is given a name: bell. Then it's given a purpose: alarm bell. And then it's given the person: me. I've got to get up. That's right at the end of the process. Right at the end.

It's the same with all the senses. The information is always being taken into the mind, and then the mind makes sense of it. But at the sense base, it's just very simple information coming in.

You might have seen those photographs showing how the eye moves around a picture — when it's looking at a piece of art in a gallery, for instance. The eye is moving at a tremendous rate, all over the place, often centring on something you're particularly interested in. But you don't see that. What you see is the picture.

The porridge is only offering you chemicals. The tongue and nose are sensing those chemicals, and then the information goes in, and then there's all this mental activity going on around porridge.

I saw a programme where they explained that the process of smelling also happens at a subatomic level. I can't tell you exactly how that works, but it's not a simple case of a cell touching a chemical — it's actually happening at an atomic level. Remarkable.

The next part of the question is: "This reminds me of the question, if a tree falls in the forest and no one hears it, does it make a sound? I guess the answer is no, in the absence of an ear and ear consciousness. But if you leave a tape recorder in the forest, it picks up the noise. Can you comment on this?"

Human beings are incredibly clever at extending tools. All animals use tools — I just read an article about a puffin that picks up a stick to scratch itself. So it seems even birds, which are dinosaurs, can actually use tools. But they can't develop them further. They can't then think, "Oh, well, I'll manufacture this as a steel object."

Human beings, through imagination and so forth, have been able to extend tools. We have these massive machines that do all our heavy work for us, and they're just an extension of an arm. Our groundsman, Roy — if you ever see him moving his machine around, it really does look like his arm. He's got complete control over it as he shifts soil here and there. Quite remarkable. And all he's doing is this little business with his hands.

When it comes to hearing things, of course, we've manufactured gadgets that are sensitive to sound waves. That's all. There's nothing magical about it — it's not an ear. It's just sensitive to sound waves, and it repeats them. So it's the sound waves you're hearing. The recorder has caught the pressure waves coming from the falling tree, and then it's able to repeat them so that you hear the tree falling. But the recorder hasn't heard the tree falling. It has simply recorded the pressure waves.

So it doesn't upset the Buddhist psychology. Porridge still has no taste, and the tree doesn't make a sound.

And there's the old Zen story, isn't there? I can't remember it exactly, but there's a flag. The student says to the master, "The flag is flying," and the master says, "Is the flag flying, or is your mind flying?" What are you actually seeing — the flag or your mind? That's one of these koans.

I can only hope my words have been of some assistance and that I haven't created even greater confusion — and that through your arduous practice you will soon be liberated from all suffering. Sooner rather than later.

Discourse on the Establishment of Awareness - Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta (MN 10)

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 22 min

Originally given as *Discourse on the Establishment of Awareness - Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta (MN 10)* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this continuation of his series on the Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta (MN 10), Bhante Bodhidhamma explores the fourth foundation of Right Awareness: contemplation of mind objects (dhammānupassanā). He examines specific Buddhist teachings as objects of contemplation, including the five hindrances (pañca nīvaraṇa), the five aggregates (pañca khandha), the six sense bases (saḷāyatana), and begins discussion of the seven factors of awakening (satta bojjhaṅga).

Bhante emphasizes the practical application of these teachings in vipassanā meditation, warning against over-analysis during practice itself. He explains how recognition of hindrances like sensual desire and aversion leads to understanding their arising and passing away, demonstrating the characteristic of impermanence (anicca). The talk illuminates how the aggregates represent a cross-section of human experience, while the sense bases function as different dimensions of awareness.

This teaching provides essential background knowledge for insight meditation while maintaining that during actual practice, one must simply watch, feel, and experience without analytical thinking. The discourse reveals how systematic awareness of these mind objects leads toward the liberation that is the ultimate goal of the path.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

We are making our way through the discourse on how to establish right awareness. We've covered the body, then feelings, then mental states. This last section is called the contemplation of mind objects. In older translations, they sometimes

talked about thoughts and things like that. But when you actually read the discourse, it's quite obvious that the mind objects are specific teachings from the Buddha: the five hindrances, the five aggregates, the six sense bases, the seven factors of enlightenment, and the four noble truths.

I'm going through this at great speed, and the reason is that there are many good books on this sort of study if you want to take it more deeply. But I'm also always fearful that meditation turns into a sort of analysis, which is exactly what you don't want. If you're meditating and speaking to yourself, saying, "Now, is this a worldly, neither pleasant nor unpleasant feeling? Or is this an unworldly, neither pleasant nor unpleasant?" — then in a sense, you've lost the plot.

The idea of studying like this is for it to remain in the background. When we come to *vipassanā*, we forget all that. We just watch, we just feel. After *vipassanā*, of course, you can reflect — that's not the problem. But it will be quite clear that all thinking processes have to be put aside when we're just watching, just feeling, just experiencing.

I'll just read it so you get the phraseology of how the Buddha would have talked about it. How does a bhikkhu — remember this word bhikkhu means anybody who's practising — abide contemplating mind objects as mind objects? Here, a bhikkhu abides contemplating mind objects as mind objects in terms of the five hindrances. When something comes into the mind, the heart-mind really, and it's one of the hindrances, that is an object to be observed, felt, understood.

How does a bhikkhu abide contemplating mind objects as mind objects in terms of the five hindrances? Here, there being sensual desire in him, a bhikkhu understands there is sensual desire in him. It's a direct acknowledgement of desire. This is the benefit of the noting — it's just "desire, desire." And then of course, when it passes, there being no sensual desire in him, he understands there's no sensual desire in him.

This is something we have to really experience for ourselves. If the mind is full of some sort of desire — or if we go through the other hindrances: all the aversive stuff, all the dullness and lethargy, all the restlessness and guilt, and finally all these doubts — when these come to mind, we actually recognise what it is. In recognising what it is, we're also experiencing how it affects us: the agitation of desire, the burning of anger and that sort of stuff. Then when it passes, you experience the heart-mind without that. And knowing that, you want to move always towards the heart-mind which is not disturbed by any of the hindrances.

And so it ends by saying how there comes to be the arising of an unarisen sensual desire — in other words, what triggers the sensual desires — and how there comes to be the abandonment of the sensual desire, which is of course not getting involved. That's the indulgence bit. Remember, there's always the original desire that comes up and then there's the desire to indulge it. Are you planning your holiday, for instance, and off you go dreaming about how wonderful it will be? That's when the fetter's out.

And how there comes to be a future non-arising of abandoned sensual desire — which means that eventually the whole process of wrong desire, wrong aversion is completely gone. That's a high state of realisation, what we call the non-returner. This means somebody has arrived at a place where the sensual world no longer appeals. It's like when we're children and we grow out of snakes and ladders — the game no longer appeals. We come to a place in our practice where fine, the sensual world is fine, but it doesn't draw you into it anymore.

The Buddha goes on with the other four hindrances — remember: aversion, dullness and lethargy, restlessness (and included in there are things like guilt, remorse, shame), and sceptical doubt. Now, sceptical doubt isn't the honest doubt of the philosopher in us, that sense of wonder. None of this is meant to be taken as gospel — remember, we're supposed to be investigating it so it becomes true for ourselves.

There's a type of doubt which stops you from doing something, and that's the sceptical doubt. When you say "I can't do something" and you convince yourself you can't do it, that stops you from doing it. Something we've perhaps all experienced is the high diving board: you might have got up there and you're just too afraid to go — "can't do it, can't do it" — until somebody pushes you, and then of course you get in.

And of course, he does this — you're aware of these hindrances within you, but you can also be aware of them in others: greed in others, anger in others, and so forth. Then there's always this: vanishing factors and arising factors, both the arising factors and vanishing factors. Always this realisation, this constant understanding that things are continuously arising and continuously disappearing. That's the *anicca*, the impermanence of what it is that we're experiencing.

Then finally, when we get to that point of *vipassanā* where we're just watching, just feeling, just experiencing — simply established in him to the extent necessary for — now the word is *ñāṇa*, and it's translated here as bare knowledge. But *ñāṇa* is a similar word to *paññā*, which means to realise, to actually see something dir-

ectly. Enough of that intuitive intelligence and awareness to arise. And that word "mattāya", that word "just enough" — just enough for the insight to arise. That's the investigation of the five hindrances.

Then there are the five aggregates. If you forget them, let me remind you: there's the body with all its sensations, and it includes the sense bases. Then there's feelings. This is now — those of you who know dependent origination — that's the process: the human being in process of creating the world. Mainly the process of how we create suffering, and as we undo that, the process of how we slowly become fully liberated from wrong views and the purification of the heart. The dependent origination is the description of the process. Now the five aggregates is more a cross-section — if you were to take a human being at any one time and just look at that human being, then you'd come across these five aggregates.

An aggregate is telling us that it's made up of all sorts of little bits and pieces, like the body — billions of cells. There's the body, which from the mind's point of view, from our personal experience point of view, of course are the senses. We'll come to that in a minute. And then there's the feeling.

And then perception. This is all the meditation stuff that goes on. The perception, which is like a photograph or a photocopy of something, and how that photocopy is changed as we get to experience similar things over and over again, until we reach the higher concepts — things like freedom and happiness, for heaven's sake.

When those two are combined, feeling and perception, with the will to create something, that's when you have a habit. Sometimes you'll see it translated literally as volitional formations. In other words, the act of will has to be there for something to be done, and when you make an action and you repeat it, then you get the habit. And as they say, a compendium of habits, a whole collection of habits, is your personality. That's all that character and personality is — it's a collection of habits. Once you've got that, your destiny. It'll drive you somewhere.

What our practice is doing is making us look at these habits and decide, "Well look, this habit is going to take me into the hell realm and these habits are going to take me into the heavenly realm. So where do you want to be tomorrow?"

Again, he says, and how does a bhikkhu abide contemplating mind objects as mind objects in terms of the five aggregates? Here, a bhikkhu understands: such is material form, such is its origin — in other words, aware of the body when it arises like an itch, aware of its disappearance and of its arising and passing. And

the same with feeling: such is its origin, such is its disappearance. Perception: such is its origin, such is its disappearance. The habits: such is their origin and their disappearance. And finally consciousness.

I'll put that right at the end as it's mentioned — that consciousness. Remember, that's just a screen upon which everything is arising to be known. It's the first act, you might say, of cognition.

The next one is the six sense bases, the āyatana — dimensions, six dimensions, six spheres of experience, because the sense bases are mono, aren't they? You can only see through your eyes. You can't see through your ears — even if you try very hard through your ears, you can only hear. They are different ways of experiencing the world, and of course our inner experience too. And so they are to be seen more as dimensions.

This word āyatana is also used to explain Nibbāna, because he'll talk about Nibbāna as an āyatana where all this is not included, where all this does not manifest. It's a very famous verse in the inspiring discourse, the inspiring verses, the inspiring verse of Udāna, which perhaps we'll come upon another time.

Again, it's the same thing. You're observing the eye; he understands forms — the perception in the eye. He understands the fetter that arises with both. The fetter, of course, is desire or aversion.

Just as a side point, you can sometimes, as it were, if you're standing in a park — I think we're allowed now some parks anyway — or in the garden, and if you pan your garden from one side to the other or you pan what you can see out of your window, what you're looking at or what you're being aware of is how the eye picks things up for you. You don't have to try at all. As soon as the eye hits something, then it'll be recognized by the mind. You can actually step back, as it were, from that process and recognize that it's just happening as a psychological habit, you might say. That, of course, gives you the sense of, again, anattā — not me, not mine.

He does the same with all the other sense bases. He understands the ear and sounds, the nose and odours, the tongue and flavours, the body and tangibles — what you can feel. He understands the mind and mind objects — what you think, what you emot. And in each case, he understands the fetter that's dependent on both, and how that fetter arises. It's always this desire, this aversion, or a certain deluded understanding about what we're experiencing. And so there comes also the abandoning of that fetter, and how there comes to be no more fetters arising.

These fetters — that's a special word. We've actually touched upon it earlier. There are ten of them, and two are to do with sensual pleasure and aversion. They're fetters because they're holding us to this level of existence, this level of being, which is causing us suffering at some level or another.

The next section is slightly different, and these are beautiful. Again, the bhikkhu abides contemplating mind objects as mind objects — this time in terms of the seven enlightenment factors. How does he do that? When the mindfulness enlightenment factor is in him, he understands: 'There is this mindfulness enlightenment factor in me.' And when there's no mindfulness enlightenment factor in him, he understands that too. When the mind has wandered, you wake up and think, 'Ah, that's being mindless.'

Then the paragraph continues: he also understands how there comes to be the arising of the unarisen mindfulness factor. In other words, what makes mindfulness come, what establishes mindfulness for us. And how the arisen mindfulness enlightenment factor comes to fulfilment by development — how we can develop this mindfulness to a point where the fulfilment is eventually, not at this point but eventually, the liberation, the awakening.

Then he talks about the investigation of states — the factor of investigation. Here it's put in a particular form, but the way I've come to understand it is by seeing the opposites. This applies to interest, your curiosity, but that has to be balanced with a certain calmness. And then there's concentration, which has to be balanced with effort. If there's not enough effort you fall asleep; if there's too much effort you get restless. And equanimity — coming from a place of a balanced heart-mind where you can do the investigation clearly.

The investigation is this direct understanding of what we're experiencing, which is always from the point of view of relationship: desire, wrong desire, aversion, impermanence, and not-self.

With all of them, you get this same standard refrain: he also understands how there comes to be the arising of what was not there before — how there come to be all these different seven factors of enlightenment, and how to maintain them and develop them to their fullness. And at which point, hopefully, some liberation arises.

I think we can leave it there and finish off tomorrow evening.

Again, apologies for rushing through this, but as I say, there are many texts and this is a very fulsome discourse. There are other scriptures, the main one being from the Sarvāstivādins. This was another school which existed at the same time as Theravāda but seems to have died out. Their scriptures were kept in Chinese and have now virtually all been translated. So we have a translation of their Satipaṭṭhāna discourse, their discourse on how to establish awareness. It's not as full as this one. This has obviously been augmented — made fuller, grown over time with memory from what the Buddha was teaching, trying to get it all together in one discourse.

I hope my words have been of some assistance. May you, by your devotion to practice, be liberated from all suffering sooner rather than later.

Anusaya - Latent Tendencies

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 8 min

Originally given as *Anusaya - Latent Tendencies* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this DhammaBytes talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the concept of anusaya - latent tendencies or predispositions that lie dormant in our psychic system, ready to manifest when conditions arise. Drawing from early Buddhist scriptures through to the Abhidhamma, he explores how these seven fundamental tendencies evolved in the Buddha's teaching: sensual lust, attachment to existence (bhava), aversion, conceit, wrong views, doubt, and ignorance.

Using the compelling analogy of a computer's latent potential, Bhante explains how these anusaya exist not as stored memories but as pure potentiality - conditioned by past saṅkhāra (volitional formations) yet having no substantial existence until activated. He maps their psychological structure, showing how ignorance forms the foundation, branching into conceit and wrong views, which then manifest as the three primary responses: greed (wanting pleasure and becoming), aversion (not wanting), and confusion (doubt).

This teaching offers profound insight into how our conditioned responses arise and why insight meditation is essential for liberation. As Bhante emphasizes, until these latent tendencies are eradicated through wisdom, unwholesome actions will continue to arise. The talk connects ancient Buddhist psychology with modern understanding of subconscious conditioning, showing how paṭicca samuppāda (dependent origination) can be broken at the crucial point of ignorance through vipassanā practice.

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammāsambuddhassa. Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammāsambuddhassa. Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammāsambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the Blessed, Noble and Fully Self-Enlightened.

The word tonight is *anusaya*, A-N-U-S-A-Y-A. The Pali Text Dictionary translates it as a bent, a proclivity, latent tendency, and predisposition. The one that really interests me is latent tendency. But we'll come to that in a minute.

In the early scriptures, the Buddha talks about *anusaya* without actually saying what they are — just latent tendencies. We've all got latent tendencies. But later on, in a different level of the scriptures, perhaps as his teaching matures, things are added: pride, doubt, ignorance, lust, and so on. And in the end, in the *Abhidhamma*, they list them as seven.

The first one, the way they list it, is sensual lust. I think it's probably better described as bodily lust, even though it says *kāmarāga*. Then: attachment to existence, aversion, conceit, wrong views, doubt, and ignorance. None of them come as a big surprise, eh?

Now, to try and make sense of this list, it seems to me you've got to turn the order around a bit. If we take ignorance as the basic platform — a latent tendency in the sense of not knowing — then you immediately enter into delusion. On one side, wrong views; on the other, self, which expresses itself as conceit. "I have this view, I'm right and everybody else is wrong." That's your basic position.

From there, you fork into three, which relates to how the self relates to the world. Sensual pleasure and becoming — that's to do with greed and acquisitiveness. Then you've got aversion, the negative side, not wanting. And then doubt, which is the befuddlement that comes from this basic ignorance. Those are your latent dispositions.

Now, these latent dispositions — at least as I understand it — can't mean the Buddha taught we had some sort of store memory that you pick books off, like a library. It's more like a predisposition, and that's why I like this word latent tendency. It doesn't actually have any actuality.

I think one of the best analogies is a computer. If you take a metaphor to its logical end it's normally a sign of madness, so it only works at certain levels. When we shut the computer down and unplug it, it's dead — well, it's not, but we know it's got this tremendous latent ability. Plug it in and you can connect to the whole worldwide web, for heaven's sake. That's the potential of it. But when it's unplugged, it remains there as purely latent.

All these conditionings — see, the other word it uses is predisposition, and that links us with these *saṅkhāras*, these volitional conditionings. They're lying there in wait, you might say, but in this non-existent form. Yet it's there within the psychic system. Something happens and they're there to be pulled out.

This connects rather nicely with modern psychology about subliminal stuff and subconscious stuff. Although you do get the feeling from Freudian stuff that it's already there, as it were, in a sort of stored memory. But I think this is slightly more subtle in the sense that every moment comes to an end completely. It's a radical impermanence. You can't hold anything, and yet there's the potential. It's one of these little mysteries, really.

There's always that *bhavataṇhā*. When the Buddha describes *dukkha* as such, it's attachment to pleasure, the desire to keep becoming — becoming a self, in other words, keep being reborn as me. And the opposite is *vibhava*, the desire to put an end to that. That comes into the other fork, the aversion, not wanting. It shows up in obvious forms of not wanting something and not wanting to live. And the third is this doubt which comes from befuddlement, from confusion that arises out of this self.

Those are your seven *anusaya*. And in a sense, if you think about it, that is the platform out of which we then create the world. We create these *saṅkhāras*, these volitional conditionings.

Underneath it, there is that not knowing. It's creating a certain disposition, which then manifests as a disposition of "I am" with a view, then manifests as this more obvious psychological thing of wanting, not wanting, being confused. And then as something happens to us in daily life, it picks up on one of these and you suddenly find yourself being greedy or being hateful or being confused. That's basically, I think, how it is.

The final thing is that until these *anusaya* are actually eradicated from the system, there's no way our unwholesome actions can stop. And the only way you can undermine them is through insight, which breaks the delusion. That's why in dependent origination the real break is at that point of ignorance.

That brings to an end my little homily on the *anusaya*. I can only hope it has been of some benefit. May you be liberated from all your *anusaya* sooner rather than later.

Saṅkhāra: Volitional Conditioning

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 7 min

Originally given as *Saṅkhāra: Volitional Conditioning* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this fourth talk on the khandhas (aggregates), Bhante Bodhidhamma examines saṅkhāra - the aggregate of volitional formations or mental conditionings. Unlike the other aggregates which are largely given to us, saṅkhāra represents the active realm of will where we directly engage with life through our thoughts, emotions, and intentional actions.

Bhante explains how saṅkhāra operates on two levels: passively as our established habits and dispositions that form the platform for behavior, and actively as volitional formations that govern our thinking, speech, and actions in each moment. He clarifies how this specialized meaning within the khandhas differs from the broader usage where 'sabbe saṅkhāra' refers to all conditioned phenomena in the universe.

The talk emphasizes the crucial importance of saṅkhāra for liberation, as this is where the will operates and where vipassanā meditation works to transform unwholesome mental patterns. Bhante explains how even the Buddha has habits (saṅkhāra), but they are all beautiful and no longer govern him. The goal of practice is to purify these volitional formations, removing what is unwholesome while cultivating what supports awakening and ethical living.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato samma-sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato samma-sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato samma-sambuddhassa.

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-enlightened one.

So we're still going through these *khandha*. Just to remind you that *khandha* means heap or aggregate — bits and pieces all stuck together. We started off with *rūpa*, which was the body itself, and really what we were looking at was how the mind experiences the body. That's where we came across these four great

elements: fire, earth, water and air. Then we looked at *saññā*, which was basically the perceptual base — how it's turned into little percepts, how labels are put on things, and how later these are the basis for our intellect. Then we looked at *vedanā*, which was the feeling content. There were two types of feelings: those created by the body and those created by the mind. In the body, these will congregate to form our emotions.

So the fourth element is this *sankhāra*. Now *sankhāra* is used in a very wide sense by the Buddha. We chant "*sabbe sankhārā aniccāti*" in the morning chant, "*sabbe sankhārā dukkhāti*", "*sabbe sankhārā anattāti*". All compounded things are impermanent, unsatisfactory and not-self. So this *sankhāra* means all compounded things — it's the phenomenal universe. There's nothing substantial there; it's all made up of bits and pieces which through the magic of the mind take on a certain substantiality.

We know that from our science. You walk into a door, it hurts, but we know it's made up of subatomic particles. In fact, it was the meeting of one set of subatomic particles with another set — as simple as that. But in the *khandhas*, it has a more specialized meaning. It has those *sankhāras* which are within the mind itself. When I say mind here, remember it's the heart and mind, so when I write about this I usually use the word psyche to draw them both together. In our older medieval language, it would have been the soul.

So *sankhāra* there is the passive side, which we can talk about as our habits or dispositions. They are the platform upon which we then behave into the world. When they become activated, they're normally translated as volitional formations. So what we're talking about is our thinking and emotional life. The reason why the Buddha separates this out from all the rest of this psychophysical organism is because here is where the will is active. The rest are given.

Your body gives you the sensations and you can't do much about it. The mind has its own way of perceiving things and you can't do much about it — it's often dependent on our culture, frankly. And feelings just arise because of the makeup of the psychophysical organism. But here with *sankhāra*, this is the world we're living in in a much more direct way, and it's governed by the will, governed by what we intend to do, through our thoughts, our actions, our speech. That's where we get these volitional conditionings.

In our meditation — just before I say that, remember that the *khandhas* are a snapshot of the psychophysical organism. If you take a moment, this is what you'll find. It doesn't tell us much about the process. The process of the psychophysical

organism is expressed in the Wheel of Dependent Origination, and the *sankhāra* are really that middle bit which includes the reaction to things, the *tanhā*, and the grasping of it as "I want," and then the empowerment of it, which there is known as becoming. But here it's included in the understanding of *sankhāra*.

So these *sankhāras* are really where it all happens for us, where we actually experience life. The point of *vipassanā* is to take the unpleasantness out of those *sankhāras*. It's not as though the Buddha doesn't have habits, but he's not governed by them anymore, and they're all beautiful. That's the difference. We also have beautiful *sankhāras*, but there's a lot which aren't so beautiful.

In the Buddha's way of looking at things, a lot of them have to do with our ethical behaviour, so that brings a certain quality of morality to our behaviour too. The whole point of our *vipassanā* is to eradicate everything that's unwholesome within us which is established in these *sankhāras*.

So that brings to the end my little homily on *sankhāra*. I hope it has been of some assistance. May you be liberated from all your negative *sankhāra* sooner rather than later.

Sādhu, sādhu, sādhu.

PART 6

The Heart Practices



Mettā cittaṃ bhāṇeyāmi — I cultivate a mind of loving-kindness

Guided Mettā

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 28 min

Originally given as *Guided Mettā* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



This guided mettā bhāvanā session offers a complete practice of developing loving-kindness, one of the four brahmavihāras (divine abodes). Bhante Bodhidhamma leads practitioners through the traditional sequence: beginning with a loved one, extending to family and friends, turning mettā toward oneself, and radiating goodwill progressively outward to all beings everywhere.

The session includes the beautiful chanting of the Karaṇīyamettā Sutta (Discourse on Loving-Kindness) from the Sutta Nipāta, followed by practical forgiveness work - both seeking forgiveness from those we have hurt and offering forgiveness to those who have hurt us. Bhante emphasizes that mettā practice is primarily about cultivating the right attitude of goodwill rather than generating particular emotional states.

The guidance incorporates the 'four great efforts' from Right Effort, encouraging practitioners to abandon unwholesome mental states and cultivate beneficial qualities. This comprehensive approach makes mettā practice not just a meditation technique but a foundation for ethical living and spiritual development, ultimately pointing toward the peace and bliss of Nibbāna.

Mettā bhāvanā—developing goodwill. Don't be concerned if loving feelings don't arise during the exercise. Here we're concerned with attitude, with developing an attitude of goodwill, *mettā*. If pleasant emotions do arise, all well and good. If not, the exercise is still working for us, and eventually the heart will respond. Remember, you can stop the tape at any time and develop a part of it further. Make sure you're sitting in a comfortable position, and feel free to move—so long as you move slowly, it won't disturb your concentration.

Let's begin. Bring to mind someone you have a warm regard for—not someone you're connected to erotically or romantically. An old friend, a friend of the family, and so on. Offer them some worldly blessings: good health, long life, prosperity, whatever's appropriate. And we can offer them some spiritual blessings.

May you be free of greed and selfishness, hatred and ill will, fear and anxiety, ignorance and delusion. May you be kind and gentle, sympathetic and benevolent. May you be forgiving and compassionate. May you be joyful and rejoice in the success of others. May you be peaceful and calm. May you be liberated of all your sufferings. May you experience the peace and bliss of *Nibbāna*.

Now, allowing those images to fade away, sense that goodwill in your heart. Bring to mind all those who are near and dear to you, offering them worldly blessings.

May you be free of greed and selfishness, hatred and ill will, fear and anxiety, ignorance and delusion. May you be kind and gentle, sympathetic and benevolent. May you be forgiving and compassionate. May you be joyful and rejoice in the success of others. May you be peaceful and calm. May you be liberated of all your sufferings. May you experience the peace and bliss of *Nibbāna*.

Allowing those images to fade away, bring to mind friends, people at work, whomever you wish—offering them worldly blessings.

May you be free of greed and selfishness, hatred and ill will, fear and anxiety, ignorance and delusion. May you be kind and gentle, sympathetic and benevolent. May you be forgiving and compassionate. May you be joyful and rejoice in the success of others. May you be peaceful and calm. May you be liberated of all your sufferings. May you experience the peace and bliss of *Nibbāna*.

Allowing those images to fade away, turn the stream of compassion inward towards yourself. Offer yourself some worldly blessings.

May I be free of greed and selfishness. May I be free of hatred and ill will. May I be free of fear and anxiety. May I be free of ignorance and delusion. May I be kind and gentle, sympathetic and benevolent. May I be forgiving and compassionate. May I be joyful and rejoice in the success of others. May I be peaceful and calm. May I be liberated of all my sufferings. May I experience the peace and bliss of *Nibbāna*.

Having generated this goodwill within our hearts, let's begin to radiate it outwards. First, to those immediate to us—in our household, in our group—offering everyone worldly blessings.

May we be free of greed and selfishness, hatred and ill will, fear and anxiety, ignorance and delusion. May we be kind and gentle, sympathetic and benevolent. May we be forgiving and compassionate. May we be joyful and rejoice in the success of others. May we be peaceful and calm. May we be liberated of all our sufferings. May we experience the peace and bliss of *Nibbāna*.

Continue to radiate it outwards until you've covered the whole of your area, your town, your city—offering everyone, the good and bad alike, worldly blessings.

Continuing to radiate it outwards till we've covered the whole of our country, offering everyone worldly blessings.

Continuing to radiate it outwards till we've covered the whole of the earth, offering everyone worldly blessings.

May you be free of greed and selfishness, hatred and ill will, fear and anxiety, ignorance and delusion. May you be kind and gentle, sympathetic and benevolent. May you be forgiving and compassionate. May you be joyful and rejoice in the success of others. May you be peaceful and calm. May you be liberated of all your sufferings. May you experience the peace and bliss of *Nibbāna*.

Pausing for a while to consider those areas where there's war, destitution, oppression.

And now, choosing a phrase which most expresses whatever quality we wish to develop, be it love, compassion, joy or just peacefulness—a phrase such as "may all beings be happy"—gently repeating it in our hearts and offering it to all beings, to all beings before us and behind us, to the left, to the right, below and above and all around.

I shall chant the Discourse on Loving Kindness:

Kāraṇīyam attha-kusalena yantaṃ santaṃ padaṃ abhisamecca, sakko ujū ca sūjū ca, suvaco c'assa mudu anatimānī. Santussako ca subharo ca, appakicco ca salahuka-vutti, santindriyocca nipako ca, appagabbho kulesu ananugiddho. Na ca khuddaṃ samācare kiñci yena viññū pare upavadeyyuṃ. Sukhino vā khemino hontu, sabbe sattā bhavantu sukhittā.

Ye keci pāṇabhūtatthi, tasā vā thāvarā vānavasesā, dīghā vā ye mahantā vā, majjhimā rassakā añuka-thulā. Diṭṭhā vā ye ca adiṭṭhā, ye ca dūre vasanti avidūre, bhūtā vā sambhavesī vā, sabbe sattā bhavantu sukhittā.

Na paro paraṃ nikubbetha, nātimaññetha katthaci naṃ kiñci. Byārosanā paṭighasaññā, nāññamaññassa dukkhaṃ iccheyya. Mātā yathā niyaṃ puttāṃ, āyusā ekaputtam anurakkhe, evaṃ pi sabbabhūtesu, mānasam bhāvaye aparimāṇaṃ.

Mettañca sabba-lokasmim, mānasam bhāvaye aparimāṇaṃ. Uddhaṃ adho ca tiriyañca, asambādhaṃ averaṃ asapattaṃ. Tiṭṭhaṃ caraṃ nisinno vā, sayāno vā yāvat'assa vigata-middho, etaṃ satim adhiṭṭheyya, brahmam etaṃ vihāram idham āhu.

Diṭṭhiñca anupagamma, sīlavā dassanena sampanno, kāmesu vineyya gedhaṃ, na hi jātu gabbha-seyyaṃ punar eti'ti.

Having established this goodwill, a heart of openness, generosity, and compassion, let us now work with the area of forgiveness.

First, bring to mind someone we have hurt. As the incident comes to mind, the attendant emotions will arise—perhaps self-righteousness, or perhaps shame, guilt, remorse. As those emotions arise, we'll have a reaction to them. We'll want to indulge our self-righteousness, and we won't want to feel our sense of remorse or guilt.

Use that memory to contact these emotions, being wary not to let the memory shoot off into fantasy—just contact the emotions, let them arise, and see how we relate to them. We're working with that little vicious circle: the memory, the attendant emotions, and how we react to those emotions. Can we see how we cause suffering for ourselves? Can we acknowledge these attitudes and emotions as unskillful, unwholesome, negative, life-destructive rather than life-enhancing? They undermine our capacity to love, to relate, leading only to more suffering, not the end of it.

The antidote, of course, is to ask for forgiveness—arising out of a sense of remorse, a desire to be reconciled, a desire to put right what we did wrong, a desire to compensate.

Bringing that person to mind, let's talk about the situation with them and ask them to forgive us. Whatever harm I have done to you, in thought, word, and deed, by way of greed, hatred, and delusion, intentionally or unintentionally, please forgive me.

Perhaps you can see a change in them, a desire to forgive, to become reconciled. Can you accept their hand of friendship? Can you accept their forgiveness? Can we forgive ourselves?

May you be free of greed and selfishness, hatred and ill-will, fear and anxiety, ignorance and delusion. May you be kind and gentle, sympathetic and benevolent. May you be forgiving and compassionate. May you be joyful and rejoice in the success of others. May you be peaceful and calm. May you be liberated of all your sufferings. May you experience the peace and bliss of *Nibbāna*.

Allowing that image to fade away, sensing that goodwill in our hearts, let's bring to mind someone who has hurt us. Again, use that memory to contact feelings and emotions—the hurt, the desire for revenge. And again, see that reaction: how we don't want to feel the hurt, how we want to indulge our sense of revenge. We're working with that same little vicious circle: the memory, the attendant emotions, and our reaction to those emotions, being careful not to spin off into fantasy.

The antidote, of course, is to forgive. Remember that to forgive is not to forget, it's not to excuse, it's not to condone. It's simply a change of attitude, away from revenge and hurt, towards understanding and compassion—driven always by a desire to be reconciled.

Let us bring that person to mind, talk about the event, and offer them our forgiveness. Whatever harm you have done to me, in thought, word, and deed, by way of greed, hatred, and delusion, intentionally or unintentionally, I forgive you.

Perhaps we can see a change in them—a feeling of relief, a desire to be reconciled. Can we offer them a hand of friendship, and with it worldly blessings?

May you be free of greed and selfishness, hatred and ill-will, fear and anxiety, ignorance and delusion. May you be kind and gentle, sympathetic and benevolent. May you be forgiving and compassionate. May you be joyful and rejoice in the success of others. May you be peaceful and calm. May you be liberated of all your sufferings. May you experience the peace and bliss of *Nibbāna*.

Now we've completed two of the four great efforts: to develop what is beautiful in us, and to get rid of what is ugly within us. The next two are to prevent further ugliness and to develop virtues not yet developed.

First, let us recognise a certain trait within us—something unskillful, unwholesome—that we don't want to develop further. We can use the four affirmations: I can, I am able to resist its temptation. I ought to, for my own benefit and the benefit of others. I want to, and I will. Can, ought, want, will. Let us make a resolution that should a temptation ever arise, we will be resolute not to fall to it.

Sometimes there's a trait within us, a virtue not yet fully developed. Sometimes we see a virtue in another that we'd like for ourselves. Again, we use the four affirmations: I can, I am able to develop that virtue. I ought to, for my own benefit and the benefit of others. I want to, and I will. Let us make a resolve that should an occasion offer itself, we will practise that virtue.

Now let us turn that stream of compassion inwards once more, and offer ourselves some worldly blessings.

May I be free of greed and selfishness. May I be free of hatred and ill-will. May I be free of fear and anxiety. May I be free of ignorance and delusion. May I be kind and gentle, sympathetic and benevolent. May I be forgiving and compassionate. May I be joyful and rejoice in the success of others. May I be peaceful and calm. May I be liberated of all my sufferings. May I experience the peace and bliss of *Nibbāna*.

And so, finally, let us offer our goodwill once more to all beings in all directions.

May all beings be free of physical pain. May all beings be free of mental distress. May all beings be liberated of all their sufferings. May all beings live in contentment and joy. May all beings live together in peace and harmony. May all beings experience the peace and bliss of *Nibbāna*.

Sabbe sattā sukhitā hontu. Sabbe sattā sukhitā hontu. Sabbe sattā sukhitā hontu.

Karaṇīya Mettā Sutta

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 28 min

Originally given as *Karaṇīya Mettā Sutta* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



Bhante Bodhidhamma offers an in-depth study of the Karaṇīya Mettā Sutta (Khuddakapāṭha 9), the Buddha's foundational discourse on loving-kindness practice. This talk explores the traditional verses that outline both the moral prerequisites for developing mettā and the progressive stages of boundless goodwill cultivation.

Drawing from Buddhaghosa's classical definitions in the Visuddhimagga, Bhante explains mettā as friendliness with the function of promoting goodwill and manifesting as the absence of ill-will. He examines the sutta's opening qualities — being skilled (sakko), upright (ujū), gentle in speech (suvaco), tender-hearted (mudu), and without pride (atimāni) — as essential foundations for authentic loving-kindness practice.

The talk addresses practical aspects including contentment (santuṭṭhako), simplicity of lifestyle (subharo), reducing busyness (appakicco), and calming the sense faculties (santindriyo). Bhante emphasizes mettā as one of the brahmavihāra (divine abodes) and pāramī (perfections), explaining how this practice extends boundlessly through space and time to all breathing beings (pāṇa).

With references to Gerard Manley Hopkins' poetry and practical guidance for establishing a 'touchstone' for warming the heart, this talk provides both scholarly insight and accessible meditation instruction for developing this fundamental Buddhist practice.

I was rooting around on the internet and came across a course written by Andrew Olendzki. He was the director of the Barre Center for Buddhist Studies, an offshoot of IMS, the big meditation centre in Barre, Massachusetts — the one begun by Joseph Goldstein, Sharon Salzberg, Jack Kornfield, and others. He did a lot of good work while he was there, and they produce a very good magazine.

Anyway, his course is based on the Karaṇīya Mettā Sutta, which is what we normally chant at the end of this sitting. I thought I'd go through it to give you an idea of how the Buddha puts it all together. If you want to take it further, I'll put up the link.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā-sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā-sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā-sambuddhassa. — Homage to the Buddha, the Blessed Noble and fully Self-Awakened One.

Just in case I forget at the end — I usually do forget to say these things — I hope you have a joyful Christmas and a great new year.

The Karaṇīya Mettā Sutta is the discourse on what we ought to do in order to develop *mettā*. That's what Karaṇīya means. It comes from a very early stratum of the Buddha's teachings, a collection of verses. Remember that in those days they couldn't read and write. It's a bit odd to think of the Buddha as illiterate, but he was. Because it was composed as verse, it's pretty close to what he himself would have developed.

The word *mettā* comes from *mitta*, which means friends. To translate it, we can use the words you'll often see: loving kindness. Loving is the attitude you have within yourself; kindness is the way you express it. There's another translation: goodwill. That stresses the role of intention and the will itself. And of course, it's there in the Christmas greeting, isn't it? Peace on earth and goodwill to all men — or as we would say, all sentient beings.

Bhikkhu Bodhi's definition is a heartfelt concern for the well-being and happiness of others. I think that touches a bit on compassion, really. And it doesn't mention that there's no self-interest and no attachment.

We've got lots of types of love: erotic, romantic, family relationships, friends, people at work. These aren't evil relationships. You would still have them even if you were fully liberated. But unfortunately, because we're not liberated, there'll be some attachment to them, some expectations, which leads to disappointment and sometimes to control. That's all to do with the type of unwholesome love.

Buddhaghosa, who wrote the Path of Purification — some of you might know it, a great big tome which is probably one of the great spiritual manuals of the world — gave this definition in the fifth century. It's how he defined all virtues. Mettā has the mode of friendliness as its characteristic. Its natural function is to promote friendliness. It is manifested as the disappearance of ill will. That's a bit

odd, isn't it? To manifest something that disappears. But basically, when there's no ill will, you know it's got to be mettā. And its footing, its basis, is seeing with kindness.

Here's a line I like. When it succeeds, it eliminates ill will — because you can't have those two mental states together. If you've got goodwill, there can't be ill will. When it fails, it degenerates into selfish, affectionate desire. Those are a couple of strong lines.

Mettā appears quite often in the Buddha's lists. It's one of the perfections. It's one of the divine abodes, the most beautiful mental state you can develop. It's one of the four illimitables — along with compassion, joy, and equanimity — which means you can develop it indefinitely. And it's also a suitable subject for developing the absorptions, those blissed-out states.

The first stanza says, "This is what has to be done. One has to be skilled in what is good in order to reach the peaceful state." *Santampadam* — the path of peacefulness. Now, this is about achieving Nibbāna, though if you do that course you'll find he stretches it into peace in society, peace within yourself, and all that. But actually, this discourse is about achieving Nibbāna. It's worthwhile to notice when you're peaceful, because that quality of peacefulness is one of the seven factors of enlightenment — one of those things we ought to develop just generally.

These are qualities the Buddha presumes we've already begun to develop. The first is *sakko* — a confidence, a capability in doing this work. Then comes *ujū ca, suhujū ca*: to be upright, really upright. This concerns our moral rectitude, getting away from the stuff that comes out of delusion — acquisitiveness, aversion, and fear.

Next is *suvaco*, which means skilful speech. Our words need to be kindly, truthful, beneficial, and — rather importantly — timely. Something might be kind, truthful, and beneficial, but you shouldn't have said it then. *Mudu* is a softness, a tenderness, normally paired with the word for heart. So it's a gentle heart, a tender person. And *atimānī* means to be without pride, arrogance, or conceit — to be unpretentious.

In the next verse he speaks of *santussako* — to be contented. This isn't the contentment you feel when you've done a good job, or found someone you like to be with. This contentment is more basic, a fundamental attitude. It's entering each moment with a sense of 'this will do.' It doesn't mean you can't change things, but it underlies everything we do.

Subhara means easily maintained — this probably refers to monastics originally. But it's about making a distinction between what you need, what you want, and what is actually sufficient. That will depend on your daily life, but basically it means needing only a little. And these days, of course, with climate change, it carries a bit more meaning.

Appakicco means to be less busy. I think that rings a bell, doesn't it? We're always trying to do too much, achieve too much — burnout and all that. So it's good to reflect on our lifestyle, find out where we're actually stressing, and just let go of a few things. I think it's to do with priority.

What also helps, I think, is making the small tasks we do meaningful. Just washing pots, vacuuming, all that. Normally we want to get them out of the way and get on with life. But if you see them as occasions to stop for a minute and do them very mindfully, in a relaxed way, abandoning all ill will — they become little islands. From there you launch into your next project. Remember the old Zen saying: when you wash the pots, just wash the pots.

Salahuka vutti — engaging lightly. This means not taking things too seriously, keeping mindfulness, being able to relax and maintain that wholesome heart attitude. It's actually just keeping a smile on the face. That background smile really helps, so you don't get too serious about things.

Santindriyo is quietening the faculties. We're a very visual culture with all this YouTube and TV and Netflix and social media. We're always looking for some sensual delight — the countryside, some excitement. And in a sense, that misses the mark because it's not quite happiness. That's why excitement often doesn't work for us; whatever used to make us really excited loses its flavour. So it comes back to being content. Every so often, spend some time looking at a blank wall, allowing that sense to calm down a bit.

Nipako means prudent, wise, discreet, thoughtful. That's a lovely quality, isn't it? To be considerate, basically — aware of what other people need. We're always centring upon ourselves.

Apagabho means to be modest, courteous, not impudent. Again, it's about not pushing yourself. The word humility doesn't go down too well these days because we all believe in the sovereign self. But humility actually just means to be natural, to be in communication with people, to see yourself in relationship.

This is another reinforcement not to hanker after worldly things. When you walk down the shopping mall, your eyes are constantly gazing — the clothes, the jewellery, the computers, the laptops, the phones. Always looking for something. But if you're there to get something specific, just go for it and then have a cup of tea.

The third stanza sums it all up: not to commit even the slightest deeds that a wise person could find fault with. That basically says it all.

This wise person is the spiritual friend, your *kalyānamitta*. That could be a teacher, or it could be a very close friend — somebody you can talk to about things that have spiritual meaning. And if there isn't one, there's always the Buddha within. When I have a moral question, or really any question, if I just sit very still and plunk it into the heart, I normally get a fairly good answer. We have wisdom inside us, but sometimes we're overcome with doubt, and to discuss it with somebody can be very helpful.

Then we get the first well-wishing: may all beings live in safety, *khemino*, and in gladness, *sukhino*. The word *sukhi* simply means happy. Put a D instead and it's *dukkhi* — not happy. And then it says, *sabbe sattā bhavantu sukhittā*: may all beings develop, may they become more happy.

This gives us a hint as to what we ought to say. And notice — it's not about me feeling happy. When you're doing mettā, you're not trying to make yourself feel happy; your intention is directed towards others. There is a point where you turn inward and say, may I be happy — there's no problem with that. But you're not practising mettā in order to be happy, or it just becomes a self-centred practice. You're doing it to establish a relationship with the world, one of giving, of offering.

Then the Buddha gives us ways to do this — a technique. He says: whatever beings there are, weak or strong, without exception, long or short, big, medium-sized, small, subtle or gross. The word here is *pāna*, which means breathing beings. I presume this includes insects, though I'm not so sure about bacteria. What he's suggesting is that no matter how a being looks, no matter what their physical shape, it's always that attitude of offering goodwill.

In the second verse, he opens it out further: those who are visible or invisible — you can't even see them. Residing near or far, those who have already been born and those yet to be born. This is almost transcending space and time. You're really just expanding it outwards.

In the sixth verse he returns to conduct: let no one deceive another. Once you've developed this mettā, you can't do that. To deceive somebody is really to take advantage of them. And let him wish no harm — not to take advantage of somebody.

The next line is not to despise anybody. You have to be careful about that — not to be excessively or angrily critical. Watch out for jealousy and bad-mouthing. And of course, this also refers to ourselves, to what they call the inner critic. When you hear yourself lambasting yourself, just turn towards it and say, calm down. Turn it into a little devil and give it a hug.

In the seventh verse, he points out: just as a mother would protect her only child at the risk of her own life, even so we should cultivate boundless thoughts of loving kindness towards all beings. That's a very strong image — a mother protecting a child who's being threatened.

I saw a video recently of a lion and a lioness who were beginning to mate. They were walking on opposite sides of a fence — obviously a containment in some reservation — and as the lion moved down one side he was making sounds like yawning, if you can imagine that. The lioness was coming the other way with a companion, yawning as well. So I thought when they got together there'd be a bit of hanky-panky and smooching. But in fact, as soon as he got close, he attacked her viciously. Both lionesses attacked him back, and then he pulled away.

I thought, that is so strange — there was no comment about it in the video. But here's what happens: if a lioness has cubs by a particular lion, that lion goes off. He's done his bit. If a stray lion comes past, he'll try to kill all those cubs and mate with her so she has his cubs instead. She has to defend them. Sometimes she's actually killed, but most times she just comes away with bites and bruises. So what he was doing was testing her fierceness. Then the commentator says, and now he's showing respect. I couldn't work that out, but seemingly he was showing her respect.

And of course, we have the story of the Buddha calming the elephant that had been set upon him by the dastardly Devadatta — a cousin who wanted to lead the order and had lots of criticism. That was the picture I had up before. Just in case you didn't see it, I'll share the screen quickly.

So that's the *mudrā* — what we associate with loving kindness. That hand, offering it from love. It's nicely shaped there; normally it's just a flat hand, which isn't so appealing. And in his lap, I'm taking that to be the Dhamma, the jewel of the Dhamma. It's a Thai statue, that.

So now we have a third way to develop mettā, and it goes even further: let him cultivate boundless thoughts of loving kindness towards the whole world. What the Buddha means, of course, is all the worlds, all the cosmos — above, below, and all around. This is the practice of radiating mettā in the six directions. Normally it's a compass thing — north, south, and so on — but as we do it: all beings in front, behind, left, right, below, and above. Unobstructed, free from hatred and enmity.

In the next verse, he's saying this should be developed all the time — it should become a natural state of mind. Whether you're standing, walking, seated, or lying down, as long as you're awake, you should develop this mindfulness.

Whenever I read a translation, I always slip in 'affectionate' there. It's not just mindfulness. It's an affectionate mindfulness.

Just now, as we're all looking at each other, put a little kindling of kindness in your heart towards everybody. See, you can do it, can't you? That warmth can be there all the time, even when we're not so aware of it. And that's what he's asking us to do. He calls it a divine abiding — so this is like being a god.

In the final verse, he sums it up: you don't want to have erroneous views. These are the views about how we create suffering for ourselves through wrong desire, through not understanding impermanence, through not accepting that we're going to grow old, get sick, and die. And there's this relationship we have with body, heart, and mind — taking it all to be 'me.' That's the identity of having this human form. Our practice of *vipassanā* is trying to make that clear. In fact, what we are looking for is what's looking.

There's also erroneous views about *kamma* — that you can't get away with anything. It comes back one way or another. There's a very interesting quote from Jung I came across. He says, 'Whatever has been repressed will manifest as fate.' If you look at your life and find yourself doing something over and over again, falling into the same sort of mistake, then underneath that there will be some suppressed or repressed mental state. I think that's really quite an insight.

Then he says: endowed with these virtues and wise with insight. The next line is a bit heavy because you have to abandon all sensual desire. But remember, it doesn't mean you stop eating. It just means abandoning wrong desire — that greed which tries to get happiness from the sensual world as a permanent thing. That's the problem. Happiness arises and passes away like anything else.

So that's a quick run through this particular discourse. How do we practise it? Well, remember it's good to have a touchstone — something you can go back to that raises that sense of warmth, that kindling in the heart. For instance, one teacher I know talks about holding a baby. You might use a pet — we always love pets. Or we normally start with the benefactor, somebody who warms the heart.

Once you've got that and developed it a bit, you can always return to it. Whenever you move into a new category and feel the warmth in your heart has gone, just go back and remind yourself of that kindling by bringing that person or pet or whatever it is to mind. And remember, you're developing it in order to cultivate right attitude towards all beings.

The other thing is not to worry if it doesn't come. The heart has its own logic, doesn't it? You want to feel loving, but you're just not feeling it. If you obsess about that, it becomes a misery. But just by doing the practice, I think you'll find...

I have a poet, Gerard Manley Hopkins, who some of you might know. He's known as the father of modern English poetry, and some of his sonnets are really about his own spiritual development. There's one that starts: 'My own heart, let me more have pity on. Let me live to my sad self, hereafter kind, charitable. Not live this tormented mind with this tormented mind tormenting yet. I cast for comfort. I can no more get by groping round my comfortless than blind eyes in their darkened day or thirst confined thirsts all in all, in all the world of wet.'

Those first two lines I've often used — 'My own heart let me more have pity.' If you can get that kindling within yourself, then you offer it out from there. I find it extremely strong. 'Let me live to my sad self hereafter, kind and charitable' — to my anxious self, my angry self, my guilty self. It doesn't do much for the poem, but you can use it that way to generate warmth towards yourself. And of course, it's easier to move from that heart. But as I say, if it's not there, don't worry at all — you can use your pet or something to generate it.

I can only hope these words have been of some help, and that through your practice of *mettā*, you will cultivate a beautiful heart — one that leads you to lasting peace and happiness.

To Love or To Be Loved: That is the Question!

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 17 min

Originally given as *To Love or To Be Loved: That is the Question!* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this exploration of mettā (loving-kindness), Bhante Bodhidhamma examines a fundamental question that shapes our spiritual practice and relationships: Do we love in order to develop our capacity for love, or do we love to be loved in return? Drawing insights from Eric Fromm's psychology alongside Buddhist teachings, he reveals how our deepest loneliness stems from the self's inherent sense of insecurity and separation.

The talk illuminates how we typically try to fill this existential void through acquisitiveness—seeking wealth, power, pleasure, or appreciation—but these strategies only deepen our dependency and anxiety. Bhante explains the Buddhist concept of anusaya (latent tendencies), the unconscious motivations that drive our seemingly loving actions, and how bringing awareness to these hidden patterns can transform our practice.

Using vipassanā techniques, he guides us toward embracing difficult emotions like loneliness rather than escaping through distraction. When we courageously stay present with these raw feelings, allowing them to run their course, they naturally transform into their opposites—potentially bursting into universal love for all beings. This process of purifying our intentions and developing genuine mettā requires conscious effort, unlike the natural loves that arise spontaneously in human relationships.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

Greetings to all you revellers in full moon delights. Some of these months lend themselves to certain subjects, so obviously this one is about love.

I reread Eric Fromm's classic, *The Art of Loving* — I've read it about five times over the years. Some of you might know it; definitely worth a read. He starts off with something I'm going to turn into a question: when we do something, or say something, or think something out of love, do we do it in order to love — in order to develop our love — or do we do it to be loved? That's a cheeky one, that.

Fromm talks about why we need this love. Of course, it's a psychoanalysis thing. When we're born, for those first few months or so, there's no separation between us and our mothers. That's really a halcyon peace, a heavenly state to be in. Then, of course, the separation starts, which is needed for the child to become a little independent being. But that separation brings a sense of loss. According to psychoanalysis, this is what produces our loneliness in life — we want to get back to that wonderful place we were when we were babies.

From the Dharma's point of view, it's more to do with the essential relationship we make with this psychophysical organism we call the self. The self knows that it's unstable. It comes to know that it's not secure. So the fundamental position from a dharma point of view is this feeling of unsafety.

Because of that feeling, we start collecting things. That's the first thing the Buddha talks about. It's translated as greed, but it's much better to see it as acquisitiveness. We acquire things, and there are four major areas where we do that.

First, riches — I want to be rich, loads of money, like Scrooge. The more I have, the safer I feel. If I've got a million pounds in the bank, I feel really safe.

Then there's power. Control over our lives, control over people makes us feel safe. We're in charge. That can also be a real pain.

Then there's pleasure — seeking people who just want one experience after another. Been there, got the T-shirt, all that stuff. Foodies who live for the next exciting menu.

Finally, there are those who seek to be appreciated, to be praised. Usually we're seeking some sort of fame. Here we're dealing with fame, or the desire to be loved.

This desire would also be a cause of loneliness. When we feel lonely, we have these little words going on in our heads about how useless we are, how horrible. What we do is reinforce that by forming friendships — padding out our friendships by making sure they're stable. We don't want to lose them because then we'd feel really lonely.

But unfortunately that's a bad strategy, because it makes us dependent on those friendships. It means our self-worth or self-esteem is dependent on what other people think about us, what they say about us, how they treat us. And so sometimes you feel pretty rotten if you do that.

Of course, people we love disappear. They leave us, or they get fed up with us, or they die. Nothing can be taken for granted. There's always that little sense of anxiety about loss. Anything we become attached to will create some anxiety of loss.

The best strategy is actually to love — to come from a position of love. When you do that, you immediately fill yourself with good feelings, good feelings about yourself. That sense of self-worth, of self-esteem, comes naturally when we act from a position of love and all the other social virtues: compassion, joy, and so on.

How do we purify our love? First, we have to recognise that this thing about the self — its loneliness, its neediness — has to be seen clearly. When we're doing something, we've got to notice these little background voices. In the Buddhist teachings, they're known as latent tendencies, the *anusaya*. They're always there, ready to be fired. In psychology, they'd call them subconscious motivations. That's where we get the idea of Freudian slips — something's happening in the back of the mind, we're not recognising it, and it comes out in a slip that makes us feel embarrassed.

When we're about to do something, say something, or even think something, we've always got to be aware of this other little dialogue going on. It might be, for instance, "I'm going to do your garden," while the background voice is saying, "And you'll come and do mine when I need it," or "I know you'll really love me after this. You'll really appreciate my friendship." There are always these little things going on in the background. It's really a case of making them conscious.

Now, as soon as they become conscious, they lose power over you. If you remember, after the Buddha was fully liberated, there were seven years, it's said, that Mara chased him with his three daughters. Sensual desire, sexual desire... and if you don't know the third one, I'll leave you to guess it. After seven years, Mara began to go away. The Buddha said, "What's happening?" Mara said, "The Buddha sees me. He sees me." The Buddha said, "Give us a bit more time." Mara said, "No, after seven years, I'm not going to get through to the Buddha."

As soon as we see these little conversations coming from the self — the neediness of the self, the wanting to be loved — they don't have power over us. We then reestablish our commitment to doing something from the heart of love. That's how we begin to purify our hearts.

The purification of the heart demands a lessening of the self. Therefore, the path of love is a path of liberation. The path of purification is itself a path of liberation. Normally, of course, we put the accent on insight, on seeing things, which is absolutely necessary as well. But with the path of love, this is the process: you're constantly purifying your intentions, coming from the heart.

It's funny — there's always an effort in philosophy to give you reasons. There's not time to go into the way philosophers think about ethical behaviour, love, compassion, joy, and all that. They try to give us rational reasons. But the great Scottish philosopher Hume — I've heard him called the philosopher's philosopher — says that whenever he looked into an act of goodwill, he didn't find a reason at the bottom of it. He found a sentiment. That's his word for something that arises out of the heart. Confucius said that the ground of a harmonious society was benevolence and concern, love and compassion.

Everything around love always begins in the heart. The only problem is that it's not always a feeling. You don't have to feel loving in order to act from a position of goodwill. A surgeon who's operating — I doubt they feel some great big gushing love towards their patient. Their attention is on what they're doing. They should be equanimous, calm, cool.

So again, when we say the heart, we're really talking about attitude, not feeling. The feeling is sometimes there and sometimes it isn't. That's important to understand.

When we feel lonely, it's a bit of a downer for the self because the language is something like, "Nobody loves me. Who could love me? I'm horrible." All that really, really upsetting talk. So we try to escape it. As soon as you feel lonely, as soon as it just drips into consciousness, off we go. We turn on the TV, get onto social media, open a new packet of biscuits — anything but feel the loneliness.

That's why we don't like to tell people we feel lonely — because what we're really saying to them is that we're not loved, not appreciated. So it's a difficult one for us.

By trying to escape loneliness, of course, it still remains there as one of these anusaya, these latent tendencies. And what it's going to do is make you overact your love to other people so you can prove that you are appreciated. You're going to be overly joyous at people's success just so they know you are joyous, so you can be praised for it, appreciated, loved.

So you've got to tackle the loneliness in its rawness. This is what vipassanā teaches us. We go into the mental state, the feel of it. You have to have patience. You have to be open to it. It helps to have a sense of care towards it, a sense of wanting to heal the heart of it. That gives you the right attitude towards the feeling of loneliness.

But you still have to go in there. You have to sink into it and feel the raw feelings. What you're doing, of course, is opening up to your heart. The heart wants to speak to you, and it speaks in feelings, in mental states. In so doing, we're letting off that steam. We're allowing that turbulence to manifest as turbulence, as energy — and therefore it's exhausting itself, just like anything else. If you go for a run, at the end of it you feel exhausted. So if you give the heart a run, it'll feel exhausted too.

Now the really important thing — if you can — is to stay to the very last sensation caused by that loneliness. Because if you stay there, you might see the transformation. That energy is never lost. It always transforms towards its opposite. What you may experience is a sense of wonderful relief and peacefulness. But also, to your great surprise, it might burst out into this universal love for all beings. It's quite remarkable what will happen if you stay to the end.

You don't have to stay to the end for this technique to allow the heart to purify itself. But if you do, it gives you real confidence — because now you know that all these negative mental states are always moving towards their opposites. No energy is lost. Of course, that doesn't mean that when they reach their opposites, when you do feel love, these mental states can be developed indefinitely. In other words, after a year of real commitment, you should be constantly sailing in a sea of joyous love. No doubt about it.

Unfortunately, this universal love that we're trying to get to — this love which is above any love to do with attachments — is something we have to develop. All these other loves, if you think about it, come naturally. There's a natural loving of parents towards their children. You don't organise yourself. You don't set yourself up to fall in love. You just fall in love. You meet somebody and you like them, and before you know it, you've fallen in love, or you've developed a friendship be-

cause of that connection between two hearts. All these types of love are just part of our natural human nature. But to lift it into this universal love, this mettā, takes effort. You've got to lift yourself out of that stuff and really make an effort to open up your heart to all beings in all directions. That's really the final thing.

So the question then is: to love or to be loved? Like Shakespeare in Hamlet: "That is the question." To love or to be loved — in terms of our daily activity, in terms of our spiritual practice. If we keep an eye on these anusaya, these latent tendencies, we'll get a hang of it.

It means you've got to have a slightly more spacious awareness — an awareness which is not only about what's out there, but a constant inner awareness. You know all the time how you're feeling. It's just there in the background. When something moves, an irritation or something like that, you become aware of it. And because you're aware of it, it no longer has control over you. You can just park it — you're not pushing it away with fear or with aversion, those are suppressive measures. You're just putting it to the side and reestablishing your attitude, your act of will.

I think that's it. I think I've done it. So I can only hope my words have been of some assistance, and that by your sincere practice of goodwill and concern, you will be liberated from all sufferings sooner rather than later.

Karuṇā: The Fourth Brahmavihāra - Compassion Practice and Pitfalls

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 28 min

Originally given as *Karuṇā: The Fourth Brahmavihāra - Compassion Practice and Pitfalls* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this heartfelt exploration of karuṇā (compassion), the fourth of the brahmavihāras (divine abodes), Bhante Bodhidhamma begins with personal reflections from his travels on the hippie trail in 1970s Calcutta, illustrating how witnessing suffering without responding can teach us about the nature of compassionate action. He distinguishes between sympathy and empathy, and explains the Buddha's term anukampā (literally 'trembling towards') as the heart's connection to others' suffering.

The talk examines both passive and active modes of compassion, warning against common pitfalls including do-gooding, empathy bias, codependency, and compassion fatigue. Bhante emphasizes that true compassion brings deep happiness rather than suffering, and references the Buddha's teaching about caring for the sick monk as caring for the Buddha himself. The session concludes with a guided compassion practice using traditional blessing phrases, extending loving wishes through the ten directions to all beings who suffer.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

I've chosen to look at compassion, the last of our four *brahmavihāras*—the dwelling places of the highest gods. By this we mean the most beautiful mental states we can achieve. We've done love, done joy, done equanimity. So compassion is the last one.

I'd like to start with my own little story. I went along the hippie trail around about the 70s and ended up in Calcutta during the Indo-Pakistan War, when Bangladesh got its liberation from West Pakistan. Every day for three weeks, while we were expecting bombers to come over, I used to go to this Sikh restaurant. On the opposite side of the road sat a woman with a huge goitre under her chin. I passed that woman every day. I never gave her a penny.

One day, just as I turned around the corner, there was a little girl who must have been well over seven—undernourished, looking very young. She was squatting down chewing a dried-out black banana skin. She had this self-possession, really, to cover her sex, because all she had was this little dress. And I walked straight past her.

I've got these two images from this callow youth, and they're very difficult for me to remember without a certain sense of pain. The pain is there not simply because I saw this sort of suffering, which I'd just never seen before—sick people everywhere, lepers, people with elephantiasis, lying there on the pavement. What pains me is that I didn't respond. I didn't put a penny in that woman's hand. She sat there all day, completely emotionless, with her hand out like that. And I didn't go out and buy a banana for this little girl. This is what happens when you haven't responded from a compassionate heart, for whatever reason.

It all begins with connection—what we call empathy, and sometimes sympathy. I want to make a little distinction here, an arbitrary one because these words are used in different ways. Sympathy these days has some suggestion of pity, but for me, sympathy is when you have to imagine what the person is suffering. I've never been starving. I've been hungry, but I've always had food. I've never been in a state where I'm actually starving. All I can do is imagine what it must be like, because I've felt hungry. There's a connection there.

But when it comes to refugees, I've never been a refugee. I haven't a clue what it means to suddenly up and out of your home, to find yourself on the road without much money, having to buy your way, sometimes being attacked. There's a point where sympathy requires you to imagine what the person is going through. And there's empathy, where you've actually had an experience that connects you.

The Buddha himself uses a word, *anukampā*. The prefix *anu* suggests movement towards, and *kampā* actually means trembling. He says: whatever a teacher can do for his students out of *anukampā*, out of this connection with his students,

I have done for you. This *anukampā* is that point where you have a sense in your own heart of the suffering of the other—whether it's imaginative sympathy or empathic connection.

The other word we use is *karuṇā*, which has its root in doing. The Sanskrit word *kṛ* means doing, but it was also used for what is holy—it was part of the rituals of the Vedas. So *karuṇā* is actually the action. You might call it the sacrifice or the sacrament.

When we have responded to somebody's suffering, no matter what it is—the smallest to the most awful—there are two modes: one passive, one active.

In the passive mode, it's often good enough just to be with the person, not even to say anything. An obvious case would be when someone is extremely ill, just lying there in bed, and all you can do is accompany them. And of course, when somebody is dying. What we come across in such situations is our sense of powerlessness, and that's very difficult for us because we want to do something. Yet if we're sensitive enough to the situation and to the person, often it's good enough just to be with them, just to accompany them.

When it comes to compassionate action—when you're actually going to do something—our tendency is to try and overdo, to slip into the error of the do-gooder. We've all got it in us: wanting to do the good we want to do for your benefit, whether you want it or not. Of course, this really gets up people's noses.

It's a good idea to ask them what they want to do. Even if your suggestion is rejected—even if you know your suggestion would actually be the better thing to do—we've got to pull back and let the person who's suffering have the last say. Often when we over-help like that, perhaps it's coming from some inner feeling of wanting to be esteemed, to be loved—all the usual rubbish that we suffer from.

Compassionate presence requires courage. In extreme cases, where someone is really suffering, you've got to have the courage simply to be with them. It's very difficult when a person is in a lot of pain, especially when they're dying. I read a book about a poor woman who was screaming every time towards the end of her life. Eventually the doctor decided to sedate her, with the permission of the family. It often takes real courage to be with somebody who's in that kind of pain.

There are certain situations—perhaps at work, or when you're looking after someone—where you have reactions of disgust. They're sick, they're suffering from diarrhoea, all the impurities of the body manifest. Somehow you have to recognise that disgust for what it is, and yet still come from the heart of compassion.

We can often be caught unawares when somebody asks us to do something and we feel messed about. I had my day carefully planned, and now they want me to do this and that—especially within a family—and you can feel yourself getting angry. Again, it's being aware of these negative emotions that come up, these negative mental states, and still focusing on what you can do for the person.

Sometimes a person hurts themselves in an accident, and you might find yourself wanting to blame them. So stupid—how could you do that? I remember I once had an assistant here who put a ladder up against the gutter on the decking. The ladder slipped and he fell flat onto his face, almost. Luckily there was nothing but a bit of a bruise. But I could hear myself thinking, well, that was stupid, wasn't it? I didn't say it. No, I didn't say it. I went up and made sure he was okay. But you've got to be careful.

If it's somebody close to you, you can feel quite overcome by grief. That can have an immobilising effect. Again, it's just resting with that, trying to come above it, and connecting with the person. That way, I think we can keep these emotional states at bay. You might have to deal with them afterwards, but not while you're in the situation with them.

You can understand things like panic—when a child hurts itself and the parents just panic. Obviously that doesn't help the child. But again, hopefully we can bring that mindfulness, that connection with our own hearts and our reaction, and then rise above it and respond.

Then there's pity—another one that isn't particularly nice. Pity comes from a superior position, often because we're trying to guard ourselves against actually connecting with what's happening. 'Oh, poor thing. I feel so sorry for you. I know how you're feeling.' Often we find that's because we're a bit afraid of facing our own possible sickness and eventual death.

There can be a sense of relief when somebody has a serious illness, as we have in our family. First you feel the fear—well, if it's in the family, I might get it. And then a sense of relief: oh, it's not me. We have to understand that as basically coming from this false view of self, and not get all guilty about it. It's just a reaction. But again, it's this ability to rise above it.

I've picked these up from various things I've read. There's what's known as empathy bias. If a nurse, for instance, is on a ward but has a particular connection with one of the patients, you might find her visiting them slightly more often—and not really heeding someone calling from the other side of the ward because she doesn't particularly like them. So there's always that going on.

Codependency is another problem. If a person is getting a lot of self-esteem from helping, it's very difficult for them to stop. Often they're feeding the person who's suffering so that they don't have to stop doing good. I knew a mother whose son was a drug addict, and she was always helping him—paying his rent when he didn't have it, buying food for him. I said to her, 'What you're doing is just feeding his habit financially.' She said, 'Yes, but I'm his mother.' She couldn't get over that feeling of guilt if she stopped helping her son. But it would have been the best thing to do.

You have to be careful when you're dealing with a long situation—someone you're looking after, perhaps. There's the matter of your emotional boundary: knowing when you're being taken advantage of, even perhaps abused. That's something else to be careful about.

Sometimes we find ourselves becoming very involved in a compassionate cause. I'm thinking of people who get deeply involved with refugees, completely on the side of the refugees, and they can lose sight of what it's doing to them. So you get burnout, and then resentment—what they call compassion fatigue. I think that's easy to fall into because there's so much bad news. Everywhere you go, there's just bad news, and you can feel your heart going out to various situations and various people. But in the end, you've got to recognise that enough's enough. Stop feeding on all the bad news and try to find some good news.

Sometimes overemphasising this kind of helping, becoming too attached to somebody, might blind us to the fact that we're not allowing them to reflect on their own situation and take a moral stance about themselves. I'm thinking of ADHD—that hyperactive, impulsive behaviour. Somebody might, for instance, get into gambling because of it, and we're being over-compassionate. The problem with medicalising something is that the person then drops their moral responsibility towards themselves. 'Oh well, I'm ADHD,' or 'I'm on the whatever it is.' So it's also a case of recognising that we might be making excuses for them, avoiding difficult conversations. All these things are things to be wary of.

It's not as though we have to go around with a great big list. Every time we help somebody, you've got to have your list out just in case you're doing something wrong. It's more about recognising that when we are being compassionate, there's probably some undertone going on, coming from this wrong sense of ego, this wrong sense of self.

But there are, of course, great virtues to be had from compassion. One of them is patience, which we've dealt with. One of the telltales of compassion, I think, is that you're actually deeply happy about it. This is not the happiness of joy or the happiness of buying an ice cream. This is a sense of inner worthiness, an inner sense that you're doing the right thing—a deeper sense of joy, which I think you've all experienced at some point when you've helped people. So that's the sign of compassion. We're not supposed to be suffering. When you're being compassionate, you're not supposed to be suffering. That would be ridiculous.

In fact, this confusion came up when I was at a particular meditation centre where lay people had been discussing the matter, and they eventually came to the conclusion that the Buddha could not have been compassionate because he'd have been suffering. How ridiculous that is. So we have to be careful there.

I'll just mention it because it's a whole subject on its own, but the Tibetan practice of *tonglen* is all about making that connection with others. Pema Chödrön has a very good introduction to the meditation up on YouTube.

So the Buddha and Ānanda looked after this monk, and then he gathered the monks together and said to them, 'Look, you have no mother, you have no father who might tend to you. If you don't tend to one another, then who will tend to you? Whoever would tend to me should tend to the sick.' There he's getting them to make a connection to himself, to the Buddha—like whoever is attending to somebody who's sick, you are attending to a Buddha.

Now, you might not take that literally as the Buddha himself, but as the Buddha within—that within us which is transcendent. And then he goes on and gives a whole list of people who should be looking after them. So he was involved in that.

I'm going on a bit, I'm afraid. What I want to do now is just do a bit of compassion practice, and I'm going to share this with you.

I'm hoping you can see that. So these are the blessings that we do here in the morning *puja*. The idea is that as we go through this list, we can bring up a phrase which expresses our compassion. The one that's normally used is, 'May your sufferings lessen, may all your sufferings come to an end.' That comes out of the

Visuddhimagga, this compendium of Buddhism written by Buddhaghosa in the Middle Ages. Or you can make up some other phrase that makes sense to you. But just for this, it might be good to stay with this one.

So if we just settle for a moment. We can bring to mind anyone we know who's having a hard time. At this moment, there are people suffering from severe physical or mental disease. There are people in the process of dying, and those who have died and left grieving family, relatives, and friends. There are people going hungry, homeless and destitute. There are those struggling with personal and interpersonal difficulties. There are all the victims of prejudice. All those caught up in wars and repressive regimes, and those being tortured.

There are all the criminals, oppressors, and all who willingly do harm. All those suffering from natural disasters and climate crisis. All sentient beings who have been cruelly treated and unnecessarily slaughtered. And all who find life meaningless.

Now we can continue with the ten directions: to all beings in front of us who are suffering, all beings behind us, all beings to our left, all beings to our right, all beings below us, all beings above us — and to all beings in all directions.

Feel free to continue this practice, or simply sit in *vipassanā*.

Kosambi (MN 48)

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 19 min

Originally given as *Kosambi (MN 48)* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this engaging talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the Kosambi Sutta (MN 48), where quarreling monks at Kosambi monastery refused to listen even to the Buddha himself. What began as a trivial disagreement about emptying a water pot escalated into bitter disputes that divided the community. The Buddha's initial attempts at reconciliation failed, leading him to retreat to the forest where he was cared for by an elephant and monkey.

Bhante draws parallels to everyday arguments—from toilet seat positions to shoe polishing methods—showing how minor issues can trigger major conflicts when underlying tensions exist. The turning point came when lay supporters withdrew their support, forcing the monks to reconsider.

The Buddha then taught the six memorable qualities that create love, respect, and unity: bodily, verbal, and mental acts of loving-kindness; sharing material gains; maintaining virtue; and most importantly, holding right view. He explained how abandoning the five hindrances (sensual desire, ill will, sloth and torpor, restlessness and remorse, and doubt) along with worldly speculation purifies the mind for awakening. This comprehensive teaching culminates in the seven factors that characterize one ready for stream-entry, the first stage of awakening, emphasizing how community harmony and individual spiritual development are intimately connected.

Now we're at Kosambi, in Gosita's park. At that time, the bhikkhus—the monks—were quarrelling and brawling, deep in disputes, stabbing each other with verbal daggers. They could neither convince each other nor be convinced, neither persuade nor be persuaded.

It got so bad that somebody snitched on them to the Blessed One. Of course, he went to see them. 'Is it true you've been quarrelling and brawling and all that?' And they said, 'Yes, Venerable Sir.' 'What do you think?' he asked—and then he went into this discourse.

Now, this brawling was all about the Vinaya. You might think to yourself: well, this big argument that's created such huge anger within the monastery, people shouting at each other and falling into all sorts of disgraceful actions—surely this must be something very important. But actually, it was because the teacher of the Dhamma had not emptied the water pot in the toilet. He should have emptied it, it seems.

When the Vinaya teacher—the person who understands Vinaya—saw this, he said, 'Now that's an offence. That's an offence, unless you didn't mean it.' The Dhamma teacher said, 'Well, I didn't mean it.' And he probably didn't even know. But anyway, it was an offence.

Later on, the Vinaya teacher was talking to his students, telling them about this occasion. They eventually came to the conclusion that even though it was unintentional, it was still an offence. Then the Dhamma teacher's pupils got really upset about that. And before you know it—quarrelling and all sorts of bad things, stabbing each other with verbal daggers.

Now you might think to yourself, well, that's ridiculous. How could anybody get angry over that? But consider the arguments that perhaps you've not been in—though I remember other people, and occasionally I myself, falling into arguments about whether you leave the toilet seat up or down. Whether you put the milk in before you pour the tea or after. Whether a cup of tea is finished when you finish drinking it and just leave the pots hanging around, or only when you wash the pots and put them away.

There was one I remember from childhood. My father was in the Royal Air Force during the war, and of course, probably his family did it this way—but in the military, you have to do things in a certain way. When it came to polishing shoes and boots, you put the polish on with the cloth and you shine it up with the brush. Well, my mother was not going to have anything to do with that. She wasn't going to mess around with cloths and brushes. You just put it on with a brush and brushed it up. I remember as a child this roaring argument in the kitchen about how to put the polish on shoes. They were really at each other. Can you imagine that?

Whether we like it or not, we've got these little covert rules. When a friend or somebody comes to visit and starts doing things like putting dirty pots directly into the water in the bowl rather than setting them on the side—oh, argumentation. Little things can spark into these huge arguments. And of course, we don't know the history of these two monks. They might not like each other. They might have been in some sort of argument before. By the time the Buddha gets there, it's a big deal.

The Buddha tries to give them advice, but they won't listen to him. So he goes off. He goes off and lives in the forest. And while he lives in the forest, he's looked after by an elephant who brings him fruits. When a monkey saw the elephant doing that, the monkey also went off and got him food.

The point is that when the lay people found out the Buddha had not been listened to—that the monks weren't ready to come to an agreement—they stopped feeding the monks. They stopped serving them. That's the power of the lay people, because the monastic orders, monks and nuns, are entirely dependent upon the gifts that lay people give them: the food, the clothing, the medicine, the housing. If lay people decide these monastics are not behaving well and they don't support them, then basically they've either got to find another monastery or leave the order.

Of course, that brought them to their senses. They asked the Buddha to come back, the Blessed One. And then he talked to them.

This is what he said: 'Did you, on that occasion when you were arguing and all that—did you maintain acts of loving-kindness of body, speech, and mind, in public and private, towards your companions in the holy life?' 'No, Venerable Sir.'

And then he says there are six memorable qualities that create love and respect, that conduce to helpfulness, to non-dispute, to concord, and to unity.

The first three are fairly straightforward: to maintain bodily acts of loving-kindness towards your companions, both in public and in private. The second is verbal acts of loving-kindness. The third, mental acts of loving-kindness.

The fourth is sharing with them any gain that accords with the Dhamma and has been obtained in a way that accords with the Dhamma—including even the contents of your bowls. Sharing what we have is a really lovely way to create the kind of relationship where it's difficult to get into big arguments.

And then, of course, to live a virtuous life. The virtues that are unbroken, untorn, unblotched, unmottled, liberating, commended by the wise, not misapprehended, and conducive to concentration or meditation. People honour and respect those who are virtuous.

And then there's the view that is noble and emancipating, that leads one who practises in accordance with it to the complete destruction of suffering. That view, of course, is the Noble Eightfold Path.

All these things are conducive to helpfulness, non-dispute, concord, and unity. But then the Buddha goes on to say that the highest of all these six is that view which is noble and emancipating and leads the one who practises in accordance with it to the complete destruction of suffering. In a sense, the Noble Eightfold Path includes everything he's just said.

And how does one practise with that view? How does one put it into action? Gone to the forest, to the root of a tree, to an empty hut—in other words, to meditate. To bring this into everyday life as well as the sitting, into everything that we do.

A person might be obsessed with sensual lust, sensual desire; obsessed by ill will; obsessed by sloth and torpor; obsessed by restlessness and remorse; obsessed by doubt. These, of course, are your five hindrances.

The next one is not to be absorbed in speculation about the world. Oh my goodness—COVID, Brexit, the world—too much. Not to be absorbed in that sort of speculation. And not to be absorbed in speculation about the other world. I don't think that bothers us Westerners very much. We don't tend to think about the next life, except that something might happen. And of course, something might not.

Now, when he comes to understand that no obsession is unabandoned in himself—that no obsession might so obsess his mind that he cannot know and see things as they actually are—the heart has been purified to a point where it can really begin to see things as they are. 'My mind is well disposed for awakening to the Four Noble Truths. When I pursue, develop, and cultivate this view, I personally obtain serenity. I obtain quenching.' That means the lessening of these desires.

He also understands that there is no recluse or brahmin outside the Buddha's dispensation who possesses a view such as he possesses. That is confidence in the Buddha's teachings.

And then there's that ability: do I possess the character of a person who possesses right view? There's that ability to know when you've done something wrong, to accept it, confess, reveal, and disclose it to the teacher or to wise companions. Basically, the ability to know you've done something wrong and to put it right—to apologise.

Just as a young tender infant lying prone draws back at once when his foot or hand touches a live coal—so too, any time we approach anything unwholesome, unhelpful, unbeneficial to ourselves or to others, we simply bounce off it. That is the sensitivity of a virtuous person.

Although he may be active in various matters for his companions in the holy life, yet he has a keen regard for training in the higher virtue, training in the higher mind, training in the higher wisdom. Just as a cow with a new calf watches her calf while she grazes. Basically, even though we're busy in our daily lives, there's always that inclination to keep an eye on our awareness, on our mindfulness—and of course, our practice.

This isn't about being self-critical. You're not supposed to be hunting yourself down, pointing at yourself, criticising yourself. It's simply the relaxation into present-moment mindfulness. That's all. And every time the mind wanders, just keep bringing it back, very patiently.

And then: do I possess the strength of one who holds right view? This strength comes when, on hearing the Dhamma, he heeds it, gives it attention, engages with it with all his mind, hears the Dhamma with eager ears. That is when a person knows he has the strength.

The second strength is this: when he listens to the Dhamma and practises virtue, he gains inspiration in the meaning, gains inspiration in the Dhamma, gains gladness connected to the Dhamma. In other words, it gives your life a certain deep meaningfulness.

When a noble disciple is thus possessed of these seven factors, he has well sought the character for realisation of the fruit of stream entry. These are the sorts of reflections a person can have which lead them to that first attainment—that moment when somebody actually perceives, in some way or other, the truth of Nibbāna.

A lot of this pertains to ordinary daily life—ordinary daily life in society. I can only hope it has been inspirational, and that you'll be very persistent in bringing yourself back into this present moment. By doing so, may you be liberated from all suffering sooner rather than later.

Forgiveness

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 1h02

Originally given as *Forgiveness* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



Drawing inspiration from the story of Aṅgulimāla, Bhante Bodhidhamma presents a profound exploration of forgiveness through the lens of Buddhist psychology. Using the Buddha's teaching on paṭicca-samuppāda (Dependent Origination), he demonstrates how we create our own suffering through our reactions to harm, rather than being victims of others' actions. The talk begins with guided contemplations to understand our psychological responses to being hurt and causing harm, then examines how avijjā (ignorance/nescience) is the root mistake that leads to all suffering.

Bhante explains that since we cannot truly cause others to suffer psychologically—we only be catalysts for their own conditioned reactions—we are fundamentally innocent, having acted from delusion rather than inherent evil. This insight makes genuine forgiveness possible. The talk addresses challenging topics including childhood trauma, existential guilt from Western religious conditioning, and the apparent injustice of those who 'get away with' harmful actions.

Practical guidance is offered for releasing victim suffering and victimizer guilt through vipassanā meditation, including a 'four steps to determination' method for transforming unwanted mental habits. The teaching emphasizes that true forgiveness is neither forgetting nor excusing, but a complete letting go of hurt and revenge through understanding the deeper psychology of how suffering actually arises.

This talk came about because a friend of mine, a musician, wanted to write music around the theme of Angulimala. As some of you may know, Angulimala was a murdering thief. But he meets the Buddha, undertakes the training, and before he dies becomes fully enlightened. So there's hope for us all.

My friend wanted me to write something he could attach his music to. Having done that, I wanted to add something to explain the psychology — how somebody so steeped in evil might arrive at enlightenment even within this very lifetime.

In the first part I'll ask you to do some imaginative work, and then we'll do some explanation. At the end you can have a go at practising forgiving yourself for all those people whom you've murdered, and forgiving all those people who've done you harm.

Just try this one for size, shall we say. Close your eyes and catch the process of your psychology. Imagine, if you can, an actual occasion in your life — that might be even better — but just think of an occasion where somebody says something that hurts you. It might be just a flippant thing, like "you're an idiot" or something. If you can imagine that, just let the insult come.

Now catch your reaction. I wonder what it might have been. Irritation? Anger? Indignation? And what might it lead you to once you've left that person? A slander? A knife in the back?

Now try something else on a similar line. Instead of somebody saying something awful to you, they actually do something to you. Perhaps they push you, or stick their finger into you, or at worst they bop you on the nose. Can you imagine that? Can you see what your reaction might be? I would suggest it's much the same — unless they're much bigger than you, in which case you'd probably get a bit fearful.

The question we have to ask ourselves is: did that person cause us suffering? Do you think they were the direct cause of your suffering?

Now turn that around and take somebody whom you're going to insult. It might be the same person, of course. As you make that scene in your mind, offer them your insult and see how you feel about it. I would suggest that maybe you feel a little satisfied. A job well done. Pleased.

Now let that person come back to you and say they're really upset — and you see that you've been the cause of their being upset. How do you feel about that? A little remorseful, a bit guilty, ashamed.

Let's take an occasion which is much worse. Supposing you've unfortunately had one or two drinks and you knock somebody over on the road. What's your first reaction? Just play it through your mind. Shock. Fear. Dread of consequences when other people find out. Shame when you realise what you've done to the person. Remorse.

If we take the process of that psychology, what we have is the Wheel of Dependent Origination. What the Buddha is teaching us there is that whatever somebody does to us — just taking the first instance — has to stop at the point of reception, at the point where we perceive something.

If somebody called me "fathead" — that's not very nice, is it? — what actually happens is that I've just heard these words, "fathead." Then, having heard those words, I take them into myself and define them as unpleasant. They are, aren't they? So they're unpleasant. But this person hasn't actually made me think they're unpleasant. I'm defining them as unpleasant within myself. If I didn't speak English I'd probably smile.

Something has happened there: I've defined this as unpleasant. And I've taught myself that when something unpleasant arises, I have to get rid of it — I want to push it away. That's my reaction to anything unpleasant. And again, it's done by me, within me, because of my past conditioning.

If we look at our psychology very carefully, we can see that the person who called us fathead hasn't actually caused me to suffer. It's the way I've responded to it. If the person who just called me fathead is reckoned by everybody to be a bit loopy, I wouldn't have that reaction. I'd probably just say, "Oh well, they're a bit daft" or something. All the hurt I get when somebody insults me or says something cruel to me is my own inner reaction. I can't blame them for making me suffer.

Now, if somebody pulls my nose, or tugs my ears, or gives me a shove — where does that stop? It stops at the physical body, doesn't it? It stops at a sensation on the body. But then, inwardly, I see what the person's done, I feel what they've done to me, and again I define it as unpleasant. Again I respond with irritation, with anger, with hurt. But that's all happening in me as a response to what this person has done.

I can't say this person has made me suffer. They've given me, shall we say, severe sensations on the nose, which I've defined as pain — but pain isn't suffering. Pain as such is just sensation, no matter how severe it is. What makes us suf-

fer, what makes it hard to stay with, is our reaction to it, our inability to be patient with it. It's the internal reaction we have to these things that actually causes us to suffer.

These are the links on the Wheel of Dependent Origination — which, remember, is the Buddha's paradigm for how we cause suffering for ourselves. How we cause suffering for ourselves.

Now you can widen that out, and you begin to recognise that nobody in the world can cause you psychological pain. Which is hard to accept, because until now we've been very happy blaming everybody else. Parents, society, Tony Blair — all these people have made me suffer, you see. But when I look into my psychology, I can't say that anymore.

If we turn it the other way now: I say to somebody, "You fathead." The same process is happening within them. I can't say that I've caused them to suffer — but I have to recognise what's happening in me. What's happening in me is that I'm developing a conditioning of hate, a conditioning of cruelty.

I might get immediate satisfaction by watching somebody cringe when I call them "you fathead," but inside me there's this turbulence — this desire to be cruel, this desire to get my own back, the hatred within me. And of course the effect is that, not surprisingly, people start staying away. They don't hang about. They don't want to talk to me. My cruelty, my hatred, goes into the world, and the world moves away from me.

It causes me to be lonely, and so on, and if I don't see that, I then blame others for not being friendly, for not being open-hearted to me — and I begin to hate them the more. I'm in a sort of whirlwind, taking me downwards into a perpetual state of hatred and grumbling and whinging. Which can keep you awake.

Worse still, if I actually hit somebody or push somebody, that's a more violent act — and therefore the inner violence is even worse. So here we have a situation where I think I'm hurting somebody, but in fact I'm only hurting myself.

So you might ask: well, what stops you from hurting somebody anyway? When we've contacted the hurt that I feel when somebody insults me or harms me — even though I recognise that I'm the cause of it — it's out of compassion for the other that you don't. You choose not to be the catalyst whereby they cause themselves to suffer. So you begin to take responsibility not to enter into situations, not to confront people in such a way that you know you're just pressing their buttons.

Now, although that may seem at first to land us in a load of suffering, it's the very fact that we create our own suffering that will allow us to escape it in the end. That's the purpose of meditation. That's the purpose of vipassana — to see these mechanisms that are causing us to suffer.

And then you realise that you must stop behaving like that — which means maintaining sharp mindfulness in daily life, knowing your own habits. Even if you respond in an old way, you don't indulge it. Even though somebody says to you, 'You fathead,' it stays right there at the point of hurt. You're prepared to let the hurt hurt, because you know that is your own personal response to such a thing. But you don't allow yourself to begin fantasising about getting your own back.

If somebody insults you once, as you know, by the end of the day they've insulted you a thousand times. And the punishment for their insult has got worse. At first you just shouted at them in your mind. But by the time you go to bed, you're hanging them. You're chucking them out of the window.

Remember, it's through the process of thinking and fantasising that we develop these states of mind. And it's not a great distance between thinking about doing something and actually doing it.

What vipassana is teaching us to do is to stay right there with the hurt, to let the hurt die away. When it does, we're not only stopping it from developing — more importantly, we're actually undercutting that old conditioning of being hurt when somebody calls us a name or insults us. We're going underneath it, so that there will come a time when somebody might say something which in the past you would have felt to be hurtful, but actually it just stops at the sense door. You just hear the word. There isn't that reaction.

So you can see that taking full responsibility for our inner suffering, using vipassana to allow things to burn out and heal, is actually the process of psychotherapy — healing the heart, purifying the heart. That would be impossible if you thought the other person was making you suffer, in which case you'd have to change everybody in the world. Because a lot of people go around calling other people fatheads.

Then there's the other side, where we hurt people. Even though we can't cause somebody to suffer, by actually wanting to hurt them we're creating a turbulence within our own mind — which is suffering — and we're creating a habit which eventually begins to push people away from us.

Once we recognise that the serpent is biting its own tail, we realise that this sort of behaviour has to stop. Again, the purpose of vipassana is to sit with it in silence, to allow it to burn away. But then we have to maintain that sense of sharp mindfulness in daily life so that we don't fall into those old habits.

What we discover is that very slowly, over a period of time — you know, twenty-odd years — those habits of trying to do harm to everybody just fade away. And the opposite takes their place. Nature abhors a vacuum. We're talking here about transformation. So where there was cruelty, now there's compassion. Where there was hate, now there's love. Openness. Open-heartedness. Warm-heartedness.

Just as a little aside, talking about these things that we suffer: we have within us a mechanism that decides whether something is good or bad, skilful or unskilful. We call it our conscience.

Now, just because our conscience — which is the judge, remember, judging us — just because our conscience says something is wrong or bad doesn't mean we have to accept it. Because sometimes this judge is a tyrant. Sometimes the conscience is too tight, and it creates a life of dread, a life of unnecessary shame. On the other hand, the conscience can sometimes be very loose, so that we don't feel appropriate shame, appropriate dread, when we do things.

So we haven't got to trust our conscience blindly. There has to be some sort of reflection about it, and talking to other people whom you trust, so that there's a balance in the mind — knowing what is good and what is bad at a basic moral level. But remember that at a more refined level, it's about what's skilful and unskilful. And when the Buddha talks about what is skilful and unskilful, he's always talking about that which leads to liberation and that which leads to suffering.

Those two emotions we feel, dread and shame — shame is that feeling of loss of self-esteem, that we haven't lived up to our own standards. That's why we blush. And dread is the fear of consequences.

When we do something harmful and feel shame and dread, that's not to be seen as punishment — though that's how people often look at it. It's better understood as a warning. When we accept these feelings and they become part and parcel of our psychology, they actually prevent us from doing harmful things. As soon as you think, 'Well, I'll do that,' there comes just that little bite of shame, just that little bite of dread, and it stops you.

When shame and dread function like this, the Buddha calls them guardians of society. You can see from the way a lot of young people behave that the line they draw about shame and dread is pretty low. They can do certain things they're not ashamed of, nor do they dread any consequence. Once these reactions are lowered, you're going to get behaviour that's unsociable. And when there's no shame and dread at all, then we're talking about psychopaths, about sociopaths. It's an actual psychological disease.

Remorse, on the other side, is suddenly feeling that compunction — that desire to be rid of all the guilt and shame, and to be reconciled with the person you've hurt, or indeed who's hurt you. Remorse is a natural feeling that comes after we accept we've done wrong.

In our meditation, we have to sit with that. If you try to block it out, you'll just harden your heart. You must respond to that desire to be reconciled — to go to the person, if necessary. But in some way, that remorse has to be answered.

Going through that whole cycle — guilt, shame, feeling bad about oneself, fearful of consequences, feeling remorse, and then bringing that remorse to an end through reconciliation — this isn't just a process of healing that particular event. It also undermines the whole conditioning. Eventually, we don't get ourselves into those corners anymore.

What helps us here is that our conditioning is always fairly much the same. This is what we mean by karma. We're always doing the same thing, always making the same mistake. If you look back on your life, you'll see there's a trait within us that's always popping up; given the occasion, it comes up.

Catching that trait right before it comes up and letting it go, not responding to it — that's what undermines the whole pattern. And why do we do it? Because we've recognised it leads nowhere but to suffering, to our discomfort.

Now we have to go a little deeper. In a sense, what we've covered tells us how we cause ourselves to suffer, and how to get rid of it. But the next point on the wheel of dependent origination to investigate is that whole point at the beginning — *avijjā*.

Avijjā is normally translated as ignorance. But in English, ignorance has a feeling of stupidity about it, and that's not really the meaning. I came across this word, *nescience*, which fits it more beautifully. *Nescience* just means 'don't know.' I just don't know.

In the Buddha's understanding, when consciousness arises, it arises from a base of don't know. It moves into this body and mind — body, mind, and heart — and simply presumes this is what it is. From there, you eventually form a concept of yourself: I am who I am. I'm here. I'm my personality, my character. I'm my body. I'm my emotions, and so on. That little mistake is actually the fundamental cause for all the suffering we've just discussed.

If we go back on that and recognise that right at the very beginning there's been a mistake — just a mistake — and that if it weren't for that mistake we would never have done any harm, then you begin to understand something important: at fundament, we're innocent. It's only because of a mistake, not because of something culpable, not because of something blameworthy. We just made a mistake.

I'll give you an example from one of my experiences in Sri Lanka. They had these very nasty little flies called Ohopatua — just little gnats that fly in the air. They have a nasty habit of biting you and leaving you with a very itchy pimple for about three days. Sometimes they can even creep through a mosquito net.

So here I am with these little pimples, scratching away, wondering what to do —when I suddenly notice that a spider has built a web in the kuṭi, the hut. I think to myself, that's it, I need to get more spiders in and they'll get rid of these flies. So I put up little signs saying, 'This way please.'

Within a few days, there were hundreds of them—spiders everywhere, all around the room. I thought, this is really crazy. And it was getting to a point where I was so bitten and miserable that I decided I just had to leave. Go up country somewhere. Just get out of these flies.

Happily, just at that time, a friend of mine, a Canadian monk, came to visit. I told him, looking really grim, that this was it. I showed him my pimples and said, 'Look at this.' He looked around and said, 'These spider webs—don't you get rid of the webs out of your room?' I said no. 'Well,' he said, 'they breed on those.'

Here's a wonderful occasion where innocent ignorance leads me into suffering. And at fundament, that's all the Buddha's saying. We've made a mistake. We were never meant to do any harm. So at fundament, we are innocent. If we weren't—if it was actually part of our essential nature not to be innocent—then how could we ever become enlightened?

Just one reflection on existential guilt. This really refers to people who have been brought up in Christianity or a religion which has a god, because according to those religions, we are born evil. In Buddhism, evil and all that is a secondary thing. This means that Western people can suffer from what you might call an existential guilt—in other words, they feel themselves to be essentially evil.

If you feel that way, you can see the necessity of having someone to intercede, somebody who can save you, take away that essential evil, and thereby find some reconciliation with God. Now, if you're a Westerner brought up on that, then it will probably be somewhere in your psyche. So that also has to be suffered and allowed to pass away. Sometimes it goes very deep.

And when you couple it with the idea of eternal damnation, that's bad news. What we have to do is go underneath that and really accept those sorts of feelings. They can be extraordinarily nasty—fear, dread, and all that. But you have to stay there, you have to feel it, you have to investigate it and recognise your reaction to it, which is of course that we don't want to feel that. Eventually, as that evaporates, that essential innocence arises.

There is a movement in Christianity where they don't talk about original sin—that's what they're referring to. Most of you will know the myth of Adam and Eve in the Garden of Eden. But you'll also find movements in Christianity that, instead of talking about that, talk about the original blessing—the fact that Adam and Eve were born in innocent happiness. In that sense, they come closer to a Buddhist understanding.

So there is an end to guilt, there is an end to shame, and there is therefore an end to forgiveness.

Two things always come up whenever I discuss this. First: why is it that some people seem to get away with it? They seem to die happily. Take Stalin, for instance. He died fairly happily in bed, having murdered forty million people. It seems he got everything he wanted—although he must have been in a dreadful state of mind in a way, because he only worked at night, and I think on one trip he had five trains going, all giving the impression that he was on one of them, constantly in dread of being assassinated.

Well, here we have to, in a sense, open towards the acceptance of rebirth—the idea that perhaps this isn't the only life we've ever lived, and it's not the only life we're going to live. That there is some sort of justice in the process of the world, in which individual consciousnesses do work their way up towards enlightenment through a process of being born and being reborn.

However, if a person finds that difficult to accept, it's not actually necessary in order to get the benefits of the psychology we've just been explaining, because those benefits are immediate. Through the practice of insight meditation, seeing that we cause ourselves suffering—and seeing that we cause ourselves suffering when we press other people's buttons—is immediate. We immediately stop behaving in certain ways, and we feel happier for it.

But in a cosmic sense, this was one of the Buddha's insights. It was part of his enlightenment, when he saw that people were dying and being reborn elsewhere, and that a great deal of where they were going depended on their bodily behaviour—which creates these dispositions within us.

And finally, there's a really difficult one, very hard for people to accept who haven't come across this psychology before. That's the suffering of innocence—especially the suffering of a child. But it is the same. It is the same psychology.

What is horrific to us about a child's situation is its absolute vulnerability and its inability, through language or conceptual reasoning, to find any distance or objectivity to the suffering it's undergoing. But still, the child ends up with a trauma, and in a sense the rest of its life is spent working out that psychological trauma within itself. I think it's very rare for a person not to have a childhood trauma somewhere.

These childhood traumas are not only caused by people who actually mean to do harm. The very process of birth is a trauma, for heaven's sake. So the suffering in the child follows the same psychology, and that's why eventually, as adults, we can empty ourselves of this suffering.

Now, for the person who harms a child—well, that's something else, you see, because they have to bear the awful responsibility for that child's suffering. They might not be the direct cause of the suffering, but they were the catalyst that caused it.

Let me give you two examples that bring this home. The Moors murderer, Brady, was asked if he ever thought about the child victims he tortured and murdered up here in Lancashire. He said, if I did that, it would drive me mad.

Some of you may have come across a book called *The Man Who Mistook His Wife for a Hat*. Ever come across that one? It's a really good book, written by a psychologist called Oliver Sacks. He's interested in brain damage and the way people are. The title refers to a man who couldn't distinguish objects. As he was leaving the office after a talk, he simply grabbed his wife's head, thinking it was his hat. His wife, I don't think, was all that pleased.

In that same book there's a very interesting tale which says something to Buddhists. There's a man who murders his daughter in such a vicious way that the facts of the case aren't brought out in public in the court—they're just too horrific. This man could not remember a thing.

Eventually they had to convict him as insane and send him to a secure prison for the mentally insane. This is in America. They couldn't convict him as a straight criminal. While he was there he acted seemingly quite normal, and within a few years the staff had such confidence in him that they let him go out on bicycle rides.

On one of these rides, a car hit him and he fell over and banged his head on the road. When he woke up from the concussion, this had the effect of awakening in him what he'd actually done. The story goes that it took six months for the staff to restrain him and stop him from committing suicide.

So eventually the harm we do catches up on us, and to harm innocence would leave us with an enormous sense of guilt and remorse.

So now we come to—well, I'll just give you a final reflection on harm. There's a very famous simile of the saw which the Buddha gives. He says, oh monks, even if bandits were to sever you savagely, limb by limb with a two-handed saw, he who gave rise to hatred towards them would not be carrying out my teaching.

Now I'd like to ask you to do another contemplation exercise. The first question is: how do we free ourselves from a victim's suffering—the suffering we feel when we've been victimised? And the second is: how do we liberate ourselves from the suffering of being a victimiser?

Let's start with how to let go of the suffering we feel when we've been hurt. The first thing to recognise is that to forgive is not to forget. You have to be very careful here. If you try to forget the hurt that's been given to you, all you're doing is suppressing it. It just works underground, turning into grudges that sabotage our lives.

When we forgive somebody, we're not excusing them either. Sometimes we feel that if we forgive someone, we're secretly condoning what they did. That's not forgiveness.

Forgiveness is simply a change of attitude—a letting go of that hurt, letting go of revenge, and establishing within us a sense of compassion towards the person.

So now take somebody who's hurt you—it can be someone real, but not the big one. The first thing to recognise is that there's no need for us to punish them. They themselves will suffer the consequences of their own actions. That's the karmic law. There's no need for us to seek revenge. A Chinese proverb warns us: those who seek revenge should dig two graves.

The second thing is to remind ourselves that this person has made a mistake. It's by way of delusion that they've come to behave in this unskillful way. Fundamentally they're actually innocent—they didn't mean to do harm. Sometimes it's good to have a dialogue with the person in your mind.

Having done that, having corrected our relationship to that person, we can then turn inward and get in contact with the hurt we feel. You can bring up the occasion when you were hurt, run through it again.

Here you've got to be very careful not to be taken away by fantasy. You've got to keep your attention as much as you can right at the physical base—the feelings around hurt, the anger that may still come up, the desire for revenge. Try to stay as close as you can to the body, to sensation, to feeling.

As those feelings begin to decrease, the next step is to contemplate the other person's better nature. When the hurt and the desire for revenge begin to fade, you can start to reform your relationship to that person. Try to see their better nature. Give them the benefit of the doubt. Send them good wishes from the heart. And if that's too difficult, well, at least an attitude of no harm. That's the base, isn't it? No harm.

In the future, we can resolve not to approach that person about this occasion unless we're absolutely equanimous—which means we have to wait for the right time. And when we do decide to approach them, we should speak almost as if we're a mediator. Be very careful not to put blame on them, not to lay it on, but just to be clear about the feelings we felt.

We have to take responsibility for our part in the incident. Takes two to tango. And the next thing is not to expect an apology—that's a presumption on our part. If they do apologise, of course, it's very healing. But it's not important to us that they should. The healing comes through this inner process.

Sometimes, of course, we can't do anything because the person's moved on or they may have died. So we have to work with this process of reconciliation inwardly, until all the emotional pain around the memory is slowly drained away.

Don't solidify around it, don't get hard around it—just see it as a process. You can often sit with an emotion and say gently, 'Not me, not mine.' It's there, I'm looking at it, I'm experiencing it—so I can't be it.

That's one approach you might try when suffering comes because somebody has victimised you.

If we now go to the other side and consider the suffering we've been a catalyst to in other people—where we've been the victimiser—it might be a good start to reflect on the fact that we are fundamentally deluded. We've acted primordially out of a mistake. We are fundamentally innocent, and therefore utter forgiveness of ourselves by ourselves is possible.

Then we have to convince ourselves that of course we do have a responsibility. We did play a role in causing that person harm; we were a catalyst. In chemistry, a catalyst is something that causes a change between two chemicals but itself doesn't change. The word I might have said to somebody doesn't change—it just hits the same space—but it creates within the other a whole sequence of psychological events that causes them suffering. We have to take responsibility for that. Sometimes we know how to press somebody's buttons too. We enjoy doing it.

But when we do this, we have to be careful not to take on false guilt. We're taking on false guilt if we take on their personal suffering.

Now we make resolutions not to do that again. I'm very careful about resolutions, because you know the old phrase that the path to hell is paved with good resolutions. So it has to be realistic. These behaviour patterns are deeply ingrained—they've come to us over a long time. We shouldn't be surprised if we keep making the mistake over and over again. We have to accept that this process is going to be repeated and repeated and repeated. What we're hoping is that given a length of time, the behaviour lessens, eventually dies away.

But we still have to make these resolutions, these determinations. And that determination has to be one of being really awake, really mindful. The alarm bell should go off whenever we enter a situation where we know we normally do something stupid, something silly, something unskillful.

Then there's the usual business of sitting with the remorse, the shame, the guilt which is in our hearts. That's part of the process of vipassana insight meditation—we can do that. We can watch them as a process. We can see that if we push guilt away, push shame away, push remorse away, that causes us more suffering. There we're catching this process of how we cause ourselves to suffer.

We can so distance ourselves from those emotions within us that they become very objective. There's shame. There's the feelings of guilt. And we just watch them as a process. Don't get involved by way of identity or possessing them. They're not me, not mine. These are the things that insight meditation teaches us.

Two of our most powerful reasons for hurting people are jealousy and hatred—all forms of hatred. Jealousy isn't just simple covetousness. It's not just wanting what the other person has. It's wanting what the other person has and hating them for having it.

The antidote to that, having sat with it for a while, is to begin to rejoice in the other person's good fortune. This is what we mean by sympathetic joy—and that's a contemplation. When somebody wins the lottery, you rejoice for them. You're happy that a bit of the pound you spent went to their fortune. When your friend who went with you for the same job gets the job, you rejoice for them. This sort of thing undermines jealousy.

Hatred is undermined by seeing the other person in a different light. As we said before, actually bring to mind their good qualities, so there's a balance of attitude towards them.

And then finally, if it's possible, meet with the person and express our remorse, express our sorrow. The Visuddhimagga also suggests that we offer them a gift when it's appropriate.

Now supposing at work you'd had a bit of an upset with somebody and you'd gone through this exercise. When you go back to work and you're walking through that door, say of a corridor, and they see you at the end of it—our ability to tell where people are at is very refined. We know from a person's body language, we know from what's on their face, even at quite a distance, whether they're friend or foe.

This person may still feel hardened by what happened, or they may feel remorse themselves, or they may feel a desire to be reconciled. Just by having that attitude in us, it'll show on our face, it'll show in the way we walk, so that they know there's a desire in us to be reconciled. These are really very important preparatory exercises, so that when we actually meet up with people we've hurt, they're open to our apology.

The fact is that, generally speaking, unless they've been fortunate enough to come to the Buddha's teaching about pain, they will definitely blame you for the suffering they're experiencing. That's what they do. That's what people do.

That doesn't mean you have to take on their suffering, but there's no point going into a great dissertation about how they're causing themselves suffering and that your insult didn't actually cause them to suffer. That won't do at all. All they'll think is that you're trying to escape your responsibility. So we apologise. That's not a problem. We apologise, but in our hearts we apologise for our part in the process. That's enough. You don't have to explain anything.

What happens now if the person refuses to forgive, harbours vengefulness, resentment? What can we do about that? We don't have an option, really, do we? We have to accept that this person now sees themselves as an enemy.

That will also create a reaction within us—maybe fear, maybe a desire to set up battle formations. But because of this psychology they can't actually do us any harm. Outwardly they might: they might slander us, they might undermine us in all sorts of ways. But inwardly they're not causing any suffering.

Often when you get a person like that, it's best just to stay out of their way, because even the sight of you raises hackles. Hopefully there comes a time when you can be reconciled.

It also takes a bit of philosophy to recognise that when you do something into the world, you never know what the consequences are going to be. It enters into a situation over which we don't have control.

You may one day say something flippant to somebody, and they laugh it off, and nothing ever comes of it—because they're a forgiving type. You may say the very same thing, the same slight sarcastic joke, and somebody takes it as a personal hatred and off they go on a vendetta. From your point of view it's the same input into the world, but you hadn't a clue it was going to come back to you. When something comes back which seems completely inappropriate to what you did, that's a lesson to understand.

Finally, I'd like to leave you with a little exercise, which at the moment I've called four steps to determination. When you see in yourself a trait you don't like, you have to make a determination—you have to go through something of this nature to undermine that particular trait.

Supposing you do have a certain sarcastic twist to the way you say things. The first thing is that you have to convince yourself you can undo that particular conditioning. You have to say to yourself, I can. You have to keep saying that until you convince yourself you're able to do it, just by letting it go. Just by not indulging it, the habit will die out.

Then you have to reinforce that can-do with a sense of ought—a sense of responsibility, taking responsibility for your own self. Now, words like ought, must, and have to tend to be looked down upon, especially in psychotherapeutic circles, because they cause further blame, further guilt when you don't fulfil what you said you would do.

But that's only when it's imposed upon us. If we ourselves take responsibility, then these words become ours, and it's easy to act on them. "I ought to do it for my own benefit and others" is an act of compassion on my part—compassion towards myself and compassion to others. I'm motivated to do what is good for myself and other people. So that ought isn't going to cause any trouble.

Then you've got to convince yourself that you want to do it. You may find that a bit of a sticking point, so you've got to cajole yourself. You do want to do it. You have to convince yourself to give up a habit you don't want.

Finally, when you feel there is that desire to give it up—a real committed desire—then you have to empower it. You have to say, "I will. I will." And then you make the decision that whenever that particular trait comes up, "I will resist it. I will resist it."

These four stages—convincing ourselves that we can do it, that it's our responsibility for the benefit of ourselves and others, that we actually do want to do it, and that we will do it—you'll find, I think, fairly powerful in helping you get rid of unwanted traits in your personalities.

The opposite is also true: it works for the positive. If you want to become more generous, you have to convince yourself that you can be, that you ought to be for your own benefit and others, that you want to be—you can get stuck there, see—and then you will. On any given occasion you'll express your generosity.

I think that brings us to the end of my little effort to explain how we can come to the end of forgiveness. We've covered two major things. First, the psychological process by which suffering arises in us—because of our reactions to things that hurt us, and because of behaving from an attitude which is unskilful: cruelty, hatred, and all that.

I own my actions. I inherit the results of my actions. I am born of my actions. I form relations through my actions. I live dependent on my actions. Whatever I do for good or for ill, I shall inherit the results. — Kamma and Rebirth

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 25 min

Originally given as *I own my actions. I inherit the results of my actions. I am born of my actions. I form relations through my actions. I live dependent on my actions. Whatever I do for good or for ill, I shall inherit the results.* — Kamma and Rebirth at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this profound contemplation, Bhante Bodhidhamma explores the Buddhist understanding of kamma (action) and vipāka (consequences) through the traditional five reflections on personal responsibility. Drawing from the canonical teachings, he clarifies that kamma refers specifically to intentional actions of body, speech, and mind, while distinguishing this from popular misconceptions about karma.

The talk examines each of the five contemplative reflections: owning our actions, inheriting their results, being born of our actions, forming relationships through them, and living dependent upon them. Bhante emphasizes the crucial role of intention (cetanā) in determining karmic consequences and addresses common misunderstandings, including the relationship between genetic conditions and past actions.

Using contemporary examples like Nelson Mandela and referencing the Ubuntu philosophy ('I am because we are'), he illuminates the interconnected nature of existence and how our actions ripple through both inner psychological matrices and outer social environments. The session concludes with a guided contemplation where practitioners repeat each reflection into the heart, allowing the truth to penetrate beyond intellectual understanding into emotional and spiritual transformation. This practice helps develop wise reflection and moral sensitivity essential for the Buddhist path.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble, and fully self-awakened one.

It's November, time for our lugubrious contemplations. We've done death, ageing, sickness, and all that. Now we come to the contemplations of *kamma*.

First of all, in Pali, *kamma* simply means action. Consequences are called *vipāka*. Our English usage, of course, takes the Sanskrit term karma—with an R—to mean consequence. During this talk, when I say karma, I'm talking about the action itself.

The first little quote here is: beings are owners of their actions, heirs of their actions. They originate from their actions, are bound to their actions, have their actions as their refuge. It is action that distinguishes beings as inferior and superior. This isn't a distinction according to artistic or intellectual or physical talent. It's to do with morals—whether we are moral or immoral, virtuous or not. The equation is this: the more deluded you are, the more unethical you will be; the more wise you are, the more ethical.

We'll be using this traditional way of contemplating karma: I own my actions. I inherit the results of my actions. I am born of my actions. I form relations through my actions. I live dependent on my actions. And then a final catch-all phrase: whatever I do, for good or for ill, I shall inherit the results.

The first contemplation: I own my actions. We are totally responsible for what we say, for what we think, and for what we do. It's coming out of us—that's the first thing to really grasp. The consequences that follow depend upon the intention. Remember, the role of intention in the Buddhist teachings is crucial, and it must be separated from desire. There may be a desire to say something angry, but you see it and you let it go. If you speak angrily, however, that will have consequences.

Remember, it goes into a matrix. There's the inner matrix of our psychology, making us more angry. And there's the outer matrix—all these people coming together to hear what you said—and you don't know what the response will be. You can't tell what the consequence of an action will be, because it's either enlarged or diminished by the milieu it finds itself in, the environment you speak into or act into.

That's why the Buddha constantly asks us to make wise reflections, and why we need a guide at this point. I always think to myself how fortunate I am to have such a wise person, the Buddha, to guide me. I doubt there's anybody more wise than the Buddha. There may be somebody equal, but I doubt more wise—such is the profundity of his wisdom.

A desire is just something arising; nothing's happened yet. As soon as you empower that desire—if you remember the word *cetanā*, the will—then something comes of it. The general rule is simple: if something is good, some good will come of it. If something is not good, something not good will come of it.

The second reflection is: I am heir to my kamma, or I inherit the results of my kamma. Here we have to remind ourselves again of the specific law of conditionality. We don't know what will happen once we say something or do something. In fact, we don't even know inwardly what will happen when we allow thoughts to develop within ourselves.

What's important for me here is to accept what comes back to us, even when it's not directly related to my personal karma. And what that does away with—which I found a real freedom, a real liberation—is the need for punishment. Punishment comes on top of the natural consequences. When we're self-criticising, when we're full of aversive self-blaming, when we're beating ourselves up, it's all completely unnecessary. You do something unwholesome. It comes back to you. You bear the consequences. You learn from it. You make an intention not to do that again. And that's the end of it. If you do it again, the same process applies. Habits are hard to overcome.

If you do something really beautiful, something wonderful, and praise comes towards you in response, you accept it—but there's no need to go into how wonderful I am, what an amazing person I really am. All that's not necessary.

A brief note here about Glenn Hoddle, the England football manager between 1996 and 1999. He somehow gave the impression—or at least this is what people thought he meant—that people who suffered genetic disabilities were bearing the consequences of a past life. It created such a furore that he had to resign. According to the Buddha's teachings, that's not right. The body you receive comes from all your past generations. So what is your kamma, no matter how unhappy you are with the body you've received? It might not be disabled—it might just be ugly, or you simply don't like it. Whatever body you end up with is not the direct consequence of your past actions. But the way you relate to it is.

Then we have: I am born of my actions. This is really about habits. Remember that once you create a set of actions, you develop a habit. When we collect all our habits together, that's our personality, our character—and it will drive us to our destiny. Our job is to see what is driving us towards an unfortunate destiny, towards perdition, and what is driving us towards a heavenly one.

This happens not only in terms of future lives—though that's the normal understanding in Buddhism, that our actions do affect future life. In fact, your last consciousness as you die has a great effect on what's going to happen next. It will drive you to do something about it. If you die, for instance, with a lot of guilt on your mind—something you did that has just come up as you're dying, and you die with that on your heart—in the next life you'll want to do something about that. If your last thoughts are of what a wonderful life you've had, what a wonderful relationship you enjoyed, then you'll be seeking the same thing in the next life.

But remember that this is also happening in the present moment, and from day to day, from year to year. We're being reborn all the time. The only thing that happens at death is that the body falls off.

Going back to the idea of genetic inheritance, there was a young man brought to the monastery at Amaravati who was severely disabled from a genetic illness. This is going back thirty-odd years now. He was about to move into a flat and become fairly independent. We were asked to go and have a chat with him and help out—we would have to carry him to the toilet, things like that. He was perfectly happy as far as we could see. He was accustomed to his situation and had adapted to it.

His parents had been told that such a thing could never happen again—a million-to-one chance of the same disease recurring. They had a daughter, and she suffered exactly the same condition. Seemingly she was extremely embittered. So here we have a similar situation and two different ways of coping with it. That's the kamma—the way they've coped with it.

The next reflection is: I form relations through my kamma. It can be sobering to think about one's past relationships and to see what we did, what we said, which either made them flower into something beautiful or crumble into something horrible. I personally have lots of regrets about being unkind and things like that. It's reflecting on that which makes you want to be different in the future.

Here we return to this interconnectedness, this specific law of conditionality. It's the understanding that we are all interconnected, interdependent—that even these words, even these thoughts I'm giving you, they're not mine. They don't belong to me. I've read them all. In fact, I also use GPT to give me some ideas. Then I normally just fill out around those ideas and maybe add something I picked up from somewhere else. It's not as though anybody is completely original. That's

very rare indeed. You'd have to be a Newton, an Einstein, an original composer. But all these people rest, as I think it was Newton who said, on the shoulders of giants.

The philosophy I always point to here is the South African philosophy of Ubuntu, which in short just says: I am because we are. It captures that relationship we have with others, and helps us realise that the relationships we create with others affect the way they relate to us.

Now let's talk about a certain paradox which is not understood in popular Buddhism: that you can purposefully suffer and yet be inwardly perfectly happy. I once asked someone in Sri Lanka, a born Buddhist brought up as a Buddhist, why he thought Jesus Christ suffered such a terrible death. He said, well, he must have done something terrible in his past life. That's the way regular Buddhists, born Buddhists, would think of it. Anything that happens to them, there must be something they did in a past life. So there's very little understanding that you can put yourself out for a cause—that you can become a martyr to a cause.

If we look at some of our modern-day saints and martyrs, the obvious ones that come up are Nelson Mandela and, for me, the very tragic figure of Alexei Navalny. To lose someone with that clarity of vision and courage is really heart-rending—especially when you hear that he would have been one of those released with the other prisoners just recently.

Now with these reflections, we have to turn them into contemplations. The way we do that is by repeating these phrases into the heart. When you do that, you've got to be aware of any aversion—you don't want to know that, you don't want to feel what comes up when you say to yourself, I am heir to all my actions. You have to keep repeating it and feeling that negativity if the negativity is there. You have to wait until the truth of that statement begins to penetrate and the aversion begins to disappear. Finally, there's a feeling of digestion.

When a contemplative subject is being digested, that's when it's going to change us—that's when it's changing our attitudes. So here's what we're going to do: we'll spend a minute with each statement. During that time, just keep repeating it into the heart. This is not an intellectual exercise. This is an emotional exercise, a heart exercise. Just keep repeating it gently to yourself. Then after the five minutes, we'll go into the sitting. If you want to keep it up after that, that's fine.

I am the owner of my actions of mind, speech, and body.

I inherit the results of my actions.

I am born each moment, each day, each lifetime of my actions.

I form relations through my actions.

I live dependent on my actions.

Whatever I do, for good or for ill, I shall inherit the results.

Now we can either continue that contemplation or return to *vipassanā*.

Social Conditioning or Karma — Our Social Conditioning is a Given, but Even So We Have to Take Responsibility for It and Cleanse Any Unwholesomeness

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 13 min

Originally given as *Social Conditioning or Karma — Our Social Conditioning is a Given, but Even So We Have to Take Responsibility for It and Cleanse Any Unwholesomeness* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the difference between personal karma and social conditioning, drawing on the Buddha's teachings about individual responsibility within cultural contexts. He explores how we absorb societal prejudices, class assumptions, and cultural biases from childhood, sharing personal examples of racial prejudice, monarchical deference, and neoliberal individualism that shape our mental formations (saṅkhāra).

Referencing the Sigālovāda Sutta's guidance on social relationships and the Buddha's emphasis on noble friendship (kalyāṇamittatā) as "the whole of the spiritual life," Bhante explains how our conditioning becomes our responsibility once we recognize it. While we cannot choose our cultural programming, we can work to purify unwholesome mental states through mindful awareness and ethical reflection.

This teaching offers practical wisdom for practitioners seeking to understand how societal influences affect their meditation practice and daily interactions, emphasizing our duty to transform negative conditioning while recognizing the positive aspects of communal care and support.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble, and fully self-awakened one.

I thought this evening I'd tackle the thorny problem of social karma. According to the Buddha, the *kamma* we own consists of the actions we've performed—whether thought, speech, or deed. All of these are products of the will. It's the will that manifests them.

Some of these actions are automatic. We're just habitually thinking, doing things. Speech tends to be spontaneous—or unfortunately impulsive. But then there are times when our responses are measured, when we have to think about what we're going to do. Those considered actions often have the greatest force within our personality. What's important in the process of liberation is the ethical value—or lack of it, of course.

These mental states, these *saṅkhāra*, are created by our decisions moment after moment, whether habitual or considered. Given that, it might be a little confusing to talk about social karma. I think it's better to talk about social conditioning—that makes more sense.

The fact is that we're embedded in our culture. I was visiting my brother down in the Isle of Wight and happened to watch a grandfather and grandmother taking their grandchild for a walk. The child stopped, turned around, and lifted her arms to the air—obviously asking her grandfather to pick her up. I could hear him saying, "And?" She'd probably been saying, "Lift me up," and he'd reply, "And?" This went on for a little while. Unfortunately, my attention was taken away. I presume the grandmother cut in, unable to bear her husband's unwillingness to respond to the child's pleas, and prompted her with that magic word: "please."

Right there, he took it upon himself to teach the child that you have to say please. Usually, of course, as children we totally accept the conditioning. It's only when we get to be naughty teenagers—and later in life when we can reflect—that we begin to see the conditioning we have.

We also pick up our prejudices. I remember my niece and nephew playing hospital. My nephew was two years older than my niece, but they were both under seven—six and four. Of course, he said, "I'll be the doctor and you'll be the nurse." Afterwards, I thought to myself: if she'd been the elder, would she have chosen to be the doctor?

The same is true of racial prejudice. I was travelling home and had to get from Liverpool Street to Waterloo, which really is a pain. Unfortunately, I ended up in Canary Wharf thinking it'd be easier, and I hadn't a clue where I was. Everybody said I should take the Jubilee line. I was really stuck, and everybody disappeared apart from this black guy, so I asked him how to get there.

As I asked him, I could feel this anxiety that he might reject my request in some way—based on my assumptions about how he feels about white people. I was lucky. He happened to be working near the Jubilee line, which was something like a fifteen-minute walk away through I don't know how many streets. He was very glad to take me. But I was interested in my experience, in that idea that came up as I was asking him. I actually go out of my way to ask people of colour.

Then there's the monarchy. We've just celebrated the Queen's Platinum Jubilee, and there's no doubt she's fulfilled that role admirably. But have we ever actually considered the institution of monarchy? I have to confess, I'm a lifelong republican—you'll have to forgive me for that. The monarchy as an institution is the preserve of nobility, of privilege, the House of Lords and all that. It has an influence on us, on how we see ourselves in society. How would you feel if you met her?

And then there's something I've been banging on about these past couple of weeks: the neoliberal ideology and what it's done to us, made us much more selfish. For instance, in the NHS, instead of being patients, we were told we were clients. This meant we moved away from an attitude of gratitude to one of entitlement. The amount of suing of the NHS went up enormously. Last year it stood at £2.4 billion.

It's not that we shouldn't be compensated for poor treatment—that's not the problem. It's where we're coming from: the entitled, the indignant entitled, as opposed to the injured patient. How do you feel when you go for a service and the bus doesn't arrive? My parents would have just felt grateful. There's even now—I don't know whether you know about this—defensive dentistry. Dentists won't do anything on your teeth unless they have proof of something wrong. They're absolutely scared of being sued for anything they do. There have been some really bad cases because of that.

At a deeper level, of course, it's our race. How do we feel if we're black, being in a white-dominated culture? Jews' unrelenting history of persecution. And then there's, of course, whites who are, at the moment, being encouraged by extreme Brexiteers with their shining luminary Boris, who projects us as British, special, etcetera, etcetera.

All this will be there within us. I came across real prejudice when I became a monk. One time I walked into a shop and the assistant or the shopkeeper simply turned around and walked out. I was left just standing there until I realised she

wasn't going to come out to serve me. Then there was a quite nasty occasion when I was at Dubai. I was flying back from Sri Lanka when this drunken Englishman just went on and on about how stupid and ridiculous I looked.

It's catching, how our personal conditioning—not the societal conditioning—how we are personally conditioned. Although we've had little choice in that conditioning, the fact of the matter is, it's us. We are an expression of our culture and it's our duty, our responsibility, to accept that and to do something about it when it's unwholesome. I have stressed the unwholesomeness within society, but obviously there's beauty too. Just mentioning the NHS, it's a product of a society of care.

The Buddha has lots of advice for lay people in the *Sigālovāda Sutta*, where he talks in detail about your relationship within a family. It's, of course, very patriarchal, but then he was a man of his time. The monks were allowed to wander any way they wished, but during the rainy season, they had to come together and reestablish the fact that they were a community. And of course, he goes on to say how good companionship is the whole of the spiritual life.

Ānanda has come to the opinion that it's only half the holy life. And the Buddha replies, "Don't say that, Ānanda, don't say that. Admirable friendship, admirable companionship, admirable camaraderie is actually the whole of the spiritual life. When a monk has admirable people as friends, companions and comrades, he can be expected to develop and pursue the Noble Eightfold Path."

And of course, he also has compassionate advice that he gave to the king who wanted to attack the Vajji Confederacy, pointing out that the nation's welfare was dependent on frequent meetings, that assemblies assemble and disperse peacefully and attend to their affairs in concord, that they do not enact new decrees or abolish old ones and proceed in accordance with ancient constitutions. And they respect, honour and esteem their elders, refrain from abducting women and maidens of good families, show respect, honour, esteem and veneration to shrines, and look after their Arahats.

Of course, you can retranslate that for our own times. But here the Buddha is actually saying that the society we are in—we are dependent on it for our conditioning. We are responsible. Once we know we're conditioned, once we know our conditioning, we are responsible for it. And where we can, we develop a right conditioning. And in so doing, we affect the people around us.

I don't know whether that's created more confusion or in some way brightened up this little dark area, which I don't think many people talk about. I can only hope my words have been of some assistance, and that you will, by your endeavour to overcome all negative social conditioning, arise into the glory of Arahatship sooner rather than later.

PART 7

Wisdom in Daily Life



Dhammena samaṅgī — Endowed with righteousness

Paññā - Wisdom and Intuitive Intelligence

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 10 min

Originally given as *Paññā - Wisdom and Intuitive Intelligence* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the Pali term paññā - often translated as wisdom or insight - revealing it as our fundamental intuitive intelligence. He explores the etymology of paññā, showing how its root connects to the Greek 'gnosis' and our English 'know,' with 'pa' serving as an intensifier meaning 'really knowing.'

Bhante explains how this primordial intelligence expresses itself through three main channels: physical (as seen in athletic performance), aesthetic (through artistic expression), and intellectual (through conceptual understanding). In vipassanā meditation, we work to disembody this pure intelligence from its confusion with body, heart, and mind by making these phenomena objects of awareness.

The talk reveals how this intelligence operates beyond our conscious control - often providing insights when least expected, such as during eating or upon waking. Bhante emphasizes that paññā cannot know itself as an object, yet it is the very faculty that knows all objects. This understanding points to the not-self (anattā) characteristic and our lack of ultimate control over even this wonderful capacity.

Drawing on the Mahasi tradition's understanding that deep insights often arise unexpectedly, this teaching offers both newcomers and experienced practitioners valuable perspective on the nature of wisdom and the goal of liberation from suffering.

I want to look at this word, paññā, which often comes up alongside sati—awareness—though I'll deal with that another time.

The word paññā has two parts. The ñā comes right through the Greek as gnos- is, then through Latin, and ends up with us as 'know.' It's the same root word—a sentimental link with the Buddha. And the pa is just a reinforcing of it: to really, really know.

We tend to translate paññā as insight, but in its passive form it's wisdom. And wisdom here isn't to be confused with knowledge in the sense of cleverness. It's the way we relate to life, either wisely or unwisely. It's a position. When this wisdom becomes active, it becomes an insightful process.

Sometimes it's translated as 'a knowing,' which I think is a lovely word for it. Knowing tells you what it does without concretizing it into an object.

When we're meditating, what we're trying to pull out, as it were, or make obvious to ourselves, is this faculty of paññā—this pure intelligence, this intuitive intelligence that we have. The reason we get confused is because it's always expressing itself through something phenomenal, something within the world.

Physical intelligence—you see that in sports people. A tennis player might practice a great deal, but on the court there's no thought, just that immediate response. It's a sort of physical wisdom, you can say. Even ordinary people, not sports people—if something comes flying at you, you don't think about it, you just move. That's intelligence expressing itself through our physical nature.

The other main one would be aesthetic intelligence, through art. We can see that in people, especially those who perform. They're not thinking, they just do. They've practiced the piece, and then it's just that complete absorption in the expression—singing, playing piano, whatever.

And then there's the intellect, of course. This intelligence has to express itself, its knowledge, through words as well, through concepts.

Through the process of vipassanā—specifically this process of vipassanā—we're trying to disembed this intelligence from its confusion with body, heart, and mind. That's what we're doing when we make these things an object.

When we see feelings and sensations, when we're moving around and aware of the body moving, when we're aware of our emotional states, and when we're aware of our images and thoughts—we're aware of something. The awareness there, even in the language, tells us that awareness is something separate, shall we say, from what it's aware of.

We're making everything very clearly an object to ourselves, so that this intelligence begins to recognize its own specific quality. And it can't know itself in the same way that it can know an object. In the Mahayana they'll say the eye can't see itself. The tongue doesn't taste itself.

It's something beyond the phenomenal world. Can you imagine if your tongue had its root taste—if the actual taste of the tongue was curry? It'd ruin the porridge, wouldn't it?

Our senses, you see, are totally receptive. They don't come coloured, you might say—they come with an ability. Sight, for instance, comes with the ability to see, though a person may be colour blind; it's still a receptive faculty. This primordial intelligence we have is similar: it isn't something that can ever be fully described, and yet it knows. That's the peculiar thing.

And it doesn't know what it knows until it expresses what it knows. That's why an artist—a painter, say—keeps working with a piece, keeps working with it. In that process, this intelligence finds a way of expressing what it knows.

When we're describing something, even now as I'm talking, some of it I might know in the sense of something I've already learnt from the past. But often, even when I'm talking, I say something in a slightly different way, or I say something differently—something that hasn't been thought out. It just comes. I'm sure you've all had the experience of saying something amazingly wise and wondering where it came from. It's that intelligence, you see, which is within us.

The last thing to really understand is that this intelligence sparks at any time. The practice of vipassanā is just a training—it's simply helping us discover this original intelligence. But it sparks off whenever it will.

It's well known in the Mahasi tradition, for instance, that deep insights often come exactly when you don't expect them—like when you're eating and such. Because often our vipassanā is distorted by wrong effort: trying to see something, trying to understand something.

And this intelligence isn't limited to the spiritual life. We're talking here about the spiritual life, where that darting forth is really to do with understanding the three characteristics, because the purpose of our practice is simply to bring an end to suffering. But it's there in everything we do—whether it's opening the bonnet of your car and looking to see what's wrong, or whether it's something you're struggling with and you sleep on it and wake up next morning with an idea, whether it's a personal problem or a problem in life.

And that's another little insight into this idea of not me, not mine, not in control. We're not in control—not even in control of this wonderful intelligence we have. It has its own way of working things out.

And so finally, you see, the Buddha himself, having gone through his own training and coming to that point of liberation—which is the liberation of this intelligence—then begins to teach. All those things—his body, his aesthetic sense, because he likes to use imagery and such, and his intellect—are put to the service of expressing his understandings.

So that, in summary, is this word *paññā*: this fundamental, basic Buddha nature we have, this intuitive intelligence.

I can only hope my words have been of some use. May you be liberated sooner rather than later.

Sati — Knowing

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 11 min

Originally given as *Sati — Knowing* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this teaching, Bhante Bodhidhamma presents sati as the single most important word encapsulating the Buddha's practical teaching. Moving beyond conventional translations of 'mindfulness' or 'awareness,' he reveals sati as 'knowing' — a dynamic, intelligent awareness that operates beyond the thinking mind.

Drawing from the Buddha's own awakening story, Bhante explains how the Buddha discovered vipassanā absorptions that contained this special quality of intelligence. This knowing is not our personal knowing, but rather a bare, open receptivity that allows insights to arise naturally. When we establish this 'noble awareness' (sammā sati), we step out of conditioned existence and discover the unconditioned space within us — our Buddha nature.

The talk explores how our fundamental delusion lies in believing we are merely this psychophysical organism, driving us to seek the deathless (amatadhammaṃ) in transient pleasures. Through vipassanā practice, every time we make an object of our experience — thoughts, emotions, sensations — we discover the unconditioned awareness that observes them. This 'default position' of pure knowing becomes our refuge and the foundation for liberation from suffering.

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā-Sambuddhassa Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā-Sambuddhassa Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā-Sambuddhassa

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-enlightened one.

If you were to choose one word that encapsulates the Buddha's teaching when it comes to practice as opposed to theory, it would have to be this word *sati*. Its Sanskrit root means actual remembrance, and it's used that way in certain

exercises. We talk about *buddhānusati*, recollection of the Buddha's qualities, recollection of the qualities of the Dhamma, and even *maranasati*. But when it comes to the word *sati*, the Buddha uses it in a specific way.

He always pairs it with the word *ariya*, which we translate as noble. It's probably more accurate to say correct, or that awareness which leads to liberation. And that's what he's really pointing to.

From his life story, we know he happens upon it. The teaching of the time tended to focus on developing mental states that we now call the absorptions or *jhānas*. Although these are very blissful states — and you find them in all religions because they're brought about by contemplations; this *mettā* practice we're doing, if you do it very strongly, will create bliss within you — they also suffer from impermanence. So they didn't actually produce the answer he was looking for about human suffering. They still left him with his existential angst.

Then he tried self-mortification, if you remember, which is really the understanding that the body's at fault. Our appetites and greeds come from the body, and therefore you have to renounce the body to such an extent that you almost kill it. He became very thin. And that didn't take him anywhere either.

It was only after he'd been revived by that rice pudding that he has this memory of childhood. He's watching his father doing the ploughing ceremony. The scriptures speak of the first absorption. But there's something else in that absorption which wasn't there before — what we call the *vipassanā* absorptions. That quality which was present, and which wasn't in the practice he'd been doing with those other teachers, was the intelligence.

He's watching his father, absorbed in watching his father, but with that question mark in the mind. That's why I have that picture at the back, given to me by an Irish student. A little girl is reaching out and pulling away a leaf to discover this beautiful butterfly, but you can see she's coming from a position of don't-know — and it's quite frightening for her. When we open up to ourselves like this it can be a bit frightening, but the power behind it is this intelligence.

This intelligence, this knowing, is that within us which is to be liberated. Because the problem lies within the knowing itself. The knowing doesn't know where it's at, and it makes a wrong decision, a wrong association. If I were to choose one word for this *sati* — which is often translated as awareness, mindfulness, and so on — for me the word that really encapsulates it is knowing.

We're rather lucky in English that we have the gerund, which is a verbal noun. In so doing, it doesn't coagulate into a thing. It's not the known. It's not our knowing. You take away its personality, its solidity. It's just knowing — like being, like becoming. That quality of just knowing what is happening liberates the knowing from delusion.

That intelligence, that internal intelligence we have, is part of *sati*. The awareness really points to just that openness, the receptivity you need. And this knowing is beyond our control. When insights come, even in ordinary daily life, it's not as though we've thought them through. Sometimes you go to bed with a problem and wake up to find it's as clear as day — and you haven't thought about it. There's something about this intelligence within us that doesn't belong to the thinking mind.

That's why in meditation we make such an effort to close the thinking mind. In so doing, we liberate this intelligence. The awareness is the passive side of it — the openness, the receptivity. As we receive information, there sparks forward out of it this grasping, this sudden understanding. And that's really the *paññā* part, the wisdom part within us. *Sati* is your default position.

In our standing meditation, we come back to that bare awareness. A lovely word is *stop*. Just catch the moment after you say it — before the mind rushes in for the next thing to do. It's catching that moment and recognising the tremendous potential there, because you're open to what is.

Developing that awareness in his sitting, the Buddha was then able to let the heart and mind, all the conditioning that he had, simply express itself. And it was in that expression that he became aware of how we manufacture the world — where the actual original delusion lies. It lies in the belief that we're human beings. Very simple. That we are this psychophysical organism.

Once we've made that delusive step, we're driven to make the best we can of this world, to seek happiness in sensual pleasure, in what the world can give us. It's not as though the world doesn't give us happiness or joy, but it can never totally satisfy this search. The search is for something eternal, not dying — the immortal, the deathless, as he would put it.

We're trying to find that deathless Dhamma, the *amatadhamma*. We say it when we repeat these phrases: the unborn, the undying, the uncreated, the unconditioned. What is that? Where do we find that position within the world of creation, within the world of transient things?

That's the process of *vipassanā*. Every time we make something an object within us — be it a thought, an emotion, a feeling, a sensation — in order to do that, we've stepped out of creation, stepped out of the conditioned. We're discovering this place within us which is the unconditioned. In so doing, we're discovering the real, true, deeper meaning of *sammāsati*, this noble awareness. That's our Buddha nature.

Once we become certain about that, once we begin to understand it, then the training begins. Because we're constantly drawn back into the old conditioning — and that's the problem. The old conditioning is heavy. It keeps sucking us back in. But every time we return to that position of just awareness, bare attentiveness, pure knowing, we reinforce within ourselves where the object of our quest lies.

That's why this practice of *vipassanā* is fundamental to the spiritual life — because it's so easy to get lost in daily life. But just to settle in the morning, a little bit in the evening, and as many small times as we can during the day, to re-establish that position of pure knowing — just coming back down into that default position.

I can only hope my words have been of some assistance. May you be liberated from all suffering — sooner rather than later.

The Discourse to the Kālāmas: Discernment, the Ethical Life and Fake News

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 53 min

Originally given as *The Discourse to the Kālāmas: Discernment, the Ethical Life and Fake News* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the Kālāma Sutta (AN 3.65), often cited as the Buddha's charter for free inquiry, but reveals its deeper message about skillful discernment. The discourse addresses the Kālāmas' confusion about conflicting religious teachings, with the Buddha advising against blind acceptance of tradition, scripture, rumor, logical conjecture, or teacher authority alone. However, rather than promoting complete relativism, the Buddha establishes a clear ethical foundation based on recognizing the harmful effects of greed, hatred, and delusion versus their absence.

Bhante explores how these ancient teachings apply to modern challenges of 'fake news' and information overload, drawing parallels with contemporary cognitive biases and the importance of critical thinking. The talk covers the development of the brahmavihāras (loving-kindness, compassion, joy, and equanimity) as practical responses to moral clarity, and concludes with the four consolations that arise from ethical living. Throughout, Bhante emphasizes the compatibilist Buddhist view of free will - that while we are conditioned beings, we retain the capacity for discernment and choice in developing wholesome mental states that lead to genuine happiness and, ultimately, the unconditioned peace of Nibbāna.

I'm going to do something a little topical here. It's about fake news. I'll recommend a book that's very good on this: *The Art of Clear Thinking* by Rolf Dobelli, a Swiss author. But I'll come back to that.

The main discourse that tries to give us some basic ideas about how to judge what is correct or incorrect is called the Kalama Sutta. I'm going to go through it. Normally people use this to say that the Buddha allowed complete free thinking

— that it was entirely up to you to decide what was true or not true. You'll see why when we go through it. But when you read the full discourse, the message is slightly different, because it's not quite complete freedom to do what you want.

There's this post-modern thing: I do my own thing, in my own time, in my own way. Everything's relative. What's true for me is true for me — it might not be true for you. Tough. Forget tradition and all that. Even rationality is undermined, or at least questioned.

Remember that the Enlightenment, our wonderful Enlightenment in the 18th century — people like Kant and Hobbes, and others I can't remember — produced, of course, eventually the United Nations human rights document. But it also produced Nazism and communism. Rationality, remember, is always based on a premise. If the premise is wrong, then that's it. If the premise is right, that's good fortune.

This is the Buddha's own particular position. He always talks about wrong view, and the path always starts with right view. If your view is wrong, if your understanding is wrong, then the rest follows through as being unwholesome — and vice versa.

Thus have I heard. Remember, this is Ananda recalling this particular discourse. Once the Blessed One was wandering in the Kosala country with a large community of bhikkhus, monks, and entered a town of the Kalama people called Kesaputta. The Kalamas, inhabitants of Kesaputta, said: 'Reverend Gautama, the monk, the son of the Sakyans, has, while wandering in Kosala country, entered Kesaputta.'

'The good repute of the Reverend Gautama has been spread in this way: Indeed, the Blessed One is thus consummate, fully enlightened, endowed with knowledge and practice sublime, knower of the worlds, peerless, guide of tamable men, teacher of divine and human beings, which he by himself has through direct knowledge understood clearly. He set forth the Dhamma, good in the beginning, good in the middle, good in the end, possessed of meaning and the letter, and complete in everything. And he proclaims the holy life that is perfectly pure. Seeing such consummate ones is good indeed.'

Now, they didn't say that. That's a pat phrase you get whenever the Buddha appears somewhere — that last bit always appears with him. It's obviously an implant.

But the point is that when he gets there, they went to where the Blessed One was and, arriving, paid some homage to him. This is a nice little aside that tells you how people behaved. Some exchanged greetings with him, and after cordial small talk, sat down to one side. Some saluted him raising their joined palms and sat down to one side. Some announced their name and family and sat down to one side. And some, without speaking, sat down to one side. You get this idea of people coming in very slowly. They also had this way of going around somebody three times, paying respects.

'There are some monks and Brahmins, Venerable Sir, who visit Kesaputta. They expound and explain only their own doctrines; the doctrines of others they despise, revile, and pull to pieces. Some other monks and Brahmins too come to Kesaputta. They also expound and explain only their own doctrines; the doctrines of others they despise, revile, and pull to pieces. Venerable Sir, there is doubt, there is uncertainty in us concerning them. Which of these venerable monks and Brahmins spoke the truth, and which falsehood?'

Now, if the Buddha had been like one of these wandering ascetics they just mentioned, you would have expected him to say, 'Well, they're all rubbish. Here's the four noble truths.' But he doesn't.

He answers this way: 'It is proper for you, Kalamas, to doubt, to be uncertain. Uncertainty has arisen in you about what is doubtful. Come, Kalamas.'

Now this is the statement that everybody quotes whenever you get a passage on free speech or the freedom of thought that the Buddha allowed. This is usually what they will quote:

Do not go upon what has been acquired by repeated hearing, upon tradition, upon rumour, or upon what is in a scripture, nor upon surmise, upon axiom, nor upon specious reasoning, nor upon a bias towards a notion that has been pondered over, nor upon another's seeming ability, nor upon the consideration, 'This teacher is our teacher.'

Just because someone is a teacher, you believe him, you see. Now, if we go through that list, you'll see it covers virtually everything — though I think there's one point that might be missed.

The first four are to do with tradition. The word is *anussava*, and it means 'in conformity with what has been heard.' Remember, in those times nothing was written down as such. It was all remembered. And that was partly the Brahmins' job — to remember all the discourses, all their Vedas and such.

What Bhikkhu Bodhi writes is that this is generally understood to refer to the Vedic system, which according to the Brahmins had originated with the primal deity and had been handed down orderly through successive generations. Here you've got the equivalent of things like the Bible, the Quran, the Guru Granth Sahib of the Sikhs. The Buddha is saying: don't just believe something because it has this deep history to it, this claim that it was written by God and therefore you have to believe it.

The reference here is clearly to the tradition of blind repetition — you were taught this as a child and this is what you believe. You never question it.

The second one, parampara, has to do with legends, tradition, lineage — signifying tradition in general, an unbroken succession of teachers. It's very similar. Again it's referring to this way of just believing something because that's what you were taught.

The next one, number three, is just by hearsay. They're very close, these — tradition, rumour, a source of confusion. Or by general consensus. That's another problem we have: just because a lot of people believe something, therefore it must be true. Gandhi was supposed to have said that truth can be in a minority of one.

Just using this little point here for the referendum that we had — it's interesting what the respondents said to certain questions. They were asked separately whether they had enough information about what would happen in the event of a remain vote and a leave vote. 65% agreed they had enough information about what would happen if we remained; 26% disagreed. But only 45% agreed they had enough information about what would happen if we left, while 46% disagreed.

So there's a whole load of people who were voting, feeling they didn't have enough information to vote. They probably just went along with what was generally in the air — the feeling that was in the air.

It was the same about the conduct of the referendum. Was it fair and balanced? 63% of people who voted didn't think it was. Strange, isn't it? The main reasons people thought the campaigns were not fair and balanced: 31% thought it was one-sided, unbalanced, biased, partial. And 31% said the information was inaccurate and misleading. Remain voters were more likely to cite inaccurate and misleading information; 38% of leave voters thought the campaign was one-sided. The report really just damns the whole referendum as a democratic exercise.

There was a case in Sri Lanka which is related. A monk who lives up in the forests in a three-sided kuti — the tarantulas and snakes, they're all there. He's very well known; I believe some other monks have joined him up there. It seems — I met him actually — he had gone for his normal morning alms round, and on the way back an elephant jumped out and ran over him.

Now, what they say is that if an elephant wants to kill you, it'll kill you — no problem. This one obviously didn't want to kill him; he just wanted to run over him. But unfortunately, one of those big feet stood on him and really messed up his hip. He lay there all night on what was basically a path. The villagers where he normally went for alms round were wondering why he hadn't turned up, went looking for him, and that's when they found him and brought him to hospital. The doctors didn't do a very good job on his hip, actually — his leg was still up in the air somewhere.

So I met him, and that's actually what happened. But I didn't know this at first. The first bit of news I got was when I'd gone into Colombo for some reason or other, and the Swedish monk there said to me, 'Have you heard about Sonsai?' I said no. He said, 'It's just an amazing story. He was sat under a tree meditating in posture, and a she-elephant with a calf came along. When they saw him, the calf became really interested, walked up to him, tried to sit in posture, fell over and broke his hip.'

From Kandy to Colombo is only about sixty miles. So it just shows you what can happen to a story.

We used to do little exercises like Chinese whispers when we were doing anti-racist work at the college I was at. You'd tell an initial story about a carriage, and somebody stole something. You'd describe certain people in the carriage — one of them, of course, was coloured — and you'd point to somebody and say they stole it. By the time the story got round through all the whispers, it was always the coloured guy who'd committed the crime. This was in a mainly white class, of course.

So you can see how prejudice, how what you want to think, keeps changing the story ever so slightly towards your bias.

So that was the referendum. The final one — the word actually means much the same — is collection of scriptures, what is in the scripture. It's seeing them as infallible.

For instance, even though the study of the Bible, the exegesis of the Bible, is so developed these days — scholars can tell you what parts of the story came from where, like the whole business of the flood being a Mesopotamian myth, and there are two stories of the creation melded together, it's all pulled apart like that — yet you still get people who believe it is actually the word of God and that the whole of creation happened in six days and whatnot. You can see the authority people give to scripture because of its ancientness and so on.

Okay, so that means whatever we read in the Buddhist scriptures, we don't just take for granted. That applies to us as people interested in the Dharma.

The next four are concerned with thinking. The first one is translated as logical reasoning, logical conjecture or surmise — reflection, logic, reflection. This is on the basis of logical reasoning.

Now, rationality — there's a lovely story. The story around Galileo is informative here, because when Galileo wrote his paper, it was deemed to be heresy. They really got into him for it. Galileo had basically supported the works of Copernicus — I'll be hazy about all this — but when the authorities discovered this and read it, they decided it was heretical.

And the reason was this: God had created the world, and the apex of his creation, the wonder of his creation, was the human being. The idea that we should be floating around the sun rather than the sun floating around us was horrific. And not only that, you could see it — you could see it every morning. The sun was rising and falling. So there's a bit of perceptual understanding there.

But the reasoning was that it was unreasonable to think that the apex of God's creation would be wandering around the sun, or around the stars, rather than them wandering around us. And of course he had to recant — he had to take it back. I think later on he got it out there. But that just shows you how reasoning based on some premise, if the premise is wrong, then you've messed up.

The second criterion is inferential reasoning — the basis of inference. The Buddha wouldn't go there at all.

Consider, shall we say, a Hindu position as opposed to the Buddhist one: the union with God, with Brahman. Christianity has something similar — union with God in the Christian tradition. When you read the mystics, it's actually a singular experience. To quote Meister Eckhart, the thirteenth-century mystic: the I — that's E-Y-E — the I, or consciousness, that I see God with is the same consciousness God sees me with.

In that experience, there's no duality. That's what they mean by non-dual — no other, no separation. The reason they say 'non' is that if you say 'one' you beg the number two, so they get beyond this by saying non-dual.

We have the same problem with attachment. If you read the earlier Buddhist books, they'll use the word 'detached' — to be detached. Well, that sounded awful to people. I could be detached and yet love somebody. So they had to coin this new term: non-attachment. It's neither detached nor attached; it's non-attached. It's something that lies above it. You've got the same sort of language problem with duality and oneness. You say it's non-dual — neither this nor that.

Here you've got Meister Eckhart telling us about this experience, which he says is an experience of God — but there's no object there. In other words, he's inferring that this must be an experience of God. And from that inference, there's a presumption that everybody's soul has this same experience. And from that, you get the concept of God with all these beings that have this union with him. You can see that that's an inference. You can't actually experience it.

It's the same with Hinduism, shall we say. The *atta*, when it is non-dual experience in Hinduism, is to be at one with Brahman. That's an inference.

The Buddha wouldn't go there. That's why there's no teaching about what relationship your *Nibbāna-dhātu*, your Nibbānic element, your Buddha nature has with anybody else's. Or what relationship it has to, shall we say, something that's created it or not created it. There's nothing at all in the Buddhist scriptures about that.

The Buddha is quite clear that all he's teaching is what can actually be experienced, and he's clear that *Nibbāna* is, as far as he's concerned, the ultimate happiness — and that's it. Once you've attained that in this life, you're radically changed by it. That's why I put up that quote from the nun Mechi Khema.

And when you die, again, the inference is that you either disappear, or you disappear into that state as an eternal state. But even that's a little bit hazy because, as you know, the *Mahāyāna* say that the Buddha comes out of that, called by compassion towards all beings. But it's all inference. We don't know.

The Buddha says you have to be careful when somebody talks to you about these things — when he talks — that you can distinguish between what's experiential and what's actually being inferred.

The next criterion is really about specious reasoning, silly reasoning. It's a reflection on appearances, which refers to theories such as — the example given here is — the Big Bang Theory. That is a theory. There can't be, I don't think, any absolute decision about it because it begs the question as to why it happened in the first place. It always goes back to this original point where, okay, there was this explosion, but hey, why? Where has it come from? Because nothing comes of nothing, to quote wonderful Shakespeare. It's that sort of reflection you have to be careful of.

There's also this business about having thought about something, having actually gone through the whole process, but again it says there's a bias towards a notion. And that's what we're not always aware of — our biases.

These days you hear the word 'bias' used as opposed to 'prejudice.' A prejudice is something you're quite aware of, but a bias is a way of looking that operates beneath awareness. I gave a talk a couple of weeks back on how we as a culture receive Buddhism through biases unknown to us. We're not fully aware that we're always judging the Buddha's teachings, always reframing them in terms of science or in terms of the Romantic movement.

Take the whole idea of being at one with nature. You get Buddhist writers talking about how eventually what we want is this beautiful oneness with everything — which is actually a Romantic idea. There's nothing that I know of in the scriptures about oneness with nature. It's always about getting your morals right and really discovering this other transcendent experience of Nibbāna.

Not that you don't have those experiences, but that's definitely not where Buddhism has got its teachings directed. If they arise, all well and good, but that's not the purpose. Such states would also be transitory, as the Romantics themselves pointed out. You could get blissed out in nature one day, and then the next day it rained. You can't hold it.

So you've got to be careful of these biases that we're not aware of. And how do you become aware of them? Well, that's another good question. The answer is through really discussing these things with people who have different views.

This came out very clearly in the American election, where on the surface of things it looked as though Clinton had it made. But then — and Facebook is especially criticised for this — people were really only reading their own little group,

just re-establishing, cementing their views and opinions, and therefore weren't listening at all to anybody else. When the election came, of course, it was all a big surprise.

One thing that seems to be missed in all this is intuition — that sort of gut feeling, that sense of being right or being wrong. You get people saying things like 'I feel,' and it annoys people who say 'I think,' because people who say 'I feel' have an intuitive grasp of something but can't often explain why. And people who say 'I think' want to know why. Meanwhile, people who say 'I think' annoy people who say 'I feel' because often their thinking isn't right according to the way they've intuited something.

But you can't trust your intuition either, because you don't know where you're coming from. Just because you have an intuition that something is right or wrong, it still has to be tested; you still have to question it. Your intuitions are also based upon a bias — an internal bias through which we're looking at the world.

In terms of the spiritual life, our fundamental biases are these: that happiness is to be found in this world, in the sensual world; that things have some sort of permanency; that I have a sense of me that is permanent, even though everything else is changing. That's the problem with the self. These deeper biases, these delusions, are actually shaping the way we experience life, creating perhaps expectations that aren't possible.

The final criterion has to do with the teacher — really just having too much faith in the teacher and what seems probable.

This is an interesting one because generally you have to have a certain confidence in your teacher. And if anything happens whereby you lose that confidence, the whole thing is actually snapped.

I remember it happened to me. I had a teacher whom I had a lot of admiration for. And then he did something and just something snapped, and I thought, no, this guy won't do. I left; I went somewhere else. It wasn't that he was evil or anything — I just lost confidence in him. It's not that I didn't go back later and stay with him and form a good relationship, but it was as though something had snapped my faith in him. Which might have been a good thing.

Sometimes you do over-invest. I don't think you can help giving your teacher an aura that they don't actually have, because you're always looking to them for advice and whatnot. There's always that tendency to see them as slightly more enlightened, better, more ethical than they actually are. And when they trip, you think, oh, blood and sand, I'm not going to follow this one.

You're probably doing it to me, you see. I'm preparing for you to say, what the bloody hell's going on? But you can't help it — everybody does it to anybody who leads. That's the whole point of a leader, isn't it? They surround themselves with this charisma, which isn't something they may have particularly developed. People have dumped it on them. I've actually seen it happen. And it's very blinding.

The Buddha wouldn't have any of that, either. There's a lovely bit just as he's dying where a young monk is looking upon him with the eyes of adoration, and he sends him off into the forest to go and meditate. That's the wrong sort of relationship.

So he's very clear about what the relationship between teacher and student should be: the student should be constantly questioning the teacher. Obviously following the directions as best they can, but never being completely taken in. You'll probably all be leaving tomorrow.

Anyway, if we now just read on. He made this statement about what not to believe, but he doesn't leave it there. Remember, these people probably haven't seen him before. They don't know him very well. They've heard this rumour, this reputation that he has, but they don't know him. So he starts right from the beginning.

He says, what do you think, Kālāmas? Does greed appear in a man for his benefit or harm?

It's for his harm, Venerable Sir.

Being given to greed, being overwhelmed and vanquished mentally by greed, this man takes life, steals, commits adultery and tells lies. He prompts another to do likewise. Will that be long for his harm or ill?

For his ill, Venerable Sir.

Then he goes on with the same process about hate. Does hate appear for his harm and ill? Well, yes, Venerable Sir. And what about delusion? Overwhelmed by delusion, he takes life, steals, and so on. So that's also not so very good.

Are these things for good or bad? They're bad, Venerable Sir. Blameable or not blameable? Blameable, Venerable Sir. Censured or praised by the wise?

Here, you see, he's not saying you can make up your own mind about things, that you can have your own thoughts and go your own way. This business of blameable and praised by the wise constantly comes up in his teaching. You have to actually find out what somebody whom you see as more trustworthy or more advanced than yourself — in terms of morals and spiritual life — thinks, and be able to take that advice.

Undertaken and observed, do these things lead to harm and ill or not? And how does it strike you? Undertaken and observed, these things lead to harm and ill. This is how it strikes us. Therefore I say — and then it repeats that formula: do not just believe somebody because of this and this and that.

And then, of course, he says the opposite. When there isn't greed, and a person does not take life, does not steal, and so on, will that be for his benefit and happiness? Yes, Venerable Sir.

Then he goes through the same process. Remember, this is the oral tradition, so it's all put in a particular way so you can actually remember it — phrases spoken over and over again. Again, hate — will that be for his benefit? No, definitely not. And then the same with delusion.

These people don't know him, and he's giving them a way to find out whether something is beneficial or not. He's giving them something they can relate to immediately: greed, hatred, aversion, and delusion.

Now, having laid down a moral platform by which they can decide whether something is good or bad, he tells them how to live.

A disciple of the noble ones, Kalamas, in this way, devoid of coveting — that's the greed — devoid of ill will, undeluded, clearly comprehending and mindful, dwells having pervaded with the thought of amity, of love, one quarter, likewise the second, the third, the fourth — like we do in the evening. And so above and below and across, he dwells having pervaded all the existence of all living beings everywhere, the entire world, with the great exalted boundless thought of love that is free of hatred and malice.

Here he's telling them how to actually practise in daily life. He says the same thing with compassion, the same thing with joy, and the same thing with equanimity. There you've got your four illimitables — something you can actually develop in your ordinary daily life.

Having laid down a moral platform that we should be doing what is a benefit to ourselves and to others, he then gives a practice to support that attitude: developing love, compassion, joy, and peacefulness.

And he says when you get to this, you get four consolations, four solaces. When a disciple of the noble ones has such a hate-free mind, such a malice-free mind, such an undefiled mind, such a purified mind, one of the four consolations is to be found here.

Suppose there is a hereafter. Suppose there's an afterlife, and there is a fruit, a result of deeds done well or ill. Then it is possible that at the dissolution of the body after death, I shall arise in the heavenly world which is possessed of the state of bliss. This is the first consolation.

Supposing there is no hereafter — no afterlife and no fruit, no result of deeds well done or ill — yet in this world here and now, free from hatred, free from malice, safe and sound and happy, I keep myself. This is the second consolation. Even if you drop dead and that's the end of it, practising like this at least brings you a certain level of happiness in this very life.

And in the opposite way: supposing evil befalls an evildoer. I, however, think of doing evil to no one. Then how can it affect me who has done no evil? In other words, there's a presumption that if you're not committing evil, it's less likely for evil to come towards you. Obviously, if you're a very angry person, you might find somebody who's actually more angry than you — and then you're stuck.

This doesn't mean that evil doesn't approach us, but there's a consolation that you won't excite somebody's hatred towards you.

Supposing evil results don't befall an evildoer — well, then I see myself purified in any case. If I don't do evil and there are consequences, evil won't come to me. If there are no consequences to evil, that's fine too — because I don't do evil, no consequences will come to me either way. Here he's arguing about fate and free will, and we'll come to that towards the end.

These are the four solaces. And of course he says the opposite with doing good: we can expect good results from a moral life.

Now, at the end of the discourse, they're all absolutely gobsmacked by the Buddha, and they end up saying: 'Marvellous, Venerable Sir, marvellous! As if a person were to turn face upwards what is upside down, or to uncover the concealed, or to point the way to one who is lost, or to carry a lamp in the darkness, thinking those who have eyes will see visible objects — so has the Dharma been set forth in many ways by the Blessed One.'

'We, Venerable Sir, go to the Blessed One for refuge, to the Dharma for refuge, to the community for refuge. Venerable Sir, may the Blessed One regard us as lay followers who have gone for refuge for life from today.'

To sum up the Discourse to the Kalamas: remember that they don't know the Buddha — or they don't seem to know him — and he's not going to try and convert them. He's going to help them discover for themselves what is wholesome and what is not.

First of all, remember he asks these questions about the moral life: is something wholesome or unwholesome? Once he's done that, he goes on to explain about greed, hatred, and delusion — well, that's part of it really — and then what happens when they're not there. And then of course he says, once you've got your moral life going, you've got to develop these four qualities, the four brahma viharas, the illimitables: love, compassion, joy, and peacefulness. But you could extend that to any virtue.

So that's basically the teaching of this particular discourse. It's only right at the end that they actually accept the Buddha as their teacher. Presumably after that — or shortly after, at least on the next visit — he would hit them with the four noble truths, the eightfold path, and so on. Skilful teaching. These sorts of things are repeated in various scriptures throughout.

So what does this discourse tell us? It tells us to be very discriminating about what we actually hear or read or see. And not only to use our own intellect and understanding, but also — this accent upon what others think too. There's always that sense of relationship, that you're not isolated. But then, as Gandhi pointed out, the truth can be in a minority of one. So it really is a bit dodgy.

The other thing I wanted to very quickly mention was this lovely book called *The Art of Thinking Clearly* by Rolf Dobelli, the Swiss author. Just certain things he says in it — I've noted one or two here.

How we believe something because of authority bias — that's one of these little phrases psychologists have conjured up. That's why they put film stars in adverts for all these products, even though the film stars probably never use them at all. But because this film star ended up using this toothpaste, well, it must be good. The same with newspapers — if you've got a bias towards the left or right in whatever you read, then that newspaper is giving you the correct news.

There's also social proof — another one of these phrases. If somebody else believes it, then it must be right. If you've got a whole crowd of you believing the thing, it must be right.

This awful thing that's been happening with Buddhists and Muslims — first of all in Burma, in Myanmar, really stoking up a real irrational hatred — seems now to be happening in Sri Lanka, which is absolutely awful. It's just a hard core of nationalists who have this idea that Sri Lanka ought to be Buddhist and all that. There've been race riots and stuff. They've pulled out what they call emergency measures — the army's out on the streets to stop people attacking Muslims. And Muslims are only about seven percent of the population.

That's what happens. You have this bias, you look for people who agree with you, you have your rationality — and off you go. We live in an age of extremes at the moment.

There's also this business of cognitive error — that's what psychologists call this kind of bias. One example is the neglect of probability, overridden by magnitude.

Take the lottery. The lottery gives you millions if you win, but national savings only give you a million — yet you get your money back. Still, people pour their money into the lottery because it's big money. It's weird. You lose it the moment you hand it over — as soon as you give your money to the lottery, that's it, you've lost. But if you were to put it with Ernie — I think everybody's forgotten about Ernie, but in my younger days he was big. That's what you did: you put your money in national savings and you knew your money was there. They just used the interest. Okay, you don't get millions and millions, but you could get a million. And there were smaller prizes. I won once — a hundred quid. See? I was very fortunate, because I crashed my brother's car. That's actually true, that.

Then there's the lovely gambler's fallacy — where you think, something good's got to happen, I can't be having bad luck all the time. But probability actually says you could be having bad luck all the time.

Dobelli also mentions the problems with gut feelings. They're not to be trusted. Our emotions colour everything.

A lovely story I heard about this: a divorce settlement. This man was being told by somebody who comes here, who's a solicitor — look, you'll lose the case, you will lose the money, there is no way you're going to win. But he wanted to do it anyway. Just driven by, I suppose, hatred and some sort of twisted revenge. His emotions wouldn't let him see the sheer impossibility of what he was trying to do.

Another one Dobelli points out is too many choices. I'm sure you've all had that when you go along the biscuit racks at the supermarket. You always end up with your favourites anyway — chocolate biscuits or something.

There's overconfidence: my belief's better than yours. That, of course, comes down to what the Buddha called conceit, where you're always comparing yourself. That's the problem with the self — the self is always, remember, unsafe. So it either says it's better than somebody else, or it feels safer by claiming an inferiority complex: I'm not as good as you, I know that. And then there's that one about being equal, which is just a very subtle way of saying my group is better than anybody else's — or worse than anybody else's.

There's also the matter of miracles — giving meaning to happenings which don't have any real basis.

Consider the story of Constantine, who converted to Christianity just before the big battle where his troops were completely outnumbered by the opposition in front of Rome. He was attacking Rome, and he had this dream, it seems, of a cross. So he must have been listening to the Christian preachers who were around at the time — this is the fourth century, and there were lots of religions in those days, or at least one major understanding about polytheism. Christianity was battering its way through.

It seems he had a dream with this cross, some sort of cross with a cross in the middle of it. He woke up with the presumption that this was going to win him his battle, so he had everybody paint it on their shields — and he won. Then he thought, well, I'm a Christian after all. And that was it. It's a weird story, how the whole of history can be changed by a dream and the empowerment you give to a dream.

So, yes, that brings us to the end of that. And just as a side topic: the whole thing about free will. How free is the will? Well, it hasn't really exercised the East very much. There are, of course, people who've talked about conditioning and all that. But the West is really caught up in it.

If I'm right—you'd have to do your own research—this all goes back to St. Augustine. Augustine argued that God created human beings to love him. Now, you can't condition somebody to love you and feel really good about it. You feel good about somebody who loves you out of their free will. So God gave everybody the free will to love him or not. Which in Christian terms is really about morals, because that's what Moses brought down from the mountain—a set of rules whereby people could live peacefully together.

But free will has exercised our philosophers a great deal. Jean-Paul Sartre said something to the point that you are free to make any decision, but you're either too afraid to do it or too stuck in a rut. You're actually free to make that decision as a conscious choice.

And then you get the fatalists, who think you've no choice at all. Similar things were happening in the Buddha's time. There were people who said it didn't matter whether you went down the Ganges one way with great acts of love and the other way murdering and thieving. Eventually it was all just conditioned and there were no consequences. It just happened.

So free will... What most Buddhist writers have argued is what they call a compatibilist position: yes, you are conditioned, but you do have a measure of free will.

Think of the path—people talk about the spiritual path, and the Buddha talks about the path and says it's an ancient path. Now, if you're walking along a path and you come to a fork, you tend to get out your map to make sure you're going the right way. You consult the map and then you go off on that way. If as you go along you think you've misread the map, you come back to the crossroad and go the other way.

So there's a choice. Because of our delusion there's a choice. The choices come up because we're deluded, because we don't actually know the path. But that's all it is. It's not as though the Buddha was unconditioned as a human being. He was still conditioned.

We can see from Mechi Kyo that she still sees these leftover traces in the mind of greed, hatred, and delusive thinking. It's not as though they've gone. And she would have behaved in a conditioned way—she'd have got up in the morning, gone for her alms round, sat down, had talks about the Dhamma with the nuns, and so on.

So it's not as though you become completely... This psychophysical organism working in society becomes unconditioned. That's not the unconditioned bit. That's always going to be conditioned. Our job, as the Buddha points out in the Kalama discourse, is to get those habits which are going to bring us a natural happiness, a natural ease with life.

The unconditioned is pointing to something else—to that which doesn't belong to this order of things. But there's nothing there. The Nibbanic experience is so transcendent of this life that it's completely empty of it. That's what he means by *suññatā*. It's empty of anything we gain from this psychophysical organism. And it's that which is the unconditioned, and that's why it doesn't have any suffering. That's why it's a perfect blissful state, even though there are no emotions.

All these words we use are anchored in our actual living day-to-day life. But what he's saying is that there is something which is simply not of this order.

And the process of getting there is not the process of free will, of choosing. Yes, there are choices. But the main thing is discernment—actually looking at what we're doing and questioning everything we do to see whether it's bringing us a natural happiness or unhappiness. And then beginning to see things from these three vantage points of desire, impermanence, not-self. Slowly but surely there's an awakening. That's the best word of all. A slow awakening of something in us which doesn't belong to this phenomenal world.

And that's it, folks. I can only hope my words have been of some assistance. That they haven't caused even greater confusion. And that by your devotion to the spiritual life you will relieve yourself of all suffering sooner rather than later.

Free Will

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 40 min

Originally given as *Free Will* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this exploration, Bhante Bodhidhamma tackles the Western philosophical problem of free will from a Buddhist perspective, revealing how our fixation on choice and control actually deepens suffering. Drawing from the Brahmajāla Sutta (DN 1), he explains how speculative views about freedom are "merely the feeling of those who do not know and see, the worry and uncertainty of those immersed in craving."

The talk examines three Western approaches—fatalism, libertarianism, and determinism—showing how each misses the Buddha's central insight. Using the honey bowl discourse and dependent origination (paṭicca samuppāda), Bhante demonstrates how our experiences arise through contact, feeling, and perception, creating the illusion of a separate self that demands control.

Rather than debating free will, the Buddha's path focuses on clarity and investigation. True freedom comes not through choice but through understanding the conditioned nature of experience and following the Noble Eightfold Path. The talk concludes with the liberating recognition that awakening isn't a choice we make but a discovery we uncover through devoted practice and surrender to the Dhamma.

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble, and fully self-enlightened one.

I thought I'd tackle the problem of free will. How does it come up in the Buddha's teaching?

This idea of free will has been with us for a heck of a long time. Even going back to the earliest religions, the question was there: were we at the mercy of the gods, or could we instruct the gods to do things for us? In terms of polytheism, that's how it began—this idea that there was some controlling deity or deities, and the aim was to get them on your side through sympathetic magic and things like that.

Then somehow it corrupted into the idea that if you actually did the ritual perfectly, you could control the outcome. That was the situation when the Buddha appeared. The Brahmins, who controlled the whole business of sacrifice, knew the specific words—nobody else could learn them—and they knew the specific actions, exactly what to do, and this would bring about the desired results. So there's some sort of free will thrown in there, along with some sense of control.

In the West, I think we've cornered ourselves into a very sharp individualism. We don't really see ourselves as social beings, as having social will. We tend to see ourselves as very little individual pods who demand to do what we want to do. The idea of free will, especially from the Enlightenment onwards, is core stuff for us. And it comes out, as you'll see when I talk later, in capitalism, in the idea of freedom, freedom of choice, all that sort of stuff.

The other thing is that with the Enlightenment—that's ours, 18th century, which I totally believe in—came the idea of the rational. Free will has to do with thinking about it and coming to some sort of philosophical conclusion that we have or we don't have free will.

But there's a very interesting discourse here—or at least a part that really interests me—from the Buddha's opening discourse, actually the longer of the longer discourses. He lists quite a huge amount, I think 64 different speculative views. Some of them you'll have heard of: whether the cosmos was infinite or finite, whether the enlightened person was born or died or what not. Everybody has a view on these things, and this is what he says: all such views are merely the feeling of those who do not know and see, the worry and uncertainty of those immersed in craving.

What catches my attention is "merely the feeling." We tend to be up here in the head, and if we can work something out logically, it sort of separates out from feeling. Therefore you believe in free will, whether you actually feel it or not—or rather, you discard feeling, you push it away, on the understanding that there is free will. Even if I don't feel free, so long as I say to myself I am free, I go around thinking that I am free. I don't know if that makes sense. Hopefully, as we go on, it will get more obvious.

If we take another discourse, which the Buddha actually called his honey-ball discourse—it's a delicious sweet you can still buy in India—he gave a cryptic teaching there, and all the monks who were listening didn't ask him anything about it. They went off to another monk called Mahākaccāna, who was very good at expounding the short teachings of the Buddha. They ask him, and he says, why

don't you ask the Buddha? And they go, well, whatever. So Mahākaccāna gives them the longer teaching, and then they go back to the Buddha and say, this is what Mahākaccāna said. It's funny, isn't it? And the Buddha says, well, if you'd have asked me, I would have said the same thing. A roundabout way of getting there.

Anyway, the core of it is this: what we come to know is dependent on contact. That's the part of the Wheel of Dependent Origination—contact. If it's something visual, there's got to be contact at the visual base, the retina. But remember there's also the sixth sense in Buddhism, which is emotion, thought. Something must arise into the mind to make contact—your stimulus. That's what happens, for instance, when you wake up in the morning. The first thing that comes up, you don't beckon it; it just arises. So much of our day is just stuff arising, either coming from an outside stimulus or from something inside us.

Then he says that upon this contact, feelings arise—feelings and perceptions. In Buddhist psychology, feeling and perception arise at the same time. All a feeling is, is a distinguishing in the mind between what is experienced as pleasant or unpleasant. And that's your perception. Whatever feeling arises, as it arises, it's always experienced as neutral. But as soon as you flip into a perception of it, it immediately cuts the world up into likeable and unlikeable.

For instance, in your meditation, you might find some emotion arising which you describe or label as—or at least your attitude towards it is—unlikeable. It's a bit of depression or something. Now, if you take your attention away from the emotional value of it to the sensation value of it in the body, and you get down to just thick feelings or those funny feelings that come up with depression—whatever, heat, whatever it is—then you'll see that as you move towards that base, the idea of like and dislike begins to fade out a bit. You can get to a point where there's just sensation. At that point, you're at the point where the stimulus comes in. You've gone back on it.

When you do something like that, you begin to realise that our definition of things is the core problem—because it comes from our view, our view of something. For instance, if we're conditioned to be racist, as soon as we see somebody of another race, unpleasant feelings arise. It just happens naturally. If you're not conditioned that way, it doesn't arise. These feelings we get are based on our views and opinions, and they arise together with feeling. The heart and mind work in unison. It's we in the West who have split these two up.

Then the Buddha says that as soon as we perceive something, we start thinking about it—and then you get that proliferation.

At the root of this feeling-perception is the me—that self-awareness. When you're in meditation and you get that very strong feeling of being an observer, you've distanced yourself, shall we say, so much from your body, your feelings, your sensations, that you get this sense of the watcher. Turn on that. Where's it coming from? If you're aware of the watcher, you can't be the watcher. As soon as you make something an object, you can't be it. So if you're observing and there's that feeling of watching, of a watcher, just shift your attention and try to catch where that feeling's arising from.

At its most deluded, this me thinks it is this body and mind. And what's its purpose? What does the self want? It just wants to be happy, doesn't it? I want to be happy, full stop. In order to be happy, it has that feeling, that need to control. If something painful comes up in the body, it wants to get rid of it, so you take a tablet. If emotions come up that it doesn't like, it suppresses them. And underneath all that, remember, it's always afraid of the body falling sick, the body growing old, the body dying.

This business of always wanting to live in a pleasant atmosphere, a happy atmosphere, is, shall we say, the motivation behind the self. But it's coming from that root misunderstanding—that we are this body, this mind, this heart, and that the happiness of this body, heart, and mind is dependent on the world. Good food makes me happy, so I want to control my food. I want to be able to cook beautiful things for myself.

The Buddha points this out in the second sermon he gives to those five companions who deserted him because he'd gone a bit soft eating rice pudding. He says, well, if the self were the body, it'd be able to say, be like this, be like that—be able to control it. He's not talking here about simple movements like lifting something. He's talking about what we really want: not to grow old, to be a bit more beautiful, a bit more handsome, and definitely not to die.

That wanting to control is, I think, what we mean by free will—the desire for free will. That's actually what I think we mean at the root of it. Because if we're to receive what we desire, then we need to control the source of pleasure. Full stop. Simple as that.

Now, it's because we fail to do that—in the West anyway—that we have these three ideas. They split into fatalism, libertarianism, and determinism. You can read all these philosophers and they'll slot into one of these, one way or the other.

Fatalism is just the understanding that actually you don't have any free will at all. The self is utterly impotent. Acts of free will don't have any effect. We don't really have any control over our lives; anything that happens to us was previously ordained—it's going to happen. So if on Thursday I'm driving into Newton Abbot, it doesn't matter if I go fast or slow, whether I take this turn or that turn. If I'm going to have a crash, I'm going to have a crash. Full stop. It's bound to happen.

You get this view from people who believe in the stars, don't you? And then you get that psychology of self-fulfilling prophecy. If the stars say you're bound to fall in love, they'll find anyone—a chicken, a horse, whatever—they'll fall in love. It's got to happen.

When you think about it, the real important things of our lives—well, it's difficult to say we've got any control at all. We didn't choose to be born. We definitely don't know the hour and day of our death. We didn't have a choice in our cultural conditioning. What about economic, social, cultural factors? We just ended up with those. And then there's the elements—we're at the mercy of the elements. We don't even choose to fall in love, now that I've mentioned it.

I suppose there's a bit to do with personality as well. If you're a fatalist—that hopeless resignation—if you're that sort of person, you tend to be one, I think. Or the other side: sanguine optimist or something. At best, I suppose, it might build up a stoic patience, a fortitude, a stiff upper lip. And on with the British.

This whole idea that we don't have choice, that everything's predestined—it comes up in the spiritual literature too. In the Buddha's day, there was Makkhali Gosāla. His teaching was this: if you went down one side of the Ganges doing great acts of compassion and huge donations, then came up the other side murdering and pillaging, it wouldn't make a blind bit of difference. The whole road of karma was already set. Every soul that was born would have to go through the entire process of karmic refinement, and in his system it did actually lead to some sort of heavenly state. But of course this undermines any morality, because it doesn't matter what you do in the end—the universe is so manufactured through *saṃsāra* that it'll push you to that definite end regardless. A sort of absolute fatalism.

In Christianity you've got Saint Augustine, of course. He started the one about predestination: if God knew everything, he knew whether you were saved or not. At its worst, that became Calvinism and Scottish Presbyterianism—you're predestined, and that's that.

From that came the Protestant work ethic. Even though you couldn't tell whether somebody was going to heaven or hell by their earthly deeds, you can understand that one presumed if you were successful in business, basically you had to be going to heaven. So then you get that work ethic: people who are rich get to heaven, and people who aren't—well, they don't. They go to hell.

Islam is also fatalistic. It's all written on the tablet, this original tablet—your life's written on it. There was a case I heard of where a friend of mine was working on an oil rig out in the Middle East. Two Westerners fell off the rig. The current was taking them away, and they were shouting for help. Two soldiers just stood there watching them. The manager came rushing down, threw out the lifeboard, pulled it back in. He said to these soldiers, "Why didn't you do that? Why didn't you help them?" They said, "The will of Allah." Heavy, isn't it?

And in our existentialism, we've got Albert Camus. He's the one who wrote *The Myth of Sisyphus*. Now, Sisyphus ended up in hell, if I remember rightly, because of avarice. His job, if you recall, was to roll a boulder up a hill, and then of course it would go down the other side, so he had to go back down and roll it back up again. For Camus, that was the metaphor of life. Every morning you roll this thing to the top, and overnight it falls back down.

When Camus came to make a judgement about what was the point of having a consciousness which suffered—what was the point of that?—his answer was: it's absolutely absurd. Take God away, take any ultimate freedom away, take the idea of salvation or nibbāna or liberation away. What's the point of being conscious when it's such a misery? So his idea was that a human being, really to maintain his dignity, had only one choice, which was to commit suicide. Luckily he was saved the consequence of his own philosophy—died in a car accident. One wonders whether he'd have carried that one through, actually.

The opposite of fatalism, of course, is libertarianism. And that, as far as I can remember, is definitely the fruit of our Enlightenment—the eighteenth-century Enlightenment. It gets corrupted, of course, when a person says they want to do their own thing in their own way in their own time. A teenage rebellion.

But the idea is that we do feel empowered to make choices. When you look back, you do see that you've made certain choices. You could argue those choices are conditioned, but from a libertarian point of view, there's this bit of rationality coming in. Things don't just happen; you can stop, you can think about whether this is good or this is bad. And those decisions, a libertarian would say, are not random, and they're not predetermined. So there's a sense of freedom, a sense of being able to guide one's life. You can choose—the idea of choice—and thereby affect your decision-making.

That sort of view went on to support things like individual rights, freedom of speech, freedom of voting, and indeed the capitalist market—because it's the individual now who has to make choices for themselves and build up their own wealth. That's at its most painful, you might say.

On the other hand, it does make an individual entirely responsible for their actions. So if a person ends up a robber, you can't suggest mitigating circumstances—poverty, say. It's their choice. They chose to be a robber, so we'll hang them. Get on your bike when there's unemployment. You blame the worker for lack of skills because they've not got jobs. It leads, doesn't it, to a dog-eat-dog society, if you take it to an extreme.

At a spiritual level, though—unfortunately from a Buddhist point of view—this libertarian idea does give us the notion of something inside us, this little person, that is a rational self, detached from the world, able to see things from some vast, indifferent plane and make decisions about it. From the Buddha's point of view, that's actually the source of our misery.

Say you walk into a supermarket with the idea of buying biscuits. You're walking down the aisle and you come across a brand you hadn't seen before—Goblet or something. You pick it up and it says, "Goblet makes you happy." You look at multi-flavoured biscuits. Then you think, well, in my mind I'm going to buy my favourite figs. So there you're stuck between a so-called choice. You can always say it's all heavily conditioned, but there's some sort of rationality there. Do I want this? Do I want that? Feeling.

That's the problem with libertarianism: it lifts choice, it lifts freedom into this idea that it's up in the head somewhere. But actually you can see, even on a simple thing like choosing a biscuit, or making a vote—which we call a freedom of vote—actually it's your feeling, isn't it? When you see certain politicians, you feel sick. When you see others, you feel happy.

It's very interesting because before the war, if you look at the adverts for products, they were very centred on the product and very pragmatic. People only bought what they needed. That was the idea. You only bought what you needed. So if you were selling that in an earlier advert, you would simply point out that it has an alarm, it's got red lighting so you can see it in the night. And you'd buy it if you needed it. If you do it these days—because this was Freud coming through—you've got to put a naked woman next to it. And the desire that comes up is immediately latched onto the clock so you can't help but buy it. It keeps you awake.

So finally, that business of a separate rational self—that won't work in the Buddha's teaching. Because that's also embedded.

The third position is determinism. Here there's the idea that the personal self does have a choice and it does affect things. So it's unlike fatalism. But unlike libertarianism, even the choices you make are determined. So whatever's going to happen is going to happen.

Now, if you think about that, if everything is just cause and effect, cause and effect, as a sequel from the past, it's very difficult to imagine anything but a repetitive universe. Where does the newness come in? Where does something stop this chain of cause and events? How is it that we have actually a very creative universe? So it can't be just as simple as a direct historical cause and effect.

The Jains seem to have held that, in the Buddhist scriptures. Now, you've got to be careful here because this is Buddhist propaganda. There's a man called Upāli, for instance, who was a great supporter of the Buddha, a very rich person. And he told the Jain leader, Nigaṇṭha, some teaching about what the Buddha had given. And the Nigaṇṭha sent him, delegated him to go to the Buddha to prove him wrong. Of course, Upāli gets up to the Buddha there and starts his discussion. And by the end of it, he becomes a follower of the Buddha.

So he wants to become a follower. He says, "I shall leave the Nigaṇṭha." This is where the Buddha's magnanimity—one of the little examples of his magnanimity—is: "Well, don't. Don't stop supporting your other teacher. You can support me, but don't stop supporting him."

Anyway, Upāli returns back to the Nigaṇṭha and tells him that he's now been converted. And the Nigaṇṭha, it seems, is so angry that he spews blood and dies. It's that sort of tale which makes you think, well, when they're talking about Jains, maybe it's a bit of propaganda. I think he died in the Jain way, starving himself to death.

What the Buddha points out about the Jain theory, which was some idea of pre-destination, is that you had to stop. You had to stop doing. So you stopped killing, and eventually you stopped eating. The idea was just to draw karma to an end. So the Jain saint actually dies of starvation. You build up your courage for it, I suppose.

What the Buddha points out is that even that decision is part of karma. That actually won't end the sequence of cause and effect. It's like when we don't do something, it has an effect. Even if you take this gathering now: we've all come from different paths to create this particular situation. And in this situation, hopefully something creative is happening—only because we've all come here from different places. So there is something about the way the universe works which is about different lines of cause and effect meeting at a certain point to create something new.

So we see that these three perspectives—fatalism, determinism, libertarianism—I think we might argue that if you look back in time, you might just get the feeling that everything has been predetermined. Your life's actually been fairly set, and you didn't have much of a choice, and you've ended up where you are because... But when you're actually stuck in a present dilemma, when you're actually stuck between this and that, it definitely feels like you've got a choice. So again, it's to do with feeling. It's to do with the way we're looking at something as to which side of this business you tend to fall on.

Anyway, you might be relieved to know that from the Buddha's point of view, we're simply asking the wrong question. So you can now forget the first part of this particular essay.

Because this whole business of free will arises out of a profound delusion—a nebulous idea of me, of me in control. As the self discovers the world, it encounters pleasant and unpleasant experiences, and it wants to create something out of them: this dualistic world where all things are either over there as rivals or on this side as accomplices. It's driven by greed and aversion, indulging and accumulating, rejecting and annihilating. And it's through this process that the self gains its idea of power. It's just a little game it's playing.

So obviously the right question is: how do we put an end to suffering? Remember that the Buddha always reduced his teaching to a very simple statement: suffering and the end of suffering, full stop. The question is, how do we end suffering? How do we get down to really cut the root?

The first thing is to understand this business about conditionality. As we've already said, it's a concurrence of past events meeting present situations, and this is what allows us that feeling of creativity—something new, all the time.

Secondly, the aim is not concerned with freedom of choice at all. The aim to end suffering has nothing to do with choice. It's to do with clarity—with seeing where the path is. It's to do with investigation and exploration of our lives, of the way things are, and of how it is that we keep falling into suffering.

If, for instance, we set out for a walk in the country, we've already decided where we want to go. It's not random. In our case, you want to be happy—you want to find this happiness. And you've got your map, you've got your compass. When you come to a fork in the road, you don't stand there choosing, 'Shall I go down this one or shall I go down that one?' You already know where you're going. All you've got to do is consult the map and make the right decision.

In the Buddha's path, the path is already delineated. This feeling of choice that we have turns out to be nothing but doubt. The self lifts it up to the level of 'Shall I do this or shall I do that?' But actually, if you knew all the facts, you wouldn't have a choice. The path would be directly in front of you. Spiritually speaking, especially.

When I say doubt, there are two types here. There's what you might call honest doubt and sceptical doubt. Honest doubt comes from that business of not knowing. It comes from, shall we say, a sense of grounded humility—like, I don't know. I really don't know. And it's a very difficult place to be, isn't it? We like to know. That not knowing can cause us extreme anxiety. You don't know whether you're going to have the job next week. You don't know whether the cheque's going to come. It creates anxiety.

But if we can sit patiently, if we can sit calmly within that not knowing and accept that state, and then just keep looking, keep observing—then the path manifests. It either manifests because somebody's pointed it out to us, or because our own experience reveals it.

One of the points in the process of the vipassanā ñāṇas, the vipassanā understandings, is this business of what is the path and what is not the path. It's a very simple thing, and most of you have probably been there: in your meditation you'll suddenly start getting these beautiful states. They're very peaceful, very spaced out, very lovely and joyful. And of course the self immediately wants to get in there and say, 'Well, this is it! Finally I made it.'

I remember one man told me he had this—quite deluded, really—he had this amazing experience while sitting on the toilet. Now, that's not relevant; you can have these amazing experiences anywhere. Remember that Luther had his great breakthrough while sitting on the toilet. It's faith only. But this man absolutely insisted he'd reached nibbāna. And what he was describing was just amazing, you know—just a blissful state, really.

But knowing that whatever nibbāna is, it is not felt. Whatever nibbāna is, it is not an emotional state. Whatever nibbāna is, it cannot be described. Immediately, that takes you off that indulgence. See? That's a correction. That's a correction to that not knowing, that doubt which comes up from this desire to seek the end of suffering. That's a wisdom thing. That's coming from something deeper than the self.

When you get the doubt which is really sceptical doubt—a doubt which is a mental illness in the same way that sloth and torpor and all these addictions are—then of course there's something else going on. That's usually a fear of commitment, a fear of giving yourself to something because you don't know what's going to happen. But that fear stops you committing, and therefore stops you meditating.

One of the people who used to organise the doubling group—his father, when he was a young child, put him on a table, opened his arms and said, 'Jump, son.' And he jumped, and the father moved away. Splat on the ground. And the father said, 'That'll teach you. Don't trust anybody.' You can imagine, yeah? So when this man came to the Buddha's teaching, it was quite amazing that he should actually put his heart and soul into it.

So just be aware that the path isn't about 'shall I do this or shall I do that?' That's one reason for having a schedule. You set your schedule down—a schedule you know you can follow—and you just do that religiously. You don't let this little self come in and say, 'Well, shall I do it? Can't do it? Maybe a little kip. I'll go for a walk. Don't feel like it.' All the time you're just feeding the self.

When it comes to joining the order, you don't get up in the morning and say, 'Shall I wear blue?' It doesn't occur. Even the idea of 'What shall I eat?' doesn't arise. So it's about taking out all that edge around where the self can manifest. It doesn't mean to say it doesn't manifest in very peculiar and staged ways, but at least you try to draw a circle around what you can do and what you can't do.

And then you liberate. That's the benefit. You liberate this wisdom factor, this paññā, this intuitive intelligence, to investigate. If this intuitive intelligence gets locked into what the self wants to do, then it's just taken all over the place. Fine, you feel nice when you get out for a walk, but has it helped you overcome suffering? Not at all. All it's done is give you a greater addiction to walking the countryside—just deepening your attachment to the country. Which I've learnt since coming down to Devon, by the way. Terrible.

We could almost say, if you really think about it: when have you been most happy? Isn't it when you've been doing exactly what you wanted to do? I mean the actual doing of it. It's never occurred, has it, when you've been doing exactly what you wanted to do—it's never occurred, 'Shall I do this or shall I not do that?' And it's the same with interest. If you notice, whenever you're interested in something, do you ever have any problems with concentration? No.

Now when it comes to will itself, there is will in terms of power. The Buddha equates that to action. He states it quite clearly: will I call action.

Those of you who know the Wheel of Dependent Origination will recognise this. It starts off with that contact we talked about—a perception, a feeling of pleasant or unpleasant. Then comes that reaction of wanting or not wanting. That's your taṇhā. Only then does this self come in. Which is very interesting, because in language we say, 'I want that.' But actually it's 'that want I.' That's how it happens in terms of psychology.

As soon as that 'I' comes in, you can't stop it—you've empowered it. As soon as that 'I' says 'I want,' then you get that empowerment, that's the will coming in, and you have that next link, bhava, which is becoming. That's when you become. That's your act—act of thought, word, or deed.

So that's why in your meditation, when it comes to things like pleasant and unpleasant, you just want to keep the mind very close to that business of wanting, not wanting, liking, not liking. And that's the way out to liberation—by understanding dukkha, by understanding suffering and unsatisfactoriness.

This power that we have is quite mysterious. It's totally neutral—not good or bad. It depends how you use it. It depends on your attitude. And you can't separate it from the action.

You can try. When you do walking meditation, just stand there. Keep saying, 'Intending to walk. Intending to walk.' And even though you're saying it and intending it, nothing's going to happen. Then suddenly the foot lifts. So what is it

that has taken something out of a potential into an actual? That's what the Buddha's calling will. And you can't separate it from your foot. You can't say, 'Well, that's it over here, and this is my foot over here.' It's one and the same thing. It's within the structure of this whole becoming business.

But the power of that will is your conditioning. Remember, an intention moves you to an action, and that action forms further intention. If that action is wholesome or unwholesome, you're going to get the product of that conditioning. An unwholesome action moves you towards unwholesome conditioning. This is inwardly, remember—all kamma in terms of liberation is inward. It's not something to do with the outside world at all, actually. And anything you do which is wholesome will produce that wholesome conditioning within you. In Buddhist understanding, that's what's driving us to a particular destiny.

This is why, of course, right view heads the Noble Eightfold Path. As soon as you understand, as soon as there's a seeing, a perception of the way things are, this immediately informs your attitude.

Of course, when it gets down into the attitude, you may find the opposite attitude too strong. You might go down and very clearly perceive that the body doesn't need tea. But that's not going to stop you, because of this huge conditioning to drink tea. At least there's the perception that at this present time the body doesn't actually need tea, and you're hanging on to that, waiting for it to drop into the heart as an attitude. Then it balances up with the desire to have tea, and eventually, because you're not feeding that desire anymore, it drops away. The right attitude of seeing food and water and all that as nourishment for the body—not as a place for seeking happiness—begins to get the upper hand and lead you to enlightenment. That's the one I'm struggling with.

This is called Dhamma Chanda, the will for Dhamma. In Mahayana it translates as the Bodhicitta, the heart seeking enlightenment. Eventually, that's the force—the force behind your drive to liberation.

Just finally, to end with this lovely refrain: when anybody gets liberated, you always get this little refrain at the end of it. 'Birth is destroyed.' Now, this is the birth of self, remember. 'The holy life has been lived. What had to be done has been done. There is no more coming into any state of self-existence.' Can you feel the relief in that? What had to be done has been done.

Really, it's a case of being clear that the path to enlightenment isn't a choice. It's not a choice—it's a discovery. What leads us to it is the general dissatisfaction about our lives. And once you perceive which way to go, then it's a case of building up that courage, that determination, that resolution to follow it. And then you get the benefit of it. That's the answer. That's what we have to do.

So what's the message? Abandon free will. Devote yourself. Surrender to the path.

May these words have been of some help to you in your path to liberation. Thank you very much.

The Problem Lies in the Looking

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 43 min

Originally given as *The Problem Lies in the Looking* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this dharma talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines how our suffering stems from a fundamental error in perception—like wearing glasses with the wrong prescription that causes discomfort without obvious visual distortion. Drawing on the Buddha's teaching of Right View as the foundation of the Noble Eightfold Path, he explains how we create continuity where none exists and seek lasting happiness in an impermanent world.

The talk provides detailed guidance on working skillfully with the five hindrances (pañca nīvaraṇa): sensual desire, ill-will, sloth and torpor, restlessness and worry, and doubt. Bhante emphasizes that these mental formations are symptoms of our deeper delusion, not problems to be analyzed but energies to be observed with equanimity until they naturally dissipate.

Using the metaphor of removing an arrow before investigating who shot it, he demonstrates why Vipassanā practice focuses on present-moment awareness of the three characteristics (tilakkhana) rather than exploring psychological origins. The teaching culminates in understanding how this passive purification of the heart prepares the ground for the active cultivation of positive mental states through mettā practice.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble, and fully self-enlightened one.

This morning we discussed the three characteristics, and what we were really concerned with is the first factor of the Noble Eightfold Path: right view, right understanding. What the Buddha is saying is that it's actually the way we're looking

that is at fault — the way we understand things. The quality of that understanding lies deep within the actual intelligence that we are, the Buddha nature within, for want of a better word. We call it a delusion. He calls it a delusion.

The definition of a delusion is that, of course, you don't know you're deluded — this is the problem. If somebody is deluded, what we're saying is that they don't know how mad they are. So here we are, completely mad and not knowing it. Something awakens us to that delusion, and it's suffering. The Buddha says quite clearly that coming to look at suffering leads us to the end of suffering. So although it's not a pleasant thing, finding where suffering ends, how we can bring it to an end — that actually becomes our goal.

I like to tell my sad tale about the optician. I got a new pair of glasses and the left eye felt uncomfortable. But as far as I could see, I saw properly. So I went back and said, "The left eye feels uncomfortable." She tested me — a different optician — and said it was a wrong prescription. It hadn't taken into account astigmatism. Now for those of you with twenty-twenty eyesight, astigmatism is a wave in the lens, like the old glass that used to have a wave — when you looked through it, the image would be distorted. She corrected it, I had a new lens, and the discomfort disappeared.

What amazed me was that I could see no difference between seeing with the wrong lens and seeing with the right one. It all seemed exactly the same to me, except for the discomfort. I think that's a wonderful metaphor for our situation. Somehow being here is *dukkha*. *Dukkha* means a hard place. One of the little descriptions they use is of an axle that doesn't fit the wheel quite right. It's just not quite right. That essential delusion, that essential wrong way of looking, is what we're trying to correct when we see these three characteristics.

We're actually in a better position than the Buddha himself. When he started off, there was very little information as to where suffering might arise. Through his own efforts, he came to pinpoint exactly where the problem lay. We talked this morning about a mistake, because the process begins at the level of not knowing. It's through not knowing that we presume to know. As a child, what do we know? There you are — gurgling, weeping. You just presume yourself to be this little bundle of flesh. And it continues.

As we said this morning, what we're trying to do is create heaven on earth. Interestingly enough, no religion predicts heaven on earth. They always say you have to die, then you go. You can't get it here. You get a glimpse of it here, but you can't maintain it because of the situation of the world.

When we come to see that, our next task arises. Having seen the problem — having seen that we create continuity where there isn't continuity, that we create solidity, substantiality, a sense of self where there isn't one, and that we try to find happiness in a world that can't deliver — once we begin to understand that, to see it in ourselves, then the next question comes up: how do we create the transformation? How do we become Buddha? Because that's what he did, and he said there was no distinction to be made between himself and anybody else.

Our problem now, having perceived these wrong views, this wrong understanding, is how do we proceed in order to get rid of our suffering and — this is the positive side, remember — to end up with this beautiful mind, the beautiful heart.

Remember that once the Buddha had liberated himself from delusion, it wasn't as though he turned into some gormless, amorphous blob sat by the road. He was obviously quite charismatic. In fact, very shortly after his enlightenment, his awakening, he is wandering off to see his five earlier companions, to tell them what he has to teach, and he meets one of these ascetics on the way. The ascetic says to him, "You look so bright, you're gleaming. What's your understanding? Who's your teacher?" And he goes into this wonderful self-panegyric about how he is the enlightened one, the fully self-enlightened. Understandably, the ascetic goes, "Oh, very interesting," and wanders off. That was one of his first lessons — that this wasn't quite the way to teach ascetics.

When he actually approaches his disciples, they know him as this Siddhartha who'd been struggling like them. They think he's gone soft anyway because he'd eaten and such. They refuse to acknowledge him. But as he comes close, they feel there's something quite strange, quite different about him, and almost unwillingly they prepare a seat and start listening. He tries to convince them and they're saying, "Well, yeah, yeah, yeah." Then he says, "Have you ever heard me speaking like this before? Have you ever heard me say things like this?" And they say no. That's when they open up.

Even by the end of the first talks, one of them has reached the first rung of enlightenment, the rung of awakening. So the teaching isn't just about trying to see something — it's about this process of transformation.

There are two processes we have to go through. The first is more passive, the second more active. The passive one is already happening when we practise *Vipassanā*. Simply by turning our gaze away from the symptoms of our disease — away from the symptoms of our wrong view — these symptoms begin to disappear.

What are these symptoms? They are the five hindrances. All the things we desire — desire meaning this drive to find happiness in a sensual world. All those things we're averse to, get angry about, upset about. All those habits of going into oblivion to escape problems. When you feel a bit off, feel things have got on top of you, or feel a bit down, you get these neon lights: head for the bed, throw yourself on the couch, disappear for a while. Using sleep as a suppressant — well, it is a suppressant — push it away, push it down.

Then there's all the stuff that makes us restless, including things like guilt and shame — secondary emotions arising out of wrong actions. And doubts. Doubts that dog us, not only spiritual doubts but ordinary ones. Should I be in this job? Should I be with this person? Should I not be with this person? Just doubts that dog us. And these aren't honest doubts — not a sense of wonder, for want of a better word — but doubts that rest upon fear, fear of commitment.

All this turbulence we have — the depressions, the anxieties, the guilt and shame, all the rubbish that slides inside us — these are symptoms. They're all symptoms of this fundamental mistake. That doesn't mean you can't treat them as symptoms. Often when I speak like this, people think I'm talking against things like therapy — not at all. But therapy itself won't actually get to the root of the problem, although it obviously can be extremely helpful.

There was a book called — you might know it — *Emotional Intelligence*. Another author, a woman, wrote *Intelligent Emotions* as a commentary. It's an excellent book. Her understanding of how we make these emotions worse and worse is second to none. But the preface tells us quite distinctly that there is no end to suffering. It's a Freudian position where all we can do is accommodate. We can only come to a kind of sanity about life, accepting that it's always going to be uncomfortable and there's no way out. Which isn't a particularly — but as truthful as she, from her point of view, perfectly truthful.

Now, when we avert our gaze to those three characteristics, the hindrances still come up. They come up. We can see them in our fantasies. We suddenly get caught up in some erotic, lustful, or romantic dream. We're suddenly building a

huge business that's going to take over the world. We're suddenly saving the world — that's a lovely one. We suddenly have the answers to our climate problems, all these lovely compassionate ideas.

All of that is desire, even if it's arising out of some sort of compassion or love — it's still a production of the ego, of wanting to save the world. You'll notice that the direction is always to stop the dream, to stop the fantasy. That's your symptom. The fantasy is the symptom of the disorder. When you come in from the fantasy, at least you're at a secondary level of the disorder, which is the emotional state you can actually experience.

As you descend into the body — and the answer always lies in the body — as you descend and feel that restlessness, questions may arise: why is this, where's it come from, and so on. But that's again treating the symptom. The Buddha's image for this is of a man shot by an arrow. We all know it. People come to help him take it out and he says, "Hold on. I want to know who fired it, why they fired it, who made the arrow." Well, before they know it, he's dead.

So again we avert our gaze. We're not concerned with the problem as such, the problem of this restlessness. We're concerned with either seeing its transient nature, or with distancing from it and creating in that distance a feeling of it being not me, not mine. When we do that, to our amazement, the thing begins to evaporate, begins to exhaust itself. That's one way we come to understand that these emotions, these states, don't have any reality. They don't have any substance at all — they're just forms of energy. In allowing them to dissipate like that, we begin to see that when it comes to this therapy level of things, the wonder of the system is that you don't have to do anything. You don't have to do a damn thing. You just have to sit there and bear it, sit there and allow it to express itself. In so doing, it's just a force — it just evaporates.

A little warning here: sometimes we're using that to actually suppress it gently. Be careful. When you're noting something like restlessness, restlessness — careful you're not using the word to gently kill it. Because you won't kill it. All you're doing is gently pushing it away. That distancing is a little technique that allows us to regain a certain equanimity within a situation. But once that equanimity is gained, we have to go into it, we have to feel it, to experience it. At that point, its impermanent, insubstantial quality becomes more apparent. And it's seeing its non-substantial nature that undermines the idea of it being a me, a mine.

The third approach is by way of a very simple psychology, open to everybody. Having experienced this restlessness, we catch our relationship to it — our perhaps aversion to it, or our desire to indulge it. Either way, we're actually steering the turbulence.

When you suppress it, the very force with which you suppress it — that negative force of pushing away — simply feeds back into the system. It's like a spring waiting to be sprung. It comes up with the energy of that resistance. As you resist, your attention is on the feeling of that resistance. Is it just aversion, or is it fear? Or is it subtly moving from fear to aversion? Fear and aversion are two sides of the same coin, very close together. Anger and anxiety, fear and hatred — very close. The mind can switch from one to the other at almost lightning speed.

This became apparent to me once when I was — I confess — rather cruel to a little pup. I was playing with it, pushing it away repeatedly, and it kept barking at me. But when I pushed it too hard, it would whine with fear. I could see very clearly how my same action created a dual movement within this little being. One minute it was barking at me fiercely; the next it was trying to get away. That's all we're doing, all the time, with anything we feel negative towards.

The great thing about aversion or fear is that at least it distances us from the object — at least we can create a not wanting. Yet in a paradoxical way, it also makes us stick to the object. You know this if you've ever lived somewhere you could hear next door's music coming through as a continuous thump of the bass. Dum, da-dum, dum, da-dum. Aversion arises, and you just cannot get your ear off that wall. The aversion makes your ear stick to it more and more. As soon as the aversion goes or you're distracted, you don't hear it anymore.

So again, it's a case of opening up — that default position where you allow things to come in their fullness. You're aware of the fear, of the aversion that might arise. Sometimes it comes up at a speed that's difficult to handle. Sometimes our openness allows it to manifest too quickly, and you find yourself feeling a bit panicky. When that happens, you just chill out. You cool the whole system and regain your equanimity. If it's very bad, the way to do that is simply to get up from the posture and go for a walk.

If it's not that bad, just put your attention on a neutral sensation — your breath, your knees, your hands. That neutrality allows the reaction to begin to diminish.

At a much more subtle level, there's that identity, that indulgence. And that is extremely difficult to counteract because it's such a conditioned force in us to indulge what we like. But even so, when that feeling comes — something desirable — you have to be with it.

Take, for instance, some dream we have, something we want to achieve in our lives. The mind is constantly creating scenarios whereby we can achieve it — let's say, setting up a small business. In meditation, we're observing how this desire is constantly manufacturing an inner world. And remember: everything human beings have ever done started with that image. Everything you see, from jet planes to computers, has always begun with an idea. It's always begun coming out of the mind.

As you come off that desire and return to the body, you may feel the excitement around it. Keep your attention within the body, but if you can, just feel that energy moving out to create the world, moving out to create the dream. You can feel it — it's quite a strong pull.

Now, if your attention stays with the original excitement in the body, and with that feeling of wanting to go back into the dream world — if you stay at that level of feeling and wait until this power that wants to manifest the excitement as a dream dies away — then you'll see you're emptying the mind of that desire. It's not that difficult to do, so long as you know where to look for it. And the way you look for it is always starting with that physical base. You can't do it in the mind; the mind's too quick. Once you've manifested through the mind, through a dream, you've lost it — you've become unconscious, you might say. You've lost that awareness, that mindfulness.

That's why when you wake up from a dream, you note planning, planning — that gives you the in. You know something is in the heart that wants to achieve something. That's when you come back down into the body and try to contact it. If you can't contact it, fine — you just stay with the breath. It's not a problem.

This is our unfortunate position: these turbulences cannot release themselves except into consciousness. And they've only got two ways to go — either through some feeling, some emotional state, or if they're too suppressed, too repressed, they'll come out through the body as illness, or at least as some form of discomfort. That's why in meditation people get headaches, feel nausea, get backaches. All of that is this turbulence manifesting through the body. And once it goes, something goes — but for the most part, you never know what the hell it was. All you know is that something's gone.

For about four or five weeks, I had this continual pain at the back of my neck for seemingly no reason. I couldn't understand it at all. And then it just disappeared — one of those things. As your psyche begins to empty itself, as your psychology begins to purify itself, this process of purification is not particularly pleasant. You have to be prepared for that.

It's the same with all the hatreds and aversions, the angers we've got locked in the system. Once you allow them to manifest as dreams, as fantasies, unwittingly you're developing them. You know this from ordinary daily life. Somebody says something to you in the morning that's just a little upsetting. You brush it aside. Then while you're having your cup of tea, you're bloody fuming. By lunchtime, you're biting the fork. By evening, you're taking aspirin. It all builds up.

The person only insulted you once, said something slightly hurtful just that one time. But you've had them repeat it millions of times, just to drive the point home. This mind of ours, which is so creative and has produced so many beautiful things — the music, the art, all of that — is also incredibly destructive. We have to see that within ourselves. We have to be very clear that when the mind wanders off on an aversion or whatever it is, pulling the attention out of it is not suppressing anything. That's not suppression. And it's of little value to investigate the causes. If it's something obvious — somebody at work upsetting you, bullying you — then obviously one has to investigate that. But in terms of our inner psychology, something that perhaps has been there from childhood, and in Buddhist understanding even before, there's absolutely nothing to be gained by digging into it. The attention is simply drawn back into the body.

In a sense, it's only through your own practice that you become confident that staying with the heart, staying with these turbulences at a feeling level, actually allows them to exhaust themselves. I wouldn't want to give anybody the wrong impression that if one works hard enough, within a couple of months one is perfectly... Think in terms of a quarter century to see tremendous progress. But even in the short term — six months or a year — one can see that at least things might be getting just a wee bit better.

Now it's the same with sloth and torpor. It's been translated as 'sloth', which gives it a moral twist. But this dullness in the head and lethargy in the body — remember that this too is a consequence of developing that attitude of seeking comfort in oblivion. Not just conking out. And the great thing about oblivion is that there really is no suffering there. It's perfect. There is a place where you can go where there is no suffering. Unfortunately, we wake up. And in the Buddha's un-

derstanding, there will always be a waking up. So long as there's a self, there will be a form of existence. There will always be a seeking of that consciousness to find expression.

Recognising that, be careful in your daily life not to enter into that state. Rather, go for a walk or do something — just keep awake, as it were — and don't begin to develop that lethargy. In bad cases of depression, I remember a woman who was sleeping sixteen, eighteen hours a day, making things worse for herself, really.

Then there's all this business of restlessness, which can be caused by anything really — just a sense of restlessness. And it's a case of — remember, just like dullness — when there's restlessness in the mind or dullness in the head, actually put your attention there. Just stay with it, attend to it, as a nurse might to a patient. You don't have to do anything; you just bear with it.

Now when the mind's rushing off all over the place, it's just patiently bringing it back, patiently bringing it back. When we do this business of reflection at the end of a sitting and I say, just reflect on your meditation — if the whole of your meditation you've just been coming back off this turbulent mind, that's a good meditation. But if you give in, if you say, 'Well, I will think about that,' then that's it. You could say to yourself, that was a really bad meditation.

If you feel that dullness in the head and you're feeling lethargic, and you're constantly waking yourself up — stretching the body, opening your eyes, standing up — and even if it stays with you in your walking meditation, but you're constantly just keeping awake, just keeping above it, making those feelings and sensations something to observe, something to feel and experience — then that's a good meditation. But if at any time you say to yourself, 'Well, I'll just have a kip,' knowing full well that there is no real tiredness, then one can say to oneself, that was a bad meditation. One should feel guilty. One should feel shame.

The point is that whenever that thought arises, the shame and guilt arise with it — which one does not want to suffer. The Buddha puts on the same hindrance this quality of guilt, shame, remorse. Remorse, of course, is a healing feeling, but it's still not a pleasant feeling. Remember that guilt and shame are — here we talk about the dread of consequences.

So it's actually beginning to understand that there's a way in which we are creating our own suffering. And the true statement would be that we can only create our own suffering, and only we create our own suffering. Nobody can create suffering for us. It's always the way we relate to what we're actually experiencing.

When we perceive that, we need to take full responsibility for our situation. At first this is disappointing, because it's always nice to blame somebody else — or blame the system, or the government. But actually, when you turn into yourself and realise that you're the only one creating your suffering — I'm the only one creating my suffering — taking on that responsibility at least narrows the avenue of escape to just me. Before, I had to change the world. Before, I had to get rid of my enemies and all the people who were making it awful for me. But now it's just me. That makes it very simple. Because all I have to do now is investigate myself, my own psychology, to realise where I'm making the mistakes.

The final one is this business of doubt. Doubt in the spiritual life is a real, pernicious illness because it stops you committing yourself. If you doubt the practice, you won't do it. If you doubt yourself — if you say that everybody else can do it but not me — that'll stop you doing it. So this sceptical doubt is something that has to be investigated. And again, it's very simple. You don't get caught up in the mind, in what the mind is saying. You go into the feelings of doubt, the feelings that surround this so-called doubt. And I think invariably you'll find some form of resistance, some form of fear — fear of consequences, or lack of confidence, which is only another form of self-aversion. It's investigating at that level of feeling, that level of emotional feeling, that these things begin to evaporate.

That sense of doubt — don't confuse it with a sense of wonder. Wonder is the philosopher's emotion, isn't it? It's the philosopher within us that wonders. That's the emotion, that's the drive the Buddha actually wants us to develop. That's what we mean by curiosity — one of the seven factors of enlightenment, the desire of wanting to know. And it's as though we come not from a position of belief — 'the Buddha said this, therefore it must be right' — but rather, 'the Buddha said this, now let's see if it's right for me.' That's our attitude, the attitude he would want us to develop. So we go into the investigation always from that position of not sure, don't know.

In your meditation, when you're sitting, you're developing the skills of practice. Whenever a mental state arises and you're not sure what to do with it, make sure you find out. When a mental state arises, there should arise with it the knowledge of how to deal with it. And it's through dealing with it properly that this process of purifying the heart takes place.

That's why reflection at the end of a sitting is important, even if it's only a single reflection — just looking back and thinking, well now, how did I fall asleep again? Why did I move at that point? It's like going back and saying, okay, next time I'll do this, next time I'll do that.

Even if you don't follow through, even if you forget, that's fine. In your next sitting, when you make the same mistake, simply note that this has happened before and make a firm determination not to fall into that same error. Very slowly, you train yourself into the skills of meditation.

We've all got a technique, a basic way of doing it: watching the breath, noting, going slow — I haven't stressed the going slow, I'll do that tomorrow. We've got the technique, but we also know what we're looking at. We're looking at impermanence. We're looking at non-substantiality, the not-me, not-mine, the distance between the knower and the knowing. We're looking at the way we react to things — learnt reactions. And in that, we're looking at all those negative things that come up: the things we desire that cause excitement, that cause us to dream of a better life. We're looking at all the aversions. We're looking at dullness and lethargy. We're looking at restlessness, and we're looking at doubt.

But we're also looking at our responses to those things — not getting caught up in indulgence or aversion. We're constantly lifting ourselves out of the mind with its machinations, not getting drawn into any history. Whatever happened in the past, this is a product happening now. The product itself is the problem, not the past. It manifests now as this mental state, and in dealing with this mental state, the past loses its effect.

When we practise vipassanā, two things are happening. We're correcting that initial delusion, that astigmatism in our faculty of knowing, in our intuitive intelligence, in the Buddha within. And we're allowing the heart to purify itself. That's what vipassanā is doing, and that's what we're practising over this weekend.

The positive side, which we practise at the end of the weekend, is how we transform that energy into its opposite — through the practice of mettā. That's the first step in the transformation. In the Eightfold Path, having got the right under-

standing of how the whole thing works — the psychophysical organism — we then purify the heart, which is part of the attitudinal, the second step. Then we begin to work with attitudes to transform them: from hatred to love, from cruelty to compassion, and so on. These are then established, confirmed, and developed through right speech, right action, and right livelihood. The whole process of liberation is systemic.

If it stops up in the head, there's a danger of it becoming intellectual and callous. If it stops in the heart, there's a danger of it becoming mawkish and sentimental. The whole process has to be taken through to its logical conclusion: the good life, the wholesome, virtuous life.

I can only hope my words have been of some assistance. May you be fully liberated sooner rather than later. It might be good to do a little walking meditation, about a quarter of an hour. Don't worry about the schedule — give me about twenty minutes, and then we'll do another section. The evening will unfold. Now, if there are any questions that arise from that.

Let's have a look at this business of looking. We've been talking about investigation, and I said earlier that sometimes the investigation can be problematic. Let me give you an example from my own practice.

I remember sitting in meditation one day, feeling quite concentrated, quite settled. Then I noticed some tension in my shoulder. Naturally, being a good meditator, I thought, "Right, I'll investigate this tension." So I turned my attention to the shoulder and started looking at it very carefully, really examining it, trying to see what was there, trying to understand the nature of the sensation.

But what happened was that the more I looked at it, the more tense it became. The more I investigated, the more solid and problematic it seemed. I was creating more of what I was trying to investigate. The very act of looking was making the thing I was looking at more prominent, more solid, more of a problem.

Now, this is where we need to understand something quite subtle about awareness. There's a difference between awareness and looking. When we're looking at something, there's often a sense of effort, a sense of focusing, a sense of trying to get something, trying to understand something, trying to fix something. There's a subject here looking at an object over there.

But awareness — pure awareness — is much more spacious than that. It's not focused in the same way. It's more like the sky that holds the clouds, rather than a spotlight that illuminates an object. When we rest in this more spacious awareness, things can be present without being problematic. They can be noticed without being magnified.

When I went back to that tension in my shoulder, instead of looking at it, I tried to just let it be present in awareness. I didn't focus on it, I didn't try to understand it, I didn't try to make it go away. I just let it be there, held in this broader field of awareness. And what happened? It started to soften. It started to dissolve. Not because I was trying to make it dissolve, but because I wasn't feeding it with my attention in that focused, problematic way.

This is what I mean when I say the problem lies in the looking. It's not that we shouldn't be aware. Of course we should be aware. But we need to understand the difference between this spacious, open awareness and the more focused, effortful kind of attention that we often mistake for mindfulness.

When we're really looking at something — examining it, investigating it, trying to figure it out — there's usually a sense of self involved. There's someone here looking at something over there. There's a subject and an object. And as long as that division is there, as long as there's this sense of self trying to deal with experience, then we're in the realm of *dukkha*. We're in the realm of suffering.

But when we rest in pure awareness, this division starts to soften. The sense of someone looking at something begins to fade. There's just knowing. There's just awareness itself, without a knower. And in that space, things can be as they are without being problematic.

This is why the Buddha said that the highest knowledge is the knowledge of non-self, *anattā*. It's not that we figure out what the self is and then get rid of it. It's that we stop looking for it altogether. We stop creating this division between observer and observed. We rest in awareness itself.

Now, this might sound very philosophical, but it's actually extremely practical. In your meditation, when you notice something — a sensation, a thought, an emotion — see if you can be aware of it without looking at it. See if you can let it be present without focusing on it, without trying to understand it, without trying to change it. Just let it float in this open space of awareness.

The invitation is this: next time you're meditating and you notice something that seems to require investigation, pause. Ask yourself, "Am I looking at this, or am I simply aware of it?" If you find you're looking — focusing, trying, efforting — see if you can relax that looking. See if you can let go of the investigator and just rest in awareness itself.

This is the deepest teaching of *vipassanā*. It's not about becoming a better investigator. It's about discovering that there was never really anything to investigate in the first place. There's just this — awareness aware of itself, with no one looking at anything.

Hetu — The Unwholesome Roots

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 10 min

Originally given as *Hetu — The Unwholesome Roots* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this DhammaBytes talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the Pali term 'hetu' (root) and the three unwholesome roots that drive our suffering: lobha (greed/acquisitiveness), dosa (aversion), and moha (delusion). He reveals how these roots function as Buddhism's depth psychology, showing how our fundamental delusion of selfhood creates the basic relationship of 'this is me and mine' that separates us from the world.

Bhante explains how this mistaken identity generates constant anxiety about control, leading to the twin impulses of grasping what we want and pushing away what threatens us. He distinguishes between avijjā (not-knowing) and moha (delusion), showing how our innocent not-knowing becomes the active delusion that we are separate psychophysical beings. Through practical examples like struggling with a stubborn gate, he demonstrates how these roots manifest in everyday moments.

The talk emphasizes how vipassanā practice helps us recognize these deeply conditioned patterns, creating space between awareness and reactive impulses. Bhante addresses the fear that arises when we challenge our fundamental assumptions about selfhood, explaining how becoming comfortable with 'don't know' mind is essential for liberation. This foundational teaching connects to the broader framework of paṭicca samuppāda (dependent origination), offering practitioners insight into the psychological mechanisms that perpetuate dukkha and the path to freedom.

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā Sambuddhassa
 Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā Sambuddhassa
 Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā Sambuddhassa

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-enlightened one.

The word I'd like to tackle this evening is *hetu*. It means root—the roots of our suffering. This is really what you would call these days our depth psychology. And it splits into three roots, which won't come as a surprise to you: greed, hatred and delusion.

The word for greed is *lobha*. Most of you would know perhaps the word *taṇhā*, which means desire, but *lobha* is that attitude translated as greed—though I think it's much better understood as acquisitiveness. The second is *dosa*, meaning aversion, not wanting. And the third, *moha*, is delusion.

Now we've come across the word *avijjā*, which is translated as ignorance, but actually it's far better translated in a very neutral sense as simply not knowing. From that not knowing we make a mistake, and that mistake we call our delusion.

The mistake, of course, is to believe ourselves to be phenomenal psychophysical organisms, human beings—which is understandable. Our consciousness moves into the cellular life of the fetus, and when it's born, what does it know apart from what it's experiencing? You can't expect anything else except for that consciousness to say, this is what I am. Not saying it intellectually, but through a direct relationship with what it experiences as being me. And this is what we call the self.

The self isn't a thing, not an object—it's a relationship. It's the relationship we have to what we experience: this is me or mine. So there's your basic position in the world, which we call delusive, a delusion, *moha*. This is me and these things are mine. Identity and possessions.

Once you've established that relationship with the world, you can see there's a whole load of things which aren't me, aren't mine. And that's where the barrier comes. Underlying the sense of self—and this is really quite an important understanding—is that the self actually in itself, or we in ourselves, never truly believe in the self. The way this expresses itself is through a constant anxiety about being in control of our lives, our things and so on.

If the self were actually rock hard, immutable and eternal, then obviously that anxiety wouldn't happen. It's just that somewhere inside us we know this relationship doesn't quite fit, isn't quite right. And so we're constantly trying to acquire the future. That's what *lobha* means in its deepest sense—we're trying to control the future.

To do that, you've got to get rid of anything that upsets your presumed future. Our attitude to life is always this trying to make sure things are going to go the way I want them to. And if anything gets in the way, I want to get rid of it. Simple

as that. In the moment, it comes down to holding on to what we have and defending it from the enemy. And the enemy is simply all those who want what we have. Very simple.

Once we recognise that mechanism, and we know it's coming from this deeper delusion—this deeper mistake we've made of presuming that this is what we are—then our challenge is to be aware of it. That's what the *vipassanā* is about. It leads us to awareness of every time the mind is holding on to something or pushing something away. And what we find is that just to be aware of it allows us a small space of freedom. The freedom is not to act according to those impulses. That's where the liberation is.

But these roots—they're roots, deep within our psychology—are so deeply rooted that we're not aware of how afraid we are of letting go. So afraid of just living in the moment and making decisions in the moment, with the faith that things evolve. And if things happen that we don't want to happen, then that's also part of our evolution. We can't stop things happening which are against us, because we live in a world that we can't control.

Even a simple thing like opening the gate. I was out there the other day, and for some reason it wouldn't open. I found myself getting irritated with it. The gate should open when I want it to open, in the way I want it to open—and it simply refused. Even the slightest things: you'll catch the irritation, you'll catch the grabbing, you'll catch the desire.

The more we don't act on those impulses, the more we're challenging that deep delusion about who we are. And the more we do that, the more we come across this anxiety, this deep-seated fear. It's not a place we like to be—not a place we like to be at all. We don't like to be in a state of don't know. So it's about getting used to that. Getting used to the fear that surrounds it, the anxiety that surrounds it.

Once we're used to those feelings—how it actually feels to be like that—we've already distanced from them. And what we realise is that a great prevention, keeping us from digging deep, has been the fear of that fear, the fear of that anxiety. We just bounce off it, pull away quick. But by making fear itself an object, by getting used to the feelings of fear and anxiety, this fear of it disappears—or begins to disappear, or at least diminishes.

And of course, once we lose the fear of fear, what is there to frighten us? This is the Buddha's deep psychology, really. From here, the teaching moves into how all this manifests through daily life—through the dependent wheel of origination.

I can only hope my words have been of some assistance. May you be liberated in this very lifetime—sooner rather than later.

The Dog Duty Ascetic Discourse — Kukkuravatika Sutta (MN 57)

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 1h21

Originally given as *The Dog Duty Ascetic Discourse — Kukkuravatika Sutta (MN 57)* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this thought-provoking discourse, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the Kukkuravatika Sutta (MN 57), where the Buddha encounters two unusual ascetics: one who imitates ox behavior and another who lives like a dog. Through their earnest questions about rebirth destinations, the Buddha reveals profound teachings about kamma and its results.

The talk explores the Buddha's classification of four types of actions: dark actions with dark results, bright actions with bright results, mixed actions with mixed results, and the transcendent actions of the fully liberated that lead to the destruction of kamma itself. Bhante explains how wrong views about spiritual practice can lead to unfortunate rebirths, while right understanding opens the path to Awakening.

Despite the discourse's seemingly grim beginning, it concludes with hope as both ascetics abandon their misguided practices. One even ordains as a bhikkhu and attains arahantship, demonstrating that even those following wrong paths can find liberation through the Buddha's teaching. The session includes guided meditation on the body's impermanence and loving-kindness practice, emphasizing the human realm's unique opportunity for spiritual development.

Good evening. I trust you had a fruitful day. I don't say happy, though I hope it has been.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble, and fully self-awakened one.

I've chosen, from our present-day point of view, a rather strange discourse. It's entitled the Dog Duty Ascetic. Ascetics are well known in most religions. As you know, the Buddha himself underwent certain ascetic practices, especially the pro-

cess of drawing the body down through eating less and less—more of a Jain practice. In the early Christian ages there were ascetics who lived on top of pillars. They would come down every so often, but they stayed there for quite some time, lowering their chamber pots, I think. And in the medieval ages, the anchorites—men and women who locked themselves into a room in a cathedral. Most famous, of course, was Julian of Norwich, who's worth reading.

There was this very strong element in all religious traditions of a fierce asceticism. But there's nothing quite like this in the West, because this is on the basis of rebirth, of reincarnation.

Here we have the Blessed One living in Koliya country. Two people have come to see him: Puṇṇa, one of the Koliyas, who was an ox duty ascetic, and Seniya, a naked dog duty ascetic. Puṇṇa paid homage to the Blessed One and sat to one side, and they exchanged greetings. After the courteous and amiable talk was finished, Puṇṇa addressed the Blessed One.

"Venerable sir, this Seniya is a naked dog duty ascetic who does what is hard to do. He eats his food when it's thrown on the ground. He has long taken up and practised dog duty." You can imagine him there, sitting like a dog. "What will be his destination? What will be his future course?"

"Enough, Puṇṇa, let that be. Do not ask me that."

A second time and a third time, the ox duty ascetic asked the Blessed One, "Venerable sir, this Seniya is a naked dog duty ascetic. What will be his destination? What will be his future course?"

"Well, Puṇṇa, since I certainly cannot persuade you when I say, 'Enough, Puṇṇa, let that be. Do not ask me,' I shall therefore answer you. Here, Puṇṇa, someone develops the dog duty fully and uninterruptedly. He develops the dog duty habit fully and uninterruptedly. He develops the dog duty mind fully and uninterruptedly. And he develops dog behaviour fully and uninterruptedly. Having done so, on the dissolution of the body after death, he will reappear in the company of dogs. But if he has such a view as this—'By this virtue or observance or asceticism or holy life, I shall become a great god or lesser god'—that is wrong view in this case. Now, there are two destinations for one with wrong view, I say: hell or the animal realm. So, Puṇṇa, if his dog duty succeeds, it will lead him to the company of dogs. And if it fails, it will lead him to hell."

When this was said, Seniya, the naked dog ascetic, cried out and burst into tears. Well, you would.

Then Seniya said, "Venerable sir, I'm not crying because the Blessed One has said this about me, but because I have long taken up and practised this dog duty asceticism." In other words, he's very quickly recognised that it's been a waste of time. Worse than that—it's been worse than a waste of time. He's now developed the dog duty mind. He's developed a mind like a dog.

Then, of course, he says, "Look, my friend Puṇṇa, son of the Koliyas, is an ox duty ascetic. He's long taken up and practised the ox duty. What's his destination? What will his future course be?"

"Do not ask me that."

A first and second time, "Venerable Sir, this Puṇṇa, son of the Koliyas, is an ox duty ascetic. He's taken up this practice a long time. What will be his destination?"

"Seniya, since I certainly cannot persuade you when I say, 'Enough, Seniya, let that be. Do not ask me that,' I shall therefore answer you. Seniya, someone who develops the ox duty fully and uninterruptedly, the ox duty habit fully and uninterruptedly, the ox duty mind, and the ox behaviour fully and uninterruptedly—having done so, on the dissolution of the body after death, he reappears in the company of oxen. But if he has such a view that by this observance or asceticism or holy life I shall become a great god or some lesser god, this is wrong view. Now there are two destinations for one with wrong view, I say: hell and the animal realm. So, Seniya, if this ox duty succeeds, it will lead him to the company of oxen, and if it fails, it will lead him to hell."

When this was said, Puṇṇa, son of the Koliyas, the ox duty ascetic, cried out and burst into tears. Well, he would, wouldn't he?

"Venerable sir," says Puṇṇa, "I'm not crying because the Blessed One has said this about me, but because I have long taken up and practised the ox duty." Again, this ox duty ascetic realises his big mistake.

And he says, "I have confidence in the Blessed One thus: the Blessed One is capable of teaching me the Dhamma in such a way that I can abandon this ox duty, and that this Seniya, the naked dog ascetic, can abandon his dog duty."

Then he says, "Well, listen to what I have to say. There are four kinds of actions proclaimed by me after realising them for myself with direct knowledge, direct experience. There is dark action with dark result. There is bright action with

bright result. There is dark and bright action with dark and bright result. And there is action that is neither dark nor bright, with neither dark nor bright result, action that leads to the destruction of action."

Well, you've got to get into the language. Basically, this dark action is of course immoral behaviour, unethical behaviour. So unethical behaviour leads to unethical results and ethical moral behaviour leads to lovely results. And of course most people have a mixture of both, a little bit on the dark side and a little bit on the bright side. But there's also a level where there's none of that, and that belongs to the one who is fully liberated.

So that sort of action in the Abhidhamma, this later work, was called *kriya*, functional. So most people's actions are either *kusala* or *akusala*, skilful or unskilful, wholesome or unwholesome. But when you become liberated, because there's no self-generation, no selfing going on, no attachment going on, the actions are simply pure. And of course, the defilements are gone too. So it's always a wholesome action, but there's no consequence for that person in terms of rebirthing, because there's no identity with it. It's just pure action.

So then, of course, he says those with dark action will have afflictive bodily formations, afflictive verbal formations and afflictive mental formations. So those people who are acting immorally or unethically will have afflictive, painful mental, verbal and bodily actions. And they will reappear in such a world that is afflicted, that's painful. And that's because of this constant rebirthing. So that's what he says. "This, I say, beings are heirs to their actions." You're an heir to your actions. So whatever a previous self did yesterday, this self now has to deal with it.

And so he says the same, of course, with those things that are bright and those things that are dark and bright. There's a mixture there of afflictive and unafflictive contacts. And so unafflictive and afflictive feelings, mixed with pain and pleasure, as in the case of human beings and some gods and some beings in the lower worlds.

So the ones who are bright action would end up in the heavenly realm where basically you're happy all the time. And if, of course, you've done some really bad stuff, you end up in the animal or worse, the hell realm. But the human beings, it's a bit of mixture of both. And, of course, that's the blessing of this particular existence because with our bright intelligence, this intuitive awareness, we can find our way out of the problem. This is not open to people in hell. They're suffering too much. Animals, of course, don't have the intelligence and people in the heavens are enjoying life too much. And of course remember that these realms are

mirrored in the human life, aren't they? There are people who are basically so caught up in their desires that they're enjoying themselves because they've got billions of pounds or whatever and then they don't think about the spiritual life.

And there are people caught up in an animal existence of drugs and the like, where intelligence is dulled. And there are people in great suffering, whether mental or physical, where it's difficult to practise spiritually — they're lost in it. So all these realms are really just mirrors of what we see in human life.

And then finally, of course, there's the neither-dark-nor-bright action — that's the one with no consequence. The volition to abandon the kind of action that is bright brings bright results, and the volition to abandon the kind that is dark brings dark results, and likewise with dark-and-bright results. But the Arahant, the one who's liberated, is lifted above that duality. "These four kinds of actions I've realised for myself," the Buddha says.

So now Puṇṇa — he's the ox ascetic, isn't he? Yes, the ox. He's really taken to this teaching. He says, "Magnificent, Venerable Sir, magnificent," and becomes a lay follower from that time onwards.

The dog-duty ascetic also says the same thing, using that lovely phrasing that comes up throughout the discourses: "turning upright what has been overthrown, revealing what was hidden, showing the way to one who was lost, holding up a lamp in the dark for those with eyesight to see form." He too goes to the Blessed One, but he actually wants to become a bhikkhu. Now, when somebody who's been involved in another tradition wants to ordain, they have to be on probation for four months — that's a rule in the order. So the Buddha put him on probation for four months and then ordained him.

The last little paragraph tells us what happens to Seniya, the naked dog-duty ascetic. He received full ordination from the Blessed One, and not long after, dwelling alone, withdrawn, diligent, ardent and resolute, the Venerable Seniya, by realising for himself with direct knowledge, here and now entered upon and abided in that supreme goal of the holy life for the sake of which clansmen rightly go forth from home life into homelessness.

And then comes this lovely phrase — you'll find it repeated often throughout the discourses. He directly knew: "Birth is destroyed. The holy life has been lived. What had to be done has been done. There is no more coming to any state of being." And the Venerable Seniya became one of the Arahants.

So although we started off in a gloomy place, with somebody behaving like an ox and another behaving like a dog, it seems they finally ended up in a very good place indeed. Seniya became an Arahant, fully liberated. We don't have to choose that particular path, of course. We don't have to do the dog-duty part to become fully liberated. We've got a slightly easier path, you might say — just being ordinary people.

So there we are. I hope this discourse on the dog-duty ascetic has been of interest. I can only hope that, like Seniya, you will be ardent with your practice, and I trust you'll be fully liberated from all suffering sooner rather than later.

So we can do a little practice. *Puraṃ pūjemi Buddhaṃ pūjemi Dhammaṃ pūjemi Saṅghaṃ pūjemi.*

Buddhaṃ saraṇaṃ gacchāmi. Dhammaṃ saraṇaṃ gacchāmi. Saṅghaṃ saraṇaṃ gacchāmi. Dutiyampi Buddhaṃ saraṇaṃ gacchāmi. Dutiyampi Dhammaṃ saraṇaṃ gacchāmi. Dutiyampi Saṅghaṃ saraṇaṃ gacchāmi. Tatiyampi Buddhaṃ saraṇaṃ gacchāmi. Tatiyampi Dhammaṃ saraṇaṃ gacchāmi. Tatiyampi Saṅghaṃ saraṇaṃ gacchāmi.

Pāṇātipātā veramaṇī sikkhāpadaṃ samādiyāmi. Adinnādānā veramaṇī sikkhāpadaṃ samādiyāmi. Kāmesumicchācārā veramaṇī sikkhāpadaṃ samādiyāmi. Musāvādā veramaṇī sikkhāpadaṃ samādiyāmi. Surāmerayamaj-japamādaṭṭhānā veramaṇī sikkhāpadaṃ samādiyāmi.

Make sure your posture is the expression of the awakened one. As usual, lift up from the lower spine, the lower back, the abdomen. Sit tall. Spend a moment relaxing the brow. Jaw lifts together, teeth apart. Relax the shoulders. Hands on the lap, whatever's comfortable.

This body is subject to disease. It is of a nature to fall ill. It has not gone beyond sickness. This body is subject to ageing. It has not gone beyond ageing. It is now in a process of ageing. This body is subject to death. It has not gone beyond death. This body will die.

There is the unborn, undying, uncreated, uncompounded. The unconditioned. True refuge, harbour and home. Perfect peace and contentment. Those who are mindful are in the presence of *Nibbāna*.

Waiting for that settlement upon the breath, then opening up to whatever draws our attention within the field of awareness. Just observing. Just feeling. Just experiencing intimately. It's enough.

A moment's reflection. Resolution.

We can begin our evening contemplations. Make sure you're sitting comfortably, speaking gently into your own heart.

May I be free of physical pain. May I be free of mental distress. May I be liberated of all my sufferings.

Bringing to mind someone we know is having a hard time. May you be free of physical pain. May you be free of mental distress. May you be liberated of all your sufferings.

And there are all those at this moment who are sick, suffering from mental illness. People in the process of dying, and those who have died and left grieving family, relatives and friends. People going hungry, homeless and destitute. Those having to deal with severe personal and interpersonal difficulties. All those caught up in wars and repressive regimes, and those being tortured. Those suffering from natural disasters and climate crisis. All the sentient beings being cruelly treated and unnecessarily slaughtered. And all who find life meaningless.

May you be free of physical pain. May you be free of mental distress. May you be liberated of all your sufferings.

Radiating our compassion to all beings in all directions. May all beings be free of physical pain. May all beings be free of mental distress. May all beings be liberated of all their sufferings.

Bringing to mind now some moments of joyfulness we've experienced today. Happiness. Peacefulness.

May I be joyful. May my joyfulness increase. May I experience the bliss of liberation.

Bringing to mind someone we know who's joyful. May you be joyful. May your joyfulness increase. May you experience the bliss of awakening.

And to all those at this moment who are happy and content with their lives — who are enjoying the warmth of friendships, the delights of art and nature, hobbies and so on; who find their work meaningful; who enjoy the fruitfulness of their spiritual lives and rejoice in the success of others.

May you be joyful. May your joyfulness increase. May you experience the bliss of *Nibbāna*.

Radiating our goodwill and joy to all beings in all directions. May all beings be joyful. May all beings' joyfulness increase. May all beings experience the bliss of *Nibbāna*.

If you're wise and want to reach the state of peace, you should behave like this: be upright, responsible, gentle and humble; easily contented and needing only a few things; not always busy and having the right sort of work. Your senses should be guarded and you should be modest. You should not be exclusively attached to only a few people, and you should not do the slightest thing that a wise person could blame you for. You should always be thinking: may all beings be happy. Whatever living beings there are — be they weak or strong, big or small, large or slender, living nearby or far away, those who have already been born and those who have yet to be born — may all beings be happy.

Without exception, may all beings be happy. You should not tell lies to each other and do not think anyone, anywhere, is of no value. Do not wish harm to anyone, even when you're angry. Just as a mother would protect her only child at the risk of her own life, so you should let the warmth of your heart go out to all beings.

Let your thoughts of love go through the whole world — above and below, without any barrier, with no ill will or hatred — whether you're standing, walking, sitting or lying down. As long as you're awake, you should develop this affectionate mindfulness. This, they say, is the noblest way to live.

And if you do not fall into unskillful ways, and live well, and develop insight, and are no longer attached to all the desires of the senses — then truly you never need to be reborn into this world again.

Please join me in the chanting, or if you wish, offer these blessings. May you be safe, well and happy. May you live contented, in harmony with the world.

*Kāraṇīyam atthakusalena yaṃ taṃ santaṃ padaṃ abhisamecca
Sakko ujū ca suhujū ca sūvaco cassa mudu anatiṃānī
Santuṭṭho ca subharo ca appakicco ca sallahukavutti
Santindriyo ca nipako ca appagabbho kulesu ananugiddho
Na ca khuddaṃ samācare kiñci yena viññū pare upavadeyyuṃ
Sukhino vā khemino hontu sabbe sattā bhavantu sukhittā
Ye keci pāṇabhūtatthi tasā vā thāvarā vā anāvasesā
Dīghā vā ye mahantā vā majjhimā rassakāṇukathulā
Diṭṭhā vā ye ca adiṭṭhā ye ca dūre vasanti avidūre*

*Bhūtā vā sambhavesī vā sabbe sattā bhavantu sukhittā
Na paro paraṃ nikubbetha nātimaññetha katthaci naṃ kañci
Byārosanā paṭighāṇasaññā nāññamaññassa dukkham iccheyya
Mātā yathā niyaṃ puttā āyusā ekaputtam anurakkhe
Evampi sabbabhūtesu mānasambhāvaye aparimāṇaṃ
Mettañca sabbalokasmi mānasambhāvaye aparimāṇaṃ
Uddhaṃ adho ca tiriyañca asambādhaṃ averaṃ asapattaṃ
Tiṭṭhañcamaṃ nisinno vā sayāno vā yāvat'assa vigata middho
Etaṃ satīṃ adhiṭṭheyya brahmam etaṃ vihāram idham āhu
Diṭṭhiñca anupagamma sīlavā dassanena sampanno
Kāmesu vineyya gedhaṃ na hi jātu gabbhaseyyaṃ punar etīti*

May all beings be happy.

Very good. I hope you were somewhat amused by the dog ascetic practice — and also by the Buddha's presumed sense of humour. He comes across sometimes with a wry wit. He likes to have a little dig at people too.

Don't forget: from now until we fall asleep, it's also about practice — putting something beautiful into the heart, drifting away into sweet oblivion, and rising in the morning to make the best of the day. May you sleep peacefully.

Importance of Resolution

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 45 min

Originally given as *Importance of Resolution* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



Bhante Bodhidhamma explores the Buddhist understanding of human psychology through the five aggregates (pañca-khandha) and the crucial role of resolution (adhiṭṭhāna) in spiritual development. Drawing from the Buddha's teaching on dependent origination (paṭicca samuppāda), he examines how consciousness operates through momentary cognitions, and how our identification with the process creates suffering through grasping (upādāna). The talk addresses the difference between wholesome intention (chanda) and unwholesome craving (taṇhā), emphasizing that suffering arises not from desire itself but from the sense of 'I want.' Bhante discusses three types of happiness and explains how ethical conduct makes the self happier, paradoxically preparing it for eventual transcendence. He touches on the transcendent dimension of consciousness that the Buddha described as 'boundaryless' and 'not touched by the senses,' pointing toward Nibbāna as already present rather than something to be manufactured. The teaching concludes with practical guidance on making and maintaining spiritual resolutions, emphasizing that mental formations (saṅkhāra) are simply habits that can be transformed through mindful awareness and non-identification.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa.

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble, and fully self-enlightened one.

This is an opportunity to revise our understanding of the Buddhadhamma—according to a certain Bhikkhu Bodhidhamma. I'm trying to put it in the context of New Year, a time for resolutions and such: an opportunity to look back and reflect upon our lives.

It's good to remind ourselves of the basic psychology the Buddha teaches. We can start by seeing that he gives us both a cross-section of every moment and an account of what happens over time, what unfolds in process.

That cross-section he called the five aggregates, and the one that's particularly interesting for our purposes is cognition, the fifth aggregate. As you all know, cognition is momentary. If we could really see what was happening right now, we would experience a stroboscopic universe—arising and passing away at tremendous speed. These are like little photographs caught by consciousness, each one an act of cognition. It's only because this is happening at such enormous speed that it gives us a sense of flow, a sense of continuity.

From the point of view of delusion, it's easy to identify with that process. I am the one. I am that process of knowing, because I always seem to be there. Whenever I'm knowing something, it's always me. Even if I lose myself in an absorption, I still come out and say, 'Oh, that was me.' So there's this problem of identity, which we'll come to when we look at the flow of our psychology.

What this moment of cognition catches are the four other aggregates in a singular instant. There's always the body, *rūpa*. I translate it as 'the body,' but at a subtle level, it's not the body itself. What we actually know of the body, what we can experience of it, is quite minimal. What do you know about your big toenail? Very little. You can feel it, you can see the colour of it. But you've never been it, have you? Have you ever been a toenail? It's not something you can absorb into. It's just there. And of course, we're quite happy to cut it off when it gets too long. We don't think we're losing a bit of me. At least I don't. I don't go through a burial ceremony whenever I cut my toenail off. Or any nail, when I think about it.

When you investigate what this body actually is, it's quite surprising how little we're aware of at any given time. Whether it's an organ such as the liver, or the blood flow, or the passage of red corpuscles out of the marrow of the bone, through the bone, into the bloodstream—I haven't a clue what's going on. In fact, I would have been quite happy in ignorance. It's just reading these silly books that has opened up this realisation: I haven't a clue, generally speaking, what's happening in my body. I know when it goes wrong, of course. When it's okay, it feels all right—there's a general feeling of wellness. When it goes off, I get very worried.

When the Buddha talks about the body, he's talking about the way we relate to it. And we can see that there are three delusive ways of relating. One is through a sense of disgust—not being happy with the way the body smells and does things.

The Buddha gives us exercises for looking at the disgusting nature of the body, but that's not to make us more disgusted. It's to help us overcome disgust, to see the body as it really is. It's an animal, for heaven's sake. There's no difference between us and those sheep you see out in the field. They've got everything we've got—just different shapes.

Going beyond disgust is really about the way we see ourselves, the way we perceive the world. If something is smelly, for instance, we think it's bad. But it's not. It's just smelly. That's all right. Then there's this business of the way we look, which is of course a social construct—whether you're beautiful or not. That can cause us all sorts of misery. It causes people terrible misery. Pimples on the end of your nose can be the cause of deep depression.

It's a case of recognising that the body is just a body. It doesn't have to be beautiful to perform its tasks; it's just an organism. The other thing we discover when we investigate our relationship with the body is that we've invested a tremendous amount of our happiness in it. If we start going blind or deaf, for instance, it's a horror story for us. We might know from people who are disabled that eventually it makes no difference to our quality of life—if we approach the situation with acceptance. But that doesn't undermine the fact that getting there is very painful.

Even this—I've got this pain in my tooth, right at the back of my mouth; nobody would ever know about it. But I'm very worried. I might have to have it taken out, and then I've only got one gnasher on the top. Well, that's terrible, isn't it? If I lose that, I've had it—I'm going to have to wear one of those plastic things in my mouth. Terrible.

The Buddha is saying all that about the body, but in a sense that's the more obvious part of our relationship to it. When we really investigate what we know—what are the building blocks upon which we know the body—and you actually go into your meditation, the obvious example I normally talk about is pain. Because when you go into pain, there's no pain there at all. What you've got is tightness or pressure, burning, prickling, all sorts of sensations, but there's no pain as such. Then you realise that actually all we can know of the body is sensation—the sensations coming from the body. From that we build up concepts, emotional concepts too, like pain. Pain is not just a simple medical description; it's something you feel.

When we go into that first heap, that first aggregate of the body, the Buddha is actually pointing to the place where the mind touches the body. The mind is against the body. What it can actually cognise—we have to begin to see—is only these momentary sensations. And they're momentary because that's the way cognition behaves. It just catches every moment like that. Like the old film reels.

From that, we create our *saññā*, our perception. These perceptions are memories—that's what perception is. At first they're very simple: red, blue, box, and all that. But they eventually build up into concepts, ways in which we start looking at the world through the history we've had with it.

These *saññā*, you can see them as basic perceptions lying at the back of the slow growth of concepts. But as you get a concept, it becomes a *saññā*, because that's the way you perceive the world—through a particular concept. In our meditation, we're trying to go beyond that by getting back down to the initial sensations we have in the body, grounding ourselves in the body.

Feelings, sensations—they're not made up by the mind; they're a direct experience. When you're walking around the meadow and you can feel your boots sinking into the mud, it's a case of actually feeling what the sensation is of sinking into mud. That's not made up. That's not some conceptual idea. That's a direct experience of sinking in the mud. And while I remember—there's all those moles out there. I'm walking around thinking I shall sink my boot into a molehill. Stop Morris reappearing. We've got a rationale, haven't we?

So those are sensations, *saññā*, perceptions. On top of that we have a whole second layer of experience that we call feelings, *vedanā*. This is what we feel in the body. These *vedanā* are made up of basic sensations, but they're being described as either pleasant, unpleasant, or neutral. As soon as we do that, in any given moment, we're living in a dualistic world in terms of feeling. It's either pleasant, unpleasant, or some shade in between. Even neutral sensations, when you really investigate them, will have a shade of being pleasant or unpleasant. That's the mind. That's a given, you might say—the *vedanā*.

Then we have these *saṅkhāras*. The Buddha created these five aggregates really to point to a certain process—these *saṅkhāras*. Because that's where our problems lie. The other stuff is just a given. The problems lie within these *saṅkhāras*.

You get lots of models of a human being, from Freudian and so on. But the Buddha's model is really to keep pointing us to where the suffering arises, because that's all he's concerned with, isn't it? Just this problem of suffering, human suffering.

When these five aggregates start moving in time, we see this process much more clearly. The five aggregates are always there, but we see that some things are with us, as it were, all the time as a way of looking at the world—and that's our *saṅkhāras*. These mental habits, which express themselves through our body language, are all generated by an act of will.

This is really where we come to the point where the Buddha is pointing to what actually creates something. It's a very mystical thing. The Buddha doesn't describe will—it's a force, a force which manifests something into the world, and it arises after an intention. That moment when intention becomes a flow of thought, or becomes an action of speech or body, is a split second. Normally we don't even notice it; we just do, we just carry on. But that distinction is crucial. At the point of the arising of an intention—which is only a thought flavoured with desire—nothing has actually happened yet. That's a really crucial understanding, because we might think that every time an intention arises we've already behaved either wholesomely or unwholesomely. But that's not so. It's the arising of that intention.

The intention in this process is called *taṇhā*. That's what he's referring to—that point of intention. If it's something unwholesome, we have this special word, *taṇhā*, for it. But if it's something wholesome, we can use the word *chanda*, which also has both an unwholesome and wholesome sense, but at least here we can talk about desires that are wholesome.

The Buddha also goes through this process. You don't get this written up, of course. But it's not as though he was an automaton. He was aware of what he was doing, and when he got up, when his body signalled that he was hungry, he made the intention to go out on alms round. That wasn't something that happened automatically. He must have seen the intention arise, and he must have thought to himself, right, this is time to get some food. He gets his bowl and his robe, does all the things that any other of his monks would do, and his nuns, and out he goes. But there's something missing. There's something missing from that process which does not cause him any problems. For us, there's something in there which is causing the problems.

Once *taṇhā* has arisen, we have this next thing: *upādāna*, grasping. What happens at that point? It's a point of identity. The wanting becomes *I* want. And at that moment of identity, where the *I* comes in, the sense of me, into an action, into that flow—that is the point of suffering. There's no suffering as long as it stays at *taṇhā*.

We can know this in our practice, when we're aware of some desire coming up which we're not going to fulfil—say, when we're eating. Hunger is there, which isn't a pleasant feeling in itself. It's pleasant in the sense that if a thirsty person sees a water tap somewhere, that thirst doesn't become so painful as it was if there was no water around, if you were stuck at sea or something. But it's still not a pleasant sensation as such. Hunger is not a pleasant sensation.

When we sit at the table and we're in contact with that hunger, and we're not reacting, not identifying with it, it's just a sensation. We can describe it as unpleasant, but there's no suffering. There is no suffering. Now, if we were to carry on this fast for sixty-odd days, it would get very, very painful, and then the sense of hunger would become something that grasps. We would enter into that suffering as an *I*, as a *me*—and that's the point of suffering. The point of suffering begins with *upādāna*.

And of course, once we're in that suffering, we want to escape from it. The escape is the commitment, the empowerment of that desire. What that creates is an action. The Buddha, in this particular stream of actions, calls that *bhāva*—becoming. Becoming moment after moment, driven by an unwholesome desire, driven by this force—it's the will that the Buddha talks about, *cetanā*. These are all included in that one moment.

We've got the becoming, meaning the *I* becomes, reinvents itself: *I* want, *I* scream, *I* want, *I* scream—it keeps on going, keeps flipping around itself. And every time it does that, it empowers the desire, so there's this force going into it. As it's doing that, it's creating this habit, this *saṅkhāra*; it's whirling around itself. When we begin to see that process, we see that the original problem lies in that identity. That's why the Buddha is always pointing to this quality of self. It's the self, you see—the point of identity—which is the core problem.

This core problem is deep within us because it's buried in a fundamental delusion which runs right underneath all our daily lives. It's just there as a given. *I* am a human being. Terrible delusion. Committing ourselves to the human form, we're obviously committed to finding happiness in the human form.

And that's why a lot of this mindfulness stuff—you see how it veers off towards finding happiness. Not that the mindfulness movement isn't a good thing, but it takes us away from the core problem. Mindfulness and stress relief, mindfulness and eating problems, mindfulness and good business, and all that. It's in big business now. All that mindfulness is really about making the world a more pleasant place. But it's a goose chase, because eventually it will corrupt, eventually it won't satisfy. The person keeps looking for happiness in the world.

The Buddha is actually pointing us to a different sort of happiness, which is what he calls *Nibbāna*. In our meditation, where do we find this? Where do we begin to experience this nirvanic type of happiness? Because it's not as though we invent it. I remember my old teacher always saying: when you get on a train to London, London is not being manufactured as you take the journey there. London's already there, and you arrive. It's the same with *Nibbāna*. We're not manufacturing *Nibbāna*. *Nibbāna*'s already there. It's staring us in the face. But for some reason, we can't see it. We can't get a handle on it.

I always mention this, usually in the evening when I'm doing that Mahāsi course—this verse from the Dhammapada: those who are mindful in the presence of *Nibbāna*. He's actually saying that you're in the vicinity of, in the presence of, *Nibbāna*. There must be something about our meditation, especially the specific Vipassanā practice, which is taking us very close to that level of—for want of a better word—consciousness. It's definitely a place where there's no suffering.

When you're sitting there in your practice and all sorts of things are coming up, and things begin to subside a bit, there's just that one little occasional moment of peace and stillness. There's just this inner I, this thing that keeps looking, and a sense of me looking—the observer, the observer, the observer, the knower. In that particular state, after you've come out of it, or even as you hold it, just ask yourself: what is the inner state? What's the inscape of the observer?

This lovely word *inscape* was coined by Gerard Manley Hopkins—like you get landscape and seascape. Inscape. We know through our meditation the inscape of the body. We know what we feel; we can see our images. That's what the meditation makes us very alive to. But when you're just the knower, when you're just the feeler, what's the inscape of the knower? What's the inscape of the feeler?

There's something about that which is pointing to a level of consciousness—you've got to be careful with these words—a level of knowing which is somehow radically different from everything else we experience. It's different in the sense

that inwardly, in that inner space, nothing's arising. Nothing's arising. And if nothing's arising, nothing's passing away. So already, when we begin to experience that, we're actually touching upon something which is transcendent.

I only bring this up because a lot of the material you get these days from certain teachers in Dharma circles places the accent on the immanent—on what's actually present—and moves away from the transcendent. To quote the words of Jesus Christ: to be in the world but not of it. If all you're interested in is immanence, the present moment, it stops you having a vision of where you're going. One can argue, well, you're on the path and the future will arise, and so on. But to take away the transcendent is to bring the immanent back into this world as it is. And because we know the world is transient, it's very difficult to see what is immanent as not being transient.

That's just an aside. Our practice is both to see that there is only this present moment, and to recognise that this present moment belongs only to the world of apparition. To the world of the transcendent there are no moments. Moments don't belong there. They're something manufactured, something whereby we measure what is happening. Time is completely constructed. It's not that you don't need these things in the world, but there's something else—and I'm just leaving that as a possibility, that's all.

Remember, we're not into belief as such, but we are definitely into an openness—the possibility that there is something in us which is completely transcendent of the phenomenal world. It just isn't part of it at all. The phenomenal world is within its scope, but it's not part of it.

The basic quotations that support this would be things like—the Buddha uses a word there which means exists, not like 'this is a book'—there exists that which is not born, doesn't die, is not conditioned, not created. You can't get more obvious than that.

He also talks about an *āyatana*—a sphere—and specifically the sixth *āyatana*. This is another way in which he made us look at human experience by way of consciousness. These acts of cognition are limited by their sense base. The eye cannot hear, and the ear can't smell, and so on. All those cognitions based on a sense base constitute an actual way of experiencing the universe. Each is a sphere, separate from the other spheres. The mind is very clever in getting all these things to happen altogether. You can be watching a film and hearing what's being said and chewing your popcorn, and it all seems one fantastic moment. But

in terms of Buddhist psychology, these are all really stroboscopic, minute little acts of cognition coming onto a screen, happening so fast that it gives us the impression of it all happening together and all in a flow.

Another phrase comes when he's questioned. Somebody asks him: where is it that the four *mahābhūtas* come to an end, are destroyed? The *mahābhūtas*, of course, are your four great elements—how the mind experiences the body, in other words, this world. Where does this world come to an end? That's another way of saying it. And the Buddha says the question is wrongly put. It's not where are these four *mahābhūtas* destroyed—it's where do they not find a footing? Where do you not find these four *mahābhūtas*? Nothing, remember, is destroyed in the process of liberation. The Buddha is clear about that too. He says the only thing that's destroyed, annihilated, are greed, hatred, and delusion.

So where is it? He says there is a consciousness which is not touched by any of the senses, not coloured—the word can be translated as not coloured—by any of the senses, and this includes all the inner senses of emotions and thoughts and all that. And it is boundaryless. There's no boundary to it. What does that tell us? It tells us there are no phenomena there. The only reason we're in this room is because it's bounded by these walls. If there were no walls you'd have an infinite room. So this consciousness doesn't have a boundary, doesn't have limitations, and in all directions is full of light. And just this, he says, is the end of suffering.

So now this brings us to our new year, which is to do with making intentions. Every year we have this opportunity of reflecting upon the life we've just been living and how we would like to progress. This moment of resolution—*adhiṭṭhāna*, one of the great perfections, one of those things that take us to the other shore—is itself a practice.

A resolution or a vow or a specific undertaking of this nature—whether it's even on a social level like a marriage vow—we tend to think that once you've made it, that's it, it's done for life, you don't have to do it again. But the whole point about resolutions is that they die out, and they die out very quickly. The resolution not to snack between meals, for instance, lasts probably half a day. You've got to make a special effort.

What a resolution is, is a point in time when you are directing yourself in life—like you're turning the ship to the north. But then it has to be reinforced, constantly reinforced. Not just every day—every time it comes to mind. You have to remind yourself that you've made this commitment. Abandon all biscuits. You've made that commitment. So when you walk into a supermarket, you steer yourself

away from the biscuits. And of course, the more this resolution takes on strength, the more it gathers energy, the less the old temptations can hijack you. It's only when the resolution drops for a moment that the old habits begin to take over.

A resolution is a point in time where we decide to behave in a certain manner. It might be resolving the same thing; it doesn't really matter. The point is, the power of resolution, the power of determination, is right there within the psychology, right there within the grasping, the *upādāna*. But here, this grasping which normally is seen as something deluded because it's coming from the I—when it's not coming from that sense of delusion, then at least the sense of self is working towards *Nibbāna*.

The Buddha talks about inclining to *Nibbāna*. When we talk about no-self, the point where all identity with this psychophysical organism has stopped—that's the point of liberation. But until that point, we have to keep, shall we say, amending the self. How do you incline towards *Nibbāna*? You incline towards *Nibbāna* by sorting out your ethics.

Eventually, what we find is that the path is the path of relationships. It's how we relate to the world, to things, to objects—how we close the fridge door. That matters. And then how we relate to individuals, to people, to the earth, to ecology. It's all to do with our relationships and what motivates us in those relationships. That's where resolutions are normally based.

When we realise that this inclining towards *Nibbāna* is about ethics, what we're actually doing is making this sense of self more and more happy. We're not trying to get rid of the self. If you try to get rid of the self, you're in conflict immediately. What you're trying to do is make yourself a happier self. And a happier self comes about through our ethical relationships. Then when we're really, really happy, all the stuff that makes us unhappy doesn't disturb our meditations. The hindrances begin to slough away because we're not feeding them. The more we create a happy self, the closer we are to getting rid of it. See?

There's one lovely example that you might have heard me mention before. In the Mahāsi centre in Rangoon, so the story goes, a woman arrived and told the teacher that her life was utterly and profoundly miserable—she wanted to meditate and get out of this suffering. As he asked her to explain, he agreed that her life was absolutely awfully miserable. But he didn't say, now you've got to do Vipassanā. If she'd done Vipassanā, she'd probably have committed suicide, because she'd have had to go into this misery at that raw, raw meat level.

Instead, he gets her to do mettā practice. And through the practice of mettā, she actually begins to experience these beautiful ecstatic states and realises that happiness is possible. *Nibbāna* is something beyond that, but happiness is possible. With that basis of confidence she begins to practise Vipassanā, and in no length of time, as the scriptures say, she was able to make a breakthrough. See?

The study of happiness is now a big thing in psychology—positive psychology, for heaven's sake. I think we can split it into three types. First, there are those happinesses that are pretty immediate and pass away quickly: ordinary sensual pleasures, meeting a friend in the street and going for a quick coffee, all those little fleeting moments where we experience little bursts of happiness.

Then there are those happinesses where we absorb into something that really interests us. It might be a DVD, it might be some hobby, gardening—something where in that absorption we lose a sense of self and we lose a sense of time. That's always a good sign. Then you come out of it and say to yourself, that was really lovely, a great time. But of course, as soon as you come out of it, you've lost it. The whole point of that sort of happiness is the absorption and the loss of self. That's why people do these dangerous sports, because at that point they've got to concentrate so much into the moment that there's no time for that reflection of me flying through the air with the greatest of ease. And as I understand it, that's what Aristotle talked about with his Eudaimonia.

But the deeper happiness that gives life its propulsion, you might say, is a sense of meaning. This has also been investigated by positive psychologists: it's only when your life has an aim beyond itself that suddenly there is a very deep fundamental meaningfulness, which is the base of happiness. So long as we're working just for our little selves, we might produce these little moments, but there'll always be this underlying meaninglessness to our lives. It's a funny thing, but that's the way it is. As soon as your life is for the purpose of somebody else, for some other great aim, for some other ideal, suddenly it takes on a deeper meaning and there you get your deep satisfaction. That's why people will undergo a lot of suffering for this. Afterwards, they would say it was meaningful; looking back they wouldn't have done anything else.

Think about people who've been imprisoned—Nelson Mandela. But these are the people we know, like Nelson Mandela and Aung San Suu Kyi. There are hundreds of people who undergo torture and all sorts of things for something bigger than themselves, and in that they get this real deep sense of meaningfulness. And with it, there is that happiness.

We see this in the Buddha's own story. At that moment when there's a great doubt, see? He sat under the tree and, as it's put mythically—but it's his own mind, of course—he's saying, well, what's all this? I've been through all these teachers. I've got this far. Nobody's discovered the end of suffering. Who the hell am I to try and discover it anyway? How can I do it? There are all these great teachers and people I've worked with and they've not been able to do it. Who am I?

So you get this sense of the great doubt about me—can I do it? And then he touches the earth goddess, and the earth goddess arrives. He remembers that he's not doing it just for himself, because in his past life he's perfected this idea of generosity. It suddenly comes to his mind that what I'm going through, it's not just for me—it's for my family, my wife, my child, for all these people and all these beautiful people I've met, and all the ugly ones too. That's what gives him, I think, that little extra power to sit under that tree and go through that process, which couldn't have been pleasant, until finally he cracks it.

Now, the downside is that whenever you make a resolution and don't fulfil it, you always get this little voice saying, well, you're useless anyway. You couldn't keep a sausage. So it's a case of recognising that that judgmental self, that self which is always trying to undermine us, has to be seen for what it is. It's just another mental state. As soon as you identify with it, you're stuck in self-hatred. But as soon as you see it as judging, judging, and you separate from it, you distance from it—you see it for what it is and perhaps you feel it. You feel this sense of lack of self-worth, and nobody loves me, and all that. You keep that, you see it, and you wait for it to pass away.

And then you regenerate your self-worth. You regenerate your worthiness and your inner dignity. Dignity, remember, comes from the Latin *dignus*, which means worthy—worthiness.

So it doesn't matter how many times we stumble and fall and crack our heads. What's important is that we get up, dust ourselves off, and start all over again. That's why—I'm sure you've heard me say this—Fred Astaire and Ginger Rogers are my heroes. Because that's exactly what he did every time he slipped on the dance floor. He got up, dusted himself off, and started all over again.

Tomorrow, when we do this contemplation, thinking about our lives, take the opportunity to look back—not simply over the past year, but over a whole life—to see certain trends, certain saṅkhāras, certain habits, certain formulations. And

see the ones that are good. We tend to have a downer on ourselves, dwelling on how horrible we are and the dreadful things that can happen to us. But it's equally important to reinforce the fact that we have lots of goodness in us.

That's why I began to institute this evening chant on joy. I realised that we can get stuck on compassion—all this suffering of people, and love and all that—but we've got to generate joy as well. It's one of the four illimitables. And you generate joy by being joyful, for heaven's sake. If you remember a point of joy in the day, even something very simple, and you recall it and rejoice in it—you say, 'That was wonderful, I really enjoyed that. How fortunate I am, how lucky I am to have had that moment of joy'—that in itself is cranking up the amount of joy in us.

And when we see other people who are happy and joyful, and our joy rises on their behalf—rejoicing in their joy—that also increases our potential for inner joy. So this could even be a real positive resolution, or one of them for the day: that from now on I shall develop joyfulness and abandon all misery.

Remember, all we're working with is habits. All we're working with is these saṅkhāras—they're just habits, for God's sake. When a habit arises that we can see is not doing us any good, we simply don't indulge it. But not indulging it doesn't mean we don't feel it. There's a real distinction to be made here. To feel a depression, to feel an anxiety, to feel an anger, to feel hatred or jealousy—all these things have to be felt, have to be recognised, acknowledged. But you don't have to reinforce them by putting the 'I' in there.

And how do these things reinforce? Through the mind—through this thinking, thinking, thinking. So as soon as you see your thought patterns running in a negative direction, as soon as you catch it—and see this in ordinary daily life, not just here in meditation—and you actually name it for what it is, what's actually driving it, whether misery or hatred or whatever, immediately you've disengaged. You've disengaged. It cannot make things worse when it's disengaged.

And so long as you remain at the feeling level of an emotional state, of a mental state, it's not going anywhere. That's a real insight that has to be understood. A mental state, an emotional state, cannot be released except through consciousness. But when it's released as a feeling, it's actually exhausting itself. As soon as it catches into a thought pattern, it's immediately regenerating itself and generating itself more.

Seeing this in our meditation and in daily life, our practice becomes this constant effort to be awake to what the mind is leading us to. As soon as you see you're caught up in a dream, a fantasy, actually name it for what it is. And then, if there's time and possibility, you stay with it and wait for that feeling to die out.

If there's a strong desire for something and you know it's not wholesome, you stay with it, you stay in the body. You stay in the body as a force. You can feel the energy of it. And every time it releases that energy, it's losing its power. It's losing its power.

I can only hope my words have been of some assistance. May you buy your fierce resolutions. A struggle always towards the end of suffering—sooner rather than later.

Renunciation — The Path of Letting Go

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 15 min

Originally given as *Renunciation — The Path of Letting Go* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this dharma talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines renunciation (nekkhamma) as one of the three Right Intentions in the Noble Eightfold Path. He distinguishes between harmful self-mortification—which the Buddha rejected after his own extreme ascetic practices—and skillful renunciation, which involves restraining the senses and letting go of taṇhā (craving) rather than blaming the body itself.

The talk explores how renunciation addresses the fundamental delusion of selfhood that drives our constant seeking for happiness through sensual pleasures, intellectual pursuits, and even spiritual experiences. Bhante explains practical approaches to letting go: recognizing unhealthy patterns, bearing the discomfort of withdrawal, and distinguishing between mere boredom and genuine disinterest—a spiritual quality of non-attachment.

Drawing from the Dhammapada and other teachings, he offers concrete examples for daily practice: simplifying consumption, releasing control in relationships, limiting news intake, and decluttering our busy lives. The talk emphasizes that renunciation isn't deprivation but liberation—freeing energy for genuine service to others while remaining vigilant against the ego's attempts to co-opt even generous actions. This teaching provides both newcomers and experienced practitioners with clear guidance for developing one of the essential factors leading toward Awakening.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā-sambuddhassa — Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble, and fully self-awakened one.

This evening I've chosen the topic of renunciation. It's not a word we particularly love — we don't fall for it. But you won't find a wisdom tradition that doesn't have some level of sensual restraint in its teachings. Consider Lent for Christians, Ramadan for Muslims. The Hindu tradition and the Jains, of course, all have some form of fasting as part of their practice.

In the Buddha Dharma, the Buddha made a clear distinction between self-mortification and renunciation. Self-mortification assumes the body is to blame — that if we lost our tongues, we wouldn't have any greed. The Buddha himself underwent such practices, nearly starving himself to death. He ended up saying that this approach was just adding more suffering to the already inherent discontent of life.

Renunciation, by contrast, is the restraint of the senses, understanding that the problem has nothing to do with the body itself, but with our relationship to it. There is a direct path through renunciation. You'll get monks and nuns who live way out in the jungle, completely renouncing any contact with the sensual life and only going into the village to collect alms.

To understand the importance of renunciation, we have to go back to the roots of the Buddha's teaching — and that always lies in this delusion of a self. What do we mean by that? Whatever you finish this sentence with — "I am..." — that's what you're not. That's what we presume ourselves to be. In fact, the "I" in the "I am" is also part of that delusion.

It's the problem of this "me" always wanting to be happy. That's not so bad in itself — the Buddha actually has a whole chapter in the Dhammapada devoted to being happy, a happy self. But it's what we're seeking for our happiness that's going to cause disappointment and eventually sorrow.

That's easy to overcome when we keep reminding ourselves that everything — absolutely everything — arises and passes away and does not repeat. You can't repeat the party that you had. It just doesn't happen. It's only going to cause suffering trying to do that. When we become dependent on something — the mobile, or a person we become dependent on — then when we lose it, that's where the pain is.

What we have to find out is where this self manifests, and that's the point of desire. Desire is the direct psychological indicator that the self is active. But it's a certain type of desire. There's a special word in Pali for it: *taṇhā*. There are other words for desire, but this specific desire is the one that leads to indulgence — the one that leads us to attachment.

This obviously includes all the physical senses, such as food and sex. But it's the sensual pleasures too — art, nature, human association. All that comes under the name of sensual. Some people only think of sexual, but it's not. It's the total sense organ of the psychophysical organism, which includes the intellect — all the stuff we learn, the history, science, all the stuff we talk about, the politics. And the culture, all the imagination, the fantasy. All that's part of the sensual life. And of course the pleasures and joys we get from work.

In everything we're doing, everything we experience, we always have to be careful that there's this little bit of *taṇhā* when it's making us happy. Even in the practice, when we enter into beautiful states of mind — a bit of peacefulness, a bit of joy, and those concentration exercises that some of you might practise, the absorptions — we become attached to them.

All this would be perfectly lovely except for the clinging. That's why we're practising renunciation — it's a way of letting go of our cravings, no matter how small they are.

The importance of renunciation is found in the Eightfold Noble Path. The first factor, of course, is right understanding, which is exactly what we're trying to do here. The second has to do with right intentions. Sometimes it's translated as right thoughts, but intentions, I think, captures it better — because it's the intentions that create the attitudes that then manifest in speech, in action, and in our livelihoods.

What are these right intentions? The first one is renunciation. The second one is non-ill will. And the third one is harmlessness.

For instance, if you find yourself snacking and grazing throughout the day at a particular time — say TV in the evening — and you recognise it as unhealthy, you make a decision: "Stop it. I'm going to stop it." But then you have to remind yourself, you have to bear the discomfort. Every time the word "toast" comes to mind, or "biscuit," whatever comes to mind, the alarm bell should go off. Then we repeat the reasons to ourselves why we're not going to fall for it. We're going to renounce it and then reaffirm that determination.

Surprisingly, these desires begin to really loosen up after two or three days and they go. We regain our agency. We gain back our control over our appetites. That's what we're heading for, because generally speaking, we're enslaved to these things. As soon as they come up, they come up as demands and they become needs. They're not needs, are they?

But even when we've got through that discomfort and now we feel we've got our agency back, you always have to be careful about that little demon of the self, the demon of desire. It's only lying low. If we're not careful, we'll soon become an obedient servant again. We have to remind ourselves: not until the delusive self has been completely extinguished will such unskillful desires cease.

Here we might make a little distinction between boredom and disinterest. Remember that desires are excited by stimuli and they lose their intensity over time. That's when we get bored with something. Taking food for instance as our little object here — you can't keep eating the same biscuit. You've got to look for something else. We need variety. But given enough time, we go back to our favourite biscuit. That's how boredom works. It gets fed up with something, we seek something else, and then we remember, "Oh, wait a minute, what about my favourite biscuit?" And then you're back to that.

Disinterest is something different. It's a spiritual quality. We lose interest in something. We no longer care about biscuits or what biscuits we have or even if there are any. Yet there's still the enjoyment of biscuit if it comes our way. To quote an ancient Zen master, when asked to explain Buddha Dharma, his reply was: "No preference." No preference. That's where we're aiming. We're aiming to a point where we're not sticking onto anything.

At a mental level, it's views and opinions. It's the same attitude that we apply, renouncing this "I'm right and everybody else is wrong or almost wrong or not as right as I am." There's always a conceit that underlies these positions, doesn't matter what it is — religious, political, cultural and so on. Now, it doesn't mean to say that we have to change our understanding. It may be fine. But being open to others, allowing us to nuance our understanding. And occasionally, we might even change our opinion, especially today with all this polarization.

Then there's being members of the human community, aware of climate crisis, of mindless consumption. We have a duty here to simplify our lifestyle. How many pairs of shoes do we actually need? When you're buying some clothing, do you actually need it? We have to see that the culture is caught up — we are caught up in this selfishness that's been generated by neoliberalism and consumerism.

Then we get the idea of giving something away. In the very act of generosity, we're actually exercising renunciation. Of course, it makes living a little lighter.

When it comes to personal relationships, we possess other people. So it manifests as control. We manipulate. We use anger, threats of abandonment, spiteful action. We hold grudges and nurse them. We offer presents and promises to entice them. Becoming aware of those little behaviors, developing the skills of forgiveness, trust, training ourselves to see the situation from the other person's point of view — all that is the exercise of renunciation.

Then there's the news. Oh my goodness. Trawling through the news every morning, every evening, during the day, always onto it, finding out what's happened next with this constant daily messaging of war, Trumpian shocks, injustice, and so on. It's no wonder that we can build up a sense of hopelessness, disempowerment. Now we can undermine this by method, of course, but sometimes the best policy is just to stop listening, to limit the input.

During my first twelve years as a monastic, I took very little interest in world affairs. For long times, I was quite secluded. It took a while when I got back into ordinary daily life here to find out what was happening. But I never felt I'd lost anything. The Buddha, in the discourse on developing *mettā*, which we read at the end, advises us not to be too busy.

When we do that, we find ourselves more relaxed. We meditate better. We become more aware of the underlying turbulence in our hearts — turbulence that's often fueling all the overactivity. Stepping back allows that to exhaust itself, bringing a greater sense of calmness. It really is wise to constantly remind ourselves that tranquility is a factor of enlightenment. A factor of awakening.

Now, renunciation isn't the fullness of the spiritual life. Such practice brings a sense of ease into our lives, and with it, clean energy. Letting go of the demands of the egoistic self is a relief, not a deprivation. The energy, the freedom we feel — it seeks a different focus. And that focus is the other.

We're social animals. Everybody knows that. We love people. We love animals. We love to help others. Some of our greatest joys come from supporting others in their griefs and in their joys. But you have to remember: this little devil of self may sneak in, and we find ourselves doing good in order to feel happy. That's no good. Danger lurks in the most heartfelt generosity.

Luckily, it's enough just to acknowledge the unskillful motivations and then re-affirm the good intentions. We don't have to be hard on ourselves. A dash of humility is needed here — just acknowledge that the work on ourselves is yet to be done. That's a comfort. The Buddha warns us the path is gradual. Very gradual, in my experience anyway.

So renunciation — well, it's important. We need to reflect on our lives, see where we're sticking onto something, someone, some behaviour, and just allow ourselves to let go for a while. Suffer gladly the pain of releasing the numbed cramp, and enjoy a bit of peace.

I can only hope my words have been of some assistance, that I haven't caused confusion, and that by your practice of renunciation you will be liberated from all suffering — sooner rather than later.

The Dangers of Indulgence

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 20 min

Originally given as *The Dangers of Indulgence* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



Drawing from the Dhammacakkappavattana Sutta (SN 56.11), Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the Buddha's teaching on the middle path that transcends both indulgence in sensual pleasures and self-mortification. Through vivid examples including Greek mythology and personal anecdotes, he explores how indulgence differs from healthy enjoyment and leads to five key forms of suffering: compulsive behavior, frustration, grief, anxiety, and boredom.

The talk emphasizes three crucial distinctions practitioners must understand: differentiating enjoyment from indulgence, recognizing the separation between body and mind in sensory experience, and distinguishing between desire and action. Bhante explains how our consumer culture confuses happiness with excitement, leading to endless seeking for stimulation rather than genuine contentment.

Practical guidance is offered on working with intention - eating to live rather than living to eat - and using renunciation as a tool to contact and transform unwholesome desires. The teaching concludes with the Buddha's comparison of nibbāna's taste to freedom, specifically freedom from compulsive craving that underlies so much of our suffering.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa — Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble, and fully self-awakened one.

Tonight I thought I'd tackle the problem of indulgence. In the Buddha's first discourse — which is really a formalised teaching; I can't imagine this is exactly what he said — he speaks of indulgence in sensual pleasures, which is base, vulgar, worldly, ignoble, and not beneficial. Then he speaks of the practice of self-mortification, which is simply painful, ignoble, and not beneficial. And then he talks about the middle path.

This middle path isn't a little bit of indulgence and a little bit of mortification. It's something that transcends them both. That's the 'middle', as it were — a way of saying there is a path that includes neither indulgence nor self-mortification. Self-mortification means blaming the body for our problems. If your eye sees something that brings up lust, you start blaming the eye. That wouldn't be correct, would it? In those days, the Jains especially thought the body itself was the product of our *kamma*, and you had to let go of the body — so to die, to stop eating, was considered the way to go. I believe elderly people still do that even today. But we're talking about indulgence here, and this is an essay I've written really around eating, though I'll try to spread it out to include everything.

I've always liked the Greek myths. So, how bad can greed get? Erysichthon, the Greek king of Thessaly, had the temerity to build a banqueting hall over the shrine of Demeter, goddess of Earth's fertility and protector of the harvest. She cursed him with insatiable hunger. First he ate everything in his kingdom that could be eaten. Then he started on his people and even ate his own family. Finally, still famished, he ate himself. That's how bad it can get.

When I was staying at Kanduboda in Sri Lanka, an American turned up and told me that once, when he got lost in the wilds, he went through a period of a few days without any food. When he eventually caught a pigeon, he said he just ripped it open and ate it raw. I don't think we ever get close to that sort of hunger usually. Normally, when we feel a bit peckish, we put an end to it as quickly as we can. Those are the extreme conditions.

The first thing is to distinguish when we're enjoying something as opposed to indulging in it. The second is to see the distinction between body and mind, and what the body is actually giving us, which is pure. All that's coming in through the ears, for instance, is vibrations in the air. From there it's taken into the mind, and it's the mind that gives it meaning — so you get a bell, an alarm bell, and so on. And finally, we need to know the distinction between a desire and an action. This is the Buddha making clear what the role of the will is.

The first thing is to really understand the downside of indulgence. The problem is that when we're indulging in something — a food, or we're out in nature and we're loving it and bathing in it — while we're doing that, there's no problem. It's heaven, isn't it? We think it's *Nibbāna*. It's the aftermath that we have to become aware of.

The first thing that arises from indulgence is compulsive behaviour. The psychology here is the same as any addict's. They've got it bad, but for most of us it becomes an obsessive thing that we need. Take a simple example: everybody has a special time for tea or coffee and biscuits, coffee and a piece of cake. When you get to that time, if you just sit in front of it, you'll feel the process of wanting and the compulsive nature of having to have it. You can get quite depressed if you don't get it. That's the other side too. As soon as we have one of these unwholesome habits, there's a certain compulsion around that behaviour.

Here's an example: somebody gives up smoking and thinks they're completely over it. Then at a party they have just that one cigarette. Before they know it, of course, they're buying a packet. I know smoking has a physical dependency to it, but the psychology is the same even for biscuits.

The second problem is the frustration that arises when we don't get what we want. If you've forgotten to buy the tea, that's terrible. Or the coffee — that's even worse sometimes. Amazon, of course, has spent millions getting their products to customers as quickly as possible, knowing that if they can gratify a person's desire more quickly than anyone else, they get their loyalty. And it's worked. We get angry over silly things — the bus doesn't arrive on time, the train's late as usual. That's the frustration of not getting what we want, and it comes from attachment.

The third problem is grief — especially when you lose something treasured: an engagement ring, a wedding ring, some token of friendship, an heirloom. If that's stolen from you, it's devastating. I remember at college, my girlfriend at the time was living in a place with other girls, and the landlord turned out to be some sort of thief. One day they found that all their little treasures had been stolen — all the jewellery they had. It was absolutely awful. When we lose something like a mobile phone, we get more angry than anything, but there's a sense of grief there too.

When it comes to objects, it's good to remind ourselves that the idea of possessing something is a legal fiction. It's something we presume onto the object — that the object is mine. But actually, when you think about it, you can only use objects. You can only use your phone. And when the thief takes it, it's his. It's not mine anymore.

The fourth problem is anxiety. Beneath anything we possess, I'm sure you'll find some level of anxiety about loss. The more we have, the more that anxiety grows. You can see this in people who are very rich. Once they reach a billion, it's hardly enough — they've got to insure that billion by having another billion. It's

the same with other things we have, like friendships. We feel safer when we have lots of friendships, people we can call our friends, family, and so on. It's also to do with power. The more power you have, the safer you feel.

When those things begin to dissipate, when we start to lose them, that's when we touch this underground anxiety. And of course, that anxiety goes right to the basis of the real problem that sits under everything: the idea of a self. The self is telling us to enjoy ourselves, to try and make this life really enjoyable. So when that joy we've become attached to begins to disappear, the anxiety arises. Now, that isn't to say there isn't enjoyment and the joys of life — we'll come to that in a bit.

Finally — and I don't think this is an exhaustive list — there's boredom. If you remember, after the Buddha became fully liberated, Māra, the evil one, sent his three daughters: sensual pleasure, sexual pleasure, and boredom. This boredom is an aversive state. What used to give you happiness doesn't give you that happiness anymore. And if we look at it, it's actually not so much the happiness we're after; it's that little sliver on top, which is the excitement. That's the big delusion of our consumerist societies: confusing happiness with excitement.

Think of a Christmas cake — a British and Irish Christmas cake. You get the solid bit, the fruit cake underneath it all. Then you get this sliver at the top of marzipan and icing. Children will peel that off and just eat that, of course. It gives the cake that little special zing. It's just an ordinary fruitcake unless you have that little bit of marzipan and icing on top. And of course, that's what gives you diabetes, isn't it? The sugar. But we're not worried about that. We'd rather just enjoy it.

It's the same with happiness and excitement. Often when we make the right intention to just enjoy something and not to indulge, there's always that sense that we've lost a little bit of the pleasure we used to have through indulgence. And that's your renunciation. When the Buddha talks about renunciation as the path to liberation, it's getting rid of that excitement.

At a physical level, we know this excitement is drenching the brain with dopamine. But at the mental level, it's what we call attachment — that's the dependency. When we talk about attachment, we mean that we're dependent on something to give us happiness. But when we look at that happiness, it's actually a little level of excited energy. That's what we've got to give up, because if we don't, it creates all these problems we've been through: compulsive behaviour, frustration, grief, anxiety, and finally boredom.

If your whole life is about being excited and it begins to lose that excitement — through illness, for instance — boredom arises. What boredom is saying is: what's the purpose of life if I can't be excited? I've got to search for something. So you can see that boredom is the underlying engine of the whole consumerist society. It's the boredom that makes you seek the next thing that's going to make you excited. We have this phrase, don't we? Variety is the spice of life. Well, that attitude is the path to perdition, the path to hell. But that's not necessary. We can just be happy.

The big thing we have to do is make sure that whenever we're going to do something that brings happiness, we're very clear about our intention. Take food as an example, which is pretty straightforward: what's the purpose of eating? The real purpose is to nourish the body, so that we can continue living and practising. The fact that it tastes nice is part and parcel of that process. It might not be the taste we expected, but at least that's just there — we're not eating it for that reason.

It's very difficult to separate excitement from indulgence. Aversion is clear — it pushes you away from the object you don't want to know. To be aware of aversion is much easier because it separates out from what it's averse to. Same with fear. But when it comes to indulgence, it melds. The connection is melding. So it's very difficult to pull it apart and see what the indulgence actually is.

One way to do that — if we find ourselves with a compulsive habit — is to stop it. When the desire comes, you sit with the agony of letting go. An example I used to use — it doesn't work anymore, as you'll see — was to have a favourite TV programme, a serial or something like that, and you turn it on and just look at the blank screen. That would send you absolutely berserk. These days, of course, you can't do that because everybody's got iPlayer or something else.

But the whole point of renunciation, or an act of renunciation, is to contact that unwholesome desire. As you work with it over time, the habit begins to dissolve. It's not being fed, so it just begins to die away. Once you've got it down to a decent basis of control, you simply have to watch that it doesn't get the better of you again. That's all.

Eventually, though, we've got to give all that up — and we don't give it up unless we see the juice that comes from it, the fruit of that renunciation. So if you take something you can see is compulsive — it might be just a cup of tea at a certain time of day — you sit there with the empty cup. You get that feeling of wanting to want it. If you just sit with it, it's quite remarkable. If you wait for that

desire to go away, that bad energy — remember — is transformed. Suddenly you're contented and you don't want a cup of tea. And that's the joy of renunciation.

Let me end with the Buddha's own words: he says the taste of Nibbāna is freedom, just as the taste of the ocean is salt. Freedom from what? Freedom from this compulsive desire. Remember, this is the desiring side — the craving for pleasure. There's the other side too, which is all about suffering: anxiety, depression, and so on.

So just to recap: when we get into this indulgence business, we can expect an aftermath. There'll be compulsive behaviour, frustration, grief, anxiety, boredom. If we can get into that and work with it, then hopefully we'll liberate ourselves from it. That's the whole point of our practice, really.

I can only hope my words have been of some assistance, that I haven't caused confusion, and that by your devotion to separating indulgence from enjoyment you will be liberated from all suffering — sooner rather than later.

The Dangers of Indulgence

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 20 min

Originally given as *The Dangers of Indulgence* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this discourse, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the Buddha's first teaching on the middle path, distinguishing between wholesome enjoyment and harmful indulgence. Drawing from the Dhammacakkappavattana Sutta's rejection of both sensual pleasure and self-mortification, he explores how attachment to excitement and pleasure creates a cycle of suffering.

The talk identifies five key dangers of indulgence: compulsive behavior, frustration when desires aren't met, grief over loss, underlying anxiety about possession, and the boredom that drives endless seeking. Using vivid examples from Greek mythology to modern consumerism, Bhante illustrates how the confusion between happiness and excitement traps us in cycles of craving and dissatisfaction.

Practical guidance is offered for distinguishing pure enjoyment from attachment-driven indulgence, emphasizing the importance of clear intention. Whether eating, enjoying nature, or engaging with possessions, the key lies in understanding our true motivations and practicing renunciation when compulsive patterns emerge. The teaching concludes with the liberating truth that genuine contentment and happiness arise not from feeding desires, but from the freedom that comes through wise renunciation—the very taste of Nibbāna itself.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa.

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed noble and fully self-awakened one.

Tonight I thought I'd tackle this problem of indulgence. If I were to quote the Buddha from his first discourse—which is really just a formalised teaching; I can't imagine this is exactly what he said—he says that indulgence in sensual pleasures

is base, vulgar, worldly, ignoble and not beneficial. Then he says the practice of self-mortification is simply painful, ignoble and not beneficial. And then he talks about the middle path.

This middle path isn't a little bit of indulgence and a little bit of mortification. It's something that transcends them both. That's the 'middle', as it were—a way of saying there is a path that includes neither indulgence nor self-mortification. Self-mortification means blaming the body for our problems. If your eye sees something that brings up lust, you start blaming the eye. That wouldn't be correct, would it? In those days, especially among the Jains, they thought the body itself was the product of our *kamma* and you had to let go of it. To die, to stop eating, was considered the way to go. I believe elderly people still do that even these days.

I always like the Greek myths. How bad can greed get? Erysichthon, the Greek king of Thessaly, had the temerity to build a banqueting hall over the shrine of Demeter, goddess of earth's fertility and protector of the harvest. She cursed him with insatiable hunger. First he ate everything in his kingdom that could be eaten. Then he started on his people and even ate his own family. Finally, still famished, he ate himself. That's how bad it can get.

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But there are three things we need to become clear about. Remember, this is the other side of suffering. Everybody knows the depressions and the anxiety—we know how to deal with those. But indulgence is rather difficult because it's so close to enjoyment.

The first thing is to be able to distinguish when we're enjoying something as opposed to indulging it. The second is to begin seeing the distinction between body and mind, and what the body is actually giving us—which is pure. All that's coming in through the ears, for instance, is vibrations in the air. From there it's taken into the mind, and it's the mind that gives it meaning: a bell, an alarm bell, and so on. The third is to know the distinction between a desire and an action. This is the Buddha making clear what the role of the will is.

The first thing is to really understand the downside of indulgence. The problem is that when we're indulging something—we're getting food, or we're out in nature and we're loving it, bathing in it—while we're doing that, there's not a problem. It's heaven, isn't it? We think it's *Nibbāna*. It's the aftermath we have to become aware of.

The first thing that arises from indulgence is, of course, compulsive behaviour. The psychology here is the same as any addict's. They've got it bad, but for most of us it becomes an obsessive thing that we need. Just to take a very simple example: everybody has a special time for tea or coffee and biscuits, coffee and a piece of cake. When you get to that time, if you just sit in front of it, you'll feel the process of wanting and the compulsive nature of having to have it. You can get quite depressed if you don't get it. But that's the other side too. It's a case of recognising that as soon as we have one of these unwholesome habits, there's a certain compulsion around that behaviour.

I've got an example here of somebody who gave up smoking and thought they were completely over it. Then at a party they had just one cigarette. Before they knew it, of course, they were buying a packet. Now, I know that has a physical dependency to it, but the psychology is the same even for biscuits.

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The third problem is grief. This is especially true with things—if you lose something treasured by you: an engagement ring, a wedding ring, some token of friendship, some heirloom. If that's stolen from you, it's devastating. I remember at college, my girlfriend at the time was living in a place with other girls, and the landlord turned out to be some sort of thief. One day they found all their little treasures had been stolen—all the jewellery they had. It was absolutely awful. And of course, when we lose something like a mobile, we get more angry than anything, but there's a sense of grief there too.

When it comes to objects, it's good to remind ourselves that the idea of possessing something is a legal fiction. We presume the object is mine, but actually, when you think about it, you can only use objects. You can only use your phone. And when the thief takes it, it's his—not mine anymore.

The fourth problem is anxiety. Under anything we possess, I'm sure you'll find some level of anxiety about loss. And the more we have, the more that anxiety grows. You can see this with people who are very rich. Once they reach a billion, it's hardly enough—they've got to insure that billion by having another billion. It's the same with other things we have, like friendships. We feel safer when we have lots of friends, people we can call on, family, and so on. There's also power: the more power you have, the safer you feel. When those things begin to dissipate, when we start to lose them, that's when we touch this underground anxiety.

And of course, that anxiety goes right to the basis of the real problem sitting under everything: the idea of a self. The self tells us to enjoy ourselves, to try and make this life really enjoyable. And when the joy we've become attached to begins to disappear, that's when the anxiety arises. Now, that isn't to say there isn't enjoyment and the joys of life—we'll come to that in a bit.

Finally—and I don't think this is an exhaustive list—there's boredom. If you remember, after the Buddha became fully liberated, Māra, the evil one, sent his three daughters: sensual pleasure, sexual pleasure, and boredom. This boredom is an aversive state. What used to give you happiness doesn't give you that happiness anymore. And if we look closely, it's actually not so much the happiness we're after—it's that little sliver on top, which is the excitement. That's the big delusion of our consumerist societies: confusing happiness with excitement.

Think of a Christmas cake—a British and Irish Christmas cake. You get the solid bit, the fruit cake underneath it all, and then this sliver at the top of marzipan and icing. Children will peel that off and just eat that, of course. It gives the cake that little special zing. It's just an ordinary fruitcake unless you have that bit of marzipan and icing on top. And of course, that's what gives you diabetes, isn't it? The sugar. But we're not worried about that. We'd rather just enjoy it.

It's the same with happiness and excitement. Often when we make the right intention to just enjoy something and not indulge, there's always that sense that we've lost a little bit of the pleasure we used to have through indulgence. And that's your renunciation. When the Buddha talks about renunciation as the path to liberation, it's getting rid of that excitement.

The Buddha was happy. He actually says that when you get to *Nibbāna*, you are contented and with it happy. We're not going to lose contentment and happiness—but it means giving up that little sliver of excitement. Even though I say it's a little sliver, for a lot of people, that's what life is about. That's where you get this clickbait they talk about, when people are scrolling through fashions and computers and anything else they want to feed off.

If your whole life is about being excited and it begins to lose that excitement—through illness, for instance—boredom arises. And what boredom is saying is: what's the purpose of life if I can't be excited? I've got to search for something. You can see that boredom is the underlying engine of the whole consumerist society. It's the boredom that makes you seek the next thing that's going to make you excited.

We have this phrase, don't we? Variety is the spice of life. That attitude is the path to perdition, the path to hell. But it's not necessary. We can just be happy.

The big thing we have to do is make sure that whenever we're going to do something that brings happiness, we're very clear about our intention. Take food as an example, which is pretty straightforward: what's the purpose of eating? The real purpose is to nourish the body, so that we can continue living and practising. The fact that it tastes nice is part and parcel of that process. It might not be the taste we expected, but at least it's just there—we're not eating for that reason.

It's very difficult to separate excitement from indulgence. Aversion is clear—it pushes you away from the object you don't want to know. To be aware of aversion is much easier because it separates out from what it's averse to; same with fear. But when it comes to indulgence, it melds. The connection is melding. It's very difficult to pull it apart and see what the indulgence actually is.

One way to do that is this: if we find ourselves with a habit that's compulsive, we stop it. And when the desire comes, we sit with the agony of letting go. One example I used to use—it doesn't work anymore, as you'll see—was to have a favourite TV programme, a serial or something like that. You turn it on and just look at the blank screen. That would send you absolutely berserk. These days, of course, you can't do that because everybody's got iPlayer or something else.

The whole point of renunciation—or any act of renunciation—is to contact that desire. It's an unwholesome desire. And as you work with it over time, the habit begins to dissolve. It's not being fed, so it simply dies away. Then, once you've got it down to a decent basis of control, you just have to watch that it doesn't get the better of you again. That's all.

Eventually, though, we've got to give all that up. And we don't give it up unless we see the juice that comes from it—the fruit of that renunciation. Take something you can see is compulsive. It might be just a cup of tea at a certain time of day. You sit there with the empty cup and you get that feeling of wanting it. If you just sit with it, it's quite remarkable. If you sit there and wait for that desire to go away, that bad energy is transformed. Suddenly you're contented and you don't want a cup of tea. That's the joy of renunciation.

To end with the Buddha's own words: he talks about the taste of the sea, how the taste of the ocean is salt. And just as that has a taste, the taste of *Nibbāna* is freedom. Freedom from what? Freedom from this compulsive desire. And remember, this is the desiring side—the craving for pleasure. There's the other side too, which is all about suffering: anxiety, depression, and so on.

Just to recap: when we get into this indulgence business, we can expect an aftermath. There'll be compulsive behaviour. There'll be frustration, grief, anxiety, and boredom. If we can get into that—really see it—then hopefully we'll liberate ourselves from it. That's the whole point of our practice, really.

I can only hope my words have been of some assistance, that I haven't caused confusion, and that by your devotion to separating indulgence from enjoyment you'll be liberated from all suffering—sooner rather than later.

The Investigation of Eating

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 23 min

Originally given as *The Investigation of Eating* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this Easter evening talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the Buddha's powerful metaphor about food from the discourse on the Four Nutriments, where parents crossing a desert must eat their son's flesh to survive. This stark image illustrates how we should approach eating with Right Intention—for nourishment rather than indulgence.

Bhante guides us through eating meditation, a cornerstone practice for understanding the difference between wholesome enjoyment and unwholesome attachment. He outlines three essential distinctions: between enjoying and indulging, between body and mind, and between desire and action. Through careful investigation of our relationship with food, we learn to recognize the overlay of excitement we project onto simple nourishment.

The teaching reveals how indulgence leads to obsession, frustration, grief, anxiety, and boredom—all forms of dukkha. By practicing with something as basic as a cup of tea and biscuit, we develop the insight to see how this pattern of craving and attachment operates throughout all areas of life, from entertainment to relationships. This mindful approach to eating becomes a daily laboratory for understanding the Four Noble Truths and cultivating liberation from suffering.

Good evening. I trust you had a fruitful day. I don't say happy, but I do hope it has been.

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammāsambuddhassa. Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammāsambuddhassa. Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammāsambuddhassa.

Homage to the Buddha, blessed, noble, and fully self-awakened one.

Happy Easter to those of you still connected to Christianity.

This evening I thought I'd make a bit of a meal out of that discourse we read last night—a pun on words, of course. I want to centre in on the first metaphor the Buddha uses there, about food: the son's flesh, as it's called. He always teaches, first of all, from a rational, intellectual point of view. Then he makes a great effort to give us a metaphor—there are literally hundreds of metaphors in the scriptures. He says that some people think that way; they understand things better through images, they make a stronger connection. Most of us, of course, would use both.

So we're back in the desert. Suppose a couple, husband and wife, had taken limited provisions and were travelling through a desert. They have with them their only son, dear and beloved. Then in the middle of the desert, their limited provisions are used up and exhausted, while the rest of the desert remains to be crossed. The husband and wife would think: 'Our limited provisions have been used up and are exhausted, while the rest of the desert remains to be crossed. Let us kill our only son, dear and beloved, and prepare dried and spiced meat. By eating our son's flesh, we can cross the rest of the desert. Let not all three of us perish.' And they do that, of course: they kill him and prepare dried and roasted meat.

Cannibalism doesn't particularly appeal to us. But this is a very strong image, telling us that hunger is one of our basic fears—and that when we eat, we ought to eat with the right intention, not for indulgence's sake. But we'll come to that.

None of us have really experienced hunger. We've experienced being peckish and then just going for that evening piece of toast. We might have ended up a day in some peculiar situation where we haven't eaten, and when we get home we're famished. But actually, we've never really experienced hunger—that agonising feeling. I certainly haven't: where you really do believe that if you don't get some food, you're dying. You can see it in the gaunt faces of refugees. For me, the images that stay are from the 60s and 70s, the famines in India especially.

I've mentioned already the Greek myth of Erysichthon, who upset the goddess Demeter. Her Roman name was Ceres, from which we get 'cereal'—she was in charge of all that grows, all the stuff that people eat. Erysichthon went and built a banqueting hall over her shrine, so she cursed him with insatiable hunger. He ends up eating all the food, then everybody, his own family, and finally himself. This is a myth about what happens when you're actually, really hungry.

I did meet a man in Sri Lanka many years ago who told me he'd got lost out in the wilderness in the US. He'd reached this stage of real hunger. And he said there came a point where he caught a bird—a large bird, let's say a pigeon or something—and he actually ripped it apart and ate the raw flesh. That gives you an idea of how hunger, when it gets right to the point of life or death, becomes utterly overwhelming. The same with thirst, of course.

There are three things when we're eating that we have to try and distinguish in order to liberate ourselves from indulgence. Now, we won't liberate ourselves from indulgence unless we see the consequences. The problem is that while we're indulging ourselves, it's great—it's Nibbāna. What's the problem? But it's only afterwards that we begin to realise there's quite a lot of suffering involved.

The first is just that obsessive nature of indulgence: having to have. Take a morning cup of tea—try giving that up for a while, or coffee, and you'll see how obsessive it is. If you look at any of your habits and try to stop them, you'll see there's a real strong desire coming up from that habit, demanding to be satisfied. To be gratified, really, is the right word: gratification.

The second problem is frustration. Frustration always comes when you can't get what you want. Just look at the past week and see how many times you've been frustrated. Somebody hasn't behaved the way you wanted them to—a family member, somebody at work. Some piece of equipment hasn't worked for you. The shopping didn't arrive at the right time. The bus was late. It goes on and on. And what you feel is anger: a frustration at not getting what you want. Once we drop all that, we begin to establish an equanimity with the way things are. 'This is the way it is'—that's the constant phrase we have to repeat to ourselves. This is the way it is. What's the point of getting upset?

Third is grief—grief at loss. You've only got to think what it would be like if somebody went off with your mobile phone. That's a heavy grief, definitely grief. Our lives are now wrapped up in that little machine. But of course, grief takes on a much deeper meaning, as we mentioned the other day, when we lose somebody we're attached to. Grief is always waiting for us when we possess something or somebody. At worst, when we're identifying with ourselves.

Underneath all that, there's this anxiety—an anxiety of loss. That's why we have insurance. Some of it's realistic, of course; you want to insure your house. I had a cousin who thought house insurance was just a trick to get money out of you, so he never paid it. Then there was one very bad storm and his roof caved in. I don't know whether he made up his money—how much that roof cost him, and

whether over thirty-odd years of never paying insurance he would have actually saved something. But when we buy anything, from a laptop onwards, they always want to give you insurance to make it last three years so you don't worry. See, there's your anxiety: worry at loss, worry at breakage, breaking down. The more we have, the more we're in for some level of dissatisfaction, some level of suffering. It's all to do with this attachment, this indulgence.

The final one is boredom. Boredom is when we're not getting the same excitement we used to get from what we're indulging in. And boredom is not a nice place to be—it's an aversive place. There's a search for something new. Variety is the spice of life, and that's what we do: we chase things, one pleasure after another, just to keep ourselves occupied, keep ourselves happy. But this happiness isn't true happiness. It's an excitement based on over-wanting something more than we actually get from any object. That's when we have to remind ourselves that we don't actually want the object so much as the mental state it produces.

So there are three things we have to do to undermine all this. The first is to distinguish between enjoying something and indulging in it. It's not as though the Buddha is saying we shouldn't enjoy life—we shouldn't enjoy art, nature, friendship and all that sort of stuff. That's perfectly viable. He himself enjoyed, for instance, going to shrines, just the normal things of life. But the distinction is very difficult because indulgence is so close to enjoyment. Aversion pushes you apart from the object, but indulgence sticks you to it.

The second thing is to begin distinguishing the body from the mind. That's all to do with deconstructing our sense of self, our sense of identity, our sense of being a whole—entire, like an integer, one number.

The third, just as important, is to distinguish between a desire and an action. We've looked at that a little bit.

Let me go back over those. Distinguishing between enjoyment and indulgence, as I say, is difficult. The way you overcome indulgence is by putting a clear intention in your mind. This food, as the Buddha says with the example of the mother and father who ate their son, has to have a real purpose. That food is something to nourish the body for the purpose of becoming liberated. It has a spiritual purpose to it. If it has any other purpose, then you have to question whether it's wholesome, whether it's actually leading you on the path.

Every time we're with a cup of tea, with that mythical biscuit, with a meal, we have to sit there for a moment and remind ourselves: okay, this is to nourish the body, full stop, that's all. The fact that I enjoy it has to be received as a gift. You don't have to enjoy food that's nourishing—it can be quite tasteless, porridge without sugar and all that sort of stuff. That's the first thing.

Then as you go through the meal, begin to notice that the excitement you had at the beginning is fading away and there's just this tasting of the food. There you're beginning to distinguish the overlay of excitement we have when a good meal is in front of us—and then very slowly, over even as little as ten bites, it becomes ordinary. That's the chance to really investigate just enjoying. Just enjoying.

To make this clear to ourselves, we separate the body from the mind—the heart-mind—from feeling, from thinking. You do that by driving your attention first into the body, into the process of tasting and smelling. By isolating that physical taste process, you begin to realise that this is just the body. It's the mind that translates it into something beautiful. When you, as it were, swallow—intending to swallow—and it's dropped, you stop for a moment and get the afterglow. That afterglow is the mind. The feeling of well-being, the feeling of joy, is our habituated reaction to the food we're eating. That's a habit we have: to become happy and to indulge in the food we're eating. It's recognising that these are two different processes.

As the meal goes on and the excitement dies out, one can get close to this business of just enjoyment. You might find that when you're just enjoying something, there's a sense of loss—because before, you really enjoyed it. See, that's the overlay of excitement. Then you have to remind yourself: well, fine, I can indulge, but then I've got consequences. It's this constant reminder. Eventually, of course, we find that indulgence is just too much. It's too much sugar, and you just want to taste things as they are without overlaying excitement onto it.

Years ago, when I was teaching at the Birmingham Buddhist Vihara, a young man came to the class. When he returned the next week, he told me he'd been meditating and could no longer listen to heavy rock. There you can see how refined this young fellow was becoming.

The final thing, of course, is action: the distinction between a desire and an action. When you have your cup of tea—and I'd suggest you try this at least once a day with a cup of tea and a biscuit or a sandwich, it doesn't matter what—just sit with it. Get the feel of the hunger, know that some of it is natural appetite and

some of it is this excitement we get from indulging, and stay there with it for a while. Then feel the force of that desire, the wanting to eat. The more hungry you are, of course, the greater that desire will be.

Then at some point, a decision is made. Something shifts—yes, like you're giving permission for the desire to manifest. And that manifests through an act of will. That's your power: the power to bring something from potential into actual. Now, the will itself is completely neutral. It's just a power. It's the intention that matters. It's the intention that conditions us. It's good to make that distinction and to realise that you really can sit with a desire you don't want until it fades away.

When we sit with a desire we don't want, no matter how strong it is, and wait for it to fade away completely, we get our little gift. The gift is a feeling of release, as if we've been imprisoned or shackled. With that comes a sense of joy. But more than that, we're undermining the very habit we don't want. If we keep this going, eventually there comes a point where the habit just doesn't have that force over us anymore. We can see it come and let it pass. That comes through constant practice.

If we fail—if we find ourselves chucking ten biscuits down our throats—there's no point in getting guilty or feeling horrible about it. You just notice that, well, for that moment there, you gave in. But then you have to make a firm resolution, a resolute resolution, that you'll be very quick to see when that desire arises and just stay with it. Suffer it. You've got to stay with the feeling of it until it completely passes away.

And the opposite, of course: if a desire comes up that you see is wholesome, then you empower it. In just that very simple way, we can actually change ourselves. We are nothing but a compendium of habits—just a collection of habits. And it's a decision to keep some of them, develop some of them, and get rid of the ones we don't want. That's the process.

I'm not saying it's easy. The stronger the habit, the more established it is, the more difficult it is to get the better of it. Eventually, of course, once we're fully awakened, fully liberated from suffering, the traces of that habit might still appear in the heart-mind, but they just don't have any power over us at all.

The final thing to say is this: when we practise on something so obvious as eating—which we have to do every day, it's not as though you can give up eating—it becomes a constant little practice for us, a constant reminder.

When we do that, we begin to realise this cuts across everything in our lives: our enjoyment of art, television, film, our enjoyment of nature, the hobbies we have. Anything you enjoy will have that overlay of wanting something more from it.

And of course, relationship—the obsessive part of relationship. That often manifests in the way we try to manipulate the other, demand of the other, try to control the other, feel disappointed in the other, frustrated by the other, and so on.

This practice of just having a cup of tea with a biscuit will eventually bring that insight into our lives and begin to change them. Going back to what we said about the Eightfold Path, this is the feedback—the feedback from our right understanding through right action. And that reinforces the insight, makes it more and more real for us.

I think that's enough about food for the moment. I suggest we now turn to our meditation. I can only trust my words have been of some assistance and haven't caused greater confusion.

The Investigation of Eating

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 23 min

Originally given as *The Investigation of Eating* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this insightful talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the Buddha's striking metaphor from the Puttamamsa Sutta about parents eating their son's flesh to survive crossing a desert - a powerful teaching on the nature of nutriment (āhāra) and right intention in consumption. He guides practitioners through the practice of eating meditation, one of his signature teachings, showing how mindful consumption becomes a vehicle for understanding attachment and developing Right Awareness.

The talk addresses three crucial distinctions for liberation from indulgence: distinguishing enjoyment from indulgence, separating body from mind in the eating process, and recognizing the difference between desire and action. Bhante explains how the suffering of obsessive craving, frustration, grief at loss, anxiety, and boredom all arise from attachment to sensory pleasures. Through careful investigation of the eating process - from initial excitement to the fading of taste pleasure - practitioners learn to see how the mind overlays excitement onto bodily sensations.

This practical teaching extends beyond food to all areas of life, offering a daily laboratory for understanding the mechanics of craving (taṇhā) and developing the will power to choose wholesome actions over habitual reactivity. Perfect for anyone seeking to transform everyday activities into opportunities for insight and liberation.

Good evening. I trust you had a fruitful day. I don't say happy, but I do hope it has been.

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammāsambuddhassa. Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammāsambuddhassa. Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammāsambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, blessed, noble, and fully self-awakened one.

Happy Easter to those of you still connected to Christianity. I thought this evening we might make a bit of a meal out of that discourse we read last night — a pun on words, of course. I want to focus on the first metaphor the Buddha uses there about food: the son's flesh, as it's called.

The Buddha always teaches first from a rational, intellectual point of view. Then he makes a great effort to give us a metaphor — there are literally hundreds of metaphors in the scriptures — because he knows some people think that way, understanding things better through images. Most of us, of course, use both. So we were talking about the nutrients, and I want to read that bit again. Then we'll talk about eating meditation, which those of you who've been here before will know is one of my obsessive teachings.

So suppose a couple — we're back in the desert. Suppose a husband and wife had taken limited provisions and were travelling through a desert. They have with them their only son, dear and beloved. In the middle of the desert their provisions are used up and exhausted while the rest of the desert remains to be crossed. The husband and wife think, "Our provisions have been used up while the rest of the desert remains to be crossed. Let us kill our only son, dear and beloved, and prepare dried and spiced meat. By eating our son's flesh, we can cross the rest of the desert. Let not all three of us perish." And they do, of course. They kill him and prepare dried and roasted meat.

Cannibalism doesn't particularly appeal to us, but this is a very strong image. It tells us that hunger is one of our basic fears, and that when we eat, we ought to eat with right intention — not for indulgence's sake. But we'll come to that.

None of us really — I mean, maybe you have, but none of us really — have experienced hunger. We've experienced being peckish and then going for that evening piece of toast. We might have ended up a day in some peculiar situation where we haven't eaten, and when we get home we're famished. But we've never really experienced true hunger, that gnawing feeling where you genuinely believe that if you don't get some food, you're dying. You can see it in the gaunt faces of refugees. For me, the images go back to the 60s and 70s, when there were famines in India especially.

I've mentioned already the Greek myth of Erysichthon, who upset the goddess Demeter — the Roman name was Ceres, from which we get cereal. She was in charge of all that grows, all the stuff that people eat. Erysichthon went and built a

banqueting hall over her shrine, so she cursed him with insatiable hunger. He ends up eating all the food, then everybody, his own family, and finally himself. This is a myth about what happens when you're actually, really hungry.

I did meet a man in Sri Lanka many years ago who told me he had got lost in the wilderness in the US. He'd reached this stage of real hunger. He said there came a point where he caught a bird — a large bird, let's say a pigeon or something — and he actually ripped it apart and ate the raw flesh. That gives you an idea of how hunger, when it gets right to the point of life or death, becomes utterly overwhelming. The same with thirst, of course.

There are three things we have to distinguish when eating if we want to liberate ourselves from indulgence. Now, we won't liberate ourselves from indulgence unless we see the consequences. The problem is that while we're indulging, it's great — it's nibbana, what's the problem? But it's only afterwards that we begin to realise there's quite a lot of suffering involved.

The first consequence is the obsessive nature of indulgence itself. You know, having to have — I mean, just the morning cup of tea. Try giving that up for a while, or coffee, and you'll see how obsessive it is. If you look at any of your habits and try to stop them, you'll see there's a real strong desire coming up from that habit which demands to be satisfied — gratification is the right word.

The second problem is frustration. Frustration always comes when you can't get what you want. Just look at the past week and see how many times you've been frustrated. Somebody hasn't behaved the way you wanted — a family member, somebody at work, whatever. Some piece of equipment hasn't worked for you. The shopping didn't arrive at the right time. The bus was late. It goes on and on. What you feel is anger, a frustration at not getting what you want. And of course, once we drop all that, we begin to establish an equanimity with the way things are. This is the way it is — that's the constant phrase we have to repeat to ourselves. This is the way it is. What's the point of getting upset?

Then there's grief — grief at loss. Just think how you'd feel if somebody went off with your mobile phone. That's a heavy grief, that is. Our lives are now wrapped up in that little machine. But of course grief takes on a much deeper meaning, as we mentioned the other day, when we lose somebody we're attached to. Grief is always waiting for us when we possess something — or worse, when we identify with it, when we make it part of ourselves.

And underneath all that there's this anxiety — an anxiety of loss. That's why we have insurance. Some of it's realistic, of course; you want to insure your house. I had a cousin who thought house insurance was just a trick to get money out of you, so he never paid it. Then there was one very bad storm and his roof caved in. I don't know whether he came out ahead in the end — how much that roof cost him versus what he'd saved over thirty-odd years of never paying premiums. He might actually have lost money by not having insurance.

But when we buy anything — a laptop, say — they always want to sell you insurance to make it last three years so you don't worry. There's your anxiety: worry at loss, worry at breakage, worry at breaking down. The more we have, the more we're in for some level of dissatisfaction, some level of suffering. It's all to do with this attachment, this indulgence.

And the final consequence is boredom. Boredom is when we're not getting the same excitement we used to get from what we're indulging in. It's not a nice place to be — it's an aversive place. So there's a search for something new. Variety is the spice of life, as they say. And that's what we do: one pleasure after another just to keep ourselves occupied, keep ourselves happy. But this happiness isn't true happiness. It's an excitement based on wanting something more than we actually get from any object. That's when we have to remind ourselves that we don't actually want the object so much as the mental state it produces.

So there are three things we have to do in order to undermine all this. The first is to distinguish between enjoying something and indulging it. It's not as though the Buddha is saying we shouldn't enjoy life — we shouldn't enjoy art, nature, friendship and all that sort of stuff. That's perfectly viable. He himself enjoyed going to shrines, just the normal things of life. But the distinction is difficult because indulgence is so close to enjoyment. Aversion pushes you apart from the object, but indulgence sticks you to it.

The second thing is to begin distinguishing the body from the mind. This is all to do with deconstructing our sense of self, our sense of identity, our sense of being whole and entire — like an integer, one number.

And the final one, just as important, is to distinguish between a desire and an action.

Let me go back over those. Distinguishing between desire and indulgence, as I say, is difficult. The way you overcome indulgence is by putting a clear intention in your mind. This food — as the Buddha says with the example of the mother and

father who ate their son — has to have a real purpose. That food is something to nourish the body for the purpose of becoming liberated. It has a spiritual purpose. If it has any other purpose, then you have to question whether it's wholesome, whether it's actually leading you on the path.

Every time we're with a cup of tea, with that mythical biscuit, with a meal, we have to sit there for a moment and remind ourselves: 'Okay, this is to nourish the body. Full stop. That's all.' The fact that I enjoy it has to be received as a gift. You don't have to enjoy food that's nourishing — it can be quite tasteless, like porridge without sugar and all that sort of stuff. That's the first thing.

Then as you go through the meal, begin to notice that the excitement you had at the beginning is starting to fade and there's just this tasting of the food. You're beginning to distinguish the overlay of excitement we have when a good meal is in front of us. Very slowly, over even as little as ten bites or so, it becomes ordinary. And that's the chance to really investigate just enjoying — just enjoying.

To make this clear to ourselves, we separate the body from the mind — the heart-mind — from feeling, from thinking. You do that by driving your attention first into the body, into the process of tasting and smelling. By isolating that physical taste process, you begin to realise this is just the body. It's the mind that translates it into something beautiful. When you swallow, intending to swallow, and the food has dropped, you stop for a moment and get the afterglow. That afterglow is the mind. The feeling of wellbeing, the feeling of joy — that's our habituated reaction to the food we're eating. It's a habit: to become happy and to indulge the food we're eating. Recognising that these are two different processes is the key.

As the meal goes on and the excitement dies out, you can get close to this business of just enjoyment. You might find that when you're just enjoying something, there's a sense of loss — because before, you really enjoyed it. That's the overlay of excitement. Then you have to remind yourself: 'Well fine, I can indulge, but then I've got consequences.' It's this constant reminder. Eventually we find that indulgence is just too much. It's too much sugar. And you just want to taste things as they are, without overlaying excitement onto them.

Years ago, when I was teaching at the Birmingham Buddhist Vihara, a young man came to a session. When he returned the following week, he told me he'd been meditating and could no longer listen to heavy rock. You can see how refined this young fellow was becoming.

The final thing, of course, is action — the distinction between a desire and an action. When you have your cup of tea — and I'd suggest you try this at least once a day with a cup of tea and a biscuit or a sandwich, it doesn't matter what — just sit with it. Get the feel of the hunger, know that some of it is natural appetite and some of it is this excitement we get from indulging, and stay there with it for a while. Then feel the force of that desire, the wanting to eat. The more hungry you are, of course, the greater that desire will be.

At some point, a decision is made — something like giving permission for the desire to manifest. And that manifests through an act of will. That's your power: to bring something from potential into actual. Now, the will itself is completely neutral. It's just a power. It's the intention that matters, the intention that conditions us. It's good to make that distinction and to realise that you really can sit with a desire you don't want until it fades away.

When we sit with a desire we don't want, no matter how strong it is, and wait for it to fade away completely, we get our little gift. The gift is a feeling of release, as if we've been imprisoned or shackled. With that comes a sense of joy. But more than that, we're undermining the very habit we don't want. If we keep this going, eventually there comes a point where the habit just doesn't have that force over us. We can see it come and let it pass. That comes through constant practice.

If we fail — if we find ourselves chucking ten biscuits down our throats — there's no point in getting guilty or feeling horrible about it. We just notice that, well, for that moment there, we gave in. But then we have to make a firm resolution, a resolute resolution, to be very quick to see when that desire arises and just stay with it, suffer it. We've got to suffer. We've got to stay with the feeling of it until it completely passes away.

The opposite, of course, is that when a desire comes up which we see is wholesome, we empower it. In just this simple way, we can actually change ourselves. We are nothing but a compendium of habits — just a collection of habits. And it's a decision to keep some of them, develop some of them, and get rid of the ones we don't want. That's the process.

I'm not saying it's easy. The stronger the habit, the more established it is, the more difficult it is to get the better of it. Eventually, of course, once we're fully awakened, fully liberated from suffering, the traces of that habit might still appear in the heart-mind, but they just don't have any power over us at all.

The final thing to say is that when we practise this on something so obvious as eating — which we have to do every day; it's not as though we can give up eating — it becomes a constant little practice for us, a constant reminder.

When we do this, we begin to realise that it cuts across everything in our lives: our enjoyment of art, television, film, our enjoyment of nature, the hobbies we have. Anything we enjoy will have that overlay of wanting something more from it.

And of course, relationship — relationship with its obsessive quality. That often manifests in the way we try to manipulate the other, demand of the other, try to control the other, become disappointed in the other, frustrated by the other, and so on.

This practice on just eating, just having a cup of tea with a biscuit, will eventually bring that sort of insight into our lives and begin to change them. Going back to what we said about the Eightfold Path, this is the feedback — the feedback from our right understanding through right action. And that reinforces the insight, makes it more and more real for us.

I think that's enough about food for the moment. I suggest we now turn to our meditation. I can only trust my words have been of some assistance and have not caused greater confusion.

Investigative Eating Meditation — An Explanation

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 16 min

Originally given as *Investigative Eating Meditation — An Explanation* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma presents eating as a powerful vehicle for liberation, drawing on the Buddha's own approach to food as described in the Brahmāyu Sutta. He explores how mindful eating can help us distinguish between enjoying and indulging, between bodily sensations and mental reactions, and between desire and action.

The talk examines five forms of suffering that arise from indulgence: attachment and compulsive behavior; frustration when desires are thwarted, grief over loss, anxiety about possessions, and the boredom that drives endless seeking. Bhante explains how these patterns reflect the Second Noble Truth's teaching on taṇhā (thirst) as the root cause of dukkha.

Drawing on the Buddha's example of experiencing taste without greed, this teaching offers practical guidance for developing Right Awareness around food and all sensual pleasures. By cultivating attentive eating, practitioners learn to undermine the wrong view of self as a single, undivided entity, recognizing instead our compound nature as the five khandhas. This approach extends beyond food to transform our relationship with all attachments, moving toward the freedom of Nibbāna.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa
 Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa
 Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

This is a talk about eating meditation — using the process of eating as a path to full liberation.

First, how bad can greed get? Erysichthon, the Greek king of Thessaly, had the temerity to build a banqueting hall over the shrine of Demeter, goddess of earth's fertility and protector of the harvest. (In Rome she became Ceres, from which we get the word cereal.) She cursed him with insatiable hunger. First he ate everything there was to eat in his kingdom. Then he started on his people and even ate his own family. Still famished, he ate himself.

While I was staying at Kanduboda Meditation Centre in Sri Lanka, a man told me that once, out in the wilds, he had got lost and over a period of a few days became so hungry that when he finally caught a pigeon, he ripped it open and ate it raw. He was a good meditator.

Hopefully we won't have to suffer such extreme conditions. Even so, there are other good reasons to investigate the process of eating: to distinguish between enjoying and indulging; to distinguish between the body and the mind — that is, sensations from emotions and thoughts; and to distinguish between a desire and an action, the role of the will.

The first complication that arises from indulgence is attachment and compulsive behaviour. When we indulge some unwholesome but pleasing habit, we're using something to create a mental state we enjoy. It's not the biscuit we want, but the mental state it produces — be it happy or comforting. This also produces a dependency, and just like any addict, we're compelled to raid the biscuit box. Only a strong act of will and a refusal to have biscuits in the house can break the habit. It's precisely at the moment we renounce the biscuit that we suffer the strength of that habit and the hold it has on us. But the potential is always there. A person who gives up smoking and after a long time thinks they're immune to becoming habituated again, on surrendering at a party to have just one, finds themselves buying a packet. Attachment, then, is none other than a dependency on something — or indeed someone — to create a mental state of happiness.

The second complication is the suffering of frustration. Anger arises when we can't get what we want or when what we want is denied us. We live at a time of almost immediate gratification. Consider fast food. Amazon has spent millions on delivery, knowing that to satisfy a customer as quickly as possible is to ensure their loyalty. You want some beer? Non-alcoholic, of course. They'll get it to you tomorrow. We can even be angry with ourselves for forgetting to buy tea or coffee. We get angry if the bus, the train, the taxi is late. We get angry if someone doesn't turn up for a meeting. Frustration doesn't help. It just burns us.

The third complication is grief. The misery we feel when we have to diet. The shock we suffer when we lose a mobile. The distress of leaving an expensive hat or bag behind in a restaurant only to find it has disappeared. Although we believe in possessing things, in reality we can only use them. If a thief has run off with our mobile, for all intents and purposes it's their mobile now, no matter how much we keep moaning about the loss of *my* mobile. And grief takes on a different intensity when we lose a spouse, partner, family member, or friend.

Fourthly, there's anxiety, which always sits beneath everything we possess. The run on flour, pasta and — bewilderingly — toilet paper at the start of the lockdown was driven by fear of what may or may not happen in the future. The more we possess, the more we feel loss. And the more we have to possess to cushion any blow. A billion pounds to a billionaire cannot be enough; they must cushion it by moving towards a trillion. We're afraid of loneliness, so we build up a coterie of friendships and lots of things to do. We feel insecure, so we accumulate excessive insurance or power, which manifests in controlling and bullying.

Finally there is boredom. If you remember Māra the evil tempter — the sensual life personified — he sent his three daughters to inveigle the Buddha to return to the good life: sensual pleasure, sexual pleasure, and boredom. Boredom is that state where what once gave such pleasure and excitement is now stale, overindulged and unpleasing. It's an aversive state, and to escape it we seek some other pleasure. 'Variety is the spice of life' is the basic motto of the consumerist. Consider the foodies who choose their holidays depending on a variety of restaurants. And just as all the other consequences of indulgence can become mental illness, boredom can drive you into depression. Indeed, what would be the purpose of living when there is nothing and no one who can raise any degree of excitement?

Here lies the distinction between happiness and excitement. True happiness is based on contentment. Excitement that passes for true happiness is based on an insatiable appetite for the new and the thrill. This excitement is what fuels consumerism, and the underlying engine is boredom — caused by the lack of excitement — that drives the consumer to seek relief in more excitement. This is none other than the psychology of addiction. Just as a drug addict feels normal when under the influence and abnormal when in need, so the consumer feels they have to buy something or go somewhere, do anything that excites, no matter how little, in order to feel happy. Retail therapy is no therapy at all. It's an addiction.

The second noble truth states that the cause of suffering is insatiable thirst — the craving that generates moment-to-moment becoming, accompanied by obsessive indulgence, finding fresh excitement now here, now there. This is the insatiable hunger for sensual pleasures, for continued becoming, and for non-becoming.

What do we do? First, we need to make a clear distinction between body and mind — between sensations and physical feelings on one hand, and the heart-mind with its emotions, moods, thoughts and imagination on the other. This is part of the endeavour to undermine the sense of self, the wrong view of self. We have this sense of being one entire undivided integer, a single uncompounded being, whole and absolute. By drawing apart what the body does through the senses and what the heart-mind does, we begin to realise that we're but a compound made up of many pieces, all depending on each other to create an embodied person. We're beginning to undermine this delusion: I am what I feel or think I am.

Secondly, we need to distinguish a desire from an action. This gives us that chink of freedom where we can change the conditioning we don't want into conditioning we do want. Remember, our personality is but a collection of habits and will always be so. Our work is to rid ourselves of habits that bring any degree of suffering and dissatisfaction, and to develop those that bring a sense of well-being.

So long as there's only a desire, nothing has actually happened. It remains an idea laced with the energy of wanting. It arises out of a state of discomfort and is itself uncomfortable until gratified. If we're fully aware of a desire, we won't be caught up in its demands but will have the occasion to ask: Is it wholesome? Is it beneficial to myself, to another, or to both?

If we determine it's unwholesome, all we have to do is bear with the desire until it burns itself out. In so doing, the habit it expresses is weakened and will eventually lose all power over us. If a desire is judged to be wholesome, then we empower it — it produces an act of body, speech and mind, and this reinforces the habit. In this quite simple way we can change ourselves. Though, as we discover, it's not easy. We need a highly alert attentiveness, or we quickly gratify those habits we don't want and so develop them.

In the Brahmāyu Sutta, there's a passage describing how the Buddha receives food and eats it. He describes what he actually experiences: he takes the food experiencing the taste, though not experiencing greed for the taste. In other words, just the pleasant sensations. This is on occasion chanted by monastics at meal-times.

Food I take has eight factors. It is neither for amusement nor for intoxication, indulgence, or for the sake of physical beauty or attractiveness, but only for the endurance and continuance of my body, for ending discomfort and assisting the spiritual life. I consider: thus I shall terminate old unwholesome feelings without arousing new unwholesome feelings, and I shall be healthy and blameless and live in comfort.

What we're developing is an attitude, and an attitude is a way of relating — it's not specific to a particular object. So as we undermine greed around food, we're undermining all indulgence, for the same psychology applies to everything that delights us. Whether it's sensual pleasure, art, nature, even people and animals, the same problem of attachment arises. Once we've understood — I repeat — that attachment is a psychological dependency on some object or other for happiness, we begin to be more aware of other dependencies and slowly let go of all obsessiveness. The Buddha tells us the taste of *Nibbāna* is freedom. It's freedom from unwholesome desires.

Now a warning. I once sat next to a monk who by the look of him you'd presume a true ascetic — hollow-cheeked and gaunt. When the delicious fruit salad with buffalo curd was offered, he placed it before him, and while the other monks continued to eat, he simply stared at the bowl. As we were finishing, he picked it up and quick as lightning spooned it down his throat.

Of course, I may be judging him very wrongly, but it seemed to me he was afraid of enjoying the food for fear of indulging. Such an attitude, if taken to all we enjoy, would turn life into a sour grape. As always in our spiritual practice, we have to tread that narrow path between direct enemies and subtle enemies of virtues — here, between indulgence and self-mortification. The pleasures and joys of life are a human birthright, but they come and go like everything else. What are we actually holding on to?

In conclusion, since our personality is made up of a compendium of habits, our psychotherapeutic task is to liberate ourselves from their control — but not from the habit itself when it's wholesome. After all, we have to eat. So our task, when it concerns anything pleasurable and enjoyable, is to begin to experience what it's like to enjoy and not indulge.

I can only hope my words have been of some assistance, that they haven't caused confusion, and that by your careful attentive eating you will liberate yourself from all suffering.

Meditation and Daily Life

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 45 min

Originally given as *Meditation and Daily Life* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



Bhante Bodhidhamma addresses the common difficulty practitioners face in connecting meditation practice with daily life. Drawing from his early experience with Zen Buddhism, he explains how Vipassanā meditation naturally flows into everyday activities through the structure of the Noble Eightfold Path. The talk explores the Buddha's concept of 'the all' (sabbaṃ) - the six sense doors that constitute our entire experiential universe - and how establishing awareness at this interface allows us to step back from identification with the psychophysical process.

The discussion moves through the progression from Right Understanding (sammā dīṭṭhi) to Right Livelihood (sammā ājīva), showing how wisdom naturally expresses itself through compassionate action and service to others. Bhante emphasizes practical techniques for maintaining mindfulness throughout the day, such as pausing when the phone rings and setting time boundaries for activities. He addresses common questions about ambition and career choices from a Buddhist perspective, advocating for an attitude of service that honors both self-care and care for others.

The talk concludes with practical guidance for establishing a daily meditation routine and maintaining the meditative perspective through regular 'stopping' practices, making the connection between formal sitting practice and the lived expression of the Dhamma increasingly seamless.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa.

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble, and fully self-enlightened one.

There's always this blank when I begin a talk. It has to start somewhere. What I'd like to do is make a link between what we're doing in meditation and what we do in the world out there. People find that difficult—I mean people in this particular tradition, especially Theravāda, though it happens in other traditions too. I was rather fortunate. I began with Zen Buddhism up in North England, at the Throssel Hole Abbey Foundation. I don't know whether you know of it.

Zen practice is very much based on work—you do a lot of physical work. I'm talking now about the monastic routine up there. Obviously when they do a special course of just meditation, a sesshin as they call it, there tends to be more sitting. But in their ordinary daily rota they do a lot of physical work. They keep gardens. This came about because of the history of Buddhism in China, which then spread to Japan, where the idea of begging was just not on. So the Chinese monks began to grow their own food.

The reason you worked hard—I mean really put a lot of energy into it—was because in the work you got your concentration and your mindfulness, so that when you went to sit there was that attention, that ability to watch. This mixture of physical work and meditation made it quite easy for me to see how meditation worked in daily life, how it just moved into it. There was no real thought about it; it simply went into daily life. Whatever you were doing, you attended to it.

One thing that helps, of course, is the way that Zen, or Chan, or Dzogchen—some of you might know Dzogchen from the Tibetan tradition—begin their meditation. You might describe it as awareness at the six sense doors. In Buddhism you have the five senses, which we're all aware of, and the sixth sense, which is the mind itself. It's a sensing thing; it receives thoughts, it receives emotions. Being at the forefront, within the all, it's easy to maintain that general awareness when you go out into the world. So there didn't seem to be this huge distinction.

Now, I just used the word *the all*. That's the Buddha, you see. He says the all—the six senses is the all. To understand this, we have to get the idea that we are actually living in a bubble, a bubble of consciousness. It doesn't have an edge to it which is contained. It's just this space. At this present time, in terms of my eye consciousness, I'm caught within this room. It's difficult for me to see outside it. So visually, I'm caught within the bubble, you might say, of this visual consciousness. And that's all I know, isn't it?

It's a truism: all you know is what you know. You can't go beyond what you know. And what you know is that which the senses give you, and your own mind, and your own heart. There's nothing else. You can't go beyond that. So in a sense we're living in this enclosed little universe of my consciousness. And it's obviously similar to yours, but different—otherwise we couldn't communicate.

Walking into this room, nobody will deny that the room has, as it were, its own existence, for want of a better word. If we all leave, nobody believes the room disappears. It's not here because we see it. But on the other hand, thinking subjectively, there exist as many rooms as there are people in it, in terms of how the room is experienced. We all walk in here and there's your room and my room, and so on. And with it we have our relationship to it.

That's the all the Buddha's talking about. Within that all, there is the whole of *saṃsāra*, the whole of onward going, the whole of unsatisfactoriness—and within that whole, eventually, is the Nibbanic experience. The nirvanic experience isn't outside consciousness; we're not going somewhere to experience *nirvana*. It's not like you take a train down from Manchester to London, and it's over there. *Nirvana* is simply another way of being in the world. So what we're investigating is the way we're being—or perhaps better, becoming—this constant sense of becoming somebody in the world.

With the Zen or Dzogchen approach, that distance between being up in the front of your mind, as it were, and then going out into the world didn't seem so separate. But in the Theravāda tradition, and also in the Tibetan tradition known as Mahamudra, they have this form of meditation too. We're actually trying to find within ourselves a sort of observation post, a position at the interface of consciousness and what the mind is offering, what the senses are offering. It's as though we've stepped out of ourselves, stood behind it, and just watched. Or above it, or below it—it doesn't matter what image you want to use. But it's as though we are exiting from the personality, finding a place where you're up front as to where thoughts arise. They arise there.

Now, you see, as I'm speaking to you, I can't be looking at my thoughts that way, or else I'd lose it. If I become objective to my thoughts, I'll just know thinking, and the talk comes to an end and we'll have to do some walking meditation. I've got to be up there in the thought. It's the same with my emotional life. If I'm depressed, say, and I start feeling my depression, well, it's going to be really depressing for you all, because I'm just going to express how depressed I am.

Somehow, I've got to maintain that distance. Yet when I'm talking, I've got to manufacture—I've got to manufacture a particular mood to go with the talk. When I meet somebody I know, a happiness arises; I manufacture a particular mood for that encounter too. I've got to be up there, in that emotion, as it were. Whereas here, you see, I can step behind it. I can see it. I can point to it. I can say 'joy' and it's there, as it were, in front of me.

When we have a pain—a headache or something—and we're trying to do some work, it's there, we're in it. It's very difficult to separate entirely from it, and we immediately search for some pills to get rid of it. But here I can form a sort of space between that which knows—the knowing—and the headache, the knee ache, the back ache. The sneeze. I can see the body going 'achoo' like that, in front of me.

So there's some way in which I can objectify the whole psychophysical organism that usually I'm in—being it, walking around the world as this being. To do that, we use this little technique of pointing with a word. You don't have to do that. There are perfectly viable vipassanā techniques that don't use the pointing with a word. But they still get that position. They still know it as an object.

The reason the noting is there is, as we discussed last night, just to keep the intellect pointed. But there's a more subtle reason: even when you're not using a word, you're still conceptualising what you look at. You're still seeing it by way of a concept. So just to say the word, at least, brings that concept to mind, and then we can move towards it.

So one thing might be, you see, that you have an itch. You recognise it: 'itching, itching.' You can feel it—I've got one right now. And so long as I say 'itching,' there comes that whole response to it: got to scratch it, get rid of the itch. But if I keep saying 'itching' while putting my attention directly onto the sensation, it's as though I'm going beyond the idea of itching. And when that idea goes, the idea of reacting to it goes, because I only react to something I recognise.

When I get down to an itch as it really manifests in the body, it's just a little sense disturbance—like a little scratching on the surface of the skin. Being with that means this awareness I've got, this intelligence I've got, is pulling itself out of its embeddedness, its confusion with the intellect.

When I was at the college I used to work at, I once went to a colleague who was a fundamental materialist. There is the body, full stop—when you're dead, that's the end of it. I said to him, in the corridor, 'Is there an intelligence which doesn't

think?' He looked at me. We used to have these silly conversations. And he looked at me, and just for a moment, he looked. He never said anything. He just turned around and walked away.

I was left thinking, what the hell have I said? He took about ten, twenty paces, stopped, turned around, came straight back at me and said, 'No,' and then walked off. So presumably he's still stuck in the mire of delusion.

What we recognise by noting, by seeing thought—by recognising thought—is that there must be something that recognises the thought. There must be something outside thought which knows thought. And then we begin to see that thought is just there.

What do we mean by concept? They're symbols, aren't they? They're just symbols which carry history. If I say, for instance, 'ice cream'—just say ice cream. What comes immediately? It's not just the word, is it? A cornet came, with a swirl of ice cream. And then I'm on the beach and there's donkeys. All sorts of things—Blackpool and stuff. All these things come up just with the word 'ice cream.' If you said it to me another time, I might get a whole load of different history. And there comes with it this deliciousness. Got to have an ice cream.

Whenever we have a word, we always bring with it our understanding, which is historical, and our emotional involvement in whatever we're conceiving. And that's okay. You need it in ordinary life. But here, in our meditation, we actually want to see that process—and how it stops us from directly experiencing what we're actually experiencing.

So, for instance, today we had lasagna. Am I correct? I think it was lasagna. I'm sure there'll be amongst us a specialised cook who knows exactly what a lasagna ought to be, how it should be cooked. So the pasta was not al dente, you see. It wasn't quite right. Teeth should go through it, but there should be a hardness to it. It shouldn't be too soft. If there's a little hardness in the middle, it's not properly cooked.

Anyone approaching that meal with a concept of what lasagna ought to be—because they're an expert lasagna connoisseur—might not like it at all. They might form a real aversion, unable to eat it. You get that with gourmets, don't you? 'It's terrible, take it away, I can't stand it.' And it's perfectly good food.

So as we're eating, we can see how concept affects us. Take the chips. When the chips came, I thought, oh, lovely. But I had no vinegar, so I could feel this disappointment. I had salt, but no vinegar. Where's the vinegar? And I thought, well, relax. It's not the end of the world. Chips without vinegar. No HP. Terrible. This just arises naturally because of my conditioning with chips. What can you do?

If you battle that—if you think, well, you shouldn't be thinking that, that's terrible—that's just suppressive, isn't it? You're layering another negativity on top. So here we are, taking this position always behind the mind, if you'll excuse that image, just watching things arise and pass away.

What is there, really? Sensations coming from the body—pleasant, unpleasant. Feelings from the heart—pleasant, unpleasant. Thoughts and images. That's it. And it all works in unison with different little habits, producing this personality. The personality changes, doesn't it? You're this way with one person, slightly different with another, slightly different again when you're by yourself. It's not as though personality is a static thing. It's got all sorts of shades and nuances depending on the situation. Different types of habits arise.

Next time you happen to talk to a policeman, just watch your body. Or even seeing a policeman. 'Not me.' All the guilt comes up. 'Not me. I didn't do it.' Or when you're standing next to somebody over whom you have some position—just watch your body posture. You always lift it. Lift your chin. Even if the person is six foot six. Just engage. And if you walk into a room of somebody you have to have respect for—even a doctor, and very few people have the old respect for doctors—but even so, walking in to see a doctor, just notice: you lower yourself a bit.

One of the more obvious ones is when you meet little children. You suddenly take on this baby voice and act in a stupid way. The kid thinks there's something wrong with this adult. As far as you're concerned, you have this special communication with a child. 'Hello, how are you doing?'

So here we are, taking this position within ourselves, and the process is a detachment. We're not getting involved. It's one of allowing things to manifest and watching them die away. Very passive, not active. We're not manufacturing anything in the mind. What it's leading us to is a stillness of thought, a complete calmness of the heart, and a stillness of the body. Silence in the mind, calmness in the heart, stillness in the body. That's what *vipassanā* leads you to. It brings all that energy finally rolling down to this perfect stasis. Perfect stasis.

Now, if that was it—if that was the end of the plot—then of course that would be the end of the practice. You would just meditate, come to this end point, and that would be it.

If you go back to the Buddha's life, he's struggling to find a way out of his question. Why do we suffer? Why are we unhappy? Why don't we find perfect fulfillment? Why am I here? All these existential questions. And just as an aside, remember that he recalls a point in childhood. This is really very crucial, very important. These stories that come through give you a pointer as to where the insight about going beyond suffering comes from.

He's tried all these different methods—the absorptions and the mortifications. And he comes to this point where he remembers that moment in childhood, watching his father doing the ploughing ceremony. What is it about the attention he had there that's different from all the attention he'd developed through practice with his teachers, through his mortification? It goes back to that mind the child has—best recognised before seven, that pre-conceptual stage, before the mind begins to really proliferate. You can see it especially in young children when they encounter something they've never seen before—a bug or something.

I have a picture of two little girls watching a bug, and it's perfect. They just lock on to it. The world shuts down and all they know is this little bug. And the jaw drops.

That's why in your meditation the jaw has to be relaxed. The jaw and the tongue are intimately connected to thought. Sometimes, if you watch, you'll actually catch your tongue moving with thought. It's already ready to speak, just tickling away on the roof of your mouth. By relaxing that, you immediately relax the whole process of thinking.

Only after the child has truly observed this little bug—absorbed what it's looking at—will it ask for its name. And once it's told it's a beetle, it has a concept and a history. So the next time it sees a beetle, it's much more interested in telling the parent that it recognises what it is. 'A beetle!' But it's not seeing the beetle. It's not seeing the beetle like it saw the beetle before. From now on, all beetles are seen with that history, with that word, with that concept. Even if the beetle is slightly different, it's still a beetle. That's a beetle. That's the end of it.

And that's what we're doing. We're not seeing what's coming in with clarity—there's too much historical garbage attached to everything we experience. So here, we're trying to cleanse that. We go through the process of very gently allow-

ing the mind to calm down, to bring it to a stop. We let these emotions express themselves, because that's the emotional history we have. That's the baggage we're carrying from all the past. And we allow it to pass away, to burn itself out.

Now, if that were the end of the process, when the Buddha was enlightened, that would have been it, wouldn't it? He'd have just turned into a blob. He'd have sat there and people would have come and said, 'What's wrong with you?' And he wouldn't be able to speak. He'd have just said, 'Ugh,' or something. 'Enlightened. Shut up. Go away.' So he'd have just sat there and done nothing because he's done it. He's perfectly happy.

But peculiarly enough, that doesn't happen at all. The first thought—the first thoughts that arise in his mind—is: Who? Who can I teach this to? So now we have something very different arising. There must be some connection between this wisdom, this intelligence we have, and the world it finds itself in, and the people it finds itself connected to.

This is what's put into the Eightfold Path. As soon as there is right understanding, there moves into a right attitude. It happens naturally. We do have exercises—we do mettā practice, developing goodwill, developing compassion. There are all sorts of practices in Buddhism to do that. But actually, it's not necessary, because that wisdom will always want to express itself.

How do we know this wisdom always wants to express itself? Because this same intelligence, which has now become, shall we say, very wise—when it was deluded, it wanted to express itself. This intelligence we have, this intuitive intelligence, is always in a state of wanting to express what it knows. And the reason is that it doesn't know what it knows until it's expressed. If it did not express anything, it would stay in a complete state of original ignorance. That's the beginning of the Eightfold Path, the one we chant in the morning: *avijjā*, not knowing.

This ignorance isn't a culpable thing. It's not as though we're evil because we don't know. We don't know because we don't know. It's like little children—they don't know. They have to be taught. It's simply a case of not knowing. The inner quality of intelligence is that it wants to know. That's how it's defined. Intelligence wants to know. And in wanting to know, it needs to be able to know it knows. It can only know it knows when it expresses something—when it says something, paints something, creates music, talks to people, relates to people, does something in the world, creates something in the world. A business, whatever it is. These are all expressions of either the delusive nature in our intelligence or its wisdom nature.

In other words, you can't exist and not express. Otherwise you just remain a vegetable. So there's the Buddha. He's become fully enlightened. And he says, 'I've attained the unconditioned consciousness.' Unconditioned. Perhaps a better word is unbound, unbounded.

The intelligence that we have is bounded, caught up in the sensual world. It thinks itself to be what it sees, and the seeing process. It experiences itself as not only the hearing, but 'I hear, I am the one who hears.' That binds us to hearing, and it binds us to seeking in hearing the happiness that it craves.

What is suffering? That's not a definition of suffering. What is it that is suffering? Does the body suffer? When you get pain in the knees, is the body suffering? It's just a sensation, isn't it? The knee isn't saying, 'Ouch, I'm suffering.' The knee is just giving off certain sensations. When you're depressed and the depression is there in front of you, is the depression depressed about being depressed? The depression is just a feeling. It doesn't have any intelligence. It doesn't know anything. It's just there as depression. Does the intellect understand what it's actually saying? Words are just little symbols, aren't they?

So that which understands, that which has a relationship to emotions, that which has knowledge and understanding of sensations from the body—that is something else. It must be that that suffers. The answer lies not in the pain of the body, or in the emotional state of the heart, or in the way the mind thinks, but in the relationship that this intelligence has to the psychophysical organism it finds itself in.

So there's an intimate link between the wisdom we gain from observing ourselves, the purity we gain from allowing these emotions to expend their energy, and the new attitudes that arise in the heart—attitudes we recognise as sharing, love, giving, generosity, compassion, sympathetic joy. All of this arises because of the communication we have with other people.

But when that love drops further outward, as it were, into expression—what use is it if you're stuck there? If you went to a cave and just sat there saying, 'May all beings be happy'—well, you might be doing something. Of course you might. I'm not being cynical about this. You might be sending out colossal waves of love, changing the world and all that. But in a sense, it might also be just you in this cave feeling very happy about how much you love people. And if somebody comes along and says, 'Can you help me shift this bowl?' you say, 'Go away. Don't disturb me, I'm in a state of perfect love here.'

You can get stuck at these stages. You might think the whole purpose of life is just to sit and meditate and get into this perfect state of peace and happiness. But that's not what the Buddha did. Remember, he's the exemplar, the paradigm of our path. Or you might think, 'Well, in that case, I'll stop that attitude and just develop this huge compassion, the Buddha heart.' But that just turns you into a self-regarding person. You just sit there beaming out this love.

So it has to move out, it has to express itself—and it expresses itself through right speech, right action, and right livelihood. You can see how the Eightfold Path just follows, one after the other. The way we speak, the way we communicate, is an expression of that heart—the kindness, the compassion, the sympathy, the joyfulness—which is itself an expression of our understanding, of the way we relate to the world.

When we start doing something, it's done with that attention, because that's what this intelligence is—a state of attention. And that's a nice word in English, because there's also the word 'attend,' to attend to. Nurses attend to their patients. In that word there's almost an inclusive idea of caring—attention and care, care and attention. You could say those are the hallmarks of your daily life. Some things require more attention, like a phone call. Some things require more care, like when you're cooking. Be careful.

The two are one and the same, but they come from, shall we say, a different type of relationship. One is more based on the intellect, on understanding; the other is more based in the heart, on a sense of care. They're always there together. So now you can see how this intelligence—which we've been training to sit back and watch, to understand and see what's going on—begins to come down into the attitude, into the heart. And how it begins to flow outward into the world in the way we speak and the way we act, and finally into the very livelihood that we have.

Here's the Buddha putting livelihood in the path. Logically speaking, there's no need to include it because it's already covered by right action. But such is his understanding of the fact that most of our lives are spent doing something—unless we're unfortunate not to have a job, though even then, in the West anyway, jobs come and go. So now, your attitude. What is your attitude to the work you're doing?

Yesterday I was talking to somebody going through one of these awful periods—that vanity about what they're doing, the uselessness, 'Why am I doing this, it means nothing to me,' and all that. What you often find when you get into that

mood is that it's coming again from this idea of self. All we're concerned about is making the job interesting to me. What's it for me? How much am I earning? And there's always going to be dissatisfaction, because the 'I' always wants to aggrandise. That's the self—it always wants to accumulate. The more it accumulates, the safer it feels. You'd feel much safer with a million pounds in the bank than just a hundred. I would. You'd have this fallback.

What's missing is that connection with the other person. As soon as we lose that, people become objects. You're just using them to fulfil your desires. And that's bound to bring dissatisfaction, because people refuse to be objects to your desire. They always do something you don't want them to do. And then you get angry and say, 'Why did you do that?'

If we now turn around in ourselves and ask, 'What would be a proper attitude to my work?'—well, there has to be some self-care, obviously. We've tried to make that distinction with our eating: we're not eating just to gain happiness, just to feel blissed out on chips. We're actually trying to feed the body, trying to change our relationship to food, seeing it as medicine, as nourishment. That gives us a very different attitude.

So now, when I'm doing my work, when we're doing work in society, surely the attitude I ought to give out is one of service. Service. As soon as you serve other people, you're immediately in a state of communication with them as people, because you're trying to be of service to them. To be of service to somebody means you have to open up to them as individuals. They have to speak to you. They have to tell you what they want. Even if it's just brushing the streets, for heaven's sake—you're doing it as a service.

This puts a very different timbre on life, doesn't it? A very different shading. We do it naturally with people we love, with family members. We'll do things for them with a good heart and an open heart. And when you do that, you get that good feeling, don't you? You get that glow. So that's the attitude of livelihood—one of being of service.

That doesn't take away the fact that there has to be self-regard as well. You have to do something which is good for you, good for them. In this way you can see how the meditation is preparing us to develop a completely different—not completely, I'm sure you all have this sense of service—is preparing us to develop the attitude of service, and to distinguish between doing something simply for ourselves out of selfish motivations and doing something which is caring for us and caring for the other.

This brings us into that funny area where people get stuck. Should I go for a position? Where does ambition come in? Should I just say, 'I want to serve society, I want to serve people,' and wait for the job to come—only to end up on the dole? Again, if you're serving, what you want to serve is your best, isn't it? If you invite someone round for a meal, you want to serve the best food you can make. You want to offer what you have as the best. If you invite a friend round for beans on toast, it can be depressing. Unless you told them, of course.

So when you offer your services to society, you're offering your best. If there's an opening you feel you can do, you go and offer your service to that. And if you don't get the job you wanted, because you did it out of an attitude of service—in other words, there's an acceptance that you don't fit what they want—then there's no pain, no hurt. The potential to do that job still lies there. It's just that they found somebody else, or whatever.

We had a case just recently at Gaia House where somebody came to apply for one of the managers' jobs. We knew her—she was a fairly regular visitor. And she'd set her heart on becoming a manager. But there was another person who applied for the same position, and eventually it was this other person who got the job. It was like a disaster, really. Weeping, despair. And it was only a year's job. You'd be out after a year. There wasn't some huge life commitment to it. But the suffering she went through because of that belies that.

Even though there was that wanting to serve, there was something else there which attached her to that job. And not getting it brought about the pain. So it's a case of offering ourselves as a service and then recognising that it might not be received, might not be accepted. And that's okay. That's okay. This doesn't stop you from following an ambitious route. There's nothing stopping any of you becoming Prime Minister if you feel that's where your talent lies.

To reinforce all this, you have to take some of the tricks you gain from your meditation retreat into daily life. One of the most powerful is simply to stop. Keep stopping. Very simple occasions—like if the phone rings. When you get the first ring, you don't have to launch yourself at the phone, do you? You can note that the phone is ringing and just relax. Most people will hold on for three rings. I hold on for seven, ten rings for heaven's sake. I'm very patient. Three rings at least. So there's just that recognition—the phone is ringing—and then you finish off what you're doing. You don't just forget, only to find when you come back that you've lost your place. Then the next ring goes, you pick it up on the third, and you're calm, collected, not in a rush—and therefore open to the telephone call.

After you've set yourself a task at work or in your daily life, if you're aware of that intention, put an end time to it. For instance, I mess around a lot with this crazy computer stuff. And if I don't put a time on it, two hours pass. I'm sure you've all experienced that. You wake up and two hours are gone. Two and a half hours. Whoa! So I've got in the habit—I have this little watch here which gives me a beep every forty minutes. Just stop for a minute. It stops you getting caught up in something.

When you set yourself a job, no matter what it is, no matter the length—you could just be mowing the lawn—say to yourself that at the end of it, you'll stop. Just relax. And then the accumulation of that job—maybe you got a bit of irritation, who knows, maybe you picked up some irritation, maybe you developed unwittingly some rush, some pressure around it—just stop, let it go, let it go. In this way, throughout the day, we're constantly bringing ourselves back to this very posture, this posture of just being here. Then you move again from that base.

For those of you who haven't done this before, it's important to do meditation in the morning and evening. Two hours is good, but twenty minutes is enough. You just need enough time to access this level of consciousness—a way of being in the world. Just remind yourself: this is where I'm supposed to be all day. And then throughout the day you do these little stoppings. Keep bringing yourself back. Remember how it was in that sitting.

Then in the evening when you come back—always better before you eat, before you have an evening ahead of you—just sit for twenty minutes and see what you've accumulated during the day. The tensions, the irritations, the disappointment. Just let them calm down, calm down. And of course it makes your evening much more pleasant. If you do it too late, you just fall asleep. If you do it just before bed, it's really just preparation for falling asleep. Nothing happens. So do it when you're still awake, especially before you eat. And then you'll see it has an effect on the evening.

So just very slowly, very slowly. And after each of these meditations, just a moment of developing mettā, goodwill, which we'll do tomorrow. That prepares this intelligence to move into the world with a proper attitude. So that's the path in a nutshell.

Reflections on Polarization: A Dharma Perspective on Division and Understanding

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 15 min

Originally given as *Reflections on Polarization: A Dharma Perspective on Division and Understanding* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this dharma talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the phenomenon of social and political polarization through the lens of Buddhist psychology and ethics. Drawing from the Madhupiṇḍika Sutta (MN 18), he explains how the process of proliferation (papañca) - from sense contact through perception to mental elaboration - creates the conditions for division and conflict.

Bhante explores how identity-based thinking, rooted in the three conceits (māna), fuels polarization by creating in-groups and out-groups. He demonstrates how the not-self (anattā) teaching reveals the suffering inherent in clinging to fixed positions and tribal identities. The talk addresses contemporary issues including immigration debates, social media echo chambers, and conspiracy theories, showing how they manifest the Buddha's insights about papañca and the proliferating mind.

Offering practical solutions, Bhante suggests ways to work with our own biases and prejudices through meditation practice, encouraging open dialogue across different viewpoints. He emphasizes the importance of good companionship (kalyāṇamittatā) and provides concrete methods for transforming aversion and hatred into understanding and compassion. This talk offers valuable guidance for maintaining Right Awareness (sammā sati) and Right Intention in our polarized times.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa — Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

I'm going to offer some reflections on polarization. I've been researching this topic, and I'm trying to situate it within the Dharma of the Buddha.

Polarization often happens in times of change, when people take positions. This would be fine, except for identity. In my research, identity seems to be the primary cause of polarization — or at least its foundation. And of course, that's at the root of suffering, according to the Buddha's not-self doctrine.

Each party thinks of itself as morally superior, hence more virtuous, more intelligent and, of course, more patriotic. This is the working of the self that thrives on comparison — not on the various definitions of what virtue might be, but on personalising and criticising the person. Hence the three conceits: I'm better than you, I'm worse than you, and the more subtle conceit, I'm equal. This last one is what supports group identity. You find your companions, and that group now compares itself with other groups.

When it comes to immigration, for instance, we have those who accept it and even say we need more of it. And the opposite, of course — those who say it's a conspiracy to replace the white race. These people see each other as existential threats because they've personalised it. Disagreements are no longer about policy, but about who you are.

Now we as Dhammikas — *Dhammika* was the original way that followers of the Buddha referred to themselves, followers of the true law — we need to be aware when we're identifying with a group, and not lose the objective perspective that enables us to criticise their stance on any particular topic. For instance, if there's a general agreement in the group that immigration has gone too far, especially since COVID, then we also need to know that there are changes happening in the European Convention of Human Rights, which also protect our own freedoms.

All this leads to a hardening of positions, a moralising of areas such as public health, climate crisis and wealth. They become moral absolutes, such that any compromise is experienced as betrayal. Because of the distortion of conceit, such positions fail to see that interconnectedness, interrelatedness, interdependence that we talk about.

For instance, withdrawing international aid — in other words, not sharing our wealth — leads to greater poverty. It should not be a surprise that the numbers grow of people wanting to escape that very poverty and destitution. This fact that richer countries are reducing aid also tells us something about this neoliberal order and its economic system — one that has allowed the market to rule without any social responsibility, following the dictum, "greed is good."

The system has produced such uncertainty that more and more people feel their jobs are insecure, causing anxiety about loss of status and wealth. Such unhealthy and unwholesome mental states drive people to believe anyone who says they've got the answer. All these fears — around loss of work, rising cost of living, immigration, climate — are coupled with a growing despair that normal institutions are incapable of bettering the situation.

This leads to a loss of confidence in political parties, unions, religious organizations, and other civic institutions that once were able to mediate and bring needed change. It's no wonder that people start to join mass movements, emotionally manipulated by demagogues and led by populists who deceive them into believing they are working for the common good.

What has made everything exponentially worse, of course, is social media. From the heady days when it was believed the internet would bring a harmonious world community, we're descending into a worldwide verbal brawl. At the moment it's words, but it could soon become violent action. Witness the storming of the Capitol by MAGA devotees.

The algorithms feed on our natural bent for threat and opposition, rather than helping us to welcome and cooperate. They herd people into what are called epistemic silos — isolated groups of like-minded people that go on to intensify the situation, even to the point of conspiracies. This, of course, has actually happened many times in history, leading to civil wars. Europe's been full of civil wars.

Something like this happened in our tiny village of Whitegrit. A neighbour working for the Shropshire Council to bring more wealth to the area won a grant — a million pounds, actually — from the lottery fund. A local eco-warrior saw this as a danger, fearing it would turn the area into a holiday resort. There were meetings and finally a confrontation with the grant receiver. Young men used foul language, happily stamped out by a retired magistrate. Eventually everything calmed down.

In the meantime, an email went round full of expletives calling for resistance. Frankly, the whole fracas was beyond pathetic. To this day, I haven't seen any change and still wonder what happened to the money. But all the markers were there. Moral outrage: "What right has the Shropshire Council to do this to us? We're in Powys, Wales." Simplified narrative: "It's going to ruin the area." Conspiracy theories: "What else are the council going to do?" And group validation: "I was told the meeting at the pub went very well."

It's a wonder they didn't turn up armed with picks, shovels, and trowels — the local population being farmers and retired well-to-do. But what stays with me is the amount of anger it generated. Quite weird.

The consequence of these silos is that they create realities which can't coexist with other realities. That's the problem with conspiracies. This is also a consequence of the postmodernism that questioned objective truth, declaring we all have our own realities, hence all is relative. So we move to post-truth and, of course, outright lying.

Now, the Buddha taught that the whole of the spiritual life was good companionship. We're interdependent beings. And of course, the obverse is also true: a den of thieves. "Good companionship" is equally necessary to invoke false narratives and conspiracies. The disturbing fact is that feedback loops intensify — thoughts feed on thoughts, emotions on emotions — all backed by social media and the rewards of finding such friends: the feeling of safety, emotional support, and ideological fantasising.

The Buddha tells us about this inner process very clearly and how it produces proliferation. The Pali word is *papañca*, which I particularly like. Sense consciousness arises from the base of the eye, ear, nose, tongue, body, and mind, dependent on those senses. When you have an object, a sense base, and consciousness, that's what he calls contact. Contact is a requirement for feeling. What we feel, we perceive. What we perceive, we think about. What we think about, we proliferate. What we proliferate is the source from which judgments driven by proliferating perceptions beset a person. This occurs across all the senses. For those of you who are interested, that's from the Honeyball discourse in the Middle Length Sayings, number 18.

The same process is magnified between people. Moral outrage rewarded by groups leads to certainty, and the group reinforces itself by denigrating the opposition, leading to a loss of empathy and a loss of communication. This distrust simply hardens positions, especially where the others are seen as potential threats. And again, there are the emotional rewards of like-minded friends.

So how can we reverse this process, or at least undermine it? We have here the basic cause: identity — how people define themselves. This identity narrows to a particular cause, creating a barrier that expels anyone who disagrees and then places verbal and other weapons on that barrier to destroy those it describes as enemies.

For such alienated groups, one approach is to point to a higher identity that embraces, to some extent, those of other parties. This is the work of politics, of course. When it comes to immigration, for instance, both sides of the argument need to be lifted to a greater overall view of the situation. And this can be done through the very media that supports polarisation — by bringing opposing groups to dispute in the open. No matter how distasteful we may find some of the people, they need to be engaged in open debate.

When we identify with a cause, everything becomes saturated with me — and me is always right. We might refer to this as ego, but I prefer the old word pride. Pride finds it hard to compromise, and any giving in to the opposition is seen as shaming betrayal. But once we soften the grip and admit that no one has total exclusive truth, once we open up to another's views, compromise allows a wise solution. These are perspectives that can accommodate different views. Enemies can become people we can discuss and argue with. And there's our Dharma practice.

As ordinary citizens, we need to make our views known to politicians, to our local MP, and whenever possible encourage the government to control media content. We also need to be sensitive to journalists — to make sure we know who are non-partisan and independent. We need to be able to tell facts from comment. And when it comes to media, to limit the amount and type we allow into our hearts.

We also have to admit to our biases. Biases can be explicit — we're aware of them — or implicit — we're not. Prejudices, meanwhile, are those biases we're actively developing. Acknowledging biases allows us to counteract their effect. It's virtually impossible not to have religious, racial, gender, and class bias. It's in the DNA of our culture. We may find that difficult to accept, but unless we're aware of them, they'll affect our behaviour. And we may be embarrassed by Freudian slips — suddenly becoming self-defensive or aggressive when accused.

Practising *mettā* is not just a contemplative exercise. It means approaching people or media we're strongly against with a heart that's open to understanding where they come from. And it would really help to find a discussion group — online, or better still in person — set up to bring people of differing views into dialogue with each other.

This leads us to realise how destructive it is to shame other people — calling them ignorant, for instance. This happened after the Brexit referendum. And there's no point showering people with facts if they don't trust us. The wisest approach is the Buddha's own: understand the other's position and question it before launching into our own views and opinions.

So what do we do when a racist, sexist, religious, gender, or any other biased thought comes into the mind? We might feel guilty and push the thought away without really accepting it. That conditioning hasn't been allowed to manifest, so it continues to fester. If instead we allow the bias to manifest in our minds and hearts, we can begin to undermine it.

First, there's acceptance: "This is a bias in my heart." Once I accept it, I can recognise it as unwholesome. Usually it arises because we've seen or heard someone whom the bias hates. So we can bring that person to mind, see the situation from their point of view. We can apologise to them as an active Dharma practice within ourselves. Then we can hold them in a caring embrace. You can't hate and care at the same time.

Sometimes you have to be creative with this process of undermining biases. If we're sitting in meditation and one of these biases comes up, you might find it just as useful to simply sit with the aversion — just the feeling of it. What we're doing is allowing that bad energy to exhaust itself. And if we stay to the very end, to the point where the aversion disappears, we might experience it transforming into its opposite. Suddenly the heart is full of love or peacefulness or some other positive state.

Nothing is lost in allowing these negative states to come up and pass away. They're always changing towards their opposites. This is what we find in Right Attitude of the Eightfold Path, which is stated as going from greed to generosity, hatred to love, and cruelty to compassion. It happens naturally in meditation, as long as we allow the heart full freedom to express itself.

I can only hope my words have been of some assistance, that they haven't caused confusion. Write to me if they have, by the way. And may your practice liberate you from all suffering — sooner rather than later.

PART 8

The Goal



*Nibbānaṃ paramaṃ sukhaṃ — Nibbāna is the ultimate
bliss*

Exploring Dukkha

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 43 min

Originally given as *Exploring Dukkha* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this dharma talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines dukkha - often translated as suffering but more accurately understood as unsatisfactoriness or life being 'a hard place.' He explores the three types of dukkha, beginning with ordinary suffering rooted in wrong view and the psychological cycles that perpetuate our distress.

Drawing on the Buddha's core teaching, Bhante explains how our meditation practice offers a third way beyond suppression and indulgence - the transcendent position of mindful awareness. Through developing Right Awareness (sammā sati), we learn to objectify our experiences rather than identify with them, discovering the liberating insight of anattā (not-self).

The talk weaves together practical meditation guidance with profound psychological insights, explaining how we construct our experienced world through mind and how the three characteristics - impermanence (anicca), unsatisfactoriness (dukkha), and not-self (anattā) - work together to deconstruct our fundamental delusions. Bhante emphasizes that awakening comes through understanding rather than force, offering hope that small tastes of nibbāna are available in daily life through practices like mindful eating and letting go of unnecessary desires.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa — Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-enlightened one.

The Buddha's teaching is a mandala. It doesn't matter at which point you enter it — you end up touching all parts of its petals, and somewhere along the line you touch the base. It's one whole teaching, and it makes sense as a whole. Just occasionally I allow myself to wander around and see where it takes me.

My entrance point is this little word which is central to the Buddha's teaching: *dukkha*. Various etymologies have been put to this word, various roots where it comes from. One of the strangest, I think — because in those days the early commentators were creative in their etymology; if a word sounded like something else, it must have its root there — is an axle where the rod that goes into the bracket doesn't fit properly. You get that? It's not... you get that crunch. But the most obvious etymology is simply a hard space, or a hard place.

What the Buddha is saying is that this life is a hard place. If he had left it at that, we'd have been stuck in the existential horror of just being in a hard place and not being able to make much sense of it. But through his own investigations, he discovered at least the psychological cause for it — the deeper causes, but at least the psychological cause — which we translate slightly badly as desire. And then, of course, the announcement that there is an end to it. There is an end to *dukkha*. It is possible to come to an end of *dukkha*, which is not annihilation, by the way.

What does he mean by *dukkha*, this word of a hard place? The first kind is rather comically called *dukkha-dukkha*, which means simply the suffering of ordinary suffering. I don't think I have to go into that too deeply. That's just the pains in the body, the emotional states we come across. Even these pains in the body are not, strictly speaking, what he's referring to as *dukkha*, although they are unpleasant.

These emotional states that we get into, these mental states, have their root cause in some sort of wrong view. We aren't seeing things properly. We don't have a right perspective. And this wrong perspective causes us to form wrong relationships. That wrong relationship includes within it a whole set of emotional responses which we end up conditioning. These emotional responses, because we can't find our way out of them, reinforce the original wrong view. So we get caught up in this cycle.

This cycle of going round and round — that's the root meaning of the word *kamma*. That's what we mean in Buddhism by *kamma*. It's not, strictly speaking, what happens to you on the outside. You can also call that *kamma*. But in terms of what we're trying to do, which is come to the end of suffering, the *kamma* the Buddha is referring to is these cycles within our own head. And these cycles within our own head are then projected onto the world, so we keep recreating similar situations. Through our dullness, we blame the other. It's got to be my parents. I

would never have ended up like this were it not for my mother. She comes in for a lot of stick, poor mother. And then there's society, education, educators. Oh my goodness. Everybody has caused me this dreadful suffering.

This sense of ordinary *dukkha*, this sense of ordinary suffering, has its root cause in some sort of wrong view. We're not seeing things properly. We'll come to that in time. Our meditation is concerned with undermining that whole process — that's what we're doing when we practise vipassanā. Vipassanā is not simply a correction of view, though that's its actual main point. But fortunately, as one of the gifts of vipassanā, the purification of the heart takes place of its own. You don't have to do anything to purify the heart. In fact, if you try to purify your heart, it's a bit like the blind leading the blind. It's the very deluded part of ourselves trying to do something about the effects of its own delusion. And you just end up in a mess.

When we're sitting here and this *dukkha*, these mental states arise, what possibilities have you got? What can you do about them? One option, of course, is to suppress it, to turn away from it, turn your attention somewhere else. If you feel lonely, turn the TV on. Easy enough. But it's there. It's a conditioning within the mind that hasn't been dealt with. We know that from our own Western psychology. And it sits there, just bubbling away, boiling away, burning, burning. This is the Buddha's old expression of burning.

The only other option is to indulge it. If you indulge loneliness, you get into self-pity. Why me? And that self-pity simply fuels the sense of loneliness more and more. Eventually you end up on Westminster Bridge on Prozac.

Here we are, stuck with a feeling of me wanting to do something about myself. As soon as I want to do something about myself, as soon as I want to change myself, I have to engage with this state of mind. And this engagement leaves me with two options. I can either suppress it — try to destroy it, kill it, turn away from it, ignore it — or I can try to do something about it and get involved in it. Both sides, we begin to realise, are actually going to cause more suffering. More suffering.

Through vipassanā, we discover a third position. Imagine a triangle, with the base being this suppression-indulgence, suppression-indulgence, suppression-indulgence, creating a vicious circle. And at the top of the triangle — or the cone perhaps, the circle of the cone. That's good, I never thought of that. Yes, that's good. The vicious circle at the base of the cone. That's a good one. And as you

climb up the cone, as you lift yourself out of that involvement with what the heart is presenting you, you're discovering a transcendental position. It's transcendent of this game, of this play. It's transcendent.

From this vantage point, you're able to discover a place where you're looking at something rather than being involved in it. When you shift your consciousness to that point, when you lift yourself up to become the onlooker, the experiencer of what's going on inside you, you've discovered a different level of consciousness. It's not the same as a consciousness that considers itself emotional: 'I am happy. I am sad.' It's not the same as a thought consciousness: 'I think, therefore I am.' And it's not the same as a body consciousness: 'I am this body.' It's something which is, shall we say, transcendent of all that.

You're discovering a position where everything that previously in our lives we've experienced as subject — 'This is me' — becomes objectified, turned into an object. As soon as we do that, we have, as it were, discovered the understanding of *anattā*, this very difficult doctrine of not-self.

When the Buddha talks about not-self, that's not a philosophical or metaphysical position. He's not saying there is no self. If he were in his day to say there is no self, he would have been in constant argument with people who said there was. He didn't have to argue. The *anattā* doctrine, the doctrine of not-self, is simply a skilful tool. Whatever you experience — within yourself or without yourself — can be looked at, and you can say, 'This is not me. This is not me.' Which doesn't deny the fact that there may be something. We'll come to that in a bit. It's just a very skilful tool with which we can say, 'This is not me.'

That's the purpose of accessing that level of consciousness. Every time you experience something — a pain in the knee — you can look at it, feel it, sense it. And because of that distance you've created, because you haven't fallen into the error of suppressing it, turning away from it — 'I don't want to feel this' — or indulging it — 'Oh, my knee' — all that stuff. Because you're there, just feeling, sensing, experiencing the pain, it's an object. You're looking at it. If it's an object, it can't be the subject. It's as simple as that.

Even though I say it's as simple as that, when the pain gets too heavy — if you feel that your knee is just about to explode — all that lovely doctrine disappears. This not-self business takes us so far, but when it comes to the hard point, we immediately collapse into the old level of consciousness of being a human being.

Now, level of consciousness here is not to be confused with a state of mind. What I'm referring to — the word in Pali, for some of you who know, is *citta*. A state of mind is whether you're happy, whether you're sad, the thoughts that go around that, the physical feelings that arise with that. All that you can say is a state, a state of mind.

A level of consciousness, by contrast, is concerned with how we understand things. One of the obvious leaps of consciousness that happens to the vast majority of human beings occurs around the age of seven. Two important things happen to us then. First, we shift from a universe which has no basic moral laws to one in which suddenly there is right and wrong. This is the truth within the myth of the Garden of Eden. The other thing, of course, is that we stop believing in our imagination as being real. It has to be reality-tested.

That's why now we're in this pitiful situation of being unable to believe that Father Christmas will come down that chimney and present us a present. Which is sad, isn't it? Those magic days, they've all gone, disappeared. We now live in this rather terrible reality. So that shift, you see, is a change in the way that young consciousness understands and sees the world.

When the Buddha's talking about the process of awakening, in our language, in our terminology, it is a movement within consciousness itself. The root problem lies in consciousness itself. It's consciousness itself that knows which doesn't know properly. That's why it's so difficult for us to awaken — because that which is trying to awaken is that which is deluded. And the whole definition of delusion is that you don't know where the delusion is. If you knew where the delusion was, you wouldn't be deluded.

So here's the Buddha with his very clever teaching saying, 'Listen, don't worry about who you are. Don't get involved in that question of who you are, but who you are not.' If you can find who you are not, eventually you should end up finding out who you are. The doctrine of *anattā*, the doctrine of not-self, is a teaching tool. It's not a philosophical statement.

In our meditation, through the process of distancing from what we experience, that little distance which objectifies what we're looking at is taking us backwards. So we're not the body, we're not the emotion, we're not thought. And then we're stuck with this: 'I must be the thinker, the knower, the witness.' So now we make that final mistake of thinking that we are that consciousness itself.

The mistake there is one of, shall we say, a mirror. When you look at your face in the mirror, generally speaking you believe that's how people see you. Big mistake! Because they see your face the other way around. It's only when you use two mirrors that you realise how big your ears are. I was very upset with my sister. I was surprised at the size of my ears when I cut my hair off. It can hurt. So it's coming to recognise that what we see in the mirror isn't actually what people see.

When we're at that level, consciousness feels its presence within the mind. A good example is when you're watching TV and you can see yourself reflected in the screen. Now you can decide: are you going to watch the programme or watch yourself watching it? But even as you're watching TV, you're aware of that reflection. So there's a slippage. There are moments of consciousness absorbed in the programme, but also moments switching over to this image of yourself in the television screen. Consciousness oscillates like that.

That's what's happening when we become very self-aware of being the onlooker, the witness, the feeler, the experiencer of what we're actually experiencing — whether it's a pain, an emotion, a sound, something we're looking at. That's why in meditation there's always this accent on bringing ourselves back into the present moment. The immediate present moment, which isn't any longer than a millisecond, if that. And that's what we mean by concentration.

Now whenever you say 'concentration' to somebody, you always get this tension. 'You've got to concentrate.' Knitted forehead. I remember as a kid getting a clout on the back of the head because I wasn't concentrating. This idea of force. But actually, concentration comes about mainly through interest. Did you have any problem concentrating when you were interested in something? It doesn't arise, does it? If you're interested, there's an immediate giving of oneself to what you're actually doing.

In our meditation, again, there is this wanting to know. That's the essence of this Buddha mind within us — it wants to know. And that wanting to know, if you join into it, will draw you into the investigation of things arising and passing away. That in itself is strong enough to make us focus in and in to a single point.

But when that single point appears — very occasionally, virtually impossible on a weekend retreat, I'm sorry to say, although I know you're probably good enough to get there — there is that single point where there isn't time for reflection. Those are the moments of pure vipassanā. Those are the moments when con-

sciousness is experiencing itself in its purity. And at that point, to confuse matters, the object-subject relationship collapses. There's no object and there's no subject. There's just direct experience.

We get it occasionally in our lives as adults, though it's very difficult. You'll get it, for instance, just for a moment when you trap your finger in the door. There's a single moment of pure pain, and there's nobody experiencing it. It's only the moment afterwards that you say, 'Oh, my thumb.' Just that moment of absolute pure stillness within the present moment.

When you're meditating, watching the rising and falling of the breath and looking at its quality of transience, its quality of process, what you're trying to do is see it more and more closely. So closely that you begin to break up the idea that somebody's breathing, that there is anything called a breath. That's only a mental idea.

All there are are minute moments of sensations arising into consciousness. From these minute moments, the mind builds up a concept whereby you can hold a certain length of time within which you call it the in-breath or the out-breath. And that's all mentation — all done in the mind. The only thing actually happening in terms of input are these little sparky moments of sensations.

To get down to that level is to deconstruct the way we construct the world around us. It's to begin to see that everything we experience is being totally, completely manufactured by the mind. Everything. Even this room — you wouldn't doubt its objective existence in the sense that if we all left, the room wouldn't disappear. The room has, in a sense, its own being, using that word very loosely. But when we walk into this room, there aren't as many rooms as there are people here, because each of us experiences it in our own way. In this sense, we're living in a world which is completely mind-made.

This dukkha that we're looking at — one of the ways the Buddha talks about it is *loke dukkha*, *dukkha nirodha*. It's in this world that there is suffering, this unpleasantness, and there is an end to it in this world. When he defines 'in this world,' he defines it as this body, mind and heart. In his terms, for those of you who know, it would have been the five aggregates.

So this whole world we're living in, which no doubt has an objective existence outside us, is recreated by us — and we have to live within that creation. What we do, of course, is project all our ways of looking onto the world we're living in. And if that projection is wrong, if it's unwholesome, unskillful, then it's not surprising that the world should mirror that back to us.

For instance, if I have an angry disposition, I shouldn't be surprised that people get angry with me. Because I'm exciting it in them. There's a resonance between us, isn't there? Even though there's no direct contact within our emotions, there's a resonance. We can feel another person's emotions against our own hearts. So if I go into a situation angry, that resonates. Everybody comes back at me angry. Or fearful, or they run away — which is preferred.

Now, if you really think this body is what you are — taking it at that absolute basic level — then two things follow. First, it has to be protected at all costs. That's the most fundamental thing, isn't it? It's what we want from our government: safety first. Prosperity next, but definitely safety first. So we try to make the world safe, safe at all levels.

That drive for safety, of course, overreaches itself. We feel far safer with a million pounds in the bank than ten thousand — or than none, definitely. So there's that accumulation, that greed. And greed steps into other people's territory. You can see how the world, especially at the moment through our economic system, is constantly trying to fill this gap, this lack, this feeling that any minute now something terrible could happen. So I have to surround myself with security.

This self that we have, this idea of self in the body — seeking safety means that subconsciously it lives in a state of fear. The root emotion of the self is fear. And we touch that fear when death approaches us.

Once we have the understanding that the more I accumulate, the safer I feel, then of course anything that threatens that safety is seen as an enemy. You get your aversion, your pushing away. And if you can't push away what's threatening you, if what you're pushing away is too big, then you run for it. That fight-or-flight response is the other side of the self — presuming always that this body is what I am.

Through the process of insight, as we disengage from that, as we deconstruct all that wrong understanding, the fear lessens. You begin to live in a more benign world. There comes a point through the process of awakening when a person knows quite distinctly that they're not this body. The fully liberated person has no

doubt whatsoever; they know they're not the body. So you can see — if you are now absolutely certain within yourself, through your personal experience, that you are not the body — what can frighten you? That's really why we say the liberated person doesn't have any fear, can't have fear. There's nothing there to be fearful about.

How do we begin to undermine that sense of self? First, it's to use that technique of distancing within our meditation, where noting something is like pointing at it. When you've got a pain in the knee, if you say 'pain, pain,' you're already distancing from it. You have to be careful with this technique because it might become a way of pushing it away — 'Pain, pain.' It's more like an acknowledgement, a clear acknowledgement. And once you've steadied yourself, you go towards it, plunge into the experience of it.

The same applies to our emotions, no matter how painful they are. Distance for a moment and say, this is an emotional state — whatever it might be. Despair, all that sort of stuff. Then once you've gained that equanimity, once you've gained that position of courage, go into the emotion and stay there, watching it as feeling, just as sensations.

If we can stay at that level, the emotion loses its name. Despair is just an awful sickly feeling. Fear is just an awful sickly feeling. And you can stay there with it. All the time, you're just allowing this state — what is it? An energy. That's all it is, a turbulence — to express itself. All these emotional states, remember, all they're saying is, 'Listen to me, I'm very afraid. Help.' They only want to tell you how they feel. That's all. And to allow that to happen is the process of liberating ourselves through understanding dukkha, through understanding suffering.

So the distancing allows us to understand that this is not me, not mine — undermining that fundamental position we hold, that this is me, I am a human being, I am in a sense continuous, in a sense forever. There's this feeling that you're never actually going to die. Everybody else does, but for you it might happen tomorrow. So it's a matter of undermining that, and then going into what you're being presented with to actually see how we create the suffering. How do we create these mental states?

That's when we begin to discover this split of indulging and suppressing, indulging and suppressing. This process of psychology is called in Buddhism the wheel of dependent origination — sometimes they call it interdependent origination —

and it's the psychological teaching of the Buddha. As far as I've read from people who should know better than me, it was completely new within Indian literature. There was nothing like that sort of psychology until the Buddha came.

The Buddha begins with this lovely word, *avijjā*, which means not knowing. So this consciousness we've been talking about begins from a position of not knowing. Sometimes it's translated as ignorance, but that gives it a pejorative, heavy sense — like you're stupid. But it's not that; you just don't know. And from this not knowing, consciousness begins to build up a world. This world is built around the middle part, where we experience things as pleasant or unpleasant, and then we try to add to that accumulation.

Now that process of accumulation, that process of attachment, of holding on to things, grasping on to things — that's what's meant by this word desire. Unfortunately, that word also covers desires we ought to have, such as wanting to meditate continuously. So you have to be careful with it. Sometimes it's translated as craving, which is over the top. What we're really talking about is desires that arise from a wrong view of self.

The picture of the world we build up and live in — this uncomfortable construction — rests on a foundation. When you hit the root of not-self, when you begin to see it's not me, not mine, you're actually taking that foundation away. The whole pack of cards just falls. It's not a case of having to go back step by step. As soon as you see it, the whole delusion collapses.

For instance, suppose somebody comes up on the street and gives you a kick in the butt, then runs off before you can turn around. You might go away thinking, that's the worst thing that's ever happened to me. How could anybody do that? You'd be angry and furious. Then you read in the evening news that it was somebody who'd lost their bottle and was going around kicking people. Suddenly you think, oh well, the guy was a lunatic. He's just gone off his rocker. There's an immediate forgiveness — all because of a change of understanding, a change of view. That's all we're doing. We're trying to undercut the original view we had. And in so doing, the whole pack of cards begins to crumble.

So we have three views. The first is seeing not-self. The second is understanding how we create suffering through attachment, through grasping, through aversion, through suppression. The third is to see the transience of things — to see that everything we're experiencing is only here for this millisecond and then disappears.

You can see this most clearly in the breath. That's why we always begin with the breath as a starting position. First of all, it's always there — or you've got problems. And secondly, because of its movement, especially in the abdomen, it's rising and falling. Just to stay with that flow, that wave of rising and falling, and if you can, to feel how delicious it is. These are very subtle, gentle sensations.

We always live on this high point of wanting our sensational life to be sensational. We're always living at that point where we ought to be in a state of gross happiness, jumping up and down. But there's a much deeper, much more subtle, much more gratifying happiness to be found in peace. And that peace is measured — is found — in the body through these neutral sensations. Just a state of contentment with a simple, neutral feeling. As you get into that, you'll see there's a lovely loveliness there.

You can go down to the river here. That river isn't exciting. It's probably one of the most boring rivers — it just flows and it's flat. On this little corner here there are no ripples, nothing; just this glass plate which continually changes, catching the shades of light. If you watch, if you keep your mind on that and just keep watching, you'll catch its peace. It's trying to use nature like that — the starkness of the trees, the blueness of the sky which never changes in a sense — just to see that there's a real deeper contentment and happiness in stillness, in quiet, in silence. In fact, one of the epithets of Nibbāna is the noble silence.

It's through this process of just looking, just focusing, drawn by interest, that we begin to experience how extraordinarily momentary life actually is. And what's the effect on our psychology when we realise this? There's nothing worth holding on to. There's an immediate release, an immediate stopping of trying to grasp things, keep things as they are. It's a relief. One of the things the Buddha says — which we read out in our little opening ceremony — is that the taste of Nibbāna is the taste of freedom. It's liberation, relief. Every time you get that little sense of relief, of letting go, of just letting be — in all these little pat phrases that you get — these are little touches of Nibbāna.

Tomorrow, I hope I remind you — I probably will forget, as usual — but when you're eating, there's a distinction to be made between satisfaction and contentment. These are just my own distinctions of words. If you want satisfaction, you keep eating until you feel completely full, bloated, and you think that's enough, and then you go and have a sleep.

If you practise your meditation when you're eating, you can feel that draw of greed just for that extra toast. We're promised toast tomorrow. Just for that extra piece of toast and marmalade. And you wait, and you know this is not necessary. This is overeating. Bad for the body. Producing early death. Toast can be lethal, taken in vast quantities. Once you see that — now hold on, this is greed — you just hold on in there. You let the greed come. This wolf. Marmalade after all. And you just wait for the wolf to die. To die, you see. There will come a point where there's no desire in the mind. That's contentment. That is a taste of Nibbāna.

Nibbāna, this awakened state, isn't something totally transcendent from what we can experience here and now. It's something we can get little bites of. But you have to acknowledge it, because this consciousness doesn't know that contentment is actually a better place than satisfaction. It's driven by everything in this society. The whole of our industry, the whole of our advertising is driven towards satisfaction. Only when you begin to realise that satisfaction actually produces more desire, more greed, a non-end to it, a churning of it — only then do you realise there must be a better place. And that's it. But you can't get there without enduring happily, joyously, the suffering. That suffering is not the suffering of hell. It's not going to get worse. It's the suffering of purgatory — the suffering of purging.

I was brought up a Catholic, and we had three distinctive realms: hell, purgatory, and heaven. Hell, you were stuck — you couldn't get out of that one. Couldn't even get a drop of water from heaven. Purgatory was a transient state where you went through sufferings in order to attain the final glory of heaven. Whether these actually exist is not of particular consequence to us here and now. But in terms of mental states, definitely. Those mental states where we see no end to it — the despairs, the sudden impossibility of life — that's hell. Purgatory are those states of mind where we're quite happy to suffer because we know there's an end to it.

So our meditation is 99.999% purgatory. I hold out no great hope for sudden or swift liberation. Neither did the Buddha. He said it was a gradual path, and I shall leave you with this quote. Somebody comes to him and says, listen, this training you've got to be doing — very hard, very painful, very awful. And the Buddha said, yes, it is. But you just keep going and you'll attain Nibbāna. The reply was, Nibbāna, so what? And he says, when you get to Nibbāna, you are contented and with it happy. He's describing his own state of mind: contented and with it happy.

Mindfulness: Time

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 1h03

Originally given as *Mindfulness: Time* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this teaching, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the Buddha's understanding of dukkha (suffering/unsatisfactoriness) and how Right Awareness (sammā sati) offers liberation from self-created mental suffering. Drawing from the Four Noble Truths and the psychology of paṭicca samuppāda (dependent origination), he explains how mindfulness creates space between primary pain and our secondary reactions of craving, aversion, and fear.

The talk explores three levels of identity - body, emotions, and thoughts - and how stepping back into the observer position allows healing without indulgence. Bhante discusses the therapeutic applications of mindfulness in treating depression, anxiety, and grief, while emphasizing the ethical dimension of our responses to life's inevitable challenges.

The teaching concludes with insights into the Buddhist understanding of time, impermanence (anicca), and the gradual recognition of anattā (not-self) through sustained awareness practice. This comprehensive exploration shows how mindfulness-based approaches can lead not only to psychological healing but potentially to complete liberation from suffering.

The general feeling I was getting from people was that therapy was very good at getting them in touch with their stuff, but didn't quite know what to do with it once it was up. Then came the research by John Teasdale here in Cambridge, and of course Kabat-Zinn bringing mindfulness to pain management, depression, anxiety. According to John, there was something like a 90% success rate with mindfulness and panic — people not going back into panic.

It's really about understanding what the Buddha means by *dukkha*, by suffering. Once we're clear on that, we can see the role of mindfulness in undermining it. This understanding is there in the Second Noble Truth. The first is just a basic statement that there is this *dukkha* — we'll define that in a minute. The second is the cause of it, which is desire. The third is very hopeful: there is an end to it. And the fourth, of course, is the path leading to that end — the actual practice.

So what does he mean by this word *dukkha*? It translates as 'hard to bear'. But what he's referring to are three types, as he lists them: the suffering caused by attachment to sensual pleasure, attachment to becoming, and attachment to annihilation.

It's a case of separating out what you would call the natural pain of being a human being — the physical pain. It wasn't as though the Buddha got rid of physical pain. He died very uncomfortably with some sort of gastroenteritis. And he once asked Ananda to take over his speech because his back was hurting. So whatever he means by *dukkha*, this suffering, he's not referring to physical pain as such. Nor, in our state of non-enlightenment, is he talking about the primary level of mental suffering. When we feel, in an obvious way, depressed or anxious, there isn't actually any suffering there in his terminology. There is just this mental state.

To understand that, you have to go into his psychology, which he called dependent origination. It basically says that something arises dependent on something else, that's all. And therefore it doesn't have its own existence, its own reality base. Everything is interdependent — I'm sure you've heard that. The Buddha went on and on about it. This was turned into a universal idea by Mahayana. But in the original teaching, the Buddha stayed very close to actual human experience. He was very wary of turning anything into some sort of metaphysics. So when you read the Theravada scriptures, he's right there with the human being and what we experience — our personal experience within this globe of consciousness through which we experience the world.

This problem of desire... We begin by asking what is our essential mistake. The Buddha is saying that somehow we've made some mistake somewhere, which is often translated as delusion. And this fundamental mistake is a mistake of relationship: the relationship is to seek happiness in a world that's not going to deliver happiness, if only by the fact that it just doesn't stay. It's always in a process of change. So as soon as you think you've entered into this heavenly place, in whatever way you might define that for yourself, it moves on. It comes to an end.

When you have a great party and somebody says, 'We must do this again,' you know you're heading for disaster. Because the second time is never the same. It loses juice.

The fundamental position, then, is one of trying to seek happiness in a world that's transient and doesn't deliver. And the more you accumulate, the more you feel safe. The more friends you have, the more feeling of friendship, you feel safe. The more money you have in the bank, you feel safe. You're always moving back to this business of safety. And that fundamental feeling of safety rests upon a deep understanding somewhere within our being that we're not safe, that there is death. So we cover that up by making something of life. We move towards life and what it can give us, and we make ourselves feel safe by all sorts of little mechanisms.

Unfortunately, once we've accumulated this stuff, it has to be defended against marauders and against the government. So you have to build up a certain aversion to get the energy to get rid of the enemy. If the enemy looms a little too large, you've got to run for it. And there are your three basic dispositions in life, all coming from this fundamental delusion or mistake about seeking happiness — real happiness, not transient happiness; real, permanent meaningfulness; real, permanent existential groundedness — in the transient world: the business of acquisition, accumulation, aversion, and fear.

Once you've done that, you've created something within yourself. You've created a conditioning. And it's these conditionings that drive your destiny. The conditionings we built up unwittingly in childhood and early life, up to our teenage years and even beyond — people who are not aware, who are not mindful — this compendium of habits is basically what we call our character, our personality. It drives our destiny. It's only when we hit walls that we begin to question. Normally speaking, we blame everybody else. That's much easier. Society, parents, everybody — their fault. But slowly we wake up to the possibility that maybe this crash has come about because of a certain way that I'm behaving.

When the Buddha was fully liberated, we say he had three knowledges. The first was that he had come to the end of what he called defilements — these wrong ways of relating. There was nothing unwholesome in his heart, nothing unskillful in his thinking anymore. That had been completely taken away because some deep delusion had been destroyed. We'll come to that in a minute. Then he had memories of all his past lives, and he saw that it was his ethical decisions which had moved him into hell realms, into hellish places, and then finally driven

him to his liberation. And then he saw beings moving from one place to another, driven by this same cause of *kamma*. What he's saying there is that our consciousness is in a process of relationship. Everything is to do with ethics.

We in our time, we medicalize things, or we socialize them. You do things because your parents have done this to you, or you've got some sort of illness. Remember that our forebears would talk about being a bit off, or getting out the wrong side of bed, or feeling heavy. Now we talk about depression and it becomes a sort of mental dis-ease. When you go to the East, they don't — they physicalize it, they embody it. They say they're feeling down or feeling heavy, but they don't turn it into a psychological thing. As soon as you turn it into a psychological problem, you have to move towards therapy. And in a sense, it takes away the personal responsibility we have for having constructed these mental states. That's the problem — the personal responsibility of having constructed depression, anxiety.

Now, the understanding is that when something comes towards us — either a physical pain, somebody hits me on the nose, or some anger from somebody — somehow they're causing this reaction. Their anger is causing my anger. This clout on the nose is causing my grief. And because I can't get my own back, I feel very depressed.

I once went to a group for people suffering from depression. We sat in a circle and everybody started telling everybody else how depressed they were, which was extraordinarily depressing. Then when we got round to one person who said he wasn't depressed — he was really happy, obviously up on a bit of a high — everybody looked very jealous and glum. Let me give you an example. The leader of the group said that a week or so ago, he'd tripped over the pavement and hurt himself. So he wrote to the council and asked for compensation. The council wrote back and said it wasn't on — he wasn't going to get a penny. So he got very angry. And then he got depressed. And it was the council with this pavement that had caused his depression.

In Buddhist psychology, that's not actually what's happening. What's happening is that some information is coming towards us, and the reaction we have to it is actually coming from a different centre. It's not coming from this person. It's not coming from the pain on my nose. The reaction is: pain on my nose, which I'm well aware of, and then inside me, coming from a different place, is this little being who's quite frightened because somebody's just hit them on the nose. And

the way you respond to somebody hitting you on the nose is you get very angry — unless they're very big, and then you run for it. That's coming from this inner centre of the heart, not from the bump on the nose.

These days, a lot of people are suffering from unemployment. When you become unemployed, as I remember it, there's a loss of your wealth, a loss of your status, an immediate loss of your place right now. That's bad enough as it were, because you have to reorganise yourself. But on top of that, something else happens: you become depressed about it. That's this inner reaction to a situation. And what mindfulness is drawing us to understand is that that isn't necessary. That second part is not necessary.

The Buddha always talks about two darts. The first dart is just the pains and sorrows and woes of ordinary living on this planet. The second one is completely self-manufactured — a relationship to what's happening. And that relationship is our ethical position. Either we're trying to accumulate something, or we're trying to push it away, or we're trying to run for it. That's a relationship. It's an ethical relationship.

The Buddha himself didn't have a brilliant time all the time. Towards the end of his life, I think he got quite worried. The two great kings who had been his supporters — one was murdered by his son, and the other died naturally. The two sons who became kings didn't like him at all. In fact, one plotted with Devadatta, a dastardly fellow who was a monk, and tried to kill him. I'm going to tell you the story.

The other prince actually married into the Sakya family, the Buddha's family. Because they thought he was of a lower caste, they secretly gave him a slave girl — an untouchable. When he found this out, of course, he was raging. He got on his elephant with all his other elephants and started going to destroy the Sakyas. The Buddha turned up and said, hey, what's going on here? The prince got a bit of sense and rode back. But after a while, he got into his heart again. He got on his elephant, and off he went again. The Buddha turned up and said, hey, what's happening? So the prince said, okay, and went back again. Third time on his elephant, and the Buddha turns up — come on, he says. So he turns back. The fourth time, the Buddha says, I can't do anything. That's it. He won't listen now. And of course, he didn't. Many of the Sakyas were killed. They had to move their capital elsewhere.

So these were very worrying times for him towards the end, and he was obviously concerned about the order, the support of the order, because, as you know, these religions grow because of temporal support. In China, for instance, whenever the emperor was Buddhist, you were away. When he wasn't, you ran for the hills. That's how they developed this kung fu — self-defence. In our rule as a monk, we can defend ourselves. You're not supposed to attack, but you can definitely defend yourself. So that whole way of combat developed in which you're trying to use the other person's energy to undermine them, to destroy them — and as they pass you by, it's a quick rabbit chop. Just finish it off, coup de grâce.

So the Buddha's saying: if you put your attention in between the original pain — whether it comes physically at you, like you bump your head and catch your finger in the door, or whether it arises within yourself as some old conditioning, some depression, some sadness, some guilt, some shame — if you put your attention there, upon that object, and you observe this relationship you have with it, of indulging it... Indulging our depression: 'I'm so depressed, I'm depressed,' all this self-hatred, 'I'm terrible, I'm useless, nobody loves me, it's true, I'm horrible' — things like that. You're actually developing that particular conditioning by this indulgence, a sort of false humility. So by observing that reaction, you're cutting in between the original suffering or pain that's coming up, physical or mental, and this reaction.

When this reaction falls away, you can stay with the original pain and you've discovered a sort of equanimity with it, a non-reactive position. And when you do that, you find that this original pain — whether it's the pain in the nose, the physical thing, or something in the heart as a mental state — begins to evaporate. If you do it long enough, you realise that actually there's some therapy going on. The heart's purifying itself. It's healing itself. You begin to realise you don't have to do anything. All you have to do is be aware of it.

But that awareness demands a certain ability to bear with, to bear with the conditions. And what we also discover is that the heart cannot purify itself except into consciousness. It will either do it as a felt emotional state or as a physical illness, a psychosomatic illness.

So this ability to cut in between the original given unfortunate state and the reaction to it is, you might say, the point of escape. That's how he would put it. There's the escape. The escape from what? The escape from further suffering and

past suffering — the escape from suffering caused by the past. When you realise the power of that mindfulness to be with suffering, then you obviously want to be there more and more.

So this mindfulness that the Buddha's talking about — that's mindfulness at its most obvious position in the Four Noble Truths: desire the cause of suffering. Remember, desire here is the desire to accumulate, the desire to annihilate, to get rid of what you don't want, and the desire to run from fear. If a person can see that in their depression, in their anxiety, in their rage, in their revenge — if they can see that — they've found an escape from suffering.

You can see how helpful this is in all these therapies — getting a person to find that position within themselves. It's talked about as the objective observer, the objective feeler, or simply the one who knows, the one who experiences.

So what do we mean by transcending? We mean finding a different identity point. When we are in the body, when we are the body, we are the body self. That's who I am. Children — that's where they live, in their bodies. They don't separate their emotions or thought life. They are their bodies in a very embodied way.

We really can only get to that level by accident. If you trap your finger in a door, just for that one singular sweet moment, you are the body. And then you jump out of that and start kicking the door. So to be a body self, you have to get into high states. That's why people like these dangerous sports — because just for that one moment, they are that experience of going through rapids or flying through the air. And when you identify with something so totally, you feel completely alive. In that moment of absorption, there's no you. There's just the action.

So that's the paradox. When we're completely happy, we don't know it. As soon as you bounce out of it, you've lost it. What you're aware of is the dregs of the happy state. This ability to absorb into something — many of us do it at work, which we find interesting, and you're just absorbed into it. People have hobbies like gardening. Time passes. The garden's been done beautifully, but there's not been a sense of somebody doing it.

These are our happiest moments. And as soon as you jump out, then there's something that knows your happiness. You've lost that happiness in a way — you've objectified it. Coming out of the body and being aware of the body as something means that my identity isn't there. My identity will soon re-establish itself if something is life-threatening; as soon as something threatens my life, I really be-

come my body very quickly. But I can actually find this other position of having a body without being one. When I'm looking at my hand, there's something looking at the hand. It's not in the hand.

So the hand becomes an object to me. That's a different relationship. I still own this hand, but my relationship with it is different from my relationship to your hand. If you lost your hand, I'd be very compassionate. But if I lost my hand, I'd go berserk. That's the difference.

The next identity is, of course, emotions. 'I am happy, I am sad,' and so on. That's an easy one for us to stay with. If it's a good one, we like it. If we don't, we tend to jump out of it and become aware of it. Only when you go into it completely do you find yourself becoming mentally ill or falling into an uncontrollable rage. So there's that point of identity that 'I am.' In that moment of identity, there is no 'I am' — there is just the identity. Just depression, just panic. In a panic situation, you just lose it, you just go for it, and then you wake up out of it.

And then there's the mental identity of thought. That's even easier. We'll go off on these thought trips anytime, just get lost in thought, and then wake up and the thought's gone. In meditation sometimes, when this ability to remain as the observer is very acute, you can see thoughts arising and passing away. They don't develop because you're not in there to develop them. You can see a thought arising and passing away, like a neon light.

So you've got these three major identities, which you're pulling out of: the body with its sensations and feelings; the heart with its emotions and moods; and the mind with its thoughts and images. When you pull out of all that, you've found a different identity. You're now the observer, the feeler, the knower. And that's the position of somebody who's being mindful — in this particular case with therapy, mindful of painful states, painful mental states.

Now that isn't your final position. To be the observer, the feeler and whatnot — it's not your final position. But the Buddha actually says those who are mindful like that are in the vicinity of, in the neighbourhood of, Nibbāna.

When we're in that state, mainly in the sitting posture, and you find yourself acutely being this observer within all this body, mind and heart — usually the body has to be very still, the heart has to be very calm, and the mind has to be silent. Then there's this very acute sense of the observer, the feeler. When that comes to you, after that experience, ask yourself: what was it like being there? What were the constituents of the observer?

Because at that point, there's the ability to discover what we really are, which is something transcendent. Something which transcends all these identities — even the identity of an observer, of a feeler. That's what the Buddha is pointing to. When he's teaching of not-self, it's just this way of saying: everything that we experience, if you can objectify it, it can't be you.

When you're aware of yourself as a self, as an observer, as a feeler, there's something that feels itself to be a self. So it can't be that — because it's an object. You're always moving, always taking a step backwards. And when you actually fall off the cliff of the self, that's it. That's when we realise who we really are. That's the transcendent point. And that's what the Buddha is referring to when he calls himself the *Tathāgata*. *Tathāgata* means 'arrived there' or 'gone there'. Its best translation is 'the transcendent one' — the one who's transcended the psycho-physical world.

Now, when it comes to ordinary problems of life — ordinary mental problems like anxiety and all the rest — what mindfulness does is allow the person to find that position where they're no longer making things worse by identifying with the emotional state. That's the desire, that's this business of saying, 'I am depressed.' As soon as you say, 'I am depressed,' where's the escape? But as soon as you say, 'There's depression,' there's an escape, isn't there? You can do something about it if it's there within yourself. But as soon as you say 'I am,' that's it. We're locked into a particular type of relationship, this identity with it.

The ability to maintain mindfulness stops that identity — which is indulging it, which is actually making it worse — and allows the original state to manifest. And that's what's so difficult: to be with these very painful mental states and just be with them in this calm way, to feel them, experience them fully. What you're doing is saying to your heart, 'Manifest your turbulence.' And it's in that manifestation that turbulence can exhaust itself. Over time, you begin to feel this alleviation of all the turmoil within the heart.

Think twenty-five years. I wouldn't want to give you any false hope.

This business of indulgence — how do we develop our mental states? We develop them through thought. It's through making up these constant stories that we're actually developing mental states. The first thing is to know that the mind, if it's not under our control, is really working against us. Anxiety, remember, is being anxious — ninety-nine percent of the time — about things that aren't going to happen. Because the mind, in a state of fright, in a state of uncertainty, extends the future outwards. It always builds up this tremendous fearful storyline. The

scenario of fear just extends itself. And that's completely unnecessary, because if you come back into the moment and feel the fear and do it anyway — you all know the book, yeah?

You feel the fear, and you're letting it go. And then when there's equanimity, when the fear has subsided, you see the situation with much more clarity. It doesn't mean you can't see that unfortunate things may happen, but at least it takes away the huge agitation around it, the exaggeration of it.

On a very obvious psychological level, what mindfulness is doing is putting this awareness — this mindfulness — which is our intuitive intelligence, into play. We talk about mindfulness, we talk about awareness, but remember that two words always come together in the Buddhist scriptures. It's *sampajañña-sati*, which means intuitive intelligence and awareness.

To think of them as two things is really to look at two sides of the same coin. We have it in our language when we say, 'If you look carefully, you'll see.' The seeing is the grasping of the situation. Awareness is the ability to look dispassionately, to look from an objective position, and as we look, we grasp the situation — we see what's wrong. Although we say 'awareness and intuitive intelligence,' it's actually intuitive awareness. And that's the reason I call this centre Satipañña, because that is the Buddha mind.

To be in that state is actually to be in a state of awakening. You can't say awakened, but we can definitely say a state of awakening. When we see the power of that to stop us making things worse and to undermine old habits — that's the point. When these mental states come up, remember, these are conditioning, they're old habits. And when we're allowing them to manifest, we're actually allowing that turbulence to exhaust itself. That's the healing. These turbulences find it harder and harder to hijack our lives. We can stay above them, walk with them, see them as our companions, but also turn a certain kindness towards them too — as if you were with somebody who was depressed or anxious. This awareness, this mindfulness, can be saturated or flavoured with loving-kindness, and that gives us great strength. It gives us great courage to stay with the actual state no matter how long it stays.

Through that process, two things are happening. One is that the psychological dis-ease is being eased. The other is a slow recognition of where the escape is from all suffering — through non-indulgence, non-reactivity, non-aversion, non-fear. It's by seeing that second arrow, as the Buddha would call it — that second dart of aversion, fear, pushing away — and just allowing that to manifest and die

away, that we slowly recede backwards to this place of pure equanimity, of non-reactivity. It could be, in my understanding, that somebody who comes into therapy, a mindfulness-based therapy, very easily — just by observing the process of how suffering is created — finds their way to complete liberation on one of the insights.

As you do that, of course, the other two insights, the other two characteristics of existence, become obvious. As you move along, first you realise that everything is impermanent because you're watching it. It dawns upon you that there's nothing you're experiencing which remains. Nothing that is permanent. Therefore, everything we experience is unreliable. You can't rely on it. You can't rely on a relationship lasting. The person might think better of it and off they go. Or they die. You can't rely on human beings. It's terrible. You can't rely for your happiness on another human being. You're in a hell realm. Because you're not in control. The whole point about being happy is that you're in control. And if you can't control something, there's always going to be fear that you'll lose control.

This is your attachment coming from this position of 'I am.' I am a human being. As soon as you say 'I am a human being,' you're stuck. Because now you've got to seek perfect happiness in this form. And so you're constantly in conflict with the world because it just doesn't deliver.

This recognition of impermanence leads you to one of the Buddha's most beautiful statements: there's nothing in the world worth holding on to. When you come across a phrase like this in your reading and it strikes you, one thing you can do is keep repeating it. This is spiritual reading. You find a phrase and you repeat it, gently, in all its inflections. *There is nothing in the world worth holding on to. There is nothing in the world worth holding on to. There is nothing in the world worth holding on to.*

You keep repeating it gently until you feel a sort of digestion — and that means it's moved from being an intellectual understanding into a disposition. When it's really grasped, it comes out in your actions, in your speech. That's your Eightfold Path. If it stays at an intellectual level, it's sterile. Nothing's ever going to happen. You're going to sound very clever, but nothing's ever going to change. It's got to move into the heart, as a disposition.

One sees this impermanence. And in seeing the world as impermanent, one begins to realise what is permanent within the world. These qualities, these characteristics, are always making us find the opposites. Where the Buddha says this is suffering, he talks about this place — for want of a better word, *Nibbāna* — where

there is no suffering. Don't call it happiness; he just says there's no suffering, because if you say happiness we immediately associate that with some sort of emotional state. So he prefers the phrase *no suffering*. And what is able to see that which arises and passes away must itself not be arising and passing away. Another quality of *Nibbāna* is that it's not transient, not changing. It's a state which has a permanency about it and is utterly reliable. That's what he's saying.

As you begin to take this position of the observer, two things become more plain to you. First, your control over your body, heart, and mind is only apparent. You can move your body around here and there, but there's very little you can do about your bones. Whatever skeleton you've got, you're stuck with it. You can get rid of bits of it, break bits of it, but so much of our physical nature is a given, isn't it? We don't even know what's happening. Do we know what's happening now in our liver? Completely blank as far as I'm concerned. And as long as it doesn't hurt, I'm quite happy to leave it alone.

Neurobiology tells us about all these chemicals and neurons, but I don't experience any of that. I haven't a clue what's going on. All I know is that I have these thoughts and images coming up, and I'm aware of feelings and emotions. My actual experience of life — it's nothing to do with chemicals and whatnot. Not to say that chemicals don't affect the experience of my life.

But that's not what I actually experience. And in thought, what happens if we become senile? We suffer from Alzheimer's. Who are we then? This business of pulling out of and looking at something makes us realise — and it's a frightening thing — that actually you're not in control.

But it's also beginning to discover a position which is outside it. This is the transcendent position. The transcendent position in its absoluteness cannot know itself. If it knows itself, then it must have an object. If it's an object, then it can't be it. Simple as that. Whatever is an object to awareness can't be the awareness — it's an object. That's why the Buddha says even *Nibbāna* doesn't have this sense of self. And that's the process of liberation: the eventual abandonment and destruction of any idea of a self. That's all there is to it.

Now, when we experience these things, they don't have to be mind-blowing experiences. They're sometimes like a drip feed. And over a period of time, you wake up and realise that you don't see the world as you did five, ten, fifteen years ago. It's a slow dawning. That's why the word awakening is so much better than enlightenment.

As you begin to find this identity, remember that it doesn't stop there. You have to re-enter the psychophysical organism. You have to become a person. And it's through the personhood that you begin to express the wisdom you have. In the Buddha's own story, he retreats from life, goes into these meditative experiences. And when he wakes up to what he's actually discovered, his first thought is: who can I share this with? Who can I teach? It's a natural outflow.

This Eightfold Path that he left — right understanding, right attitude — flows naturally into right speech, right action, and right livelihood. And that's how you begin to understand that this process of mindfulness is actually making you re-engage in life in a much fuller way. It's no longer enclosed by a barrier we call the self. The self is always defining the world for its own benefit, so the relationship we have with everybody or anything always has this angle of what's in it for me. When the what's-in-it-for-me goes, then you get that pure relationship. Not that there isn't anything in it for you — it's just that that's not the dominant thought. It hasn't become a barrier. It may be a boundary, but you can step over boundaries. Barriers, you can't step over.

You can see how somebody who has entered into therapy just with the purpose of overcoming panic or grief — they've had a terrible grief in their lives — can be taught this business of separating the grief from the indulgence. So often when people die and we're left with grief, we make the mistake of thinking that the amount of grief I have is the measure of my love. That means every time your grief begins to disappear, you panic. And you've got to start grieving again because you're saying to yourself, I don't love this person anymore. So you have to grieve again. And so it goes on and on — a never-ending indulgence in grief. There's a deep satisfaction that, oh, I'm so grieving, I'm so happy that I love this person so much. But the grief is actually an expression of your attachment. Real love allows the person to go on.

It's like a parent who won't let the child go. You're holding on to the child. But when the child is launched into the world, there should be happiness as well as relief. There's more happiness in letting go. Parents see their children flourishing and they're happy for them. They don't hold on.

When a person sees that grief is something coming out of attachment and allows it to pass—stops indulging in it, stops confusing it with love, and allows the person who's passed away to actually pass away—they can rejoice in the relationship they had and simply let go. Then, of course, the grief begins to exhaust itself. It's not as though mindfulness is going to help you get over the grief quicker. The

process will be determined by the measure of your attachment—it's still going to take three, six, nine months. They say if it goes on longer than that, it's becoming chronic. But mindfulness doesn't stop the suffering. What it does is open you up to it in a way that's going to heal the heart.

You can see how this works with grief. Suppose someone comes in, and they cut through this business of indulging grief from a wrong understanding that it's an expression of love. This misunderstanding dies away, and the reaction of indulging grief therefore stops. The grief is now allowed to arise and pass away, and they're beginning to see that it's impermanent. Then they're beginning to see that actually, I'm looking at it, I'm feeling it, it's not me—even if it's only a slight insight. All the time they're discovering this new identity of being the one who knows.

It seems to me that even though a person might enter at the level of deep psychological suffering, there's a great possibility that they find their way completely. As the scripture says, 'in no length of time, so and so became fully liberated.' And the commentaries gloss that with twenty-five years in the forest. Fifty years in the forest, but 'in no length of time.' Well, cosmically speaking, that's twenty-five years.

Are there any questions around that?

Bhante, a lot of what you were saying related to experience of time—impermanence and the passing of things. I wonder if you could say a little more about the Buddhist experience of time and the importance of the present, because there's very much an idea of letting go of the past, not becoming too involved in the future. And in a deeper sense, there's an underlying picture of what reality is. It's saying, in a sense, there is no past and future. They aren't solid, real things at all. And that's something that can be quite disturbing.

Well, the mind is very clever in maintaining a certain continuity for us. In a sense, it'd be difficult to see how you could operate without some level of continuity as to who you are, where your position was in society, what your job was. You can't just wake up in the morning and think, what am I supposed to be doing today? You'd have to ring around and find out, oh yeah, I'm supposed to be at work. So there has to be some connection to the past. You have to have known; it puts you in a position of time in flux. And time in flux is basically a series of events. You're slotted into that series, and there's a presumption it's going onwards.

Remember that in the West we have this impression that time is linear—it's going somewhere, it has some sort of progress. Whereas in the East and in more ancient cultures it was more circular, just going round on itself. That's why in the West we often find it very difficult to think of rebirth or reincarnation, because we have this idea of progress as a linear state. You begin here and you end up somewhere up there. But the more circular idea of time which you find in the East allows us to create the possibility that things come round again.

In daily life, you have to know. If you've got a dental appointment on Monday, you have to reorganise yourself for that appointment. You can't lose a reality base of what's actually happening—where you are in society, what you're supposed to be doing, where you're supposed to be going. That's right. But of course the delusion is that this has an absolute reality about it. If you walk into a door, there's something absolutely real about that. It's solid, it's there, and you've hurt yourself. But we know that actually it's just subatomic particles meeting subatomic particles. There's another level of reality where there's not much there apart from energy. This is what we're told—I've never experienced that myself. But this is what we're told: that there's this level of reality about the universe we're living in which is just energy. Just this frazzled energy.

In the belief of continuity, there's an underlying belief that it's the same person. That's where the delusion is. Even though you see that your face has changed since you were a child—even in the last five, ten years—you still say, well, it's me. That's me. There's something in us which remains this insoluble, permanent sense of I-ness, of me-ness. Even though all our opinions have changed over a lifetime, there's still me that hasn't changed. Even though all my emotions are constantly changing and moving around, I don't change. This sense of I. And this sense of I creates a permanency dependent on this impermanent relationship, on this impermanent happening in our lives. It's I that's going to the dentist. It's I that's thinking. It's I that's doing this. And this I substantiates the present moment, turns it into a real thing.

Now, when you bring your attention to the present moment, into the here and now—you'll hear that, you read that in the literature—you are able to stop this growth of I. This is the other problem with this fundamental delusion of becoming. By always being in a state of becoming, it's a way that we feel we can control the future. You're going to do this. I'm going on holiday to this sort of place. When I retire... And it makes you feel very safe because you've got it all worked out. The rest of the world doesn't know you've got it all worked out—this is the problem. It's only you that knows. As you move into the present moment and see it in its to-

tality, this sense of I begins to collapse. It begins to move. You're aware of the difference of the next moment and that it's arising dependent on and yet separate from this present moment.

There's a feeling of letting go of that grasping onto time, onto this present, onto a future which you can only imagine. The future doesn't actually exist, but you imagine it. And what this letting go does is open you up to the present moment in a way that allows its potential and its expression to be much more available.

If, for instance, your sense of control is about the sort of person you like—if you go through all your friends, you'll notice that you like them all. That's one of the... If you go through all your enemies, you'll notice that you don't like them. You've split the world into all these people whom you like. Every time you form a friendship, you reinforce this idea of who you like. And without you knowing it, you've put blinkers on because you've defined what is likeable—and what's likeable is what's likeable to you. Now, if you're in the present moment much more, and you're open to a new person coming towards you, and you haven't got this history of what I like and what I don't like, and you're completely open, and you're not envisaging some sort of friendship out of this—then as you meet this person you're much more open to them. Your sense of who you like and what you don't like begins to expand much more at ease.

This whole business of time, in Buddhist understanding, is a mental construct. It doesn't actually exist, and I think most people would see that fairly clearly. We're in a vortex of actions and reactions, and what awareness is trying to do is weave a way through that will create happiness. Does that make sense? We're in this state of time flux, but awareness is absolutely now, within the flux. It's not allowing itself to build up a future from what's happening now because it knows it doesn't know what the future is. And in not knowing the future, when the next moment comes up, awareness is completely open to it—not trying to manipulate it. When one isn't trying to manipulate something, one sees the fullness of it. When one sees the fullness of it, one sees the potential of it. And in seeing that fullness and potential, one hopes the decision made will produce something greater out of that situation.

I'm sure everybody here has experienced that point in their lives when you come to a full stop. You don't know what to do. And in that emptiness of not knowing what to do, where to go, there's a certain type of openness. Then something always arises—especially if you have a generalised aspiration to be involved in something. The key is being able to stop presumptions from the past launching

into the future and creating what we think is something real. When something comes against that projection we've made, we're always in conflict with it. And if it happens to conjoin with our projection, we'll drive it to its bitter end because we don't see its consequences.

An obvious example is the financial crash. Who was the last Treasury guy in the States? The one with the glasses. Names evade me—I suffer from nominal aphasia. Yes, Greenspan. He said it was just greed, that nobody foresaw the whole thing would collapse because they were still stuck in this greed. That's a wonderful example of what happens. You don't think things are going to end because you keep projecting. It can't end. This is always going to be this tremendous growth of wealth. They just don't see it coming. And the Queen writes to all these economists at the London School of Economics and says, why didn't anybody see this? Because they're all greedy. It's tunnel vision, isn't it? Very few people foresaw this collapse coming.

But it's interesting, isn't it? We have such a different way of thinking about the future than thinking about the past. We think the future is completely open and undetermined, not there in a way—we make it. And we think the past is all fixed and definite, an absolute reality. But the actual situation is a lot more fluid than that.

That's right. And I think you've hit the point there. What was that—Ayn Rand? *Atlas Shrugged*? It gave this generation of entrepreneurs and Silicon Valley people the feeling that they could control their lives. And for the most part, the situation actually supported it. Here's the point: sometimes the world will support your aspiration. But then we lose the understanding that it's happening because of contingency, not only because I'm in control. It's happening because at this particular time certain things have come together to form a situation where I make a million, I make a billion for myself—like Zuckerberg with his Facebook. He might think he's done it. His idea, he's built up the empire, et cetera. And he completely loses the idea that in fact he's just one part in a whole contingency.

That's what the self does. The self takes control because underneath it, at a deeper level in our psyche, we know we're not in control. We know there is death. That's the problem. So it's an evasion of death—a running away from death all the time.

When we say death, we don't just mean physical death. We mean ending. Every time the day ends, that is a death. Every time you finish your lunch, just stay there for a minute and say, the meal is now dead. It has come to an end. It no longer ex-

ists. When you walk out of the house, turn around and say, that moment is dead. Keep using the word dead, and slowly it dawns upon you that actually we're dying every moment.

Well, that's true on the actual level of the physical world and all that, but the problem is the I doesn't change. The I always remains the same. It was always me. That's the problem. I never change. As far as I'm concerned, I'm still thirty-five.

The Two Darts

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 15 min

Originally given as *The Two Darts* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this teaching, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the Buddha's famous parable of the two darts, which illustrates how we compound our suffering through unskillful reactions to life's inevitable difficulties. The first dart represents the unavoidable painful experiences of life - illness, aging, loss, and death. The second dart is our mental reaction: the resistance, aversion, and seeking of escape through sensual pleasures that we add to these natural experiences.

Drawing from the Buddha's discourse to the monks, Bhante explains how an "uninstructed worldling" experiences both physical and mental suffering, while the "instructed noble disciple" learns to feel only the bodily sensation without the additional mental torment. The teaching explores the three underlying tendencies (anusaya) that keep us trapped: aversion to painful feelings, attachment to pleasant feelings, and ignorance regarding neutral feelings.

This talk offers practical insight into developing a healthy relationship with both pleasure and pain, learning to enjoy life's gifts without attachment while accepting difficulties without resistance. Bhante emphasizes that this is not about becoming cold or detached, but about cultivating wise non-attachment that allows us to be fully present to life without the psychological dependency that creates suffering. Essential listening for understanding the psychological foundations of Buddhist practice and the path to freedom through Vipassanā meditation.

We're following this compilation by Bhikkhu Bodhi, and we've been through the heavy bit—sickness, aging and death—so we're still, unfortunately, on the heaviness of life. The joys come at the end. Here the Buddha goes into what you might call the basic psychology of how we create suffering for ourselves.

He uses the word 'worldling'—an uninstructed worldling—as though looking at the world as if we were aliens. But he's just trying to translate a word which simply means an ordinary person who doesn't know why they cause themselves suffering. I think you might wonder what he means by it.

So, monks—and remember that these discourses always begin with 'monks,' but it stands for anybody who's listening, really—when the uninstructed worldling experiences a painful feeling, he sorrows, grieves and laments. He weeps, beating his breast, and becomes distraught. He feels two feelings: a bodily one and a mental one.

Now suppose they were to strike a man with a dart and then strike him immediately afterwards with a second dart, so that the man would feel a feeling caused by two darts. So too, when the uninstructed worldling experiences a painful feeling, he feels two feelings: a bodily one and a mental one.

While experiencing that same painful feeling, she harbours aversion towards it. And when she harbours aversion towards painful feeling, the underlying tendency to aversion towards painful feeling lies behind this.

While experiencing painful feeling, she seeks delight in sensual pleasure. For what reason? Because the uninstructed worldling does not know of any escape from painful feeling other than sensual pleasure. When she seeks delight in sensual pleasure, the underlying tendency of lust for pleasant feeling lies behind this.

She does not understand as it really is the origin and the passing away, the gratification, the danger and the escape in the case of these feelings. When she does not understand these things, the underlying tendency to ignorance in regard to neither painful nor pleasant feeling lies behind this.

If they feel a pleasant feeling, they feel it attached. If they feel a painful feeling, they feel it attached. If they feel a neither painful nor pleasant feeling, they feel it attached. This is called an uninstructed worldling who is attached to birth, aging and death, who is attached to sorrow, lamentation, pain, dejection and despair—who is attached to suffering, I say.

So what's the Buddha saying? First of all, when we feel something harmful, something painful in the body—now remember there are two types of feelings in the body: those that come from the body itself, such as painful knees when you're sitting, and those painful feelings that are in the body but come from the heart, our emotional states.

That's bad enough to be able to sit with. But then we have this second dart, as he calls it, which is the resistance—not wanting to go there. So we have both the painful feeling and now we've created an aversion to it. Now we're in turmoil.

Because we're in turmoil, we're seeking an escape. And the escape is tea and biscuits, basically. Turn on the TV, phone up a friend, do anything apart from feel these feelings. That's the gratification.

Unfortunately, if we go on like this, we don't see the danger. When we're gratified, when we're enjoying ourselves, it's okay—we're in heaven. What's the problem? We don't see the problems that arise afterwards: we've suppressed these feelings and they're still there within the system. We haven't actually dealt with them.

And secondly, when that pleasant feeling disappears, we find we've become attached to it. 'Attached' here means psychologically dependent on something for our happiness. So there's a lot of psychology in this.

Just think of a time when you've been even a little bit ill—a bad cold, a flu—and it stops you going to work or doing something you'd planned. There's that negativity, that resistance. Now that's the second dart. What the Buddha is saying is that it's not necessary. The illness is one thing; the mental reaction is another. And unless we're aware of that reaction, we'll keep making things worse for ourselves.

So we harbour aversion towards it. We develop that aversion towards painful feeling, and that means there's a lot of fear there too. Whatever we feel, whatever we think is going to bring a bit of difficulty, a bit of painfulness, we tend to run from it.

What's manifesting here is an underlying tendency to aversion—a conditioning within us to either resist or run from what we find unpleasant. Every time we react like that, we reinforce this tendency, this habit. We're actually making things worse for ourselves all the time.

And because it gets so bad, while experiencing a painful feeling, we seek sensual pleasure. That's what we do, isn't it? Things get a bit tough, so you get drunk. Anything not to feel those feelings, not to endure them.

Because of that, the underlying tendency of seeking happiness in pleasure is reinforced. We keep thinking that the way to happiness is through more and more pleasure from worldly things. But there's the danger.

The danger is that worldly things—we don't understand, as it really is, their origin and passing away. Anything you get attached to is going to let you down because it's going to change. It's going to pass away. Just when you thought you've got the right person, the right job, the right house, the right car—see, you drop dead. Or worse, it passes away.

It's a case of recognising that as soon as we hold on to something, it has great potential to create suffering for us. That's the problem with gratifying ourselves in the world of pleasure: we don't see the danger. And when the danger comes, we're stuck with the suffering. We don't see the escape.

Then the Buddha says, when a pleasant feeling arises, they feel attached. This 'attached' means attached to something like, for instance, I'm attached to my car. It's that use of the word. When you're attached to somebody, you're psychologically connected with them—but often in a way that, if they disappear or if the car breaks down, there's sorrow, lamentation, grief and despair.

What the Buddha is saying is this: it's not necessary for us to get rid of the joys of life, and it's not necessary for us to reject what is painful. Life is full of joy and woe. All we have to know is how to relate to this stuff.

When something unpleasant comes, we simply accept it, bear with it, endure it. And when pleasant stuff comes, we're careful not to form an attachment to it.

Now that's really difficult. It's one of my regular teachings here around food. The distinction between enjoying the food and indulging in it is a very fine one. But you've got to work at it—because when we indulge, the suffering comes.

We have to be very careful not to interpret the Buddha's teaching as life-negative. Far from it. Once he was fully liberated, he became one of the most sensual beings there can be. Why? Because now he's completely open to the sensual world. He's not afraid of it, and he's not indulging in it.

Now we have the other side of the equation. 'Monks, when the instructed noble disciple experiences a painful feeling, they do not sorrow, grieve or lament. They do not weep beating their breasts and become distraught. They feel one feeling—a bodily one, not a mental one.'

'Suppose they were to strike a man with a dart, but they would not strike him immediately afterwards with a second dart, so that man would feel a feeling caused by one dart only. So too, when the instructed disciple experiences a painful feeling, they feel one feeling—a bodily feeling, not a mental one.'

'While experiencing that same feeling, they harbour no aversion towards it.' And since they harbour no aversion towards painful feeling, the underlying tendency to aversion does not lie behind this.

In other words, even the very conditioning within us that causes this resistance and this indulgence is beginning to fade away. The liberated person simply can't react like that anymore—that habit has been completely wiped out.

'While experiencing painful feeling, they do not seek delight in sensual pleasure. For what reason? Because the instructed noble disciple knows of an escape from painful feeling other than sensual pleasure.' And that's what the purpose of vipassanā is—to discover that escape.

'And they understand it as it really is—the origin and the passing away, the gratification, the danger and the escape in the case of these feelings.' Since they understand these things, the underlying tendency of ignorance towards neither-painful-nor-pleasant feeling does not lie behind this.

Remember, we tend to ignore those sensations that we don't see as either painful or pleasant. When we come to the breath, generally speaking, we find it boring. And that shows us that we're constantly trying to seek excitement—whereas the spiritual life is drawing us towards silence, towards stillness.

If they feel a pleasant feeling, they feel it detached—they're not becoming psychologically dependent on it. If they feel a painful feeling, they feel it detached. And if they feel a neither-painful-nor-pleasant feeling, they feel it detached.

This is called a noble disciple who is detached—though the better phrase is 'non-attached'. The word 'detached' tends to give you the feeling of callousness almost, of being detached from people's suffering and all that.

They are non-attached from birth, aging and death. Non-attached from sorrow, lamentation, pain, dejection and despair. 'Non-attached from suffering,' I say.

'This, monks, is the distinction, the disparity, the difference between the instructed noble disciple and the uninstructed worldling'—which we are no longer.

I can only hope my words have been of some assistance, and that the Buddha's Dhamma is coming through loud and clear. May you, by your great efforts, overcome suffering—and not seek escape through indulgence in pleasure. Sooner rather than later.

The Eight Worldly Winds

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 20 min

Originally given as *The Eight Worldly Winds* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



*Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the *atta loka dhammā* (eight worldly conditions) that create mental turbulence and suffering when we become obsessed with them: gain and loss, fame and disrepute, praise and blame, pleasure and pain. Drawing from the Buddha's teachings, he explores how these conditions arise from our sense of self and create attraction and repulsion that bind us to suffering.*

*Through practical reflection questions, Bhante guides us to investigate our own relationships with these inevitable life experiences. He explains how an awakened Arahant remains unmoved by worldly vicissitudes—described in the *Maṅgala Sutta* as "a mind unshaken by worldly vicissitudes, sorrowless, stainless and secure"—representing one of life's greatest blessings.*

The talk emphasizes developing equanimity toward these conditions through understanding their impermanent nature and learning to receive rather than grasp experiences. Bhante distinguishes between wholesome desires and obsessive craving, showing how we can engage with life's ups and downs without the personalization that creates suffering. He concludes by connecting this wisdom to daily life and the Noble Eightfold Path, demonstrating how Buddhist practice extends beyond meditation into skillful engagement with worldly realities.

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammāsambuddhassa — Homage to the Buddha, the Blessed, Noble, and fully self-awakened one.

This month I've chosen the *Aṭṭhalokadhamā* — these eight worldly conditions. They're also called worldly concerns, winds, fortunes, vicissitudes. Basically, they're the ups and downs of life.

This is what the Buddha says: Gain obsesses the mind and loss obsesses the mind. Fame obsesses the mind and disrepute obsesses the mind. Blame obsesses the mind and praise obsesses the mind. Pleasure obsesses the mind and pain obsesses the mind. They are attracted to gain and repelled by loss. They are attracted to fame and repelled by disrepute. They are attracted to praise and repelled by blame. They are attracted to pleasure and repelled by pain. Thus involved with attraction and repulsion, they are not freed from birth, from old age and death, from sorrow, lamentation, pain, dejection and anguish. They are not freed from suffering, I say.

Those are the eight worldly conditions. When we look at them, we can see they all arise out of a notion of self. It's *me* that's blamed. It's *me* that's praised. And when we do that, it just creates mental turbulence. When this happens at a societal level, you can see communities being split, as we see these days. And when it gets to an international level, there's always war going on.

So what's it like to be freed of these worldly concerns? In the discourse on the greatest blessings, the Buddha describes how an awakened Arahant — somebody who's fully liberated — is unmoved by any of the eight worldly conditions. He calls this one of the great blessings: a mind unshaken by worldly vicissitudes, sorrowless, stainless and secure — this is the greatest blessing. And we can extend that to families and countries. We might just get to a peaceful world.

What I've done is made up questions around these eight factors, to give some idea of how we can use them to reflect on the way we are with these fortunes and misfortunes. Take gain, for instance. We ask ourselves: What am I obsessing about? What sort of accumulation am I gathering? What collections do I have? Wealth, power — even though we might not have much wealth at all, or indeed hardly any power. The point is this obsession about it, this need for control. How much energy do we give to it? How much time do we waste brooding and planning over these sorts of things?

As a practice, once we can bring a past event to mind, we can get in touch with that feeling — that craving, that holding on, the cramped grip. What does it feel like? And then we try to separate that from what you might call just an ordinary wholesome desire. We need money, we need friends. But there's a way of having that without the obsessiveness.

Then there's loss. Everybody feels that. You might lose your job. What does that feel like? If you have lost your job in the past, how did that feel? The despair, the confusion, the anxiety, the panic? So much depends upon our work and the wage that we have. And then there's the self-worth we get from our work, the sense of status. But we'll come to that a bit later.

We have to ask ourselves: What if I let go of that? What if I just let go of the obsessiveness and was more content with what I have? By going to a past occasion, investigating it and reflecting on it, we prepare ourselves for the next time. We're not so shocked when we lose things — lose our work, lose money on the horses and stuff like that.

The next one is praise. Again, we look back and ask: What have I done or said, or am doing or saying, which has an underlying demand for praise, for admiration, for compliments, for appreciation? How does that feel? Is it necessary? How does it reflect on ourselves and how we're judging ourselves? And how embarrassed we feel when we suddenly realise we've said something or done something just to be praised, just to be admired. What would have happened if you hadn't had that intention in that particular case? What should the attitude have been?

When it comes to blame, nobody likes that. Nobody likes to be blamed for anything. Again, we bring up an occasion in the past where we've been blamed, judged, criticised — and we get to the hurt of that, and how we reacted. Sometimes we react silently within ourselves. We spend hours getting our own back in these fantasies, throwing people on fires and chucking them off bridges and things like that.

It's about getting in touch with those feelings and naming them for what they are. What is it like to be humiliated? Instead of hiding that from ourselves, suppressing it because of our pride, we let it up. We let it up and just feel it, and know that if I can allow these things to manifest, they're actually dying out. They're actually curing.

Some of these things are very difficult. The hurt, the humiliation — it really punches the ego, really wounds the self. And if we're afraid of criticism, does that make us timid? Then when we have been blamed and it has been our fault, have we been humble enough to accept that and try to do something about it? Or do we let it rumble on afterwards as self-criticism? I'm such a fool. I'm an idiot. How could I have done that? It's just being able to let go of something.

Then we have the area of success and failure. Again, it's much the same thing. You bring to mind a past occasion when you feel you've been successful, a job well done. There's nothing wrong with appropriate congratulations. But again, it's this business of hanging on to that success.

I've got here just what the Buddha says about somebody who becomes an Arahant. He says that someone who's an Arahant, with their taints destroyed — taints are the roots of all our defilements: craving for pleasure, craving to become, and ignorance, the basic ignorance of self. These are the roots from which all defilements arise. He says when those are destroyed, one has lived the holy life, done what has to be done, laid down the burden, reached the goal, destroyed the fetters of becoming, and is completely liberated through final knowledge. You can see it's that sense of completion. What had to be done has been done. And if you look at your own life where you've really completed something — it's done, it's finished, it's gone — there's a sense of joy about that.

Laying down the burden — there's such a sense of relief in that phrase. Laying down the burden of being a human being, basically. And the taste of *Nibbāna* is the joy of freedom. That's where we're heading. It's good to remind ourselves of that.

When we are praised, we tend to personalise things. Immediately it's not the job that's being praised — it's me. I'm amazing. I get very big-headed. And sometimes if you catch yourself like that, catch yourself being big-headed and full of self-praise, and you notice that other people are seeing it as big-headedness — that again produces a sense of shame within us.

All these things — just recognise all the ego stuff as unnecessary evaluation tags. Let them fade away. And eventually, as the Buddha said, they just fall off.

Then there's failure. A job didn't turn out well, a relationship sadly ended. How does it feel not to achieve something, even if you've put a lot of work into it and it just hasn't happened? Again you get this personalisation. The job failed, therefore I'm a failure. The relationship failed, so I'm unlovable.

Reflecting on that, we recognise that those personalisations are just not necessary — they only add suffering. And if it was a genuine mistake, we can be realistic about it and make sure we don't repeat it. But then again, circumstances change. We don't have that total control anymore.

Finally, there's pleasure and pain. Pleasure, both mental and physical — we're always seeking that, always trying to be in that pleasurable state. But it's a case of not attaching to it, not making it something that is repeatable. When we have something joyful, something pleasant, we accept that it's come to an end and there's no need to go any further with it. And we find out how we experience desire.

Sometimes, for instance, when it comes to food, you don't feel hungry, so you're not attracted so much to the cake. But sometimes when you are hungry, you can't stop yourself from eating the whole cake. There's something about desire which is separate from seeing something pleasant. There's that movement towards it of wanting, wanting, wanting. And then we need to make that distinction between the desire and the action.

Remember, in Buddhist psychology this is really crucial: when something is a desire, nothing's actually happened. It's just potential. But as soon as you decide to let that energy go and produce something — a thought or speech, something that you do — it becomes an action. And that action goes out into a matrix of relationships on the outside, but it also moves into the inner matrix of our psyche. That's what we mean by *kamma*, action.

We're trying to make a distinction here between indulgence and enjoyment. And we do that — the Buddha's always on about this — by restraining ourselves. That's very difficult in our society. We're not expected to restrain; in fact, everybody wants us to indulge. But the act of restraint gets us in touch with the unacceptable level, you might say, from a Dharma point of view, of desire. In other words, nothing's wrong with appetite. Everything's wrong with greed.

And then finally, pain. Pain can be very difficult. One thing we have to be careful of here is that we don't take whatever pain comes to us as some sort of karmic resolve — as if we deserve the pain. We're not in charge of the body, and the body has its own weaknesses. Sometimes when pain comes, it's to do with genetics. It's not to do with the person themselves.

It's up to us to decide whether this pain is something we want to work with — working with it in terms of getting that right relationship with pain, of patience, of understanding what pain is at different levels. At the basic level of contact, pain is just sensation. It's when it becomes a feeling, when it's acknowledged as a feeling, that you get the sense of pain and then that reaction of not wanting it. But if you can't do that sort of investigation, if you haven't got the patience for it, then take an aspirin. Do something.

Going back to the Buddha: 'When gain arises for an uninstructed, run-of-the-mill person, they do not reflect. Gain has arisen for me. It is inconstant, stressful and subject to change. They do not discern it as it has come to be.' That's what's missing. We presume that once we've got something, it's just going to grow, that it's not going to leave us. But it's a good thing to remind oneself that whatever I have received, which is bringing me joy, pleasure — this too will pass.

One of the things I try to remind people to do is that after lunch, say to yourself: well, this is one less lunch in this lifetime. We can measure our lives by how many lunches we have, how many breakfasts we have.

And then those people who are not instructed — they welcome, they grab hold of an arisen gain and rebel against an arisen loss. It's the same with status and disgrace, with praise and blame, and with pleasure and pain. As they are thus engaged in welcoming and rebelling, they are not released from birth, aging and death, from sorrows, lamentations, pain, distresses and despairs. They are not released, I tell you, from suffering and unhappiness.

Those who are awakened, those who have developed to some degree — they don't welcome it in that sense of wanting to indulge it. They just receive it. And this is the difference, the Buddha says, the distinction. This is the distinguishing factor between a well-instructed disciple of the noble ones and an uninstructed, run-of-the-mill person.

What's this underlying attitude that we're trying to develop to all these worldly conditions? It's equanimity. And this comes about more and more as identity, a sense of self, becomes less and less. The less we personalise things, the more we find ourselves at ease with the way things are. It's this sense of self which is producing all the problems.

We undermine that by reminding ourselves what the correct — or should we say, the more wholesome, skilful — attitude ought to be. And it's a working process. I wouldn't talk about progress. Don't get involved with progress. Just get involved with process. How do I get rid of these wrong attitudes I have to these eight worldly winds, which are going to happen anyway in my life? We're not going to stop them.

It's one of the attractions of the Buddha's teachings that he really has buried his teachings into daily life. It's not just meditation and beautiful mental states and developing *mettā* from the heart. It's actually driving us into right action, the noble eightfold path — right speech, right action and right livelihood. And one of the things we have to do is just be able to handle these eight worldly winds.

Very good. I hope that these words have been of some assistance, that they have not caused confusion. And that by your careful investigation of these eight worldly winds, you will soon be liberated from all suffering. Sooner rather than later.

The Eight Worldly Conditions

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 17 min

Originally given as *The Eight Worldly Conditions* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this DhammaBytes teaching, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines one of the Buddha's most practical teachings about navigating life's inevitable ups and downs. The eight worldly conditions (aṭṭha lokadhamma) - gain and loss, fame and disrepute, praise and blame, pleasure and pain - constantly affect our lives, but the Buddha shows us how our relationship to these experiences determines whether they lead to suffering or freedom.

The key difference between the 'uninstructed worldling' and the 'instructed noble disciple' lies not in what happens to them, but in their understanding. When we recognize that all conditions are impermanent, bound up with suffering, and subject to change, we can experience life's pleasures without attachment and face life's difficulties without despair.

Bhante Bodhidhamma offers practical guidance on applying this wisdom - from enjoying a meal without greed to losing wealth without devastation. He emphasizes that this teaching doesn't ask us to become emotionless, but rather to develop the right relationship to our experiences. Through gentle reminders of impermanence and the cultivation of non-attachment, we can find the middle way between indulgence and suppression, leading to genuine freedom from the endless cycle of elation and dejection that characterizes unreflected living.

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā Sambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-enlightened one.

We're now moving on to the next piece of scripture, still within the section on the tribulations of unreflective living. If you remember, last week we talked about the two darts—how we create suffering for ourselves through our reactions to things. This particular passage addresses the vicissitudes of life: the eight worldly conditions.

These eight worldly conditions keep the world turning round, and the world turns round these eight worldly conditions. What eight? Gain and loss, fame and disrepute, praise and blame, pleasure and pain. These eight worldly conditions are encountered by an uninstructed worldling, and they are also encountered by an instructed noble disciple.

What now is the distinction, the disparity, the difference between an instructed noble disciple and an uninstructed worldling?

Venerable Sir, our knowledge of these things has its roots in the Blessed One. It has the Blessed One as guide and resort. It would be good, Venerable Sir, if the Blessed One would clarify the meaning of that statement. Having heard it from him, we will bear it in mind.

That means us.

Listen then, and attend carefully; I shall speak.

Yes, Venerable Sir, they replied, and the Blessed One spoke thus.

When an uninstructed worldling comes upon gain, they do not reflect on it thus: This gain that has come to me is impermanent, bound up with suffering and subject to change. They do not know it as it really is. And when they come upon loss, fame and disrepute, praise and blame, they do not reflect on them thus: All these are impermanent, bound up with suffering and subject to change. They do not see them as they really are. With such a person, gain and loss, fame and disrepute, praise and blame, pleasure and pain, keep their minds engrossed. When gain comes, they are elated. When they meet with loss, they are dejected. When fame comes, they are elated. When they meet with disrepute, they are dejected. When praise comes, they are elated. When they meet with blame, they are dejected. When they experience pleasure, they are elated. But when they experience pain, they're dejected. Being thus involved in likes and dislikes, they will not be free from birth, aging and death, from sorrow, lamentation, pain, dejection and despair. They will not be free from suffering, I say.

But when an instructed noble disciple comes upon gain, they reflect thus: This gain has come to me. This gain that has come to me is impermanent, bound up with suffering and subject to change. And so they will reflect when loss or so forth comes upon them. They understand all things as they really are and they do not engross their minds. Thus, they will not be elated by gain and dejected by loss, elated by fame and dejected by disrepute, elated by praise and dejected by blame, elated by pleasure and dejected by pain. Having thus given up likes and dislikes, they will be freed from birth, aging, and death, from sorrow, lamentation, pain, dejection, and despair. They will be free from suffering, I say.

This is the distinction, the disparity, the difference between an instructed noble disciple and an uninstructed worldling.

So what's the Buddha saying here? Some of it is pretty obvious. There are these eight worldly conditions, starting with gain and loss. We've just lived through eight years of economic growth, and then suddenly it all collapsed. While it was growing, nobody thought it would end—it felt like it would go on forever. Then suddenly everything fell apart. Everybody's in a tizzy. Poor old Prime Minister Brown's chewing his fingernails. It's a catastrophe. Nobody thought it would come to an end.

Fame and disrepute. It might not be disrepute. Just a loss of fame can be a disaster. A couple of weeks back, there was a program on Tony Hancock, the 1960s comedian. He was famous, and he loved his fame, and he loved being famous. The new comedy was coming in, all that satirical stuff. This was the week that was, and then Monty Python. He became old hat. He began to lose fame, and he became despairing about it. He tried to make it in Australia, failed, committed suicide. Desperate. It gets worse if you get disrepute, of course. If you're one of these MPs who got caught up in all that—they thought they were getting away with it, some of them thought they were actually obeying the rules and regulations—and then suddenly a couple of them find themselves in jail. What a way to go. At one point they're elated, life's wonderful; the next minute they're despairing.

Praise and blame. We all like to be praised for what we do, and when we don't get it we don't feel good. It's worse, of course, if they blame. We had a meditator here just recently who seems to be in a real toxic atmosphere at work in IT. Everybody's blaming everybody. He just finds it so difficult in a blame culture. Instead of saying something's gone wrong, how did it go wrong, how can we stop it going wrong in the future—it's much easier to say, he did it.

When I was in Sri Lanka, there used to be this bird. I think it was a sea bird. I never actually saw it, mainly because there were so many trees around. But as it flew over, it used to say, "He did it, he did it." And I'd be sitting there saying, "No, I didn't, honestly, I didn't. It wasn't me." Nobody wants to be blamed. "He did it."

And then, of course, there's pleasure and pain. We all know about that. When we're enjoying life, when we're enjoying food, all that sort of stuff, we're elated by it. And then of course when we're sick, when we're ill, when we don't feel well, when we can't eat and we want to eat and all that, you just get dejected. You're miserable. You can see how it works.

Now what does he mean? You have to be careful here. What does he mean by elated and dejected? And then he goes on to say, of course, that the instructed person does not become elated. You have to be very careful here, because if you say to yourself, this is a great meal, and then you say to yourself, it is subject to change, it's going to finish, I'm not going to enjoy this at all—then the whole of life becomes miserable. At one time you were enjoying things and then it did get miserable, but now it's all miserable. You have to be very careful what the Buddha is saying here.

What he means by elated, of course, is that sense of indulgence, that sense of whoopee, that sense of over-excitement in things, and of course this underlying presumption that it's always going to be like this. That's the problem. It's not a case of not enjoying things. The Buddha experiences and enjoys the taste of food, but he does not greed for it.

Now that distinction, as we've said before, is very difficult for us, but at least we can stop this big depression at the end of things when things go wrong by just this gentle reminder to ourselves that everything changes. What's his little phrase here? That is impermanent, bound up with suffering and subject to change. The suffering comes because of our relationship to what we're enjoying.

He's saying that when an instructed noble disciple reminds themselves about this, they understand things as they really are. It does not engross the mind. In other words, you're not caught up in it. You're not deluded by it. You have to be slightly careful about that, or else life becomes miserable.

And the other thing is not to be afraid of pleasure just in case you indulge and then get all the misery, because that fear then stops you really enjoying things. When it comes to something that you know in advance you're going to enjoy, it's just putting in that right intention, just getting that right relationship.

If for instance great wealth comes to you because you played the lottery or something—heaven forbid you play that—and you've got all these millions of pounds come your way, that's great wealth. Now what would you do with it? What they say is that people who get this enormous amount of money are elated for one year and that's it. Then they get really depressed and it goes back to ordinary horrible life. If wealth comes to us by whatever means, it's having the right relationship to it. It's using it for our benefit and the benefit of others. And that's where you get your joy.

Do you remember that win from the lottery? It was quite a while ago now, but it was an ordinary fellow. And when he got his win, he divided it all between his family and friends. Do you remember that? I think everybody went, "You know, he must be a fool, he must be an idiot." And he said something like, "There's no point in me being happy if others around me aren't." Something of that nature. And that was a lovely interconnectedness. He was happy in the right way. He didn't fall. His mind did not become engrossed.

What he's saying is that this is actually seeing impermanence. To see impermanence is to change our relationship to things. There's a lovely phrase that I continuously repeat to myself: there is nothing in the world worth holding on to. It's not only worth holding on to because if you do, as he says, it causes suffering because it disappears, but because you're not holding on to actually anything. You think you're holding on to something but it's actually in a continual state of change while you're trying to hold on to it. And grasping that fact is a liberation. You can release the grip.

And he's given up likes and dislikes. Now it's not as though when you put food on your tongue you can't say, 'I like this.' That's not the problem. The problem is preferences. If somebody asks how you like your tea, are you one of these people who says, 'Well, I leave the bag in for two seconds, shake it about a bit, only a drop of milk, and precisely one, two, or three grains of sugar, no more'? And if it doesn't come exactly as you have it, it's no good.

I had an old friend who died recently, about a year or so ago. I went to visit, and he had a very elderly mother, about ninety. She says to me, 'Will you make me a cup of tea?' Oh no—I said, would you like a cup of tea? She says, 'Yes I would. Make it very weak.' I said, okay. I went out, made this tea, and brought it back in. 'Oh, this is ridiculous, it's too weak.' I said, how do I know how weak you want it?

She was really upset, so I took it out and made another one. 'It's too strong, oh my goodness.' She had this sort of—whatever she meant by weak, I never really figured out.

There's somebody who's suffering because of preference. If you're the sort of person who says, 'Well, as it comes,' ah, you've liberated yourself from a lot of suffering around tea. Just as it comes. And that's all the Buddha's saying.

Now, how do we do it? Well, he gives us the technique right here. Any time gain or fame or praise or pleasure comes your way, you just gently repeat to yourself: 'This is impermanent; if I don't get it right, it's going to be bound up with suffering; and it is itself subject to change.' That's it.

If somebody gives you a gift of a crystal glass, say thank you very much and very quietly say to yourself, 'Any moment this could break.' And when it breaks, you just say, 'Oh look, it's broken.' What's the problem? It's the same with something like one of these iPhones—they cost a bit. You buy one and say to yourself, 'This could disappear, this could be stolen.' Then you leave it somewhere by mischance, and it's stolen. It's gone, that's it. What's the problem? And then out of the goodness of your heart, you say, 'May the person who has it benefit from it. I give it to them freely.' But I'll still call the police.

In this little bit here, the Buddha is simply looking at our experience of life through these eight worldly conditions. There they are: gain and loss, fame and disrepute, praise and blame, pleasure and pain. I can only hope this reading and my amazing commentary has been of some use, and that you will drive yourself hastily to liberation sooner rather than later.

Thank you very much.

Grief

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 18 min

Originally given as *Grief* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this compassionate talk during the 2020 coronavirus lockdown, Bhante Bodhidhamma addresses the profound topic of grief and loss. Drawing from personal correspondence with practitioners experiencing multiple bereavements, he explores the crucial distinction between sorrow—our empathetic response to others' suffering—and grief, which arises from our psychological attachments.

Bhante examines the Buddha's teaching to Ānanda following the death of Sāriputta and Moggallāna, emphasizing the instruction to 'be an island unto yourself' while acknowledging our fundamental interconnectedness. He discusses how grief represents the karmic consequence of unwholesome attachment, not immoral behavior, and must be fully experienced for healing to occur.

The talk includes the story of Visākhā, a devoted lay follower who grieved her grandchild's death, illustrating the Buddha's teaching that attachment multiplies our sorrows. Bhante clarifies that diminishing grief doesn't indicate diminishing love, and explains the natural healing process that allows us to reconnect with pure love and joyful memories. This teaching offers profound guidance for working skillfully with loss while maintaining compassionate relationships.

Evening and greetings. I trust you had a fruitful day. I do not say happy, though I wish it has been happy.

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Samma Sambuddhasa. Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Samma Sambuddhasa. Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Samma Sambuddhasa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

So I've had two rather sad emails. We've discussed all this business about death, and then, of course, there's the complementary side, which is grief. One writer says these last years has brought to my door a series of griefs: the deaths of

close ones and beloveds, some unexpected due to suicide, some through the combination of illness. One, the most beloved, from a cardiac arrest. And she also lost her pet. And they themselves were diagnosed with cancer, but is in remission now. She's found that during this lockdown, a lot of this grief and sorrow arising, particularly in dreams during meditation. So when we're alone, these turbulences, whatever they are, they tend to come back to haunt us.

And very recently, a very sad case: a young man, well youngish — thirty-four from my point of view, youngish — Pete, who had a seizure at night and died, leaving his wife and three small children. So that, of course, is a huge shock to somebody who has to suffer that, to all those close to him.

First of all, is to try to make a distinction, just using these words, between sorrow and grief. I mean, they're interchangeable. Sorrow is that trembling, as the Buddha would say, in the heart — what we would call empathy — where you feel the sorrow of somebody else. And you can say that when somebody dies in an unfortunate way or they're too young to die, died before their time as we say, that there's a certain sorrow on their behalf as a thing that they could have offered more to society. They could have lived a longer life. But generally, there's a sense of sorrow about it. And that's really looking at it, as it were, from their point of view, not from our point of view.

The big case, of course, was that little boy on the beach, which caused Angela Merkel to allow refugees in. So there was a movement there, a sort of a resonance in the heart with the suffering of others. And that sorrow normally demands some sort of action into compassion, or else it lies as unrequited. It lies as a pain in the heart. And of course, if you can't do anything, then you can at least send your good wishes. You can do the meditation on loving-kindness. And you have to accept that. You can't do anything. There's no point in beating ourselves up about that. So in a sense, that sorrow is part and parcel of our communication, our being with people.

I'd like to read this really lovely poem by John Donne. John Donne was a poet in the Restoration period, James I, all that. And he says: "No man is an island, entire of itself. Each is a piece of the continent, a part of the main. If a clod is washed away by the sea, Europe is the less. Each man's death diminishes me, for I am involved in mankind. Therefore, send not to know for whom the bell tolls; it tolls for thee."

So in other words, every man's death is also a little death within me. I had a friend down in Cornwall I would visit on occasion, and he died. And of course, I've lost that relationship. So something in me has been lost. And there's a wholeness about that because we need people. We need friendships. We need to be able to relate, to communicate. It's just part of that — hopefully next tomorrow I'll be talking about the nutriments and you'll see that this was recognized by the Buddha — that we do need other people.

Interestingly enough, when the Buddha's two main disciples died — that's Moggallāna and Sāriputta — I'm going to read this little bit. This again is taken from the book *Mindfully Facing Disease and Death* by Venerable Analayo. Highly recommend it. There is another book, by the way, which I might have mentioned: *Living in the Light of Death: The Art of Being Truly Alive* by Larry Rosenberg.

When Sāriputta died, Ānanda said, "I declare having myself known them on attaining full awakening before establishments of mindfulness and so on and so forth. These have all been taken away." In other words, Ānanda is grieving the loss of his teacher. And there's a series of questions that the Buddha asks him.

"Has he taken away your ability to observe your mind?" He goes through the discourse on how to establish right awareness. "Has he taken away your ability to investigate? Has he taken away your ability to become fully liberated yourself?" And of course, Ānanda says no.

And then the Buddha gives him his advice, which you also get right at the end of the discourse which tells about the last few days of the Buddha. He reminds him that he himself, the Buddha, the Tathāgata, would go. "Therefore, do not be so very sad, Ānanda. You should know that soon the Tathāgata will also be of the past. Therefore, Ānanda, you should have yourself as an island by relying on yourself. You should have the Dhamma as an island by relying on the Dhamma. You should not have another island, no other reliance."

Now this seems contrary to what we've just read from John Donne — that no man is an island. But of course, we're talking about two different things. On one hand, there's our necessary relationship with other people; on the other, there's the fact that relationships go wrong. And where does the relationship go wrong? It goes wrong through attachment. We all know this. Attachment is just another way of saying a psychological dependency on somebody for my happiness, my security, my comfort, and so on.

What the Buddha is saying is that when you put that aside, you've got to find your own inner safety, your own inner place. And of course, we're doing that every time we sit in meditation. We're discovering the observer, the feeler, the one who knows. When that's very clear to you — when you are really the one who knows within yourself and everything else is happening around you: the body with its feelings, the heart with its emotions, the mind with its thoughts — when you're quite separate from all that and you are the observer, the feeler, ask yourself: what's it like? Is it okay? Is it worth being there most of the time?

The Buddha actually says that when Sāriputta died, and Moggallāna too — Moggallāna was murdered, it seems, by another sect who got jealous of him — when these two main disciples died, the *saṅgha*, the order of monks and nuns, felt empty without them. They would have been a similar age to the Buddha. He was thirty-five when he began teaching, and they became his disciples very quickly — his first disciples. So they would have been in their late twenties or thirties, very close to him in age. That's the other side. That's the business of no man is an island.

But we've got this more negative side, which is really about the grief that we feel. This grief has to be felt. It has to be suffered. It's what's left — the consequence, the *kamma*, the *kamma* of unwholesome relationship. Now, you have to be careful here. This isn't immoral. It's not as though you go to hell forever because you had an attachment to somebody. Not at all. It's unwholesome in the sense that eventually it causes pain and it causes us to suffer.

Grief, especially with sudden death — as we had with Pete who died a couple of nights back, and with this woman who's come carrying all these griefs — is extremely difficult to stay with. That shock, the constant death of people in our lives. And of course, as you grow older, as I am, people begin to disappear. Eventually, if you live long enough, it's just you. I mean, you've made other friends, younger friends, whatever. But all those old friends you've known for years, that maybe even go back to childhood — they've all gone. And you're just left there with all these memories.

Grief is that sore, the wound, caused when something from the heart is taken out — ripped out when it's a shock like that. There's no other way but to sit with it, to give the heart time to heal, and to know that this is the result of a psychological dependency. But that isn't to take away the fact that there was also love. There was also a sense of care for the person.

Sometimes you get confused about that. The big confusion is to think that as your grief diminishes, it's telling you that you don't love the person as you used to — that you're losing their love. If you get into that, you're into a never-ending cycle of grief, which lessens and then you have to grieve a bit more. You have to keep pumping it up because you're trying to prove that the grief you have is the measure of your love.

But if the grief process is gone through in its normal passage — which they say is about nine months, and I'm sure you all know if you happen to have grief in your life; there is a charity, Cruse, which helps people — if you allow the heart to express its pain, then over a period of up to nine months, it begins to dissipate. Not that it doesn't come back in little blips, but at least the terrible pain, especially in the first three to six months, begins to ease. Slowly one begins to contact that love, that care that one had. And of course, that brings up beautiful memories and joy arises. That would be the normal passage of things.

There's a story about this. A lay woman who was a great supporter of the Buddha — it goes right back to his early days — turns up one day at the monastery with her hair drenched, weeping, crying out in sorrow. It says she went to see the Buddha in the middle of the day in spite of the sun. Her favourite grandchild, Datta, who had always helped to distribute alms, had suddenly passed away.

When she told the Blessed One of her sorrow, he asked whether she wanted to have as many children and grandchildren as there were people in the city of Sāvattī — that's the capital of Kosala. She joyfully agreed. "But how many people die in Sāvattī every day?" said the Blessed One. She considered and said, "Oh, Lord, in Sāvattī, nine or ten people, five or three or two people, or at least one, die every day. Sāvattī is never free of dying."

Being asked whether in this case she would ever be without sorrow, she had to admit that she would feel sorrow every single day. So the Blessed One said, "Those who have a hundred loved ones have a hundred sorrows. Those who have ninety, all the way down to one, have only one sorrow. And those who have no loved ones have no sorrow. Those alone, I say, are without sorrow, without suffering, without desperation."

Of course, he's not talking about love and care. He's talking about what happens when you're attached, when you are dependent on somebody for some well-being, some happiness, some comfort. That is something we simply have to work through. And as I say, don't make the mistake between grief and love. Grief — the way I'm using the word — is the measure of attachment.

And we simply have to suffer it. That's something else to remind ourselves of: punishment is out of the question in Buddhism. You don't have to punish anybody, or punish yourself, or get angry with yourself. All we're doing then is adding more suffering to the suffering. All we're asked to do is suffer the consequences — that's all. And give the heart time to heal.

01. Sickness, Ageing and Death

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 11 min

Originally given as 01. *Sickness, Ageing and Death* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this opening talk from the series on the human condition, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines how the Buddha could speak directly about life's harsh realities—sickness, ageing, and death—because he had discovered a way beyond suffering. Through the Buddha's dialogue with King Pasenadi of Kosala, we see how even the most powerful rulers cannot escape mortality through wealth, armies, or political cunning.

The Buddha's teaching reveals that not even arahats—fully awakened beings—are exempt from bodily decay and death, yet they face these realities without being overwhelmed. This discourse emphasizes that when 'ageing and death are rolling in on you,' the only meaningful response is to 'live by the Dharma, live righteously and do wholesome and meritorious deeds.'

Bhante reflects on the Buddha's own experience of loss, including the deaths of his chief disciples Sāriputta and Moggallāna, demonstrating that sadness exists even for the awakened, though without the crushing grip of grief. The episode concludes with the Buddha's memorable verse: 'The beautiful chariots of kings wear out. This body too undergoes decay. But the Dharma of the good does not decay.' This teaching serves as essential groundwork for understanding why we need the Buddhist path.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-enlightened one.

I'm continuing these little evening talks using Bhikkhu Bodhi's book, *In the Buddha's Words*, an anthology. I thought I'd begin at the beginning, instead of going all over the place. The book starts with what he calls the human condition. When the Buddha came to his realisation, he saw an end to this suffering business.

Imagine a doctor having to tell somebody they have a terminal illness with no chance of being healed. They might say, "You might last nine months, one year, two years," but the news is really bad. It must be difficult, even if they've done it many times, to actually say that to somebody, knowing the shock and horror it causes. It must be similar when somebody has a chronic illness, something like rheumatoid arthritis. They have to say, "We can't do anything about it; we can give you drugs, but you're stuck with it." Again, there's a despairing note about it and no help.

Very different, of course, if the illness is something they can cure. Then they're happy to tell you that you'll be suffering miserably for a month, but at the end you'll be all right. When it comes to the harsh conditions of our life, the Buddha can be right in our face with it because he's got an answer. He says, "There is an end to this suffering." So he can be fairly straight on the nose about this business. These passages show you how he doesn't pull his punches.

There were two kings in that region. One was Pasenadi, who ruled the northern part of the Gangetic plain. The other was Bimbisara in the south, who ruled the kingdom of Magadha. The Buddha must have known Pasenadi even as a child, because his people, the Sakyas, would have been under that kingship.

You often hear tales of the Buddha being the prince of a great king and all that. But actually, the Sakyas were a small tribe who lived on the borders of what is present-day Nepal. His father was the head man, the chief, and an elective one at that. It would have been a more democratic arrangement—democratic only within that caste, the Kshatriyas, the warrior caste, the rulers. They came under the king of Kosala. The king of Kosala was their lord, you might say. Very feudal. There's no record as to whether they paid duty or anything like that. But anyway, the Buddha obviously knew him, and King Pasenadi became a great supporter of his.

The Buddha is at the capital, Sāvattthī, and King Pasenadi of Kosala says to the Blessed One: "Venerable Sir, is anyone who is born free from ageing and death?"

"Great King, no one who is born is free from ageing and death. Even those affluent Kshatriyas"—that's the ruling caste—"rich with great wealth and property, with abundant gold and silver, abundant treasures and commodities, abundant wealth and grain, because they've been born, are not free from ageing and death. Even those affluent brahmins and those affluent householders with abundant wealth and grain, because they've been born, they're not free from ageing and death. Even those monks who are arahats, fully liberated, whose taints are destroyed, who've lived the holy life, done what has to be done, laid down the burdens, reached their own goal, utterly destroyed the fetters of existence and are completely liberated through final knowledge—even for them this body is subject to breaking up, subject to being laid down."

There's no escape. Even somebody who's fully liberated has to go through the horror. We know that Moggallāna, one of the Buddha's two main disciples and known for his powers, was seemingly murdered by bandits. His other great disciple, Sāriputta, seems to have died at home in peace. But it would have been a sad thing for the Buddha that both of them died before he went.

When I was in Burma, I saw a beautiful statue of the Buddha sitting with his hand pointing towards his heart like that. I'd never seen this mudrā—what's the word for mudrā? The position, like you get them, like this one here; that's the samādhi posture. They told me it represented a sadness he felt when he heard that the two teachers who had brought him so far were dead, and he had wanted to pass on his message to them. This tells us that sadness isn't beyond the Buddha. He's sad, but he's not overwhelmed by it. He's not grieving over it.

There's a little verse he creates: "The beautiful chariots of kings wear out. This body too undergoes decay. But the *Dhamma* of the good does not decay. So the good proclaim along with the good." A little verse to remind us that the Dhamma is beyond time. It's *akālika*. One of the qualities of the Dhamma is that it exists as a law no matter what time or space you happen to be in.

Then he goes on, and this is quite a long passage but we'll get through it. At Sāvattthī, in the middle of the day, King Pasenadi of Kosala approached the Blessed One, paid homage to him and sat down to one side. The Blessed One then asked him: "Now where have you come from, great king, in the middle of the day?"

"Just now, Venerable Sir, I've been engaged in those affairs of kingship typical for kings who are intoxicated with the intoxication of sovereignty, who are obsessed by greed for sensual pleasures and who've attained stable control of their country and who rule, having conquered a great sphere of territory on earth."

Intoxicated with the intoxication of sovereignty. "What do you think, great king? Suppose a man would come to you from the east, one who is trustworthy and reliable, and would tell you: 'For sure, great king, you should know this. I'm coming from the east and there I saw a great mountain high as the clouds coming this way, crushing all living beings. Do whatever you think should be done, great king.' Then a second man would come to you from the west, and a third from the north, and a fourth from the south, one who is trustworthy and reliable, and would tell you: 'For sure, great king, you should know this. I'm coming from the south and there I saw a great mountain high as the clouds coming this way, crushing all living beings. Do whatever you think should be done, great king.' If, great king, such a great peril should arise, such a terrible destruction of human life, the human state being so difficult to obtain, what should be done?"

"If, Venerable Sir, such a great peril should arise, such a terrible destruction of human life, the human state being so difficult to obtain, what else should be done but to live by the Dhamma, to live righteously and to do wholesome and meritorious deeds?"

"I inform you, great king, I announce to you, great king: ageing and death are rolling in on you. When ageing and death are rolling in on you, great king, what should be done?"

"As ageing and death are rolling in on me, Venerable Sir, what else should be done but to live by the Dhamma, to live righteously and to do wholesome and meritorious deeds? Venerable Sir, kings intoxicated with the intoxication of sovereignty, obsessed by greed for sensual pleasures, who've attained stable control of their country and rule over a great sphere of territory, conquer by means of elephant battles, cavalry battles, chariot battles and infantry battles. But there is no hope of victory by such battles, no chance of success when ageing and death are rolling in.

"In this royal court, Venerable Sir, there are counsellors who, when the enemies arrive, are capable of dividing them by subterfuge. There is no hope of victory by subterfuge, no chance of success when ageing and death are rolling in. In this royal court, Venerable Sir, there exists abundant bullion and gold stored in vaults and lofts. With such wealth we are capable of mollifying the enemies when they come. But there is no hope of victory by wealth, no chance of success when ageing and death are rolling in. As ageing and death are rolling in on me, Venerable Sir, what else should I do but live by Dhamma, live righteously and do wholesome and meritorious deeds?"

"So it is, great king, so it is, great king. As ageing and death are rolling in on you, what else should you do but live by Dhamma, live righteously and do wholesome and meritorious deeds?"

This is what the Blessed One said. We can only hope that his words have some effect upon us and that we will live righteously and according to the Dhamma. May you be fully liberated from all suffering sooner rather than later.

02. Divine Messengers

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 14 min

Originally given as 02. *Divine Messengers* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this teaching from the Devadūta Sutta (MN 130), Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the Buddha's discourse on the three divine messengers: old age, sickness, and death. Drawing parallels to the Buddha's own awakening story, he explores how these universal experiences serve as profound reminders of our shared human condition.

The talk delves into the deeper workings of kamma, emphasizing how our actions create ripples both externally in our relationships and internally in our mental states. Bhante particularly highlights how seemingly small acts - respect for parents, elders, and spiritual teachers - carry significant karmic weight, shaping the world we create around ourselves.

Rather than viewing these divine messengers as causes for despair, Bhante shows how mindful awareness of impermanence can awaken us to life's preciousness. By contemplating aging, illness, and death not morbidly but wisely, we learn to treasure each moment and relationship more deeply. This teaching offers practical guidance for incorporating this contemplation into daily practice, transforming our relationship with mortality from fear to appreciation.

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā-Sambuddhassa (three times)

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-enlightened one.

These evening talks are built around passages from *In the Buddha's Words* by Bhikkhu Bodhi, a collection of the Buddha's main teachings from the scriptures. One thing you notice when reading these texts is their repetitive nature. Remember, this was an oral tradition, preserved for over 500 years before being written down. The way you remembered things was by repeating them in sequence, in a formula. So it's very repetitious—but that drives the point home. It has a purpose.

We've been exploring the human condition, starting rather gloomily with the fact that it is, in essence, misery. This particular passage concerns the divine messengers. Those of you who know the Buddha's story will recall that in the mythology surrounding his awakening, there are four messengers. This text mentions only three. What it's saying is that somewhere in his youth—his late youth—he became aware of three things: sickness, old age, and death.

There was also something else he noticed: an ascetic sitting under a tree, which suggested there might be an escape. According to the story, on four journeys while out hunting, he comes across a very sick person, a very old person, a corpse, and this monk sitting under a tree. Each time he asks what it is, because he's not supposed to know—he's been brought up in a life of luxury. When he finds out, he says, "Well, this will happen to me—will I get sick, will I age, will I die?" That's quite a shock. You could look upon this as an existential crisis in his life, one that eventually drives him from home to seek an answer.

This passage uses the same imagery of the divine messengers—only three here—but with a slightly different purpose. I'll read it, and you'll get the flavour of the scriptures too.

"There are, monks, these three divine messengers." He translated it as "monks," but really it's a word better rendered as "listeners" or "those who are listening to what he's saying." "What three? There is a person of bad conduct in body, speech and mind, and on the dissolution of the body after death he's reborn in a plane of misery, in a bad destination, in a lower world, in hell."

"There the warders of hell seize him by both arms and take him before Yama, the lord of death, saying, 'This man, your majesty, had no respect for father and mother, nor for ascetics and Brahmins, nor did he honour the elders of the family. May your majesty inflict due punishment on him.'"

"Then, monks, King Yama questions that man, examines him and addresses him concerning the first divine messenger. 'Didn't you ever see, my good man, the first divine messenger appearing among humankind?' And he replies, 'No, Lord, I didn't see him.'"

"Then King Yama says to him, 'But my good man, didn't you ever see a woman or a man, 80, 90 or 100 years old, frail, bent like a roof bracket, crooked, leaning on a stick, shakily going along, ailing, youth long gone, with broken teeth, with grey and scanty hair, or bald, wrinkled, with blotched limbs?'"

That's a great old description, isn't it?

"And the man replies, 'Yes, Lord, I have seen him.' Then King Yama says, 'But my good man, didn't it ever occur to you, an intelligent and mature person, that I too am subject to old age and cannot escape it? Let me now do noble deeds of body, speech and mind.' 'No, Lord, I could not do it. I was negligent.'"

'Through negligence, my good man, you have failed to do noble deeds by body, speech and mind. Well, you'll be treated as befits your negligence. That evil action of yours was not done by mother or father, brothers, sisters, friends or companions, nor by relatives, *devas*, ascetics or Brahmins. You alone have done that evil deed, and you alone will have to experience the fruit.'

'Now, monks, when King Yama has questioned, examined and addressed him thus concerning the first divine messenger, he again questions, examines and addresses the man about the second one: 'Didn't you ever see, my good man, the second divine messenger appearing among mankind?' 'No, Lord, I didn't see him.'

'But my good man, didn't you ever see a woman or a man who was sick and in pain, seriously ill, lying in his own filth, having to be lifted up by some and put to bed by others?' 'Yes, Lord, I have seen this.'

'My good man, didn't it ever occur to you, an intelligent and mature person, that I too am subject to illness and cannot escape it? Let me now do noble deeds by body, speech and mind.' 'No, Lord, I could not do it. I was negligent.'

Now, monks, when King Yama has questioned, examined and addressed him thus concerning the second divine messenger, he again questions, examines and addresses the man about the third one: 'Didn't you ever see, my good man, the third divine messenger appearing among mankind?' 'No, Lord, I did not see him.'

'But, my good man, didn't you ever see a woman or a man one or three days dead, the corpse swollen, discoloured and festering?' 'Yes, Lord, I have seen this.'

'Then, my good man, didn't it ever occur to you, an intelligent and mature person, that I too am subject to death and cannot escape it? Let me now do noble deeds by body, speech and mind.' 'No, Lord, I could not do it. I was negligent.'

'Through negligence, my good man, you have failed to do noble deeds of body, speech and mind. Well, you'll be treated as befits your negligence. That evil action of yours was not done by mother or father, brothers, sisters, friends or companions, nor by relatives, *devas*, ascetics or Brahmins. You alone have done the evil deed, and you alone must experience the fruit.'

Let me take this apart a bit. We've discussed what these divine messengers are. Obviously this is told in a mythological way, but the basic law of *kamma* is very simple: when you do something wholesome, wholesomeness arises from it. When you do something unwholesome, unskillful, unskillfulness arises from it. And remember, there are two waves of that action.

When you say something warm and kind and supportive, or when you say something cutting and horrible, it goes out into the world and affects somebody. They'll react to you in their own particular way. But that, in a sense, is not your *kamma*. Most people think of *kamma* as something that happens to them. The real *kamma* is internal, because the more you find yourself speaking kindly and gently, the more good you feel inside. And the more you're being angry and making cutting remarks, the more you feel unhappy inside.

Of course, as we do this we build up a world around us. People begin to know us: this person speaks kindly and is nice and gentle; that person is horrible. Eventually you find yourself being liked or disliked, and so the world out there begins to mirror what's in your own heart. And here's a really subtle point: even if you think you're being kind, but actually there's something in your voice that's unkind or insincere — even if you don't know that in yourself, the other person does. Then although you're being kind, you keep wondering, 'Why doesn't anybody like me?'

Here you see what he's saying is the deeper teaching about *kamma*. Notice that he's not talking about evil deeds — he's not talking about murdering and thieving and all that. He's talking about ordinary social things, relationships. No respect for mother or father, for ascetics or Brahmins; didn't honour the elders of the family. These are things we wouldn't normally consider so important from the point of view of the karmic doctrine about evil, but actually it's all important. If you take care of your relationships, if you take care of the small things in life, then the big things tend to take care of themselves. It's interesting that he should make such a big point of just this — relationship in society.

For those of you who are new to Buddhism, the Buddha did teach rebirth. He taught that after death, one carries on — driven by one's ethical actions, shaped by one's ethics. That was the important point. In the scriptures he often uses imagery and tales, the ways things would be told in those days. In a sense it's a bit difficult for us to enter into that mythology, but there's a connection: as you know, in Christianity one is judged at the pearly gates, the day of judgment, whether you get in or not.

This day of judgment, really, spiritually speaking, is happening internally. We ourselves end up being our own judges. When you reflect upon your life — the Dalai Lama says that you live your life twice, if you live long enough: once as you live towards old age, and then in old age you live it again as memory. Hopefully when we get to advanced old age, our memories are full of beautiful ones, because they're caused by past actions which have been beautiful.

You have to take certain scriptures within the mythology of their time, but the teaching is there: making ourselves more and more aware of these three divine messengers, these three signs — sickness, old age, and death. It's not something we particularly like to think about. You don't have to get morose about it. You don't have to be on it all day and all night. But you might find it very useful just to bring those three to mind every morning, as a reminder. Then when the body does get sick, as you do advance in age, and as death does come upon us, it doesn't arrive as this huge, enormous shock — 'I never thought it would happen to me.'

There was this lovely cartoon I saw: a woman is dying in bed, all her friends around her. She says, 'Why me? Why not one of you?' We don't want to get into that position of terminal shock.

Just now a friend phoned up — one of his close friends has been told he has a terminal illness. He's only 61, which is young these days, younger than me. It's a case of always just having that mindfulness. And of course the effect isn't to make us depressed — that's the point. The effect is to begin to see how precious life is. We begin to treasure it more. That's the joy of it. You begin to really open up to the joys of life, taking nothing for granted. Because you might not be here tomorrow.

I hope my words have been of some assistance. May you, by your careful discernment between wholesome and unwholesome action, lead yourself to complete liberation from suffering.

The Five Constant Contemplations

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 24 min

Originally given as *The Five Constant Contemplations* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this profound teaching, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the five themes for regular contemplation outlined by the Buddha in the Aṅguttara Nikāya (AN 5.57). These contemplations address our universal human condition: aging, illness, death, separation from all we hold dear, and our ownership of karma. Rather than morbid reflections, these practices serve to undermine our intoxications with health, youth, and life that lead to unwholesome conduct.

Bhante explains how proper contemplation works—not as mere intellectual thinking, but as a heart-practice that allows us to deeply digest difficult truths until resistance dissolves into acceptance. He provides practical phrases and methods for each contemplation, emphasizing how this universal human condition offers strange comfort rather than despair. The teaching includes the Buddha's own verse on how these reflections led to his renunciation and awakening.

These contemplations directly support the path to liberation by abandoning the fetters and uprooting underlying unwholesome tendencies. The session concludes with guided contemplative phrases for each of the five themes, offering practitioners concrete tools for this transformative practice.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā-sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā-sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā-sambuddhassa — Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

This is our November moon — a little earlier than November, but a November moon even so. There are thirteen this year. I've pre-recorded this talk because I'm on retreat, and I'm very grateful to Mark for running it through for us.

If you remember last November, that lugubrious month, I devoted it to our favourite party topic: death. We saw how powerful that contemplation was, according to the Buddha — leading directly to liberation. I'm going to say something about how that works in terms of contemplation. But death is only one of a set of five. In the Numerical Sayings, section five, number 57, we find a discourse on the Five Constant or Regular Contemplations.

First, the Buddha enumerates the five contemplations: "There are these five themes that should often be reflected upon by a woman or a man, by a household-er or one gone forth." One gone forth is a monastic. What five? "I am subject to aging, not exempt from aging. I'm subject to illness, not exempt from illness. I'm subject to death, not exempt from death. I must be parted and separated from everyone and everything dear and agreeable to me. I am the owner of my *kamma*, my actions of body, speech and mind." That's the *kamma* here — not the consequence. "The heir to my *kamma*, I have *kamma* as my origin, *kamma* as my relative, *kamma* as my resort. I will be heir to whatever *kamma* actions I do, good or bad."

We're going to leave *kamma* till next November because there's too much to cover here. But even so, you can still contemplate it.

The Buddha then tells us how we should reflect upon these themes. "I'm subject to illness. I'm not exempt from illness." In a state of health, beings are intoxicated with their health, and when they're intoxicated with their health, they engage in misconduct of body, speech, and mind. In other words, when we feel okay, we tend to push the body. Just think about our eating habits — the difference between living to eat and eating to live.

"I'm subject to aging. I'm not exempt from aging." In their youth, beings are intoxicated with their youth, and when they're intoxicated with their youth, they engage in misconduct of body, speech and mind. Of course, it's not only the young who are intoxicated with youth. This is a very youth-oriented culture. Everybody is intoxicated with youth — Botox. Old people are useless, a weight on society. And of course, sixty is the new forty. The practice is really about getting beyond that and accepting our age as it comes towards us.

"I'm subject to death. I'm not exempt from death." During their lives, beings are intoxicated with life, and when they're intoxicated with life, they engage in misconduct by body, speech and mind. What we try to do is live to create as many

great experiences as we can. We want to suck as much joy out of life as we can, squeeze the stone for more excitement. This leads to unfortunate behaviour. We need only think about the societal denial of death.

"I must be parted from everyone and everything dear and agreeable to me." Beings have desire and craving in regard to these people and things that are dear and agreeable, and excited by this craving, they engage in misconduct of body, speech and mind.

Here's a little exercise I suggest you might try. Create two lists: one of all the things you wouldn't want to lose, wouldn't want to be robbed of; the other of all the people you wouldn't want to lose or see go away or disappear. Then go through each list and catch your relationship to those things and people.

Remember that when it comes to things, we can't actually own them. That's a legal fiction. What we can do is use them. If somebody steals my mobile phone, I go around moping and moaning about this dreadful thief who has taken my phone. But it's no longer my phone, is it? It belongs to the thief. Instead, I have to wish that he uses that phone to good purpose, and that if he sells it on, the money be used for the benefit of himself and other people. That's the way we ought to look at it. People are different, of course, and that's a different area we don't want to go into this evening.

And then there's the reflection on *kamma*: "I am the owner of my actions, heir to my *kamma*. I have *kamma* as my origin, *kamma* as my relative, *kamma* as my resort. I will be heir to whatever *kamma*, good or bad, that I do." People engage in misconduct by body, speech and mind because we're not always conscious of the effects of what we might be doing. But as I say, we shall leave that for more detail next November.

This is how the Buddha wants us to reflect: 'I am not the only one subject to illness, not exempt from illness. All beings that come and go, that pass away and undergo rebirth, are subject to illness, not exempt from illness.' Personally, I find this sort of contemplation rather comforting. It's simply knowing that you're not on your own — this is the big picture. Everybody falls ill sometime or other.

It's the same with aging: 'I'm not the only one subject to aging, not exempt from aging. All beings that come and go, that pass away and undergo rebirth, are subject to aging. None are exempt from aging.' And that's all beings — even our little pet rats who run over our property. Again, there's a strange comfort in this.

And the same with death: 'I'm not the only one subject to death, not exempt from death. All beings that come and go, that pass away and undergo rebirth, are subject to death. None are exempt from death.' There's comfort in looking back and seeing your mother and father, if they have died, and the generations before — your grandfathers and grandmothers, your uncles and aunts. If they can go, then of course I can go. That's not a problem. It's a case of feeling some comfort that you're just part of that process.

I remember seeing a cartoon once where an elderly lady is on her deathbed, surrounded by her friends. She's asking, 'Why me? Why not one of you?' Consider if we were the only ones to die. Everybody else is alive, everybody else is mucking about and having a great time — and just me, I've got to die. Well, it wouldn't be fair, would it?

'I am not the only one who must be parted and separated from everyone and everything dear and pleasing to me. All beings that come and go, pass away and undergo rebirth, must be parted and separated from everyone and everything dear and pleasing.' This, of course, is renunciation — being able to let go and bring ourselves back to the reality of our relationships with things and, more touchingly, with people. It's really about accepting the way it is.

And finally: 'I'm not the only one who is owner of my *kamma*, heir to my *kamma*, who has *kamma* as my origin, *kamma* as my relative, *kamma* as my resort, who will be heir to whatever *kamma*, good or bad, that I do. All beings that come and go, that pass away and undergo rebirth, are owners of their *kamma*, heirs of their *kamma*, have *kamma* as their origin and also their resort.'

Now, what the Buddha says is this: as we often reflect on these themes, the path is generated. We pursue the path, develop it and cultivate it. And as we do so, the fetters are entirely abandoned and the underlying tendencies are uprooted.

What he's saying is that by practising in this way, we are undermining all our delusion. The fetters are wrong view of self, sceptical doubt, and clinging to mere rules and rituals as if they're enough to become liberated — and these are what you abandon when you enter the stream, the first level of attainment. But sensual craving and ill will don't go until the third attainment. Then finally, in the fourth attainment, the *arahat*, the fully liberated, abandons craving for those beautiful *jhānic* states, both the lower four and the upper four; conceit, this business of 'I am better, I am worse, I'm equal to'; restlessness, which really includes all the de-

filements we've had before but now are so fine that they're experienced as mere restlessness; and finally the whole of ignorance. Delusion disappears — the very thing upon which all our suffering was grounded.

The *anusaya*, these underlying tendencies, are subconscious, unwholesome habits. We know this from our Freudian psychology — that underneath us there's all this unresolved stuff. Given the right impetus, the right circumstance, it'll pop up. Hence we have those embarrassing Freudian slips.

This is what the Buddha said, or what he said to himself at some point in his training: 'It terrifies ordinary people to contemplate sickness, aging and death, and that they are inescapable. If I find myself detesting such people, it would not be proper for me, for I have the same flaws. Contemplating this, while knowing that there's no acquisitiveness in *Nibbāna* — you can't take anything with you to *Nibbāna* — I overcame these obsessions with health, youth and even life. I saw safety in renunciation, so I put effort into the practice and realised *Nibbāna*. It is no longer possible for me to indulge in sensual pleasures. Now I have fulfilled the spiritual path. I shall not come back again.'

So how does contemplation work? First of all, it's not thinking. We use thought, but really it's to get in touch with our feelings. When you get in touch with your feelings — let's say about death, which is an easy one to start with because it's so heavy — you find a phrase that touches you. By 'touches' I mean it frightens you a bit, or you feel you don't want to go there. The more you don't want to repeat that phrase, the more you have to repeat it. You just keep repeating it into the heart until you feel there's a becoming, a sort of acceptance.

When it's fully digested, when the reality of what you're saying is fully digested and there's no more aversion, no more fear of whatever you're saying, then you'll find that a sense of relief comes. This is the way it is. With it, you might even find yourself smiling. That's what we have to do: find phrases that move us, phrases that push us a little to accept things.

It might be memories that do this work. Perhaps we remember seeing a friend's corpse, or a parent's. Anything that brings up our fear of death. The same is true for falling sick. Everybody has a particular illness they're afraid of — everybody is, to some extent, a hypochondriac. It might be some terrible paralyzing disease, or picking up a tick while walking in the fields and worrying about the illnesses and parasites you can get from such things. And there's dementia, of

course. That's a background fear for anybody approaching my age. Anyone over seventy, you know — you begin to forget things and think, 'Oh, that must be the first sign.'

So you have to allow these things to come up into your mind. You're using the word, using the memory, but really what you're doing is getting in contact with your heart's feeling about it. You keep repeating it gently, staying with the heart's reaction, waiting for that resistance to disappear — and then it's digested. Now that's not the end of it. You'll find another sentence that brings up much the same thing. But over time we're getting used to the idea that we may fall sick, we will definitely grow old — even if you're very young, you're still growing old — and we will die.

Sickness is a mini death, a preparation for death. The body manifests its vulnerability. There is discomfort, pain, and some disability. This undermines our obsession with health and beauty.

So you might find a phrase to repeat, something like: 'Sickness is unpreventable. I will probably fall sick. This body is of a nature to fall ill. This body has not gone beyond sickness.'

Then there's aging, which is, you might say, a progressive dying. This contemplation undermines our intoxication with youth, our trying to stay young forever. Abandon that. 'Aging is inevitable. This body is subject to aging. This body has not gone beyond aging. This body is now in a process of aging.'

Death, of course, is certain. Life is uncertain. That's straight from the Buddha. Sometimes saying the obvious gets through the thick shell of not wanting to know. 'Life is uncertain. Death is certain. Death is inescapable. Everyone must die. The remainder of our lifespan is decreasing continually.' This is what I say — every time we have breakfast, remind ourselves: this is one less breakfast in this lifetime. When we've had a superb lunch somewhere: one less superb lunch in this lifetime. When we've had an amazing meal with friends out at a restaurant: one less amazing meal with friends I shall have.

'Death will come regardless of whether or not I've made time for practice.' Now that's a killer. You've got to really meditate on that — it's no good, as you're dying, saying, 'Oh, if only, if only I had.' We don't know when we're going to die. Human life expectancy is uncertain. There are many causes of death. The human body is very fragile. Only the practice of Dharma can help us at the time of death. Our

wealth cannot help us. Our loved ones cannot help us. Our own body cannot help us. 'Death is inescapable. This body is subject to death. This body has not gone beyond death. This body will die.'

And then there's the second contemplation: 'I must be parted and separated from everyone and everything dear and agreeable to me.' That's something we can make lists about in our own time — but you can't take anything with you. That's the problem.

Then comes the contemplation of *kamma*: 'I own my actions. I inherit the results of my actions. I'm born of my actions. I form relations through my actions. I live dependent on my actions. Whatever I do, for good or for ill, I will inherit the results.' Actions here means actions of body and speech mainly, but of course it all begins in the mind.

I'm going to leave this here. I hope this little homily will have been of some use to you, that I've not caused confusion, and that you will — by your sincere practice of these five contemplations — arrive at the goal we're all striving for sooner rather than later.

The Contemplation of Death

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 25 min

Originally given as *The Contemplation of Death* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this November teaching, Bhante Bodhidhamma presents maraṇasati (mindfulness of death) as what the Buddha called "the most powerful of all contemplations." Drawing from his Catholic upbringing's November traditions of remembering the deceased, Bhante explains how death contemplation addresses our fundamental delusion of selfhood and the biological terror that drives human behavior toward acquisition, aversion, and fear.

The talk explores how the Buddha taught monks to contemplate death with each breath, not merely daily or with each meal. Bhante presents the traditional contemplations of aging, sickness, and death using repetitive phrases that allow practitioners to feel and surrender to resistance rather than merely thinking about mortality. He explains how this practice leads to "a footing in nibbāna" - glimpses of the deathless dimension that can ultimately bring complete liberation from dukkha.

The practical benefits include relief from fighting the inevitable, increased appreciation for life's preciousness, gratitude, compassion for others' suffering, and deeper presence with anicca (impermanence). This contemplation directly supports vipassanā practice by revealing the insubstantial nature of self and the arising-passing nature of all conditioned existence, leading practitioners toward the unconditioned peace of nibbāna.

I was brought up a Roman Catholic, and November is a month where the souls in purgatory are remembered. In Catholic doctrine, there are three realms. There's hell, and if you get in there, you're stuck—there's no way out. Then there's heaven, which of course is very blissful, and that's where you really want to get stuck. But there's this in-between place where, well, you weren't that bad in life. You don't deserve hell. But on the other hand, you're not clean enough to get into heaven. You've got to really purify the heart. That was the purpose of purgatory.

In the purgatorial realm, you might suffer just as much as in hell, but the distinction is you know the way out. Whether these realms actually exist or not is not important. They definitely do mirror mental states. When you're in hell—in those times when everything falls apart, when the whole world seems to be against you and you don't see a way out—well, that's hell, isn't it? We know certain illnesses, certain mental states, drive people to suicide. These are hellish states. And heaven, of course, are those wonderful little times when we feel perfectly happy and the world seems to be supporting us. But I think I can safely say that for most of the time, life is purgatory. This, of course, is the meaning of dukkha. It's somehow not entirely satisfactory.

In the Roman Catholic tradition, a month was set aside—November. Now, November doesn't have the colour of autumnal October, and it definitely hasn't got the promise of December. It's a dark, dank month, at least in these climes, and a lovely one to devote to thinking about our ancestors, people who have died. We can do that. But this happy idea came to me that November would be a wonderful month every year to contemplate death. Now, I know you're very excited about that idea.

We have to begin at the beginning. When I talk about the beginning of time, I'm not talking about time in the past, when time began. I'm talking about every single moment of consciousness. Just in that absolute moment of beginning, we become—we fall into an identity with what we're actually experiencing, which is of course through this psychophysical organism. And herein, just in this understanding, is the fear of death. Right there, at the end point of that consciousness, is the letting go of a moment of being awake. That point is the point of death.

Unfortunately, these series of conscious moments are so quick that they all seem to run together, giving us an impression of continuity. And in that impression, of course, there is also the destruction of fear.

The Buddha tells us that the contemplation of death is the most powerful of all contemplations. We are actually reaching down to the very foundation stone of our delusion—this delusion of identity, the delusion of self. And if there's one thing the self does not want to do, it does not want to die.

Here is what he says about it: "Disciples, mindfulness of death, when developed and pursued, is of great fruit and great benefit. It gains a footing in nibbāna, the deathless. Has nibbāna, the deathless, as its final end." Nibbāna here is, of course, that transcendent dimension.

What's he actually saying? He's saying that if we really contemplate this whole idea of death, this notion of death that we have, we will get a glimpse of what nibbāna actually is. That's the footing—a glimpse. And if we continue to do it, this path alone—this is what he's saying—just the contemplation of death will actually bring us to the end of dukkha, the end of suffering. It will be done at that point where the whole notion, the whole concept of self, completely disappears.

I do mention a book here by Ernest Becker called *The Denial of Death*, written in 1973. It's still a smashing read and well worth buying. What he says is that the basic motivation of human behaviour is our biological need to control our basic anxiety, to deny the terror of death.

This leads us exactly to those three basic attitudes that come out of the delusion of believing we are this body, heart, and mind. The first is gathering, acquiring. The more we have—more money, more power, more riches—the more safe we feel. Safety: that's what we're searching for. And of course, if anything undermines that, it becomes the enemy, the rival. We've got to get rid of it. And if it happens to be bigger than us, we've got to run. So these three fundamental attitudes—acquisitiveness, fear, and aversion—are coming out of that fundamental delusion of self. I like it when Becker says it's a biological, a physical need. Because without a body, you're not here. This fear roots itself in the body.

Here's the Buddha asking his monks: how often should we meditate on death? On one occasion—I'm paraphrasing—the Buddha asked several monks, "How often do you contemplate death?" One replied, "I contemplate death every day, Lord." He said, "That's not good enough." He asked another monk, "How often do you contemplate death?" "I contemplate death with each mouthful I eat during a meal." "Not good enough." Then he turned to another and said, "What about you?" And he said, "I contemplate death with each in-breath and out-breath." The Buddha smiled and was pleased.

Of course, we can't be thinking about death all the time—completely all the time. But as you know, in medieval times, death was very obvious. People died in front of you. And they always kept a memento mori, a reminder of death, which was normally some sort of little skull kept on a table by the bedside or wherever it could be easily seen. It could catch your eye and just in that moment bring up: there is an end to my life. And every day shortens the period by which I'm going to actually reach this point.

When we think about the actual moment of death, that's all it is, isn't it? A single moment. Someone could throw you under a bus, and in that shocking instant you'd be breathing in—and then you'd be dead. Or you could be breathing out, your last breath, just letting go, and at the end of the out-breath, there's death. So every time you sit in meditation, simply knowing that the in-breath ends and the out-breath ends keeps you in touch with the truth that everything vanishes. Everything comes to an end. This body will die. This person will die.

If we keep constantly distracting ourselves, always finding something to do, something to achieve, we're just going to be taken by surprise. What would our last thoughts be? Just consider. You're sitting at breakfast holding a piece of toast, saturated, dripping with hot butter and layers of marmalade. As you raise it to your mouth, suddenly you have a heart attack. Can you imagine the agony? What would you do? Would you go for a final bite, or would you sit there calmly, knowing, and just let that toast drop, falling away into death?

On the other hand, there's the story of a Zen monk—apocryphal, but still—falling over a cliff, hanging on by his nails for dear life, yet having the time to admire a little wildflower sneaking from a cranny. That's how we want to go, isn't it? Calm, peaceful, with joy in our hearts. Why not? Why not?

The Buddha says there are four types of people. There are those who wake up to death, to its immediacy, even upon hearing the word very early in life. There are those who don't wake up until someone dear to them dies—I remember when my mother and father died, I was telling the family that I'm next. There are those who wake up when lots of people die; this whole catastrophe around COVID, with people dying here and there in that first wave, really created a lot of fear and anxiety in society. And the final one, the worst case, is to suddenly wake up to the whole notion of death when the doctor tells you you've got six weeks to live. That's called being unprepared for a terminal shock.

But no matter how ready we are for death, it'll always come with a shock. So long as the self is there, there's always that residue of fear, however small. Now that we've got this war right on our doorstep—and of course war's going on all over the place—consider the soldier, what he must brace himself for. He goes in with his machine gun and whatnot, but he knows he could be shot. There's always that wonderful ability to be open to the idea that you're going to die. And I think a soldier who goes in with proper intention has the ability to turn it into a spiritual practice.

Anyway, how do we do it? This is the big question, isn't it? How do we actually do this contemplation on death? Now, contemplation is not the same as thinking. We're not going to sit here thinking about death—what is death? What does it mean? Where is it going? What will happen to me when I die? That's a complete waste of time.

What we're going to do is use a phrase, a mantra. You can choose a passage, but it should be something that brings up the feelings, the attitudes we have around death. As we repeat these phrases, we get in touch with the resistance, the not wanting to accept the truth of it. And it's being able to keep on saying it, keep on saying it gently into the heart, until you get that surrender. Then there's that digestion that comes into the heart—the whole idea of sickness, aging, and death.

Sickness, of course, is a prelude to death. And aging is just a slow, miserable death, which I am now coming to myself. As we practise this, and that openness comes, and we surrender to the truth of it, you might find a sense of wonderful relief—even a smile appearing on the face. Then there's that ability to hold it with a gentle kindness. And there's always that sense of humour about it. The whole situation is ridiculous. You get born, you do all this work, and then you drop dead. Remember the old comedian joke: life's hard and then you die. Samuel Beckett says it beautifully in his own inimitable way: we are born astride a grave.

What I'm going to do is give you these sentences. You simply repeat them gently within your heart. We're going to do it for about a good half minute each. It sounds long, but you'd be surprised how quickly it passes.

First, there's sickness, which you can look upon as a preparation for death—the body manifesting its vulnerability. There's discomfort or pain, and there's always some disability. This contemplation undermines our intoxication with youth, that constant trying to stay young, sixty as the new forty, things like that. Sickness is unpreventable. The body is going to fall sick to some degree or another in our lifetimes. Hopefully, of course, it will be something that passes.

These are the three sentences:

The body is subject to disease.

The body is of a nature to fall ill.

This body has not gone beyond sickness.

The next set of phrases concerns aging—which is, as I say, a progressive dying. This contemplation undermines our obsession with health and beauty, with intolerances and fasting and food ingredients. It's the obsession with it all. Aging, of course, is inevitable.

This body is subject to aging.

This body has not gone beyond aging.

This body is now in the process of aging.

Again, we simply repeat these phrases into our hearts, observing any resistance, feeling it, allowing it to manifest and waiting for it to die—until we surrender to the truth of the statement.

Life is uncertain; death is certain. This contemplation undermines the overwhelming clinging to life at all costs—shoring it up, barricading it with fame, riches, and power. Death is inescapable. Everyone must die.

The remainder of our lifespan is decreasing continually.

Death will come regardless of whether or not we have made time to practise Dharma.

We don't know when we are going to die. These are all phrases from the Buddha.

Human life expectancy is uncertain.

There are many causes of death, and the human body is fragile.

Only the practice of Dharma can help us at the time of death.

Our wealth cannot help us.

Our loved ones cannot help us.

Our own body cannot help us.

Death is inescapable.

These are the phrases to repeat:

This body is subject to death.

This body has not gone beyond death.

This body will die.

There is a final contemplation that links into this, and it concerns karma. We recognise that we own our actions. We inherit the results of our actions. We are born because of our actions into every moment. We are related through our actions. And we live dependent upon our actions. Whatever good or ill I do, I shall inherit the results. That's a nice little thing just to repeat.

Having done these exercises, you might think, "Oh well, so I get a footing in Nibbāna. I might get a little hint of what Nibbāna actually is. And if I do it often enough and with real sincerity, I might even be liberated. But is that all?" Not at all. There are amazing benefits to be had right through this practice of contemplation.

First of all, there's the relief that comes from accepting the inevitable. We simply stop fighting. So much energy is lost pushing thoughts and feelings away—energy now released to do better things with. The underlying fear of sickness, ageing, and death puts a pall over our lives. But when we face them directly, life becomes more colourful. We appreciate it more. We regain some of that childlike wonder at the miracle of being alive. It's as though somebody has pulled up a blind in a room we didn't think was dark.

With this comes gratitude. And from gratitude, a desire to share our joys with others and to comfort them in their sorrow. Accepting death as part of the life cycle, we are more at ease by someone's dying bedside.

This practice also brings us sharply into the present—to the arising and passing away of every moment, and to the realisation that within all this change is the unchangeable, the unconditioned, the beatitude of Nibbāna.

That is why in vipassanā we investigate anicca, impermanence, one of the three characteristics of existence. It leads to the realisation that holding on to anything is illusory and bound to bring some level of dissatisfaction. And it leads us to see the insubstantiality of the self—once so solid, but now just arising and passing away with every moment of consciousness.

What is the practice in daily life? It's putting aside just a few moments in the morning. You could do it after the sitting, before mettā—I think it's nice to do before mettā—in which you simply repeat those phrases gently into your heart. These contemplations work over time. They don't work just because you've done

them once. Even if you were to do it all day, which would be a good idea, the effect would disappear without repetition. It has to be done every day, all day, for every day of our lives. Just that little reminder. And it is a really powerful practice.

I can only hope that my words have been of some assistance, that they haven't caused confusion, and that your daily practice of the contemplation of ageing, sickness, and death will lead you to your liberation—sooner rather than later.

Contemplation of Death (Again) - Living with Frugality

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 32 min

Originally given as *Contemplation of Death (Again) - Living with Frugality* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this compelling talk from the 2020 lockdown series, Bhante Bodhidhamma returns to the profound practice of maraṇasati (mindfulness of death), sharing vivid feedback from a practitioner who experienced both the challenging and calming aspects of this contemplation. Drawing from the Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta (MN 10) cemetery meditations and Aṅguttara Nikāya teachings, he explores how death awareness brings us into the present moment and transforms our relationship with mortality.

The talk then shifts to practical wisdom on living frugally during economic uncertainty, reflecting on the Buddha's four requisites (food, shelter, clothing, medicine) and how previous generations naturally lived with less. Bhante emphasizes examining our true needs versus wants, drawing parallels between monastic simplicity and the necessity many face during difficult times. He offers both spiritual and practical guidance for maintaining dignity and practice while living with reduced resources.

This teaching skillfully weaves together the urgency that death contemplation brings to spiritual practice with compassionate advice for navigating material hardship, showing how Buddhist wisdom applies to both our deepest existential questions and everyday challenges.

Greetings. I hope you've had a fruitful day. I don't say happy — I say fruitful.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble, and fully self-awakened one.

I did say I'd be approaching the question of the Eightfold Noble Path, but I've been dragged back to contemplation of death. I hope you don't mind. It's always an absorbing topic for me.

I want to read an email from somebody who's been practising this. He says, "This morning, I managed to catch up with the talk on death and the virus, which I found intriguing. I followed it up with a twenty-minute contemplation on the last breath. It's powerful stuff, a quick way of generating a lot of unpleasant feelings. After twenty minutes, I decided to switch to mettā, compassion practice for myself and others, to balance the exercise. The feelings that came up in the death contemplation lingered through the morning and gave a certain edge to the day."

Get that? An edge to the day — living in the moment.

He continues: "In the afternoon, I went on a cycle ride and ended up doing a second death contemplation in a quiet local graveyard, the one about decay of the dead body." Now, that refers to the *Satipaṭṭhāna* discourse, where the last section on mindfulness of the body concerns the cemetery contemplations. In those days bodies were simply laid out in the charnel grounds, eaten by animals, and so forth. They were shrouded in white, and the monks would take that cloth and stitch it into robes. I think this was a general habit among the *śramaṇas*, the recluses of various teachers. The Buddha in that discourse is really saying: go and sit there, watch that decomposition, and remind yourself, "As this body is, so mine will be." That's pretty heavy.

Anyway, he goes on: "I found this one surprisingly easy. Maybe it was the ecologist's perspective. For me, there's something comforting about the realisation that I'm going to end up as food for something else. Waste not, want not. I left the graveyard with a great sense of calm."

That, of course, is one purpose of death meditation: to come to an acceptance of it, a growing acceptance. We never know how much we've truly accepted the process of dying, or the moment of death, until we're actually doing it. But at least we can approach it and take away its sting. O death, where is thy sting? "I left the graveyard with a great sense of calm."

His last paragraph: "I will soon have more cause to observe and contemplate death and its effect on the living as a coffin bearer in a local gypsy funeral. Apparently it's becoming difficult to find four physically fit people who don't have to isolate themselves. There may be a whole new unexpected line of work opening up for me over the next few months." And may that be so.

So there we have an email from somebody who's been practising. I would love to know that you've been practising it too, and what effect it's had on you. For me, it was an enormously powerful practice in my youth — in my twenties, actually.

That's when this whole thing about death really hit me. At that time I was an annihilationist; I thought that when you die, that was the end of it. So my big question was a really silly question, really: what was it like to go into nothingness? It would be like nothing, wouldn't it? But for some reason it became an obsessive investigation.

This is definitely something to practise. You'd have to do it. He did it for twenty minutes — that's quite a lengthy stretch. If you want to do it on a regular basis, it can be just those few breaths where you remind yourself that life is on a knife edge. And occasionally during the day, just acknowledge that the cup of tea is finished. That's it. It's gone. There is no more. There's another cup of tea, but that cup of tea is completely gone. The effect, of course, is to bring you into the present moment. That's the purpose: to live in the now. Whereas, for the most part, we're planning to live in the now. That's ridiculous, isn't it?

I mentioned last night that the discourse I read was from a collection extant only in Chinese, which has been translated and is used by Bhikkhu Anālayo. He seems to like those — probably to make us aware of them and encourage us to read them. But there are parallel discourses in the Theravāda tradition.

One of them is very much like that, except with a slightly different approach. Again, the Buddha has been through all these bhikkhus who tell him they just want enough time to eat half their alms food so they may attend to the Blessed One's teaching. "I could then accomplish much." We could translate that these days as: you would only want to eat half your meal so that you could practise spiritually.

Then another one says, "May I live just the time it takes to chew and swallow four or five mouthfuls of food so that I may attend to the Blessed One's teaching. I could then accomplish much." They're always doing this contemplation of death in order to listen to the Buddha's teachings. And as I say, we can translate that these days as: in order to continue our spiritual practice.

But at the end of the discourse, the Buddha delineates what in fact constitutes a proper contemplation of death, using a similar image. The bhikkhu, remember, refers to anybody who's listening or reading the scriptures. It's a figure of speech — I can't remember what it's called now. It's like when you say "all hands on deck." We don't expect just the hands to turn up.

"The bhikkhu who develops mindfulness of death thus: 'May I live just the length of time it takes to chew and swallow a single mouthful of food so that I may attend to the Blessed One's teachings. I could then accomplish much' — he is one who develops mindfulness of death." And there is one who develops mindfulness of death thus: "May I live just the length of time it takes to breathe out after breathing in, and to breathe in after breathing out, so that I may attend to the Blessed One's teachings."

Then he says, "These I call bhikkhus who dwell heedfully." We could also say diligently. I think the word being translated here — because I haven't been able to look up the Pāli — is *appamāda*, a very favourite word of the Buddha. It's one of his last: *appamādena sampādetthāti* — strive diligently for your liberation.

That one is similar to the discourse we read last night. But there's another one, which is a slightly different take on mindfulness of death. Again the Buddha tells the bhikkhus, "Mindfulness of death, when developed and cultivated, is of great benefit, of great fruit, culminating in the deathless, having the deathless as its consummation." The deathless is just another word for *nirvāṇa*.

So he says here, "Bhikkhus, when the day has receded and night has approached," the bhikkhu reflects thus: "I could die on account of many causes. A snake might bite me, or a scorpion or centipede might sting me, and I might thereby die. That would be an obstacle to me." In other words, that's not good. "I might stumble and fall, or my food might disagree with me. Or my bile might become agitated. My phlegm might become agitated." Remember, this was in those days of the four humours, the four temperaments: the melancholic, sad people; the choleric, angry ones; the phlegmatic, easygoing ones; and the sanguine, happy ones. There's only one of the lot who are happy. Human miseries.

And then finally: people might attack me, wild spirits might attack me, and then I might die. This would be a disadvantage — remember the preciousness of human life. The whole point about remaining a human being as long as we can is that this is the best place to free ourselves from suffering.

Now, when the bhikkhu has reflected on the possibility of death during the night, he's then supposed to ask himself, "Do I have any bad, unwholesome qualities that have not been abandoned, which might become an obstacle to me if I were to die tonight?" If upon review the bhikkhu knows, "I have bad, unwholesome qualities that have not been abandoned, which might become an obstacle to

me if I were to die tonight," then he should put forth extraordinary desire, effort, zeal, enthusiasm, indefatigability, untiringness, mindfulness, and clear comprehension to abandon those bad, unwholesome qualities.

This actually reminds me of my own upbringing. I think in most Christian circles you would go to bed with an examination of conscience — that's what it was called in my particular form, which was Catholicism. The idea was that you'd look back over the day and see where you got angry, where you got nasty, where you got greedy, and so on. And of course you would ask for forgiveness for that.

You can extend that, of course, to how you related to a sense of anxiety. Did you get caught up in it? Did you start getting panicky? Did you know what to do about that? So it's not just on a moral level, but the whole of our habits, the habitudes that we have — to be aware of them when they come up. Then at the end of the day, we can reflect: well, I should have been quicker there, I could have been a bit kinder there, and so forth. And then make that determination: tomorrow I will be. That's what he says here.

And then, of course, the opposite of that. He actually gives a nice little image here. The Buddha is always trying to match an intellectual understanding with some sort of imagery, some imaginative way, because as he says, some people think that way — in stories, in images, rather than in a straightforward intellectual manner. So he said we should practise like one whose clothes or head had caught fire, who would put forth extraordinary desire, effort, zeal, and so on, to extinguish the flames. That's how somebody should do it, you see.

Now, for somebody who doesn't have... Oh, yeah, excuse me. There's the opposite, of course. But upon review, the bhikkhu knows I do not have any bad unwholesome qualities that have not been abandoned, which might become an obstacle for me if I were to die tonight. Then the Buddha says he should dwell in the same rapture and joy, training night and day in wholesome qualities.

So remember the wholesome qualities. We can also reflect on that. We don't have to be completely free of unwholesome qualities. We can reflect on the wholesome qualities that we expressed during the day and determine that we will continue to develop them. All these mental states can be developed indefinitely, right? You can become as evil as evil and become as beautiful as beautiful. Mentally beautiful, of course, heart beautiful.

And then, as always, these scriptures, they're not only repetitive, but they also, as it were, reinforce. By being repetitive, they reinforce the teaching. So just as we started off by saying, when day has receded and night has approached. So the final paragraph is, when night has receded and day has approached. So again, it's that recollection in the morning. Very good.

So I think we can put death to bed for a little while. But I would love to hear from you if you happen to practice and just see if it did have a beneficial effect on your life, on your sense of awareness.

So I had a question about how to live frugally. Many people now have found themselves without work, either because the firm has dismissed its workers or you've been furloughed. This is a new word for me, furloughed. I don't quite know. It just means that you're still employed by the firm, but you're not being paid. And many of you know Carl, Carl Fuchs, who teaches here. So he works for the Department of Work and Pensions. And the amount of people applying now for the Dole, what we call the Dole, is enormous. So you may find yourself in that position, of course. And the question is how to live frugally.

I think it's good to remember that we weren't always, the society wasn't always as rich as it has been over these past 20, 25 years. Even after the 2008 crash, unemployment stayed pretty high. The bulk of people did get decent wages. I'm sorry about the West now. Or should we say the rich countries in the West. But it's not that long ago. I mean, World War II, rationing was there for 14 years from the beginning of the war to, I've got the date here, 4th of July, 1954. And that was when food rationing came to an end, when restrictions on the sale of the purchase of meat and bacon was lifted. It was 14 years of people having to be careful, were limited in what they could eat.

And as a child, of course, I would have been a child then, born in 47. I'd been about seven years old. You don't know. You're not aware of being poor or not poor. But in those days, you know, you've got a clip around the ear if you left the light on. If you broke a cup, yeah, your dad would be on to you. That costs money. You know what I mean? It's not going to jump at you. And I do remember my aunties, you know, when we used to go and visit, you get a piece of bread and the jam on it was, well, you wouldn't say there was any jam on it. There was a touch of jam expressing itself on the bread. I remember cucumber sandwiches, really thin, thin little pieces of cucumber. So you don't have to die because you're going to be frugal.

Just in my own case, there was a period there in the 80s when I was unemployed and I was on the dole. And I just remember by that time I was practicing. I was into Buddhism, so I wasn't drinking at that time or anything like that. And I remember, you know, I handled it well. Well, I was rather lucky, really, because I went to live in a lodging where they allowed me just to make a donation, basically. I was very fortunate. And I remember eating a lot of awful, you know, liver and kidney and beginning to feel a bit ill about it. It was about that time I decided to go vegetarian. But there wasn't much on the market then for vegetarian food.

Even as a child, I remember waking up in the morning. There was no heat in the house. The old man had to go downstairs and build a fire. And on weekends, I'd be down there with him, screwing up paper and putting coal on top. And you'd get up in the freeze, especially winter. There'd be ice on the window, and you didn't bother. You just got up, you washed your face, you went down, and the kitchen was the only place that was warm. And they had three kids, three of us bundling in there and making a bit of a row. And that was the only warm place, the kitchen. By evening, of course, mum had built the fire and all that, so it was a bit more pleasant.

But central heating for us didn't come until the mid-60s, and for many came in much later. So you can get used to a situation. You can get used to that. I mean, it's the same as coming on retreat. You change all your habits. It's difficult the first two or three days, and that's it.

The horror story for me, of course, would be, well, as you know, no toast, but worse. Worse, no soya milk or oatly to put in my tea. I mean, that brings up almost a panicky sort of feeling.

And I remember too kids coming to school with no socks and things like that, a bit scruffy. Even though you had three changes. You had one for your ordinary messing about clothes. You had your school uniform, if your parents could afford it. And you had your Sunday best. That was it. I remember being a student. I only had, I think, two or three shirts. So, you know, it's like realising that you don't need all this.

So how can we approach a situation where we find we don't have the money we used to have? It really is just drawing up a list of what you actually need, as opposed to what you want—which might not be particularly greedy. You might want another shirt or another piece of clothing. But when you look around, you don't need it. It's just a matter of bringing yourself down to need.

For the monastic life, the Buddha had what we call the four requisites. The idea is that you had to be happy with what you were given. And in those days, you often ended up with the very simplest of things. For instance, we're supposed to be happy with whatever is put into the bowl. I remember once in Thailand, we went out to the villages. When we came back, there was only rice. Very poor, extremely poor—just a bit of rice. And I think they put in a bit of something from the ponds. It wasn't fish, it was something else, which I won't forget, frankly. But luckily, when we got back to the monastery, the middle class from the towns had brought some delicious food. But if I had lived deep in the countryside of Thailand at that time—going back to the late 80s—you'd have had to be happy with just rice. So that was the first requisite.

Shelter is another. The four basic requisites are food, shelter, clothing, and medicine. That's what the body needs. We're not talking about what the heart or the mind needs, but what the body needs. That's all.

When it came to shelter, you were just to be happy under the root of a tree or to build yourself a temporary shelter. Later on, monasteries were built for the Buddha, so they became a bit more flashy. But you're just to be happy with the place you're living in, basically. Now, having said that, we know there are people out there on the streets, and that's an abomination, frankly, for a rich country. An absolute abomination.

Then there's clothing. The clothing is just to protect the body from heat, in India from flies and gadflies and mosquitoes and such. And of course, for modesty's sake. But your basic need is to clothe the body so it doesn't get cold—in this country anyway. It doesn't matter what you're actually wearing, does it? As long as it keeps you warm. It doesn't have to be fashionable.

And finally, medicine. In those days, what the scripture says, what the Buddha says, is that you have to be happy with fermented cow's urine. Now, frankly, I never tried it. I never got around to doing that. And I'm not so sure anybody else has since those times. But obviously, that was considered to be a medicine. Just happy with the medicine that comes.

It might be that you end up with the NHS with a minor or serious complaint, a serious disease. And we know it's being so heavily used—at breaking point constantly. The nurses, the doctors have been completely overworked. So you might find yourself not being treated well, or not being treated for quite some time. And you have to accept that. There's no point in getting angry about it. That doesn't do

anything, does it? Anxiety will be there, of course, if you feel you have something serious. But that's basically what you have to accept. Fermented cow's urine. I'm sure it's good for you.

So thinking about frugality, seeing what the need is. When it comes to the heart-mind, the thing is really to keep the mind active, to keep feeding it. These days, there's so much free material on the websites. It really doesn't have to cost you anything. Free book downloads from—what is it—the Gutenberg Project on Google, things like that. And of course, there are still, I believe, one or two libraries around. And of course, conversation. Good conversation with friends.

The heart also needs to be nourished. There's not just the social virtues of compassion, love and all that, conversation with people, but art—art and nature. We need that sort of feed. It's one of the reasons meditation monasteries are often way out in the forests: to get away from the city jungle and into a beautiful place. One has to accept that as part of frugality. In the old days, you might have done all sorts of things that cost money, but there's plenty of stuff out there that wouldn't cost anything.

And the least costly of all, of course, is spiritual practice. All you need is the space of your own body. Sit down and carry on.

There Is No Reason for Being!

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 54 min

Originally given as *There Is No Reason for Being!* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



Drawing inspiration from a six-year-old child who declared "there's no reason for being" while playing, Bhante Bodhidhamma explores the profound difference between simply 'being' and the process of 'becoming' (bhāva). He examines how children naturally embody the spontaneous, joyful presence found in play—doing something for its own sake without future aims or pressures.

The talk delves into the Buddhist understanding of how we construct a sense of self through identification with body, emotions, and thoughts, creating the suffering of constant 'becoming' driven by future expectations. Through Paṭicca Samuppāda (Dependent Origination), we see how this process differs fundamentally from the awakened state, where actions arise as kriya (functional karma) rather than driven by self-centered intentions.

Using examples from the Buddha's life and teaching style, Bhante illustrates how awakened beings respond spontaneously from wisdom without fixed positions or future goals. The talk emphasizes how vipassanā meditation reveals the distinction between the observer and observed, gradually dissolving the delusion of 'I am' through direct investigation of our psychophysical processes. This leads to the natural contentment and joy that arise when we relate to life without the constant pressure of becoming someone or achieving something.

On one of the Tuesday evenings, someone who came along told us this tale of a six-year-old child who was playing a game and suddenly said to her mother, "There's no reason for being," and then went back to playing.

This child must have heard her parents or friends talk about the meaning of life and all that. It must have worked on her mind. She must have understood what she was saying, because how can you come out with something like that without having some inkling, some feel for what you actually mean?

And the interesting thing is that she was playing. The thing about play, isn't it, is that you do it for yourself. You don't do it for any other reason. You don't play Monopoly to make yourself famous. A game is just a game. I know we put a lot of things on games these days—football has become an industry. But when a child plays a game, or when we ourselves play a game with a child, we're just playing. It doesn't have any objective apart from that. And therefore, all your attention is in just that doing.

The second quality is that it's very joyful, isn't it? It's a happy thing to do, playing a game, playing cards. As adults we might have things like hobbies, which don't have any reason beyond themselves. They're just something you like to do. They don't have any aim or objective beyond just that doing. And usually, a person would say they enjoy their hobby. It wouldn't make sense to have a hobby you didn't enjoy.

If you like cooking, for instance, you do it just for the pleasure of it. Then you might share it with friends. You might lose a few friends, but it's a joyful occasion. It's something you've enjoyed doing.

So this little girl is playing with "There's no reason for being." It depends, of course, what we mean by reason. If we mean that there's something outside the game, something outside what we're doing—we're aiming at some future result, some end point we're moving towards—then that puts a pressure, doesn't it? It puts a pressure on what you're doing now, because what you're doing now is not in itself entire and whole. The action is not completed until some future event arises.

These professional games—these footballers and tennis players—sure, they play the game, but it's not just a game, is it? There's something else. There's an ambition about it. There's the climbing up the ladder of success. There's the money. So the game itself no longer has that immediate sense of perfect joy that a game might have for a child. It's got a pressure on it now, hasn't it?

Now as opposed to this word being, we've got this other word becoming. The word in the Pali for that is *bhāva*, to become. When the Buddha describes this process of becoming, he describes it quite clearly in the Dependent Origination, which is what we'll chant tomorrow—the sequence of mental events.

Somewhere in that process of play, which ends around about the age of seven or so, we lose that immediate innocence of life. Thought comes in—thought launches us out into some future. We've lived long enough to imagine a future.

How futuristic can a child of three be? What does it mean to a child of three to say that in two months' time there'll be Christmas? They don't live that long to understand what two months really is. It's an imaginative thing. But for us, having lived so long, we begin to project, don't we? We know where we're going. We've got an idea of time. It's all blocked out for us.

Somewhere in that process, something goes wrong. Now as opposed to that—as opposed to that going wrong and living for some future event—you have the Buddha or the enlightened ones who don't do that. They're still living in time. They know what two months is. They also have a clear idea of time. But somehow they don't suffer. Somehow they don't get this comeback which is in the process of becoming.

In the law of karma, when Buddhism talks about karma, it talks about two types: *kusala* and *akusala*. This translates as wholesome and unwholesome actions, virtuous and unvirtuous actions, skillful and unskillful actions. That's how you can translate it.

But interestingly, when they try to find a word for an enlightened person doing an action, they use another term: *kriya*, which is translated in a funny way as 'functional'—functional action. There's something distinctive between somebody who is fully liberated and somebody who isn't. It's a sharp line, not a progression. You either are liberated or you're not. You might be a little bit liberated, but you're not fully liberated. There's always that peculiar way of looking at things which causes some form of dissatisfaction.

So what is it that goes wrong within that process—what causes us to become rather than simply to be?

When the Buddha decides to teach, that comes out of just the desire to share the goodness he's discovered. It's a natural thing, isn't it? They say in Zen, for instance, that out of wisdom, compassion arises naturally, love arises naturally.

And there are some Zen teachers who won't touch practices like loving-kindness. It's off the path, they say. You want to get to the enlightenment, to the awakening, and then everything else just happens naturally.

When the Buddha was awakened and this natural desire came to teach, he thought, well, who could he teach? Having understood that his two teachers—the first people he thought he might help—were dead, he then walks to find his other five companions. These were the ones who had told him he'd gone soft, who didn't want to know him anymore because he'd had that rice pudding, if you remember.

He walks from where he becomes enlightened in Bodh Gaya all the way to Sarnath. Now I've got this figure of 400 miles, but I don't think that's quite right—it's a heck of a long way anyway. It's five hours on the train; I remember that. So it's quite a journey. He's off, and he has to ask directions. It's not as though people had mobiles in those days to find out where others are.

Then he begins to teach, and throughout his career as a teacher, when somebody comes to him who doesn't accept what he's saying—like there's an occasion when this fellow called Dandapani, which means 'stick in hand' (must have been a nickname), comes and asks what he teaches. The Buddha tells him, and Dandapani goes away clicking his tongue, shaking his head—a lot of rubbish.

In fact, there's a lovely incident when he first sets off to find his five companions. He comes across an ascetic who sees a certain glow around him, a certain brightness, and says, 'My, you're bright. Who's your teacher?' The Buddha launches into this sort of self-panegyric: 'I am the fully enlightened one,' lots of stuff. And the fellow sort of says, 'Oh, right, OK,' and wanders off. I think that was an early lesson that that's not what you do if you're going to teach.

When people don't accept his teaching, he says he's not saddened by it, not upset by it. And yet when people do accept his teachings, he's joyful.

When he describes the Buddha heart, when he describes how he experiences Nibbāna as this present experience, he talks about it being contented—and with it, happy. Contented, and with it, happy.

Those four limitables—love, compassion, joy, equanimity—but especially the first three, which are about relationship: love, compassion, and joy. These contain, as it were, in their various shades, the way the Buddha heart actually responds to the world. And if he's on his own, if an enlightened person is quiet, they just fall into this state of equanimity.

So you get the sense that somebody who's awakened is living very much in the present moment, doesn't have any particular aim. He's just responding from that wisdom point to a given situation now, without any care for future results.

Even when he goes to begin his teaching and men and women approach him to join him, he doesn't seem to have any particular idea of where the order is going. He's just following the general customs of ascetics in those days. It's only as things go wrong, as certain monks and nuns make mistakes or do something wrong, that he produces a rule.

By the end of his life, he's produced all these rules, and they rest on a particular platform of understanding. That's what you would call an institution, isn't it? An institution has a given reason, some sort of platform, and then you build up rules around it to give it legal solidity. Marriage is an institution, isn't it—even just between two people. There's a basic understanding, and then there are rules, spoken or unspoken, which maintain that particular relationship.

And he ends up with that. Not that he had any specific idea as to where it was going, but by the end of his life he can look back and think, well, yeah, what's been produced is good. He talks about the four sanghas or the four assemblies: monks and nuns, laywomen and laymen. But that sort of happened naturally. He didn't seem to have gone out particularly to establish that. It just happened as he walked around and people joined him.

So you get the sense of spontaneity rather than knee-jerk reactions or some preconditioned idea as to where he's going. That's another quality of play, isn't it—it's spontaneous. A child is very spontaneous.

All that perhaps we can talk about: a sense of just being in the moment, moving from one moment to the next, responding to it with wisdom. Without any sense of future success—success and failure, all that's out the window. Without any sense of gain, riches or anything like that. Without any sense of power, wanting to control.

He didn't particularly want to control monks and nuns. He just wanted to set up a situation where eventually all they could do was meditate and study the Dharma—those are the two duties he put to the monks. And he set up certain institutions for lay people: taking refuges, the five precepts, and general guidelines.

So there's no sense of him wanting to be rich, to be powerful, to be successful in any sense. He's not driven by some future aim. And he's not worried about being famous. There's no hint in the scriptures that he gets upset if people don't recognise him.

In fact, there's a point where a monk or somebody enters into a small congregation of monks and they ask, "Well, which one is the Bhagavad?" He hasn't got a special hat on, or three stripes on his shoulders. He's just an ordinary person. He just looks like—he doesn't try to lift himself above others.

The question of what am I supposed to be doing, or where am I supposed to be going, or why am I here? Who am I? All those questions have disappeared. There is just this moment, this relationship, and this response coming from the point of wisdom.

In that moment there's complete openness to it, because there's nothing negative within the person—nothing that has to be hidden or repressed, no little dislike or guilt or whatever, the usual gamut of human misery. Because there's nothing there, there's that ability just to be completely open to the situation. And whatever the situation presents, there's just this coming out from the heart of wisdom.

When it comes to certain incidents—like the woman who comes crazed with grief because she's lost her child, her dead child—she's got this idea that these ascetics have some magic, some mystical powers. And in her grief-stricken situation, the Buddha is able to realise that to give her the straight teaching is just going to send her off berserk. So he gives her a little trick, you know, to come to realise the way life is.

He sends her off to find a mustard seed. Mustard seeds are a million a penny. But he says, you must get it from a house where there's not been any death. So off she goes, desperate, knocking on doors. "You got a mustard seed?" "Well, of course." "Anybody died?" "Of course."

And by the end of a certain sequence of hours, there comes this dawning—you see—that death is part of life. It just happens. That's the way it is. So she comes back more balanced of mind, and then she's open to the teachings. And as all these stories go, she enters the order and becomes fully awakened.

So he's able to respond easily to people because he's not coming from a fixed place—no fixed point, no presumption, no view, no opinion.

This idea of being totally receptive means you've got to have the ability to receive different perspectives and bring them into your general way of seeing things. A perspective suggests you're not holding on to it. You recognise that there are other perspectives, that you're prepared to have your own widened or broadened or somehow changed because you hear other people's views.

But the word opinion gives us the idea that this is right, everybody else is wrong. It immediately closes you off, shuts you off. It makes relationship difficult. You're immediately in contradiction with somebody who has a different opinion.

So when somebody comes to the Buddha and asks him to give a teaching, he never launches straight into his teaching. He always says, "Well, what do you think?" The person says what they think, and then he undermines their position. Bit of a trick, really, I suppose. And when they're completely floored, completely lost, he says, "Well, now this is the truth." And off he goes.

But he doesn't seem to have been the sort of person who said, "Look, if you come to me, this is what it is. If you don't accept it, go away." He's prepared to try and understand where that person's coming from, and in so doing, to show that maybe they haven't got it quite right. Then there's an openness to the Dhamma—that's what the texts say. There's a subtleness, a malleability in that person's mind, and that's when he offers the teaching.

So we can see that all these qualities are about being very present—like a child is with play. There's nothing being deposited onto this present moment, either by way of some past opinion, some view we've held onto and must see this present moment through, or by launching this present moment into some future successful result. It remains just entire and whole in itself. And you're moving through time in these little blocks.

But you're not coming from nowhere. That's the point. The Buddha's not coming from a blank sheet. He's coming from a specific way of relating to the world, which brings with it a specific understanding.

Now, as opposed to that, you've got this becoming—which is generally speaking what we do. This becoming. What's the core of it? How do these opinions and views and futures and fame and riches and power—from where do they spring? Around what do they coagulate? What are they an expression of?

This is what the Buddha refers to as the self. And the self isn't a thing. It's not that you can point to it or pick it up or say what it is. It's a relationship.

So it's a mistake that we make, which is completely understandable. It's not as though it's a culpable mistake. We're not supposed to go beating ourselves around the head because we made it. We come from a point of not knowing.

There's a film called *Zenoid*, and there's a nice little passage where the master is asked, "What happens when you die?" And he says, "Don't know." "Why don't you know?" "I'm not dead yet." It's recognising that what we've done is made a presumption, fallen into some sort of what the Buddha called a delusion. And a delusion, by definition, is something you don't know you're deluded about—or else you wouldn't be deluded.

So there we are, this little bundle of flesh and bones. What do we know? And then society comes at us with definitions, gives us a name. Parents tell us this and tell us that. We pick up the history, we get a language. Everything's dumped on us.

So is it any wonder that we should end up thinking, well, this is what I am. And this is what I am. I am. I am English. I am a teacher. I am. I am. This "am" business. This "I" with its definition, with its being, you might say, with its sense of self in all those definitions that we have about who we are and what we are.

So once we've cornered ourselves, once we've gathered all these definitions about ourselves, you can see how it becomes an imprisonment. And you get these wonderful statements like, the one I love is, "If I did that, that wouldn't be me. If I thought that, that wouldn't be me." And it's a sort of—you can feel the clampness of that. It's like something that's so tight about who I am.

Now this "who I am" produces a doing. You walk into life with "who I am" and you start doing something. Very simply, if you say I am a teacher, then you have to teach. But this teaching now isn't like the Buddha's teaching where he's just in relationship. It falls back on a definition. It falls back on who I am.

So if I lose my job, who am I? Then I get the depression. Losing your job is bad enough to lose the income. That's bad enough. But then to lose a definition of yourself, well, that's an identity crisis. You might go around saying, well, I was a teacher, which is a bit of a downer.

Now, of course, it goes deeper than that because at the deepest level we think we're humans. I am a human being. That's a pretty general statement most people on earth would agree with. I am a human being. But when you say, I am a human being, what do you mean? Are you the body?

If you say, well, I am the body, I am this body, how long are you this body for? When you talk about this body, I think every—I don't know, I read it somewhere—but every atom is exchanged in your body something like every few days or something. It's quite remarkable how quickly the body is changing. The cornea on your eye changes every week. I know that for sure because the optician told me, and I believe the optician.

If you go into the biology of certain parts of your body, you'll be quite amazed how they're not actually in unison. Bits are falling off without you knowing. Bits take time to fall off. A bone, I think, takes about three months to renew itself. So even now, you walked into that door with this body, but it isn't this body anymore. It's moved on. It's changed.

This idea of a self has something static about it, something solid. This is what I am. But when we investigate the body, we find this am-ness can't be static. And if it's moving, if it's changing, then which am I? Am I the body that I was born with, or this body, or the future body? The sense of I begins to corrupt, it begins to fall apart.

But if I say I am the body, you can imagine. We know, don't we? We know the suffering of I am the body. It comes out when you fall sick, when somebody close to you dies. Then you know, oh, if that body went that way, probably mine will follow in the same way. And we all dread the moment when the doctor will tell you you've got six weeks to go. That's not a laughing matter, is it?

This sense of self, this identity with the body, manifests when the body moves into danger. And that fear that we have, that real fear of death, of dying, of severe illness, of being crippled, of losing our minds, Alzheimer's—all that fear is the measure of that delusion.

When the Buddha died, he was in pain. He had gastroenteritis or some such. He would have been in pain. But by how it's come down to us, he's just lying on his side. And there's even still that desire to make sure that he's said everything. He asks, are there any more questions? And when there are no more questions, he says, "Well, all compounded things arise and pass away. Work diligently for your liberation." And off he goes.

What will be our last words? "Why me?" What will be our last thoughts? Will they be as equanimous as that? As easy? Will we let go as easily as that?

The reason we can't let go as easily as that is because this is what I think I am. Dying means losing a bit of me.

Think about your emotional life. That's changed, hasn't it? It's constantly changing, probably faster than the body. All these intentions we make, the way we create this inner life within ourselves—all the depressions and anxieties, the happinesses, the loves, the joys of life. They come and go, don't they?

And even more fleeting is thought. So which thought are you? Would you want to go back to being a three-year-old, to the three-year-old's thoughts?

When we begin to investigate this self, this 'I am'—I think therefore I am, I feel therefore I am, I walk around therefore I am, I brush my teeth therefore I am—when you investigate that as something solid, entire, whole unto itself, it begins to crumble. It begins to crumble.

And what this makes us do is hold on to the present moment tightly, or make sure this present moment has some sort of sense to this ongoing feeling of self—and so it creates a future. You've got to be going somewhere. What's the point of just being here if you're not going somewhere? What's the point of meditating if you're not going to get some results? That's a hard one, isn't it? You've all come here for some result. Very disappointing.

This self, this becoming, this process of being me all the time, is driven by the desire to be happy. That's what we want, isn't it? To be happy, for heaven's sake. I don't want to be rich—I just want to be happy.

Being driven by this want to be happy, I've got to manipulate, I've got to struggle against the way things are to make me happy. Because my happiness is defined by what's made me happy in the past. If crumpets and cocoa made me happy on Thursday, then next Thursday I've got to have crumpets and cocoa. Otherwise I won't be happy. Simple as that.

So I begin to try and manipulate the future. Now when we say the future, that's not some abstract idea. That means people. I've got to manipulate you to make me happy. If you get in my way, I've got to manipulate you, play around with you. If an object gets in my way, I kick it out. I burn it. I get rid of it.

We have these ideologies, don't we? When a group of people take on a similar idea, you get these vast ideologies—Christianity, communism, capitalism. And you can see what it does. It destroys people, because they all have to fit into this future idea, this thing that's created only in somebody's head. And if you don't fit in, you get shot.

This self has a way of collecting other selves to support its idea. And then you have a movement. Oh my goodness. That's what happens to religions, isn't it? From the first inspiration, it becomes locked into a series of beliefs and attitudes, and then it becomes a movement. It loses that original spontaneity.

Every so often a teacher comes along and reforms it, and you get that burst of energy again. But often it will just solidify into rites and rituals, customs, rules and regulations. Jesus, with the Jewish tradition: 'Man was not made for the Sabbath, Sabbath was made for man.' That's what he's saying—these rules and regulations are not there to bind us.

Now, that's the crucial importance of Vipassana meditation—or in other forms of Buddhism, Zazen, or Dzogchen. It's all about getting down to that root level of the problem.

Every evening I quote this teaching: those who are mindful are in the presence of Nibbāna, in the vicinity of Nibbāna. So what do we mean by that?

When you sit still—when you've steadied the body and stilled it, found this observation post within yourself, become an observer, a feeler, an experiencer—and you're looking into the so-called self, this psychophysical complex organism, you see, that's a very different position from 'I am the body,' isn't it?

Because now you're saying, 'There's the body.' When somebody has a headache, they say, 'I have a headache, I am ill.' But here, suddenly, from this position, you're looking at the knee, feeling the knee, and saying, 'There's pain.' A gap has appeared between this knowing and what it knows. And that gap is a loss of self. It's a loss of relationship. It's no longer my knee, my pain. It's simply: there's pain.

When an emotion comes up—depression, joy, excitement, dullness and lethargy—normally you'd say, 'I am tired,' and that's good enough reason to go to bed. 'I am depressed'—good enough reason to go to bed. Lots of amazing good reasons to go to bed! But here you can't. If you go to bed, I'll be very upset.

Instead, you have to say, 'Oh, there's dullness. There's dullness in the head. It feels like porridge. And there's tiredness in the body.' This 'there is' has made whatever knows—that which knows—separate itself from what is known. It's formed a new relationship with it. It's not me. It's not mine. There is this.

It's just like a property you've sold, or a car you used to have. You have a very different relationship to it, don't you? It's not yours anymore. It's somebody else's. The fact that all the pipes burst—well, you're very compassionate, but it's not your problem anymore, is it? But if it's your house, your car, it's very upsetting when things go wrong.

So can you see that if we develop a relationship with the body where this is the body—not me, not mine—when things go wrong, why should fear arise? It's not me, it's not mine. Why should I get depressed? It's not me, it's not mine.

Emotions, we find out, are just these volitional conditionings—that's a sort of translation of the word *sankhara*. They're just conditionings. Mental conditionings. What is an emotion? What is it before you give it a name?

So here you are, meditating, and this feeling comes up. You can see it's not a physical feeling like pain or pleasure. It's a mental feeling, more of a subtle sort of energy. And as you look into it, you say, 'Oh, that feels like depression,' or 'That feels like anxiety,' or 'That feels like joy, like excitement.'

But to do that, you must have separated yourself. To investigate something, you've got to be outside it. If you want to look at cells, you've got to find an instrument and look at them. If you want to look up at the sky, you've got to get an instrument and look at it. You can't be the star. You can't get lost in some sort of romantic emotion if you want to study the star.

So here, in order to find out what an emotion is, we've had to separate from it. And that separation, that distinction, is a loss of self—because you're not saying, 'I am depressed.' You're saying, 'There is depression.' You're not saying, 'I am excited.' There's excitement.

We can take this as far as thoughts and images. When you get into a really good quiet state, you can see a thought coming. You see an image beginning to grow. Sometimes a thought passes through your mind like a neon light. And when you have those sorts of experiences, you know: I didn't think that. It just arose and passed away.

So very slowly, through the practice of *vipassana*, we're distinguishing, finding out that this is not what I am—this is not me, not mine. And that process, of course, leads us backwards. This is the unfortunate thing: you don't know where you're going. It leads us backwards to the knowledge of who I am.

That's the koan. That's the big question, as I understand it anyway, of Korean Zen. Just that: Who am I? And it's the moment after you've asked the question which is the potential moment. After that, the mind rushes in to tell you who you are and what you are. But just to hang on in there—who am I? That moment of not knowing has all the potential of breaking that essential delusion that hangs around the word 'I'.

From the Buddha's teaching, this becoming—this constant becoming me, this arising out of one moment into the next—is the fundamental problem creating this wrong relationship with the world. It puts us into conflict with it. Whether it's a subtle conflict or a major conflict, it doesn't matter. It's always a conflict, because we're always trying to manipulate things to fit in with this sense of me.

Now when that goes, there's a whole new relationship. There's no future. There's no past. You're not coming from a fixed position. You're not going to a fixed position. Our ability will be to be completely receptive, without any sieve, without any separation of what we don't want, what we don't like. And in that, there's a very open communication.

In that open, immediate communication—whether it be with a person or with an animal or just with nature, with a tree, just an openness to a tree, to a leaf—there's that sense of just being here in a very total way, for no other reason than just to be here. And with it there arises a natural joy. This is what the Buddha says: just a natural joy.

That contentment is being with the moment, not wanting anything more than what the moment is giving us. And the happiness comes out of the response to that moment. Contentment and happiness.

So that's where we're going. And we should be happier. That's what we mean by hope as opposed to expectation. Hope is the knowledge—that inner knowledge, that inner feeling, that intuitive understanding—that there's an end to suffering. There's an end to that wrong sort of relationship.

Becoming has to have this objective. Becoming has to have this expectancy, which is slightly different. Making a distinction between hope and expectation: hope is a fundamental position to life—that life is good, it has meaning. There is a reason for suffering, and the reason for suffering is this wrong relationship. Once the wrong relationship is corrected, happiness arises, perfect peace arises.

Expectation would want to put a date on it. Expectation would want to achieve it. But what we realise in the meditation is that it's not achievable by you. That's another thing you recognise, isn't it? That it happens.

Once you find yourself in that position, the heart begins to purify itself. You don't have to do anything. It's like the body heals itself.

You can't have a spiritual insight on demand. You can't say, 'Well, I'm going to sit down now and I'm going to have a spiritual insight.' You can't do it. You can have an intellectual insight—you can think about something. You can have an aesthetic insight—you can set yourself a task to understand something aesthetically. But you can't make yourself have a spiritual insight.

In fact, you might argue that when it comes to certain problems, even insights of that nature are beyond the self. Scientists will talk about how the answer just came. They'll go to sleep, sleep on an answer, and then wake up with it. Who thought that one out?

So how do we train ourselves in daily life to cultivate this sense of being rather than becoming? The trick is to get your intentions right.

When you're eating, you're just eating to nourish the body. You're not asking the food to make you happy. It's as simple as that. If you're asking it to make you happy, you've formed a different relationship with food. But if food is there simply as medicine for the body, what's the problem? The fact that it tastes nice is a plus—a little gift.

When you want to help somebody, make sure your intention is right. You're doing it for that person, out of the goodness of heart, with no subliminal reasons—not because you want your kitchen decorated too and expect them to come along and do it, things like that.

Whatever job you do, get the intention right: you're doing it as a service. Of course there's pay, and hopefully enjoyment too. But those are to be seen as merit. We have this idea in Buddhism of merit—you receive something added on because of your good heart. So the merit of doing your job is that you get a wage and a certain joy out of it. But that's not why you're doing it. The reason we should be doing work is out of service, for the benefit of the other.

This doesn't get rid of ambition. You don't have to stop being ambitious because you've decided to live the spiritual life. But your attitude becomes: 'These are the talents I've got, and I can see that I could do that job, so I'll offer these talents as a service.'

If somebody else gets the job, there's not that disappointment—because it was an offering. It's like giving a present. If you give a present and the person says, 'It's all right, no, I don't want it,' you shouldn't feel bad about it, should you? You only feel bad because there's some ego, some self involved in the giving. It's as if they haven't accepted you. You've been rejected, so you feel dejected.

In our meditation, we're trying to make this distinction between what is me and what is not me. The technique is mainly to see: not me, not mine, not me, not mine. And then when we go out into daily life, we stay aware of any selfish, any self-centred intention.

Now, you've got to be careful here. There's a difference between selfishness and self-regard, self-care. Sometimes you've got to look after yourself. But in terms of what you're doing, you're doing it with the right attitude, for the benefit of the other.

So there are three positions: you do things for your own benefit, you do things for the benefit of the other, or you do things for both your own benefit and the benefit of the other. That's how the Buddha states it.

And then you see the result—not the result out there, because you never know what happens when you do something out there. You see the result inside. Has it caused attachment? Has it caused disappointment? If anything negative comes up from an action, you know something's crept in.

So let's presume that little girl who said there's no reason for being is already there. She might be fully and completely liberated. You never know.

I can only hope my words have been of some assistance. May you be liberated sooner rather than later.

Identity and Not-Self

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 21 min

Originally given as *Identity and Not-Self* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this exploration of one of Buddhism's most challenging teachings, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines anattā (not-self) through the lens of everyday experience. Drawing from the Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta (MN 10), he explains how our identification with roles—whether as cook, teacher, or meditator—becomes a source of dukkha (suffering and unsatisfactoriness) when things don't go as planned.

Using vivid personal anecdotes about failed attempts with gas cylinders and printer cartridges, Bhante illustrates how emotional storms can become "rocket fuel for awakening" when met with mindful awareness. He demonstrates the practical application of internal and external mindfulness practice from the Mahāsi tradition, showing how we can observe the process of "selfing" (upādāna) as temporary identities arise and dissolve based on conditions.

The talk offers valuable insights into working with identification patterns in daily life, explaining how unpleasant sensations can serve as messengers reminding us "this is not who you really are." This teaching provides both theoretical understanding and practical tools for recognizing the conditional, impermanent nature of all constructed identities, pointing toward the peace that comes from seeing through these limited self-concepts.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā-sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā-sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā-sambuddhassa.

Homage to the Blessed, Noble and Fully Self-Enlightened One.

The Buddha's teaching on *anattā*, not-self, is one of the hardest aspects of the Dhamma to understand. We'll all be grappling with it till the moment of enlightenment. To motivate ourselves for the challenge, it's worth reflecting on the suffering we experience because of identifying with our body, our mind, our life stories.

Take the example of role identification. Whatever role we're playing in life—father, daughter, gardener—we want to do it well, which is a good motive, no problem there. It's when we over-identify, when we can't see beyond our role, that *dukkha*, suffering, emerges.

On a good day, we get a buzz out of doing things well: cooking a meal, mending a puncture, teaching a class. But we all have days when these go wrong. The sponge cake turns out as a stodgy lump. The tyre deflates the minute we put the wheel back on. We go blank in the middle of teaching. This is when the *dukkha* of identification is felt.

The more we identify as a good cook, a good DIYer, a good teacher, the harder it is to bear the letdown. We can't stop thinking about it. What went wrong? How could I have made such a mess of things? What did they think of me? We look for someone to blame. If he hadn't interrupted, it would have been perfect.

While none of us enjoy those times when we've made a hash of something, it's worth dwelling on them long enough to acknowledge that the source of the misery isn't actually the gooey mess or the deflating tyre. It's the sense of me and how badly I've let myself down. That's the real nub—a loss of confidence, perhaps an almost desperate need to reassert ourselves, to prove our ability.

The more clearly we acknowledge the suffering that comes from identification, the more willing we'll be to explore this difficult Buddhist teaching of *anattā*, not-self. And there's no doubt *anattā* is a difficult nut to crack. We all have a strong sense that we are the ones baking the cake, mending the tyre, teaching the class, living our life. It's hard to even toy with the idea that this might not be so.

The Buddha's advice is to keep breaking down experience into smaller and smaller chunks. It's easier to get glimpses of the truth in these. Then gradually, over time, the notion of not-self becomes easier to contemplate. We start to see its benefits—how much easier life is when we're not identified with our roles or opinions or abilities or achievements. It's wonderful to have nothing to defend.

One instruction from the *Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta*, the Four Foundations of Mindfulness, that I found very helpful for exploring anattā is the advice to practise internally and externally. Internal can be interpreted as our subjective felt experience, while external means our mental understanding of it. We feel the sensations of breathing for internal practice. For external practice, we reflect that we are breathing.

The Mahāsi noting technique provides a way of practising both internally and externally. We feel the breath and at the same time make a mental note of it. Same for walking, eating, talking. All of life can be known both internally, as moment-to-moment sensations and feelings, and externally, as our objective mental perception of what's happening.

As concentration deepens, it can seem like our identity shifts. Instead of being the one who is sitting here breathing, we sense ourselves as the observer—some sort of spaced-out entity hovering around our head, the one who is watching the body breathe. On a good day, we'll also be able to watch our thoughts coming and going, watch emotions rise and fade, and realise we don't have to get caught up in them.

All of this is helping us disentangle our confusion about identity. Internally, we feel ourselves breathing, thinking, growing happy one moment, sad the next. But because of our external perspective, we realise we don't need to identify with our thoughts, emotions, breathing. We see these as happening of their own accord, driven by various stimuli, but not driven by what I now think of as me.

This can be a lovely experience, a sense of coming home, having found our true self—a sort of disembodied entity that hovers in and around the body, equanimous, interested, watching the show without getting caught up in it. But after a while, we might grow uncomfortable. Things start to feel sticky, as if there's a sheet of velcro passing over each sensation, pulling us along with it. We start getting caught up with experience again, identified with thoughts and feelings and emotions. We are again the one who is sitting here breathing and now anxiously trying to find our way back to the lofty crow's nest from which we've been able to observe the show.

Although there's a temptation to see this as bad meditation, we should really see it as a precious opportunity to learn the Dhamma more deeply. Pema Chödrön likens these episodes to rocket fuel for enlightenment.

To take a practical example: we got a new connector for our gas canister the other day, and so I overcame all my fears about gas and explosions and went to hook it up. After about a dozen failed attempts, all the bits eventually came together. It looked perfect. But gas started leaking the moment I opened the cylinder. I took it apart, reread the instructions, reconnected it. Still no go. Disappointing.

I was then asked to look at the printer because it wasn't working. It needed a new toner cartridge. Again, I overcame my deep suspicion of all things electrical and mechanical and managed to replace the cartridge. But no go. Every page came out white as snow with nothing at all being printed. Again, I took it all apart, reread the instructions, watched a few videos on replacing the cartridge, tried again. Still no go. Another disappointment.

This time I felt the edge of bad humour. My mind was starting to close up, feel oppressed by others and by the world in general. A bit later, Bhante came over, took the cartridge out and, in his own words, gave it a few thumps and put it back in place. Lo and behold, it worked perfectly. Of course, I was impressed and amused and grateful, but alongside these happy responses, my incipient bad humour gave a painful kick within. Why couldn't it have worked for me?

I decided to go to my room to explore this more deeply. Rationally, it was just silliness, the mind building a mountain out of a molehill. And yet there was—not quite a mountain, but certainly more than a molehill of frustration at my failure to connect up a gas cylinder and change a toner cartridge. But what was more distressing was the admission of being so emotionally impacted by such trivial matters. What was the point of decades of Dhamma practice only to be getting distraught over nothing?

This is the *dukkha*, the suffering, of identification: identifying with self as manager, the one who is supposed to sort out problems; identification with self as meditator, who should by now have developed outstanding equanimity; not to speak of self as meditation teacher who should know the Dhamma upside down and be able to instantly see through this latest delusion.

As always, mindfulness allowed the storm to blow itself out. Looking back now, I sense the truth of Pema Chödrön's advice to see these times when our buttons are pressed and we feel like a two-year-old again as rocket fuel for enlightenment. Emotional storms have so much energy that negative thoughts and feelings we normally suppress come skyrocketing into consciousness. In the light of awareness, their pain becomes so acute that our system is forced to learn a new way of coping with the *dukkha*.

In my own example, a new doorway opened because of feeling so acutely the pain of identification, how it traps the mind in a prison of delusion. The pain of this prison sharpened when the storyline of "me who should be better at everything" had fallen away, and I could more clearly feel the emotional patterns underlying the thoughts.

Practising mindfulness internally, I could feel how eagerly the body and mind pounced on a pleasant feeling, sending tentacles of energy around it to clutch and hold as mine, while a bright light switched on in my head, which I perceived as me—confident, on top of things, in control. A whirlpool of energy rose around my chest and head to sustain this delight. The feeling of confidence was gorgeous, but watching it, the external perspective showed up the craziness and pain underneath.

Seeing this, I desperately wanted to escape the prison of identification. The external perspective let me recognise the crazy whirlpool of energy and the bright light as what the Buddha terms *upādāna*, usually translated as grasping or clinging. It's also sometimes referred to as selfing. What is happening is that unskilful desire, *taṇhā*, has driven us to create a new identity so as to fulfil this desire.

The better we get to know this experience of selfing, the more we're persuaded of the Buddhist teaching on *anattā*, not-self. When we know from direct experience that a 'me' has suddenly arisen, it becomes hard to take that 'me' too seriously. We start to see how various 'mes' arise and fade depending on external stimuli. When things go well, a happy, pleased, self-confident 'me' emerges. But that fades quickly when things go wrong, and the deflated, miserable 'me' takes its place.

Back to my own example of watching the fallout from my emotional storm. Internally, I was experiencing the selfing process, which was generating a confident, delighted sense of 'me'—one who could fix all the printers and gas cylinders in the world. However, the external perspective knew this as delusion. Undermined by that news, the confident self suddenly collapsed into a timid, scared, stiff entity that felt it had no right to exist. A moment later, the confident self reappeared, wildly insisting it was totally in control of the situation.

This yo-yo between elated confidence and abject fear continued for some time. Both identities felt excruciatingly painful and vulnerable. There was a strong desire to abandon the meditation, but I persisted, allowing my emotional roller coaster to take its course, trusting that a lesson would eventually be learned.

In vipassanā, we can't interfere; we can't tell ourselves to stop being deluded. We have to bear patiently with our greeds, hatreds, and delusions, trusting them to burn out in the light of awareness, to teach us the Dhamma as we suffer their flames.

And sure enough, the energy of the roller coaster gradually diminished. As it did, my attention extended gingerly beyond the whirlpool of elated and fearful energies in my chest and head to sense my arms, legs, my body sitting. I couldn't really feel these in any detail—I only knew them as faint suggestions. They seemed like strangers from another world: alien, scary.

Luckily, curiosity was stronger than fear, and each out-breath let awareness rest more attentively in the seemingly alien body. At last, some feelings rippled through. They were unpleasant and carried the message that the heady whirlpool of confidence was not me, not mine. The emotionally energetic, deluded part of myself felt this as a threat. But some wisdom emerged from the depths to welcome the unpleasantness. Here was something I wouldn't want to cling to—therefore very welcome.

Letting attention rest on the unpleasantness became a non-interfering way of containing and restraining the deluded self. Gradually, the energetic, bright-light 'me' felt glad of being contained and limited—embodied rather than a totally deluded mental entity. It became like looking in a mirror.

The desire to know who I really am has always been very strong for me. And the part of me that was observing, watching, felt this now as an almost overwhelming attraction towards the mirror image. I wanted to grasp hold of it, devour it even. But whenever I gave in to that desire, it was as if I'd gobbled up my own reflection. All that was left were little shivers of fear and grief as I realised how I destroyed what I desired.

I had to suffer the fear and grief, wait patiently till peace prevailed, before I could again glimpse the mirror image. I became grateful for any unpleasant sensations in that image. These acted like repulsive forces, countering the attempt to grasp and own it. They carried the message: this isn't who you really are. That understanding also helped me not to grasp and thereby destroy the image of 'me' that I desired so deeply.

I became grateful for the fact that the body can repel the mind as well as attract it. By this stage, I'd forgotten altogether about my sense of having let myself down. It just wasn't an issue. And I was very glad I'd persisted with the meditation, hadn't given up at the height of the emotional storm.

The great gift of sitting with the misery was that the message 'this is not who you really are' became, for the first time, totally welcome. As the meditation went on, the message brought joy, relief, gratitude. I understood it as necessary to counter the strong desire to identify with my body and mind—the only reflection I can find for whatever it is I sense myself to be.

In subsequent meditations and in daily life, I was better able to recognise all 'mes' as temporary and conditional. I could smile at them, appreciate them, but not be surprised when they dissolved. This is such a gift. The deluded 'me' expects too much of me, expects me always to be on top of everything. Being able to see myself as limited brings forth compassion, as well as appreciation for whatever efforts I make to follow the path and fulfil my various roles.

And if I'm getting a bit heated in conversation, clinging to my opinion, I can focus on some unpleasant sensation and welcome it as a messenger: this strongly opinionated one is not your true self either. Again, this brings a smile. It allows me to be more flexible, ready to change my mind and see the other's point of view.

I hope this illustration of working with the dukkha of identification encourages you to explore the teaching around anattā, not-self—and perhaps to see how those external and internal mindfulness perspectives can help with this challenging teaching. In this way, may we all see through our identification as daughter, manager, cook, or whatever. May we see these as temporary, conditional, never designed to be satisfactory.

As the Buddha said, whatever is inconstant, conditioned, unsatisfactory, is not worthy of being thought of as me. We sell ourselves short by investing in these limited identities. Our continued practice leads us to a truth, a resting place beyond all such limitations. May we all experience the peace and bliss of Nibbāna.

Khandha, the Aggregates, as Person and Sati, Awareness

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 48 min

Originally given as *Khandha, the Aggregates, as Person and Sati, Awareness* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this teaching, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the fundamental architecture of the Buddha's teaching, beginning with dukkha as the ground of existence—encompassing not just obvious suffering but also the transient nature of pleasures and the existential challenges of aging, sickness, and death. He then offers a detailed exploration of the five khandhas (aggregates) as the Buddha's systematic deconstruction of what we conventionally consider our "person."

Using the myth of Narcissus as a metaphor, Bhante explains how awareness becomes entranced by its own reflection in the "pond" of psychophysical experience. Through Vipassanā meditation, we learn to step back onto the "bank" and observe from the position of the knower. He guides us through each aggregate: rūpa (body) and our minimal actual knowledge of its biological processes; vedanā (feeling) and the deconstruction of emotions into component sensations; saññā (perception/concepts) and their limiting nature; saṅkhāra (volitional formations/habits) as our personal karmic creations; and viññāṇa (consciousness) as the screen upon which all experience manifests.

This teaching clarifies that our true karma lies not in external circumstances but in our volitional habits and the fundamental delusion of selfhood. Through understanding impermanence, unsatisfactoriness, and not-self at this deep level, we can begin the process of liberation from wrong concepts and unwholesome mental habits.

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammāsambuddhassa Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammāsambuddhassa Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammāsambuddhassa

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

This evening I thought we'd look at the ground upon which the Buddha builds the whole architecture of his teaching: the word *dukkha*. From there we'll examine the five *khandhas*, which is really a deconstruction of our person, our personhood. And then we'll see what we mean by *kamma* from that point of view.

The word *dukkha* has a root meaning from two words: *du* and *kha*. *Du* simply means hard, and *kha* means to bear — hard to bear. It's variously translated as suffering, unsatisfactoriness, and so on. But *dukkha* doesn't simply include the obvious forms of suffering like physical pain — that's pretty straightforward. It also includes pleasure. Pleasures are pleasant while we're enjoying them, but the problem is they're transient and therefore never actually produce what we want. What we're trying to head for is a continuous and perfect happiness — that's the definition of *nibbāna*. But it's not quite an emotional happiness; we'll come to that, hopefully, in the fullness of time.

This word *dukkha* includes all our physical problems, all our mental sufferings, our emotional difficulties. But it also includes all the delightful side of life — because it disappears. And at base, it includes this existential angst, all this business around sickness, ageing, and death. In a sense, *dukkha* is a view of life as basically unsatisfactory.

And that in itself isn't a problem. That's the thing. The actual sufferings of life and the joys of life, sickness, ageing and death — these are in themselves not the problem. The problem is how we relate to them. This is the problem of attachment, indulgence, wrong view. And it roots itself in this whole idea of a self.

Let's stop for a minute with this business of a self — what do we actually mean there? What the Buddha is proposing is that there's something in us which doesn't belong to this psychophysical organism — and we'll deconstruct that as he does it in a minute. He says there's something in us which is not that, and the discovery eventually, of course, is that it's none other than this very awareness.

The image I use — or shall we say the myth I use — to give us an idea of what's happening is the myth of Narcissus. Remember, Narcissus looks into a pond and sees this beautiful youth and falls in love with it. That draws him into an embrace of this figure in the pond. And of course, he drowns.

Water is mostly in mythology something creative. If we think of the mind, the heart-mind, the body-heart-mind — this whole organism — as a pond, the awareness is looking into it. And when it looks in, it has that feeling of presence. When you're in a very quiet moment, just with yourself, you get that sense of presence.

It's not the self of embarrassment, not the self of trying to get something — just that sense of being, that sense of presence. That is our first construction. And it's through that construction that we enter into the world being created by this psychophysical organism.

What we're doing in meditation is pulling ourselves out of that pond and sitting back up onto the bank. When we do that, we get that sense of being the knower, the feeler, the one who is experiencing. Everything that's happening is happening on that screen — you might say the surface of the pond. But of course you can see through the pond into the pond. This consciousness we have is multi-dimensional; it contains everything we experience at a physical level, at a heart-emotional-mood level, and at the intellectual level, the imaginary level. Everything has to manifest on that surface. And that's the *khandha*, the aggregate of consciousness.

These consciousnesses are arising and passing away because they can only hold one sense base at a time. If you're watching a film on the telly while having a biscuit and a cup of tea, hearing what's happening, seeing what's happening — we get the impression it's all happening at the same time. But actually, in Buddhist psychology, these are all minute, infinitesimal little consciousnesses that run one after the other and give us the impression of wholeness. That's really seeing impermanence at the level of how we create the world we experience. And it's all based upon this psychophysical organism.

When we understand that we're pulling ourselves back onto that observation post within ourselves — observing and feeling and knowing the physical stuff that comes up, the emotional stuff, even the mental stuff — then we've already pulled out of that delusion of being this organism. To reinforce that understanding, the Buddha then begins to deconstruct this very organism, splitting it up into these aggregates, these heaps. The first one is the body.

It's a very strange situation we're in. I definitely feel myself to be in the body, and often when I'm enjoying something — or when I've got a headache — I definitely am the body. And yet, when I question myself and ask, well, what is it I actually know of the body? It's an infinitesimal amount. For instance, at this present moment, our toenails are growing. Have you any idea that's happening? It's only when you look down every so often and think, well, I've got to cut those toenails. We never actually experience a toenail growing.

I've got this book on biology, and every page has some detail that's quite amazing — beyond acceptance in a way. For instance, I picked up this little bit of fact: the brain has 12 billion neurons. You might know this, of course, but for me it's a bit shocking. Twelve billion neurons and 50 billion supporting glial cells. I haven't a clue what a glial cell is, but there's 50 billion of them, all up here in my head. At least I think I've got that amount — I might have a bit less. But even so, there are billions. Not thousands, not millions — billions. And the fact is, if I hadn't read that book, I basically wouldn't know that. I've no experience of a single neuron. That shows you how ignorant I am of how my brain works. But it works. Generally speaking, I'm fairly happy with it. I could wish it to be just a little bit quicker, but there we are.

Wherever you look at the body, what you find are these cells. They say there are trillions of cells making up the body, and they're all dying and then replacing. They tell you that every seven years you've got a new body — but not for an instant have I felt anything dying as such. And yet this is what I'm told is happening. There's a disconnect between my experience of the body as something I feel I'm in, I'm of, something I can move around and wave my hands about — and yet the body itself has its own agenda, an agenda I have no control over. Obviously the most shocking one is growing old and dropping dead, which is not something I'm particularly looking forward to.

You can see that when you actually contemplate the relationship we have with the body, it's very minimal. And it's all dependent upon our senses. These five physical senses give us information, and it's from this information that we construct the world we're experiencing — the outer world at least, and of course some of the inner world: the pain, the pleasures, and so on.

If we then ask, well, what is it that we're actually experiencing right down there at that physical base? The Buddha points to the four great elements — that's what they're called. Earth, water, fire, and air. I'm sure you know them. And what they're referring to are specific types of sensations.

Somebody once had this big doubt and said that these things don't exist in the actual material world — it doesn't match with science, as it were. And that's where the confusion sometimes lies. The Buddha is not talking about the external world as a scientific object. He's talking about the internal world and how we experience the external world.

When it comes to feeling, we can always go into feeling and discover the basic pieces or parts that make up that particular feeling. Take a very simple instance: pain in the knees from sitting. First of all, you get this word 'pain,' right? And you draw your attention to it. Now, in the process of vipassanā, we also see the reaction we've got to the pain. But what we're interested in at the moment is recognising that the word 'pain' is a concept, and it carries with it all our understanding about pain, all our personal experience about pain, what we've read about pain. So we're not actually experiencing the pain as pain, as a sensation — we're experiencing the concept we're putting onto the pain. In order to experience the pain as pain, you have to go into the pain. And when you go into it, what you discover is things like heat, pressure, tightness.

There, we're beginning to deconstruct our physical nature. In so doing, we're taking away this concept of pain and we're just there with the body as it gives us information. That's where the Buddha is pointing, because right there we can see this process of impermanence much more clearly. These little sensations are continuously arising and passing away. But it also deconstructs for us this pain, right? So that's the process of really understanding what he means by our physicality.

It's the same with eating — we're getting down to the actual experience of just the taste before we describe what food it is. You have to go right down to that physical base. It's the same with hearing, but the other senses are much more difficult to grasp — the hearing and the seeing.

There's a book called *Just Seeing* — I can't remember her name now. Obviously her insight was the way that what she was looking at broke up into all these different little pixels. She talks about seeing the world like those pointillists, those artists that use little dots to create the image, trying to copy photography, I think. And just for a moment the world split up into all these pixels — and that's the information coming in on the retina.

When it comes to the ear, right there at the eardrum, there's no sound. There's only pressure — the pressure waves of air hitting the drum in the ear. So there's no sound in the universe. There's only these pressure waves. But because we have this mechanism inside us to determine what the meaning of it is in terms of sound, from that point of just this pressure, these little drummings on top of the eardrum, it's taken into the mind. And it's the mind that creates the sound.

Now we can take that investigation into feeling. Again, feeling comes at the point where you're describing to yourself, where you determine to yourself whether something is pleasant or not — pleasant and unpleasant. That's how we

immediately categorise feeling, and that's the dual world we live in. There's a whole area of neutral feelings, but if we really look into those neutral feelings, you'll see they shade off into slightly unpleasant and slightly pleasant. That's the business of the mind. It's part of, I suppose, just being able to survive in the world — to know what's pleasant and what's not pleasant if you're a hunter or something.

So as soon as these basic sensations come in, they're immediately described by us to ourselves as pleasant or unpleasant. That's what the Buddha means by feeling. And these feelings are of two types: those coming from the body itself, and those coming from the heart-mind — our emotional mood life.

Now, just as we penetrated down into a physical feeling to discover it's actually made up of all these various little sensations, we can do the same with an emotion. Take anxiety. First you recognise it: this is anxiety, this is anxiety. Then, when you're steady, when you're feeling at ease with it, you actually go in and sink into it. You sink into it and discover the sensations that make up this feeling of anxiety. You may find a lot of heat, a lot of agitation. And by doing that, you're deconstructing anxiety and beginning to realise — actually, it's just a feeling.

Somehow we take this feeling, give it a perspective by putting a concept on it — anxiety — and then we identify with it. We say, 'I am anxious.' And that's how the suffering builds up. But when we go down to the feeling of anxiety as a direct physical experience in the body, well, it's just a bit of heat and commotion. That's all, see? By deconstructing emotions like this, we lose our fear of them, we begin to get a handle on them. We recognise that anytime I feel like this, all I have to do is just sit with it. And of course, there's the therapy — because the heart then releases that energy outwardly as a feeling. And of course, it dies out.

The Buddha collects all of this in one word: *vedanā*, just feeling. At the base, he doesn't make a distinction between mental and physical feelings. That's the next step up, when he says: if you look again, you'll see that some feelings — pleasant or unpleasant — are coming from the body, and some are coming from the heart-mind. When it comes from the body, sometimes you can't do anything about it. Physical pain, chronic pain and all that. One technique for getting used to chronic pain, if somebody has such a thing to suffer, is to begin to deconstruct it and see it just as sensation. Then at least it becomes bearable. It can never become a pleasant experience, but at least it becomes bearable.

Now, the third one is a little more, shall we say, difficult — because it's to do with concepts, with perception. What we have to recognise is that when we have a particular experience, we create a photocopy of it in the mind. It can be a physical thing like eating an apple. It could be something you see, a visual thing. It could be some intellectual understanding. But at some point, there's a copy of it in the mind, a little photocopy. That's your perception. And the more you have of that experience, the more this perception grows into a concept. Take apples, for instance — everybody's eaten an apple, and we have a concept of an apple.

Now there are all types of apples: sweet apples, sour apples, cooking apples, small apples, big apples. Lots of types. But we definitely know they're not oranges. And that's what a concept does — it allows us to categorise everything.

Unfortunately, concepts also distort what we're actually experiencing. Our concept of an apple comes with a value judgement — what I like. So I like sweet apples. And if I bite into an apple that's sour, or has a certain bitterness, or is too soft, I immediately get that reaction of not wanting it. But if I'd never tasted an apple before, and this was my first one — with a little bitterness and a little softness — I'd say, 'Well, this is an amazing fruit.' And I'd build up my concept from there about apples and what I like.

So our concepts are quite constricting. Part of our process is to get beyond concepts and reach a point of no preference. That's one of the signs of liberation — we don't worry about whether the apple is soft or hard, bitter or sweet; you just eat the damn thing. Concepts are really one of our biggest enemies when it comes to the process of liberation.

You can even have a concept of *nibbāna*. You read about it, and there's this idea about it being blissful. You'll often hear 'the bliss of nibbāna.' So we immediately think it must be some amazing emotional experience. But there are no emotions in nibbāna. When somebody says to Sāriputta, 'How is it you talk about the bliss of nibbāna when there are no emotions, no moods, nothing there?' — he says, 'Well, it's the very absence of emotions and moods. That is the bliss of nibbāna.' Try to get your head around that one.

Our process of meditation, when we're sitting in vipassanā, is really to stop all that business. That's one of the purposes, remember, of using a single word. What that word does is draw this intellect down to a very simple, concrete concept. So you're noting 'lifting' or 'moving' or 'pushing' or 'pulling.' These are still concepts,

but at least they're not creating a process of thinking about something. And we're always looking through the word, right? The word isn't meant to be right in front of us.

Some people who begin noting find they can't actually get to the feeling of things because the word is so tight up against them. It's like a barrier to actually feeling something. What this tells a person is how this awareness, this ability to feel and directly experience, is being locked into a concept. So we say: look through the word, or around the word, or under the word. Find some way of, as it were, letting the word go and actually getting down to the feeling of it. That's how this awareness, this intuitive awareness, liberates itself from conceptual thinking. And that's very much part of our process.

This doesn't mean you can then forget all about concepts — not at all. You use them when you have to use them. But in order to begin to see the world as it really is, we have to see the limitation of these concepts.

On a grand scale, you can see that people in the East—I'm thinking of places like China, Japan, and so on—have a very different concept of society. They have a feel for community in a way that the Westerner, because of this accent upon the individual, doesn't have. For us, our rights are so important. We jump up and down: it's my right, it's my right. Whereas for somebody who sees themselves as part of a community, it's much more a sense of connection, a sense of belonging to others.

For the Easterner, the idea of being your own agent is difficult. And that's why, I presume—this is my own little understanding—they're much more comfortable with authoritarian regimes. You can see that conceptual thinking is quite a problem for us, and we have to really see it.

The greatest concept, of course—the one that really is at the root of everything—is this concept of a self. This idea of being a me, an individual, whole, entire person: the basis of everything we build up into being a person. This is undermined by really understanding ourselves as a collection of these different heaps, these different aggregates.

And it's not just an intellectual process. Remember, it begins there, but you actually have to see it, you have to feel it. You have to see that a sensation, that an emotion, is just sensations—that's all it is. And thinking: you don't have to believe a thought, you don't have to describe yourself by a particular set of concepts. You can step outside them.

So that's this whole business of perception and conceptualisation. And remember, this also includes memory. Once, my teacher said, 'There are these five aggregates,' and he went through them, and then he said, 'And there's memory. The Buddha forgot memory.' It was like everybody's jaw dropped.

The reason why the Buddha doesn't talk about memory as such is because our memories are hidden from us. What we're working with moment after moment are these concepts and ideas, these feelings, that arise in the present moment. So the Buddha is not denying memory. It's just that as soon as you remember something, it becomes something actual. But all the past is hidden to us unless it comes into our consciousness. In terms of the Buddha's understanding, it's not pertinent to seeing ourselves as we really are.

The fourth aggregate is *saṅkhāra*—those things that are compounded. People try to translate it in various ways: 'volitional conditionings' or 'concoctions.' One writer called them concoctions. But I think it's much easier for us to see them as habits. These are our habits.

The thing about a habit is that it's driven by will. The Buddha is quite clear that an action and the will are the same thing. That's why, when we're having a meal, that's the time to really make the distinction between a desire, which is only potential, and the moment it's suddenly empowered by an act of will. A decision is made, the power goes into that desire, and it begins to manifest.

Now, the process is this: you've performed an action and there are consequences, of course—that's the *kamma*, we'll come to that in a minute—but once you produce an action and repeat it, you're building up a habit. When you put all these habits together, that's our personality, that's our character. And once that's set, your destiny is right ahead of you. It's only by reflecting upon our habits and beginning to see that some of them are taking us to the cliff edge, while others are taking us up the mountain—up the *Nibbānic* mountain—that you begin to try and get rid of some and increase the others.

So these habits are a collection of things that we ourselves have created. We've done it from our sense of wisdom or lack of wisdom. We've empowered these desires. This is what we have created within ourselves. My habits are my creation. Now, it might have been done because of somebody's advice, or because somebody told me to do it. It doesn't really matter. Eventually, the process is internal: I've made the decision, and I've created the habit.

In this sense, you begin to understand that nobody can actually make you suffer. Nobody can make you suffer. All the suffering is made by us. These are our habits, our mental states, and I've created them. Once we recognise that, we also begin to realise that just as we've created them, we can uncreate them. And that's part of the therapy of our process when we sit in meditation.

When you sit with a habit that's causing you problems—I don't know, something like a quick temper—by sitting with that feeling of anger and allowing it to evaporate, to release itself, you're undermining the habit of anger. Now, anger itself is like a balloon inside our psyche, and it's not actually attached to an object. This is a funny thing. It's not that somebody standing on my toe is causing the anger. It's my reaction to somebody standing on my toe that causes the anger to arise.

In other words, these mental states we have—these emotional habits—don't actually have an object. They are a way of reacting to something. And because the outer world and other people are not the direct cause of my unwholesome mental states, I can actually heal myself. If other people caused me suffering, then the only way to achieve Nibbāna would be to get rid of all these other people. But that isn't the way the Buddha pointed. He said, no, the problem is us internally.

So these saṅkhāras, these habits—our job is to allow the unwholesome ones to evaporate and to build up the ones that are beautiful. And we can do that. In sitting meditation, we tend to allow the more unfortunate mental states to evaporate. Then in our daily lives, that's when we can build up our goodness, our goodness power—puñña. Sometimes that's translated as 'merit', but it's much better to think of it as goodness power.

This is where the transition comes from vipassanā into daily life. This is where the Eightfold Path comes in: right speech, right action, right livelihood. It's through action in the world that we can change these habits. In fact, that's the most powerful place to do it, because it's only when we come up against things that make us anxious, depressed, or angry that we can work with them right there as they arise—and undermine the energy we put into reinforcing those states.

This definitely happens when you're sitting. And if we've got this awareness, this mindfulness in daily life, it'll also happen in ordinary daily life. Because you're aware—like for instance, you talk to somebody and you can feel a little bit of irritation coming. So that awareness has to be both on the person who's talking and also inwardly. When you see this irritation rising, you don't join in. You just

let it burn a little bit. You put your attention on what the person is saying. Whereas often what we do is immediately identify with this: I'm right and that person's wrong. And before you know it, it's all shouting.

Finally, there's consciousness. We've already touched upon that with Narcissus looking into the pond. Everything has to arise on that consciousness. Now, unfortunately, the Buddha had this massive breakthrough and the language couldn't hold it. He couldn't make up a word to actually express things. So he's always playing around with words, and words depend upon the situation he's describing.

Often he'll talk about *viññāṇa*, consciousness, as something that discriminates—which actually is the effect of these *saṅkhāras*, this ability to understand on the screen of consciousness. But when we go down to that root position, the contact—that place of contact of consciousness with the physical body, consciousness with emotions, consciousness with thought—when we get down to that point, there's always an object, internal or external. There's always a sense base. The sixth sense, remember, is the mind itself. It's the mind that senses emotions and images and all that. And consciousness.

So consciousness turns out to be just a screen. And the whole position of *vipassanā* is to step, as it were, backwards outside the screen. But there's always that sense of a self, which is awareness itself catching its own sense of presence on that screen. That's the first object we make. That's the first concept we have. And breaking through that is the point of liberation. To be able to sustain that separation in ordinary daily life—that, of course, is the sign of someone who's fully liberated.

So finally, what then is our *kamma*? When you look at all this, when we talk about *kamma*—what we are responsible for, what the consequences are—it actually is confined to what we will. So it wouldn't be right to think, say, this body is my personal *kamma*. This body is a construction that's arisen out of generations of people. And I didn't choose it. I would have preferred a better body. But this one's okay. I'm not complaining. Oh, no. This one's been healthy, et cetera, et cetera. So I'm definitely not complaining.

But the body has been given to me. I find myself in a body. The society I'm born into with all its language and concepts and art—all that is given. That is also not my personal *kamma*. If I happen to cross a road and get knocked over by a car, even if I'm not seriously injured, just bumped, you might say—we can't say that's my personal *kamma*.

Personal kamma, the kamma which is to do with liberation, is this process of purifying the heart of its unwholesome conditionings and beginning to see where the fundamental delusion rises—which is this sense of self. If we go backwards and recognise what's happening, this awareness, this intuitive awareness, sees itself. It gets a feeling for itself, a sense of presence on that screen of consciousness. And it sees on that screen the world which the body, heart, and mind are creating. And it moves into that world with the idea of becoming happy.

Hence, it has to acquire things. The whole position of acquisition is to make us safe, to make us happy. The more you have, the better we think we're going to be. It's much better to have a couple of million in the bank than just a couple of pounds. So we're always trying to accumulate things. Once we've accumulated, we find that other people want what we have, and therefore you have to defend and protect—and that's the aversion. And when the...

...when the enemy is a bit too big, you run for it. So there's your fear, there's your reaction of fight and flight. These are our basic unwholesome motivations that run through from that initial delusion.

So it's by doing the opposite—by renouncing ownership, by giving—that we begin to undo the delusion. That's the whole process of the Eightfold Path. And undoing the delusion, we go right back to this sense of self. At some point there is this opening of the heart, this recognition of community, of communion—not only with people but with all beings. That's when, you might say, the path of love takes us towards the end of this very tight sense of me.

This leads us to a deeper understanding of awareness itself. Ultimately, through the process of insight, there comes a realisation of the uniqueness of this intuitive awareness. And this is what the Buddha is pointing to when he says there is an unborn, undying, uncreated, unconditioned—and that's it, that's the statement. He makes other statements too, such as: there is a dimension, āyatana, which doesn't have any of the other dimensions in it.

Now the word āyatana refers to the dimensions of each of the sense spaces. These sense spaces can't be mixed—you can't hear through your nose, even if you try. So these are different dimensions of experience. And the Buddha says there is a dimension where none of these can be found: no hearing, no seeing, and so on. Many times he points to something beyond, transcendent of the world we're actually experiencing.

So our process is through vipassanā to begin to see these three characteristics. We haven't talked so much about reaction, which is also part of that saṅkhāra business, the habits. We pointed to it in terms of acquisition—greed, avarice, and so on—and the opposite of fight and flight. That's all in the habitual thing. That's all part of our true kamma.

The process of vipassanā is partly to do with purifying that, which happens quite naturally. But more pertinent, shall we say, is that we're actually seeing the process of desire. We're seeing the process of impermanence. And from that position of the observer, we see that things arise of their own accord, that they don't have a possessor—they just happen through habitual practice. So these are your three characteristics.

In ordinary daily life, it's this process of undoing that selfishness, that constant looking after me as opposed to others, that opening of the heart to other people. This undermines the self as a concept, as an emotional concept. That's the process through love, compassion, sympathetic joy—it undermines the idea, the notion of a self. And eventually, of course, there is liberation. Liberation from all these wrong concepts, from all these wrong habits. That's what the liberation is.

Very good. So I hope that's been of some use. I hope it hasn't caused even further confusion—and that you will, by your effort, liberate yourself sooner rather than later.

Detailed Sequence Leading to Conflict

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 14 min

Originally given as *Detailed Sequence Leading to Conflict* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the Buddha's profound teaching on dependent origination (paṭicca samuppāda) through what he calls 'the dark chain of causation.' Using the relatable example of ice cream on a hot day, he traces the psychological steps from initial pleasant feeling through craving (taṇhā), pursuit, gain, possessiveness, and niggardliness, ultimately leading to defensiveness and conflict.

Drawing from the Buddha's detailed analysis of how we create our own suffering, Bhante explains how each link in this chain reinforces the next, creating a vicious cycle that can escalate from simple desire to 'clubs, weapons, conflicts, quarrels and disputes.' The key insight is recognizing where to break this cycle - right at the beginning with craving itself.

The talk offers practical guidance on how to interrupt this process through Right Awareness, noting thoughts without suppression, and redirecting attention back to the heart. Bhante emphasizes the importance of diligence (appamāda) in this practice, sharing humorous personal anecdotes about the challenges of maintaining awareness in daily situations. This teaching provides essential understanding for anyone seeking to comprehend how our mental formations create dukkha and how mindful awareness can lead to freedom.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā-sambuddhassa (three times).
Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-enlightened.

Bhikkhu Bodhi keeps choosing some nice juicy passages for us. This one is taken from one of the main discourses on dependency—the wheel of dependent origination, which is the Buddhist psychology of how we cause problems in ourselves. I'll read it through first and then we'll take it from there. It's called "The Dark Chain of Causation."

Thus Ānanda, in dependence upon feeling there is craving. In dependence upon craving there is pursuit. In dependence upon pursuit there is gain. In dependence upon gain there is decision making. In dependence upon decision making there is desire and lust. In dependence on desire and lust there is attachment. In dependence upon attachment there is possessiveness. In dependence upon possessiveness there is niggardliness. In dependence upon niggardliness there is defensiveness. And because of defensiveness various evil, unwholesome things originate: the taking up of clubs and weapons, conflicts, quarrels and disputes, insults, slander and falsehood. What a miserable outcome!

What the Buddha is doing here is showing us the round of how things create this cycle, this vicious circle, and how things just get worse unless we see where we have to pop it—where we have to actually break that cycle.

Feeling here always arises with perception. Feelings are either pleasant or unpleasant, and we tend to rate our happiness according to our feeling. We say "I feel happy"—that's one of the big mistakes, but I won't go into that. We have a feeling of happiness and because of this, craving arises. Craving here is really a strong word for a specific Pali term, *taṇhā*, which means desiring something that isn't wholesome for us, that isn't skilful for us. We don't really have that word in English. "Desire" doesn't give us that meaning, so translators tend to use "craving"—but of course that's a bit strong. Although it can be a craving, obviously. It can be an addiction.

Dependent upon this craving, there's pursuit—which means we go and get it. Let's take a very simple thing: ice cream. You're walking down the street on a hot day, which happens occasionally in this country once a year, and you see a sign for an ice cream. The seeing of it, the perception of it, brings a memory and a feeling tone to that memory. You say to yourself, "Oh, I'd like an ice cream." That business of "I'd like an ice cream" is the craving, the wanting.

Once you've done that, of course, you go and buy it. You're on the path into the shop to get yourself an ice cream—that's the pursuit. In dependence upon the pursuit, there's gain: you get in the shop, you buy it, and there you've got it. You've got your ice cream.

In dependence upon gain, there is decision making. Now you happen to be with a friend. You want the ice cream, you're about to buy it, and you're going to decide whether you should offer to buy one for your friend or not. This is a big problem. Whether it's their turn to offer you the ice cream. There's all these little machinations going on in the mind—and then there's decision making.

Upon this decision making, there is desire and lust. What does he mean by that? It means that when we're going into a shop to buy this ice cream with a friend, we're buying it for ourselves. We may feel reluctant to have to buy one for our friend, and this creates a disturbance within us.

In dependence upon that desire, there becomes an attachment. The attachment is basically pointing out this psychological dependency on ice cream. Because ice cream brings us this happy feeling, and that's how we define our happiness—"I feel happy"—we become dependent on it. That's what attachment means.

In dependence upon attachment, there's possessiveness. That's pretty straightforward: it's mine. You hold on to it, you get fist cramp. And in dependence upon possessiveness, there is niggardliness. You're not going to give somebody else a lick of your ice cream. It's for me.

In dependence upon niggardliness, there's defensiveness. Your friend says, "Go on, give us a lick." "No, get off!" See? And then they say, "Well, I gave you one when I had an ice cream." And then there's a big fight. Before you know it: clubs, weapons, conflicts, insults, slander and falsehoods. Good God, there's no end to misery.

Now, you have to take this back again, because the whole process has reinforced the original feeling. The next time you see ice cream, there's an even greater desire for it—an even greater psychological dependency on it for happiness. And there you've got your rounds. This is the vicious circle.

All the Buddha is saying is this: if you look at this process within yourself, if you're aware of it and see that it's actually causing you problems, then you have to find where you're going to cut the circle. And you cut it right at the beginning, with the craving. When you see ice cream and you get this addiction for it, this almost overwhelming desire to get it, you have to just stay still. Allow it to pass. Keep walking, keep walking past the shop. Just keep going.

When the craving goes, some of that attachment's gone. When some of that attachment's gone, some of the possessiveness has gone. When some of the possessiveness has gone, some of the niggardliness has gone. When some of the niggardliness has gone, the defensiveness has gone. And when the defensiveness has gone, there's no more taking up of clubs and weapons, no conflicts, quarrels and disputes, no insults, slander and falsehoods. Get it?

This is the Buddha trying to explain in detail how we create problems within ourselves. I can only hope my words have been of some assistance. May you, through your lack of niggardliness, come to the complete end of niggardliness—which is, of course, nibbanic bliss—sooner rather than later. Any questions around niggardliness?

The main thing is to see that the processes in the mind we call thinking and imagining are actually what's causing the problems. As soon as you can stop that—but you have to be careful, remember, that's not suppressing anything. When you see some thought going on and on, and you stop it, you see.

If it's stopped with aversion—"I don't want it"—or if it's stopped with fear, then that's suppressing. In other words, you've got this underlying, unexpressed attitude, and it keeps coming up into the mind as a constant thought, an obsessive thought pattern, and you push it down. You push it down with aversion or fear. That's suppression. And that, of course, is negative mental energy on top of mental negativity.

But if you note the thought and accept it for what it is—"this is niggardliness"—and you just turn away back into the heart, you've not suppressed anything. Because the problem is here, in the feeling. If you open up to that and let it express itself as pure feeling, then that is the process of therapy. That's the heart healing itself—just letting go of this turbulence. See?

Once you've understood that, you get in the habit of doing it, and everything cools down. But it's the habit, you see. For instance, you might have this business of when somebody says something that's upset you. And you've just batted it away—"That's the way they are." Then tea break comes. Then lunchtime. By evening you're stabbing them, clubs and all that. It's just built up through the mind. Even though they've only insulted you once, you've had them insult you a hundred thousand times. No wonder you want to kill them.

So it's actually getting right there with the thought, knowing the thought for what it is, staying with the heart for a little while, and then putting the attention elsewhere. That's the process. Unfortunately, if we're not diligent—and that's one of the Buddha's favourite words, appamādo—we're not diligent, and before you know it, it starts off again. You've worked hard to get rid of all this anguish and hatred and fear, and then one moment it's all fired up again through the mind. So it's just that constant effort, constant effort.

"It's not easy to always nip it in the bud when the craving starts. Perhaps it would be anywhere in the cycle."

Well, once it's shot off and you're right there holding your club, then you've got to stop. You've got to catch the heaviness of the mood in the heart. So if you're driving and you're getting cheesed off with this guy going so slow in front of you—if you don't watch it, you're trying to overtake them all the time, shooting ahead.

It was funny—a few weeks ago I went to see the treasurer, Rob, who lives in Shrewsbury, and for some reason he plied me with two very strong coffees. So I've got this energy. I end up at Morrison's for a cup of tea, walk in, and I'm stuck in this queue. They're all octogenarians, these old people in front of me, and there's these two women taking hours over deciding what to have. I can feel this energy. I try to go past them—"Do you mind? Moving the queue." And I start off—I know, I know, this is it! You see, one has to always be alert to one's...

09. Power

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 25 min

Originally given as 09. Power at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the Buddha's teaching on power and its potential for both liberation and destruction. He contrasts the unwholesome power driven by greed (lobha), hatred (dosa), and delusion (moha) with the wholesome spiritual power of the Iddhipāda — the four bases of psychic power including desire (chanda), energy (vīriya), heart (citta), and investigation (vimamsa).

Drawing fascinating parallels between the Buddha's temptations and those of other spiritual figures, Bhante explores how our fundamental delusion of selfhood creates the drive to control others and our environment. He addresses the psychological roots of political oppression, examining how dictators maintain power and why non-violent resistance ultimately succeeds where violence perpetuates suffering.

The talk illuminates how we unconsciously wield power in relationships through emotional manipulation and control, often disguised as love or care. Through practical examples, including the difference between being 'in authority' versus being 'an authority,' Bhante shows how to recognize and transform our own power dynamics. He concludes by exploring the Buddhist understanding of identity ('I am' versus 'there is') and how releasing false identifications liberates us from the compulsive need to control, opening the heart to genuine compassion and interconnectedness.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā-sambuddhassa, namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā-sambuddhassa, namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā-sambuddhassa — homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-enlightened one.

"Greed, hatred and delusion of every kind are unwholesome. Whatever action a greedy, hating and deluded person keeps up by deeds, words and thoughts, that too is unwholesome. Whatever suffering such a person, overpowered by greed,

hatred and delusion, his thoughts controlled by them, inflicts under false pretexts upon another by killing, imprisonment, confiscation of property, false accusations or expulsion, being prompted in this by the thought, 'I have power and I want power,' all this is unwholesome too."

We have to be careful here about power as such. If we look at our own psycho-analytic history, we find that Freud thought our main problem was pleasure — the pleasure principle. One of his students, Adler, thought it was power. And another, Frankl — I just looked these up on Wikipedia — thought it was meaning, which is rather interesting actually. Our search for meaning was the driving force in our lives.

So here you have three driving forces: the pleasure principle — wanting to be happy for heaven's sake; power, which gives us control; and meaning — why are we alive? Where are we going? Why were we born?

It's interesting to note that in the Buddha's own story, his main problem seemed to be around pleasure. *Māra*, the evil one, sent his three daughters: one was sensual pleasure, one was sexual pleasure, and one was boredom. That was his problem. Compare that to Christ. Jesus was taken to the top of the mountain by Satan and offered power over all. His was a power complex. Very interesting, the contrast between those two great spiritual leaders.

Then you get all sorts of ideas about power. Even Nietzsche, who had such an influence on the Nazis — that drive of will to power, the will to be the best you could be. That's another one, isn't it? Driven by the idea of being the best. And then you get people like Schopenhauer, I think, with the will to live, just to be alive. We come across that when our lives are in danger — you just want to be alive for God's sake.

So there are all these types of power. When it comes to the Buddha's teachings, we have a positive power. They're called the *iddhipāda*, the paths of power, accompanied by the effect of will. One of them is desire, intention. Remember, you can have a desire to become liberated from suffering. But unless your will is behind it, unless there's a real power, nothing's going to happen. You're going to sit there dreaming.

And there's energy. What the Buddha's saying is, to progress spiritually, you've got to have a real energy, a real power behind that energy. Then there's the heart — your heart's got to be empowered. There's got to be a real inner desire to become liberated. And finally there has to be this quality of investigation. Because

our problem fundamentally is delusion and misunderstanding somewhere. So we have to search within our lives, within the way we think, what we do — where are we going wrong, how are we creating problems for ourselves? That has to be really empowered.

These are all the positive sides of power. But here of course the Buddha is saying that there is such a power which is driven by greed, hatred and delusion. That's obviously something else.

He says it is "whatever suffering such a person overpowered by greed, hatred and delusion, his thoughts controlled by them, inflicts under false pretext upon another by killing, imprisonment, confiscation of property, false accusation and expulsion. Being prompted in this by the thought, 'I have power and I want power.'" So obviously that's a completely different form of power. That's a power which comes from control — getting what you want at the expense of anybody or anything, even the earth.

To understand this, we have to go back to the basic idea of the self itself and who we think we are. Remember that our essential delusion is a problem of identity, of who we are. And having defined ourselves as human beings — this is a big problem, because now we're searching for absolute or real happiness as a human being. In so doing, we have a relationship to the world of making sure that through the body, through the world, we can find happiness. And we want to control the world.

So you either control it by getting rich — that's one way of trying to control it. Or fame. Being famous is a lovely feeling. Being loved, even though it's not a real love. People drop you as soon as you're not making up the right songs. Fame is very flimsy, but it gives you a feeling of being wanted. You have a control over your fans. And then, of course, there's just naked power. Just power. And we have lots of examples in our own history of that.

Machiavelli was the one, wasn't he? The Renaissance thinker who said, if you want to be a good ruler, forget love — fear is the way to keep control. And of course, if you look around the world at the dictators we still have, this terrible thing going on in Syria — all these are people who've gained power and who gather support by making sure that everybody has a little share of the goods. That's how you get your support, isn't it? If you're a dictator, you want to make sure your army gets exactly what it needs and wants, that your soldiers have a good night

out. Then they've got something to lose, in which case they'll be right behind you. And they definitely don't want the opposition to win, because the opposition will take their power. That's the awful thing.

Compare, for instance, what's happened in Burma, where the opposition has been non-violent. Because it's been non-violent, eventually — even though it's caused sacrifice, and that's the problem with non-violence, it demands sacrifice — eventually the military, the dictator, begins to give way. It's the same with India, with Gandhi and the British. Non-violence, and eventually it just gives way, even though there's sacrifice. But when you're into some violent revolution, such as what's happening in Syria, you have many more deaths. Because it's two sides facing each other with the desire for absolute power, both wanting to destroy the other. There's not going to be much chance for peace if you're going to do that. Look at South Africa and the whole way Nelson Mandela moved towards reconciliation. But there has to be — this is the problem — there has to be that sacrifice. Most people don't want to do that; they'd rather just go for the enemy and that's the end of it.

So power in terms of our lives — really we have to see where it is that we're exercising power in this bad sense, trying to control people. We can do it very cleverly, by hints and emotional blackmail. 'I will not love you unless you give me everything I need.' And then there's just naked power, money power.

It's worth investigating our relationships and the way that, because we depend on them for happiness — not to say there isn't a true love there. It doesn't negate the fact that there is true love. It's just that there's another bit which is about this relationship being for me. Am I for you? And that's where you get the power. That's where you want the control.

Parents definitely love their children, but they also want to be able to tell their children what to do — not so much for the benefit of the child but for their own benefit. The worst case is when somebody — I remember seeing a programme where a parent had failed to become the violinist she wanted to be. And so by every means she could, her daughter was going to be this great violinist. Of course it was just messing the daughter up. It's an imposition of her desire on the other.

This is where power causes us problems in our lives. And eventually, of course, we might end up doing exactly what the Buddha says here: 'inflicts under false pretext upon another, killing, imprisonment, confiscation of property, false accusation and expulsion.' Terrible.

I hope my words have been of some assistance and that, overcoming all temptation to control, to have power in a bad sense, you will achieve full liberation from suffering sooner rather than later. Thank you very much.

'Some sort of clarification about the difference between taṇhā and chanda. Is it the delusion and the ego identification which is the problem, which turns something neutral into something bad?'

Yes. The word taṇhā has a specific meaning of a desire which is unwholesome, unskillful. The word for desire generally speaking is chanda — that's the word they use in those paths to power I was talking about. The desire to become liberated would be considered wholesome, I think. And one has to empower that desire; you want to really need that, you're seeking liberation from suffering. So that's chanda. Chanda is the will. That's the power, you see.

For instance, you can intend, but nothing may happen. You can intend, 'Well, now we'll have a cup of tea.' But if it's not empowered, you'll just be sitting here still intending till tomorrow morning. The power is what takes something out of potential into actual. That's a force. I can intend to move the chair, but unless I actually put energy into it, it's not going to happen. That's the power there.

Now, power itself is completely neutral. What makes it wholesome or unwholesome is the attitude driving it. If you want to make somebody suffer, you'll use your power to do that. If you want to make somebody happy, you'll use your power to do that.

And then there are also, generally speaking, two types of power that we can wield. We have the word 'authority.' You can be 'in authority over' — to be in authority over somebody, you inspire fear. But you can also be 'an authority,' whereby you inspire respect. If you're somebody who people think is an authority, like when you go to the doctor, hopefully you think they're an authority. They've got to be right. There's a completely different sort of relationship there, you see.

Most positions involve a bit of both. Having some power along with being an authority is often necessary to get done what needs to be done. But you can see there's a distinction between these two types of power that's often invested in us. And remember that dictators only arise because people invest them with power. It wouldn't happen if people didn't give them that power in the first place.

Going back to your original point about the self — the self, remember, is in Buddhist terms a relationship. When we say 'I am,' the way we finish that sentence tells us something about ourselves. It could be something like, 'I am depressed.' Now this is me, I am depressed. Once you identify with something, there's no escape, is there? What are you going to do? What we're learning here is to see depression as something outside the I, outside this observer. It's more accurate to say, 'there is depression.'

Now that liberates me from suffering the depression. It doesn't take away the depression — the depression still remains a depression — but now I can find another identity: no matter what, no matter that there's a feeling of depression, I'll carry on doing what I need to do. It won't hijack my life.

Then there are definitions like 'I am an electrician, I'm a teacher, I'm a doctor.' When these are taken away from us, of course you get depression. Once you lose your job and you say 'I am' — but if you take the I away and say that there is an action of being an electrician or whatever it is, then there's not that identity. If it goes away, you still don't lose that sense of self-esteem. That's the point. If your self-esteem is based on your job and your job goes, then you lose your self-esteem. You feel diminished by it.

It's the same with watching these Paralympics. Some of these people have had really bad accidents, suffered greatly, but you can see they've all regained a lot of their self-esteem — which they might have lost through becoming disabled. Before, you said, 'I am a fully able person,' and now you've got to go around saying, 'I am disabled.' That's a loss of something, isn't it?

It's the same with a lesser sense of identity, which is 'I have.' 'I own.' If you think about it, you can only use an object; you can't in any absolute sense own it. Legally you might say 'this is my car,' but when the thief takes it, it's his — it's not yours anymore. You still go around saying 'somebody's stolen my car.' But that's just a legal fiction.

Say you get some precious glassware or something like that. It's 'my glassware,' something you possess. If it breaks, of course, a lot of suffering. But if you already see it broken — when it breaks, well, it's going to break anyway. I saw it broken. It's about getting a different relationship with things so that when they disappear, it doesn't hurt. Or it doesn't hurt so much.

'Self-remembering is then something which is opposite to self-identifying.'

Self-remembering is — yes, dissociating ourselves from — yes, but you have to be careful with that word. Primarily it's a dissociation to get away from the wrong relationship. But then you have to re-engage with the right relationship. You might dissociate yourself from somebody's suffering and say, 'Well, that's their kamma. What's it got to do with me?' But then you've got to re-engage and recognise that we're all in this together. And there comes that compassion and a desire to alleviate suffering.

I always like to tell the story of when I was in Thailand. I went to visit this monk and there was a cat playing around with a mouse which was already dead. I said to him, 'Didn't you stop that? It's a fat cat. It's a monastery cat. It's a fat cat. Didn't you stop that?' He said, 'No. It's cat kamma, mouse kamma.'

Funnily enough, very shortly after that, I was sitting on a bench with a few monks, and this cat jumped out and caught a bird. Well, this monk, as quick as lightning, got up, gave this cat one hell of a smack, picked up the bird — it was already dead, the lungs had been punctured — and held it up beautifully by the wings and chanted, 'All compounded things arise and pass away.'

Obviously this monk didn't think it was cat kamma and bird kamma entirely. The fact that he was aware of it was part of their kamma. There's the engagement, there's the connection. Whereas the first monk had completely dissociated — it was all there like it's not my problem. This other monk was completely engaged. And that's this right attitude.

That's why at the end of every sitting we do with *vipassanā*, we follow it with *mettā* — because that re-engages us properly.

'But how do we know which one we need to dissociate from?'

Well, compassion is the right one. To create dissociation without connection is just creating another barrier.

Now a barrier is not the same as a boundary. Take the seashore: one minute it's the sea, the next minute it's the land. That's a boundary — fluid, easy. But a cliff? That's a barrier. As soon as you create barriers, you're isolating yourself. If you say this is not my business, all the problems of the world are not my business, then remember: the world has no business taking any of your problems as their business. You go to a doctor and say, 'I'm really ill, I've got this pain,' and the doctor says, 'It's not my business.' Do you know what I mean? It works both ways. And that produces a sort of callousness.

So there has to be that recognition. When you go deeper and realise our inter-connectedness, you realise that everything we do has an effect on everything else in some way. The ripples of every action go completely out and then completely back. This is reinforced even by physics, ordinary science — the theory of chaos, where small conditions, given supporting conditions, will grow. The usual example is a butterfly flapping its wings in South America which, given supporting conditions, becomes a storm in North America.

Take that on the positive side: even to make a small gift towards, shall we say, some problem in the Middle East may eventually be just that condition that brings about peace. You don't know. When you begin to see the world as this inter-connectedness, this interdependency, the barriers break down.

The Buddha, when he was fully liberated — he could have just sat there, couldn't he? 'I'm happy.' But it's funny, because the first thought that comes into his head is 'Who can I teach this to?' There's a natural outflow from wisdom. Wisdom in action is compassion. It simply doesn't work the other way.

Bāhiya of the Bark Cloth

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 11 min

Originally given as *Bāhiya of the Bark Cloth* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines one of Buddhism's most direct teachings on liberation through the story of Bāhiya of the Bark Cloth from the Udāna Sutta. He contextualizes this encounter by exploring the historical background of bark cloth-wearing ascetics who followed Upanishadic teachings, particularly the Brhadāranyaka Upanishad's concept of the "unseen seer."

The Buddha's revolutionary instruction to Bāhiya—"In the seen, there is merely the seen; in the heard, there is merely what is heard"—represents a radical departure from Brahmanical ideas of an eternal self. Bhante Bodhidhamma explains how this teaching points to the dissolution of the subject-object relationship through the six sense doors, leading to the cessation of consciousness and the end of dukkha.

Using Buddhist psychology's framework of sense base, sense object, and consciousness, he demonstrates how liberation occurs when we neither identify "with that" (the object) nor remain "in that" (the sense base), transcending the psycho-physical organism entirely. This discourse offers profound insight into the direct path of Awakening through understanding the nature of sensory experience and the construction of self-hood.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the Blessed Noble, and fully self-awakened one.

Today I thought we'd tackle a slightly more — for want of a better word — mystical discourse. It's named after somebody called Bahiya of the Bark Cloth.

Now, whenever people write about saints and holy figures — hagiography — they always pump it up to make sure that either the person is amazing or the teacher is. It's not that the Buddha wasn't an amazing teacher, but in order to make him more amazing, we got this story about Bahiya.

So Bahiya was a merchant who used to ply up and down the Indian coast. One day he was shipwrecked and on a raft he made land. Suddenly he starts wearing a bark cloth. For those of you who want to know what a bark cloth is: you have to peel the inner bark off trees and beat it until it's soft. Then it can be used as a loincloth, skirt, draperies, wall hangings, and in thick layers it makes an excellent bed. So that's what you can do tomorrow. But it also says it's an ancient art deeply involved in religious and ceremonial life — remember that bit.

Anyway, he starts wearing this bark cloth and becomes a mendicant. Of course, people feed him. After a while, he got the impression that he was fully liberated. Well, as these stories go, a god appeared to him — an old relation — and said, "No, you're not liberated. You're not enlightened. In fact, spiritually speaking, you're as thick as a plank. The person you want to go and meet is the Buddha." So off he goes to meet the Buddha. He must have been a bit disappointed at that revelation.

I think there's a better story, which seems more true. The Brahmins were developing their own scriptures called the *Upanishads* — the word translates as "connection." They're also known as the *Vedanta*, the end of the Vedas. These texts were specifically interested in who we were, what was the ground of our being — ontology.

This is a passage from the *Bṛhadāraṇyaka Upaniṣad*: "That imperishable is the unseen seer, the unheard hearer, the unthought thinker, the un-understood understander. Other than it there is naught that sees, other than it there is naught that hears, other than it there is naught that thinks, and other than it there is naught that understands." In other words, it's pointing to a self that is transcendent of everything. But it's interesting to see how it's expressed. The imperishable — that which does not change — is the unseen seer. It's very Zen, like the effortless effort: the unseen seer.

The people who followed this particular Upanishad used to wear the bark cloth. That was their signature dress, just like the Buddhist monks went around with a bald head. Everybody else had long matted hair, dreadlocks, but the Buddha made us shave our heads. All these sects had their own little way of manifesting who or what they were following.

So Bahiya has obviously heard about the Buddha. He comes to find him and discovers him on alms round. The Buddha says this isn't the time. Bahiya replies, "Look, I'm a very old man and you're not so young, and we could die any moment. So really, please give me the teaching." And the Buddha, out of his compassion, does so.

This is what the Buddha says to him: "Here, Bahiya, you should train yourself thus. In the seen, there is merely the seen. In the heard, there is merely what is heard. In the sensed, there is merely what is sensed. In the cognized, there is merely what is cognized. In this way you should train yourself, Bahiya." Now, if you're listening to this, you may very well become fully liberated.

Here's the crucial bit: "When, Bahiya, for you in the seen there is merely what is seen, in the heard merely what is heard, in the sensed merely what is sensed, and in the cognized merely what is cognized — then, Bahiya, you will not be with that. When you are not with that, then you will not be in that. And when you are not in that, then you will neither be here nor beyond nor in between the two. Just this is the end of suffering."

Anybody awaken? No? Don't worry — it didn't work for me either.

So what is the Buddha saying here? In Buddhist psychology, we have a sense base, we have something that the sense base senses, and we have the awareness — the consciousness. This consciousness is dependent on the sense base. That's why the Buddha enumerates consciousnesses according to the sense bases: eye consciousness, nose consciousness, ear consciousness, and so on.

What the Buddha is saying is that in any given experience, there's an object. It could be a video you're watching, a biscuit you're eating — whatever. That's the object. When you are not with that — not connected to the object — then you're not in the sense base either. If you're not in the sense base, consciousness cannot arise. So you're neither there with the object, nor here with the sense base, nor in between with that consciousness, which is the screen upon which these two things arise. When you experience something beyond all that, you've experienced something that is not part of the psycho-physical organism. And just this is the awakening.

The remarkable thing is that when Bahiya hears this, he is immediately enlightened. The Buddha actually gave him a title — he gave titles to certain disciples who had special gifts. Sāriputta, for instance, was called the *Dhammasenapati*, the general of the Dharma, because of his understanding of the teach-

ing, which was said to be second only to the Buddha's. Bahiya he called *Khippābhiññānaṃ*, the quickest to become liberated amongst all those who were quick to become liberated. That's the title he gave him. And then, as I say, shortly afterwards Bahiya dies from an attack by a cow.

So I hope this has been of some use, that it hasn't confused you, and that through your insight meditation — by seeing this process of how we create the world — you will be liberated from all suffering sooner rather than later.

The Relay of Chariots — Rathavināta Sutta (MN 24)

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 23 min

Originally given as *The Relay of Chariots — Rathavināta Sutta (MN 24)* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this exploration of the Rathavināta Sutta (MN 24), Bhante Bodhidhamma presents one of Buddhism's most systematic teachings on the path to awakening. The discourse unfolds through a profound dialogue between two great disciples: Sāriputta and Puṇṇa Mantāniputta, who meet for the first time in the Blind Man's Grove near Sāvattthī.

Through their exchange, we learn the seven stages of purification that lead to final nibbāna without clinging: purification of virtue (sīla), mind (citta), view (diṭṭhi), overcoming doubt, knowledge and vision of path and non-path, knowledge and vision of the way, and finally knowledge and vision itself. The Buddha's famous relay chariot simile illustrates how each stage serves as a vehicle to reach the next, just as King Pasenadi would use successive chariots to complete his journey.

Bhante contextualizes this teaching within the broader Theravāda tradition, noting how this sutta provided the structural framework later adopted by works like Upatissa's Path of Liberation and Buddhaghosa's Visuddhimagga. The episode beautifully captures the mutual respect and joy these two accomplished practitioners experience upon meeting, offering both systematic guidance for the spiritual path and inspiration for noble friendship in the Dhamma.

Good evening everyone. I trust you had a fruitful day. I do not say happy, though I hope it has been happy.

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa, Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa — homage to the Buddha, the Blessed Noble and Fully Self-Awakened One.

This evening I thought we'd move on to the *Majjhima Nikāya*, the middle length discourses, to discourse number 24 called the Relay of Chariots. The interesting thing about this is that it laid down a schema which was later copied in two works: the Path of Liberation by Upatissa, which if I remember rightly was only in the Chinese and then translated. And the way it's written, people think that Upatissa was in fact fully liberated. But a later book, which is more well known, of course, is the Path of Purification, the *Visuddhimagga*, which I hold in my hand here.

This is more of an encyclopedia, if you haven't come across it. It's a great book to dip into, and it's got to be one of the great spiritual manuals of the world because it contains virtually all the teachings and all the practices that are in Theravāda Buddhism. It's more of a scholastic work. I for one couldn't read it from page one to the end, but it's great to dip into. You can download it as a PDF if you're interested. It's got all the exercises.

In this discourse, it seems some monks have come down from the Buddha's own territory — his own country, the Sakyan country, which remember is just on the southern border of present-day Nepal. At that time, on one occasion, the Blessed One was living at Rājagaha in the bamboo grove, the squirrel's sanctuary.

Rājagaha is now Rajgir; you can visit. It was the capital of the southern Magadha and King Bimbisāra would have lived there. It's surrounded by a circle of hills and on one of the hills is Vulture's Peak, which is where most of the Mahāyāna discourses were given and some of the Buddhist discourses in the Theravāda tradition. On one hill, there's a really magnificent peace pagoda, all white and shiny. And you can go down and visit the hut where — oh dear, his name has gone out of my head — Bimbisāra's son murdered his father, starved him to death by putting him in that little hut. You can visit that if you want. In the middle of Rajgir, which is only a small town now, there's a fountain where people bathe. And there's a yoga centre there, a Gandhi yoga centre. So if you're ever in that place, you can always pay a little visit.

So that's where the Buddha is, in this bamboo grove, the squirrel sanctuary. A number of *bhikkhus* from his native land had spent the rains there — they'd gone there for the rainy season, which is the monsoon season, July, August, September. They went to the Blessed One and, paying homage, sat down at one side. The Blessed One asked them, "Is there anyone in my own country, my own native land, who is esteemed by the monks and the order, his companions in the holy life? One who has few wishes and talks to the *bhikkhus* of the fewness of wishes.

Content in himself, he talks to them about contentment. Secluded himself, he talks about seclusion. Aloof from society, he talks about the benefits of being aloof from society. Energetic in himself, he talks about arousing energy to the order. Attained to virtue himself, he talks about the attainment of virtue; attaining concentration, he talks about the attainment of concentration; attained to wisdom, he talks about wisdom; attained to deliverance, he talks about deliverance; attained to knowledge and vision of deliverance, he talks about that too — and he is one who advises, informs, instructs, urges, rouses and encourages his companions in the holy life?"

And they answer, "Yes indeed there is. There is a venerable and he is highly esteemed in his native land." Now it would seem that this particular monk was ordained by Añña Koṇḍañña, who was one of the five companions when the Buddha was — before he became liberated — the five companions he gave his first talk to. And the first one who got it, the first insight, stream entry, was in fact this Koṇḍañña. The Buddha gave him this name, Añña Koṇḍañña — Koṇḍañña, the one who knows. So he must have been up in the Sakyan territory, probably a Sakyan himself, although I can't find that out at the moment. And he ordained this monk, who became known by a special name given by the Buddha. Koṇḍañña, being the first, was given this nickname Añña, the one who knows, and to Mantāniputta the Buddha gave the nickname of the most eminent amongst preachers, so he was obviously very good at giving talks.

At that time, Sāriputta is with the Buddha and he hasn't met him. This gives you an idea that by now the order is quite large. Senior monks are ordaining monks, not just the Buddha. In those days — ox carts, no mobiles — how did they communicate? How did you find out where the Buddha was? It was all by hearsay. You hear somebody has come out: "Oh, the Buddha's making his way to the squirrel's grove." So everybody said, "Right, well, we'll go and try and meet him there."

Sāriputta was with the Buddha at the time. And he thought to himself, "It's great gain for Venerable Puṇṇamantāniputta. It is great gain for him to have wise companions, and perhaps sometime or other we might meet." So there is that desire in Sāriputta to meet this famous monk from the Sakyan country. It doesn't say that Mantāniputta himself was a Sakyan; he just happened to be in that country when he was ordained.

The Blessed One stayed long enough and then set out on stages to Sāvattthi. Remember, that's just north of present-day Varanasi, Benares, and that's where he gave his first talk to the five companions. Wandering by stages, he finally arrived there, staying at Jeta's Grove, Anāthapiṇḍika's park.

Now the Venerable Puṇṇamantāniputta heard, "Oh, the Blessed One has arrived at Sāvattthi and is living there." Somehow the rumour had got through, and off he goes, determined to see the Buddha. Wandering by stages, he eventually arrived at Sāvattthi. On paying homage to the Buddha, the Blessed One, he sat to one side. The Blessed One instructed, urged, roused and encouraged him with a talk on the *Dhamma*. Then the Venerable Puṇṇamantāniputta, instructed, urged, roused and encouraged by the Blessed One's words, delighted and rejoiced in them. Rising from his seat, he paid homage, keeping to his right, and went to the blind man's grove for a day's abiding to meditate.

Then a certain *bhikkhu* went to the Venerable Sāriputta and said to him, "Look, this Puṇṇamantāniputta that you speak so highly of — he's just been talking with the Buddha, with the Blessed One, and he's delighted and all that, and he's gone off and sat for a day's abiding at the blind man's grove." Of course the Venerable Sāriputta quickly picked up a mat and followed him, following close behind the Venerable Puṇṇamantāniputta, keeping his head in sight. So he obviously didn't know he was being followed.

And so they were both sat abiding for the day in the blind man's grove. Then when it was evening, the Venerable Sāriputta rose from meditation, went to the Venerable Puṇṇamantāniputta and exchanged greetings with him. When the courteous and amiable talk was finished — and don't confuse that with useless talk; when you meet somebody, there's always that little exchange of how are you, how are you doing, and so forth. Especially these days, we don't meet; we've probably forgotten how to do that after this lockdown.

Then he begins to talk to this monk, as if he himself was a beginner or not so new or fairly immature in the order. He asks him, "Is it for the sake of purification of virtue that we live under the *Dhamma* of the Buddha? Is that the purpose of the Buddha's *Dhamma*? Purification of virtue?" And he says, "No, no, no, that's not it."

"Then is it for the sake of the purification of the mind?" He says, "No friend, no, it's not that at all." "Is it for the sake of purification of view?" He says, "No friend, I'll explain these things when we've gone through them." "Is it for the purification of overcoming doubt that the holy life is lived?" He says, "No friend, no." "Then is it for the sake of purification of knowledge and vision of what is the path and

what is not the path that the holy life is lived?" "No." "Then is it for the sake of purification of knowledge and vision of the way?" He says, "No, no, it's not that either." "Then is it for the sake of purification of knowledge and vision that the life is lived under the Blessed One?" He said, "No, friend, no."

It's interesting that he approached him as "no friend." There are two ways in which, in the scriptures, the monks talk to each other. One is *bhante*, when you are addressing somebody who's older than you in the order, and the other one is *āvuso*, which is "friend," when somebody is your same age in the order — that means anybody who was ordained five years before you and five years after you. The monks you meet who are within that ten-year period, you would have approached as friend, and anybody above you, you would have said *bhante*, and anybody much younger than you, you would have said *āvuso*, friend, but they would have approached you with the word *bhante*. That's just a little aside.

"For the sake of what, then, friend, is the holy life lived under the Blessed One?" And here's the answer: "It is for the sake of final *Nibbāna* without clinging that the holy life is lived under the Blessed One."

But now, having stated that, you see, all the questions are asked again with a slightly different angle. "Is purification of virtue final *Nibbāna* without clinging?" So are any of these other six stages final *Nibbāna* without clinging? And of course there's "No. The purification of mind final *Nibbāna*?" "No." He says, "Purification of views?" Says "No." He says, "Purification of overcoming doubt?" "No. Purification by knowledge and vision of what is the path and what is not the path?" "No. Purification of knowledge and vision of the way?" "No, it's not that either," you see. "Then is purification of knowledge and vision final *Nibbāna* without clinging?" Says "No, friend," you see.

And then there's a nice little sentence here. He says, "But friend, is final *Nibbāna* without clinging to be attained without these states?" Okay, so could you get there without going through these stages? "There's no friend." "But how, friend, should the meaning of these statements be regarded?" So then he repeats all that, you see. In other words, you've got to go through these stages.

And then he says, "If final *Nibbāna* without clinging were to be attained without these states, then an ordinary person would have attained final *Nibbāna*. For an ordinary person is without these states." Now an ordinary person is someone who's not instructed in the *Dhamma*. So what he's saying is, if somebody reaches *Nibbāna* without any of this, then these teachings wouldn't pertain. But they do pertain. You've got to go through these stages.

And then he gives a simile of it, you see. He says, "For some wise men understand the meaning of a statement by means of a simile." So there's always this way of doing it as, shall we say, an academic thing. And there's always a more artistic way of expressing the *Dhamma* through some image, through some simile or metaphor.

So this is where we get the chariots. "Supposing King Pasenadi of Kosala, while living in Sāvatti, so that's where they are at the moment, so the local king was Pasenadi, had urgent business to settle in Sāketa. And that between Sāvatti and Sāketa, seven relay chariots were kept ready for him. Then King Pasenadi of Kosala, leaving Sāvatti through the inner palace door, would mount the first chariot, and by means of the first chariot, he would arrive at the second chariot." And then he goes through all the business of arriving with the second chariot, gets the third et cetera, et cetera, and then he would arrive at the inner palace door of Sāketa.

"Then when he had come to the inner door, his friends and acquaintances, his kinsmen and relatives would ask him, 'Sire, how did you come from Sāvatti to the inner palace door of Sāketa by means of this relay chariot?'" How then should King Pasenadi of Kosala answer in order to answer correctly? And of course, this gives the reciter an opportunity to say all that again. It's just one of those tricks of the ancient way of remembering things. A mnemonic.

So then he says, "So friend, the purification of virtue is for the sake of reaching purification of heart, mind." So remember the word mind in the scriptures is referring to the combination of the heart and the mind. "Purification of mind is for reaching the purification of view. Purification of view is for reaching the purification of overcoming doubts. Purification of overcoming doubt is for the sake of reaching purification by knowledge and vision of what is the path and what is not the path. Purification by knowledge and vision of what is the path and what is not the path is for the sake of reaching purification of knowledge and vision of the way. Purification by knowledge and vision of the way is for the sake of reaching purification by knowledge and vision. And purification by knowledge and vision is for the sake of reaching final *Nibbāna* without clinging. It is for the sake of final *Nibbāna* without clinging that the holy life is lived under the Blessed One."

And then Venerable Sāriputta, so this is the nice little bit where they finally meet, Venerable Sāriputta asks him, "What is the Venerable One's name and how do his companions in the holy life know the Venerable One?"

"So my name is Puṇṇa and my companions in the holy life know me as Mantānīputta."

Now what I understand from this is that Puṇṇa would have been his ordination name and that people would recognize him as Mantāniputta, the son of Mantāni. I think that probably was the remnants of a matriarchal society where you're known by your mother, Sāriputta, you see, son of Sāri. And that, I think, is kept in Thailand. It's not kept in Burma or in Sri Lanka, where a monk is known by his ordination name. But in Sri Lanka, they often call you by your lay name as a nickname, so when I was there I was Prapita, holy Peter, well you know what I mean.

"So it is wonderful, friend, it is marvellous, each profound question has been answered point by point by the venerable as a learned disciple who understands the teacher's dispensation correctly." So it is gain for his companions in the holy life, et cetera. "Even if it were by carrying the Venerable Puṇṇa Mantāniputta upon a cushion on their heads, that his companions of the holy life would get the opportunity to see and honour him, it would be a great gain for them. And it is a great gain for us, a great gain for us, that we have the opportunity to see and honour the Venerable Puṇṇa Mantāniputta."

Now, when this was said, the venerable Mantāniputta said to the venerable Sāriputta, "What is the venerable one's own name and how do his companions in the holy life know him?"

"My name is Upatissa." So that's his ordination name.

My companions know me as Sariputta." Now he's suddenly come across Sariputta. So it's a big shock, you see.

"Indeed, friend, we did not know we were talking to the venerable Sariputta, the disciple who is like the teacher himself." Calling somebody *Satukappa* is the highest of praise. It means you are like the Buddha. "If we had known that this was Venerable Sariputta, we should not have said so much. It is wonderful, friend. It is marvelous. Each profound question has been posed point by point by the Venerable Sariputta as a learned disciple who understands the teacher's dispensation correctly. It is gain for his companions in the holy life. It is great gain for them that they have the opportunity to see and honor the Venerable Sariputta, even if it were by carrying the Venerable Sariputta on a cushion on their heads, that his companions in the holy life would get the opportunity to see and honor him, it would be a great gain for them. And it is a great gain for us, a great gain for us that we have the opportunity to see and honor the venerable Sariputta."

This was how the two great beings rejoiced in each other's good words.

So I'm going to leave that there. And tomorrow I shall explain to you all these different levels of purification of the path.

So a nice little discourse there of two monks meeting and enjoying each other's company. I can only hope you found this little discourse encouraging and I trust that by your practice you will be liberated from all suffering sooner rather than later. So we can begin our practice.

Comments on a Statement by Mae Chee Kaew

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 45 min

Originally given as *Comments on a Statement by Mae Chee Kaew* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this dharma talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines a powerful statement by Mae Chee Kaew, a recognized Thai forest nun: "The presence that knows them never changes for an instant. It is forever unborn and undying. This is the end of suffering." Using this as a foundation, he provides a comprehensive exploration of the Buddha's core teachings on dukkha (unsatisfactoriness) and its cessation.

The talk delves deeply into the Four Noble Truths, examining how our fundamental delusion about selfhood creates suffering through the process of paṭicca samuppāda (dependent origination). Bhante explains how we create our experiential world through the six āyatana (sense spheres) and how attachment arises through vedanā (feeling-tone). He emphasizes the crucial distinction between experiencing pleasant and unpleasant sensations versus becoming identified with our reactions to them.

Drawing from the Mahāsi Sayādaw tradition, Bhante highlights the importance of observing intentions as they arise, explaining how this awareness allows unwholesome sankharas to exhaust themselves naturally. He explores the Eightfold Path as a systematic approach to liberation, showing how right awareness (sammā sati) serves as the foundation for all spiritual development. The talk concludes with reflections on the transcendent "presence that knows" – the unchanging awareness that remains unaffected by all arising and passing phenomena.

Mae Chee Kaew is a Thai forest nun recognised as a fully liberated being. Here is one of her statements—and we'll use it to find out how we might get there ourselves, even this week.

Body, mind and essence are all distinct and separate realities. Absolutely everything is known. Earth, water, fire and wind. Body, feeling, memory, thought and consciousness. Sounds, sights, smells, tastes, touches and emotions. Anger,

greed and delusion—all are known. I know them all as they exist in their own natural states. But no matter how much I am exposed to them, I am unable to detect even an instant when they have any power over my heart. They arise and cease. They are forever changing. But the presence that knows them never changes for an instant. It is forever unborn and undying. This is the end of suffering.

That's pretty clear. So how do we get to this point, I wonder—the end of suffering?

We'll come back to this in a moment. But if we want to teach people the Dharma, we've got to be clear ourselves about the basic position the Buddha took. We need to feel the internal logic of his teaching, the internal rationality of it, before we can make that bold statement: there is an end of suffering.

I don't think there's a single Western psychologist or school that says there's an end to suffering. Perhaps if they were Christians they might have thought so. But an end of suffering right here in this very life? That's quite a bold statement to make.

So let's revise the four basic truths the Buddha taught. First, this truth of dukkha. Remember, dukkha means something hard to bear—that's its translation. Hard to bear. It's not only referring to the pains and aches of the body, the emotional upsets, the pressures and stress of life. It always boils down to these three characteristics. Our deeper level of existential suffering comes about because we're not actually seeing things as they really are. That's the Buddha's normal statement.

Now that statement, which is a translation of the Pali, isn't actually absolutely correct. The translation is to see and understand how things have come to be. This is the Buddha—he's interested in process.

When we, today for instance, are observing the process of eating, it's the whole process we're trying to engage with, trying to understand. How is it that we create this world within this psychophysical organism, this body and mind, this fathom-length body, as the Buddha puts it? Within this fathom-length body is the world, the creation of the world, and so on.

We begin to understand that we're limited by the body as to what we can experience anyway. And then whatever information the body gives us is always taken inward and fixed into our concepts about things—concepts built up from past perceptions.

Very simply, today we had chilli beans. We've probably made our own chilli beans and had chilli beans elsewhere. So as soon as we tasted these chilli beans, we knew whether they were the real chilli beans or not—because either they're not the proper chilli beans, or they are the proper chilli beans, or they're almost the proper chilli beans. It's this judging mind. And that's something else, remember: there's a distinction between judging and being judgmental. But putting that aside, this whole process of creating the world within ourselves, having this memory of past events, reliving the world through our particular memory patterns—that's the sankharas, that's our habits.

When the Buddha talks about dukkha, he's digging deep at the level of our perception, how we perceive things. One of the things we perceive is continuity. We really do believe that the person—me—who got up this morning is pretty well the same person now. I don't see, I don't experience myself arising and passing away. I experience myself as absolutely constant within a mass of change. It's me always that's doing stuff.

Getting down to anicca, getting down to this real deep level of impermanence, is to see that the actual self is arising and passing away. The sense of me arises with every experience I'm having, every momentary experience. This digs even deeper, to the point of identity.

Now, in this statement she says, 'I am unable to detect, even for an instant, when they have any power over my heart.' To have power is to have control—it's the self. Whenever you say 'this is me,' you define it. If you say 'I am' and put something at the end of that sentence—I am angry, I am happy, I am an engineer, I am a nurse—whatever follows, you're locked into that definition, even if only for that moment. And that's how we define ourselves.

When that definition disappears, it can send us into a process of not knowing who we are. You get this crisis—an identity crisis.

I remember I used to have a Tai Chi teacher, a lovely man. I stopped going, and I met him years later—not that far on, maybe two or three years. He was half the man I remembered. I said, 'What's happened?' I thought he'd had an illness. He said no—he'd just lost his job.

With his job, he lost his self. It wasn't only the pain of losing the income, which we were finding out about. The whole self-definition of who he was and what his position was in the world—it was just taken away from him. And he had the usual depression and all that stuff that comes with that loss of identity.

And of course, the final loss of identity is when they lay us out in the morgue. That's when we know we've lost our identity.

The way the Buddha digs really deep—it's a place, of course, that most therapies don't want to go; it's a bit frightening to get down to that level—but that's where we want to get to. We want to get down to this business of who am I before I describe myself, before there's something coming after the 'am.' I am whatever.

And it's because of this deep delusion as to who I am—meaning this body, this heart, this mind, this person—which exists, by the way. The person exists in the sense that it's momentary. It's a momentary total conception of me.

There are experiences in meditation where you can step out of the self. It's a bit strange, but you can step out of it and see, 'Oh, there's the self.' And that self—it's not permanent. That's the problem.

Now, because of this identity thing, this identity of being this person, remember that I have this relationship with the world. And when we ask ourselves, 'How do I want to be? What do I want to be?'—I think we've come to this word: happy. I just want to be happy, for heaven's sake. Everybody will define their happiness in their own way, but that I want to be happy—that's all I want to be.

You want to be happy, and because of this delusion, remember, we seek happiness in just the wrong places. That's where we form attachments. Attachments are simply our psychological dependency on something—and then we find we don't have control over it. So the whole gamut of human misery starts: the frustration, grief, and so on. And of course, once you've gained something you've got to protect it one way or the other, whether against some nasty person or a government—you've got to protect what you have. And so there's that aversion and the fear of loss.

So you can see that from this deep delusion arises a more tangible dukkha. If you were to say to somebody, 'Are you suffering?' they'd probably point to these sorts of things—I'm depressed, my job's not going well, my relationship's collapsing. They're pointing to something concrete, something they can actually feel and explain. But at a deeper level we have this inexplicable sense of identity.

And you can see from her statement that something's missing there, isn't it? Because no matter what's happening to her at any level, it doesn't have any power over her heart. In other words, she cannot be grasped by it. She cannot be lost in it. Deluded by it.

So that's where the Buddha stakes out his cause. There is dukkha. And there's no way—there can't be no dukkha. That's the point. With the idea of a self, there can only be dukkha in the end. Even when we're totally happy, when things are going perfectly right and the world is full of gold and shining, there's always that awful feeling underneath—that things are passing, that you don't have control over it. Nothing can give us absolute total satisfaction.

Now, in terms of how we'd normally define our happiness—a state of adukkha, not suffering—we'd define it in a very positive way: feeling happy, going on holiday, having a good job, all that. We'd define it as some sort of existing experience. But this can't be that, can it? Because she's opted out of all experiences.

This is a presence that knows. It never changes for an instant. It's forever unborn and undying—in other words, it's not part of the process of the phenomenal world that we're experiencing, which is arising and passing away. Completely distinct from it. This is the end of suffering.

So our question then—the next position the Buddha takes—is: what's the cause of it?

Now, having stated these three delusions of anicca, dukkha, and anattā, he doesn't drive at the cause of being. This is an important point. The problem is identity, but that's not where he's positioning us, because that would be impossible to work with directly. Instead, he's pointing to how this delusion and this wrong identity manifests. And it manifests in our desires.

This brings us to the dependent origination, which is in the second noble truth. Here he tries to point out where the weak link is in this whole process of creating suffering for ourselves.

You'll notice that at the base you've got this sense of ignorance. Now remember, ignorance is not culpable. It's not as though we should have known better—it's a state of not knowing. And just like we don't know some things, we then presume to know, or we think we know, or we make a guess, or we take a leap. And it's usually into some sort of pit.

So it's accepting that at the base of our being—the fundamental part of us—is a state of not knowing. And this, remember, translates into the heart as a sense of innocence. From a moral heart point of view—compassion, joy, and peace—we start from the point of innocence, which means not doing harm. It's the Latin: no harm. So 'no harm' and 'not knowing' are combined to form what she's referring to here as body-mind, mind especially.

I don't know what words she's referring to in the Pali. The Buddha uses words contextually—sometimes they seem to contradict each other if you're just going for a word. Take the word *citta*. *Citta* could be translated in our language as the combination of mind and heart. The old word 'soul' as opposed to 'spirit.' Psyche.

We split those in our Enlightenment period, in the great eighteenth-century Enlightenment. So we think of ourselves as rational beings and/or feeling beings. You get people who say, 'I think,' and then others who say, 'I feel.' This split is something we have, which has of course had its brighter side—it's brought about science and technology and all that. But in the Buddha's understanding, that would all be just one faculty. And that's known as *citta*.

And yet in his victory verse—the one we chant in the morning—he says he's achieved the *asaṅkhata citta*. He's achieved something which is not conditioned. That obviously can't be the body, the mind-heart matrix. So we have to be careful about the words she's referring to here.

The first few links are always there at any given time. There's always that not knowing beneath everything we do, a sense of which expresses itself as a lack of wisdom. And because of that, we've created these delusions, these *saṅkhāra*. They're running underneath every moment as a potential, like a program in a computer.

Then you have a moment of action—a moment that drops into this flow, you might say. These moments are arising and passing away constantly, but even so, there's this drop into the present. And that's when you get the body, mind, and consciousness. The Buddha separates them: body and mind form one matrix, working off each other.

That's what we do when we're eating. We see that there's the body taste, the heart responds with a bit of joy, and so on. This matrix is always happening, and there's the consciousness of it.

Consciousness here—you have to be careful—is a discriminative consciousness. Included in there, shall we say, is a certain knowing, a certain habitual way of discriminating things, even at a very simple perceptual level.

When Cook arrived in Australia, the Aborigines didn't see the ships because they didn't have a context in which to see them. It's the same with me. When I was in Sri Lanka, I heard this barking. For some reason, I hadn't associated that sort of noise with monkeys. When they told me it was monkeys and they were up there,

for the life of me I couldn't see them. They were amazed that I couldn't see these monkeys. Then suddenly I saw them, because I had a picture of a monkey in my eye. There they were, surrounded by blooming monkeys. I just hadn't seen them.

It's astonishing really. That whole process has to be, shall we say, put onto a screen—and that's your *viññāṇa*. But it also includes all the knowledge and intelligence, all the understanding we have. It's all on that screen.

Now once that's happened, remember, you've got the body, and you've got the splitting up of that into the six *āyatana*. *Āyatana* are spheres, and what the Buddha is saying is that each sphere is distinct and discrete. You can't hear through your eyes and you can't see through your ears. It's just one of those things. I know there's this thing about synaesthesia, but I think that's just the mind itself working on it inside—the sixth sense.

The fact is you're never going to hear through your eyes whether you like it or not. We experience the world through very different avenues, which we have to collect onto this screen. Even here, you can hear me, you can see me, you can feel the atmosphere of this room. All of that is happening in little bits and blobs, but somehow it's held on this screen. That's what *viññāṇa* is referring to.

When that's held there, we have our moment-to-moment contacts. There have to be those three things present: an object, the sense base, and that consciousness—that holding on a screen for us.

Now it's the next point that turns this world into likeable or unlikeable: *vedanā*. And once we've experienced something like that, remember, there's always a reaction—always wanting to make the world pleasant for myself and get rid of anything unpleasant.

It's at that point that we see the escape. The escape lies between experiencing things as pleasant and unpleasant and seeing how we're reacting to it—which is then creating a relationship to it.

If we see that, we also become aware that actually, even at this point, there's no suffering. Have you grasped that in your meditation? Have you seen that when you're aware of, say, pain in the knee, and you're aware of aversion to the pain—not wanting it—if those two become clear objects in your mind, you're not actually suffering? Even at that point, you're not actually suffering.

It's only at the next point, when you dive into that reaction, when you lose yourself in it and become 'I don't want'—that's when real suffering begins. The point of real suffering is always the point of identity.

Now, the question is: who's suffering? It's the Buddha who's suffering. The Buddha's suffering, and that's why he wants to get out of suffering. There's no suffering as such in the body and mind—all there is, is what's pleasant and unpleasant. The point of suffering is when this very thing, this knowing, is unable to detect even for an instant when pleasant and unpleasant have power over the heart.

As soon as this heart, this knowing, falls into that wrong identity, it's that which is suffering. It's the Buddha's suffering, and the Buddha wants to get out of suffering.

Grasping this, we see that what's happening at the point of identity is that the Buddha within us is actually losing itself through delusion—that initial delusion of believing that true happiness is to be found in the sensual world. And 'sensual' here means the whole phenomenal world, the world that's being created by the mind out of quite minimal data, I believe.

Then, of course, having said that this is the cause, the Buddha tells us how to do it—just missing that third step about Nibbāna, the end of suffering. He tells us how we're actually going to achieve this.

Just seeing, for instance, how desire arises when we're eating—knowing that there's an overlay of greed, an overlay of attachment to the food, an overlay of wanting to seek happiness there—just the seeing of that clearly, clearly, clearly. Even though we see it absolutely clear, it's clearly not enough, because we keep being greedy. There's something else that has a problem here.

And when we look down into the lie, we find attitude. 'Attitude' refers to these conditionings within us. When we look at one of them—this selfishness, which manifests as anything we do for our own good, for our own benefit, driven by the idea that this is happiness—that's always the internal delusion there.

When we see that, we realise it has to be hit at an attitudinal level. Now, how do you change at an attitudinal level? It's by seeing these intentions. And that's why this is such a strong teaching within the Mahasi Sayadaw's tradition. To see an intention is to see the initial manifestation of a delusion, the initial manifestation of a habit that we've created which is unwholesome for us.

So as soon as I see this desire for scones, for instance, arise tomorrow—as soon as that desire hits me—I say, 'Oh, that's the old greed. I'm hoping it's as good as last time.' It's actually catching that moment.

Now, if we have this mindfulness, this awareness, this alertness to actually be with that, then we'll allow it to exhaust itself. And every time we do that, we're drawing energy from that old habit. So this compact energy that we've got now, directed just towards this object that we call a scone, is being drawn out.

So tomorrow, when the scone is there, you'll be able to say, 'I'm going to renounce the scone and sit with the pain of renunciation'—knowing that this pain is a healing pain, because it's drawing the poison out of the system.

When all that's gone and you feel perfectly equanimous, then of course you can have your scone. But not without clearly seeing any arising of greed for the scone after that.

On the opposite side, of course, when the intention is seen as wholesome, we empower it. And in this sense, the heart's growing.

So when we look at right attitude, it's normally put in those three ways, isn't it? Selfishness to generosity, hatred to love, cruelty to compassion.

Now you'll notice there's no in-between state. You're either greedy or you're not greedy. So I've tended these days to use the word 'sublimate' rather than 'transform', because the change is immediate. As soon as you let this greedy feeling burn itself out, that energy isn't lost. It's there as potential, and it'll be used for the right intention.

In this way, the growth from darkness to light—as the Buddha says—becomes a natural process through renunciation. And remember what we mean by renunciation. We're not trying to beat ourselves up. We're just trying to really feel those initial intentions, to stay steady amongst them, and wait for them to die away.

And of course it doesn't finish there, does it? Because then the intention has to translate into the way we speak, into what we do, and into our livelihood. In other words, it has to manifest.

Remember that an intention, unless it's empowered, hasn't done anything. It's not what we call a kamma, an act. So just my feeling greedy is, shall we say, an energy coming out of a past habit—but it hasn't been potentialised. Nothing's happened yet.

Have you heard about the rule about stealing from monks? Have I explained that to you? All the different levels of stealing that a monk can get up to when he's really bad. I think you have heard it. What it points out very clearly is the distinction between these processes.

For instance, if I pass this gong and I like it, I can feel the draw of wanting it. If I just let that go, it'll disappear. But if I don't, and my mind works on it, then I might develop a real greed for it. And at some point, passing it again, my hand might stretch out towards it. Then I pull it back and think, what are you doing, you fool? But I've already committed what's known as a dukkaṭa—a small offence against the Vinaya.

And if I'm lazy-minded and I don't watch my thoughts, next time I might really go for it. I think, yeah, I do want it, and I put my finger on it—that's a garuka, a very heavy offence.

However, if I then, under a point of weakness—because I'm so entranced by this gong—reach out and move it a nano-centimetre, and then pull my hand back and go... that's it. I've done it. That's the theft, completed. I lose my robes. There's no way you can get beyond that. And I don't even get the gong—I left it there. It's absolutely useless. But the act was done.

So you can see through this lovely way that the Vinaya splits up how we create a bad act—by not seeing that initial intention.

In the same way, of course, we sometimes have initial good intentions but don't act upon them. The key is catching a good intention and then making the effort so that it translates into action.

In other words, an attitude is potential. It manifests its potential in an intention. And the intention still remains potential until it's intentioned—this peculiar language we've got. Then you commit an act. That act can be an internal thought, creating something malevolent. It can be an act of speech. It can be something we've done with our body. And it shapes our livelihood.

When you think of livelihood, you might wonder why the Buddha included it separately—after all, it comes under action. But he's pointing out something important: what we do for the best part of our lives, our work in society where we put a tremendous amount of energy, is conditioning us.

If you work in a pub, that's one kind of environment. If you work in a nursery, that's quite another. It's not that pubs are essentially evil, but it would be difficult not to have an occasional drink. So if you look back on your life and the work you've done, consider the effect it had on you as a personality, as a character-forming thing.

And then, of course, underlying all of this is right concentration, right mindfulness, and right effort. These always have to do with a certain level of awareness, a certain being here. And that's very difficult for us because we're constantly forgetting to do it.

This is why we need to stop as often as we can during the day and reestablish that sense of presence. Look at what she says: the presence that knows. We have to reestablish that every moment. Even if the presence that knows may still be a little off, may still have a chink in the eye, it's still a presence that knows. Constantly going back to that presence—that is the reminder.

And then, once we're in that presence that knows, we need to make sure that the intention we're going to act out—and this is the point—absorb into, is going to help us maintain that presence.

When we're in that position, we can recognise it as something transcendent. It's no longer caught up in what's happening. There may be pain in the knee and there may be a reaction of aversion, but there's no doing. There's just that happening. Within what? Within that presence. Within that awareness.

When you hear a bird singing, there is the sound hitting the eardrum and you can clearly see it—it's there in the ear. Then you can feel that your heart might lift—unless it's one of these raucous crows—but if it's a nice little bird, your heart lifts and you can see that. But you don't get lost in it; you're observing it.

Even though we want to reach that position and stabilise it in our meditation, remember that's only a first position in terms of what we want to do. The second position is to become so curious about what's happening within this body and mind that we centre in on something, and as we do that, we absorb into it.

Because we've absorbed into whatever's happening within us—some emotional state, some feeling—with the right intention to understand the Dhamma, when we come out of that and we're back to being the observer, we've actually developed that sense of curiosity. And with it we've developed an understanding, because we've gone into the subject in a more intimate way.

On the opposite side, when we absorb into something with a bad intention, we come out the other side with that being developed instead.

That's why this process of right awareness is paramount in our practice. To be aware, to keep bringing ourselves back into the present moment—that is the practice. That's all it is. You can file down all the Buddha's teachings on practice into that one word: *sati, sammā-sati*.

How can we now understand what she's saying here? The body, mind, and essence are all distinct and separate realities. I'm presuming that what she means by essence is this very sense of presence—because all there is, is body and mind and essence. Remember, this is translating the Thai. It's all second-hand.

Absolutely everything is known. Within that field of awareness, nothing is blocked out, nothing separated or put to one side, nothing given special attention. It's just the stuff that arises through this psychophysical organism.

Earth, water, fire and wind—these are the four elements. Remember, those four elements don't exist out there. I know it's put as earth, water, fire and wind, but what they're really telling us is how the mind contacts matter. The mind contacts matter through this sensibility to heat, to elasticity, to pressure and to movement.

And then there's the body, feeling, memory, thought and consciousness. Remember that when you're observing something, you're observing it on that screen of consciousness. It's there. There's nothing behind it. You can't get behind it. You can't get through it. That's it—that's the world we're living in. Whatever we're conscious of.

Now here's a funny statement—this is why Noreen emailed me. Anger, greed and delusion are all known.

Here I'm presuming she actually means that she sees anger, greed and delusion in other people, and that it's not affecting her, not coming into her. I'm presuming she hasn't got that within her, because it wouldn't make sense for her to have it—she's undercut the whole process by destroying that wrong identity from which it all arises.

But I did suggest something else to Noreen. You'll know that there are four levels of sanctity, of spiritual attainment: the stream-enterer, the once-returner, the non-returner, and the arahat.

Normally speaking, the way the commentaries put it, there's a *magga* and a *phala*—the path and the fruit. It's said that when a person becomes a *sotāpanna*, there is that initial moment, which is the path. And then all the other moments of their life as a *sotāpanna* are the fruit of that insight.

That's the same for all four levels. But there's definite evidence in the scriptures to say that actually these are two paths—and this makes great sense to me personally. The first is to do with right understanding, where a person sees quite clearly one of the three characteristics. But that seeing now has to become systemic. It has to run through right attitude, right speech, right action, right livelihood. It has to manifest outwards. And until it's done that totally, we can't talk about the fruit of it.

One argument for this is the experience the Buddha himself had. It's said in the scriptures that he has this moment of enlightenment, but then *Māra* chases him—remember?—for seven years, with his three daughters: sensual pleasure, eroticism and boredom.

We can see that's where his problems lay. He wasn't so much into power. If you remember, Jesus was tempted by power—taken to the top of the mountain by the devil: you can have all this. So there's always power, riches and sensuality. Sensuality was where, you might say, the Buddha had been stuck.

Seven years, and *Māra* finally gives up. He sees me, *Māra* says. But the purity had not yet become systemic. There's a suggestion there. Whether it was literally seven years, who knows? But there's an understanding that it took time for this huge insight, this new liberation, to find its way through all his habits.

And because his habits were still there, he would have seen them as unwholesome. So it may be that this is also what she's referring to—that she's not yet reached the fruit of her insight.

But I prefer to see it the other way—that she actually has reached the fruit, and that she's quite aware when somebody's being greedy or deluded. She's not fooled by it.

What a wonderful thing to be able to say: I'm unable to detect even an instant when they have power over my heart. I want to be able to say that.

We can get a hint of this in ourselves. When you've isolated the sense of the observer very clearly, and then you reflect at the end of your sitting—what was it like to be there? What's inside the observer? What's it made of?

This is where we glimpse what the Buddha means when he says that those who are mindful in this way are in the presence of Nibbāna. He's not saying we can't get a taste for it, can't get a feel for it. And it's important, because the more we get that feel—the silence of it, the lack of excitement—the more we understand.

Our happiness is always gauged by how happy we are emotionally, how excited we are, what the future has to offer. And yet here there's a pointing to some sort of stasis, some sort of peacefulness that never changes. An internal position of silence.

When we begin to sense that, we also begin to realise it's not part of this process of arising and passing away. It is forever there. Now that's very difficult for us to grasp, because for us there is time. We can't imagine something not being in time, not being caught up in some sort of changing process.

And then, finally: just this is the end of suffering.

May it be that Mae Chee Kaew has inspired us, driven us to greater efforts. May we all be fully realised and free from all suffering—sooner rather than later.

Nibbāna: The Kevaddha Sutta and the Luminous Consciousness

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 16 min

Originally given as *Nibbāna: The Kevaddha Sutta and the Luminous Consciousness* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this dharma talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the Kevaddha Sutta's unique teaching on nibbāna through the story of a monk who seeks to know where the four great elements (earth, water, fire, wind) cease without remainder. The monk journeys through increasingly sublime divine realms—from the Four Great Kings to Brahmā himself—only to find that none of these gods possess the answer to his question.

The Buddha redirects the inquiry, explaining that the question itself is wrongly framed. Rather than asking where the elements cease, one should ask where they 'find no footing.' The answer points to a consciousness that is 'signless, non-manifestive, limitless, all-illuminating'—a luminous knowing beyond the five aggregates where nāma-rūpa (name-and-form) come to an end.

Bhante explores this rare scriptural description of nibbāna in positive terms, contrasting it with the more common via negativa approach. He addresses the apparent paradox of consciousness ceasing while a transcendent consciousness remains, offering insights into the profound not-self (anattā) realization where all mundane experience disappears yet luminous awareness persists. This teaching bridges early Buddhist descriptions of the unconditioned with later Yogācāra developments, making it essential study for serious practitioners seeking to understand the ultimate goal of the path.

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā sambuddhassa
 Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā sambuddhassa
 Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā sambuddhassa

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble, and fully self-awakened one.

I'm continuing what we did last time, which is to talk about *Nibbāna*. That's the long and short of it.

Here I'm going to go through a discourse the Buddha addressed to a monk called Kevaddha. As we go through it, you'll see what it's all about.

The Buddha tells Kevaddha: there was a monk in this community, the Sangha, in whose awareness a thought arose. Where do these four great elements cease without remainder? The earth property—heavy or light; the liquid property—cohesive elasticity; the fire property—heat and cold; and the wind property—movement or stillness or stiffness. Where are they annihilated?

This monk then attained such a state of concentration that the way leading to the gods appeared in his focused mind. He approached the gods—these seem to be the lowest of them, the retinue of the four great kings—and said, "Friends, where do these four great elements cease without remainder?" They replied, "Well, we also don't know. But there are the four great kings themselves, who are higher and more sublime than we."

So off he goes to find these four great kings. When he does, they also say, "We don't know where these four great elements cease without remainder." They suggest he go a little higher, to the gods of the Thirty-Three. When he arrives there, they say the same thing: "We don't know, but Sakka, the ruler of the gods, who is higher and more sublime than we, will know."

In this way he goes up and up—through the Yama gods, the Suyama gods, the Santusita gods, the Nimmanarati gods, the Sunamita gods—higher and higher, and they're all saying the same thing: "I don't know, but somebody upstairs knows better." You can see this is getting to be a bit of a satire.

Finally the Paranimmita Vasavatti, chief of the Paranimmita gods, says, "Why don't you approach the retinue of Brahma?" When he does, they say, "Of course, we don't know—but Brahma himself will know."

So this monk approaches Brahma and asks the same question: "Where do these four great elements cease without remainder?" But first—going back a little—the text describes how a light shines forth and a radiance appears, for these are the portents of Brahma's appearance.

Brahma appears, and the monk approaches him: "Friend, where do these four great elements cease without remainder?" The great Brahma replies, "I, monk, am Brahma, the great Brahma, the conqueror, the unconquered, the all-seeing, the all-powerful, the sovereign Lord, maker, creator, chief, appointer, ruler, father of all that has been and shall be."

The monk says to him, "Friend, I didn't ask you if you were Brahma, the great Brahma, the conqueror, the unconquered, and so on and so forth. I asked you: where do the four great elements cease without remainder?"

Well, poor old Brahma, he goes off again with his string of attributes: "I am Brahma, the maker, creator, chief, appointer, ruler," and so on. So again, he asks him, only this time, the great Brahma, taking the monk by the arm and leading him off to the side, said to him, "These gods of the retinue of Brahma believe there is nothing that the great Brahma does not know. There is nothing the great Brahma does not see. There is nothing the great Brahma is unaware of. There is nothing that the great Brahma has not realized. That is why I did not say in their presence that I too don't know where the four great elements cease without remainder."

"So you've acted wrongly. You've acted incorrectly in bypassing the Blessed One in search of an answer to this question elsewhere. Go right back to the Blessed One and on arrival, ask him this question. However he answers it, you should take it to heart."

Then because of his powers, as a man might flex his arm, he appears from the Brahma world before the Buddha.

"Once, monk, some seafaring merchants took a shore-sighting bird and set sail in their ship. When they could not see the shore, they released the shore-sighting bird. It flew to the east, south, west, north, straight up, and to all the intermediate points of the compass. If it saw a shore in any direction, it flew there. If it did not see the shore in any direction, it returned right back to the ship. In the same way, monk, having gone as far as the Brahma world in search of an answer to your question, you have come right back to my presence."

Anyway, what he says to this monk is: "Your question should not be phrased in this way: 'Where do these four great elements, the earth element, liquid element, fire element and wind element cease without remainder?' Instead, it should be

phrased like this: 'Where do earth, water, fire and air find no footing? Where are long and short, small and great, fair and foul? Where are name and form, body and mind brought to an end?'"

And the answer is this: "Consciousness that is signless, non-manifestive, limitless, without boundary and all-illuminating in all directions, full of light. There water, earth, fire and wind find no footing. There long and short, small and large, pleasant and unpleasant. There name and form, body and mind have all been brought to an end. With the cessation of consciousness, all is brought to an end."

Now we have a problem. The Buddha is a little bit like any person who suddenly sees something which is beyond the culture, something new to the culture. They are always scrabbling for new words. An obvious example would be Freud, who had to come up with id, ego, and superego to get across his model of the human mind.

Here he is using consciousness in two different ways. The first consciousness is the one that is going to cease, going to come to an end. This is the consciousness that the Buddha describes by sense bases: there is eye consciousness, ear consciousness, nose consciousness, mind consciousness. This consciousness belongs to the five aggregates, which are the body or our physicality, all our feelings driven by both the body and emotions, all our perceptions, and the saṅkhāras—these habits of thought, habits of action, which we remember create through an act of will—and this consciousness. This consciousness is like a screen upon which this information arises. That is the consciousness which disappears. That is the consciousness which can experience these four great elements. He goes as far as to say that even the mind and the body also are brought to an end. But this is not a final end. It is where they find no footing.

Then he describes this experience, which has to be the experience of Nibbāna. He says there is a consciousness, a knowing, which is non-manifested. The word is *nidassanaṃ*—cannot be seen. What cannot be seen? What cannot be felt? It stands for all the sense bases. It is limitless. It does not have a boundary. It is not dependent on anything. Interestingly, it is all-illuminating, or in another translation, in all directions full of light. It is here that the earth, fire, wind, and water elements find no footing.

What we have here is, again, a restatement that there is a mundane experience that we have through this form of body and mind. And there is something which sits within it, but beyond it. When we experience what is beyond in its purity, then what is mundane—the body and mind—do not appear. That really is one of

the most profound experiences of not-self, because everything that we experience, we tend to associate with either by way of identity or possession. But here, everything is gone, and yet there remains this luminous consciousness.

Just as a reminder, going back to the early quotes of last month, here he says there is a dimension where there is no earth, no water, no fire, no wind. He is saying the same thing here, but he is not actually telling us what it is. He is telling us what is not there. He says no dimension of infinite space, infinite consciousness, nothingness, neither perception nor non-perception. There are none of those higher states of mind that we refer to as the *jhānas*, the absorptions. There is not this world or another world. There is no moon, no sun. I say there is no coming or going, remaining or passing away or reappearing. There is absolutely nothing there which is either phenomenal or physical.

Then we have this other quote, which again tells us what is not there: "There is that which is unborn"—this is how it is translated—"unborn, undying, uncreated, uncompounded," which means it is unconditioned. There is something which was never born. It has never died. It was never created, does not develop, and is not bound by any conditions.

So we've had these statements now—both the negative, what is not in *Nibbāna*, and also this very positive statement about an experience that is nibbanic. Interestingly, this positive description is quoted only twice in the whole of the scriptures, and it does not appear in the *Udāna* collection, which is a collection of the Buddha's inspired verses. Some filtering has clearly gone on.

Just as an aside, in the *Mahāyāna*—when Buddhism developed into the *Mahāyāna*—there was a school, the *Yogācāra* school, that actually has what they call a transcendent *Abhidhamma*, and it is based upon this particular phrase, this particular verse we've just been reading.

This doesn't complete the mystery of *Nibbāna*, unfortunately, and there is more to be said. I'll find some time to talk about it.

I can only hope these words have been of assistance, that they haven't caused confusion, and that by your careful investigation through your practice of *vipassanā*, you will attain this particular experience.

Sādhū, sādhū, sādhū.

The Nature of Nibbāna and the Path to Liberation

Bhante Bodhidhamma · 16 min

Originally given as *The Nature of Nibbāna and the Path to Liberation* at Satipanya Buddhist Retreat



In this dharma talk, Bhante Bodhidhamma examines the Buddha's description of nibbāna as "consciousness in which nothing is manifest, with no boundary and full of light in all directions" - the place where the world finds no footing. Through two illuminating metaphors, he explores how we can liberate ourselves from the self-deception created by Māra, the deluded self or "house builder."

The first metaphor draws parallels between infant development and vipassanā practice - how babies gradually create objects and spatial awareness from overwhelming sensory input, similar to how meditators distance their intuitive awareness (sati) from mental and physical phenomena. The second uses the myth of Narcissus to illustrate how awareness catches its own reflection in the pool of consciousness, only to drown in self-absorption until the Buddha's method rescues us.

Bhante presents specific techniques for investigating the nature of self-awareness itself, recognizing it as the very portal into the world of the six senses. The talk concludes with the remarkable testimony of Meichi Kiao, an unlettered village woman who achieved complete liberation, describing her direct experience of the "unborn and undying" awareness that remains untouched by all conditioned phenomena. This teaching offers both theoretical understanding and practical guidance for recognizing our true nature beyond the aggregates and sense bases.

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā Sambuddhassa — Homage to the Buddha, the Blessed Noble and Fully Self-Awakened One.

In the last two talks, we looked first at the Buddha's victory verse and his naming of the house builder — that deluded self which is Māra. When we speak of Māra, the evil tempter, we're speaking of the self, the deluded self. Then in the

following presentation, we explored a monk who wanted to know where the world ended. The Buddha tells him the question is badly phrased; it should be: where does the world not find a footing? He then gives a very clear description of that place: There is a consciousness in which nothing is manifest. It has no boundary and is full of light in all directions. We can understand this to be a description of *Nibbāna*.

Our task now is to find a way to practise such that this might become manifest to us. But before we do that, I'd like to offer some metaphors — ways of thinking about what we're doing — so we can understand the process of liberating ourselves from the self-deception generated by this deluded self, this house builder.

The first metaphor draws on what happens to us as babies, which has a striking similarity to the process of insight meditation. For the first four months of our lives, it seems, we're bombarded by sensual information and can make no head or tail of it. But we do know when we're experiencing what is pleasant or unpleasant — that is the dual world we enter into. Then around four months, we start to delineate our first object out of this bewildering mass, and in so doing, we create the third dimension of depth. Usually from this we find our first object: our mother, our carer.

The process continues until around the age of three, when we're pretty clear that I'm not anything outside my body. My body and my sense of me are separate from everyone and everything. And I know my toys belong to me — they're mine. A very strong sense of possession. There's still a great connection to Mother, but what we've done is distance the outer world from the inner world.

Our practice is to distance this inner world from the intuitive awareness. Every time we experience a feeling or sensation, an emotion or mood, a thought or an image as an object, we're telling ourselves that this cannot be the awareness that knows it. The knower, the feeler, the experiencer experiences itself as quite other to everything it knows, feels, and experiences.

That's what happens when we turn everything into an object. Just as the baby creates a third dimension by reaching out — and so creating distance — we're pushing away what overwhelms us: our sensations, feelings, and thoughts. The distance between the object and the awareness is the inner third dimension.

The second metaphor I like to use is the myth of Narcissus. As you remember, Narcissus was a handsome, beautiful young man. He looked into a pool, caught the image of his own face, fell in love with it, went to embrace it, and drowned. This is understood as a myth about self-absorption, pride, vanity, conceit. Water in mythology often represents life and creation, as well as chaos and purification.

However, we can read this myth spiritually. *Sati*, the intuitive awareness — I notice, not AI — catches its image on the screen of consciousness. Consciousness itself is that screen upon which the six senses manifest, which is why consciousness is defined by the sense base: eye consciousness, ear consciousness, mind consciousness, and so on.

Every morning we wake up, the first thing we're aware of is ourselves — our self-awareness. I'm sure you've had the experience of waking up in an unfamiliar room, at a hotel or at friends'. For those first few seconds, you can't recognise where you are and so who you are. There's a momentary panic till we situate ourselves. Thus it is that *sati* sees itself, senses itself in the pool of the mind — the pool of the world that the mind is creating — and then we drown in it.

However, the Buddha has come to the rescue and offered us a methodology to resuscitate ourselves. We must drag Narcissus out of the water and sit him back on the bank of the pool. So it is that in vipassanā, we draw our awareness out of the body and mind with its feelings, perceptions, and habits, and we experience ourselves as the one who knows.

In this, our basic identity begins to change — where we base our identity. As children, our identity is very body-centred. We have that experience when we bite our tongues while eating: just for that singular moment of stabbing pain, we're absorbed into it and become a physical self. We then very quickly bounce out of it and are annoyed with ourselves, becoming an emotional self. We might then reflect upon it and counsel ourselves to eat more slowly and mindfully, becoming a thinking self. But the position of the observer, the feeler, transcends them all. It can be aware of all the experiences the body and heart-mind have.

From here, we might acknowledge more and more clearly the distinction between object and subject. This takes us back to the distancing, the disidentifying process of the baby and young child — and then a step further, to investigate the nature of this identity of the self as observer and feeler. For having accessed within ourselves this inner position — called by Nyanaponika Thera in his classic work *The Heart of Buddhist Meditation*, still worthy of a read, an 'observation post'

— from this observation post, we can see clearly that the body and heart-mind, the emotions and thought life, continue of themselves without the engagement of this self-awareness that we now experience ourselves to be.

Now we have a situation where the self-awareness sees the body as other, and sees that the body keeps on being the body with its sensations and feelings. The emotions and moods still arise; the thoughts and images continue to flit across the mind. None of it needs the direct control of *sati*, this intuitive awareness. So we're left with a question: what is the nature of this self-awareness?

Our investigation now turns towards the self-awareness itself — that sense of presence. Since we're aware of it, that makes it an object. So we can't be it. Worse, we realise that this identity is the very portal into the world manufactured by the six senses: the five physical senses and the heart-mind. This is the face in the pool. Indeed, this primary self is Māra, the evil tempter, inviting us into the pleasures and joys of the world, only to find ourselves entangled, ensnared, and imprisoned. This is the house builder the Buddha discovered to be the agent of rebirth, the root of all our discontent and suffering.

There's a practice that's pretty specific to this investigation, and I'm indebted — well, we are indebted — to the Mahāyāna school for it. When the body is very still, the heart calm, and the mind silent — admittedly that's pretty rare in our daily lives, though it does arise on retreat — we can raise our attention into that feeling of presence located in the forehead. We can stay there to the exclusion of everything else and simply gaze.

We now know, because we are aware of that sense of self, that it's an object and therefore belongs to the mind. So it must be arising and passing away, even though it seems coexistent with the awareness that knows it. Remember, consciousnesses are flashing at enormous speeds, giving us a sense of continuity. We need to hold that position as best we can without straining — just gazing with wonder. Is that sense of self arising and passing away? That is all. Just gaze with wonder. Presume that the awareness knows what it's looking for.

The other technique is the one we usually use when practising vipassanā: directly investigating the process of impermanence. Whenever we see an object — whether it's a sensation or a feeling, mood or emotion, thought or image — appearing and disappearing, the same principle applies. The *sati*, this observer, this feeler, that experiences the object arising and passing away, cannot itself be

arising and passing away. That gap, minute as it is, between the passing of an object and the arising of another, would also constitute a glimpse into our true nature — which is unborn, undying, uncreated, and unconditioned.

We can sum up the techniques like this. First, pull away from the object we're aware of, so it becomes something to observe and feel — remembering that the perceiver cannot be the perceived. This is the first step of 'not me, not mine, not self.' Then, the direct experience of the appearance and disappearance of the object allows *sati* to experience itself as other: whole, entire, and permanent. Slowly but surely, this intuitive awareness, *satipaññā*, becomes an island unto itself, impervious to the physical and mental worlds. This is where the very world cannot find a footing.

Fortunately, we have an example of someone who describes what it's like to be fully liberated from the delusion of self. This actually warrants a talk of its own, but for our present purpose it's enough to quote her. I'm presuming for the time being that you know the categories the Buddha teaches: the four great elements, the six sense bases, and the five aggregates.

Mae Chi Kaew was an ordinary, barely educated village girl who died in 1991 at the age of ninety. This is her statement: 'Body, mind and essence are all distinct and separate realities. Absolutely everything is known. Earth, water, fire and wind. Body, feeling, memory, thought and consciousness. Sounds, sights, smells, tastes and touches and emotions. Anger, greed and delusion — all are known. I know them all as they exist in their own natural states. But no matter how much I'm exposed to them, I am unable to detect even an instant when they have any power over my heart. They arise and cease, they're forever changing, but the presence that knows them never changes for an instant. It is forever unborn and undying. This is the end of all suffering.'

I can only hope this little homily has been of interest, and that by your dedication to the practice you will be liberated from all suffering — like Mae Chi Kaew — sooner rather than later.

Glossary of Pāli Terms

anattā — Not-self; the characteristic that no permanent, unchanging self can be found

anicca — Impermanence; the characteristic that all conditioned phenomena are transient

anāgāmī — Non-returner; the third stage of awakening

arahant — Fully awakened one; one who has completed the path

ariya — Noble; one who has attained a stage of awakening

bhāvanā — Mental cultivation, meditation

brahma vihāra — Divine abode; the four sublime states (*mettā*, *karuṇā*, *muditā*, *upekkhā*)

byāpāda — Ill-will, aversion; the second hindrance

cetanā — Intention, volition; the mental factor of will

dhamma — Teaching, truth, natural law; the Buddha's doctrine

dukkha — Suffering, unsatisfactoriness; the inherent stress of conditioned existence

jhāna — Absorption; deep states of meditative concentration

kamma — Action, especially intentional action; the law of cause and effect

karuṇā — Compassion; the wish for beings to be free from suffering

khandha — Aggregate; the five components of psychophysical existence

kāmacchanda — Sensual desire; the first of the five hindrances

magga — Path; specifically the Noble Eightfold Path

mettā — Loving-kindness; goodwill toward all beings

muditā — Sympathetic joy; rejoicing in others' happiness

nibbāna — The unconditioned; the cessation of suffering and the goal of the Buddhist path

nāma-rūpa — Mind and matter; mentality-materiality

nīvaraṇa — Hindrance; the five mental obstructions to meditation

pañcasīla — The five precepts; the basic ethical training rules

paññā — Wisdom; direct insight into the nature of reality

paṭiccasamuppāda — Dependent origination; the twelve-link chain of causation

phala — Fruit; the result of path attainment

sakadāgāmī — Once-returner; the second stage of awakening

samatha — Calm, tranquility meditation; concentration practice

sammā — Right, correct, proper; prefix used in the Noble Eightfold Path

sammā diṭṭhi — Right View; the first factor of the Noble Eightfold Path

sammā samādhi — Right Concentration; the eighth factor of the Noble Eightfold Path
sammā sati — Right Mindfulness; the seventh factor of the Noble Eightfold Path
sati — Mindfulness; present-moment awareness
satipaṭṭhāna — Foundation of mindfulness; the four fields of mindful observation
saṃsāra — The cycle of rebirth; the round of existence
saṅgha — Community; the assembly of noble disciples
saṅkhāra — Mental formations, volitional activities; conditioned phenomena
sotāpanna — Stream-enterer; the first stage of awakening
sīla — Moral conduct, virtue, ethics
taṇhā — Craving, thirst; the origin of suffering
thīna-middha — Sloth and torpor; the third hindrance
tilakkhana — The three characteristics: anicca, dukkha, anattā
uddhacca-kukkucca — Restlessness and worry; the fourth hindrance
upekkhā — Equanimity; balanced, impartial awareness
upādāna — Clinging, attachment; grasping at the five aggregates
vedanā — Feeling tone; pleasant, unpleasant, or neutral quality of experience
vicikicchā — Skeptical doubt; the fifth hindrance
vipassanā — Insight meditation; direct observation of the three characteristics
viññāṇa — Consciousness; awareness of sense objects
āyatana — Sense base; the six internal and external bases of perception

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